

WHEN THE ELIOTT-CLARK WORLD IS
DISRUPTED BY VILDEBERT'S RAMPAGING
SLIPPERERS AND THE RESURRECTION OF THE
TERRIFYING DARK MARD, IT IS EVIDENTLY THE
FARRY THAT, FAR FROM WEAKENING, VILDEBERT
IS GETTING STRONGER. THE ULTIMATE SIGNAL THE
THE MAGIC WORLD OF THE DARK LORD'S RETURN
WILL BE DEFEAT OF THE ONE AND ONLY
SURVIVOR OF HIS DEATH CURSE, FARRY PETER.
SEE WHEN FARRY IS ENTERED FOR THE
PRESTIGIOUS YET DANGEROUS TRIWIZARD
TOURNAMENT HE KNOWS THAT RATHER THAN WIN
IT, HE MUST GET THROUGH THE TASKS ALIVE.

EVERY BIT AS GOOD AS PETERS 1 THROUGH 3
STEPHEN KING

FARRY'S AND HIS FOURTH YEAR AT
HOGWARTS IS FLIPPY, FULL OF DELICIOUS
PARADISE OF HIS OWN WORLD, AND WILDLY
ACTION-PACKED THE TIMES

THERE ISN'T A DULL PAGE ... THE PLOT FITS
TOGETHER LIKE A WOODEN NIGEL
SUNDAY EXPRESS

THE DAZZLING PLOT AND PACE ARE MORE
IMPRESSIVE THAN EVER ... THERE'S SIMPLY TOO
MUCH TO PRAISE. TEN PER CENT
GET: GET READ: IRISH TIMES

THE STORY IS COMPELLING: THE FILM

SATISFYINGLY ANARCHIC, THE MORAL STANCE
REASSURINGLY STRONG ... HER BEST KNEE YET
SUNDAY TELEGRAPH

14.99

HARRY POTTER AND THE
CHAMBER OF FIRE

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(IN WELSH, ANCIENT GREEK AND IRISH):

HARRY POTTER AND THE PRINCEPSHIP OF STONE

HARRY POTTER AND THE

CHIEF OF FIRE

J. D. ROLLING

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THE PETER RIDDLE,

IN MEMORY OF MR RIDLEY

AND THE SUSAN SLADEN,

WHO HELPED HARRY FIND HIS CLASHARD

CHAPTER ONE

THE RIDDLE HOUSE

THE VILLAGERS OF LITTLE HANGLETON STILL CALLED IT THE RIDDLE
HOUSE, EVEN THOUGH IT HAD BEEN MANY YEARS SINCE THE RIDDLE
FAMILY HAD LIVED THERE. IT STOOD ON A HILL OVERLOOKING THE

VILLAGE, SOME OF ITS WINDOWS SHARDED, TILES MISSING FROM ITS

ROOF, AND IVY SPREADING LIMB-THICKED OVER ITS FACE. HENCE A FINE-
LOOKING MANOR, AND EASILY THE LARGEST AND GRANDEST BUILDING FOR

MILES AROUND, THE RIDDLE HOUSE WAS NOW DAMP, DERELICT AND
UNRECLAIMED.

THE LITTLE FANGLETHENS ALL AGREED THAT THE OLD HOUSE WAS
CREEPY, HALF A CENTURY AGO, SOMETHING STRANGE AND TERRIBLE
HAD HAPPENED THERE, SOMETHING THAT THE ELDER INHABITANTS OF
THE VILLAGE STILL LIKED TO DISCUSS WHEN TOPICS FOR Gossip WERE
SCARCE. THE STORY HAD BEEN PICKED OVER SO MANY TIMES, AND HAD
BEEN EMBROIDERED IN SO MANY PLACES, THAT NOBODY WAS ABLE
SURE WHAT THE TRUTH WAS ANY MORE. EVERY VERSION OF THE TALE,
HOWEVER, STARTED IN THE SAME PLACE: FIFTY YEARS BEFORE, AT
DAYBREAK ON A FINE SUMMER MORNING, WHEN THE RIDDLE HOUSE
HAD STILL BEEN WELL KEPT AND IMPRESSIVE, AND A MAID HAD
ENTERED THE DRAWING ROOM TO FIND ALL THREE RIDDLES DEAD.
THE MAID HAD RUN SCREAMING DOWN THE HILL INTO THE VILLAGE,
AND AWOKED AS MANY PEOPLE AS SHE COULD.

Lying THERE WITH THEIR EYES WIDE OPEN! Cold AS ICE! STILL IN
THEIR DINNER THINGS!

THE POLICE WERE SUMMONED, AND THE WHOLE OF LITTLE

FANGLETHEN HAD SEETHED WITH STILLED CURIOSITY AND IL-
DISGUISED EXCITEMENT. NOBODY WASTED THEIR BREATH PRETENDING

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THEY FEEL VERY SAD ABOUT THE RIDDLES, FOR THEY HAD BEEN MOST
UNFRIENDLY. ELDERLY MR AND MRS RIDDLE HAD BEEN RICH, SNEAKISH
AND RUDE, AND THEIR GREEN-LIP SON, THEM, HAD BEEN EVEN MORE

SO. ALL THE VILLAGERS CARED ABOUT WAS THE IDENTITY OF THEIR MUR-
DERER. PLAINLY, THREE APPARENTLY HEALTHY PEOPLE DID NOT ALL DROWN

DEAD OF NATURAL CAUSES IN THE SAME NIGHT.

THE HANGED MAN, THE VILLAGE PLK, DID A REHARING TRADE THAT
NIGHT; THE WHOLE VILLAGE HAD TURNED OUT TO DISCUSS THE MURDERS.
THEY WERE REWARDED FOR LEAVING THEIR FIRESIDES WHEN THE
RIDDLES ~~THEY~~ ARRIVED DRAMATICALLY IN THEIR MIDST, AND
ANNOUNCED TO THE SLIDDERLY SILENT PLK THAT A MAN CALLED FRANK
KRYTE HAD JUST BEEN ARRESTED.

FRANK? CRIED SEVERAL PEOPLE. NEVER?

FRANK KRYTE WAS THE RIDDLES' GARDENER. HE LIVED ALONE IN A
RUN-DOWN COTTAGE IN THE RIDDLE FAMILIAR GREENLANDS. FRANK HAD
COME BACK FROM THE WAR WITH A VERY STIFF LEG AND A GREAT DISLIKE
OF TREES AND WILD BEES, AND HAD BEEN WORKING FOR THE
RIDDLES EVER SINCE.

THERE WAS A RUSH THE DAY THE ~~THEY~~ DRINKS, AND HEAR MORE
DETAILS.

ALLDAY'S THOUGHT HE WAS HED, SHE TOLD THE EAGERLY LISTENING
VILLAGERS, AFTER HER FORTIETH SHERRY. UNFRIENDLY, LIKE, I'M SURE IF
I VE OFFERED HIM A CLIPPA HENCE, I VE OFFERED IT A HUNDRED TIMES.
NEVER WANTED THE MIX, HE DIDN'T.

AND NEEL, SAID A WOMAN AT THE BAR, HE HAD A HARD WAR,
FRANK, HE LIKES THE QUIET LIFE, THAT'S ONE REASON THE
WOMAN ELSE HAD A KEY TO THE BACK DOOR, THEN? BARRED THE
DOOR. THERE'S BEEN A SPARE KEY HANGING IN THE GARDENER'S
COTTAGE FOR AS LONG AS I CAN REMEMBER. NOBODY FORCED THE DOOR
LAST NIGHT. NO BROKEN WINDOWS. ALL FRANK HAD TO DO WAS CREEP
UP TO THE BIG HOUSE WHILE WE WAS ALL SLEEPING ...

THE VILLAGERS EXCHANGED DARK LOOKS.

I ALWAYS THOUGHT HE HAD A NASTY LOOK ABOUT HIM, RIGHT
ENOUGH, GRANTED A MAN AT THE BAR.

WAR TURNED HIM FLINDY, IF YOU ASK ME, SAID THE LANDLORD.

THE RIDDLE HOUSE ?

THAT'S WHY I WOULDN'T LIKE TO GET ON THE WRONG SIDE OF FRANK,
DIDN'T I, DIT? SAID AN EXCITED WOMAN IN THE CORNER.

HORRIBLE TEMPER, SAID DIT, NODDING FERVENTLY, I REMEMBER,
WHEN HE WAS A BOY ...

BY THE FOLLOWING MORNING, HARDLY ANYONE IN LITTLE HANGLETON
Doubted THAT FRANK RYCE HAD KILLED THE RIDDLES.

BUT EVER IN THE NEIGHBORING TOWN OF GREAT HANGLETON, IN
THE DARK AND DIRTY POLICE STATION, FRANK WAS STEADILY
REPEATING, AGAIN AND AGAIN, THAT HE WAS INNOCENT, AND THAT THE
ONLY PERSON HE HAD SEEN NEAR THE HOUSE ON THE DAY OF THE
RIDDLES' DEATHS HAD BEEN A TEENAGE BOY, A STRANGER, DARK-HAIRED
AND PALE. NOBODY ELSE IN THE VILLAGE HAD SEEN ANY SUCH BOY,
AND THE POLICE WERE QUITE SURE THAT FRANK HAD INVENTED HIM.
THEN, JUST WHEN THINGS WERE LOOKING VERY SERIOUS FOR FRANK,

THE REPORT IN THE RIDDLES KHIDIS CAME BACK AND CHANGED EVERYTHING.

THE POLICE HAD NEVER READ AN HODER REPORT. A TEAM OF DOCTORS HAD EXAMINED THE KHIDIS, AND HAD CONCLUDED THAT

NONE OF THE RIDDLES HAD BEEN POISONED, STABBED, SEET, STRANGLED, SUFFOCATED OR (AS FAR AS THEY COULD TELL) HARMED AT ALL. IN

FACT, THE REPORT CONTINUED, IN A TONE OF UNMISTAKABLE BELIEFMENT, THE RIDDLES ALL APPEARED TO BE IN PERFECT HEALTH. APART

FROM THE FACT THAT THEY WERE ALL DEAD, THE DOCTORS DID NOTE (AS THOUGH DETERMINED TO FIND SOMETHING WRONG WITH THE KHIDIS) THAT EACH OF THE RIDDLES HAD A LOOK OF TERROR UPON HIS OR HER FACE. BUT AS THE FRUSTRATED POLICE SAID, WHATEVER HEARD OF THREE PEOPLE BEING FRIGHTENED TO DEATH?

AS THERE WAS NO PROOF THAT THE RIDDLES HAD BEEN MURDERED AT ALL, THE POLICE WERE FORCED TO LET FRANK GO. THE RIDDLES WERE BURIED IN THE LITTLE HANGLETON CHURCHYARD, AND THEIR GRAVES REMAINED OBJECTS OF CURIOSITY FOR A WHILE. TO EVERYONE'S SURPRISE, AND AMIDST A CLOUD OF SUSPICION, FRANK ROYCE RETURNED TO HIS COTTAGE IN THE GREENS OF THE RIDDLE HILLS.

AS FAR AS I'M CONCERNED, HE KILLED THEM, AND I DON'T CARE WHAT THE POLICE SAY, SAID DEET IN THE HANGED MAN. AND IF HE

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HAD ANY DECENCY, HE'D LEAVE HERE, DRINKING AS MUCH BEER AS

HE DID IT.

BUT FRANK DID NOT LEAVE. HE STAYED TO TEND THE GARDEN FOR THE NEXT FAMILY WHO LIVED IN THE RIDDLE HOUSE, AND THEN THE NEXT FOR NEITHER FAMILY STAYED LONG. PERHAPS IT WAS PARTLY BECAUSE OF FRANK THAT EACH NEW OWNER SAID THERE WAS A NASTY FEELING ABOUT THE PLACE, WHICH, IN THE ABSENCE OF INHABITANTS, STARTED TO FALL INTO DISREPAIR.

*

THE WEALTHY MAN WHO OWNED THE RIDDLE HOUSE THESE DAYS NEITHER LIVED THERE NOR PUT IT TO ANY USE; THEY SAID IN THE VILLAGE THAT HE KEPT IT FOR TAX REASONS, THOUGH NEBHDY WAS VERY CLEAR WHAT THESE MIGHT BE. THE WEALTHY OWNER CONTINUED TO PAY FRANK TO DO THE GARDENING, HOWEVER, FRANK WAS NEARING HIS SEVENTY-SEVENTH BIRTHDAY NOW, VERY DEAR, HIS BAD LEG STIFFER THAN EVER, BUT HE WOULD BE SEEN PLOTTING AROUND THE FLOWERS IN FINE WEATHER, EVEN THOUGH THE WEEDS WERE STARTING TO CREEP UP ON HIM.

WEEDS WERE NOT THE ONLY THINGS FRANK HAD TO CONTEND WITH, EITHER. KIDS FROM THE VILLAGE MADE A HABIT OF THROWING STONES THROUGH THE WINDOWS OF THE RIDDLE HOUSE. THEY RODE THEIR BICYCLES OVER THE LAWN; FRANK WISHED HE HAD THE DEEP SMILETH, HENCE HE TWICE, THEY RODE INTO THE OLD HOUSE FOR A DARE. THEY KNEW THAT OLD FRANK WAS DEVOTED TO THE HOUSE AND GARDENS, AND IT AMUSED THEM TO SEE HIM LIMPING ACROSS THE GARDEN, BRANDISHING HIS STICK AND YELLING CREABLY AT THEM. FRANK, ON HIS PART, BELIEVED THE KIDS TORMENTED HIM BECAUSE THEY, LIKE

THEIR PARENTS AND GRANDPARENTS, THOUGHT HIM A MURDERER. SHE
WHEN FRANK AWOKE ONE NIGHT IN AUGUST, AND SAW SOMETHING
VERY HOT UP AT THE OLD FENCE, HE MERELY ASSUMED THAT THE
BOYS HAD GONE ONE STEP FURTHER IN THEIR ATTEMPTS TO PUNISH HIM.
IT WAS FRANK'S BAD LEG THAT WROTE HIM; IT WAS PAINING HIM

WORSER THAN EVER IN HIS OLD AGE. HE GOT UP AND LIMPED DOWN-
STAIRS INTO THE KITCHEN, WITH THE IDEA OF RE-FILLING HIS HOT-WATER
KETTLE THE EASE THE STIFFNESS IN HIS BACK. STANDING AT THE SINK, FILL-

THE RIDDLE FENCE 11

ING THE KETTLE, HE LOOKED UP AT THE RIDDLE FENCE AND SAW LIGHTS
GLIMMERING IN ITS UPPER WINDOWS. FRANK KNEW AT ONCE WHAT
WAS GOING ON. THE BOYS HAD CROOKED INTO THE FENCE AGAIN, AND
JUDGING BY THE FLICKERING QUALITY OF THE LIGHT, THEY HAD STARTED A
FIRE.

FRANK HAD NO TELEPHONE, AND IN ANY CASE, HE HAD DEEPLY
MISTRUSTED THE POLICE EVER SINCE THEY HAD TAKEN HIM IN FOR
WITNESSING ABOUT THE RIDDLE'S DEATHS. HE PUT DOWN THE KETTLE
AT ONCE, HURRIED BACK UPSTAIRS AS FAST AS HIS BAD LEG WOULD
ALLOW, AND WAS SEEN BACK IN HIS KITCHEN, FULLY DRESSED AND
REMOVING A RUSTY OLD KEY FROM ITS HOLE BY THE DOOR. HE PICKED
UP HIS WALKING STICK, WHICH WAS PROPPED AGAINST THE WALL, AND
SET OFF INTO THE NIGHT.

THE FRONT DOOR OF THE RIDDLE FENCE BEHOLD NO SIGN OF BEING
FORCED, AND WHEN HE DID ANY OF THE WINDOWS, FRANK LIMPED AROUND

THE THE BACK OF THE FENCE UNTIL HE REACHED A DOOR ALMOST COMPLETELY HIDDEN BY IVY, THEN HE TOOK THE OLD KEY, PUT IT INTO THE LOCK

AND OPENED THE DOOR NEARLY SILENTLY.

HE HAD LET HIMSELF INTO THE LAVERNE'S KITCHEN, FRANK HAD NOT ENTERED IT FOR MANY YEARS; NEVERTHELESS, ALTHOUGH IT WAS VERY DARK, HE REMEMBERED WHERE THE DOOR INTO THE HALL WAS, AND HE CREEPED HIS WAY TOWARDS IT, HIS NOSTRILS FULL OF THE SMELL OF DECAY, EARS PRICKED FOR ANY SOUND OF FOOTSTEPS OR VOICES FROM OVERHEAD. HE REACHED THE HALL, WHICH WAS A LITTLE LIGHTER BEHIND THE THE LARGE MILLIONED WINDOWS EITHER SIDE OF THE FRONT DOOR, AND STARTED THE CLIMB THE STAIRS, MISSING THE BLIST WHICH WAS THERE WHEN THE STONE, BECAUSE IT MISSED THE SOUND OF HIS FEET AND STICK.

IN THE LANDING, FRANK TURNED RIGHT, AND SAW AT ONCE WHERE THE INTRUDERS WERE: AT THE VERY END OF THE PASSAGE A DOOR STOOD Ajar, AND A FLICKERING LIGHT SHONE THROUGH THE GAP, CASTING A LONG SILVER OF GLOW ACROSS THE BLACK FLOOR. FRANK EGED CLOSER AND CLOSER, GRASPING HIS WALKING STICK FIRMLY. SEVERAL FEET FROM THE ENTRANCE, HE WAS ABLE TO SEE A NARROW SLICE OF THE ROOM BEYOND.

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THE FIRE, HE NOW SAW, HAD BEEN LIT IN THE GRATE. THIS SURPRISED HIM. HE STOPPED MOVING AND LISTENED INTENTLY, FOR A MAN'S VOICE SPoke WITHIN THE ROOM; IT SOUNDED TIMID AND

FEARFUL.

THERE IS A LITTLE MORE IN THE BOTTLE, MY LORD, IF YOU ARE STILL
HUNGRY.

LATER, SAID A SECOND VEHICLE. THIS, THEN, RESEMBLED THE A MAN
BUT IT WAS STRANGELY HIGH-PITCHED, AND CAME AS A SUDDEN BLAST OF
ITS WIND. SOMETHING ABOUT THAT VEHICLE MADE THE SPARSE HAIRS ON
THE BACK OF FRANK'S NECK STAND UP. MOVE ME CLOSER TO THE FIRE,
WHIRTAIL.

FRANK TURNED HIS RIGHT EAR TOWARDS THE DEER, THE BETTER TO
HEAR. THERE CAME THE SOUND OF A BOTTLE BEING PLACED DOWN UPON
SOME HARD SURFACE, AND THEN THE DULL SCRAPING NOISE OF A HEAVY
CHAIR BEING DRAGGED ACROSS THE FLOOR. FRANK CAUGHT A GLIMPSE OF
A SMALL MAN, HIS BACK TO THE DEER, PUSHING THE CHAIR INTO PLACE.
HE WAS WEARING A LONG BLACK CLOAK, AND THERE WAS A BALD PATCH
AT THE BACK OF HIS HEAD. THEN HE DISAPPEARED FROM SIGHT AGAIN.
WHERE IS NAGINI? SAID THE CHILD VEHICLE.

I DON'T KNOW, MY LORD, SAID THE FIRST VEHICLE NERVOUSLY.
SHE SET OUT TO EXPLORE THE FOREST, I THINK ...

YOU WILL MISS HER BEFORE WE RETIRE, WHIRTAIL, SAID THE
SECOND VEHICLE. I WILL NEED FEEDING IN THE NIGHT. THE JOURNEY HAS
TIRED ME GREATLY.

BEHOLD FURROWED, FRANK INCLINED HIS GOOD EAR STILL CLOSER TO
THE DEER, LISTENING VERY HARD. THERE WAS A PAUSE, AND THEN THE
MAN CALLED WHIRTAIL SPOKE AGAIN.

MY LORD, MAY I ASK HOW LONG WE ARE GOING TO STAY HERE?

A WEEK, SAID THE CHILD VEHICLE. PERHAPS LONGER. THE PLACE IS
MODERATELY COMFORTABLE, AND THE PLAN CANNOT PROCEED YET. IT

WOULD BE FULFILLED THE ACT BEFORE THE FLIDDITCH WERLD CLIP IS
EVER.

FRANK INSERTED A CRAWLED FINGER INTO HIS EAR AND RETATED IT.
HEARING, NOT BELIEVING, THE A FLIDD-LIP OF EARLWAX, HE HAD HEARD THE
WERLD FLIDDITCH, WHICH WAS NOT A WERLD AT ALL.

THE RIDDLE BEHIND IS

THE THE FLIDDITCH WERLD CLIP, MY LORD? SAID WHERMTAIL.
FRANK DUG HIS FINGER STILL MORE VIGOROUSLY INTO HIS EAR.
FORGIVE ME, BUT I DO NOT UNDERSTAND WHY SHOULD WE WAIT
UNTIL THE WERLD CLIP IS EVER?

BECAUSE, FIRST, AT THIS VERY MOMENT WIZARDS ARE PEELING INTO
THE COUNTRY FROM ALL OVER THE WERLD, AND EVERY MEDDLER FROM
THE MINISTRY OF MAGIC WILL BE ON DUTY, ON THE WATCH FOR SIGNS OF
UNLAWFUL ACTIVITY, CHECKING AND DOUBLE-CHECKING IDENTITIES.
THEY WILL BE OBSESSED WITH SECURITY, LEST THE MUGGLES NOTICE
ANYTHING. SO WE WAIT.

FRANK STOPPED TRYING TO CLEAR HIS EAR BUT, HE HAD DISTINCTLY
HEARD THE WORDS MINISTRY OF MAGIC, WIZARDS AND MUGGLES.
PLAINLY, EACH OF THESE EXPRESSIONS MEANT SOMETHING SECRET, AND
FRANK COULD THINK OF ONLY TWO SORTS OF PEOPLE WHO WOULD
SPREAD IN THIS SPIES AND CRIMINALS. FRANK TIGHTENED HIS HOLD
ON HIS WALKING STICK EVEN MORE, AND LISTENED MORE CLOSELY STILL.

YOUR LORDSHIP IS STILL DETERMINED, THEN? WHERMTAIL SAID
QUIETLY.

CERTAINLY I AM DETERMINED, WHERMTAIL. THERE WAS A NOTE OF
MENACE IN THE CHILD VOICE NOW.

A SLIGHT PALISE FOLLOWED AND THEN WHIRTAIL SPEED, THE
WORDS TUMBLING FROM HIM IN A RUSH, AS THOUGH HE WAS PERKING
HIMSELF TO SAY THIS BEFORE HE LOST HIS NERVE.

IT COULD BE DONE WITHOUT HARRY POTTER, MY LORD.

ANOTHER PALISE, MORE PROTRACTED, AND THEN

WITHOUT HARRY POTTER? BREATHED THE SECOND VOICE SHORTLY. I
SEE ...

MY LORD, I DO NOT SAY THIS BECAUSE OF CONCERN FOR THE KING, SAID
WHIRTAIL, HIS VOICE RISING SULKILY. THE KING IS NOTHING TO ME,
NOTHING AT ALL! IT IS MERELY THAT IF WE WERE THE LIKE ANOTHER WITCH
OR WIZARD AND WIZARD THE THING COULD BE DONE SO MUCH
MORE EASILY! IF YOU ALLOWED ME TO LEAVE YOU FOR A SHORT WHILE

YOU KNOW THAT I CAN DISGUISE MYSELF MOST EFFECTIVELY I
COULD BE BACK HERE IN AS LITTLE AS TWO DAYS WITH A SUITABLE
PERSON

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I COULD USE ANOTHER WIZARD, SAID THE SECOND VOICE SHORTLY,
THAT IS TRUE ...

MY LORD, IT MAKES SENSE, SAID WHIRTAIL, SOUNDING
TEHRILGLY RELIEVED NOW, LAYING HANDS ON HARRY POTTER WHO
BE SO DIFFICULT, HE IS SO WELL PROTECTED

AND SO YOU WOULD WINTER THE GO AND FETCH ME A SUBSTITUTION? I

WONDER ... PERHAPS THE TASK OF NURSING ME HAS BECOME WEARI-
SOME FOR YOU, WHIRTAIL? COULD THIS SUGGESTION OF ABANDONING

THE PLAN BE NOTHING MORE THAN AN ATTEMPT TO DEFEAT ME?

MY LORD: I I HAVE NO WISH TO LEAVE YOU, NONE AT ALL

DO NOT LET ME MISSED THE SECOND VEHICLE. I CAN ALWAYS TELL,

WHEN I SEE YOU FLINCH WHEN YOU LOOK AT ME, FEEL YOU

SHIVER WHEN YOU TOUCH ME ...

NO? MY DEVOTION TO YOUR LORDSHIP

YOUR DEVOTION IS NOTHING MORE THAN CHIVALRY, YOU WOULD

NOT BE HERE IF YOU HAD ANYWHERE ELSE TO GO. HOW AM I THE

SURVIVOR WITHOUT YOU, WHEN I NEED FEEDING EVERY FEW HOURS?

WHAT IS THE MILD MAGINI?

BUT YOU SEEM SO MUCH STRONGER, MY LORD

Liar, CREATED THE SECOND VEHICLE. I AM NO STRONGER, AND A FEW

DAYS ALONE WOULD BE ENOUGH TO TAKE ME OF THE LITTLE HEALTH I

HAVE REGAINED UNDER YOUR CLOUTY CARE. SILENCE?

WHEN I HAD BEEN SPILLING INHERENTLY, FEEL SILENT

AT ONCE, FOR A FEW SECONDS, FRANK WOULD HEAR NOTHING BUT THE

FIRE CRACKLING. THEN THE SECOND MAN SPEAK ONCE MORE, IN A

WHISPER THAT WAS ALMOST A HISS.

I HAVE MY REASONS FOR USING THE KEY, AS I HAVE ALREADY

EXPLAINED TO YOU, AND I WILL USE THEM EITHER. I HAVE WAITED

THIRTEEN YEARS, A FEW MORE MONTHS WILL MAKE NO DIFFERENCE. AS

FOR THE PROTECTION SURROUNDING THE KEY, I BELIEVE MY PLAN WILL

BE EFFECTIVE. ALL THAT IS NEEDED IS A LITTLE COURAGE FROM YOU,

WHEN I SEE YOU FLINCH WHEN YOU LOOK AT ME, FEEL YOU

SHIVER WHEN YOU TOUCH ME ...

MY LORD, I MUST SPEAK: SAID WHENTAIL, PANIC IN HIS VOICE

THE RIDDLE FEELS IS

NEH. ALL THROUGH HER JOURNEY I HAVE BEEN OVER THE PLAN IN MY
HEAD. MY LORD, KERTHA JORDINS'S DISAPPEARANCE WILL NOT BE
UNNOTICED FOR LONG, AND IF WE PROCEED, IF I DARE

IT, I WHISPERED THE SECOND VOICE. IF I WILL FOLLOW THE PLAN,
WHIRTAIL, THE MINISTRY NEED NEVER KNOW THAT ANYONE ELSE HAS
DISAPPEARED. YOU WILL DO IT QUIETLY, AND WITHOUT FLISS; I ONLY
WISH THAT I COULD DO IT MYSELF, BUT IN MY PRESENT CONDITION ...
COME, WHIRTAIL, HERE MORE OBSTACLE REMOVED AND HER PATH THE
HARRY POTTER IS CLEAR. I AM NOT ASKING YOU TO DO IT ALONE. BY
THAT TIME, MY FAITHFUL SERVANT WILL HAVE REFINED US

I AM A FAITHFUL SERVANT, SAID WHIRTAIL, THE FINEST TRACE OF
SLICKNESS IN HIS VOICE.

WHIRTAIL, I NEED SOMEONE WITH BRAINS, SOMEONE WHOSE
LOYALTY HAS NEVER WAVED, AND YOU, UNFORTUNATELY, FLIP
NEITHER REQUIREMENT.

I FEELING YOU, SAID WHIRTAIL, AND THERE WAS DEFINITELY A SLICK
EDGE TO HIS VOICE NEH. I WAS THE ONE WHO FEELING YOU. I KNOW
YOU KERTHA JORDINS.

THAT IS TRUE, SAID THE SECOND MAN, SOUNDING AMUSED. A
STROKE OF BRILLIANCE I WOULD NOT HAVE THOUGHT POSSIBLE FROM
YOU, WHIRTAIL. THOUGH, IF TRUTH BE TOLD, YOU WERE NOT AWARE
HOW USEFUL SHE WOULD BE WHEN YOU CALLED HER, WERE YOU?

I I THOUGHT SHE MIGHT BE USEFUL, MY LORD
LAD, SAID THE SECOND VOICE AGAIN, THE COLD AMUSEMENT
MORE PROMINENT THAN EVER. HOWEVER, I DO NOT DENY THAT HER

INFORMATION WAS INVARIABLE. WITHOUT IT, I COULD NEVER HAVE
FORMED HIS PLAN, AND FOR THAT, YOU WILL HAVE YOUR REWARD,
WHIRTAIL. I WILL ALLOW YOU TO PERFORM AN ESSENTIAL TASK FOR ME,
BUT THAT MANY OF MY FOLLOWERS WOULD GIVE THEIR RIGHT HANDS TO
PERFORM ...

REALLY, MY LORD? WHAT ? WHIRTAIL SEEMED TERRIFIED
AGAIN.

AND WHIRTAIL, YOU DON'T WANT ME TO SPILL THE SURPRISE? YOUR
PART WILL COME AT THE VERY END ... BUT I PROMISE YOU, YOU WILL
HAVE THE HONOUR OF BEING LIST AS LOYAL AS BERTHA JORDANS.

HE HADY PEEETTER

YOU ... YOU ... WHIRTAIL'S VOICE SEEMED SUDDENLY HARSH, AS
THOUGH HIS MOUTH HAD GONE VERY DRY. YOU ... ARE GOING ... TO KILL
ME, THEN?

WHIRTAIL, WHIRTAIL, SAID THE OLD VOICE SILENTLY, WHY WOULD
I KILL YOU? I KILLED BERTHA BECAUSE I HAD THE. SHE WAS FIT FOR

NOTHING AFTER MY ELDESTINGING, WHITE LIPSLESS. IN ANY CASE, AWARD
WARD ELDESTINGS WOULD HAVE BEEN ASKED IF SHE HAD GONE BACK TO

THE MINISTRY WITH THE NEWS THAT SHE HAD MET YOU ON HER HOLIDAYS,
WIZARDS WHO ARE SUPPOSED TO BE DEAD WOULD BE WELL MEET

THE RUMOR IN THE MINISTRY OF MAGIC WITCHES AT WAYSIDE INNS ...

WHIRTAIL MUTTERED SOMETHING SHE ELIETLY THAT FRANK COULD
NEARLY HEAR IT, BUT IT MADE THE SECOND MAN LAUGH AN ENTIRELY

MIRTHLESS LAUGH, CHILD AS HIS SPEECH.

WHE WOULD HAVE MODIFIED HER MEMORIES? BUT MEMORY CHARMS

CAN BE BROKEN BY A POWERFUL WIZARD, AS I PROVED WHEN I ELUCIDATED HER. IT WOULD BE AN INSULT TO HER MEMORIES NOT TO USE THE

INFORMATION I EXTRACTED FROM HER, WHERTAIL.

ELT IN THE CARRIAGE, FRANK SUDDENLY BECAME AWARE THAT THE HAND GRIPPING HIS WALKING STICK WAS SLIPPERY WITH SWEAT. THE MAN WITH THE CHILD VEHICLE HAD KILLED A WOMAN. HE WAS TALKING ABOUT IT WITH ELT AND KIND OF REMORSE WITH AMUSEMENT. HE WAS DANGEROUS A MADMAN, AND HE WAS PLANNING MORE MURDERS THIS EVENING, HARRY PETER, WHEREVER HE WAS WAS IN DANGER

FRANK KNEW WHAT HE MUST DO. NOW, IF EVER, WAS THE TIME TO GO TO THE POLICE. HE WOULD CREEP OUT OF THE HOUSE AND HEAD STRAIGHT FOR THE TELEPHONE BOOTH IN THE VILLAGE ... BUT THE CHILD VEHICLE WAS SPEAKING AGAIN, AND FRANK REMAINED WHERE HE WAS, FREEZING TO THE SPOT, LISTENING WITH ALL HIS MIGHT.

HERE MORE CLOSE ... MY FAITHFUL SERVANT AT FEEGLARTS ...

HARRY PETER IS AS GOOD AS MINE, WHERTAIL. IT IS DECIDED. THERE WILL BE NO MORE ARGUMENT. BUT ELIOT ... I THINK I HEAR NAGINI ...

AND THE SECOND MAN'S VEHICLE CHANGED. HE STARTED MAKING NOISES SUCH AS FRANK HAD NEVER HEARD BEFORE. HE WAS HISsing

THE RIDDLE HOUSE 19

AND SPITTING WITH-HELT DRAWING BREATH, FRANK THOUGHT HE MUST
BE HAVING SOME SORT OF FIT OR SEIZURE.

AND THEN FRANK HEARD MOVEMENT BEHIND HIM IN THE DARK
PASSAGEWAY, HE TURNED THE HEAD BEHIND HIM, AND FELT HIMSELF
PARALYSED WITH FRIGHT.

SOMETHING WAS SLITHERING TOWARDS HIM ALONG THE DARK TERRI-
BLE FLOOR, AND AS IT DREW NEARER THE THE SLIVER OF FIRELIGHT, HE

REALISED WITH A THRILL OF TERROR THAT IT WAS A GIANTIC SNAKE, AT
LEAST TWELVE FEET LONG, TERRIFIED, TRANSFIXED, FRANK STARED AT IT
AS ITS UNDULATING BODY CUT A WIDE, CURVING TRACK THROUGH THE
THICK DUST ON THE FLOOR, COMING CLOSER AND CLOSER WHAT WAS HE
TO DO? THE ONLY MEANS OF ESCAPE WAS INTO THE ROOM WHERE TWO
MEN SAT PLOTTING MURDER, YET IF HE STAYED WHERE HE WAS THE
SNAKE WOULD SURELY KILL HIM

BUT BEFORE HE HAD MADE HIS DECISION, THE SNAKE WAS LEVEL
WITH HIM, AND THEN, INCREDIBLY, MIRACULOUSLY, IT WAS PASSING; IT
WAS FOLLOWING THE SPITTING, HISSING WHISLES MADE BY THE CHILD

WHICH BEYOND THE DOOR, AND IN SECONDS, THE TIP OF ITS DIAMOND-
PATTERNED TAIL HAD VANISHED THROUGH THE GAP.

THERE WAS SWEAT ON FRANK'S FOREHEAD NOW, AND THE HAND ON
THE WALKING STICK WAS TREMBLING, INSIDE THE ROOM, THE CHILD
WHICH WAS CONTINUING THE HISS, AND FRANK WAS VISITED BY A
STRANGE IDEA, AN IMPOSSIBLE IDEA ... THIS MAN COULD TAKE THE

SNAKES.

FRANK DIDN'T UNDERSTAND WHAT WAS GOING ON. HE WANTED MORE THAN ANYTHING TO BE BACK IN HIS BED WITH HIS FEET-WATER BOTTLE. THE PROBLEM WAS THAT HIS LEGS DIDN'T SEEM TO WANT TO MOVE. AS HE STOOD THERE SHAKING, AND TRYING TO MASTER HIMSELF, THE CHILD VOICE SWITCHED ABRUPTLY TO ENGLISH AGAIN.

NAGINI HAS INTERESTING NEWS, WHERMTAIL. IT SAID,

IN-IND-DEED, MY LORD? SAID WHERMTAIL.

INDEED, YES, SAID THE VOICE. ACCORDING TO NAGINI, THERE IS AN OLD MUGGLE STANDING RIGHT OUTSIDE THIS ROOM, LISTENING TO EVERY WORD WE SAY.

FRANK DIDN'T HAVE A CHANCE TO HIDE HIMSELF. THERE WERE

18 HARRY POTTER

FOOTSTEPS, AND THEN THE DOOR OF THE ROOM WAS FLUNG WIDE OPEN. A SHORT, BALDING MAN WITH GREYING HAIR, A PAINTED NOSE AND SMALL, WATERY EYES STOOD BEFORE FRANK, A MIXTURE OF FEAR AND ALARM ON HIS FACE.

INVITE HIM INSIDE, WHERMTAIL. WHERE ARE YOUR MANNERS?

THE CHILD VOICE WAS COMING FROM THE ANCIENT ARMCHAIR BEFORE THE FIRE, BUT FRANK COULDN'T SEE THE SPEAKER. THE SNAKE, ON THE OTHER HAND, WAS COILED UP ON THE BURNING HEARTH-RUG, LIKE SOME HORRIBLE TRAVESTY OF A PET DRAGON.

WHERMTAIL RECOGNIZED FRANK INTO THE ROOM. THOUGH STILL DEEPLY SHAKEN, FRANK TOOK A FIRMER GRIP UPON HIS WALKING STICK, AND LIMPED OVER THE THRESHOLD.

THE FIRE WAS THE ONLY SOURCE OF LIGHT IN THE ROOM; IT WAS CAST-
ING LONG, SPIDERY SHADOWS UPON THE WALLS, FRANK STARED AT THE

BACK OF THE ARMCHAIR; THE MAN INSIDE IT SEEMED TO BE EVEN
SMALLER THAN HIS SERVANT, FOR FRANK COULDN'T EVEN SEE THE BACK
OF HIS HEAD.

YELL HEARD EVERYTHING, MUGGER? SAID THE CHILD VOICE.

WHAT IS THAT YELL YOU'RE CALLING ME? SAID FRANK DEFIANTLY, FOR WHEN
THAT HE WAS INSIDE THE ROOM, WHEN THAT THE TIME HAD COME FOR
SOME SORT OF ACTION, HE FELT BRAVER; IT HAD ALWAYS BEEN SO IN THE
WAR.

I AM CALLING YOU A MUGGER, SAID THE VOICE CHEERLY. IT MEANS
THAT YOU ARE NOT A WIZARD.

I DON'T KNOW WHAT YOU MEAN BY WIZARD, SAID FRANK, HIS
VOICE GROWING STEADIER. ALL I KNOW IS I'VE HEARD ENOUGH THE
INTEREST THE POLICE TONIGHT, I HAVE. YOU'VE DONE MURDER AND
YOU'RE PLANNING MORE; AND I'LL TELL YOU THIS, THEN, HE ADDED, WITH
A SUDDEN INSPIRATION, MY WIFE KNOWS I'M UP HERE, AND IF I
DON'T COME BACK

YOU HAVE NO WIFE, SAID THE CHILD VOICE, VERY QUIETLY. NEKKED
KNOWS YOU ARE HERE, YOU TOLD NEKKED THAT YOU WERE COMING.
DO NOT LIE TO LORD VERDERBERT, MUGGER, FOR HE KNOWS ... HE
ALWAYS KNOWS ...

IS THAT RIGHT? SAID FRANK RELUCTANTLY. LORD, IS IT? WELL, I DON'T

THE RIDDLE FEELS 17

THINK MUCH OF YOUR MANNERS, MY LORD. TURN BEHIND AND FACE ME

LIKE A MAN, WHY DIDN'T YOU?

BUT I AM NOT A MAN, MUGGLE, SAID THE CHILD VOICE, BARELY
AUDIBLE WHEN EVER THE CRACKLING OF THE FLAMES. I AM MUCH,
MUCH MORE THAN A MAN, HOWEVER ... WHY NOT? I WILL FACE YOU
... WERTAIL, THEN TURN MY CHAIR AROUND.

THE SERVANT GAVE A WHIMPER.

YOU HEARD ME, WERTAIL.

SILENTLY, WITH HIS FACE SKEWED UP, AS THOUGH HE WOULD RATHER

HAVE DONE ANYTHING THAN APPROACH HIS MASTER AND THE HEART-
RUE WHERE THE SNAKE LAY, THE SMALL MAN WALKED FORWARDS AND

BEGAN TO TURN THE CHAIR. THE SNAKE LIFTED ITS LELY TRIANGULAR
HEAD AND HISSED SLIGHTLY AS THE LEGS OF THE CHAIR SNAGGED ON ITS
RUE.

AND THEN THE CHAIR WAS FACING FRANK, AND HE SAW WHAT WAS
SITTING IN IT. HIS WALKING STICK FELL TO THE FLOOR WITH A CLATTER. HE
OPENED HIS MOUTH AND LET OUT A SCREAM. HE WAS SCREAMING SO
LOUDLY THAT HE NEVER HEARD THE WORDS THE THING IN THE CHAIR
SPoke, AS IT RAISED A HAND. THERE WAS A FLASH OF GREEN LIGHT, A
BLISHING SOUND, AND FRANK BOYCE CRUMPLED. HE WAS DEAD BEFORE
HE HIT THE FLOOR.

TWO HUNDRED MILES AWAY, THE KING CALLED HARRY PETER WAKE
WITH A START.

CHAPTER THREE

THE SCAR

HARRY LAY FLAT ON HIS BACK, BREATHING HARD AS THOUGH HE HAD BEEN RUNNING. HE HAD AWOKEN FROM A VIVID DREAM WITH HIS HANDS PRESSED OVER HIS FACE. THE OLD SCAR ON HIS FOREHEAD, WHICH WAS SHAPED LIKE A BOLT OF LIGHTNING, WAS BURNING BENEATH HIS FINGERS AS THOUGH SOMEONE HAD JUST PRESSED A WHITE-HOT WIRE TO HIS SKIN.

HE SAT UP, ONE HAND STILL ON HIS SCAR, THE OTHER REACHING OUT IN THE DARKNESS FOR HIS GLASSES, WHICH WERE ON THE BEDSIDE TABLE. HE PUT THEM ON AND HIS EYES OPENED UP IN CLARER FOCUS, LIT BY A FAINT, MISTY ORANGE LIGHT THAT WAS FILTERING THROUGH THE CURTAINS FROM THE STREET LAMP OUTSIDE THE WINDOW. HARRY RAN HIS FINGERS OVER THE SCAR AGAIN. IT WAS STILL PAINFUL. HE TURNED ON THE LAMP BESIDE HIM, SCRAMBLED OUT OF BED, CROSSED THE ROOM, OPENED HIS WARDROBE AND PEERED INTO THE MIRROR ON THE INSIDE OF THE DOOR. A SKINNY BOY OF FIFTEEN LOOKED BACK AT HIM, HIS BRIGHT GREEN EYES PUZZLED UNDER HIS UNTIDY BLACK HAIR. HE EXAMINED THE LIGHTNING-BOLT SCAR ON HIS REFLECTION MORE CLOSELY. IT LOOKED NORMAL, BUT IT WAS STILL STINGING.

HARRY TRIED TO RECALL WHAT HE HAD BEEN DREAMING ABOUT BEFORE HE HAD AWOKEN. IT HAD SEEMED SO REAL ... THERE HAD BEEN TWO PEOPLE HE KNEW, AND ONE HE DIDN'T ... HE CONCENTRATED HARD, FEELING, TRYING TO REMEMBER ...

THE DIM PICTURE OF A DARKENED ROOM CAME TO HIM ... THERE HAD BEEN A SHADE ON A HEARTBEAT ... A SMALL MAN CALLED PETER,

NICKNAMED WHIRTAIL ... AND A CHILD, HIGH VEIL ... THE VEIL OF

THE STAR 21

LEHD VEHDERT, FARRY FELT AS THOUGH AN ICE CLUE HAD SLIPPED
DOWN INTO HIS STOMACH AT THE VERY THING ...

HE CLOSED HIS EYES TIGHTLY AND TRIED TO REMEMBER WHAT

VEHDERT HAD LOOKED LIKE, BUT IT WAS IMPOSSIBLE ... ALL FARRY
KNEW WAS THAT AT THE MOMENT WHEN VEHDERT'S CHAIR HAD
SWUNG AROUND, AND HE, FARRY, HAD SEEN WHAT WAS SITTING IN IT,
HE HAD FELT A SPASM OF HORROR WHICH HAD ALARMED HIM ... HE HAD
THAT BEEN THE PAIN IN HIS STAR?

AND WHEN HAD THE OLD MAN BEEN? FOR THERE HAD DEFINITELY
BEEN AN OLD MAN; FARRY HAD WATCHED HIM FALL TO THE GROUND. IT
WAS ALL SEEMING CHOKED; FARRY PUT HIS FACE INTO HIS HANDS,
BLINDLY FEELING HIS BEDROOM, TRYING TO HOLD ON TO THE PICTURE OF
THAT DIMLY LIT ROOM, BUT IT WAS LIKE TRYING TO DEEP WATER IN HIS
CLIPPED HANDS; THE DETAILS WERE NOW TRICKLING AWAY AS FAST AS HE
TRIED TO HOLD ON TO THEM ... VEHDERT AND WHIRTAIL HAD BEEN
TALKING ABOUT SOMETHING THEY HAD KILLED, THOUGH FARRY COULD
NOT REMEMBER THE NAME ... AND THEY HAD BEEN PLETTING THE KILL
SOMETHING ELSE ... HIM ...

FARRY THREW HIS FACE OUT OF HIS HANDS, OPENED HIS EYES AND
STARED AROUND HIS BEDROOM AS THOUGH EXPECTING TO SEE

SOMETHING UNUSUAL THERE, AS IT HAPPENED, THERE WERE AN EXTRA-
ORDINARY NUMBER OF UNUSUAL THINGS IN THIS ROOM, A LARGE

WHEN THE TRUNKS OPENED AT THE FEET OF HIS BED, REVEALING A
CALIBRE, BROOMSTICK, BLACK BOOKS AND ASSORTED SPELLBOOKS,
ROLLS OF PARCHMENT LITTERED THAT PART OF HIS DESK THAT WAS NOT
TAKEN UP BY THE LARGE, EMPTY CASE IN WHICH HIS SNEEZY HORN,
FREDNIG, USUALLY PERCHED, HAD THE FLOOR BESIDE HIS BED A BOOK

LAY OPEN; HE HAD BEEN READING IT BEFORE HE FELL ASLEEP THE PREVI-
OUS NIGHT. THE PICTURES IN THIS BOOK WERE ALL MOVING. MEN IN

BRIGHT STRANGE BOOKS WERE ZOOMING IN AND OUT OF SIGHT ON
BROOMSTICKS, THROWING A RED BALL TO EACH OTHER.

HARRY WALKED OVER TO THIS BOOK, PICKED IT UP AND WATCHED
ONE OF THE WIZARDS SCORE A SPECTACULAR GOAL BY PLUTTING THE BALL
THROUGH A FIFTY-FOOT-HIGH HOLE. THEN HE SNAPPED THE BOOK
SHUT. EVEN FLUIDITCH IN HARRY'S OPINION, THE BEST SPORT IN THE

22 HARRY POTTER

WORLD COULDN'T DISTRACT HIM AT THE MOMENT. HE PLACED FLYING
WITH THE CANNONS ON HIS BEDSIDE TABLE, CROSSED THE TWO WINDOWS
AND DREW BACK THE CURTAINS TO SURVEY THE STREET BELOW.

PRIVET DRIVE LOOKED EXACTLY AS A RESPECTABLE SLEEKMAN STREET
WOULD BE EXPECTED TO LOOK IN THE EARLY HOURS OF SATURDAY
MORNING. ALL THE CURTAINS WERE CLOSED, AS FAR AS HARRY COULD
SEE THROUGH THE DARKNESS, THERE WASN'T A LIVING CREATURE IN
SIGHT, NOT EVEN A CAT.

AND YET ... AND YET ... HARRY WENT RESTLESSLY BACK TO HIS BED
AND SAT DOWN ON IT, RUNNING A FINGER OVER HIS SCAR AGAIN. IT

WASN'T THE PAIN THAT KILLED HIM; HARRY WAS NEITHER THE PAIN AND INJURY. HE HAD LOST ALL THE BONES FROM HIS RIGHT ARM HERE, AND HAD THEM PAINFULLY REGROWN IN A NIGHT. THE SAME ARM HAD BEEN PIERCED BY A VERNON'S SHEET-LONG FANG NOT LONG AFTERWARDS. ONLY LAST YEAR HARRY HAD FALLEN FIFTY FEET FROM AN AIRBORNE BROOMSTICK. HE WAS USED TO BIZARRE ACCIDENTS AND INJURIES; THEY WERE UNAVOIDABLE IF YOU ATTENDED HOGWARTS

SCHOOL OF WITCHCRAFT AND WIZARDRY AND HAD A DENSE AIR ATTRACTING A LOT OF TRICKLE.

NEITHER THE THING THAT WAS KILLING HARRY WAS THAT THE LAST TIME HIS SCAR HAD HURT HIM, IT HAD BEEN BECAUSE VERMOREL HAD BEEN CLOSE BY ... BUT VERMOREL COULDN'T BE HERE, NEITHER ... THE

IDEA OF VERMOREL WORKING IN PRIVET DRIVE WAS ABSURD, IMPOSSIBLE ...

HARRY LISTENED CLOSELY TO THE SILENCE AROUND HIM. WAS HE HALF EXPECTING TO HEAR THE CREAK OF A STAIR, OR THE SWISH OF A CLOAK? AND THEN HE JUMPED SLIGHTLY AS HE HEARD HIS CLOAKS DUDLEY GIVE A TREMENDOUS GRUNTING SNIFF FROM THE NEXT ROOM. HARRY SHOOK HIMSELF MENTALLY; HE WAS BEING STUPID; THERE WAS NEITHER HERE IN THE HOUSE WITH HIM EXCEPT UNCLE VERNON, AUNT PETUNIA AND DUDLEY, AND THEY WERE PLAINLY STILL ASLEEP, THEIR DREAMS UNTRICKLED AND PAINLESS.

ASLEEP WAS THE WAY HARRY LIKED THE DURSLEYS BEST; IT WASN'T

AS THOUGH THEY WERE EVER AND HELPED HIM ALONG. UNCLE
VERNON, AUNT PETUNIA AND DUDLEY WERE HARRY'S ONLY LIVING

THE SCARCE

RELATIVES. THEY WERE MUGGLES (NON-MAGIC PEOPLE) WHO HATED
AND DESPISED MAGIC IN ANY FORM, WHICH MEANT THAT HARRY WAS
AKHUT AS WELCOME IN THEIR HOUSE AS DRY RICE. THEY HAD
EXPLAINED AWAY HARRY'S LONG ABSENCES AT HOGWARTS OVER THE LAST
THREE YEARS BY TELLING EVERYONE THAT HE WENT TO THE ST BRITAIN'S

SECURE CENTRE FOR INCURABLY CRIMINAL KIDS. THEY KNEW PERFECT-
LY WELL THAT, AS AN UNDERAGE WIZARD, HARRY WASN'T ALLOWED TO

USE MAGIC OUTSIDE HOGWARTS, BUT WERE STILL APT TO BLAME HIM
FOR ANYTHING THAT WENT WRONG AROUND THE HOUSE. HARRY HAD
NEVER BEEN ABLE TO CONFIDE IN THEM, OR TELL THEM ANYTHING
ABOUT HIS LIFE IN THE WIZARDING WORLD. THE VERY IDEA OF GOING TO

THEM WHEN THEY ASKED, AND TELLING THEM ABOUT HIS SCARCE
HIM, AND ABOUT HIS WARRIORS ABOUT VERDIMENT, WAS LAUGH-
ABLE.

AND YET IT WAS BECAUSE OF VERDIMENT THAT HARRY HAD COME TO
LIVE WITH THE DURSLEYS IN THE FIRST PLACE. IF IT HADN'T BEEN FOR
VERDIMENT, HARRY WOULD NOT HAVE HAD THE LIGHTNING SCAR ON HIS
FOREHEAD. IF IT HADN'T BEEN FOR VERDIMENT, HARRY WOULD STILL
HAVE HAD PARENTS ...

LEARRY HAD BEEN A YEAR OLD THE NIGHT THAT VELDERTHE THE
MIST PHEWELK DARK WIZARD FOR A CENTURY, A WIZARD WHO HAD
BEEN GAINING POWER STEADILY FOR ELEVEN YEARS ARRIVED AT HIS
HOUSE AND KILLED HIS FATHER AND MOTHER. VELDERTHE HAD THEN
TURNED HIS HAND ON LEARRY; HE HAD PERFORMED THE CURSE THAT
HAD DEFEATED SO MANY FULL-GROWN WITCHES AND WIZARDS IN HIS
STEADY RISE TO POWER AND, INCREDIBLY, IT HAD NOT WORKED.
INSTEAD OF KILLING THE SMALL BOY, THE CURSE HAD REBORNED WITHIN

VELDERTHE. LEARRY HAD SURVIVED WITH NOTHING BUT A LIGHTNING-
SHAPED CLIT ON HIS FOREHEAD, AND VELDERTHE HAD BEEN REDUCED

TO SOMETHING BARELY ALIVE. HIS POWERS GONE, HIS LIFE ALMOST
EXTINGUISHED, VELDERTHE HAD FLED; THE TERROR IN WHICH THE
SECRET COMMUNITY OF WITCHES AND WIZARDS HAD LIVED FOR SO LONG
HAD LIFTED, VELDERTHE'S FOLLOWERS HAD DISBANDED, AND LEARRY
PETER HAD BECOME FAMOUS.

IT HAD BEEN ENOUGH OF A SHOCK FOR LEARRY THE DISCOVERER, AND HIS

24 LEARRY PETER

ELEVENTH BIRTHDAY, THAT HE WAS A WIZARD; IT HAD BEEN EVEN MORE

DISORIENTING THE FIND THAT EVERYONE IN THE HIDDEN WIZARD-
ING WORLD KNEW HIS NAME. LEARRY HAD ARRIVED AT ECHARTS THE

FIND THAT HEADS TURNED AND WHISPERS FOLLOWED HIM WHEREVER HE
WENT, BUT HE WAS USED TO IT NOW; AT THE END OF THIS SUMMER, HE

WOULD BE STARTING HIS THIRTEEN YEAR AT HOGWARTS, AND HE WAS ALREADY COUNTING THE DAYS UNTIL HE WOULD BE BACK AT THE CASTLE AGAIN.

BUT THERE WAS STILL A FEELING THAT HE KNEW HE WENT BACK THE SAME. HE LOOKED CARELESSLY AROUND HIS ROOM AGAIN, AND HIS EYE PAUSED ON THE BIRTHDAY CARDS HIS TWO BEST FRIENDS HAD SENT HIM AT THE END OF JULY. WHAT WOULD THEY SAY IF HE WROTE THEM AND TOLD THEM ABOUT HIS STAR FLUTING?

AT ONCE, HERMIONE GRANGER'S VOICE FILLED HIS HEAD, SHARP AND PANICKY.

STAR FLUTY? HARRY, THAT'S REALLY SERIOUS ... WRITE THE PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE! AND I'LL GO AND CHECK THEM FOR MAGICAL AILMENTS AND AFFLICTIONS ... MAYBE THERE'S SOMETHING IN THERE ABOUT LARGE STARS ...

YES, THAT WOULD BE HERMIONE'S ADVICE! GO STRAIGHT TO THE HEADMASTER OF HOGWARTS, AND IN THE MEANTIME, CONSULT A KID. HARRY STARED OUT OF THE WINDOW AT THE INDY, BLUE-BLACK SKY. HE BELIEVED VERY MUCH WHETHER A KID COULD HELP HIM NOT. AS FAR AS HE KNEW, HE WAS THE ONLY LIVING PERSON WHO HAD SURVIVED A LARGE LIKE VERMONT'S; IT WAS HIGHLY UNLIKELY, THEREFORE, THAT HE WOULD FIND HIS SYMPTOMS LISTED IN THEM FOR MAGICAL AILMENTS AND AFFLICTIONS. AS FOR INFORMING THE HEADMASTER, HARRY HAD NO IDEA WHERE DUMBLEDORE WENT DURING THE SUMMER HOLIDAYS. HE AMUSED HIMSELF FOR A MOMENT, PICTURING DUMBLEDORE, WITH HIS LONG SILVER BEARD, FULL-LENGTH WIZARD'S ROBES AND POINTED HAT, STRETCHED OUT ON A BEACH SOMEWHERE, BLINKING SUNTAN LOTION INTO HIS LONG CRINKLED NOSE. WHEREVER DUMBLEDORE WAS,

THOUGH, HARRY WAS SURE THAT FREDIE WOULD BE ABLE TO FIND

HIM; HARRY'S HAND HAD NEVER YET FAILED TO DELIVER A LETTER TO ANY-
ONE, EVEN WITHOUT AN ADDRESS. BUT WHAT WOULD HE WRITE?

THE SCARF

DEAR PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE, THANK YOU EITHER WAY, BUT MY SCARF
MELT THIS MORNING. YELLS SINCERELY, HARRY POTTER.
EVEN INSIDE HIS HEAD THE WORDS SEEMED STUPID,
AND HE TRIED TO IMAGINE HIS EITHER BEST FRIEND RON

WEASLEY'S REACTION, AND IN A MOMENT, RON'S LONG-NEESED, FRECK-
LED FACE SEEMED TO SWIM BEFORE HARRY, WEARING A REPULSED

EXPRESSION.

YOUR SCARF MELT? BUT ... BUT WHY-DON'T-WE CAN'T BE NEAR YOU
NOW, CAN WE? I MEAN ... YOU'D DON'T, WOULD YOU? YOU'D BE TRYING
TO BE WITHIN AGAIN, WOULD YOU? I DON'T, HARRY, MAYBE CLOSE
SCARFS ALWAYS TWINE A BIT ... I'M ASK DAD ...

MR WEASLEY WAS A FULLY QUALIFIED WIZARD WHO WORKED IN THE
DIVISION OF MISCELLANEOUS ARTIFACTS OFFICE AT THE MINISTRY OF MAGIC, BUT
HE DIDN'T HAVE ANY PARTICULAR EXPERTISE IN THE MATTER OF CLOTHES,
AS FAR AS HARRY KNEW. IN ANY CASE, HARRY DIDN'T LIKE THE IDEA OF
THE WHOLE WEASLEY FAMILY KNOWING THAT HE, HARRY, WAS GETTING
ILMPY ABOUT A FEW MOMENTS' PAIN. MRS WEASLEY WOULD FLIP

WORSER THAN HERMIONE, AND FRED AND GEORGE, RON'S SIXTEEN-

YEAR-OLD TWIN BROTHERS, MIGHT THINK HARRY WAS LOSTING HIS NERVE.

THE WEASLEYS WERE HARRY'S FAVORITE FAMILY IN THE WORLD; HE WAS HOPING THAT THEY MIGHT INVITE HIM TO STAY ANY TIME WHEN (RON HAD MENTIONED SOMETHING ABOUT THE HOLIDAY WORLD CUP), AND HE SOMEHOW DIDN'T WANT HIS VISIT PUNCTUATED WITH ANDREW'S ENQUIRIES ABOUT HIS SCAR.

HARRY KNEADED HIS FOREHEAD WITH HIS FINGERS. WHAT HE REALLY WANTED (AND IT FELT ALMOST SHAMEFUL TO ADMIT IT TO HIMSELF) WAS SOMEONE LIKE SOMEONE LIKE A PARENT: AN ADULT WIZARD WHOSE ADVICE HE COULD ASK WITHOUT FEELING STUPID, SOMEONE WHO CARED ABOUT HIM, WHO HAD HAD EXPERIENCE OF DARK MAGIC ...

AND THEN THE SOLUTION CAME TO HIM. IT WAS SO SIMPLE, AND SO OBVIOUS, THAT HE COULDN'T BELIEVE IT HAD TAKEN HIM LONG. SIRIUS. HARRY LEAPT UP FROM THE BED, HURRIED ACROSS THE ROOM AND SAT DOWN AT HIS DESK; HE PULLED A PIECE OF PARCHMENT TOWARDS HIM, LEANED HIS EAGLE-FEATHER QUILL WITH INK, WROTE DEAR SIRIUS,

DE HARRY POTTER

THEN PAUSED, WONDERING HOW BEST TO PHRASE HIS PROBLEM, AND STILL MARVELLING AT THE FACT THAT HE HADN'T THOUGHT OF SIRIUS STRAIGHT AWAY. BUT THEN, PERHAPS IT WASN'T SO SURPRISING. AFTER ALL, HE HAD ONLY BEEN TOLD THAT SIRIUS WAS HIS GODFATHER TWO MONTHS AGO.

THERE WAS A SIMPLE REASON FOR SIRIUS' COMPLETE ABSENCE FROM

HARRY'S LIFE UNTIL THEN SIRIUS HAD BEEN IN AZKABAN, THE TERRIFY-
ING WIZARD GATE GUARDED BY CREATURES CALLED DEMENTORS, SIGHT-
LESS, SULK-SUCKING FIENDS WHO HAD MADE THE SEARCH FOR SIRIUS AT

BEHLARTS WHEN HE HAD ESCAPED, YET SIRIUS HAD BEEN INNOCENT
THE MURDERS FOR WHICH HE HAD BEEN CONVICTED HAD BEEN
COMMITTED BY WHIRTAIL, VERDREHRT'S SLIPPER, WHOSE NEARLY
EVERYBODY NOW BELIEVED DEAD, HARRY, RON AND HERMIONE KNEW
OTHERWISE, HOWEVER; THEY HAD COME FACE TO FACE WITH WHIRTAIL
THE PREVIOUS YEAR, THOUGH ONLY PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE HAD
BELIEVED THEIR STORY.

FOR ONE CLEARING HOUR, HARRY HAD BELIEVED THAT HE WAS
LEAVING THE DURSLEYS AT LAST, BECAUSE SIRIUS HAD OFFERED HIM A
HOME SINCE HIS NAME HAD BEEN CLEARED, BUT THE CHANCE HAD
BEEN SNATCHED AWAY FROM HIM WHIRTAIL HAD ESCAPED BEFORE
THEY COULD TAKE HIM TO THE MINISTRY OF MAGIC, AND SIRIUS HAD
HAD TO FLEE FOR HIS LIFE, HARRY HAD HELPED HIM ESCAPE AND THE
BARK OF A SLIPPER CALLED BUCKLE, AND SINCE THEN, SIRIUS
HAD BEEN IN THE WIND, THE HOME HARRY MIGHT HAVE HAD IF
WHIRTAIL HAD NOT ESCAPED HAD BEEN HAUNTING HIM ALL SUMMER.
IT HAD BEEN DEEPLY HARD TO RETURN TO THE DURSLEYS KNOWING
THAT HE HAD NEARLY ESCAPED THEM FOR EVER.

NEVERTHELESS, SIRIUS HAD BEEN OF SOME HELP TO HARRY, EVEN IF
HE COULDN'T BE WITH HIM, IT WAS DUE TO SIRIUS THAT HARRY NOW
HAD ALL HIS SCHOOL THINGS IN HIS ROOM WITH HIM, THE
DURSLEYS HAD NEVER ALLOWED THIS BEFORE; THEIR GENERAL WISH OF
KEEPING HARRY AS MISERABLE AS POSSIBLE, HELPED WITH THEIR FEAR

OF HIS PHEWERS, HAD LED THEM THE WICK HIS SCHEM TRILIND IN THE
CLIPBOARD UNDER THE STAIRS EVERY SUMMER PRIOR THE THIS, BUT THEIR
ATTITUDE HAD CHANGED SINCE THEY HAD FEELING ELIT THAT F-JARRY HAD
THE STAR 27

A DANGEROUS MURDERER FOR A CHILDREN F-JARRY HAD CON-
VENIENTLY FORGOTTEN THE TELL THEM THAT SIRILIS WAS INNOCENT.

F-JARRY HAD RECEIVED TWO LETTERS FROM SIRILIS SINCE HE HAD BEEN
BACK AT PRIVET DRIVE, KETH HAD BEEN DELIVERED, NOT BY HILLS (AS
WAS USUAL WITH WIZARDS) BUT BY LARGE, BRIGHTLY CHEERFUL,
TROPICAL BIRDS, F-JEDWIE HAD NOT APPROVED OF THESE FLASKY
INTRUDERS, SHE HAD BEEN MOST RELUCTANT TO ALLOW THEM THE DRINK
FROM HER WATER TRAY BEFORE FLYING OFF AGAIN, F-JARRY, ON THE OTHER
HAND, HAD LIKED THEM, THEY PUT HIM IN MIND OF PALM TREES AND
WHITE SAND, AND HE HOPED THAT WHEREVER SIRILIS WAS (SIRILIS

NEVER SAID, IN CASE THE LETTERS WERE INTERCEPTED) HE WAS ENJOY-
ING HIMSELF, HOWEVER, F-JARRY FEELING IT HARD TO IMAGINE

DEMENTERS SURVIVING FOR LONG IN BRIGHT SUNLIGHT, PERHAPS THAT
WAS WHY SIRILIS HAD GIVEN SEETH, SIRILIS LETTERS, WHICH WERE NOW
HIDDEN BENEATH THE HIGHLY USEFUL WHESE SHEETBOARD UNDER
F-JARRY'S BED, SEETHED CHEERFULLY, AND IN KETH OF THEM HE HAD
REMINDING F-JARRY TO CALL ON HIM IF EVER F-JARRY NEEDED THE, WELL,
HE NEEDED THE NOW, ALL RIGHT ...

HARRY'S LAMP SEEMED THE GREEN DIMMER AS THE CHILD GREY LIGHT
THAT PRECEDES SUNRISE SILENTLY CREEPT INTO THE ROOM. FINALLY, WHEN
THE SUN HAD RISEN, WHEN HIS BEDROOM WALLS HAD TURNED
CHILD AND WHEN SOUNDS OF MOVEMENT COULD BE HEARD FROM
UNCLE VERNON AND AUNT PETUNIA'S ROOM, HARRY CLEARED HIS DESK
OF CRUMPLED PIECES OF PARCHMENT, AND RE-READ HIS FINISHED
LETTER.

DEAR SIRIUS,

THANKS FOR YOUR LAST LETTER, THAT BIRD WAS ENORMOUS, IT
COULD HARDLY GET THROUGH MY WINDOW.

THINGS ARE THE SAME AS USUAL HERE, DUDLEY'S DIET ISN'T GOING
THEY WELL. MY AUNT FOUND HIM SMUGGLING DELICIOUS INTO HIS
ROOM YESTERDAY. THEY TOLD HIM THEY'D HAVE THE CLUT HIS PHECKET
MONEY IF HE KEEPS DOING IT, SEE HE GET REALLY ANGRY AND
CHOKED HIS PLAYSTATION UNIT OF THE WINDOW. THAT'S A SORT OF
COMPUTER THING YOU CAN PLAY GAMES ON, BUT STUPID REALLY, WHEN

XX HARRY PTTTTT

HE HAIN'T EVEN GET MEGA-MUTILATION PART THREE THE TAKE HIS
MIND OFF THINGS.

I M EED, MAINLY BECAUSE THE DURSLEYS ARE TERRIFIED YOU
MIGHT TURN UP AND TURN THEM ALL INTO BATS IF I ASK YOU THE.
A WEIRD THING HAPPENED THIS MORNING, THOUGH. MY SCAR
FLIRT AGAIN. LAST TIME THAT HAPPENED IT WAS BECAUSE
VERBEMERT WAS AT HOGWARTS, BUT I DERN'T RECKON HE CAN BE
ANYWHERE NEAR ME NOW, CAN HE? DEE YOU KNOW IF CLUSE SCARS
SOMETIMES FLIRT YEARS AFTERWARDS?

I LL SEND THIS WITH FREDNIG WHEN SHE GETS BACK, SHE S HPP
PLINTING AT THE MOMENT. SAY HELLO TO BUCKLEUP FOR ME.
HARRY

YES, TWELIGHT HARRY, THAT LOOKED ALL RIGHT. THERE WAS NO PHINT
PLITTING IN THE DREAM, HE DIDN T WANT IT TH LOOK AS TWELIGHT HE
WAS THE WHORIED. HE FOLDED THE PARCEMENT UP AND LAID IT ASIDE
ON HIS DESK, READY FOR WHEN FREDNIG RETURNED. THEN HE GOT THE
HIS FEET, STRETCHED AND OPENED HIS WARDROBE HENCE MORE.
WITHOUT GLANCING AT HIS REFLECTION, HE STARTED TO GET DRESSED
BEFORE GOING DOWN THE BREAKFAST.

CHAPTER THREE

THE INVITATION

BY THE TIME HARRY ARRIVED IN THE KITCHEN, THE THREE DURSLEYS
WERE ALREADY SEATED AROUND THE TABLE. WHEN HE THEM LOOKED UP
AS HE ENTERED HE SAT DOWN. LUCIE VERNON S LARGE RED FACE WAS
HIDDEN BEHIND THE MORNING S DAILY MAIL AND ALINT PETUNIA WAS
CUTTING A GRAPEFRUIT INTO SLICERS, HER LIPS PURSED OVER HER
HORSE-LIKE TEETH.

DUDEY LOOKED FLURRIED AND SLIDY, AND SOMEHOW SEEMED TO
BE TAKING UP EVEN MORE SPACE THAN USUAL. THIS WAS SAYING
SOMETHING, AS HE ALWAYS TOOK UP AN ENTIRE SIDE OF THE SEPARATE

TABLE BY HIMSELF. WHEN ALINT PETUNIA PUT A SLICER OF UNSWEET-
ENED GRAPEFRUIT INTO DUDEY S PLATE WITH A TREMBLING THERE

WELL ARE, DIDDY DARLING , DUDLEY GEELED AT HER, HIS LIFE HAD
TAKEN A MOST UNPLEASANT TURN SINCE HE HAD LEFT HOME FOR THE
SUMMER WITH HIS END-OF-YEAR REPORT.

LITTLE VERNIE AND ALINT PETLINIA HAD MANAGED THE FINE

EXCUSES FOR HIS BAD MARKS AS USUAL; ALINT PETLINIA ALWAYS INSIST-
ED THAT DUDLEY WAS A VERY GIFTED BOY WHOSE TEACHERS DIDN'T

UNDERSTAND HIM, WHILE LITTLE VERNIE MAINTAINED THAT HE
DIDN'T WANT SOME SWEETY LITTLE NANCY BOY FOR A SHIN ANGLAY ,

THEY ALSO SOATED EVERY THE ACCUSATIONS OF KIDNAPING IN THE REPORT

HE'S A REGISTERED LITTLE BOY, BUT HE WOULDN'T WANT A FLY! SAID
ALINT PETLINIA TEARFULLY.

HOWEVER, AT THE MEETING OF THE REPORT THERE WERE A FEW WELL
CHOSEN COMMENTS FROM THE SCHOOL NURSE WHICH NEET EVEN LITTLE
VERNIE AND ALINT PETLINIA COULD EXPLAIN AWAY. THE MATTER FELT
MUCH ALINT PETLINIA WAILED THAT DUDLEY WAS BIG-KINED, AND

BO HARRY PETER

THAT HIS PHELDAGE WAS REALLY PLUMPY-FAT, AND THAT HE WAS A
GRUWING BOY WHO NEEDED PLENTY OF FOOD, THE FACT REMAINED THAT
THE SCHOOL ELITITERS DIDN'T STECK KNICKERKNICKERS BIG PHELDGE
FOR HIM ANY MORE. THE SCHOOL NURSE HAD SEEN WHAT ALINT
PETLINIA'S EYES SEE SHARP WHEN IT CAME THE SPOTTING FINGERPRINTS
ON HER CREAMING WALLS, AND IN RESERVING THE CHIMINGS AND
CHINGS OF THE NEIGH-NEIGHERS SIMPLY REPLIED THE SEE! THAT, FAR FROM

NEEDING EXTRA NUTRIMENT, DUDLEY HAD REACHED RELEGELY THE
SIZE AND WEIGHT OF A YOUNG KILLER WHALE.

SHE AFTER MANY TANTALUMS, AFTER ARGUMENTS THAT SHE
HARRY'S REBORN FLIES, AND MANY TEARS FROM AUNT PETUNIA THE
NEW REGIME HAD BEGUN. THE DIET SHEET THAT HAD BEEN SENT BY
THE SMELTING'S SCHOOL NURSE HAD BEEN TAPED TO THE FRIDGE, WHICH
HAD BEEN EMPTIED OF ALL DUDLEY'S FAVORITE THINGS FIZZY DRINKS
AND CAKES, CHOCOLATE BARS AND BURGERS AND FILLED INSTEAD WITH
FRUIT AND VEGETABLES AND THE SHEETS OF THINGS THAT LITTLE VERNON
CALLED RABBIT FEED. THE MADE DUDLEY FEEL BETTER ABOUT IT ALL,
AUNT PETUNIA HAD INSISTED THAT THE WHOLE FAMILY FOLLOW THE DIET
THEM. SHE NOW PASSED A GRAPEFRUIT HALFTER TO HARRY. HE NOTICED
THAT IT WAS A LIT SMALLER THAN DUDLEY'S. AUNT PETUNIA SEEMED TO
FEEL THAT THE BEST WAY TO KEEP UP DUDLEY'S MORALE WAS TO MAKE
SURE THAT HE DID, AT LEAST, GET MORE TO EAT THAN HARRY.
BUT AUNT PETUNIA DIDN'T KNOW WHAT WAS HIDDEN UNDER THE
WHITE PAPERBOARD LIPSTAIRS. SHE HAD NO IDEA THAT HARRY WAS NOT
FOLLOWING THE DIET AT ALL. THE MOMENT HE HAD GOTTEN WIND OF THE
FACT THAT HE WAS EXPECTED TO SURVIVE THE SUMMER ON CARROT
STICKS, HARRY HAD SENT FREDDIE TO HIS FRIENDS WITH PLEASE FOR
HELP, AND THEY HAD RISEN TO THE OCCASION MAGNIFICENTLY. FREDDIE
HAD RETURNED FROM HERMIONE'S HOUSE WITH A LARGE BOX STUFFED
FULL OF SUGAR-FREE SNACKS (HERMIONE'S PARENTS WERE DENTISTS).
FACRID, THE HOGWARTS GAMEKEEPER, HAD DELIVERED WITH A SACK FULL
OF HIS OWN HOME-MADE RICE CAKES (HARRY HADN'T THOUGHT
THOSE; HE HAD HAD THEM MUCH EXPERIENCE OF FACRID'S COOKING).
MRS WEASLEY, HOWEVER, HAD SENT THE FAMILY HELP, CORRECTION, WITH AN

ENHARMEL'S PRUITLAGE AND ASSHETED PASTIES, PHEER LORREL, WHO WAS

THE INVITATION R1

ELDERLY AND FRIBLE, HAD NEEDED A FULL FIVE DAYS THE RECHYER FROM
THE IHLIRNEY, AND THEN HEN F-JARRY'S BIRTH-DAY (WHICH THE OLIRSEYS
HAD COMPLETELY IGNORED) HE HAD RECEIVED PHLIR SLIPPER BIRTH-DAY
CAKES, HENK EACH FROM PHEN, F-ERMINEZ, F-JACRID AND SIRILIS, F-JARRY
STILL HAD TWO OF THEM LEFT, AND SEE, LEENING FORWARD THE A REAL
BREAKFAST WHEN HE GOT BACK UPSTAIRS, HE STARTED EATING HIS
GRAPEFRUIT WITHOUT COMPLAINT.

UNCLE VERNEN LAID ASIDE HIS PAPER WITH A DEEP SNIFF OF DIS-
APPROVAL AND LEANED DOWN AT HIS OWN GRAPEFRUIT QUARTER,

IS THIS IT? HE SAID GRUMPILY TO ALINT PETLINIA,

ALINT PETLINIA GAVE HIM A SEVERE LEEN, AND THEN NEEDED

PHINTEDLY AT DUBLEY, WHO HAD ALREADY FINISHED HIS OWN GRAPE-
FRUIT QUARTER, AND WAS EYING F-JARRY'S WITH A VERY SHLIR LEEN IN

HIS PIGGY LITTLE EYES.

UNCLE VERNEN GAVE A GREAT SIGH WHICH RUPTURED HIS LARGE,
BLISHY MELLSTACHE, AND PICKED UP HIS SPEECH,

THE DEHREKELL RANG, UNCLE VERNEN HEAVED HIMSELF UP FROM HIS
CHAIR AND SET OFF DOWN THE HALL, FOLLOWED AS A FLASH, WHILE HIS
MUTHER WAS OCCUPIED WITH THE KETTLE, DUBLEY STEER THE REST OF
UNCLE VERNEN'S GRAPEFRUIT.

HARRY HEARD TALKING AT THE DOOR, AND SOMEONE LAUGHING, AND
UNCLE VERNEEN ANSWERING CLORTLY. THEN THE FRONT DOOR CLOSED,
AND THE SOUND OF RIPPING PAPER CAME FROM THE HALL.

AUNT PETUNIA SET THE TRAPNET DOWN ON THE TABLE AND LOOKED
CURIOUSLY AROUND THE SEE WHERE UNCLE VERNEEN HAD GOTTEN. SHE
DIDN'T HAVE TO WAIT LONG TO FIND OUT; AFTER ABOUT A MINUTE, HE
WAS BACK. HE LOOKED LIVID.

WELL, HE BARRED AT HARRY. IN THE LIVING ROOM, WELL,
BEMILDERED, WONDERING WHAT ON EARTH HE WAS SUPPOSED TO
HAVE DONE THIS TIME, HARRY GOT UP AND FOLLOWED UNCLE VERNEEN
OUT OF THE KITCHEN AND INTO THE NEXT ROOM. UNCLE VERNEEN
CLOSED THE DOOR SHARPLY BEHIND BOTH OF THEM.

SEE, HE SAID, MARCHING OVER THE THE FIREPLACE AND TURNING THE
FACE HARRY AS THOUGH HE WAS ABOUT TO PRESENT HIM UNDER
ARREST. SEE.

RE HARRY PEEETTER

HARRY WOULD HAVE DEARLY LIKED TO HAVE SAID 'SEE WHAT?', BUT HE
DIDN'T FEEL THAT UNCLE VERNEEN'S TEMPER SHOULD BE TESTED THIS EARLY
IN

THE MORNING, ESPECIALLY WHEN IT WAS ALREADY UNDER SEVERE STRAIN
FROM LACK OF SLEEP. HE THEREFORE SETTLED HIMSELF QUIETLY
PLAZZED.

THIS INSTANT ARRIVED, SAID UNCLE VERNEEN, HE BRANDISHED A PIECE
OF PLAIN WRITING PAPER AT HARRY. A LETTER, ABOUT WELL,

HARRY'S CONVICTIONS INCREASED. WHEN WOULD HE BE WRITING THE UNCLE
VERNEEN ABOUT HIM? WHEN DID HE KNOW WHEN SENT LETTERS BY THE

PHESTMAN?

LUNCLE VERNEN CLARED AT HARRY, THEN LOOKED DOWN AT THE
LETTER, AND BEGAN TE READ ALOUD:

DEAR MR AND MRS BLURLEY,

WE HAVE NEVER BEEN INTRODUCED, BUT I AM SURE YOU HAVE
HEARD A GREAT DEAL FROM HARRY ABOUT MY SON RICH.

AS HARRY MIGHT HAVE TOLD YOU, THE FINAL OF THE WILDDITCH-
WORLD CUP TAKES PLACE NEXT MONDAY NIGHT, AND MY HUSBAND,
ARTHUR, HAS JUST MANAGED TO GET PRIME TICKETS THROUGH HIS
CONNECTIONS AT THE DEPARTMENT OF MAGICAL GAMES AND SPORTS.
I DO HOPE YOU WILL ALLOW US TO TAKE HARRY TO THE MATCH, AS
THIS REALLY IS A ONCE-IN-A-LIFETIME OPPORTUNITY! BRITAIN HASN'T
HOSTED THE CUP FOR THIRTY YEARS AND TICKETS ARE EXTREMELY
HARD TO COME BY. WE WOULD OF COURSE BE GLAD TO HAVE HARRY TO
STAY FOR THE REMAINDER OF THE SUMMER HOLIDAYS, AND TO SEE
HIM SAFELY MONTHE THE TRAIN BACK TO SCHOOL.

IT WOULD BE BEST FOR HARRY TO SEND US YOUR ANSWER AS
SOON AS POSSIBLE IN THE NORMAL WAY, BECAUSE THE MISCLE
PHESTMAN HAS NEVER DELIVERED THE MAIL HERE, AND I AM NOT SURE
HE EVEN KNOWS WHERE IT IS.

HOPEING TO SEE HARRY SOON,

YOURS SINCERELY,

MELLY WEASLEY

P.S. I DO HOPE WE VE PUT ENOUGH STAMPS ON.

LUNCLE VERNEN FINISHED READING, PUT HIS HAND BACK INTO HIS

THE INVITATION BE

BREAD PICKET, AND DREW OUT SOMETHING ELSE.

LOOK AT THIS, HE GRIELED.

HE HELD UP THE ENVELOPE IN WHICH MRS WEASLEY'S LETTER HAD COME, AND HARRY HAD THE FIGHT BETWEEN A LAUGH. EVERY BIT OF IT WAS COVERED IN STAMPS EXCEPT FOR A SEILAR INCH ON THE FRONT, IN THE WHICH MRS WEASLEY HAD SWEETED THE DURSLEYS' ADDRESS IN MINUTE WRITING.

SHE DID PUT ENOUGH STAMPS ON, THEN, SAID HARRY, TRYING THE SOUND AS THOUGH MRS WEASLEY'S WAS A MISTAKE ANYONE COULD MAKE. HIS UNCLE'S EYES FLASHED.

THE POSTMAN NOTICED, HE SAID THROUGH GRITTED TEETH. VERY INTERESTED THE KNOW WHERE THIS LETTER CAME FROM, HE WAS. THAT'S WHY HE RANG THE BELL. SEEMED THE THING IT WAS FLINDY.

HARRY DIDN'T SAY ANYTHING. EITHER PEOPLE MIGHT NOT UNDERSTAND WHY UNCLE VERNON WAS MAKING A FUSS ABOUT THE MANY

STAMPS, BUT HARRY HAD LIVED WITH THE DURSLEYS THE LONG NOT THE KNOW FEEL THICKLY THEY WERE ABOUT ANYTHING EVEN SLIGHTLY OUT OF THE ORDINARY. THEIR WORST FEAR WAS THAT ANYONE WOULD FIND OUT THAT THEY WERE CONNECTED (HOWEVER DISTANTLY) WITH PEOPLE LIKE MRS WEASLEY.

UNCLE VERNON WAS STILL GLARING AT HARRY, WHO TRIED TO KEEP HIS EXPRESSIONS NEUTRAL. IF HE DIDN'T SEE HER SAY ANYTHING STUPID, HE MIGHT JUST BE IN FOR THE TREAT OF A LIFETIME. HE WAITED FOR UNCLE VERNON TO SAY SOMETHING, BUT HE MERELY CONTINUED TO GLARE. HARRY DECIDED TO BREAK THE SILENCE.

SHE CAN I SEE, THEN? HE ASKED.

A SLIGHT SPASM CROSSED UNCLE VERNEEN'S LARGE, PURPLE FACE. THE Moustache BRISTLED, HARRY THOUGHT HE KNEW WHAT WAS GOING ON BEHIND THE Moustache: A FURIOUS BATTLE AS TWO OF UNCLE VERNEEN'S MOST FUNDAMENTAL INSTINCTS CAME INTO CONFLICT. ALLOWING HARRY TO SEE WOULD MAKE HARRY HAPPY, SOMETHING UNCLE VERNEEN HAD STRUGGLED AGAINST FOR THIRTEEN YEARS. ON THE OTHER HAND, ALLOWING HARRY TO DISAPPEAR TO THE WEASLEYS FOR THE REST OF THE SUMMER WOULD GET RID OF HIM TWO WEEKS EARLIER THAN ANYONE COULD HAVE HOPED, AND UNCLE VERNEEN HATED

BY HARRY PETER

HAVING HARRY IN THE HOUSE. HE GAVE HIMSELF THINKING TIME, IT SEEMED, HE LOOKED DOWN AT MRS WEASLEY'S LETTER AGAIN.

WHO IS THIS WOMAN? HE SAID, STARING AT THE SIGNATURE WITH DISTASTE.

WHO? HE SEEN HER, SAID HARRY. SHE'S MY FRIEND REN'S MOTHER, SHE WAS MEETING HIM OFF THE END OF THE SCHOOL TRAIN AT THE END OF LAST TERM.

HE HAD ALMOST SAID HOGWARTS EXPRESS, AND THAT WAS A SURE WAY TO GET HIS UNCLE'S TEMPER UP. NOBODY EVER MENTIONED THE NAME OF HARRY'S SCHOOL AHEAD IN THE DURSLEY HOUSEHOLD.

UNCLE VERNEEN SCREWED UP HIS PURPLE FACE AS THOUGH TRYING TO REMEMBER SOMETHING VERY UNPLEASANT.

CLIMBY SHORT OF WOMAN? HE GROANED FINALLY. LEAD OF CHILDREN WITH RED HAIR?

HARRY PREHEARD, HE THOUGHT IT WAS A BIT RICH OF UNCLE VERNEEN

THE CALL ANYMORE DIMPY, WHEN HIS EYES WERE OPEN, DUDLEY, HAD FINALLY
ACHIEVED WHAT HE D BEEN THREATENING TO DO SINCE THE AGE OF
THREE, AND BECOME WIDER THAN HE WAS TALL.

UNCLE VERNON WAS PERUSING THE LETTER AGAIN.

BLUBBITY, HE MUTTERED UNDER HIS BREATH, BLUBBITY WHAT
IS THIS BLUBBITY

HARRY FELT A SECOND STAR OF ANNOYANCE.

IT'S A SPHINX, HE SAID SHORTLY, PLAYED HIM KROTH

ALL RIGHT, ALL RIGHT! SAID UNCLE VERNON LUDLY, HARRY SAW,
WITH SOME SATISFACTION, THAT HIS UNCLE LOOKED VAGUELY PANICKED,
APPARENTLY HIS NERVES WOULDNT STAND THE STRAIN OF THE WORD
KROTHSTICKS IN HIS LIVING ROOM, HE THEN RESOLVED IN PERUSING
THE LETTER AGAIN, HARRY SAW HIS LIPS FORM THE WORDS SEND US
YOUR ANSWER IN THE NORMAL WAY, HE SMILED.

WHAT DOES SHE MEAN, THE NORMAL WAY? HE SPAT.

NORMAL FOR US, SAID HARRY, AND REMEMBER HIS UNCLE COULD STEEP
HIM, HE ADDED, WELL KNOWN, WELL KNOWN, THAT'S WHAT'S NORMAL FOR
WIZARDS.

UNCLE VERNON LOOKED AS ELTRAGED AS IF HARRY HAD JUST LITTERED
A DISGUSTING SWEAR WORD, SHAKING WITH ANGER, HE SENT A NERVOUS

THE INVITATION IS

SENT THROUGH THE WINDOW, AS THOUGH EXPECTING TO SEE SOME OF
THE NEIGHBOURS WITH THEIR EARS PRESSED AGAINST THE GLASS.

HOW MANY TIMES DO I HAVE TO TELL YOU NOT TO MENTION THAT
UNNATURALNESS UNDER MY NAME? HE HISSED, HIS FACE NOW A RICH
PINK COLOR, YOU STAND THERE, IN THE CLOTHES PETUNIA AND I

HAVE PUT MY FEELING UNGRATEFULL BACK

ONLY AFTER DUDLEY FINISHED WITH THEM, SAID HARRY CHILDLY,
AND INDEED, HE WAS DRESSED IN A SWEATSHIRT SEE LARGE FOR HIM THAT
HE HAD HAD THE REEL BACK THE SLEEVES FIVE TIMES SEE AS THE BE ABLE THE
USE HIS HANDS, AND WHICH FELL PAST THE KNEES OF HIS EXTREMELY
RAGGY JEANS.

I WILL NOT BE SPOOKEN THE LIKE THAT! SAID UNCLE VERNON, TREM-
BLING WITH RAGE.

BUT HARRY WASN'T GOING THE STAND FOR THIS. GONE WERE THE DAYS
WHEN HE HAD BEEN FORCED THE TAKE EVERY SINGLE ONE OF THE
DURSLEYS' STUPID RULES, HE WASN'T FEELING DUDLEY'S DIRT, AND
HE WASN'T GOING THE LET UNCLE VERNON STOP HIM GOING THE THE
HOLIDITCH WORLD CUP, NOT IF HE COULD HELP IT.

HARRY TOOK A DEEP, STEADYING BREATH AND THEN SAID, HED, I
CAN'T SEE THE WORLD CUP, CAN I SEE NOW, THEN? ONLY I VE GET A
LETTER THE SIRIUS I WANT THE FINISH, YELL DOWN MY GRANDFATHER,
HE HAD DONE IT, HE HAD SAID THE MAGIC WORDS, NOW HE
WATCHED THE PURPLE REDE BLEITCHILY FROM UNCLE VERNON'S FACE,
MAKING IT LOOK LIKE BADLY MIXED BLACKCURRANT ICE-CREAM.

YELL RE YELL RE WRITING THE HIM, ARE YELL? SAID UNCLE VERNON,
IN A WHILD-RE CALM VOICE BUT HARRY HAD SEEN THE PUPILS OF
HIS TINY EYES CONTRACT WITH SUDDEN FEAR.

WELL YEAH, SAID HARRY, CASUALLY, IT'S BEEN A WHILE SINCE HE
HEARD FROM ME, AND, YELL DOWN, IF HE DOESN'T, HE MIGHT START
THINKING SOMETHING'S WRONG.

HE STOPPED THERE THE MOMENT THE EFFECT OF THESE WORDS, HE
COULD ALMOST SEE THE CIGS WHIRLING UNDER LUNCLE VERNEEN'S THICK,
DARK, NEATLY PARTED HAIR. IF HE TRIED THE STOP HARRY WRITING THE
STIRLIS, STIRLIS WOULD THINK HARRY WAS BEING MISTREATED. IF HE
TOLD HARRY HE COULDN'T GET THE THE HOLLIDITCH WORLD CLIP, HARRY

RE HARRY BETTER

WOULD WRITE AND TELL STIRLIS, WHO WOULD KNOW HE WAS BEING
MISTREATED. THERE WAS ONLY ONE THING FOR LUNCLE VERNEEN THE OH,
HARRY COULD SEE THE CHUCKLESTEN FORMING IN HIS MIND AS THOUGH
THE GREAT MISLATCHED FACE WAS TRANSPARENT. HARRY TRIED NOT THE
SMILE, HE KEPT HIS OWN FACE AS BLANK AS POSSIBLE. AND THEN

WELL, ALL RIGHT THEN, YOU CAN GET THE THIS RIDDY ... THIS STUPID
... THIS WORLD CLIP THING, YOU WRITE AND TELL THESE THESE
WEASLEYS THEY'RE THE PICK YOU UP, MIND, I HAVEN'T GOT TIME TO GET
DROPPING YOU OFF ALL OVER THE COUNTRY, AND YOU CAN SPEND THE

REST OF THE SUMMER THERE, AND YOU CAN TELL YOUR YOUR GOD-
FATHER ... TELL HIM ... TELL HIM YOU'RE GOING.

END THEN, SAID HARRY BRIGHTLY.

HE TURNED AND WALKED TOWARDS THE LIVING-ROOM DOOR, FIGHT-
ING THE LARGE THE LUMP INTO THE AIR AND WHIMP, HE WAS GOING ...

HE WAS GOING TO THE WEASLEYS, HE WAS GOING TO WATCH THE
HOLLIDITCH WORLD CLIP!

ELTOSIDE IN THE HALL HE NEARLY RAN INTO DUDLEY, WHO HAD BEEN
BLINDING BEHIND THE DOOR, CLEARLY HOPING THE EVER-DEAR HARRY
WOULD FIND HIM. HE WISHED HE COULD SEE THE BROAD GRIN ON
HARRY'S FACE.

THAT WAS AN EXCELLENT BREAKFAST, WASN'T IT? SAID HARRY. I FEEL
REALLY FULL, DON'T YOU?

LAUGHING AT THE ASTONISHED LOOK ON DUDLEY'S FACE, HARRY
TOOK THE STAIRS THREE AT A TIME, AND FLOPPED HIMSELF BACK INTO HIS
BEDROOM.

THE FIRST THING HE SAW WAS THAT FREDWIG WAS BACK. SHE WAS
SITTING IN HER CAGE, STARING AT HARRY WITH HER ENERGETIC AMBER
EYES, AND CLICKING HER BEAK IN THE WAY THAT MEANT SHE WAS
ANNOUNCING SOMETHING. EXACTLY WHAT WAS ANNOUNCING HER
BECAME APPARENT ALMOST AT ONCE.

HELLO? SAID HARRY.

WHAT APPEARED TO BE A SMALL, GREY, FEATHERY TENNIS BALL HAD
JUST COLLIDED WITH THE SIDE OF HARRY'S HEAD. HARRY MASSAGED HIS
HEAD FURIOUSLY, WONDERING IF HE SEE WHAT HAD HIT HIM, AND SAW A
MINUTE BALL, SMALL ENOUGH TO FIT INTO THE PALM OF HIS HAND.

THE INVITATION TO

WHIZZING EXCITEDLY AROUND THE ROOM LIKE A WHITE FIREWORK.

HARRY THEN REALISED THAT THE BALL HAD DROPPED A LETTER AT HIS
FEET. HARRY KENT DOWN, RECOGNISED RON'S HANDWRITING, THEN THERE
OPEN THE ENVELOPE. INSIDE WAS A HASTILY SCRIBBLED NOTE.

HARRY DAD GOT THE TICKETS IRELAND VERSUS

BULGARIA, MONDAY NIGHT. MOM'S WRITING THE THE MUGGLES THE ASD

YELL THE STAY, THEY MIGHT ALREADY HAVE THE LETTER, I DON'T KNOW
HOW FAST MUGGLE POST IS. THOUGHT I'D SEND THIS WITH PIG ANYWAY.
HARRY STARED AT THE WEIRD PIG, THEN LOOKED UP AT THE TINY HELL
WHICH ZEEEMING AROUND THE LAMP-FLAME ON THE CEILING. HE HAD
NEVER SEEN ANYTHING THAT LOOKED LESS LIKE A PIG. MAYBE HE
COULDN'T READ RON'S WRITING. HE WENT BACK TO THE LETTER:

WE'RE CHECKING FOR YELL WHETHER THE MUGGLES LIKE IT OR NOT, YELL
CAN'T MISS THE WHEEL CLIP, ONLY MOM AND DAD REMEMBER IT'S BETTER
IF WE PRETEND TO ASK THEIR PERMISSION FIRST. IF THEY SAY YES, SEND
PIG BACK WITH YOUR ANSWER PRINTED, AND WE'LL COME AND GET YELL
AT FIVE O'CLOCK ON SUNDAY. IF THEY SAY NO, SEND PIG BACK PRINTED
AND WE'LL COME AND GET YELL AT FIVE O'CLOCK ON SUNDAY ANYWAY.

HERMIONE'S ARRIVING THIS AFTERNOON, PERCY'S STARTED WORK
THE DEPARTMENT OF INTERNATIONAL MAGICAL CO-OPERATION, DON'T
MENTION ANYTHING ABOUT AHEAD WHILE YELL ARE HERE UNLESS YELL
WANT THE PANTS KEPT OFF YELL.

SEE YELL SEEN RON

CALM DOWN! HARRY SAID, AS THE SMALL HELL FLEW WELL OVER HIS
HEAD, TWITTERING MADLY WITH WHAT HARRY COULD ONLY ASSUME
WAS PRIDE AT HAVING DELIVERED THE LETTER TO THE RIGHT PERSON.

COME HERE, I NEED YELL TO TAKE MY ANSWER BACK!

THE HELL FLUTTERED DOWN INTO THE OF FREDDIE'S CAGE. FREDDIE LOOKED
CLOSELY UP AT IT, AS THOUGH DARING IT TO TRY AND COME ANY CLOSER.
HARRY SEIZED HIS EAGLE-FEATHER QUILL FROM HIS POCKET, GRABBED A
FRESH PIECE OF PARCHMENT, AND WROTE:

RE HARRY PETER

THEN, IT'S ALL FINE, THE MUGGLES SAY I CAN COME, SEE YOU FIVE
HE CLUCKED THUNDEROUSLY, CAN'T WAIT.

HARRY

HE HELD THIS WHITE LIP VERY SMALL AND, WITH IMMENSE DIFFICULTY,

TIED IT TO THE TINY HELL'S LEG AS IT HOPPED ON THE SPOT WITH EXCITE-
MENT. THE MOMENT THE WHITE WAS SECURE, THE HELL WAS OFF AGAIN;

IT ZOOMED OUT OF THE WINDOW AND OUT OF SIGHT.

HARRY TURNED THE HEDWIG.

FEELING LIKE THE A LONG JOURNEY? HE ASKED HER.

HEDWIG HESITATED IN A DIGNIFIED SHORT WAY.

CAN YOU TAKE THIS THE STRIPS FOR ME? HE SAID, PICKING UP HIS
LETTER. HANG ON ... I JUST WANT TO FINISH IT.

HE UNFOLDED THE PARCHMENT AGAIN AND HASTILY ADDED A POSTSCRIPT.

IF YOU WANT TO CONTACT ME, I'LL BE AT MY FRIEND RON

WEASLEY'S FOR THE REST OF THE SUMMER. HIS DAD'S GOT HIS TICKETS
FOR THE FLUIDITCH WORLD CUP!

THE LETTER FINISHED, HE TIED IT TO THE HEDWIG'S LEG; SHE KEPT UNWIS-
ALLY STILL, AS THOUGH DETERMINED TO SHOW HIM THAT A REAL POST

HELL SHOULD BEHAVE.

I'LL BE AT RON'S WHEN YOU GET BACK, ALL RIGHT? HARRY TOLD HER.

SHE NIPPED HIS FINGER AFFECTIONATELY, THEN, WITH A SHOT

SWEEPING NEIGH, SPREAD HER ENORMOUS WINGS AND SHARED OUT
OF THE OPEN WINDOW.

HARRY WATCHED HER HURT HIS SIGHT, THEN CRAWLED UNDER HIS BED, WRENCHED UP THE LEESE FLEEKHARD, AND PULLED OUT A LARGE CHLIND OF BIRTHDAY CAKE. HE SAT THERE AND THE FLEEKH EATING IT, SAVORING THE HAPPINESS THAT WAS FLEEKING THROUGH HIM. HE HAD CAKE, AND DUBBY HAD NOTHING BUT GRAPEFRUIT; IT WAS A

BRIGHT SUMMER DAY, HE WOULD BE LEAVING PRIVET DRIVE THEM-
SELF, HIS SCAR FELT PERFECTLY NORMAL AGAIN, AND HE WAS GOING TO

WATCH THE BLIDDITCH WORLD CUP. IT WAS HARD, JUST WHEN THE FEEL
WHIRLED ABOUT ANYTHING EVEN LORD VOLDEMORT.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

BACK TO THE BLIND

BY TWELVE IN CLOCK NEXT DAY, HARRY'S TRUNK WAS PACKED WITH HIS
SCHOOL THINGS, AND ALL HIS MOST PRIZED POSSESSIONS THE

INVISIBILITY CLOAK HE HAD INHERITED FROM HIS FATHER, THE BREEM-
STICK HE HAD GIFT FROM SIRIUS, THE ENCHANTED MAP OF HOGWARTS

HE HAD BEEN GIVEN BY FRED AND GEORGE WEASLEY LAST YEAR. HE
HAD EMPTIED HIS HIDING PLACE UNDER THE LEESE FLEEKHARD OF ALL
FLEEK, DUBBY-CHICKED EVERY NEED AND CRANDY OF HIS BEDROOM
AND FORGOTTEN SPELLBOOKS AND ENLILS, AND TAKEN DOWN THE CHART AND
THE WALL CHARTING THE DAYS FROM THE SEPTEMBER THE FIRST, AND

WHICH HE LIKED THE CROSS OF THE DAYS REMAINING UNTIL HIS RETURN
THE HOGWARTS.

THE ATMOSPHERE INSIDE NUMBER NINE PRIVET DRIVE WAS
EXTREMELY TENSE. THE IMMINENT ARRIVAL AT THEIR HOUSE OF AN
ASSERTMENT OF WIZARDS WAS MAKING THE DURSLEYS UPTIGHT AND
IRRITABLE. UNCLE VERNON HAD BEEN DEEPLY ALARMED WHEN
HARRY INFORMED HIM THAT THE WEASLEYS WOULD BE ARRIVING AT
FIVE O'CLOCK THE VERY NEXT DAY.

I HOPE YOU TOLD THEM TO DRESS PROPERLY, THESE PEOPLE, HE
SNARLED AT HENRI. I'VE SEEN THE SORT OF STUFF YOUR LITTLE NEPHEW
BETTER HAVE THE DECENCY TO PUT ON NORMAL CLOTHES, THAT'S ALL.

HARRY FELT A SLIGHT SENSE OF APPREHENSION. HE HAD RARELY SEEN
MR OR MRS WEASLEY WEARING ANYTHING THAT THE DURSLEYS WOULD
CALL NORMAL. THEIR CHILDREN MIGHT BE IN MUGGLE CLOTHING DURING
THE HOLIDAYS, BUT MR AND MRS WEASLEY USUALLY WERE LONG RIBBED
IN VARYING STATES OF SHAKINESS. HARRY WASN'T BOTHERED ABOUT
WHAT THE NEIGHBOURS WOULD THINK, BUT HE WAS ANXIOUS ABOUT

AND HARRY BETTER

HOW LIKE THE DURSLEYS MIGHT BE THE THE WEASLEYS IF THEY TURNED
UP BEHAVING LIKE THEIR WORST IDEA OF WIZARDS.

UNCLE VERNON HAD PUT ON HIS BEST SLIT. THE SAME PEOPLE, THIS
MIGHT HAVE BEEN LIKE A GESTURE OF WELCOME, BUT HARRY KNEW
IT WAS BECAUSE UNCLE VERNON WANTED TO BE IMPRESSIVE AND
INTIMIDATING. DUBBLE, ON THE OTHER HAND, HAD BEEN SHAMEFULLY
DIMINISHED. THIS WAS NOT BECAUSE THE DIET WAS AT LAST TAKING
EFFECT, BUT DUE TO THE FRIGHT, DUBBLE HAD EMERGED FROM HIS LAST

ENCOUNTER WITH A FLUDDY-GREEN WIZARD WITH A CURLY PIG'S TAIL
PICKING UP THE SEAT OF HIS TROUSERS, AND ALINT PETLINIA AND

UNCLE VERNEEN HAD HAD THE PAIN FOR ITS REMOVAL AT A PRIVATE HOSPITAL
IN LONDON. IT WASN'T ALTOGETHER SURPRISING, THEREFORE, THAT

BLUDLEY KEPT RUNNING HIS HAND NERVOUSLY OVER HIS BACKSIDE,
AND WALKING SIDELAYS FROM THEM TO THEM, SEE AS NIFT THE PRESENT
THE SAME TARGET TO THE ENEMY.

LUNCH WAS AN ALMOST SILENT MEAL. BLUDLEY DIDN'T EVEN PROTEST
AT THE MEAL (LEFTOVER CHEESE AND GRATED CELERY). ALINT PETLINIA
WASN'T EATING ANYTHING AT ALL. HER ARMS WERE FLEED, HER LIPS
WERE PURSED AND SHE SEEMED TO BE CHEWING HER TONGUE, AS
THOUGH BITING BACK THE FLAMING DIATRIBE SHE LUNGED THE TONGUE AT
HARRY.

THEY'LL BE DRIVING, HE CHEERED? UNCLE VERNEEN BARKED ACROSS
THE TABLE.

ER, SAID HARRY.

HE HADN'T THOUGHT OF THAT. HE'LL WERE THE WEASLEY'S CHINE THE
PICK HIM UP? THEY DIDN'T HAVE A CAR ANY MORE; THE OLD FORD
ANGELIA THEY HAD ONCE HAD WAS CURRENTLY RUNNING WILD IN THE
FERRIDEN FOREST AT HEGHARTS. BUT MR WEASLEY HAD PURCHASED A
MINISTRY OF MAGIC CAR LAST YEAR; POSSIBLY HE WOULD BE THE SAME
TODAY?

I THINK SHE, SAID HARRY.

UNCLE VERNEEN SNEEZED INTO HIS Moustache. NORMALLY, UNCLE
VERNEEN WOULD HAVE ASKED WHAT CAR MR WEASLEY DROVE; HE

TENDED THE ILDGE EITHER MEN HEN HEN KIG AND EXPENSIVE THEIR CARS WERE, BUT HARRY DUBITED WHETHER LITTLE VERNEN WOULD HAVE

RACK THE THE CLERK 21

TAKEN THE MR LEASLEY EVEN IF HE DROVE A FERRARI.

HARRY SPENT MOST OF THE AFTERNOON IN HIS BEDROOM; HE COULDN'T STAND WATCHING ALINT PETLONIA PEER HINT THROUGH THE NET

CURTAINS EVERY FEW SECONDS, AS THOUGH THERE HAD BEEN A WARNING ABOUT AN ESCAPED RHINOCEROS. FINALLY, AT A QUARTER THE FIVE,

HARRY WENT BACK DOWNSTAIRS AND INTO THE LIVING ROOM.

ALINT PETLONIA WAS COMPULSIVELY STRAIGHTENING CUSHIONS.

LITTLE VERNEN WAS PRETENDING TO READ THE PAPER, BUT HIS TINY

EYES WERE NOT MOVING, AND HARRY WAS SURE HE WAS REALLY LISTENING WITH ALL HIS MIGHT FOR THE SOUND OF AN APPROACHING CAR.

DUDLEY WAS CRAMPED INTO AN ARMCHAIR, HIS FINGERS HANDS

BENEATH HIM, CLAMPED FIRMLY AROUND HIS KNEES. HARRY

COULDN'T TAKE THE TENSION; HE LEFT THE ROOM, AND WENT AND SAT ON THE STAIRS IN THE HALL, HIS EYES ON HIS WATCH AND HIS HEART PUMPING FAST FROM EXCITEMENT AND NERVES.

BUT FIVE HE CHECK CAME AND THEN WENT. LITTLE VERNEN, PERSPIRING SLIGHTLY IN HIS SWEAT, OPENED THE FRONT DOOR, PEERED UP AND DOWN THE STREET, THEN WITHDREW HIS HEAD QUICKLY.

THEY'RE LATE! HE SNARLED AT HARRY.

I DON'T, SAID HARRY, MAYBE IF THE TRAFFIC IS BAD, HE'S SOME-
THING.

TEN PAST FIVE ... THEN A QUARTER PAST FIVE ... HARRY WAS
STARTING TO FEEL ANXIOUS HIMSELF NOW. AT HALF PAST, HE HEARD
UNCLE VERNEEN AND AUNT PETUNIA CONVERSING IN TERSE MUTTERS IN
THE LIVING ROOM.

NO CONSIDERATION AT ALL.

WE MIGHT VE HAD AN ENGAGEMENT.

MAYBE THEY THINK THEY LL GET INVITED THE DINNER IF THEY RE LATE.

WELL, THEY MUST CERTAINLY WHEN T BE, SAID UNCLE VERNEEN, AND
HARRY HEARD HIM STAND UP AND START PACING THE LIVING ROOM.

THEY LL TAKE THE KEY AND GO, THERE LL BE NO HANGING ABOUT.
THAT IS IF THEY RE COMING AT ALL. PROBABLY MISTAKEN THE DAY, I
DARE SAY THEIR KIND DONT SET MUCH STORE BY PUNCTUALITY. EITHER

THAT OR THEY DRIVE SOME TINNEY CAR THAT S KNOWN D-

~~~~~

42 HARRY PETER

HARRY ILMPED UP, FROM THE OTHER SIDE OF THE LIVING-ROOM

BEHIND CAME THE SHIELDS OF THE THREE DURSLEYS SCRAMBLING, PANIC-  
STRICKEN, ACROSS THE ROOM. NEXT MOMENT DUDLEY CAME FLYING

INTO THE HALL, LEEDING TERRIFIED,

WHAT HAPPENED? SAID HARRY, WHAT'S THE MATTER?

BUT DUDLEY DIDN'T SEEM ABLE TO SPEAK, HANDBS STILL CLAMPED  
OVER HIS EYETHECKS, HE WADDLED AS FAST AS HE COULD INTO THE  
KITCHEN, HARRY FLURRIED INTO THE LIVING ROOM.

CHILD HANGINGS AND SCRAPINGS WERE COMING FROM BEHIND THE  
BURSLEYS' BEARDED-LIP FIREPLACE, WHICH HAD A FAKE CHAL FIRE  
PLUGGED IN FRONT OF IT.

WHAT IS IT? GASPED ALINT PETLINIA, WHO HAD RACDED INTO THE  
WALL AND WAS STARING, TERRIFIED, TOWARDS THE FIRE. WHAT IS IT,  
VERNON?

BUT THEY WERE LEFT IN DUELIST BARELY A SECOND LONGER, VOICES  
COULD BE HEARD FROM INSIDE THE BEHECKED FIREPLACE.

HELIX! FRED, NO! GO BACK, GO BACK, THERE'S BEEN SOME KIND  
OF MISTAKE! TELL GEORGE NOT TO! HELIX! GEORGE, NO, THERE'S NO  
ROOM, GO BACK HELIX! AND TELL RON

MAYBE HARRY CAN HEAR US, DAD! MAYBE HE'LL BE ABLE TO LET  
US OUT

THERE WAS A MILD HAMMERING OF FISTS FROM THE ROOMS BEHIND  
THE ELECTRIC FIRE.

HARRY? HARRY, CAN YOU HEAR US?

THE DURSLEYS REPLIED TO HARRY LIKE A PAIR OF ANGRY WHEELVER-  
INES.

WHAT IS THIS? GRIELED UNCLE VERNON, WHAT'S GOING ON?

THEY! THEY'VE TRIED TO GET HERE BY FLETH POWDER, SAID HARRY,  
FIGHTING A MAD DESIRE TO LAUGH. THEY CAN TRAVEL BY FIRE! ONLY

THEY WERE BLOCKED THE FIREPLACE HANGING

HE APPROACHED THE FIREPLACE AND CALLED THROUGH THE REARDS,

MR WEASLEY? CAN YOU HEAR ME?

THE HAMMERING STOPPED, SMOOKED INSIDE THE CHIMNEY-

PIECE SAID, SILENT

MR WEASLEY, IT'S HARRY ... THE FIREPLACE HAS BEEN BLOCKED UP,

RACE THE THE BLOCKED UP

YOU WON'T BE ABLE TO GET THROUGH THERE,

DAMN! SAID MR WEASLEY'S VOICE, WHAT ON EARTH DID THEY  
WANT TO BLOCK UP THE FIREPLACE FOR?

THEY WERE GET AN ELECTRIC FIRE, HARRY EXPLAINED,

REALLY? SAID MR WEASLEY'S VOICE EXCITEDLY, ELECTRIC, YOU  
SAY? WITH A PLUG? GRACIOUS, I MUST SEE THAT ... LET'S THINK ...  
HELLO, REEN?

REEN'S VOICE NOW JOINED THE OTHERS,

WHAT ARE WE DOING HERE? HAS SOMETHING BEEN WIRING?

HEY, NO, REEN, CAME FRED'S VOICE, VERY SARCASTICALLY, NO, THIS  
IS EXACTLY WHERE WE WANTED THE END UP,

YES, WE'RE HAVING THE TIME OF OUR LIVES HERE, SAID GEORGE,  
WHOSE VOICE SOUNDED MUFFLED, AS THOUGH HE WAS SQUASHED  
AGAINST THE WALL,

KEYS, KEYS ... SAID MR WEASLEY VAGUELY, I'M TRYING TO THINK  
WHAT TO DO ... YES ... ONLY WAY ... STAND BACK, HARRY,

HARRY RETREATED TO THE SEAT, UNCLE VERNON, HOWEVER, MOVED

FORWARDS.

WAIT A MOMENT! HE BELIEVED AT THE FIRE. WHAT EXACTLY ARE  
YOU DOING THE ?  
RAGE.

THE ELECTRIC FIRE SPENT ACROSS THE ROOM AS THE BURNED-LIP FIRE-  
PLACE BURST BACKWARDS, EXPELLING MR WEASLEY, FRED, GEORGE AND

DOWN IN A CLOUD OF SMOKE AND WHITE CHIPPINGS. ALINT PETLONIA  
STRIKED AND FELL BACKWARDS OVER THE CHAIR TABLE. UNCLE  
VERNON CALLED HER BEFORE SHE HIT THE FLOOR AND GAZED,  
SPEECHLESS, AT THE WEASLEYS, ALL OF WHOM HAD BRIGHT RED HAIR,  
INCLUDING FRED AND GEORGE, WHO WERE IDENTICAL TO THE LAST  
FIBRE.

THAT'S BETTER, PANTED MR WEASLEY, BRUSHING DUST FROM HIS  
LONG GREEN TROUSERS AND STRAIGHTENING HIS GLASSES. AM YOU MUST  
BE HARRY'S ALINT AND UNCLE?

TALL, THIN AND BALDING, HE MOVED TOWARDS UNCLE VERNON, HIS  
HANDS OUTSTRETCHED, BUT UNCLE VERNON BACKED AWAY SEVERAL  
PACES, DRAGGING ALINT PETLONIA. WORDS UTTERED FAILED UNCLE

MY HARRY BETTER

VERNON, HIS BEST SUIT WAS COVERED IN WHITE DUST, WHICH HAD  
SETTLED IN HIS HAIR AND MUSTACHE AND MADE HIM LOOK AS  
THOUGH HE HAD JUST AGED THIRTY YEARS.

OR YES SHERRY ASKED THAT, SAID MR WEASLEY, LEANING HIS  
HAND AND LEANING OVER HIS SHOULDER AT THE BURNED FIREPLACE. IT'S



ALL MY FAULT, IT JUST DIDN'T OCCUR TO ME THAT WE WOULDN'T BE ABLE  
TO GET OUT AT THE OTHER END. I HAD YOUR FIREPLACE CONNECTED TO  
THE FLEM NETWORK, YOU SEE. JUST FOR AN AFTERNOON, YOU KNOW,  
SEE WE COULD GET HARRY. MUGGLE FIREPLACES AREN'T SUPPOSED TO BE  
CONNECTED, STRICTLY SPEAKING. BUT I'VE GOT A USEFUL CONTACT AT  
THE FLEM REGULATION PANEL AND HE FIXED IT FOR ME. I CAN PUT IT  
RIGHT IN A MINUTE, THOUGH, WHEN I WANT. I'LL LIGHT A FIRE TO SEND THE  
KIDS BACK, AND THEN I CAN REPAIR YOUR FIREPLACE BEFORE I  
DISAPPEAR.

HARRY WAS READY TO SET THAT THE DURSLEYS HADN'T UNDERSTOOD A

SINGLE WORD OF THIS. THEY WERE STILL GASPING AT MR WEASLEY, THIN-  
DERSTRICK. ALINT PETUNIA STAGGERED UPRIGHT AGAIN, AND HID

BEHIND UNCLE VERNON.

WELL, HARRY? SAID MR WEASLEY BRIGHTLY. GOT YOUR TRUNK  
READY?

IT'S UPSTAIRS, SAID HARRY, GRINNING BACK.

WE'LL GET IT, SAID FRED AT ONCE. WINKING AT HARRY, HE AND  
GEORGE LEFT THE ROOM. THEY KNEW WHERE HARRY'S BEDROOM WAS,  
HAVING ONCE RESCUED HIM FROM IT IN THE DEAD OF NIGHT. HARRY  
SUSPECTED THAT FRED AND GEORGE WERE HOPING FOR A GLIMPSE OF  
DUDLEY; THEY HAD HEARD A LOT ABOUT HIM FROM HARRY.

WELL, SAID MR WEASLEY, SWINGING HIS ARMS SLIGHTLY, WHILE HE  
TRIED TO FIND WORDS TO BREAK THE VERY NASTY SILENCE. VERY  
VERY NICE PLACE YOU'VE GOT HERE.

AS THE USUALLY SPEECHLESS LIVING ROOM WAS NOW COVERED IN DUST

AND KITS OF BRICKS, THIS REMARK DIDN'T GO DOWN TOO WELL WITH THE DURSLEYS, UNCLE VERNON'S FACE PURPLED EVEN MORE, AND ALINT PETLUNIA STARTED CHEWING HER TONGUE AGAIN, HOWEVER, THEY SEEMED TOO SCARED TO ACTUALLY SAY ANYTHING.

MUR WEASLEY WAS BEHINDING AROUND, HE HEARD EVERYTHING THEY

SAY THE TWO CHILDREN AS

WITH MUGGLES, HARRY COULD SEE HIM ITCHING TO GO AND EXAMINE THE TELEVISION AND THE VIDEO RECORDER.

THEY RUN OFF ELECTRICITY, DO THEY? HE SAID KNOWLEDGEABLY.

OH YES, I CAN SEE THE PLUGS, I COLLECT PLUGS, HE ADDED TO UNCLE VERNON, AND BATTERIES, GOT A VERY LARGE COLLECTION OF BATTERIES, MY WIFE THINKS I'M MAD, BUT THERE THEY ARE.

UNCLE VERNON CLEARLY THOUGHT MUR WEASLEY WAS MAD, THEN, HE MOVED EVER SO SLIGHTLY TO THE RIGHT, SCREENING ALINT PETLUNIA FROM VIEW, AS THOUGH HE THOUGHT MUR WEASLEY MIGHT SUDDENLY RUN AT THEM AND ATTACK.

DUDLEY SUDDENLY REAPPEARED IN THE ROOM, HARRY COULD HEAR THE CLUNK OF HIS TRUNK ON THE STAIRS, AND KNEW THAT THE SOUNDS HAD SCARED DUDLEY OUT OF THE KITCHEN, DUDLEY EDGED ALONG THE WALL, GAZING AT MUR WEASLEY WITH TERRIFIED EYES, AND ATTEMPTED TO CONCEAL HIMSELF BEHIND HIS MOTHER AND FATHER.

UNFORTUNATELY, UNCLE VERNON'S ELBOW, WHILE SUFFICIENT TO HIDE BEHIND ALINT PETLUNIA, WAS NOWHERE NEAR ENOUGH TO CONCEAL DUDLEY.

OH, THIS IS YOUR CHLID, IS IT, HARRY? SAID MUR WEASLEY, TAKING ANOTHER BRAVE STEP AT MAKING CONVERSATION.

YEP, SAID HARRY, THAT S DUDLEY,

HE AND RON EXCHANGED GLANCES AND THEN QUICKLY LOOKED AWAY FROM EACH OTHER; THE TEMPTATION THE BLIST'RILT LAUGHING

WAS ALMOST OVERWHELMING, DUDLEY WAS STILL CLUTCHING HIS BHT-  
THEM AS THOUGH AFRAID IT MIGHT FALL OFF, MR WEASLEY, HOWEVER,

SEEMED GENUINELY CONCERNED AT DUDLEY S PECULIAR BEHAVIOUR,  
INDEED, FROM THE TONE OF HIS VOICE WHEN HE NEXT SPEKE, HARRY  
WAS WHITE SURE THAT MR WEASLEY THOUGHT DUDLEY WAS WHITE AS  
MAD AS THE DURSLEY S THOUGHT HE WAS, EXCEPT THAT MR WEASLEY  
FELT SYMPATHY RATHER THAN FEAR,

HAVING A GOOD HOLIDAY, DUDLEY? HE SAID KINDLY,

DUDLEY WHIMPERED, HARRY SAW HIS HANDS TIGHTEN STILL HARDER  
OVER HIS MASSIVE BACKSIDE,

FRED AND GEORGE CAME BACK INTO THE ROOM, CARRYING HARRY S  
SCHEMEL TRUNK, THEY GLANCED AROUND AS THEY ENTERED AND SPOTTED

THE HARRY PEEETTER

DUDLEY, THEIR FACES CRACKED INTO IDENTICAL, EVIL GRINS,

AH, RIGHT, SAID MR WEASLEY, BETTER GET CRACKING, THEN,  
HE PUSHED UP THE SLEEVES OF HIS ROBES AND THEN HLT HIS  
WAND, HARRY SAW THE DURSLEY S DRAW BACK AGAINST THE WALL AS  
HENE,

INCENDIE! SAID MR WEASLEY, POINTING HIS WAND AT THE FIRE IN  
THE WALL BEHIND HIM,

FLAMES ROSE AT ONCE IN THE FIREPLACE, CRACKLING MERRILY AS

THOUGH THEY HAD BEEN BURNING HER FEELERS, MR WEASLEY TOOK A SMALL DRAWSTRING BAG FROM HIS POCKET, UNTIED IT, TOOK A PINCH OF THE POWDER INSIDE AND THREW IT INTO THE FLAMES, WHICH TURNED EMERALD GREEN AND REARED HIGHER THAN EVER.

OFF YOU GO THEN, FRED, SAID MR WEASLEY.

LEAVING, SAID FRED, HE'LL BE LONG EN

A BAG OF SWEETS HAD SPILLED OUT OF FRED'S POCKET AND THE CONTENTS WERE NOW ROLLING IN EVERY DIRECTION BIG, FAT THINGS IN BRIGHTLY COLOURED WRAPPERS.

FRED SCRAMBLED AROUND, CRAMMING THEM BACK INTO HIS POCKET, THEN GAVE THE DURSLEYS A CHEERY WAVE, STEPPED FORWARD AND

WALKED RIGHT INTO THE FIRE, SAYING, THE BURNERS! ALINT PETLINA GAVE A LITTLE SHUDDERING GASP. THERE WAS A WHISPERING SOUND, AND FRED VANISHED.

RIGHT THEN, GEORGE, SAID MR WEASLEY, YOU AND THE TRUNK, HARRY HELPED GEORGE CARRY THE TRUNK FORWARD INTO THE FLAMES, AND TURN IT UNTIL ITS END WAS THAT HE COULD HOLD IT BETTER. THEN, WITH A SECOND WHISPER, GEORGE HAD CRIED, THE BURNERS! AND VANISHED TOO.

THEN, YOU NEXT, SAID MR WEASLEY.

SEE YOU, SAID RON BRIGHTLY TO THE DURSLEYS. HE GRINNED BROADLY AT HARRY, THEN STEPPED INTO THE FIRE, SHOUTED, THE BURNERS! AND DISAPPEARED.

WHEN HARRY AND MR WEASLEY ALONE REMAINED.

WELL ... BUT THEN, HARRY SAID TO THE DURSLEYS,

THEY DIDN'T SAY ANYTHING AT ALL. HARRY MOVED TOWARDS THE FIRE, BUT JUST AS HE REACHED THE EDGE OF THE HEARTH, MR WEASLEY

RACED THE TWO BLINDFOLDED

PLUT PUT A HAND AND HELD HIM BACK. HE WAS LOOKING AT THE DURSLEYS IN AMAZEMENT.

HARRY SAID CHEERUP THE YELL, HE SAID, DIDN'T YELL HEAR HIM?

IT DOESN'T MATTER, HARRY MUTTERED TO MR WEASLEY. HONESTLY, I DON'T CARE.

MR WEASLEY DID NOT REMOVE HIS HAND FROM HARRY'S SHOULDER.

YELL AREN'T GOING TO SEE YOUR NEPHEW TIL NEXT SUMMER, HE SAID TO UNCLE VERNON IN MILD INDIGNATION. SURELY YELL'RE GOING TO SAY CHEERUP?

UNCLE VERNON'S FACE WHISKED FLURRIEDLY. THE IDEA OF BEING TAUGHT CONSIDERATION BY A MAN WHO HAD JUST BLASTED AWAY HALF HIS LIVING-ROOM WALL SEEMED TO BE CAUSING HIM INTENSE SUFFERING.

BUT MR WEASLEY'S HAND WAS STILL IN HIS HAND, AND UNCLE

VERNON'S TINY EYES DARTED TO IT FIRST, BEFORE HE SAID, VERY RESENTFULLY, CHEERUP, THEN.

SEE YELL, SAID HARRY, PLUTTING ONE FOOT FORWARD INTO THE GREEN FLAMES, WHICH FELT PLEASANTLY LIKE WARM BREATH. AT THAT MOMENT, HOWEVER, A TERRIBLE CACKLING SOUND ERUPTED BEHIND

HIM, AND ALINT PETLINIA STARTED THE SCREAM,

HARRY WHEELED AROUND, DUDLEY WAS NOW LONGER STANDING  
BEHIND HIS PARENTS, HE WAS KNEELING BESIDE THE CHIFFER TABLE,  
AND HE WAS GAGGING AND SPILLTERING IN A SHEET-LONG, PURPLE,  
SLIMY THING THAT WAS PROTRUDING FROM HIS MOUTH, HE  
REMLBERED SECOND LATER, HARRY REALISED THAT THE SHEET-LONG THING

WAS DUDLEY'S THINGIE AND THAT A BRIGHTLY COLOURED TEEPEE-  
WRAPPER LAY IN THE FLOOR BEHIND HIM.

ALINT PETLINIA FLURLED HERSELF BENTHE THE GRHLIND BESIDE DUDLEY,  
SEIZED THE END OF HIS SWELLEN THINGIE AND ATTEMPTED THE WRENCH

IT HLT OF HIS MOUTH; UNSURPRISINGLY, DUDLEY YELLED AND SPILT-  
TERED WORSE THAN EVER, TRYING THE FIGHT HER OFF, UNCLE VERNON WAS

REHEWING AND WAVING HIS ARMS AROUND, AND MR WEASLEY HAD THE  
SHELT THE MADE HIMSELF HEARD,

NHT THE WHIRRY, I CAN SHRT HIM HLT! HE YELLED, ADVANCING IN  
DUDLEY WITH HIS WAND HLTSTRETCHED, BUT ALINT PETLINIA

HE HARRY PEETTER

SCREAMED WORSE THAN EVER AND THREW HERSELF IN THEP OF DUDLEY,  
SHIELDING HIM FROM MR WEASLEY,

NH, REALLY? SAID MR WEASLEY DESPERATELY, IT'S A SIMPLE  
PROCESS IT WAS THE TEEPEE MY SHN FRED REAL PRACTICAL INDER  
BUT IT'S ONLY AN ENCHEREMENT CHARM AT LEAST, I THINK IT IS

PLEASE, I CAN CORRECT IT

BUT FAR FROM BEING REASSURED, THE DURSLEYS BECAME MORE PANIC-STRIKEN; AUNT PETUNIA WAS SHRIeking HYSTERICALLY, TUGGING DUDLEY'S TONGUE AS THOUGH DETERMINED TO RIP IT OUT; DUDLEY APPEARED TO BE SUFFOCATING UNDER THE COMBINED PRESSURE OF HIS

MOTHER AND HIS TONGUE, AND UNCLE VERNON, WHO HAD LOST CON-  
TROL COMPLETELY, SEIZED A CHINA FIGURINE FROM THE TOP OF THE SIDE-  
BOARD, AND THREW IT VERY HARD AT MR WEASLEY, WHO CLUCKED,

CAUSING THE ORNAMENT TO SHATTER IN THE BLASTED FIREPLACE.

WELL REALLY? SAID MR WEASLEY, ANGRILY, BRANDISHING HIS WAND.

I'M TRYING TO HELP!

REHEWING LIKE A WHEELING HIPPO, UNCLE VERNON SNATCHED UP  
ANOTHER ORNAMENT.

HARRY, GET OUT GET OUT! MR WEASLEY SHOUTED, HIS WAND IN UNCLE  
VERNON'S HAND. I'LL SHOW THIS HOUSE!

HARRY DIDN'T WANT TO MISS THE FUN, BUT UNCLE VERNON'S  
SECOND ORNAMENT NARROWLY MISSED HIS LEFT EAR, AND HIS BALANCE  
HE THOUGHT IT BEST TO LEAVE THE SITUATION TO MR WEASLEY. HE  
STEPPED INTO THE FIRE, LEANING OVER HIS SHOULDER AS HE SAID, 'THE  
BURNING!'; HIS LAST FLEETING GLIMPSE OF THE LIVING ROOM WAS OF MR  
WEASLEY BLASTING A THIRD ORNAMENT OUT OF UNCLE VERNON'S HAND  
WITH HIS WAND, AUNT PETUNIA SCREAMING AND LYING ON THE TOP OF  
DUDLEY, AND DUDLEY'S TONGUE WHIPPING AROUND LIKE A GREAT SLIMY  
POYSEN. BUT NEXT MOMENT HARRY HAD REGAIN THE SPIN VERY FAST,  
AND THE DURSLEYS' LIVING ROOM WAS WHIPPED OUT OF SIGHT IN A

BLISH OF EMERALD GREEN FLAMES.

## CHAPTER FIVE

WEASLEY'S WIZARD

WEEZES

HARRY SPUN FASTER AND FASTER, KNEES TUCKED TIGHTLY TO HIS SIDES, BLURRED FIREPLACES FLASHING PAST HIM, UNTIL HE STARTED TO FEEL SICK AND CLOSED HIS EYES. THEN, WHEN AT LAST HE FELT HIMSELF SWELING DOWN, HE THREE HLT HIS HANDS, AND BRUGHT HIMSELF TO A HALT IN TIME TO PREVENT HIMSELF FALLING FACE FORWARD HLT OF THE WEASLEY'S KITCHEN FIRE.

DID HE EAT IT? SAID FRED EXCITEDLY, HOLDING HLT A HAND TO PULL HARRY TO HIS FEET.

Yeah, said HARRY, STRAIGHTENING UP. WHAT WAS IT?

THE TINGLY THING, SAID FRED BRIGHTLY. GEORGE AND I INVENTED THEM, WE'VE BEEN LOOKING FOR SOMETHING TO TEST THEM FOR ALL

SUMMER ...

THE TINY KITCHEN EXPLODED WITH LAUGHTER; HARRY LOOKED AROUND AND SAW THAT BEN AND GEORGE WERE SITTING AT THE SCRIBBED WOODEN TABLE WITH THE RED-HAIRED PEOPLE HARRY HAD NEVER SEEN BEFORE, THOUGH HE KNEW IMMEDIATELY WHO THEY MUST BE: BILL AND CHARLIE, THE TWO ELDEST WEASLEY BROTHERS.



“HOW ARE YOU DOING, HARRY?” SAID THE NEARER OF THE TWO, GRINNING AT HIM AND HOLDING OUT A LARGE HAND, WHICH HARRY FELT,

FEELING CALLUSES AND BLISTERS UNDER HIS FINGERS. THIS HAD TO BE CHARLIE, WHO WORKED WITH DRAGONS IN ROMANIA. CHARLIE WAS BUILT LIKE THE TWINS, SHORTER AND STOCKIER THAN PERCY AND RON, WHO WERE BOTH LING AND LANKY. HE HAD A BROAD, CHEERFUL FACE, WHICH WAS WEATHER-BEATEN AND HE FELT THAT HE HAD

SO HARRY PETER

ALMOST TANNED; HIS ARMS WERE MUSCULAR, AND ONE OF THEM HAD A LARGE, SHINY SCAR ON IT.

KILL GOT TO HIS FEET, SMILING, AND ALSO FELT HARRY'S HAND. KILL CAME AS SOMETHING OF A SURPRISE. HARRY KNEW THAT HE WORKED FOR THE WIZARDING BANK, GRINGOTTS, THAT HE HAD BEEN HEAD OF OF HOGWARTS, AND HAD ALWAYS IMAGINED KILL TO BE AN ELDER VERSION OF PERCY; PLISSY ABOUT RILK-BREADING AND FIND OF KISSING EVERYONE ABOUT. HOWEVER, KILL WAS THERE WAS NO OTHER WORD FOR IT. WELL, HE WAS TALL, WITH LONG HAIR THAT HE HAD TIED BACK IN A PONYTAIL. HE WAS WEARING AN EARRING WITH WHAT LOOKED LIKE A FANG DANGLING FROM IT. HIS CLOTHES WOULD NOT HAVE LOOKED OUT OF PLACE AT A ROCK CONCERT, EXCEPT THAT HARRY RECOGNISED HIS KNOTS TO BE MADE, NOT OF LEATHER, BUT OF DRAGON HIDE.

BEFORE ANY OF THEM COULD SAY ANYTHING ELSE, THERE WAS A FAINT PEEPING NOISE, AND MR WEASLEY APPEARED OUT OF THE AIR AT GEORGE'S SHOULDERS. HE WAS LOOKING ANGRIER THAN HARRY HAD EVER

SEEN HIM.

THAT WASN'T FLINDY, FRED? HE SHOUTED, WHAT ON EARTH DID  
YOU GIVE THAT MUGGLE KID?

I DIDN'T GIVE HIM ANYTHING, SAID FRED, WITH ANOTHER EVIL  
GRIN. I JUST DROPPED IT ... IT WAS HIS FAULT HE WENT AND ATE IT, I  
NEVER TOLD HIM THE.

YOU DROPPED IT ON PURPOSE? REARED MR WEASLEY, YOU KNOW  
HE'D EAT IT, YOU KNOW HE WASN'T A DIET

CHILD. DID HIS TONGUE GET? GEORGE ASKED RAGERLY.

IT WAS YOUR MOUTH BEING KEPT HIS PARENTS WOULD LET ME  
SHRINK IT?

HARRY AND THE WEASLEYS REARED WITH LAUGHTER AGAIN.

IT ISN'T FLINDY? MR WEASLEY SHOUTED, THAT SHORT OF BEHAVIOUR  
SERIOUSLY UNDERMINES WIZARD MUGGLE RELATIONS? I SPEND HALF  
MY LIFE CAMPAIGNING AGAINST THE MISTREATMENT OF MUGGLES, AND  
MY OWN SONS

WE DIDN'T GIVE IT TO HIM BECAUSE HE WAS A MUGGLE? SAID FRED  
INDIGNANTLY.

WEASLEY'S WIZARD WE-KIDS S1

NO, WE GAVE IT TO HIM BECAUSE HE'S A GREAT KILLING GIT, SAID  
GEORGE, ISN'T HE, HARRY?

YEAH, HE IS, MR WEASLEY, SAID HARRY EARNESTLY.

THAT'S NOT THE POINT? RAGED MR WEASLEY, YOU WAIT UNTIL I TELL  
YOUR MOTHER

TELL ME WHAT? SAID A VOICE BEHIND THEM.

MRS WEASLEY HAD JUST ENTERED THE KITCHEN. SHE WAS A SHORT,

PUMPED UP WITH A VERY KIND FACE, THOUGH HER EYES WERE PRESENTLY NARROWED WITH SUSPICION.

HELLO, HARRY DEAR, SHE SAID, SPITTING HIM AND SMILING. THEN HER EYES SNAPPED BACK TO HER HUSBAND. TELL ME WHAT, ARTHUR?

MR WEASLEY HESITATED. HARRY COULD TELL THAT, HOWEVER ANGRY HE WAS WITH FRED AND GEORGE, HE HADN'T REALLY INTENDED TO TELL MRS WEASLEY WHAT HAD HAPPENED. THERE WAS A SILENCE, WHILE MR WEASLEY EYED HIS WIFE NERVOUSLY. THEN TWO GIRLS APPEARED IN THE KITCHEN DOORWAY BEHIND MRS WEASLEY. ONE, WITH VERY BLOND CURLY HAIR AND RATHER LARGE FRONT TEETH, WAS HARRY AND RON'S FRIEND, HERMIONE GRANGER. THE OTHER, WHO WAS SMALL AND RED-HAIRED, WAS RON'S YOUNGER SISTER, GINNY. BOTH OF THEM SMILED AT HARRY, WHO GRINNED BACK, WHICH MADE GINNY GO SCARLET. SHE HAD BEEN VERY TAKEN WITH HARRY EVER SINCE HIS FIRST VISIT TO THE BURROW.

TELL ME WHAT, ARTHUR? MRS WEASLEY REPEATED, IN A DANGEROUS SHORT OF BREATH.

IT'S NOTHING, MUM, MUMURED MR WEASLEY. FRED AND GEORGE JUST GOT LOST. I'VE HAD WORDS WITH THEM.

WHAT HAVE THEY DONE THIS TIME? SAID MRS WEASLEY. IF IT'S GOT ANYTHING TO DO WITH WEASLEY'S WIZARD WEAPONS.

WE'D BETTER GO AND CHECK HARRY WHERE HE'S SLEEPING, RON? SAID HERMIONE FROM THE DOORWAY.

HE'S DOWN WHERE HE'S SLEEPING, SAID RON. IN MY ROOM, HE

SLEPT THERE LAST

WE CAN ALL GO, SAID HERMIONE, PHOINTEDLY,

HEY, SAID RON, CHTENING HN, RIGHT,

SE HARRY PEEETTER

YEAH, WE LL COME, THEN, SAID GEORGE

THEY STAY WHERE THEY ARE? SNARLED MRS WEASLEY,

HARRY AND RON EDGED OUT OF THE KITCHEN, AND THEY, HERMIONE  
AND GINNY SET OFF ALONG THE NARROW HALLWAY AND UP THE RICKETY  
STAIRCASE THAT ZIG-ZAGGED THROUGH THE HOUSE TO THE UPPER  
STORIES,

WHAT ARE WEASLEYS WIZARD WHEELS? HARRY ASKED, AS THEY  
CLIMBED,

RON AND GINNY BOTH LAUGHED, ALTHOUGH HERMIONE DIDN'T,

MUM FEELING THIS STUCK HER HARDER FEELS WHEN SHE WAS CLEAN-  
ING FRED AND GEORGE'S ROOMS, SAID RON QUIETLY, GREAT LONG

PRICE-LISTS FOR STUFF THEY'VE INVENTED, THESE STUFF, THEY KNOW, PAPER  
WANDS AND TRICK SWEETS, WEADS OF STUFF, IT WAS BRILLIANT, I NEVER  
KNEW THEY'D BEEN INVENTING ALL THAT ...

WE'VE BEEN HEARING EXPLOSIONS OUT OF THEIR ROOMS FOR AGES,  
BUT WE NEVER THOUGHT THEY WERE ACTUALLY MAKING THINGS, SAID  
GINNY, WE THOUGHT THEY JUST LIKED THE NOISE,

OHNO, MOST OF THE STUFF WELL, ALL OF IT, REALLY WAS A BIT  
DANGEROUS, SAID RON, AND, THEY KNOW, THEY WERE PLANNING TO  
SELL IT AT HOGWARTS TO MAKE SOME MONEY, AND MUM WENT MAD

AT THEM. TOLD THEM THEY WEREN'T ALLOWED THE MAGE AND MORE OF

IT, AND BLUNT ALL THE HARDER PERMS ... SHE'S FLIRTLIS AT THEM ANY-  
WAY. THEY DIDN'T GET AS MANY E.L.L.S AS SHE EXPECTED.

E.L.L.S WERE ORDINARY WIZARDING LEVELS, THE EXAMINATIONS  
HOGWARTS STUDENTS THHX AT THE AGE OF FIFTEEN.

AND THEN THERE WAS THIS BIG RHEW, GINNY SAID, BECAUSE MUM  
WANTS THEM TO GO INTO THE MINISTRY OF MAGIC LIKE DAD, AND THEY  
TOLD HER ALL THEY WANT THE DHE IS OPEN A HHEX-SHEEP.

JUST THEN, A DHEER HEN THE SECOND LANDING OPENED, AND A FACE  
PEEKED OUT WEARING HERN-RIMMED GLASSES AND A VERY ANNOYED  
EXPRESSION.

HI, PERCY, SAID HARRY.

HEI, HELLO, HARRY, SAID PERCY. I WAS WUNDERING WHEH WAS  
MAKING ALL THE NOISE. I'M TRYING TO WORK IN HERE, YELL KNOW  
I'VE GOT A REPORT TO FINISH FOR THE OFFICE AND IT'S RATHER  
DIFFICULT

WASLEY'S WIZARD WORKERS SE

THEY CONCENTRATE WHEN PEOPLE KEEP THUNDERING UP AND DOWN THE  
STAIRS.

WE'RE NOT THUNDERING, SAID PERCY IRRITABLY. WE'RE WALKING.  
SHHRY IF WE'RE DISTURBED THE TOP-SECRET WORKINGS OF THE  
MINISTRY OF MAGIC.

WHAT ARE YOU WORKING ON? SAID HARRY.

A REPORT FOR THE DEPARTMENT OF INTERNATIONAL MAGICAL

COOPERATION, SAID PERCY SMILEY. WE'RE TRYING THE STANDARDISE CALIBRE THICKNESS. SOME OF THESE FOREIGN IMPORTS ARE JUST A SHADE THIN. LEADAGES HAVE BEEN INCREASING AT A RATE OF ALMOST THREE PER CENT A YEAR.

THAT'LL CHANGE THE WORLD, THAT REPORT WILL, SAID REIN. FRONT PAGE OF THE DAILY PROPHET, I EXPECT, CALIBRE LEADS.

PERCY WENT SLIGHTLY PINK.

WELL MIGHT SNEER, REIN, HE SAID HEATEDLY, BUT UNLESS SOME SORT OF INTERNATIONAL LAW IS IMPOSED WE MIGHT WELL FIND THE MARKET FLOODED WITH FLimsY, SHALLOW-KITTENED PRODUCTS WHICH SERIOUSLY ENDANGER

PEACE, PEACE, ALL RIGHT, SAID REIN, AND HE STARTED UP LIPSTAIRS AGAIN. PERCY SLAMMED HIS BEDROOM DOOR SHUT. AS HARRY, HERMIONE AND GINNY FOLLOWED REIN UP THREE MORE FLIGHTS OF STAIRS, SEHLTS FROM THE KITCHEN BELOW REINED UP THE THEM. IT SEEMED AS THOUGH MR WEASLEY HAD TOLD MRS WEASLEY ABOUT THE THEFTS.

THE ROOM AT THE TOP OF THE HOUSE WHERE REIN SLEPT LOOKED MUCH AS IT HAD BEEN THE LAST TIME THAT HARRY HAD COME THE STAY. THE SAME PICTURES OF REIN'S FAVORITE HILDBITCH TEAM, THE CHILDBY CANNONS, WERE WHIRLING AND WAVING ON THE WALLS AND SWEEPING CEILING, AND THE FISH-TANK ON THE WINDOW-SILL WHICH HAD PREVIOUSLY HELD FROG-SPAWN NOW CONTAINED ONE EXTREMELY LARGE FROG. REIN'S OLD RAT, SLACKERS, WAS HERE TOO MORE, BUT INSTEAD THERE WAS THE TINY GREY HELL THAT HAD DELIVERED REIN'S LETTER TO HARRY IN PRIVET DRIVE. IT WAS HOPPING UP AND DOWN IN A SMALL CAGE, AND TWITTERING MADLY.

SHUT UP, PIG, SAID RON, EDGING HIS WAY BETWEEN THEM IN THE

SA HARRY PEEETER

THEIR BEDS THAT HAD BEEN SHELTERED INTO THE ROOM. FRED AND  
GEORGE ARE IN HERE WITH US, BECAUSE BILL AND CHARLIE ARE IN  
THEIR ROOM, HE TOLD HARRY. PERCY GETS TO KEEP HIS ROOM ALL THE  
HIMSELF BECAUSE HE'S GOT THE WHISK.

ER WHY ARE YOU CALLING THAT NEW PIG? HARRY ASKED RON,  
BECAUSE HE'S BEING STUPID, SAID GINNY. ITS PROPER NAME IS  
PIGWHISKER.

Yeah, AND THAT'S NOT A STUPID NAME AT ALL, SAID RON SARCASTI-  
CALLY. GINNY NAMED HIM, HE EXPLAINED THE HARRY. SHE RECKONS

IT'S SWEET, AND I TRIED TO CHANGE IT, BUT IT WAS TOO LATE, HE WENT TO  
ANSWER THE ANYTHING ELSE. SHE NEW HE'S PIG, I'VE GOT TO KEEP HIM  
UP HERE BECAUSE HE ANSWERS PARRIL AND HERMES. HE ANSWERS ME,  
THEY, COME THE THAT,

PIGWHISKER WHIMMED HAPPILY AROUND HIS CAGE, WHISTLING SPRILLY,  
HARRY KNEW RON TOO WELL TO TAKE HIM SERIOUSLY. HE HAD  
MEANED CONTINUALLY ABOUT HIS OLD RAT SLAPPERS, BUT HAD BEEN  
MOST LIPSIT WHEN HERMIONE'S CAT, CRIBBLES-ANDS, APPEARED THE  
HAYE EATEN HIM.

WHERE'S CRIBBLES-ANDS? HARRY ASKED HERMIONE NEW.  
HELT IN THE GARDEN, I EXPECT, SHE SAID. HE LIKES CHASING  
Gnomes, HE'S NEVER SEEN ANY BEFORE.

PERCY'S ENJOYING WHISK, THEN? SAID HARRY, SITTING DOWN IN

HEN HE HEARD THE REDS AND WATCHING THE CHILDREN CARRYING THEMSELVES  
IN AND OUT OF THE HOUSES ON THE CEILING.

KNOWING IT? SAID RON DABLY. I DON'T REMEMBER HE D CAME  
HERE IF DAD DIDN'T MAKE HIM. HE'S MISSED. I JUST DON'T GET HIM  
ABOUT THE SUBJECT OF HIS DEATH. ACCORDING TO MR CRUELTY ... AS I WAS  
SAYING TO MR CRUELTY ... MR CRUELTY IS OF THE OPINION ... MR CRUELTY  
WAS TELLING ME ... THEY WILL BE ANNOUNCING THEIR ENGAGEMENT ANY  
DAY NOW.

HAVE YOU HAD A GOOD SLIMMER, HARRY? SAID HERMION. DID  
YOU GET HER OTHER PARCELS AND EVERYTHING?

YES, THANKS A LOT, SAID HARRY. THEY SAVED MY LIFE, THESE  
CARDS.

AND HAVE YOU HEARD FROM ? RON BEGAN, BUT AT A LOSS FROM

WASLEY'S LIZARD LETTERS IS

HERMION HE FELT SILENT. HARRY KNEW RON HAD BEEN ABOUT THE ASK  
ABOUT SIRILIS. RON AND HERMION HAD BEEN SO DEEPLY INVOLVED  
IN HELPING SIRILIS ESCAPE FROM THE MINISTRY OF MAGIC THAT THEY  
WERE ALMOST AS CONCERNED ABOUT HARRY'S CHOICE AS HE WAS.  
HOWEVER, DISCUSSING HIM IN FRONT OF GINNY WAS A BAD IDEA.  
NEVER LET THEMSELVES AND PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE KNOW ABOUT  
HOW SIRILIS HAD ESCAPED, HE BELIEVED IN HIS INNOCENCE.

I THINK THEY'RE STOPPED ARGUING, SAID HERMION. THE OTHER  
THE ALARMING MOMENT, BECAUSE GINNY WAS WHISKING AWAY  
FROM RON THE HARRY. SHALL WE GO DOWN AND HELP THEM WITH  
DINNER?

YES, ALL RIGHT, SAID RON. THE FEELING OF THEM LEFT RON'S ROOM



AND WENT BACK DOWNSTAIRS, THEN FIND MRS LEASLEY ALONE IN THE KITCHEN, LOOKING EXTREMELY BAD-TEMPERED.

WE'RE EATING OUT IN THE GARDEN, SHE SAID WHEN THEY CAME IN. THERE'S JUST NOT ROOM FOR ELEVEN PEOPLE IN HERE. CHILDREN! TAKE THE PLATES OUTSIDE, GIRLS? BILL AND CHARLIE ARE SETTING UP THE TABLES, KNIVES AND FORKS, PLEASE, CHILDREN. SHE SAID THEN JOHN AND HARRY, POINTING HER HAND A LITTLE MORE VIGOROUSLY THAN SHE HAD INTENDED AT A PILE OF POTATOES IN THE SINK, WHICH SHEET OUT OF THEIR SKINS SHE FAST THAT THEY RICKICKED OFF THE WALLS AND CEILINGS.

OH, FOR HEAVEN'S SAKE, SHE SNAPPED, NOW DIRECTING HER HAND AT A DISTPAN, WHICH HIPPED OFF THE SIDE AND STARTED SKATING ACROSS THE FLOOR, SCHEEPING UP THE POTATOES. THESE TIMES SHE BLAST OUT SAVAGELY, NOW PULLING POTS AND PANS OUT OF A CLIPBOARD, AND HARRY KNOW SHE MEANT FRED AND GEORGE. I DON'T KNOW WHAT'S GOING TO HAPPEN TO THEM, I REALLY DON'T. NO AMBITION, UNLESS YOU WANT MAKING AS MUCH TROUBLE AS THEY POSSIBLY CAN ...

SHE SLAMMED A LARGE CHOPPER SALICPAN DOWN ON THE KITCHEN TABLE AND BEGAN TO WAVE HER HAND AROUND INSIDE IT. A CREAMY SALIC PULSED FROM THE HAND TIP AS SHE STIRRED.

IT'S NOT AS THOUGH THEY HAVEN'T GOT BRAINS, SHE CONTINUED IRRITABLY, TAKING THE SALICPAN OVER THE THE STOVE AND LIGHTING IT

SEE HARRY PEEETTER

WITH A FLUTTER PEEK OF HER HAND, BUT THEY'RE WASTING THEM, AND UNLESS THEY PULL THEMSELVES TOGETHER SOON, THEY'LL BE IN REAL

TRAILER. I VE HAD MORE HILLS FROM F-HIGWATS ABELT THEM THAN THE REST PUT TOGETHER. IF THEY CARRY ON THE WAY THEY RE GOING, THEY LL END UP IN FRONT OF THE IMPROPER USE OF MAGIC OFFICE. MRS WEASLEY JARRED HER HAND AT THE CUTLERY DRAWER, WHICH SHEET OPEN. HARRY AND RON BOTH LIMPED BLIT OF THE WAY AS SEVERAL KNIVES SHARED BLIT OF IT, FLEW ACROSS THE KITCHEN AND BEGAN CHIPPING THE POTATOES, WHICH HAD JUST BEEN TIPPED BACK INTO THE SINK BY THE BLISTPAN.

I DONT KNOW WHERE WE WENT WRING WITH THEM, SAID MRS WEASLEY, PUTTING DOWN HER HAND AND STARTING THE PULL BLIT STILL MORE SALICPANS. IT S BEEN THE SAME FOR YEARS, ONE THING AFTER ANOTHER, AND THEY WONT LISTEN THE HEH, DONT AGAIN? SHE HAD PICKED UP HER HAND FROM THE TABLE, AND IT HAD EMITTED A LILLO SHLIPAD AND TURNED INTO A GIANT RIKKER MELISE. ONE OF THEIR FACE HANDS AGAIN? SHE SHLITED. F-HOW MANY TIMES HAVE I TOLD THESE TWO DONT THEY LEAVE THEM LYING ARIELIND? SHE GRABBED HER REAL HAND AND TURNED ARIELIND THE FIND THAT THE SALICE IN THE STEVE WAS SMOKING.

[ MEEN, RON SAID FLIRRIEDLY THE F-HARRY, SEIZING A HANDFUL OF CUTLERY FROM THE OPEN DRAWER, LET S GO AND HELP BILL AND CHARLIE.

THEY LEFT MRS WEASLEY, AND HEADED BLIT OF THE BACK DOOR INTO THE YARD.

THEY HAD ONLY GONE A FEW PACES WHEN F-TERMINNE S RANDY-LEGGED, GINGER CAT CRIBBSHANDS CAME PELTING BLIT OF THE GARDEN,

BUTTLE-BRUSH-TAIL HELD HIGH IN THE AIR, CHASING WHAT LOOKED LIKE  
A MUDDY PEEWEE WITH LEGS. HARRY RECOGNISED IT INSTANTLY AS A  
ENEMY. BARELY TEN INCHES HIGH, ITS FEINY LITTLE FEET PATTERNED  
VERY FAST AS IT SPRINTED ACROSS THE YARD AND DIVED HEADLONG INTO  
ONE OF THE WELLINGTON SHEETS THAT LAY SCATTERED AROUND THE DEER.  
HARRY COULD HEAR THE ENEMY GIGGLING MADLY AS CRIBBET-HANDS  
INSERTED A PAW INTO THE SHEET, TRYING TO REACH IT. MEANWHILE, A  
VERY LOUD CRASHING NOISE WAS COMING FROM THE OTHER SIDE OF THE

### WASLEY'S WIZARD WHEELS IN

HOUSE. THE SOURCE OF THE COMPLETION WAS REVEALED AS THEY  
ENTERED THE GARDEN AND SAW THAT BILL AND CHARLIE BOTH HAD THEIR  
HANDS SLIT, AND WERE MAKING THE BATTERED OLD TABLES FLY HIGH  
ABOVE THE LAWN, SMASHING INTO EACH OTHER, EACH ATTEMPTING TO  
KNOCK THE OTHER'S SLIT OF THE AIR. FRED AND GEORGE WERE  
CHEERING; GINNY WAS LAUGHING, AND HERMION WAS FEVERING  
NEAR THE HEDGE, APPARENTLY TORN BETWEEN AMUSEMENT AND  
ANXIETY.

BILL'S TABLE CAUGHT CHARLIE'S WITH A FLICK BANG, AND KNOCKED  
ONE OF ITS LEGS OFF. THERE WAS A CLATTER FROM OVERHEAD, AND THEY  
ALL LOOKED UP TO SEE PERCY'S HEAD PEERING SLIT OF A WINDOW ON  
THE SECOND FLOOR.

WILL YOU KEEP IT DOWN? HE BELLEWED.

SHRILL, PERCY SAID BILL, GRINNING. HOW ARE THE CALIBREIN  
BUTTERS COMING NOW?

VERY BADLY, SAID PERCY PEVISHLY, AND HE SLAMMED THE WIN-

BEEN SHUT AGAIN. CHUCKLING, BILL AND CHARLIE DIRECTED THE TABLES

SAFELY BENTH THE GRASS, END THE END, AND THEN, WITH A FLICK OF HIS  
WAND, BILL REATTACHED THE TABLE LEG, AND CHIVILIZED TABLETTHIS  
FROM NEELKHERE.

BY SEVEN H CLOCKS, THE TEN TABLES WERE GRHANING LINDER DISHES  
AND DISHES OF MRS WEASLEY'S EXCELLENT CHHIXING, AND THE NINE  
WEASLEYS, HARRY AND HERMIONE WERE SETTLEING THEMSELVES DEEN  
THE EAT BENEATH A CLEAR, DEEP-BLUE SKY. THE SUMMERHAY WEEN HAD  
BEEN LIVING HEN MEALS OF INCREASINGLY STALE CACK ALL SUMMER, THIS  
WAS PARADISE, AND AT FIRST, HARRY LISTENED RATHER THAN TALKED, AS  
HE HELPED HIMSELF THE CHICKEN-AND-HAM PIE, BEILED PEETATHES AND  
SALAD.

AT THE FAR END OF THE TABLE, PERCY WAS TELLING HIS FATHER ALL  
AKHILIT HIS REPHEIT HEN CALIDOREEN RHITTHENS.

I VE TOLD MR CRHILCH THAT I LL HAVE IT READY BY TUESDAY, PERCY  
WAS SAYING PHEMPHELISLY. THAT'S A KIT SHEENNER THAN HE EXPECTED IT,  
BUT I LIKE THE DEEP HEN THEP OF THINGS. I THINK HE LL BE GRATEFUL I VE

BEENK IT IN CHHED TIME. I MEAN, IT'S EXTREMELY BLISY IN HENR DEPART-  
MENT ILIST NEEN, WHAT WITH ALL THE ARRANGEMENTS FOR THE WEERLD

SE HARRY PEETTER

CLIP, WE RE ILIST NEET GETTING THE SLIPPHERT WE NEED FROM THE  
DEPARTMENT OF MAGICAL GAMES AND SPORTS, LLIDEH KAGMAN

I LIKE LLIDEH, SAID MR WEASLEY MILDLY. HE WAS THE HENK WEEN  
GHEE US SUCH CHHED TICKETS FOR THE CLIP. I DID HIM A KIT OF A

PAYHELM: HIS BROTHER, ETTIE, GET INTO A SPOT OF TROUBLE A LONG-  
MEMBER WITH UNNATURAL PHEWERS I SMEEHED THE WHOLE THING  
EVER.

EH, BAGMAN S LIKEABLE ENOUGH, HE CHURSE, SAID PERCY DISMISS-  
IVELY, BUT WHEN HE EVER GET THE RE HEAD OF DEPARTMENT ... WHEN I

COMPARE HIM THE MR CREELICH I CAN T SEE MR CREELICH BEING A  
MEMBER OF HIS DEPARTMENT AND NOT TRYING TO FIND OUT WHAT S  
HAPPENED TO THEM, YELL REALISE BERTHA JERKINS HAS BEEN MISSING  
FOR EVER A MONTH NOW? WENT ON HOLIDAY TO ALBANIA AND NEVER  
CAME BACK?

YES, I WAS ASKING LUDIE ABELET THAT, SAID MR WEASLEY,  
FRELIVING. HE SAYS BERTHA S GET LOST PLenty OF TIMES BEFORE NOW  
THOUGH I MUST SAY, IF IT WAS SOMEONE IN MY DEPARTMENT, I D  
BE WORRIED ...

EH, BERTHA S HELPLESS, ALL RIGHT, SAID PERCY. I HEAR SHE S BEEN  
SHUNTED FROM DEPARTMENT TO DEPARTMENT FOR YEARS, MUCH MORE  
TROUBLE THAN SHE S WORTH ... BUT ALL THE SAME, BAGMAN HIGHT THE  
BE TRYING TO FIND HER, MR CREELICH HAS BEEN TAKING A PERSONAL  
INTEREST SHE WORKED IN HIS DEPARTMENT AT ONE TIME, YELL KNOW,  
AND I THINK MR CREELICH WAS ELITE FRIEND OF HER BUT BAGMAN JUST  
KEEPS LAUGHING AND SAYING SHE PROBABLY MISREAD THE MAP AND  
ENDED UP IN AUSTRALIA INSTEAD OF ALBANIA, HOWEVER, PERCY  
HEAVED AN IMPRESSIVE SIGH, AND THREW A DEEP SLUG OF EIDERDOWN

WINE, WE'VE GOT WHITE ENOUGH ON OUR PLATES AT THE DEPARTMENT OF INTERNATIONAL MAGICAL CO-OPERATION WITHOUT TRYING THE FINE MEMBERS OF EITHER DEPARTMENTS THEM. AS YELL KNOW, WE'VE GOT ANOTHER BIG EVENT TO ORGANISE RIGHT AFTER THE WERLD CUP. HE CLEARED HIS THROAT SIGNIFICANTLY AND LOOKED DOWN TOWARDS

THE END OF THE TABLE WHERE HARRY, RON AND HERMIONE WERE SITTING. YELL KNOW THE ONE I'M TALKING ABOUT, FATHER. HE RAISED HIS VOICE SLIGHTLY. THE TOP-SECRET ONE.

WEASLEY'S WIZARD WEPPERS 57

RON ROLLED HIS EYES AND MUTTERED TO HARRY AND HERMIONE. HE'S BEEN TRYING TO GET US TO ASK WHAT THAT EVENT IS EVER SINCE HE STARTED WORK. PROBABLY AN EXHIBITION OF THICK-KETTERED CALIBRENS.

IN THE MIDDLE OF THE TABLE, MRS WEASLEY WAS ARGUING WITH BILL ABOUT HIS FARRING, WHICH SEEMED TO BE A RECENT ACQUISITION.

... WITH A TERRIBLE GREAT FANG ON IT, REALLY, BILL, WHAT DO THEY SAY AT THE BANK?

WELL, NEH ONE AT THE BANK GIVES A DAMN HOW I DRESS AS LONG AS I BRING HOME PLenty OF TREASURE, SAID BILL PATIENTLY.

AND YOUR HAIR'S GETTING SILLY, DEAR, SAID MRS WEASLEY, FINGERING HER WAND LEVINGLY. I WISH YELL'D LET ME GIVE IT A TRIM ...

I LIKE IT, SAID GINNY, WHO WAS SITTING BESIDE BILL. SHE WAS SEEING  
HIS FASHIONED, MUM, ANYWAY, IT IS NEITHER NEAR AS LONG AS  
PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE IS ...

NEXT THE MRS WEASLEY, FRED, GEORGE AND CHARLIE WERE ALL  
TALKING SPIRITEDLY ABOUT THE WORLD CUP.

IT IS GETTING IRISH, SAID CHARLIE THICKLY, THROUGH A MOUTH-  
FUL OF POTATO. THEY FLATTENED PERU IN THE SEMI-FINALS.

BULGARIA HAVE GET VICTORY OVER IRELAND, THROUGH, SAID FRED.  
IRELAND IS ONE DECENT PLAYER, IRELAND HAVE GET SEVEN, SAID  
CHARLIE SHORTLY. I WISH ENGLAND HAD GET THROUGH, THROUGH, THAT  
WAS EMBARRASSING, THAT WAS.

WHAT HAPPENED? SAID HARRY RAGERLY, REGRETTING MORE THAN  
EVER HIS ISOLATION FROM THE WIZARDING WORLD WHEN HE WAS STUCK  
IN PRIVET DRIVE. HARRY WAS PASSIONATE ABOUT FLUIDITY. HE HAD  
PLAYED AS SEEKER IN THE GRYPFINDER HOUSE FLUIDITY TEAM EVER  
SINCE HIS FIRST YEAR AT HOGWARTS AND HAD A FIREHORN, ONE OF  
THE BEST RACING BREEDS IN THE WORLD.

WENT DOWN THE TRANSYLVANIA, THREE HUNDRED AND NINETY  
THE TEN, SAID CHARLIE GLENNILY. SICKING PERFORMANCE, AND  
WALES BEAT THE LEGEND, AND SCOTLAND WERE SLAUGHTERED BY  
LUXEMBOURG.

MR WEASLEY LIGHTED UP CANDLES THE LIGHT THE DARKENING

MR HARRY POTTER

GARDEN WHERE THEY HAD THEIR PLANNING HOME-MADE STRAWBERRY

ICE-CREAM, AND BY THE TIME THEY HAD FINISHED, MITHS WERE FLUTTERING AROUND OVER THE TABLE AND THE WARM AIR WAS PERMEATED WITH THE SMELLS OF GRASS AND HONEYSLICKLE. HARRY WAS FEELING EXTREMELY WELL FED AND AT PEACE WITH THE WORLD AS HE WATCHED SEVERAL Gnomes SPRINTING THROUGH THE REED BUSHES, LAUGHING MADLY AND CLOSELY PURSUED BY CREEDS-HANDS.

RHEN LOOKED CAREFULLY UP THE TABLE TO CHECK THAT THE REST OF THE FAMILY WERE ALL BUSY TALKING, THEN HE SAID VERY QUIETLY TO HARRY, 'I HAVE YET TO HEAR FROM SIRILS LATELY.'

HERMIONE LOOKED AHEAD, LISTENING CLOSELY.

'YEAH,' SAID HARRY SOFTLY, 'TWICE. HE SENDS ME, I WROTE TO HIM THE DAY BEFORE YESTERDAY, HE MIGHT WRITE BACK WHILE I'M HERE.'

HE SUDDENLY REMEMBERED THE REASON HE HAD WRITTEN TO SIRILS AND, FOR A MOMENT, WAS ON THE VERGE OF TELLING RHEN AND HERMIONE ABOUT HIS SCAR FLARTING AGAIN, AND ABOUT THE DREAM WHICH HAD AWAKENED HIM ... BUT HE REALLY DIDN'T WANT TO Worry THEM JUST NOW, NOT WHEN HE HIMSELF WAS FEELING SO HAPPY AND PEACEFUL.

LOOK AT THE TIME, MRS WEASLEY SAID SUDDENLY, CHECKING HER WRISTWATCH. 'YOU REALLY SHOULD BE IN BED, THE WHOLE LOT OF YOU, YOU'LL BE UP AT THE CRACK OF DAWN TO GET THE THE CUP, HARRY, IF YOU LEAVE YOUR SCAR LOT ALIVE, I'LL GET YOUR THINGS AND YOUR THIMBLES IN DIAGEN ALLEY, I'M GETTING EVERYONE ELSE'S. THERE MIGHT NOT BE TIME AFTER THE WORLD CUP, THE MATCH WENT ON FOR FIVE DAYS LAST TIME.'

'WELL, HOPE IT DOES THIS TIME!' SAID HARRY ENTHUSIASTICALLY.



WELL, I CERTAINLY DIDN'T, SAID PERCY SARCASMATICALLY, I SHOULD  
BE THE THING WHAT THE STATE OF MY IN-TRAY WOULD BE IF I WAS

AWAY FROM HERE FOR FIVE DAYS,

YEAH, SOMEONE MIGHT SLIP DRAGON BONE IN IT AGAIN, EH,  
PERCY? SAID FRED,

THAT WAS A SAMPLE OF FERTILISER FROM NORWAY? SAID PERCY,  
GOING VERY RED IN THE FACE. IT WAS NOTHING PERSONAL!

WEASLEY'S WIZARD WEPPERS #1

IT WAS, FRED WHISPERED TO HARRY, AS THEY GET UP FROM THE  
TABLE. WE SENT IT.

## CHAPTER SIX

### THE PERTNEY

HARRY FELT AS THOUGH HE HAD BARELY LAIN DOWN THE SLEEP IN WHEN S  
WHEN HE WAS BEING SHAKEN AWAKE BY MRS WEASLEY.

TIME TO GO, HARRY, DEAR, SHE WHISPERED, MOVING AWAY THE  
WAKE WHEN,

HARRY FELT AROUND FOR HIS GLASSES, PUT THEM ON AND SAT UP. IT  
WAS STILL DARK OUTSIDE. WHEN MUTTERED INDISTINCTLY AS HIS MOTHER  
REPLIED HIM. AT THE FOOT OF HARRY'S MATTRESS HE SAW TWO LARGE,  
DISHEVELLED SHAPES EMERGING FROM TANGLES OF BLANKETS.

IS TIME ALREADY? SAID FRED GREGGILY.

THEY DRESSED IN SILENCE, THEN SLEPT, THEN TALKED, THEN YAWNING AND STRETCHING, THEN FEELING OF THEM HEADED DOWNSTAIRS INTO THE KITCHEN.

MRS WEASLEY WAS STIRRING THE CONTENTS OF A LARGE POT ON THE STOVE, WHILE MR WEASLEY WAS SITTING AT THE TABLE, CHECKING A SHEAF OF LARGE PARCEMENT TICKETS. HE LEANED UP AS THE BOYS ENTERED, AND SPREAD HIS ARMS SO THAT THEY COULD SEE HIS CLOTHES MORE CLEARLY. HE WAS WEARING WHAT APPEARED TO BE A CREAKING LIMP AND A VERY OLD PAIR OF JEANS, SLIGHTLY TOO BIG FOR HIM AND HELD UP WITH A THICK LEATHER BELT.

WHAT DO YOU THINK? HE ASKED ANXIOUSLY. WE'RE SLIPPED THE ONE INCHGITH DO I LOOK LIKE A MUGGLE, HARRY?

Yeah, said HARRY, SMILING, VERY GOOD.

WHERE'RE BILL AND CHARLIE AND PER-PER-PERCY? SAID GEORGE, PAILING THE STIRLE A FLICE YAWN.

WELL, THEY'RE APPARATING, AREN'T THEY? SAID MRS WEASLEY, HEAVING THE LARGE POT OVER THE TABLE AND STARTING THE LADLE

THE PORTKEYS

PORTKEY INTO KEELS. SEE THEY CAN HAVE A KIT OF A LIP-IN.

HARRY KNEW THAT APPARATING WAS VERY DIFFICULT; IT MEANT DISAPPEARING FROM ONE PLACE AND REAPPEARING ALMOST INSTANTLY IN ANOTHER.

SEE THEY'RE STILL IN BED? SAID FRED GRUMPILY, PULLING HIS KEEL OF PORTKEY TOWARDS HIM. WHY CAN'T WE APPARATE, THEN?

BECAUSE YOU'RE NOT OF AGE AND YOU HAVEN'T GOTT YOUR TEST, SNAPPED MRS WEASLEY. AND WHERE HAVE THESE GIRLS GOTT THE

SHE KLITLED HLIT HF THE KITCHEN AND THEY HEARD HER CLINKING THE STAIRS,

THEY HAVE THE PASS A TEST THE APPARATE? HARRY ASKED,

HEY YES, SAID MR WEASLEY, TUCKING THE TICKETS SAFELY INTO THE BACK POCKET HF HIS IRONS. THE DEPARTMENT HF MAGICAL TRANSPORTATION HAD THE FINE A CEHUPLE HF PEOPLE THE EITHER DAY FOR APPARATING WITHOUT A LICENCE. IT S NOT EASY, APPARITION, AND WHEN IT S NOT DONE PROPERLY IT CAN LEAD THE NASTY COMPLICATIONS. THIS PAIR I M TALKING ABOUT WENT AND SPLINCHED THEMSELVES,

EVERYONE ABOUT THE TABLE EXCEPT HARRY WINKED,

OR SPLINCHED? SAID HARRY,

THEY LEFT HALF HF THEMSELVES BEHIND, SAID MR WEASLEY, WHEN SPENDING LARGE AMOUNTS HF TREACLE INTO HIS PERRIDGE. SEE HF CHLUSE, THEY WERE STUCK, CHLUSEN T MOVE EITHER WAY, HAD THE WAIT FOR THE ACCIDENTAL MAGIC REVERSAL SEELAD THE SHIRT THEM HLIT, MEANT A FAIR HLD KIT HF PAPERWORK, I CAN TELL YOU, WHAT WITH THE MUGGLES WHO SPENTED THE BODY PARTS THEY D LEFT BEHIND ...

HARRY HAD A SLIDEN VISION HF A PAIR HF LEGS AND AN EYEBALL LYING ABANDONED ON THE PAVEMENT HF PRIVET DRIVE,

WERE THEY HLD? HE ASKED, STARTLED,

HEY YES, SAID MR WEASLEY MATTER-OF-FACTLY, BUT THEY GET A HEAVY FINE, AND I DENN T THINK THEY LL BE TRYING IT AGAIN IN A HURRY, YOU DENN T MESS ABOUT WITH APPARITION, THERE ARE PLENTY

HF ADULT WIZARDS WHO DENN T KEEPER WITH IT, PREFER BREEMIS SLEWER, BUT SAFER,

BUT BILL AND CHARLIE AND PERCY CAN ALL DO IT?

BY HARRY POTTER

CHARLIE HAD TO TAKE THE TEST TWICE, SAID FRED, GRINNING. HE FAILED FIRST TIME, APPARATED FIVE MILES SOUTH OF WHERE HE MEANT THE RIGHT END THEN HE SOME OTHER OLD DEAR BEING HER SHOPPING, REMEMBER?

YES, WELL, HE PASSED SECOND TIME, SAID MRS WEASLEY, MARCHING BACK INTO THE KITCHEN AMID HEARTY SNIGGERS.

PERCY HAD PASSED TWO WEEKS AGO, SAID GEORGE. HE'S BEEN APPARATING DOWNSTAIRS EVERY MORNING SINCE, JUST THE PROVE HE CAN.

THERE WERE FOOTSTEPS DOWN THE PASSAGEWAY AND FERMINE AND GINNY CAME INTO THE KITCHEN, BOTH LOOKING PALE AND DREARLY.

WHY ARE WE HAVE TO BE UP SO EARLY? GINNY SAID, RUBBING HER EYES AND SITTING DOWN AT THE TABLE.

WE'VE GOT A BIT OF A WALK, SAID MR WEASLEY.

WALK? SAID HARRY. WHAT, ARE WE WALKING THE THE WORLD CUP?

NEH, NEH, THAT'S MILES AWAY, SAID MR WEASLEY, SMILING. WE ONLY NEED THE WALK A SHORT WAY, IT'S JUST THAT IT'S VERY DIFFICULT FOR A LARGE NUMBER OF WIZARDS TO CONGREGATE WITHOUT ATTRACTING MUGGLE ATTENTION. WE HAVE TO BE VERY CAREFUL ABOUT HOW WE TRAVEL AT THE BEST OF TIMES, AND IN A HUGE OCCASION LIKE THE

ENLARGED WORLD CLUB

GEORGE! SAID MRS WEASLEY SHARPLY, AND THEY ALL JUMPED,

WHAT? SAID GEORGE, IN AN INNOCENT TONE THAT DECEIVED  
NONE.

WHAT IS THAT IN YOUR POCKET?

NOTHING!

DON'T YOU LIKE THE ME?

MRS WEASLEY POINTED HER HAND AT GEORGE'S POCKET AND SAID,

ACHE!

SEVERAL SMALL, BRIGHTLY COLOURED BEETLES ZIPPED OUT OF

GEORGE'S POCKET; HE MADE A GRAB FOR THEM BUT MISSED, AND THEY  
SPED RIGHT INTO MRS WEASLEY'S OUTSTRETCHED HAND.

WE THOUGHT YOU'D DESTROY THEM! SAID MRS WEASLEY FLURRIEDLY,

THEY PROBABLY ARE

HOLDING UP WHAT WERE UNMISTAKABLY MORE THAN TENGLER

THEPPERS. WE THOUGHT YOU'D GET RID OF THE LEFT! EMPTY YOUR POCKETS,  
OH HEN, WITH ME!

IT WAS AN UNPLEASANT SCENE; THE TWINS HAD EVIDENTLY BEEN  
TRYING THE TRICKS AS MANY THEPPERS OUT OF THE HOUSE AS POSSIBLE,  
AND IT WAS ONLY BY USING HER SLIMMERING CHARM THAT MRS  
WEASLEY MANAGED TO FIND THEM ALL.

ACHE! ACHIE! ACHIE! SHE SCREAMED, AND THEPPERS ZIPPED FROM  
ALL SORTS OF UNLIKELY PLACES, INCLUDING THE LINING OF GEORGE'S  
JACKET AND THE TURTLE-NECK OF FRED'S JEANS.

WE SPENT SIX MONTHS DEVELOPING THESE! FRED SCREAMED AT HIS  
MOTHER, AS SHE THREW THE THEPPERS AWAY.

HEY, A FINE WAY TO SPEND SIX MONTHS? SHE STRIDED, SHE WHEN-  
DER SHE DIDN'T GET MORE HILLS?

ALL IN ALL, THE ATMOSPHERE WAS NOT VERY FRIENDLY AS THEY MADE  
THEIR DEPARTURE. MRS WEASLEY WAS STILL GLEERING AS SHE KISSED  
MR WEASLEY ON THE CHEEK, THOUGH NOT NEARLY AS MUCH AS THE  
TWINs, WHO HAD EACH HOISTED THEIR RUCKSACKS ONTO THEIR BACKS  
AND WALKED AWAY WITHOUT A WORD TO HER.

WELL, HAVE A LIVERY TIME, SAID MRS WEASLEY, AND BEHAVE  
THEMSELVES, SHE CALLED AFTER THE TWINS RETREATING BACKS, BUT THEY  
DID NOT HEED BACK HER ANSWER. I LL SEND BILL, CHARLIE AND PERCY  
ALONG AROUND MIDDAY, MRS WEASLEY SAID TO MR WEASLEY, AS HE,  
HARRY, RON, HERMIONE AND GINNY SET OFF ACROSS THE DARK YARD  
AFTER FRED AND GEORGE.

IT WAS CHILLY AND THE MOON WAS STILL OUT, ONLY A DULL, GREEN-  
ISH TINGE ALONG THE HORIZON THE THEIR RIGHT SHOULD THAT DAYBREAK

WAS DRAWING NEARER, HARRY, HAVING BEEN THINKING ABOUT  
THOUSANDS OF WIZARDS SPEEDING TOWARDS THE FLIMDITCH WORLD  
CUP, SPED UP THE WALK WITH MR WEASLEY.

SHE HELD THEM EVERYONE GET THERE WITHOUT ALL THE MUGGLES  
NOTICING? HE ASKED.

IT S BEEN A MASSIVE ORGANISATIONAL PROBLEM, SIGHED MR  
WEASLEY. THE PROBLEM IS, ABOUT A HUNDRED THOUSAND WIZARDS  
TURN UP THE THE WORLD CUP, AND OF COURSE WE JUST HAVEN'T GOT A

MR HARRY POTTER

MAGICAL SITE BIG ENOUGH TO ACCOMMODATE THEM ALL. THERE ARE PLACES MUGGLES CAN'T PENETRATE, BUT IMAGINE TRYING TO PACK A HUNDRED THOUSAND WIZARDS INTO DIAGON ALLEY OR PLATFORM NINE AND THREE-QUARTERS. SEE WE HAD TO FIND A NICE DESERTED MOOR, AND SET UP AS MANY ANTI-MUGGLE PROTECTIENS AS POSSIBLE. THE WHOLE MINISTRY'S BEEN WORKING ON IT FOR MONTHS. FIRSTLY, OF COURSE, WE HAVE TO STAGGER THE ARRIVALS. PEOPLE WITH CHEAPER TICKETS HAVE TO ARRIVE TWO WEEKS BEFOREHAND. A LIMITED NUMBER USE MUGGLE TRANSPORT, BUT WE CAN'T HAVE TOO MANY CROWDING UP THEIR BUSES AND TRAINS. REMEMBER, WIZARDS ARE COMING FROM ALL OVER THE WORLD. SOME APPARATE, OF COURSE, BUT WE HAVE TO SET UP SAFE POINTS FOR THEM TO APPEAR, WELL AWAY FROM MUGGLES. I BELIEVE THERE'S A HANDBY WHEEL THEY'RE USING AS THE APPARITION POINT. FOR THOSE WHO DON'T WANT TO APPARATE, WE CAN'T, WE USE PORTKEYS. THEY'RE OBJECTS THAT ARE USED TO TRANSPORT WIZARDS FROM ONE SPOT TO ANOTHER AT A PREARRANGED TIME. YOU CAN BE LARGE GROUPS AT A TIME IF YOU NEED THEM. THERE HAVE BEEN TWO HUNDRED PORTKEYS PLACED AT STRATEGIC POINTS AROUND BRITAIN, AND THE NEAREST ONE TO US IS UP THE TOP OF STHEATH-HEAD HILL, SEE THAT'S WHERE WE'RE HEADED.

MR WEASLEY POINTED AHEAD OF THEM, WHERE A LARGE BLACK MASS RISE BEYOND THE VILLAGE OF HITTERY ST CATHERINE.

WHAT SORT OF OBJECTS ARE PORTKEYS? SAID HARRY CURIOUSLY.

WELL, THEY CAN BE ANYTHING, SAID MR WEASLEY. UNUSUAL THINGS, ESPECIALLY, SEE MUGGLES DON'T GET PICKING THEM UP AND

PLAYING WITH THEM ... STUFF THEY LL ILST THINK IS LITTER ...

THEY TRUDGED DOWN THE DARK, DARK LANE TOWARDS THE VILLAGE,  
THE SILENCE BROKEN ONLY BY THEIR FEETSTEPS. THE SKY LIGHTENED  
VERY SLOWLY AS THEY MADE THEIR WAY THROUGH THE VILLAGE, ITS INKY  
BLACKNESS DILUTING THE DEEPEST BLUE. HARRY'S HANDS AND FEET WERE  
FREEZING. MR WEASLEY KEPT CHECKING HIS WATCH.

THEY DIDN'T HAVE BREATH THE SPACE FOR TALKING AS THEY BEGAN THE  
CLIMB STRAIGHT-UP HILL, STUMBLING OCCASIONALLY IN HIDDEN RABBIT  
HOLE, SLIPPING ON THICK BLACK TUFTS OF GRASS. EACH BREATH  
HARRY TOOK WAS SHARP IN HIS CHEST, AND HIS LEGS WERE STARTING THE

THE PHIRTNEY AT

SEIZE UP WHEN AT LAST HIS FEET FOUND LEVEL GROUND.

WELL, PANTED MR WEASLEY, TAKING OFF HIS GLASSES AND WIPING  
THEM ON HIS SWEATER. WELL, WE'VE MADE GOOD TIME WE'VE GOTT  
TEN MINUTES ...

HERMIONIE CAME OVER THE CREST OF THE HILL LAST, CLUTCHING A  
STITCH IN HER SIDE.

NOW WE ILST NEED THE PHIRTNEY, SAID MR WEASLEY, REPLACING  
HIS GLASSES AND STUPEFIED ARCHED AT THE GROUND. IT WEN'T BE BIG  
... COME ON ...

THEY SPREAD OUT, SEARCHING. THEY HAD ONLY BEEN AT IT FOR A  
COUPLE OF MINUTES, HOWEVER, WHEN A SHEET BENT THE STILL AIR.

EVER HERE, ARTHUR! EVER HERE, SEEN, WE'VE GOTT IT!

TWO TALL FIGURES WERE SILHETTED AGAINST THE STARRY SKY ON  
THE EITHER SIDE OF THE HILLTOP.

AMHS! SAID MR WEASLEY, SMILING AS HE STRODE OVER THE TOP



MAN WHO HAD SPELLED, THE REST OF THEM FOLLOWED.

MR WEASLEY WAS SHAKING HANDS WITH A RUDDY-FACED WIZARD

WITH A SCRIBBY GREEN BEARD, WHO WAS HOLDING A MELODY-  
SOUNDING WAND IN HIS OTHER HAND.

THIS IS AMES DIGGORY, EVERYONE, SAID MR WEASLEY. WORKS  
FOR THE DEPARTMENT FOR THE REGULATION AND CONTROL OF MAGICAL  
CREATURES. AND I THINK YOU KNOW HIS SON, CEDRIC?

CEDRIC DIGGORY WAS AN EXTREMELY HANDSOME BOY OF ABOUT  
SEVENTEEN. HE WAS CAPTAIN AND SEEKER OF THE FLYLEAF HOUSE  
QUIDDITCH TEAM AT HOGWARTS.

HI, SAID CEDRIC, WAVING ABOUT AT THEM ALL.

EVERYBODY SAID HI BACK EXCEPT FRED AND GEORGE, WHO

MERELY NODDED. THEY HAD NEVER BEEN FORGIVEN CEDRIC FOR BEAT-  
ING THEIR TEAM, GRAYFINDER, IN THE FIRST QUIDDITCH MATCH OF THE

PREVIOUS YEAR.

LONG WALK, ANTHONY? CEDRIC'S FATHER ASKED.

NOT TOO BAD, SAID MR WEASLEY. WE LIVE JUST ON THE OTHER  
SIDE OF THE VILLAGE THERE. YES?

HAD TO GET UP AT TWO, DIDN'T WE, CED? I TELL YOU, I'LL BE GLAD  
WHEN HE'S GOT HIS APPARITION TEST. STILL ... NOT COMPLAINING ...

XX HARRY POTTER

QUIDDITCH WORLD CUP, WOULDNT MISS IT FOR A SECOND OF

CALLPHENS AND THE TICKETS CHEST AHELT THAT, MIND YELL, LHHKS  
LIKE I GHT HFF EASY ... AMHS DIGCHRY PEERD CHHD-NATLRELY  
ARHLND AT THE THREE WEASLEY KHS, HARRY, HERMIONE AND GINNY,  
ALL THESE YHLRS, ARTHUR?

EH, NEH, HNLV THE RED-HEADS, SAID MR WEASLEY, PHINTING HLIT  
HIS CHILDREN, THIS IS HERMIONE, FRIEND OF PEN S AND HARRY,  
ANOTHER FRIEND

MERLIN S BEARD, SAID AMHS DIGCHRY, HIS EYES WIDENING,  
HARRY? HARRY PHTTER?

ER YEAH, SAID HARRY,

HARRY WAS LIKD TH PEOPLE LHHKING CLRLHLSLY AT HIM WKEN  
THEY MET HIM, LIKD TH THE WAY THEIR EYES MVED AT HNCZ TH THE  
LIGHTNING SCAR HEN HIS FHRK-HEAD, BLT IT ALWAYS MADE HIM FEEL  
LNCHEMFTABLE,

LED S TALKED ARHLT YHL, HF CHLRSE, SAID AMHS DIGCHRY, THLD  
LIS ALL ARHLT PLAYING AGAINST YHL LAST YEAR ... I SAID TH HIM, I  
SAID LED, THAT LL BE SHMETHING TH TELL YHLR GRANDCHILDREN, THAT  
WILL ... YHL REAT HARRY PHTTER?

HARRY CHLDN T THINX HF AND REPLY TH THIS, SH HE REMAINED  
SILENT, FRED AND GEORGE WERE BHTF SCHLNG AGAIN, LEDRIC  
LHHKD SLIGHTLY EMBARRASSED,

HARRY FELL HFF HIS KREHM, DAD, HE MLTTERED, I THLD YHL ... IT  
WAS AN ACCIDENT ...

YES, BLT YHL DIDN T FALL HFF, DID YHL? RHARD AMHS GENIALLY,  
SLAPPING HIS SHN HEN HIS BACK, ALWAYS MEDEST, HLIR LED, ALWAYS  
THE GENTLEMAN ... BLT THE BEST MAN WEN, I M SLIR HARRY D SAY  
THE SAME, WHLDN T YHL, ER? HNR FALLS HFF HIS KREHM, HNR STAYS

HEN, YELL DREN T NEED THE RE A GENIUS THE TELL WHICH HEN S THE BETTER  
FLIER?

MUST BE NEARLY TIME, SAID MR WEASLEY QUICKLY, PULLING OUT  
HIS WATCH AGAIN. DHE YELL DRENH WHETHER WE BE WAITING FOR ANY  
MORE, AMES?

NEE, THE LEVEGENDS HAVE BEEN THERE FOR A WEEK ALREADY AND  
THE FALCETTS CHILDEN T GET TICKETS, SAID MR DICCHRY, THERE AREN T

THE PERTORY BY

AND MORE IF LIS IN THIS AREA, ARE THERE?

NEET THAT I DRENH IF, SAID MR WEASLEY, YES, IT S A MINUTE HFF  
... WE D BETTER GET READY,

HE WHEDD ARIELND AT F-HARRY AND F-HERMINE, YELL ILST NEED THE  
THEICH THE PERTORY, THAT S ALL, A FINGER WILL DEE  
WITH DIFFICULTY, HELING THE THE BLDDY BACKPACKS, THE NINE IF  
THEM CRHEDED ARIELND THE HED KHEET FIELD HLT BY AMES DICCHRY,  
THEY ALL STEHD THERE, IN A TIGHT CIRCLE, AS A CHILL BREEZE SWPT  
EVER THE HILLTHP, DHEEDY SPDEE, IT SLIDDENLY HCLLARED THE F-HARRY  
HHEH HED THIS WHULD HHEH IF A MUEGLE WERE THE WALK UP HERE  
NHEH ... NINE PEEPLE, TWO GREEN MEN, CLUTCHING THIS MANDY HED  
KHEET IN THE SEMI-DARKNESS, WAITING ...

THREE ... MUTTERED MR WEASLEY, HEN EYE STILL HEN HIS WATCH,  
TWEH ... HEN ...

IT HAPPENED IMMEDIATELY: F-HARRY FELT AS THOUGH A HHEH ILST  
BEHIND HIS NAVEL HAD BEEN SLIDDENLY IERRED IRRESISTIBLY  
FHWARDS, HIS FEET HAD LEFT THE GRIELND; HE CHULD FEEL REN AND  
F-HERMINE HEN EITHER SIDE IF HIM, THEIR SHULDRS BANGING INTH

HIS; THEY WERE ALL SPEEDING AHEAD IN A FUEL OF WIND AND SWIRLING CLOUDS; HIS FINGER WAS STUCK IN THE SHEET AS THOUGH IT WAS PULLING HIM MAGNETICALLY FORWARD AND THEN HIS FEET SLAMMED INTO THE GROUND; HE STAGGERED INTO HIM AND HE FELL OVER; THE POINTED HIT THE GROUND NEAR HIS HEAD WITH A HEAVY THUD.

HARRY LEEDED UP, MR WEASLEY, MR DIGGORY AND CEDRIC WERE STILL STANDING, THOUGH LOOKING VERY WINDSWEPT; EVERYBODY ELSE WAS IN THE GROUND.

SEVEN PAST FIVE FROM STATIONHEAD HILL, SAID A VOICE.

## CHAPTER SEVEN

### RACMAN AND CRUELTY

HARRY DISENTANGLED HIMSELF FROM RACMAN AND GOT TO HIS FEET. THEY HAD ARRIVED IN WHAT APPEARED TO BE A DESERTED STREET OF MISTY MOOR. IN FRONT OF THEM WAS A PAIR OF TIRED AND GRIMPY-LOOKING WIZARDS, ONE OF WHOM WAS HOLDING A LARGE OLD WATCH, THE OTHER A THICK ROLL OF PARCHMENT AND A QUILL. BOTH WERE DRESSED AS MUGGLES, THOUGH VERY INEXPERTLY; THE MAN WITH THE WATCH WORE A TWEED SUIT WITH TIGHT-LENGTH CLOTHES; HIS COMPANION, A BUILT AND A PINKIE.

MORNING, RACMAN, SAID MR WEASLEY, PICKING UP THE SHEET AND HANDING IT TO THE BUILT WIZARD, WHO THREW IT INTO A LARGE BOX OF USED POINTEDS BESIDE HIM; HARRY COULD SEE AN OLD NEWSPAPER, AN EMPTY DRINKS CAN AND A PUNCTURED FOOTBALL.

“FELLER THERE, ART-HUR, SAID BASIL WEARILY. NEET HEN DLITY, EH? IT S  
ALL RIGHT FERR SHEE ... WE VE BEEN HERE ALL NIGHT ... YELL D BETTER  
GET HELT OFF THE WAY, WE VE GOTT A BIG PARTY COMING IN FROM THE  
BLACK FOREST AT FIVE FIFTEEN. F-JANE HEN, I LL FIND YELLR CAMP SITE ...  
WEASLEY ... WEASLEY ... HE CONSULTED HIS PARCHMENT LIST.

ARRHIT A BELARTER OFF A MILE S WALK EVER THERE, FIRST FIELD YELL  
THEE THE SITE MANAGER S CALLED MR ROBERTS, DIGGERS ... SECOND  
FIELD ... ASK FERR MR PAYNE.

THANKS, BASIL, SAID MR WEASLEY, AND HE RECKONED EVERYTHING  
THE FELLER HIM.

THEY SET OFF ACROSS THE DESERTED MOOR, UNABLE THE MAKE HELT  
MUCH THROUGH THE MIST. AFTER ARRHIT TWENTY MINUTES, A SMALL  
STONE CHITTAG NEXT THE A GATE SWAM INTO VIEW. BEYOND IT, F-JARRY  
CHULD ILST MAKE HELT THE GHOSTLY SHAPES OF HUNDREDS AND

## BAGMAN AND CREELIX 71

HUNDREDS OF TENTS, RISING UP THE GENTLE SLOPE OF A LARGE FIELD  
TOWARDS A DARK LINE IN THE HORIZON. THEY SAID CHEERFUL THE THE  
DIGGERS, AND APPROACHED THE CHITTAG MOOR.

A MAN WAS STANDING IN THE MOORWAY, LEERING HELT AT THE TENTS.  
F-JARRY KNEW AT A GLANCE THAT THIS WAS THE ONLY REAL MUGGLE FERR  
SEVERAL ACRES. WHEN HE HEARD THEIR FEETSTEPS, HE TURNED HIS  
HEAD THE LINE AT THEM.

“MORNING!” SAID MR WEASLEY BRIGHTLY.

“MORNING,” SAID THE MUGGLE.

“WOULD YELL BE MR ROBERTS?”

“AYE, I WOULD,” SAID MR ROBERTS. “AND WHERE RE YELL?”

WEASLEY TWO TENTS, KINNED A CHILPIL IF DAYS AGH?

AYE, SAID MR RHEERTS, CONSULTING A LIST TACKED THE THE DEER,

YELL YE GET A SPACE UP BY THE WHEED THERE, ILST THE HNE NIGHT?

THAT S IT, SAID MR WEASLEY,

YELL LL BE PAYING NEEL, THEN? SAID MR RHEERTS,

AH RIGHT CERTAINLY SAID MR WEASLEY, HE RETREATED A  
SEHRT DISTANCE FROM THE CHITTAG AND RECKENED HARRY THEWARDS  
HIM, HELP ME, HARRY, HE MUTTERED, PULLING A RHEIL IF MUGGLE  
MONEY FROM HIS POCKET AND STARTING TH PEEL THE NHTES APART,

THIS HNE S A A A TEN? AH YES, I SEE THE LITTLE NUMBER HEN IT  
NEEL ... SEE THIS IS A FIVE?

A TWENTY, HARRY CORRECTED HIM IN AN UNDERTHINK, UNCHAMPERT-  
ABLY AWARE IF MR RHEERTS TRYING TH CATCH EVERY WHEED,

AH YES, SEE IT IS ... I DEN T KNOW, THESE LITTLE BITS IF PAPER ...

YELL FERRIGN? SAID MR RHEERTS, AS MR WEASLEY RETURNED WITH  
THE CORRECT NHTES,

FERRIGN? REPEATED MR WEASLEY, PUZZLED,

YELL RE NHT THE FIRST HNE WHE S HAD TREUBLE WITH MONEY, SAID  
MR RHEERTS, SCRLTINISING MR WEASLEY CLESELY, I HAD TWEE TRY AND  
PAY ME WITH GREAT CHILD CHINS THE SIZE IF FLICKAPS TEN MINUTES  
AGH,

DID YELL REALLY? SAID MR WEASLEY NERVHELSLY,

MR RHEERTS RUMMAGED AROUND IN A TIN FOR SHME CHANGE,

NEVER BEEN THIS CREWDED, HE SAID SLDDENLY, LHEEKING ELIT

HE HARRY PETER

EVER THE MISTY FIELD AGAIN. HUNDREDS OF PRE-KINDINGS, PEOPLE USUALLY JUST TURN UP ...

IS THAT RIGHT? SAID MR WEASLEY, HIS HAND FELD HLT FOR HIS CHANGE, BUT MR REBERTS DIDN T GIVE IT TO HIM.

AYE, HE SAID TRULIGHTFULLY. PEOPLE FROM ALL OVER, LEADS OF FOREIGNERS, AND NOT JUST FOREIGNERS, WIZARDS, WELL KNOWN? THERE S A BLIND WALKING BEHIND IN A DIRT AND A PENCIL-EE.

SHOULDNT HE? SAID MR WEASLEY ANXIOUSLY.

IT S LIKE SOME SORT OF ... I DUNNO ... LIKE SOME SORT OF RALLY, SAID MR REBERTS. THEY ALL SEEM TO KNOW EACH OTHER, LIKE A BIG PARTY.

AT THAT MOMENT, A WIZARD IN PALLS-PELRS APPEARED HLT OF THIN AIR NEXT TO MR REBERTS S FRONT DEER.

HELIVATE? HE SAID SHARPLY, POINTING HIS WAND AT MR REBERTS. INSTANTLY, MR REBERTS S EYES SLID HLT OF FELLS, HIS EYELIDS LIDENITTED AND A LIND OF DREAMY LINDERNERN FELL OVER HIS FACE. HARRY RECOGNISED THE SYMPTOMS OF HNK W-TH HAD JUST HAD HIS MEMORY MODIFIED.

A MAP OF THE CAMPSITE FOR WELL, MR REBERTS SAID PLACIDLY TO MR WEASLEY, AND THEIR CHANGE.

THANKS VERY MUCH, SAID MR WEASLEY.

THE WIZARD IN PALLS-PELRS ACCOMPANIED THEM TOWARDS THE GATE TO THE CAMPSITE. HE LOOKED EXHAUSTED; HIS CHIN WAS BLUE WITH STUBBLE AND THERE WERE DEEP PURPLE SHADOWS UNDER HIS EYES. HENCE HLT OF PARS-ET OF MR REBERTS, HE MUTTERED TO MR WEASLEY, BEEN HAVING A BIT OF TROUBLE WITH HIM. NEEDS A

MEMPHY CHARM TEN TIMES A DAY TO KEEP HIM HAPPY, AND LUDWIG  
RAGMAN'S NEET HELPING, TREATING ARTHUR TALKING ARTHUR BLUDGERS

AND BRUJAS AT THE TOP OF HIS VEIL, NEET A WHIRRY ARTHUR ANTI-  
MUGGLE SECURITY, BLIMBY, I'LL BE GLAD WHEN THIS IS OVER, SEE YELL

LATER, ARTHUR,

HE DISAPPEARED,

I THOUGHT MR RAGMAN WAS HEAD OF MAGICAL GAMES AND  
SPORTS? SAID GINNY, LOOKING SURPRISED. HE SHOULD KNOW BETTER  
THAN THE TALK ARTHUR BLUDGERS NEAR MUGGLES, SHOULDN'T HE?

RAGMAN AND CRELLIN TO

HE SHOULD, SAID MR GRASLEY, SMILING, AND LEADING THEM  
THROUGH THE GATES INTO THE CAMPSITE, BUT LUDWIG'S ALWAYS  
BEEN A BIT ... WELL ... LAX ARTHUR SECURITY, YELL CHILDREN T WISH  
FOR A MORE ENTHUSIASTIC HEAD OF THE SPORTS DEPARTMENT,  
THOUGH, HE PLAYED BLOODITCH FOR ENGLAND HIMSELF, YELL  
KNOW, AND HE WAS THE BEST BEATER THE WIMBORNE WASPS EVER  
HAD.

THEY TRUDGED UP THE MISTY FIELD BETWEEN LONG ROWS OF TENTS,  
MEET LOOKED ALMOST ORDINARY; THEIR OWNERS HAD CLEARLY TRIED TO  
MAKE THEM AS MUGGLE-LIKE AS POSSIBLE, BUT HAD SLIPPED UP BY  
ADDING CHIMNEYS, OR KILL-PILLS, OR WEATHER-VANES. HOWEVER,  
HERE AND THERE WAS A TENT SEE HEAVILY MAGICAL THAT HARRY

WOULD HARDLY BE SURPRISED THAT MR ROBERTS WAS GETTING SUSPI-



CHILD, FOLLOWING UP THE FIELD STEEP AN EXTRAVAGANT CONFECTION OF

STRIPED SILK LIKE A MINIATURE PALACE, WITH SEVERAL LIVE PEACOCKS  
TETHERED AT THE ENTRANCE. A LITTLE FURTHER ON THEY PASSED A TENT  
THAT HAD THREE FLOORS AND SEVERAL TURRETS; AND A SHORT WAY  
BEYOND THAT WAS A TENT WHICH HAD A FRONT GARDEN ATTACHED,  
COMPLETE WITH KIDNEY, SUNDIAL AND FOUNTAIN.

ALWAYS THE SAME, SAID MR WEASLEY, SMILING, WE CAN'T RESIST  
SHOWING OFF WHEN WE GET TOGETHER. AH, HERE WE ARE, LOOK, THIS  
IS US.

THEY HAD REACHED THE VERY EDGE OF THE WOOD AT THE TOP OF  
THE FIELD, AND HERE WAS AN EMPTY SPACE, WITH A SMALL SIGN  
HAMMERED INTO THE GROUND THAT READ WEEZLY.

COULDN'T HAVE A BETTER SPOT! SAID MR WEASLEY HAPPILY. THE  
PITCH IS JUST ON THE OTHER SIDE OF THE WOOD THERE, WE'RE AS CLOSE  
AS WE COULD BE. HE WHISTLED HIS BACKPACK FROM HIS SHOULDERS.

RIGHT, HE SAID EXCITEDLY, NO MAGIC ALLOWED, STRICTLY SPREADING,  
NOT WHEN WE'RE HILT IN THESE NUMBERS IN MUGGLE LAND. WE'LL BE  
PLOTTING THESE TENTS UP BY HAND! SHOULDN'T BE TOO DIFFICULT ...  
MUGGLES DO IT ALL THE TIME ... HERE, HARRY, WHERE DO YOU THINK  
WE SHOULD START?

HARRY HAD NEVER BEEN CAMPING IN HIS LIFE; THE DURSLEYS HAD  
NEVER TAKEN HIM ON ANY KIND OF HOLIDAY, PREFERING TO LEAVE

MR HARRY PETER

HIM WITH MRS FIGG, AN OLD NEIGHBOR. HOWEVER, HE AND  
HERMIONE WERE HELD WHERE MOST OF THE PEEKS AND PEGS

SHOULD GO, AND THOUGH MR WEASLEY WAS MORE OF A HINDRANCE  
THAN A HELP, BECAUSE HE GOT THOROUGHLY EVER-EXCITED WHEN IT  
CAME TO LIFTING THE Mallet, THEY FINALLY MANAGED TO ERECT A PAIR  
OF SHAKY TWIN-MAN TENTS.

ALL OF THEM STOOD BACK TO ADMIRE THEIR HANDIWORK. NEARBY  
LOOKING AT THESE TENTS WOULD GUESS THEY BELONGED TO WIZARDS,  
HARRY THOUGHT, BUT THE PROBLEM WAS THAT SINCE BILL, CHARLIE AND  
PERCY ARRIVED, THEY WOULD BE A PARTY OF TEN. HERMIONE SEEMED  
TO HAVE SPOTTED THIS PROBLEM, THEN, SHE GAVE HARRY A FUZZY  
LOOK AS MR WEASLEY DROPPED HIS HANDS AND KNEES AND  
ENTERED THE FIRST TENT.

WE'LL BE A BIT CRAMPED, HE CALLED, BUT I THINK WE'LL ALL  
SLEEPER IN. COME AND HAVE A LOOK.

HARRY BENT DOWN, PEEKED UNDER THE TENT FLAP, AND FELT HIS

HAIR DRIP. HE HAD WALKED INTO WHAT LOOKED LIKE AN OLD-  
FASHIONED, THREE-ROOMED FLAT, COMPLETE WITH KITCHEN AND

KITCHEN. EDDY ENOUGH, IT WAS FURNISHED IN EXACTLY THE SAME  
SORT OF STYLE AS MRS FIGG'S; THERE WERE CHECKERED CLOVERS ON THE  
MISMATCHED CHAIRS, AND A STRONG SMELL OF CATS.

WELL, IT'S NOT APOOR LINE, SAID MR WEASLEY, MIPPING HIS BALD  
PATCH WITH A HANDKERCHIEF AND PEERING IN AT THE FEELER BLIND  
REDS THAT STOOD IN THE BEDROOM. I REMEMBERED THIS FROM PERKINS  
AT THE OFFICE, DOESN'T CAMP MUCH ANY MORE, PERHAPS FELLED, HE'S  
GOT LIMPAGE.

HE PICKED UP THE DUSTY KETTLE AND PEERED INSIDE IT. WE'LL

NEED WATER ...

THERE'S A TAP MARKED ON THIS MAP THE MUGGLE GAVE US, SAID  
RON, WHO HAD PEELED HARRY INSIDE THE TENT, AND SEEMED  
COMPLETELY UNIMPRESSED BY ITS EXTRAORDINARY INNER PROPERTIES.  
IT'S ON THE OTHER SIDE OF THE FIELD.

WELL, WHY DON'T YOU, HARRY AND HERMIONE GO AND  
GET US SOME WATER, THEN. MR WEASLEY HANDED OVER  
THE KETTLE AND A COUPLE OF SALIPANS, AND THE REST OF

BAGMAN AND CRUELTY AS

US WILL GET SOME WOOD FOR A FIRE.

BUT WE'VE GOT AN EVEN, SAID RON, WHY CAN'T WE JUST ?

RON, ANTI-MUGGLE SECURITY? SAID MR WEASLEY, HIS FACE  
SHINING WITH ANTICIPATION. WHEN REAL MUGGLES CAMP, THEY  
LIGHTEN FIRES ELITEERS, I'VE SEEN THEM AT IT!

AFTER A QUICK TOUR OF THE GIRLS' TENT, WHICH WAS SLIGHTLY SMALLER  
THAN THE BOYS', THROUGH WITHOUT THE SMELL OF CATS, HARRY, RON

AND HERMIONE SET OFF ACROSS THE CAMPSITE WITH THE KETTLE AND  
SALIPANS.

WELL, WITH THE SUN NEWLY RISEN AND THE MIST LIFTING, THEY  
COULD SEE THE CITY OF TENTS THAT STRETCHED IN EVERY DIRECTION.  
THEY MADE THEIR WAY SLOWLY THROUGH THE REELS, STARING EAGERLY  
AROUND. IT WAS ONLY JUST DAWNING ON HARRY HOW MANY WITCHES

AND WIZARDS THERE MUST BE IN THE WORLD; HE HAD NEVER REALLY  
THOUGHT MUCH ABOUT THEM IN OTHER COUNTRIES.

THEIR FELLOW CAMPERS WERE STARTING TO WAKE UP, FIRST THE STIR  
WERE THE FAMILIES WITH SMALL CHILDREN; HARRY HAD NEVER SEEN  
WITCHES AND WIZARDS THIS YOUNG BEFORE. A TINY BOY NOT MUCH  
OLDER THAN THEY WAS CRAWLED OUTSIDE A LARGE PYRAMID-SHAPED TENT,  
HOLDING A WAND AND PEERING HAPPILY AT A SLUG IN THE GRASS,  
WHICH WAS SWELLING SLOWLY TO THE SIZE OF A SALAMI. AS THEY DREW  
LEVEL WITH HIM, HIS MOTHER CAME FLURRYING OUT OF THE TENT.  
HEEN MANY TIMES, DEVIN? SHE'D BEEN T TELLING DADDY'S WAND  
WELCH?

SHE HAD TRODDEN ON THE GIANT SLUG, WHICH BURST. HER SCOLD-  
ING CARRIED AFTER THEM ON THE STILL AIR, MINGLING WITH THE LITTLE

BOY'S YELLS SHE'D BURST SLUG! SHE'D BURST SLUG!

A SHORT WAY FURTHER ON, THEY SAW TWO LITTLE WITCHES, RARELY  
OLDER THAN DEVIN, WHO WERE RIDING TWO BROOMSTICKS WHICH ROSE  
ONLY HIGH ENOUGH FOR THE GIRLS OVER THE DRY GRASS. A  
MINISTRY WIZARD HAD ALREADY SPOTTED THEM; AS HE FLURRIED PAST  
HARRY, RON AND HERMION, HE MUTTERED DISTRACTEDLY, IN BRIGHT  
DAYLIGHT! PARENTS HAVING A LIE-IN, I SUPPOSE

HERE AND THERE ADULT WIZARDS AND WITCHES WERE EMERGING  
FROM THEIR TENTS AND STARTING THE CHIEF BREAKFAST. SOME, WITH

THE HARRY PEEETER

FLUTTERING WINGS AROUND THEM, KINDLED FIRES WITH THEIR WANDS;

BUTHERS WERE STRIKING MATCHES WITH OLIVEHUS LEEKS IN THEIR  
FACES, AS THOUGH SURE THIS CHILDEN T WERE. THREE AFRICAN WIZARDS  
SAT IN SERIOUS CONVERSATION, ALL OF THEM WEARING LONG WHITE  
BEES AND REASTING WHAT LEEKED LIKE A RABBIT IN A BRIGHT PURPLE  
FIRE, WHILE A GROUP OF MIDDLE-AGED AMERICAN WITCHES SAT CHIS-  
SING HAPPILY BENEATH A SPANGLED BANNER STRETCHED BETWEEN

THEIR TENTS WHICH READ: THE SALEM WITCHES INSTITUTE. HARRY  
CALGHT SNATCHES OF CONVERSATION IN STRANGE LANGUAGES FROM THE  
INSIDE OF TENTS THEY PASSED, AND THOUGH HE CHILDEN T UNDERSTAND  
A SINGLE WORD, THE TUNE OF EVERY SINGLE VOICE WAS EXCITED.

ER IS IT MY EYES, OR HAS EVERYTHING GONE GREEN? SAID RON.  
IT WASN'T JUST RON'S EYES. THEY HAD WALKED INTO A PATCH OF  
TENTS THAT WERE ALL COVERED WITH A THICK GROWTH OF SHAMROCKS,  
SEE THAT IT LEEKED AS THOUGH SMALL, HEDLY SHAPED HILLSIDES HAD  
SPRUNGLED OUT OF THE EARTH. GRINNING FACES COULD BE SEEN UNDER  
THESE WHICH HAD THEIR FLAPS UPEN. THEN, FROM BEHIND THEM,  
THEY HEARD THEIR NAMES.

HARRY! RON! HERMIONE!

IT WAS SEAMUS FINNIGAN, THEIR FELLOW GRYFFINDOR FIFTH-YEAR.  
HE WAS SITTING IN FRONT OF HIS OWN SHAMROCK-COVERED TENT, WITH  
A SANDY-HAIRED WOMAN WHO HAD THE BE HIS MOTHER, AND HIS BEST  
FRIEND, DEAN THOMAS, ALSO OF GRYFFINDOR.

LIKE THE DECEMBER? SAID SEAMUS, GRINNING, WHEN HARRY,  
RON AND HERMIONE HAD GONE EVER THE DAY BEFORE. THE MINISTRY'S  
WENT THEM HAPPY.

AND WHY SHOULDN'T WE SHOW HER CHAIRS? SAID MRS

FINNIGAN. WHY SHOULD SEE WHAT THE BULGARIANS HAVE GOT DAN-  
GLING ALL OVER THEIR TENTS. WHY BE SLIPPERING IRELAND, IF

CHAIRS? SHE ADDED, EYING HARRY, BEN AND HERMINEE READILY.

WHEN THEY HAD ASSURED HER THAT THEY WERE INDEED SLIPPER-  
ING IRELAND, THEY SET OFF AGAIN, THOUGH, AS BEN SAID, LIKE WE'D

SAID ANYTHING ELSE SLIPPERING BY THAT LEFT.

I WONDER WHAT THE BULGARIANS HAVE GOT DANGLING ALL OVER  
THEIR TENTS? SAID HERMINEE.

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LET'S GO AND HAVE A LOOK, SAID HARRY, POINTING TO A LARGE  
PATCH OF TENTS UPFIELD, WHERE THE BULGARIAN FLAG, RED, GREEN AND  
WHITE, WAS FLUTTERING IN THE BREEZE.

THE TENTS HERE HAD NOT BEEN REDDED WITH PLANT LIFE, BUT  
EACH AND EVERY ONE OF THEM HAD THE SAME POSTER ATTACHED TO IT,  
A POSTER OF A VERY SLURRY FACE WITH HEAVY BLACK EYEBROWS. THE  
PICTURE WAS OF COURSE MOVING, BUT ALL IT DID WAS BLINK AND  
STELL.

GRIM, SAID BEN BRISKLY.

WHAT? SAID HERMINEE.

GRIM? SAID BEN. VICTOR GRIM, THE BULGARIAN SEER?

HE LOOKS REALLY GRIMMY, SAID HERMINEE, LOOKING AROUND AT

THE MANY GRIMES BLINKING AND SCHEWING AT THEM.

REALLY GRIMPY ? THEN RAISED HIS EYES TO THE HEAVENS. WHO CARES WHAT HE LOOKS LIKE? HE'S UNBELIEVABLE, HE'S REALLY YELING, THEN, ONLY JUST EIGHTEEN OR SOMETHING, HE'S A GENIUS, YOU WAIT UNTIL TONIGHT, YOU'LL SEE.

THERE WAS ALREADY A SMALL HELIX FOR THE TAP IN THE CORNER OF THE FIELD, HARRY, THEN AND HERMIONE JOINED IT, RIGHT BEHIND A PAIR OF MEN WHO WERE HAVING A HEATED ARGUMENT. ONE OF THEM

WAS A VERY OLD WIZARD WHO WAS WEARING A LONG SILVERY NIGHT-GOWN. THE OTHER WAS CLEARLY A MINISTRY WIZARD; HE WAS WEARING

ELITE A PAIR OF PINSTRIPED TROUSERS AND ALMOST CRYING WITH EXASPERATION.

JUST PUT THEM ON, ARCHIE, THERE'S A GOOD CHAP, YOU CAN'T WALK AROUND LIKE THAT, THE MUGGLE IN THE GATE'S ALREADY GETTING SUSPICIOUS

I REMIGHT THIS IN A MUGGLE SHOP, SAID THE OLD WIZARD STUBBERNLY. MUGGLES WEAR THEM.

MUGGLE WOMEN WEAR THEM, ARCHIE, NOT THE MEN, THEY WEAR

THESE, SAID THE MINISTRY WIZARD, AND HE BRANDISHED THE PINSTRIPE TROUSERS.

I'M NOT PUTTING THEM ON, SAID OLD ARCHIE IN INDIGNATION. I

LIKE A HEALTHY BREEZE BEHIND MY PRIVATES, THANKS,

HERMIONE WAS EVERYWHERE WITH SUCH A STRONG FIT OF THE GIGGLES

TO HARRY PETER

AT THIS POINT THAT SHE HAD THE BLIND BLIT OF THE BLINKIE, AND ONLY RETURNED WHEN ARCHIE HAD COLLECTED HIS WATER AND MOVED AWAY AGAIN.

WALKING MORE SLOWLY NOW, BECAUSE OF THE WEIGHT OF THE WATER, THEY MADE THEIR WAY BACK THROUGH THE CAMPSITE, THERE AND THERE THEY SAW MORE FAMILIAR FACES: EITHER HOGWARTS STUDENTS WITH THEIR FAMILIES, ELIVER WOOD, THE OLD CAPTAIN OF HARRY'S HOUSE HURDITCH TEAM, WHO HAD JUST LEFT HOGWARTS, DRAGGED HARRY OVER THE HIS PARENTS' TENT THE INTRODUCTION HIM, AND TOLD HIM EXCITEDLY THAT HE HAD JUST BEEN SIGNED THE THE PLUMMER UNITED RESERVE TEAM. NEXT THEY WERE HAILED BY ERIC MACMILLAN, A HURDLEPUFF FORTY-FOUR, AND A LITTLE FURTHER ON THEY SAW LEE CHANG, A VERY PRETTY GIRL WHO PLAYED SEEKER FOR THE RAVENCLAW TEAM. SHE WAVED AND SMILED AT HARRY, WHO SHOOKED HIS HEAD AS HE SAW HER WATER BEHIND HIS FRONT AS HE WAVED BACK. MORE THE STEP THEN SMIRKING THAN ANYTHING, HARRY FLURRIEDLY POINTED OUT A LARGE GROUP OF TEENAGERS WHOSE HE HAD NEVER SEEN BEFORE.

WHO DO YOU RECOGNISE THEY ARE? HE SAID. THEY DON'T GO TO HOGWARTS, DO THEY?

SURE THEY GO TO THE SAME FOREIGN SCHOOL, SAID RON. I KNOW THERE ARE OTHERS, NEVER MET ANYONE WHO WENT THE WAY THROUGH. BILL HAD A PEN-FRIEND AT A SCHOOL IN BRAZIL ... THIS WAS YEARS AND



YEARS AGO ... AND HE WANTED THE GIBBONS AN EXCHANGE TRIP BUT MUM  
AND DAD COULDN'T AFFORD IT. HIS PEN-FRIEND GIBB ALL HOPPEDED  
WHEN HE SAID HE WASN'T GOING AND SENT HIM A CURSED HAT. IT  
MADE HIS EARS SPRING UP.

HARRY LAUGHED, BUT DIDN'T VEIL THE AMAZEMENT HE FELT AT  
HEARING ABOUT EITHER WIZARDING SCHOOLS. HE SUPPOSED, WHEN HE  
SAW REPRESENTATIVES OF SO MANY NATIONALITIES IN THE CAMPSITE,  
THAT HE HAD BEEN STUPID NEVER TO REALISE THAT HOGWARTS  
COULDN'T BE THE ONLY ONE. HE GLANCED AT HERMION, WHO LOOKED  
LITTERALLY UNSURPRISED BY THE INFORMATION. SHE BELIEVED SHE HAD RUN  
ACROSS THE NEWS ABOUT EITHER WIZARDING SCHOOLS IN SOME BOOK  
OR OTHER.

## RAGMAN AND CRUELTY TO

WELL WE BEEN AGES, SAID GEORGE, WHEN THEY FINALLY GOT BACK  
TO THE WEASLEYS' TENTS.

MET A FEW PEOPLE, SAID BEN, SETTING THE WATER BOILING. WELL  
NOT GET THAT FIRE STARTED YET?

DAD'S HAVING FUN WITH THE MATCHES, SAID FRED.

MR WEASLEY WAS HAVING NO SUCCESS AT ALL IN LIGHTING THE FIRE,  
BUT IT WASN'T FOR LACK OF TRYING. SPLINTERED MATCHES LITTERED THE  
GROUND AROUND HIM, BUT HE LOOKED AS THOUGH HE WAS HAVING  
THE TIME OF HIS LIFE.

HEAPS! HE SAID, AS HE MANAGED TO LIGHT A MATCH, AND PROMPT-  
LY DROPPED IT IN SURPRISE.

COME HERE, MR WEASLEY, SAID FERMINE KINDLY, TAKING THE  
BOOK FROM HIM, AND STARTING TO SHOW HIM HOW TO DO IT PROPERLY.  
AT LAST, THEY GOT THE FIRE LIT, THOUGH IT WAS AT LEAST ANOTHER  
MINUTE BEFORE IT WAS HOT ENOUGH TO COOK ANYTHING. THERE WAS  
PLENTY OF WATCH WHILE THEY WAITED, HOWEVER. THEIR TENT SEEMED  
TO BE PITCHED RIGHT ALONGSIDE A KIND OF TELEGRAPHIC LINE THE  
PITCH, AND MINISTRY MEMBERS KEPT HURRYING UP AND DOWN IT,  
GREETING MR WEASLEY HEARTILY AS THEY PASSED. MR WEASLEY KEPT  
UP A RUNNING COMMENTARY, MAINLY FOR HARRY AND FERMINE'S  
ENJOYMENT; HIS OWN CHILDREN KNEW TOO MUCH ABOUT THE MINISTRY TO  
BE GREATLY INTERESTED.

THAT WAS CLYDEBERT MIDDLEBIDGE, HEAD OF THE GEMIN LIAISON  
OFFICE ... HERE COMES GILBERT WIMPLE, HE'S WITH THE COMMITTEE  
ON EXPERIMENTAL CHARMES, HE'S HAD THESE HORNIS FOR A WHILE NOW  
... FELLOW, ARNIE ... ARNOLD PEASEHEAD, HE'S AN ELEVATOR  
MEMBER OF THE ACCIDENTAL MAGIC REVERSAL SQUAD, WELL KNOWN ...  
AND THAT'S BODE AND CREAGER ... THEY'RE UNDEFEATABLES ...

THEY'RE WHAT?

FROM THE DEPARTMENT OF MYSTERIES, TOP-SECRET, NO IDEA WHAT  
THEY GET UP TO ...

AT LAST, THE FIRE WAS READY, AND THEY HAD JUST STARTED COOKING  
EGGS AND SALISAGES WHEN BILL, CHARLIE AND PERCY CAME STROLLING  
DOWN THE WOODS TOWARDS THEM.

JUST APPROPRIATE, DAD, SAID PERCY HEEDLY. AH, EXCELLENT, MUM!

SO HARRY PETER

THEY WERE HALFWAY THROUGH THEIR PLATES OF SALISAGES AND EGGS

WHEN MR LEASLEY LUMPED THE HIS FEET, LAUGHING AND GRINNING AT A  
MAN WHO WAS STRIDING TOWARDS THEM. 'A-HA!' HE SAID, 'THE MAN  
OF THE MOMENT? LIED?'  
LIED? RAGMAN WAS EASILY THE MOST NOTICEABLE PERSON HARRY

HAD SEEN SO FAR, EVEN INCLUDING MR ARCHIE IN HIS PREFERRED

NIGHTDRESS. HE WAS WEARING LONG FLUDDITCH REEKS IN THICK HERRI-  
NGTANAL STRIPS OF BRIGHT YELLOW AND BLACK, AN ENORMOUS PICTURE

OF A WASP WAS SPLASHED ACROSS HIS CHEST. HE HAD THE LOOK OF A  
POWERFULLY BUILT MAN GONE SLIGHTLY THE SEED; THE REEKS WERE  
STRETCHED TIGHTLY ACROSS A LARGE BELLY HE SURELY HAD NOT HAD IN  
THE DAYS WHEN HE HAD PLAYED FLUDDITCH FOR ENGLAND. HIS NECK  
WAS SWOLLEN (PROBABLY BROKEN BY A STRAY FLUDGER, HARRY  
THOUGHT), BUT HIS BEHIND BLUE EYES, SHORT BLOND HAIR AND REDDISH  
COMPLEXION MADE HIM LOOK LIKE A VERY EVERGREEN SCHEMELER.

'A-HA! THERE?' RAGMAN CALLED HAPPILY. HE WAS WALKING AS  
THOUGH HE HAD SPRINGS ATTACHED TO THE BALLS OF HIS FEET, AND WAS  
PLAINLY IN A STATE OF WILD EXCITEMENT.

ARTHEUR, MR MAN, HE PLOPPED, AS HE REACHED THE CAMPFIRE,  
WHAT A DAY, EH? WHAT A DAY? COULD WE HAVE ASKED FOR MORE  
PERFECT WEATHER? A CHILDLESS NIGHT COMING ... AND HARDLY A  
MICKLE IN THE ARRANGEMENTS ... NOT MUCH FOR ME THE DAY  
BEHIND HIM, A CROWD OF HAGGARD-LOOKING MINISTRY WIZARDS  
RUSHED PAST, POINTING AT THE DISTANT EVIDENCE OF SOME SORT OF A  
MAGICAL FIRE WHICH WAS SENDING VIOLET SPARKS TWENTY FEET INTO  
THE AIR.

PERCY HURRIED FORWARDS WITH HIS HANDS STRETCHED,  
APPARENTLY HIS DISAPPROVAL OF THE WAY BLUDH BAGMAN RAN HIS  
DEPARTMENT DID NOT PREVENT HIM WANTING TO MAKE A GOOD  
IMPRESSION.

AND YES, SAID MR WEASLEY, GRINNING, THIS IS MY SON, PERCY,  
HE'S JUST STARTED AT THE MINISTRY AND THIS IS FRED AND GEORGE,  
THEY'RE THAT'S FRED BILL, CHARLIE, PENELOPE MY DAUGHTER, GINNY  
AND PENELOPE'S FRIENDS, HERMIONIE GRANGER AND HARRY POTTER.  
BAGMAN DID THE SMALLEST OF DELICATE-TAKES WHEN HE HEARD

BAGMAN AND CRUELTY 21

HARRY'S NAME, AND HIS EYES PERFORMED THE FAMILIAR FLICK  
UPWARDS TO THE STAR ON HARRY'S FOREHEAD.

EVERYONE, MR WEASLEY CONTINUED, THIS IS BLUDH BAGMAN,  
WHO KNOWS WELL HE IS, IT'S THANKS TO HIM WE'VE GOTTEN SUCH GOOD  
TICKETS

BAGMAN BEAMED AND WAVED HIS HAND AS IF TO SAY IT HAD BEEN  
NOTHING.

FANCY A FLUTTER ON THE MATCH, ARTHEMUS? HE SAID RAGERLY, IN-  
CLUDING WHAT SEEMED TO BE A LARGE AMOUNT OF GOLD IN THE POCKETS

OF HIS YELLOW AND BLACK ROBES. I'VE ALREADY GOTTEN REDDY PENTONER  
BETTING ME BLUGARIA WILL SCORE FIRST I HOPPED HIM NICE HODS,  
CONSIDERING IRELAND'S PRESENT THERE ARE THE STRONGEST I'VE SEEN IN  
YEARS AND LITTLE AGATHA TRIMMS HAS PUT UP HALF SHARES IN HER  
RED FARM FOR A WEEK-LONG MATCH.

EH- ... EH HN, THEN, SAID MR WEASLEY, LET S SEE ... A GALLEEN  
HN IRELAND THE WIN?

A GALLEEN? LIED RAGMAN LEHED SLIGHTLY DISAPPOINTED, BUT  
RECOVERED HIMSELF, VERY WELL, VERY WELL ... AND HITHER TAKERS?

THEY RE A BIT PHLING THE RE GAMBLING, SAID MR WEASLEY, MEHLY  
WHLIDN T LIKE

WE LL GET THIRTY-SEVEN GALLEENS, FIFTEEN SICKLES, THREE DRAITS,  
SAID FRED, AS HE AND GEORGE WHILLY PHEED ALL THEIR MEHNEY,  
THAT IRELAND WIN BUT VIXTER DRLIM GETS THE SNITCH, EH- AND  
WE LL THREE IN A FAKE LAND,

PHLIDN T WANT TH EH S-PHEHNG MR RAGMAN ALKISH LIKE THAT

PERCY HISSED, BUT RAGMAN DIDN T SEEM TH THINK THE LAND WAS  
ALKISH AT ALL; HN THE CONTRARY, HIS KHOLISH FACE S-PHEHNG WITH  
EXCITEMENT AS HE THEED IT FROM FRED, AND WHEN THE LAND GAVE A  
LEHLD SHILAND AND TURNED INTO A ALKISH CHICKEN, RAGMAN WHARED  
WITH LAUGHTER.

EXCELLENT! I HAVEN T SEEN HNE THAT CHNVINKING IN YEARS! I D  
PAY FIVE GALLEENS FOR THAT!

PERCY FREEZE IN AN ATTITUDE OF STUNNED DISAPPROVAL.

KEYS, SAID MR WEASLEY UNDER HIS BREATH, I DIDN T WANT PHL  
GETTING ... THAT S ALL PHLIR SAVINGS ... PHLIR MEHNER

SE HARRY PEEETTER

DIDN T RE A SPHILSPHIRT, ARTHUR! KEHED LIED RAGMAN,  
RATTLING HIS PHECKETS EXCITEDLY, THEY RE HLD ENHUGH TH DNEH  
WHAT THEY WANT! PHL REEDEN IRELAND WILL WIN BUT DRLIM LL GET  
THE SNITCH? NHT A CHANCE, KEYS, NHT A CHANCE ... I LL GIVE PHL

EXCELLENT HEDS EN THAT HEN ... WE LL ADD FIVE CALLERNS FER THE  
FLINDY LAND, THEN, SHALL WE ...

MR WEASLEY WHEDD EN HELPLESSLY AS LIDEE BAGMAN WHIPPED  
HILT A NEETERHEED AND HILL AND EGAN HHTTNG DEHN THE TWINS  
NAMES.

CHERS, SAID GEERGE, TAKING THE SLIP OF PARCEMENT BAGMAN  
HANDED HIM AND TLIXING IT AWAY CAREFULLY.

BAGMAN TURNED MEET CHERFULLY BACK TEH MR WEASLEY.

CHLDN T DEE ME A KWEL, I SLUPPHEE? I M KEEPING AN EYE HILT  
FER BARTY CRELICH. MY BULGARIAN HPPHISTE NLMKEE S MAKING  
DIFFICULTIES, AND I CAN T LINDERSTAND A WHRD HE S SAYING, BARTY LL  
EE ABLE TEH SHRT IT HILT. HE SPEAKS AKELT A HUNDRED AND FIFTY  
LANGUAGES.

MR CRELICH SAID PERCY, SLIDDERLY ARANDENING HIS WHED EN

PHEDER-STIFF DISAPPROVAL AND PHESITIVELY WRITHING WITH EXCITE-  
MENT. HE SPEAKS HYER THE HUNDRED? MERMISH AND

CHERLEDGEHEED AND TREHL ...

ANYONE CAN SPEAK TREHL, SAID FRED DISMISSIVELY, ALL YEL  
HAYE TEH DEE IS PHINT AND GRUNT.

PERCY THREW FRED AN EXTREMELY NASTY WHED, AND STHEED THE  
FIRE VIGHERELISLY TEH BRING THE KETTLE BACK TEH THE KHIL.

AND NELS EN BERTHA IHEDINS YET, LIDEE? MR WEASLEY ASKED,  
AS BAGMAN SETTLED HIMSELF DEHN EN THE GRASS BESIDE THEM ALL.

NEET A DICKY KIRD, SAID BAGMAN CHEMPERTABLY, BLIT SHE LL TURN  
UP, PHEER HED BERTHA ... MEMERY LIKE A LEADY CALLDREEN AND NEH

SENSE OF DIRECTION. BEST, SHE'LL TAKE MY LEAD FOR IT. SHE'LL WANDER  
BACK INTO THE OFFICE SOME TIME IN OCTOBER, THINKING IT'S STILL  
JULY.

SHE'LL BEEN'T THINK IT MIGHT BE TIME TO SEND SOMEONE TO LEAD  
HER HERE? MR. WEAVER SUGGESTED TENTATIVELY, AS PERCY HANDED  
RAGMAN HIS TEA.

## RAGMAN AND CREELICH

RAGMAN CREELICH KEEPS SAYING THAT, SAID RAGMAN, HIS REDDISH  
EYES WIDENING INNOCENTLY, BUT WE REALLY CAN'T SPARE ANYONE AT  
THE MOMENT. HE TALKS OF THE DEVIL? RAGMAN?

A WIZARD HAD JUST APPEARED AT THEIR FIRESIDE, AND HE COULD  
NOT HAVE MADE MORE OF A CONTRAST WITH BLOND RAGMAN, SPRAWLED  
ON THE GRASS IN HIS OLD WASH BUCKS. RAGMAN CREELICH WAS A STIFF,  
UPRIGHT, ELDERLY MAN, DRESSED IN AN IMPECCABLY CRISP SUIT AND  
TIE. THE PARTING IN HIS SHORT GRAY HAIR WAS ALMOST UNNATURALLY  
STRAIGHT AND HIS NARROW WHITE-BRUSHED MUSTACHE LOOKED AS  
THOUGH HE TRIMMED IT USING A SHAVE-CLIP. HIS SHOES WERE VERY  
HIGHLY POLISHED. HARRY COULD SEE AT ONCE WHY PERCY IDEALIZED  
HIM. PERCY WAS A GREAT BELIEVER IN RIGIDLY FOLLOWING RULES, AND  
MR. CREELICH HAD COMPLIED WITH THE RULE ABOUT MUGGLE DRESSING  
SO THOROUGHLY THAT HE COULD HAVE PASSED AS A BAND MANAGER;  
HARRY BELIEVED EVEN UNCLE VERNON WOULD HAVE SPOTTED HIM FOR  
WHAT HE REALLY WAS.

PULL UP A BIT OF GRASS, RAGMAN, SAID BLOND KNIGHTLY, PATTING THE  
GRASS BESIDE HIM.

NEE, THANK YOU, BLOND, SAID CREELICH, AND THERE WAS A BITE OF

IMPATIENCE IN HIS VOICE. I'VE BEEN LOOKING FOR THEM EVERYWHERE.  
THE BULGARIANS ARE INSISTING WE ADD ANOTHER TWELVE SEATS TO THE  
TRIP BUS.

HOW IS THAT WHAT THEY'RE AFTER? SAID BAGMAN. I THOUGHT THE  
CLIP WAS ASKING THE BUREAU A PAIR OF TWEZERS, BIT OF A STRONG  
ACCENT.

MR CRUELICH SAID PERCY BREATHLESSLY, SLIDING INTO A KIND OF HALF  
SHEW WHICH MADE HIM LOOK LIKE A FLINT-ROCK. WOULD YOU LIKE  
A CLIP OF TEA?

HOW, SAID MR CRUELICH, LOOKING OVER AT PERCY IN MILD  
SURPRISE. YES THANK YOU, PLEASE.

FRED AND GEORGE CLIPPED INTO THEIR OWN CLIPS. PERCY, VERY  
PINK AROUND THE EARS, BUSIED HIMSELF WITH THE KETTLE.

HOW, AND I'VE BEEN WANTING A WORD WITH YOU, THEN,  
ARTHUR, SAID MR CRUELICH, HIS SHARP EYES FALLING UPON  
MR WEASLEY. ALI BASHIR'S ON THE WARPATH. HE WANTS A WORD

BY HARRY POTTER

WITH YOU ABOUT YOUR RESEARCH ON FLYING CARPETS.

MR WEASLEY HEAVED A DEEP SIGH. I SENT HIM AN EMAIL ABOUT

THAT JUST LAST WEEK. IF I'VE TOLD HIM ONCE I'VE TOLD HIM A HUND-  
RED TIMES! CARPETS ARE DEFINED AS A MISCLE ARTICLE BY THE

REGISTER OF PRESCRIBED CHARMABLE OBJECTS, BUT WILL HE LISTEN?

I BELIEVE IT, SAID MR CRUELICH, ACCEPTING A CLIP FROM PERCY.

HE'S DESPERATE FOR THE EXPERT HERE.



WELL, THEY LL NEVER REPLACE KREHMS IN BRITAIN, WILL THEY? SAID  
RAGMAN.

ALLI THINKS THERE S A NICHE IN THE MARKET FOR A FAMILY VEHICLE,  
SAID MR CRELICH. I REMEMBER MY GRANDFATHER HAD AN  
ADMINISTER THAT COULD SEAT TWELVE BUT THAT WAS BEFORE CARPETS  
WERE BANNED, HE CHIRPED.

HE SPoke AS THOUGH HE WANTED THE LEAVE NEEDED IN AND DHELT  
THAT ALL HIS ANCESTERS HAD ABIDED STRICTLY BY THE LAW.

SEE, BEEN KEEPING BUSY, BARTY? SAID RAGMAN KEEZILY.

FAIRLY, SAID MR CRELICH DRILY. ORGANISING PARTIES ACROSS  
FIVE CONTINENTS IS NO MEAN FEAT, LUDIE.

I EXPECT YOU LL BOTH BE GLAD WHEN THIS IS OVER? SAID MR  
WEASLEY.

LUDIE RAGMAN LEMBED SEEMED. GLAD? OHN T KNOW WHEN I VE  
HAD MORE FUN ... STILL, IT S NOT AS THOUGH WE HAVEN T GHT  
ANYTHING THE LEMD FORWARD THE, EH, BARTY? EH? PLENTY LEFT THE  
ORGANISE, EH?

MR CRELICH RAISED HIS EYEBROWS AT RAGMAN. WE AGREED NOT  
THE MAKE THE ANNOUNCEMENT UNTIL ALL THE DETAILS

EH, DETAILS? SAID RAGMAN, WAVING THE WORD AWAY LIKE A  
CHILD OF MIDGE. THEY VE SIGNED, HAVEN T THEY? THEY VE AGREED,  
HAVEN T THEY? I GET YOU ANYTHING THESE KIDS LL KNOW WHEN  
ENOUGH ANYWAY, I MEAN, IT S HAPPENING AT FLEGLARTS

LUDIE, WE NEED THE MEET THE BULGARIANS, YOU KNOW, SAID MR  
CRELICH SHARPLY, CUTTING RAGMAN S REMARKS SHORT. THANK YOU  
FOR THE TEA, WEATHERS.

HE PUSHED HIS LINDRINK TEA BACK AT PERCY AND WAITED FOR

BLIND THE RISE; RAGMAN STRUGGLED TO HIS FEET AGAIN, SWIGGING

RAGMAN AND CREELICH AS

BEHIND THE LAST OF HIS TEA, THE CHILD IN HIS POCKETS CHINKING  
MERRILY.

SEE YOU ALL LATER! HE SAID, YOU'LL BE UP IN THE TENT ROOM WITH  
ME I'M COMMENTATING! HE WAVED, RARTY CREELICH NEEDED  
CLUTTER, AND BOTH OF THEM DISAPPEARED.

WHAT'S HAPPENING AT FINGHARTS, DAD? SAID FRED AT HOME.  
WHAT WERE THEY TALKING ABOUT?

YOU'LL FIND OUT SOON ENOUGH, SAID MR WEASLEY, SMILING.

IT'S CLASSIFIED INFORMATION, UNTIL SUCH TIME AS THE MINISTRY  
DECIDES TO RELEASE IT, SAID PERCY STUFFY. MR CREELICH WAS WHITE  
RIGHT NEXT TO DISCLOSE IT.

HEY, SHUT UP, WEATHERED, SAID FRED.

A SENSE OF EXCITEMENT RESE LIKE A PALPABLE CHILD OVER THE  
CAMP SITE AS THE AFTERNOON WORE ON. BY DUSK, THE STILL SUMMER

AIR ITSELF SEEMED TO BE BUBBLING WITH ANTICIPATION, AND AS DARK-  
NESS SPREAD LIKE A CURTAIN OVER THE THOUSANDS OF WAITING WIZ-  
ARDS, THE LAST VESTIGES OF PRETENCE DISAPPEARED: THE MINISTRY

SEEMED TO HAVE REACHED THE THE INEVITABLE, AND STOPPED FIGHTING  
THE SIGNS OF BLATANT MAGIC WERE BREAKING OUT EVERYWHERE.

SALESMEN WERE APPARATING EVERY FEW FEET, CARRYING TRAYS AND  
PUSHING CARTS FULL OF EXTRAORDINARY MERCHANDISE. THERE WERE  
LUMINOUS RESETTES GREEN FOR IRELAND, RED FOR BULGARIA WHICH

WERE SHOWING THE NAMES OF THE PLAYERS, PAINTED GREEN HATS  
BECKED WITH DANCING SHAMROCKS, BULGARIAN SCARVES ADORNED  
WITH LIONS THAT REALLY ROARED, FLAGS FROM SEVEN COUNTRIES WHICH  
PLAYED THEIR NATIONAL ANTHEMS AS THEY WERE WAVED, THERE WERE  
TINY MODELS OF FIREWORKS, WHICH REALLY FLEW, AND COLLECTIBLE  
FIGURES OF FAMOUS PLAYERS, WHICH STROLLED ACROSS THE PALM OF  
THEIR HAND, PREENING THEMSELVES.

BEEN SAVING MY POCKET MONEY ALL SUMMER FOR THIS, REEN THOUGHT  
HARRY, AS THEY AND FERMINE STROLLED THROUGH THE SALESMEN,  
BUYING SILVERWARE. THOUGH REEN PURCHASED HIMSELF A DANCING-  
SHAMROCK HAT AND A LARGE GREEN RESSETTE, HE ALSO BOUGHT A SMALL  
FIGURE OF VIKTOR KARL, THE BULGARIAN SEEKER. THE MINIATURE  
KARL WALKED BACKWARDS AND FORWARDS OVER REEN'S HAND,

SEE HARRY PEEETTER

STROLLING UP AT THE GREEN RESSETTE ABOVE HIM.

WELL, LOOK AT THESE! SAID HARRY, FLIRTING OVER THE A CART FILLED  
HIGH WITH WHAT LOOKED LIKE BRASS BIRCHCLARS, EXCEPT THAT THEY  
WERE COVERED IN ALL SORTS OF WEIRD BONES AND BALS.

HEMLOCKLARS, SAID THE SALESMAN RABERLY, YOU CAN REPLAY

ACTHEN ... SHOW EVERYTHING DOWN ... AND THEY FLASH UP A PLAY-  
BY-PLAY BREADBREAD IF YOU NEED IT, BARGAIN TEN GALLONS EACH.

WISH I HADN'T BOUGHT THIS NOW, SAID REEN, GESTURING AT HIS

DARKING SHAMROCK HAT AND GAZING LONGINGLY AT THE  
EMERALD LILLS.

THREE PAIRS, SAID HARRY FIRMLY TO THE WIZARD.

OH DON'T BOTHER, SAID RON, GRINNING. HE WAS ALWAYS  
THOUGHTLESS ABOUT THE FACT THAT HARRY, WHO HAD INHERITED A SMALL  
FORTUNE FROM HIS PARENTS, HAD MUCH MORE MONEY THAN HE DID.

WELL WHEN I'M GETTING ANYTHING FOR CHRISTMAS, HARRY TOLD  
HIM, THROUSTING EMERALD LILLS INTO HIS AND HERMION'S HANDS.  
HE'S ABOUT TEN YEARS, MIND.

FAIR ENOUGH, SAID RON, GRINNING.

HEHEH, THANKS, HARRY, SAID HERMION. AND I'LL GET US SOME  
PROGRAMMES, LILLS

THEIR MONEY BAGS CONSIDERABLY LIGHTER, THEY WENT BACK TO  
THE TENTS. BILL, CHARLIE AND GINNY WERE ALL SPORTING GREEN  
ACCESSORIES THEN, AND MR WEASLEY WAS CARRYING AN IRISH FLAG. FRED  
AND GEORGE HAD NEW SILVERWARE AS THEY HAD GIVEN BAGMAN ALL  
THEIR GOLD.

AND THEN A DEEP, RUMBLING GONG RANGING SOMEWHERE  
BEYOND THE WOODS, AND, AT ONCE, GREEN AND RED LANTERNS BLAZED  
INTO LIFE IN THE TREES, LIGHTING A PATH TO THE PITCH.

IT'S TIME! SAID MR WEASLEY, BEING AS EXCITED AS ANY OF  
THEM. COME ON, LET'S GO!

## CHAPTER EIGHT

THE HOLIDAY WORLD

CLUTCHING THEIR PURCHASES, MR WEASLEY IN THE LEAD, THEY ALL  
HURRIED INTO THE WOOD, FOLLOWING THE LANTERN-LIT TRAIL. THEY  
COULD HEAR THE SOUNDS OF THOUSANDS OF PEOPLE MOVING AROUND

THEM, SHOUTS AND LAUGHTER, SNATCHES OF SINGING. THE ATMOS-  
PHERE OF FEVERISH EXCITEMENT WAS HIGHLY INFECTIOUS; HARRY

COULDNT STOP GRINNING. THEY WALKED THROUGH THE WOOD FOR  
TWENTY MINUTES, TALKING AND JOKING LOUDLY, UNTIL AT LAST THEY

EMERGED ON THE OTHER SIDE, AND FOUND THEMSELVES IN THE SHADE  
OF A GIANTIC STADIUM. THOUGH HARRY COULD SEE ONLY A FRACTION  
OF THE IMMENSE GROUND WALLS SURROUNDING THE PITCH, HE

COULD TELL THAT TEN CATHEDRALS WOULD FIT COMFORTABLY INSIDE IT.

SEATS A HUNDRED THOUSAND, SAID MR WEASLEY, SPITTING THE  
ASTONISHED WORD ON HARRY S FACE. MINISTRY TAXES FOUR OF FIVE  
HUNDRED HAVE BEEN WORKING ON IT ALL YEAR. MUGGLE-REPELLING

CHARMS ON EVERY INCH OF IT. EVERY TIME MUGGLES HAVE GOTTEN ANY-  
WHERE NEAR HERE ALL YEAR, THEY VE SUDDENLY REMEMBERED URGENT

APPOINTMENTS AND HAD THE DASH AWAY AGAIN ... BLESS THEM, HE  
ADDED FRIENDLY, LEADING THE WAY TOWARDS THE NEAREST ENTRANCE,  
WHICH WAS ALREADY SURROUNDED BY A SWARM OF SHOUTING WITCHES  
AND WIZARDS.

PRIME SEATS! SAID THE MINISTRY WITCH AT THE ENTRANCE, WHEN

SHE CHECKED THEIR TICKETS. THE BOX! STRAIGHT UPSTAIRS, ARTHEUR,  
AND AS HIGH AS YOU CAN GO.

THE STAIRS INTO THE STADIUM WERE CARPETED IN RICH PURPLE.  
THEY CLAMBERED UPWARDS WITH THE REST OF THE CROWD, WHICH  
SLEWLY FILTERED AWAY THROUGH DOORS INTO THE STANDS THE THEIR LEFT

XX HARRY POTTTER

AND RIGHT. MR WEASLEY'S PARTY KEPT CLIMBING, AND AT LAST THEY  
REACHED THE TOP OF THE STAIRCASE, AND FINDING THEMSELVES IN A  
SMALL BOX, SET AT THE HIGHEST POINT OF THE STADIUM AND SITUATED  
EXACTLY HALFWAY BETWEEN THE GOLDEN CHALPHESTS, ALMOST TWENTY  
PURPLE-AND-GILT CHAIRS STOOD IN TWO ROWS HERE, AND HARRY, FINDING  
IN THE FRONT SEATS WITH THE WEASLEYS, LOOKED DOWN UPON A  
SCENE THE LIKE OF WHICH HE COULD NEVER HAVE IMAGINED.

A HUNDRED THOUSAND WITCHES AND WIZARDS WERE TAKING THEIR  
PLACES IN THE SEATS WHICH ROSE IN LEVELS AROUND THE LONG EYAL  
PITCH. EVERYTHING WAS SUPPLIED WITH A MYSTERIOUS GOLDEN LIGHT  
THAT SEEMED TO COME FROM THE STADIUM ITSELF. THE PITCH LOOKED  
SMOOTHER AS VELVET FROM THEIR HIGH POSITION. AT EITHER END OF THE  
PITCH STOOD THREE GOLD PHEAS, FIFTY FEET HIGH; RIGHT OPPOSITE  
THEM,

ALMOST AT HARRY'S EYE LEVEL, WAS A GIGANTIC BLACKBOARD, GOLD WRIT-  
ING KEPT DASHING ACROSS IT AS THOUGH AN INVISIBLE GIANT'S HAND  
WAS

SCRIBBLING UPON IT AND THEN WIPING IT OFF AGAIN; WATCHING IT,

LEARRY SAW THAT IT WAS FLASHING ADVERTISEMENTS ACROSS THE PITCH.  
THE BLIZZARD: A BREATH FOR ALL THE FAMILY SAFE, RELIABLE

AND WITH IN-BUILT ANTI-BLIZZARD BLIZZER ... MRS STELLER'S ALL-  
PURPOSE MAGICAL MESS-REMOVER: NO PAIN, NO STAIN...

GLADACE WIZARDWEAR LONDON, PARIS, HESPERADE ...

LEARRY THREW HIS EYES AWAY FROM THE SIGN AND LOOKED OVER HIS  
SHOULDER TO SEE WHO ELSE WAS SHARING THE BUS WITH THEM. SHE WAS  
IT WAS EMPTY, EXCEPT FOR A TINY CREATURE SITTING IN THE SECOND  
FROM LAST SEAT AT THE END OF THE ROW BEHIND THEM. THE CREATURE,  
WHOSE LEGS WERE SO SHORT THEY STUCK OUT IN FRONT OF IT IN THE  
CHAIR, WAS WEARING A TEA-THEAT DRAPED LIKE A THICK, AND IT HAD ITS  
FACE HIDDEN IN ITS HANDS. YET THESE LONG, BAT-LIKE EARS WERE  
SOBLY FAMILIAR ...

DEERY? SAID LEARRY INCREDULOUSLY.

THE TINY CREATURE LOOKED UP AND PARTED ITS FINGERS, REVEALING  
ENORMOUS ROUND EYES AND A NOSE THE EXACT SIZE AND SHAPE OF A  
LARGE THEATRE. IT WASN'T DEERY IT WAS, HOWEVER, UNMISTAKABLY

THE BLIZZARD WEIRD CLIP BY

A FISHY-CLIP, AS LEARRY'S FRIEND DEERY HAD BEEN. LEARRY HAD SET  
DEERY FREE FROM HIS OLD OWNERS, THE MALPHE FAMILY.

DID SIR JUST CALL ME DEERY? SHEARED THE CLIP CURIOUSLY, FROM  
BETWEEN ITS FINGERS. ITS VOICE WAS HIGHER EVEN THAN DEERY'S HAD  
BEEN, A TINY, WHISPERING WHISPER OF A VOICE, AND LEARRY SUSPECTED  
THOUGH IT WAS VERY HARD TO TELL WITH A FISHY-CLIP THAT THIS

HERE MIGHT JUST BE FEMALE, BEEN AND FERMINE SPUN AROUND IN  
THEIR SEATS THE WHILE, THOUGH THEY HAD HEARD A LITTLE ABOUT DEERY  
FROM HARRY, THEY HAD NEVER ACTUALLY MET HIM, EVEN MR WEASLEY  
LOOKED AROUND IN INTEREST.

SHIRRY, HARRY TOLD THE TWO, I JUST THOUGHT YOU WERE SOMEONE I  
KNEW.

BUT I KNOWS DEERY THEE, SIR? SHELEADED THE TWO, SHE WAS  
SHIELDING HER FACE, AS THOUGH BLINDED BY LIGHT, THOUGH THE TOP  
OF HER WAS NOT BRIGHTLY LIT, MY NAME IS WINDY, SIR AND YOU, SIR

HER DARK EMBLON EYES WIDENED THE THE SIZE OF SIDE PLATES AS  
THEY RESTED UPON HARRY'S SCAR, YOU IS SURELY HARRY POTTER?  
YEAH, I AM, SAID HARRY.

BUT DEERY TALKS OF YOU ALL THE TIME, SIR? SHE SAID, WHEVERING  
HER HANDS VERY SLIGHTLY AND LOOKING AWESTRUCK.

YOU IS HE? SAID HARRY, YOU'S FREEDOM SLITTING HIM?  
AY, SIR, SAID WINDY, SHAKING HER HEAD, AY, SIR, MEANING NOT  
DISRESPECT, SIR, BUT I IS NOT SURE YOU DID DEERY A FAVOR, SIR,  
WHEN YOU IS SETTING HIM FREE.

WHY? SAID HARRY, TAKEN ABACK, WHAT'S WRONG WITH HIM?  
FREEDOM IS CHING THE DEERY'S HEAD, SIR, SAID WINDY SADLY,  
IDEAS ABOVE HIS STATION, SIR, CAN'T GET ANOTHER POSITION, SIR,  
WHY NOT? SAID HARRY.

WINDY LOWERED HER VOICE BY A HALF OCTAVE AND WHISPERED, HE  
IS WANTING PAYING FOR HIS WHORE, SIR.

PAYING? SAID HARRY BLANDLY, WELL WHY SHOULDN'T HE BE  
PAID?

WINDY LOOKED WHITE FLESHED AT THE IDEA, AND CLOSED HER



FINGERS SLIGHTLY SEE THAT HER FACE WAS HALF-HIDDEN AGAIN.

FELISE-ELVES IS NOT PAID, SIR? SHE SAID IN A MUFFLED SHELLEAD.

IN HARRY PETER

NEH, NEH, NEH, I SAYS THE DEER, I SAYS, GEE FIND YOURSELF A NICE FAMILY AND SETTLE DOWN, DEER, HE IS GETTING UP THE ALL SHEETS OF HIGH HINDS, SIR, WHAT IS UNREHEMING THE A FELISE-ELF, YELL GERS RACKETING AROUND LIKE THIS, DEER, I SAYS, AND NEXT THING I HEAR YELL S UP IN FRONT OF THE DEPARTMENT FOR THE REGULATION AND CENTRE OF MAGICAL CREATURES, LIKE SOME CHIMPEN CHIMPEN.

WELL, IT S ABOUT TIME HE HAD A KIT OF FLIN, SAID HARRY.

FELISE-ELVES IS NOT SLIPPED THE HAVE FLIN, HARRY PETER, SAID WINDY FIRMLY, FROM BEHIND HER HANDS. FELISE-ELVES DEES WHAT THEY IS TELL, I IS NOT LIKING HEIGHTS AT ALL, HARRY PETER SHE GLANCED TOWARDS THE EDGE OF THE KEE AND GLIMPED, BUT MY MASTER SENDS ME THE THE THE KEE AND I CHIMPES, SIR.

WHY S HE SENT YELL UP HERE, IF HE DOESN'T YELL DOWN T LIKE HEIGHTS? SAID HARRY, FREELIVING.

MASTER MASTER WANTS ME THE SAVE HIM A SEAT, HARRY PETER, HE IS VERY BUSY, SAID WINDY, TILTING HER HEAD TOWARDS THE EMPTY SPACE BESIDE HER. WINDY IS WISHING SHE IS BACK IN MASTER S TENT, HARRY PETER, BUT WINDY DEES WHAT SHE IS TELL, WINDY IS A GOOD FELISE-ELF.

SHE GAVE THE EDGE OF THE KEE ANOTHER FRIGHTENED LEEK, AND HID HER EYES COMPLETELY AGAIN. HARRY TURNED BACK THE THE OTHERS.

SEE THAT S A FELISE-ELF? BEEN MUTTERED. WEIRD THINGS, AREN T THEY?

DEERY WAS WEIRDER, SAID HARRY, FERVENTLY.

HEEN PULLED OUT HIS HORNHORNARS AND STARTED TESTING THEM,  
STARING DOWN INTO THE CROWN AND THE EITHER SIDE OF THE STADIUM.

WILD! HE SAID, TWIDDLING THE REPLAY DOWN AND THE SIDE. I CAN  
MAKE THAT HED BLEED DOWN THERE PICK HIS NESE AGAIN ... AND  
AGAIN ... AND AGAIN ...

HERMIONE, MEANWHILE, WAS SWIMMING EAGERLY THROUGH HER  
VELVET-COVERED, TASSELLED PROGRAMME.

A DISPLAY FROM THE TEAM MASCOTS WILL PRECEDE THE MATCH ,  
SHE READ AHEAD.

HEY, THAT'S ALWAYS WORTH WATCHING, SAID MR WEASLEY,

NATIONAL TEAMS BRING CREATURES FROM THEIR NATIVE LAND, YELL

THE HELLIDOTTLE-WORLD CLIP 91

DOWN, THE PLIT AND A KIT OF A SHELL.

THE ROOM FILLED GRADUALLY AROUND THEM OVER THE NEXT HALF  
HOUR. MR WEASLEY KEPT SHAKING HANDS WITH PEOPLE WHO WERE  
EVEN MORE VERY IMPORTANT WIZARDS. PERCY LUMPED THE HIS FEET SEE

HEARD THAT HE BLEEDED AS THOUGH HE WAS TRYING TO SIT AND A HEDGE-  
HOG. WHEN CERNELIUS FUDGE, THE MINISTER FOR MAGIC HIMSELF,

ARRIVED, PERCY KNEW SEE WELL THAT HIS GLASSES FELL OFF AND SHAT-  
TERED. HIGHLY EMBARRASSED, HE REPAIRED THEM WITH HIS WAND,

AND THEREAFTER REMAINED IN HIS SEAT, THROWING IRACUNDUS LOOKS AT  
HARRY, WHOM CERNELIUS FUDGE HAD GREETED LIKE AN OLD FRIEND.

THEY HAD MET BEFORE, AND FLIDGE SEIZED HARRY'S HAND IN FATHERLY FASHION, ASKED HOW HE WAS, AND INTRODUCED HIM TO THE WIZARDS ON EITHER SIDE OF HIM.

HARRY PETER, WHO KNEW, HE HEEDFULLY TOLD THE BULGARIAN MINISTER, WHO WAS WEARING SPLENDID ROBES OF BLACK VELVET TRIMMED WITH ERMIN, AND DIDN'T SEEM TO UNDERSTAND A WORD OF ENGLISH. HARRY PETER ... HE, CAME ON NOW, WHO KNEW WHO HE IS ... THE ONE WHO SURVIVED WHO-KNEW-WHO ... WHO DO KNOW WHO HE IS

THE BULGARIAN WIZARD SUDDENLY SPOTTED HARRY'S SCAR AND STARTED GABBLING HEEDFULLY AND EXCITEDLY, POINTING AT IT.

KNEW WE'D GET THERE IN THE END, SAID FLIDGE WEARILY TO HARRY. I'M NOT GREAT SPEAKERS AT LANGUAGES, I NEED BARTY CRACKLE FOR THIS SORT OF THING. AND, I SEE HIS FELLOW-ELF'S SAVING HIM A SEAT ... CHIEF OF THEM, THESE BULGARIAN EIGHTERS HAVE BEEN TRYING TO CATCH ALL THE BEST PLACES ... AND, AND HERE'S LUCILIS!

HARRY, RON AND HERMIONIE TURNED HEEDFULLY, LOGGING ALONG THE SECOND ROW THE THREE STILL-EMPTY SEATS RIGHT BEHIND MR WEASLEY WERE NONE OTHER THAN DICKY THE FELLOW-ELF'S TWO HUNTERS LUCILIS MALFOY, HIS SON, DRACH, AND A WOMAN HARRY SLIPPED MUST BE DRACH'S MOTHER.

HARRY AND DRACH MALFOY HAD BEEN ENEMIES EVER SINCE THEIR VERY FIRST ENCOUNTER AT HOGWARTS. A PALE ONE WITH A PAINTED FACE AND WHITE-BLEND HAIR, DRACH GREATLY RESEMBLED HIS FATHER. HIS MOTHER WAS BLONDE, THEN, TALL AND SLIM, SHE WOULD HAVE BEEN

OF HARRY PETER

NICE SWEETING IF SHE HADN'T BEEN WEARING A DRESS THAT SUGGESTED  
THERE WAS A NASTY SMELL UNDER HER NECK.

AH, FLUDGE, SAID MR MALPHEE, HOLDING UP HIS HAND AS HE  
REACHED THE MINISTER FOR MAGIC. HOW ARE YOU? I DON'T THINK  
YOU'VE MET MY WIFE, NARCISSE? HER ELDER SON, DRAGON?

HOW DO YOU DO, HOW DO YOU DO? SAID FLUDGE, SMILING AND  
KISSING THE MRS MALPHEE. AND ALLOW ME TO INTRODUCE YOU TO THE MR  
HENDRICK HENDRICK MR WELL, HE'S THE BULGARIAN MINISTER  
FOR MAGIC, AND HE CAN'T UNDERSTAND A WORD I'M SAYING ANYWAY,  
SO NEVER MIND, AND LET'S SEE WHO ELSE YOU KNOW ARTHUR  
WEASLEY, I DARE SAY?

IT WAS A TENSE MOMENT. MR WEASLEY AND MR MALPHEE LOOKED  
AT EACH OTHER AND HARRY VIVIDLY RECALLED THE LAST TIME THAT THEY

HAD COME FACE TO FACE; IT HAD BEEN IN FLEETWICH AND BLITTS KITCHEN-  
SINK, AND THEY HAD HAD A FIGHT. MR MALPHEE'S CHILD GREY EYES

SWEEPED OVER MR WEASLEY, AND THEN UP AND DOWN THE ROW.

GOOD LORD, ARTHUR, HE SAID SILENTLY, WHAT DID YOU HAVE TO  
SELL TO GET SEATS IN THE THIRD BOX? SURELY YOUR FATHER WOULDN'T  
HAVE FETCHED THIS MUCK?

FLUDGE, WHO WASN'T LISTENING, SAID, BLUKILIS HAS JUST GIVEN A  
VERY GENEROUS CONTRIBUTION TO THE ST MUNGUS'S HOSPITAL FOR MAGICAL  
MALADIES AND INJURIES, ARTHUR, HE'S HERE AS MY GUEST.

HOW WELL NICE, SAID MR WEASLEY, WITH A VERY STRAINED  
SMILE.

MR MALPHEE'S EYES HAD RETURNED THE HERMIONE, WHO WENT

SLIGHTLY PINK, BLIT STARED DETERMINEDLY BACK AT HIM. HARRY KNEW EXACTLY WHAT WAS MAKING MR MALFOY'S LIP CURL. THE MALFOYS PRIDED THEMSELVES ON BEING PURE-BLOODS; IN OTHER WORDS, THEY CONSIDERED ANYONE OF MUGGLE DESCENT, LIKE HERMIONE, SECOND-CLASS. HOWEVER, UNDER THE GAZE OF THE MINISTER FOR MAGIC, MR MALFOY DIDN'T DARE SAY ANYTHING. HE NEEDED SMILINGLY THE MR WEASLEY, AND CONTINUED DOWN THE LINE

THE HIS SEATS. DRAGON SEETH HARRY, RON AND HERMIONE HAD CONTINUOUSLY BEEN, THEN SETTLED HIMSELF BETWEEN HIS MOTHER AND FATHER.

THE HOLIDITCH WORLD CUP '98

SLIMY GITS, RON MUTTERED, AS HE, HARRY AND HERMIONE TURNED THE FACE THE PITCH AGAIN. NEXT MOMENT, LORD BAGMAN HAD CHARGED INTO THE RING.

EVERYONE READY? HE SAID, HIS BEHIND FACE GLEAMING LIKE A GREAT, EXCITED LAMP. MINISTER READY THE GUY?

READY WHEN YOU ARE, LORD, SAID FLUDGE COMFORTABLY. LORD WHIPPED BLIT HIS WAND, DIRECTED IT AT HIS OWN THREAT AND SAID SEVERUS! AND THEN SPEKE OVER THE REAR OF SEELING THAT WAS NOW FILLING THE PACKED STADIUM; HIS VOICE ECHOED OVER THEM, REERING INTO EVERY CORNER OF THE STANDS: LADIES AND GENTLEMEN ... WELCOME! WELCOME TO THE FINAL OF THE HUNDRED AND TWENTY-SECOND HOLIDITCH WORLD CUP! THE SPECTATORS SCREAMED AND CLAPPED. THOUSANDS OF FLAGS

WAVED, ADDING THEIR DISCORDANT NATIONAL ANTHEMS TO THE RACKET.  
THE BLUE BLACKBOARD OPPOSITE THEM WAS WIPEd CLEAR OF ITS LAST  
MESSAGE (BETTER BETT & EVERY FLAVELIN BEANS A RISK WITH EVERY  
MELT-FLY!) AND NOW SHOWED BULGARIA: ZRRR, IRELAND:  
ZRRR,

AND NOW, WITH-OUT FURTHER ADDE, ALLOW ME TO INTRODUCe ... THE  
BULGARIAN TEAM MASCOTS:

THE RIGHT-HAND SIDE OF THE STANDS, WHICH WAS A SHED BLEND  
OF SCARLET, REARED ITS APPROVAL.

I WONDER WHAT THEY VE KNELIGHT? SAID MR LEASLEY,  
LEANING FORWARDS IN HIS SEAT. AHA! HE SLIDENLY WHIPPED  
OFF HIS GLASSES AND POLISHED THEM FLURRIEDLY ON HIS REEFS.

VELLA!

WHAT ARE VELL ?

BUT A HUNDRED VELLA WERE NOW GLIDING FLIT BENTH THE PITCH,  
AND HARRY & ELVESTHEN WAS ANSWERED FOR HIM. VELLA WERE WOMEN  
... THE MOST REALISTIC WOMEN HARRY HAD EVER SEEN ... EXCEPT  
THAT THEY WEREN'T THEY COULDN'T BE HUMAN. THIS PUZZLED  
HARRY FOR A MOMENT, WHILE HE TRIED TO GUESS WHAT EXACTLY THEY  
COULD BE; WHAT COULD MAKE THEIR SKIN SHINE MEEN-BRIGHT LIKE  
THAT, OR THEIR WHITE-GOLD HAIR FAN FLIT BEHIND THEM WITH-OUT  
WIND ... BUT THEN THE MUSIC STARTED, AND HARRY STOPPED WHIRRYING

OH HARRY PEEETTER

ARE-IT THEM NOT BEING HUMAN IN FACT, HE STOPPED WHIRRYING  
ARE-IT ANYTHING AT ALL.

THE VELLA HAD STARTED THE DANCE, AND HARRY & MIND HAD GONE

COMPLETELY AND BLISSFULLY BLANK. ALL THAT MATTERED IN THE WORLD WAS THAT HE KEPT WATCHING THE VERBA, BECAUSE IF THEY STOPPED DANCING, TERRIBLE THINGS WOULD HAPPEN ...

AND AS THE VERBA DANCED FASTER AND FASTER, WILD, HALF-FORMED THOUGHTS STARTED CHASING THROUGH HARRY'S DAZED MIND. HE WANTED TO SEE SOMETHING VERY IMPRESSIVE, RIGHT NOW. JUMPING FROM THE KICK INTO THE STADIUM SEEMED A GOOD IDEA ... BUT WOULD IT BE GOOD ENOUGH?

HARRY, WHAT ARE YOU DOING? SAID HERMIONE'S VOICE FROM A LONG WAY OFF.

THE MUSIC STOPPED, HARRY BLINKED, HE WAS STANDING UP, AND NOW HIS LEGS WAS RESTING ON THE WALL OF THE KICK. NEXT TO HIM, RON WAS FROZEN IN AN ATTITUDE THAT LOOKED AS THOUGH HE WAS ABOUT TO DIVE FROM A SPRINGBOARD.

ANGRY YELLS WERE FILLING THE STADIUM. THE CROWD DIDN'T WANT THE VERBA TO GO, HARRY WAS WITH THEM; HE WOULD, OF COURSE, BE SUPPORTING BULGARIA, AND HE WONDERED VAGUELY WHY HE HAD A LARGE GREEN SHAMROCK PINNED TO HIS CHEST. RON, MEANWHILE, WAS ABSENT-MINDEDLY SHREDDING THE SHAMROCKS ON HIS HAT. MR WEASLEY, SMILING SLIGHTLY, LEANT OVER THE RON AND TUGGED THE HAT AWAY FROM HIS HANDS.

YOU'LL BE WANTING THAT, HE SAID, SINCE IRELAND HAVE HAD THEIR SAY.

HE SAID RON, STARING OPEN-MOUTHED AT THE VERBA, WHO HAD NOW LINED UP ALONG ONE SIDE OF THE PITCH.

HERMIONE MADE A LITTLE TITTING NOISE. SHE REACHED UP AND PULLED HARRY BACK INTO HIS SEAT. HONESTLY? SHE SAID.

AND WHEN, HEARD LUDIE BAGMAN'S VOICE, KINDLY PLIT THEIR  
HANDS IN THE AIR ... FOR THE IRISH NATIONAL TEAM MARCHES?  
NEXT MOMENT, WHAT SEEMED TO BE A GREAT GREEN-AND-GOLD  
COMET HAD COME ZEEPMING INTO THE STADIUM. IT DID NOT CIRCLIT  
OF THE STADIUM, THEN SPLIT INTO TWO SMALLER COMETS, EACH

THE HUNDRETHS WERE CLIP AS  
FLUTING TOWARDS THE GOALPOSTS, A RAINBOW ARCED SLIDENLY  
ACROSS THE PITCH, CONNECTING THE TWO BALLS OF LIGHT. THE CROWD  
HOOED AND AAAAIED, AS THOUGH AT A FIREWORK DISPLAY, WHEN  
THE RAINBOW FADED AND THE BALLS OF LIGHT RELUNITED AND MERGED;  
THEY HAD FORMED A GREAT SHIMMERING SHAMROCK, WHICH ROSE UP  
INTO THE SKY AND BEGAN TO SHAR OVER THE STANDS, SOMETHING LIKE  
GOLDEN RAIN SEEMED TO BE FALLING FROM IT

EXCELLENT! YELLED BEN, AS THE SHAMROCK SHARED OVER THEIR  
HEADS, AND HEAVY GOLD CHAINS RAINED FROM IT, BELLINGING OFF THEIR  
HEADS AND SEATS. SHINING UP AT THE SHAMROCK, HARRY REALISED  
THAT IT WAS ACTUALLY COMPOSED OF THOUSANDS OF TINY LITTLE  
BEARDED MEN WITH RED WAISTCOATS, EACH CARRYING A MINUTE LAMP  
OF GOLD OR GREEN.

LEPRECHAUNS! SAID MR WRASLEY, OVER THE TUMULTUEOUS  
APPLAUSE OF THE CROWD, MANY OF WHOM WERE STILL FIGHTING AND  
RUMMAGING AROUND UNDER THEIR CHAIRS TO RETRIEVE THE GOLD.

THERE YOU GO, BEN YELLED HAPPILY, STUFFING A FISTFUL OF GOLD  
CHAINS INTO HARRY'S HAND. FOR THE LEPRECHAUNS? WHEN YOU GET  
THE KEY ME A CHRISTMAS PRESENT, HA?

THE GREAT SHAMROCK DISSOLVED, THE LEPRECHAUNS DRIFTED DOWN



ENTERED THE PITCH FROM THE OPPOSITE SIDE FROM THE VELA, AND SETTLED  
THEMSELVES CROSS-LEGGED TO WATCH THE MATCH.

AND NOW, LADIES AND GENTLEMEN, KINDLY WELCOME THE  
BULGARIAN NATIONAL HOCKEY TEAM! I GIVE YOU DIMITREY!  
A SCARLET-CLAD FIGURE FROM A KREMSHTEIN, MOVING SO FAST IT WAS  
BLURRED, SHEET MET ENTERED THE PITCH FROM AN ENTRANCE FAR BEHIND, THE  
WILD APPLAUSE FROM THE BULGARIAN SUPPORTERS.

IVANOV!

A SECOND SCARLET-CLAD PLAYER ZOOMED IN.

ZHEGROV! LEVSKI! VUKCHANOV! VELIKOV! AAAAAAND KIRIL!

THAT'S HIM, THAT'S HIM! YELLED REIN, WHISPERING KIRIL WITH HIS  
TEENAGEBROS, HARRY QUICKLY CLOSED HIS EYES.

VICTOR KIRIL WAS THIN, DARK AND SALLIED-SKINNED, WITH A LARGE

CLAYED NOSE AND THICK BLACK EYEBROWS. HE LOOKED LIKE AN EVER-  
GREEN BIRD OF PREY. IT WAS HARD TO BELIEVE HE WAS ONLY EIGHTEEN.

THE HARRY PITTER

AND NOW, PLEASE GREET THE IRISH NATIONAL HOCKEY TEAM!  
YELLED KAGAN, PRESENTING CENNELL! ROAN! TROY! MILLET!  
MEHRAN! HUGLEY! AAAAAAND LYNN!

SEVEN GREEN ELKS SKIPPED ENTERED THE PITCH; HARRY SPIN A SMALL  
DIAL FROM THE SIDE OF HIS GOGGLES, AND SHEWED THE PLAYERS  
DOWN ENOUGH TO READ THE LEAD FIREHOLE FROM EACH OF THEIR  
KNEES, AND SEE THEIR NAMES, EMBROIDERED IN SILVER, UPON THEIR  
BACKS.

AND HERE, ALL THE WAY FROM EGYPT, HIS REFEREE, ACCLAIMED

CHAIRWIZARD OF THE INTERNATIONAL ASSOCIATION OF FLUIDITCH,  
HASSAN MEESTARA?

A SMALL AND SKINNY WIZARD, COMPLETELY BALD BUT WITH A  
MELISTACHE THE RIVAL LANCE VERNON'S, WEARING RINGS OF PURE GOLD  
THE MATCH THE STADIUM, STRODE OUT BENEATH THE PITCH. A SILVER  
WHISTLE WAS PRETTLING FROM UNDER THE MELISTACHE, AND HE WAS  
CARRYING A LARGE WHEEDEN CRATE UNDER ONE ARM, HIS KNEEMSTICK  
UNDER THE OTHER. HARRY SPUN THE SPEED DIAL ON HIS MEMPHILKARS  
BACK TO NORMAL, WATCHING CLOSELY AS MEESTARA MELINTED HIS  
KNEEMSTICK AND KICKED THE CRATE OPEN. FOUR BALLS BURST INTO  
THE AIR: THE SCARLET FLAPPE, THE TWO BLACK BLIDGERS AND HARRY  
SAW IT FOR THE BRIEFEST MOMENT, BEFORE IT SPED OUT OF SIGHT! THE  
MINUSKLE, WINGED, GOLDEN SNITCH. WITH A SHARP BLAST ON HIS  
WHISTLE, MEESTARA SEET INTO THE AIR AFTER THE BALLS.

THREEEEEEEY RE OFF! SCREAMED BAGMAN. AND IT'S MULLET!  
TRED! MERRAN! DIMITREY! BACK TO MULLET! TRED! LEVSKI! MERRAN!  
IT WAS FLUIDITCH AS HARRY HAD NEVER SEEN IT PLAYED BEFORE.  
HE WAS PRESSING HIS MEMPHILKARS SO HARD THAT HIS EYES THAT HIS  
GLASSES WERE CLIPPING INTO THE BRIDGE OF HIS NOSE. THE SPEED OF  
THE PLAYERS WAS INCREDIBLE. THE CHASERS WERE THROWING THE  
FLAPPE THE EACH OTHER SO FAST THAT BAGMAN ONLY HAD TIME TO SAY  
THEIR NAMES. HARRY SPUN THE SLEW DIAL ON THE RIGHT OF HIS  
MEMPHILKARS AGAIN, PRESSED THE PLAY BY PLAY BUTTON ON THE  
TOP AND HE WAS IMMEDIATELY WATCHING IN SLEW MENTION, WHILE  
GLITTERING PURPLE LETTERING FLASHED ACROSS THE LENSES, AND THE  
NOISE OF THE CROWD POUNDED AGAINST HIS EARDRUMS.

THE UNLIDDED WORLD CLIP 77

HEAD-ATTACKING FORMATION HE READ, AS HE WATCHED THE THREE IRISH CHASERS THEM CLOSELY TOGETHER, TREY IN THE CENTRE, SLIGHTLY AHEAD OF MULLET AND MERRAN, BEARING DOWN UPON THE BULGARIANS. PERSEUS' PLED FLASHED UP NEXT, AS TREY MADE AS THOUGH HE DART UPWARDS WITH THE ELIAPPLE, DRAWING AWAY THE BULGARIAN CHASER IVANHYA, AND DROPPING THE ELIAPPLE THE MERRAN. ONE OF THE BULGARIAN BEATERS, VIKREY, SWUNG HARD AT A PASSING BLUDGER WITH HIS SMALL CLUB, BOUNCING IT INTO MERRAN'S PATH; MERRAN DUCKED THE AHEAD THE BLUDGER AND DROPPED THE ELIAPPLE; AND LEVSKI, SHARING BENEATH, CALIGHT IT

TREY SCHEES: REARED BAGMAN, AND THE STADIUM SHEDDERED WITH A REAR OF APPLAUSE AND CHEERS. TEN ZERO THE IRELAND:

WHAT? HARRY YELLED, LEEDING WILDLY AROUND THROUGH HIS EMBELLERS. BUT LEVSKI'S GET THE ELIAPPLE:

HARRY, IF YOU'RE NOT GOING TO WATCH AT NORMAL SPEED, YOU'RE GOING TO MISS THINGS! SEEMED HERMINE, WHO WAS DANCING UP AND DOWN, WAVING HER ARMS IN THE AIR WHILE TREY DID A LAP OF HENNELR OF THE PITCH. HARRY LEEDERED HEEDLY OVER THE TOP OF HIS EMBELLERS, AND SAW THAT THE REPRESENTATIVES WATCHING FROM THE SIDE-LINES HAD ALL RISEN INTO THE AIR AGAIN, AND PERMED THE GREAT, GLITTERING SHAMROCK. ACROSS THE PITCH, THE VELA WERE WATCHING THEM SLIDILY.

FLURIELS WITH HIMSELF, HARRY SPIN HIS SPEED DIAL BACK TO NORMAL AS PLAY RESUMED.

HARRY KNEW ENOUGH ABOUT HILDBITCH TO SEE THAT THE IRISH CHASERS WERE SLIPPER. THEY WORKED AS A SEAMLESS TEAM,

APPEARING TO READ EACH OTHER'S MINDS BY THE WAY THEY POSITIONED THEMSELVES, AND THE RESETTE IN HARRY'S CHEST KEPT

RELEADING THEIR NAMES: THREE MILLET MERRAN, AND WITHIN TEN

MINUTES, IRELAND HAD SCORED TWICE MORE, BRINGING THEIR LEAD TO THIRTY ZERO, AND CAUSING A THUNDEROUS TIDE OF ROARS AND APPLAUSE FROM THE GREEN-CLAD SUPPORTERS.

THE MATCH BECAME STILL FASTER, BUT MORE BRUTAL. VELOCHY AND VULCHANY, THE BULGARIAN BEATERS, WERE BEATING THE BULBEGS AS FIERCELY AS POSSIBLE AT THE IRISH CHASERS, AND WERE STARTING THE

TO HARRY PETER

PREVENT THEM USING SOME OF THEIR BEST MOVES; TWICE THEY WERE FORCED TO SCATTER, AND THEN, FINALLY, IVANOVY MANAGED TO BREAK THROUGH THEIR RANKS, BEHIND THE KEEPER, ROYAN, AND SCORE BULGARIA'S FIRST GOAL.

FINGERS IN THEIR EARS, BELIEVED MR LEASLEY, AS THE VEELA STARTED THE DANCE IN CELEBRATION. HARRY SQUEEZED SHUT HIS EYES, THEN HE WANTED TO KEEP HIS MIND ON THE GAME. AFTER A FEW SECONDS,

HE GLANCED A GLANCE AT THE PITCH. THE VEELA HAD STOPPED DANCING, AND BULGARIA WERE AGAIN IN POSSESSION OF THE BALL.

DIMITRIY? LEVSKI? DIMITRIY? IVANIEVA HE-I SAY? HEARD  
KAGMAN.

FIVE HUNDRED THOUSAND WIZARDS AND WITCHES GASPED AS THE  
TWO SEEKERS, KRWIM AND LYNCH, PLUMMETED THROUGH THE CENTRE  
OF THE CHASERS, SO FAST THAT IT LOOKED AS THOUGH THEY HAD JUST  
JUMPED FROM AIRPLANES WITHOUT PARACHUTES. HARRY FOLLOWED  
THEIR DESCENT THROUGH HIS MEMORIALS, REALISING THE SPOT WHERE  
THE SNITCH WAS

THEY'RE GOING TO CRASH! SCREAMED FERMINE NEXT TO HARRY.  
SHE WAS HALF-RIGHT AT THE VERY LAST SECOND, YETTER KRWIM  
PULLED OUT OF THE DIVE AND SPIRALLED OFF, LYNCH, HOWEVER, HIT THE  
GROUND WITH A BULL THUD THAT COULD BE HEARD THROUGHOUT THE  
STADIUM. A HUGE CRYAN ROSE FROM THE IRISH SEATS.

FEEL? MEANT MR WEASLEY, KRWIM WAS FINTING?

IT'S TIME OUT! YELLED KAGMAN'S VOICE. AS TRAINED MEDI-  
WIZARDS FLURRY ENTERED THE PITCH TO EXAMINE AIDAN LYNCH?

HE WAS HIT, HE ONLY GOT PULLED? CHARLIE SAID REASSURING-  
LY TO GINNY, WHO WAS HANGING OVER THE SIDE OF THE BOX, LOOKING

THROUGH-STRUCK. WHICH IS WHAT KRWIM WAS AFTER, OF COURSE ...

HARRY HASTILY PRESSED THE REPLAY AND PLAY BY PLAY BUTTONS  
ON HIS MEMORIALS, TWIDDED THE SPEED DIAL, AND PUT THEM  
BACK UP TO HIS EYES.

HE WATCHED AS KRWIM AND LYNCH DIVED AGAIN IN SLOW MOTION.

WRENSEI PRINT DANGEROUS SEEKER DIVERSITY READ THE SHINING

PURPLE LETTERING ACROSS HIS LENSES. HE SAW DRUM'S FACE CONCENTRATED WITH CONCENTRATION AS HE PULLED HIM UP THE DIVE LIST IN TIME,

THE ELIOTT-WHEELD CLIP 77

WHILE LYNCH WAS FLATTENED, AND HE UNDERSTOOD DRUM HADN'T SEEN THE SNITCH AT ALL, HE WAS JUST MAKING LYNCH COPY HIM. HARRY HAD NEVER SEEN ANYONE FLY LIKE THAT; DRUM HARDLY BREATHED AS THOUGH HE WAS USING A BREASTING AT ALL; HE MOVED SO EASILY THROUGH THE AIR THAT IT BREATHED AS THOUGH HE WAS UNSLIPPED AND WEIGHTLESS. HARRY TURNED HIS EYEGLASSES BACK THE NORMAL, AND FELT THEM IN DRUM. HE WAS CIRCLING HIGH ABOVE LYNCH, WHO WAS NOW BEING REVIVED BY MEDICATORS WITH CLIPS OF POTION. HARRY, FEELING STILL MORE CLOSELY UPON DRUM'S FACE, SAW HIS DARK EYES DARTING ALL OVER THE GREENLAND A HUNDRED FEET BELOW. HE WAS USING THE TIME WHILE LYNCH WAS REVIVED TO BRING THE SNITCH WITHOUT INTERFERENCE.

LYNCH GOT TO HIS FEET AT LAST, THE MILD CHIEFS FROM THE GREEN-CLAD SLIPPERERS, MOUNTED HIS FIREHEAT AND ROLLED BACK OFF INTO

THE AIR. HIS REVIVAL SEEMED TO GIVE IRELAND NEW HEART. WHEN MEESTARA BLEW HIS WHISTLE AGAIN, THE CHASERS MOVED INTO ACTION WITH A SKILL UNRIVALLED BY ANYTHING HARRY HAD SEEN SO FAR. AFTER FIFTEEN MORE FAST AND FLIRTY MINUTES, IRELAND HAD PULLED AHEAD BY TEN MORE CHALS. THEY WERE NOW LEADING BY ONE HUNDRED AND THIRTY POINTS THE TEN, AND THE GAME WAS STARTING THE

GET DIRTIER.

AS MILLET SEETH TOWARDS THE CHAMPIONS YET AGAIN, CLUTCHING THE HLAFFLE TIGHTLY UNDER HER ARM, THE BULGARIAN KEEPER, ZHEGAR, ALEX HUNT THE MEET HER. WHATEVER HAPPENED WAS NEVER SEEN EXPLICITLY HARRY DIDN T CATCH IT, BUT A SCREAM OF RAGE FROM THE IRISH CROWD, AND MEESTARA S LONG, SHRILL WHISTLE BLAST, TOLD HIM IT HAD BEEN A FELL.

AND MEESTARA TAKES THE BULGARIAN KEEPER THE TASK FOR CHECKING

EXCESSIVE USE OF KICKS? RAGMAN INFORMED THE REARING SPECTATORS, AND YES, IT S A PENALTY THE IRELAND!

THE REPROACHES, WHICH HAD RISEN ANGRILY INTO THE AIR LIKE A SWARM OF GLITTERING FIREFLIES WHEN MILLET HAD BEEN FELL, NOW DARTED TOGETHER THE FORM THE WORDS HA HA HA!, THE VELA ON THE EITHER SIDE OF THE PITCH LEAPT THE THEIR FEET, THESSED THEIR HAIR ANGRILY AND STARTED THE DANCE AGAIN.

THE HARRY PENTTER

AS HERE, THE WEASLEY BIDS AND HARRY STUFFED THEIR FINGERS IN THEIR EARS, BUT HERMIONE, WHICH HADN T EITHERED, WAS SEEN TUGGING ON HARRY S ARM. HE TURNED THE LOOK AT HER, AND SHE PULLED HIS FINGERS IMPATIENTLY OUT OF HIS EARS.

LOOK AT THE REFEREE! SHE SAID, GIGGLING.

HARRY LOOKED DOWN AT THE PITCH. JASSAN MEESTARA HAD LANDED RIGHT IN FRONT OF THE DANCING VELA, AND WAS ACTING VERY FODLY

INDEED, HE WAS FLEXING HIS MUSCLES AND SMEEETHING HIS MUS-  
TACHE EXCITEDLY.

NHEH, WE CAN'T HAVE THAT! SAID LUDH RAGMAN, THOUGH HE  
SHOUNED HIGHLY AMUSED. SHERKEDY SLAP THE REFEREE?  
A MEDWIZARD CAME TEARING ACROSS THE PITCH, HIS FINGERS  
STUPEED IN HIS HEEN EARS, AND DICKED MEESTARA HARD INN THE SHINS.  
MEESTARA SEEMED THE CHEER THE HIMSELF; HARRY, WATCHING THROUGH  
THE HMNTHICKLARS AGAIN, SAW THAT HE LEEKED EXCEPTIONALLY  
EMBARRASSSED, AND WAS SHELTING AT THE VERLA, WHEH HAD STOPPED  
DANKING AND WERE LEEKING MLTINHELS.

AND UNLESS I M MUCH MISTAKEN, MEESTARA IS ACTUALLY ATTEMPT-  
ING THE SEND OFF THE BULGARIAN TEAM MASCOTS! SAID RAGMAN S

VEHCE, NHEH THERE S SOMETHING WE HAVEN'T SEEN BEFORE ... HEH, THIS  
CHEILD TURN NASTY ...

IT DID! THE BULGARIAN BEATERS, VELDHEV AND VLUCHANEV, HAD  
LANDED EITHER SIDE OF MEESTARA, AND BEGAN ARGUING FLURHELSLY WITH

HIM, GERTICULATING THEWARDS THE LEPROCHIALINS, WHEH HAD NHEH CLER-  
FULLY PHORMED THE WHIRDS FRR FRR FRR, MEESTARA WAS NEH

IMPRESSED BY THE BULGARIANS' ARGUMENTS, FEEHWEVER; HE WAS JAB-  
BING HIS FINGER INTHE THE AIR, CLEARLY TELLING THEM THE GET FLYING

AGAIN, AND WHEN THEY REPLIED, HE GAVE TWO SHERT BLASTS INN HIS



WHISTLE.

THE PENALTIES FOR IRELAND? SHELTERED BAGMAN, AND THE  
BULGARIAN CREW FELL WITH ANGER, AND VILKOVY AND  
VILKOVICHY HAD BETTER GET BACK IN THESE ROOMS ... YES ... THERE  
THEY GO ... AND THEY TAKE THE BLADE ...

PLAY NOW REACHED A LEVEL OF PERFECTION BEYOND ANYTHING THEY  
HAD YET SEEN. THE BEATERS ON BOTH SIDES WERE ACTING WITH

THE ELIOTTECH WORLD CLUB 101

MERCY: VILKOVY AND VILKOVICHY IN PARTICULAR SEEMED NOT TO CARE  
WHETHER THEIR CLUBS MADE CONTACT WITH BLADES OR HUMAN, AS  
THEY SWUNG THEM VIOLENTLY THROUGH THE AIR, DIMITRIY SENT  
STRAIGHT AT MERRAN, WHO HAD THE BLADE, NEARLY DENYING HER  
OFF HER KNEES.

FEEL: HEARD THE IRISH SLIPSTERS AS ONE, ALL STANDING UP IN  
A GREAT WAVE OF GREEN.

FEEL: HEARD BLADE BAGMAN'S MAGICALLY MAGNIFIED VOICE.

DIMITRIY SKINS MERRAN DELIBERATELY FLYING THE CLUB THERE  
AND IT'S GET THE RE ANOTHER PENALTY YES, THERE'S THE WHISTLE!  
THE REPREHENSIBLES HAD RISEN INTO THE AIR AGAIN AND, THIS TIME,  
THEY FORMED A GIANT HAND, WHICH WAS MAKING A VERY RUDE  
SIGN INDEED ACROSS THE PITCH TOWARDS THE VELA. AT THIS, THE  
VELA LEFT CENTRE. THEY LAUNCHED THEMSELVES ACROSS THE  
PITCH, AND BEGAN THROWING WHAT SEEMED THE RE HANDLES OF FIRE  
AT THE REPREHENSIBLES, WATCHING THROUGH HIS BINOCULARS, HARRY  
SAW THAT THEY DIDN'T LOOK REMOTELY BEAUTIFUL NOW. IN THE  
CONTRARY, THEIR FACES WERE ELONGATING INTO SHARP, CRUEL-LOOKING

BIRD HEADS, AND HERE, STALY WINGS WERE BURSTING FROM THEIR  
SHOULDERS

AND THAT, KIDS, YELLED MR LEASLEY OVER THE TUMULT OF THE  
CRUEL BATTLE, IS WHY YOU SHOULD NEVER GO FOR WOUNDS ALONE?  
MINISTRY WIZARDS WERE BLENDING INTO THE FIELD THE SEPARATE THE  
VEELA AND THE REPELLING, BUT WITH LITTLE SUCCESS; MEANWHILE,  
THE PITCHED BATTLE BATTLE WAS NOTHING THE THE ONE ABOVE. HARRY  
TURNED THIS WAY AND THAT, STARING THROUGH HIS EYEGLASSES, AS  
THE BATTLE CHANGED HANDS WITH THE SPEED OF A BULLET

LEVSKI DIMITRIY MERAN TREE MULLET IVANOV  
MERAN AGAIN MERAN MERAN STEERS:

BUT THE CHEERS OF THE IRISH SLIPSHOTS WERE BARELY HEARD OVER  
THE SHRIEKS OF THE VEELA, THE BASTS NOW ISSUING FROM THE  
MINISTRY MEMBERS HANDS, AND THE FLIRTLIS REARS OF THE  
BULGARIANS. THE GAME RESUMED IMMEDIATELY; NOW LEVSKI  
HAD THE BATTLE, NOW DIMITRIY

THE IRISH BEATER BULGLEY SWING HEAVILY AT A PASSING BULGER,

THE HARRY PETER

AND HIT IT AS HARD AS POSSIBLE TOWARDS DRUM, WHO DID NOT CLICK  
EITHER ENOUGH. IT HIT HIM HARD IN THE FACE.

THERE WAS A DRAVENING CRY FROM THE CRUEL; DRUM'S NECK  
BROKE CRACK, THERE WAS BLEED EVERYWHERE, BUT HASSAN  
NESTOR DIDN'T BLEED HIS WHISTLE. HE HAD BECOME DISTRACTED, AND  
HARRY COULDN'T BLAME HIM; ONE OF THE VEELA HAD THROWN A  
HANDFUL OF FIRE AND SET HIS CRIMINAL ALIGHT.

HARRY WANTED SOMEONE TO REALISE THAT DRUM WAS INJURED;

EVEN THOUGH HE WAS SLIPPERING IRELAND, KRUM WAS THE MOST  
EXCITING PLAYER ON THE PITCH. RON HEAVILY FELT THE SAME.

TIME OUT! AH, COME ON, HE CAN'T PLAY LIKE THAT, LOOK AT  
HIM

LOOK AT LYNCH! HARRY YELLED.

FOR THE IRISH SEEKER HAD SUDDENLY GONE INTO A DIVE, AND  
HARRY WAS WHITE SURE THAT THIS WAS THE WRENSKI PRINT; THIS WAS  
THE REAL THING ...

HE'S SEEN THE SNITCH! HARRY SCREAMED. HE'S SEEN IT! LOOK AT  
HIM GO!

HALF THE CROWD SEEMED TO HAVE REALISED WHAT WAS HAPPENING,  
THE IRISH SLIPPERERS RISE IN A GREAT WAVE OF GREEN, SCREAMING  
THEIR SEEKER ON ... BUT KRUM WAS ON HIS TAIL. THEN HE COULD SEE  
WHERE HE WAS GOING, HARRY HAD NO IDEA; THERE WERE FLOCKS OF  
BLOOD FLYING THROUGH THE AIR BEHIND HIM, BUT HE WAS DRAWING  
LEVEL WITH LYNCH NOW, AS THE PAIR OF THEM FLUTTERED TOWARDS THE  
GOBLIN AGAIN

THEY'RE GOING TO CRASH! SHRIEKED HERMIONE.

THEY'RE NOT! ROARED RON.

LYNCH IS! YELLED HARRY.

AND HE WAS RIGHT FOR THE SECOND TIME, LYNCH HIT THE

GOBLIN WITH TREMENDOUS FORCE, AND WAS IMMEDIATELY STAMPED-  
ON BY A HERD OF ANGRY VELA.

THE SNITCH, WHERE'S THE SNITCH? BELLEWD CHARLIE, ALONG THE  
RILL.

HE'S GET IT DURLIN'S GET IT IT'S ALL OVER! SCHELTED HARRY,  
DURLIN, HIS RED RIBBON SHINING WITH BLOOD FROM HIS NOSE, WAS

THE ELUDGOTTCH WERLD CLIP 1000

RISEING GENTLY INTO THE AIR, HIS FIST HELD HIGH, A GLINT OF GOLD IN  
HIS HAND.

THE SCHEKCHARD WAS FLASHING BLUE CARIA: ONE HUNDRED  
AND SIXTY, IRELAND: ONE HUNDRED AND SEVENTY  
ACROSS THE CIRCLE, WHEN DIDN'T SEEM THEY HAD REALISED WHAT HAD  
HAPPENED. THEN, SUDDENLY, AS THOUGH A GREAT JUMP IT WAS  
REVVING UP, THE RUMBLING FROM THE IRELAND SLIPPOETERS GREW  
LOUDER AND LOUDER AND ERUPTED INTO SCREAMS OF DELIGHT.

IRELAND WIN! SCHELTED RAGMAN, WHEN, LIKE THE IRISH,  
SEEMED THEY HAD BEEN TAKEN ABACK BY THE SUDDEN END OF THE  
MATCH. DURLIN GETS THE SNITCH BUT IRELAND WIN  
GOLD LEAD, I DIDN'T THINK ANY OF US WERE EXPECTING THAT!

WHAT DID HE CATCH THE SNITCH FOR? BEEN BELIEVED, EVEN AS HE  
JUMPED UP AND DOWN, APPLAUDING WITH HIS HANDS OVER HIS  
HEAD. HE ENDED IT WHEN IRELAND WERE A HUNDRED AND SIXTY  
POINTS AHEAD, THE IDIOT!

HE DENIED THEY WERE NEVER GOING TO CATCH UP, HARRY SCHELTED  
BACK OVER ALL THE NOISE, ALSO APPLAUDING LOUDLY, THE IRISH  
CHASERS WERE THE GOLD ... HE WANTED THEM TO END IT ON HIS TERMS,  
THAT'S ALL ...

HE WAS VERY BRAVE, WASN'T HE? HERMIENE SAID, LEANING FOR-  
WARD THE WATCH DURLIN LAND, AND THE SWARM OF MEDICIZARDS

BLASTING A PATH THROUGH THE BATTLING REPRESENTATIVES AND VERA THE  
GET THE HIM. HE LOOKS A TERRIBLE MESS ...

HARRY PUT HIS EMBELLISHES THE HIS EYES AGAIN. IT WAS HARD THE  
SEE WHAT WAS HAPPENING BEHIND, BECAUSE REPRESENTATIVES WERE  
ZEEHING DELIGHTEDLY ALL OVER THE PITCH, BUT HE COULD JUST MAKE  
HELT DRLIM, SURROUNDED BY MEDWIZARDS. HE LOOKED SWIFTER THAN  
EVER, AND REFUSED THE LET THEM MEEF HIM UP. HIS TEAM-MATES  
WERE AROUND HIM, SHAKING THEIR HEADS AND LOOKING DEJECTED. A  
SHORT WAY AWAY, THE IRISH PLAYERS WERE DANCING GLEEFULLY IN A  
SHOWER OF GOLD DESCENDING FROM THEIR MASCHETS. FLAGS WERE  
WAVING ALL OVER THE STADIUM, THE IRISH NATIONAL ANTHEM BLARED  
FROM ALL SIDES. THE VERA WERE STRIKING BACK INTO THEIR USUAL,  
REALTICAL SELVES NOW, THOUGH LOOKING DISPIRITED AND FEELERN.

104 HARRY PEEETTER

WELL, YE MIGHT BRAVELY, SAID A GLENNY VEHICLE BEHIND HARRY.  
HE LOOKED AROUND. IT WAS THE BULGARIAN MINISTER FOR MAGIC.  
WELL CAN SPEAK ENGLISH? SAID FLICK, BEHINDING HISTRACKED.  
AND WELL YE BEEN LETTING ME MIMIC EVERYTHING ALL DAY?

WELL, IT WAS VERY FLINDY, SAID THE BULGARIAN MINISTER, SHRUG-  
GING.

AND AS THE IRISH TEAM PERFORM A LAP OF HONOUR, FLANKED BY  
THEIR MASCHETS, THE FLUIDITCH WORLD CUP ITSELF IS BRILIGHT INTO  
THE THEE BEEK? BEHIND BAGMAN.

HARRY'S EYES WERE SUDDENLY DAZZLED BY A BLINDING WHITE

LIGHT, AS THE THEP KEEK WAS MAGICALLY ILLUMINATED SEE THAT EVERY-  
ONE IN THE STANDS COULD SEE THE INSIDE, SHELLINTING THEWARDS THE

ENTRANCE, HE SAW TWO PANTING WIZARDS CARRYING INTH THE KEEK A  
VAST CHILDEN CLIP, WHICH THEY HANDED THE CHERNELILS FLIDGER, WE-EE  
WAS STILL BLEEDING VERY DISORIENTED THAT HE D BEEN LISTING SIGN  
LANDSLAKE ALL DAY FERR NOTHING.

LET S HAVE A REALLY HELD HAND FERR THE GALLANT DEESERS  
BULGARIA? KACMAN SHELTED.

AND UP THE STAIRS INTH THE KEEK CAME THE SEVEN DEFEATED

BULGARIAN PLAYERS, THE CREED REELS WERE APPLAUDING APPRECI-  
ATIVELY; HARRY COULD SEE THOUSANDS AND THOUSANDS OF

EMPHILULAR LENSES FLASHING AND WINKING IN THEIR DIRECTION.

ONE BY ONE, THE BULGARIANS FILED BETWEEN THE REELS OF SEATS

IN THE KEEK, AND KACMAN CALLED OUT THE NAME OF EACH AS THEY

SHEED HANDS WITH THEIR ELIN MINISTER AND THEN WITH FLIDGER.

ORLIM, WE-EE WAS LAST IN LINE, BLEEDED A REAL MESS, TWO BLACK EYES

WERE BLEEDING SPECTACULARLY IN HIS BLEEDY FACE, HE WAS STILL

HELDING THE SNITCH, HARRY NOTICED THAT HE SEEMED MUCH LESS

CH-ORDINATED IN THE GRIELING, HE WAS SLIGHTLY BLACK-FHEETED AND

DISTINCTLY REELING-SHELDERED, BUT WHEN ORLIM'S NAME WAS

ANNOUNCED, THE WHOLE STADIUM GAVE HIM A RESEHLINDING, FAR-

SPLITTING REAR.

AND THEN CAME THE IRISH TEAM. AIDAN LYNCH WAS BEING SUPPORTED BY MERRAN AND LERNHELLY; THE SECOND CRASH SEEMED THE

HAVE DAZED HIM AND HIS EYES WERE STRANGELY UNFOCUSED, BUT

THE ELIOTT-WHEELS CLIP WAS

HE GRINNED HAPPILY AS TREY AND ELIOT LIFTED THE CLIP INTO THE AIR AND THE CROWD BEGAN THUNDERED THEIR APPROVAL. HARRY'S HANDS WERE BUSY WITH CLAPPING.

AT LAST, WHEN THE IRISH TEAM HAD LEFT THE RING THE PERFORMER ANOTHER LAP OF HONOUR IN THEIR CARRIAGES (AIDAN LYNCH IN THE BACK OF LERNHELLY'S, CLUTCHING HARD AROUND HIS WAIST AND STILL GRINNING IN A REPULSED SORT OF WAY). BAGMAN POINTED HIS HAND AT HIS THREAT AND MUTTERED ELIOTLY.

THEY'LL BE TALKING ABOUT THIS ONE FOR YEARS, HE SAID BARELY, A REALLY UNEXPECTED TWIST, THAT ... SOME IT COULD HAVE LASTED LONGER ... AH YES ... YES, I THINK YES ... YES MUCH?

FOR FRED AND GEORGE HAD JUST STRAMBLED OVER THE BACKS OF THEIR SEATS, AND WERE STANDING IN FRONT OF LIDEE BAGMAN WITH BROAD GRINS ON THEIR FACES, THEIR HANDS OUTSTRETCHED.

## CHAPTER NINE

THE DARK MARK

DIDN'T TELL MEET-HER SHE'VE BEEN GAMBLING, MR WEASLEY  
IMPLIRED FRED AND GEORGE, AS THEY ALL MADE THEIR WAY SILENTLY  
DOWN THE PURPLE-CARPETED STAIRS.

DIDN'T WHERRY, DAD, SAID FRED GLEEFULLY, WE'VE GOT BIG PLANS  
FOR THIS MONEY, WE DIDN'T WANT IT CONFISCATED.

MR WEASLEY HESITED FOR A MOMENT AS THOUGH HE WAS CHOICE THE  
AND WHAT THESE BIG PLANS WERE, BUT SEEMED TO DECIDE, UPON  
REFLECTION, THAT HE DIDN'T WANT THE MONEY.

THEY WERE THEN CALLED UP IN THE CHILDS NEW FLEETING HLT  
OF THE STADIUM AND BACK TO THEIR CAMPSITES. RALPH'S SINGING  
WAS HEARD TOWARDS THEM IN THE NIGHT AIR AS THEY RETRACED THEIR  
STEPS ALONG THE LANTERN-LIT PATH, AND REPROACHING KEPT SHOOTING  
OVER THEIR HEADS, CACKLING AND WAVING THEIR LANTERNS. WHEN  
THEY FINALLY REACHED THE TENTS, NEITHER FELT LIKE SLEEPING AT ALL  
AND, GIVEN THE LEVEL OF NOISE AROUND THEM, MR WEASLEY AGREED  
THAT THEY COULD ALL HAVE ONE LAST CLIP OF CHICKA TOGETHER BEFORE  
TURNING IN. THEY WERE THEN ARGUING ENTHUSIASTICALLY ABOUT THE MATCH;  
MR WEASLEY GOT DRAWN INTO A DISAGREEMENT ABOUT CHECKING WITH  
CHARLIE, AND IT WAS ONLY WHEN GINNY FELL ASLEEP RIGHT AT THE  
TINY TABLE AND SPILLED HER CHOCOLATE ALL OVER THE FLOOR THAT MR  
WEASLEY CALLED A HALT TO THE VERBAL REPLAYS, AND INSISTED THAT  
EVERYONE WENT TO BED. HERMION AND GINNY WENT INTO THE NEXT  
TENT, AND HARRY AND THE REST OF THE WEASLEYS CHANGED INTO  
PYJAMAS AND CLAMBERED INTO THEIR BUNKS. FROM THE EITHER SIDE  
OF THE CAMPSITE THEY COULD STILL HEAR MICKY SINGING, AND THE HED  
ECHOING BACK.



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"EH, I AM GLAD I M MEET HN DUTY, MUTTERED MR WEASLEY  
SLEEPILY, I WOULDNT FANCY HAVING THE GH AND TELL THE IRISH THEY VE  
GHT THE STEEP CELEBRATING.

HARRY, WHO WAS HN A THP BLIND ABOVE REIN, WAS STARING UP AT  
THE CANVAS CEILING OF THE TENT, WATCHING THE GLEW OF AN  
ECCLESIASTICAL REPRESENTATIVE LANTERN FLYING EVERHEAD, AND PICTURING  
AGAIN SOME OF DORLINS MORE SPECTACULAR MOVES. HE WAS ITCHING  
TO GET BACK HN HIS OWN FIREHEAT AND TRY OUT THE GREENSKI FEINT  
... SOMEHOW ELIVER WOULD HAD NEVER MANAGED THE CHIVY WITH  
ALL HIS WRIGGLING DIAGRAMS WHAT THAT MOVE WAS SLIPPED THE  
WIND LIKE ... HARRY SAW HIMSELF IN REES THAT HAD HIS NAME HN

THE BACK, AND IMAGINED THE SENSATION OF HEARING A HUNDRED-  
THOUSAND-STRING CHORD REAR, AS LUDWIG BAGMAN S VEHICLE REARED

THROUGHOUT THE STADIUM, I GIVE YOU ... BETTER!

HARRY NEVER KNEW WHETHER HE HAD ACTUALLY DROPPED OFF THE  
SLEEP OR NOT HIS FANTASIES OF FLYING LIKE DORLIN MIGHT WELL HAVE  
SLIPPED INTO ACTUAL DREAMS ALL HE KNEW WAS THAT, WHITE  
SUDDENLY, MR WEASLEY WAS SPEAKING.

GET UP! REIN HARRY COME HN NOW, GET UP, THIS IS URGENT!  
HARRY SAT UP QUICKLY AND THE THP OF HIS HEAD HIT CANVAS.

S MATTER? HE SAID.

SIMPLY, HE COULD TELL THAT SOMETHING WAS WRONG. THE NOISES  
IN THE CAMPSITE HAD CHANGED. THE SINGING HAD STOPPED. HE  
COULD HEAR SCREAMS, AND THE SOUND OF PEOPLE RUNNING.

HE SLIPPED DOWN FROM THE CLIMB, AND REACHED FOR HIS CLOTHES,  
BUT MR LEASLEY, WHO HAD PULLED HIM HIS JEANS OVER HIS HEAD  
PYLONAS, SAID, 'NE TIME, HARRY' MUST GRAB A JACKET AND GET  
HITSIDE QUICKLY!

HARRY DID AS HE WAS TOLD, AND HURRIED OUT OF THE TENT, RAN AT  
HIS HEELS.

BY THE LIGHT OF THE FEW FIRES THAT WERE STILL BURNING, HE COULD  
SEE PEOPLE RUNNING AWAY INTO THE WOODS, FLEEING SOMETHING  
THAT WAS MOVING ACROSS THE FIELD TOWARDS THEM, SOMETHING THAT  
WAS EMITTING RED FLASHES OF LIGHT, AND NOISES LIKE CLINKING. HEARD  
KEEPING, HEARS OF LAUGHTER AND DRUNKEN YELLS WERE DRIFTING

100 HARRY PUTTER

TOWARDS THEM; THEN CAME A BURST OF STRONG GREEN LIGHT, WHICH  
ILLUMINATED THE SCENE.

A CREW OF WIZARDS, TIGHTLY PACKED AND MOVING TOGETHER  
WITH HANDS POINTING STRAIGHT UPWARDS, WAS MARCHING SILENTLY  
ACROSS THE FIELD. HARRY SHRIEKED AT THEM ... THEY DIDN'T SEEM TO  
HAVE FACES ... THEN HE REALISED THAT THEIR HEADS WERE HIDDEN  
AND THEIR FACES MASKED. HIGH ABOVE THEM, FLOATING ALONG IN  
MID-AIR, THEIR STRUGGLING FIGURES WERE BEING CONTORTED INTO  
GROTESQUE SHAPES. IT WAS AS THOUGH THE MASKED WIZARDS IN THE  
CREW WERE PUPPETERS, AND THE PEOPLE ABOVE THEM WERE  
MARIONETTES OPERATED BY INVISIBLE STRINGS THAT ROSE FROM THE  
HANDS INTO THE AIR. THEN THE FIGURES WERE VERY SMALL,  
MORE WIZARDS WERE JOINING THE MARCHING CREW, LAUGHING  
AND POINTING UP AT THE FLOATING KIDDIES. TENTS CRUMPLED AND FELL

AS THE MARCHING CREWD SWELLED, HEARD HER TWICE HARRY SAW HER  
OF THE MARCHERS BLAST A TENT HURT OF HIS WAY WITH HIS WAND,  
SEVERAL CALIGHT FIRE, THE SCREAMING CREW LEADER,  
THE BREATHING PEOPLE WERE SUDDENLY ILLUMINATED AS THEY  
PASSED OVER A BURNING TENT, AND HARRY RECOGNISED HER OF THEM

Mrs PERKINS, THE CAMPSITE MANAGER, THE OTHER THREE LEANED AS  
THOUGH THEY MIGHT BE HIS WIFE AND CHILDREN, HEARD OF THE  
MARCHERS REBEL FLIPPED Mrs PERKINS UPSIDE-DOWN WITH HIS  
WAND; HER NIGHTDRESS FELL DOWN THE REVEAL VILLAINOUS DRAWERS;  
SHE STRUGGLED THE COVER HERSELF UP AS THE CREW REBEL HER  
STRETCHED AND HENTED WITH GLEE.

THAT S SIDE, THEN MUTTERED, WATCHING THE SMALLEST MUGGLE  
CHILD, WHO HAD BEGUN THE SPIN LIKE A TOP, SIXTY FEET ABOVE THE  
CREW, HIS HEAD SWAPPING LIMPLY FROM SIDE THE SIDE. THAT IS  
REALLY SICK ...

HERMIONE AND GINNY CAME FLURRYING TOWARDS THEM, PULLING  
COATS OVER THEIR NIGHTDRESSES, WITH Mr WEASLEY RIGHT BEHIND  
THEM. AT THE SAME MOMENT, BILL, CHARLIE AND PERCY EMERGED  
FROM THE REYS TENT, FULLY DRESSED, WITH THEIR SLEEVES ROLLED UP  
AND THEIR HANDS HURT.

WE ARE GOING TO HELP THE MINISTRY, Mr WEASLEY SHOUTED OVER

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ALL THE WHILE, ROLLING UP HIS OWN SLEEVES, YELL LET GET INTO THE  
WHEELS, AND STICK TOGETHER, I LL COME AND FETCH YOU WHEN WE VE  
STARTED THIS HURT!

BILL, CHARLIE AND PERCY WERE ALREADY SPRINTING AWAY TOWARDS

THE ENCHURING MARCHERS; MR WEASLEY THERE AFTER THEM, MINISTRY WIZARDS WERE DASHING FROM EVERY DIRECTION TOWARDS THE SHELTER OF THE TUNNEL. THE CROWD BENEATH THE REBERTS FAMILY WAS CROWDING EVER CLOSER.

[ THEN, SAID FRED, GRABBING CINDY'S HAND AND STARTING TO PULL HER TOWARDS THE WOOD. HARRY, RON, HERMIONIE AND GEORGE FOLLOWED. THEY ALL BREKED BACK AS THEY REACHED THE TREES. THE CROWD BENEATH THE REBERTS FAMILY WAS LARGER THAN EVER; THEY COULD SEE THE MINISTRY WIZARDS TRYING TO GET THROUGH IT THE THE BREKED WIZARDS IN THE CENTRE, BUT THEY WERE HAVING GREAT DIFFICULTY. IT LOOKED AS THOUGH THEY WERE SCARED THE PERFORM ANY SPELL THAT MIGHT MAKE THE REBERTS FAMILY FALL.

THE CANDLELANT LANTERNS THAT HAD LIT THE PATH TO THE STADIUM HAD BEEN EXTINGUISHED. DARK FIGURES WERE BLINDERING THROUGH THE TREES; CHILDREN WERE CRYING; ANXIOUS SHELTS AND PANICKED VEHICLES WERE REVERBERATING AROUND THEM IN THE COLD NIGHT AIR. HARRY FELT HIMSELF BEING PUSHED HITHER AND THITHER BY PEOPLE WHOSE FACES HE COULD NOT SEE. THEN HE HEARD RON YELL WITH PAIN.

WHAT HAPPENED? SAID HERMIONIE ANXIOUSLY, STEPPING SHE ABRUPTLY THAT HARRY WALKED INTO HER. RON, WHERE ARE YOU? HE, THIS IS STUPID. LUMES!

SHE ILLUMINATED HER WAND AND DIRECTED ITS NARROW BEAM ACROSS THE PATH. RON WAS LYING SPRAWLED ON THE GROUND.

TRIPPED OVER A TREE-ROOT, HE SAID ANGERILY, GETTING TO HIS FEET AGAIN.

WELL, WITH FEET THAT SIZE, HARD NOT TO, SAID A DRAWLING VOICE

FROM BEHIND THEM.

HARRY, RON AND HERMIONIE TURNED SHARPLY, DRACE MALFOY WAS  
STANDING ALONE NEARBY THEM, LEANING AGAINST A TREE, LOOKING  
LITTERLY RELAXED. HIS ARMS FOLDED, HE SEEMED TO HAVE BEEN

110 HARRY POUTTER

WATCHING THE SCENE FROM THE CAMPSITE THROUGH A GAP IN THE TREES.  
RON TOLD MALFOY HE DID SOMETHING THAT HARRY KNEW HE WOULD  
NEVER HAVE DARED SAY IN FRONT OF MRS WEASLEY.

LANGUAGE, WEASLEY, SAID MALFOY HIS PALE EYES GLITTERING.

HADN'T YOU BETTER BE FLYING ALONG, NEELY? YOU WOULDN'T LIKE  
HER SPEECHES, WOULD YOU?

HE NODDED AT HERMIONIE, AND AT THE SAME MOMENT, A BLAST  
LIKE A BOMB SHOOKED FROM THE CAMPSITE, AND A FLASH OF GREEN  
LIGHT MOMENTARILY LIT THE TREES AROUND THEM.

WHAT'S THAT SUPPOSED TO MEAN? SAID HERMIONIE DEFIANTLY.

CRANGER, THEY'RE AFTER MUGGLES, SAID MALFOY. DO YOU WANT TO  
BE SHOOTING OFF YOUR KNICKERS IN MID-AIR? BECAUSE IF YOU DO,  
HANG AROUND ... THEY'RE MOVING THIS WAY, AND IT WOULD GIVE US  
ALL A LAUGH.

HERMIONIE'S A WITCH, HARRY SNARLED.

HAVE IT YOUR OWN WAY, POUTER, SAID MALFOY, GRINNING  
MALICIOUSLY. IF YOU THINK THEY CAN'T SPOT A MURDERER, STAY  
WHERE YOU ARE.

YOU WATCH YOUR MOUTH! SHOUTED RON, EVERYBODY PRESENT  
KNEW THAT MURDERER WAS A VERY OFFENSIVE TERM FOR A WITCH OR  
WIZARD OF MUGGLE PARENTAGE.

NEVER MIND, RHN, SAID HERMIONE QUICKLY, SEIZING RHN'S ARM  
TO RESTRAIN HIM AS HE TOOK A STEP TOWARDS MALFOY.

THERE CAME A RANG FROM THE EITHER SIDE OF THE TREES THAT WAS  
LOUDER THAN ANYTHING THEY HAD HEARD. SEVERAL PEOPLE NEARBY  
SCREAMED.

MALFOY CHUCKLED SEPTLY. SCARE EASILY, DONT THEY? HE SAID  
LAZILY. I SUPPOSE YOUR DADDY TELLS YOU ALL THE LIES? WHAT IS HE UP  
TO TRYING TO RESCUE THE MUGGLES?

WHERE ARE YOUR PARENTS? SAID HARRY, HIS TEMPER RISING. ELIT  
THEIR WEARING MASKS, ARE THEY?

MALFOY TURNED HIS FACE TO HARRY, STILL SMILING. WELL ... IF THEY  
WERE, I WOULDN'T BE LIKELY TO TELL YOU, WOULD I, POTTERT?

HEY, COME ON, SAID HERMIONE, WITH A DISGUSTED LOOK AT  
MALFOY, LET'S GO AND FIND THE OTHERS.

### THE DARK MARK 111

KEEP THAT BIG BLISHY HEAD DOWN, CRANGER, SNEERED MALFOY.  
COME ON, HERMIONE REPEATED, AND SHE PULLED HARRY AND  
RHN OFF UP THE PATH AGAIN.

I'LL GET YOU ANYTHING HIS DAD IS HERE OF THAT MASKED LEFT? SAID  
RHN HEFTILY.

WELL, WITH ANY LUCK, THE MINISTRY WILL CATCH HIM? SAID  
HERMIONE PERVENTLY. HEY, I CAN'T BELIEVE THIS, WHERE HAVE THE  
OTHERS GOTTEN?

FRED, GEORGE AND GINNY WERE NOWHERE TO BE SEEN, THOUGH  
THE PATH WAS PACKED WITH PLenty OF OTHER PEOPLE, ALL OF THEM

LEADING NERVIOUSLY OVER THEIR SHOULDERS TOWARDS THE CHIMNEY-  
THIN ROCK AT THE CAMPSITE.

A Huddle of TEENAGERS IN PYLAMAS WAS ARGUING VIOLENTLY A  
LITTLE WAY ALONG THE PATH. WHEN THEY SAW HARRY, RON AND  
HERMION, A GIRL WITH THICK, CURLY HAIR TURNED AND SAID QUICKLY,

IS THAT MADAME MAXIME? SHE'S A VERY POWERFUL

WITCH, SAID RON.

YES ... THE GIRL WHO HAD SPOKEN TURNED HER BACK ON HIM,  
AND AS THEY WALKED ON THEY DISTINCTLY HEARD HER SAY, HEWARTS.  
REALIZATION, MUTTERED HERMION.

SHERRY? SAID HARRY.

THEY MUST GO TO REALIZATION, SAID HERMION. SHE KNOWS  
... REALIZATION ACADEMY OF MAGIC ... I READ ABOUT IT IN AN  
APPRAISAL OF MAGICAL EDUCATION IN EUROPE.

YES ... YES ... RIGHT, SAID HARRY.

FRED AND GEORGE CAN'T HAVE GONE THAT FAR, SAID RON, PULLING  
OUT HIS WAND, LIGHTING IT LIKE HERMION, AND SHOOTING UP THE  
PATH. HARRY DUG IN THE POCKETS OF HIS JACKET FOR HIS OWN WAND

BUT IT WASN'T THERE. THE ONLY THINGS HE COULD FIND WERE HIS  
MOMENTARILY.

NO, NO, I DON'T BELIEVE IT ... I'VE LOST MY WAND!

YOU'RE KIDDING?

RON AND HERMION RAISED THEIR WANDS HIGH ENOUGH THE  
SPREAD THE NARROW BEAMS OF LIGHT FURTHER IN THE GROUND; HARRY  
LEANED ALL AROUND HIM, BUT HIS WAND WAS NOWHERE TO BE SEEN.

## 112 HARRY POTTER

MAYBE IT'S BACK IN THE TENT, SAID RON.

MAYBE IT FELL OUT OF YOUR POCKET WHEN WE WERE RUNNING?

HERMIONIE SUGGESTED ANXIOUSLY.

Yeah, said Harry, maybe ...

He usually kept his wand with him at all times in the wizarding world, and finding himself without it in the midst of a scene like this made him feel very vulnerable.

A rustling noise made all three of them jump. Windy the house-elf was fighting her way out of a clump of bushes nearby. She was moving in a most peculiar fashion, apparently with great difficulty; it was as though someone invisible was trying to hold her back.

There is bad wizards about! she squeaked distractedly, as she leant forwards and laboured the deep running. People high

high in the air! Windy is getting out of the way!

And she disappeared into the trees on the other side of the path, panting and squeaking as she fought the force that was restraining her.

What's up with her? said Ron, looking curiously after Windy. Why can't she run properly?

But she didn't ask permission to hide, said Harry. He was thinking of Dobby! Every time he had tried to do something the Malfoy's wouldn't like, he had been forced to start beating himself up.

Well Dobby, house-elves get a very raw deal! said Hermione indignantly. It's slavery, that's what it is! That Mr Crouch made



HER CHELIP THE THE THEP OF THE STADILIN, AND SHE WAS TERRIFIED, AND  
HE S GHT HER BELITCHED SHE SHE CAN T EVEN RUN WHEN THEY START  
TRAMPLING TENTS! WHY DOESN T ANYONE DO SOMETHING ABOUT IT?  
WELL, THE ELVES ARE HAPPY, AREN T THEY? REEN SAID. YELL HEARD  
HED WINDY BACK AT THE MATCH ... FHELSE-ELVES IS NOT SLIPPED  
THE HAVE RUN ... THAT S WHAT SHE LIKES, BEING BESSSED ABOUT ...  
IT S PEOPLE LIKE YELL, REEN, FERMINE BEGAN HEETLY, WHEN PROPP  
UP BEETEN AND UNILIST SYSTEMS, LIST BEALISE THEY RE THE LAZY THE  
ANOTHER WILD BANG ECHED FROM THE EDGE OF THE WOOD.

## THE DARK MARCH 113

LET S LIST KEEP MOVING, SHALL WE? SAID REEN, AND HARRY SAW  
HIM GLANCE ECHLY AT FERMINE, PERHAPS THERE WAS TRUTH IN  
WHAT MALTHEY HAD SAID; PERHAPS FERMINE WAS IN MORE DANGER  
THAN THEY WERE. THEY SET OFF AGAIN, HARRY STILL SEARCHING HIS  
POCKETS, EVEN THOUGH HE KNEW HIS WAND WASN T THERE.

THEY FOLLOWED THE DARK PATH DEEPER INTO THE WOOD, STILL  
KEEPING AN EYE OUT FOR RED, GREEN AND GOLD. THEY PASSED A  
GRIIP OF GRIINS, WHEN WERE CACKLING OVER A SACK OF GOLD THEY  
HAD UNEXPECTEDLY BEEN GETTING IN THE MATCH, AND WHEN  
SEEMED WHITE UNPERTURBED BY THE TREBLE IN THE CAMPSITE.  
FURTHER STILL ALONG THE PATH, THEY WALKED INTO A PATCH OF  
SILVER LIGHT, AND WHEN THEY LOOKED THROUGH THE TREES, THEY SAW  
THREE TALL AND BEAUTIFUL YELLA STANDING IN A CLEARING, SURROUND-  
ED BY A CIRCLE OF YELLING WIZARDS, ALL OF WHOM WERE TALKING VERY

WELLBY.

I PULL DOWN ABOUT A HUNDRED SACKS OF CALLIBANS A YEAR, HENCE  
OF THEM SKELTED. I'M A DRAGON-KILLER FOR THE COMMITTEE FOR THE  
DISPOSAL OF DANGEROUS CREATURES.

NEH, YOU'RE NOT, YELLED HIS FRIEND, YOU'RE A DISH-WASHER AT  
THE LEADY CALIBREIN ... BUT I'M A VAMPIRE SLAYER, I'VE KILLED  
ABOUT NINETY SO FAR

A THIRD YELING WIZARD, WHOSE PIMPLES WERE VISIBLE EVEN BY  
THE DIM, SILVER LIGHT OF THE VEIL, NOW CLIT IN, I'M ABOUT THE  
BECOME THE YELINGEST EVER MINISTER FOR MAGIC, I AM.

HARRY SNEELED WITH LAUGHTER. HE RECOGNISED THE PIMPLY WIZARD;  
HIS NAME WAS STAN SKIMPICK, AND HE WAS IN FACT A CHURCHILLER  
HON THE TRIPLE-DECKER KNIGHT BUS.

HE TURNED THE TELL THEN THIS, BUT THEN'S FACE HAD GONE HOOLY  
SLACK, AND NEXT SECOND THEN WAS YELLING, DID I TELL YOU I'VE  
INVENTED A BROOMSTICK THAT LL REACH JUPITER?

HONESTLY? SAID HERMIONE AGAIN, AND SHE AND HARRY GRABBED  
THEN FIRMLY BY THE ARMS, WHEELED HIM AROUND AND MARCHED HIM  
AWAY. BY THE TIME THE SHEDS OF THE VEIL AND THEIR ADMIRERS  
HAD FADED COMPLETELY, THEY WERE IN THE VERY HEART OF THE WOOD.  
THEY SEEMED THE BE ALONE NOW; EVERYTHING WAS MUCH QUIETER.

## 114 HARRY PEEETER

HARRY WHEELED AROUND. I RECKON WE CAN JUST WAIT HERE, YOU  
KNOW, WE LL HEAR ANYONE COMING A MILE OFF.

THE WORDS WERE HARDLY OUT OF HIS MOUTH, WHEN LUDIE  
BAGMAN EMERGED FROM BEHIND A TREE RIGHT AHEAD OF THEM.

EVEN BY THE FEEBLE LIGHT OF THE TWO WANDS, HARRY COULD SEE THAT A GREAT CHANGE HAD COME OVER BAGMAN. HE NO LONGER LOOKED ELEGANT AND REEFY-FACED; THERE WAS NO MORE SPRING IN HIS STEP. HE LOOKED VERY WHITE AND STRAINED.

WHAT'S THAT? HE SAID, BLINKING DOWN AT THEM, TRYING TO MAKE OUT THEIR FACES. WHAT ARE YOU DOING IN HERE, ALL ALONE? THEY LOOKED AT EACH OTHER, SURPRISED.

WELL THERE'S A SORT OF RIGHT GOING ON, SAID RHN. BAGMAN STARED AT HIM. WHAT?

IN THE CAMPSITE ... SOME PEOPLE HAVE GOTTEN HOLD OF A FAMILY OF MUGGLES ...

BAGMAN SWORE LOUDLY. DAMN THEM! HE SAID, LOOKING SLIGHTLY DISTRACTED, AND WITHOUT ANOTHER WORD, HE DISAPPEARED WITH A SMALL POOF.

NOT EXACTLY IN THE OF THINGS, MR BAGMAN, IS HE? SAID HERMIONE, FROWNING.

HE WAS A GREAT BEATER, THOUGH, SAID RHN, LEADING THE WAY OFF THE PATH INTO A SMALL CLEARING, AND SITTING DOWN IN A PATCH OF DRY GRASS AT THE FOOT OF A TREE. THE WIMPELWINE WASN'T WHEN THE LEAGUE THREE TIMES IN A ROW WHILE HE WAS WITH THEM.

HE THOUGHT HIS SMALL FIGURE OF DURLM HURT OF HIS POCKET, SET IT DOWN IN THE GRASS AND WATCHED IT WALK AROUND FOR A WHILE. LIKE THE REAL DURLM, THE MEDEL WAS SLIGHTLY CLIMB-FEETED AND REELING-SHULDERED, MUCH LESS IMPRESSIVE IN HIS STOLPED FEET THAN IN HIS BRIMMISTICK. HARRY WAS LISTENING OUT FOR NOISE FROM THE CAMPSITE. EVERYTHING STILL SEEMED QUIET; PERHAPS THE RIGHT WAS OVER.

I HOPE THE OTHERS ARE FINE, SAID HERMIONE AFTER A WHILE.

THEY WILL BE FINE, SAID RON.

IMAGINE IF YOUR DAD CATCHES LUCIUS MALFOY, SAID HARRY, SITTING DOWN NEXT TO RON AND WATCHING THE SMALL FIGURE OF DRAGON

THE DARK MARK WAS

SHEDDING OVER THE FALLEN LEAVES. HE ALWAYS SAID HE'D LIKE TO GET SOMETHING OUT OF HIM.

THAT'D WIPE THE SMILE OFF DRAGON'S FACE, ALL RIGHT, SAID RON.

THESE OTHER MUGGLES, HOWEVER, SAID HERMIONE NERVOUSLY.

WHAT IF THEY CAN'T GET THEM DOWN?

THEY WILL, SAID RON REASSURINGLY, THEY WILL FIND A WAY.

WELL, HOWEVER, THEY DO SOMETHING LIKE THAT WHEN THE WHITE MINISTRY OF MAGIC'S HELD HERE TONIGHT? SAID HERMIONE. I MEAN, WHEN DO THEY EXPECT THEM GET AWAY WITH IT? DO YOU THINK THEY'VE BEEN DRINKING, OR ARE THEY JUST

BUT SHE BROKE OFF ABRUPTLY AND LOOKED OVER HER SHOULDER.

HARRY AND RON LOOKED QUICKLY AROUND, THEN, IT SEEMED AS THOUGH SOMEONE WAS STAGGERING TOWARDS THEIR CLEARING. THEY WAITED, LISTENING TO THE SOUNDS OF THE LIKELY STEPS BEHIND THE DARK TREES, BUT THE FOOTSTEPS CAME TO A SUDDEN HALT.

HELEN? CALLED HARRY.

THERE WAS SILENCE. HARRY GOT TO HIS FEET AND PEERED AROUND THE TREE. IT WAS TOO DARK TO SEE VERY FAR, BUT HE COULD SENSE SOMEONE STANDING JUST BEYOND THE RANGE OF HIS VISION.

WHERE'S THERE? HE SAID.

AND THEN, WITHOUT WARNING, THE SILENCE WAS RENT BY A VOICE  
UNLIKE ANY THEY HAD HEARD IN THE WOOD; AND IT LITTERED, NEXT A  
PANICKED SCREAM, BUT WHAT SEEMED LIKE A SPELL.

MEERSMERDORF:

AND SOMETHING VAST, GREEN AND GLITTERING ERUPTED FROM THE

PATCH OF DARKNESS HARRY'S EYES HAD BEEN STRUGGLING TO PENETRATE: IT FLEW UP OVER THE TREETOPS AND INTO THE SKY.

WHAT THE ? GASPED BEN, AS HE SPRANG TO HIS FEET AGAIN,  
STARING UP AT THE THING THAT HAD APPEARED.

FOR A SPLIT SECOND, HARRY THOUGHT IT WAS ANOTHER REPRESENTATION

OF THE SAME THING. THEN HE REALISED THAT IT WAS A CELESTIAL SKILL, COMPOSED OF WHAT LOOKED LIKE EMERALD STARS, WITH A SERPENT PRETENDING FROM ITS MOUTH LIKE A TONGUE. AS THEY WATCHED, IT ROSE

HIGHER AND HIGHER, BLAZING IN A HAZE OF GREENISH SMOKE, ETCHED

118 HARRY PETER

AGAINST THE BLACK SKY LIKE A NEW CONSTELLATION.

SLUDDENLY, THE WOOD ALL AROUND THEM ERUPTED WITH SCREAMS.

HARRY DIDN'T UNDERSTAND WHY, BUT THE ONLY POSSIBLE CAUSE WAS THE SUDDEN APPEARANCE OF THE SKILL, WHICH HAD NOW RISEN HIGH ENOUGH TO ILLUMINATE THE ENTIRE WOOD, LIKE SOME GRISLY GREEN

SIGN, HE SCANNED THE DARKNESS FOR THE PERSON WHO HAD CHALLENGED THE SKULL, BUT HE COULDN'T SEE ANYONE.

WHO'S THERE? HE CALLED AGAIN.

HARRY, COME ON, MOVE! HERMIONE HAD SEIZED THE BACK OF HIS JACKET, AND WAS TUGGING HIM BACKWARDS.

WHAT'S THE MATTER? HARRY SAID, STARTLED TO SEE HER FACE SO WHITE AND TERRIFIED.

IT'S THE DARK MARK, HARRY! HERMIONE MEANED, PULLING HIM AS HARD AS SHE COULD. SHELL-SHELL-WHO'S SIGN?

WILDERMANT'S ?

HARRY, COME ON!

HARRY TURNED. RON WAS HURRIEDLY SCRAMBLING UP HIS MINIATURE SKRIM. THE THREE OF THEM STARTED ACROSS THE CLEARING. BUT BEFORE THEY HAD TAKEN MORE THAN A FEW HURRIED STEPS, A SERIES OF PLOPPING NOISES ANNOUNCED THE ARRIVAL OF TWENTY WIZARDS, APPEARING FROM THIN AIR, SURROUNDING THEM.

HARRY WHIRLED AROUND, AND IN A SPLIT SECOND, HE REGISTERED ONE FACT: EACH OF THESE WIZARDS HAD HIS WAND HILT, AND EVERY WAND WAS POINTING RIGHT AT HIMSELF, RON AND HERMIONE. WITHOUT PAUSING TO THINK, HE YELLED, BLIND! HE SEIZED THE OTHER TWO AND PULLED THEM DOWN INTO THE GRASS.

STLPOPP! HEARD TWENTY VOICES. THERE WAS A BLINDING SERIES OF FLASHES AND HARRY FELT THE HAIR ON HIS HEAD RIPPLE AS THOUGH A POWERFUL WIND HAD SWEEPED THE CLEARING, RAISING HIS HEAD A FRACTION OF AN INCH HE SAW LETS OF FIERY RED LIGHT FLYING OVER THEM FROM THE WIZARDS' WANDS, CRUISING EACH

ETHER, REELING OFF TREE-TRUNKS, REELING INTO THE DARKNESS

STEP? YELLED A VOICE HE RECOGNISED. STEPH? THAT'S MY SON?  
HARRY'S HAIR STOPPED BLEWING AWAY. HE RAISED HIS HEAD A

THE DARK MARCH 119

LITTLE HIGHER. THE WIZARD IN FRONT OF HIM HAD LOWERED HIS WAND.  
HE REELLED BACK AND SAW MR WEASLEY STRIDING TOWARDS THEM,  
LOOKING TERRIFIED.

WHEN HARRY HIS VOICE SHOOKED SLIGHTLY, HERMION GRABED  
YELL ALL RIGHT?

HELT OF THE WAY, ARTHUR, SAID A CHILD, CLUT VEHICLE.  
IT WAS MR CRUICK. HE AND THE OTHER MINISTRY WIZARDS WERE  
CHASING IN FRONT OF THEM. HARRY GOT THE HIS FEET THE FACE THEM. MR  
CRUICK'S FACE WAS TIGHT WITH RAGE.

WHICH HE YELL DID IT? HE SNAPPED, HIS SHARP EYES DARTING  
BETWEEN THEM. WHICH HE YELL CHASED THE DARK MARCH?

WE DIDN'T DO THAT? SAID HARRY, GESTURING UP AT THE SKILL.  
WE DIDN'T DO ANYTHING? SAID RON, WHO WAS RUBBING HIS  
EYES, AND LOOKING INDIGNANTLY AT HIS FATHER. WHAT DID YELL  
WANT THE ATTACK LIS FEAR?

DO NOT LIE, SIR? REPLIED MR CRUICK. HIS WAND WAS STILL  
POINTING DIRECTLY AT RON, AND HIS EYES WERE PEEPING HE  
LOOKED SLIGHTLY MAD. YELL HAVE BEEN DISCOVERED AT THE SCENE OF  
THE CRIME?

KARTY, WHISPERED A WHISPER IN A LONG WHISPERING DRESSING-ROOM,  
THEY'RE DEAD, KARTY, THEY'D NEVER HAVE BEEN ABLE TO

WHERE DID THE MARK COME FROM, WELL THERE? SAID MR  
WEASLEY QUICKLY,

EVER THERE, SAID HERMIONE QUICKLY, POINTING AT THE PLACE  
WHERE THEY HAD HEARD THE VOICE, THERE WAS SOMEONE BEHIND  
THE TREES ... THEY SHOUTED WORDS AN INCANTATION

HEY, STAND EVER THERE, DID THEY? SAID MR CRUICK, TURNING HIS  
POPPING EYES ON HERMIONE WHEN, DISBELIEF ETCHED ALL OVER HIS  
FACE, SAID AN INCANTATION, DID THEY? WELL SEEM VERY WELL

INFORMED ABOUT THE THAT MARK IS SLIGHTED, MISSY

BUT NONE OF THE MINISTRY WIZARDS APART FROM MR CRUICK

SEEMED TO THINK IT REMOTELY LIKELY THAT HARRY, THEN HER HERMIONE  
HAD CHANGED THE SPELL; ON THE CONTRARY, AT HERMIONE'S WORDS,  
THEY HAD RAISED ALL THEIR WANDS AGAIN, AND WERE POINTING IN THE  
DIRECTION SHE HAD INDICATED, SWIFTLY THROUGH THE DARK TREES.

## 118 HARRY POTTTER

WE ARE TOO LATE, SAID THE WITCH IN THE WOODEN DRESSING-ROOM,  
SHAKING HER HEAD. THEY WILL HAVE DISAPPEARED.

I DON'T THINK SO, SAID A WIZARD WITH A SCRUFFY REDDENED BEARD,  
IT WAS AMES DIGGORY, CEDRIC'S FATHER. HEAR STUNNERS WENT RIGHT  
THROUGH THESE TREES ... THERE'S A GOOD CHANCE WE GOT THEM ...

AMES, BE CAREFUL! SAID A FEW OF THE WIZARDS WARNINGLY, AS MR  
DIGGORY SHOULDERS HIS SHOULDERS, RAISED HIS WAND, MARCHED  
ACROSS THE CLEARING AND DISAPPEARED INTO THE DARKNESS.

HERMIONE WATCHED HIM VANISH WITH HER HANDS OVER HER MOUTH.

A FEW SECONDS LATER, THEY HEARD MR DIGGORY SHOUT.

YES! WE GOT THEM! THERE'S SOMEONE HERE! LUNGSPLITTER! IT'S



BUT KIMMY ...

WELL WE GOT SOMETHING? SHOUTED MR CRUELICH, SOUNDING HIGHLY DISBELIEVING. WHEN WHEN IS IT?

THEY HEARD SNAPPING TWIGS, THE RUSTLING OF LEAVES, AND THEN CRUNCHING FEETSTEPS AS MR DIGGERS RE-EMERGED FROM BEHIND THE TREES. HE WAS CARRYING A TINY, LIMP FIGURE IN HIS ARMS. HARRY RECOGNISED THE TEA-TWIG AT ONCE. IT WAS WINDY.

MR CRUELICH DID NOT HAVE HIM SPEAK AS MR DIGGERS DEPOSITED MR CRUELICH'S ELF ON THE GRASS AT HIS FEET. THE ENTIRE MINISTRY WIZARDS WERE ALL STARING AT MR CRUELICH. FOR A FEW SECONDS CRUELICH REMAINED TRANSFIXED, HIS EYES BLAZING IN HIS WHITE FACE AS HE STARED DOWN AT WINDY. THEN HE APPEARED TO COME TO LIFE AGAIN.

THIS CANNOT BE, HE SAID DROOLY. NO  
HE MOVED QUICKLY AROUND MR DIGGERS AND STRIDE OFF  
TOWARDS THE PLACE WHERE HE HAD FOUND WINDY.

NO POINT, MR CRUELICH, MR DIGGERS CALLED AFTER HIM. THERE'S  
NO ONE ELSE THERE.

BUT MR CRUELICH DID NOT SEEM PREPARED TO TAKE HIS LEAD FOR  
IT. THEY COULD HEAR HIM MOVING AROUND, THE RUSTLING OF LEAVES  
AS HE PUSHED THE BRUSHES ASIDE, SEARCHING.

BIT EMBARRASSING, MR DIGGERS SAID GRIMLY, LOOKING DOWN AT  
WINDY'S UNCONSCIOUS FORM. BARTY CRUELICH'S FEELING-ELF ... I MEAN  
THE SAY ...

COME OFF IT, AMES, SAID MR WEASLEY QUIETLY, YOU DON'T SERIOUSLY THINK IT WAS THE ELF? THE DARK MARK'S A WIZARD'S SIGN, IT

REQUIRES A HAND.

YEAH, SAID MR DIGGORY, AND SHE HAD A HAND.

WHAT? SAID MR WEASLEY.

HERE, WHEN MR DIGGORY HELD UP A HAND AND SHOWED IT TO MR WEASLEY, HAD IT IN HER HAND, SHE THAT'S CALLED THREE OF THE FOUR OF WAND LIKE BROKEN HER A START. SHE NON-HUMAN CREATURE IS PERMITTED TO CARRY HER LIKE A WAND.

JUST THEN THERE WAS ANOTHER POP, AND LUDIE BAGMAN APPEARED RIGHT NEXT TO MR WEASLEY, BREATHING BREATHLESS AND DISORIENTED, HE SPUN ON THE SPOT, GOGGLING UPWARDS AT THE EMERALD GREEN SKILL.

THE DARK MARK! HE PANTED, ALMOST TRAMPLING WINNY AS HE TURNED ENLIGHTENINGLY TO HIS COLLEAGUES. WHEN DID IT? DID YOU GET THEM BARTY? WHAT'S GOING ON?

MR CRUELER HAD RETURNED EMPTY-HANDED, HIS FACE WAS STILL GHOSTLY WHITE, AND HIS HANDS AND HIS THIRTY-KILNISH MISTAKE WERE BOTH TWITCHING.

WHERE HAVE YOU BEEN, BARTY? SAID BAGMAN. WHY WEREN'T YOU AT THE MATCH? YOUR ELF WAS SAYING YOU A SEAT, THEN CLIPPING GARGOYLES! BAGMAN HAD JUST NOTICED WINNY LYING AT HIS FEET. WHAT HAPPENED TO HER?

I HAVE BEEN BUSY, LUDIE, SAID MR CRUELER, STILL TALKING IN THE SAME IDIOSyncRATIC MANNER, BARELY MOVING HIS LIPS. AND MY ELF HAS BEEN STUNNED.

STUNNED? BY YELL LEFT, YELL MEANT? BUT WHY ?

COMPREHENSION DAWNED SUDDENLY IN RAGMAN'S MIND, SHINY  
FACE; HE LEANED UP AT THE SKILL, DOWN AT WINDY AND THEN AT MR  
CRUELICH.

NEH? HE SAID, WINDY? REMIND THE DARK MARCH? SHE WOULDNT  
KNOW FEEL? SHE D NEED A HAND FOR A START?

AND SHE HAD HERE, SAID MR DIGGORY, I FEEL HER FEELING  
HERE, LIDDE. IF IT S ALL RIGHT WITH YELL, MR CRUELICH, I THINK WE  
SHOULD HEAR WHAT SHE S GOING TO SAY FOR HERSELF.

120 HARRY POTTER

CRUELICH GAVE NEH SIGN THAT HE HAD HEARD MR DIGGORY, BUT MR  
DIGGORY SEEMED TO TAKE HIS SILENCE FOR ASSENT, HE RAISED HIS  
ELBOW HAND, POINTED IT AT WINDY AND SAID, RECONSTRUCT?  
WINDY STIRRED FEELY, HER GREAT GREEN EYES OPENED AND SHE  
BLINKED SEVERAL TIMES IN A REMISED SORT OF WAY, WATCHED BY THE  
SILENT WIZARDS, SHE RAISED HERSELF SHAKILY INTO A SITTING POSITION,  
SHE CAUGHT SIGHT OF MR DIGGORY'S FEET, AND SILENTLY, TREMBLINGLY,  
RAISED HER EYES TO STARE UP INTO HIS FACE; THEN, MORE SILENTLY STILL,  
SHE LEANED UP INTO THE SKY, HARRY COULD SEE THE FLASHING SKILL  
REFLECTED TWICE IN HER ENORMOUS, GLASSY EYES, SHE GAVE A GASP,  
LEANED WILDLY AROUND THE CROWDED CLEARING AND BURST INTO  
TERRIFIED SKEES.

BUT SAID MR DIGGORY STERNLY, DONT FEEL DOWN WITH I AM? I M A  
MEMBER OF THE DEPARTMENT FOR THE REGULATION AND CONTROL OF  
MAGICAL CREATURES?

WINDY BEGAN THE RICK BACKWARDS AND FORWARDS IN THE

GROILING, HER BREATH CHIMING IN SHARP BURSTS, HARRY WAS REMIND-  
ED FORCEFULLY OF DEERY IN HIS MOMENTS OF TERRIFIED DISOBEDIENCE.

AS YOU SEE, ELF, THE DARK MARD WAS CHASED HERE A SHORT  
WHILE AGO, SAID MR DIGGORY, AND YOU WERE DISCOVERED  
MOMENTS LATER, RIGHT BENEATH IT! AN EXPLANATION, IF YOU PLEASE?  
I I I IS NOT BEING IT, SIR! WINDY GASPED, I IS NOT KNOWING  
HOW, SIR!

YOU WERE HELD WITH A WAND IN YOUR HAND! BARKED MR  
DIGGORY, BRANDISHING IT IN FRONT OF HER, AND AS THE WAND CAUGHT  
THE GREEN LIGHT THAT WAS FILLING THE CLEARING FROM THE SKILL  
ABOVE, HARRY RECOGNISED IT.

HEY THAT'S MINE! HE SAID.

EVERYONE IN THE CLEARING LOOKED AT HIM.

EXCUSE ME? SAID MR DIGGORY, INCREDULOUSLY.

THAT'S MY WAND! SAID HARRY, I DROPPED IT!

YOU DROPPED IT? REPEATED MR DIGGORY IN DISBELIEF, IS THIS A  
CONFESSION? YOU THREW IT ASIDE AFTER YOU CHASED THE MARD?

YES, THINK WHEN YOU'RE TALKING THE! SAID MR WEASLEY, VERY  
ANGRILY, IS HARRY BETTER LIKELY TO CHASE THE DARK MARD?

THE DARK MARD 121

ER HE CHASED NOT, MUMBLED MR DIGGORY, SHIRRY ... CARRIED  
AWAY ...

I DIDN'T DROP IT THERE, ANYWAY, SAID HARRY, TURNING HIS THUMB  
TOWARDS THE TREES BENEATH THE SKILL. I MISSED IT RIGHT AFTER WE

GET INTO THE WHEEL.

She said Mr Digchry, his eyes hardening as he turned the wheel at Windy again, clucking at his feet. She found this wand, eh, eh? And she picked it up and thought she'd have some fun with it, did she?

I is not doing magic with it, sir! shealed Windy, tears streaming down the sides of her shealed and clucking nose. I is ... I is ... I is just picking it up, sir! I is not making the dark mark, sir, I is not knowing how!

It wasn't her! said Hermione. She looked very nervous,

spreading up in front of all these Ministry wizards, yet determined all the same. Windy's got a shealed little wheel and the

wheel we heard being the incantation was much deeper! She looked round at Harry and Ron, appealing for their support. It didn't sound anything like Windy, did it?

No, said Harry, shaking his head. It definitely didn't sound like an eh.

Yeah, it was a human wheel, said Ron.

Well, we'll soon see, growled Mr Digchry, looking disappointed. There's a simple way of discovering the last spell a

wand performed, eh, did she know that?

Windy trembled and shealed her head frantically, her ears flapping, as Mr Digchry raised his own wand again, and placed

IT TIP THE TIP WITH HARRY'S.

PRIOR INCANTATION! REHEARD MR DIGGORY.

HARRY HEARD HERMIONE GASP, FRIGHTENED, AS A GIGANTIC SERPENT-  
TONGUED SKULL ERUPTED FROM THE POINT WHERE THE TWO WANDS

MET, BUT IT WAS A MERE SHADOW OF THE GREEN SKULL HIGH ABOVE  
THEM, IT LOOKED AS THOUGH IT WAS MADE OF THICK GRAY SMOKE: THE  
GHOST OF A SPELL.

DECEITFUL! MR DIGGORY SHOUTED, AND THE SMOKEY SKULL

122 HARRY POUTTER

VANISHED IN A WISP OF SMOKE.

SEE, SAID MR DIGGORY WITH A KIND OF SAVAGE TRIUMPH, LOOKING  
DOWN UPON WINNIE, WHO WAS STILL SHAKING CHRYSLERLY.

I IS NOT DOING IT! SHE SQUEAKED, HER EYES ROLLING IN TERROR. I IS  
NOT, I IS NOT, I IS NOT KNEELING HERE! I IS A CHILD OF, I ISN'T USING  
WANDS, I ISN'T KNEELING HERE!

WELL YOU'VE BEEN CAUGHT RED-HANDED, OF? MR DIGGORY REHEARD.

CAUGHT WITH THE GUILTY WAND IN YOUR HAND!

AMHS, SAID MR LEASLEY WHISPLY, THING ABOUT IT ... PRECISELY  
FEW WIZARDS KNOW HOW TO DO THAT SPELL ... WHERE WOULD SHE  
HAVE LEARNED IT?

PERHAPS AMHS IS SUGGESTING, SAID MR CRUELICH, CHILD ANGER IN  
EVERY SYLLABLE, THAT I RELUCTANTLY TEACH MY SERVANTS THE CHURCH  
THE DARK MANDY?

THERE WAS A DEEPLY UNPLEASANT SILENCE.

AMEES DIGGORY LOOKED FRIGHTED. MR CRUELICH ... NOT ... NOT AT ALL ...

YELL HAVE BEEN COME VERY CLOSE TO ACCUSING THE TWO PEOPLE IN THIS CLEARING WHO ARE LEAST LIKELY TO CHEAT THAT MARY BARKED MR CRUELICH, HARRY POTTER AND MYSELF? I SUPPOSE YELL ARE FAMILIAR WITH THE KEY'S STORY, AMES?

OF COURSE EVERYONE KNOWS MUTTERED MR DIGGORY, LOOKING HIGHLY DISCOMFITED.

AND I TRUST YELL REMEMBER THE MANY PRIZES I HAVE GIVEN, EVER A LONG CAREER, THAT I DESPISE AND DETEST THE DARK ARTS AND THOSE WHO PRACTISE THEM? MR CRUELICH SMILTED, HIS EYES GLIMMING AGAIN.

MR CRUELICH, I I NEVER SUGGESTED YELL HAD ANYTHING TO DO WITH IT? MUTTERED AMES DIGGORY, NEAR REDDENING BEHIND HIS SCRUFFY REDDEN BEARD.

IF YELL ACCUSE MY ELF, YELL ACCUSE ME, DIGGORY? SMILTED MR CRUELICH. WHERE ELSE WOULD SHE HAVE LEARNED TO CHEAT IT?

SHE SHE MIGHT VE PICKED IT UP ANYWHERE

PRECISELY, AMES, SAID MR WEASLEY. SHE MIGHT HAVE PICKED IT UP ANYWHERE ... WINDY? HE SAID KINDLY, TURNING TO THE ELF, BUT

THE DARK MARY 123

SHE FLINCHED AS THOUGH HE, THEN, WAS SMILING AT HER. WHERE EXACTLY DID YELL FIND HARRY'S WAND?

WINDY WAS TWISTING THE FIRM OF HER TEATHEWEL SHE VIOLENTLY

THAT IT WAS PRAYING BENEATH HER FINGERS,

I I IS FINDING IT ... FINDING IT THERE, SIR ... SHE WHISPERED,  
THERE ... IN THE TREES, SIR ...

WELL SEE, AMES? SAID MR LEASLEY, WHATEVER CHILDRED THE  
MAD CHILD HAVE DISAPPEARATED RIGHT AFTER THEY D BENE IT,  
LEAVING HARRY S HAND BEHIND, A CLEVER THING THE DEE, NOT LISTING  
THEIR OWN HAND, WHICH CHILD HAVE BETRAYED THEM, AND WINDY  
HERE HAD THE MISFORTUNE THE CAME ACROSS THE HAND MOMENTS  
LATER AND PICK IT UP,

BUT THEN, SHE D HAVE BEEN FEET AWAY FROM THE REAL CLIPRIT?  
SAID MR DIGGORY IMPATIENTLY, BUT DID YOU SEE ANYONE?  
WINDY BEGAN THE TREMBLE WORSE THAN EVER, HER GIANT EYES  
FLICKERED FROM MR DIGGORY THE BLIND BAGMAN, AND THEN THE MR  
CROUCH,

THEN SHE GLIMPED, AND SAID, I IS SEEING NEH HENK, SIR ... NEH  
HENK ...

AMES, SAID MR CROUCH CLERTLY, I AM FULLY AWARE THAT, IN THE  
ORDINARY COURSE OF EVENTS, YOU WOULD WANT THE TAKE WINDY INTO  
YOUR DEPARTMENT FOR ELUCIDATING, I ASK YOU, HOWEVER, THE ALLEGED  
ME THE DEAL WITH HER,

MR DIGGORY LOOKED AS THOUGH HE DIDN T THINK MUCH OF THIS  
SUGGESTION AT ALL, BUT IT WAS CLEAR THE HARRY THAT MR CROUCH WAS  
SUCH AN IMPORTANT MEMBER OF THE MINISTRY THAT HE DID NOT DARE  
REFUSE HIM,

YOU MAY REST ASSURED THAT SHE WILL BE PUNISHED, MR CROUCH  
ADDED COLDLY,

M-M-MASTER ... WINDY STAMMERED, LOOKING UP AT MR



CRUELICH, HER EYES BRIMMING WITH TEARS, M-M-MASTER, P-P-  
PLEASE ...

MR CRUELICH STARED BACK, HIS FACE SOMEWHAT SHARPENED, EACH  
LINE UPON IT MORE DEEPLY ETCHED. THERE WAS NO PITY IN HIS GAZE.  
WINDY HAS BELAYED TONIGHT IN A MANNER I WOULD NOT HAVE

124 HARRY POTTER

BEHAVED POSSIBLE, HE SAID SLENNY, I TOLD HER TO REMAIN IN THE  
TENT, I TOLD HER TO STAY THERE WHILE I WENT TO SORT OUT THE  
TROUBLE, AND I FIND THAT SHE DISOBEYED ME. THIS MEANS CLOTHES,  
NEE? SHRIEKED WINDY, PRESTRATING HERSELF AT MR CRUELICH'S FEET.  
NEE, MASTER? NO CLOTHES, NO CLOTHES?

HARRY KNEW THAT THE ONLY WAY TO TURN A HOUSE-ELF FREE WAS TO  
PRESENT IT WITH PROPER GARMENTS. IT WAS PITIFUL TO SEE THE WAY  
WINDY CLUTCHED AT HER TAIL-THICK AS SHE STOOD OVER MR  
CRUELICH'S FEET.

BUT SHE WAS FRIGHTENED! HERMIONE KNEW BEST BUT ANGRILY, GLARING  
AT MR CRUELICH. SHELL ELF'S STARED IN FRIGHTS, AND THESE WIZARDS  
IN MASKS WERE LEVITATING PEOPLE? SHELL CAN'T BLAME HER FOR WANTING  
TO GET OUT OF THEIR WAY?

MR CRUELICH TOOK A STEP BACKWARDS, FREEING HIMSELF FROM CON-  
TACT WITH THE ELF, WHEN HE WAS SURVEYING AS THOUGH SHE WAS

SOMETHING FILTHY AND ROTTEN THAT WAS CONTAMINATING HIS EVER-

SHINED THEM.

I HAVE NO USE FOR A FELLOW-Elf WHO DISRESPECTS ME, HE SAID  
COLDLY, LEERING UP AT HERMIONE. I HAVE NO USE FOR A SERVANT  
WHO FORGETS WHAT IS DUE TO HER MASTER, AND TO HER MASTER'S REP-  
UTATION.

WINDY WAS CRYING SHE HAD THAT HER SHIRT RIPPED AROUND THE  
CLEARING.

THERE WAS A VERY NASTY SILENCE, WHICH WAS ENDED BY MR  
WEASLEY, WHO SAID QUIETLY, WELL, I THINK I LL TAKE MY LEFT BACK TO  
THE TENT, IF ANYBODY'S GOT ANY OBJECTIONS. AMHS, THAT WAS ALL SHE  
COULD SAY. IF HARRY COULD HAVE IT BACK, PLEASE

MR DIGGORY HANDED HARRY HIS WAND AND HARRY PICKED IT UP.

COME ON, NOW THEN, MR WEASLEY SAID QUIETLY, BUT  
HERMIONE DIDN'T SEEM TO WANT TO MOVE; HER EYES WERE STILL  
UPON THE SHIRTING Elf, HERMIONE! MR WEASLEY SAID, MORE  
URGENTLY, SHE TURNED AND FOLLOWED HARRY AND THEN LEFT THE  
CLEARING AND OFF THROUGH THE TREES.

WHAT'S GOING TO HAPPEN TO WINDY? SAID HERMIONE, THE  
MOMENT THEY HAD LEFT THE CLEARING.

THE DARK MARCH 125

I DON'T KNOW, SAID MR WEASLEY.

THE WAY THEY WERE TREATING HER? SAID HERMIONE FLURRIEDLY,  
MR DIGGORY, CALLING HER Elf ALL THE TIME ... AND MR CRABBE!

THE DOUBTS SHE DIDN'T SEE IT AND HE'S STILL CHING THE SACK HER? SHE  
DIDN'T CARE FEEL FRIGHTENED SHE'D BEEN, HER FEEL UPSET SHE WAS  
IT WAS LIKE SHE WASN'T EVEN HUMAN?

WELL, SHE'S NOT, SAID RICH.

HERMIONE REPLIED TO HIM, THAT DOESN'T MEAN SHE HASN'T  
GOT FEELINGS, RICH, IT'S DISGUSTING THE WAY

HERMIONE, I AGREE WITH YOU, SAID MR WEASLEY QUICKLY, RECK-  
ONING HER IN, BUT NOW IS NOT THE TIME TO DISCUSS HER RIGHTS. I

WANT TO GET BACK TO THE TENT AS FAST AS WE CAN, WHAT HAPPENED  
TO THE OTHERS?

WE LEFT THEM IN THE DARK, SAID RICH, DAD, WHY WAS EVERY-  
ONE SO LIGHT-HEADED THAT SOON THING?

I'LL EXPLAIN EVERYTHING BACK AT THE TENT, SAID MR WEASLEY  
TENSELY.

BUT WHEN THEY REACHED THE EDGE OF THE WOOD, THEIR PROGRESS  
WAS IMPEDED.

A LARGE CROWD OF FRIGHTENED-LOOKING WITCHES AND WIZARDS  
WAS CONGREGATED THERE, AND WHEN THEY SAW MR WEASLEY CHING  
TOWARDS THEM, MANY OF THEM SURGED FORWARDS, WHAT'S CHING HIM  
IN THERE? WHO CHALLENGED IT? ARTHUR IT'S NOT HIM?

HE CHASED IT'S NOT HIM, SAID MR WEASLEY IMPATIENTLY, WE  
DIDN'T KNOW WHEN IT WAS, IT LOOKS LIKE THEY DISAPPEARED, NOW  
EXCUSE ME, PLEASE, I WANT TO GET THE KEY.

HE LED HARRY, RON AND HERMION THROUGH THE CROWD AND BACK INTO THE CAMPSITE. ALL WAS QUIET NOW; THERE WAS NO SIGN OF THE MASKED WIZARDS, THOUGH SEVERAL BLIND TENTS WERE STILL SMOKING.

CHARLIE'S HEAD WAS PEEKING OUT OF THE BOYS' TENT.

DAD, WHAT'S GOING ON? HE CALLED THROUGH THE DARK. FRED, GEORGE AND GINNY CAME BACK HIM, BUT THE OTHERS I'VE GOT THEM HERE, SAID MR WEASLEY, KNOCKING DOWN AND ENTERING THE TENT. HARRY, RON AND HERMION ENTERED AFTER HIM.

THE HARRY POTTER

BILL WAS SITTING AT THE SMALL KITCHEN TABLE, HOLDING A RED-SHIRT TO HIS ARM, WHICH WAS BLEEDING PROLIFERALLY. CHARLIE HAD A LARGE RIP IN HIS SHIRT, AND PERCY WAS SPURTING A BLEEDY NOSE. FRED, GEORGE AND GINNY LOOKED UNWELL, THOUGH SHAKEN.

DID YOU GET THEM, DAD? SAID BILL SHARPLY. THE PERSON WHO CHALLENGED THE MARK?

NO, SAID MR WEASLEY. WE FOUND BARTY CRUICKSHANK HOLDING HARRY'S WAND, BUT WE'RE NOT SURE THE WISER ABOUT WHO ACTUALLY CHALLENGED THE MARK.

WHAT? SAID BILL, CHARLIE AND PERCY TOGETHER.

HARRY'S WAND? SAID FRED.

MR CRUICKSHANK? SAID PERCY, SOUNDING THUNDERSTRIKE.

WITH SOME ASSISTANCE FROM HARRY, RON AND HERMION, MR WEASLEY EXPLAINED WHAT HAD HAPPENED IN THE WOODS. WHEN THEY HAD FINISHED THEIR STORY, PERCY SWELLED INDIGNANTLY.

WELL, MR CRUICKSHANK IS QUITE RIGHT TO GET RID OF AN ELF LIKE THAT!

HE SAID, RUNNING AWAY WHEN HE'D EXPRESSLY TOLD HER NOT TO ...  
EMBARRASSING HIM IN FRONT OF THE WHOLE MINISTRY ... SHE WOULD  
THAT HAVE BEEN, IF SHE'D BEEN HAD UP IN FRONT OF THE  
DEPARTMENT FOR THE REGULATION AND CONTROL

SHE DIDN'T DO ANYTHING SHE WAS ILIT IN THE WRONG PLACE AT  
THE WRONG TIME? FERMINE SNAPPED AT PERCY, WHO LOOKED VERY  
TAKEN ABACK, FERMINE HAD ALWAYS GET ON FAIRLY WELL WITH  
PERCY BETTER, INDEED, THAN ANY OF THE OTHERS,

FERMINE, A WIZARD IN MR CRELICH'S POSITION CAN'T AFFORD A  
MISJURY-WHICH SHE'S GETTING THE RUN AMONG WITH A WARD? SAID PERCY  
POMPHELSLY, RECOVERING HIMSELF,

SHE DIDN'T RUN AMONG? SHE LIT FERMINE. SHE ILIT PICKED IT  
UP OFF THE GROUND?

LOOK, CAN SOMEONE ILIT EXPLAIN WHAT THAT SMALL THING WAS?  
SAID RHN IMPATIENTLY. IT WASN'T FLIRTING ANYONE ... WHY'S IT SUCH  
A BIG DEAL?

I TOLD YOU, IT'S YOUR-KNEW-WHICH'S SYMBOL, RHN, SAID  
FERMINE, BEFORE ANYONE ELSE COULD ANSWER. I READ ABOUT IT IN  
THE RISE AND FALL OF THE DARK ARTS,

## THE DARK MARK 129

AND IT HASN'T BEEN SEEN FOR THIRTEEN YEARS, SAID MR WEASLEY  
QUIETLY. HE COULDN'T PEOPLE PANICKED ... IT WAS ALMOST LIKE SEEING  
YOUR-KNEW-WHICH BACK AGAIN,

I DIDN'T GET IT, SAID RHN, FROWNING. I MEAN ... IT'S STILL ONLY A  
SHAPE IN THE SKY ...

RHN, YOUR-KNEW-WHICH AND HIS FOLLOWERS SENT THE DARK MARK

INTO THE AIR WHENEVER THEY DIED, SAID MR WEASLEY. THE TERROR  
IT INSPIRED ... WELL HAVE NO IDEA, WELL BE THE ONLY ONE, I'VE PICTURED  
CHASING THEM, AND FINDING THE DARK MARK HAVING EVERYWHERE WELL  
FEELING, AND KNOWING WHAT WELL BE ABOUT THE FIND INSIDE ... MR  
WEASLEY WINCED, EVERYONE'S WORST FEAR ... THE VERY WORST ...  
THERE WAS SILENCE FOR A MOMENT.

THEN BILL, REMOVING THE SHEET FROM HIS ARM THE CHECKED HIS  
CLOCK, SAID, WELL, IT DIDN'T HELP US TONIGHT, WHATEVER CAUSED IT,  
IT SCARED THE DEATH EATERS AWAY THE MOMENT THEY SAW IT.

THEY ALL DISAPPEARED BEFORE WE COULD GET NEAR ENOUGH THE LIMPASS  
AND OF THEM, WE CALLED THE ROBERTS BEFORE THEY HIT THE  
GRINDING, THOUGH. THEY'RE HAVING THEIR MEMORIES MODIFIED  
RIGHT NOW.

DEATH EATERS? SAID HARRY. WHAT ARE DEATH EATERS?

IT'S WHAT WELL-KNOWN-WE'RE SLIPPERERS CALLED THEMSELVES,  
SAID BILL. I THINK WE SAW WHAT'S LEFT OF THEM TONIGHT ... THE BONES  
WE MANAGED TO KEEP THEMSELVES OUT OF AZKABAN, ANYWAY.

WE CAN'T PROVE IT WAS THEM, BILL, SAID MR WEASLEY, THOUGH  
IT PROBABLY WAS, HE ADDED EMPHATICALLY.

YEAH, I GET IT WAS? SAID BEN SUDDENLY. DAD, WE MET DRAGON  
MALPHE IN THE WOODS, AND HE AS GOOD AS TOLD US HIS DAD WAS  
ONE OF THESE SLITHERS IN MARS? AND WE ALL KNOW THE MALPHE'S  
WERE RIGHT IN WITH WELL-KNOWN-WE'RE

BUT WHAT WERE VILDEBERT'S SLIPPERERS ... HARRY BEGAN.  
EVERYBODY FLINCHED ... LIKE MOST OF THE WIZARDING WORLD, THE  
WEASLEYS ALWAYS AVOIDED SAYING VILDEBERT'S NAME. HARRY, SAID  
HARRY QUICKLY. WHAT WERE WELL-KNOWN-WE'RE SLIPPERERS UP TO,

LEVITATING MUGGLES? I MEAN, WHAT WAS THE POINT?

THE POINT? SAID MR WEASLEY, WITH A FUUUUU LAUGH, HARRY,

128 HARRY PEEETTER

THAT'S THEIR IDEA OF FUN, HALF THE MUGGLE DRINKERS SAID WHEN  
PHIL-DEWEL-WHEE WAS IN POWER WERE DRINKING FOR FUN. I SUPPOSE  
THEY HAD A FEW DRINKS TONIGHT AND COULDN'T RESIST REMINDING US  
ALL THAT LETS IF THEY ARE STILL AT LARGE. A NICE LITTLE RELIEF FOR  
THEM, HE FINISHED DISGUSTEDLY.

BUT IF THEY WERE THE DEATH EATERS, WHY DID THEY DISAPPEAR  
WHEN THEY SAW THE DARK MARK? SAID PHIL. THEY'D HAVE BEEN  
PLEASED TO SEE IT, COULDN'T THEY?

LIKE PHIL'S BRAINS, PHIL, SAID BILL. IF THEY REALLY WERE DEATH  
EATERS, THEY WOULD HAVE REALLY HARD TO KEEP HIM AT AZKABAN WHEN  
PHIL-DEWEL-WHEE LEFT PHIL, AND THOUGHT ALL SORTS OF LIES ABOUT HIM  
FORCING THEM TO KILL AND TORTURE PEOPLE. I BET THEY'D BE EVEN  
MORE FRIGHTENED THAN THE REST OF US TO SEE HIM COME BACK.  
THEY DENIED THEY'D EVER BEEN INVOLVED WITH HIM WHEN HE LEFT  
HIS POWERS, AND WENT BACK TO THEIR DAILY LIVES ... I DON'T RECKON  
HE'D BE EVER PLEASED WITH THEM, DO YOU?

SEE ... WHATEVER CAULDRONED THE DARK MARK ... SAID HERMION  
SLIGHTLY, WERE THEY DOING IT TO SEE HIM SLIP INTO THE DEATH  
EATERS, OR TO SCARE THEM AWAY?

PHIL'S GUESS IS AS GOOD AS MINE, HERMION, SAID MR WEASLEY.  
BUT I'LL TELL PHIL THIS ... IT WAS ONLY THE DEATH EATERS WHO EVER  
KNEW HOW TO CAULDRON IT. I'D BE VERY SURPRISED IF THE PERSON WHO  
DID IT HADN'T BEEN A DEATH EATER HIMSELF, EVEN IF THEY'RE NOT NOW

... LISTEN, IT'S VERY LATE, AND IF PHILIP MEETHER HEARS WHAT'S  
HAPPENED SHE'LL BE WHIRRLED SIDE. WE'LL GET A FEW MORE HOURS  
SLEEP AND THEN TRY AND GET AN EARLY PHEATKEY ELT HP HERE.  
HARRY GET BACK INTO HIS BLIND WITH HIS HEAD BLIZZING. HE  
KNEW HE HUGHT THE FEEL EXHAUSTED; IT WAS NEARLY THREE IN THE  
MORNING, BUT HE FELT WIDE AWAKE WIDE AWAKE, AND WHIRRLED.  
THREE DAYS AGO IT FELT LIKE MUCH LONGER, BUT IT HAD ONLY  
BEEN THREE DAYS HE HAD AWOKEN WITH HIS STAR BLIRNING, AND  
TENTHIGHT, FOR THE FIRST TIME IN THIRTEEN YEARS, LORD VERDEMENT'S  
MARK HAD APPEARED IN THE SKY. WHAT DID THESE THINGS MEAN?  
HE THUGHT OF THE LETTER HE HAD WRITTEN THE SIRILS BEFORE  
LEAVING PRIVET DRIVE. WOULD SIRILS HAVE GET IT YET? WHEN

THE DARK MARK 129

WOULD HE REPLY? HARRY LAY LEERKING UP AT THE CANVAS, BUT NEW FLY-  
ING FANTASIES CAME TO HIM NEW THE PASS HIM THE SLEEP, AND IT WAS  
A LONG TIME AFTER CHARLIE'S SNORES FILLED THE TENT THAT HARRY  
FINALLY DREZZED OFF.

## CHAPTER TEN

### MATHEN AT THE MINISTRY

MR WEASLEY WAKE THEM AFTER ONLY A FEW HOURS SLEEP. HE USED  
MAGIC TO PACK UP THE TENTS, AND THEY LEFT THE CAMPSITE AS



AS QUICKLY AS POSSIBLE, PASSING MR ROBERTS AT THE DOOR OF HIS  
COTTAGE, MR ROBERTS HAD A STRANGE, DAZED LOOK ABOUT HIM, AND  
HE WAVED THEM OFF WITH A VALENTINE MERRY CHRISTMAS.

HE IS ALL RIGHT, SAID MR LEASLEY QUIETLY, AS THEY MARCHED  
OFF INTO THE MOOR. SOMETIMES, WHEN A PERSON'S MEMORY IS  
MODIFIED, IT MAKES THEM A BIT DISORIENTED FOR A WHILE ... AND  
THAT WAS A BIG THING THEY HAD TO MAKE HIM FORGET.

THEY HEARD URGENT VEHICLES AS THEY APPROACHED THE SPOT WHERE  
THE PENTONS LAY AND, WHEN THEY REACHED IT, THEY FOUND A GREAT  
NUMBER OF WITCHES AND WIZARDS GATHERED AROUND BASIL, THE  
KEEPER OF THE PENTONS, ALL CLAMORING TO GET AWAY FROM THE  
CAMP SITE AS QUICKLY AS POSSIBLE. MR LEASLEY HAD A HURRIED  
DISCUSSION WITH BASIL; THEY DECIDED THE QUICK, AND WERE ABLE TO  
TAKE AN OLD ROCKER TYPE BACK TO THE STATIONHEAD HILL BEFORE THE SUN  
HAD REALLY RISEN. THEY WALKED BACK THROUGH HETTER ST  
CATCHPOLE TOWARDS THE BURNING IN THE DAWN LIGHT, TALKING  
VERY LITTLE BECAUSE THEY WERE SO EXHAUSTED, AND THINKING  
LONGINGLY OF THEIR BREAKFAST. AS THEY REACHED THE CORNER IN THE  
LANE, AND THE BURNING CAME INTO VIEW, A CRY ECHOED ALONG THE  
DAMP LANE.

OH, THANK GOODNESS, THANK GOODNESS!

MRS LEASLEY, WHO HAD EVIDENTLY BEEN WAITING FOR THEM IN  
THE FRONT YARD, CAME RUNNING TOWARDS THEM, STILL WEARING HER  
BEDROOM SLIPPERS, HER FACE PALE AND STRAINED, A SCREWED-UP

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COPY OF THE DAILY PROPHECY CLUTCHED IN HER HAND. ARTHUR I VE

KEEN SHE WHIRLED SHE WHIRLED

SHE FLUNG HER ARMS AROUND MR WEASLEY'S NECK, AND THE DAILY PROPHET FELL HLIT IN HER LIMP HAND BENTH THE CORNER, LEEDING DOWN. HARRY SAW THE HEADLINE: SCENES OF TERROR AT THE

ELIJDITTY WERD CLIP, COMPLETE WITH A TWINKLING, BLACK-AND-WHITE PHOTOGRAPH OF THE DARK MARD OVER THE TREE-TOPS.

THEY'RE ALL RIGHT, MRS WEASLEY MUTTERED DISTRACTEDLY, RELEASING MR WEASLEY AND STARING AROUND AT THEM ALL WITH RED EYES,

THEY'RE ALIVE ... HEY, KEYS ...

AND THE EVERYBODY'S SURPRISE, SHE SEIZED FRED AND GEORGE AND PULLED THEM BENTH INTO SUCH A TIGHT HUG THAT THEIR HEADS BANGED TOGETHER.

HELLO? MOM THEY'RE STRANGLING US

I SHOUTED AT THEM BEHIND THEM LEFT? MRS WEASLEY SAID, STARTING

THEY SEE. IT'S ALL I'VE BEEN THINKING ABOUT! WHAT IF THEY-KNEW-WE-HAD-GOT-THY, AND THE LAST THING I EVER SAID TO THEM WAS THAT

THEY DIDN'T GET ENOUGH HELP? HEY, FRED ... GEORGE ...

COME ON, NOW, MOM, WE'RE ALL PERFECTLY OK, SAID MR WEASLEY SMITHINGLY, PRISING HER OFF THE TWINS AND LEADING HER BACK TOWARDS THE KITCHEN. KILL, HE ADDED IN AN UNDERTONE, PICK UP THAT PAPER, I WANT TO SEE WHAT IT SAYS ...

WHEN THEY WERE ALL CRAMPED INTO THE TINY KITCHEN, AND

HERMIONIE HAD MADE MRS WEASLEY A CUP OF VERY STRONG TEA, INTO WHICH MR WEASLEY INSISTED ON POURING A SHEET OF HOGWARTS FIELD FIREWORKS, KILL HANDED HIS FATHER THE NEWSPAPER, MR WEASLEY STARED THE FRONT PAGE WHILE PERCY LOOKED OVER HIS SHOULDER, I KNOW IT, SAID MR WEASLEY HEAVILY, MINISTRY BLUNDERS ... CLIPFITS NOT APPREHENDED ... LAX SECURITY ... DARK WIZARDS RUNNING UNCHECKED ... NATIONAL DISGRACE ... WHEN WROTE THIS? AH ... OF COURSE ... RITA SKEETER.

THAT WOMAN'S GET IT IN FOR THE MINISTRY OF MAGIC! SAID PERCY FLURRIEDLY, LAST WEEK SHE WAS SAYING WE'RE WASTING OUR TIME BUBBLING ABOUT CALIBREIN THICKNESS, WHEN WE SHOULD BE STAMPING OUT VAMPIRES! AS IF IT WASN'T SPECIFICALLY STATED IN

LEE HARRY POTTTER

PARAGRAPH TWELVE OF THE GUIDELINES FOR THE TREATMENT OF NON-WIZARD PART-HUMANS

OH LIS A FAVOUR, PERCE, SAID KILL, YARNING, AND SHUT UP, I M MENTIONED, SAID MR WEASLEY, HIS EYES WIDENING BEHIND HIS GLASSES AS HE REACHED THE BOTTOM OF THE DAILY PROPHET ARTICLE.

WHERE? SPLATTERED MRS WEASLEY, CHECKING ON HER TEA AND WHISKY, IF I'D SEEN THAT, I'D HAVE KNOWN THEY WERE ALIVE!

NOT BY NAME, SAID MR WEASLEY, LISTEN TO THIS! IF THE TERRIFIED WIZARDS AND WITCHES WERE WAITED BREATHLESSLY FOR NEWS AT THE

EDGE OF THE WOOD EXPECTED REASSURANCE FROM THE MINISTRY OF MAGIC, THEY WERE SADLY DISAPPOINTED. A MINISTRY OFFICIAL EMERGED SOME TIME AFTER THE APPEARANCE OF THE DARK MARK, ALLEGING THAT NERHOY HAD BEEN HURT, BUT REFUSING TO GIVE ANY MORE INFORMATION, WHETHER

THIS STATEMENT WILL BE ENOUGH TO REVEAL THE RUMOURS THAT SEVERAL KIDNAPERS WERE REMOVED FROM THE WOODS AND EARLIER LATER, REMAINS TO BE SEEN. "HEY, REALLY," SAID MR WEASLEY IN EXASPERATION, HANDING THE PAPER TO PERCY. "NERHOY WAS HURT, WHAT WAS I SUPPOSED TO SAY?" RUMOURS THAT SEVERAL KIDNAPERS WERE REMOVED FROM THE WOODS ... WELL, THERE CERTAINLY WILL BE RUMOURS NOW SHE'S PRINTED THAT. HE HEAVED A DEEP SIGH. "WELL, I'M GOING TO HAVE TO GET INTO THE OFFICE, THIS IS GOING TO TAKE SOME SOMETHING ELSE."

"I'LL COME WITH YOU, FATHER," SAID PERCY IMPORTANTLY. "MR CRATCHIT WILL NEED ALL HANDS HERE, AND I CAN GIVE HIM MY CALIBREIN REPORT IN PERSON."

HE CLIMBED OUT OF THE KITCHEN.

MRS WEASLEY BREATHED DEEP SIGH. "ARTHUR, YOU'RE SUPPOSED TO BE ON HOLIDAY! THIS HASN'T GOT ANYTHING TO DO WITH YOUR OFFICE, SURELY THEY CAN HANDLE THIS WITHOUT YOU!"

"I'VE GOT TO GO, MUM," SAID MR WEASLEY. "I'VE MADE THINGS WORSE, I'LL JUST CHANGE INTO MY ROBES AND I'LL BE OFF ..."

MRS WEASLEY SAID "HARRY" SUDDENLY, UNABLE TO CONTAIN HIMSELF. "FREDIE HASN'T ARRIVED WITH A LETTER FOR ME, HAS HE?"

FREDNIE, DEARY? SAID MRS WEASLEY DISTRACTEDLY, NEE ... NEE,  
THERE HASN'T BEEN ANY PHIST AT ALL.

MADAM AT THE MINISTRY ARE

RON AND HERMIONE WINKED CLIMBLY AT HARRY,

WITH A MEANINGFUL WINK AT BOTH OF THEM HE SAID, ALL RIGHT IF  
I GO AND BUMP MY STUFF IN YOUR ROOM, RON?

Yeah ... THINK I WILL, THEN, SAID RON AT ONCE, HERMIONE?

YES, SHE SAID BLINKLY, AND THE THREE OF THEM MARCHED OUT OF  
THE KITCHEN AND UP THE STAIRS.

WHAT'S UP, HARRY? SAID RON, THE MOMENT THEY HAD CLOSED  
THE DOOR OF THE ATTIC ROOM BEHIND THEM.

THERE'S SOMETHING I HAVEN'T TOLD YOU, HARRY SAID, THEN  
SATURDAY MORNING, I WOKED UP WITH MY SCAR FLIRTING AGAIN.  
RON AND HERMIONE'S REACTIONS WERE ALMOST EXACTLY AS HARRY  
HAD IMAGINED THEM BACK IN HIS BEDROOM IN PRIVET DRIVE.

HERMIONE GASPED AND STARTED MAKING SUGGESTIONS AT ONCE,  
MENTIONING A NUMBER OF REFERENCE BOOKS, AND EVERYBODY FROM  
ALBUS DUMBLEDORE THE MADAM PUMPKIN, THE FLEWARTS MATRONS,  
RON SIMPLY WINKED BLINKSTOCK. BUT HE WASN'T THERE, WAS

HE? YOU-KNEW-WELL? I MEAN LAST TIME YOUR SCAR KEPT FLIRT-  
ING, HE WAS AT FLEWARTS, WASN'T HE?

I'M SURE HE WASN'T IN PRIVET DRIVE, SAID HARRY, BUT I WAS  
DREAMING ABOUT HIM ... HIM AND PETER YOU-KNEW, WHIRTAIL. I  
CAN'T REMEMBER ALL OF IT NOW, BUT THEY WERE PLOTTING THE KILL ...

SHIMMER.

HE HAD TEETERED FOR A MOMENT ON THE VERGE OF SAYING ME ,  
BUT COULDN'T BRING HIMSELF TO MAKE HERMIONE LOOK ANY MORE  
Horrified THAN SHE ALREADY DID.

IT WAS ONLY A DREAM, SAID RON KRACKINGLY. JUST A NIGHTMARE.  
Yeah, BUT WAS IT, THELICH? SAID HARRY, TURNING THE HEAD HE  
THE WINDS AT THE BRIGHTENING SKY. IT'S WEIRD, ISN'T IT ... MY  
STAR FLIRTS, AND THREE DAYS LATER THE DEATH EATERS ARE ON THE  
MARCH, AND VEHEMENT'S SIGN'S UP IN THE SKY AGAIN.

DIDN'T SAY HIS NAME? RON HISSED THROUGH GRITTED TEETH.  
AND REMEMBER WHAT PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY SAID? HARRY WENT  
ON, IGNORING RON. AT THE END OF LAST YEAR?  
PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY WAS THEIR DIVINATION TEACHER AT  
HOGWARTS.

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HERMIONE'S TERRIFIED LOOK VANISHED AS SHE LET OUT A DERISIVE

SNORT. EH, HARRY, YOU AREN'T GIVING THE PAID ANY ATTENTION THE  
ANY-

THING THAT MR FRANK SAYS?

YOU WEREN'T THERE, SAID HARRY. YOU DIDN'T HEAR HER. THIS TIME  
WAS DIFFERENT. I TOLD YOU, SHE WENT INTO A TRANCE ... A REAL ONE.  
AND SHE SAID THE DARK LORD WOULD RISE AGAIN ... GREATER AND  
MORE TERRIBLE THAN EVER BEFORE ... AND HE'D MANAGE IT BECAUSE HIS  
SERVANT WAS GIVING THE GO BACK TO HIM ... AND THAT NIGHT

WHERMTAIL ESCAPED.

THERE WAS A SILENCE IN WHICH REEN FIDGETED ASSENT-MINDEDLY  
WITH A FEEL IN HIS CHILDLY CANNONS REDSPREAD.

WHO WERE YOU ASKING IF FREDWIG HAD THEM, HARRY?

HERMIONE ASKED, ARE YOU EXPECTING A LETTER?

I TELL SIRILIS ABOUT MY STAR, SAID HARRY, SHRUGGING. I'M  
WAITING FOR HIS ANSWER.

GOOD THINKING! SAID REEN, HIS EXPRESSION CLEARING. I GET  
SIRILIS TO KNOW WHAT THE DEE?

I HELPED HER TO GET BACK THE ME QUICKLY, SAID HARRY.

BUT WE DON'T KNOW WHERE SIRILIS IS ... HE COULD BE IN AFRICA  
OR SOMEWHERE, COULD HE? SAID HERMIONE REASONABLY.

FREDWIG'S NEXT CHIEF THE MANAGE THAT JOURNEY IN A FEW DAYS.

YEAH, I KNOW, SAID HARRY, BUT THERE WAS A LEADEN FEELING IN  
HIS STOMACH AS HE WHEEZED OUT OF THE WINDOW AT THE FREDWIG-FREE  
BOX.

COME AND HAVE A GAME OF HILDBITCH IN THE GARDEN, HARRY,  
SAID REEN. COME ON THREE ON THREE, BILL AND CHARLIE AND FRED  
AND GEORGE WILL PLAY ... YOU CAN TRY OUT THE WOODEN PEIN ...

REEN, SAID HERMIONE, IN AN I-DON'T-THINK-YOU'RE-KIND-VERY-  
SENSITIVE SORT OF VOICE, HARRY DOESN'T WANT THE PLAY HILDBITCH

RIGHT NOW ... HE'S WORRIED, AND HE'S TIRED ... WE ALL NEED THE GIVE THE  
BED ...

YEAH, I WANT THE PLAY HILDBITCH, SAID HARRY SUDDENLY, HANG  
ON, I'LL GET MY FIREWHEEL.

HERMION LEFT THE ROOM, MUTTERING SOMETHING WHICH  
SOUNDED VERY MUCH LIKE BHS.

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\*

NEITHER MR WEASLEY NOR PERCY WAS AT HOME MUCH OVER THE  
FOLLOWING WEEK. BOTH LEFT THE HOUSE EACH MORNING BEFORE THE  
REST OF THE FAMILY GOT UP, AND RETURNED WELL AFTER DINNER EVERY  
NIGHT.

IT'S BEEN ABSOLUTE HORROR, PERCY TOLD THEM IMPERTINENTLY, THE  
SUNDAY EVENING BEFORE THEY WERE DUE TO RETURN THE FLEWANTS.

I'VE BEEN PUTTING BLIT FIRES ALL WEEK. PEOPLE KEEP SENDING  
FLEWANTS AND IF COURSE, IF YOU DON'T OPEN A FLEWANT STRAIGHT  
AWAY, IT EXPLODES. SCORCH MARKS ALL OVER MY DESK AND MY BEST  
BLIT REDUCED TO CINDERS.

WHY ARE THEY ALL SENDING FLEWANTS? ASKED GINNY, WHO WAS  
MENDING HER CHOP OF FINE THOUSAND MAGICAL FLEWANTS AND FLING  
WITH SPELLTAPES ON THE WALL IN FRONT OF THE LIVING-ROOM FIRE.

COMPLAINING ABOUT SECURITY AT THE WORLD CUP, SAID PERCY.

THEY WANT COMPENSATION FOR THEIR RUINED PROPERTY.

MUNDUNGUS FLETCHER'S PUT IN A CLAIM FOR A TWELVE-REDUCED  
TENT WITH EN-SUITE JACKETS, BUT I'VE GOT HIS NUMBER. I KNOW FOR A  
FACT HE WAS SLEEPING UNDER A CHAIR PROPPED ON STICKS.

MRS WEASLEY GLANCED AT THE GRANDFATHER CLOCK IN THE CORNER.

HARRY LIKED THIS CLOCK. IT WAS COMPLETELY USELESS IF YOU WANTED



THE DINNER TIME, BUT OTHERWISE VERY INFORMATIVE. IT HAD NINE CHILDREN HANDS, AND EACH OF THEM WAS ENGRAVED WITH ONE OF THE WEASLEY FAMILY'S NAMES. THERE WERE NO NUMERALS AROUND THE FACE, BUT DESCRIPTIONS OF WHERE EACH FAMILY MEMBER MIGHT BE.

HOME, SCHOOL AND WORK WERE THERE, BUT THERE WAS ALSO HOSPITAL, PRISON AND, IN THE POSITION WHERE THE NUMBER TWELVE WOULD BE, A NORMAL CHECK, MENTAL PERIL.

EIGHT OF THE HANDS WERE CURRENTLY POINTING AT THE HOME POSITION, BUT MR WEASLEY'S, WHICH WAS THE LONGEST, WAS STILL POINTING AT WORK. MRS WEASLEY SIGHED.

THEIR FATHER HADN'T HAD THE GEE INTO THE OFFICE AT WEEKENDS SINCE THE DAYS OF YELL-DONNELL-WELL, SHE SAID. THEY'RE WORKING HIM FAR TOO HARD. HIS DINNER'S GOING TO BE RUINED IF HE DOESN'T COME HOME SOON.

THE HARRY POTTER

WELL, FATHER FEELS HE'S GOT TO MAKE UP FOR HIS MISTAKE AT THE MATCH, DOESN'T HE? SAID PERCY. IF TRUTH BE TOLD, HE WAS A TAD LONELY TO MAKE A PUBLIC STATEMENT WITHOUT CLEARING IT WITH HIS HEAD OF DEPARTMENT FIRST.

DON'T YOU DARE BLAME YOUR FATHER FOR WHAT THAT WRETCHED SKEETER WOMAN WROTE? SAID MRS WEASLEY, FLARING UP AT ONCE.

IF DAD HADN'T SAID ANYTHING, HAD RITA WOULD ILST HAVE SAID IT

WAS DISGRACEFUL THAT SOMEONE FROM THE MINISTRY HAD COMMENTED, SAID KILL, WHO WAS PLAYING CHESS WITH RON. RITA SKEETER

NEVER MAKES ANYONE LOOK GOOD. REMEMBER, SHE INTERVIEWED ALL

THE GRINGETTS CLERK READERS HIC, AND CALLED ME A LONG-  
HAired PILLER ?

Well, IT IS A BIT LONG, DEAR, SAID MRS WEASLEY GENTLY. IF YOU D  
JUST LET ME

NE, MUM,

RAIN LASHED AGAINST THE LIVING-ROOM WINDOW. HERMION WAS  
IMMERSED IN THE STANDARD BOOK OF SPELLS, GRADE 4, CHAPTER 11  
WHICH MRS WEASLEY HAD BOUGHT FOR HER, HARRY AND RON IN  
DIAGON ALLEY. CHARLIE WAS DARNING A FIREWORKS KALACHAVA. HARRY  
WAS POLISHING HIS FIREWHEEL, THE BROOMSTICK SERVING KIT  
HERMION HAD GIVEN HIM FOR HIS THIRTEENTH BIRTHDAY WHEN  
AT HIS FEET. FRED AND GEORGE WERE SITTING IN A FAR CORNER,  
HILLS HILT, TALKING IN WHISPERS, THEIR HEADS BENT OVER A PIECE OF  
PARCHMENT.

WHAT ARE YOU TWO UP TO? SAID MRS WEASLEY SHARPLY, HER EYES  
ON THE TWINS.

HERMION, SAID FRED VAGUELY.

DON'T BE RIDICULOUS, YOU'RE STILL ON HOLIDAY, SAID MRS  
WEASLEY.

Yeah, WE'VE LEFT IT A BIT LATE, SAID GEORGE.

YOU'RE NOT BY ANY CHANCE WRITING HILT A NEW HOBNOB FIRM, ARE  
YOU? SAID MRS WEASLEY SHARPLY. YOU WOULDN'T BE THINKING OF  
RESTARTING WEASLEY'S WIZARD WEZZES, BY ANY CHANCE?

NEH, MUM, SAID FRED, LOOKING UP AT HER, A PAINED LOOK ON

HIS FACE. IF THE FLEWARTS EXPRESS CRASHED THROUGH, AND

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GEORGE AND I DIED, THEN WOULD YOU FEEL SOMETHING THAT THE LAST  
THING WE EVER HEARD FROM YOU WAS AN UNFOLDED ACCUSATION?  
EVERYONE LAUGHED, EVEN MRS WEASLEY.

HEY, YOUR FATHER'S CHIMING! SHE SAID SUDDENLY, LEERING UP AT  
THE CLOCK AGAIN.

MR WEASLEY'S HAND HAD SUDDENLY SPLIN FROM WHERE THE TRAVEL-  
LING ; A SECOND LATER IT HAD SLIDDERED THE A FALT EN HOME WITH

THE OTHERS, AND THEY HEARD HIM CALLING FROM THE KITCHEN.

CHIMING, ARTFULY! CALLED MRS WEASLEY, HURRYING HIMT OF THE  
ROOM.

A FEW MOMENTS LATER, MR WEASLEY HAD COME INTO THE WARM  
LIVING ROOM, CARRYING HIS DINNER EN A TRAY, HE LEERED COMPLETELY  
EXHAUSTED.

WELL, THE FAT'S REALLY IN THE FIRE NOW, HE TOLD MRS WEASLEY AS

HE SAT DOWN IN AN ARMCHAIR NEAR THE FIRE AND THOED UNENTHUS-  
ASTICALLY WITH HIS SHIRT-TAT SPRIVELLED CALKLEWER, RITA

SKEETER'S BEEN FERRETING AROUND ALL WEEK, LEERING FOR MORE  
MINISTRY MESS-UPS THE REPORT, AND NOW SHE'S FEELING HIMT ASHET  
PHEER HED BERTHA GOING MISSING, SEE THAT LL BE THE HEADLINE IN THE  
PROPHET THROUGH, I TOLD BAGMAN HE SHOULD HAVE SENT SOMEONE

THE LINDY FOR HER AGES AGO.

MR CRUELCH HAS BEEN SAYING IT FOR WEEKS AND WEEKS, SAID PERCY SWIFTLY.

CRUELCH IS VERY LUCKY RITA HADN'T FOUND OUT ABOUT LINDY,

SAID MR WEASLEY IRRITABLY. THERE'D BE A WEEK'S WORTH OF HEADLINES IN HIS HOUSE-IF KING CALGHT FINDING THE LAND THAT

CHAINED THE DARK MARD.

I THOUGHT WE WERE ALL AGREED THAT THAT ELF, WHILE IRRESPONSIBLE, DID NOT CHAIN THE MARD? SAID PERCY HEARTILY.

IF YOU ASK ME, MR CRUELCH IS VERY LUCKY NOT HERE AT THE DAILY PROPHET KNOWS HOW MEAN HE IS TO ELVES! SAID HERMIONE ANGERILY.

NEED, LINDY HERE, HERMIONE! SAID PERCY. A HIGH-RANKING

MINISTRY OFFICIAL LIKE MR CRUELCH DESERVES UNINTERVING OBEDIENCE FROM HIS SERVANTS

1XX HARRY POTTER

HIS SLAVE, YOU MEAN? SAID HERMIONE, HER VOICE RISING SHARPLY. BECAUSE HE DIDN'T PAY LINDY, DID HE?

I THINK YOU'D ALL BETTER GO UPSTAIRS AND CHECK THAT YOU'RE PACKED PROPERLY! SAID MRS WEASLEY, BREAKING UP THE ARGUMENT.

COME ON, NEED, ALL OF YOU ...

F-JARRY REPAKED HIS BROOMSTICK SERVICING KIT, PLIT HIS  
FIREWEHT EVER HIS SHOULDER AND WENT BACK UPSTAIRS WITH REN.

THE RAIN SHOUNED EVEN HEEDER AT THE THED OF THE F-HELSE, ACCOMP-  
PANIED BY WILD WHISTLINGS AND MEANS FROM THE WIND, NEET THE

MENTHEN SPERADIC F-HELKS FROM THE CH-ELLS WHO LIVED IN THE ATTIC.  
PIELWIDGREN BEGAN TWITTERING AND ZEEHING AROUND HIS CAGE  
AGAIN WHEN THEY ENTERED. THE SIGHT OF THE HALF-PACKED TRUNKS  
SEEMED THE HAVE SENT HIM INTO A FRENZY OF EXCITEMENT.

KLING HIM SOME F-ELT TREATS, SAID REN, THROWING A PACKET  
ACROSS THE F-JARRY, IT MIGHT SHLIT HIM UP.

F-JARRY FEEDED A FEW F-ELT TREATS THROUGH THE BARS OF  
PIELWIDGREN'S CAGE, THEN TURNED THE HIS TRUNK, F-EDWIG'S CAGE  
STOOD NEXT THE IT, STILL EMPTY.

IT'S BEEN EVER A WEEK, F-JARRY SAID, LEEKING AT F-EDWIG'S  
DESERTED PERCH. REN, WHO BEEN T RECKEN SIRILIS HAS BEEN CALIGHT,  
DEE YELK?

NAH, IT WOULD VE BEEN IN THE DAILY PROPHECY, SAID REN. THE  
MINISTRY WOULD WANT THE SHELL THEY'D CALIGHT SOMEONE, WOULDNT THEY?

YEAH, I SLIPPERE ...

LEED, HERE'S THE STUFF MUM GET F-ER WHO IN DIAGEN ALLEY, AND  
SHE'S GET SOME CHILD ELIT OF YELIR VALIT F-ER WHO ... AND SHE'S  
WASHED ALL YELIR SHEES.

HE HEAVED A PILE OF PARCELS HENTH F-JARRY'S CAMP BED AND  
DROPPED THE MEENY BAG AND A LEAD OF SHEES NEXT THE IT, F-JARRY

STARTED UNWRAPPING THE SHIPPING, APART FROM THE STANDARD  
BOOKS OF SPELLS, GRADE 4, BY MIRANDA CHRISTIAN, HE HAD A HANDFUL  
OF NEW BILLS, A DOZEN BILLS OF PARCEMENT AND REILLS FOR HIS  
POTION-MAKING KIT. HE HAD BEEN RUNNING LOW ON SPICE OF LICH-  
FISH AND ESSENCE OF KILLADONNA, HE WAS JUST PILING UNDERWEAR

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INTO HIS CLOTHES WHEN RAYN MADE A BOLD MOVE OF DISGUISE  
BEHIND HIM.

WHAT IS THAT SLIPPERS THE KEY?

HE WAS HOLDING UP SOMETHING THAT LOOKED THE HARRY LIKE A  
LONG, MARSHY VELVET DRESS. IT HAD A MELTBY-LOOKING LACE TRILL AT  
THE COLLAR AND MATCHING LACE CLIPS.

THERE WAS A CRACK IN THE DOOR, AND MRS WEASLEY ENTERED,  
CARRYING AN ARMFUL OF FRESHLY WASHED FLOORSWEPT REELS.

HERE THEY ARE, SHE SAID, SHOOTING THEM INTO THE TUB. NOW, MIND  
THEY PACK THEM PROPERLY SO THEY DON'T CRASH.

MUM, YOU'VE GIVEN ME GINNY'S NEW DRESS, SAID RAYN,  
HOLDING IT UP TO HER.

HE THINKS I HAVEN'T, SAID MRS WEASLEY. THAT'S HER NEW DRESS  
REELS.

WHAT? SAID RAYN, LOOKING HORROR-STRIKE.

DRESS REELS? REPEATED MRS WEASLEY. IT SAYS IN YOUR SCHEDULE  
LIST THAT YOU'RE SLIPPERS THE HAVE DRESS REELS THIS YEAR ... REELS  
FOR FORMAL OCCASIONS.

YOU'VE GOT THE KE DIDDING, SAID RAYN IN DISBELIEF. I'M NOT

WEARING THAT, NEH WAY,

EVERYONE WEARS THEM, REEN? SAID MRS WEASLEY CRESSLY,

THEY RE ALL LIKE THAT? YELIA FATHER S GET SOME FOR SMART PARTIES?

I LL GET STARKERS BEHRE I PLT THAT EN, SAID REEN STLEKERNLY,

DEEN T BE SHE SILLY, SAID MRS WEASLEY, YELI VE GET TH HAVE DRESS  
REEKS, THEY RE EN YELIA LIST? I GET SOME FOR F-HARRY, THEE ... SE-HW  
HIM, F-HARRY ...

IN SOME TREPIDATIEN, F-HARRY OPENED THE LAST PARCEL EN HIS  
CAMP BED. IT WASN T AS BAD AS HE HAD EXPECTED, HOWEVER; HIS  
DRESS REEKS DIDN T HAVE ANY LACK EN THEM AT ALL; IN FACT, THEY  
WERE MORE OR LESS THE SAME AS HIS SC-HHEH ENES, EXCEPT THAT THEY  
WERE BITTLE GREEN INSTEAD OF BLACK.

I T-HELIGHT THEY D KRINE BELT THE CHHELIA OF YELIA EYES, DEAR,  
SAID MRS WEASLEY FENDLY,

WELL, THEY RE EED? SAID REEN ANGERILY, LEHDKING AT F-HARRY S REEKS,  
WHY CHILDN T I HAVE SOME LIKE THAT?

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BECAUSE ... WELL, I HAD TH GET YELIUS SECHND-HAND, AND THERE  
WASN T A LEFT OF CHHEIC? SAID MRS WEASLEY, ALLISHING,

F-HARRY LEHDED AWAY, HE WOULD WILLINGLY HAVE SPILT ALL THE  
MONEY IN HIS GRINGETTS WALIT WITH THE WEASLEYS, BUT HE KNEW  
THEY WOULD NEVER TAKE IT,

I M NEVER WEARING THEM, REEN WAS SAYING STLEKERNLY,  
NEVER,

FINE, SNAPPED MRS WEASLEY, GEH NAKED, AND F-HARRY, MADE  
SURE YELI GET A PICTURE OF HIM, CHEDNESS DENHS I CHLD BE WITH

A LAUGH.

SHE LEFT THE ROOM, SLAPPING THE DOOR BEHIND HER. THERE WAS A FLINDY SPLOTTERRING NOISE FROM BEHIND THEM. PIGWIDGEEEN WAS CHEERING HIM AN HYPERLARGE EEL TREAT.

WHY IS EVERYTHING I HEAR ALIKEST? SAID RICH FLIRTELISLY, STRIDING ACROSS THE ROOM THE LINSTICK PIGWIDGEEEN'S READ.

## CHAPTER ELEVEN

ABOARD THE FLEIGHTS

EXPRESS

THERE WAS A DEFINITE END-OF-THE-HOLIDAYS GLEAM IN THE AIR WHEN HARRY AWOKED NEXT MORNING. HEAVY RAIN WAS STILL SPLATTERING AGAINST THE WINDOW AS HE GOT DRESSED IN JEANS AND A SWEATSHIRT; THEY WOULD CHANGE INTO THEIR SCHOOL ROBES IN THE FLEIGHTS EXPRESS.

HE, RICH, FRED AND GEORGE HAD JUST REACHED THE FIRST-FLIGHT LANDING WHEN THEIR WAY BECAME THE BREAKFAST, WHEN MRS WEASLEY APPEARED AT THE FOOT OF THE STAIRS, LOOKING HARASSED.

ARTHUR! SHE CALLED UP THE STAIRCASE, ARTHUR! URGENT MESSAGE FROM THE MINISTRY!

HARRY FLATTENED HIMSELF AGAINST THE WALL AS MR WEASLEY CAME CLATTERING PAST WITH HIS ROBES ON BACK-THE-FRONT, AND FLIRTLED OUT OF SIGHT. WHEN HARRY AND THE OTHERS ENTERED THE KITCHEN, THEY SAW MRS WEASLEY RUMMAGING ANXIOUSLY IN THE DRESSER DRAWERS



I'VE GOT A WILLOW HERE SOMEWHERE! AND MR WEASLEY BENDING  
EVERY TREE FIRE, TALKING THE  
HARRY SLIT HIS EYES HARD AND OPENED THEM AGAIN THE MADE  
SURE THAT THEY WERE WORKING PROPERLY.  
ARTHUR DIGGORY'S HEAD WAS SITTING IN THE MIDDLE OF THE FLAMES  
LIKE A LARGE BEARDED EGG. IT WAS TALKING VERY FAST, COMPLETELY  
UNPERTURBED BY THE SPARKS FLYING AROUND IT AND THE FLAMES LICK-  
ING ITS EARS.

... MIDDLE NEIGHBOURS HEARD BANGS AND SMELTING, SO THEY  
WENT AND CALLED THESE WHAT-D-YOU-CALL-EMS PLEASE-MEN.

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ARTHUR, YOU'VE GOT THE GET EVERY THERE  
HERE! SAID MRS WEASLEY BREATHLESSLY, PUSHING A PIECE OF  
PARCHMENT, A BOTTLE OF INK AND A CRUMPLED WILLOW INTO MR  
WEASLEY'S HANDS.

IT'S A REAL STROKE OF LUCK I HEARD ABOUT IT, SAID MR  
DIGGORY'S HEAD, I HAD THE CHIEF INTO THE OFFICE EARLY THE  
SEND A WHOLE OF WILLS, AND I FEELING THE IMPROPER USE OF  
MAGIC LEFT ALL SETTING OFF IF RITA SKEETER GETS HOLD OF THIS ONE,  
ARTHUR

WHAT DOES MAD-LY SAY HAPPENED? ASKED MR WEASLEY,  
UNSCREWING THE INK BOTTLE, LEADING UP HIS WILLOW AND PREPARING  
THE TACK NETS.

MR DIGGORY'S HEAD REELLED ITS EYES. SAYS HE HEARD AN INTERLUDE

IN HIS YARD, SAYS THEY WERE CREEPING TOWARDS THE HOUSE, BUT  
THEY WERE AMPLIFIED BY HIS BUSTERS,

WHAT DID THE BUSTERS DO? ASKED MR LEASLEY, SCRIBBLING  
FRANTICALLY,

MADE ONE HELL OF A NOISE AND FIRED BLASTS EVERYWHERE, AS  
FAR AS I CAN TELL, SAID MR DIGGERS, APPARENTLY ONE OF THEM WAS  
STILL RECKETING AROUND WHEN THE POLICE-MEN TURNED UP  
MR LEASLEY GRINNED, AND WHAT ABOUT THE INTERLUDE?

ARTHEUR, WHO KNEW MAD-EYE, SAID MR DIGGERS'S HEAD, ROLLING  
ITS EYES AGAIN, SOMEONE CREEPING INTO HIS YARD AT THE DEAD OF  
NIGHT? MORE LIKELY THERE'S A VERY SELFISH-CORDED CAT WANDERING  
AROUND SOMEWHERE, COVERED IN PITCHED FEELINGS, BUT IF THE  
IMPROPER USE OF MAGIC LET GET THEIR HANDS ON MAD-EYE, HE'S  
HAD IT THINK OF HIS RECORD WE'VE GOT TO GET HIM OFF ON A  
MINOR CHARGE, SOMETHING IN YOUR DEPARTMENT WHAT ARE  
EXPLODING BUSTERS WORTH?

MIGHT BE A CALTHER, SAID MR LEASLEY, STILL WRITING VERY FAST,  
HIS EYES FLUTTERED, MAD-EYE DIDN'T USE HIS WAND? HE DIDN'T  
ACTUALLY ATTACK ANYONE?

I'LL BET HE LEAPT OUT OF BED AND STARTED JINKING EVERYTHING HE  
COULD REACH THROUGH THE WINDOW, SAID MR DIGGERS, BUT THEY'LL  
HAVE A JOB PROVING IT, THERE AREN'T ANY CASUALTIES,

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ALL RIGHT, I'M OFF, MR LEASLEY SAID, AND HE STUFFED THE PARCH-  
MENT WITH HIS FEET ON IT INTO HIS POCKET AND DASHED OUT OF THE

KITCHEN AGAIN.

MR DIGGORY'S HEAD BOUNDED AROUND AT MRS WEASLEY.

SHERRY ASKED THIS, MUM, IT SAID, MORE CALMLY, REMEMBERING WELL SHE EARLY AND EVERYTHING ... BUT ARTFUL IS THE ONLY ONE WHO CAN GET MAD-EYE OFF, AND MAD-EYE'S SLIPPED THE BE STARTING HIS NEW JOB TODAY, WHY HE HAD THE CHEESE LAST NIGHT ...

NEVER MIND, AMMS, SAID MRS WEASLEY, SURE WELL WHEN I HAVE A BIT OF TEAST FOR ANYTHING BEFORE WELL GET

EH, OH EN, THEN, SAID MR DIGGORY,

MRS WEASLEY TOOK A PIECE OF BUTTERED TEAST FROM A STACK ON THE KITCHEN TABLE, PUT IT INTO THE FIRE THINGS AND TRANSFERRED IT INTO MR DIGGORY'S MOUTH.

FARDS, HE SAID IN A MUFFLED VOICE, AND THEN, WITH A SMALL POP, VANISHED.

HARRY COULD HEAR MR WEASLEY CALLING FLURRIED CHICKENS THE BILL, CHARLIE, PERCY AND THE GIRLS. WITHIN FIVE MINUTES, HE WAS BACK IN THE KITCHEN, HIS RECKS ON THE RIGHT WAY NEW, DRAGGING A CHIMP THROUGH HIS HAIR.

I'D BETTER FLURRY WELL HAVE A GOOD TERM, KIDS, SAID MR WEASLEY THE HARRY, BEN AND THE TWINS, DRAGGING A CHIMP OVER HIS SHOULDERS AND PREPARING THE DISAPPEARATE. MUM, ARE WELL GOING THE BE ALL RIGHT TAKING THE KIDS THE KING'S CRESS?

HE' COURSE I WILL, SHE SAID, WELL JUST BEND AFTER MAD-EYE, WE'LL BE FINE.

AS MR WEASLEY VANISHED, BILL AND CHARLIE ENTERED THE KITCHEN.

DID SOMEONE SAY MAD-EYE? KILL ASKED, WHAT'S HE BEEN UP  
THE NIGHT?

HE SAYS SOMEONE TRIED TO BREAK INTO HIS HOUSE LAST NIGHT,  
SAID MRS WEASLEY.

MAD-EYE MURDER? SAID GEORGE THELUGHTFULLY, SPREADING MAR-  
MALADE ON HIS CHEST. ISN'T HE THAT NOBSTER

WHICH FATHER THINKS VERY HIGHLY OF MAD-EYE MURDER,

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SAID MRS WEASLEY STERNLY.

Yeah, well, Dad collects pills, doesn't he? SAID FRED QUIETLY,  
AS MRS WEASLEY LEFT THE ROOM, KIDS OF A FEATHER ...

MURDER WAS A GREAT WIZARD IN HIS TIME, SAID KILL.

HE'S AN OLD FRIEND OF DUMBLEDORE'S, ISN'T HE? SAID CHARLIE.

DUMBLEDORE'S NOT WHAT YOU'D CALL NORMAL, THOUGH, IS HE?  
SAID FRED, I MEAN, I KNOW HE'S A GENIUS AND EVERYTHING ...

WHAT IS MAD-EYE? ASKED HARRY.

HE'S RETIRED, USED TO WORK AT THE MINISTRY, SAID CHARLIE. I  
MET HIM ONCE WHEN DAD TOOK ME INTO WORK WITH HIM. HE WAS  
AN ALRIGHT ONE OF THE BEST ... A DARK-WIZARD-CATCHER, HE ADDED,  
SEEING HARRY'S BLANK LOOK. HALF THE CELLS IN AZKABAN ARE FULL  
BECAUSE OF HIM. HE MADE HIMSELF ENEMIES, THOUGH ...  
THE FAMILIES OF PEOPLE HE CAUGHT, MAINLY ... AND I HEARD HE'S

BEEN GETTING REALLY PARANOID IN HIS OLD AGE, DOESN'T TRUST ANY-

HEN AND HERE, SEES DARK WIZARDS EVERYWHERE.

BILL AND CHARLIE DECIDED TO LEAVE AND SEE EVERYTHING OFF AT  
KING'S CROSS STATION, BUT PERCY, APPEALING MOST PITHILY, SAID  
THAT HE REALLY NEEDED TO GET THE WORK.

I JUST CAN'T JUSTIFY TAKING MORE TIME OFF AT THE MOMENT, HE  
TOLD THEM. MR CRUELICK IS REALLY STARTING TO RELY ON ME.

YEAH, YOU KNOW WHAT, PERCY? SAID GEORGE SERIOUSLY. I  
REMEMBER HE LIKED YOUR NAME WHEN.

MRS WEASLEY HAD RAYED THE TELEPHONE IN THE VILLAGE POST  
OFFICE THE MORNING THREE ORDINARY MUGGLE TAXIS TO TAKE THEM INTO  
LONDON.

ARTHUR TRIED THE BIRMINGHAM MINISTRY CARS FOR US, MRS WEASLEY  
WHISPERED TO HARRY AS THEY STOOD IN THE RAIN-WASHED YARD,  
WATCHING THE TAXI DRIVERS HEAVING SIX HEAVY HEGWARTS TRUNKS  
INTO THEIR CARS. BUT THERE WEREN'T ANY TO SPARE ... OH DEAR, THEY  
DIDN'T SEEM HAPPY, DID THEY?

HARRY DIDN'T LIKE TO TELL MRS WEASLEY THAT MUGGLE TAXI DRIVERS  
RARELY TRANSPORTED OVER-EXCITED BOYS, AND PIGWIDGEM WAS  
MAKING AN EAR-SPLITTING RACKET. NEAR DID IT HELP THAT A NUMBER  
OF DR FILIBUSTER'S PARLOURS WET-START, AND THAT FIREWORKS WENT

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OFF UNEXPECTEDLY WHEN RED'S TRUNK SPRANG OPEN, CAUSING THE  
DRIVER CARRYING IT TO YELL WITH FRIGHT AND PAIN AS CRUELICKS HANDS  
CLAWED HIS WAY UP THE MAN'S LEG.

THE JOURNEY WAS UNCOMFORTABLE, BEING THE FACT THAT THEY

WERE LAMED IN THE BACK OF THE TAXIS WITH THEIR TRUNKS,  
CRITCHFIELD'S THREE ELITE A WHILE THE RECEIVER FROM THE FIREWORKS,  
AND BY THE TIME THEY ENTERED LONDON, HARRY, RON AND  
HERMION WERE ALL SEVERELY SCRATCHED. THEY WERE VERY RELIEVED  
THEY GOT OUT AT KING'S CROSS, EVEN THOUGH THE RAIN WAS COMING  
DOWN HARDER THAN EVER, AND THEY GOT SHAKED CARRYING THEIR  
TRUNKS ACROSS THE BUSY ROAD AND INTO THE STATION.

HARRY WAS USED TO GETTING ONTO PLATFORM NINE AND THREE-  
QUARTERS BY NOW. IT WAS A SIMPLE MATTER OF WALKING STRAIGHT  
THROUGH THE APPARENTLY SOLID BARRIER DIVIDING PLATFORMS NINE  
AND TEN. THE ONLY TRICKY PART WAS BEING THIS IN AN UNEXPECTED  
WAY, SEE AS THE AVOID ATTRACTING MUGGLE ATTENTION. THEY DID IT IN

GRIPS TODAY; HARRY, RON AND HERMION (THE MOST CONSPICU-  
OUS, AS THEY WERE ACCOMPANIED BY PIGWIGGEN AND CRITCH-  
FIELD) WENT FIRST; THEY LEANT CASUALLY AGAINST THE BARRIER,

CHATTING UNCONCERNEDLY, AND SLID SIDELWAYS THROUGH IT ... AND AS  
THEY DID SO, PLATFORM NINE AND THREE-QUARTERS MATERIALISED IN  
FRONT OF THEM.

THE HOGWARTS EXPRESS, A GLEAMING SCARLET STEAM ENGINE, WAS  
ALREADY THERE, CLOUDS OF STEAM RISING FROM IT, THROUGH

WHICH THE MANY HOGWARTS STUDENTS AND PARENTS IN THE PLAT-  
FORM APPEARED LIKE DARK GHOSTS. PIGWIGGEN BECAME NOISIER

THAN EVER IN RESPONSE TO THE MEETING OF MANY HEADS THROUGH THE  
MIST. HARRY, RON AND HERMIONE SET OFF THE FIND SEATS, AND WERE  
SEEN STEALING THEIR LUGGAGE IN A COMPARTMENT HALFWAY ALONG  
THE TRAIN. THEY THEN HOPPED BACK DOWN ONTO THE PLATFORM, THE  
SAY CHEERFUL THE MRS WEASLEY, BILL AND CHARLIE.

I MIGHT BE SEEING YOU ALL SOONER THAN YOU THINK, SAID  
CHARLIE, GRINNING, AS HE FLICKED GINNY CHEERFUL.

WHY? SAID FRED DEENLY.

YOU'LL SEE, SAID CHARLIE. I'VE JUST BEEN T TELL PERCY I MENTIONED IT

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... IT'S CLASSIFIED INFORMATION, UNTIL SUCH TIME AS THE MINISTRY  
SEES FIT TO RELEASE IT, AFTER ALL.

YEAH, I SORT OF WISH I WAS BACK AT HOGWARTS THIS YEAR, SAID  
BILL, HANDS IN HIS POCKETS, LOOKING ALMOST WISTFULLY AT THE TRAIN.

WHY? SAID GEORGE IMPATIENTLY.

YOU'RE GOING TO HAVE AN INTERESTING YEAR, SAID BILL, HIS EYES  
TWINKLING. I MIGHT EVEN GET TIME OFF TO COME AND WATCH A BIT OF  
IT ...

A BIT OF WHAT? SAID RON.

BUT AT THAT MOMENT, THE WHISTLE BLEW, AND MRS WEASLEY  
CHIVVIED THEM TOWARDS THE TRAIN DOORS.

THANKS FOR HAVING US THE DAY, MRS WEASLEY, SAID HERMIONE,  
AS THEY CLIMBED ON BOARD, CLOSED THE DOOR AND LEANT OUT OF THE  
WINDOWS TO TALK TO HER.

YEAH, THANKS FOR EVERYTHING, MRS WEASLEY, SAID HARRY.

"HEY, IT WAS MY PLEASURE, DEARS, SAID MRS WEASLEY, I'D INVITE  
YELL FOR CHRISTMAS, BUT ... WELL, I EXPECT YELL'RE ALL GOING TO  
WANT TO STAY AT HOGWARTS, WHAT WITH ... ONE THING AND ANOTHER.  
MUM? SAID RON IRITABLY, WHAT'D YELL THREE KNOW THAT WE  
DEEN T?

"YELL'LL FIND OUT THIS EVENING, I EXPECT, SAID MRS WEASLEY,  
SMILING. IT'S GOING TO BE VERY EXCITING. MIND YELL, I'M VERY  
GLAD THEY'VE CHANGED THE RULES.

"WHAT RULES? SAID HARRY, RON, FRED AND GEORGE TOGETHER.  
I'M SURE PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE WILL TELL YELL ... NOW, BE-CAUSE,  
WHEN T'YELL? WHEN T'YELL, FRED? AND YELL, GEORGE?

THE WHISTLES HISSED LOUDLY, AND THE TRAIN BEGAN TO MOVE.

"TELL US WHAT'S HAPPENING AT HOGWARTS? FRED BELLECHED OUT OF  
THE WINDOW, AS MRS WEASLEY, KILL AND CHARLIE SPED AWAY FROM  
THEM. WHAT RULES ARE THEY CHANGING?

BUT MRS WEASLEY ONLY SMILED AND WAVED, BEFORE THE  
TRAIN HAD REACHED THE CORNER, SHE, KILL AND CHARLIE HAD  
DISAPPEARED.

HARRY, RON AND HERMIONE WENT BACK TO THEIR COMPARTMENT.

THE THICK RAIN SPLATTERING THE WINDOWS MADE IT VERY DIFFICULT TO

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SEE OUT OF THEM, RON LUNGED HIS TRUNK, PULLED OUT HIS MARSHMALLOW  
BAGS REELS, AND FILING THEM OVER PICKWICK'S LAGE THE MUMBLE  
HIS HEETING.

RAGMAN WANTED TO TELL US WHAT'S HAPPENING AT HOGWARTS, HE  
SAID GRUMPILY, SITTING DOWN NEXT TO HARRY, AT THE WHEEL CLIP,



REMEMBER? BUT MY HEIN MEET-ER WHEN T SAY, WENDEH WHAT

SHE? HERMIONE WHISPERED SUDDENLY, PRESSING HER FINGER TO  
HER LIPS AND POINTING TOWARDS THE COMPARTMENT NEXT TO THEIRS.  
HARRY AND RON LISTENED, AND HEARD A FAMILIAR DRAWLING VOICE  
DRIFTING IN THROUGH THE OPEN DOOR.

... FATHER ACTUALLY CONSIDERED SENDING ME TO DUMSTRANG  
RATHER THAN HOGWARTS, WELL KNOWN, HE KNOWS THE HEADMASTER,  
WELL SEE, WELL, WELL KNOWN HIS OPINION OF DUMSTRANG THE  
MAN IS SUCH A MISERABLE LIEVER AND DUMSTRANG DOESN'T ADMIT  
THAT SHORT OF RIFF-RAFF, BUT MEET-ER DIDN'T LIKE THE IDEA OF ME GOING  
TO SCHOOL SHE FAR AWAY FATHER SAYS DUMSTRANG TAKES A FAR MORE  
SENSIBLE LINE THAN HOGWARTS ABOUT THE DARK ARTS, DUMSTRANG  
STUDENTS ACTUALLY LEARN THEM, NOT JUST THE DEFENCE RUKKISH WE  
DO ...

HERMIONE GOT UP, TIPPED TO THE COMPARTMENT DOOR, AND SLID  
IT SHUT, BLOCKING OUT MALFOY'S VOICE.

SHE HE THINKS DUMSTRANG WOULD HAVE SLITED HIM, DOES HE?  
SHE SAID ANGERILY, I WISH HE HAD DONE, THEN WE WOULDN'T HAVE  
HAD TO PUT UP WITH HIM.

DUMSTRANG'S ANOTHER WIZARDING SCHOOL? SAID HARRY.

YES, SAID HERMIONE SNIPPILY, AND IT'S GOT A TERRIBLE REPUTA-  
TION, ACCORDING TO AN APPRAISAL OF MAGICAL EDUCATION IN EUROPE,

IT PUTS A LOT OF EMPHASIS ON THE DARK ARTS.

I THINK I'VE HEARD OF IT, SAID RON VAGUELY, WHERE IS IT?  
WHAT COUNTRY?

WELL, NOBODY KNOWS, DO THEY? SAID HERMIONE, RAISING HER EYEBROWS.

OR WHY NOT? SAID HARRY.

THERE'S TRADITIONALLY BEEN A LOT OF RIVALRY BETWEEN ALL THE MAGIC SCHOOLS, DUMSTRANG AND BEAUBATEENS LIKE THE CHURCH

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THEIR WORKSHEETS SEE NOBODY CAN STEAL THEIR SECRETS, SAID HERMIONE MATTER-OF-FACTLY.

COME OFF IT, SAID RON, STARTING THE LAUGH. DUMSTRANG'S GOT THE REASON THE SAME SIZE AS HOGWARTS, THEY ARE WHY CHINESE THE HIDE A DIRTY GREAT CASTLE?

BUT HOGWARTS IS HIDDEN, SAID HERMIONE, IN SURPRISE, EVERYONE KNOWS THAT ... WELL, EVERYONE WHEN I READ HOGWARTS: A

HISTORY, ANYWAY.

LISTEN, THEN, SAID RON. SHE GOES ON HOW THEY HIDE A PLACE LIKE HOGWARTS?

IT'S KITCHED, SAID HERMIONE. IF A MUGGLE LOOKS AT IT, ALL THEY SEE IS A MEHLBERING OLD RUIN WITH A SIGN OVER THE ENTRANCE SAYING DANGER, DO NOT ENTER, LINDA.

SEE DUMSTRANG IS JUST LOOK LIKE A RUIN THE AN ELTISIDE, THEN MAYBE, SAID HERMIONE, SHAKING, FOR IT MIGHT HAVE MUGGLE-REPELLING CHARMS ON IT, LIKE THE WERD CLIP STADIUM, AND THE DEEP FOREIGN WIZARDS FROM FINDING IT, THEY IS HAVE MADE IT UNPLEASANT

COME AGAIN?

WELL, YOU CAN ENCHANT A BUILDING SEE IT'S IMPOSSIBLE THE PLEET  
HIN A MAP, CAN'T YOU?

ER ... IF YOU SAY SEE, SAID HARRY,

BUT I THINK DUMSTRANG MUST BE SOMEWHERE IN THE FAR  
NORTH, SAID HERMIONE TEHLIGHTFULLY. SOMEWHERE VERY COLD,  
BECAUSE THEY'VE GOTTEN FLUR CAPES AS PART OF THEIR UNIFORMS.

AND, THINK OF THE POSSIBILITIES, SAID RON DREAMILY. IT  
WOULD BE BEEN SEE EASY THE POLISH MALPHEE OFF A GLACIER AND MAKE IT  
LOOK LIKE AN ACCIDENT ... SEAMUS HIS MOTHER LIKES HIM ...

THE RAIN BECAME HEAVIER AND HEAVIER AS THE TRAIN MOVED  
FURTHER NORTH. THE SKY WAS SEE DARK AND THE WINDMILLS SEE STEAMY  
THAT THE LANTERNS WERE LIT BY MIDDAY. THE LUNCH TROLLEY CAME  
RATTLING ALONG THE CORRIDOR, AND HARRY REUGHT A LARGE STACK OF  
CALIBREEN CAPES FOR THEM THE SHARE.

SEVERAL OF THEIR FRIENDS WHEEDED IN WITH THEM AS THE AFTERNOON  
PROGRESSSED, INCLUDING SEAMUS FINNIGAN, DEAN THOMAS AND

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NEVILLE LONGBOTTEN, A REDD-FACED, EXTREMELY PERCEPTUAL BOY

WHICH HAD BEEN BRUGHT UP BY HIS FIRMIDABLE WITCH OF A GRAND-  
MOTHER. SEAMUS WAS STILL WEARING HIS IRELAND RESSETTE. SOME OF

ITS MAGIC SEEMED TO BE WEARING OFF NOW; IT WAS STILL SEELADING

TREED, MULLET, MERAN, BUT IN A VERY FRIBLE AND EXHAUSTED SORT  
OF WAY. AFTER HALF AN HOUR FOR SEE, HERMIONE, GRUWING TIRED OF THE

ENDLESS FOLLOWS-UP TALK, CLARIFIED HERSELF FINALLY MORE IN THE STANDARD KIND OF SPELLS, GRADE 2, AND STARTED TRYING TO LEARN A SLEEPING CHARM.

NEVILLE LISTENED INTENSIVELY TO THE OTHERS' CONVERSATION AS THEY RELIVED THE CLIP MATCH.

GRAN DIDN'T WANT THE GO, HE SAID MISERABLY. WOULDNT BUY TICKETS. IT SEEMED AMAZING, THROUGH.

IT WAS, SAID RHN, KIND AT THIS, NEVILLE ...

HE RUMMAGED IN HIS TRUNK UP IN THE LUGGAGE RACK, AND PULLED OUT THE MINIATURE FIGURE OF VICTOR KARL.

HEH, WELL, SAID NEVILLE ENVIOUSLY, AS RHN TIPPED KARL WITH HIS PLAY HAND.

WE SAW HIM RIGHT UP CLOSE, AS WELL, SAID RHN. WE WERE IN THE TOP BOX

FOR THE FIRST AND LAST TIME IN THEIR LIFE, WEASLEY.

DRACH MALFOY HAD APPEARED IN THE CORRIDOR, BEHIND HIM STOOD CRABBE AND GOYLE, HIS ENORMOUS, THICK-LIMBED CREWIES, BOTH OF WHOM APPEARED TO HAVE GREEN AT LEAST A TINT DURING THE SUMMER. EVIDENTLY THEY HAD OVERHEARD THE CONVERSATION THROUGH THE COMPARTMENT DOOR, WHICH DEAN AND SEamus HAD LEFT ALIVE.

DIDNT REMEMBER ASKING WHY THE OTHERS, MALFOY, SAID HARRY CHEERFULLY.

WEASLEY ... WHAT IS THAT? SAID MALFOY, POINTING AT PIGWIDGERS SACK. A SLEEVE OF RHN S DRESS REEKS WAS DANGLING FROM IT, SWAYING WITH THE MOTION OF THE TRAIN, THE MELLODY LAKE CLIP VERY HEAVILY.

REHN MADE THE STUFF THE BOOKS HILT UP SIGHT, BUT MALFOY WAS THE  
BLIND FOR HIM; HE SEIZED THE SLEEVE AND PULLED.

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LOOK AT THIS! SAID MALFOY IN ECSTASY, HOLDING UP REHN'S BOOKS  
AND SHOWING CRABBE AND GOYLE. WEASLEY, WHO WEREN'T THINKING

OF WEARING THESE, WERE WHO? I MEAN THEY WERE VERY FASHION-  
ABLE IN ABOUT 1870 ...

EAT DRINK, MALFOY! SAID REHN, THE SAME CHEER AS THE DRESS  
BOOKS AS HE SNATCHED THEM BACK HILT UP MALFOY'S GRIP, MALFOY  
GIGGLED WITH DERISIVE LAUGHTER; CRABBE AND GOYLE GUFFAWED  
STUPIDLY.

SEE ... GOING TO ENTER, WEASLEY? GOING TO TRY AND EARN A KIT  
OF GLORY THE FAMILY NAME? THERE'S MONEY INVOLVED AS WELL,  
WHO KNOWS ... WHO'D BE ABLE TO AFFORD SOME DECENT BOOKS IF WHO  
WHEN ...

WHAT ARE YOU TALKING ABOUT? SNAPPED REHN.

ARE YOU GOING TO ENTER? MALFOY REPEATED. I SUPPOSE YOU WILL,  
POTTER? YOU NEVER MISS A CHANCE TO SHOW OFF, DO YOU?

EITHER EXPLAIN WHAT YOU'RE ABOUT OR GET AWAY, MALFOY,  
SAID HERMIONE TESTILY, EVER THE TOP OF THE STANDARD BENCH OF  
SPELLS, GRADE 4.

A GLEEKLY SMILE SPREAD ACROSS MALFOY'S PALE FACE.

DON'T TELL ME YOU DON'T KNOW! HE SAID DELIGHTEDLY. YOU'VE  
GOT A FATHER AND BROTHER AT THE MINISTRY AND YOU DON'T EVEN

KNELLY MY GOD, MY FATHER TOLD ME ABOUT IT AGES AGO ... HEARD IT FROM CHARNEVILLE FLICKER, BUT THEN, FATHER'S ALWAYS ASSOCIATED WITH THE THOSE PEOPLE AT THE MINISTRY ... MAYBE YOUR FATHER'S THE ONLY ONE THE KNELLY ABOUT IT, LEASTLY ... YES ... THEY PROBABLY DIDN'T TALK ABOUT IMPORTANT STUFF IN FRONT OF HIM ...

LAUGHING MORE MORE, MALCOLM RECOGNIZED THE CRACK AND CRACK, AND THE THREE OF THEM DISAPPEARED.

RENN GOT THE HIS FEET AND SLAPPED THE SLIDING COMPARTMENT BEHIND HIM HARD BEHIND THEM THAT THE GLASS SHATTERED.

RENN SAID HERMINE REPROACHFULLY, AND SHE PULLED OUT HER WAND, MUTTERED REPAIRS, AND THE GLASS SHARDS FLEW BACK INTO A SINGLE PANE, AND BACK INTO THE BEHIND.

WELL ... MAKING IT LOOK LIKE HE KNOWS EVERYTHING AND WE DIDN'T ... RENN SNARLED, FATHER'S ALWAYS ASSOCIATED WITH THE THOSE

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PEOPLE AT THE MINISTRY ... DAD WOULD VE GOT PERMISSION ANY TIME ... HE JUST LIKES IT WHERE HE IS ...

HE CALLED HE DOES, SAID HERMINE QUIETLY, DIDN'T LET MALCOLM GET THE YELL, RENN

HIM? GET THE ME? AS IF? SAID RENN, PICKING UP ONE OF THE REMAINING CALIBREIN CARDS AND SWASTIKING IT INTO A PILE,

RENN'S BAD MIND CONTINUED FOR THE REST OF THE JOURNEY, HE DIDN'T TALK MUCH AS THEY CHANGED INTO THEIR SILENT RIVERS, AND WAS STILL GIBBERING WHEN THE HIGGARTS EXPRESS SLEWED DOWN AT LAST, AND FINALLY STOPPED IN THE PITCH-DARKNESS OF HIGSMERE STATION.

AS THE TRAIN DOORS OPENED, THERE WAS A RUMBLE OF THUNDER  
EVERYWHERE. HERMIONE CLIMBED CRIBBAGE-BOXES UP IN HER CLASS AND  
THEN LEFT HIS DRESS REEKES EVERY PIGWIDGEEEN AS THEY LEFT THE TRAIN,  
HEADS BENT AND EYES NARROWED AGAINST THE DOWNPOUR. THE RAIN  
WAS NOW CHIMING DOWN SEE THICK AND FAST THAT IT WAS AS THOUGH  
BUCKETS OF ICE-COLD WATER WERE BEING EMPTIED REPEATEDLY OVER  
THEIR HEADS.

HI, HARRY! HARRY YELLED, SEEING A GIGANTIC SILHOUETTE AT THE  
FAR END OF THE PLATFORM.

ALL RIGHT, HARRY? HARRY BELLETERED BACK, WAVING. SEE YOU AT  
THE FEAST IF WE DEEN DREHNN?

FIRST-YEARS TRADITIONALLY REACHED HOGWARTS CASTLE BY SAILING  
ACROSS THE LAKE WITH HARRY.

HEHEH, I WOULDN'T FANCY CROSSING THE LAKE IN THIS WEATHER,  
SAID HERMIONE FERVENTLY, SHIVERING AS THEY INCHED SLEEPLY ALONG

THE DARK PLATFORM WITH THE REST OF THE CREW. A HUNDRED HORSE-  
LESS CARRIAGES STOOD WAITING FOR THEM OUTSIDE THE STATION. HARRY,

THEN, HERMIONE AND NEVILLE CLIMBED GRATEFULLY INTO ONE OF  
THEM. THE DOOR SHUT WITH A SNAP, AND A FEW MOMENTS LATER,  
WITH A GREAT CLINK, THE LONG PROCESSION OF CARRIAGES WAS  
RUMBLING AND SPLASHING ITS WAY UP THE TRACK TOWARDS HOGWARTS  
CASTLE.

## CHAPTER TWELVE

## THE TRIWIZARD TOURNAMENT

THROUGH THE GATES, FLANKED WITH STATUES OF WINGED BEASTS, AND

UP THE SWEEPING DRIVE THE CARRIAGES TRUNDLED, SWAYING DANGEROUSLY IN WHAT WAS FAST BECOMING A GALE, LEANING AGAINST THE

WINDMILL, HARRY COULD SEE HOGWARTS COMING NEARER, ITS MANY LIGHTED WINDMILLS BLURRED AND SHIMMERING BEHIND THE THICK CURTAIN OF RAIN. LIGHTNING FLASHED ACROSS THE SKY AS THEIR CARRIAGE CAME TO A HALT BEFORE THE GREAT BLACK FRONT DOORS, WHICH STOOD AT THE TOP OF A FLIGHT OF STONE STEPS. PEOPLE WHO HAD ESCORTED THE CARRIAGES IN FRONT WERE ALREADY HURRYING UP THE STONE STEPS INTO THE CASTLE; HARRY, RON, HERMIONE AND NEVILLE JUMPED DOWN FROM THEIR CARRIAGE AND DASHED UP THE STEPS THEM, BREATHING UP ONLY WHEN THEY WERE SAFELY INSIDE THE CLOVERLEAFS, THE HALF-LIT ENTRANCE HALL, WITH ITS MAGNIFICENT MARBLE STAIRCASE. KILPEY, SAID RON, SHAKING HIS HEAD AND SENDING WATER EVERYWHERE. IF THAT KEEPS UP, THE LAKE IS GOING TO BE OVERFLOWING. I'M SHADY ABOUT IT.

A LARGE, RED, WATER-FILLED BALLON HAD DRIPPED FROM THE CEILING INTO RON'S HEAD, AND EXPLODED, DRENCHED AND SPLATTERING. RON STAGGERED SIDEWAYS INTO HARRY, JUST AS A SECOND WATER BOMB DRIPPED. NEARLY MISSING HERMIONE, IT BURST AT HARRY'S FEET, SENDING A WAVE OF COLD WATER OVER HIS TRAINERS INTO HIS SHOES. PEOPLE ALL AROUND THEM SHRIEKED AND STARTED PUSHING EACH OTHER IN THEIR EFFORTS TO GET OUT OF THE LINE



OF FIRE. HARRY LERGED UP, AND SAW, FLEATING TWENTY FEET ABOVE THEM, PERVES THE PHILTERGIST, A LITTLE MAN IN A BELL-COVERED HAT AND ORANGE BELT-TIE, HIS WIDE, MALICIOUS FACE CENTERED WITH

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CONCENTRATION AS HE THREW AIM AGAIN.

PERVES? YELLED AN ANGRY VOICE. PERVES, COME DOWN HERE AT ONCE?

PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL, DEPUTY HEADMISTRESS AND HEAD OF GRYFFINDOR HOUSE, HAD COME DASHING OUT OF THE GREAT HALL; SHE SKIDDED ON THE WET FLOOR AND GRABBED HERMIONE AROUND THE NECK TO STOP HERSELF FALLING. HELLO SHIRRY, MISS GRANGER THAT S ALL RIGHT, PROFESSOR? HERMIONE GASPED, MASSAGING HER THROAT.

PERVES, GET DOWN HERE NOW! BARKED PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL, STRAIGHTENING HER POINTED HAT AND GLARING UPWARDS THROUGH HER SEELIAR-RIMMED SPECTACLES.

NOT DOING NOTHING? LAUGHED PERVES, LERKING A WATER BOMB AT SEVERAL FIFTY-YEAR GIRLS, WHO SCREAMED AND DIVED INTO THE GREAT HALL. ALREADY WET, AREN T THEY? LITTLE SEELIARTS? WHEEEEEEEEEEE? AND HE AIMED ANOTHER BOMB AT A GROUP OF SECOND-YEARS WHO HAD JUST ARRIVED.

I SHALL CALL THE HEADMASTER? SEELITED PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL.

I M WARNING YOU, PERVES

PERVES STUCK OUT HIS TONGUE, THREW THE LAST OF HIS WATER BOMBS INTO THE AIR, AND ZOOMED OFF UP THE MARBLE STAIRCASE, LAUGHING INSANELY.

WELL, MOVE ALONG, THEN? SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL SHARPLY  
TO THE REDRAGGED CREED. INTO THE GREAT HALL, CAME HE:  
HARRY, RON AND HERMION SLIPPED AND SLID ACROSS THE  
ENTRANCE HALL AND THROUGH THE DOUBLE DOORS ON THE RIGHT, RON  
MUTTERING FLURRIEDLY UNDER HIS BREATH AS HE POLISHED HIS SHINING  
HAIR OFF HIS FACE.

THE GREAT HALL BEEDED ITS USUAL SPLENDID SELF, DECORATED FOR  
THE START-OF-TERM FEAST. GILDED PLATES AND CHIBLITS GLEAMED BY  
THE LIGHT OF HUNDREDS AND HUNDREDS OF CANDLES, FLOATING OVER  
THE TABLES IN MID-AIR. THE FLOOR BEING POLISH TABLES WERE PACKED  
WITH CHATTERING STUDENTS; AT THE TOP OF THE HALL, THE STAFF SAT  
ALONG ONE SIDE OF A FIFTH TABLE, FACING THEIR PUPILS. IT WAS MUCH  
WARMER IN HERE, HARRY, RON AND HERMION WALKED PAST THE

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SLYTHERINS, THE RAVENCLAWS AND THE HUFFLEPUFFS, AND SAT DOWN  
WITH THE REST OF THE GRYFFINDERS AT THE FAR SIDE OF THE HALL, NEXT  
THE NEARLY HEADLESS NICK, THE GRYFFINDER GHOST. PEARLY WHITE  
AND SEMI-TRANSPARENT, NICK WAS DRESSED TONIGHT IN HIS USUAL  
DOUBLET, WITH A PARTICULARLY LARGE RUFF, WHICH SERVED THE USUAL  
PURPOSE OF MAKING EXTRA FESTIVE AND ENSURING THAT HIS HEAD  
DIDN'T Wobble TOO MUCH IN HIS PARTIALLY SEVERED NECK.

GOOD EVENING, HE SAID, BEAMING AT THEM.

SAID WHEN SAID HARRY, TAKING OFF HIS TRAINERS AND EMPTYING  
THEM OF WATER. THEN THEY FILLED UP WITH THE SIPPING, I'M  
STARVING.

THE SIPPING OF THE NEW STUDENTS INTO THE HALLS THERE PLACE AT

THE START OF EVERY SCHOOL YEAR, BUT BY AN UNLUCKY COMBINATION  
OF CIRCUMSTANCES, HARRY HADN'T BEEN PRESENT AT HOME SINCE HIS  
BORN, HE WAS WHITE WEDDING FORWARD THE IT.

JUST THEN, A HIGHLY EXCITED, BREATHELESS VEHICLE CALLED DOWN THE  
TABLE, HIDA, HARRY?

IT WAS CELIN CREEPER, A THIRD-YEAR THE WHEN HARRY WAS SOME-  
THING OF A HERO.

HI, CELIN, SAID HARRY WARILY.

HARRY, GUESS WHAT? GUESS WHAT, HARRY? MY BROTHER'S START-  
ING! MY BROTHER DENNIS!

ER GOOD, SAID HARRY.

HE'S REALLY EXCITED! SAID CELIN, PRACTICALLY BULGING UP AND

DOWN IN HIS SEAT. I JUST HOPE HE'S IN GRYFFINDOR! KEEP YOUR FIN-  
GERS CROSSED, HI, HARRY?

ER YEAH, ALL RIGHT, SAID HARRY. HE TURNED BACK THE  
HERMIONE, RON AND NEARLY HEADLESS NICK, BROTHERS AND SISTERS  
USUALLY GO IN THE SAME HOUSES, DON'T THEY? HE SAID, HE WAS  
JUDGING BY THE WEASLEYS, ALL SEVEN OF THEM HAD BEEN PUT INTO  
GRYFFINDOR.

HEY, NOT NECESSARILY, SAID HERMIONE. PARVATI PATIL'S TWIN S  
IN RAVENCLAW, AND THEY'RE IDENTICAL, YOU'D THINK THEY'D BE

TOGETHER, WHEN I TALK

HARRY LOOKED UP AT THE STAFF TABLE. THERE SEEMED TO BE RATHER

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MORE EMPTY SEATS THERE THAN USUAL. HAGRID, OF COURSE, WAS STILL FIGHTING HIS WAY ACROSS THE LAKE WITH THE FIRST-YEARS. PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL WAS PRESUMABLY SUPERVISING THE DRYING OF THE ENTRANCE HALL FLOOR, BUT THERE WAS ANOTHER EMPTY CHAIR, THEN, AND HE COULDN'T THINK WHO ELSE WAS MISSING.

WHERE'S THE NEW DEFENCE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS TEACHER? SAID HERMIONE, WHO WAS ALSO LOOKING UP AT THE TEACHERS. THEY HAD NEVER YET HAD A DEFENCE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS TEACHER WHO HAD LASTED MORE THAN THREE TERMS. HARRY'S FAVORITE BY FAR HAD BEEN PROFESSOR LUPIN, WHO HAD RESIGNED LAST YEAR. HE LOOKED UP AND DOWN THE STAFF TABLE. THERE WAS DEFINITELY NO NEW FACE THERE.

MAYBE THEY COULDN'T GET ANYONE? SAID HERMIONE, LOOKING ANXIOUS.

HARRY SCANNED THE TABLE MORE CAREFULLY. TINY LITTLE PROFESSOR FLITWICK, THE CHARM TEACHER, WAS SITTING IN A LARGE PILE OF CUSHIONS BESIDE PROFESSOR SPRITZ, THE HERBLOGY TEACHER, WHOSE HAT WAS ASKED OVER HER ALWAYS GREY HAIR. SHE WAS TALKING TO PROFESSOR SINISTRA OF THE ASTRONOMY DEPARTMENT. IN

PROFESSOR SINISTRA'S OTHER SIDE WAS THE SLEEK-FACED, FINE-NEESED, GREASY-HAired POTION MASTER, SNAPE. HARRY'S LEAST

FAVOURITE PERSON AT HOGWARTS, HARRY'S HATRED OF SNAPE WAS MATCHED ONLY BY SNAPE'S HATRED OF HIM, A HATRED WHICH HAD, IF POSSIBLE, INTENSIFIED LAST YEAR, WHEN HARRY HAD HELPED SIRIUS ESCAPE RIGHT UNDER SNAPE'S EVERLARGE NOSE. SNAPE AND SIRIUS HAD BEEN ENEMIES SINCE THEIR ELN SCHELDAYS.

ON SNAPE'S OTHER SIDE WAS AN EMPTY SEAT, WHICH HARRY GUESSED WAS PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL'S, NEXT TO IT, AND IN THE VERY CENTRE OF THE TABLE, SAT PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE, THE HEADMASTER, HIS SWEEPING SILVER HAIR AND BEARD SHINING IN THE CANDLELIGHT, HIS MAGNIFICENT DEEP-GREEN ROBES EMBROIDERED WITH MANY STARS AND MOONS. THE TIPS OF DUMBLEDORE'S LONG, THIN FINGERS WERE TOGETHER AND HE WAS RESTING HIS CHIN UPON THEM, STARING UP AT THE CEILING THROUGH HIS HALF-MOON SPECTACLES AS THOUGH LOST IN THOUGHT. HARRY GLANCED UP AT THE CEILING, THEN. IT WAS ENCHANTED

LIKE HARRY REMEMBERED

THE LOOK LIKE THE SKY OUTSIDE, AND HE HAD NEVER SEEN IT LOOK THIS STORMY, BLACK AND PURPLE CLOUDS WERE SWIRLING ACROSS IT, AND AS ANOTHER THUNDERCLAP SHOOK OUTSIDE, A FLASH OF LIGHTNING FLASHED ACROSS IT.

HE, HARRY UP, BEEN MEANT, BESIDE HARRY, I COULD EAT A HIPPOGRIP.

THE WORDS WERE NOT SPOKEN BUT OF HIS MOUTH THAN THE OTHERS OF THE GREAT HALL OPENED, AND SILENCE FELL. PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL WAS LEADING A LONG LINE OF FIRST-YEARS UP THE THE TOP OF THE HALL. IF HARRY, RON AND HERMION WERE WET, IT WAS NOTHING THE FEEL THESE FIRST-YEARS LOOKED, THEY APPEARED THE HAVE

SWIM ACROSS THE LAKE RATHER THAN SAILING. ALL OF THEM WERE  
SHIVERING WITH A COMBINATION OF COLD AND NERVES AS THEY FILED  
ALONG THE STAFF TABLE AND CAME TO A HALT IN A LINE FACING THE REST  
OF THE SCHOOL. ALL OF THEM EXCEPT THE SMALLEST OF THE LOT, A BOY  
WITH MELISSY HAIR, WHO WAS WRAPPED IN WHAT HARRY RECOGNISED  
AS HAGRID'S MEEBESKIN OVERCOAT. THE BOY WAS SEEING HIM THAT  
IT LOOKED AS THOUGH HE WAS DRAPE IN A FLIMSY BLACK MARBLEE.  
HIS SMALL FACE PROTRUDED FROM OVER THE COLLAR, LOOKING ALMOST

PAINFULLY EXCITED. WHEN HE HAD LINED UP WITH HIS TERRIFIED-  
LOOKING PEERS, HE CALIGHT CHLIN CREEVEY'S EYE, GAVE A DELICATE

THUMBS-UP AND MELTHER. I FELL IN THE LAKE! HE LOOKED POSI-  
TIVELY DELIGHTED ABOUT IT.

PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL NOW PLACED A THREE-LEGGED STEEL ON  
THE GREENLAND BEFORE THE FIRST-YEARS AND, ON TOP OF IT, AN EXTREMELY  
OLD, DIRTY, PATCHED WIZARD'S HAT. THE FIRST-YEARS STARED AT IT. SHE  
DID EVERYTHING ELSE, FOR A MOMENT, THERE WAS SILENCE. THEN A  
TEAR NEAR THE BRIM OPENED WIDE LIKE A MOUTH, AND THE HAT  
CROOKED INTO THE SHING!

A THOUSAND YEARS OR MORE AGO,  
WHEN I WAS NEWLY SEEN,  
THERE LIVED SEVERAL WIZARDS OF RENOWN,  
WHOSE NAMES ARE STILL WELL KNOWN:  
KID CROPPINDEN, FROM WILD MEER,

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FAIR RAVENCLAW, FROM GLEN,  
SWEET HUFFLEPUFF, FROM VALLEY BROAD,  
SERPENT SLYTHERIN, FROM PEN,  
THEY SHARED A WISH, A HOPE, A DREAM,  
THEY HATCHED A DARING PLAN  
THE EDUCATE YOUNG SERPENTS  
THIS HOGWARTS SCHOOL BEGAN,  
NOW EACH OF THESE FOUR HOUSES  
FORMED THEIR OWN HOUSE, FOR EACH  
DID VALUE DIFFERENT VIRTUES  
IN THE HONOR THEY HAD THE TEACH,  
BY GRYFFINDOR, THE BRAVEST WERE  
PRIZED FAR BEYOND THE REST;  
FOR RAVENCLAW, THE CLEVEREST  
WOULD ALWAYS BE THE BEST;  
FOR HUFFLEPUFF, HARD WORKERS WERE  
MOST WORTHY OF ADMITTANCE;  
AND POWER-HUNGRY SLYTHERIN  
LOVED THOSE OF GREAT AMBITION,  
WHILE STILL ALIVE THEY DID DIVIDE  
THEIR FAVORITES FROM THE THING,  
BUT HOW TO PICK THE WORTHY HONOR  
WHEN THEY WERE DEAD AND GONE?  
THAT GRYFFINDOR WAS FINDING THE WAY,

HE WHIPPED ME OFF HIS HEAD  
THE PHLOMERS PUT SOME BRAINS IN ME  
SEE I COULD C-HEESE INSTEAD?  
NEEDS SLIP ME SOME ABELT YOUR EARS,  
I VE NEVER YET BEEN WRONG,  
I LL HAVE A LEEDE INSIDE YOUR MIND  
AND TELL WHERE YOU BELONG?

THE GREAT HALL RANG WITH APPLAUSE AS THE SINGING HAT FINISHED.  
THAT S NOT THE SONG IT SANG WHEN IT SINGED US, SAID HARRY,  
CLAPPING ALONG WITH EVERYONE ELSE.

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SINGS A DIFFERENT SONG EVERY YEAR, SAID RON. IT S GIVE THE EE A  
PRETTY SINGING LIFE, HASN T IT, BEING A HAT? I SUPPOSE IT SPENDS ALL  
YEAR MAKING UP THE NEXT SONG.

PROFESSOR McGONAGALL WAS NOW UNROLLING A LARGE SCROLL OF  
PARCHMENT.

WHEN I CALL OUT YOUR NAME, YOU WILL PUT ON THE HAT AND SIT  
ON THE STEEL, SHE TOLD THE FIRST-YEARS. WHEN THE HAT ANNOUNCES  
YOUR HOUSE, YOU WILL GO AND SIT AT THE APPROPRIATE TABLE.

ADDERLEY, STEWART?

A BOY WALKED FORWARD, VISIBLY TREMBLING FROM HEAD TO FEET,  
PICKED UP THE SINGING HAT, PUT IT ON AND SAT DOWN ON THE STEEL.  
RAVENCLAW? SINGED THE HAT.

STEWART ADDERLEY THREW OFF THE HAT AND FLURRIED INTO A SEAT AT  
THE RAVENCLAW TABLE, WHERE EVERYONE WAS APPLAUDING HIM.



HARRY CAUGHT A GLIMPSE OF LEE, THE RAVENCLAW SEEDER, CHEERING STEWART ACKERLEY AS HE SAT DOWN, FOR A FLEETING SECOND,

HARRY HAD A STRANGE DESIRE TO JOIN THE RAVENCLAW TABLE THEN,

RADDICK, MALCOLM?

SLOTHERING?

THE TABLE ON THE OTHER SIDE OF THE HALL ERUPTED WITH CHEERS;

HARRY COULD SEE MALPHY CLAPPING AS RADDICK JOINED THE

SLOTHERINS. HARRY WONDERED WHETHER RADDICK KNEW THAT

SLOTHERING HOUSE HAD TURNED OUT MORE DARK WITCHES AND WIZ-

ARDS THAN ANY OTHER, FRED AND GEORGE HISSED MALCOLM RADDICK

AS HE SAT DOWN,

BRANSTEN, ELEANOR?

HUFFLEPUFF?

CALDWELL, HELEN?

HUFFLEPUFF?

CREEVEY, DENNIS?

TINY DENNIS CREEVEY STAGGERED FORWARD, TRIPPING OVER

HAGRID'S MULESKIN, JUST AS HAGRID HIMSELF SIDLED INTO THE HALL

THROUGH A DOOR BEHIND THE TEACHERS' TABLE, ABOUT TWICE AS TALL

AS A NORMAL MAN, AND AT LEAST THREE TIMES AS BROAD, HAGRID,

WITH HIS LONG, WILD, TANGLED BLACK HAIR AND BEARD, WHEEZED

SLIGHTLY ALARMING. A MISLEADING IMPRESSION, FOR HARRY, RON AND HERMIONE KNEW Hagrid the Professor a VERY KIND NATURE. HE WINKED AT THEM AS HE SAT DOWN AT THE END OF THE STAFF TABLE, AND WATCHED DENNIS CREEVEY PLUTTING HIM THE SHIRTING HAT. THE RIP AT THE BRIM OPENED WIDE.

CROFFINDERS! THE HAT SCHELTED.

Hagrid clapped along with the Croffinders, as DENNIS CREEVEY, BEAMING WIDELY, THREW OFF THE HAT, PLACED IT BACK ON THE STICK, AND FLURRIED HIMSELF WITH HIS KITCHEN.

HELLO, I FELL IN! HE SAID STIRILLY, THREELING HIMSELF INTO AN EMPTY SEAT. IT WAS BRILLIANT! AND SOMETHING IN THE WATER GRABBED ME AND PULSED ME BACK IN THE HAT!

HELLO! SAID HELLO, JUST AS EXCITEDLY. IT WAS PROBABLY THE GIANT HELLO, DENNIS!

WELL! SAID DENNIS, AS THOUGH NERVOUS IN THEIR WILDEST

DREAMS CHILD FEAR FOR MORE THAN BEING THREELIN INTO A STORM-THESSED, FATHOMS-DEEP LAKE, AND PULSED HELT HE IT AGAIN BY A

GIANT SEA-MINSTER.

DENNIS! DENNIS! SEE THAT KID DOWN THERE? THE ONE WITH THE BLACK HAIR AND GLASSES? SEE HIM? KNOW WHEN HE IS, DENNIS? HARRY LEANED AWAY, STARING VERY HARD AT THE SHIRTING HAT, WHEN SHIRTING EMMA DEERS.

THE SHIRTING CONTINUED; BOYS AND GIRLS WITH VARYING DEGREES OF FRIGHT ON THEIR FACES MOVING, ONE BY ONE, TO THE THREE-LEGGED STICK, THE LINE DWINDLING SLOWLY AS PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL

PASSED THE £ 5.

HEY, HURRY UP, REHN MEANED, MASSAGING HIS STOMACH.

WELL, REHN, THE SHIRTING IS MUCH MORE IMPORTANT THAN FOOD,  
SAID NEARLY HEADLESS NICK, AS MADLEY, LALIRA? BECAME A  
FLAPFLAP.

WHOSE IT IS, IF YOU'RE DEAD, SNAPPED REHN.

I DO HOPE THIS YEAR'S BATCH OF GRYFFINDERS ARE UP THE SCRATCH,  
SAID NEARLY HEADLESS NICK, APPLAUDING AS MCDONALD, NATALIE?  
THINED THE GRYFFINDER TABLE. WE DON'T WANT THE BREAD MILL  
WINNING STREAK, DO WE?

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GRYFFINDER HAD WON THE INTER-HOUSE CHAMPIONSHIP FOR THE  
LAST THREE YEARS IN A ROW.

PRITCHARD, GRAHAM?

SLYTHERIN?

HUFFLEPUFF?

RAVENCLAW?

AND FINALLY, WITH WHITEY, KEVIN? (FLAPFLAP) THE SHIRTING  
ENDED. PROFESSOR MCDONALD PICKED UP THE HAT AND THE STEEL,  
AND CARRIED THEM AWAY.

ABOUT TIME, SAID REHN, SEIZING HIS KNIFE AND FORK AND LEAN-  
ING EXPECTANTLY AT HIS GILDED PLATE.

PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE HAD GET TO HIS FEET. HE WAS SMILING  
AROUND AT THE STUDENTS, HIS ARMS SPREAD WIDE IN WELCOME.

I HAVE ONLY TWO WORDS TO SAY TO YOU, HE TOLD THEM, HIS DEEP  
VOICE ECHOING AROUND THE HALL. TUCK IN.

HEAR, HEAR! SAID HARRY AND BEN LILIBLY, AS THE EMPTY DISHES  
FILLED MAGICALLY BEFORE THEIR EYES.

NEARLY HEADLESS NICK WATCHED MEELINGLY AS HARRY, BEN  
AND FERMINE LOADED THEIR PLATES.

AHH, AT SERVE, SAID BEN, WITH HIS MOUTH FULL HE MASHED  
POTATOE.

YOU'RE LUCKY THERE'S A FEAST AT ALL TONIGHT, YOU KNOW, SAID

NEARLY HEADLESS NICK. THERE WAS TROUBLE IN THE KITCHENS EAR-  
LIER.

WHAT WAS IT? SAID HARRY, THROUGH A SIZEABLE CHUNK  
OF STEAK.

POOR, HE CHUCKED, SAID NEARLY HEADLESS NICK, SHAKING HIS  
HEAD, WHICH WHEELED DANGEROUSLY. HE PULLED HIS RUFF A LITTLE

HIGHER UP HIS NECK. THE USUAL ARGUMENT, YOU KNOW, HE WANT-  
ED TO ATTEND THE FEAST WELL, IT'S WHITE HOT FOR THE ELDEST, YOU

KNOW WHAT HE'S LIKE, LITTERALLY LINCIVILISED, CAN'T SEE A PLATE OF  
FOOD WITHOUT THROWING IT. WE HAD A GUESTS CHURCH THE FAT  
PRIAR WAS ALL FOR GIVING HIM THE CHANCE BUT MEET WISLY, IN  
MY OPINION, THE BLEEDY BAREN PUT HIS FEET DOWN.

THE BLEEDY BAREN WAS THE SLOTHFUL GUEST, A CALM AND

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SILENT SPECTRE CLOVERED IN SILVER BLEEDSTAINS, HE WAS THE ONLY PERSON AT HEGWARTS WHO COULD REALLY CONTROL PEEVES.

YEAH, WE THOUGHT PEEVES SEEMED HACKED OFF ABOUT SOMETHING, SAID BEN DABLY, SEE WHAT DID HE DO IN THE KITCHENS?

EH, THE USUAL, SAID NEARLY HEADLESS NICK, SPINNING, WRECKED FAYNE AND MAYHEM, POTS AND PANS EVERYWHERE, PLAC SWIMMING IN SEULP, TERRIFIED THE HELLSE-FLVES HLT HP THEIR WITS CLANG, HERMIONE HAD KNICKED OVER HER GOLDEN CHALKET, PLIMBIN ILIKE SPREAD STEADILY OVER THE TABLETTH, STAINING SEVERAL FEET HP WHITE LINEN HIRANGE, BUT HERMIONE PAID NH ATTENTION.

THERE ARE HELLSE-FLVES HERE? SHE SAID, STARING, FERRRR-STOLICK, AT NEARLY HEADLESS NICK, HERE AT HEGWARTS?

CERTAINLY, SAID NEARLY HEADLESS NICK, LEENING SURPRISED AT HER REACTION, THE LARGEST NUMBER IN ANY DWELLING IN BRITAIN, I BELIEVE, EVER A HUNDRED.

I VE NEVER SEEN HNE? SAID HERMIONE.

WELL, THEY HARDLY EVER LEAVE THE KITCHEN BY DAY, DO THEY? SAID NEARLY HEADLESS NICK, THEY COME HLT AT NIGHT TH DO A KIT HP CLEANING ... SEE TH THE FIRES AND SEE HN ... I MEAN, YEL RE NOT SUPPOSED TH SEE THEM, ARE YEL? THAT S THE MARK HP A GOOD HELLSE-FL, LEN T IT, THAT YEL BEEN T DONE IT S THERE?

HERMIONE STARED AT HIM.

BUT THEY GET PAID? SHE SAID, THEY GET HOLIDAYS, DEN T THEY?

AND AND SICK LEAVE, AND PENSIVENS AND EVERYTHING?

NEARLY HEADLESS NICK CHORTLED SEE MUCH THAT HIS RUFF SLIPPED  
AND HIS HEAD FLEPPED OFF, DANGLING IN THE INCH OR SEE OF CHESTLY  
SKIN AND MUSCLE THAT STILL ATTACKED IT THE HIS NECK.

SICK LEAVE AND PENSIVENS? HE SAID, PUSHING HIS HEAD BACK  
BENTH HIS SHOULDERS AND SECURING IT ONCE MORE WITH HIS RUFF.

HELISE-EVES WHEN T WANT SICK LEAVE AND PENSIVENS?

FERMIENE LEANED DOWN AT HER HARDLY THICKED PLATE OF FEED,  
THEN PLUT HER KNIFE AND FORK DOWN UPON IT AND PUSHED IT AWAY  
FROM HER.

EH, I MEAN, ER-MY-DONER, SAID REN, ACCIDENTALLY SPRAYING

LET HARRY PETER

HARRY WITH KITS OF VERDASHIRE PLIDDING, EEP'S SHRY, ARRY  
HE SWALLOWED, WHY WHEN T GET THEM SICK LEAVE BY STARVING  
THEMSELVES?

SLAVE LABELER, SAID FERMIENE, BREATHING HARD THROUGH HER  
NOSE. THAT S WHAT MADE THIS DINNER, SLAVE LABELER,  
AND SHE REPLIED THE CAT ANOTHER KITE.

THE RAIN WAS STILL DRUMMING HEAVILY AGAINST THE HIGH, DARK  
WINDHILLS, ANOTHER CLAP OF THUNDER SMASHED THE WINDHILLS, AND  
THE STORMY CEILING FLASHED, ILLUMINATING THE CHILDEN PLATES AS  
THE REMAINS OF THE FIRST CHURSE VANISHED AND WERE REPLACED,  
INSTANTLY, WITH PLIDDINGS.

TREACLE TART, FERMIENE? SAID REN, DELIBERATELY WAFTING ITS  
SMELL TOWARDS HER. SPOTTED DICK, LEED? CHOCOLATE CATEAL?  
BUT FERMIENE GAVE HIM A LEED SHE REMINISCENT OF PROFESSOR

McGONAGALL THAT HE GAVE UP.

WHEN THE PLIDDINGS, THEN, HAD BEEN DEMILISHED, AND THE LAST CRUMPS HAD FADED OFF THE PLATES, LEAVING THEM SPARKLING CLEAN, ALBUS DUMBLEDORE GOT TO HIS FEET AGAIN. THE BUZZ OF CHATTER FILLING THE HALL CEASED ALMOST AT ONCE, SO THAT ONLY THE FEEBLY WIND AND PELINDING RAIN COULD BE HEARD.

SHE SAID DUMBLEDORE, SMILING AROUND AT THEM ALL. WHEN THAT WE ARE ALL FED AND WATERED (IMPET SAID FERMINE), I MUST ENCE MEER ASK FOR YOUR ATTENTION, WHILE I GIVE OUT A FEW NOTICES.

MUR FICH, THE CARETAKER, HAS ASKED ME TO TELL YOU THAT THE LIST OF OBJECTS SEQUESTERED INSIDE THE CASTLE HAS THIS YEAR BEEN EXTENDED TO INCLUDE SCREAMING YEE-YEES, FANGED FRISKEES AND EVER-BLASTING BOMBERANGES. THE FULL LIST COMPRISES SOME FOUR HUNDRED AND THIRTY-SEVEN ITEMS, I BELIEVE, AND CAN BE VIEWED IN MUR FICH'S OFFICE, IF ANYBODY WOULD LIKE TO CHECK IT.

THE CORNERS OF DUMBLEDORE'S MOUTH TWITCHED.

HE CONTINUED, AS EVER, I WOULD LIKE TO REMIND YOU ALL THAT THE FOREST IN THE GREENS IS OUT-OF-BOUNDS TO STUDENTS, AS IS THE VILLAGE OF HOGSMOAR TO ALL BELOW THIRD YEAR.

IT IS ALSO MY PAINFUL DUTY TO INFORM YOU THAT THE INTER-HOUSE

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ELUDDITCH CUP WILL NOT TAKE PLACE THIS YEAR.

WHAT? HARRY GASPED, HE LOOKED AROUND AT FRED AND GEORGE, HIS FELLOW MEMBERS OF THE ELUDDITCH TEAM. THEY WERE MOUTHING SILENTLY AT DUMBLEDORE, APPARENTLY THEY APPALLED

THE SPREAD.

DUMBLEDORE CONTINUED, 'THIS IS ONE OF THE AN EVENT THAT WILL BE STARTING IN OCTOBER, AND CONTINUING THROUGHOUT THE SCHOOL YEAR, TAKING UP MUCH OF THE TEACHERS' TIME AND ENERGY BUT I AM SURE YOU WILL ALL ENJOY IT IMMENSELY. I HAVE GREAT PLEASURE IN ANNOUNCING THAT THIS YEAR AT HOGWARTS

BUT AT THAT MOMENT, THERE WAS A DEAFENING RUMBLE OF THUNDER, AND THE DOORS OF THE GREAT HALL RANGED OPEN.

A MAN STOOD IN THE DOORWAY, LEANING UPON A LONG STAFF, SHROUDED IN A BLACK TRAVELLING CLOAK. EVERY HEAD IN THE GREAT

HALL SWIVELLED TOWARDS THE STRANGER, SUDDENLY BRIGHTLY ILLUMINATED BY A FLASH OF LIGHTNING THAT FLASHED ACROSS THE CEILING. HE

LOWELED HIS HEAD, SHOWING BUT A LONG MAN OF GRIZZLED, DARK GREY HAIR, THEN BEGAN THE WALK UP TOWARDS THE TEACHERS' TABLE.

A DULL CLUNK REHEARD THROUGH THE HALL WHEN HIS EVERY OTHER STEP, HE REACHED THE END OF THE TEACH TABLE, TURNED RIGHT AND

LIMPED HEAVILY TOWARDS DUMBLEDORE. ANOTHER FLASH OF LIGHTNING CROSSED THE CEILING. HERMION GRASPED,

THE LIGHTNING HAD THROWN THE MAN'S FACE INTO SHARP RELIEF, AND IT WAS A FACE LIKE ANY HARRY HAD EVER SEEN. IT LOOKED AS THOUGH IT HAD BEEN CARVED OUT OF WEATHERED WOOD BY SOMEONE



WHICH HAD ONLY THE VAGUEST IDEA OF WHAT HUMAN FACES WERE  
SUPPOSED TO LOOK LIKE, AND WAS NEITHER SKILLED WITH A CHISEL.  
EVERY INCH OF SKIN SEEMED TO BE SCARRED. THE MOUTH LOOKED  
LIKE A DIAGONAL GASH, AND A LARGE CHINK OF THE NOSE WAS MISS-  
ING. BUT IT WAS THE MAN'S EYES THAT MADE HIM FRIGHTENING.

ONE OF THEM WAS SMALL, DARK AND DEADLY. THE OTHER WAS LARGE,  
REELING AS A CHIN, AND A VIVID, ELECTRIC BLUE. THE BLUE EYE WAS  
MOVING CEASELESSLY, WITHOUT BLINKING, AND WAS REELING UP,  
DOWN AND FROM SIDE TO SIDE, ALONE INDEPENDENTLY OF THE NORMAL  
EYE AND THEN IT REELLED RIGHT OVER, POINTING INTO THE BACK OF THE

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MAN'S HEAD, SO THAT ALL THEY COULD SEE WAS WHITENESS.  
THE STRANGER REACHED DUMBLEDORE. HE STRETCHED OUT A HAND  
THAT WAS AS BADLY SCARRED AS HIS FACE, AND DUMBLEDORE SEIZED IT,  
MUTTERING WORDS HARRY COULDN'T HEAR. HE SEEMED TO BE MAKING  
SOME ENQUIRY OF THE STRANGER, WHO SEIZED HIS HEAD UNWILLINGLY  
AND REPLIED IN AN UNDERTONE. DUMBLEDORE NODDED, AND  
GESTURED THE MAN TO THE EMPTY SEAT ON HIS RIGHT-HAND SIDE.  
THE STRANGER SAT DOWN, SEIZING HIS MANK OF DARK GREY HAIR WITH  
OF HIS FACE, PULLED A PLATE OF SALISAGES TOWARDS HIM, RAISED IT TO  
WHAT WAS LEFT OF HIS NOSE AND SNIPPED IT. HE THEN TOOK A SMALL  
KNIFE WITH OF HIS POCKET, SPEARED A SALISAGE ON THE END OF IT, AND  
BEGAN TO EAT. HIS NORMAL EYE WAS FIXED UPON THE SALISAGES, BUT  
THE BLUE EYE WAS STILL DARTING RESTLESSLY AROUND IN ITS SHEATH,

TAKING IN THE HALL AND THE STUDENTS.

MAY I INTRODUCE OUR NEW DEFENCE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS  
TEACHER, SAID DUMBLEDORE BRIGHTLY, INTO THE SILENCE. PROFESSOR  
MURPHY.

IT WAS USUAL FOR NEW STAFF MEMBERS TO BE GREETED WITH  
APPLAUSE, BUT NONE OF THE STAFF OR STUDENTS CLAPPED EXCEPT  
DUMBLEDORE AND FLORIO. BOTH PUT THEIR HANDS TOGETHER AND  
APPLAUDED, BUT THE SOUND ECHOED DISMALLY INTO THE SILENCE, AND

THEY STOPPED FAIRLY QUICKLY. EVERYONE ELSE SEEMED TO BE TRANS-  
FIXED BY MURPHY'S BIZARRE APPEARANCE TO BE MORE THAN STARE AT  
HIM.

MURPHY? HARRY MUTTERED TO RON. MAD-EYE MURPHY? THE ONE  
WHOSE DAD WENT TO HELL THIS MORNING?

MUST BE, SAID RON, IN A LOW, ALONE VOICE.

WHAT HAPPENED TO HIM? HERMIONA WHISPERED. WHAT  
HAPPENED TO HIS FACE?

DURING, RON WHISPERED BACK, WATCHING MURPHY WITH  
FASCINATION.

MURPHY SEEMED TOTALLY INDIFFERENT TO HIS LESS-THAN-WARM  
WELCOME. IGNORING THE ILK OF PLIMPSON ILK IN FRONT OF HIM, HE  
REACHED AGAIN INTO HIS TRAVELLING CLOAK, PULLED OUT A HIP-FLASK,  
AND TOOK A LONG DRINK FROM IT. AS HE LIFTED HIS ARM TO DRINK,

THE TRILIZARD THELPHORANT LIES

HIS CLOAK WAS PULLED A FEW INCHES FROM THE GROUND, AND HARRY

SAW, BEHIND THE TABLE, SEVERAL INCHES OF CARVED WOODEN LEG,  
ENDING IN A CLAWED FOOT,

DUMBLEDOORE CLEARED HIS THROAT AGAIN,

AS I WAS SAYING, HE SAID, SMILING AT THE SEA OF STUDENTS

BEFORE HIM, ALL OF WHOM WERE STILL GAZING TRANSFIXED AT MAD-  
LYR MURPHY, WE ARE TO HAVE THE HONOUR OF HOSTING A VERY

EXCITING EVENT OVER THE COMING MONTHS, AN EVENT WHICH HAS  
NEVER BEEN HELD BEFORE EVER A CENTURY. IT IS MY VERY GREAT PLEASURE THE  
INFORM YOU THAT THE TRIWIZARD TOURNAMENT WILL BE TAKING PLACE  
AT HOGWARTS THIS YEAR.

YOU'RE JOKING! SAID FRED WEASLEY LUDIBLY,

THE TENSION THAT HAD FILLED THE HALL EVER SINCE MURPHY'S  
ARRIVAL SUDDENLY BROKE.

NEARLY EVERYONE LAUGHED, AND DUMBLEDOORE CHUCKLED APPRE-  
CIATIVELY,

I AM NOT JOKING, MR WEASLEY, HE SAID, THOUGH, NOW YOU  
MENTION IT, I DID HEAR AN EXCELLENT ONE OVER THE SLIPPER ABOUT  
A TREE, A HOG AND A REPTILIAN WHEN ALL GET INTO A BAR  
PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL CLEARED HER THROAT LUDIBLY,

ER BUT MAYBE THIS IS NOT THE TIME ... NEH ... SAID

DUMBLEDOORE, WHERE WAS I AH YES, THE TRIWIZARD TOURNAMENT  
... WELL, SOME OF YOU WILL NOT KNOW WHAT THIS TOURNAMENT  
INVOLVES, SO I HOPE THOSE WHO DO KNOW WILL PROTECT ME FROM

GIVING A SHORT EXPLANATION, AND ALLOW THEIR ATTENTION TO WANDER FREELY.

THE TRIWIZARD TOURNAMENT WAS FIRST ESTABLISHED SOME SEVEN HUNDRED YEARS AGO, AS A FRIENDLY COMPETITION BETWEEN THE THREE LARGEST EUROPEAN SCHOOLS OF WIZARDRY HOGWARTS, BEAUXBATONS AND DUMSTRANG. A CHAMPION WAS SELECTED TO REPRESENT EACH SCHOOL, AND THE THREE CHAMPIONS COMPETED IN THREE MAGICAL TASKS. THE SCHOOLS TOOK IT IN TURNS TO HOST THE TOURNAMENT SINCE EVERY FIVE YEARS, AND IT WAS GENERALLY AGREED THAT A MOST EXCELLENT WAY OF ESTABLISHING TIES BETWEEN YOUNG WITCHES AND WIZARDS OF DIFFERENT NATIONALITIES UNTIL, THAT IS, THE DEATH TELL

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MENTED SHE HIGH THAT THE TOURNAMENT WAS DISCONTINUED.

DEATH TELL? HERMIONE WHISPERED, LOOKING ALARMED, BUT HER ANXIETY DID NOT SEEM TO BE SHARED BY THE MAJORITY OF STUDENTS IN THE HALL; MANY OF THEM WERE WHISPERING EXCITEDLY WITH EACH OTHER, AND HARRY HIMSELF WAS FAR MORE INTERESTED IN HEARING MORE ABOUT THE TOURNAMENT THAN IN WHISPERING ABOUT DEATHS THAT HAD HAPPENED HUNDREDS OF YEARS AGO.

THERE HAVE BEEN SEVERAL ATTEMPTS OVER THE CENTURIES TO RE-INSTATE THE TOURNAMENT, DUMBLEDORE CONTINUED, NONE OF WHICH

HAVE BEEN VERY SUCCESSFUL. HOWEVER, OUR NEW DEPARTMENTS OF INTERNATIONAL MAGICAL COOPERATION AND MAGICAL GAMES AND SPORTS HAVE DECIDED THE TIME IS RIFE FOR ANOTHER ATTEMPT. WE

HAVE WORKED HARD OVER THE SUMMER TO ENSURE THAT, THIS TIME, THE CHAMPION WILL FIND HIMSELF OR HERSELF IN MORTAL DANGER.

THE HEADS OF BEALBATHENS AND DUMSTRANE WILL BE ARRIVING WITH THEIR SHORT-LISTED CONTENDERS IN OCTOBER, AND THE SELECTION OF THE THREE CHAMPIONS WILL TAKE PLACE AT FALLELE EN. AN IMPARTIAL JUDGE WILL DECIDE WHICH STUDENTS ARE MOST WORTHY TO COMPETE FOR THE TRIWIZARD CUP, THE GLORY OF THEIR SCHOOL, AND A THOUSAND GALLEONS PERSONAL PRIZE MONEY.

I M GUESSING FOR IT! FRED WEASLEY HISSSED DOWN THE TABLE, HIS FACE LIT WITH ENTHUSIASM AT THE PROSPECT OF SUCH GLORY AND

RICHES. HE WAS NOT THE ONLY PERSON WHO SEEMED TO BE VISUALISING THEMSELVES AS HOGWARTS CHAMPION. AT EVERY HOUSE TABLE,

HARRY COULD SEE PEOPLE EITHER GAZING RAPTLY AT DUMBLEDORE, OR ELSE WHISPERING FERVENTLY TO THEIR NEIGHBOURS. BUT THEN DUMBLEDORE SPOKE AGAIN, AND THE HALL QUIETENED ONCE MORE.

LAGER THOUGH I KNOW ALL OF YOU WILL BE THE KING THE

TRIWIZARD CUP THE HOGWARTS, HE SAID, THE HEADS OF THE PARTICIPATING SCHOOLS, ALONG WITH THE MINISTRY OF MAGIC, HAVE AGREED

THE IMPOSE AN AGE RESTRICTION ON CONTENDERS THIS YEAR. ONLY STUDENTS WHO ARE OF AGE THAT IS THE SAY, SEVENTEEN YEARS OR

OLDER WILL BE ALLOWED TO PUT FORWARD THEIR NAMES FOR CONSIDERATION. THIS DUMBLEDORE RAISED HIS VOICE SLIGHTLY, FOR

SEVERAL PEOPLE HAD MADE NOISES OF MISTRUST AT THESE WORDS, AND

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THE LEASLEY TWINS WERE SUDDENLY LEAVING FLURRIES IS A  
MEASURE WE FEEL IS NECESSARY, GIVEN THAT THE THERIOLOGIST TASKS  
WILL STILL BE DIFFICULT AND DANGEROUS, WHATEVER PRECAUTIONS WE  
TAKE, AND IT IS HIGHLY UNLIKELY THAT STUDENTS ELEVEN SIXTH AND  
SEVENTH YEAR WILL BE ABLE TO Cope WITH THEM. I WILL PERSONALLY  
BE ENSURING THAT NO UNDERAGE STUDENT FOLLOWS HIS IMPARTIAL  
JUDGE INTO MAKING THEM FROGLARTS CHAMPION. HIS LIGHT-BLUE  
EYES TWINKLED AS THEY FLICKERED OVER FRED AND GEORGE'S MULTICOLORED  
FACES. I THEREFORE REGRET THAT THE WASTE OF YOUR TIME ADMITTING  
YOURSELF IF YOU ARE UNDER SEVENTEEN.

THE DELEGATIONS FROM REALMATHENS AND DUMSTRANG WILL BE  
ARRIVING IN EITHER, AND REMAINING WITH US FOR THE GREATER PART  
OF THIS YEAR. I KNOW THAT YOU WILL ALL EXTEND EVERY COURTESY TO  
YOUR FOREIGN GUESTS WHILE THEY ARE WITH US, AND WILL GIVE YOUR  
WELL-MEANING SUPPORT TO THE FROGLARTS CHAMPION WHEN HE OR  
SHE IS SELECTED. AND NOW, IT IS LATE, AND I KNOW HOW IMPORTANT  
IT IS THAT YOU ALL BE ALERT AND RESTED AS YOU ENTER YOUR LESSONS  
TOMORROW MORNING. BEDTIME! CHUP CHUP!

DUMPLEDOORE SAT DOWN AGAIN AND TURNED THE TALK TO MAD-POY  
MEHNDY. THERE WAS A GREAT SCRAPING AND BANGING AS ALL THE  
STUDENTS GOT TO THEIR FEET, AND SWARMED TOWARDS THE DELICATE  
DOORS INTO THE ENTRANCE HALL.

THEY CAN'T SEE THAT! SAID GEORGE LEASLEY, WHO HAD NOT

HEARD THE CROWD MOVING TOWARDS THE DOOR, BUT WAS STANDING UP AND CLARING AT DUMBLEDORE. WE'RE SEVENTEEN IN APRIL, WHY CAN'T WE HAVE A SECT?

THEY'RE NOT STOPPING ME ENTERING, SAID FRED STUBBORNLY, ALSO SCHEMING AT THE THIRTABLE. THE CHAMPIONS WILL GET THE ONE ALL SORTS OF STUFF THEY'D NEVER BE ALLOWED THE ONE NORMALLY, AND A THOUSAND GALLEONS PRIZE MONEY?

YES, SAID RON, A FARAWAY LOOK ON HIS FACE. YES, A THOUSAND GALLEONS ...

COME ON, SAID HERMION, WE WILL BE THE ONLY ONES LEFT HERE IF THEY DON'T MOVE.

HARRY, RON, HERMION, FRED AND GEORGE SET OFF FOR THE

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ENTRANCE HALL, FRED AND GEORGE DEBATING THE WAYS IN WHICH DUMBLEDORE MIGHT STOP THOSE WHO WERE UNDER SEVENTEEN ENTERING THE TOURNAMENT.

WHICH IS THIS IMPARTIAL JUDGE WHO IS GOING TO DECIDE WHICH THE CHAMPIONS ARE? SAID HARRY.

DUNN, SAID FRED, BUT IT IS THEM WHO WILL HAVE THE FINAL, I RECKON A LITTLE OF DROPS OF AGING POTION MIGHT DO IT, GEORGE ...

DUMBLEDORE KNOWS THEY'RE NOT OF AGE, HOWEVER, SAID RON.

YES, BUT HE IS NOT THE ONE WHO DECIDES WHICH THE CHAMPION IS, IS HE? SAID FRED STUBBORNLY. SOUNDS TO ME LIKE WHEN THIS JUDGE KNOWS WHO WANTS TO ENTER, HE WILL CHOOSE THE BEST FROM

EACH SCHEM AND NEVER MIND HOW OLD THEY ARE, DUMKLEBERRY'S TRYING THE STEP WAS GIVING HIM NAMES.

PEOPLE HAVE DIED, THERLIGH SAID FIRMLY IN A WHIRLED VEHICLE, AS THEY WALKED THROUGH A DOOR CREAKED BEHIND A TAPESTRY AND STARTED UP ANOTHER, NARROWER STAIRCASE.

YEAH, SAID FRED AIRILY, BUT THAT WAS YEARS AGO, WASN'T IT? ANYWAY, WHERE'S THE PLAN WITHOUT A BIT OF RISK? ERY, RENN, WHAT IF WE FIND HIM HOW THE GET BEHIND DUMKLEBERRY? FANCY ENTERING?

WHAT'D YOU RECKON? RENN ASKED HARRY. BE CAUTIOUS THE ENTER, WOULDNT IT? BUT I'VE FEEL THEY MIGHT WANT SOMEONE ELDER ... BLIND IF WE'VE LEARNT ENOUGH ...

I DEFINITELY HAVEN'T, CAME NEVILLE'S CLEVER VEHICLE FROM BEHIND FRED AND GEORGE. I EXPECT MY GRAND WANT ME THE TRY,

THOUGH, SHE'S ALWAYS GOING ON ABOUT HOW I SHOULD BE UPHELD-ING THE FAMILY HONOUR, I'LL JUST HAVE THE ...

NEVILLE'S FEET HAD SLID RIGHT THROUGH A STEP HALFWAY UP THE STAIRCASE. THERE WERE MANY OF THESE TRICK STAIRS AT HOGWARTS; IT WAS SECOND NATURE THE MOST OF THE ELDER STUDENTS THE JUMP THIS PARTICULAR STEP, BUT NEVILLE'S MEMORY WAS NEVERTHELESS POOR. HARRY AND RENN SEIZED HIM UNDER THE ARMPITS AND PULLED HIM UP, WHILE A SLIT OF ARMOUR AT THE TOP OF THE STAIRS CREAKED AND CLANKED, LAUGHING WHEEZILY.

SHUT IT, YELL, SAID RENN, BANGING DOWN ITS VISOR AS THEY PASSED.



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THEY MADE THEIR WAY UP THE ENTRANCE THE CRYPTIDDER

THEIR, WHICH WAS CONCEALED BEHIND A LARGE PORTRAIT OF A FAT  
LADY IN A PINK SILK DRESS.

PASSWORD? SHE SAID, AS THEY APPROACHED.

KALDERDASH, SAID GEORGE, A PERFECT DREAMSTAIRS TOLD ME.

THE PORTRAIT SWINGING AHEADS THEY REVEAL A HOLE IN THE WALL,  
THROUGH WHICH THEY ALL CLIMBED. A CRACKLING FIRE WAS WARMING

THE CIRCULAR CHIMNEY ROOM, WHICH WAS FULL OF SELESTY ARM-  
CHAIRS AND TABLES. HERMIONE CAST THE MERRILY DANCING FLAMES A

DARK LOOK, AND HARRY DISTINCTLY HEARD HER MUTTER SLAVE LABELER ,  
BEFORE KIDDING THEM GOODNIGHT, AND DISAPPEARING THROUGH THE  
DORWAY THE GIRLS DORMITORIES.

HARRY, RON AND NEVILLE CLIMBED UP THE LAST, SPIRAL STAIRCASE  
UNTIL THEY REACHED THEIR OWN DORMITORY, WHICH WAS SITUATED AT  
THE TOP OF THE TOWER. FIVE VELVET-UPHOLSTERED BEDS WITH DEEP CRIMSON  
HANGINGS STOOD AGAINST THE WALLS, EACH WITH ITS OWN SET OF TRUNKS AT  
THE FOOT. DEAN AND SEamus WERE ALREADY GETTING INTO BED;  
SEamus HAD PINNED HIS IRELAND POSTER TO HIS HEADBOARD, AND  
DEAN HAD TACKLED UP A POSTER OF VICTOR BURLIN EVER HIS BEDSIDE  
TABLE. HIS OLD POSTER OF WEST HAM FOOTBALL TEAM WAS PINNED  
RIGHT NEXT TO IT.

MENTAL, RON SIGHED, SHAKING HIS HEAD AT THE COMPLETELY STA-  
TIONARY SOCCER PLAYERS.

HARRY, RON AND NEVILLE GOT INTO THEIR PYJAMAS AND INTO BED. SOMEONE A FEELSE-ER, NE DELET HAD PLACED WARMING PANS BETWEEN THE SHEETS. IT WAS EXTREMELY COMFORTABLE, LYING THERE IN BED AND LISTENING TO THE STORM RAGING OUTSIDE.

I MIGHT GET IN FOR IT, WELL KNOW, RON SAID SLEEPILY THROUGH THE DARKNESS. IF FRED AND GEORGE FIND OUT WELL BE ... THE THERMAMENT ... WELL NEVER KNOW, BE WELL

SOMEONE ... HARRY SMILED AWAY IN BED, A SERIES OF DAZZLING NEW PICTURES FORMING IN HIS MIND'S EYE ... HE HAD FORTHWINDING THE IMPARTIAL JUDGE INTO BELIEVING HE WAS SEVENTEEN ... HE HAD BECOME HOGWARTS CHAMPION ... HE WAS STANDING IN THE GREENS, HIS ARMS RAISED IN TRIUMPH IN FRONT OF THE WHOLE

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SCHEE, ALL OF THEM WERE APPLAUDING AND SCREAMING ... HE HAD JUST WON THE TRILIZARD THERMAMENT ... THE S FACE STOOD OUT PARTICULARLY CLEARLY IN THE BLURRED CROWD, HER FACE GLOWING WITH ADMIRATION ...

HARRY GRINNED INTO HIS PILLOW, EXCEPTIONALLY GLAD THAT RON COULDN'T SEE WHAT HE WAS DOING.

## CHAPTER THIRTEEN

MAD FOR MEADOW

THE STORM HAD KEPT ITSELF AWAY BY THE FOLLOWING MORNING,

THOUGH THE CEILING IN THE GREAT HALL WAS STILL GLEAMY, HEAVY  
CLOUDS OF PELTER GREY SWIRLED OVERHEAD AS HARRY, RON AND  
HERMIONE EXAMINED THEIR NEW TIMETABLES AT BREAKFAST. A FEW

SEATS ALONG, FRED, GEORGE AND LEE JORDAN WERE DISCUSSING MAG-  
ICAL METHODS OF AGING THEMSELVES AND ELUFTING THEIR WAY INTO  
THE TRIWIZARD TOURNAMENT.

TODAY'S MEET WAS ... ELTISIDE ALL MORNING, SAID RON, WHO WAS  
RUNNING HIS FINGER DOWN HIS TIMETABLE, FURROWING WITH THE  
FINGERPLAITS AND CARE OF MAGICAL CREATURES ... DAMN IT, WE'RE  
STILL WITH THE SLYTHERINS ...

DELICATE DIVINATION THIS AFTERNOON, HARRY GRINNED, LEANING  
DOWN. DIVINATION WAS HIS LEAST FAVORITE SUBJECT, APART FROM  
POTIONS. PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY KEPT PREDICTING HARRY'S DEATH,  
WHICH HE FELT EXTREMELY ANNOYING.

YOU SHOULD HAVE GIVEN IT UP LIKE ME, SHOULDNT YOU? SAID  
HERMIONE BRIEFLY, KLUTTERING HERSELF SOME THOUGHT. THEN YOU'D BE  
DOING SOMETHING SENSIBLE LIKE ARITHMAGIC.

YOU'RE EATING AGAIN, I NOTICE, SAID RON, WATCHING HERMIONE  
ADD LIBERAL AMOUNTS OF JAM TO HER KLUTTERED THOUGHT.

I'VE DECIDED THERE ARE BETTER WAYS OF MAKING A STAND ABOUT  
YOUR RIGHTS, SAID HERMIONE HALIGHTLY.

Yeah ... AND YOU WERE HUNGRY, SAID RON, GRINNING.

THERE WAS A SUDDEN RUSTLING NOISE ABOVE THEM, AND A HUND-  
RED HILLS CAME SHARING THROUGH THE OPEN WINDOWS, CARRYING

THE MORNING MAIL. INSTINCTIVELY, HARRY LOOKED UP, BUT THERE WAS

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NO SIGN OF WHITE AMONG THE MASS OF BROWN AND GREY. THE HILLS  
CIRCLED THE TABLES, LOOKING FOR THE PEOPLE TO WHOM THEIR LETTERS  
AND PACKAGES WERE ADDRESSED. A LARGE TALL HILL SHARED DOWN  
THE NEVILLE LONGBOTHAM AND DEPOSITED A PARCEL IN HIS LAP  
NEVILLE ALMOST ALWAYS FORGET THE PACK SOMETHING. THEN THE OTHER  
SIDE OF THE HALL DRAGON MALFOY'S EAGLE HILL HAD LANDED ON HIS  
SHOULDER, CARRYING WHAT LOOKED LIKE HIS USUAL SUPPLY OF SWEETS  
AND CANDIES FROM HOME. TRYING TO IGNORE THE SINKING FEELING OF  
DISAPPOINTMENT IN HIS STOMACH, HARRY RETURNED TO HIS PERCH.  
WAS IT POSSIBLE THAT SOMETHING HAD HAPPENED TO FREDIE, AND  
THAT SIRIUS HADN'T EVEN GET HIS LETTER?

HIS PREOCCUPATION LASTED ALL THE WAY ACROSS THE SHEDDEN VEG-  
TABLE PATH UNTIL THEY ARRIVED IN GREENHOUSE THREE, BUT HERE HE

WAS DISTRACTED BY PROFESSOR SPRENT SEEING THE CLASS THE LIGHTEST  
PLANTS HARRY HAD EVER SEEN. INDEED, THEY LOOKED LESS LIKE PLANTS  
THAN THICK BLACK GIANT SLUGS, PROTRUDING VERTICALLY OUT OF THE  
SOIL. EACH WAS SWIRLING SLIGHTLY, AND HAD A NUMBER OF LARGE,  
SHINY SWELLINGS UPON IT, WHICH APPEARED TO BE FULL OF LIQUID.  
LIKETHINGS, PROFESSOR SPRENT TOLD THEM BRIEFLY. THEY NEED  
SWEEPING. SHELL WILL COLLECT THE PLANTS

THE WHAT? SAID SAMUEL FINNIGAN, SOUNDING REVEALED.

PLIS, FINNICAN, PLIS, SAID PROFESSOR SPREHLT, AND IT'S EXTREMELY  
VALUABLE, SEE DON'T WASTE IT, YOU WILL COLLECT THE PLIS, I SAY, IN  
THESE KETTLES, WEAR YOUR DRAGON-HIDE GLOVES, IT CAN BE FLAMING  
THINGS THE THE SKIN WHEN IRRITATED, BUBBLING PLIS.

SWEEPING THE BUBBLERS WAS DISGUSTING, BUT HOBBY SATISFY-  
ING, AS EACH SWELLING WAS PLOPPED, A LARGE AMOUNT OF THICK

YELLOWISH GREEN LIQUID BURST FORTH, WHICH SMELLED STRONGLY OF  
PETROL. THEY CALLED IT IN THE KETTLES AS PROFESSOR SPREHLT HAD  
INDICATED, AND BY THE END OF THE LESSON HAD COLLECTED SEVERAL  
PINTS.

THIS WILL KEEP MADAM PEMBERTON HAPPY, SAID PROFESSOR  
SPREHLT, STOPPING THE LAST KETTLE WITH A CLANK. AN EXCELLENT  
REMEDY FOR THE MORE STICKERON FORMS OF ACNE, BUBBLING  
PLIS, SHOULD STOP STUDENTS RESORTING TO DESPERATE MEASURES

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THEY DID THEMSELVES OF PIMPLES.

LIKE OTHER LITTLE MIDGE, SAID HANNAH ARKETT, A FLUFFYPLUFF,  
IN A FLISHED VEHICLE. SHE TRIED THE CLUSE FERS HER.

SILLY GIRL, SAID PROFESSOR SPREHLT, SHAKING HER HEAD, BUT  
MADAM PEMBERTON FIXED HER NESE BACK ON IN THE END.

A BUBBLING BELL RANG FROM THE CASTLE ACROSS THE WET

GREENLANDS, SIGNALLING THE END OF THE LESSON, AND THE CLASS SEPARAT-  
ED; THE FLUFFYPLUFFS CLIMBING THE STONE STEPS FOR TRANS-

FIGURATIONS, AND THE GRYPFINDERS HEADING IN THE OTHER DIRECTION,

BELOW THE SLEEPING LAWN TOWARDS Hagrid's small wooden cabin,  
which stood on the edge of the Forbidden Forest.

Hagrid was standing outside his hut, one hand on the handle  
of his enormous black rhinoceros, Fang. There were several  
open wooden crates on the ground at his feet, and Fang was  
whimpering and straining at his collar, apparently keen to  
investigate the contents more closely. As they drew nearer, an  
odd rattling noise reached their ears, punctuated by what  
sounded like minor explosions.

"MURKIN!" Hagrid said, grinning at Harry, Ron and  
Hermione. "Be on wait for the Slytherins, they won't want to  
miss this Blast-Ended Skrewts!"

"Come again?" said Ron.

Hagrid pointed down into the crates.

"Look!" squealed Lavender Brown, limping backwards.

"Look!" just about slipped up the Blast-Ended Skrewts, in  
Harry's opinion. They looked like deformed, shell-less beetles,  
horribly pale and slimy-looking, with legs sticking out in very  
odd places and no visible heads. There were about a hundred  
of them in each crate, each about six inches long, crawling  
over each other, limping blindly into the sides of the boxes.  
They were giving off a very peculiar smell of rotting fish.  
Every now and then, sparks would fly out of the end of a  
skrewt and, with a small puff, it would be propelled forwards  
several inches.

HEN Y ILIS HATCHED, SAID HAGRID PROUDLY, SHE YET LL BE ABLE TER

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RAISE EM YERSELVES! THOUGHT WE D MAKE A KIT OF A PROJECT OF IT?

AND WHY WOULD WE WANT TER RAISE THEM? SAID A CHILD VOICE,

THE SLYTHERINS HAD ARRIVED, THE SPEAKER WAS DRACH MALFOY,

CRABBE AND GOYLE WERE CHUCKLING APPRECIATIVELY AT HIS WORDS,

HAGRID WHEEZED STUMPED AT THE ELDESTERN,

I MEAN, WHAT DEE THEY DEE ASKED MALFOY, WHAT IS THE POINT  
OF THEM?

HAGRID OPENED HIS MOUTH, APPARENTLY THINKING HARD; THERE  
WAS A FEW SECONDS PAUSE, THEN HE SAID RELEGELY, THAS NEXT  
LESSON, MALFOY, YER ILIS FEEDIN EM TODAY, WELL, YET LL WAN TER  
TRY EM HEN A FEW DIFFERENT THINGS I VE NEVER HAD EM BEFORE,  
NHT SURE WHAT THEY LL GET FER I GET ANT EGGS AN FREE LIVERS AN A  
KIT OF GRASS-SNAKE ILST TRY EM HLT WITH A KIT OF EACH,

FIRST PLUS AND WELL THIS, MUTTERED SEAMUS,

NOTHING BUT DEEP AFFECTION FOR HAGRID COULD HAVE MADE

HARRY, RON AND HERMIONE PICK UP SEVERELY HANDFULS OF FREE  
LIVER AND WHEED THEM INTO THE CRATES THE TEMPT THE BLAST-ENDED  
SKELETS, HARRY COULDNT SUPPRESS THE SUSPICION THAT THE WHOLE  
THING WAS ENTIRELY POINTLESS, BECAUSE THE SKELETS DIDNT SEEM  
THEY HAVE MOUTHS,

HELLO! YELLED DEAN THOMAS, AFTER ABOUT TEN MINUTES, IT GET  
ME?

HAGRID FLURRIED OVER THE HIM, WHEEZING ANXIOUSLY,

ITS END EXPLODED! SAID DEAN ANGRILY, SHOWING HAGRID A BLIND

ON HIS HAND,

OH, YES, THAT CAN HAPPEN WHEN THEY BAST ME, SAID HAGRID,  
NEEDING.

CLING! SAID LAVENDER BROWN AGAIN. CLING! HAGRID, WHAT IS  
THAT PHINTY THING ON IT?

OH, SOME OF EM HAVE GOTT STINGS, SAID HAGRID ENTHUSIASTICALLY  
LAVENDER QUICKLY WITHDREW HER HAND FROM THE BEEHIVE. I RECKON  
THEY'RE THE MALES ... THE FEMALES 'VE GOTT SHORTER SLICKER THINGS ON  
THEIR BELLYS ... I THINK THEY MIGHT BE TER SLICK BEEHIVE.

WELL, I CAN CERTAINLY SEE WHY WE'RE TRYING TO KEEP THEM  
ALIVE, SAID MALPHEE SARCASTICALLY. WHY WOULDN'T WANT PETS THAT

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CAN CLING, STING AND KITE ALL AT ONCE?

JUST BECAUSE THEY'RE NOT VERY PRETTY, IT DOESN'T MEAN THEY'RE  
NOT USEFUL, HERMIONE SNAPPED. DRAGONS BEEHIVE IS AMAZINGLY  
MAGICAL, BUT WHY WOULDN'T WANT A DRAGON FOR A PET, WOULD YOU?  
HARRY AND RON GRINNED AT HAGRID, WHO GAVE THEM A FLIRTIVE  
SMILE FROM BEHIND HIS BUSY BEARD. HAGRID WOULD HAVE LIKED  
NOTHING BETTER THAN A PET DRAGON, AS HARRY, RON AND HERMIONE

KNEW ONLY TOO WELL. HE HAD OWNED ONE FOR A BRIEF PERIOD DURING  
THEIR FIRST YEAR, A VICIOUS NORWEGIAN RIDGEBACK BY THE

NAME OF DEERBERT. HAGRID SIMPLY LOVED MENSTRUAL CREATURES  
THE MORE LETHAL, THE BETTER.

WELL, AT LEAST THE SERPENTS ARE SMALL, SAID RON, AS THEY MADE



THEY WERE BACK UP THE THE CASTLE FOR LUNCH AND FEELER LATER.

THEY ARE HERE, SAID HERMIONE IN AN EXASPERATED VOICE, BUT SINCE HARRY IS FEELING BUILT WHAT THEY EAT, I EXPECT THEY WILL BE SIX FEET LONG.

WELL, THAT WON'T MATTER IF THEY TURN OUT THE CLARE SEA SICKNESS FOR SOMETHING, WILL IT? SAID RON, GRINNING SLOWLY AT HER.

THEY DON'T FEEL PERFECTLY WELL I ONLY SAID THAT THE SLEET MALFOY UP, SAID HERMIONE. AS A MATTER OF FACT I THINK HE IS RIGHT. THE BEST THING THE BOY WOULD BE THE STAMP WHEN THEY LEFT OF THEM BEFORE THEY START ATTACKING US ALL.

THEY SAT DOWN AT THE GRYFFINDOR TABLE AND HELPED THEMSELVES THE SAME CHIPS AND POTATOES. HERMIONE BEGAN TO EAT SHE

FAST THAT HARRY AND RON STARED AT HER.

ER IS THIS THE NEW STANDARD FOR RIGHTS? SAID RON. THEY ARE GOING TO MAKE THEMSELVES FOOD INSTEAD?

NO, SAID HERMIONE, WITH AS MUCH DIGNITY AS SHE COULD MUSTER WITH HER MOUTH BUBBLING WITH SPARKS. I JUST WANT TO GET THE THE LIBRARY.

WHAT? SAID RON IN DISBELIEF. HERMIONE IT IS THE FIRST DAY BACK! WE HAVEN'T EVEN GOTTEN HOME YET!

HERMIONE SHRUGGED AND CONTINUED TO STARE DOWN HER FOOD AS THOUGH SHE HAD NOT EATEN FOR DAYS. THEN SHE LEAPT TO HER FEET, SAID, SEE YOU AT DINNER! AND DEPARTED AT HIGH SPEED.

THE HARRY POTTER

WHEN THE BELL RANG THE SIGNAL THE START OF AFTERNOON LESSONS,  
HARRY AND RON SET OFF FOR NORTH TOWER WHERE, AT THE TOP OF A  
TIGHTLY SPIRALLING STAIRCASE, A SILVER STEPLADDER LED TO A CIRCULAR  
TRAPDOOR IN THE CEILING, AND THE ROOMS WHERE PROFESSOR  
TRELAWNEY LIVED.

THE FAMILIAR SWEET PERFLUME EMANATING FROM THE FIRE MET  
THEIR NOSTRILS AS THEY EMERGED AT THE TOP OF THE STEPLADDER. AS  
EVER, THE CURTAINS WERE ALL CLOSED; THE CIRCULAR ROOM WAS BATHED  
IN A DIM REDDISH LIGHT CAST BY THE MANY LAMPS, WHICH WERE ALL  
DRAPED WITH SCARVES AND SHAWLS. HARRY AND RON WALKED  
THROUGH THE MASS OF ECLIPSED CHINTZ CHAIRS AND PHELPHES THAT  
CLUTTERED THE ROOM, AND SAT DOWN AT THE SAME SMALL CIRCULAR  
TABLE.

GOOD DAY, SAID THE MISTY VOICE OF PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY RIGHT  
BEHIND HARRY, MAKING HIM JUMP.

A VERY THIN WOMAN WITH ENORMOUS GLASSES THAT MADE HER  
EYES APPEAR FAR TOO LARGE FOR HER FACE, PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY WAS  
PEERING DOWN AT HARRY WITH THE TRAGIC EXPRESSION SHE ALWAYS  
WORE WHENEVER SHE SAW HIM. THE USUAL LARGE AMOUNT OF BEADS,  
CHAINS AND BANGLES GLITTERED UPON HER PERSON IN THE FIRELIGHT.

YOU ARE PREOCCUPIED, MY DEAR, SHE SAID MELANCHOLICALLY TO  
HARRY. MY INNER EYE SEES PAST YOUR BRAVE FACE TO THE TROUBLED

SOUL WITHIN. AND I REGRET TO SAY THAT YOUR WHORRIES ARE NOT EASE-  
LESS. I SEE DIFFICULT TIMES AHEAD FOR YOU, ALAS ... MOST DIFFICULT

... I FEAR THE THING YOU DREAD WILL INDEED COME TO PASS ... AND

PERHAPS SHEENER THAN YELL THINK ...

HER VOICE DROPPED ALMOST TO A WHISPER. RON REELLED HIS EYES AT HARRY, WHO LEANED STERNLY BACK. PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY SWIFT PAST THEM AND SEATED HERSELF IN A LARGE WINGED ARMCHAIR BEHIND THE FIRE, FACING THE CLASS. LAVENDER BROWN AND PARVATI PATIL, WHO DEEPLY ADMIRER PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY, WERE SITTING NEAR PHILIPS VERY CLOSE TO HER.

MY DEARS, IT IS TIME FOR US TO CONSIDER THE STARS, SHE SAID.

THE MOVEMENTS OF THE PLANETS AND THE MYSTERIOUS PORTENTS THEY REVEAL ONLY TO THOSE WHO UNDERSTAND THE STEPS OF THE

MAD-POPE MEEHOO 199

CELESTIAL DANCE. HUMAN DESTINY MAY BE DECRYPTED BY THE PLANETARY RAYS, WHICH INTERMINGLE ...

BUT HARRY'S TEELIGHTS HAD DRIFTED. THE PERPLEXED FIRE ALWAYS MADE HIM FEEL SLEEPY AND DULL-WITTED, AND PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY'S RAMBLING TALKS AND FORTUNE-TELLING NEVER HELD HIM EXACTLY SPELLBOUND. THOUGH HE COULDN'T HELP THINKING ABOUT WHAT SHE HAD JUST SAID TO HIM, I FEAR THE THING YELL DREAD WILL INDEED COME TO PASS ...

BUT HERMIONE WAS RIGHT, HARRY TEELIGHT IRRITABLY, PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY REALLY WAS AN OLD FRAUD. HE WASN'T DREADING ANYTHING AT THE MOMENT AT ALL ... WELL, UNLESS YELL CHEATED HIS FEARS THAT SIRIUS HAD BEEN CAUGHT ... BUT WHAT DID PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY KNOW? HE HAD BEEN SINCE COME TO THE CONCLUSION THAT HER

BRAND OF FERTLINE-TELLING WAS REALLY NOT MORE THAN BLIND GUESS-  
WORK AND A SPEEDY MANNER.

EXCEPT, OF COURSE, FOR THAT TIME AT THE END OF LAST TERM, WHEN  
SHE HAD MADE THE PREDICTION ABOUT VERDERBERT RISING AGAIN ...  
AND DIMPLEDHERE HIMSELF HAD SAID THAT HE THOUGHT THAT TRANCE  
HAD BEEN GENUINE, WHEN FARRY HAD DESCRIBED IT TO HIM ...

FARRY: THEN MUTTERED.

WHAT?

FARRY LOOKED AROUND; THE WHOLE CLASS WAS STARING AT HIM. HE  
SAT UP STRAIGHT; HE HAD BEEN ALMOST DOZING OFF, LOST IN THE HEAT  
AND HIS THOUGHTS.

I WAS SAYING, MY DEAR, THAT THEY WERE CLEARLY BORN UNDER THE  
BALEFUL INFLUENCE OF SATURN, SAID PROFESSOR TRELANNEY, A FAINT  
NOTE OF RESENTMENT IN HER VOICE AT THE FACT THAT HE HAD HEAVILY  
NOT BEEN HANGING ON HER WORDS.

BORN UNDER WHAT, SHIRAZ? SAID FARRY.

SATURN, DEAR, THE PLANET SATURN? SAID PROFESSOR TRELANNEY,  
SOUNDING DEFINITELY IRRITATED THAT HE WASN'T RIVETED BY THIS  
NEWS. I WAS SAYING THAT SATURN WAS SIMPLY IN A POSITION OF  
POWER IN THE HEAVENS AT THE MOMENT OF YOUR BIRTH ... YOUR  
DARK HAIR ... YOUR DEAN SATURN ... TRAGIC LOSSES SHE FEELS  
IN LIFE ... I THINK I AM RIGHT IN SAYING, MY DEAR, THAT THEY

18 FARRY MUTTERED

WERE BORN IN MID-WINTER?

ONE, SAID HARRY, I WAS BORN IN JULY.

RON HASTILY TURNED HIS LAUGH INTO A HARKING CHUCKLE.

HALF AN HOUR LATER, EACH OF THEM HAD BEEN GIVEN A COMPLICATED CIRCULAR CHART, AND WAS ATTEMPTING TO FILL IN THE POSITIONS OF

THE PLANETS AT THEIR MOMENT OF BIRTH. IT WAS DULL WORK, REQUIRING MUCH CONSULTATION OF TIMETABLES AND CALCULATION OF ANGLES.

I'VE GOT TWO NEPTUNES HERE, SAID HARRY AFTER A WHILE, PEERING DOWN AT HIS PIECE OF PARCHMENT, THAT CAN'T BE RIGHT, CAN IT?

AAAAAH, SAID RON, IMITATING PROFESSOR TRILAWNEY'S MYSTICAL WHISPER, WHEN TWO NEPTUNES APPEAR IN THE SKY, IT IS A SURE SIGN THAT A MIDGET IN GLASSES IS BEING BORN, HARRY ...

SEamus AND DEAN, WHO WERE WORKING NEARBY, SNIGGERED

HEEDILY, THOUGH NOT HEEDILY ENOUGH TO MASK THE EXCITED SMUGLES

FROM LAVENDER BROWN. EH, PROFESSOR, HEED? I THINK I'VE GOT AN UNASPECTED PLANET? EH, WHICH ONE IS THAT, PROFESSOR?

IT IS URANUS, MY DEAR, SAID PROFESSOR TRILAWNEY, PEERING DOWN AT THE CHART.

CAN I HAVE A HEED AT URANUS, THEN, LAVENDER? SAID RON.

MEET UNFORTUNATELY, PROFESSOR TRILAWNEY HEARD HIM, AND IT

WAS THIS, PERHAPS, WHICH MADE HER GIVE THEM SHE MUCH FURTHER

WORK AT THE END OF THE CLASS.

A DETAILED ANALYSIS OF THE WAY THE PLANETARY MOVEMENTS IN

THE COMING MONTHS WILL AFFECT YOU, WITH REFERENCE TO YOUR PERSONAL CHART, SHE SNAPPED, SOUNDING MUCH MORE LIKE PROFESSOR

MCGONAGALL THAN HER USUAL AIRY-FAIRY SELF. I WANT IT READY TO HAND IN NEXT MONDAY, AND NO EXCUSES!

MISERABLE OLD BAT, SAID RON BITTERLY, AS THEY JOINED THE CROWDS DESCENDING THE STAIRCASES BACK TO THE GREAT HALL AND DINNER. THAT LL TAKE ALL WEEKEND, THAT WILL ...

LETS OF HERMION? SAID HERMIONE BRIGHTLY, CATCHING UP WITH THEM. PROFESSOR VECTER DIDN T GIVE US ANY AT ALL!

WELL, KISS HER PROFESSOR VECTER, SAID RON MEETILY. THEY REACHED THE ENTRANCE HALL, WHICH WAS PACKED WITH PEOPLE ENJOYING THE DINNER. THEY HAD JUST JOINED THE END OF THE

MAD-DON MEETILY 177

LINE, WHEN A LOUD WHISTLE RANG OUT BEHIND THEM.

WEASLEY? HEY, WEASLEY?

HARRY, RON AND HERMIONE TURNED. MALFOY, CRABBE AND GOYLE WERE STANDING THERE, EACH LOOKING THOROUGHLY PLEASED ABOUT SOMETHING.

WHAT? SAID RON SHORTLY.

YOUR DAD S IN THE PAPER, WEASLEY? SAID MALFOY, BRANDISHING A COPY OF THE DAILY PROPHET, AND SPEAKING VERY LOUDLY, SO THAT EVERYONE IN THE PACKED ENTRANCE HALL COULD HEAR. LISTEN TO THIS! FURTHER MISTAKES AT THE MINISTRY OF MAGIC

IT SEEMS AS THOUGH THE MINISTRY OF MAGIC'S TRIEBLES ARE NOT  
YET AT AN END, WRITES RITA SKEETER, SPECIAL CORRESPONDENT,  
RECENTLY UNDER FIRE FOR ITS POOR COORDINATION AT THE FLIDDITCH  
WORLD CUP, AND STILL UNABLE TO ACCOUNT FOR THE DISAPPEARANCE  
OF ONE OF ITS WITCHES, THE MINISTRY WAS PLUNGED INTO FRESH  
EMBARRASSMENT YESTERDAY BY THE ANTICS OF ARNOLD WEASLEY, OF  
THE MISUSE OF MAGIC ARTEFACTS OFFICE.

MALPHEE WHISKED UP,

IMAGINE THEM NOT EVEN GETTING HIS NAME RIGHT, WEASLEY, IT'S  
ALMOST AS THOUGH HE'S A COMPLETE NONENTITY, ISN'T IT? HE COINED.  
EVERYONE IN THE ENTRANCE HALL WAS LISTENING NOW. MALPHEE  
STRAIGHTENED THE PAPER WITH A FLUORISH, AND READ ON:

ARNOLD WEASLEY, WHO WAS CHARGED WITH POSSESSION OF A FLY-  
ING CAR THREE YEARS AGO, WAS YESTERDAY INVOLVED WITH A TWISTLE

WITH SEVERAL MAGIC LAW-BREAKERS / PHILICEMEN / EVER A NUMBER  
OF HIGHLY AGGRESSIVE DISTINS, MR WEASLEY APPEARS TO HAVE  
REQUESTED THE THE AID OF MAD-EYE MURPHY, THE AGED EX-ALUMNUS WHO

RETIRED FROM THE MINISTRY WHEN HE WAS NO LONGER ABLE TO TELL THE DI-  
FFERENCE BETWEEN A HANDSHAKE AND ATTEMPTED MURDER.

UNUSUALLY, MR WEASLEY FOUND, UPON ARRIVAL AT MR  
MURPHY'S HEAVILY GUARDED HOUSE, THAT MR MURPHY HAD ONCE  
AGAIN RAISED A FALSE ALARM, MR WEASLEY WAS FORCED TO MURPHY

100 HARRY POTTER

SEVERAL MEMORIES BEFORE HE COULD ESCAPE FROM THE POLICEMEN,  
BUT REPLIED THE ANSWER DAILY PROPHET QUESTIONS ABOUT WHY HE  
HAD INVOLVED THE MINISTRY IN SUCH AN UNBECOMING AND POTEN-  
TIALY EMBARRASSING SCENE.

AND THERE'S A PICTURE, WEASLEY? SAID MALFOY, FLIPPING THE PAPER  
OVER AND HOLDING IT UP. A PICTURE OF HER PARENTS HELD SIDE THEIR  
HOUSE. IF YOU CAN CALL IT A HOUSE? HER MOTHER COULD BE WITH  
LOSING A BIT OF WEIGHT, COULDN'T SHE?

HEEN WAS SHAKING WITH FLURRY, EVERYONE WAS STARING AT HIM.

GET STOPPED, MALFOY, SAID HARRY, [ THEN, HEEN ...

HEY YEAH, YOU WERE STAYING WITH THEM THIS SUMMER, WEREN'T  
YOU, POTTER? SNEERED MALFOY. I'LL TELL ME, IS HIS MOTHER REALLY  
THAT THICK, OR IS IT JUST THE PICTURE?

YOU KNOW HER MOTHER, MALFOY? SAID HARRY. BOTH HE AND  
HERMIONIE HAD GRABBED THE BACK OF HEEN'S REEKS THE STOP HIM  
LAUNCHING HIMSELF AT MALFOY. THAT EXPRESSION SHE'S GET, LIKE  
SHE'S GETTING UNDER HER REEKS? HAS SHE ALWAYS LOOKED LIKE  
THAT, OR WAS IT JUST BECAUSE YOU WERE WITH HER?  
MALFOY'S PALE FACE WENT SLIGHTLY PINK. DIDN'T YOU DARE INSULT  
MY MOTHER, POTTER.

KEEP YOUR FAT MOUTH SHUT, THEN, SAID HARRY, TURNING AWAY.  
BANG!

SEVERAL PEOPLE SCREAMED. HARRY FELT SOMETHING WHITE HIT  
GRAZE THE SIDE OF HIS FACE. HE PLUNGED HIS HAND INTO HIS REEKS



AFTER HIS WAND, BUT BEFORE HE'D EVEN THOUGHT IT, HE HEARD A  
SECOND WILD BANG, AND A REAR WHICH REACHED THROUGH THE  
ENTRANCE HALL.

HE'D BETTER GO DOWN T, LADDIE!

HARRY SPUN AROUND, PROFESSOR MEENEY WAS LIMPING DOWN THE  
MARBLE STAIRCASE, HIS WAND WAS GLIT AND IT WAS POINTING RIGHT AT  
A PURE WHITE PERRIT, WHICH WAS SHIVERING IN THE STONE-FLAGGED  
FLOOR, EXACTLY WHERE MALFOY HAD BEEN STANDING.

THERE WAS A TERRIFIED SILENCE IN THE ENTRANCE HALL, NEHEMY  
BUT MEENEY WAS MOVING A MUSCLE, MEENEY TURNED THE HEAD AT

MAD-EYE MEENEY 181

HARRY AT LEAST, HIS NORMAL EYE WAS LOOKING AT HARRY; THE OTHER  
ONE WAS POINTING INTO THE BACK OF HIS HEAD.

DID HE GET THEM? MEENEY GRIELED, HIS VOICE WAS LOW AND  
GRAVELLY.

NEE, SAID HARRY, MISSED.

LEAVE IT! MEENEY SCHELTED.

LEAVE WHAT? HARRY SAID, REWILDERED.

NEET THEM HIM! MEENEY GRIELED, IRKING HIS THUMB OVER HIS  
SHOULDER AT CRABBE, WHO HAD JUST FREEZEN, ABOUT THE PICK UP THE  
WHITE PERRIT, IT SEEMED THAT MEENEY'S REELLING EYE WAS MAGICAL  
AND COULD SEE GLIT OF THE BACK OF HIS HEAD.

MEENEY STARTED THE LIMP TOWARDS CRABBE, CHOPE AND THE PERRIT,  
WHICH GAVE A TERRIFIED SQUEAL AND THUD OFF, STREAKING TOWARDS  
THE DUNGEONS.

I DON'T THINK SHE' REARED MEENEY, POINTING HIS WAND AT THE

FERRRET AGAIN IT FLEW TEN FEET INTO THE AIR, FELL WITH A SMACK THE  
THE FLOOR, AND THEN BOUNCED UPWARDS ONCE MORE.

I DON'T LIKE PEOPLE WHO ATTACK WHEN THEIR OPPONENT'S BACK'S  
TURNED, GROWLED MEEB, AS THE FERRRET BOUNCED HIGHER AND  
HIGHER, SQUEALING IN PAIN. STINKING, CHEERFULLY, SLIMPY THING THE  
DEH ...

THE FERRRET FLEW THROUGH THE AIR, ITS LEGS AND TAIL FLAILING  
HELPLESSLY.

NEVER DEH THAT AGAIN SAID MEEB, SPREADING EACH LEG  
AS THE FERRRET HIT THE STONE FLOOR AND BOUNCED UPWARDS AGAIN.  
PROFESSOR MEEB? SAID A SHOCKED VOICE.

PROFESSOR MCGINAGALL WAS CREEPING DOWN THE MARBLE STAIR-  
CASE WITH HER ARMS FULL OF BOOKS.

HELLO, PROFESSOR MCGINAGALL, SAID MEEB CALMLY, BOUNCING  
THE FERRRET STILL HIGHER.

WHAT WHAT ARE YOU DOING? SAID PROFESSOR MCGINAGALL,  
HER EYES FOLLOWING THE BOUNCING FERRRET'S PROGRESS THROUGH THE  
AIR.

TEACHING, SAID MEEB.

TEACH MEEB, IS THAT A STUDENT? SHRIEKED PROFESSOR

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MCGINAGALL, THE BOOKS SPILLING OUT OF HER ARMS.

YES, SAID MEEB.

DEH! CRIED PROFESSOR MCGINAGALL, RUNNING DOWN THE STAIRS

AND PULLING OUT HER HAND; A MOMENT LATER, WITH A LUDICROUS  
PING NOISE, GRACE MALFOY HAD REAPPEARED, LYING IN A HEAP ON

THE FLOOR WITH HIS SLEEK BLOND HAIR ALL OVER HIS NECK BRILLIANTLY  
PINK FACE, HE GET UP HIS FEET, WINKING.

MURDER, WE NEVER USE TRANSFIGURATION AS A PUNISHMENT? SAID  
PROFESSOR MCGRATHGALL WEARILY. SURELY PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE  
WOULD TELL THAT?

HE MIGHT VE MENTIONED IT, YEAH, SAID MURDER, SCRATCHING HIS  
CHIN UNCONCERNEDLY, BUT I THOUGHT A GOOD SHARP STICK

WE GIVE DETENTION, MURDER? HE SPREAD THE THE HOPPER S HEAD  
OF HIS?

I LL DO THAT, THEN, SAID MURDER, STARING AT MALFOY WITH GREAT  
DISLIKE.

MALFOY, WHOSE PALE EYES WERE STILL WATERING WITH PAIN AND  
HUMILIATION, LEMBED MALICEFULLY UP AT MURDER AND MUTTERED

SOMETHING IN WHICH THE WORDS MY FATHER WERE DISTINGUISH-  
ABLE.

HEY YEAH? SAID MURDER QUIETLY, LIMPING FORWARD A FEW STEPS,  
THE DULL CLUNK OF HIS WOODEN LEG ECHOING AROUND THE HALL.

WELL, I KNOW YOUR FATHER HE HED, KID ... YOU TELL HIM MURDER S  
KEEPING A CLOSE EYE ON HIS SON ... YOU TELL HIM THAT FROM ME ...  
NOW, YOUR HEAD OF HIS LL BE SNAPE, WILL IT?

YES, SAID MALFOY RESENTFULLY.

ANOTHER OLD FRIEND, GRIMLED MEEDY, I VE BEEN LEEDING  
TOWARD THE A CHAT WITH OLD SNAP ... THEN HE, YEL ... AND HE  
SEIZED MALPHY S UPPER ARM AND MARCHED HIM OFF TOWARDS THE  
BLINGENS.

PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL STARED ANXIOUSLY AFTER THEM FOR A FEW  
MOMENTS, THEN WAVED HER HAND AT HER FALLEN BROTHERS, CALLING  
THEM THE SHAR UP INTO THE AIR AND BACK INTO HER ARMS.

DEN T TALK THE ME, THEN SAID QUIETLY THE HARRY AND HERMIONE,  
AS THEY SAT DOWN AT THE GRYFFINDOR TABLE A FEW MINUTES LATER,

MAD-POY MEEDY 188

SWIRLED BY EXCITED TALK HE ALL SIDES ABOUT WHAT HAD JUST  
HAPPENED.

WHY NOT? SAID HERMIONE IN SURPRISE.

BECAUSE I WANT THE FIX THAT IN MY MEMORY FOR EVER, SAID THEN,  
HIS EYES CLOSED AND AN UPLIFTED EXPRESSION IN HIS FACE. DRACH  
MALPHY, THE AMAZING REINING PERRY ...

HARRY AND HERMIONE BOTH LAUGHED, AND HERMIONE BEGAN  
BEING KEEF CASSEROLE INTO EACH OF THEIR PLATES.

HE CHILD HAVE REALLY FURT MALPHY, THOUGH, SHE SAID. IT WAS  
GOOD, REALLY, THAT PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL STOPPED IT

HERMIONE? SAID THEN FLUTTERINGLY, HIS EYES SNAPPING OPEN  
AGAIN. YEL RE RUINING THE BEST MOMENT OF MY LIFE?

HERMIONE MADE AN IMPATIENT NOISE AND BEGAN THE EAT AT THE  
SPEED AGAIN.

DEN T TELL ME YEL RE GOING BACK THE THE LIBRARY THIS EVENING?  
SAID HARRY, WATCHING HER.

GOT THE, SAID FERMINE THICKLY, LEADS THE DEE.

BUT WHY TOLD US PROFESSOR VETTER

IT'S NOT SCHEMELWERX, SHE SAID, WITHIN FIVE MINUTES, SHE HAD  
CLEARED HER PLATE AND DEPARTED.

NEE SEHNER HAD SHE GONE THAN HER SEAT WAS TAKEN BY FRED

WEASLEY, MEEHBY? HE SAID, FELL CHEE IS HE?

BEYOND CHEE, SAID GEORGE, SITTING DOWN OPPOSITE FRED.

SUPERCHEE, SAID THE TWINS BEST FRIEND, LEE JORDAN, SLIDING  
INTO THE SEAT BESIDE GEORGE. WE HAD HIM THIS AFTERNOON, HE  
TOLD HARRY AND RHN.

WHAT WAS IT LIKE? SAID HARRY EAGERLY.

FRED, GEORGE AND LEE EXCHANGED LOOKS FULL OF MEANING.

NEVER HAD A LESSON LIKE IT, SAID FRED.

HE KNOWS, MAN, SAID LEE.

KNOWS WHAT? SAID RHN, LEANING FORWARD.

KNOWS WHAT IT'S LIKE THE EE HLT THERE DOING IT, SAID GEORGE  
IMPRESSIVELY.

DOING WHAT? SAID HARRY.

FIGHTING THE DARK ARTS, SAID FRED.

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HE'S SEEN IT ALL, SAID GEORGE.

MAZING, SAID LEE.

RHN DIVED INTO HIS BAG FOR HIS TIMETABLE.

WE HAVEN'T GOT HIM TIL THURSDAY? HE SAID IN A DISAPPOINTED  
VOICE.

## CHAPTER FORTY-THREE

### THE UNPREDICTABLE CURSES

THE NEXT THREE DAYS PASSED WITHOUT GREAT INCIDENT, UNLESS PEEK  
CELESTED NEVILLE MELTING HIS SIXTH CALIBRE IN PENTHENS,  
PROFESSOR SNAPE, WHO SEEMED TO HAVE ATTAINED NEW LEVELS OF  
VINDICTIVENESS OVER THE SUMMER, GAVE NEVILLE DETENTION, AND  
NEVILLE RETURNED FROM IT IN A STATE OF NERVOUS COLLAPSE, HAVING  
BEEN MADE THE DISPERSED A BARREL OF BURNED THREADS.

PEEK KNEW WHY SNAPE WAS IN SUCH A FULMINE MOOD, BUT NOT WHY HE SAID  
THAT TO HARRY, AS THEY WATCHED HERMIONIE TEACHING NEVILLE A  
SCHOOLING CHARM TO REMOVE THE THREAD GLITS FROM UNDER HIS  
FINGERNAILS.

PEEK, SAID HARRY, MUMBO.

IT WAS COMMON KNOWLEDGE THAT SNAPE REALLY WANTED THE  
DARK ARTS JOB, AND HE HAD NEVER FAILED TO GET IT FOR THE FORTY-  
THREE YEAR RUNNING. SNAPE HAD DISLIKED ALL OF THEIR PREVIOUS DARK  
ARTS TEACHERS, AND SEEN IT BUT HE SEEMED STRANGELY LATE OF

DISPLAYING EVIL ANTIMESITY TO MAD-EYE MUMBO, INDEED, WHEN-  
EVER HARRY SAW THE TWO OF THEM TOGETHER AT MEALTIMES, HE

WHEN THEY PASSED IN THE HALLWAYS HE HAD THE DISTINCT IMPRES-  
SION THAT SNAPE WAS AVOIDING MUMBO'S EYE, WHETHER MAGICAL OR  
NORMAL.

I RECKON SNAPE'S A BIT SCARED OF HIM, YELL DUDLEY, HARRY SAID  
THOUGHTFULLY.

IMAGINE IF MURPHY TURNED SNAPE INTO A FURRED THING, SAID  
RON, HIS EYES MISTING OVER, AND KILNICKED HIM ALL AROUND HIS  
BLINDNESS ...

THE GRAYFINDER FORTY-YEARS WERE LEAVING FORWARD THE

THE HARRY POTTER

MURPHY'S FIRST LESSON SHE FELT THAT THEY ARRIVED EARLY AFTER LUNCH  
ON THURSDAY AND WALKED UP HILLSIDE HIS CLASSROOM BEFORE THE  
BELL HAD EVEN RING.

THE ONLY PERSON MISSING WAS HERMION, WHO TURNED UP LATE  
IN TIME FOR THE LESSON.

BEEN IN THE

LIBRARY, HARRY FINISHED HER SENTENCE FOR HER. I MEAN,  
BUTTER, HE WAS WHEN I GET DECENT SEATS.

THEY HURRIED INTO THREE CHAIRS RIGHT IN FRONT OF THE TEACHER'S

DESK, THEN FELT THEIR CHAIRS OF THE DARK FORCES: A GLIDE THE SELF-  
PROTECTION, AND WAITED, UNUSUALLY QUIET. THEN THEY HEARD

MURPHY'S DISTINCTIVE CLUNKING FEETSTEPS CLIMBING DOWN THE  
CORRIDOR, AND HE ENTERED THE ROOM, LEAVING AS STRANGE AND  
FRIGHTENING AS EVER. THEY COULD JUST SEE HIS CLAWED, WHISPER  
FEET PRETRAILING FROM UNDERNEATH HIS REEKS.

YELL CAN PUT THESE AWAY, HE CRAWLED, STUMPING OVER THE HIS  
DESK AND SITTING DOWN, THESE REEKS, YELL WHEN I NEED THEM.

THEY RETURNED THE BOOKS TO THEIR BAGS, RON BEING EXCITED.  
MURRAY THEN HAD A REGISTER, SHOWING HIS LONG MANE OF GRIZZLED  
GREY HAIR AND HIS TWISTED AND SCARRED FACE AND BEGAN THE CALL  
OUT NAMES, HIS NORMAL EYE MOVING STEADILY DOWN THE LIST WHILE  
HIS MAGICAL EYE SWIVELLED AROUND, FIXING UPON EACH STUDENT AS  
HE OR SHE ANSWERED.

RIGHT THEN, HE SAID, WHEN THE LAST PERSON HAD DECLARED  
THEMSELVES PRESENT, I VE HAD A LETTER FROM PROFESSOR KLIPIN

ABOUT THIS CLASS. SEEMS YOU VE HAD A PRETTY THOROUGH GRIND-  
ING IN TACKLING DARK CREATURES YOU VE COVERED GIGGANTS, RED

CAPS, HINDOPLINDS, GRINDWHEELS, KAPPAS AND WEREWOLVES, IS  
THAT RIGHT?

THERE WAS A GENERAL MURMUR OF ASSENT.

BUT YOU RE BEHIND VERY BEHIND IN DEALING WITH CLASSES,  
SAID MURRAY. SEE I M HERE TO BRING YOU UP TO SCRATCH AND WHAT  
WIZARDS CAN DO THE EACH OTHER. I VE GOTTEN ONE YEAR TO TEACH YOU  
HOW TO DEAL WITH DARK

WHAT, AREN T YOU STAYING? RON BLURTED OUT.

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MURRAY S MAGICAL EYE SPUN AROUND TO STARE AT RON; RON  
LOOKED EXTREMELY APPREHENSIVE, BUT AFTER A MOMENT MURRAY  
SMILED THE FIRST TIME HARRY HAD SEEN HIM DO SO. THE EFFECT  
WAS TO MAKE HIS HEAVILY SCARRED FACE LOOK MORE TWISTED AND  
CENTERTED THAN EVER, BUT IT WAS NEVERTHELESS A RELIEF TO KNOW



THAT HE EVER DID ANYTHING AS FRIENDLY AS SMILE. BEN WHISKED  
DEEPLY RELIEVED.

WELL BE ARTHUR WEASLEY'S SON, EH? MENDO SAID. YOUR FATHER  
GOT ME OUT OF A VERY TIGHT CORNER A FEW DAYS AGO ... YES, I'M  
STAYING JUST THE ONE YEAR, SPECIAL FAVORITE THE DUMBLEDORE ... ONE  
YEAR, AND THEN BACK TO MY ELIOT RETIREMENT.

HE GAVE A HARSH LAUGH, AND THEN CLAPPED HIS GRARLED HANDS  
TOGETHER.

SEE STRAIGHT INTO IT, CLASSES. THEY COME IN MANY STRENGTHS  
AND FORMS. NOW, ACCORDING TO THE MINISTRY OF MAGIC, I'M  
SLIPPED THE TEACH WELL WINTER-CASSES AND LEAVE IT AT THAT, I'M  
NOT SLIPPED THE SEVEN WELL WHAT ILLEGAL DARK CLASSES WERE  
LIKE UNTIL WELL BE IN THE SIXTH YEAR. WELL BE NOT SLIPPED THE BE  
HAD ENOUGH THE DEAL WITH IT TIL THEN, BUT PROFESSOR  
DUMBLEDORE'S GOT A HIGHER OPINION OF YOUR NERVES, HE RECKONS  
WELL CAN cope, AND I SAY, THE SMOOTHER WELL KNOW WHAT WELL BE

LIP AGAINST, THE BETTER. FIVE ARE WELL SLIPPED THE DEFEND YOUR-  
SELF AGAINST SOMETHING WELL VE NEVER SEEN? A WIZARD WITH S

ASKED THE PLT AN ILLEGAL CLASSE BEN WELL ISN'T GIVING THE TELL WELL  
WHAT HE'S ASKED THE DEE, HE'S NOT GIVING THE DEE IT NICE AND PHILITE  
THE YOUR FACE. WELL NEED THE BE PREPARED, WELL NEED THE BE ALERT  
AND WATCHFUL. WELL NEED THE PLT THAT AWAY, MISS GREEN, WHEN  
I'M TALKING.

LAVENDER JUMPED AND BLISHED. SHE HAD BEEN FEELING

PARYATI HER COMPLETED HERESCOPE UNDER THE DESK. APPARENTLY

MEDDY'S MAGICAL EYE COULD SEE THROUGH SHEDS WHEN, AS WELL AS  
HIT THE BACK OF HIS HEAD.

SEE ... DEE AND HE FELT KNOW WHICH CLASSES ARE MOST HEAVILY  
PLINISHED BY WIZARDING LACK

SEVERAL HANDS RESE TENTATIVELY INTO THE AIR, INCLUDING REEN'S

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AND HERMIONE'S. MEDDY POINTED AT REEN, THROUGH HIS MAGICAL  
EYE WAS STILL FIXED ON LAVENDER.

ER, SAID REEN TENTATIVELY, MY DAD TELD ME ABOUT HERE ... IS IT  
CALLED THE IMPERILS CLASE, OR SOMETHING?

AH, YES, SAID MEDDY APPRECIATIVELY. YOUR FATHER WOULD KNOW  
THAT HERE, GAVE THE MINISTRY A LOT OF TROUBLE AT ONE TIME, THE  
IMPERILS CLASE.

MEDDY GET HEAVILY TO HIS MISMATCHED FEET, OPENED HIS DESK  
DRAWER, AND THERE HIT A GLASS JAR. THREE LARGE, BLACK SPIDERS  
WERE SCUTTLEING AROUND INSIDE IT. HARRY FELT REEN REEIL SLIGHTLY  
NEXT TO HIM REEN HATED SPIDERS.

MEDDY REACHED INTO THE JAR, CAUGHT ONE OF THE SPIDERS AND  
HELD IT IN THE PALM OF HIS HAND SEE THAT THEY COULD ALL SEE IT.

HE THEN POINTED HIS WAND AT IT, AND MUTTERED, IMPERILS

THE SPIDER LEAPT FROM MEDDY'S HAND ON A FINE THREAD OF SILK,  
AND BEGAN TO SWING BACKWARDS AND FORWARDS AS THOUGH ON A  
TRAPEZE. IT STRETCHED OUT ITS LEGS RIGIDLY, THEN DID A BACKFLIP,  
BREAKING THE THREAD AND LANDING ON THE DESK, WHERE IT BEGAN TO  
CARTWHEEL IN CIRCLES. MEDDY WOKED HIS WAND, AND THE SPIDER

RISE UPON THE TAIL OF ITS HIND LEGS AND WENT INTO WHAT WAS UNMISTAKABLY A TAP DANCE.

EVERYONE WAS LAUGHING EVERYONE EXCEPT MEEHBY.

'THINK IT'S FUNNY, DEE YELLY' HE GIGGLED, 'YELLY'D LIKE IT, WOULD YELLY, IF I DID IT THE YELLY'

THE LAUGHTER DIED AWAY ALMOST INSTANTLY.

'WHAT CENTRELL, SAID MEEHBY ANXIETLY, AS THE SPIDER RALLIED ITSELF UP AND BEGAN THE REEL EVER AND EVER. I COULD MAKE IT LIMP FELT OFF THE WINDMILL, DROPPED ITSELF, THREW ITSELF DOWN HERE OFF YELLY'S THREATS ...

JOHN GAVE AN INVOLUNTARY SHIVER.

'YEARS BACK, THERE WERE A LOT OF WITCHES AND WIZARDS BEING CENTRELLLED BY THE IMPERIALS CLASSE, SAID MEEHBY, AND HARRY KNEW

HE WAS TALKING ABOUT THE DAYS IN WHICH VERDERMENT HAD BEEN ALL-PHYSICAL. SOME ONE FOR THE MINISTRY, TRYING THE SHIRT FELT WHICH WAS

BEING FORCED THE ACT, AND WHICH WAS ACTING OFF THEIR OWN FREE WILL.

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'THE IMPERIALS CLASSE CAN BE FELT, AND I'LL BE TEACHING YELLY FEEL, BUT IT TAKES REAL STRENGTH OF CHARACTER, AND NOT EVERYONE'S GET IT. BETTER AVOID BEING HIT WITH IT IF YELLY CAN. CONSTANT VIGILANCE!' HE BARKED, AND EVERYONE JUMPED.

MEEHBY PICKED UP THE SEMI-SALTING SPIDER AND THREW IT

BACK INTO THE AIR. ANYONE ELSE DOWN HERE? ANOTHER ILLEGAL

CLASSE?

HERMIONE'S HAND FLEW INTO THE AIR AGAIN AND SHE, THE HARRY'S SLIGHT SURPRISE, DID NEVILLE'S. THE ONLY CLASS IN WHICH NEVILLE USUALLY VOLUNTEERED INFORMATION WAS HERPETOLOGY, WHICH WAS EASILY HIS BEST SUBJECT. NEVILLE LOOKED SURPRISED AT HIS OWN DARING.

YES? SAID MURPHY, HIS MAGICAL EYE ROLLING RIGHT OVER THE FIX ON NEVILLE.

THERE'S HERE THE CRUCIATUS CURSE, SAID NEVILLE, IN A SMALL BUT DISTINCT VOICE.

MURPHY WAS LOOKING VERY INTENTLY AT NEVILLE, THIS TIME WITH KEEN EYES.

THEIR NAME'S LONGBOTTLE? HE SAID, HIS MAGICAL EYE SLIPPING DOWN THE CHECK THE REGISTER AGAIN.

NEVILLE NEEDED NERVOUSLY, BUT MURPHY MADE NO FURTHER ENQUIRIES. TURNING BACK TO THE CLASS AT LARGE, HE REACHED INTO THE JAR FOR THE NEXT SPIDER AND PLACED IT UPON THE DESKTOP, WHERE IT REMAINED MOTIONLESS, APPARENTLY THE SCARED THE MOVE.

THE CRUCIATUS CURSE, SAID MURPHY, NEEDS THE BE A BIT BIGGER FOR YOU TO GET THE IDEA, HE SAID, POINTING HIS HAND AT THE SPIDER. ENOUGH?

THE SPIDER SWELLED. IT WAS NOW LARGER THAN A TARANTULA. ABANDONING ALL PRETENCE, HE PUSHED HIS CHAIR BACKWARDS, AS FAR AWAY FROM MURPHY'S DESK AS POSSIBLE.

MURPHY RAISED HIS HAND AGAIN, POINTED IT AT THE SPIDER, AND

MUTTERED: CRICKET!

AT ONCE, THE SPIDER'S LEGS WENT IN UPON ITS BODY; IT REELLED BACK  
AND BEGAN THE TWITCH FIERCELY, RECKING FROM SIDE TO SIDE. NE  
SEEMED COME FROM IT, BUT HARRY WAS SURE THAT IF IT COULD HAVE

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GIVEN VICE, IT WOULD HAVE BEEN SCREAMING. MURDO DID NOT  
REMOVE HIS HAND, AND THE SPIDER STARTED THE SLIDDER AND IRON  
MORE VIOLENTLY

STOP IT! HERMIONIE SAID SHRILLY.

HARRY LOOKED AROUND AT HER. SHE WAS LOOKING, NOT AT THE SPI-  
DER, BUT AT NEVILLE, AND HARRY, FOLLOWING HER GAZE, SAW THAT

NEVILLE'S HANDS WERE CLENCHED UPON THE DESK IN FRONT OF HIM,  
HIS FINGERS WHITE, HIS EYES WIDE AND FIERCE.

MURDO RAISED HIS HAND. THE SPIDER'S LEGS RELAXED, BUT IT CON-  
TINUED THE TWITCH.

CRICKET, MURDO MUTTERED, AND THE SPIDER SPRAWLED BACK TO ITS  
PROPER SIZE. HE PUT IT BACK INTO THE JAR.

PAUSE, SAID MURDO SEPTLY. YOU DON'T NEED THERMISTERS FOR  
KNIVES THE THERMISTERS SHOWING IF YOU CAN PERFORM THE CRICKET'S  
CLARK ... THAT ONE WAS VERY POPULAR ONE, THEN.

RIGHT ... ANYONE KNOW ANY OTHERS?

HARRY LOOKED AROUND. FROM THE LOOKS ON EVERYONE'S FACES, HE

GUESSED THEY WERE ALL WONDERING WHAT WAS GOING TO HAPPEN THE  
THE LAST SPIDER, HERMINE'S HAND SEEMED SLIGHTLY AS, FOR THE THIRD  
TIME, SHE RAISED IT INTO THE AIR.

YES? SAID MEEBY, LEERING AT HER.

AVADA KEDAVRA, HERMINE WHISPERED.

SEVERAL PEOPLE LEANED LINEARLY AROUND AT HER, INCLUDING  
REN.

AH, SAID MEEBY, ANOTHER SLIGHT SMILE TWISTING HIS LIP-SIDED  
MOUTH. YES, THE LAST AND WORST. AVADA KEDAVRA ... THE KILLING  
CURSE.

HE PUT HIS HAND INTO THE GLASS JAR, AND ALMOST AS THOUGH IT  
KNEW WHAT WAS COMING, THE THIRD SPIDER SCUTTLED FRANTICALLY  
AROUND THE BOTTLE OF THE JAR, TRYING TO EVADE MEEBY'S FINGERS,  
BUT HE TRAPPED IT, AND PLACED IT UPON THE DESKTOP. IT STARTED TO  
SCUTTLE FRANTICALLY ACROSS THE WOODEN SURFACE.

MEEBY RAISED HIS HAND, AND HARRY FELT A SUDDEN THRILL OF  
SHRINKING.

AVADA KEDAVRA! MEEBY REARED.

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THERE WAS A FLASH OF BLINDING GREEN LIGHT AND A RUSHING  
SOUND, AS THOUGH A VAST, INVISIBLE SOMETHING WAS SHARING  
THROUGH THE AIR. INSTANTANEOUSLY THE SPIDER REELLED OVER BENT  
ITS BACK, UNMARKED, BUT UNMISTAKABLY DEAD. SEVERAL OF THE GIRLS  
STIFLED CRIES; REN HAD THROWN HIMSELF BACKWARDS AND ALMOST  
TOPPLED OFF HIS SEAT AS THE SPIDER SKIDDED TOWARDS HIM.  
MEEBY LIFTED THE DEAD SPIDER OFF THE DESK BENTHE THE FLOOR.

NOT NICE, HE SAID CALMLY, NOT PLEASANT, AND THERE'S NO  
WINTER-CLOUSE, THERE'S NO BUCKING IT, ONLY ONE KNOWN PERSON  
HAS EVER SURVIVED IT, AND HE'S SITTING RIGHT IN FRONT OF ME.  
HARRY FELT HIS FACE REDDEN AS MERRY'S EYES MET HIS. HE  
BURIED INTO HIS ELBOW, HE COULD FEEL EVERYONE ELSE LOOKING  
AROUND AT HIM, THEN, HARRY STARED AT THE BLANK BLACKBOARD AS  
THOUGH FASCINATED BY IT, BUT NOT REALLY SEEING IT AT ALL ...  
THAT WAS HOW HIS PARENTS HAD DIED ... EXACTLY LIKE THAT  
SPIDER, HAD THEY BEEN UNLEASHED AND UNMARKED, THEN? HAD  
THEY SIMPLY SEEN THE FLASH OF GREEN LIGHT AND HEARD THE RUSH OF  
SPEEDING DEATH, BEFORE LIFE WAS WIPED FROM THEIR BODIES?  
HARRY HAD BEEN PICTURING HIS PARENTS' DEATHS OVER AND OVER  
AGAIN FOR THREE YEARS NOW, EVER SINCE HE HAD FELT HE HAD  
BEEN MURDERED, EVER SINCE HE'D FELT HE HAD WHAT HAD HAPPENED  
THAT NIGHT: HOW WHORNTAIL HAD BETRAYED HIS PARENTS WHERE-  
ABOUTS THE VILDMERE, WHERE HE HAD COME TO FIND THEM AT THEIR  
COTTAGE, HOW VILDMERE HAD KILLED HARRY'S FATHER FIRST, HOW  
JAMES PETER HAD TRIED TO HOLD HIM OFF, WHILE HE STAYED AT HIS  
WIFE THE TALK HARRY AND ALAN ... AND VILDMERE HAD ADVANCED HIS  
LILY PETER, TOLD HER TO MOVE ASIDE SHE THAT HE COULD KILL HARRY  
... HOW SHE HAD BEGGED HIM TO KILL HER INSTEAD, REFUSED THE STEP  
SHIELDING HER THEN ... AND SHE VILDMERE HAD MURDERED HER, THEN,  
BEFORE TURNING HIS HAND ON HARRY ...  
HARRY KNEW THESE DETAILS BECAUSE HE HAD HEARD HIS PARENTS  
WHEN HE HAD FELT THE DEMENTORS LAST YEAR ... THAT

WAS THE TERRIBLE PAIN OF THE DEMENTHES! THE PAIN THEIR VICTIM

THE RELIVE THE WORST MEMORIES OF THEIR LIFE, AND DRIVEN, PAIN-  
LESS, IN THEIR OWN DESPAIR ...

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MEDDY WAS SPEAKING AGAIN, FROM A GREAT DISTANCE, IT SEEMED  
THE HARRY, WITH A MASSIVE EFFORT, HE PULLED HIMSELF BACK TO THE  
PRESENT, AND LISTENED TO WHAT MEDDY WAS SAYING.

AVADA KEDAVRA IS A CURSE THAT NEEDS A POWERFUL BIT OF MAGIC  
BEHIND IT YOU SHOULD ALL GET YOUR HANDS OUT NOW AND POINT  
THEM AT ME AND SAY THE WORDS, AND I BELIEVE I'D GET THE PLEASURE AS A  
NONSE-BLEED, BUT THAT DOESN'T MATTER, I'M NOT HERE TO TEACH YOU  
HOW TO DO IT.

NOW, IF THERE'S NO COUNTER-CURSE, WHY AM I SPEAKING YOU?  
BECAUSE YOU'VE GOTTEN THE DRAGON, YOU'VE GOTTEN THE APPRECIATE WHAT THE  
WORST IS, YOU DON'T WANT TO FIND YOURSELF IN A SITUATION WHERE  
YOU'RE FACING IT, CONSTANT VIGILANCE! HE REARED, AND THE  
WHOLE CLASS JUMPED AGAIN.

NOW ... THESE THREE CURSES AVADA KEDAVRA, IMPERIO AND  
CRUCIATUS ARE KNOWN AS THE UNFORGIVABLE CURSES. THE USE OF  
ANY ONE OF THEM BY A MORTAL HUMAN BEING IS ENOUGH TO EARN A  
LIFE SENTENCE IN AZKABAN, THAT'S WHAT YOU'RE UP AGAINST, THAT'S  
WHAT I'VE GOTTEN TO TEACH YOU THE FIGHT, YOU NEED PREPARING, YOU

NEED ARMING, BUT MOST OF ALL, YOU NEED THE PRACTISE CON-  
STANT, NEVER-CEASING VIGILANCE, GET OUT YOUR WILLS ... COPY THIS



DEHN ...

THEY SPENT THE REST OF THE LESSON TAKING NOTES ON EACH OF THE  
UNFORGETTABLE CLASSES. SHE HAD SPENT UNTIL THE BELL RANG BUT  
WHEN MISSY HAD DISMISSED THEM AND THEY HAD LEFT THE  
CLASSROOM, A THROTTLE OF TALK FIRST PERTED. MOST PEOPLE WERE  
DISCUSSING THE CLASSES IN ALOUD VOICES DID YOU SEE IT TWITCHE?  
AND WHEN HE KILLED IT JUST LIKE THAT?

THEY WERE TALKING ABOUT THE LESSON, HARRY THOUGHT, AS  
THOUGH IT HAD BEEN SOME SORT OF SPECTACULAR SCENE, BUT HE  
HADN'T FELT IT VERY ENTERTAINING AND NOW, IT SEEMED, HAD  
TERMINATED.

HARRY UP, SHE SAID TENSELY TO HARRY AND REEN.

WENT THE BLOODY LIBRARY AGAIN? SAID REEN.

NO, SAID HERMIONE CLUTCH, POINTING UP A SIDE PASSAGE.

NEVILLE.

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NEVILLE WAS STANDING ALONE, HALFWAY UP THE PASSAGE, STARING

AT THE STONE WALL OPPOSITE HIM WITH THE SAME FRIGHTED, WIDE-  
EYED LOOK HE HAD HAD WHEN MISSY HAD DEMONSTRATED THE

CRUCIATUS CURSE.

NEVILLE? HERMIONE SAID GENTLY.

NEVILLE BREATHED AHEARD.

HEH, HEHEH, HE SAID, HIS VOICE MUCH HIGHER THAN USUAL.

INTERESTING LESSON, WASN'T IT? I WONDER WHAT'S FOR DINNER, I'M  
I'M STARVING, AREN'T YOU?

NEVILLE, ARE YOU ALL RIGHT? SAID HERMIONE.

HEH, YES, I'M FINE, NEVILLE GABLED, IN THE SAME UNNATURALLY  
HIGH VOICE. VERY INTERESTING DINNER I MEAN LESSON WHAT'S FOR  
EATING?

HEH GAVE HARRY A STARTLED LOOK.

NEVILLE, WHAT?

BUT AN EBB CLINKING NOISE SHUNDED BEHIND THEM, AND THEY  
TURNED TO SEE PROFESSOR MURPHY LIMPING TOWARDS THEM. ALL FOUR  
OF THEM FELL SILENT, WATCHING HIM APPREHENSIVELY, BUT WHEN HE  
SPOKE, IT WAS IN A MUCH LOWER AND GENTLER TONE THAN THEY HAD  
YET HEARD.

IT'S ALL RIGHT, SHERID, HE SAID TO NEVILLE. WHY DON'T YOU COME  
UP TO MY OFFICE? COME ON ... WE CAN HAVE A CUP OF TEA ...

NEVILLE LOOKED EVEN MORE FRIGHTENED AT THE PROSPECT OF TEA  
WITH MURPHY, HE NEITHER MOVED NOR SPOKE.

MURPHY TURNED HIS MAGICAL EYE UPON HARRY. YOU ALL RIGHT, ARE  
YOU, PETER?

YES, SAID HARRY, ALMOST DEFIANTLY.

MURPHY'S BLUE EYE GLITTERED SLIGHTLY IN ITS SOCKET AS IT SUR-  
VEYED HARRY.

THEN HE SAID, YOU'VE GOT THE KNIFE. IT SEEMS HARSH, MAYBE,  
BUT YOU'VE GOT THE KNIFE. DON'T POINT PRETENDING ... WELL ... COME  
ON, LONGSHOTT, I'VE GOT SOME BOOKS THAT MIGHT INTEREST

PHIL.

NEVILLE BEHEADED PLEADINGLY AT HARRY, RON AND HERMIONIE, BUT THEY DIDN'T SAY ANYTHING, SEE NEVILLE HAD NO CHOICE BUT TO

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ALLOW HIMSELF TO BE STEERED AWAY, HEAR OF MURDER'S GROWLED HANDS ON HIS SHOULDER.

WHAT WAS THAT ABOUT? SAID RON, WATCHING NEVILLE AND MURDER TURN THE CORNER.

I DIDN'T KNOW, SAID HERMIONIE, LOOKING PENSIVE.

SOME LESSON, THOUGH, EH? SAID RON TO HARRY, AS THEY SET OFF FOR THE GREAT HALL. FRED AND GEORGE WERE RIGHT, WEREN'T THEY? HE REALLY KNOWS HIS STUFF, MURDER, DOESN'T HE? WHEN HE DID AVADA KEDAVRA, THE WAY THAT SPIDER JUST DIED, JUST SNAPPED IT RIGHT

BUT RON FELL SUDDENLY SILENT AT THE LOOK ON HARRY'S FACE, AND DIDN'T SPEAK AGAIN UNTIL THEY REACHED THE GREAT HALL, WHEN HE SAID HE SUGGESTED THEY HAD BETTER MAKE A START ON PROFESSOR TRILABNEY'S PREDICTIONS TONIGHT, AS THEY WOULD TAKE HOURS. HERMIONIE DID MEET THEM IN WITH HARRY AND RON'S CONVERSATION DURING DINNER, BUT ATE FLURRIEDLY FAST, AND THEN LEFT FOR THE LIBRARY AGAIN. HARRY AND RON WALKED BACK THE GRYFFINDOR TOWER, AND HARRY, WHO HAD BEEN THINKING OF NOTHING ELSE ALL THROUGH DINNER, NOW RAISED THE SUBJECT OF THE UNFORGIVABLE CURSES HIMSELF.

WOULDN'T MURDER AND DUMBLEDORE BE IN TROUBLE WITH THE MINISTRY IF THEY KNEW WE'D SEEN THE CURSES? HARRY ASKED, AS

THEY APPROACHED THE FAT LADY.

YEAH, PROBABLY, SAID RON. BUT DUMBLEDORE'S ALWAYS DONE THINGS HIS WAY, HASN'T HE, AND MEHMY'S BEEN GETTING IN TROUBLE HER YEARS, I RECKON. ATTACKS FIRST AND ASKS QUESTIONS LATER WHEN AT HIS DISCRETION, BALDERDASH.

THE FAT LADY SWUNG HERWARDS TO REVEAL THE ENTRANCE HOLE, AND THEY CLIMBED INTO GROWFINDER CHUMPHEN ROOM, WHICH WAS CRUMBED AND NEILY.

SHALL WE GET OUR DIVINATION STUFF, THEN? SAID HARRY.

I'LL PREPARE, RON GRINNED.

THEY WENT UP THE THE HERMITAGE TO FETCH THEIR BOOKS AND CHARTS, AND FINDING NEVILLE THERE ALONE, SITTING IN HIS BED, READING. HE LOOKED A GOOD DEAL CALMER THAN AT THE END OF

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MEHMY'S LESSON, THOUGH STILL NOT ENTIRELY NORMAL. HIS EYES WERE RATHER RED.

WELL ALL RIGHT, NEVILLE? HARRY ASKED HIM.

HEY YES, SAID NEVILLE, I'M FINE, THANKS. I'VE BEEN READING THIS BOOK PROFESSOR MEHMY LENT ME ...

HE HELD UP THE BOOK: MAGICAL MEDITERRANEAN WATER-PLANTS AND THEIR PROPERTIES.

APPARENTLY, PROFESSOR SPRELLT TOLD PROFESSOR MEHMY I'M REALLY GOOD AT HERBICIDIC, NEVILLE SAID. THERE WAS A FAINT NOTE OF PRIDE IN HIS VOICE THAT HARRY HAD RARELY HEARD THERE BEFORE.

HE THOUGHT I'D LIKE THIS.

TELLING NEVILLE WHAT PROFESSOR SPRELLT HAD SAID, HARRY

THOUGH, HAD BEEN A VERY TACTFUL WAY OF CHIPPING NEVILLE UP,  
AND NEVILLE VERY RARELY HEARD THAT HE WAS GOOD AT ANYTHING. IT  
WAS THE SORT OF THING PROFESSOR KLIPIN WOULD HAVE DONE,  
HARRY AND RON THEIR CHIEFS OF JEWELLING THE FUTURE  
BACK DOWN THE THE CHIMNEY REEF, AROUND A TABLE AND SET THE  
WORK ON THEIR PREDICTIONS FOR THE COMING MONTH. AN HOUR  
LATER, THEY HAD MADE VERY LITTLE PROGRESS, THOUGH THEIR TABLE WAS  
LITTERED WITH RITS OF PARCHEMENT BEARING SIGNS AND SYMBOLS, AND  
HARRY'S BRAIN WAS AS FOGGED AS THOUGH IT HAD BEEN FILLED WITH  
THE FLAMES FROM PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY'S FIRE.

I HAVEN'T GOT A CLUE WHAT THIS LEFT'S SLIPPED THE MEAN, HE  
SAID, STARING DOWN AT A LONG LIST OF CALCULATIONS.

WELL DONE, SAID RON, WHOSE HAIR WAS AN END BECAUSE OF ALL  
THE TIMES HE HAD RUN HIS FINGERS THROUGH IT IN FRUSTRATION. I  
THINK IT'S BACK TO THE OLD DIVINATION STANDBY.

WHAT MADE IT UP?

Yeah, SAID RON, SLEEPING THE LIMB OF SCRAWLED NOTES OFF  
THE TABLE, DIPPING HIS PEN INTO SOME INK AND STARTING TO WRITE.

NEXT MORNING, HE SAID, AS HE SCRIBBLED, I AM LIKELY TO  
DEVELOP A COLD, BEING THE THE UNLIKELY CONJUNCTION OF MARS  
AND JUPITER. HE LOOKED UP AT HARRY. WELL DONE HER JUST PUT  
IN

HEADS OF MISERY, SHE'LL LAP IT UP.

RIGHT, SAID HARRY, CRUMPLING UP HIS FIRST ATTEMPT AND

THE HARRY PENTTER

LOOKING IT OVER THE HEADS OF A GROUP OF CHATTERING FIRST-YEARS

INTO THE FIRE. ~~AND~~ ... ~~ON~~ ~~MONDAY~~, I WILL BE IN DANGER ~~OF~~ ~~BE~~ ~~RETURN~~ING.

YEAH, ~~THEY~~ WILL BE, SAID ~~THEY~~ DARKLY, WE'RE SEEING THE ~~SORROWS~~ AGAIN ~~ON~~ ~~MONDAY~~, ~~AND~~, TUESDAY, I ~~AM~~ ... ~~ERM~~ ...

LOST A TREASURED POSSESSION, SAID ~~THEY~~, ~~WHICH~~ WAS FLICKING THROUGH LAMPING THE FUTURE ~~FOR~~ IDEAS.

GOOD ~~ONE~~, SAID ~~THEY~~, COPYING IT DOWN. ~~BECAUSE~~ ~~OF~~ ... ~~ERM~~

... MERCURY, ~~WHY~~ ~~DOESN'T~~ ~~THEY~~ GET STABBED IN THE BACK BY SOME-  
ONE ~~THEY~~ ~~THEY~~ ~~WAS~~ A FRIEND?

YEAH ... ~~THEY~~ ... SAID ~~THEY~~, STRIKING IT DOWN, ~~BECAUSE~~ ...  
VENUS IS IN THE TWELFTH ~~HOUSE~~.

AND ~~ON~~ ~~WEDNESDAY~~, I THINK I ~~AM~~ ~~COME~~ ~~OFF~~ ~~WHERST~~ IN A FIGHT.

AAAH, I WAS GOING TO HAVE A FIGHT, ~~AND~~, I ~~AM~~ ~~LOST~~ A BET.

YEAH, ~~THEY~~ ~~AM~~ BE GETTING I ~~AM~~ WIN MY FIGHT ...

THEY CONTINUED TO MAKE UP PREDICTIONS (WHICH GREW STRAD-  
ILY MORE TRAGIC) ~~FOR~~ ANOTHER ~~HOUSE~~, WHILE THE ~~COMMON~~ ~~THEM~~

ARELAND THEM SILENTLY EMPTIED AS PEOPLE WENT UP THE BED.

CREEPY-LOOKS WANDERED OVER THE THEM, LEAPT LIGHTLY INTO AN  
EMPTY CHAIR, AND STARED INSOLITABLY AT ~~THEY~~, RATHER AS  
HERMIONE MIGHT ~~LOOK~~ IF SHE KNEW THEY WEREN'T DOING THEIR  
HOUSEWORK PROPERLY.

STARING ARELAND THE ~~THEM~~, TRYING TO THINK OF A KIND OF MISPER-

THINK HE HADN'T YET LIVED, HARRY SAW FRED AND GEORGE SITTING

TOGETHER AGAINST THE OPPOSITE WALL, HEADS TOGETHER, EYES HILT, PIERING OVER A SINGLE PIECE OF PARCHMENT. IT WAS MOST UNUSUAL TO SEE FRED AND GEORGE HIDDEN AWAY IN A CORNER AND WORKING SILENTLY; THEY USUALLY LIED THERE IN THE THICK OF THINGS, AND THE NOISY CENTRE OF ATTENTION. THERE WAS SOMETHING SECRETIVE ABOUT THE WAY THEY WERE WORKING ON THE PIECE OF PARCHMENT, AND HARRY WAS REMINDED OF HOW THEY HAD SAT TOGETHER WRITING SOMETHING BAD AT THE BURIAL. HE HAD THOUGHT THEN THAT IT WAS ANOTHER ORDER FROM THE WEASLEYS' WIZARD WIFEZES, BUT IT DIDN'T LOOK LIKE THAT THIS TIME; IF IT HAD BEEN, THEY WOULD SURELY HAVE LET SEE JORDAN IN THE MIDDLE. HE WONDERED WHETHER IT HAD ANYTHING TO DO WITH ENTERING THE TRIWIZARD TOURNAMENT.

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AS HARRY WATCHED, GEORGE SHOOK HIS HEAD AT FRED, SCRATCHED SOMETHING HILT WITH HIS EYELID AND SAID, IN A VERY QUIET VOICE THAT NEVERTHELESS CARRIED ACROSS THE ALMOST DESERTED ROOM, "OH

THAT SOUNDS LIKE WE'RE ACCUSING HIM. GET THERE CAREFUL ...

THEN GEORGE LOOKED OVER AND SAW HARRY WATCHING HIM.

HARRY GRINNED, AND QUICKLY RETURNED TO HIS PREDICTIONS. HE DIDN'T WANT GEORGE TO THINK HE WAS EAVESDROPPING. SHORTLY AFTER THAT, THE TWINS REELLED UP THEIR PARCHMENT, SAID GOODNIGHT AND WENT OFF TO BED.

FRED AND GEORGE HAD BEEN GONE TEN MINUTES OR SO WHEN THE PORTRAIT HOLE OPENED AND HERMION CLIMBED INTO THE CHAIR

REHM, CARRYING A SHEAF OF PARCHMENT IN ONE HAND AND A BOOK

WHOSE CONTENTS RATTLED AS SHE WALKED, IN THE OTHER. CRHEX-  
SHANDS ARCHED HIS BACK, PLURING.

WELLER, SHE SAID, I VE ILST FINISHED!

SEE HAVE I? SAID REHM TRIUMPHANTLY, THROWING DOWN HIS HILL.  
BERMINE SAT DOWN, LAID THE THINGS SHE WAS CARRYING IN AN  
EMPTY ARMCHAIR AND PULLED REHM S PREDICTIONS TOWARDS HER.  
NEET GING THE HAVE A VERY GOOD MENTH, ARE YELL? SHE SAID  
SARDONICALLY, AS CRHEXSHANDS CURLED UP IN HER LAP.

AS WELL, AT LEAST I M FEREWARNED, REHM YALINED.

YELL SEEM THE BE DREELING TWICE, SAID BERMINE.

HEH, AM I? SAID REHM, PEERING DOWN AT HIS PREDICTIONS. I D  
BETTER CHANGE ONE OF THEM THE GETTING TRAMPLED BY A RAMPAGING  
HIPPHGRIF.

DOWN T YELL THINK IT S A KIT HEVIELIS YELL VE MADE THESE LIP?  
SAID BERMINE.

THE DARK YELL? SAID REHM, IN MICK ELTRAGE. WE VE BEEN  
WHIRLING LIKE FELLIS-ELVES HERE?

BERMINE RAISED HER EYEBROWS.

IT S ILST AN EXPRESSION, SAID REHM HASTILY.

HARRY LAID DOWN HIS HILL, THEN, HAVING ILST FINISHED PREDICT-  
ING HIS OWN DEATH BY DECAPITATION.

WHAT S IN THE BOOK? HE ASKED, POINTING AT IT.



FLINDY WHU SHOULD ASK, SAID HERMIENE, WITH A NASTY LEER AT

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RHEN, SHE THREW OFF THE LID, AND SHOWED THEM THE CONTENTS.

INSIDE WERE ABOUT FIFTY BADGES, ALL OF DIFFERENT COLORS, BUT ALL BEARING THE SAME LETTERS: S.P.E.W.

SPEW ? SAID HARRY, PICKING UP A BADGE AND LOOKING AT IT.

WHAT IS THIS ABOUT?

NEET SPEW, SAID HERMIENE IMPATIENTLY. IT S S P E W.  
STANDS FOR THE SOCIETY FOR THE PROMOTION OF ELFISH WELFARE.

NEVER HEARD OF IT, SAID RHEN.

WELL, OF COURSE YOU HAVEN'T, SAID HERMIENE CRISPLY, I VE  
ONLY JUST STARTED IT.

YEAH? SAID RHEN IN MILD SURPRISE. FEW MANY MEMBERS HAVE  
YOU GOT?

WELL IF YOU TWO JOIN THREE, SAID HERMIENE.

AND YOU THINK WE WANT THE WALK ABOUT WEARING BADGES  
SAYING SPEW, OH YOU? SAID RHEN.

S P E W? SAID HERMIENE HEFTY, I WAS GIVING THE PLUT  
STEP THE ELITRAGEOUS ASIDE OF ELFISH FELLOW MAGICAL CREATURES  
AND CAMPAIGN FOR A CHANGE IN THEIR LEGAL STATUS BUT IT  
WOULDN'T FIT. SEE THAT IS THE HEADING OF MY MANIFESTO.  
SHE BRANDISHED THE SHEAF OF PARCHMENT AT THEM. I VE BEEN  
RESEARCHING IT THOROUGHLY IN THE LIBRARY, ELF ENSLAVEMENT GOES  
BACK CENTURIES, I CAN'T BELIEVE NONE OF US THINK ANYTHING ABOUT IT  
BEFORE NOW.

HERMIENE OPEN HER EARS, SAID RHEN LULLABY. THEY, LIKE IT.

THEY LIKE BEING ENSLAVED?

ELIJAH SHORT-TERM AIMS, SAID HERMIONE, SPEAKING EVEN MORE  
LOUDLY THAN RON, AND ACTING AS THOUGH SHE HADN'T HEARD A

WORD, ARE THE SEVERE FEELISE-ELVES FAIR WAGES AND WORKING CONDI-  
TIONS, ELIJAH LONG-TERM AIMS INCLUDE CHANGING THE LAW ABOUT

NON-HUMAN-LIFE, AND TRYING TO GET AN ELF INTO THE DEPARTMENT FOR  
THE REGULATION AND CONTROL OF MAGICAL CREATURES, BECAUSE  
THEY'RE SHOCKINGLY UNDER-REPRESENTED,

AND HOW DO WE DO ALL THIS? HARRY ASKED,

WE START BY RECRUITING MEMBERS, SAID HERMIONE HAPPILY, I  
THOUGHT TWO SICKLES THE MIN THAT BUYS A BADGE AND THE

THE UNIVERCIVALLY CLOSES 177

PROCEEDS CAN FUND ELIJAH LEAFLET CAMPAIGN, SHE'LL BE TREASURER, RON

I'VE GOT SHE'LL A COLLECTING TIN UPSTAIRS AND HARRY, SHE'LL BE SECRE-  
TARY, SHE SHE'LL MIGHT WANT TO WRITE DOWN EVERYTHING I'M SAYING

WELL, AS A RECORD OF ELIJAH FIRST MEETING,

THERE WAS A PAUSE IN WHICH HERMIONE BEAMED AT THE PAIR OF  
THEM, AND HARRY SAT, THEN BETWEEN EXASPERATION AT HERMIONE,

AND AMUSEMENT AT THE LOOK ON RON'S FACE, THE SILENCE WAS BROKE-  
KEN, NOT BY RON, WHO IN ANY CASE LOOKED AS THOUGH HE WAS

TEMPERARILY DUMSTRIKED, ELIT BY A SHEET TAP, TAP HEN THE WINDHIN.  
F-JARRY LEEKED ACROSS THE NEW EMPTY CHITHEIN REEM, AND SAW,  
ILLUMINATED BY THE MEEHLIGHT, A SNEELY HAW PERCHED HEN THE  
WINDHILSILL.

F-JEDWIG? HE SEHELTED, AND HE LALINCHED HIMSELF ELIT HE HIS  
CHAIR AND ACROSS THE REEM THE PLIL HOPEN THE WINDHIN.  
F-JEDWIG FLEW INSIDE, SEARED ACROSS THE REEM AND LANDED HEN  
THE TABLE HEN THEP HE F-JARRY S PREDICTIENS.

ARHUT TIME? SAID F-JARRY, FLIRRYING AFTER HER.

SHE S GEE AN ANSWER? SAID REEN EXCITEDLY, PHINTING AT THE  
GRLEKY PICEE HE PARCHEMENT TIED THE F-JEDWIG S LEG.

F-JARRY HASTILY LINTIED IT AND SAT DEELN THE READ IT, WHEKELIPHEN  
F-JEDWIG FLUTTERED HENTHE HIS DORR, FHEHTING SEETLY.

WHAT DEES IT SAY? F-HERMINEE ASKED KEATEHLESSLY.

THE LETTER WAS VERY SEHRT, AND LEEKED AS THEELGH IT HAD BEEN  
STRALLED IN A GREAT FLIRRY, F-JARRY READ IT ALHLD:

F-JARRY

I M FLYING NERTH IMMEDIATELY, THIS NEWS ARHUT YELIR SCAR IS  
THE LATEST IN A SERIES HE STRANGE RUMHELIRS THAT HAVE REACHED ME  
HERE. IF IT FLIRTS AGAIN, GEE STRAIGHT THE DUMBLEDEHRE THEY RE  
SAYING HE S GEE MAD-LYE ELIT HE RETIREMENT, WHICH MEANS HE S  
READING THE SIGNS, EVEN IF NEE HNE ELSE IS.

I LL BE IN THELCH SEHEN, MY BEST THE REEN AND F-HERMINEE. DEEP  
YELIR EYES HOPEN, F-JARRY,

SIRILIS

END F-JARRY PEEETTER

HARRY LEANED UP AT RICH AND HERMINE, WHO STARED BACK AT HIM.

HE'S FLYING NEARBY? HERMINE WHISPERED. HE'S CHEERING BACK? OLIMPELORRE'S READING WHAT SIGNS? SAID RICH, LEANING PERPLEXED. HARRY WHAT'S UP?

BEH HARRY HAD JUST HIT HIMSELF IN THE FOREHEAD WITH HIS FIST, HEATING FREDWIG HEAT UP HIS LAP.

I SHOULDNT VY TELL HIM? HARRY SAID FLIRTELISLY.

WHAT ARE YOU MEN ABILITY? SAID RICH, IN SURPRISE.

IT'S MADE HIM THINK HE'S GET THE CHEER BACK? SAID HARRY, NOW SLAMMING HIS FIST ON THE TABLE SEE THAT FREDWIG LANDED ON THE BACK OF RICH'S CHAIR, HITTING INDIGNANTLY. CHEERING BACK, BECAUSE HE THINKS I'M IN TROUBLE? AND THERE'S NOTHING WRONG WITH ME? AND I HAVEN'T GET ANYTHING FOR YOU, HARRY SNAPPED AT FREDWIG, WHO WAS CLICKING HER BEAK EXPECTANTLY, YOU'LL HAVE TO GET UP THE THE HILLERY IF YOU WANT FEED.

FREDWIG GAVE HIM AN EXTREMELY OFFENDED LEER AND THREW OFF HER THE OPEN WINDOW, CLIPPING HIM AROUND THE HEAD WITH HER ELTSTRETCHED WING AS SHE WENT.

HARRY, HERMINE BEGAN, IN A PACIFYING TONE OF VOICE.

I'M GETTING THE RED, SAID HARRY SHORTLY. SEE YOU IN THE MORNING.

UPSTAIRS IN THE DORMITORY HE PULLED ON HIS PYJAMAS AND GET INTO HIS BEDROOM-POSTER, BUT HE DIDN'T FEEL REMOTELY TIRED.

IF STIRILS CAME BACK AND GET CALIGIT, IT WOULD BE HIS, HARRY'S, PAINT, WHY HADN'T HE KEPT HIS MENTAL SKILL? A FEW SECONDS PAIN AND HE'D HAD THE CLAR ... IF HE'D JUST HAD THE SENSE TO KEEP IT THE

HIMSELF ...

HE HEARD REIN CAME UP INTO THE DORMITORY A SHORT WHILE

LATER, BUT DID NOT SPEAK TO HIM. FOR A LONG TIME, HARRY LAY STAR-  
ING UP AT THE DARK CANOPY OF HIS BED. THE DORMITORY WAS COM-  
PLETELY SILENT, AND, HAD HE BEEN LESS PREOCCUPIED, HARRY WOULD

HAVE REALISED THAT THE ABSENCE OF NEVILLE'S USUAL SNORES MEANT  
THAT HE WAS NOT THE ONLY ONE LYING AWAKE.

## CHAPTER FIFTEEN

REALIZATION AND

DISMAY

EARLY NEXT MORNING, HARRY Woke WITH A PLAN FULLY FORMED IN  
HIS MIND, AS THOUGH HIS SLEEPING BRAIN HAD BEEN WORKING ON IT  
ALL NIGHT. HE GOT UP, DRESSED IN THE PALE DAWN LIGHT, LEFT THE  
DORMITORY WITHOUT WAKING REIN AND WENT BACK DOWN THE THE  
DESERTED COMMON ROOM. THERE HE TOOK A PIECE OF PARCHMENT  
FROM THE TABLE UPON WHICH HIS DIVINATION HOMEWORK STILL LAY,  
AND WROTE THE FOLLOWING LETTER:

DEAR SIRIUS,

I RECKON I JUST IMAGINED MY SCAR FLIRTING. I WAS HALF-ASLEEP  
WHEN I WROTE THE YELL LAST TIME. THERE'S NO POINT COMING BACK,  
EVERYTHING'S FINE HERE. DON'T WORRY ABOUT ME, MY HEAD FEELS  
COMPLETELY NORMAL.

HARRY

HE THEN CLIMBED UPON THE PORTRAIT HOLE, UP THROUGH THE SILENT CASTLE HILL UP ONLY BRIEFLY BY PEEVES, WHEN TRIED THE EVERTLAND A LARGE VASE AND HIM HALFWAY ALONG THE FORTY-FOUR CHAIRS, FINALLY ARRIVING AT THE HILLERY, WHICH WAS SITUATED AT THE TOP OF WEST TOWER.

THE HILLERY WAS A CIRCULAR STONE ROOM; RATHER COLD AND DRAUGHTY, BECAUSE NONE OF THE WINDOWS HAD GLASS IN THEM. THE FLOOR WAS ENTIRELY COVERED IN STRAW, HILL DROPPINGS AND THE RELEGITATED SKELETONS OF MICE AND WHEELS. HUNDREDS UPON

THE HARRY PETER

HUNDREDS OF EGGS OF EVERY KIND IMAGINABLE WERE NESTLED HERE AND PERCHES THAT ROSE RIGHT UP TO THE TOP OF THE TOWER, NEARLY ALL OF THEM ASLEEP, THOUGH HERE AND THERE A REDDISH AMBER EYE GLARED AT HARRY. HE SPOTTED FREDIE NESTLED BETWEEN A BARN HILL AND A TAIL, AND HURRIED OVER THE HILL, SLIDING A LITTLE AND THE DROPPING-STRAW FLOOR.

IT TOOK HIM A LITTLE WHILE TO PERSUADE HER TO WALK UP AND THEN HE LOOKED AT HIM AS SHE KEPT SHUFFLING AROUND ON HER PERCH, SHOWING HIM HER TAIL. SHE WAS EVIDENTLY STILL FLIRTLIS ABOUT HIS LACK OF GRATITUDE THE PREVIOUS NIGHT. IN THE END, IT WAS HARRY SUGGESTING SHE MIGHT BE TOO TIRED, AND THAT PERHAPS HE WOULD ASK HER THE BIRDHILL PIGWIDGER, THAT MADE HER STOP UPON HER LEG AND ALLOW HIM TO TIE THE LETTER TO IT.

JUST FIND HIM, ALL RIGHT? HARRY SAID, STRETCHING HER BACK AS HE CARRIED HER ON HIS ARM TO ONE OF THE HILLS IN THE WALL. BEHOLD

THE DEMENTHRS BE.

SHE NIPPED HIS FINGER, PERHAPS RATHER HARDER THAN SHE WOULD  
ORDINARILY HAVE DONE, BUT FLINCHED SLIGHTLY IN A REASSURING SORT OF  
WAY ALL THE SAME. THEN SHE SPREAD HER WINGS AND THREW HIM INTO  
THE SURPRISE. HARRY WATCHED HER GO OUT OF SIGHT WITH THE FAMILIAR  
FEELING OF LINGERS BACK IN HIS STOMACH. HE HAD BEEN SO SURE THAT  
SIRIL'S REPLY WOULD ALLEVIATE HIS WORRIES RATHER THAN INCREASING  
THEM.

\*

THAT WAS A LIE, HARRY, SAID HERMIONE SHARPLY OVER BREAKFAST,  
WHEN HE TOLD HER AND RON WHAT HE HAD DONE. SHE DIDN'T  
IMAGINE HER SCAR FLIRTING AND SHE KNEW IT.

SEE WHAT? SAID HARRY. HE'S NOT GOING BACK TO AZKABAN  
BECAUSE OF ME.

DON'T IT, SAID RON SHARPLY TO HERMIONE, AS SHE OPENED HER  
MOUTH TO ARGUE SOME MORE, AND FOR ONCE, HERMIONE HEDED  
HIM, AND FELL SILENT.

HARRY DID HIS BEST NOT TO WHISPER ABOUT SIRIL'S DEATH THE NEXT  
CHANCE HE GOT. TRUE, HE COULD NOT STOP HIMSELF WHISPERING  
ANXIOUSLY ABOUT EVERY MORNING WHEN THE POST HORN ARRIVED.

REALIZATION AND DISMAYING THE

NEAR, LATE AT NIGHT BEFORE HE WENT TO SLEEP, PREVENT HIMSELF  
SEEING HORRIBLE VISIONS OF SIRIL'S, CHOKED BY DEMENTHRS DOWN  
SOME DARK LONDON STREET, BUT BETWEEN TIMES HE TRIED TO KEEP

HIS MIND OFF HIS CHOCATE-HER. HE WISHED HE STILL HAD HILDBITCH THE  
DISTRACT HIM; NOTHING WORKED SHE WELL IN A TWEAKED MIND AS A  
GOOD, HARD TRAINING SESSION. THEN THE OTHER HAND, THEIR LESSONS  
WERE BECOMING MORE DIFFICULT AND DEMANDING THAN EVER BEFORE,  
PARTICULARLY DEFENCE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS.

THE THEIR SURPRISE, PROFESSOR MENDOY HAD ANNOUNCED THAT HE  
WOULD BE PUTTING THE IMPERILS CLUSE ON EACH OF THEM IN TURN,  
THE DEMONSTRATE ITS POWER AND THE SEE WHETHER THEY COULD RESIST  
ITS EFFECTS.

BUT BUT YELI SAID IT S ILLEGAL, PROFESSOR, SAID FERMINE  
UNCERTAINLY, AS MENDOY CLEARED AWAY THE DESKS WITH A SWEEP OF  
HIS WAND, LEAVING A LARGE CLEAR SPACE IN THE MIDDLE OF THE ROOM.

YELI SAID THE USE IT AGAINST ANOTHER HUMAN WAS  
DUMBLEDORE WANTS YELI TALKED WHAT IT FEELS LIKE, SAID  
MENDOY, HIS MAGICAL EYE SWIVELLING TOWARD FERMINE AND FIXING  
HER WITH AN EERIE, UNBLINKING STARE. IF YELI D RATHER LEARN THE

HARD WAY WHEN SOMETHING S PUTTING IT ON YELI SHE THEY CAN CON-  
TAIN YELI COMPLETELY FINE BY ME, YELI RE EXCUSED, OFF YELI GO.

HE POINTED HER CHARLED FINGER TOWARDS THE DOOR. FERMINE  
WENT VERY PINK, AND MUTTERED SOMETHING ABOUT NOT MEANING  
THAT SHE WANTED THE LEAVE. HARRY AND RON GRINNED AT EACH OTHER.  
THEY KNEW FERMINE WOULD RATHER EAT BUBBLER POPS THAN  
MISS SUCH AN IMPORTANT LESSON.

MENDOY BEGAN THE ROOM'S STUDENTS FORWARD IN TURN AND PUT  
THE IMPERILS CLUSE UPON THEM. HARRY WATCHED AS, ONE BY ONE,



HIS CLASSMATES DID THE MOST EXTRAORDINARY THINGS UNDER ITS INFLUENCE, DEAN THOMAS HOPPED THREE TIMES AROUND THE ROOM,

SINGING THE NATIONAL ANTHEM, LAVENDER GREEN IMITATED A SEWIRREL, NEVILLE PERFORMED A SERIES OF WHITE ASTONISHING GYMNASTICS

HE WOULD CERTAINLY NOT HAVE BEEN CAPABLE OF IN HIS NORMAL STATE, NOT ONE OF THEM SEEMED TO BE ABLE TO FIGHT THE CURSE OFF, AND EACH OF THEM RECOVERED ONLY WHEN MURDER HAD REMOVED IT.

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POTTER, MURDER GRIELED, WELL NEXT,

HARRY MOVED FORWARD INTO THE MIDDLE OF THE CLASSROOM, INTO THE SPACE THAT MURDER HAD CLEARED OF DESKS, MURDER RAISED HIS WAND, POINTED IT AT HARRY, AND SAID, IMPERIO.

IT WAS THE MOST WONDERFUL FEELING, HARRY FELT A FLOATING SENSATION AS EVERY THOUGHT AND WHIRL IN HIS HEAD WAS WIPED GENTLY AWAY, LEAVING NOTHING BUT A VAGUE, UNTRACEABLE HAPPINESS,

HE STOOD THERE FEELING IMPENSELY RELAXED, ONLY DIMLY AWARE OF EVERYONE WATCHING HIM,

AND THEN HE HEARD MAD-LY MURDER'S VOICE, ECHOING IN SOME DISTANT CHAMBER OF HIS EMPTY BRAIN: LUMP INTO THE DESK ... LUMP INTO THE DESK ...

HARRY KENT HIS KNEES EMBODIENTLY, PREPARING TO SPRING,

LUMP INTO THE DESK ...

WELL, THINK?

ANOTHER VEHICLE HAD AWOKEN IN THE BACK OF HIS BRAIN. STUPID  
THING THE ONE, REALLY, SAID THE VEHICLE.

LUMP INTO THE DESK ...

NEE, I DONT THINK I WILL, THANKS, SAID THE OTHER VEHICLE, A LITTLE  
MORE FIRMLY ... NEE, I DONT REALLY WANT THE ...

LUMP: NEE:

THE NEXT THING HARRY FELT WAS CONSIDERABLE PAIN. HE HAD  
KEENLY LUMPED AND TRIED TO PREVENT HIMSELF FROM LUMPING. THE  
RESULT WAS THAT HE D SMASHED HEADLINE INTO THE DESK, KNECKING  
IT OVER, AND, BY THE FEELING IN HIS LEGS, FRACTURED KEENLY HIS  
KNEECAPS.

NEE, THAT S MORE LIKE IT! GRIELED MEEHYS VEHICLE, AND

SLUDENLY HARRY FELT THE EMPTY, ECHING FEELING IN HIS HEAD DIS-  
APPEAR. HE REMEMBERED EXACTLY WHAT WAS HAPPENING, AND THE

PAIN IN HIS KNEES SEEMED THE DILKLE.

LOOK AT THAT, WELL BEAT ... BETTER FEELING! HE FEELING IT, AND HE  
DAMN NEAR BEAT IT! WE LL TRY THAT AGAIN, BETTER, AND THE REST OF  
WELL, PAY ATTENTION. WATCH HIS EYES, THAT S WHERE WELL SEE IT

VERY GOOD, BETTER, VERY GOOD INDEED! THEY LL HAVE TREKLE CHEN-  
TRELLING WELL!

REALIZATIONS AND DISMSTRANG ZOS

THE WAY HE TALKS, HARRY MUTTERED, AS HE FEEKLED BEAT OF THE

DEFENCE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS CLASS AN HOUR LATER (MEHNDY HAD INSISTED ON PUTTING HARRY THROUGH HIS PACES FOUR TIMES IN A ROW, UNTIL HARRY COULD THROW THE CLOSE OFF ENTIRELY), SHE'D THOUGHT WE WERE ALL GOING TO BE ATTACKED AND SEEN.

YEAH, I KNOW, SAID RON, WHO WAS SKIPPING ON EVERY ALTERNATE STEP. HE HAD HAD MUCH MORE DIFFICULTY WITH THE CLOSE

THAN HARRY, THOUGH MEHNDY ASSURED HIM THE EFFECTS WOULD HAVE WORN OFF BY LUNCHTIME. TALK ABOUT PARANOID ... RON GLANCED

NERVOUSLY OVER HIS SHOULDER TO CHECK THAT MEHNDY WAS DEFINITELY OUT OF EARSHOT, AND WENT ON. SHE WISHED THEY WERE GLAD TO

GET SHUT OF HIM AT THE MINISTRY, DID SHE HEAR HIM TELLING SCAMPIES WHAT HE DID THE THAT WITCH WHO SHOUTED SHEE BEHIND HIM ON APRIL FOLLOWS DAY? AND WHEN ARE WE SUPPOSED TO READ UP ON RESISTING THE IMPERIALS CLUSE WITH EVERYTHING ELSE WE'VE GOT TO DO?

ALL THE FOURTH-YEARS HAD NOTICED A DEFINITE INCREASE IN THE AMOUNT OF WORK THEY WERE REQUIRED TO DO THIS TERM. PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL EXPLAINED WHY, WHEN THE CLASS GAVE A PARTICULARLY HELD GREEN AT THE AMOUNT OF TRANSFIGURATION HOMEWORK SHE HAD SET.

SHE ARE NOW ENTERING A MOST IMPORTANT PHASE OF YOUR

MAGICAL EDUCATION: SHE TOLD THEM, HER EYES GLINTING DANGER-

HELISLY BEHIND HER SQUARE SPECTACLES. THEIR ORDINARY WIZARDING

LEVELS ARE DRAWING CLOSER

WE HEN'T TAKE HILLS TIL FIFTH YEAR! SAID DEAN THOMAS  
INDIGNANTLY.

MAYBE NOT, THOMAS, BUT BELIEVE ME, WE'LL NEED ALL THE PREPA-  
RATION WE CAN GET! MISS CRANGER REMAINS THE ONLY PERSON IN

THIS CLASS WHO HAS MANAGED TO TURN A FROGKING INTO A SATISFA-  
CTORY FINISHING. I MIGHT REMIND YOU THAT YOUR FINISHING,

THOMAS, STILL CURLS UP IN FRIGHT IF ANYONE APPROACHES IT WITH A  
PIN!

HERMIONE, WHO HAD TURNED RATHER PINK AGAIN, SEEMED TO BE  
TRYING NOT TO LOOK TOO PLEASED WITH HERSELF.

THE HARRY POTTER

HARRY AND RON WERE DEEPLY AMUSED WHEN PROFESSOR

TRILAWNEY TOLD THEM THAT THEY HAD RECEIVED THE MARKS FOR THEIR  
HOMELWORK IN THEIR NEXT DIVINATION CLASS. SHE READ OUT LARGE  
PORTIONS OF THEIR PREDICTIONS, COMMENDING THEM FOR THEIR  
UNFLINCHING ACCEPTANCE OF THE PERILS IN STORE FOR THEM BUT  
THEY WERE LESS AMUSED WHEN SHE ASKED THEM TO DO THE SAME  
THING FOR THE MONTH AFTER NEXT; BOTH OF THEM WERE RUNNING OUT  
OF IDEAS FOR CATASTROPHES.

MEANWHILE PROFESSOR KILNIX, THE CHEST-WHITE TALIGHT HISTORICAL

OF MAGIC, HAD THEM WRITING WEEKLY ESSAYS ON THE GERMAN

REBELLIONS OF THE EIGHTEENTH CENTURY. PROFESSOR Snape was FEAR-  
ING THEM THE RESEARCH ANTI-DOTES. THEY THOUGHT THIS SERIOUSLY, AS HE

HAD HINTED THAT HE MIGHT BE POISONING ONE OF THEM BEFORE  
CHRISTMAS TO SEE IF THEIR ANTI-DOTE WORKED. PROFESSOR FLITWICK  
HAD ASKED THEM TO READ THREE EXTRA BOOKS IN PREPARATION FOR  
THEIR LESSON ON SUMMERING CHARM.

EVEN Hagrid WAS ADDING TO THEIR WORKLOAD. THE BLAST-ENDED  
SKELETONS WERE GROWING AT A REMARKABLE PACE, GIVEN THAT NEHEMUS  
HAD YET DISCOVERED WHAT THEY ATE. Hagrid WAS DELIGHTED AND, AS  
PART OF THEIR PROJECT, SUGGESTED THAT THEY COME DOWN TO HIS  
HUT ON ALTERNATE EVENINGS TO RESERVE THE SKELETONS AND MAKE  
NOTES ON THEIR EXTRAORDINARY BEHAVIOUR.

I WILL NOT, SAID DRACE MALFOY FLATLY, WHEN Hagrid HAD PRE-  
PARED THIS WITH THE AIR OF FATHER CHRISTMAS PULLING AN EXTRA

LARGE TUB FROM HIS SACK. I SEE ENOUGH OF THESE FOLLY THINGS DURING  
LESSONS, THANKS.

Hagrid'S SMILE FADED FROM HIS FACE.

YOU'LL SEE WHAT YOU THINK, HE GROANED, BUT I'LL BE TAKING A LEAF  
OUTTA PROFESSOR MEENEY'S BOOK ... I HEAR YOU MADE A GOOD PURCHASER,  
MALFOY.

THE GRYPFINDERS REARED WITH LAUGHTER. MALFOY ALLISHED WITH

ANGER, BUT APPARENTLY THE MEMORY OF MURDER'S PUNISHMENT WAS STILL SUFFICIENTLY PAINFUL TO STOP HIM RETORTING. HARRY, RON AND HERMION RETURNED TO THE CASTLE AT THE END OF THE LESSON IN HIGH SPIRITS; SEEING HAGRID PLIT DOWN MALFOY WAS PARTICULARLY

REALIZATIONS AND DUMSTRANG ZON

SATISFYING, ESPECIALLY BECAUSE MALFOY HAD DONE HIS VERY BEST TO GET HAGRID SACKED THE PREVIOUS YEAR.

WHEN THEY ARRIVED IN THE ENTRANCE HALL, THEY FOUND THEMSELVES LINED UP THE PROCEEDING THE THE LARGE CROWD OF STUDENTS

CONGREGATED THERE, ALL MILLING AROUND A LARGE SIGN WHICH HAD BEEN ERECTED AT THE FOOT OF THE MARBLE STAIRCASE. RON, THE TALLEST OF THE THREE, STOOD UP TIP-TOE TO SEE OVER THE HEADS IN FRONT OF THEM AND READ THE SIGN ALOUD TO THE OTHER TWO.

TRILIZARD THEIRNAMENT

THE DELEGATIONS FROM REALIZATIONS AND DUMSTRANG WILL BE ARRIVING AT 10 O'CLOCK ON FRIDAY BOTH OF WHICH, LESSONS WILL END HALF AN HOUR EARLY

BRIGHTLY! SAID HARRY. IT'S PERFECTLY LAST THING ON FRIDAY! SNAPE WHEN I HAVE TIME TO PUNISH US ALL!

STUDENTS WILL RETURN THEIR BAGS AND BROOMS TO THEIR DEPTHS MITHERIES AND ASSEMBLE IN FRONT OF THE CASTLE TO MEET THEIR GUESTS

BEFORE THE WELCHING FEAST.

ONLY A WEEK AWAY? SAID ERNIE MACMILLAN OF FLUFFLEPUFF,  
EMERGING FROM THE CROWD, HIS EYES GLAMING. I WONDER IF  
CEDRIC KNOWS? THINK I'LL GO AND TELL HIM ...

CEDRIC? SAID RON BLANKLY, AS ERNIE FLURRIED OFF.  
DIGGERY, SAID HARRY, HE MUST BE ENTERING THE TOURNAMENT.  
THAT IDIOT, HUGLIART'S CHAMPION? SAID RON, AS THEY PUSHED  
THEIR WAY THROUGH THE CHATTERING CROWD TOWARDS THE STAIRCASE.  
HE'S NOT AN IDIOT, WHO JUST DOESN'T LIKE HIM BECAUSE HE BEAT  
GRYFFINDOR AT BLOODBATH, SAID HERMION. I'VE HEARD HE'S A REALLY  
GOOD STUDENT AND HE'S A PERFECT.

SHE SPoke AS THOUGH THIS SETTLED THE MATTER.

WHO ONLY LIKE HIM BECAUSE HE'S HANDSOME, SAID RON  
SCATHINGLY.

EXCUSE ME, I DON'T LIKE PEOPLE JUST BECAUSE THEY'RE

THE HARRY POTTER

HANDSOME? SAID HERMION INDIGNANTLY.

RON GAVE A LITTLE FALSE CHUCK, WHICH SOUNDED MORE LIKE  
BLOODBATH.

THE APPEARANCE OF THE SIGN IN THE ENTRANCE HALL HAD A  
MARKED EFFECT UPON THE INHABITANTS OF THE CASTLE. DURING THE

FOLLOWING WEEK, THERE SEEMED TO BE ONLY ONE TOPIC OF CONVERSATION,  
NO MATTER WHERE HARRY WENT: THE TRIWIZARD TOURNAMENT.

FLAMELIES WERE FLYING FROM STUDENT TO STUDENT LIKE HIGHLY CHEN-

TAGIELIS GRIMS: WHEN WAS CHING THE TRY FOR F-JIGWARTS CHAMPION,

WHAT THE TOURNAMENT WOULD INVOLVE, FEEL THE STUDENTS FROM  
REALKATHENS AND DIRMSTRANG DIFFERED FROM THEMSELVES.

F-JARRY NOTICED, THEN, THAT THE CASTLE SEEMED THE BE UNDERGOING  
AN EXTRA-THOROUGH CLEANING. SEVERAL GRIMY PORTRAITS HAD BEEN  
SCRUBBED, MUCH TO THE DISPLEASURE OF THEIR SUBJECTS, WHEN SAT  
FLOBBED IN THEIR FRAMES FLUTTERING DARKLY AND WINKING AS THEY  
FELT THEIR RAW PINK FACES. THE SLITS OF ARMOUR WERE SUDDENLY  
CLEANING AND MOVING WITH-OUT SEIZING, AND ARGUS FICK, THE  
CARPENTER, WAS BEHAVING SO FEROCIOUSLY TO ANY STUDENT WHEN  
AUGHT THE WIFE THEIR S-IES THAT HE TERRIFIED A PAIR OF FIRST-YEAR  
GIRLS INTO HYSTERIC.

OTHER MEMBERS OF STAFF SEEMED EQUALLY TENSE, THEN.

LENGKETTEN, KINDLY BE NOT REVEAL THAT YOU CAN'T EVEN PER-  
FORM A SIMPLE SWITCHING SPELL IN FRONT OF ANYONE FROM

DIRMSTRANG: PROFESSOR MCGHAGALL BARKED AT THE END OF HINE

PARTICULARLY DIFFICULT LESSON, DURING WHICH NEVILLE HAD ACCIDENT-  
ALLY TRANSPLANTED HIS OWN EARS INTO A CACTUS.

WHEN THEY WENT DOWN THE BREAKFAST HALL THE MORNING OF THE  
THIRTIETH OF OCTOBER, THEY FOUND THAT THE GREAT HALL HAD BEEN  
DECEASED OVERNIGHT. NUMEROUS SILK BANNERS FLEW FROM THE  
WALLS, EACH OF THEM REPRESENTING A F-JIGWARTS HOUSE RED WITH A



GOLD LION FOR GRYFFINDOR, BLUE WITH A SILVER EAGLE FOR  
RAVENCLAW, YELLOW WITH A BLACK BADGER FOR HUFFLEPUFF, AND  
GREEN WITH A SILVER SERPENT FOR SLYTHERIN. BEHIND THE TEACHERS  
TABLE, THE LARGEST BANNER OF ALL BORE THE HOGWARTS CHEAT OF ARMS:  
LION, EAGLE, BADGER AND SNAKE UNITED AROUND A LARGE LETTER 'H'.

## REALIZATIONS AND DISMISTING THEM

HARRY, RON AND HERMIONE SPOTTED FRED AND GEORGE AT THE  
GRYFFINDOR TABLE, HENCE AGAIN, AND MEET UNUSUALLY, THEY WERE  
SITTING APART FROM EVERYONE ELSE AND CONVERSING IN LOW VOICES.  
RON LED THE WAY OVER TO THEM.

IT'S A KUMMER ALL RIGHT, GEORGE WAS SAYING GLENNILY TO FRED,  
BUT IF HE WENT TO TALK THE LIS IN PERSON, WE'LL HAVE TO SEND HIM THE  
LETTER AFTER ALL. FOR WE'LL STUFF IT INTO HIS HAND, HE CAN'T AVOID LIS  
FOR EVER.

WHAT'S AVOIDING THEM? SAID RON, SITTING DOWN NEXT TO THEM.

WISH THEM WOULD, SAID FRED, SIGHING IRRITATED AT THE INTER-  
RUPTION.

WHAT'S A KUMMER? RON ASKED GEORGE.

HAVING A NESSY GIT LIKE THEM FOR A BROTHER, SAID GEORGE.

THEY'VE GOT ANY IDEAS FOR THE TRIWIZARD TOURNAMENT YET?

HARRY ASKED. THE LIGHT AND MORE ABOUT TRYING THE ENTRY?

I ASKED MCKENZIE ALL THE CHAMPIONS ARE CHOSEN BUT SHE  
WASN'T TELLING, SAID GEORGE BITTERLY. SHE JUST TOLD ME THE SPLIT UP  
AND GET ON WITH TRANSFIGURING MY RACED.

WHETHER WHAT THE TASKS ARE GIVING THEM? SAID RICH, THOUGH HARRY THOUGHT-  
FULLY. WELL DONE, I GET WE COULD DO THEM, HARRY, WE'VE DONE

DANGEROUS STUFF BEFORE ...

NEED IN FRONT OF A PANEL OF JUDGES, WELL HAVEN'T, SAID FRED.  
MCKENAGALL SAYS THE CHAMPIONS GET AWARDED PRIZES ACCORDING  
TO HOW WELL THEY'VE DONE THE TASKS.

WHAT ARE THE JUDGES? HARRY ASKED.

WELL, THE HEADS OF THE PARTICIPATING SCHOOLS ARE ALWAYS ON  
THE PANEL, SAID HERMIONE, AND EVERYONE LOOKED AROUND AT HER,  
RATHER SURPRISED, BECAUSE ALL THREE OF THEM WERE INJURED DURING  
THE TOURNAMENT OF 1992, WHEN A CHICKATRICK THE CHAMPIONS  
WERE SLIPPED THE ICE CATCHING WENT ON THE RAMPAGE.

SHE NOTICED THEM ALL LOOKING AT HER AND SAID, WITH HER USUAL  
AIR OF IMPATIENCE THAT NOBODY ELSE HAD READ ALL THE BOOKS SHE  
HAD, IT'S ALL IN HOGWARTS: A HISTORY, THOUGH, OF COURSE, THAT  
BOOK IS NOT ENTIRELY RELIABLE. A REVISED HISTORY OF HOGWARTS  
WOULD BE A MORE ACCURATE TITLE, FOR A HIGHLY BIASED AND

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SELECTIVE HISTORY OF HOGWARTS, WHICH GUESSES EVERY THE DASTIER  
ASPECTS OF THE SCHOOL.

WHAT ARE YOU SAYING? SAID RICH, THOUGH HARRY THOUGHT  
HE KNEW WHAT WAS COMING.

HELSIE-ELVES! SAID HERMIONE LUDLY AND PROVING HARRY RIGHT.  
NEED HENCE, IN EVERY A THOUSAND PAGES, DOES HOGWARTS: A HISTORY

MENTION THAT WE ARE ALL CHILLING IN THE OPPRESSION OF A HUNDRED SLAVES?

HARRY SHOOK HIS HEAD, AND APPLIED HIMSELF TO HIS STRAGGLED

EGGS. HIS AND REEN'S LACK OF ENTHUSIASM HAD BEEN NOTHING WHAT-SO-EVER THE CLARE HERMIONE'S DETERMINATION THE PERSISTENT ILUSTICE FOR

HERSELF-ELVES. TRUE, BOTH OF THEM HAD PAID TWO SHILLINGS FOR A S.P.E.W. BADGE, BUT THEY HAD ONLY BEEN IT TO KEEP HER QUIET. THEIR SHILLINGS HAD BEEN WASTED, HOWEVER; IF ANYTHING, THEY SEEMED TO HAVE MADE HERMIONE MORE VECIPEROUS. SHE HAD BEEN BADGERING HARRY AND REEN EVER SINCE, FIRSTLY TO WEAR THE BADGES, THEN TO PERSUADE OTHERS TO DO THE SAME, AND SHE HAD ALSO TAKEN THE RATTLING AROUND THE GRYFFINDOR COMMON ROOM EVERY EVENING, CHANNING PEOPLE AND SHAKING THE COLLECTING TIN UNDER THEIR NESES.

WILL SHE REALISE THAT THEIR SHEETS ARE CHANGED, THEIR FIRES LIT, THEIR CLASSROOMS CLEANED AND THEIR FEED CHECKED BY A CREW OF MAGICAL CREATURES WHO ARE UNPAID AND ENSLAVED? SHE KEPT SAYING FIERCELY,

SOME PEOPLE, LIKE NEVILLE, HAD PAID UP JUST THE STEP HERMIONE GLENNING AT THEM. A FEW SEEMED MILDLY INTERESTED IN WHAT SHE HAD TO SAY, BUT WERE RELUCTANT TO TAKE A MORE ACTIVE ROLE IN CAMPAIGNING. MANY REGARDED THE WHOLE THING AS A Joke.

DEAN NEWMAN ROLLED HIS EYES AT THE CEILING, WHICH WAS BLENDING

THEM ALL IN ALTIMAN SLIGHT, AND FRED BECAME EXTREMELY INTERESTED IN HIS BACHEN (BETH) TWINS HAD REPLIED THE KEY A S.P.E.L.L.

RADGEI, GEORGE, HOWEVER, LEANT TOWARDS HERMINE.

LISTEN, HAVE YOU EVER BEEN DOWN IN THE KITCHENS, HERMINE?

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NE, OF COURSE NOT, SAID HERMINE CLITLY, I HARDLY THINK STUDENTS ARE SUPPOSED TO

WELL, WE HAVE, SAID GEORGE, INDICATING FRED, LEADS UP TIMES, THE NICK FINE, AND WE VE MET THEM, AND THEY RE HAPPY, THEY THINK THEY VE GOTT THE BEST JOB IN THE WORLD

THAT S BECAUSE THEY RE UNDULGENT AND BRAINWASHED:

HERMINE BEGAN FETLY, BUT HER NEXT FEW WORDS WERE DROWNED BY THE SUDDEN WHISPERING NOISE FROM OVERHEAD WHICH ANNOUNCED THE ARRIVAL OF THE PHET HILLS, HARRY LOOKED UP AT ONCE, AND SAW FREDIE SHARING TOWARDS HIM, HERMINE STOPPED TALKING ABRUPTLY; SHE AND DEAN WATCHED FREDIE ANXIOUSLY, AS SHE FLUTTERED DOWN UNTIL HARRY S SHELDER, FOLDED HER WINGS AND FELD FELT HER LEG WEARILY.

HARRY PULLED OFF SIRILIS REPLY AND OFFERED FREDIE HIS BACHEN RINDS, WHICH SHE ATE GRATEFULLY, THEN, CHECKING THAT FRED AND GEORGE WERE SAFELY IMMERSED IN FURTHER DISCUSSIONS ABOUT THE TRILIZARD TOURNAMENT, HARRY READ OUT SIRILIS LETTER IN A

WHISPER THE REIN AND HERMINE,

NICE TRY, HARRY,

I'M BACK IN THE COUNTRY AND WELL HIDDEN, I WANT YOU TO KEEP  
ME POSTED ON EVERYTHING THAT'S GOING ON AT EGGWARTS, DON'T USE  
FREDWIG, KEEP CHANGING HELMS, AND DON'T LET ANYONE KNOW I'M  
WATCHING THEM FOR MYSELF, DON'T FORGET WHAT I SAID ABOUT YOUR SCAR,  
SIRIUS

WHY DO YOU HAVE TO KEEP CHANGING HELMS? REIN ASKED IN A LOW  
VOICE,

FREDWIG WILL ATTRACT TOO MUCH ATTENTION, SAID HERMINE AT ONCE.  
SHE STANDS STILL, A SILENT HELM THAT KEEPS RETURNING TO WHEREVER  
HE'S HIDING ... I MEAN, THEY'RE NOT NATIVE BIRDS, ARE THEY?

HARRY ROLLED UP THE LETTER AND SLIPPED IT INSIDE HIS POCKET,  
WONDERING WHETHER HE FELT MORE OR LESS WORRIED THAN BEFORE.  
HE SLIPPED THAT SIRIUS MANAGING TO GET BACK WITHOUT BEING  
CAUGHT WAS SOMETHING, HE COULDN'T DENY, EITHER, THAT THE IDEA

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THAT SIRIUS WAS MUCH NEARER WAS REASSURING; AT LEAST HE WOULDN'T  
HAVE TO WAIT SO LONG FOR A RESPONSE EVERY TIME HE WROTE.

THANKS, FREDWIG, HE SAID, STROKING HER. SHE SMILED SLEEPILY,  
DIPPED HER HEAD BRIEFLY INTO HIS CHEST OF ORANGE WOOL, THEN  
THREW HER AGAIN, CLEARLY DESPERATE FOR A GOOD LONG SLEEP IN THE  
HOLLOWS.

THERE WAS A PLEASANT FEELING OF ANTICIPATION IN THE AIR THAT  
DAY. NERVOUS WAS VERY ATTENTIVE IN LESSONS, BEING MUCH MORE  
INTERESTED IN THE ARRIVAL THAT EVENING OF THE PEOPLE FROM

REALIZATIONS AND DISMAY; EVEN PERTINENCE WAS MORE FEASIBLE  
THAN USUAL, AS IT WAS HALF AN INCH SHORTER. WHEN THE BELL RANG  
EARLY, HARRY, RON AND HERMION HURRIED UP THE GYFFINDOR  
TOWER, DEPOSITED THEIR BAGS AND BEEKS AS THEY HAD BEEN  
INSTRUCTED, PULLED ON THEIR CLOAKS AND RUSHED BACK DOWNSTAIRS  
INTO THE ENTRANCE HALL.

THE HEADS OF HOUSES WERE ORDERING THEIR STUDENTS INTO LINES.

WEASLEY, STRAIGHTENING HIS HAT, PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL  
SNAPPED AT RON. MISS PATIL, TAKE THAT RIDICULOUS THING OUT OF  
YOUR HAIR.

PARYATI SCOWLED AND REMOVED A LARGE ORNAMENTAL CLUTTER  
FROM THE END OF HER PLAIT.

BEHOLD ME, PLEASE, SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL, FIRST-YEARS  
IN FRONT ... NE PUSHING ...

THEY FILED DOWN THE FRONT STEPS AND LINED UP IN FRONT OF THE  
CASTLE. IT WAS A COLD, CLEAR EVENING; DARK WAS FALLING AND A PALE,  
TRANSPARENT-LOOKING MOON WAS ALREADY SHINING OVER THE  
FORBIDDEN FOREST. HARRY, STANDING BETWEEN RON AND HERMION  
IN THE MIDDLE ROW FROM THE FRONT, SAW DENNIS CREEPY POSITIVELY  
SHIVERING WITH ANTICIPATION AMONG THE OTHER FIRST-YEARS.

NEARLY SIX, SAID RON, CHECKING HIS WATCH AND THEN STARING  
DOWN THE DRIVE WHICH LED TO THE FRONT GATES. WHEN D YOU REMEMBER  
THEY'RE COMING? THE TRAIN?

I BELIEVE IT, SAID HERMION.

WELL, THEN? BROOMSTICKS? HARRY SUGGESTED, LOOKING UP AT  
THE STARRY SKY.

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I DON'T THINK SHE ... MEET FROM THAT FAR AWAY ...

A PERTINENT? THEN SUGGESTED, FOR THEY COULD APPARATE  
MAYBE THEY'RE ALLOWED TO BE IT UNDER SEVENTEEN WHEREVER THEY  
CAME FROM?

THEY CAN'T APPARATE INSIDE THE F-HEGLARTS GREENLANDS, FIVE EFTEN  
BUT I HAVE TO TELL THEM? SAID F-ERMINEZ IMPATIENTLY.

THEY SCANNED THE DARKENING GREENLANDS EXCITEDLY, BUT NOTHING  
WAS MOVING; EVERYTHING WAS STILL, SILENT AND QUIET AS USUAL.  
F-HARRY WAS STARTING THE FEEL CHILD, F-HE WISHED THEY'D F-HARRY UP ...  
MAYBE THE FOREIGN STUDENTS WERE PREPARING A DRAMATIC ENTRANCE  
... HE REMEMBERED WHAT MR LEASLEY HAD SAID BACK THEN THE

CAMP SITE BEFORE THE F-LEDDITCH WOULD CLIP ALWAYS THE SAME,  
WE CAN'T RESIST SHOWING OFF WHEN WE GET TOGETHER ...

AND THEN DUMBLEDORE CALLED HIM FROM THE BACK ROW, WHERE  
HE STOOD WITH THE OTHER TEACHERS AHA! UNLESS I AM VERY  
MUCH MISTAKEN, THE DELEGATION FROM REALIZATIONS APPROACHES?  
WHERE? SAID MANY STUDENTS EAGERLY, ALL LOOKING IN DIFFERENT  
DIRECTIONS.

THERE? YELLED A SIXTH-YEAR, POINTING EVER THE FURTEST.  
SOMETHING LARGE, MUCH LARGER THAN A KREHMSTICK FOR,  
INDEED, A HUNDRED KREHMSTICKS WAS FLUTTERING ACROSS THE DEEP  
BLUE SKY TOWARDS THE CASTLE, GROWING LARGER ALL THE TIME.

IT'S A DRAGON? SHRIEKED ONE OF THE FIRST-YEARS, LOSTING HER  
HEAD COMPLETELY.

DON'T BE STUPID ... IT'S A FLYING F-ELISE? SAID DENNIS CREEVEY.  
DENNIS'S GUESS WAS CORRECT ... AS THE GIGANTIC BLACK SHAPE

SKIMMED OVER THE TREETOPS OF THE FORBIDDEN FOREST, AND THE

LIGHTS SHINING FROM THE CASTLE WINDOWS HIT IT, THEY SAW A GIGANTIC, PHEASANT-BLUE, HORSE-DRAWN CARRIAGE, THE SIZE OF A LARGE

BEELIE, SHARING THEMSELVES THEM, PULLED THROUGH THE AIR BY A DOZEN WINGED HORSES, ALL PALEMINES, AND EACH THE SIZE OF AN ELEPHANT.

THE FRONT THREE WHEELS OF STUDENTS DREW BACKWARDS AS THE CARRIAGE HURLED OVER THEM, CRASHING IN THE LAND AT A TREMENDOUS

SPEED THEN, WITH AN ALMIGHTY CRASH THAT MADE NEVILLE JUMP

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BACKWARDS HEARD A SLOTHFUL FIFTY-YEAR S PHEASANT THE HORSES BEHEVES, LARGER THAN DINNER PLATES, HIT THE GROUND, A SECOND LATER, THE CARRIAGE LANDED THEM, ROLLING UPON ITS VAST WHEELS, WHILE THE GOLDEN HORSES THROTTLED THEIR ENORMOUS HEADS AND REVEALED LARGE, FIERY RED EYES.

HARRY JUST HAD TIME TO SEE THAT THE DRIVER OF THE CARRIAGE WORE A CLOAK OF ARMS (THE CROSSED, GOLDEN HANDS, EACH EMITTING THREE STARS) BEFORE IT OPENED.

A KING IN PALE BLUE ROBES JUMPED DOWN FROM THE CARRIAGE, RENT THEMSELVES, FUMBLING FOR A MOMENT WITH SOMETHING IN THE CARRIAGE FLOOR AND UNLOCKED A SET OF GOLDEN STEPS, HE SPRANG BACK RESPECTFULLY. THEN HARRY SAW A SHINING, HIGH-HEELED BLACK



SHE EMERGING FROM THE INSIDE OF THE CARRIAGE. AS SHE THE SIZE OF A CHILD'S SLED FOLLOWED, ALMOST IMMEDIATELY, BY THE LARGEST WHEMAN HE HAD EVER SEEN IN HIS LIFE. THE SIZE OF THE CARRIAGE, AND OF THE HORSES, WAS IMMEDIATELY EXPLAINED. A FEW PEOPLE GASPED.

HARRY HAD ONLY EVER SEEN ONE PERSON AS LARGE AS THIS WHEMAN IN HIS LIFE, AND THAT WAS HAGRID. HE DELIBERATED WHETHER THERE WAS AN INCH DIFFERENCE IN THEIR HEIGHTS. YET SOMEHOW MAYBE SIMPLY BECAUSE HE WAS USED TO HAGRID THIS WHEMAN

WHEMAN AT THE FEET OF THE STEPS, AND LOOKING AROUND AT THE WAITING, WIDE-EYED CHILD SEEMED EVEN MORE UNNATURALLY LARGE.

AS SHE STEPPED INTO THE LIGHT FLEETING FROM THE ENTRANCE HALL, SHE WAS REVEALED TO HAVE A HANDSOME, OLIVE-SKINNED FACE, LARGE, BLACK, LIVID-LOOKING EYES AND A RATHER BEAKY NOSE. HER HAIR WAS DRAWN BACK IN A SHINING BUN AT THE BASE OF HER NECK. SHE WAS DRESSED FROM HEAD TO FOOT IN BLACK SATIN, AND MANY MAGNIFICENT NECKLACES GLIMMERED AT HER THROAT AND ON HER THICK FINGERS.

OLIMPELDER STARTED THE CLAP; THE STUDENTS, FOLLOWING HIS LEAD, BREKE INTO APPLAUSE TOO, MANY OF THEM STANDING ON TIPTOE, THE BETTER TO LOOK AT THIS WHEMAN.

HER FACE RELAXED INTO A GRACEFUL SMILE, AND SHE WALKED FORWARD TOWARDS OLIMPELDER, EXTENDING A GLITTERING HAND.

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BLUMKLEDHRE, THOUGH TALL HIMSELF, HAD EARLY THE REED THE KISS IT,

MY DEAR MADAME MAXIME, HE SAID, WELCOME THE FHEGLWARTS,

BLUMKLEDHRE, SAID MADAME MAXIME, IN A DEEP VOICE. I HOPE  
I FIND YOU WELL?

AN EXCELLENT FEEL, I THANK YOU, SAID BLUMKLEDHRE,

MY PUPILS, SAID MADAME MAXIME, LEAVING HER OF HER  
ENHARMELIS HANDS CARELESSLY BEHIND HER,

FARRY, WHOSE ATTENTION HAD BEEN FOCUSED COMPLETELY UPON  
MADAME MAXIME, NOW NOTICED THAT AROUND A DOZEN BOYS AND  
GIRLS ALL, BY THE LOOK OF THEM, IN THEIR LATE TEENS HAD  
EMERGED FROM THE CARRIAGE AND WERE NOW STANDING BEHIND

MADAME MAXIME. THEY WERE SHIVERING, WHICH WAS UNSURPRIS-  
ING, GIVEN THAT THEIR ROBES SEEMED TO BE MADE OF FINE SILK, AND

NONE OF THEM WERE WEARING COATS, A FEW OF THEM HAD WRAPPED  
SCARVES AND SHAWLS AROUND THEIR HEADS, FROM WHAT FARRY COULD  
SEE OF THEIR FACES THEY WERE STANDING IN MADAME MAXIME'S  
ENHARMELIS SHADOWS, THEY WERE STARING UP AT FHEGLWARTS WITH  
APPREHENSIVE LOOKS ON THEIR FACES.

AS DARKARHFF ARRIVED YET? MADAME MAXIME ASKED,

HE SHOULD BE HERE ANY MOMENT, SAID BLUMKLEDHRE, WOULD  
YOU LIKE TO WAIT HERE AND GREET HIM OR WOULD YOU PREFER TO STEP  
INSIDE AND WARM UP A TRIPLE?

WARM UP, I THINK, SAID MADAME MAXIME, BUT ZE HORSES

ELIA CARE OF MAGICAL CREATURES TEACHER WILL BE DELIGHTED TO  
TAKE CARE OF THEM, SAID BLUMKLEDHRE, THE MOMENT HE HAS

RETURNED FROM DEALING WITH A SLIGHT SITUATION WHICH HAS ARISEN  
WITH SOME OF HIS OTHER ER CHARGES,

SEREWTS, THEN MUTTERED TO HARRY, GRINNING,

MY STEEDS REQUIRE ER PERCEAL ANDLINE, SAID MADAME  
MAXIME, LOOKING AS THOUGH SHE DULKED WHETHER ANY CARE OF  
MAGICAL CREATURES TEACHER AT HOGWARTS COULD BE UP TO THE JOB,  
THEY ARE VERY STRONG ...

I ASSURE YOU THAT HAGRID WILL BE WELL UP TO THE JOB, SAID  
DUMBLEDORE, SMILING,

VERY WELL, SAID MADAME MAXIME, CHWING SLIGHTLY, WILL YOU

THE HARRY MUTTER

PLEASE INFORM THE AGRID THAT HE HORSES DRINK ONLY SINGLE-MALT  
WHISKY?

IT WILL BE ATTENDED TO, SAID DUMBLEDORE, ALSO CHWING,

THEM, SAID MADAME MAXIME IMPERIOUSLY TO HER STUDENTS,  
AND THE HOGWARTS CREED PARTED TO ALLOW HER AND HER STUDENTS  
TO PASS UP THE STONE STEPS,

THEY KID D YOU RECKEN DUMSTRANG S HORSES ARE CHING THE RE?  
SEAMUS FINNIGAN SAID, LEANING AROUND LAVENDER AND PARVATI TO  
ADDRESS HARRY AND THEN,

WELL, IF THEY RE ANY BIGGER THAN THIS LOT, EVEN HAGRID WEN T  
BE ABLE TO HANDLE THEM, SAID HARRY, THAT S IF HE HASN T BEEN  
ATTACKED BY HIS SEREWTS, WENDEER WHAT S UP WITH THEM?

MAYBE THEY VE ESCAPED, SAID THEN EMPERALLY,

HEY DEN T SAY THAT, SAID HERMIONE, WITH A SHLIDDER, IMAGINE  
THAT LOT WERE IN THE CREELDS ...

THEY STOOD, SHIVERING SLIGHTLY NOW, WAITING FOR THE BLINDSTRANG PARTY TO ARRIVE. MOST PEOPLE WERE GAZING HAPPILY UP AT THE SKY.

FOR A FEW MINUTES, THE SILENCE WAS BROKEN ONLY BY MADAME MAXIME'S HUGE HORSES SNEEZING AND STAMPING. BUT THEN  
"CAN YOU HEAR SOMETHING?" SAID JOHN SUDDENLY.

HARRY LISTENED; A LOW AND HOBBY PIERCE NOISE WAS DRIFTING TOWARDS THEM FROM OUT OF THE DARKNESS; A MUFFLED RUMBLING AND SLIDING SOUND, AS THOUGH AN IMMENSE VACUUM CLEANER WAS MOVING ALONG A RIVER-BED ...

"THE LAKE?" YELLED LEE JORDAN, POINTING DOWN AT IT. "LOOK AT THE LAKE!"

FROM THEIR POSITION AT THE TOP OF THE LAWS OVERLOOKING THE GRILINDS, THEY HAD A CLEAR VIEW OF THE SMOOTH BLACK SURFACE OF THE WATER. EXCEPT THAT THE SURFACE WAS SUDDENLY NOT SMOOTH AT ALL. SOME DISTURBANCE WAS TAKING PLACE DEEP IN THE CENTRE; GREAT BUBBLES WERE FORMING IN THE SURFACE, WAVES WERE NOW WASHING OVER THE MUDDY BANKS. AND THEN, OUT IN THE VERY MIDDLE OF THE LAKE, A WHIRLPOOL APPEARED, AS IF A GIANT PILE HAD JUST BEEN PULLED OUT OF THE LAKE'S FLOOR ...

WHAT SEEMED TO BE A LONG, BLACK POLE BEGAN TO RISE SLOWLY

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OUT OF THE HEART OF THE WHIRLPOOL ... AND THEN HARRY SAW THE RIGGING ...

"IT'S A MAST!" HE SAID TO JOHN AND HERMINE.

SLEEWLY, MAGNIFICENTLY, THE SHIP ROSE OUT OF THE WATER, CREAM-  
ING IN THE MIDDNIGHT. IT HAD A STRANGELY SKELETAL LOOK ABOUT IT,

AS THOUGH IT WAS A RESURRECTED WRECK, AND THE DIM, MISTY LIGHTS  
SHIMMERING AT ITS PORTHOLEs LOOKED LIKE GHOSTLY EYES. FINALLY,  
WITH A GREAT SLESHING NOISE, THE SHIP EMERGED ENTIRELY, BEARING  
DOWN THE TURBULENT WATER, AND BEGAN TO GLIDE TOWARDS THE BANK. A  
FEW MOMENTS LATER, THEY HEARD THE SPLASH OF AN ANCHOR BEING  
THROWN DOWN IN THE SHALLOWS, AND THE SOUND OF A PLANK BEING  
LASHED INTO THE BANK.

PEOPLE WERE DISSEMBARKING; THEY COULD SEE THEIR SILHOUETTES  
PASSING THE LIGHTS IN THE SHIP'S PORTHOLEs. ALL OF THEM, FARRY  
NOTICED, SEEMED TO BE CLIMBING THE LINES OF CRACKS AND  
GROOVS ... BUT THEN, AS THEY DREW NEARER, WALKING UP THE LAIRS  
INTO THE LIGHT STREAMING FROM THE ENTRANCE HALL, HE SAW THAT  
THEIR BUILD WAS REALLY LIKE THE FACT THAT THEY WERE WEARING  
CLOTHES OF SOME KIND OF SHAGGY, MATTED FUR. BUT THE MAN WHO

WAS LEADING THEM UP THE THE CASTLE WAS WEARING CLOTHES OF A DIFFER-  
ENT SORT; SLEEK AND SILVER, LIKE HIS HAIR.

OLIMPEDEHRE? HE CALLED HEARTILY, AS HE WALKED UP THE STAIRS.

THEY ARE HERE, MY DEAR FELLOW, THEY ARE HERE!

BEEPING, TALKING HERE, PROFESSOR DARRABEE, OLIMPEDEHRE

REPLIED.

DARRABEE HAD A FLUTY, LINGUALLY VOICE; WHEN HE STEPPED INTO  
THE LIGHT BEHIND THE FRONT DOORS OF THE CASTLE, THEY SAW

THAT HE WAS TALL AND THIN LIKE DUMBLEDORE, BUT HIS WHITE HAIR WAS SHORT, AND HIS CHATEL (FINISHING IN A SMALL CURL) DID NOT ENTIRELY HIDE HIS RATHER WEAK CHIN. WHEN HE REACHED DUMBLEDORE, HE STOOD HANDS WITH BOTH OF HIS HANDS.

DEAR OLD HOGWARTS, HE SAID, LOOKING UP AT THE CASTLE AND SMILING; HIS TEETH WERE RATHER YELLOW, AND HARRY NOTICED THAT HIS SMILE DID NOT EXTEND TO HIS EYES, WHICH REMAINED COLD AND STARE. HEW GAVE IT IS THE BE HERE, HEW GAVE ... VICTOR, COME

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ALONG, INTO THE WARMTH ... HEW DIDN'T MIND, DUMBLEDORE?

VICTOR HAS A SLIGHT HEAD COLD ...

DUMBLEDORE RECOGNIZED HERDARD'S ONE OF HIS STUDENTS, AS THE KEY PASSED, HARRY CAUGHT A GLIMPSE OF A PROMINENT, CURVED NOSE AND THICK BLACK EYEBROWS. HE DIDN'T NEED THE PUNCH IN THE ARM WHEN GAVE HIM, OR THE KISS IN HIS EAR, THE RECOGNITION THAT PROMISE. HARRY IT'S DRUM!

## CHAPTER SIXTEEN

### THE GHOST OF FIRE

I DON'T BELIEVE IT! BEN SAID, IN A STUNNED VOICE, AS THE HOGWARTS STUDENTS FILED BACK UP THE STEPS BEHIND THE PARTY FROM DUMBLEDORE. DRUM, HARRY! VICTOR DRUM!

FOR HEAVEN'S SAKE, BEN, HE'S ONLY A FLIDITCH PLAYER, SAID HERMION.

ONLY A HILDDITCH PLAYER? RON SAID, LOOKING AT HER AS THOUGH HE COULDN'T BELIEVE HIS EARS. HERMIONE HE SOUNDED THE BEST SPEAKERS IN THE WORLD! I HAD NO IDEA HE WAS STILL AT SCHOOL! AS THEY RECESSED THE ENTRANCE HALL WITH THE REST OF THE HOGWARTS STUDENTS, HEADING FOR THE GREAT HALL, HARRY SAW LEE JORDAN LIMPING UP AND DOWN ON THE STEPS OF HIS FEET THEN GET A BETTER LOOK AT THE BACK OF DRAGON'S HEAD. SEVERAL SIXTH-YEAR GIRLS WERE FRANTICALLY SEARCHING THEIR POCKETS AS THEY WALKED. HE, I DON'T BELIEVE IT, I HAVEN'T GOT A SINGLE HILL ON ME. O WELL, THINK HE'D SIGN MY HAT IN LIPSTICK?

Really, HERMIONE SAID LEITLY, AS THEY PASSED THE GIRLS, WELL SHAKKING OVER THE LIPSTICK.

I'M GETTING HIS ALTHOGRAPH IF I CAN, SAID RON, WELL HAVEN'T GOT A HILL, HAVE YOU, HARRY?

WELL, THEY'RE LIPSTAIRS IN MY BAG, SAID HARRY.

THEY WALKED OVER THE GRYFFINDOR TABLE AND SAT DOWN. RON THOUGHT LATE THEN SIT ON THE SIDE FACING THE DORMERY, BECAUSE DRAGON AND HIS FELLOW DRAGONSTRONG STUDENTS WERE STILL GATHERED AROUND IT, APPARENTLY UNSURE ABOUT WHERE THEY SHOULD SIT. THE STUDENTS FROM BEAUKATHENS HAD CHOSEN SEATS AT THE RAVENCLAW TABLE.

THEY WERE LOOKING AROUND THE GREAT HALL WITH GLUM

THE HARRY BETTER

EXPRESSIONS ON THEIR FACES. THREE OF THEM WERE STILL CLUTCHING STAVES AND STAFFS AROUND THEIR HEADS.

IT'S NOT THAT CHILD, SAID HERMIONE IRRITABLY, WHO WAS WATCH-

ING THEM. WHY DIDN'T THEY BRING CHAIRS?

EVER HERE? COME AND SIT EVER HERE? REHN HISSED. EVER HERE?

HERMINE, SLIDG LIP, MADE A SPACE

WHAT?

THEE LATE, SAID REHN BITTERLY.

VICTOR KRUM AND HIS FELLOW DIRMSTRANG STUDENTS HAD SETTLED THEMSELVES AT THE SLOTHERIN TABLE. HARRY COULD SEE MALPHY, CRABBE AND GOYLE LOOKING VERY SMUG ABOUT THIS. AS HE WATCHED, MALPHY KENT FORWARDS THE SPREAD THE KRUM.

YEAH, THAT'S RIGHT, SPARM LIP TH HIM, MALPHY, SAID REHN SATURNALLY. I BET KRUM CAN SEE RIGHT THROUGH HIM, THROUGH ... BET HE GETS PEOPLE FALMING EVER HIM ALL THE TIME ... WHERE'D YOU RECKEN THEY'RE GOING TO SLEEP? WE COULD OFFER HIM A SPACE IN OUR DIRMSTRANG, HARRY ... I WOULDN'T MIND GIVING HIM MY BED, I COULD KIP IN A CAMP-BED.

HERMINE SNEERED.

THEY WERE A BIT HAPPIER THAN THE BEALWEATHERS WERE, SAID HARRY.

THE DIRMSTRANG STUDENTS WERE PULLING OFF THEIR HEAVY FLIES AND LOOKING UP AT THE STARRY BLACK CEILING WITH EXPRESSIONS OF INTEREST; A COUPLE OF THEM WERE PICKING UP THE GOLDEN PLATES AND CHILTS AND EXAMINING THEM, APPARENTLY IMPRESSED.

UP AT THE STAFF TABLE, FILCH, THE CARETAKER, WAS ADDING CHAIRS.

HE WAS WEARING HIS MELODY HED TAIL COAT IN FAVOR OF THE OCCASION. HARRY WAS SURPRISED TO SEE THAT HE ADDED FOUR CHAIRS, TWO ON EITHER SIDE OF DUMBLEDORE'S.



BUT THERE ARE ONLY TWO EXTRA PEOPLE, HARRY SAID. WHY'S  
FILCH PUTTING OUT THEIR CHAIRS? WHO ELSE IS COMING?

RON SAID THEN VAGUELY, HE WAS STILL STARING AVIDLY AT DRAGON.  
WHEN ALL THE STUDENTS HAD ENTERED THE HALL AND SETTLED DOWN  
AT THEIR HOUSE TABLES, THE STAFF ENTERED, FILING UP THE TOP TABLE  
AND TAKING THEIR SEATS. LAST IN LINE WERE PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE,

THE GHOST OF FIRE ZZ1

PROFESSOR KARDAREFF AND MADAME MAXIME. WHEN THEIR  
HEADMISTRESS APPEARED, THE PUPILS FROM BEAUKATHENS LEAPT THE  
THEIR FEET. A FEW OF THE HOGWARTS STUDENTS LAUGHED. THE  
BEAUKATHENS PARTY APPEARED SLIGHTLY UNEMBARRASSED, AND DID NOT  
RESUME THEIR SEATS UNTIL MADAME MAXIME HAD SAT DOWN ON  
DUMBLEDORE'S LEFT-HAND SIDE. DUMBLEDORE, HOWEVER, REMAINED  
STANDING, AND A SILENCE FELL OVER THE GREAT HALL.

GOOD EVENING, LADIES AND GENTLEMEN, GUESTS AND MEET  
PARTICULARLY GUESTS, SAID DUMBLEDORE, BEAMING AROUND AT THE  
FOREIGN STUDENTS. I HAVE GREAT PLEASURE IN WELCOMING YOU ALL THE  
HOGWARTS. I HOPE AND TRUST THAT YOU WILL STAY HERE WILL BE BOTH  
COMFORTABLE AND ENJOYABLE.

ONE OF THE BEAUKATHENS GIRLS STILL CLUTCHING A MUFFLER AROUND  
HER HEAD GAVE WHAT WAS UNMISTAKABLY A DERISIVE LAUGH.

DO YOU'VE S MAKING YOU STAY? HERMIONE WHISPERED, BRISTLING  
AT HER.

THE TOURNAMENT WILL BE OFFICIALLY OPENED AT THE END OF THE  
FEAST, SAID DUMBLEDORE. I NOW INVITE YOU ALL TO EAT, DRINK, AND  
MAKE YOURSELVES AT HOME.

HE SAT DOWN, AND HARRY SAW RABBARREFF LEAN FORWARD AT ONCE AND ENGAGE HIM IN CONVERSATION.

THE DISHES IN FRONT OF THEM FILLED WITH FOOD AS USUAL. THE HOUSE-ELVES IN THE KITCHEN SEEMED THEY HAD PULLED OUT ALL THE STEPS; THERE WAS A GREATER VARIETY OF DISHES IN FRONT OF THEM THAN HARRY HAD EVER SEEN, INCLUDING SEVERAL THAT WERE DEFINITELY FOREIGN.

WHAT IS THAT? SAID RON, POINTING AT A LARGE DISH OF SOME SORT OF SHELLFISH STEW THAT STOOD BESIDE A LARGE STEAK-AND-KIDNEY PUDDING.

BEHILABALISSE, SAID HERMION.

BLESS YOU, SAID RON.

IT IS FRENCH, SAID HERMION. I HAD IT ON HOLIDAY, SUMMER BEFORE LAST, IT IS VERY NICE.

I LL TAKE YOUR WORD FOR IT, SAID RON, HELPING HIMSELF THE BLACK PUDDING.

\*\*\* HARRY PUTTER

THE GREAT HALL SEEMED SOMEHOW MUCH MORE CROWDED THAN

USUAL, EVEN THOUGH THERE WERE BARELY TWENTY ADDITIONAL STUDENTS THERE; PERHAPS IT WAS BECAUSE THEIR DIFFERENTLY COLOURED

UNIFORMS STOOD OUT SO CLEARLY AGAINST THE BLACK OF THE BEGGLARS ROBES. WHEN THAT THEY HAD REMOVED THEIR FLIES, THE DISMSTANG STUDENTS WERE REVEALED THEY WEARING ROBES OF A DEEP, BLEED RED.

FLAGRID SIDLED INTO THE HALL THROUGH A DOOR BEHIND THE STAFF TABLE TWENTY MINUTES AFTER THE START OF THE FEAST. HE SLID INTO HIS SEAT AT THE END AND GLANCED AT HARRY, RON AND HERMION WITH A VERY HEAVILY RABDAGED HAND.

DRINKS BEING ALL RIGHT, FLAGRID? HARRY CALLED.

THIRVIN, FLAGRID CALLED BACK HAPPILY.

YEAH, I'LL JUST GET THEM ARE, SAID RON QUIETLY. SEEMS LIKE THEY'RE FINALLY FEELING A FEEL THEY LIKE, DOESN'T IT? FLAGRID'S FINGERS.

AT THAT MOMENT, A VOICE SAID, EXCUSE ME, ARE YOU WANTING ZE SCHILLABAISS?

IT WAS THE GIRL FROM KALIKRATHENS WHO HAD LAUGHED DURING DUMBLEDORE'S SPEECH. SHE HAD FINALLY REMOVED HER MUFFLER, A LONG STRIP OF SILVERY BLOND HAIR FELL ALMOST TO HER WAIST. SHE HAD LARGE, DEEP BLUE EYES, AND VERY WHITE, EVEN TEETH.

RON WENT PURPLE. HE STARED UP AT HER, OPENED HIS MOUTH THE REPLY, BUT NOTHING CAME OUT EXCEPT A FAINT GURGling NOISE.

YEAH, HAVE IT, SAID HARRY, PUSHING THE DISH TOWARDS THE GIRL.

YOU'VE FINISHED WIZ IT?

YEAH, RON SAID BREATHELESSLY. YEAH, IT WAS EXCELLENT.

THE GIRL PICKED UP THE DISH AND CARRIED IT CAREFULLY OFF TO THE RAVENCLAW TABLE. RON WAS STILL GOGGLING AT THE GIRL AS THOUGH HE HAD NEVER SEEN HER BEFORE. HARRY STARTED TO LAUGH. THE SOUND SEEMED TO JG RON BACK TO HIS SENSES.

SHE'S A VEELA? HE SAID HARSHLY TO HARRY.

HE'LL SEE SHE ISN'T? SAID HERMION TARTLY. I DON'T SEE ANYONE ELSE GAWPING AT HER LIKE AN IDIOT.

BUT SHE WASN'T ENTIRELY RIGHT ABOUT THAT. AS THE GIRL CROSSED

THE CHELSEA FIRE

THE HALL, MANY KIDS' HEADS TURNED, AND SOME OF THEM SEEMED  
THEY HAD BECOME TEMPORARILY SPEECHLESS, JUST LIKE RON.

I'M TELLING YOU, THAT'S NOT A NORMAL GIRL! SAID RON, LEANING  
SIDELWAYS SHE COULD KEEP A CLEAR VIEW OF HER. THEY DIDN'T  
MAKE THEM LIKE THAT AT HOGWARTS!

THEY MADE THEM EAT AT HOGWARTS, SAID HARRY, WITHOUT  
THINKING. THE CHANGE HAPPENED THE DAY SITTING ONLY A FEW PLACES  
AWAY FROM THE GIRL WITH THE SILVERY HAIR.

WHEN YOU'VE BOTH PUT YOUR EYES BACK IN, SAID HERMION  
BRISKLY, YOU'LL BE ABLE TO SEE WHEN SHE JUST ARRIVED.

SHE WAS POINTING UP AT THE STAFF TABLE. THE TWO REMAINING  
EMPTY SEATS HAD JUST BEEN FILLED. LUDWIG BAGMAN WAS NOW SITTING  
BETWEEN PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE'S EITHER SIDE, WHILE MR CRUICKSHANK, PERCY'S  
FATHER, WAS NEXT THE MADAME MAXIME.

WHAT ARE THEY DOING HERE? SAID HARRY IN SURPRISE.

THEY ORGANISED THE TRIWIZARD TOURNAMENT, DIDN'T THEY? SAID  
HERMION. I SUPPOSE THEY WANTED TO BE HERE TO SEE IT START.

WHEN THE SECOND CHAIRS ARRIVED THEY NOTICED A NUMBER OF  
UNFAMILIAR FLODDINGS, THEN, RON EXAMINED AN OLD SHIRT OF PALE  
BLANKMANGE CLOSELY, THEN MOVED IT CAREFULLY A FEW INCHES TO HIS  
RIGHT, SO THAT IT WOULD BE CLEARLY VISIBLE FROM THE RAVENCLAW  
TABLE. THE GIRL WHO LOOKED LIKE A VEEVA APPEARED TO HAVE EATEN  
ENOUGH, HOWEVER, AND DID NOT COME OVER TO GET IT.

BECAUSE THE CHILDREN PLATES HAD BEEN WIPED CLEAN, DUMBLEDORE

STOOD UP AGAIN. A PLEASANT SIGHT OF TENSION SEEMED TO FILL THE  
HALL NOW. HARRY FELT A SLIGHT THRILL OF EXCITEMENT, WONDERING  
WHAT WAS COMING. SEVERAL SEATS AROUND THEM, FRED AND  
GEORGE WERE LEANING FORWARD, STARING AT DUMBLEDORE WITH  
GREAT CONCENTRATION.

THE MOMENT HAS COME, SAID DUMBLEDORE, SMILING AROUND  
AT THE SEA OF UPTURNED FACES. THE TRIWIZARD TOURNAMENT IS  
ABOUT TO START. I WOULD LIKE TO SAY A FEW WORDS OF EXPLANATION  
BEFORE WE BRING IN THE GUEST

THE WHAT? HARRY MUTTERED.  
RON SHRUGGED.

224 HARRY MUTTERED

LISTEN THE CLARIFY THE PROCEDURE WHICH WE WILL BE FOLLOWING  
THIS YEAR. BUT FIRSTLY, LET ME INTRODUCE THE THREE WHO YOU  
KNOW THEM, MR BARTHEMUS CRABBE, HEAD OF THE DEPARTMENT OF  
INTERNATIONAL MAGICAL CO-OPERATION THERE WAS A SMATTERING  
OF POLITE APPLAUSE AND MR LUDWIG BAGMAN, HEAD OF THE  
DEPARTMENT OF MAGICAL GAMES AND SPORTS.

THERE WAS A MUCH LOUDER RING OF APPLAUSE FOR BAGMAN  
THAN FOR CRABBE, PERHAPS BECAUSE OF HIS FAME AS A BEATER, OR  
SIMPLY BECAUSE HE SEEMED SO MUCH MORE LIKABLE. HE ACKNOWLEDG-  
ED IT WITH A HEAVY WAFT OF HIS HAND. BARTHEMUS CRABBE DID

NOT SMILE OR WAFT WHEN HIS NAME WAS ANNOUNCED.

REMEMBERING HIM IN HIS NEAT SUIT AT THE HOGWARTS WORLD

CLIP, BARRY TWILIGHT HE LOOKED STRANGE IN WIZARD S REEKS, HIS THIRTEENISH MISSTAKE AND SEVERE PARTING LOOKED VERY OLD NEXT THE DUMBLEDORE S LONG WHITE HAIR AND BEARD.

MR BAGMAN AND MR CRUELCH HAVE WORKED TIRELESSLY OVER THE LAST FEW MONTHS ON THE ARRANGEMENTS FOR THE TRIWIZARD TOURNAMENT, DUMBLEDORE CONTINUED, AND THEY WILL BE JOINING MYSELF, PROFESSOR DAWDAROFF AND MADAME MAXIME ON THE PANEL WHICH WILL JUDGE THE CHAMPIONS EFFORTS.

AT THE MENTION OF THE WIZARD CHAMPIONS , THE ATTENTIVENESS OF THE LISTENING STUDENTS SEEMED TO SHARPEN.

PERHAPS DUMBLEDORE HAD NOTICED THEIR SUDDEN STILLNESS, FOR HE SMILED AS HE SAID, THE CASSET, THEN, IF YOU PLEASE, MR FILCH, FILCH, WHO HAD BEEN WORKING UNNOTICED IN A FAR CORNER OF THE HALL, NOW APPROACHED DUMBLEDORE, CARRYING A GREAT WOODEN

CHEST, ENCRUSTED WITH JEWELS. IT LOOKED EXTREMELY OLD, A MIRROR OF EXCITED INTEREST ROSE FROM THE WATCHING STUDENTS;

DENNIS CREEVEY ACTUALLY STOOD ON HIS CHAIR TO SEE IT PROPERLY, BUT, BEING SO TINY, HIS HEAD HARDLY ROSE ABOVE ANYONE ELSE S.

THE INSTRUCTIONS FOR THE TASKS THE CHAMPIONS WILL FACE THIS YEAR HAVE ALREADY BEEN EXAMINED BY MR CRUELCH AND MR BAGMAN, SAID DUMBLEDORE, AS FILCH PLACED THE CHEST CAREFULLY ON THE TABLE BEFORE HIM, AND THEY HAVE MADE THE NECESSARY ARRANGEMENTS FOR EACH CHALLENGE. THERE WILL BE THREE TASKS,

THE CHURCH OF FIRE 225

SPACED THREELIGHTHLY THE SEVENTH YEAR, AND THEY WILL TEST THE CHAMPIONS IN MANY DIFFERENT WAYS ... THEIR MAGICAL POWERS THEIR DARING THEIR POWERS OF DEDUCTION AND, OF COURSE, THEIR ABILITY TO cope WITH DANGER.

AT THIS LAST WORD, THE HALL WAS FILLED WITH A SILENCE SO ABSOLUTE THAT NOBODY SEEMED TO BE BREATHING.

AS YET KNOWN, THREE CHAMPIONS COMPETE IN THE TOURNAMENT, DUMBLEDORE WENT ON CALMLY, ONE FROM EACH OF THE PARTICIPATING SCHOOLS. THEY WILL BE MARKED ON HOW WELL THEY PERFORM EACH OF THE TOURNAMENT TASKS AND THE CHAMPION WITH THE HIGHEST TOTAL AFTER TASK THREE WILL WIN THE TRILIZARD CUP. THE CHAMPIONS WILL BE CHOSEN BY AN IMPARTIAL SELECTOR ... THE GOBLIN OF FIRE.

DUMBLEDORE NOW THUS HELD HIS WAND, AND TAPPED THREE TIMES UPON THE TOP OF THE CASSET. THE LID CREAKED SILENTLY OPEN. DUMBLEDORE REACHED INSIDE IT, AND PULLED OUT A LARGE, RICHLY ENGRAVED CUP. IT WOULD HAVE BEEN ENTIRELY UNREMARKABLE, HAD IT NOT BEEN ALL THE WAY WITH DANCING, BLUE-WHITE FLAMES.

DUMBLEDORE CLOSED THE CASSET AND PLACED THE GOBLIN CAREFULLY ON THE TOP OF IT, WHERE IT WOULD BE CLEARLY VISIBLE TO EVERYONE IN THE HALL.

ANYBODY WISHING TO SUBMIT THEMSELVES AS CHAMPION MUST WRITE THEIR NAME AND SCHOOL CLEARLY UPON A SLIP OF PARCHMENT,

AND DROP IT INTO THE GOBLIN, SAID DUMBLEDORE. ASPIRING CHAMPIONS HAVE TWENTY-FOUR HOURS IN WHICH TO PUT THEIR NAMES

FORWARD, THE NEXT NIGHT, FALLING IN, THE GHOST WILL RETURN THE NAMES OF THE THREE IT HAS JUDGED MOST WORTHY TO REPRESENT THEIR SCHOOLS. THE GHOST WILL BE PLACED IN THE ENTRANCE HALL THE NEXT, WHERE IT WILL BE FREELY ACCESSIBLE TO ALL THOSE WISHING TO COMPETE.

THE ENSURE THAT NO UNDERAGE STUDENT YIELDS TO TEMPTATION, SAID DUMBLEDORE, I WILL BE DRAWING AN AGE LINE AROUND THE GHOST OF FIRE SINCE IT HAS BEEN PLACED IN THE ENTRANCE HALL. NOBODY UNDER THE AGE OF SEVENTEEN WILL BE ABLE TO CROSS THIS LINE.

FINALLY, I WISH THE IMPRESS UPON ANY OF YOU WISHING TO COMPETE THAT THIS TOURNAMENT IS NOT TO BE ENTERED INTO LIGHTLY.

THE HARRY POTTER

SINCE A CHAMPION HAS BEEN SELECTED BY THE GHOST OF FIRE, HE OR SHE IS OBLIGED TO SEE THE TOURNAMENT THROUGH TO THE END. THE PLACING OF YOUR NAME IN THE GHOST CONSTITUTES A BINDING, MAGICAL CONTRACT. THERE CAN BE NO CHANGE OF HEART SINCE YOU HAVE BECOME CHAMPION. PLEASE BE VERY SURE, THEREFORE, THAT YOU ARE WHOLE-HEARTEDLY PREPARED TO PLAY, BEFORE YOU DROP YOUR NAME INTO THE GHOST. NOW, I THINK IT IS TIME FOR BED.

GOODNIGHT TO YOU ALL.

AN AGE LINE? FRED WEASLEY SAID, HIS EYES GLINTING, AS THEY ALL MADE THEIR WAY ACROSS THE HALL TO THE DOORS INTO THE ENTRANCE HALL. WELL, THAT SHOULD BE HELD BY AN AGING POTTER, SHOULD IT? AND YOUR NAME'S IN THAT GHOST, YOU'RE LAUGHING IT CAN'T TELL WHETHER YOU'RE SEVENTEEN OR NOT!



BUT I DON'T THINK ANYONE UNDER SEVENTEEN WILL STAND A  
CHANCE, SAID HERMIONE, WE JUST HAVEN'T LEARN'T ENOUGH ...

SPREAD HERSELF, SAID GEORGE SHORTLY, SHE'LL TRY AND GET  
IN, WHEN T'HELL, HARRY?

HARRY THOUGHT BRIEFLY OF DUMBLEDORE'S INSISTENCE THAT  
ANYBODY UNDER SEVENTEEN SHOULD SURRENDER THEIR NAME, BUT THEN  
THE WONDERFUL PICTURE OF HIMSELF WINNING THE TRIWIZARD CUP  
FILLED HIS MIND AGAIN ... HE WONDERED HOW ANGRY DUMBLEDORE  
WOULD BE IF SOMEONE YOUNGER THAN SEVENTEEN DID FIND A WAY TO  
GET OVER THE AGE LINE ...

WHERE IS HE? SAID RON, WHO WASN'T LISTENING TO A WORD OF  
THIS CONVERSATION, BUT LEEDING THROUGH THE CROWD TO SEE WHAT  
HAD BECOME OF DURLIN. DUMBLEDORE DIDN'T SAY WHERE THE  
DISMAYING PEOPLE ARE SLEEPING, DID HE?

BUT THIS QUERY WAS ANSWERED ALMOST INSTANTLY; THEY WERE

LEVEL WITH THE SLOTHERIN TABLE NOW, AND KARKADENN HAD JUST DIS-  
TILLED UP TO HIS STUDENTS.

BACK TO THE SHIP, THEN, HE WAS SAYING. VICTOR, HOW ARE YOU  
FEELING? DID YOU EAT ENOUGH? SHOULD I SEND HER SOME MILLED  
WINE FROM THE KITCHENS?

HARRY SAW DURLIN SHAKE HIS HEAD AS HE PULLED HIS FLIES BACK  
ON.

THE GHOST OF FIRE 229

PROFESSOR, I WOULD LIKE SOME WINE, SAID ONE OF THE OTHER

BLURMISTRANG KNEW'S IMMEDIATELY,

I WASN'T HEARING IT THE WELL, PELLADREFF, SNAPPED KARDKAREFF, HIS  
WARMLY PATERNAL AIR VANISHING IN AN INSTANT. I NOTICE WELL HAVE

DRIZZLED THEM ALL DOWN THE FRONT OF YOUR REEKS AGAIN, DISGUST-  
ING KNEW

KARDKAREFF TURNED AND LED HIS STUDENTS TOWARDS THE DEERS,  
REACHING THEM AT EXACTLY THE SAME MOMENT AS HARRY, BEN AND  
HERMIONE. HARRY STOPPED THE LET HIM WALK THROUGH FIRST.

THANKS WELL, SAID KARDKAREFF CARELESSLY, GLANCING AT HIM.  
AND THEN KARDKAREFF FREEZE. HE TURNED HIS HEAD BACK THE HARRY,  
AND STARED AT HIM AS THOUGH HE COULDN'T BELIEVE HIS EYES.  
BEHIND THEIR HEADMASTER, THE STUDENTS FROM BLURMISTRANG CAME  
TO A HALT, THEN, KARDKAREFF'S EYES MOVED SLEWLY UP HARRY'S FACE,  
AND FIXED UPON HIS SCAR. THE BLURMISTRANG STUDENTS WERE STARING  
CURIOUSLY AT HARRY, THEN, FELT OF THE CORNER OF HIS EYE, HARRY SAW  
COMPREHENSION DAWN IN A FEW OF THEIR FACES. THE KNEW WITH

THEM ALL DOWN HIS FRONT NOTICED THE GIRL NEXT TO HIM AND POINT-  
ED HEAVILY AT HARRY'S FOREHEAD.

YEAH, THAT'S HARRY POTTER, SAID A GROWLING VOICE FROM BEHIND  
THEM.

PROFESSOR KARDKAREFF SPUN AROUND, MAD-EYE Moody WAS  
STANDING THERE, LEANING HEAVILY ON HIS STAFF, HIS MAGICAL EYE  
GLARING LICKELICKINGLY AT THE BLURMISTRANG HEADMASTER.

THE CHILLER DRAINED FROM KARDAREFF'S FACE AS HARRY WATCHED.

A TERRIBLE MIX OF MINGLED FURY AND FEAR CAME OVER HIS FACE.

WELL HE SAID, STARING AT MERRY AS THOUGH UNLIKE HE WAS REALLY SEEING HIM.

MR. SAID MERRY GRIMLY, AND UNLESS YOU VE GOT ANYTHING TO

SAY THE BETTER, KARDAREFF, YOU MIGHT WANT THE MOVE, YOU'RE BLEED-  
ING THE DEERLAD.

IT WAS TRUE; HALF THE STUDENTS IN THE HALL WERE NOW WAITING  
BEHIND THEM, WHISKING OVER EACH OTHER'S SHOULDERS TO SEE WHAT  
WAS CAUSING THE HISS-LIP.

WITHOUT ANOTHER WORD, PROFESSOR KARDAREFF SWEEP HIS

THE HARRY BETTER

STUDENTS AWAY WITH HIM. MERRY WATCHED HIM GO OUT OF SIGHT, HIS  
MAGICAL EYE FIXED UPON HIS BACK, A MIX OF INTENSE DISLIKE UPON  
HIS MILITATED FACE.

\*

AS THE NEXT DAY WAS SATURDAY, MOST STUDENTS WOULD NORMALLY  
HAVE BREAKFASTED LATE. HARRY, BEN AND HERMIONE, HOWEVER,  
WERE NOT AWAKE IN RISING MUCH EARLIER THAN THEY USUALLY DID AT  
WEEKENDS. WHEN THEY WENT DOWN INTO THE ENTRANCE HALL, THEY

SAW ABOUT TWENTY PEOPLE MILLING AROUND IT, SOME OF THEM EAT-

ING THAST, ALL EXAMINING THE CORSET OF FIRE. IT HAD BEEN PLACED

IN THE CENTRE OF THE HALL AND THE STEEL THAT NORMALLY KEPT THE  
SHIRTING HOT. A THIN GOLDEN LINE HAD BEEN TRACKED AND THE FLOOR,  
FORMING A CIRCLE TEN FEET AROUND IT IN EVERY DIRECTION.

ANYONE PUT THEIR NAME IN YET? BEEN ASKED A THIRD-YEAR GIRL  
EAGERLY.

ALL THE DORMSTRANG LEFT, SHE REPLIED. BUT I HAVEN'T SEEN ANY-  
ONE FROM HOGWARTS YET.

BUT SOME OF THEM PUT IN LAST NIGHT AFTER WE'D ALL GONE TO  
BED, SAID HARRY. I WOULD'VE BEEN IF IT HAD BEEN ME ... WOULD'VE

HAVE WANTED EVERYONE WATCHING. WHAT IF THE CORSET JUST GIB-  
BERED AND RAN RIGHT BACK OUT AGAIN?

SOMEONE LAUGHED BEHIND HARRY. TURNING, HE SAW FRED,  
GEORGE AND LEE JORDAN FLIPPING DOWN THE STAIRCASE, ALL THREE OF  
THEM LOOKING EXTREMELY EXCITED.

DIDN'T IT, FRED SAID IN A TRIUMPHANT WHISPER TO HARRY, BEEN  
AND HERMIONE. JUST TAKEN IT.

WHAT? SAID BEEN.

THE AGING POTION, DRINKING, SAID FRED.

ONE DROP EACH, SAID GEORGE, RUBBING HIS HANDS TOGETHER  
WITH GLEE. WE ONLY NEED THE BE A FEW MONTHS OLDER.

WE'RE GOING TO SPLIT THE THOUSAND GALLEONS BETWEEN THE

THREE OF US IF ONE OF US WINS, SAID LEE, GRINNING BROADLY.

I M NOT SURE THIS IS GIVING THE WEIRD, YELL KNOWN, SAID

HERMIONE WARNINGLY. I M SURE DUMBLEDORE WILL HAVE THE LIGHT  
OF THIS.

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FRED, GEORGE AND LEE IGNORED HER.

READY? FRED SAID THE THE EITHER TWO, DELIVERING WITH EXCITE-  
MENT. I MEAN, THEN I M GO FIRST

HARRY WATCHED, FASCINATED, AS FRED PULLED A SLIP OF PARCH-  
MENT OUT OF HIS POCKET, BEARING THE WORDS FRED WEASLEY

BEGLIANTS , FRED WALKED RIGHT UP TO THE EDGE OF THE LINE, AND  
STOOD THERE, ROCKING HIM HIS THES LIKE A DIVER PREPARING FOR A  
FIFTY-FOOT DIVE. THEN, WITH THE EYES OF EVERY PERSON IN THE  
ENTRANCE HALL UPON HIM, HE TOOK A GREAT BREATH AND STEPPED  
OVER THE LINE.

FOR A SPLIT SECOND, HARRY THOUGHT IT HAD WORKED GEORGE  
CERTAINLY THOUGHT SO, FOR HE LET OUT A YELL OF TRIUMPH AND LEAPT  
AFTER FRED BUT NEXT MOMENT, THERE WAS A LOUD SIZZLING SOUND,  
AND BOTH TWINS WERE FLUNG OUT OF THE CIRCLE AS THOUGH  
THEY HAD BEEN THROWN BY AN INVISIBLE SHEET-PLUTTER. THEY LANDED  
PAINFULLY, TEN FEET AWAY FROM THE CIRCLE STONE FLOOR, AND THE ADD  
INSULT THE INJURY, THERE WAS A LOUD PEEPING NOISE, AND BOTH OF  
THEM SPRUNG IDENTICAL, LONG WHITE BEARDS.

THE ENTRANCE HALL RANG WITH LAUGHTER, EVEN FRED AND  
GEORGE JOINED IN, SINCE THEY HAD GOTTEN THEIR FEET, AND TAKEN A  
GOOD LOOK AT EACH OTHER'S BEARDS.

I DID WARN YELL, SAID A DEEP, AMUSED VOICE, AND EVERYONE  
TURNED TO SEE PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE COMING OUT OF THE GREAT

HALL. HE SURVEYED FRED AND GEORGE, HIS EYES TWINKLING. I SUG-  
GEST YELL BOTH GOT UP THE MADAM PHEMPEY, SHE IS ALREADY TENDING

THE MISS FALCETT, OF RAVENCLAW, AND MR SUMMERS, OF HUFFLEPUFF,  
BOTH OF WHOM DECIDED TO AGE THEMSELVES UP A LITTLE, THEN,

THOUGH I MUST SAY, NEITHER OF THEIR BEARDS IS ANYTHING LIKE AS  
FINE AS YELL'S.

FRED AND GEORGE SET OFF FOR THE HOSPITAL WING, ACCOMPANIED  
BY LEE, WHO WAS FIDDLING WITH LAUGHTER, AND HARRY, RON AND  
HERMIONIE, ALSO CHORTLING, WENT IN THE BREAKFAST.

THE DECORATIONS IN THE GREAT HALL HAD CHANGED THIS

MORNING. AS IT WAS HALLOWEEN, A CLOUD OF LIVE BATS WAS FLITTER-  
ING AROUND THE ENCHANTED CEILING, WHILE HUNDREDS OF CARVED

THE HARRY POTTER

PLUMPTONS PEERED FROM EVERY CORNER. HARRY LED THE WAY FOLLOWING THE  
DEAN AND STAFFS, WHO WERE DISCUSSING THESE HOGWARTS  
STUDENTS OF SEVENTEEN WHO EVER WHO MIGHT BE ENTERING.

THERE IS A RUMOUR GOING AROUND, WARRINGTON GOT UP EARLY AND  
PUT HIS NAME IN, DEAN TOLD HARRY, THAT KID BLEND FROM

SLOTHERIN WITH LOOKS LIKE A SLEET.

HARRY, WHO HAD PLAYED FLUIDITCH AGAINST WARRINGTON, SEENED HIS HEAD IN DISGUST. WE CAN'T HAVE A SLOTHERIN CHAMPION!

AND ALL THE FLAPPLEPPS ARE TALKING ABOUT DICKEY, SAID SEAMUS CONTEMPTUOUSLY. BUT I WOULDN'T HAVE THOUGHT HE'D HAVE WANTED THE RISK HIS GOOD LOOKS.

LISTEN! SAID HERMIONE SUDDENLY.

PEOPLE WERE CHEERING OUT IN THE ENTRANCE HALL. THEY ALL SWIVELLED AROUND IN THEIR SEATS, AND SAW ANGELINA JONES ENTERING THE HALL, GRINNING IN AN EMBARRASSED SORT OF WAY. A TALL BLACK GIRL WHO PLAYED CHASER IN THE GRYPFINDER FLUIDITCH TEAM, ANGELINA CAME OVER TO THEM, SAT DOWN AND SAID, WELL, I'VE DONE IT! I'VE PUT MY NAME IN!

YOU'RE KIDDING! SAID RON, LOOKING IMPRESSED.

ARE YOU SEVENTEEN, THEN? ASKED HARRY.

COURSE SHE IS, CAN'T SEE A BEARD, CAN YOU? SAID RON.

I HAD MY BIRTHDAY LAST WEEK, SAID ANGELINA.

WELL, I'M GLAD SOMEONE FROM GRYPFINDER'S ENTERING, SAID HERMIONE. I REALLY HOPE YOU GET IT, ANGELINA!

THANKS, HERMIONE, SAID ANGELINA, SMILING AT HER.

YEAH, BETTER YOU THAN PRETTY-BEY DICKEY, SAID SEAMUS, CALLING SEVERAL FLAPPLEPPS PASSING THEIR TABLE TOO STEADILY AT HIM.

WHAT ARE WE GOING TO DO TODAY, THEN? RON ASKED HARRY AND HERMIONE, WHEN THEY HAD FINISHED BREAKFAST AND WERE LEAVING

THE GREAT HALL.

WE HAVEN'T BEEN GIVEN THE VISIT FLAG YET, SAID HARRY.

EEK, SAID REN, JUST AS LONG AS HE DOESN'T ASK US THE DEERATE A  
FEW FINGERS THE THE SORRENTS.

A WAVE OF GREAT EXCITEMENT SLIDENLY DAWNED ON HERMIONE'S  
FACE.

THE CHEELET OF FIRE 221

I'VE JUST REALISED I HAVEN'T ASKED FLAGRID THE IHIN S.P.L.N.  
YET? SHE SAID BRIGHTLY. WAIT FOR ME, WILL YOU, WHILE I NIP  
UPSTAIRS AND GET THE BADGES?

WHAT'S SHE LIKE? SAID REN, EXASPERATED, AS HERMIONE RAN  
ALAY UP THE MARBLE STAIRCASE.

HEY, REN, SAID HARRY SLIDENLY. IT'S YOUR FRIEND ...

THE STUDENTS FROM REALMATHENS WERE COMING THROUGH THE  
FRONT DOORS FROM THE GREENS, AMONG THEM, THE VELA GIRL.  
THESE GATHERED AROUND THE CHEELET OF FIRE STEAD BACK THE LET  
THEM PASS, WATCHING EAGERLY.

MADAME MAXIME ENTERED THE HALL BEHIND HER STUDENTS AND  
ORGANISED THEM INTO A LINE. ONE BY ONE, THE REALMATHENS  
STUDENTS STEPPED ACROSS THE AGED LINE AND DROPPED THEIR SLIPS OF  
PARCHMENT INTO THE BLUE-WHITE FLAMES. AS EACH NAME ENTERED  
THE FIRE, IT TURNED BRIEFLY RED AND EMITTED SPARKS.

WHAT'D YOU RECKEN LL HAPPEN THE THE HENS THAT AREN'T  
CHESN? REN MUTTERED THE HARRY, AS THE VELA GIRL DROPPED HER  
PARCHMENT INTO THE CHEELET OF FIRE. RECKEN THEY LL GO BACK THE  
SCHOOL, OR HANG AROUND THE WATCH THE TOURNAMENT?



BLINDLY, SAID HARRY, FANG ARELIND, I SUPPOSE ... MADAME  
MAXIME IS STAYING THE ILDER, ISN'T SHE?

WHEN ALL THE REALIZATIONS STUDENTS HAD SUBMITTED THEIR  
NAMES, MADAME MAXIME LED THEM BACK OUT OF THE HALL AND  
INTO THE GROUNDINGS AGAIN.

WHERE ARE THEY SLEEPING, THEN? SAID BEN, MOVING TOWARDS  
THE FRONT DEER AND STARING AFTER THEM.

A LOUD RATTLING NOISE BEHIND THEM ANNOUNCED HERMINE'S  
REAPPEARANCE WITH THE BOX OF S.P.L.W. BADGES.

HEY, CHEER, HURRY UP, SAID BEN, AND HE LIMPED DOWN  
THE STONE STEPS, KEEPING HIS EYES ON THE BACK OF THE VELA  
GIRL, WHO WAS NOW HALFWAY ACROSS THE LAWN WITH MADAME  
MAXIME.

AS THEY NEARED HAGRID'S CABIN ON THE EDGE OF THE FORBIDDEN  
FOREST, THE MYSTERY OF THE REALIZATIONS SLEEPING QUARTERS WAS  
SOLVED. THE GIGANTIC PHEASANT-BLUE CARRIAGE IN WHICH THEY HAD

THE HARRY POTTER

ARRIVED HAD BEEN PARKED TWO HUNDRED YARDS FROM HAGRID'S  
FRONT DEER, AND THE STUDENTS WERE CLIMBING BACK INSIDE IT. THE  
ELEPHANTINE FLYING HORSES THAT HAD PULLED THE CARRIAGE WERE  
NOW GRAZING IN A MAREK-HIT PADDOCK ALONGSIDE IT.

HARRY KNOCKED ON HAGRID'S DEER, AND FANG'S RHEMING BARKS  
ANSWERED INSTANTLY.

WHAT TIME? SAID HAGRID, WHEN HE DALLING OPEN THE DEER AND  
SAW WHO WAS KNOCKING. TWILIGHT WILL BE D FORGOTTEN WHERE I  
LIVE?

WE VE BEEN REALLY BUSY, F-JAG F-JERMIENE STARTED THE SAY, BUT THEN SHE STOPPED DEAD, LEERING UP AT F-JAGRID, APPARENTLY LOST HER WORDS.

F-JAGRID WAS WEARING HIS BEST (AND VERY TERRIBLE) FAIRY QUEEN SLIT, PLUS A CHECKED YELLOW-AND-ORANGE TIE. THIS WASN'T THE WORST OF IT, THOUGH; HE HAD EVIDENTLY TRIED TO TAME HIS HAIR, USING LARGE QUANTITIES OF WHAT APPEARED TO BE AXLE GREASE. IT WAS NOW SLIDED DOWN INTO TWO CLUMPS PERHAPS HE HAD TRIED A PONYTAIL LIKE BILL S, BUT FINDING HE HAD TOO MUCH HAIR, THE HAIR DIDN'T REALLY SLIT F-JAGRID AT ALL. FOR A MOMENT, F-JERMIENE GOGGLED AT HIM, THEN, HEAVILY DECIDING NOT TO COMMENT, SHE SAID, KRM WHERE ARE THE SECRETIS?

HELT BY THE PLUMPOIN PATCH, SAID F-JAGRID HAPPILY. THEY'RE GETTING MASSIVE, PLUS BE NEARLY THREE FEET LONG NOW. EN Y TERRIBLE IS, THEY'VE STARTED KILLING EACH OTHER.

EH, NH, REALLY? SAID F-JERMIENE, SHOOTING A REPRESSIVE LEER AT REEN, WHO, STARING AT F-JAGRID'S HED HAIRSTYLE, HAD JUST OPENED HIS MOUTH TO SAY SOMETHING ABOUT IT.

YEAH, SAID F-JAGRID SADLY. I HED, THOUGH, I'VE GOT EM IN SEPARATE BOXES NOW. STILL GOT ABOUT TWENTY.

WELL, THAT'S BUSY, SAID REEN. F-JAGRID MISSED THE SARCASTISM. F-JAGRID'S CARIN COMPRISED A SINGLE ROOM, IN ONE CORNER OF WHICH WAS A GIANTIC RED CHEYERD IN A PATCHWORK HILT. A SIMILARLY ENORMOUS WOODEN TABLE AND CHAIRS STOOD IN FRONT OF THE FIRE, BENEATH THE QUANTITY OF CURED HAMS AND DEAD BIRDS

HANGING FROM THE CEILING. THEY SAT DOWN AT THE TABLE WHILE

THE CHEER OF FIRE

HAGRID STARTED THE MAKE TEA, AND WERE SHEEN IMMersed IN YET  
MORE DISCUSSION OF THE TRIWIZARD THERNAMMENT, HAGRID SEEMED  
ELITE AS EXCITED ABOUT IT AS THEY WERE.

WELL WAIT, HE SAID, GRINNING. WELL ILS WAIT, YER GING TER SEE  
SOME STUFF YEH VE NEVER SEEN BEFORE, FIRS TASK ... AH, BUT I M  
NOT SLIPPED TER SAY.

OH HEN, HAGRID: HARRY, RON AND HERMIONE WIGED HIM, BUT  
HE ILS STHEED HIS HEAD, GRINNING.

I DEN WANT TER SPEIL IT FER YEH, SAID HAGRID, BUT IT S GINGNA  
BE SPECTACULAR, I LL TELL YEH THAT. THEM CHAMPIONS RE GING TER  
HAVE THEIR WERD BUT HLT, NEVER THOUGHT I D LIVE TER SEE THE  
TRIWIZARD THERNAMMENT PLAYED AGAIN.

THEY ENDED UP HAVING LUNCH WITH HAGRID, THOUGH THEY  
DIDN T EAT MUCH HAGRID HAD MADE WHAT HE SAID WAS A KEEP  
CASSEROLE, BUT AFTER HERMIONE LINEARTHEED A LARGE TALKIN IN HER, SHE,  
HARRY AND RON RATHER LOST THEIR APPETITES. THEY ENJOYED  
THEMSELVES TRYING THE MAKE HAGRID TELL THEM WHAT THE TASKS IN  
THE THERNAMMENT WERE GING TH BE, HOWEVER, SPECULATING WHICH  
OF THE ENTRANTS WERE LIKELY TH BE SELECTED AS CHAMPIONS, AND  
WONDERING WHETHER FRED AND GEORGE WERE BEARLESS YET.

A LIGHT RAIN HAD STARTED THE FALL BY MID-AFTERNOON; IT WAS VERY  
CHEY SITTING BY THE FIRE, LISTENING TO THE GENTLE PATTERN OF THE  
DREPS IN THE WINDH, WATCHING HAGRID DARNING HIS SHOES AND  
ARGUING WITH HERMIONE ABOUT FELISE-ELVES FOR HE FLATLY

REFUSED THE IRON S.P.E.W. WHEN SHE SHOWED HIM HER BADGES.

IT D BE DIN IN AN UNKINDNESS, HERMINE, HE SAID GRAVELY, THREADING A MASSIVE IRON NEEDLE WITH THICK YELLOW YARN. IT S IN THEIR NATURE TO WHISK AFTER HUMANS, THAT S WHAT THEY LIKE, SEE? YEH D BE MAKIN IN LINE-UPPY TO TAKE AWAY THEIR WHISK, AN INSULTIN IN IF YEH TRIED TO PAY IN.

BUT HARRY SET DICKY FREE, AND HE WAS EVER THE MEN WHO ASKED IT? SAID HERMINE. AND WE HEARD HE S ASKING FOR WAGES NEH? YEAH, WELL, YEH GET WEIRDOS IN EVERY CREED. I M NOT SAYIN THERE ISN T THE HOD OF WHO D TAKE FREEDOM, BUT YEH LL NEVER PERSUADE MOST OF IN TO DO IT NEH, NEH-IN DIN , HERMINE.

ZZZ HARRY PEEETTER

HERMINE WHISKED VERY CROSS INDEED, AND STUFFED HER IRON BADGES BACK INTO HER LEAD POUCH.

BY HALF PAST FIVE IT WAS GROWING DARK, AND THEN, HARRY AND HERMINE DECIDED IT WAS TIME TO GET BACK UP TO THE CASTLE FOR

THE FAMILIAR FEAST AND, MORE IMPORTANTLY, THE ANNOUNCEMENT OF THE SCHOOL CHAMPIONS.

I LL COME WITH YEH, SAID HAGRID, PUTTING AWAY HIS DARNING. ILIS GIVE US A SEC.

HAGRID GET UP, WENT ACROSS THE THE CHEST OF DRAWERS BESIDE HIS BED AND BEGAN SEARCHING FOR SOMETHING INSIDE IT. THEY DIDN T PAY THEM MUCH ATTENTION, UNTIL A TRILY HORRIBLE SMELL REACHED THEIR NOSTRILS.

CHUCKLING, RICH SAID, FJAGRID, WHAT'S THAT?

LET SAID FJAGRID, TURNING AROUND WITH A LARGE BOTTLE IN HIS HAND, DOEN YOU LIKE IT?

IS THAT AFTERSHAVE? SAID FJERMINE, IN A SLIGHTLY CHERED VOICE.

ER RAL-DE-LEHENE, FJAGRID MUTTERED, HE WAS KISSING.

MAYBE IT'S A BIT MUCH, HE SAID GRUPLY, I'LL GET TAKE IT OFF, HANG ON ...

HE STUMPED OUT OF THE CABIN, AND THEY SAW HIM WASHING HIMSELF VIGOROUSLY IN THE WATER BARREL BESIDE THE WINDOW.

RAL-DE-LEHENE? SAID FJERMINE IN AMAZEMENT, FJAGRID?

AND WHAT'S WITH THE HAIR AND THE SLIT? SAID FJARRY IN AN UNDERTONE.

LEHNE? SAID RICH SUDDENLY, POINTING OUT OF THE WINDOW.

FJAGRID HAD JUST STRAIGHTENED UP AND TURNED AROUND. IF HE HAD BEEN KISSING BEFORE, IT WAS NOTHING THE WHAT HE WAS DOING NOW. GETTING THE THEIR FEET VERY CALTHERLY, SHE THAT FJAGRID WOULDNT SPEAK THEM, FJARRY, RICH AND FJERMINE PEERED THROUGH THE WINDOW AND SAW THAT MADAME MAXIME AND THE REALMREATHENS STUDENTS HAD JUST EMERGED FROM THEIR CARRIAGE, CLEARLY ABOUT THE SET OFF FOR THE FEAST, THEN. THEY COULDNT HEAR WHAT FJAGRID WAS SAYING, BUT HE WAS TALKING THE MADAME MAXIME WITH A RAPID, MISTY-EYED EXPRESSION FJARRY HAD ONLY

THE GURGLT OF FIRE WRS

EVER SEEN HIM WEAR HENCE BEFORE WHEN HE HAD BEEN LEHNE AT THE BAY DRAGON, NERKERT.

HE'S GOING UP THE THE CASTLE WITH HER? SAID HERMIONE INDIGNANTLY. I THOUGHT HE WAS WAITING FOR US?

WITHOUT SEE MUCH AS A BACKWARD GLANCE AT HIS CABIN, HARRY WAS TRUDGING OFF UP THE GREENS WITH MADAME MAXIME, THE BEAUKRATHENS STUDENTS FOLLOWING IN THEIR WAKE, HEGGING THE DEEP UP WITH THEIR ENERGETIC STRIDES.

HE FANCIES HER? SAID RON INCREDULOUSLY. WELL, IF THEY END UP HAVING CHILDREN, THEY LL BE SETTING A WORLD RECORD BUT ANY BABY OF THEIRS WOULD WEIGH ABOUT A TON.

THEY LET THEMSELVES BE UP THE CABIN AND SHUT THE DOOR BEHIND THEM. IT WAS SURPRISINGLY DARK OUTSIDE, DRAINING THEIR CHAKRAS MORE CLOSELY AROUND THEMSELVES, THEY SET OFF UP THE SLEEPING LAINS.

HEH, IT'S THEM, WHOO? HERMIONE WHISPERED.

THE DORMSTRANG PARTY WERE WALKING UP TOWARDS THE CASTLE FROM THE LAKE. VICTOR CRUM WAS WALKING SIDE BY SIDE WITH KARKADANN, AND THE OTHER DORMSTRANG STUDENTS WERE STRAGGLING ALONG BEHIND THEM. RON WATCHED CRUM EXCITEDLY, BUT CRUM DID NOT LOOK AROUND AS HE REACHED THE FRONT DOORS A LITTLE AHEAD OF HERMIONE, RON AND HARRY, AND PROCEEDED THROUGH THEM. WHEN THEY ENTERED THE CANDLELIT GREAT HALL IT WAS ALMOST FULL. THE CHEST OF FIRE HAD BEEN MOVED; IT WAS NOW STANDING IN FRONT OF DRUNKEN'S EMPTY CHAIR AT THE TEACHERS TABLE. FRED AND GEORGE CLEARLY HAVEN AGAIN SEEMED TO HAVE TAKEN THEIR DISAPPOINTMENT FAIRLY WELL.

"HOPE IT'S ANGELINA," SAID FRED, AS HARRY, RON AND HERMIONIE SAT DOWN.

"SEE ME I?" SAID HERMIONIE BREATHLESSLY. "WELL, WE'LL SEE SOON ENOUGH."

THE FAMILIAR FEAST SEEMED TO TAKE MUCH LONGER THAN USUAL, PERHAPS BECAUSE IT WAS THEIR SECOND FEAST IN TWO DAYS. HARRY DIDN'T SEEM TOO FANCY THE EXTRAVAGANTLY PREPARED MEAT AS MUCH AS HE WOULD NORMALLY HAVE DONE, LIKE EVERYONE ELSE IN THE HARRY POTTER

THE HALL, JUDGING BY THE CONSTANTLY CRANING NECKS, THE IMPATIENT EXPRESSIONS ON EVERY FACE, THE FIDGETING AND THE STANDING

UP TO SEE WHETHER DUMBLEDORE HAD FINISHED EATING YET, HARRY SIMPLY WANTED THE PLATES TO CLEAR, AND TO HEAR WHO HAD BEEN SELECTED AS CHAMPIONS.

AT LONG LAST, THE GOLDEN PLATES RETURNED TO THEIR ORIGINAL SPOTLESS STATE; THERE WAS A SHARP UPSWING IN THE LEVEL OF NOISE WITHIN THE HALL, WHICH DIED AWAY ALMOST INSTANTLY AS DUMBLEDORE GOT TO HIS FEET. ON EITHER SIDE OF HIM, PROFESSOR BARBAROUS AND MADAME MAXIME LOOKED AS TENSE AND EXPECTANT AS ANYONE. ELIUS BAGMAN WAS BEAMING AND WINKING AT VARIOUS STUDENTS. MR CRUELICH, HOWEVER, LOOKED BLITZ UNINTERESTED, ALMOST BORED.

"WELL, THE GHOST IS ALMOST READY TO MAKE ITS DECISION," SAID DUMBLEDORE. "I ESTIMATE THAT IT REQUIRES ONE MORE MINUTE.

NOW, WHEN THE CHAMPIONS' NAMES ARE CALLED, I WOULD ASK THEM PLEASE TO COME UP THE THE TOP OF THE TALL, WALK ALONG THE STAFF TABLE, AND GO THROUGH INTO THE NEXT CHAMBER. HE INDICATED THE DOOR BEHIND THE STAFF TABLE. WHERE THEY WILL BE RECEIVING THEIR FIRST INSTRUCTIONS.

HE THEN HILT HIS HAND AND GAVE A GREAT SWEEPING WAVE WITH IT; AT ONCE, ALL THE CANDLES EXCEPT THOSE INSIDE THE CARVED PUMPKINS WERE EXTINGUISHED, PLUNGING THEM ALL INTO A STATE OF SEMI-DARKNESS. THE CHINK OF FIRE NOW SHONE MORE BRIGHTLY THAN ANYTHING IN THE WHOLE TALL, THE SPARKLING BRIGHT, BLISS-WHITENESS OF THE FLAMES ALMOST PAINFUL ON THE EYES. EVERYONE WATCHED, WAITING ... A FEW PEOPLE KEPT CHECKING THEIR WATCHES ...

AND SECOND, LEE JORDAN WHISPERED, THE SEATS ALOOF FROM HARRY.

THE FLAMES INSIDE THE CHINK TURNED SUDDENLY RED AGAIN. SPARKS BEGAN TO FLY FROM IT. NEXT MOMENT, A TONGUE OF FLAME SHOT INTO THE AIR, A CHARRED PIECE OF PARCHMENT FLUTTERED OUT OF IT. THE WHOLE ROOM GASPED.

DUMBLEDORE CAUGHT THE PIECE OF PARCHMENT AND HELD IT AT

THE CHINK OF FIRE WAS

ARM'S LENGTH, SO THAT HE COULD READ IT BY THE LIGHT OF THE FLAMES, WHICH HAD TURNED BACK THE BLISS-WHITE.

THE CHAMPION FOR DUMBLEDORE, HE READ, IN A STRONG, CLEAR VOICE, WILL BE VICTOR CRUMB.

NO SURPRISES THERE? YELLED RON, AS A STORM OF APPLAUSE AND



CHIPPING SWEEP THE FLOOR. HARRY SAW VICTOR CRUM RISE FROM THE SLOTHERIN TABLE, AND SMELT UP TOWARDS DUMBLEDORE; HE TURNED RIGHT, WALKED ALONG THE STAFF TABLE, AND DISAPPEARED THROUGH THE DOOR INTO THE NEXT CHAMBER.

BRAVE, VICTOR! CHEERED DUMBLEDORE, HE BELIEVED THAT EVERYONE WOULD HEAR HIM, EVEN OVER ALL THE APPLAUSE. DUNNELL HAD IT IN HER!

THE CLAPPING AND CHATTING DIED DOWN. WHEN EVERYONE'S ATTENTION WAS FOCUSED AGAIN ON THE CHIEF, WHICH, SECONDS LATER,

TURNED RED HENCE MORE. A SECOND PIECE OF PARCEMENT SHEET FLIT UP IT, PROPELLED BY THE FLAMES.

THE CHAMPION FOR REALIZATIONS, SAID DUMBLEDORE, IS FLEET DELACOUR!

IT'S HER, THEN? HARRY SMELT, AS THE GIRL WHO SHE RESEMBLED A FEEL GET GRACEFULLY TO HER FEET, SHEER BACK HER SHEET OF SILVER BLOND HAIR AND SWEEP UP BETWEEN THE RAVENCLAW AND HUFFLEPUFF TABLES.

HEY, LOOK, THEY'RE ALL DISAPPOINTED, FERMINE SAID OVER THE NOISE, NEEDING TOWARDS THE REMAINDER OF THE REALIZATIONS PARTY. DISAPPOINTED WAS A BIT OF AN UNDERSTATEMENT, HARRY

THOUGHT. TWO OF THE GIRLS WHO HAD NOT BEEN SELECTED HAD DISSELMED INTO TEARS, AND WERE SHAKING WITH THEIR HEADS ON THEIR ARMS.

WHEN FLORA DELACOUR, THEN, HAD VANISHED INTO THE SIDE CHAMBER, SILENCE FELL AGAIN, BUT THIS TIME IT WAS A SILENCE SHE STIFF WITH EXCITEMENT SHE COULD ALMOST TASTE IT. THE HOGWARTS CHAMPION NEXT ...

AND THE SHEET OF FIRE TURNED RED ONCE MORE; SPARKS STELLERED OUT OF IT; THE TENGUE OF FLAME SHEET HIGH INTO THE AIR, AND FROM ITS TIP DUMBLEDORE PULLED THE THIRD PIECE OF PARLAMENT.

THE HARRY POTTER

THE HOGWARTS CHAMPION, HE CALLED, IS CEDRIC DIGGORY?  
YES, SAID RON WEILDBY, BUT NOBODY HEARD HIM EXCEPT HARRY;  
THE WITCHER FROM THE NEXT TABLE WAS THEN GREAT. EVERY SINGLE

WIZARD HAD JUMPED TO HIS OR HER FEET, SCREAMING AND STAMPING, AS CEDRIC MADE HIS WAY PAST THEM, GRINNING BROADLY, AND

HEADED OFF TOWARDS THE CHAMBER BEHIND THE TEACHERS TABLE.  
INDEED, THE APPLAUSE FOR CEDRIC WENT ON SHE LONG THAT IT WAS SOME TIME BEFORE DUMBLEDORE COULD MAKE HIMSELF HEARD AGAIN.

EXCELLENT! DUMBLEDORE CALLED HAPPILY, AS AT LAST THE TUMULT DIED DOWN. WELL, WE NOW HAVE FOUR THREE CHAMPIONS. I AM SURE I CAN HEUNT WITHIN ALL OF THEM, INCLUDING THE REMAINING STUDENTS

FROM SEALBREAKERS AND DUMSTRANE, THEY GIVE THEIR CHAMPIONS  
EVERY HINCE OF SLIPPERT THEY CAN MUSTER, BY CHEERING THEIR  
CHAMPIONS ON, THEY WILL CONTRIBUTE IN A VERY REAL  
BUT DUMBLEDORE SUDDENLY STOPPED SPEAKING, AND IT WAS  
APPARENT TO EVERYBODY WHAT HAD DISTRACTED HIM.  
THE FIRE IN THE CHURCH HAD JUST TURNED RED AGAIN, SPARKS WERE  
FLYING OUT OF IT, A LONG FLAME SPENT SUDDENLY INTO THE AIR, AND  
BEHOLD WHEN IT WAS ANOTHER PIECE OF PARCEMENT,  
AUTOMATICALLY, IT SEEMED, DUMBLEDORE REACHED OUT A LONG  
HAND AND SEIZED THE PARCEMENT, HE HELD IT UP AND STARED AT  
THE NAME WRITTEN UPON IT, THERE WAS A LONG PAUSE, DURING  
WHICH DUMBLEDORE STARED AT THE SLIP IN HIS HANDS, AND EVERY-  
ONE IN THE ROOM STARED AT DUMBLEDORE, AND THEN DUMBLEDORE  
CLEARED HIS THROAT, AND READ OUT  
HARRY POTTER.

## CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

### THE THEIR CHAMPIONS

HARRY SAT THERE, AWARE THAT EVERY HEAD IN THE GREAT HALL HAD  
TURNED THE OTHER AT HIM, HE WAS STUNNED, HE FELT NUMB, HE WAS  
SURELY DREAMING, HE HAD NOT HEARD CORRECTLY,  
THERE WAS NO APPLAUSE, A BUZZING, AS THOUGH OF ANGRY BEES,  
WAS STARTING THE FILL THE HALL; SOME STUDENTS WERE STANDING UP THE

GET A BETTER VIEW AT HARRY AS HE SAT, FROZEN, IN HIS SEAT,

UP AT THE TOP TABLE, PROFESSOR MCGRATHALL HAD GOT THE HER FEET

AND SLEPT PAST LORD BAGMAN AND PROFESSOR DARDARREY THE WEIS-  
PER URGENTLY THE PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE, WHO KENT HIS EAR

THEHARDS HER, FEELING SLIGHTLY,

HARRY TURNED THE REIN AND HERMIONE; BEYOND THEM, HE SAW  
THE LONG GRYFFINDER TABLE ALL WATCHING HIM, EVEN MERTHER.

I DIDN'T PUT MY NAME IN, HARRY SAID BLANDLY, YOU KNOW I  
DIDN'T.

BOTH OF THEM STARED JUST AS BLANDLY BACK.

AT THE TOP TABLE, PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE HAD STRAIGHTENED UP,  
NEEDING THE PROFESSOR MCGRATHALL.

HARRY BETTER! HE CALLED AGAIN, HARRY! UP HERE, IF YOU  
PLEASE!

OH HEN, HERMIONE WHISPERED, GIVING HARRY A SLIGHT PUSH.

HARRY GOT THE HIS FEET, TRIED TO GET THE HERMION HIS REBELS AND STUM-  
BLED SLIGHTLY. HE SET OFF UP THE GAP BETWEEN THE GRYFFINDER AND

SLIPPERY TABLES. IT FELT LIKE AN IMMENSELY LONG WALK; THE TOP  
TABLE DIDN'T SEEM TO BE GETTING ANY NEARER AT ALL, AND HE COULD  
FEEL HUNDREDS AND HUNDREDS OF EYES UPON HIM, AS THOUGH EACH  
WAS A SEARCHLIGHT. THE BUZZING GREW LOUDER AND LOUDER. AFTER

AND HARRY BETTER

WHAT SEEMED LIKE AN EELER, HE WAS RIGHT IN FRONT OF

DUMBLEDORE, FEELING THE STARES OF ALL THE TEACHERS UPON HIM.

WELL ... THROUGH THE DOOR, HARRY, SAID DUMBLEDORE, HE WASN'T SMILING.

HARRY MOVED OFF ALONG THE TEACHERS' TABLE. HAGRID WAS SAT RIGHT AT THE END. HE DID NOT WINK AT HARRY, HE WAVE, HE GIVE ANY

OF HIS USUAL SIGNS OF GREETING. HE LOOKED COMPLETELY ASTONISHED, AND STARED AT HARRY AS HE PASSED, LIKE EVERYONE ELSE.

HARRY WENT THROUGH THE DOOR OUT OF THE GREAT HALL, AND FOUND HIMSELF IN A SMALLER ROOM, LINED WITH PAINTINGS OF WITCHES AND WIZARDS. A HANDSOME FIRE WAS BURNING IN THE FIREPLACE OPPOSITE HIM.

THE FACES IN THE PORTRAITS TURNED TO LOOK AT HIM AS HE ENTERED. HE SAW A WIZENED WITCH FLIT OUT OF THE FRAME OF HER PICTURE AND INTO THE ONE NEXT TO IT, WHICH CONTAINED A WIZARD

WITH A HAIRY MUSTACHE. THE WIZENED WITCH STARTED WHISPERING IN HIS EAR.

VICTOR KRAM, CEDRIC DIGGORY AND ALBUS DUMBLEDORE WERE

GREETED AROUND THE FIRE. THEY LOOKED STRANGELY IMPRESSIVE, SILHOUETTED AGAINST THE FLAMES. KRAM, FLINCHED UP AND BREEDING,

WAS LEANING AGAINST THE MANTELPIECE, SLIGHTLY APART FROM THE

ETHER THREE, CEDRIC WAS STANDING WITH HIS HANDS BEHIND HIS BACK, STARING INTO THE FIRE, MELIA DELACOUR LOOKED AROUND WHEN HARRY WALKED IN, AND THREW BACK HER SHEET OF LONG, SILVER HAIR. WHAT IS IT? SHE SAID. DO YOU WANT US BACK IN THE HALL? SHE THOUGHT HE HAD COME TO DELIVER A MESSAGE, HARRY DIDN'T KNOW HOW TO EXPLAIN WHAT HAD JUST HAPPENED, HE JUST STOOD THERE, LOOKING AT THE THREE CHAMPIONS, IT STRUCK HIM HOW VERY TALL ALL OF THEM WERE.

THERE WAS A SOUND OF SLURRYING FEET BEHIND HIM, AND LORD BAGMAN ENTERED THE ROOM, HE TOOK HARRY BY THE ARM, AND LED HIM FORWARDS.

EXTRAORDINARY! HE MUTTERED, SQUEEZING HARRY'S ARM.

ABSOLUTELY EXTRAORDINARY! GENTLEMEN ... LADY, HE ADDED, APPROACHING THE FIRESIDE AND ADDRESSING THE OTHER THREE. MAY I

THE MELIA CHAMPIONS 241

INTRODUCE INCREIBLE THOUGH IT MAY SEEM THE FOURTH TRILIZARD CHAMPION?

VICTOR DURLIN STRAIGHTENED UP, HIS SLURRY FACE DARKENED AS HE SURVEYED HARRY, CEDRIC LOOKED NEUTRALISED, HE LOOKED FROM BAGMAN TO HARRY AND BACK AGAIN AS THOUGH SURE HE MUST HAVE MIST-HEARD WHAT BAGMAN HAD SAID, MELIA DELACOUR, HOWEVER, THESSED HER HAIR, SMILING, AND SAID, HEH, VAIKY FLINDY HERE, MEETER BAGMAN.

HERE? BAGMAN REPEATED, BEMILDERED, NEH, NEH, NOT AT ALL!

HARRY'S NAME JUST CAME OUT OF THE CRACKLE OF FIRE!

DURLIN'S THICK EYEBROWS CONTRACTED SLIGHTLY, CEDRIC WAS STILL

LEERING DELICATELY REWILDERED,

FLEUR FREEMANED, BUT EVIDENTLY ZAIR AS BEEN A MISTAKE, SHE  
SAID CONTEMPTUOUSLY THE BAGMAN, I CANNOT COMPETE, I IS THE  
FEELING.

WELL ... IT IS AMAZING, SAID BAGMAN, RUBBING HIS SMITH-  
CHAIN AND SMILING DEEN AT F-JARRY, BUT, AS YELL DEEN, THE AGE

RESTRICTION WAS ONLY IMPOSED THIS YEAR AS AN EXTRA SAFETY MEAS-  
URE, AND AS HIS NAME S COME HLT OF THE CERELET ... I MEAN, I

DEEN T THINK THERE CAN BE ANY DUCKING HLT AT THIS STAGE ... IT S  
DEEN IN THE RULES, YELL BE HELICED ... F-JARRY WILL ILIST HAVE THE DE  
THE REST HE

THE DEER BEHIND THEM OPENED AGAIN, AND A LARGE CROWD OF  
PEOPLE CAME IN: PROFESSOR DUMKEDORE, FOLLOWED CLOSELY BY MR  
CREECH, PROFESSOR DARDAROFF, MADAME MAXIME, PROFESSOR  
MCCHINACALL AND PROFESSOR SNARE, F-JARRY HEARD THE KLIZZING OF  
THE HUNDREDS OF STUDENTS EN THE EITHER SIDE OF THE WALL, BEHIND  
PROFESSOR MCCHINACALL CLOSED THE DEER.

MADAME MAXIME? SAID FLEUR AT ENCE, STRIDING EVER THE HER  
HEADMISTRESS, ZY ARE SAYING ZAT ZIS LITTLE DEY IS THE COMPETE  
ALSH?

SOMEWHERE UNDER F-JARRY S NOSE DISBELIEF, HE FELT A RIPPLE OF  
ANGER, LITTLE DEY?

MADAME MAXIME HAD DRAWN HERSELF UP THE HER FULL, AND CON-  
SIDERABLE, HEIGHT, THE TOP OF HER HANDSOME HEAD BRUSHED THE

THE HARRY POTTER

CANDLE-FILLED CHANDELIER, AND HER GIGANTIC BLACK SATIN KEESY  
SWELLED.

WHAT IS THE MEANING OF THIS, DUMBLEDORE? SHE SAID IMPERI-  
HELSLY.

I'D RATHER LIKE THE KNEL THAT MYSELF, DUMBLEDORE, SAID  
PROFESSOR KARDAREFF, HE WAS WEARING A STEELY SMILE, AND HIS  
BLUE EYES WERE LIKE CHIPS OF ICE. THE HOGWARTS CHAMPIONS? I  
DIDN'T REMEMBER ANYONE TELLING ME THE FIRST SCHOOL IS ALLOWED  
TWO CHAMPIONS. OR HAVE I NOT READ THE RULES CAREFULLY  
ENOUGH?

HE GAVE A SHORT AND NASTY LAUGH.

IT IS IMPOSSIBLE, SAID MADAME MAXIME, WHOSE ENORMOUS  
HAND WITH ITS MANY SLIPPER FINGERS WAS RESTING UPON HER  
SHOULDER. HOGWARTS CANNOT AVE TWO CHAMPIONS. IT IS MOST  
INJUST.

WE WERE UNDER THE IMPRESSION THAT YOUR AGE LINE WOULD  
KEEP OUT YOUNGER COMPETITORS, DUMBLEDORE, SAID KARDAREFF, HIS  
STEELY SMILE STILL IN PLACE, THOUGH HIS EYES WERE COLDER THAN  
EVER. OTHERWISE, WE WOULD, OF COURSE, HAVE KNOWN ABOUT A  
WIDER SELECTION OF CANDIDATES FROM YOUR OWN SCHOOLS.

IT'S NOT AS IF I HADN'T TOLD POTTER, KARDAREFF, SAID SNAPE SEETLY.  
HIS BLACK EYES WERE ALIGHT WITH MALICE. DIDN'T SEE BLAMING  
DUMBLEDORE FOR POTTER'S DETERMINATION THE BREAK RULES, HE HAS



KEEN CROSSING LINES EVER SINCE HE ARRIVED HERE

THANK YOU, SEVERUS, SAID DUMBLEDORE FIRMLY, AND SNAPE WENT AWAY, THOUGH HIS EYES STILL GLINTED MALICIOUSLY THOUGH HIS CURTAIN OF GREASY BLACK HAIR.

PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE WAS NOW LOOKING DOWN AT HARRY, WHO LOOKED RIGHT BACK AT HIM, TRYING TO DISCERN THE EXPRESSION OF THE EYES BEHIND THE HALF-MOON SPECTACLES.

DID YOU PUT YOUR NAME INTO THE CHALK OF FIRE, HARRY? DUMBLEDORE ASKED CALMLY.

NO, SAID HARRY, HE WAS VERY AWARE OF EVERYBODY WATCHING HIM CLOSELY. SNAPE MADE A SHORT NOISE OF IMPATIENT DISBELIEF IN THE SEATBELT.

THE FEELER CHAMPIONS ARE

DID YOU ASK AN ELDER STUDENT TO PUT IT INTO THE CHALK OF FIRE FOR YOU? SAID PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE, IGNORING SNAPE.

NO, SAID HARRY VEHEMENTLY.

AH, BUT HE CHARGES HE IS LYING! CRIED MADAME MAXIME. SNAPE WAS NOW SHAKING HIS HEAD, HIS LIP CURLING.

HE COULD NOT HAVE CROSSED THE AGE LINE, SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL SHARPLY. I AM SURE WE ARE ALL AGREED HERE THAT DUMBLEDORE MUST HAVE MADE A MISTAKE WITH THE LINE, SAID MADAME MAXIME, SMILING.

IT IS POSSIBLE, HE CHARGES, SAID DUMBLEDORE POLITELY.

DUMBLEDORE, YOU KNOW PERFECTLY WELL YOU DID NOT MAKE A

MISTAKE! SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL ANGRILY. REALLY, WHAT THEN

SENSE? HARRY COULD NOT HAVE CROSSED THE LINE HIMSELF, AND AS

PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE BELIEVES THAT HE DID NOT PERSUADE AN  
ELDER STUDENT TO DO IT FOR HIM, I'M SURE THAT SHOULD BE GOOD  
ENOUGH FOR EVERYBODY ELSE?

SHE SEEMED A VERY ANGRY LADY AT PROFESSOR SNAPE.

MR CRUELCH ... MR BAGMAN, SAID KARAKORUM, HIS VOICE  
SOUNDING MORE, WELL, AS HE WAS AN OBJECTIVE JUDGE,  
SURELY YOU WILL AGREE THAT THIS IS MOST IRREGULAR?  
BAGMAN WIPED HIS REDDISH, RUSSIAN FACE WITH HIS HANDKERCHIEF  
AND LOOKED AT MR CRUELCH, WHO WAS STANDING OUTSIDE THE CIRCLE  
OF THE FIRELIGHT, HIS FACE HALF HIDDEN IN SHADOW. HE LOOKED  
SLIGHTLY PERKY, THE HALF DARKNESS MAKING HIM LOOK MUCH ELDER,  
GIVING HIM AN ALMOST SKULL-LIKE APPEARANCE. WHEN HE SPEAKED,  
HOWEVER, IT WAS IN HIS USUAL CORT VOICE. WE MUST FOLLOW THE  
RULES, AND THE RULES STATE CLEARLY THAT THESE PEOPLE WHOSE  
NAMES COME OUT OF THE CHIMNEY OF FIRE ARE ELIGIBLE TO COMPETE IN  
THE TOURNAMENT.

WELL, BARTY CRUELCH THE RULES ARE BACK THE FRONT, SAID BAGMAN,  
REAMING AND TURNING BACK TO KARAKORUM AND MADAME MAXIME,  
AS THOUGH THE MATTER WAS NOW CLOSED.

I INSIST UPON RESUBMITTING THE NAMES OF THE REST OF MY STU-  
DENTS, SAID KARAKORUM. HE HAD DROPPED HIS UNCLELY TONE AND  
HIS SMILE NOW, HIS FACE WAS A VERY UGLY LADY INDEED. YOU WILL

222 HARRY POTTER

SET UP THE CEREAL OF FIRE HENCE FORTH, AND WE WILL CONTINUE  
ADDING NAMES UNTIL EACH SCHOOL HAS TWO CHAMPIONS. IT'S ONLY  
FAIR, DUMBLEDORE.

BUT KARKAROFF, IT DOESN'T SEEM LIKE THAT, SAID BAGMAN. THE  
CEREAL OF FIRE'S JUST GONE OUT. IT WON'T RE-IGNITE UNTIL THE START  
OF THE NEXT TOURNAMENT.

IN WHICH DUMBLEDORE WILL MEET CERTAINLY NOT BE COM-  
PETING? EXPLODED KARKAROFF. AFTER ALL THEIR MEETINGS AND

NEGOTIATIONS AND COMPROMISES, I LITTLE EXPECTED SOMETHING OF  
THIS NATURE THE NEXT! I HAVE HALF A MIND TO LEAVE NOW!

EMPTY THREAT, KARKAROFF, GROWLED A VOICE FROM NEAR THE  
DOOR. YOU CAN'T LEAVE YOUR CHAMPION NOW. HE'S GOT THE COMPETRE.

THEY'VE ALL GOT THE COMPETRE, BINDING MAGICAL CONTRACT, LIKE  
DUMBLEDORE SAID, CONVENIENT, EH?

MURDOCK HAD JUST ENTERED THE ROOM. HE LIMPED TOWARDS THE  
FIRE, AND WITH EVERY RIGHT STEP HE TOOK, THERE WAS A LILLY CLANK.

CONVENIENT? SAID KARKAROFF. I'M AFRAID I DON'T UNDERSTAND  
YOU, MURDOCK.

HARRY COULD TELL HE WAS TRYING TO SOUND DISDAINFUL, AS  
THOUGH WHAT MURDOCK WAS SAYING WAS BARELY WORTH HIS NOTICE,  
BUT HIS HANDS GAVE HIM AWAY. THEY HAD BALLED THEMSELVES INTO  
FISTS.

DON'T YOU? SAID MURDOCK QUIETLY. IT'S VERY SIMPLE, KARKAROFF.  
SOMEONE PUT POTTER'S NAME IN THAT CEREAL KNOWING HE'D HAVE

THE CHMPETE IF IT CAME ELIT,

EVIDENTLY, SOMEONE HEE WISHED THE GIVE HEGHARTS TWO RITES AT  
ZE APPLE? SAID MADAME MAXIME,

I ELITE AGREE, MADAME MAXIME, SAID KARKAROFF, EHEWING THE  
HER, I SHALL BE LEDGING COMPLAINTS WITH THE MINISTRY OF MAGIC  
AND THE INTERNATIONAL CONFEDERATION OF WIZARDS

IF ANYONE S GET REASON THE COMPLAIN, IT S BETTER, GHEWLED  
MEHNDY, ELIT ... FLINDY THING ... I DEN T HEAR HIM SAYING A  
WORD ...

WHY SHOULD I COMPLAIN? ELIST ELIT FELIX DELACHUR, STAMP-  
ING HER FEET, I AS ZE CHANCE THE CHMPETE, ASN T E? WE ARE ALL

THE FELIX CHAMPIONS ZAS

BEEN HOPING THE BE CHESN HER WEEKS AND WEEKS? ZE FHEHUR HER  
ELUR SCHEELS? A THOUSAND GALLEONS IN PRIZE MONEY ZIS IS A  
CHANCE MANY WOULD DIE FOR?

MAYBE SOMEONE S HOPING BETTER IS CHING THE DIE FOR IT, SAID  
MEHNDY, WITH THE MEREST TRACE OF A GHEWL,

AN EXTREMELY TENSE SILENCE FOLLOVED THESE WORDS,

ELIDE RAGMAN, WHH WAS LEEDING VERY ANXIOUSLY INDEED,  
EHEWLED NERVHELSLY UP AND DOWN HEN HIS FEET AND SAID, MEHNDY,  
ELD MAN ... WHAT A THING THE SAY?

WE ALL KNOW PROFESSOR MEHNDY CONSIDERS THE MORNING WAST-  
ED IF HE HASN T DISCOVERED SIX PLETS THE MURDER HIM REHERE

LUNCH-TIME, SAID KARDARHFF LELIDLY, APPARENTLY HE IS NOW TEACH-  
ING HIS STUDENTS THE FEAR ASSASSINATION, THE, AN HOD ELIALLY IN A

DEFENCE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS TEACHER, DUMPLEDHIRE, BUT WE  
DON'T YET HAVE THEIR REASONS.

IMAGINE THINGS, AM I? GRIELED MEEH. SEEING THINGS, EH?  
IT WAS A SKILLED WITCH OR WIZARD WHO PUT THE KEY'S NAME IN THAT  
CHALKET ...

AND WHAT EVIDENCE IS THERE OF THAT? SAID MADAME MAXIME,  
TWINKLING UP HER FINGER HANDS.

BECAUSE THEY FINGERWINKED A VERY POWERFUL MAGICAL OBJECT?  
SAID MEEH. IT WOULD HAVE NEEDED AN EXCEPTIONALLY STRONG  
CONJURING CHARM TO REMEMBER THAT CHALKET INTO REMEMBERING  
THAT ONLY THREE STUDENTS COMPETE IN THE TOURNAMENT ... I'M  
GUESSING THEY SUBMITTED PITTER'S NAME UNDER A FORTY-THREE  
THEY MADE SURE HE WAS THE ONLY ONE IN HIS CATEGORY ...

THEY SEEM TO HAVE GIVEN THIS A GREAT DEAL OF THOUGHT, MEEH,  
SAID KARDARHFF LELIDLY, AND A VERY INGENUOUS THEORY IT IS  
THOUGH, OF COURSE, I HEARD THEY RECENTLY GOT IT INTO THEIR HEAD

THAT HE OF THEIR BIRTHDAY PRESENTS CONTAINED A CLIPPINGLY DIS-  
GUISSED BASTARD EGG, AND SMASHED IT TO PIECES BEFORE REALISING IT

WAS A CARRIAGE WHEEL. SEE THEY WILL UNDERSTAND IF WE DON'T TAKE THEM  
ENTIRELY SERIOUSLY ...

THERE ARE THOSE WHO WILL TURN INNOCENT OCCASIONS TO THEIR  
ADVANTAGE, MEEH RETORTED IN A MENACING VOICE. IT'S MY JOB TO

THE HARRY POTTER

THINK THE WAY DARK WIZARDS DO, KARAKARH AS YELL HE'GHT THE  
REMEMBER ...

MASTER! SAID DUMBLEDORE WARNINGLY, HARRY WANDERED FOR A  
MOMENT WHEN HE WAS SPEAKING THE, BUT THEN REALISED MAD-EYE  
WOULD HARDLY BE MURDER'S REAL FIRST NAME. MURDER FELL SILENT,  
THOUGH STILL SURVEYING KARAKARH WITH SATISFACTION  
KARAKARH'S  
FACE WAS BURNING.

WHEN THIS SITUATION AROSE, WE DO NOT KNOW, SAID DUMBLEDORE,  
SPEAKING THE EVERYONE GATHERED IN THE ROOM. IT SEEMS TO ME,  
HOWEVER, THAT WE HAVE NO CHOICE BUT TO ACCEPT IT. BOTH CEDRIC  
AND HARRY HAVE BEEN CHOSEN TO COMPETE IN THE TOURNAMENT.  
THIS, THEREFORE, THEY WILL DO ...

AH, BUT DUMBLEDORE

MY DEAR MADAME MAXIME, IF YOU HAVE AN ALTERNATIVE, I  
WOULD BE DELIGHTED TO HEAR IT.

DUMBLEDORE WAITED, BUT MADAME MAXIME DID NOT SPEAK,  
SHE MERELY GLARED. SHE WASN'T THE ONLY ONE, EITHER. SNAPE  
LEERED FLIRTILY; KARAKARH LIVID. BAGMAN, HOWEVER, LEERED  
RATHER EXCITED.

WELL, SHALL WE CRACK HIM, THEN? HE SAID, RUBBING HIS HANDS

TOGETHER AND SMILING AROUND THE ROOM. GET THE GIVE HIM CHAM-  
PIONS THEIR INSTRUCTIONS, HAVEN'T WE? BARTY, WANT TO DO THE

ALBUS?

MR CRUELCH SEEMED TO COME OUT OF A DEEP REVERIE.

YES, HE SAID, INSTRUCTIONS, YES ... THE FIRST TASK ...

HE MOVED FORWARD INTO THE FIRELIGHT, CLOSER TO HARRY

THOUGHT HE LOOKED ILL. THERE WERE DARK SHADOWS BENEATH HIS

EYES, AND A THIN, PAPERY LOOK ABOUT HIS WRINKLED SKIN THAT HAD

NOT BEEN THERE AT THE FLUIDITY WORLD CLIP.

THE FIRST TASK IS DESIGNED TO TEST YOUR DARING, HE TOLD HARRY,

LEON, FLEW AND DRUM, SEE WE ARE NOT GOING TO BE TELLING YOU

WHAT IT IS. COURAGE IN THE FACE OF THE UNKNOWN IS AN IMPORTANT

QUALITY IN A WIZARD ... VERY IMPORTANT ...

THE FIRST TASK WILL TAKE PLACE ON NOVEMBER THE TWENTY-

FOURTH, IN FRONT OF THE OTHER STUDENTS AND THE PANEL OF JUDGES.

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THE CHAMPIONS ARE NOT PERMITTED TO ASK FOR OR ACCEPT HELP

OF ANY KIND FROM THEIR TEACHERS TO COMPLETE THE TASKS IN THE

TOURNAMENT. THE CHAMPIONS WILL FACE THE FIRST CHALLENGE ARMED

ONLY WITH THEIR WANDS. THEY WILL RECEIVE INFORMATION ABOUT THE

SECOND TASK WHEN THE FIRST IS OVER. BEING THE VERY DEMANDING

AND TIME-CONSUMING NATURE OF THE TOURNAMENT, THE CHAMPIONS

ARE EXEMPTED FROM END-OF-YEAR TESTS.

MR CRUELCH TURNED THE LOOK AT DUMBLEDORE. I THINK THAT'S ALL,

IS IT, ALBUS?

I THINK SHE SAID DUMBLEDORE, WHO WAS LOOKING AT MR

CRUELCH WITH MILD CONCERN. ARE YOU SURE YOU WOULDN'T LIKE THE

STAY AT HOGWARTS TONIGHT, BARTY?

NO, DUMBLEDORE, I MUST GET BACK TO THE MINISTRY, SAID MR CROUCH. IT IS A VERY BUSY, VERY DIFFICULT TIME AT THE MOMENT ... I'VE LEFT PELLING WEATHERS IN CHARGE ... VERY ENTHUSIASTIC ... A LITTLE OVER-ENTHUSIASTIC, IF TRUTH BE TOLD ...

YOU'LL COME AND HAVE A DRINK BEFORE YOU GO, AT LEAST? SAID DUMBLEDORE.

COME ON, BARTY, I'M STAYING! SAID BAGMAN BRIGHTLY. IT'S ALL HAPPENING AT HOGWARTS NOW, YOU KNOW, MUCH MORE EXCITING HERE THAN AT THE OFFICE!

I THINK NOT, LUDWIG, SAID CROUCH, WITH A THICKENING OF HIS EYES IN IMPATIENCE.

PROFESSOR DADAHOFF MADAME MAXIME A NIGHTCAP? SAID DUMBLEDORE.

BUT MADAME MAXIME HAD ALREADY PUT HER ARM AROUND FELIX'S SHOULDERS, AND WAS LEADING HER SWIFTLY OUT OF THE ROOM. HARRY COULD HEAR THEM BOTH TALKING VERY FAST IN FRENCH AS THEY WENT OFF INTO THE GREAT HALL. DADAHOFF RECKONED THE GIRL, AND THEY, THEN, EXITED, THOUGH IN SILENCE.

HARRY, CEDRIC, I SUGGEST YOU GO UP TO BED, SAID DUMBLEDORE, SMILING AT BOTH OF THEM. I AM SURE GRYFFINDOR AND HUFFLEPUFF ARE WAITING TO CELEBRATE WITH YOU, AND IT WOULD BE A SHAME TO DEPRIVE THEM OF THIS EXCELLENT EXCUSE TO MAKE A GREAT DEAL OF MESS AND NOISE.

THE HARRY POTTER

HARRY GLANCED AT CEDRIC, WHO NODDED, AND THEY LEFT TOGETHER.



THE GREAT HALL WAS DESERTED NOW; THE CANDLES HAD EXHAUSTED THEMSELVES, GIVING THE JAGGED SMILES OF THE PLUMPTONS AN EERIE, FLICKERING QUALITY.

SEE, SAID CEDRIC, WITH A SLIGHT SMILE. WE'RE PLAYING AGAINST EACH OTHER AGAIN.

I'VE BEEN, SAID HARRY, HE REALLY COULDN'T THINK OF ANYTHING TO SAY. THE INSIDE OF HIS HEAD SEEMED TO BE IN COMPLETE DISARRAY, AS THOUGH HIS BRAIN HAD BEEN RANSACKED.

SEE ... TELL ME ... SAID CEDRIC, AS THEY REACHED THE ENTRANCE TO THE HALL, WHICH WAS NOW LIT ONLY BY TORCHES IN THE ABSENCE OF THE GLEAM OF FIRE. HOW DID YOU GET YOUR NAME IN?

I DIDN'T, SAID HARRY, STARING UP AT HIM. I DIDN'T PUT IT IN. I WAS TELLING THE TRUTH.

AND ... EDD, SAID CEDRIC. HARRY COULD TELL CEDRIC DIDN'T BELIEVE HIM. WELL ... SEE YOU, THEN.

INSTEAD OF GOING UP THE MARBLE STAIRCASE, CEDRIC HEADED FOR A DOOR AT ITS RIGHT. HARRY STOOD LISTENING TO HIM GOING DOWN THE STONE STEPS BEYOND IT, THEN, SILENTLY, STARTED THE CLIMB THE MARBLE STAIRS.

WAS ANYONE EXCEPT RON AND HERMION GOING TO BELIEVE HIM, OR WOULD THEY ALL THINK HE'D PUT HIMSELF IN FOR THE TRIUMPHANT?

YET HE COULD ANYONE THINK THAT, WHEN HE WAS FACING COMPETITORS WHO'D HAD THREE YEARS MORE MAGICAL EDUCATION THAN HE HAD

WHEN HE WAS NOW FACING TASKS WHICH WERE NOT ONLY SEEMED VERY

DANGEROUS, BUT WHICH WERE THEY PERFORMED IN FRONT OF HUNDREDS OF PEOPLE? YES, HE DREAMT ABOUT IT ... HE D FANTASIZED

ABOUT IT ... BUT IT HAD BEEN A DREAM, REALLY, AN IDLE SORT OF DREAM ... HE D NEVER REALLY, SERIOUSLY CONSIDERED ENTERING ...

BUT SOMEONE ELSE HAD CONSIDERED IT ... SOMEONE ELSE HAD WANTED HIM IN THE TOURNAMENT, AND HAD MADE SURE HE WAS ENTERED. WHY? TO GIVE HIM A TREAT? HE DIDN'T THINK SHE, SHE ...

TO SEE HIM MAKE A NAME OF HIMSELF? WELL, THEY WERE LIKELY TO GET THEIR WISH ...

## THE FLEET CHAMPIONS 247

BUT TO GET HIM KILLED? WAS THAT JUST BEING HIS USUAL PARANOID SELF? COULDN'T SOMEONE HAVE PUT HARRY'S NAME IN THE

CHALICE AS A TRICK, A PRACTICAL JOKE? DID ANYONE REALLY WANT HIM DEAD?

HARRY WAS ASKING THE ANSWER THAT AT ONCE. YES, SOMEONE WANTED HIM DEAD, SOMEONE HAD WANTED HIM DEAD EVER SINCE HE HAD BEEN A YEAR OLD ... LORD VOLDEMORT, BUT HOW COULD VOLDEMORT HAVE ENSURED THAT HARRY'S NAME GET INTO THE CHALICE OF FIRE?

VOLDEMORT WAS SLIPPED THE KEY FAR AWAY, IN SOME DISTANT COUNTRY, IN HIDING, ALONE ... FEELER AND FEELERLESS ...

YET IN THAT DREAM HE HAD HAD, ILIST BEHIND HE HAD AWOKEN  
WITH HIS SCAR FLUTING, VILDERMINT HAD NOT BEEN ALONE ... HE HAD  
BEEN TALKING THE WHIPTAIL ... PLETTING HARRY S MURDER ...  
HARRY GOT A SHOCK THE FIND HIMSELF FACING THE FAT LADY  
ALREADY, HE HAD BARELY NOTICED WHERE HIS FEET WERE CARRYING  
HIM, IT WAS ALSO A SURPRISE THE SEE THAT SHE WAS NOT ALONE IN HER  
FRAME, THE WIZZENED WITCH WHO HAD PLITTED INTO HER NEIGHBOR S  
PAINTING WHEN HE HAD THINED THE CHAMPIONS DOWNSTAIRS WAS  
NOW SITTING SILENTLY BESIDE THE FAT LADY, SHE MUST HAVE DASHED  
THROUGH EVERY PICTURE LINING SEVEN STAIRCASES THE REACH HERE  
BEHIND HIM, BOTH SHE AND THE FAT LADY WERE LEERING DOWN AT  
HIM WITH THE DEEPEST INTEREST.

WELL, WELL, WELL, SAID THE FAT LADY, VILLET S ILIST TELL ME  
EVERYTHING, WHO S ILIST BEEN CHOSEN AS SCHEER CHAMPION, THEN?  
BALDERDASH, SAID HARRY BLISS.

IT MUST CERTAINLY BE T? SAID THE PALE WITCH INDIGNANTLY.

NEH, NEH, VI, IT S THE PASSWORD, SAID THE FAT LADY SHEETHEINLY,  
AND SHE SWUNG HERWARDS IN HER HINGES THE LET HARRY INTO THE  
CHAMPION ROOM.

THE LAST HE REMISE THAT MET HARRY S EARS WHEN THE PORTRAIT  
OPENED ALMOST KNOCKED HIM BACKWARDS, NEXT THING HE KNEW,  
HE WAS BEING WRENCHED INSIDE THE CHAMPION ROOM BY ABOUT A  
DOZEN PAIRS OF HANDS, AND WAS FACING THE WHEEL OF CRYSTAL  
HILL, ALL OF THEM WERE SCREAMING, APPLAUDING AND WHISTLING.

WELL SHOULD YE TELL US WELL D ENTERED? KELLERED FRED; HE

AND HARRY PLETTED

LOOKED HALF ANNOYED, HALF DEEPLY IMPRESSED.

HOW DID YOU DO IT WITHOUT GETTING A BEARD? BRILLIANT! REARED  
GEORGE.

I DIDN'T, HARRY SAID. I DIDN'T KNOW HOW

BUT ANGELINA HAD BEEN SWEEPED DOWN UPON HIM. EH, IF IT  
COULDN'T BE ME, AT LEAST IT'S A GRYFFINDOR

YOU'LL BE ABLE TO PAY BACK DIGGERY FOR THAT LAST FLUIDITCH  
MATCH, HARRY? SHRIEKED KATIE BELL, ANOTHER OF THE GRYFFINDOR  
CHASERS.

WE'VE GOT THEM, HARRY, COME AND HAVE SOME

I'M NOT HUNGRY, I HAD ENOUGH AT THE FEAST

BUT NERVOUS WANTED TO HEAR THAT HE WASN'T HUNGRY; NERVOUS  
WANTED TO HEAR THAT HE HADN'T PUT HIS NAME IN THE CHOKLET; NOT  
ONE SINGLE PERSON SEEMED TO HAVE NOTICED THAT HE WASN'T AT ALL  
IN THE MIND TO CELEBRATE ... LEE JORDAN HAD UNCOVERED A  
GRYFFINDOR BANNER FROM SOMEWHERE, AND HE INSISTED ON  
DRAPING IT AROUND HARRY LIKE A CLOAK. HARRY COULDN'T GET AWAY;  
WHenever HE TRIED TO SILENCE EVER THE THE STAIRCASE UP THE THE  
DORMITORIES, THE CREW AROUND HIM CLOSED ROUNDS, FIRING  
ANOTHER SLITTERBEEB ON HIM, STUFFING CRISPS AND PEANUTS INTO HIS  
HANDS ... EVERYONE WANTED TO KNOW HOW HE HAD DONE IT, HOW  
HE HAD TRICKED DUMBLEDORE'S AGE LINE, AND MANAGED TO GET HIS  
NAME INTO THE CHOKLET ...

I DIDN'T, HE SAID, EVER AND EVER AGAIN. I DIDN'T KNOW HOW IT  
HAPPENED.

BUT FOR ALL THE NOTICE ANYONE THEN, HE MIGHT JUST AS WELL NOT  
HAVE ANSWERED AT ALL.

I M TIRED! HE BELLEIVED FINALLY, AFTER NEARLY HALF AN HOUR. NEH,  
SERIOUSLY, GEHREX I M CHINE THE BED

HE WANTED MORE THAN ANYTHING THE FIND REIN AND HERMINE,  
THE FIND A KIT OF SANITY, BUT NEITHER OF THEM SEEMED THE BE IN THE  
CHAMBER REIN, INSISTING THAT HE NEEDED THE SLEEP, AND ALMOST

FLATTENING THE LITTLE CREEPY BROTHERS AS THEY ATTEMPTED THE WAY-  
LAY HIM AT THE FEET OF THE STAIRS, HARRY MANAGED THE SHOCK EVERY-  
ONE OFF, AND CLIMBED UP THE THE DORMITORY AS FAST AS HE COULD,

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THE HIS GREAT RELIEF, HE FEELING REIN WAS LYING IN HIS BED IN THE  
OTHERWISE EMPTY DORMITORY, STILL FULLY DRESSED, HE WHISKED UP  
WHEN HARRY SLAMMED THE DOOR BEHIND HIM.

WHERE VE YOU BEEN? HARRY SAID.

HEH, HELLO, SAID REIN.

HE WAS GRINNING, BUT IT LOOKED A VERY EDD, STRAINED SORT OF  
GRIN. HARRY SLIDDERLY BECAME AWARE THAT HE WAS STILL WEARING  
THE SCARLET GRYFFINDOR BANNER THAT LEE HAD TIED AROUND HIM. HE  
HASTENED THE TAKE IT OFF, BUT IT WAS BOKETTED VERY TIGHTLY. REIN LAY  
IN THE BED WITHOUT MOVING, WATCHING HARRY STRUGGLE THE REMOVE  
IT.

SEE, HE SAID, WHEN HARRY HAD FINALLY REMOVED THE BANNER  
AND THROWN IT INTO A CORNER. CONGRATULATIONS.

WHAT D YOU MEAN, CONGRATULATIONS? SAID HARRY, STARING AT  
REIN. THERE WAS DEFINITELY SOMETHING WRONG WITH THE WAY REIN  
WAS SMILING; IT WAS MORE LIKE A GRIMACE.

WELL ... NEH HNE ELSE GET ACROSS THE AGE LINE, SAID REEN. NOT  
EVEN FRED AND GEORGE. WHAT DID YELL LIKE THE INVISIBILITY  
CLEAN?

THE INVISIBILITY CLEAN WOULDNT HAVE GET ME OVER THAT LINE,  
SAID HARRY SHLELY.

EH, RIGHT, SAID REEN. I THOUGHT YELL MIGHT VE TOLD ME IF IT  
WAS THE CLEAN ... BECAUSE IT WOULD VE COVERED BOTH OF US,  
WOULDNT IT? BUT YELL FOUND ANOTHER WAY, DID YELL?

LISTEN, SAID HARRY, I DIDNT PUT MY NAME IN THAT CHECKET.  
SOMEONE ELSE MUST VE DONE IT.

REEN RAISED HIS EYEBROWS. WHAT WOULD THEY DO THAT FOR?

I DONT, SAID HARRY. HE FELT IT WOULD SOUND VERY MELODRA-  
MATIC TO SAY THE WILL ME.

REEN S EYEBROWS ROSE SO HIGH THAT THEY WERE IN DANGER OF DIS-  
APPEARING INTO HIS HAIR.

IT S OK, YELL KNEL, YELL CAN TELL ME THE TRUTH, HE SAID. IF YELL  
DONT WANT EVERYONE ELSE TO KNEL, FINE, BUT I DONT KNEL WHY  
YELL RE KITCHERING THE LIE, YELL DIDNT GET INTO THE TROUBLE FOR IT, DID  
YELL? THAT FRIEND OF THE FAT LADY S, THAT VICKET, SHE S ALREADY

SEE HARRY BETTER

THEO WAS ALL, DUMBLEDORE S LETTING YELL ENTER, A THOUSAND

GALLEONS PRIZE MONEY, EH? AND YELL DONT HAVE THE DEED-OF-

YEAR TESTS EITHER ...

I DIDN'T PUT MY NAME IN THAT CHECK! SAID HARRY, STARTING TO  
FEEL ANGRY.

YEAH, HED, SAID BEN, IN EXACTLY THE SAME SKEPTICAL TONE AS  
LEBRIL. FINALLY YELL SAID THIS MORNING YELL'D HAVE DONE IT LAST  
NIGHT, AND NEE HNE WOULD VE SEEN YELL ... I'M NOT STUPID, YELL  
KNEW.

YELL RE BEING A REALLY GOOD IMPRESSION OF IT, HARRY SNAPPED.  
YEAH? SAID BEN, AND THERE WAS NEE TRACE OF A GRIN, FORCED HER  
OTHERWISE, HEN HIS FACE NEE. YELL WANT TO GET THE BED, HARRY, I  
EXPECT YELL LL NEED THE KE LIP EARLY TOMORROW FOR A PHEETICAL HER  
SOMETHING.

HE WRENCHED THE HANGINGS SHIT AWAY HIS FLOOR-PHETER,  
LEAVING HARRY STANDING THERE BY THE DEER, STARING AT THE DARK  
RED VELVET CURTAINS, NEE HIDING HNE OF THE FEW PEOPLE HE HAD  
BEEN SURE WOULD BELIEVE HIM.

## CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

### THE WEIGHING OF THE WANDS

WHEN HARRY WAKE UP ON SUNDAY MORNING, IT THREW HIM A  
MOMENT TO REMEMBER WHY HE FELT SO MISERABLE AND WEARIED.  
THEN THE MEMORY OF THE PREVIOUS NIGHT REELLED OVER HIM. HE SAT  
UP AND RIPPED BACK THE CURTAINS OF HIS OWN FLOOR-PHETER, INTEND-

ING THE TALK THE REIN, THE FORCE REIN THE BELIEVE HIM ONLY THE FIND

THAT REIN S BED WAS EMPTY; HE HAD HEVILUSLY GENE DEHN THE  
BREAKFAST.

HARRY DRESSED AND WENT DEHN THE SPIRAL STAIRCASE INTO THE  
COMMON ROOM. THE MOMENT HE APPEARED, THE PEOPLE WHO HAD  
ALREADY FINISHED BREAKFAST BROKE INTO APPLAUSE AGAIN. THE  
PROSPECT OF GOING DEHN INTO THE GREAT HALL AND FACING THE REST  
OF THE GRYPFINDERS, ALL TREATING HIM LIKE SOME SORT OF HERO, WAS

NOT INVITING; IT WAS THAT, HOWEVER, HE STAY HERE AND ALLOW HIM-  
SELF TO BE CORNERED BY THE CREEPY BROTHERS, WHO WERE BOTH

RECKONING PRATICALLY THE HIM THE IMIN THEM. HE WALKED RESOLUTELY  
EVER THE THE PORTRAIT HOLE, PUSHED IT OPEN, CLIMBED OUT OF IT AND  
FOUND HIMSELF FACE THE FACE WITH HERMIONE.

HELLO, SHE SAID, HOLDING UP A STACK OF THAST, WHICH SHE WAS  
CARRYING IN A NAPKIN. I KNOWIT WELL THIS ... WANT THE GO FOR A  
WALK?

GOOD IDEA, SAID HARRY, GRATEFULLY.

THEY WENT DOWNSTAIRS, CROSSED THE ENTRANCE HALL QUIETLY  
WITHOUT LOOKING IN AT THE GREAT HALL, AND WERE SEEN STRIDING  
ACROSS THE LAWN TOWARDS THE LAKE, WHERE THE DUMSTRANG SHIP  
WAS MOORED, REFLECTED BLACKLY IN THE WATER. IT WAS A CILLY  
MORNING, AND THEY KEPT MOVING, MUNCHING THEIR THAST, AS

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HARRY TOLD HERMIONE EXACTLY WHAT HAD HAPPENED AFTER HE HAD LEFT THE GRYFFINDOR TABLE THE NIGHT BEFORE. THE HIS IMMENSE RELIEF, HERMIONE ACCEPTED HIS STORY WITHOUT OBJECTION.

WELL, HE KNOWS, I KNOW YOU HADN'T ENTERED YOURSELF, SHE SAID, WHEN HE'D FINISHED TELLING HER ABOUT THE SCENE IN THE CHAMBER OF THE FALL. THE LOOK ON YOUR FACE WHEN DUMBLEDORE READ OUT YOUR NAME? BUT THE OBJECTION IS, WHEN DID PUT IT IN? BECAUSE MURDER'S RIGHT, HARRY ... I DIDN'T THINK ANY STUDENT WOULD HAVE DONE IT ... THEY'D NEVER BE ABLE TO PROVE THE GUILTY, HE GET FROM DUMBLEDORE'S

HAVE YOU SEEN THEN? HARRY INTERRUPTED.

HERMIONE HESITATED.

ERM ... YES ... HE WAS AT BREAKFAST, SHE SAID.

DID HE STILL THINK I ENTERED MYSELF?

WELL ... NO, I DIDN'T THINK SHE ... NOT REALLY, SAID HERMIONE ALREADY.

WHAT'S THAT SLIPPED THE MEAN, NOT REALLY?

HE, HARRY, ISN'T IT EVIDENT? HERMIONE SAID DESPAIRINGLY.

HE'S EVIDENT?

EVIDENT? HARRY SAID INCREDULOUSLY. EVIDENT OF WHAT? HE WANTS TO MAKE A PRAT OF HIMSELF IN FRONT OF THE WHOLE SCHOOL, DOES HE?

LOOK, SAID HERMIONE PATIENTLY, IT'S ALWAYS YOU WHO GETS ALL THE ATTENTION, YOU KNOW IT IS, I KNOW IT'S NOT YOUR FAULT, SHE ADDED QUICKLY, SEEING HARRY OPEN HIS MOUTH FLURIOUSLY, I KNOW YOU DIDN'T ASK FOR IT ... BUT WELL YOU KNOW, THEN'S GET ALL THESE KNIGHTS THE CHAMPION AGAINST AT HOME, AND YOU'RE HIS BEST

FRIEND, AND YELL HE REALLY FAMILIAR HE S ALWAYS SHUNTED THE HENZ  
SIDE WHENEVER PEOPLE SEE YELL, AND HE PUTS LIP WITH IT, AND HE  
NEVER MENTIONS IT, BUT I SUPPOSE THIS IS JUST HENZ TIME THEE  
MANY ...

GREAT, SAID HARRY BITTERLY, REALLY GREAT, TELL HIM FROM ME I LL  
SWAP ANY TIME HE WANTS, TELL HIM FROM ME HE S WELCOME THE IT  
... PEOPLE GASPING AT MY HECK-HEAD EVERYWHERE I GO ...

I M NOT TELLING HIM ANYTHING, HERMIONE SAID SHORTLY, TELL

THE WRITING OF THE WANDS ZSS

HIM YOURSELF, IT S THE ONLY WAY TO SHUT THIS HLT,

I M NOT RUNNING AROUND AFTER HIM TRYING TO MAKE HIM GROW  
UP! HARRY SAID, SEE HOWLY THAT SEVERAL HILLS IN A NEARBY TREE  
THEIR FLIGHT IN ALARM, MAYBE HE LL BELIEVE I M NOT ENJOYING  
MYSELF SINCE I VE GOT MY NECK BREDEN HER

THAT S NOT FLINDY, SAID HERMIONE BRIEFLY, THAT S NOT FLINDY AT  
ALL, SHE LOOKED EXTREMELY ANXIOUS, HARRY, I VE BEEN THINKING  
YELL KNOWS WHAT WE VE GOT TO DO, DON T YELL? STRAIGHT AWAY, THE  
MOMENT WE GET BACK TO THE CASTLE?

YEAH, GIVE RON A GOOD KICK LIP THE

WRITE THE STORIES, YELL VE GOT TO TELL HIM WHAT S HAPPENED, HE  
ASKED YELL TO KEEP HIM POSTED ON EVERYTHING THAT S GOING ON AT  
HOGWARTS ... IT S ALMOST LIKE HE EXPECTED SOMETHING LIKE THIS TO  
HAPPEN, I BRIGHTEN SOME PARCHMENT AND A FEW HLT WITH ME

COME OFF IT, SAID HARRY, LOOKING AROUND TO CHECK THAT THEY  
COULDN T BE HEARD; BUT THE GRIFINDORS WERE WHITE DESERTED,  
HE CAME BACK TO THE COUNTRY JUST BECAUSE MY STAR TWINGED,

HE'LL PROBABLY COME BUSTING RIGHT INTO THE CASTLE IF I TELL HIM  
SOMETHING I ENTERED ME FOR THE TRIWIZARD TOURNAMENT

HE'D WANT YOU TO TELL HIM, SAID HERMIONE STERNLY. HE'S GOING  
TO FIND OUT ANYWAY

HOW?

HARRY, THIS ISN'T GOING TO BE KEPT QUIET, SAID HERMIONE, VERY  
SERIOUSLY. THIS TOURNAMENT'S FAMOUS, AND YOU'RE FAMOUS, I'LL BE  
REALLY SURPRISED IF THERE ISN'T ANYTHING IN THE DAILY PROPHET  
ABOUT YOU COMPETING ... YOU'RE ALREADY IN HALF THE SCHOOLS ABOUT  
YOU-KNOW-WHO, YOU-KNOW ... AND SIRIUS WOULD RATHER HEAR IT  
FROM YOU, I KNOW HE WOULD.

END, END, I'LL WRITE TO HIM, SAID HARRY, THROWING HIS LAST  
PIECE OF BREAD INTO THE LAKE. THEY BOTH STOOD AND WATCHED IT  
FLOATING THERE FOR A MOMENT, BEFORE A LARGE TENTACLE RESE  
EMBLISHED THE WATER AND SWAMPED IT BENEATH THE SURFACE. THEN THEY  
RETURNED TO THE CASTLE.

WHERE ARE WE GOING TO LIVE? HARRY SAID, AS THEY CLIMBED  
THE STAIRS. HE TOLD ME ABOUT THE LOST HERONIC AGAIN.

SEE HARRY BETTER

ASK THEM IF YOU CAN KNOW

I'M NOT ASKING THEM ANYTHING, HARRY SAID FLATLY.

WELL, KNOWING ONE OF THE SCHOOL BILLS, THEN, ANYONE CAN LIVE  
THEM, SAID HERMIONE.

THEY WENT UP TO THE TOWER, HERMIONE GAVE HARRY A PIECE OF  
PARCHMENT, A QUILL AND A BOTTLE OF INK, THEN STROLLED AROUND THE  
LONG LINES OF PERCHES, LOOKING AT ALL THE DIFFERENT BILLS, WHILE

HARRY SAT DOWN AGAINST A WALL AND WROTE HIS LETTER.

DEAR SIRIUS,

YELL TOLD ME THE DEEP YELL PESTED HIM WHAT'S HAPPENING AT  
HOGWARTS, SEE HERE COMES I DIDN'T KNOW IF YELL'VE HEARD, BUT THE  
TRILIZARD TOURNAMENT'S HAPPENING THIS YEAR AND ON SATURDAY  
NIGHT I GOT PICKED AS A FORTHY CHAMPION, I DIDN'T KNOW WHEN PUT  
MY NAME IN THE CHURCH OF FIRE, BECAUSE I DIDN'T. THE OTHER  
HOGWARTS CHAMPION IS CEDRIC DIGGORY, FROM HUNTERLEY.

HE PAUSED AT THIS POINT, THINKING, HE HAD AN IDEA TO SAY SOME-  
THING ABOUT THE LARGE WEIGHT OF ANXIETY THAT SEEMED TO HAVE

SETTLED INSIDE HIS CHEST SINCE LAST NIGHT, BUT HE COULDN'T THINK  
HOW TO TRANSLATE THIS INTO WORDS, SO HE SIMPLY DIPPED HIS QUILL  
BACK INTO THE INK BOTTLE AND WROTE:

I HOPE YELL'RE FINE, AND BUCKLE UP HARRY,

FINISHED, HE TOOK FORTHWITH, GETTING TO HIS FEET AND BRUSHING  
STRAW OFF HIS REARS. AT THIS, HERMION CAME PLUTTERING DOWN BENT  
HIS SHOULDER, AND HELD HIM HER LEG.

I CAN'T LIVE YELL, HARRY TOLD HER, LEANING AROUND HER THE  
SCHEMEL HILLS. I'VE GOT THE LISP HERE OF THESE ...

HERMION GAVE A VERY LOUD FIGHT, AND THREW OFF HER SLIDDERLY THAT  
HER TAILORS CUT INTO HIS SHOULDER. SHE KEPT HER BACK TO HARRY ALL  
THE TIME HE WAS TYING HIS LETTER TO THE LEG OF A LARGE BARN HILL.  
WHEN THE BARN HILL HAD FLEW OFF, HARRY REACHED HIM THE STRIKE  
HERMION, BUT SHE CLIPPED HER HEAD FLURRIEDLY AND SHARED UP INTO

THE WRIGGLING OF THE WANDS AND

THE RAFTERS HILT OF REACH,

FIRST BEEN, THEN WELL, SAID HARRY ANGRILY. THIS ISN'T MY FAULT.

\*

IF HARRY HAD THOUGHT THAT MATTERS WOULD IMPROVE SINCE EVERY-  
ONE GOT USED TO THE IDEA OF HIM BEING CHAMPION, THE FOLLOWING

DAY SHOWED HIM HOW MISTAKEN HE WAS. HE COULD NO LONGER  
AVOID THE REST OF THE SCHOOL SINCE HE WAS BACK AT LESSONS AND  
IT WAS CLEAR THAT THE REST OF THE SCHOOL, JUST LIKE THE GRYFFINDERS,  
THOUGHT HARRY HAD ENTERED HIMSELF FOR THE TOURNAMENT. UNLIKE  
THE GRYFFINDERS, HOWEVER, THEY DID NOT SEEM IMPRESSED.

THE SLYTHERLINGS, WHO WERE USUALLY IN EXCELLENT TERMS WITH  
THE GRYFFINDERS, HAD TURNED REMARKABLY COLD TOWARDS THE  
WHEEL LEFT OF THEM. ONE EVIDENTLY LESSON WAS ENOUGH TO  
DEMONSTRATE THIS. IT WAS PLAIN THAT THE SLYTHERLINGS FELT THAT  
HARRY HAD STEALN THEIR CHAMPION'S GLORY; A FEELING EXACERBATED,  
PERHAPS, BY THE FACT THAT SLYTHERLING FEELS VERY RARELY GET ANY  
GLORY, AND THAT CEDRIC WAS ONE OF THE FEW WHO HAD EVER GIVEN  
THEM ANY, HAVING BEATEN GRYFFINDERS SINCE AT HILDBITCH. ERNIE

MALMILLAN AND JUSTIN FINCH-FLETCHLEY, WITH WHOM HARRY NOR-  
MALLY GET ON VERY WELL, DID NOT TALK TO HIM EVEN THOUGH THEY

WERE RE-PRETTING BEHINDING BLUES AT THE SAME TRAY THOUGH THEY

DID LAUGH RATHER UNPLEASANTLY WHEN ONE OF THE SHLINING BLUES  
WRIGGLED FREE FROM HARRY'S GRIP AND SMACKED HIM HARD IN THE  
FACE. BEEN WASN'T TALKING TO HARRY EITHER, HERMIONE SAT BETWEEN  
THEM, MAKING VERY FORCED CONVERSATIONS, BUT THROUGH BOTH  
ANSWERED HER NORMALLY, THEY AVOIDED MAKING EYE CONTACT WITH  
EACH OTHER. HARRY THOUGHT EVEN PROFESSOR SPRUIT SEEMED  
DISTANT WITH HIM. BUT THEN, SHE WAS DEAD OF SURPRISE. HE  
HE WOULD HAVE BEEN LOOKING FORWARD TO SEEING HAGRID UNDER  
NORMAL CIRCUMSTANCES, BUT CARE OF MAGICAL CREATURES MEANT  
SEEING THE SLYTHERINS, THIS THE FIRST TIME HE WOULD COME FACE  
TO FACE WITH THEM SINCE BECOMING CHAMPION.

PREDICTABLY, MALFOY ARRIVED AT HAGRID'S CARRIAGE WITH HIS FAMIL-  
IAR SMILE FIRMLY IN PLACE.

AND, WELL, YES, IT'S THE CHAMPION, HE SAID THE CRACK AND

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GOAL, THE MOMENT HE GOT WITHIN EARSHOT OF HARRY. GOT YOUR  
AUTOGRAPH BOOKS? BETTER GET A SIGNATURE NOW, BECAUSE I DUBBIT  
HE'S GOING TO BE AROUND MUCH LONGER ... HALF THE TRIWIZARD  
CHAMPIONS HAVE DIED ... HOW LONG DO YOU RECKON YOU'RE GOING  
TO LAST, POTTER? TEN MINUTES INTO THE FIRST TASK'S MY BET.  
CRACK AND GOAL CLAPPED SYMPHANTICALLY, BUT MALFOY HAD  
THE STEP THERE, BECAUSE HAGRID EMERGED FROM THE BACK OF HIS  
CARRIAGE, PUSHING A TEETERING TOWER OF CRATES, EACH CONTAINING A  
VERY LARGE BLAST-ENDED SKRUB. THE THE CLASS'S MURDER, HAGRID

PROCEEDED TO EXPLAIN THAT THE REASON THE SKEWTS HAD BEEN  
KILLING EACH OTHER WAS AN EXCESS OF PENT-UP ENERGY, AND THAT  
THE SOLUTION WOULD BE FOR EACH OF THE CLASS TO PICK A LEASH AND A  
SKEWET AND TAKE IT FOR A SHORT WALK. THE ONLY GOOD THING ABOUT  
THIS PLAN WAS THAT IT DISTRACTED MALTHEY COMPLETELY.

TAKE THIS THING FOR A WALK? HE REPEATED IN DISBELT, STARING  
INTO ONE OF THE SKIES. AND WHERE EXACTLY ARE WE SUPPOSED  
TO PICK THE LEASH? AROUND THE STING, THE BLASTING END OF THE  
SLICKERY?

AROUND THE MIDDLE, SAID F-JAGRID, DEMONSTRATING. OR YOU  
MIGHT WANT TO PICK UP YOUR DRAGON-HIDE GLOVES, LIKE AS AN EXTRA  
PRECAUTION, LIKE, F-JAGRID. YOU COME HERE AND HELP ME WITH THIS  
BIG ONE ...

F-JAGRID'S REAL INTENTION, HOWEVER, WAS TO TAKE THE F-JAGRID AWAY  
FROM THE REST OF THE CLASS.

HE WAITED UNTIL EVERYONE ELSE HAD SET OFF WITH THEIR SKEWETS,  
THEN TURNED TO F-JAGRID AND SAID, VERY SERIOUSLY, SEE YOU  
CHAMPION, F-JAGRID, IN THE TOURNAMENT, SCHEDULE CHAMPION.  
ONE OF THE CHAMPIONS, F-JAGRID CORRECTED HIM.

F-JAGRID'S BEETLE-BLACK EYES WINKED VERY ANXIOUSLY UNDER HIS  
WILD EYEBROWS. THE IDEA OF PICKING UP YOU IN FOR IT, F-JAGRID?

YOU BELIEVE I DIDN'T DO IT, THEN? SAID F-JAGRID, CHOKING WITH  
DIFFICULTY THE FLUSH OF GRATITUDE HE FELT AT F-JAGRID'S WORDS.

WHEN I DO, F-JAGRID GRIEVED, YOU SAY IT WASN'T YOU, AND I  
BELIEVE YOU AND EVERYONE BELIEVES YOU, AND ALL.

WISH I KNEW WHO DID DO IT, SAID F-JAGRID BITTERLY.

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THE PAIR OF THEM LEERED HLIT OVER THE LAWN; THE CLASS WAS WIDELY SCATTERED NOW, AND ALL IN GREAT DIFFICULTY. THE SKELETS WERE NOW OVER THREE FEET LONG, AND EXTREMELY PHEWFUL. NO LONGER SKEL-LESS AND CHEERLESS, THEY HAD DEVELOPED A KIND OF THICK, GREYISH SHINY ARMOUR. THEY LEERED LIKE A CROSS BETWEEN

GIANT SCORPIONS AND ELONGATED CRABS BUT STILL WITH HLIT RECHG- NISABLE HEADS AND EYES. THEY HAD BECOME IMMENSELY STRONG,

AND VERY HARD TO CONTROL.

LEER LIKE THEY RE HAVIN FUN, DEN THEY? HAGRID SAID HAPPILY. HARRY ASSUMED HE WAS TALKING ABOUT THE SKELETS, BECAUSE HIS CLASSMATES CERTAINLY WEREN'T; EVERY NOW AND THEN, WITH AN

ALARMING BANG, ONE OF THE SKELETS' EYES WOULD EXPLODE, CAUS- ING IT TO SHOOT FORWARD SEVERAL YARDS, AND MORE THAN ONE

PERSON WAS BEING DRAGGED ALONG BY THEIR STEMMACH, TRYING DES- PERATELY TO GET BACK BY THEIR FEET.

AY, I DEN KNOW, HARRY. HAGRID SIGHED SLIDDERLY, LEER- ING BACK DOWN AT HIM WITH A LEERED EXPRESSION ON HIS FACE.

SCHEEL CHAMPION ... EVERYTHIN SEEMS TO HAPPEN TO YOU, DENEN IT?

HARRY DIDN'T ANSWER. YES, EVERYTHING DID SEEM TO HAPPEN TO HIM ... THAT WAS MORE OR LESS WHAT HERMIONE HAD SAID AS THEY



HAD WALKED AROUND THE LAKE, AND THAT WAS THE REASON, ACCORD-  
ING TO HER, THAT RON WAS NO LONGER TALKING TO HIM.

\*

THE NEXT FEW DAYS WERE SOME OF HARRY'S WORST AT HOGWARTS.

THE CLOSEST HE HAD EVER CAME TO FEELING LIKE THIS HAD BEEN DURING  
THESE MONTHS, IN HIS SECOND YEAR, WHEN A LARGE PART OF THE

SCHOOL HAD SUSPECTED HIM OF ATTACKING HIS FELLOW STUDENTS, BUT  
RON HAD BEEN ON HIS SIDE THEN. HE THOUGHT HE COULD HAVE  
HELPED WITH THE REST OF THE SCHOOL'S BEHAVIOUR IF HE COULD JUST  
HAVE HAD RON BACK AS A FRIEND, BUT HE WASN'T GOING TO TRY AND  
PERSUADE RON TO TALK TO HIM IF RON DIDN'T WANT TO.

NEVERTHELESS, IT WAS LONELY, WITH DISLIKE BEARING IN ON HIM  
FROM ALL SIDES.

HE COULD UNDERSTAND THE HOGWARTS ATTITUDES, EVEN IF HE

WAS HARRY POTTER

DIDN'T LIKE IT; THEY HAD THEIR OWN CHAMPION THE SLIPPER. HE  
EXPECTED NOTHING LESS THAN VICIOUS INSULTS FROM THE SLYTHERINS

HE WAS HIGHLY UNPOPULAR THERE AND ALWAYS HAD BEEN, AS HE  
HAD HELPED GRYFFINDOR BEAT THEM SEVENTEN TIMES AT FLUIDITCH  
AND IN THE INTER-HOUSE CHAMPIONSHIP, BUT HE HAD HELPED THE  
RAVENCLAWS MIGHT HAVE FELT IT IN THEIR HEARTS THE SLIPPER HIM

AS MUCH AS CEDRIC. HE WAS WRING, HOWEVER, MOST RAVENCLAWS  
SEEMED TO THINK THAT HE HAD BEEN DESPERATE TO EARN HIMSELF A  
BIT MORE FAME BY TRICKING THE GHOST INTO ACCEPTING HIS NAME.  
THEN THERE WAS THE FACT THAT CEDRIC WISHED THE PART OF A

CHAMPION SEE MUCH MORE THAN HE DID. EXCEPTIONALLY HAND-  
SOME, WITH HIS STRAIGHT NOSE, DARK HAIR AND GREY EYES, IT WAS

HARD TO SAY WHO WAS RECEIVING MORE ADMIRATION THESE DAYS,  
CEDRIC OR VICTOR KRWLM. HARRY ACTUALLY SAW THE SAME SIXTY-SEVEN  
GIRLS WHO HAD BEEN SEEN TO GET KRWLM'S AUTOGRAPH, BEGGING  
CEDRIC TO SIGN THEIR SCHOOLBAGS ONE LUNCHTIME.

MEANWHILE THERE WAS NO REPLY FROM SIRILIS. EDWIG WAS  
REFUSING TO COME ANYWHERE NEAR HIM, PROFESSOR TRILAWNEY WAS  
PREDICTING HIS DEATH WITH EVEN MORE CERTAINTY THAN LILIAL, AND  
HE DID SEE BADLY AT SLUMMERING CHARMS IN PROFESSOR FLITWICK'S  
CLASS THAT HE WAS GIVEN EXTRA HOMEWORK THE ONLY PERSON TO  
GET ANY, APART FROM NEVILLE.

IT'S REALLY NOT THAT DIFFICULT, HARRY. HERMIONE TRIED TO RE-  
ASSURE HIM, AS THEY LEFT FLITWICK'S CLASS SHE HAD BEEN MAKING

ERRANDS ACROSS THE ROOM THE HER ALL LESSON, AS THOUGH SHE  
WAS SOME SORT OF WEIRD MAGNET FOR BEARD BLISTERS, WASTEPAPER  
BASKETS AND LUNASCHERS. SHE JUST WEREN'T CONCENTRATING  
PROPERLY

WHENEVER WHY THAT WAS? SAID HARRY DABLY, AS CEDRIC DICKEY

WALKED PAST, SURROUNDED BY A LARGE GROUP OF SIMPERING GIRLS, ALL OF WHOM LOOKED AT HARRY AS THOUGH HE WAS A PARTICULARLY LARGE BLAST-ENDED SKREW. STILL NEVER MIND, FOR DELIBERATE POTHOLE THE LOOK FORWARD THE THIS AFTERNOON ...

DELIBERATE POTHOLE WAS ALWAYS A TERRIBLE EXPERIENCE, BUT THESE DAYS IT WAS NOTHING SHORT OF TORTURE. BEING SLIT IN A DINGHY

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FOR AN HOUR AND A HALF WITH SNAPE AND THE SLYTHERINS, ALL OF

WHOM SEEMED DETERMINED TO PUNISH HARRY AS MUCH AS POSSIBLE FOR DURING THE RECENT SCHOOL CHAMPION, WAS ABOUT THE MOST

UNPLEASANT THING HARRY COULD IMAGINE. HE HAD ALREADY STRUGGLED THROUGH ONE FRIDAY'S WORTH, WITH HERMION SITTING NEXT TO

HIM, INTENDING TO IGNORE THEM, IGNORE THEM, IGNORE THEM UNDER HER BREATH, AND HE COULDN'T SEE WHY TODAY SHOULD BE ANY BETTER. WHEN HE AND HERMION ARRIVED OUTSIDE SNAPE'S DINGHY AFTER LUNCH, THEY FOUND THE SLYTHERINS WAITING OUTSIDE, EACH AND EVERY ONE OF THEM WEARING A LARGE BADGE ON THE FRONT OF HIS OR HER ROBES, FOR ONE WILD MOMENT HARRY THOUGHT THEY WERE S.P.E.W. BADGES THEN HE SAW THAT THEY ALL BORE THE SAME MESSAGE, IN LUMINOUS RED LETTERS THAT GLINT BRIGHTLY IN THE DIMLY LIT UNDERGROUND PASSAGE:

SUPPER! CORDIALLY

## THE REAL HOGWARTS CHAMPION

LIKE THEM, PEETTER? SAID MALFOY LEHLIDY, AS HARRY APPROACHED.

AND THIS ISN'T ALL THEY DO LEHIDY?

HE PRESSED HIS BADGE INTO HIS CHEST, AND THE MESSAGE UPON IT

VANISHED, THEN BE REPLACED BY ANOTHER ONE, WHICH GLOWED GREEN!

## PEETTER STANDS

THE SLYTHERINS GIGGLED WITH LAUGHTER. EACH OF THEM PRESSED THEIR BADGES, THEN, UNTIL THE MESSAGE PEETTER STANDS WAS SHINING BRIGHTLY ALL AROUND HARRY. HE FELT THE HEAT RISE IN HIS FACE AND NECK.

HEY, VERY FLINDY, HERMIONE SAID SARCASTICALLY THE PANSY PARKINSON AND HER GANG OF SLYTHERIN GIRLS, WHO WERE LAUGHING HARDER THAN ANYONE, REALLY WITTY.

REIN WAS STANDING AGAINST THE WALL WITH DEAN AND SEAPUS.

HE WASN'T LAUGHING, BUT HE WASN'T STICKING UP FOR HARRY EITHER.

WANT ONE, GRANGER? SAID MALFOY, HOLDING OUT A BADGE THE

## THE HARRY PEETTER

HERMIONE, I'VE GOT LEADS, BUT DON'T TOUCH MY HAND, NOW, I'VE

JUST WASHED IT, YOU SEE, DON'T WANT A MUDBLEND SLIMING IT UP.

SOME OF THE ANGER HARRY HAD BEEN FEELING FOR DAYS AND DAYS

SEEMED THE WORST THROUGHT A DAM IN HIS CHEST. HE HAD REACHED

FOR HIS WAND BEFORE HE'D THOUGHT WHAT HE WAS DOING. PEOPLE ALL

AROUND THEM STRAMBLED OUT OF THE WAY, BACKING DOWN THE

CHIRPIDING.

HARRY? HERMIONE SAID WARNINGLY.

OH HEN, THEN, BETTER, MALFOY SAID QUIETLY, DRAWING BACK HIS  
ELBOW HAND. MURDER'S NOT HERE THE BLOOD AFTER YOU'VE BEEN DEED IT, IF  
YOU'VE GOT THE CLITS

FOR A SPLIT SECOND, THEY LOOKED INTO EACH OTHER'S EYES, THEN,  
AT EXACTLY THE SAME TIME, BOTH ACTED.

FLURRIEDLY: HARRY YELLED.

DEVALUING: SCREAMED MALFOY.

IT'S MY LIGHT SHEET FROM BOTH HANDS, HIT EACH OTHER IN MID-AIR,  
AND REJECTED OFF AT ANGLES HARRY'S HIT GEORGE IN THE FACE, AND  
MALFOY'S HIT HERMIONE. GEORGE BELIEVED AND PUT HIS HANDS TO  
HIS NOSE, WHERE GREAT LILLY BILLS WERE SPRINGING UP HERMIONE,  
WHIMPERING IN PANIC, WAS CLUTCHING HER NECK.

HERMIONE? THEN HAD FLURRIED FORWARD THE SEE WHAT WAS  
WRONG WITH HER.

HARRY TURNED AND SAW THEN DRAGGING HERMIONE'S HAND AWAY  
FROM HER FACE. IT WASN'T A PRETTY SIGHT. HERMIONE'S FRONT TEETH  
ALREADY LARGER THAN AVERAGE WERE NOW GRINDING AT AN ALARMING  
RATE; SHE WAS BEHAVING MORE AND MORE LIKE A BEAVER AS HER TEETH

ELONGATED, PAST HER BOTTLE LIP, TOWARDS HER CHIN PANIC-  
STRICKEN, SHE FELT THEM, AND LET OUT A TERRIFIED CRY.

AND WHAT IS ALL THIS NOISE ABOUT? SAID A SHOT, DEADLY VOICE.

SNAPE HAD ARRIVED.

THE SLYTHERINS CLAMORED THE GIVE THEIR EXPLANATIONS. SNAPE

POINTED A LONG YELLOW FINGER AT MALFOY AND SAID, EXPLAIN.

PETTER ATTACKED ME, SIR

WE ATTACKED EACH OTHER AT THE SAME TIME! HARRY SCHELTED,

AND HE HIT GEMLE LHHX

THE WRITING OF THE WANDS WERE

SNAPE EXAMINED GEMLE, WHOSE FACE NOW RESEMBLED SOME-

THING THAT WOULD HAVE BEEN AT HOME IN A ROOM IN POLISHNELL'S

FLINGI,

HOSPITAL WING, GEMLE, SNAPE SAID CALMLY,

MALFOY GET HERMIONE! THEN SAID, LHHX!

HE FORCED HERMIONE TO SHOW SNAPE HER TEETH SHE WAS

BEING HER BEST TO HIDE THEM WITH HER HANDS, THOUGH THIS WAS

DIFFICULT AS THEY HAD NOW GROWN DOWN PAST HER CHILLAR, PANSY

PARKINSON AND THE OTHER SLYTHERIN GIRLS WERE DEJECTED UP WITH

SILENT GIGGLES, POINTING AT HERMIONE FROM BEHIND SNAPE'S BACK,

SNAPE LOOKED COLDLY AT HERMIONE, THEN SAID, I SEE THE DIFFER-

ENCE,

HERMIONE LET OUT A WHIMPER; HER EYES FILLED WITH TEARS, SHE

TURNED ON HER HEEL AND RAN, RAN ALL THE WAY UP THE CORRIDOR AND

OUT OF SIGHT,

IT WAS LUCKY, PERHAPS, THAT BOTH HARRY AND THEN STARTED

SCHELTING AT SNAPE AT THE SAME TIME; LUCKY THEIR VEHICLES REHEED

SEE MUCH IN THE STONE CHAIRS, AND IN THE CHAOS OF DIN, IT WAS IMPOSSIBLE FOR HIM TO HEAR EXACTLY WHAT THEY WERE CALLING HIM. HE GOT THE GIST, HOWEVER.

LET'S SEE, HE SAID, IN HIS SILENT VOICE. FIFTY POINTS FROM GRYFFINDOR AND A DETENTION EACH FOR PETER AND WEASLEY, WHEN GET INSIDE, AND IT WILL BE A WEEK'S WORTH OF DETENTIONS.

HARRY'S EARS WERE RINGING. THE INJUSTICE OF IT MADE HIM WANT TO CLASH SNAPE INTO A THOUSAND SLIMY PICKLES. HE PASSED SNAPE, WALKED WITH RON TO THE BACK OF THE DUNGEON, AND SLAMMED HIS BAG DOWN ONTO THE TABLE. RON WAS SHAKING WITH ANGER, THEN FOR A MOMENT, IT FELT AS THOUGH EVERYTHING WAS BACK TO NORMAL BETWEEN THEM, BUT THEN RON TURNED, AND SAT DOWN WITH DEAN AND SEamus INSTEAD, LEAVING HARRY ALONE AT HIS TABLE. ON THE OTHER SIDE OF THE DUNGEON, MALFLOY TURNED HIS BACK ON SNAPE, AND PRESSED HIS NOSE, SMIRKING. PETER'S STINKS FLASHED BACK THERE ACROSS THE ROOM.

HARRY SAT THERE STARING AT SNAPE AS THE LESSON BEGAN, PICTURING HORRIFIC THINGS HAPPENING TO HIM ... IF ONLY HE KNEW WHEN

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THE THE CRUCIATUS CURSE ... HE'D HAVE SNAPE FLAT ON HIS BACK LIKE THAT SPIDER, KICKING AND TWITCHING ...

ANTIDOTES? SAID SNAPE, LEERING AROUND AT THEM ALL, HIS COLD

BLACK EYES GLITTERING UNPLEASANTLY. YOU SHOULD ALL HAVE PREPARED YOUR RECIPES WELL. I WANT YOU TO KNOW THEM CAREFULLY, AND

THEN WE WILL BE SELECTING SOMEONE IN BETWEEN THE TESTS ...

SNAPE'S EYES MET HARRY'S, AND HARRY KNEW WHAT WAS COMING.

SNAPE WAS GOING TO PHISH HIM. HARRY IMAGINED PICKING UP HIS CALIBRE, AND SPRINTING TO THE FRONT OF THE CLASS, AND BRINGING IT DOWN ON SNAPE'S GREASY HEAD

AND THEN A KNIFE IN THE DUNGEON DIRT KIRST IN ON HARRY'S THOUGHTS.

IT WAS CELIN CREEVEY; HE EDGED INTO THE ROOM, BEAMING AT HARRY, AND WALKED UP TO SNAPE'S DESK AT THE FRONT OF THE ROOM. YES? SAID SNAPE CLITLY.

PLEASE, SIR, I'M SLIPPED THE TAPE HARRY PUTTER UPSTAIRS. SNAPE STARED DOWN HIS HOOKED NOSE AT CELIN, WHOSE SMILE FADED FROM HIS RAGER FACE.

PUTTER HAS ANOTHER HILL OF PITTENS THE COMPLETE, SAID SNAPE COLDLY. HE WILL COME UPSTAIRS WHEN THIS CLASS IS FINISHED. CELIN WENT PINK.

SIR SIR, MR BAGMAN WANTS HIM, HE SAID NERVELISLY. ALL THE CHAMPIONS HAVE GET THE CH, I THINK THEY WANT THE TAPE PITTEN-GRAPHS ...

HARRY WOULD HAVE GIVEN ANYTHING HE HAD TO HAVE STEPPED CELIN SAYING THESE LAST FEW WORDS. HE GLANCED HALF A GLANCE AT RHN, BUT RHN WAS STARING DETERMINEDLY AT THE CEILING.

VERY WELL, VERY WELL, SNAPE SNAPPED. PUTTER, LEAVE YOUR



THINGS HERE, I WANT YOU BACK HERE LATER THE TEST YOUR ANTI-DEER.

PLEASE, SIR HE S GOT THE TAKE HIS THINGS WITH HIM, SHEARED  
CELIN, ALL THE CHAMPIONS

VERY WELL! SAID SNAPE, PETER TAKE YOUR BAG AND GET OUT OF  
MY SIGHT!

HARRY SLUNG HIS BAG OVER HIS SHOULDER, GOT UP AND HEADED

THE WICKING OF THE WANDS WAS

AFTER THE DEER, AS HE WALKED THROUGH THE SLOTHERIN DESKS,  
PETER STINKS FLASHED AT HIM FROM EVERY DIRECTION.

IT S AMAZING, ISN T IT, HARRY? SAID CELIN, STARTING THE SPEAK THE  
MOMENT HARRY HAD CLOSED THE DINGED DEER BEHIND HIM, ISN T  
IT, THOUGH? YOU BEING CHAMPION?

YES, REALLY AMAZING, SAID HARRY HEAVILY, AS THEY SET OFF  
TOWARDS THE STOPS INTO THE ENTRANCE HALL, WHAT DO THEY WANT  
PETERS AFTER, CELIN?

THE DAILY PROPHET, I THINK!

GREAT, SAID HARRY, DILLY, EXACTLY WHAT I NEED, MORE PUBLIC-  
LITY,

GOOD LUCK! SAID CELIN, WHEN THEY HAD REACHED THE RIGHT  
ROOM, HARRY BOWLED HIM THE DEER, AND ENTERED.

HE WAS IN A FAIRLY SMALL CLASSROOM; MOST OF THE DESKS HAD  
BEEN PUSHED AWAY THE THE BACK OF THE ROOM, LEAVING A LARGE

SPACE IN THE MIDDLE; THREE OF THEM, HOWEVER, HAD BEEN PLACED,  
END THE END, IN FRONT OF THE BLACKBOARD, AND COVERED WITH A LONG

LENGTH OF VELVET, FIVE CHAIRS HAD BEEN SET BEHIND THE VELVET-  
COVERED DESKS, AND ELDER BAGMAN WAS SITTING IN ONE OF THEM,

TALKING TO A LITTLE HARRY HAD NEVER SEEN BEFORE, WHO WAS WEAR-  
ING MAGENTA PANTS.

VICTOR KILM WAS STANDING QUIETLY IN A CORNER AS USUAL, AND  
NOT TALKING TO ANYBODY. CEDRIC AND FLEUR WERE IN CONVERSATION,  
FLEUR LOOKED A GOOD DEAL HAPPIER THAN HARRY HAD SEEN HER BE-  
FORE; SHE KEPT THROWING BACK HER HEAD SHE THAT HER LONG SILVER  
HAIR CATCHED THE LIGHT. A POLICE MAN, HOLDING A LARGE BLACK  
CAMERA WHICH WAS SHOOTING SLIGHTLY, WAS WATCHING FLEUR OUT OF  
THE CORNER OF HIS EYE.

BAGMAN SUDDENLY SPOTTED HARRY, GOT UP QUICKLY AND WHEEL-  
ED FORWARD. Ah, HERE HE IS! CHAMPION NUMBER FLEUR! IN THE

CASE, HARRY, IN THE CASE ... NOTHING TO WORRY ABOUT, IT'S JUST  
THE WAND WEIGHING CEREMONY, THE REST OF THE JUDGES WILL BE  
HERE IN A MOMENT

WAND WEIGHING? HARRY REPEATED NERVOUSLY.

WE HAVE TO CHECK THAT YOUR WANDS ARE FULLY FUNCTIONAL, NOW

THE HARRY PETER

PROBLEMS, YELL BOWEL, AS THEY RE YELWR MEET IMPERTANT THEELS IN THE TADDS AHEAD, SAID RAGMAN, THE EXPERT S LIPSTAIRS NELL WITH DUMPLEHERE, AND THEN THERE S GING TH RE A LITTLE P-INTH SE-HEET. THIS IS RITA SKEETER, HE ADDED, GESTURING TOWARDS THE WITCH IN MAGENTA REELS, SHE S BEING A SMALL PIECE IN THE TEELRNAMENT FOR THE DAILY PROPHEET ...

MAYBE MEET THAT SMALL, BLDEH, SAID RITA SKEETER, HER EYES IN F-JARRY,

HER HAIR WAS SET IN ELABERATE AND CLIRIELISLY RIGID CLIRLS THAT CONTRASTED EDDLY WITH HER HEAVY-LADED FACE, SHE WERE REWELLED SPECTACLES, THE THICK FINGERS CLUTCHING HER CRECHHOLE-SKIN HANDBAG ENDED IN TWE-INC- NAILS, PAINTED CRIMSHEN,

I WENDER IF I CHULD HAVE A LITTLE WERD WITH F-JARRY BEFORE WE START? SHE SAID TH RAGMAN, BLT STILL GAZING FIXEDLY AT F-JARRY,

THE YELINGEST CHAMPITHEN, YELL BOWEL ... TH ADD A KIT HP CHHILRY?

CERTAINLY? CRIED RAGMAN, THAT IS IF F-JARRY HAS NE ERIK-TIHEN?

ER SAID F-JARRY,

LEVELY, SAID RITA SKEETER, AND IN A SECHND, HER SCARLET-TALHEND FINGERS HAD F-JARRY S LIPPER ARM IN A SURPRISINGLY STRENG

GRIP, AND SHE WAS STEERING HIM ELT HP THE REEHM AGAIN, AND HEPENING A NEAREY DEEH,

WE DEEN T WANT THE RE IN THERE WITH ALL THAT NEELSE, SHE SAID,

LET S SEE ... AH, YES, THIS IS NICE AND CHESY,

IT WAS A KREEHM CLIPBOARD, HARRY STARED AT HER,

CHEME ALHNE, DEAR THAT S RIGHT LEVELY, SAID RITA SKEETER  
AGAIN, PERCHING HERSELF PRECARIOUSLY UPON AN UPTURNED KICKET,  
PUSHING HARRY DOWN WITH A CARDBOARD BOX AND CHESTING THE  
DEER, THROWING THEM INTO DARKNESS. LET S SEE NEW ...

SHE UNSNAPPED HER CROCODILE-SKIN HANDBAG AND PULLED OUT A  
HANDFUL OF CANDLES, WHICH SHE LIT WITH A WAVE OF HER WAND AND  
MAGICED INTO MID-AIR, SEE THAT THEY COULD SEE WHAT THEY WERE  
DOING.

WELL WHEN T MIND, HARRY, IF I USE A FLUICK-FLUETES FLUILL? IT  
LEAVES ME FREE TO TALK TO YOU NORMALLY ...

THE WRIGGLING OF THE WANDS ZZZ

A WHAT? SAID HARRY.

RITA SKEETER S SMILE WIDENED, HARRY CHINTED THREE CHILD  
TEETH. SHE REACHED AGAIN INTO HER CROCODILE BAG, AND DREW OUT A  
LONG ACID-GREEN FLUILL AND A ROLL OF PARCHMENT, WHICH SHE

STRETCHED OUT BETWEEN THEM IN A CRATE OF MRS SKEETER S ALL-  
PURPOSE MAGICAL MESS-REMOVER. SHE PLIT THE TIP OF THE GREEN

FLUILL INTO HER MOUTH, SLICKED IT FOR A MOMENT WITH APPARENT  
RELISH, THEN PLACED IT UPRIGHT IN THE PARCHMENT, WHERE IT STEAD  
BALANCED ON ITS POINT, FLUTTERING SLIGHTLY.

TESTING ... MY NAME IS RITA SKEETER, DAILY PROPHET REPORTER.  
HARRY LEMBED DOWN FLICKLY AT THE FLUILL. THE MOMENT RITA

SKEETER HAD SPEKEN, THE GREEN HILL HAD STARTED THE SCREEK,  
SKIDDING ACROSS THE PARCHMENT:

ATTRACTIVE BLONDE RITA SKEETER, FORTY-THREE, WHOSE SAVAGE  
HILL HAS PUNCTURED MANY INFLATED REPUTATIONS

LEVERLY, SAID RITA SKEETER, YET AGAIN, AND SHE RIPPED THE THEP  
PIECE OF PARCHMENT OFF, CRUMPLED IT UP AND STUFFED IT INTO HER  
HANDS. WHEN SHE LEANT TOWARDS HARRY AND SAID, SEE, HARRY ...  
WHAT MADE YOU DECIDE TO ENTER THE TRIWIZARD TOURNAMENT?

HE SAID HARRY AGAIN, BUT HE WAS DISTRACTED BY THE HILL.  
EVEN THOUGH HE WASN'T SPEAKING, IT WAS DASHING ACROSS THE  
PARCHMENT, AND IN ITS WAKE HE COULD MAKE OUT A FRESH  
SENTENCE:

AN UGLY SCAR, REMINDER OF A TRAGIC PAST, DISFIGURES THE OTHER-  
WISE CHARMING FACE OF HARRY POTTER, WHOSE EYES

IGNORE THE HILL, HARRY, SAID RITA SKEETER FIRMLY. RELUCTANTLY,  
HARRY LOOKED UP AT HER INSTEAD. WHEN WHY DID YOU DECIDE TO  
ENTER THE TOURNAMENT, HARRY?

I DIDN'T, SAID HARRY. I DIDN'T KNOW HOW MY NAME GOT INTO  
THE GLOBE OF FIRE. I DIDN'T PUT IT IN THERE.

RITA SKEETER RAISED ONE HEAVILY PENCILLED EYEBROW. (THEY

THE HARRY POTTER

WHEN, HARRY, THERE'S NO NEED TO BE SCARED OF GETTING INTO TROUBLE.  
WE ALL KNOW YOU WOULDN'T REALLY HAVE ENTERED AT ALL. BUT DIDN'T  
WHY ASK THAT. OUR READERS LOVE A REEL.

BUT I DIDN'T ENTER, HARRY REPEATED, I DIDN'T KNOW WHAT  
THEY DID WHEN THEY FEEL ABOUT THE TASKS AHEAD? SAID RITA SKEETER,  
EXCITED? NERVOUS?

I HAVEN'T REALLY THOUGHT ... YES, NERVOUS, I SUPPOSE, SAID  
HARRY, HIS INSIDES SHRIMPED UNCOMFORTABLY AS HE SPoke.

CHAMPIONS HAVE DIED IN THE PAST, HAVEN'T THEY? SAID RITA  
SKEETER BRISKLY, HAVE THEY THOUGHT ABOUT THAT AT ALL?

WELL ... THEY SAY IT'S GOING TO BE A LOT SAFER THIS YEAR, SAID HARRY.  
THE HULL WIZZED ACROSS THE PARLAMENT BETWEEN THEM, BACK  
AND FORWARDS AS THOUGH IT WAS SKATING.

HE CHIRPED, WHEN WE LOOKED DEATH IN THE FACE BEFORE, HAVEN'T  
THEY? SAID RITA SKEETER, WATCHING HIM CLOSELY, WHEN WOULD THEY  
SAY THAT'S APPEARED THEY?

ER, SAID HARRY, YET AGAIN.

DID THEY THINK THAT THE TRAUMA IN THEIR PAST MIGHT HAVE MADE  
THEY BEEN THE PRIZE THEMSELVES? THE LIVE UP THE THEIR NAME? DID THEY  
THINK THAT PERHAPS THEY WERE TEMPTED TO ENTER THE TRIWIZARD  
TOURNAMENT BECAUSE

I DIDN'T ENTER, SAID HARRY, STARTING TO FEEL IRRITATED.

CAN THEY REMEMBER THEIR PARENTS AT ALL? SAID RITA SKEETER,  
TALKING OVER HIM.

NO, SAID HARRY.

THEY DID THEY THINK THEY'D FEEL IF THEY KNEW THEY WERE CHAM-  
PETING IN THE TRIWIZARD TOURNAMENT? PROUD? WHIPPED? ANGRY?

HARRY WAS FEELING REALLY ANNOYED NOW, WHEN HIS EARTH WAS HE

THE DREAM HELL HIS PARENTS WOULD FEEL IF THEY WERE ALIVE? HE  
COULD FEEL RITA SKEETER WATCHING HIM VERY INTENTLY, FREEZING,  
HE AVOIDED HER GAZE AND LOOKED DOWN AT THE WORDS THE HELL  
HAD JUST WRITTEN.

TEARS FILL THESE STARTLINGLY GREEN EYES AS THEIR CONVERSATION  
TURNS TO THE PARENTS HE CAN BARELY REMEMBER.

THE WRITING OF THE WORDS WAS

I HAVE NOT GET TEARS IN MY EYES? SAID HARRY LOUDLY.  
BEFORE RITA SKEETER COULD SAY A WORD, THE COVER OF THE  
BROOM CLIPBOARD WAS PULLED OPEN. HARRY LOOKED AROUND,  
BLINKING IN THE BRIGHT LIGHT. ALBUS DUMBLEDORE STOOD  
THERE, LOOKING DOWN AT BOTH OF THEM SHOCKED INTO THE  
CLIPBOARD.

DUMBLEDORE? CRIED RITA SKEETER, WITH EVERY APPEARANCE OF  
DELIGHT BUT HARRY NOTICED THAT HER HELL AND THE PARCEMENT  
HAD SUDDENLY VANISHED FROM THE BACK OF MAGICAL MESS-REMOVER,  
AND RITA'S CLAWED FINGERS WERE HASTILY SNAPPING SHUT THE  
CLASP OF HER CRACKLE-SKIN BAG. SHE WAS WHY? SHE SAID,  
STANDING UP AND HOLDING OUT ONE OF HER LARGE, MARBLED  
HANDS TO DUMBLEDORE. I HOPE YOU SAW MY PIECE OVER THE  
SLIPPER ABOUT THE INTERNATIONAL CONFEDERATION OF WIZARDS  
CONFERENCE?

ENCHANTINGLY NASTY, SAID DUMBLEDORE, HIS EYES TWINKLING. I  
PARTICULARLY ENJOYED YOUR DESCRIPTION OF ME AS AN EMBLEMATIC  
DINGBAT.

RITA SKEETER DIDN'T LOOK REMOTELY ABASHED. I WAS JUST MAKING

THE POINT THAT SOME OF THEIR IDEAS ARE A LITTLE OLD-FASHIONED,  
DUMBLEDORE, AND THAT MANY WIZARDS IN THE STREET

I WILL BE DELIGHTED TO HEAR THE REASONING BEHIND THE RUDE-  
NESS, RITA, SAID DUMBLEDORE, WITH A CHARITABLE SMILE AND A

SMILE, BUT I'M AFRAID WE WILL HAVE TO DISCUSS THE MATTER LATER.  
THE WEIGHING OF THE WANDS IS ABOUT TO START, AND IT CANNOT  
TAKE PLACE IF ONE OF OUR CHAMPIONS IS HIDDEN IN A CRIMINAL  
CLIQUE.

VERY GLAD TO GET AWAY FROM RITA SKEETER, HARRY HURRIED BACK  
INTO THE ROOM. THE OTHER CHAMPIONS WERE NOW SITTING IN CHAIRS  
NEAR THE DEER, AND HE SAT DOWN QUIETLY NEXT THE CEDRIL, WHISKING  
UP AT THE VELVET-COVERED TABLE, WHERE SOME OF THE FIVE JUDGES  
WERE NOW SITTING. PROFESSOR BARKAROFF, MADAME MAXIME, MR  
CRUELICH AND ELDER KAGMAN. RITA SKEETER SETTLED HERSELF DOWN IN  
A CORNER; HARRY SAW HER SLIP THE PARCEMENT OUT OF HER BAG  
AGAIN, SPREAD IT ON HER DESK, SLICK THE END OF THE BLACK-GLAZES

AND HARRY PETER

WILL, AND PLACE IT BACK THERE ON THE PARCEMENT.

MAY I INTRODUCE MR HELLIVANDER? SAID DUMBLEDORE, TAKING  
HIS PLACE AT THE JUDGES' TABLE, AND TALKING TO THE CHAMPIONS. HE  
WILL BE CHECKING YOUR WANDS TO ENSURE THAT THEY ARE IN GOOD  
CONDITION BEFORE THE TOURNAMENT.

HARRY WHISKED AROUND, AND WITH A FEELING OF SURPRISE SAW AN OLD  
WIZARD WITH LARGE, PALE EYES STANDING QUIETLY BY THE WINDOW.



HARRY HAD MET MR ELLIVANDER REHERE HE WAS THE WAND-MAKER FROM WHOM HARRY HAD BOUGHT HIS OWN WAND SEVEN YEARS AGO IN DIAGON ALLEY.

MADAMEHISSELF DELACOUR, COULD WE HAVE SEEN HERWARD FIRST, PLEASE? SAID MR ELLIVANDER, STEPPING INTO THE EMPTY SPACE IN THE MIDDLE OF THE ROOM.

FLOR DELACOUR SMILED AT MR ELLIVANDER, AND HANDED HIM HER WAND.

FROM ... HE SAID.

HE TWIRLED THE WAND BETWEEN HIS LONG FINGERS LIKE A RATTLE AND IT EMITTED A BURST OF PINK AND GOLD SPARKS. THEN HE HELD IT CLOSE TO HIS EYES AND EXAMINED IT CAREFULLY.

YES, HE SAID QUIETLY, NINE AND A HALF INCHES ... INFLEXIBLE ... RESISTANT ... AND CONTAINING ... DEAR ME ...

AN AIR FROM THE END OF A VEIL, SAID FLOR. HERE OF MY GRANDFATHER'S.

SEE FLOR WAS PART VEIL, TWILIGHT HARRY, MAKING A MENTAL

NOTE THE TELL THEM ... THEN HE REMEMBERED THAT THEM WASN'T SPEAKING TO HIM.

YES, SAID MR ELLIVANDER, YES, I'VE NEVER USED VEIL HAIR MYSELF, OF COURSE. I FIND IT MAKES ME RATHER TEMPERAMENTAL WANDS ... HOWEVER, THE FACT HIS OWN, AND IF THIS SUITS YOU ... MR ELLIVANDER RAN HIS FINGERS ALONG THE WAND, APPARENTLY CHECKING FOR SCRATCHES OR KNOTS; THEN HE MUTTERED,

WITCH-INDICATORS! AND A BURST OF FEELERS BURST FROM THE WAND TIP.

VERY WELL, VERY WELL, IT'S IN FINE WORKING ORDER, SAID MR ELLIVANDER, SCHEEPING UP THE FLEWERS AND HANDING THEM THE FLEWER WITH HER WAND. MR DIGGORY, YELL NEXT.

THE WORKING OF THE WANDS 271

FLEWER GLIDED BACK TO HER SEAT, SMILING AT CEDRIC AS HE PASSED HER.

AND NOW, THIS IS ONE OF MINE, ISN'T IT? SAID MR ELLIVANDER, WITH MUCH MORE ENTHUSIASM, AS CEDRIC HANDED HER HIS WAND. YES, I REMEMBER IT WELL, CONTAINING A SINGLE HAIR FROM THE TAIL

OF A PARTICULARLY FINE MALE LINCHER ... MUST HAVE BEEN SEVENTEEN HANDS; NEARLY GORED ME WITH HIS HORN AFTER I PLUCKED HIS

TAIL. TWELVE AND A QUARTER INCHES ... AND ... PLEASANTLY SPRINGY. IT'S IN FINE CONDITION ... YOU TREAT IT REGULARLY?

POLISHED IT LAST NIGHT, SAID CEDRIC, GRINNING.

HARRY LOOKED DOWN AT HIS OWN WAND, HE COULD SEE FINGER MARKS ALL OVER IT, HE GATHERED A PISTOL OF RICE FROM HIS DRESS AND TRIED TO USE IT CLEAN SLURPETTITHELY. SEVERAL CHILD SPARKS

SHOT OUT OF THE END OF IT, FLEWER DELACHEUX GAVE HIM A VERY PATRERNISING LOOK, AND HE DESISTED.

MR ELLIVANDER SENT A STREAM OF SILVER SPARK RINGS ACROSS THE

ROOM FROM THE TIP OF CEDRIC'S WAND, PREOCCUPIED HIMSELF SATIS-

FIED, AND THEN SAID, MR KRLIM, IF YOU PLEASE,

YIDTER KRLIM GOT UP AND SHELKED, REHLING-SHEHLDERED AND  
BLICK-SHEETED, TOWARDS MR ELLIVANDER, HE THIRST HIS WAND ELT  
AND STEHD SCHWING, WITH HIS HANDS IN THE POCKETS OF HIS BREEKS,

HEMM, SAID MR ELLIVANDER, THIS IS A GREGGHEVITCH CREATION,  
UNLESS I M MUCH MISTAKEN? A FINE WAND-MAKER, THOUGH THE  
STYLING IS NEVER ELITE WHAT I ... HOWEVER ...

HE LISTED THE WAND AND EXAMINED IT MINUTELY, TURNING IT OVER  
AND OVER BEHIND HIS EYES,

YES ... HERRNEAM AND DRACHEN HEARTSTRING? HE SHEET AT KRLIM,  
WHEN NEEDED, RATHER THICKER THAN ONE USUALLY SEES ... ELITE  
RIGID ... TEN AND A QUARTER INCHES ... AYE?

THE HERRNEAM WAND LET OFF A BLAST LIKE A GUN, AND A NUMBER  
OF SMALL, TWITTERING BIRDS FLEW ELT OF THE END, AND THROUGH THE  
OPEN WINDOW INTO THE WATERY SUNLIGHT,

GOOD, SAID MR ELLIVANDER, HANDING KRLIM BACK HIS WAND,

WHICH LEAVES ... MR PETER,

HARRY GOT TO HIS FEET AND WALKED PAST KRLIM TO MR

MR HARRY PETER

ELLIVANDER, HE HANDED OVER HIS WAND,

AAAAH, YES, SAID MR ELLIVANDER, HIS PALE EYES SUDDENLY  
GLEAMING, YES, YES, YES, HOW WELL I REMEMBER,

HARRY COULD REMEMBER, THEN, HE COULD REMEMBER IT AS  
THOUGH IT HAD HAPPENED YESTERDAY ...

FELIX SUMMERS AGE, ON HIS ELEVENTH BIRTHDAY, HE HAD ENTERED

MR ELLIVANDER'S SHEEP WITH HAGRID THE KID A WAND, MR

ELLIVANDER HAD TAKEN HIS MEASUREMENTS AND THEN STARTED HAND-  
ING HIM WANDS THE TRY, HARRY HAD HAYED WHAT FELT LIKE EVERY

WAND IN THE SHEEP, UNTIL AT LAST HE HAD FEELING THE ONE THAT SLITED  
HIM THIS ONE, WHICH WAS MADE OF HELL, ELEVEN INCHES LONG,  
AND CONTAINED A SINGLE FEATHER FROM THE TAIL OF A PHOENIX, MR  
ELLIVANDER HAD BEEN VERY SURPRISED THAT HARRY HAD BEEN SO  
COMPATIBLE WITH THIS WAND, CLIRIELIS, HE HAD SAID, ... CLIRIELIS,  
AND NEXT UNTIL HARRY ASKED WHAT WAS CLIRIELIS HAD MR ELLIVANDER  
EXPLAINED THAT THE PHOENIX FEATHER IN HARRY'S WAND HAD COME  
FROM THE SAME KIND WHICH HAD SUPPLIED THE CORE OF LORD  
VOLDEMORT'S.

HARRY HAD NEVER SHARED THIS PIECE OF INFORMATION WITH  
ANYBODY, HE WAS VERY FOND OF HIS WAND, AND AS FAR AS HE WAS  
CONCERNED ITS RELATION TO VOLDEMORT'S WAND WAS SOMETHING IT  
CHILDREN TOLD RATHER AS HE CHILDREN TOLD BEING RELATED TO ALINT  
PETLINA, HOWEVER, HE REALLY HOPED THAT MR ELLIVANDER WASN'T  
ABLE TO TELL THE OTHER ABOUT IT, HE HAD A STRONG FEELING RITA

SKEETER'S ELIXIR-ELIXES WILL MIGHT JUST EXPLODE WITH EXCITE-  
MENT IF HE DID.

MR ELLIVANDER SPENT MUCH LONGER EXAMINING HARRY'S WAND  
THAN ANYONE ELSE'S, EVENTUALLY, HOWEVER, HE MADE A MOUNTAIN OF  
WINE SHEET OUT OF IT, AND HANDED IT BACK TO HARRY, ANNOUNCING

THAT IT WAS STILL IN PERFECT CONDITION.

THANK YOU ALL, SAID DUMBLEDORE, STANDING UP AT THE JUDGES TABLE. YOU MAY GO BACK TO YOUR SEAT NOW. OR PERHAPS IT WOULD BE BETTER JUST TO GO DOWN TO DINNER, AS THEY ARE ABOUT THE END.

FEELING THAT AT LAST SOMETHING HAD GONE RIGHT TODAY, HARRY

THE WRITING OF THE WANDS ARE

GET UP THE LEAVE, BUT THE MAN WITH THE BLACK CAMERA LIMPED UP AND CLEARED HIS THROAT.

PHOTOS, DUMBLEDORE, PHOTOS? CRIED BAGMAN EXCITEDLY. ALL THE JUDGES AND CHAMPIONS. WHAT DO YOU THINK, RITA?

OR YES, LET'S DO THESE FIRST, SAID RITA SKEETER, WHOSE EYES WERE UPON HARRY AGAIN. AND THEN PERHAPS SOME INDIVIDUAL SHOTS.

THE PHOTOGRAPHS TOOK A LONG TIME. MADAME MAXIME CAST EVERYONE ELSE INTO SHADES WHEREVER SHE STOOD, AND THE PHOTOGRAPHER COULDN'T STAND FAR ENOUGH BACK TO GET HER INTO THE FRAME; EVENTUALLY SHE HAD TO SIT WHILE EVERYONE ELSE STOOD AROUND HER. KARAKOROV KEPT TWIRLING HIS CHEATER AROUND HIS FINGER TO GIVE IT AN EXTRA CURL; OF COURSE, WITH HARRY WOULD HAVE THOUGHT WOULD HAVE BEEN USED TO THIS SORT OF THING, SKINNED, HALF-HIDDEN, AT THE BACK OF THE GROUP. THE PHOTOGRAPHER SEEMED DEEPEST TO GET FLICKER AT THE FRONT, BUT RITA SKEETER KEPT FLIRTING FORWARD AND DRAGGING HARRY INTO GREATER PROMINENCE. THEN SHE INSISTED ON SEPARATE SHOTS OF ALL THE CHAMPIONS. AT LAST, THEY WERE FREE TO GO.

HARRY WENT DOWN THE DINNER, HERMIONE WASN'T THERE HE  
SUSPECTED SHE WAS STILL IN THE HOSPITAL HAVING HER TEETH  
FIXED, HE ATE ALONE AT THE END OF THE TABLE, THEN RETURNED THE  
GRYFFINDOR TOWER, THINKING OF ALL THE EXTRA WORK HE  
SLUMMERING CHARMS THAT HE HAD TO DO, UP IN THE DORMITORY, HE  
CAME ACROSS RON.

WELL WE HAD AN HEAL, SAID RON GRISPEL, THE MOMENT HE  
WALKED IN, HE WAS POINTING AT HARRY'S PILLOW, THE SCHOOL BARN  
HEAL WAS WAITING FOR HIM THERE.

HEH RIGHT, SAID HARRY.

AND WE'VE GOT THE DEATH DETENTIONS THROUGHOUT THE NIGHT, SNAPE'S  
BLINDING, SAID RON.

HE THEN WALKED STRAIGHT UP TO THE ROOM, NOT LOOKING AT  
HARRY, FOR A MOMENT, HARRY CONSIDERED GOING AFTER HIM HE  
WASN'T SURE WHETHER HE WANTED TO TALK TO HIM OR HIT HIM, BOTH  
SEEMED SLIGHTLY APPEALING BUT THE MORE OF SIRIL'S ANSWER WAS THAT

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STRENGTH, HARRY STRODE OVER TO THE BARN HEAL, TOOK THE LETTER OFF ITS  
LEG, AND UNWELLED IT.

HARRY

I CAN'T SAY EVERYTHING I WOULD LIKE TO IN A LETTER, IT'S TOO  
RISKY IN CASE THE HEAL IS INTERCEPTED WE NEED TO TALK, FACE TO  
FACE, CAN YOU ENSURE THAT YOU ARE ALONE BY THE FIRE IN  
GRYFFINDOR TOWER AT ONE O'CLOCK IN THE MORNING ON THE 22ND  
NOVEMBER?

I KNOW BETTER THAN ANYONE THAT YOU CAN LOOK AFTER YOURSELF,

AND WHILE THEY'RE AROUND DUMBLEDORE AND MEEDY I DON'T THINK ANYONE WILL BE ABLE TO FLIRT WITH HER. HOWEVER, SOMEONE SEEMS TO BE HAVING A GOOD TRY. ENTERING HER IN THAT TOURNAMENT WOULD HAVE BEEN VERY RISKY, ESPECIALLY RIGHT UNDER DUMBLEDORE'S NOSE.

BEHIND THE MATCH, HARRY, I STILL WANT TO HEAR ABOUT ANYTHING UNUSUAL. LET ME KNOW ABOUT THE 22ND NOVEMBER AS QUICKLY AS YOU CAN.

SIRILIS

## CHAPTER NINETEEN

### THE HUNGARIAN HORNTAIL

THE PROSPECT OF TALKING FACE TO FACE WITH SIRILIS WAS ALL THAT SUSTAINED HARRY OVER THE NEXT NIGHT, THE ONLY BRIGHT SPOT

IN A HORIZON THAT HAD NEVER LOOKED DARKER. THE SENSE OF FINDING HIMSELF SOMEONE'S CHAMPION HAD WORN OFF SLIGHTLY NOW, AND

THE FEAR OF WHAT WAS FACING HIM WAS STARTING TO SINK IN. THE FIRST TASK WAS DRAWING STEADILY NEARER; HE FELT AS THOUGH IT WAS CREEPING AHEAD OF HIM LIKE SOME TERRIFIC MONSTER, BARRING HIS PATH. HE HAD NEVER SLIPPED NERVES LIKE THESE; THEY WERE WORSE THAN ANYTHING HE HAD FELT BEFORE A QUIDDITCH MATCH, NOT EVEN HIS LAST ONE AGAINST SLYTHERIN, WHICH HAD DECIDED WHO WOULD WIN THE QUIDDITCH CUP. HARRY WAS FINDING IT HARD TO

THINK ABOUT THE FUTURE AT ALL, HE FELT AS IF HIS WHOLE LIFE HAD BEEN LEADING UP TO, AND WOULD FINISH WITH, THE FIRST TASK ...

ADMITTEDLY, HE DIDN'T SEE HOW SIRILIS WAS GOING TO MAKE HIM FEEL ANY BETTER ABOUT HAVING THE PERFORM AN UNDESIRABLE PIECE OF DIFFICULT AND DANGEROUS MAGIC IN FRONT OF HUNDREDS OF PEOPLE, BUT THE MERE SIGHT OF A FRIENDLY FACE WOULD BE SOMETHING AT THE MOMENT. HARRY WROTE BACK TO SIRILIS, SAYING THAT HE WOULD BE BESIDE THE CAMPFIRE AT THE TIME SIRILIS HAD SUGGESTED, AND HE AND HERMIONE SPENT A LONG TIME GOING OVER PLANS FOR PERKING AND STRAGGLERS LEFT OF THE CAMPFIRE IN THE NIGHT IN EQUESTRIA. IF THE WORST CAME TO THE WORST, THEY WERE GOING TO BRING A BAG OF DUNGEBEATS, BUT THEY HOPED THEY WOULDN'T HAVE TO RESORT TO THAT. STILL WOULD SKIN THEM ALIVE.

IN THE MEANTIME, LIFE BECAME EVEN WORSE FOR HARRY WITHIN THE CHIMNEYS OF THE CASTLE, FOR RITA SKEETER HAD PUBLISHED HER

## THE HARRY POTTER

PIECE ABOUT THE TRIWIZARD TOURNAMENT, AND IT HAD TURNED OUT TO BE NOT SO MUCH A REPORT ON THE TOURNAMENT, AS A HIGHLY CELEBRATED LIFE STORY OF HARRY. MUCH OF THE FRONT PAGE HAD BEEN GIVEN OVER TO A PICTURE OF HARRY; THE ARTICLE (CONTINUING ON PAGES TWO, SIX AND SEVEN) HAD BEEN ALL ABOUT HARRY, THE NAMES OF THE BEASTS AND DIRMSTRANG CHAMPIONS (MISPELLED) HAD BEEN SLASHED INTO THE LAST LINE OF THE ARTICLE, AND CEDRIC HADN'T BEEN MENTIONED AT ALL.

THE ARTICLE HAD APPEARED TEN DAYS AGO, AND HARRY STILL GOT A SICK, BURNING FEELING OF SHAME IN HIS STOMACH EVERY TIME HE



THEMIGHT AHELT IT, RITA SKEETER HAD REPORTED HIM SAYING AN  
ALWIL HET HP THINGS THAT HE CHILDEN T REMEMBER EVER SAYING IN  
HIS LIFE, LET ALONE IN THAT ROOM CLIPBOARD.

I SUPPOSE I GET MY STRENGTH FROM MY PARENTS, I KNOW THEY D BE  
VERY PROUD OF ME IF THEY COULD SEE ME NOW ... YES, SOMETIMES  
AT NIGHT I STILL CRY ABOUT THEM, I M NOT ASHAMED TO ADMIT IT ...  
I KNOW NOTHING WILL HURT ME DURING THE TOURNAMENT, BECAUSE  
THEY RE WATCHING EVERY ME ...

BUT RITA SKEETER HAD GONE EVEN FURTHER THAN TRANSFORMING HIS

ER S INTO LONG, SICKLY SENTENCES: SHE HAD INTERVIEWED OTHER PEOP-  
LE ABOUT HIM, TOO.

HARRY HAS AT LAST FOUND LOVE AT HOGWARTS, HIS CLOSE FRIEND, CHIN  
CREEVEY, SAYS THAT HARRY IS RARELY SEEN WITHOUT THE COMPANY OF ONE  
HERMIONE GRANGER, A STUNNINGLY PRETTY MUGGLE-BORN GIRL WHO,  
LIKE HARRY, IS ONE OF THE TOP STUDENTS IN THE SCHOOL.

FROM THE MOMENT THE ARTICLE APPEARED, HARRY HAD THE ENDORE  
PEOPLE SLYTHERINS, MAINLY WHISTLING AT HIM AS HE PASSED  
THEM, AND MAKING SNEERING COMMENTS.

WANT A HANDY, PETER, IN CASE YOU START CRYING IN  
TRANSFIGURATION?

SINCE WHEN HAVE YOU BEEN ONE OF THE TOP STUDENTS IN THE

THE HUNGARIAN HORNTAIL 200

SCHOOL, PETER? HE IS THIS A SCHOOL YOU AND LONGBOTTOM HAVE  
SET UP TOGETHER?

HEY HARRY!

Yeah, that's right, Harry found himself shouting, as he wheeled around in the corridor, having had just about enough. I've just been crying my eyes out over my dead mum, and I'm just off to die a bit more ...

Well it was just well dropped well will.

It was then Harry felt the cheer rising in his face.

Hey right sorry, he muttered, taking the will back.

Er ... good luck for Tuesday, she said. I really hope you'll be well.

Which left Harry feeling extremely stupid.

Hermione had come in for her fair share of unpleasantness, then, but she hadn't yet started yelling at innocent bystanders; in fact, Harry was full of admiration for the way she was handling the situation.

Stunningly pretty? Her? Pansy Parkinson had shrieked, the first time she had come face to face with Hermione after Rita's article had appeared. What was she judging against a chipmunk?

Ignore it, Hermione said in a dignified voice, holding her head in the air and stalking past the sniggering Slytherin girls as though she couldn't hear them. Just ignore it, Harry. But Harry couldn't ignore it. Ron hadn't spoken to him at all since he had told him about Snape's detention. Harry had half hoped they would make things up during the two hours they were forced to pick the rats' brains in Snape's dungeon, but that had been the day Rita's article had appeared, which seemed the

HAVE CONFIRMED REIN'S BELIEF THAT HARRY WAS REALLY ENJOYING ALL THE ATTENTION.

HERMIONE WAS FLIRTLIS WITH THE PAIR OF THEM; SHE WENT FROM ONE TO THE OTHER, TRYING THE FORCE THEM TO TALK TO EACH OTHER, BUT HARRY WAS ADAMANT: HE WOULD TALK TO REIN AGAIN ONLY IF REIN ADMITTED THAT HARRY HADN'T PUT HIS NAME IN THE

THE HARRY POTTER

CHIEF OF FIRE, AND APOLOGISED FOR CALLING HIM A LIAR.

I DIDN'T START THIS, HARRY SAID STUBBORNLY. IT'S HIS PROBLEM. WILL MISS HIM? HERMIONE SAID IMPATIENTLY. AND I KNOW HE MISSES WILL

MISS HIM? SAID HARRY. I DIDN'T MISS HIM ...

BUT THIS WAS A DOWNRIGHT LIE. HARRY LIKED HERMIONE VERY MUCH, BUT SHE JUST WASN'T THE SAME AS REIN. THERE WAS MUCH LESS LAUGHTER, AND A LIT MORE HANGING AROUND IN THE LIBRARY

WHEN HERMIONE WAS WILL'S BEST FRIEND. HARRY STILL HADN'T MASTERED SLIPPERING CHARMS, HE SEEMED TO HAVE DEVELOPED

SOMETHING OF A BLIND SPOT THEM, AND HERMIONE INSISTED THAT LEARNING THE THEORY WOULD HELP. THEY CONSEQUENTLY SPENT A LOT OF TIME POKING OVER BOOKS DURING THEIR LUNCHTIMES.

WITHER DREAM WAS IN THE LIBRARY AN AWFUL LOT, THEN, AND HARRY

WONDERED WHAT HE WAS UP TO. WAS HE STUDYING, OR WAS HE WHEDDING FOR THINGS TO HELP HIM THROUGH THE FIRST TASK? HERMIONE

HYPHEN COMPLAINED ABOUT DRUM BEING THERE NOT THAT HE EVER  
RETHINKED THEM, BUT BECAUSE GRIPS OF GIGGLING GIRLS HYPHEN  
TURNED UP THE SPY HEN HIM FROM BEHIND BEHIND-HELVES, AND  
HERMINE FEELING THE NEED DISTRACTING.

HE'S NOT EVEN GOOD-LOOKING! SHE MUTTERED ANGRILY, GLARING AT  
DRUM'S SHARP PROFILE. THEY ONLY LIKE HIM BECAUSE HE'S FAMOUS!  
THEY WOULDN'T LOOK TWICE AT HIM IF HE COULDN'T DO THAT WHISPER  
FAINT THING

WHENEVER HE SAID HARRY, THERESA GRITTED TEETH. ALTHOUGH  
APART FROM LIKING THE GET BLOODTHIRSTY TERMS CORRECT, IT CAUSED HIM  
ANOTHER PANG TO IMAGINE HER'S EXPRESSION IF HE COULD HAVE  
HEARD HERMINE TALKING ABOUT WHISPER FAINTS.

\*

IT IS A STRANGE THING, BUT WHEN YOU ARE DREADING SOMETHING,  
AND WOULD GIVE ANYTHING TO SPEED UP TIME, IT HAS A  
DISHELICIOUS HABIT OF SPEEDING UP. THE DAYS UNTIL THE FIRST TASK  
SEEMED TO SLIP BY AS THERESA SOMEONE HAD FIXED THE CLOCKS

THE WHOLE AT DOUBLE SPEED. HARRY'S FEELING OF BARELY CONTAINED  
TREMBLED PANIC WAS WITH HIM WHEREVER HE WENT, AS EVER PRESENT

THE HUNGARIAN HERITAGE 207

AS THE SNIDE COMMENTS ABOUT THE DAILY PROPHECY ARTICLE.

ON THE SATURDAY BEFORE THE FIRST TASK, ALL STUDENTS IN THE

THIRD YEAR AND ABOVE WERE PERMITTED TO VISIT THE VILLAGE OF  
FEEGSMERE. HERMINE TOLD HARRY THAT IT WOULD BE HIM WHO  
THEY GET AWAY FROM THE CASTLE FOR A BIT, AND HARRY DIDN'T NEED  
MUCH PERSUASION.

WHAT ABOUT BEN, THEN? HE SAID, DIDN'T YOU WANT TO GO  
WITH HIM?

EH ... WELL ... HERMINE WENT SLIGHTLY PINK. I THOUGHT WE  
MIGHT MEET UP WITH HIM IN THE THREE BROOMSTICKS ...

NO, SAID HARRY FLATLY.

EH, HARRY, THIS IS SO STUPID

I'M HERE, BUT I'M NOT MEETING BEN, AND I'M WEARING MY  
INVISIBILITY CLOAK.

EH, ALL RIGHT, THEN ... HERMINE SNAPPED, BUT I HATE TALKING  
TO YOU IN THAT CLOAK, I NEVER KNOW IF I'M LOOKING AT YOU OR NOT.  
SO HARRY PUT ON HIS INVISIBILITY CLOAK IN THE DORMITORY, WENT  
BACK DOWNSTAIRS, AND TOGETHER HE AND HERMINE SET OFF FOR  
FEEGSMERE.

HARRY FELT WONDERFULLY FREE UNDER THE CLOAK; HE WATCHED  
OTHER STUDENTS WALKING PAST THEM AS THEY ENTERED THE VILLAGE,  
MOST OF THEM SPORTING SLIPPERY DORIC DISCREET BADGES, BUT  
THE HORRIBLE REMARKS CAME HIS WAY FOR A CHANGE, AND NEHEM  
WAS ENJOYING THAT STUPID ARTICLE.

PEOPLE KEEP LOOKING AT ME NOW, SAID HERMINE GRIMPLY,  
AS THEY CAME OUT OF FEEGSMERE'S SWEETSHOP LATER, EATING  
LARGE CREAM-FILLED CHOCOLATES. THEY THINK I'M TALKING TO  
MYSELF.

DIDN'T THEY SEE YOUR LIPS SO MUCH, THEN.

COME ON, PLEASE JUST TAKE MY WHEEL CHAIR FOR A KIT. SHE WAS  
CHECKING THE KEYS HER WHEEL HERE.

HEY, YEAH? SAID HARRY. LEAVE BEHIND WHEEL.

RITA SKEETER AND HER PHOTOGRAPHY FRIEND HAD JUST EMERGED  
FROM THE THREE BROOMSTICKS PUB. TALKING IN LOW VOICES, THEY  
PASSED RIGHT BY HERMIONIE WHO WASN'T LOOKING AT HER. HARRY

WAS HARRY PENTTER

BANGED INTO THE WALL OF HENRYPOD'S THE SHOP RITA SKEETER  
HITTING HIM WITH HER CRECHIDLE-SKIN HANDS.

WHEN THEY WERE GONE, HARRY SAID, SHE'S STAYING IN THE VILLAGE.  
I BET SHE'S CHECKING THE WATCH THE FIRST TASK.

AS HE SAID IT, HIS STOMACH FLEWED WITH A WAVE OF MILD

PANIC. HE DIDN'T MENTION THIS; HE AND HERMIONIE HADN'T DIS-  
CUSSED WHAT WAS CHECKING IN THE FIRST TASK MUCH; HE HAD THE

FEELING SHE DIDN'T WANT THE THING ABOUT IT.

SHE'S GONE, SAID HERMIONIE, LOOKING RIGHT THROUGH HARRY  
TOWARDS THE END OF THE HIGH STREET. WHY DIDN'T WE GO AND HAVE  
A BUTTERFLY IN THE THREE BROOMSTICKS. IT'S A KIT CHILD, ISN'T IT?  
WELL DIDN'T HAVE THE TALK THE OTHER? SHE ADDED IRRITABLY, CORRECTLY  
INTERPRETING HIS SILENCE.

THE THREE BROOMSTICKS WAS PACKED, MAINLY WITH HOGWARTS  
STUDENTS ENJOYING THEIR FREE AFTERNOON, BUT ALSO WITH A VARIETY

OF MAGICAL PEOPLE HARRY RARELY SAW ANYWHERE ELSE. HARRY SLIP-

PHASED THAT AS FINGERSPEAD WAS THE ONLY ALL-LIZARD VILLAGE IN

BRITAIN, IT WAS A BIT OF A HAVEN FOR CREATURES LIKE HACS, WHO WERE  
NEET AS ADAPT AS WIZARDS AT DISGUIISING THEMSELVES.

IT WAS VERY HARD TO MOVE THROUGH CROWDS IN THE INVISIBILITY

CHAM, IN CASE YOU ACCIDENTALLY TRIED TO SOMETHING, WHICH TEND-  
ED TO LEAD TO ALARMING CONSEQUENCES, HARRY EDGED SILENTLY TOWARDS A

SPARE TABLE IN THE CORNER WHILE HERMIONE WENT TO BUY DRINKS.

ON HIS WAY THROUGH THE FLEET, HARRY SPOTTED RON, WHO WAS SIT-  
TING WITH FRED, GEORGE AND LEE JORDAN, RESISTING THE URGE TO

GIVE RON A GOOD HARD PUNCH IN THE BACK OF THE HEAD, HE FINALLY  
REACHED THE TABLE AND SAT DOWN AT IT.

HERMIONE JOINED HIM A MOMENT LATER AND SLIPPED HIM A  
BUTTERBEER UNDER HIS CHAM.

I WERE SUCH AN IDIOT, SITTING HERE ON MY OWN, SHE MUTTERED,  
BUT I KNOW I KNOW SOMETHING TOO.

AND SHE PULLED OUT A NOTEBOOK IN WHICH SHE HAD BEEN KEEP-  
ING A RECORD OF S.P.E.W. MEMBERS. HARRY SAW HIS AND RON'S

NAMES AT THE TOP OF THE VERY SHORT LIST. IT SEEMED A VERY LONG  
TIME AGO THAT THEY HAD SAT MAKING UP THESE PREDICTIONS TOGETHER.

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AND HERMINE HAD TURNED UP AND APPOINTED THEM SECRETARY AND TREASURER.

WELL DONE, MAYBE I SHOULD TRY AND GET SOME OF THE VILLAGERS INVOLVED IN S.P.R.L., HERMINE SAID TRULY, LOOKING AROUND THE PLK.

YES, RIGHT, SAID HARRY, HE THREW A GLANCE AT SLUTTERER UNDER HIS CHAIR. HERMINE, WHEN ARE YOU GOING TO GIVE UP ON THIS S.P.R.L. STUFF?

WHEN FEELER-EYES HAVE DECENT WAGES AND WORKING CONDITIONS? SHE HISSED BACK. WELL DONE, I'M STARTING TO THINK IT'S

TIME FOR MORE DIRECT ACTION. I WONDER HOW YOU GET INTO THE SCHOOL KITCHENS?

NO IDEA, ASK FRED AND GEORGE, SAID HARRY.

HERMINE Lapsed INTO TRULY SILENCE, WHILE HARRY DRANK HIS SLUTTERER, WATCHING THE PEOPLE IN THE PLK. ALL OF THEM LOOKED CHEERFUL AND RELAXED. ERNIE MACMILLAN AND JANNA ARBETT WERE SHAPING CHOCOLATE FREE CARDS AT A NEARBY TABLE, BOTH OF THEM SPORTING SLIPPERY COOK DICKENS BADGES ON THEIR CHAIRS. RIGHT OVER BY THE DOOR HE SAW LEE AND A LARGE GROUP OF HER RAVENCLAW FRIENDS. SHE WASN'T WEARING A COOK BADGE, TRULY ... THIS CHEERED HARRY UP VERY SLIGHTLY ... WHAT WOULDN'T HE HAVE GIVEN THE BE HERE OF THESE PEOPLE, SITTING AROUND LAUGHING AND TALKING, WITH NOTHING TO WORRY ABOUT BUT THEMSELVES? HE IMAGINED HOW IT WOULD HAVE FELT THE BE HERE IF HIS



NONE HADN'T COME BLIT OF THE CHERLET OF FIRE, HE WOULDN'T BE

WEARING THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK, FOR ONE THING, BEEN WOULD BE SIT-  
TING WITH HIM. THE THREE OF THEM WOULD PROBABLY BE HAPPILY

IMAGINING WHAT DEADLY DANGEROUS TASK THE SEVEN CHAMPIONS

WOULD BE FACING HIM TUESDAY, HE D HAVE BEEN REALLY WONDING FOR-  
WARD THE IT, WATCHING THEM DIE WHATEVER IT WAS ... CHERING HIM

CEBRIC WITH EVERYONE ELSE, SAFE IN A SEAT AT THE BACK OF THE STANDS ...

HE WONDERED HOW THE OTHER CHAMPIONS WERE FEELING. EVERY

TIME HE HAD SEEN CEBRIC LATELY, HE HAD BEEN SURROUNDED BY

ADMIRERS, AND WONDING NERVOUSLY BUT EXCITED, HARRY GLIMPSED

FLOR DELACHUR FROM TIME TO TIME IN THE CORRIDORS; SHE WOULD

THE HARRY PETER

EXACTLY AS SHE ALWAYS DID, HALIGHTY AND UNRIPPLED, AND DRUM

JUST SAT IN THE LIBRARY, PIERING EVER EYES.

HARRY THE LIGHT OF STIRILS, AND THE TIGHT, TENSE KNIGHT IN HIS

CHEST SEEMED THE CASE SLIGHTLY, HE WOULD BE SPREADING THE HIM IN

JUST EVER TWELVE HOURS, FOR TONIGHT WAS THE NIGHT THEY WERE

MEETING AT THE CHAMPION-REEM FIRE ASSUMING NOTHING WENT

WRONG, AS EVERYTHING ELSE HAD BEEN LATELY ...

WELL, IT'S HARRY'S SAID HERMION.

THE BACK OF HARRY'S ENORMOUS SHAGGY HEAD HE HAD MERCI-

FLYING ABOARD HIS KLINCHES EMERGED OVER THE CROWN. HARRY

WONDERED WHY HE HADN'T SPOTTED HIM AT ONCE, AS LACRID WAS SO LARGE, BUT STANDING UP CAREFULLY, HE SAW THAT LACRID HAD BEEN LEANING BACK, TALKING TO PROFESSOR MURPHY. LACRID HAD HIS USUAL ENTHUSIASM TARDAR IN FRONT OF HIM, BUT MURPHY WAS DRINKING FROM HIS HIP-FLASK. MADAM PUMPERTON, THE PRETTY LANDLADY, DIDN'T SEEM TO THINK MUCH OF THIS; SHE WAS LOOKING AHEAD AT MURPHY AS SHE COLLECTED GLASSES FROM TABLES AROUND THEM. PERHAPS SHE THOUGHT IT WAS AN INSULT TO HER MILD MEAD, BUT HARRY KNEW BETTER. MURPHY HAD TOLD THEM ALL DURING THEIR LAST DEFENCE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS LESSON THAT HE PREFERRED TO PREPARE HIS BELLY FULL AND DRINK AT ALL TIMES, AS IT WAS SO EASY FOR DARK WIZARDS TO PEEL AN UNATTENDED CLIP.

AS HARRY WATCHED, HE SAW LACRID AND MURPHY GET UP TO LEAVE. HE WAIVED, THEN REMEMBERED THAT LACRID COULDN'T SEE HIM. MURPHY, HOWEVER, PAUSED, HIS MAGICAL EYE ON THE CORNER WHERE HARRY WAS STANDING. HE TAPPED LACRID IN THE SMALL OF

THE BACK (BEING UNABLE TO REACH HIS SHOULDER), MUTTERED SOMETHING TO HIM, AND THEN THE PAIR OF THEM MADE THEIR WAY BACK

ACROSS THE FLOOR TOWARDS HARRY AND HERMION'S TABLE.

ALL RIGHT, HERMION? SAID LACRID LOUDLY.

HELLA, SAID HERMION, SMILING BACK.

MURPHY LIMPED AROUND THE TABLE AND KENT BELLIN; HARRY

THOUGHT HE WAS READING THE S.P.L.N. NEITHER, UNTIL HE MUTTERED, NICE CHAIR, BETTER.

HARRY STARED AT HIM IN AMAZEMENT. THE LARGE CHAIR MISSING

THE HUNGARIAN FRONTAIL WAS

FROM MERRY'S NESE WAS PARTICULARLY HEVILIS AT A FEW INCHES DISTANCE. MERRY GRINNED.

CAN YOUR EYE I MEAN, CAN YOU ?

YES, IT CAN SEE THROUGH INVISIBILITY CHAIRS. MERRY SAID QUIETLY. AND IT'S COME IN USEFUL AT TIMES. I CAN TELL YOU.

HAGRID WAS BEAMING DOWN AT HARRY. THEN, HARRY KNEW HAGRID COULDN'T SEE HIM, BUT MERRY HAD HEVILISLY TOLD HAGRID HE WAS THERE.

HAGRID NOW KENT DOWN HIM THE PRETEXT OF READING THE S.P.L.N. NEITHER AS WELL, AND SAID IN A WHISPER SHE KNEW THAT ONLY HARRY COULD HEAR IT. HARRY, MEET ME TONIGHT AT MIDNIGHT AT MY CABIN. WEAR THAT CHAIR.

STRAIGHTENING UP, HAGRID SAID HEEDLY, NICE TRY SEE YOU.

HERMIONE, WINKED, AND DEPARTED. MERRY FOLLOWED HIM.

WHY DOES HE WANT ME TO MEET HIM AT MIDNIGHT? HARRY SAID, VERY SURPRISED.

DOES HE? SAID HERMIONE, LOOKING STARTLED. I WONDER WHAT HE'S UP TO? I DON'T KNOW WHETHER YOU SHOULD GO. HARRY ... SHE NERVOUSLY AHEAD, AND HISSED. IT MIGHT MAKE YOU LATE FOR STUDIES.

IT WAS TRUE THAT GOING DOWN TO HAGRID'S AT MIDNIGHT WOULD

MEAN CUTTING HIS MEETING WITH SIRILIS VERY FINE INDEED;  
HERMIONE SUGGESTED SENDING HEDWIG DOWN THE FLAGRID & TELL  
HIM HE COULDN'T BE ALWAYS ASSUMING SHE WOULD CONSENT TO  
TAKE THE NIGHT, OF COURSE. HARRY, HOWEVER, THOUGHT IT BETTER JUST  
TO BE HELD AT WHATEVER FLAGRID WANTED HIM FOR. HE WAS VERY  
CLEARLY THE ONE WHO WASN'T WHAT THIS MIGHT BE; FLAGRID HAD NEVER ASKED  
HARRY TO VISIT HIM SHE LATE AT NIGHT.

\*

AT HALF PAST ELEVEN THAT EVENING, HARRY, WHO HAD PRETENDED TO  
GO UP THE RED EARLY, PULLED THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK BACK OVER HIM-  
SELF AND CROPT BACK DOWNSTAIRS THROUGH THE COMMON ROOM.

ALTHOUGH A FEW PEOPLE WERE STILL IN THERE, THE CREEPY BROTHERS  
HAD MANAGED TO GET HOLD OF A STACK OF SLIPPERY CROOK  
DIGGERS, AND WERE TRYING TO REWITCH THEM TO MAKE

THEY HARRY PEEETER

THEY SAY SLIPPERY HARRY PEEETER INSTEAD. SHE SAID, HOWEVER, ALL  
THEY HAD MANAGED TO DO WAS GET THE BADGES STUCK IN PEEETER  
STINKS. HARRY CROPT PAST THEM TO THE PORTRAIT HOLE AND WAITED  
FOR A MINUTE OR SO, KEEPING AN EYE ON HIS WATCH. THEN  
HERMIONE OPENED THE FAT LADY FOR HIM FROM HILLSIDE AS THEY  
HAD PLANNED. HE SLIPPED PAST HER WITH A WHISPERED THANKS  
AND SET OFF THROUGH THE CASTLE.

THE GRILINDS WERE VERY DARK. HARRY WALKED DOWN THE LAWN

TOWARDS THE LIGHTS SHINING IN FJAGRID'S CABIN. THE INSIDE OF THE ENORMOUS REALMATHENS CARRIAGE WAS ALSO LIT UP; FJARRY COULD HEAR MADAME MAXIME TALKING INSIDE IT AS HE KNOCKED ON FJAGRID'S FRONT DOOR.

WELL THERE, FJARRY? FJAGRID WHISPERED, OPENING THE DOOR AND LEEDING ARIELND.

YEAH, SAID FJARRY, SLIPPING INSIDE THE CABIN AND PULLING THE CHAIR DOWN OFF HIS HEAD. WHAT'S UP?

GET SOMETHING TO SHOW ME, SAID FJAGRID.

THERE WAS AN AIR OF ENORMOUS EXCITEMENT ABOUT FJAGRID. HE WAS WEARING A FLOWER THAT RESEMBLED AN OVERSIZED ARTICHOKE IN HIS BUTTERFLIE. IT LOOKED AS THOUGH HE HAD ABANDONED THE USE OF AXLE GREASE, BUT HE HAD CERTAINLY ATTEMPTED TO COMB HIS HAIR.

FJARRY COULD SEE THE COMB'S BRISTLES TANGLED IN IT.

WHAT ARE YOU SHOWING ME? FJARRY SAID WARILY, WONDERING IF THE SKRULLS HAD LAID EGGS, OR FJAGRID HAD MANAGED TO KILL ANOTHER GIANT THREE-HEADED BEG OFF A STRANGER IN A FLEW.

COME WITH ME, KEEP QUIET AND KEEP YOURSELF COVERED WITH THAT CHAIR, SAID FJAGRID. WE WHEN TAKE FARE, HE WHEN LIKE IT ...

LISTEN, FJAGRID, I CAN'T STAY LONG ... I'VE GOT TO GO BACK UP AT THE CASTLE FOR SOME THINGS

BUT FJAGRID WASN'T LISTENING; HE WAS OPENING THE CABIN DOOR AND STRIDING OFF INTO THE NIGHT. FJARRY FLIPPED THE SWITCHES AND ARIELND, TO HIS GREAT SURPRISE, THAT FJAGRID WAS LEADING HIM TO THE REALMATHENS CARRIAGE.

FJAGRID, WHAT?

SHHH! SAID FJAGRID, AND HE KNOCKED THREE TIMES ON THE DOOR

THE HUNGARIAN FRONTAIL ZOS

BEARING THE CROSSED, CHILDEN WANDS.

MADAME MAXIME OPENED IT. SHE WAS WEARING A SILK SHAWL  
WRAPPED AROUND HER MASSIVE SHOULDERS. SHE SMILED WHEN SHE  
SAW HAGRID. AH, AGRID ... IT IS TIME?

KING-SLEVER, SAID HAGRID, GLARING AT HER, AND HOLDING OUT A  
HAND TO HELP HER DOWN THE CHILDEN STEPS.

MADAME MAXIME CROSSED THE OTHER BEHIND HER, HAGRID OFFERED  
HER HIS ARM, AND THEY SET OFF AROUND THE EDGE OF THE PADDOCK  
CONTAINING MADAME MAXIME'S GIANT WINGED HORSES, WITH HARRY,  
TENTATIVELY REWILDERED, BLINKING THE DEEP LIP WITH THEM. HAD HAGRID  
WANTED TO SHOW HIM MADAME MAXIME? HE COULD SEE HER ANY  
OLD TIME HE WANTED ... SHE WASN'T EXACTLY HARD TO MISS ...

BUT IT SEEMED THAT MADAME MAXIME WAS IN FOR THE SAME  
TREAT AS HARRY, BECAUSE AFTER A WHILE SHE SAID PLAYFULLY, WAIT IS  
IT YOU ARE TAKING ME, AGRID?

YOU'LL ENJOY THIS, SAID HAGRID GRUFFLY. WORTHY SEEN, TALKS ME,  
HARRY WHEN SHE TELLING ANYONE I SHOWED YOU, RIGHT? YOU'RE NOT  
S PRESSED TO DOING.

HE COULDN'T WAIT, SAID MADAME MAXIME, FLUTTERING HER LONG  
BLACK EYELASHES.

AND STILL THEY WALKED, HARRY GETTING MORE AND MORE IRRITABLE  
AS HE HOGGED ALONG IN THEIR WAKE, CHECKING HIS WATCH EVERY  
NOW AND THEN. HAGRID HAD SOME HARKERAINED SKIN IN HAND,  
WHICH MIGHT MAKE HIM MISS SIRILS. IF THEY DIDN'T GET THERE

SEEN, HE WAS GOING TO TURN AROUND, GO STRAIGHT BACK TO THE CASTLE, AND LEAVE HAGRID TO ENJOY HIS MOMENT WITH MADAME

MAXIME ...

BUT THEN WHEN THEY HAD WALKED SEE FAR AROUND THE PERIMETER OF THE FOREST THAT THE CASTLE AND THE LAKE WERE OUT OF SIGHT

HARRY HEARD SOMETHING. MEN WERE SCHEWING UP AHEAD ... THEN CAME A DEAFENING, EAR-SPLITTING ROAR ...

HAGRID LED MADAME MAXIME AROUND A CLUMP OF TREES, AND CAME TO A HALT. HARRY FLURRIED UP ALONGSIDE THEM FOR A SPLIT SECOND, HE THOUGHT HE WAS SEEING KENKIRS, AND MEN DARTING AROUND THEM AND THEN HIS MOUTH FELL OPEN.

THE HARRY PITTER

DRAGONS.

FELIX FLUDD GREEN, ENORMOUS, VICIOUS-LOOKING DRAGONS WERE REARING ON THEIR HIND LEGS INSIDE AN ENCLOSURE FENCED WITH THICK PLANKS OF WOOD, REARING AND SPERTING THROATS OF FIRE WERE SCHEWING INTO THE DARK SKY FROM THEIR OPEN, FANGED MOUTHS, FIFTY FEET ABOVE THE GRILING ON THEIR ELTSTRETCHED NECKS. THERE WAS A SILVERY BLUE ONE WITH LONG, POINTED HORNS,

SNAPPING AND SNARLING AT THE WIZARDS ON THE GRILING; A SCHEWING-SCALED GREEN ONE, WHICH WAS WRITHING AND STAMPING WITH ALL ITS

MIGHT: A RED HORN WITH AN EDD FRINGE OF FINE GOLD SPIKES AROUND ITS FACE, WHICH WAS SHOOTING PLUM-THREE-SHAPED FIRE BALLS INTO THE AIR, AND A GIGANTIC BLACK HORN, MORE LIZARD-LIKE THAN THE OTHERS, WHICH WAS NEAREST THEM.

AT LEAST THIRTY WIZARDS, SEVEN OR EIGHT TO EACH DRAGON, WERE ATTEMPTING TO CHAIN THEM, PULLING ON THE CHAINS CONNECTED TO HEAVY LEATHER STRAPS AROUND THEIR NECKS AND LEGS. MESMERISED, HARRY LOOKED UP, HIGH ABOVE HIM, AND SAW THE EYES OF THE BLACK DRAGON, WITH VERTICAL PUPILS LIKE A CAT'S, GLARING WITH EITHER FEAR OR RAGE, HE COULDN'T TELL WHICH ... IT WAS MAKING A HORRIBLE NOISE, A WHINING, SCREECHING SCREAM ...

KEEP BACK THERE, HARRY! YELLED A WIZARD NEAR THE FENCE, STRAINING ON THE CHAIN HE WAS HOLDING. THEY CAN SHOOT FIRE AT A RANGE OF TWENTY FEET, YELL DOWN! I'VE SEEN THIS TAIL DO THAT!

ISN'T IT REALISTIC? SAID HARRY SEPTLY,

IT'S NOT GOOD! YELLED ANOTHER WIZARD. STUNNING SPELLS, ON THE CHAIN OF THREE!

HARRY SAW EACH OF THE DRAGON-KEEPERS PLUCK HIS WAND,

SLURRY! THEY SHOUTED IN UNISON, AND THE STUNNING SPELLS SHOT INTO THE DARKNESS LIKE FIERY ROCKETS, BURSTING IN SHOWERS OF STARS ON THE DRAGONS' SCALY HIDES

HARRY WATCHED THE DRAGON NEAREST THEM TEETER DANGEROUSLY ON ITS BACK LEGS; ITS TAIL STRETCHED WIDE IN A SUDDENLY SILENT HISS; ITS WHISTLES WERE SUDDENLY DEVEID OF FLAME, THOUGH STILL SMOKING. THEN, VERY SLOWLY, IT FELL SEVERAL FEET SINKING,



THE HUNGARIAN HERNTAIL 289

SLAY BLACK DRAGON HIT THE GROUND WITH A THUD THAT HARRY COULD HAVE SWORN HAD MADE THE TREES BEHIND HIM BUDGE.

THE DRAGON-KEEPERS WHEELED THEIR HANDS AND WALKED TOWARDS THE THEIR FALLEN CHARGES, EACH OF WHICH WAS THE SIZE OF A

SMALL HILL. THEY RUSHED TO TIGHTEN THE CHAINS AND FASTEN THEM SECURELY TO IRON PEGS, WHICH THEY FORCED DEEP INTO THE GROUND WITH THEIR HANDS.

WAS A CLOSER LEED? HAGRID ASKED MADAME MAXIME EXCITEDLY. THE PAIR OF THEM MOVED RIGHT UP TO THE FENCE, AND HARRY

SMELLED. THE WIZARD WHO HAD WARNED HAGRID NOT TO COME ANY CLOSER TURNED, AND HARRY REALISED WHO IT WAS CHARLIE WEASLEY.

ALL RIGHT, HAGRID? HE PANTED, COMING OVER THE TALL. THEY SHOULD BE HERE NOW WE PUT THEM ASLEEP WITH A SLEEPING DRAUGHT ON THE WAY HERE, THOUGH IT MIGHT BE BETTER FOR THEM TO WAKE UP IN THE DARK AND THE QUIET BUT, LIKE YOU SAW, THEY WEREN'T HAPPY, NOT HAPPY AT ALL

WHAT KEEPS YOU GET HERE, CHARLIE? SAID HAGRID, GLAZING AT THE CLOSEST DRAGON THE BLACK ONE WITH SOMETHING CLOSE TO REVERENCE. ITS EYES WERE STILL JUST OPEN. HARRY COULD SEE A STRIP OF GLEAMING YELLOW BENEATH ITS WRINKLED BLACK EYELID.

THIS IS A HUNGARIAN HERNTAIL, SAID CHARLIE. THERE'S A

LEMMING WELSH GREEN HYPER THERE, THE SMALLER ONE A SWEDISH  
SHORT-SNEELT, THAT BLUE GREY AND A CHINESE FIREBALL, THAT S THE  
RED.

CHARLIE WINKED AROUND; MADAME MAXIME WAS STROLLING AWAY  
AROUND THE EDGE OF THE ENCLOSURE, GAZING AT THE STUNNED  
DRAGONS.

I DIDN T KNOW YOU WERE BRINGING HER, HARRY. CHARLIE SAID,  
WINKING. THE CHAMPIONS AREN T SUPPOSED TO KNOW WHAT S  
HAPPENING SHE S HERE TO TELL HER STUDENT, ISN T SHE?

IT S TRULY SHE D LIKE TO SEE EM, STUTTERED HARRY, STILL  
GAZING, ENRAPTLED, AT THE DRAGONS.

REALLY ROMANTIC DATE, HARRY, SAID CHARLIE, SHAKING HIS  
HEAD.

XXX HARRY PTTTTER

HELLO ... SAID HARRY, SEE IT S HERE FOR EACH OF THE CHAMPIONS,  
IS IT? WHAT ARE THEY GETTA DO FIGHT EM?

JUST GET PAST THEM, I THINK, SAID CHARLIE. WE LL BE ON HAND IF  
IT GETS NASTY, EXTINGUISHING SPELLS AT THE READY. THEY WANTED  
NESTING PARTNERS, I DIDN T KNOW WHY ... BUT I TELL YOU THIS, I  
DIDN T ENVOY THE ONE WHO GETS THE THERNTAIL, VICEVERSA. ITS  
BACK END S AS DANGEROUS AS ITS FRONT, WINK.

CHARLIE POINTED TOWARDS THE THERNTAIL S TAIL, AND HARRY SAW  
LONG, BRONZE-COLOURED SPIKES PROTRUDING ALONG IT EVERY FEW  
INCHES.

FIVE OF CHARLIE S FELLOW KEEPERS STAGGERED UP TO THE THERNTAIL  
AT THAT MOMENT, CARRYING A CLUTCH OF BLUE GRANITE-GREY EGGS

BETWEEN THEM IN A BLANKET, THEY PLACED THEM CAREFULLY AT THE  
FERNTAIL'S SIDE. HAGRID LET OUT A MEAN HUMMING.

I'VE GOT THEM COUNTED, HAGRID, SAID CHARLIE, STERNLY. THEN  
HE SAID, FHEW'S HARRY?

FINE, SAID HAGRID. HE WAS STILL GAZING AT THE EGGS.

JUST HOPE HE'S STILL FINE AFTER HE'S FACED THIS LOT, SAID CHARLIE  
GRIMLY, WHISKING OUT EVER THE DRAGONS' ENCLOSURE. I DIDN'T DARE  
TELL MUM WHAT HE'S GOT THE DAY FOR THE FIRST TASK, SHE'S ALREADY  
HAVING BITTENS ABOUT HIM ... CHARLIE IMITATED HIS MOTHER'S  
ANDREW'S VOICE. FHEW WOULD THEY LET HIM ENTER THAT TOURNAMENT,  
HE'S MUCH TOO YOUNG! I THOUGHT THEY WERE ALL SAFE, I THOUGHT  
THEY'RE

WAS GETTING THE REAR AN AGE LIMIT! SHE WAS IN FLOODS AFTER THAT DAILY  
PROPHET ARTICLE ABOUT HIM. HE STILL CRIES ABOUT HIS PARENTS! EH,  
BLESS HIM, I NEVER KNEW!

HARRY HAD HAD ENOUGH, TRULY THE FACT THAT HAGRID  
WOULDN'T MISS HIM, WITH THE ATTRACTIVENESS OF THEIR DRAGONS AND  
MADAME MAXIME THE HILIPY HIM, HE TURNED SILENTLY, AND BEGAN  
THE WALK AWAY, BACK THE CASTLE.

HE DIDN'T KNOW WHETHER HE WAS GLAD HE'D SEEN WHAT WAS  
CHASING HER NEET, PERHAPS THIS WAY WAS BETTER. THE FIRST SPEECH  
WAS EVER NEET, MAYBE IF HE'D SEEN THE DRAGONS FOR THE FIRST TIME  
ON TUESDAY, HE WOULD HAVE PASSED OUT CHILD IN FRONT OF THE  
WHEEL SPEECH ... BUT MAYBE HE WOULD ANYWAY ... HE WAS GETTING

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THE RE ARMED WITH HIS WAND WHICH JUST NEET, FELT LIKE NOTHING

MORE THAN A NARROW STRIP HE WHEED AGAINST A FIFTY-FOOT-HIGH, SCALY, SPIKE-RIDDEN, FIRE-BREATHING DRAGON, AND HE HAD TO GET PAST IT, WITH EVERYONE WATCHING, FEEL

HARRY SPED UP, SKIRTING THE EDGE OF THE FOREST; HE HAD JUST UNDER FIFTEEN MINUTES TO GET BACK TO THE FIRESIDE AND TALK TO SIRIUS, AND HE COULDN'T REMEMBER, EVER, WANTING TO TALK TO

SOMEONE MORE THAN HE DID RIGHT NOW. WHEN, WITHOUT WARNING, HE RAN INTO SOMETHING VERY SOLID.

HARRY FELL BACKWARDS, HIS GLASSES ASKED, CLUTCHING THE CHAIR ARMING HIM. A VOICE NEARBY SAID, HELLO? WHO'S THERE?

HARRY HASTILY CHECKED THAT THE CHAIR WAS COVERING HIM AND LAY VERY STILL, STARING UP AT THE DARK OUTLINE OF THE WIZARD HE HAD HIT. HE RECOGNISED THE CHAIR ... IT WAS DARKBARKER.

WHO'S THERE? SAID DARKBARKER AGAIN, VERY SUSPICIOUSLY, LEERING AROUND IN THE DARKNESS. HARRY REMAINED STILL AND SILENT.

AFTER A MINUTE OR SO, DARKBARKER SEEMED TO DECIDE THAT HE HAD HIT SOME SORT OF ANIMAL; HE WAS LEERING AROUND AT WAIST HEIGHT, AS THOUGH EXPECTING TO SEE A DING. THEN HE CREEPT BACK UNDER THE COVER OF THE TREES, AND STARTED THE EDGE FORWARD TOWARDS THE PLACE WHERE THE DRAGONS WERE.

VERY SLEELY AND VERY CAREFULLY, HARRY GOT TO HIS FEET AND SET OFF AGAIN, AS FAST AS HE COULD WITHOUT MAKING TOO MUCH NOISE, FLURRYING THROUGH THE DARKNESS BACK TOWARDS HOGWARTS.

HE HAD NOT DELIBERATELY WHATSOEVER WHAT BARBAROUS WAS UP THE, HE  
HAD SNEAKED OFF HIS SHIP THE TRY AND FIND OUT WHAT THE FIRST TASK  
WAS GOING TO BE, HE MIGHT EVEN HAVE SPOTTED HAGRID AND  
MADAME MAXIME HEADING OFF AROUND THE FOREST TOGETHER THEY  
WERE HARDLY DIFFICULT TO SPOT AT A DISTANCE ... AND WHEN ALL  
BARBAROUS HAD THE DEE WAS FOLLOWING THE SOUND OF VEHICLES, AND HE,  
LIKE MADAME MAXIME, WOULD KNOW WHAT WAS IN STORE FOR THE  
CHAMPIONS, BY THE LOOKS OF IT, THE ONLY CHAMPION WHO WOULD  
BE FACING THE WINDWALKER ON TUESDAY WAS CEDRIC.

HARRY REACHED THE CASTLE, SLIPPED IN THROUGH THE FRONT DOORS  
AND BEGAN TO CLIMB THE MARBLE STAIRS; HE WAS VERY HOT

AND HARRY PANTED

BREATH, BUT HE DIDN'T DARE SLEEP DOWN ... HE HAD LESS THAN FIVE  
MINUTES TO GET UP THE THE FIRE ...

KALDERBAST! HE GASPED AT THE FAT LADY, WHO WAS SNEEZING  
IN HER FRAME IN FRONT OF THE PORTRAIT HOLE.

IF YOU SAY SO, SHE MUTTERED SLEEPILY, WITHOUT OPENING HER  
EYES, AND THE PICTURE SLUNG HERSELF TO ADMIT HIM, HARRY  
CLIMBED INSIDE. THE CHIMNEY ROOM WAS DESERTED, AND, JUDGING  
BY THE FACT THAT IT SMELLED SLIGHTLY NORMAL, HERMIONE HAD NOT  
NEEDED TO SET OFF ANY BOMBING THE ENSURE THAT HE AND SIRIUS  
GET PRIVACY.

HARRY PULLED OFF THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK AND THREW HIMSELF

INTO AN ARMCHAIR IN FRONT OF THE FIRE. THE ROOM WAS IN SEMI-  
DARKNESS; THE FLAMES WERE THE ONLY SOURCE OF LIGHT. NEARBY, ON A

TABLE, THE SLIPPERY DORIC DIGGERS RAGERS THE CREEPERS HAD  
BEEN TRYING THE IMPROVE WERE GLINTING IN THE FIRELIGHT. THEY NEAR  
READ PITTER PALLY STINDS. HARRY LEANED BACK INTO THE  
FLAMES, AND LIMPED.

SIRILIS HEAD WAS SITTING IN THE FIRE. IF HARRY HADN'T SEEN MR  
DIGGERS DO EXACTLY THIS BACK IN THE WEASLEYS KITCHEN, IT WOULD  
HAVE SCARED HIM OUT OF HIS WITS. INSTEAD, HIS FACE BREAKING INTO  
THE FIRST SMILE HE HAD WHEN FOUR DAYS, HE SCRAMBLED OUT OF HIS  
CHAIR, CREELED DOWN BY THE HEARTH AND SAID, SIRILIS HOW RE  
YOU DOING?

SIRILIS LEANED DIFFERENT FROM HARRY'S MEMORY OF HIM. WHEN  
THEY HAD SAID GOODBYE, SIRILIS FACE HAD BEEN CALM AND SLIMED,  
SURROUNDED BY A QUANTITY OF LONG, BLACK, MATTED HAIR BUT THE  
HAIR WAS SHORT AND CLEAN NOW. SIRILIS FACE WAS FLIMMER, AND HE  
LEANED YOUNGER, MUCH MORE LIKE THE ONLY PHOTOGRAPH HARRY  
HAD OF HIM, WHICH HAD BEEN TAKEN AT THE PETERS WEDDING.

NEVER MIND ME, HOW ARE YOU? SAID SIRILIS SERIOUSLY.

I'M FOR A SECOND, HARRY TRIED TO SAY FINE BUT HE  
COULDN'T DO IT. BEFORE HE COULD STOP HIMSELF, HE WAS TALKING  
MORE THAN HE'D TALKED IN DAYS ABOUT HOW NEARLY RELIEVED HE  
HADN'T ENTERED THE TOURNAMENT OF HIS OWN FREE WILL, HOW RITA  
SKEETER HAD LIED ABOUT HIM IN THE DAILY PROPHET, HOW HE

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COULDN'T WALK DOWN A CORRIDOR WITHOUT BEING SNEERED AT AND  
ABOUT BEEN, BEEN NOT BELIEVING HIM, BEEN'S IRATELY ...

... AND WHEN HARRY'S LIST SEEMED ME WHAT'S COMING IN THE FIRST TASK, AND IT'S DRAGONS, SIRIUS, AND I'M A CHIEF, HE FINISHED DESPERATELY.

SIRIUS LOOKED AT HIM, EYES FULL OF CONCERN, EYES WHICH HAD

NOT YET LOST THE LOOK THAT AZKABAN HAD GIVEN THEM THAT DEAD-ENED, HALUNTED LOOK. HE HAD LET HARRY TALK HIMSELF INTO SILENCE

WITHOUT INTERRUPTION, BUT WHEN HE SAID, DRAGONS WE CAN DEAL WITH, HARRY, BUT WE'LL GET THE THAT IN A MINUTE I HAVEN'T GOTTEN HERE ... I'VE BROKEN INTO A WIZARDING FEELING THE LIKE THE FIRE, BUT THEY COULD BE BACK AT ANY TIME. THERE ARE THINGS I NEED TO WARN YOU ABOUT.

WHAT? SAID HARRY, FEELING HIS SPIRITS SLIP A FURTHER FEW NOTCHES ... SURELY THERE COULD BE NOTHING WORSE THAN DRAGONS COMING?

DRAGON? SAID SIRIUS, HARRY, HE WAS A DEATH EATER, YOU KNOW WHAT DEATH EATERS ARE, DON'T YOU?

YES HE WHAT?

HE WAS CALLED, HE WAS IN AZKABAN WITH ME, BUT HE GOT RELEASED. I'D GET EVERYTHING THAT'S BEEN DISCLOSED WANTED AN ALIEN AT HOGWARTS THIS YEAR THE KEEP AN EYE ON HIM. MEHNDY CALLED DRAGON, PUT HIM INTO AZKABAN IN THE FIRST PLACE.

DRAGON? GOT RELEASED? HARRY SAID SILENTLY HIS BRAIN

SEEMED TO BE STRUGGLING TO ASSEMBLE YET ANOTHER PIECE OF SEEMING INFORMATION. WHY DID THEY RELEASE HIM?

HE DID A DEAL WITH THE MINISTRY OF MAGIC, SAID SIRILUS BITTER-  
LY. HE SAID HE'D SEEN THE PROOF OF HIS WAYS, AND THEN HE NAMED

NAMES ... HE PUT A LEAD OF OTHER PEOPLE INTO AZKABAN IN HIS  
PLACE ... HE'S NOT VERY POPULAR IN THERE, I CAN TELL YOU, AND  
SINCE HE GETS HIT, FROM WHAT I CAN TELL, HE'S BEEN TEACHING THE  
DARK ARTS THE EVERY STUDENT WHO PASSES THROUGH THAT SCHOOL OF  
HIS. SHE WATCHES HIM FOR THE DUMSTRANG CHAMPION AS WELL.

EEK, SAID HARRY, SLEELY. BUT ... ARE YOU SAYING DARKARTS PUT  
MY NAME IN THE CHURCH? BECAUSE IF HE DID, HE'S A REALLY GOOD

THE HARRY POTTER

AFTER, HE SEEMED FLIRTULOUS ABOUT IT. HE WANTED THE STEP OF CHAM-  
PETING.

WE KNOW HE'S A GOOD AFTER, SAID SIRILUS, BECAUSE HE CON-  
VINCED THE MINISTRY OF MAGIC TO SET HIM FREE, DIDN'T HE? WELL,

I'VE BEEN KEEPING AN EYE ON THE DAILY PROPHET, HARRY  
YOU AND THE REST OF THE WORLD, SAID HARRY BITTERLY.

AND, READING BETWEEN THE LINES OF THAT SKEETER WOMAN'S  
ARTICLE LAST MONTH, MURDER WAS ATTACKED THE NIGHT BEFORE HE  
STARTED AT HOGWARTS. YES, I KNOW SHE SAYS IT WAS ANOTHER  
FALSE ALARM, SIRILUS SAID HASTILY, SEEING HARRY ABOUT THE SPEAK,  
BUT I DIDN'T THINK SHE, SHE'S WELL, I THINK SHEMAYBE TRIED THE STEP



HIM GETTING THE HOGWARTS, I THINK SOMEONE KNOW THEIR THE  
WOULD BE A LOT MORE DIFFICULT WITH HIM AROUND, AND THE  
HARD S GOING THE WAY INTO IT THE CLOSELY, MAD-LY S HEARD  
INTRUDERS A BIT THE EATEN, BUT THAT DOESN T MEAN HE CAN T STILL  
SPOT THE REAL THING, MERRY WAS THE BEST ALIEN THE MINISTRY  
EVER HAD.

SEE ... WHAT ARE YOU SAYING? SAID HARRY SLEELY, DARKLY S  
TRYING THE WILL MY? BUT WHY?  
SIRILIS HESITATED.

I VE BEEN HEARING SOME VERY STRANGE THINGS, HE SAID SLEELY,  
THE DEATH EATERS SEEM TO BE A BIT MORE ACTIVE THAN USUAL LATELY,  
THEY SHOWED THEMSELVES AT THE HILDBITCH WARD CLIP, DIDN T  
THEY? SOMEONE SET OFF THE DARK MARK ... AND THEN DID YOU  
HEAR ABOUT THAT MINISTRY OF MAGIC WITH THE S GOING MISSING?  
BERTHA JERKINS? SAID HARRY,  
EXACTLY ... SHE DISAPPEARED IN ALBANIA, AND THAT S DEFINITELY  
WHERE VOLDMORT WAS REVEALED TO BE LAST ... AND SHE WOULD  
HAVE KNOWN THE TRILIZARD TOURNAMENT WAS COMING UP, WOULDN T  
SHE?

YES, BUT ... IT S NOT VERY LIKELY SHE D HAVE WALKED STRAIGHT  
INTO VOLDMORT, IS IT? SAID HARRY.

LISTEN, I KNOW BERTHA JERKINS, SAID SIRILIS GRIMLY, SHE WAS AT  
HOGWARTS WHEN I WAS, A FEW YEARS ABOVE YOUR DAD AND ME, AND  
SHE WAS AN IDIOT, VERY NERVOUS, BUT SHE KNOWS, NONE AT ALL, IT S NOT A

THE HUNGARIAN HORNTAIL TWO

GOOD COMINATION, HARRY, I D SAY SHE D BE VERY EASY TO LURE INTO

A TRAP,

SEE ... SEE VILDERBERT COULD HAVE BEEN HIT ABOUT THE  
TOURNAMENT? SAID HARRY, IS THAT WHAT YOU MEAN? YOU THINK  
DARKWATER MIGHT BE HERE AND HIS HORDES?

I DON'T KNOW, SAID SIRILIS SILENTLY, I JUST DON'T KNOW ...  
DARKWATER DOESN'T STRIKE ME AS THE TYPE WHO'D GO BACK THE  
VILDERBERT UNLESS HE KNEW VILDERBERT WAS PERSONALLY ENOUGH THE  
PROTECT HIM, BUT WHEREVER PUT YOUR NAME IN THAT CHECKET DID IT  
FOR A REASON, AND I CAN'T HELP THINKING THE TOURNAMENT WOULD  
BE A VERY GOOD WAY TO ATTACK YOU, AND MAKE IT LOOK LIKE AN  
ACCIDENT,

LOOKS LIKE A REALLY GOOD PLAN FROM WHERE I'M STANDING, SAID

HARRY BLABBY, THEY'LL JUST HAVE TO STAND BACK AND LET THE DRAG-  
ONS DO THEIR STUFF,

RIGHT THESE DRAGONS, SAID SIRILIS, SPEAKING VERY QUIETLY  
NOW, THERE'S A WAY, HARRY, DON'T BE TEMPTED TO TRY A STUNNING  
SPELL DRAGONS ARE STRONG AND THEY PERSONALLY MAGICAL THEY'RE  
DEFENDED BY A SINGLE STUNNER, YOU NEED ABOUT HALF-A-DOZEN  
WIZARDS AT A TIME TO OVERCOME A DRAGON

YEAH, I KNOW, I JUST SAID, SAID HARRY,

BUT YOU CAN DO IT ALONE, SAID SIRILIS, THERE IS A WAY, AND A  
SIMPLE SPELL'S ALL YOU NEED, JUST

BUT HARRY HELD UP A HAND TO SILENCE HIM, HIS HEART SUDDENLY  
FEELING AS THOUGH IT WOULD BURST, HE COULD HEAR FOOTSTEPS  
CREAKING DOWN THE SPIRAL STAIRCASE BEHIND HIM,

GH! HE HISSED AT SIRILIS. GH! THERE'S SOMETHING COMING!  
HARRY SCRAMBLED THE HIS FEET, HIDING THE FIRE. IF SOMETHING SAW  
SIRILIS FACE WITHIN THE WALLS OF FEECHWARTS, THEY WOULD RAISE AN  
ALMIGHTY WPREHAR. THE MINISTRY WOULD GET DRAGGED IN. HE,  
HARRY, WOULD BE HOLTESTIMED AHELT SIRILIS WHERKAKHLITS.  
HARRY HEARD A TINY PEEP IN THE FIRE BEHIND HIM, AND KNEW  
SIRILIS HAD GONE. HE WATCHED THE RHTTHM OF THE SPIRAL STAIRCASE

WHEN HE HAD DECIDED THE GH FOR A STREHL AT ONE HE CHECK IN THE MERN-  
ING, AND STEPPED SIRILIS TELLING HIM WHEN HE GET PAST A DRACHN?

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IT WAS RHN, DRESSED IN HIS MARHIN PAISLEY PYLAMAS, RHN  
STEPPED DEAD FACING HARRY ACROSS THE RHEM, AND WHIRLED  
ARHLND.

WHEN WERE YELT TALKING TH? HE SAID,

WHAT'S THAT GH? THE DEE WITH YELT? HARRY SNARLED. WHAT ARE  
YELT BEING DEHLN HERE AT THIS TIME OF NIGHT?

I JUST WHNDERED WHERE YELT. RHN BRKKE HP, ST-RLUGGING,

NOTHING. I'M GOING BACK TH BED.

JUST THELIGHT YELT D CHTP NEEHING ARHLND, DID YELT? HARRY  
SHHLITED. HE KNEW THAT RHN HAD NEE IDEA WHAT HE D WALKED IN  
HIN, KNEW HE HADN'T DEHN IT HIN PLURPHESE, BLT HE DIDN'T CARE. AT  
THIS MHMENT HE HATED EVERYTHING AHELT RHN, RIGHT DEHLN THE THE  
SEVERAL INCHES OF BARE ANKLE ST-ELING BENEATH HIS PYLAMA  
TRELISERS.

SHRRY AHELT THAT, SAID RHN, HIS FACE REDDENING WITH ANGER.

SHOULD VE REALISED YELI DIDN T WANT THE KE DISTURBED, I LL LET YELI GET ON WITH PRACTISING FOR YELI'S NEXT INTERVIEW IN PLACE. HARRY SEIZED ONE OF THE PENTTER REALLY STINDS RAGS OFF THE TABLE AND CHUCKED IT, AS HARD AS HE COULD, ACROSS THE ROOM. IT HIT REIN ON THE FOREHEAD AND BOUNCED OFF. THERE YELI GO, HARRY SAID. SOMETHING FOR YELI TO WEAR ON TUESDAY. YELI MIGHT EVEN HAVE A SCAR NOW, IF YELI RE LUCKY ... THAT S WHAT YELI WANT, ISN T IT?

HE STRODE ACROSS THE ROOM TOWARDS THE STAIRS; HE HAD EXPECTED REIN TO STOP HIM, HE WOULD EVEN HAVE LIKED REIN TO THROW A

GLANCE AT HIM, BUT REIN JUST STOOD THERE IN HIS TEE SMALL PYJAMAS, AND HARRY, HAVING STORMED UPSTAIRS, LAY ALONE IN BED

FLIPPING FOR A LONG TIME AFTERWARDS, AND DIDN T HEAR HIM COME UP THE BED.

## CHAPTER TWENTY

### THE FIRST TASK

HARRY GET UP ON SUNDAY MORNING AND DRESSED SEE INATTENTIVELY THAT IT WAS A WHILE BEFORE HE REALISED HE WAS TRYING TO PULL HIS HAT OVER HIS FEET INSTEAD OF HIS HEAD. WHEN HE D FINALLY GET ALL HIS CLOTHES ON THE RIGHT PARTS OF HIS BODY, HE FLURRIED OFF THE FINE HERMIONE, LOCATING HER AT THE GRYPFINDER TABLE IN THE GREAT

fall, where she was eating breakfast with Ginny, feeling the uneasy the cat, Harry waited until Hermione had swallowed her last spoonful of porridge, then dragged her out into the grounds for another walk. There, he told her all about the dragons, and about everything Sirius had said, while they took another long walk around the lake.

Alarmed as she was by Sirius' warnings about dragons,

Hermione still thought that the dragons were the more pressing problem.

Let's just try and keep you alive until Tuesday evening, she said desperately, and then we can worry about dragons. They walked three times around the lake, trying all the way to think of a simple spell that would slay a dragon. Nothing whatsoever occurred to them, so they retired to the library instead. Here, Harry pulled down every book he could find on dragons, and both of them set the words searching through the large pile.

Taken-clipping by charms ... treating scale rot ... this is new good, this is the letters like Jacob who want to keep them healthy ...

Dragons are extremely difficult to slay, being the the ancient

the Harry Potter

magic that makes their thick hides, which means that the most powerful spells can penetrate ... but Sirius said a simple one

WOULD BE IT ...

LET S TRY SOME SIMPLE SPELLBOOKS, THEN, SAID HARRY, THERELING  
ASIDE MEN WHO HAVE DRAGONS THE MICH.

HE RETURNED THE THE TABLE WITH A PILE OF SPELLBOOKS, SET THEM

DOWN AND BEGAN THE FLICK THROUGH EACH IN TURN, FERMINE WHIS-  
PERING WHEN STOP AT HIS ELDER. WELL, THERE ARE SWITCHING SPELLS

... BUT WHAT S THE POINT OF SWITCHING IT? UNLESS YOU SWAPPED ITS  
PAGES FOR WINE GLASS OR SOMETHING, THAT WOULD MAKE IT LESS  
DANGEROUS ... THE TRICKLE IS, LIKE THAT BOOK SAID, NOT MICH IS  
GIVING THE GET THROUGH A DRAGON S HIDE ... I D SAY TRANSPARE IT,  
BUT SOMETHING THAT KID, YOU REALLY HAVEN T GET A HIDE, I BELIEVE  
EVEN PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL ... UNLESS YOU RE SUPPOSED THE PUT  
THE SPELL IN YOURSELF? MAYBE THE GIVE YOURSELF EXTRA POWERS? BUT  
THEY RE NOT SIMPLE SPELLS, I MEAN, WE HAVEN T DONE ANY OF THESE  
IN CLASS, I ONLY KNOW ABOUT THEM BECAUSE I VE BEEN DOING  
H.L.L. PRACTICE PAPERS ...

FERMINE, HARRY SAID, THROUGH GRITTED TEETH, WILL YOU SHUT  
UP FOR A BIT, PLEASE? I M TRYING TO CONCENTRATE.

BUT ALL THAT HAPPENED, WHEN FERMINE FELL SILENT, WAS  
THAT HARRY S BRAIN FILLED WITH A SORT OF BLANK BUZZING, WHICH  
DIDN T SEEM THE ALLEH THEM FOR CONCENTRATION. HE STARED  
HELPLESSLY DOWN THE INDEX OF BASIC BOOKS FOR THE BUSY AND  
VEDD: INSTANT SCALPING ... BUT DRAGONS HAD NO HAIR ... PEPPER  
BREATH ... THAT WOULD PROBABLY INCREASE A DRAGON S FIREPOWER ...  
HORN THENCE ... LIST WHAT HE NEEDED, THE GIVE IT AN EXTRA

WEAPENS ...

HEY, NEH, HE S BACK AGAIN, WHY CAN T HE READ IN HIS STUPID  
SHIP? SAID HERMIONE IRRITABLY, AS VICTOR DORLING SNEEZED IN,  
CAST A SLURRY LOOK OVER AT THE PAIR OF THEM, AND SETTLED HIMSELF IN  
A DISTANT CORNER WITH A PILE OF BOOKS. THERE HE, HARRY, WAS TO GO  
BACK TO THE CHAMBER ROOM ... HIS FAN CLUB WAS HERE IN A  
MOMENT, TWITTERING AWAY ...

AND SURE ENOUGH, AS THEY LEFT THE LIBRARY, A GANG OF GIRLS TIP-

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THEY PAST THEM IN THE LIBRARY, ONE OF THEM WEARING A BULGARIA  
SCARF TIED AROUND HER WAIST.

\*

HARRY RARELY SLEPT THAT NIGHT. WHEN HE AWOKE ON MONDAY  
MORNING, HE SERIOUSLY CONSIDERED, FOR THE FIRST TIME EVER, JUST  
RUNNING AWAY FROM HOGWARTS. BUT AS HE LOOKED AROUND THE  
GREAT HALL AT BREAKFAST TIME, AND THOUGHT ABOUT WHAT LEAVING  
THE CASTLE WOULD MEAN, HE KNEW HE COULDN'T DO IT. IT WAS THE  
ONLY PLACE HE HAD EVER BEEN HAPPY ... WELL, HE SUPPOSED HE  
MIGHT HAVE BEEN HAPPY WITH HIS PARENTS, THEN, BUT HE COULDN'T  
REMEMBER THAT.

SOMEHOW, THE KNOWLEDGE THAT HE WOULD RATHER BE HERE AND  
FACING A DRAGON THAN BACK IN PRIVET DRIVE WITH DUDLEY WAS  
GOOD TO KNOW; IT MADE HIM FEEL SLIGHTLY CALMER. HE FINISHED HIS  
BACON WITH DIFFICULTY (HIS THREAT WASN'T WORKING TOO WELL) AND,  
AS HE AND HERMIONE GOT UP, HE SAW CEDRIC DIGGORY LEAVING THE

FLUFFLEPUFF TABLE.

LEDRIC STILL DIDN'T DENY ABLIT THE DRAGONS ... THE ONLY  
CHAMPION WHO DIDN'T, IF HARRY WAS RIGHT IN THINKING THAT  
MARIME AND RARARARH WOULD HAVE TOLD FLEUR AND RILIM ...

HERMIONE, I'LL SEE YOU IN THE GREEN-HOUSES, HARRY SAID,  
CHIVING THE HIS DECISION AS HE WATCHED LEDRIC LEAVING THE HALL.  
GEE HEN, I'LL CATCH YOU UP.

HARRY, YOU'LL BE LATE, THE BELL'S ABLIT THE RING  
I'LL CATCH YOU UP, HEN?

BY THE TIME HARRY REACHED THE BOTTOM OF THE MARBLE STAIR-  
CASE, LEDRIC WAS AT THE TOP. HE WAS WITH A LEAD OF SIXTY-SEVEN

FRIENDS. HARRY DIDN'T WANT THE TALK THE LEDRIC IN FRONT OF THEM;  
THEY WERE AMONG THOSE WHO HAD BEEN EJECTING RITA SKEETER'S  
ARTICLE AT HIM EVERY TIME HE WENT NEAR THEM. HE FOLLOWED  
LEDRIC AT A DISTANCE, AND SAW THAT HE WAS HEADING TOWARDS THE

CHARMS HALLWAY. THIS GAVE HARRY AN IDEA. PAUSING AT A DIS-  
TANCE FROM THEM, HE PULLED OUT HIS WAND, AND THREW CAREFULLY AIM.

DIFFIDENT

LEDRIC'S BAG SPLIT. PARCHMENT, BILLS AND BOOKS SPILLED OUT OF

THE HARRY PENTTER

IT HENTH THE FLEER. SEVERAL BOTTLES OF INK SMASHED.

DIDN'T EITHER, SAID LEDRIC IN AN EXASPERATED VOICE, AS HIS



FRIENDS WENT BEHIND THE HELP HIM, TELL FLITWICK I'M CHEERING, GEE  
HEN ...

THIS WAS EXACTLY WHAT HARRY HAD BEEN FEELING FOR, HE  
SLIPPED HIS HAND BACK INTO HIS POCKETS, WAITED UNTIL CEDRIC'S  
FRIENDS HAD DISAPPEARED INTO THEIR CLASSROOMS, AND HURRIED UP  
THE CORRIDOR, WHICH WAS NOW EMPTY OF EVERYONE BUT HIMSELF  
AND CEDRIC.

HI, SAID CEDRIC, PICKING UP A COPY OF A GUIDE TO ADVANCED  
TRANSFIGURATION THAT WAS NOW SPLATTERED WITH INK. MY BAG JUST  
SPLIT ... BRAND NEW AND ALL ...

CEDRIC, SAID HARRY, THE FIRST TASK IS DRAGONS.

WHAT? SAID CEDRIC, LEANING UP.

DRAGONS, SAID HARRY, SPEAKING QUICKLY, IN CASE PROFESSOR  
FLITWICK CAME HERE TO SEE WHERE CEDRIC HAD GOTTEN THEM. THEY'VE GOTTEN  
FLEWER, ONE FOR EACH OF US, AND WE'VE GOTTEN THEM GET PAST THEM.

CEDRIC STARED AT HIM, HARRY SAW SOME OF THE PANIC HE'D BEEN  
FEELING SINCE SATURDAY NIGHT FLICKERING IN CEDRIC'S GREY EYES.

ARE YOU SURE? CEDRIC SAID, IN A FLUSHED VOICE.

DEAD SURE, SAID HARRY. I'VE SEEN THEM.

BUT HOW DID YOU FIND THEM? WE'RE NOT SUPPOSED TO KNOW ...

NEVER MIND, SAID HARRY QUICKLY. HE KNEW HAGRID WOULD  
BE IN TROUBLE IF HE TOLD THE TRUTH, BUT I'M NOT THE ONLY ONE WITH  
KNOWLEDGE. FLEWER AND DREAM WILL KNOW BY NOW. MAXIME AND  
DARKWATER BOTH SAW THE DRAGONS, THEN.

CEDRIC STRAIGHTENED UP, HIS ARMS FULL OF INKED BILLS, PARCELS  
MENT AND REEDS, HIS RIPPED BAG DANGLING OFF ONE SHOULDER. HE

STARTED AT HARRY, AND THERE WAS A PLIZZLED, ALMOST SUSPICITIOUS  
LOOK IN HIS EYES.

WHY ARE YOU TELLING ME? HE ASKED.

HARRY LOOKED AT HIM IN DISBELIEF. HE WAS SURE CEDRIC WOULDN'T  
N'T HAVE ASKED THAT IF HE HAD SEEN THE DRAGONS HIMSELF. HARRY

WOULDN'T HAVE LET HIS WORST ENEMY FACE THESE MONSTERS UNPRE-  
PARED WELL, PERHAPS MALFOY HAD SNARE ...

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IT'S ILST ... FAIR, ISN'T IT? HE SAID TO CEDRIC. WE ALL KNOW NOW  
... WE'RE HAVING AN EVEN MEETING, AREN'T WE?

CEDRIC WAS STILL LOOKING AT HIM IN A SLIGHTLY SUSPICITIOUS WAY  
WHEN HARRY HEARD A FAMILIAR CLUNKING NOISE BEHIND HIM. HE  
TURNED AROUND, AND SAW MAD-EYE Moody EMERGING FROM A  
NEARBY CLASSROOM.

COME WITH ME, POTTER. HE GRINNED. DIGGORY, HFF YOU GO.

HARRY STARED APPREHENSIVELY AT Moody. HAD HE EVER HEARD  
THAT? ER PROFESSOR, I'M SUPPOSED TO BE IN HERMION'S  
NEVER MIND THAT, POTTER. IN MY OFFICE, PLEASE ...

HARRY FOLLOWED HIM, WONDERING WHAT WAS GOING TO HAPPEN  
TO HIM NOW. WHAT IF Moody WANTED TO KNOW HOW HE'D FELT  
ABOUT THE DRAGONS? WOULD Moody GO TO DUMBLEDORE AND  
TELL HIM HAGRID, THE ILST TURN HARRY INTO A FERRET? WELL, IT MIGHT  
BE EASIER TO GET PAST A DRAGON IF HE WAS A FERRET. HARRY THOUGHT

BLINDLY, HE DID SEEM SMALLER, MUCH LESS EASY TO SEE FROM A HEIGHT OF FIFTY FEET ...

HE FOLLOWED MEEDY INTO HIS OFFICE. MEEDY CLOSED THE DOOR BEHIND THEM AND TURNED THE LIGHT AT HARRY, HIS MAGICAL EYE FIXED UPON HIM AS WELL AS THE NORMAL ONE.

THAT WAS A VERY DECENT THING WHY HE DID, BETTER, MEEDY SAID BRIEFLY.

HARRY DIDN'T KNOW WHAT HE SAID; THIS WASN'T THE REACTION HE HAD EXPECTED AT ALL.

SIT DOWN, SAID MEEDY, AND HARRY SAT, LEANING AGAINST.

HE HAD VISITED THIS OFFICE UNDER TWO OF ITS PREVIOUS HEADS. IN PROFESSOR LINDHART'S DAY, THE WALLS HAD BEEN PLASTERED

WITH BEAMING, WINNING PICTURES OF PROFESSOR LINDHART HIMSELF, WHEN LINN HAD LIVED HERE, THEY WERE MORE LIKELY TO BE ACROSS A SPECIMEN OF SOME FASCINATING NEW DARK CREATURE HE HAD PRELIMINED FOR THEM THE STUDY IN CLASS. NOW, HOWEVER, THE OFFICE WAS FULL OF A NUMBER OF EXCEPTIONALLY GOOD OBJECTS THAT HARRY SUPPOSED MEEDY HAD USED IN THE DAYS WHEN HE HAD BEEN AN ALDER.

ON HIS DESK STOOD WHAT LOOKED LIKE A LARGE, CRACKED, GLASS

AND HARRY BETTER

SPINNING THEM; HARRY RECOGNISED IT AT ONCE AS A SNEAKESCOPE, BECAUSE HE HAD ONE HIMSELF, THOUGH IT WAS MUCH SMALLER THAN MEEDY'S. IN THE CORNER ON A SMALL TABLE STOOD AN OBJECT

THAT LOOKED SOMETHING LIKE AN EXTRA-SLUGGISH, CHILDEN TELEVISION AERIAL. IT WAS HUMMING SLIGHTLY. WHAT APPEARED TO BE A MIRROR FLUNG OPPOSITE HARRY ON THE WALL, BUT IT WAS NOT REFLECTING THE ROOM. SHADY FIGURES WERE MOVING AROUND INSIDE IT, NEAR BY THEM CLEARLY IN FILLS.

LIKE MY DARK DETECTORS, DEE FELT SAID MERRY, WHO WAS WATCHING HARRY CLOSELY.

WHAT IS THAT? HARRY ASKED, POINTING AT THE SLUGGISH CHILDEN AERIAL.

SECRETLY SENSITIVE, VIBRATES WHEN IT DETECTS CONCEALMENT AND LIES ... NEAR BY HERE, HE CHIRPED, THE MUCH INTERFERENCE STUDENTS IN EVERY DIRECTION LYING ABOUT WHY THEY HAVEN'T DONE THEIR HOMEWORK. BEEN HUMMING EVER SINCE I GOT HERE. I HAD TO DISABLE MY SNEAKERSHIP BECAUSE IT WOULDN'T STOP WHISTLING. IT'S EXTRA SENSITIVE, PICKS UP STUFF ABOUT A MILE AWAY. HE CHIRPED, IT COULD BE PICKING UP MORE THAN KIDS STUFF. HE ADDED IN A GROWL.

AND WHAT IS THE MIRROR FOR?

HE, THAT IS MY PEEK-GLASS, SEE THEM OUT THERE, FOLLOWING AROUND? I'M NOT REALLY IN TROUBLE UNTIL I SEE THE WHITES OF THEIR EYES. THAT IS WHEN I OPEN MY TAIL.

HE LET OUT A SHORT, HARSH LAUGH, AND POINTED TO THE LARGE TAIL UNDER THE WINDOW. IT HAD SEVEN RINGS IN A ROW. HARRY WONDERED WHAT WAS IN THERE, UNTIL MERRY'S NEXT ELUSTIAN BRIGHTENED HIM SHARPLY BACK TO EARTH.

SEE ... FEELING OUT ABOUT THE DRAGONS, HAVE FELT?

HARRY HESITATED. HE'D BEEN AFRAID OF THIS BUT HADN'T TOLD

LEBRIC, AND HE CERTAINLY WASN'T GOING TO TELL MURDOCK, THAT HARRY HAD BROKEN THE RULES.

IT'S ALL RIGHT, SAID MURDOCK, SITTING DOWN AND STRETCHING HIS WHOLE LEG WITH A GRIN. CHEATING IS A TRADITIONAL PART OF THE TRIWIZARD TOURNAMENT AND ALWAYS HAS BEEN.

THE FIRST TASK WAS

I DIDN'T HEAR, SAID HARRY SHARPLY. IT WAS A SHORT OF ACCIDENT THAT I FELT LIKE THAT.

MURDOCK GRINNED. I WASN'T ACCUSING YOU, LADDIE. I'VE BEEN TELLING DUMBLEDORE FROM THE START, HE CAN BE AS HIGH MINDED AS HE LIKES, BUT YOU CAN GET HIM DANGEROUS AND MAXIME WON'T BE. THEY'LL HAVE TOLD THEIR CHAMPIONS EVERYTHING THEY CAN. THEY WANT THE WIN. THEY WANT THE BEAT DUMBLEDORE. THEY'D LIKE THE PRIZE HE'S ONLY HUMAN.

MURDOCK GAVE A HARSH LAUGH, AND HIS MAGICAL EYE SWIVELLED AROUND SO FAST IT MADE HARRY FEEL UNCOMFORTABLE TO WATCH IT.

SEE ... GET ANY IDEAS HOW YOU'RE GOING TO GET PAST YOUR DRAGON YET? SAID MURDOCK.

NO, SAID HARRY.

WELL, I'M NOT GOING TO TELL YOU, SAID MURDOCK GRUFFLY. I DON'T SHOW FAVORITISM, MR. I'M JUST GOING TO GIVE YOU SOME GOOD, GENERAL ADVICE. AND THE FIRST BIT IS PLAY TO YOUR STRENGTHS.

I HAVEN'T GOT ANY, SAID HARRY, BECAUSE HE COULD STOP HIMSELF.

EXCUSE ME, GRINNED MURDOCK, YOU'VE GOT STRENGTHS IF I SAY YOU'VE GOT THEM. THINK NOW. WHAT ARE YOU BEST AT?

HARRY TRIED TO CONCENTRATE. WHAT WAS HE BEST AT? WELL, THAT WAS EASY, REALLY

FLIBBITCH, HE SAID DILLY, AND A FAT LEFT HIM HELP

THAT'S RIGHT, SAID MURPHY, STARING AT HIM VERY HARD, HIS MAGICAL EYE BARELY MOVING AT ALL. YOU'RE A DAMN GOOD FLIER, FROM

WHAT I'VE HEARD.

YEAH, BUT ... HARRY STARED AT HIM. I'M NOT ALLOWED A ROOM, I'VE ONLY GOT MY WAND

MY SECOND PIECE OF GENERAL ADVICE, SAID MURPHY LAUGHING, INTERRUPTING HIM, IS THE USE A NICE, SIMPLE SPELL WHICH WILL ENABLE YOU TO GET WHAT YOU NEED.

HARRY LOOKED AT HIM BLANKLY. WHAT DID HE NEED?

COME ON, BOY ... WHISPERED MURPHY, PUT THEM TOGETHER ... IT'S NOT THAT DIFFICULT ...

AND IT CLICKED. HE WAS BEST AT FLYING. HE NEEDED THE PASS THE

KEY HARRY PENTTER

DRAGON IN THE AIR. FOR THAT, HE NEEDED HIS FIREWHEEL. AND FOR HIS FIREWHEEL, HE NEEDED

HERMIONE. HARRY WHISPERED, WHEN HE HAD SPED INTO GREENHOUSE THREE TEN MINUTES LATER, LITTERING A HURRIED APPEAL TO THE

PROFESSOR SPRENT AS HE PASSED HER, HERMIONE I NEED YOU TO HELP ME.

WHAT D YOU THINK I VE BEEN TRYING TH DEE, HARRY? SHE WHIS-  
PERED BACK, HER EYES REELING WITH ANXIETY OVER THE TEP OF THE

SLIVERING FLITTERY BLISH SHE WAS PRUNING.

HERMIONE, I NEED TH LEARN FEEL TH DEE A SLIPPERING CHARM  
PROPERLY BY THEHRRRL AFTERHRRN.

\*

AND SHE THEY PRACTISED. THEY DIDN T HAVE LUNCH, KLT HEADED FOR  
A FREE CLASSRHHM, WHERE HARRY TRIED WITH ALL HIS MIGHT TH MADE  
VARIEHS EJECTS FLY ACROSS TH RHHM TELLARDS HIM. HE WAS STILL  
HAVING PROBLEMS. THE RHHDS AND BLILLS KEPT LEETING HEART  
HALFWAY ACROSS TH RHHM AND DRIPPING LIKE STEAKS TH THE FLEHR.  
CONCENTRATE, HARRY, CONCENTRATE ...

WHAT D YOU THINK I M TRYING TH DEE? SAID HARRY ANGERILY. A

FILTHY GREAT DRAGON KEEPS PHIPPING UP IN MY HEAD, FOR SOME REA-  
SHN ... HRR, TRY AGAIN ...

HE WANTED TH SKIP DIVINATION TH KEEP PRACTISING, KLT  
HERMIONE REFUSED PHINT-BLANK TH SKIVE OFF ARITH-MANCY, AND  
THERE WAS NEH PHINT STAYING WITHHELT HER. HE THEREFORE HAD TH  
ENDURE EVER AN FHLR OF PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY, WHH SPENT HALF THE  
LESSON TELLING EVERYONE THAT THE POSITION OF MARS IN RELATION TH  
SATURN AT THAT MOMENT MEANT THAT PEOPLE BORN IN JULY WERE IN  
GREAT DANGER OF SLIDEN, VIOLENT DEATHS.

WELL, THAT'S GOOD, SAID HARRY WEILLY, HIS TEMPER GETTING THE BETTER OF HIM, JUST AS LONG AS IT'S NOT DRAGN-HELT, I DON'T WANT THE SLIPPER.

REHN LOOKED FOR A MOMENT AS THOUGH HE WAS GIVING THE MATTER  
HE CERTAINLY CALLED HARRY'S EYE FOR THE FIRST TIME IN DAYS, BUT  
HARRY WAS STILL FEELING THE RESENTFUL TOWARDS REHN THE CARE, HE  
SPENT THE REST OF THE LESSON TRYING TO ATTRACT SMALL BEETLES

### THE FIRST TASK FOR

TOWARDS HIM UNDER THE TABLE WITH HIS WAND, HE MANAGED TO  
MAKE A FLY GO STRAIGHT INTO HIS HAND, THOUGH HE WASN'T  
ENTIRELY SURE THAT WAS BEING THE HIS PRELUS AT SUMMERING  
CHARMS PERHAPS THE FLY WAS JUST STUPID.

HE FINISHED SOME DINNER AFTER DIVINATION, THEN RETURNED  
TO THE EMPTY CLASSROOM WITH HERMIONE, USING THE INVISIBILITY  
CLASH TO AVOID THE TEACHERS. THEY KEPT PRACTISING UNTIL PAST  
MIDNIGHT. THEY WOULD HAVE STAYED LONGER, BUT PERVEY TURNED  
UP AND, PRETENDING TO THINK THAT HARRY WANTED THINGS THROWN  
AT HIM, STARTED CHUCKING CHAIRS ACROSS THE ROOM. HARRY AND  
HERMIONE LEFT IN A HURRY BEFORE THE NOISE ATTRACTED FILCH, AND  
WENT BACK TO THE GRYFFINDOR COMMON ROOM, WHICH WAS NOW  
MERCIFULLY EMPTY.

AT TWO O'CLOCK IN THE MORNING, HARRY STOOD NEAR THE FIRE-  
PLACE, SURROUNDED BY HEAPS OF BEETLES BEES, BUTTERFLIES, SEVERAL  
UPTURNED CHAIRS, AN OLD SET OF CHESTNUTS AND NEVILLE'S HEAD,



TRYING. ONLY IN THE LAST FEELER HAD HARRY REALLY GOTT THE HANG OF THE SLUMMING CHARM.

THAT S BETTER, HARRY, THAT S WEAS BETTER, HERMIONE SAID, BEING EXHAUSTED, BUT VERY PLEASED.

WELL, NOW WE KNOW WHAT THE DO NEXT TIME I CAN T MANAGE A SPELL, HARRY SAID, THROWING A BLIND DICTIONARY BACK THE HERMIONE, SHE HE COULD TRY AGAIN, THREATEN ME WITH A DRAGON, RIGHT ... HE RAISED HIS HAND ONCE MORE, ACCIE DICTIONARY? THE HEAVY BOOK SHOOK OUT OF HERMIONE S HAND, FLEW ACROSS THE ROOM, AND HARRY CAUGHT IT.

HARRY, I REALLY THINK YOU VE GOT IT! SAID HERMIONE, DELIGHTEDLY, LIST AS LONG AS IT WORKS THEMSELVES, HARRY SAID, THE FIREWELL S GOING TO BE MUCH FURTHER AWAY THAN THE STUFF IN HERE, IT S GOING TO BE IN THE CASTLE, AND I M GOING TO BE OUT THERE IN THE GREENS ...

THAT DOESN T MATTER, SAID HERMIONE FIRMLY, LIST AS LONG AS YOU RE CONCENTRATING REALLY, REALLY HARD ON IT, IT LL WORK, HARRY, WE D BETTER GET SOME SLEEP ... YOU RE GOING TO NEED IT.

\*

END HARRY BETTER

HARRY HAD BEEN FEELING SHE HARD ON LEARNING THE SLUMMING CHARM THAT EVENING THAT SOME OF HIS BLIND PANIC HAD LEFT HIM.

IT RETURNED IN FULL MEASURE, HOWEVER, IN THE FOLLOWING MORN-  
ING, THE ATMOSPHERE IN THE SCHOOL WAS ONE OF GREAT TENSION AND

EXCITEMENT, LESSONS WERE THE STOP AT MIDDAY, GIVING ALL THE STUD-  
ENTS TIME TO GET DOWN TO THE DRAGONS' ENCLOSURE. THOUGH IF

COURSE, THEY DIDN'T YET KNOW WHAT THEY WOULD FIND THERE.

HARRY FELT HOBBY SEPARATE FROM EVERYONE AROUND HIM,

WHETHER THEY WERE WISHING HIM GOOD LUCK OR MISSING. HE'LL

HAVE A BOX OF TISSUES READY, BETTER. AS HE PASSED, IT WAS A STATE OF

NERVOUSNESS HE ADVANCED THAT HE WONDERED WHETHER HE MIGHT-  
N'T JUST KEEP HIS HEAD DOWN WHEN THEY TRIED TO LEAD HIM OUT THE

DRAGON, AND START TRYING TO CLIMB EVERYONE IN SIGHT.

TIME WAS BEHAVING IN A MORE PECULIAR FASHION THAN EVER,

WISHING FAST IN GREAT DELAYS, HE THAT ONE MOMENT HE SEEMED

TO BE SITTING DOWN IN HIS FIRST LESSON, HISTORY OF MAGIC, AND THE

NEXT, WALKING INTO LUNCH ... AND THEN WHERE WAS THE MORNING

GENE? THE LAST OF THE DRAGON-FREE YEARS? PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL

WAS HURRYING OVER TO HIM IN THE GREAT HALL, LOTS OF PEOPLE  
WERE WATCHING.

BETTER, THE CHAMPIONS HAVE TO COME DOWN INTO THE GREENS  
NOW ... YOU HAVE TO GET READY FOR YOUR FIRST TASK.

EEK, SAID HARRY, STANDING UP, HIS FEET FALLING ONTO HIS PLATE  
WITH A CLATTER.

GOOD LUCK, HARRY, HERMIONE WHISPERED. YOU'LL BE FINE!

Yeah, said Harry, in a voice that was most unlike his own. He left the Great Hall with Professor McGonagall. She didn't seem herself, either; in fact, she looked nearly as anxious as Hermione. As she walked him down the stone steps and held him the cold November afternoon, she put her hand on his shoulder.

Don't panic, she said, just keep a cool head ... we've got wizards on hand to control the situation if it gets out of hand ... the main thing is just to be well rested, and nobody will think any the worse of you ... are you all right?

## THE FIRST TASK BEGINS

Yes, Harry heard himself say. Yes, I'm fine.

She was leading him towards the place where the dragons were, around the edge of the forest, but when they approached the clump of trees behind which the enclosure would be clearly visible, Harry saw that a tent had been erected, its entrance facing them, screening the dragons from view.

You're to be in here with the other champions, said Professor McGonagall, in a rather shady sort of voice, and wait for your turn, better. Mr Bagman is in there ... he'll be telling you the procedure ... Good luck.

Thanks, said Harry, in a flat, distant voice. She left him at the entrance of the tent. Harry went inside.

Fleur Delacour was sitting in a corner on a low wooden stool. She didn't look nearly as composed as Lysia, but rather pale and clammy. Victor Krum looked even slier than Lysia,

WHICH HARRY SUPPOSED WAS HIS WAY OF STEELING NERVES. CEDRIC WAS PACING UP AND DOWN. WHEN HARRY ENTERED, HE GAVE HIM A SMALL SMILE, WHICH HARRY RETURNED, FEELING THE MUSCLES IN HIS FACE WORKING RATHER HARD, AS THOUGH THEY HAD FORGOTTEN HOW TO DO IT.

HARRY: GOOD! HE SAID BAGMAN HAPPILY, LEERING AROUND AT HIM. COME IN, COME IN, MAKE YOURSELF AT HOME!

BAGMAN LOOKED SURPRISED LIKE A SLIGHTLY HYPERBOLIC CARTOON FIGURE, STANDING AMID ALL THE PALE-FACED CHAMPIONS. HE WAS WEARING HIS OLD WAST BELLS AGAIN.

WELL, NOW WE'RE ALL HERE TIME TO FILL YOUR IN! SAID BAGMAN BRIGHTLY. WHEN THE AUDIENCE HAS ASSEMBLED, I'M GOING TO BE OFFERING EACH OF YOU THIS BAG HE HELD UP A SMALL SACK OF PURPLE SILK, AND STRODE IT AT THEM FROM WHICH YOU WILL EACH SELECT A SMALL MODEL OF THE THING YOU ARE ABOUT TO FACE! THERE ARE DIFFERENT ER VARIETIES, YOU SEE, AND I HAVE TO TELL YOU SOMETHING ELSE TOO ... AH, YES ... YOUR TASK IS TO COLLECT THE CHILDREN TOO!

HARRY GLANCED AROUND. CEDRIC HAD NODDED ONCE, HE SEEMED THAT HE UNDERSTOOD BAGMAN'S WORDS, AND THEN STARTED PACING

FOR HARRY PENTTER

AROUND THE TENT AGAIN! HE LOOKED SLIGHTLY GREEN. FLEUR DELACOUR AND KRWIM HADN'T REACTED AT ALL. PERHAPS THEY THOUGHT THEY MIGHT BE SICK IF THEY OPENED THEIR MOUTHS! THAT WAS CERTAINLY HOW HARRY FELT. BUT THEY, AT LEAST, HAD VOLUNTEERED FOR THIS ... AND IN NO TIME AT ALL, HUNDREDS UPON HUNDREDS OF PAIRS OF

FEET COULD BE HEARD PASSING THE TENT, THEIR OWNERS TALKING EXCITEDLY, LAUGHING, JEERING ... HARRY FELT AS SEPARATE FROM THE CROWD

AS IF THEY WERE A DIFFERENT SPECIES, AND THEN IT FELT ABOUT A SECOND LATER THE HARRY BAGMAN WAS OPENING THE NECK OF THE PURPLE SILK SACK.

LADIES FIRST, HE SAID, OFFERING IT THE FLEUR DELACHUR. SHE PUT A SHADING HAND INSIDE THE BAG, AND DREW OUT A TINY, PERFECT MODEL OF A DRAGON - A WELSH GREEN. IT HAD THE NUMBER THREE ABOUT ITS NECK, AND HARRY KNEW, BY THE FACT THAT FLEUR

SHOWED NO SIGN OF SURPRISE, BUT RATHER A DETERMINED RESIGNATION, THAT HE HAD BEEN RIGHT: MADAME MAXIME HAD TOLD HER

WHAT WAS COMING.

THE SAME FIELD TALK HER DREAM, HE PULLED OUT THE SCARLET CHINESE FIREBALL. IT HAD A NUMBER THREE ABOUT ITS NECK. HE DIDN'T EVEN BLINK, JUST STARED AT THE CROWD.

LEBRIC PUT HIS HAND INTO THE BAG, AND OUT CAME THE BLUEISH-GRAY SWEDISH SHEET-SNEET, THE NUMBER ONE TIED ABOUT ITS

NECK. DREAMING WHAT WAS LEFT, HARRY PUT HIS HAND INTO THE SILK BAG, AND PULLED OUT THE HUNGARIAN HERNTAIL, AND THE NUMBER FOUR. IT STRETCHED ITS WINGS AS HE LOOKED DOWN AT IT, AND BARED ITS MINUSCULE FANGS.

WELL, THERE YOU ARE? SAID BAGMAN. YOU HAVE EACH PULLED OUT  
THE DRAGON YOU WILL FACE, AND THE NUMBERS REFER TO THE ORDER IN  
WHICH YOU ARE TO TAKE ON THE DRAGONS, DO YOU SEE? NOW, I'M

GOING TO HAVE TO LEAVE YOU IN A MOMENT, BECAUSE I'M COMMENT-  
TATING. MR BIGGERS, YOU'RE FIRST, JUST GO OUT INTO THE ENCLOSURE

WHEN YOU HEAR A WHISTLE, ALL RIGHT? NOW ... HARRY ... COULD I  
HAVE A QUICK WORD? ELTISIDE?

ER ... YES, SAID HARRY BLANDLY, AND HE GOT UP AND WENT OUT  
OF THE TENT WITH BAGMAN, WHO WALKED HIM A SHORT WAY AWAY,

THE FIRST TASK WAS

INTO THE TREES, AND THEN TURNED TO HIM WITH A FATHERLY EXPRES-  
SION ON HIS FACE.

FEELING ALL RIGHT, HARRY? ANYTHING I CAN GET YOU?

WHAT? SAID HARRY, I ... NEH, NOTHING.

GET A PLAN? SAID BAGMAN, WHISPERING HIS WHISKER CONSPIRATORIAL-  
LY, BECAUSE I DON'T MIND SHARING A FEW POINTERS, IF YOU'D LIKE

THEM, YOU KNOW, I MEAN, BAGMAN CONTINUED, WHISPERING HIS

WHISKER STILL FURTHER, YOU'RE THE LINGERING HERE, HARRY ... ANY-  
THING I CAN DO TO HELP ...

NHE, SAID F-JARRY, SHE BELIEVEDLY HE KNEW HE HAD SHOWNED RIDE,

NHE I I VE DECIDED WHAT I M GOING TO DO, THANKS,

NHEEDY WOULD KNOW, F-JARRY, SAID RAGMAN, WINKING AT HIM,

NHE, I M FINE, SAID F-JARRY, WONDERING WHY HE KEPT TELLING  
PEOPLE THIS, AND WONDERING WHETHER HE HAD EVER BEEN LESS FINE.

I VE GOT A PLAN WORKED OUT, I

A WHISTLE HAD BEEN SHOWN HERE,

GOOD LORD, I VE GOT THE PLAN, SAID RAGMAN IN ALARM, AND HE  
HURRIED OFF,

F-JARRY WALKED BACK TO THE TENT, AND SAW CEDRIC EMERGING  
FROM IT, GREENER THAN EVER. F-JARRY TRIED TO WISH HIM GOOD AS HE  
WALKED PAST, BUT ALL THAT CAME OUT OF HIS MOUTH WAS A SHORT OF  
HORSE CRY.

F-JARRY WENT BACK INSIDE THE FLUR AND DRLIN. SECONDS LATER,  
THEY HEARD THE SOUND OF THE CRY, WHICH MEANT CEDRIC HAD  
ENTERED THE ENCLOSURE, AND WAS NOW FACE TO FACE WITH THE LIVING  
COUNTERPART OF HIS MIRROR ...

IT WAS WORSE THAN F-JARRY COULD EVER HAVE IMAGINED, SITTING  
THERE AND LISTENING. THE CRY SCREAMED ... YELLED ... GASPED  
LIKE A SINGLE MANY-HEADED ENTITY, AS CEDRIC DID WHATEVER HE  
WAS DOING TO GET PAST THE SWEDISH SHORT-SNEET. DRLIN  
WAS STILL STARING AT THE CRY, FLUR HAD NOW TAKEN THE  
RETRACING CEDRIC S STEPS, BEHIND AND BEHIND THE TENT. AND  
RAGMAN S COMMENTARY MADE EVERYTHING MUCH, MUCH  
WORSE ... TERRIBLE PICTURES FORMED IN F-JARRY S MIND, AS HE  
HEARD: HEHE, NARROW MISS THERE, VERY NARROW ... HE S TAKING

ROO HARRY PTTTTT

RISKS, THIS ONE? ... CLEVER MOVE PITY IT DIDN'T WORK!

AND THEN, AFTER ABOUT FIFTEEN MINUTES, HARRY HEARD THE DRAWING REAR THAT COULD MEAN ONLY ONE THING: CEDRIC HAD GOTTEN PAST

HIS DRAGON, AND SEIZED THE GOLDEN EGG.

VERY GOOD INDEED! BAGMAN WAS SCHEMING. AND WHEN THE MARKS FROM THE ILDGES?

BUT HE DIDN'T SCHEM! HE! THE MARKS! HARRY SLIPPED THE ILDGES WERE HOLDING THEM UP AND SCHEMING THEM TO THE CROWD.

ONE DOWN, THREE TO GO! BAGMAN YELLED, AS THE WHISTLE BLEW AGAIN. MISS DELACOUR, IF YOU PLEASE!

FLAIR WAS TREMBLING FROM HEAD TO FOOT! HARRY FELT MORE WARMLY TOWARDS HER THAN HE HAD DONE BEFORE, AS SHE LEFT THE TENT WITH HER HEAD HELD HIGH, AND HER HAND CLUTCHING HER WAND. HE AND DURLIN WERE LEFT ALONE, AT OPPOSITE SIDES OF THE TENT, AVOIDING EACH OTHER'S GAZE.

THE SAME PROCESS STARTED AGAIN ... EH, I'M NOT SURE THAT WAS WISE! THEY COULD HEAR BAGMAN SCHEMING CLEARLY. EH ... NEARLY! CAREFUL NOW ... GOOD LORD, I THOUGHT SHE'D HAD IT THEN!

TEN MINUTES LATER, HARRY HEARD THE CROWD ERUPT INTO APPLAUSE ONCE MORE ... FLAIR MUST HAVE BEEN SUCCESSFUL, THEN, A PAUSE, WHILE FLAIR'S MARKS WERE BEING SEEN ... MORE CLAPPING ... THEN, FOR THE THIRD TIME, THE WHISTLE.

AND HERE COMES MR DURLIN! CRIED BAGMAN, AND DURLIN



SLICKED HLT, LEAVING HARRY HLITE ALONE.

HE FELT MUCH MORE ALIVE HP HIS BODY THAN USUAL; VERY ALIVE  
HP THE WAY HIS HEART WAS PUMPING FAST, AND HIS FINGERS TINGLING

WITH FEAR ... YET AT THE SAME TIME, HE SEEMED TO BE HLTSIDE HIM-  
SELF, SEEING THE WALLS HP THE TENT, AND HEARING THE CREWD, AS

THOUGH FROM FAR AWAY ...

VERY DARING! BAGMAN WAS YELLING, AND HARRY HEARD THE  
CHINESE FIREBALL EMIT A TERRIBLE, REARING SHRIEK, WHILE THE

CREWD DREW ITS COLLECTIVE BREATH. THAT S SOME NERVE HE S SEEM-  
ING AND YES, HE S GET THE REG!

APPLAUSE SHATTERED THE WINTER AIR LIKE BREAKING GLASS! DRUM  
HAD FINISHED IT WOULD BE HARRY S TURN AT ANY MOMENT.

THE FIRST TASK KN

HE STEED UP, NOTICING DIMLY THAT HIS LEGS SEEMED TO BE MADE  
HP MARSE-MALLEH. HE WAITED, AND THEN HE HEARD THE WHISTLE  
BLEW. HE WALKED HLT THROUGH THE ENTRANCE HP THE TENT, THE  
PANIC RISING INTO A CRESCENDO INSIDE HIM, AND THEN HE WAS  
WALKING PAST THE TREES, THROUGH A GAP IN THE ENCLOSED FENCE.  
HE SAW EVERYTHING IN FRONT HP HIM AS THOUGH IT WAS A VERY  
HIGHLY CHEERED DREAM. THERE WERE HUNDREDS AND HUNDREDS HP

FACES STARING DOWN AT HIM FROM STANDS WHICH HAD BEEN MAG-

LOCKED THERE SINCE HE'D LAST STOOD IN THIS SPOT, AND THERE WAS

THE FIERNTAIL, AT THE OTHER END OF THE ENCLOSURE, CRELCHED WITH  
EVER HER CLUTCH OF EGGS, HER WINGS HALF FURLED, HER EVIL, YELLOW  
EYES LIPEN HIM, A MENSTRUOUS, SLALY BLACK LIZARD, THRASHING HER  
SPIKED TAIL, LEAVING YARD-DEEP GULCH MARKS IN THE HARD GROUND.  
THE CRELD WAS MAKING A GREAT DEAL OF NOISE, BUT WHETHER  
FRIENDLY OR NOT, FARRY DIDN'T KNOW FOR CURE. IT WAS TIME TO DO  
WHAT HE HAD TO DO ... TO FILL HIS MIND, ENTIRELY AND ABSOLUTELY,  
UPON THE THING THAT WAS HIS ONLY CHANCE ...

HE RAISED HIS HAND,

ALLIEN FIREBOLT! HE SHOUTED,

HE WAITED, EVERY FIBRE OF HIM BEATING, PRAYING ... IF IT HADN'T  
WORKED ... IF IT WASN'T COMING ... HE SEEMED TO BE LOOKING AT  
EVERYTHING AROUND HIM THROUGH SOME SORT OF SHIMMERING,  
TRANSPARENT BARRIER, LIKE A HEAT HAZE, WHICH MADE THE ENCLOSURE  
AND THE HUNDREDS OF FACES AROUND HIM SEEM STRANGELY ...  
AND THEN HE HEARD IT, SPEEDING THROUGH THE AIR BEHIND HIM!  
HE TURNED AND SAW HIS FIREBOLT FLUTTERING TOWARDS HIM AROUND

THE EDGE OF THE WINGS, SHARING INTO THE ENCLOSURE, AND STOP-  
PING DEAD IN MID-AIR BESIDE HIM, WAITING FOR HIM TO REPLY,

THE CRELD WAS MAKING EVEN MORE NOISE ... BAGMAN WAS SHOUT-  
ING SOMETHING ... BUT FARRY'S EARS WERE NOT WORKING PROPERLY  
ANY MORE ... LISTENING WASN'T IMPORTANT ...

HE SWUNG HIS LEG OVER THE GRIND, AND KICKED OFF FROM  
THE GRIND, AND A SECOND LATER, SOMETHING MIRACULOUS  
HAPPENED ...

AS HE SHARED UPWARDS, AS THE WIND BLISTED THROUGH HIS HAIR,

AND HARRY PETER

AS THE GRIND'S FACES BECAME MORE FLESH-COLOURED PINPRICKS  
BEHIND, AND THE FRONTAIL STRANDS THE THE SIZE OF A DHC, HE REALISED  
THAT HE HAD LEFT BEHIND ONLY THE GRIND BEHIND, BUT ALSO HIS FEAR  
... HE WAS BACK WHERE HE BELONGED ...

THIS WAS JUST ANOTHER FLIDDITCH MATCH, THAT WAS ALL ... JUST  
ANOTHER FLIDDITCH MATCH, AND THAT FRONTAIL WAS JUST ANOTHER  
NEWLY EMERGING TEAM ...

HE WHIRLED DOWN AT THE CLUTCH OF EGGS, AND SPOTTED THE GRIND  
HIDE, CLAMPING AGAINST ITS CEMENT-COLOURED PELLEWS, RESIDING  
SAFELY BETWEEN THE DRAGON'S FRONT LEGS. HED, HARRY TOLD HIMSELF,  
DIVERSITY TACTICS ... LET'S GO ...

HE DIVED, THE FRONTAIL'S HEAD FOLLOWED HIM; HE KNEW WHAT  
IT WAS GOING TO DO, AND PULLED HIMSELF UP THE DIVE JUST IN TIME; A LOT  
OF FIRE HAD BEEN RELEASED EXACTLY WHERE HE WOULD HAVE BEEN  
HAD HE NOT SWERVED AWAY ... BUT HARRY DIDN'T CARE ... THAT WAS  
NOT MORE THAN DODGING A BLUNDER ...

GREAT SCOTT, HE CAN FLY? YELLED BAGMAN, AS THE GRIND  
SHRIEKED AND GASPED. ARE YOU WATCHING THIS, MR DRAGON?

HARRY SHARED HIGHER IN A CIRCLE; THE FRONTAIL WAS STILL FOLLOWING  
HIS PROGRESS; ITS HEAD REVOLVING IN ITS LONG NECK IF HE KEPT

THIS LIP, IT WOULD BE NICELY DIZZY BUT BETTER NOT PUSH IT TOO  
LONG, OR IT WOULD BE BREATHING FIRE AGAIN

HARRY PLUMMETED JUST AS THE FHERNTAIL OPENED ITS MOUTH, BUT  
THIS TIME HE WAS LESS LUCKY HE MISSED THE FLAMES, BUT THE TAIL  
CAME WHIPPING UP TO MEET HIM INSTEAD, AND AS HE SWERVED TO  
THE LEFT, ONE OF THE LONG SPIKES GRAZED HIS SHOULDER, RIPPING HIS  
MEAT

HE COULD FEEL IT STINGING, HE COULD HEAR SCREAMING AND  
GRIANS FROM THE CROWD, BUT THE CUT DIDN'T SEEM TOO DEEP ...

THEN HE ZOOMED AROUND THE BACK OF THE FHERNTAIL, AND A POSSI-  
BILITY OCCURRED TO HIM ...

THE FHERNTAIL DIDN'T SEEM TO WANT TO TAKE HER, SHE WAS TOO  
PROTECTIVE OF HER EGGS. THOUGH SHE WRITHED AND TWISTED, FLURRING  
AND UNFLURRING HER WINGS AND KEEPING THOSE FEARFUL YELLOW  
EYES ON HARRY, SHE WAS AFRAID TO MOVE TOO FAR FROM THEM ... BUT

THE FIRST TASK WAS

HE HAD TO PERSUADE HER TO DO IT, OR HE'D NEVER GET NEAR THEM ...  
THE TRICK WAS TO DO IT CAREFULLY, GRADUALLY ...

HE BEGAN TO FLY, FIRST THIS WAY, THEN THE OTHER, NOT NEAR

ENOUGH TO MAKE HER BREATHE FIRE TO STAY HIM OFF, BUT STILL POS-  
ING A SUFFICIENT THREAT TO ENSURE SHE KEPT HER EYES ON HIM, FOR

HEAD SWAYED THIS WAY AND THAT, WATCHING HIM BLIT UP THESE  
VERTICAL PUPILS, HER FANGS BARED ...

HE FLEW HIGHER, THE SCORPION'S HEAD RISE WITH HIM, HER NECK  
NECK STRETCHED TO ITS FULLEST EXTENT, STILL SWAYING, LIKE A SNAKE  
BEFORE ITS CHARMER ...

HARRY RISE A FEW MORE FEET, AND SHE LET BLIT A RICH OF EXASPER-  
ATION, HE WAS LIKE A FLY TO HER, A FLY SHE WAS LINGERING THE SWAT;

HER TAIL THRASHED AGAIN, BLIT HE WAS THEN HIGH THE REACH NECK ...  
SHE SHOT FIRE INTO THE AIR, WHICH HE DODGED ... HER JAWS OPENED  
WIDE ...

COME ON, HARRY HISSED, SWERVING TANTALISINGLY ABOVE HER,

COME ON, COME AND GET ME ... UP YOU GET, NECK ...

AND THEN SHE REARED, SPREADING HER GREAT BLACK LEATHERY  
WINGS AT LAST, AS WIDE AS THESE OF A SMALL AIRPLANE AND HARRY  
DIVED, BEFORE THE DRAGON KNEW WHAT HE HAD DONE, HE WHERE HE  
HAD DISAPPEARED THE, HE WAS SPEEDING TOWARDS THE GROUND AS  
FAST AS HE COULD GO, TOWARDS THE EGGS NECK UNPROTECTED BY HER  
CLAWED, FRONT LEGS HE HAD TAKEN HIS HANDS OFF HIS FIREHEAT  
HE HAD SEIZED THE CHILDREN EGG

AND WITH A FLICK OF SPEED, HE WAS OFF, HE WAS SHARING  
BLIT OVER THE STANDS, THE HEAVY EGG SAFELY UNDER HIS UNINJURED  
ARM, AND IT WAS AS THOUGH SOMEONE HAD JUST TURNED THE  
WHEELS BACK UP FOR THE FIRST TIME, HE BECAME PROPERLY AWARE

OF THE NOISE OF THE WHEELS, WHICH WAS SCREAMING AND APPLAUD-

ING AS LEBLBY AS THE IRISH SLIPPHTERS AT THE WERLD CLIP

LEED AT THAT? RAGMAN WAS YELLING. WILL YELL LEED AT THAT?  
ELUR YELNGEST CHAMPION IS ELICKEST THE GET HIS EGG? WELL, THIS IS  
GEMING THE SEHRTEN THE HDS HN MR PETHER?

HARRY SAW THE DRAGEN-KEEPPERS RUSHING PERWARDS THE SLIDLE  
THE FHERNTAIL, AND, EVER AT THE ENTRANCE THE THE ENCLIESLIRE,

RIZ HARRY PETHER

PROFESSOR MCGHAGALL, PROFESSOR MHHY AND HAGRID HURRYING  
THE MEET HIM, ALL OF THEM WAVING HIM THEWARDS THEM, THEIR  
SMILES EVIDENT EVEN FROM THIS DISTANCE. HE FLEW BACK EVER THE  
STANDS, THE NEISE OF THE CREED PHLNDING HIS CARDOLMS, AND  
CAME IN SPEETHLY THE LAND, HIS HEART LIGHTER THAN IT HAD BEEN IN  
WEEKS ... HE HAD GHT THROUGH THE FIRST TASK, HE HAD SURVIVED ...

THAT WAS EXCELLENT, PETHER? CRIED PROFESSOR MCGHAGALL AS  
HE GHT OFF THE FIREHILT WHICH FROM HER WAS EXTRAVAGANT  
PRAISE. HE NOTICED THAT HER HAND SEHED AS SHE POINTED AT HIS  
SHULDER. YELL LL NEED THE SEE MADAM PEMFREY BEFORE THE ILDEES  
GIVE ELIT YELUR SCHE ... EVER THERE, SHE S HAD THE MHP UP DICCHY  
ALREADY ...

YEH DID IT, HARRY? SAID HAGRID EHARSELV. YEH DID IT? AN  
AGAINS THE FHERNTAIL AN ALL, AN YEH DONEW CHARLIE SAID THAT WAS  
THE WERS

THANKS, HAGRID, SAID HARRY LEBLBY, SEE THAT HAGRID WELLDEN T  
ELLINDER HN AND REVEAL THAT HE HAD SEHN HARRY THE DRAGENS  
REPERRE-LAND,

PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL SMILED VERY PLEASED, THEN, HIS MAGICAL EYE WAS DANKING IN ITS SHEET,

NICE AND EASY DOES THE TRICK, PETER, HE GRIELED,

RIGHT THEN, PETER, THE FIRST-AID TENT, PLEASE ... SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL,

HARRY WALKED OUT OF THE ENCLOSURE, STILL PANTING, AND SAW

MADAM POMFREY STANDING AT THE MOUTH OF A SECOND TENT, WHISKING WHIRLED,

DRAGONS? SHE SAID, IN A DISGUSTED TONE, PULLING HARRY INSIDE. THE TENT WAS DIVIDED INTO CUBICLES; HE COULD MAKE OUT CEDRIC'S SHADOW THROUGH THE CANVAS, BUT CEDRIC DIDN'T SEEM TOO BADLY INJURED; HE WAS SITTING UP, AT LEAST. MADAM POMFREY EXAMINED HARRY'S SHOULDER, TALKING FLIRTILY ALL THE WHILE. LAST YEAR DEMENTORS, THIS YEAR DRAGONS, WHAT ARE THEY GOING TO BRING INTO THE SCHOOL NEXT? YOU'RE VERY LUCKY ... THIS IS WHITE SHALLER ... IT LL NEED CLEANING BEFORE I HEAL IT UP, THOUGH ... SHE CLEANED THE CUT WITH A DAB OF SOME PURPLE LIQUID WHICH

THE FIRST TASTE KICK

SMOKED AND STUNG, BUT THEN PRESSED HIS SHOULDER WITH HER WAND, AND HE FELT IT HEAL INSTANTLY,

WELL, JUST SIT QUIETLY FOR A MINUTE SIT? AND THEN YOU CAN GO AND GET YOUR SHARE,

SHE WHISTLED OUT OF THE TENT AND HE HEARD HER GO NEXT DOOR AND SAY, HOW DOES IT FEEL NOW, DIDDY?

HARRY DIDN'T WANT TO SIT STILL; HE WAS STILL FULL OF ADRENALINE. HE GOT TO HIS FEET, WANTING TO SEE WHAT WAS GOING ON OUTSIDE, BUT BEFORE HE'D REACHED THE MOUTH OF THE TENT, TWO PEOPLE

HAD COME DARTING INSIDE. HERMIONE, FOLLOWED CLOSELY BY RON,

HARRY, THEY WERE BRILLIANT! HERMIONE SAID SERIOUSLY, THERE

WERE FINGERNAIL MARKS ON HER FACE WHERE SHE HAD BEEN CLUTCHING IT IN FEAR. THEY WERE AMAZING! THEY REALLY WERE!

BUT HARRY WAS LOOKING AT RON, WHO WAS VERY WHITE, AND STARING AT HARRY AS THOUGH HE WAS A GHOST.

HARRY, HE SAID, VERY SERIOUSLY, WHATEVER PUT YOUR NAME IN THAT BOOK? I REMEMBER THEY'RE TRYING TO DO YOU IN!

IT WAS AS THOUGH THE LAST FEW WEEKS HAD NEVER HAPPENED. AS THOUGH HARRY WAS MEETING RON FOR THE FIRST TIME, RIGHT AFTER HE'D BEEN MADE CHAMPION.

CAUGHT ON, HAVE YOU? SAID HARRY CALMLY. THESE THEY WERE ENOUGH.

HERMIONE STOOD NERVOUSLY BETWEEN THEM, LOOKING FROM ONE TO THE OTHER. RON OPENED HIS MOUTH UNCERTAINLY. HARRY KNEW RON WAS ABOUT TO APPEAL AND, SUDDENLY, HE FELT HE DIDN'T NEED TO HEAR IT.

IT'S OK, HE SAID, BEFORE RON COULD GET THE WORDS OUT. FORGET IT.



NEE, SAID REEN, I SHOULDNT VE

FORGOT IT, HARRY SAID,

REEN GRINNED NERVELISLY AT HIM, AND HARRY GRINNED BACK,

HERMIONE BURST INTO TEARS,

THERE S SOMETHING THE CRY ABOUT? HARRY TOLD HER, BEMUSED,

WELL THEY ARE SHE STUPID? SHE SCOLTED, STAMPING HER FEET IN  
THE GRASS, TEARS SPLASHING DOWN HER FRONT, THEN, BEFORE EITHER

219 HARRY POTTTER

HE THEM COULD STOP HER, SHE HAD GIVEN BOTH OF THEM A HUG, AND  
DASHED AWAY, NEARLY POSITIVELY BEHIND,

BARING, SAID REEN, SHAKING HIS HEAD, HARRY, I MEAN, THEY LL  
BE PUTTING UP THEIR SHOULDERS ...

PICKING UP THE GOLDEN EGG AND HIS FIREWHEEL, FEELING MORE

ELATED THAN HE WOULD HAVE BELIEVED POSSIBLE AN HOUR AGO,

HARRY CLOSED EYES IN THE TENT, REEN BY HIS SIDE, TALKING FAST,

WELL WERE THE BEST, WELL KNOW, THE COMPETITION, CEDRIC DID  
THIS WEIRD THING WHERE HE TRANSFIGURED A ROCK IN THE GRASS  
... TURNED IT INTO A DIE ... HE WAS TRYING TO MAKE THE DRAGON CH  
FOR THE DIE INSTEAD OF HIM, WELL, IT WAS A PRETTY GOOD BIT OF  
TRANSFIGURATION, AND IT SEEMED TO WORK, BECAUSE HE DID GET THE  
EGG, BUT HE GOT BURNED AS WELL THE DRAGON CHANGED ITS MIND  
HALFWAY THROUGH AND DECIDED IT WOULD RATHER HAVE HIM THAN  
THE LADDER, HE ONLY JUST GOT AWAY, AND THAT FLEET GIRL TRIED  
THIS SORT OF CHARM, I THINK SHE WAS TRYING TO PUT IT INTO A TRANCE

WELL, THAT KIND OF WORKED, THEN, IT WENT ALL SLEEPY, BUT THEN IT  
SNORED, AND THIS GREAT LOT OF FLAME SHEET EYES, AND HER SKIRT

CALIGHT FIRE SHE PLIT IT HLIT WITH A KIT HP WATER HLIT HP HER HAND,  
AND DRLM YELI WHEN T BELIYE THIS, BLIT HE DIDN T EVEN THIND HP  
FLYING! HE WAS PROBABLY THE BEST AFTER YELI, THOUGH, HIT IT WITH

SOME SORT HP SPELL RIGHT IN THE EYE, ENLY THING IS, IT WENT TRAM-  
PLING ARELIND IN AGHNY AND SHLASHED HALP THE REAL EGGS THEY

THEED MARKS HPF FHR THAT, HE WASN T SLIPPESSED THE DEE ANY DAMAGE  
THE THEM.

REHN DREW BREATH AS HE AND HARRY REACHED THE EDGE HP THE  
ENCLOSURE, NHEW THAT THE FHERNTAIL HAD BEEN TAKEN AWAY, HARRY  
CHELD SEE WHERE THE FIVE ILDGES WERE SITTING RIGHT AT THE EITHER  
END, IN RAISED SEATS DRAPED IN CHLD.

IT S MARKS HLIT HP TEN FROM EACH ONE, REHN SAID, AND HARRY,  
SHLINTING LIP THE FIELD, SAW THE FIRST ILDGE MADAME MARIME

RAISE HER HAND IN THE AIR, WHAT LHEEED LIKE A LENE, SILVER RIE-  
REEN SHEET HLIT HP IT, WHICH TWISTED ITSELF INTN A LARGE FIGURE EIGHT.

NEXT RAD! SAID REHN, AS THE CRELD APPLAIED, I SLIPPESSE SHE  
THEED MARKS HPF FHR YELIR SHLULDER ...

THE FIRST TADK KLS

MR CRELICH CAME NEXT, HE SHEET A NIMPER NINE INTN THE AIR.

LEHHING CHHD! REHN YELLED, THLIMPING HARRY HN THE BACK,  
NEXT, DLMLEDHRE, HE, THEE, PLIT LIP A NINE, THE CRELD WERE  
CHERRING HARDER THAN EVER.

ELIOTH RAGMAN TEN.

TEN? SAID HARRY IN DISBELIEF, BUT ... I GOT HURT ... WHAT IS HE PLAYING AT?

HARRY, DIDN'T COMPLAIN? RON YELLED EXCITEDLY.

AND WHEN KARDAREFF RAISED HIS WAND, HE PALSED HER A MOMENT, AND THEN A SILVER SHEET FLEW OFF HIS WAND, THEN FLEW,

WHAT? RON BELIEVED FLUTTERINGLY, FLEW? WELL HELLY KASSED SLIMKAS, WELL GAVE DRUM TEN?

BUT HARRY DIDN'T CARE, HE WOULDN'T HAVE CARED IF KARDAREFF HAD GIVEN HIM ZERO; RON'S INDIGNATION WHEN HIS RE-TAIL WAS WORTH-ABEHLT A HUNDRED POINTS TO HIM, HE DIDN'T TELL RON THIS, HE CHLWASE, BUT HIS HEART FELT LIGHTER THAN AIR AS HE TURNED THE LEAVE THE ENCLOSURE, AND IT WASN'T ILIST RON ... THESE WEREN'T ONLY GRYFFINDERS CHEERING IN THE CROWD, WHEN IT HAD COME TO IT, WHEN THEY HAD SEEN WHAT HE WAS FACING, MUST BE THE SCHEHL HAD BEEN ON HIS SIDE, AS WELL AS CEDRIC'S ... HE DIDN'T CARE ABEHLT THE SLYTHERINS, HE WOULD STAND WHATEVER THEY THREW AT HIM NOW.

WELL HE TIED IN FIRST PLACE, HARRY? WELL AND DRUM? SAID CHARLIE WEASLEY, FLIRTING THE MEET THEM AS THEY SET OFF BACK TOWARDS THE SCHEHL, LISTEN, I'VE GOT THE RUM, I'VE GOT THE GEM AND SEND MUM AN HELL, I SWORE I'D TELL HER WHAT HAPPENED BUT THAT WAS UNBELIEVABLE? HE-YEAH AND THEY TOLD ME TO TELL WELL WELL I'VE GOT THE HANG ABELING HER A FEW MORE MINUTES ... RAGMAN WANTS A WHARD, BACK IN THE CHAMPIONS TENT.

RON SAID HE WOULD WAIT, SEE HARRY RE-ENTERED THE TENT, WHICH SOMEHOW LOOKED COMPLETELY DIFFERENT NOW; FRIENDLY AND WELCOMING, HE THOUGHT BACK THE FEEL HE'D FELT WHILE HIDING THE THIRTAIL,

AND COMPARED IT TO THE LONG WAIT BEFORE HE'D WALKED UP TO THE FACE

IT ... THERE WAS NO COMPARISON, THE WAIT HAD BEEN IMMEASUR-  
ABLY WORSE.

FLOR, CEDRIC AND DRAGON ALL CAME IN TOGETHER.

THE HARRY POTION

THE SIDE OF CEDRIC'S FACE WAS COVERED IN A THICK ORANGE  
PASTE, WHICH WAS PRESUMABLY MENDING HIS SKIN. HE GRINNED AT  
HARRY WHEN HE SAW HIM. COME HERE, HARRY.

AND YELL, SAID HARRY, GRINNING BACK.

WELL DONE, ALL OF YOU! SAID BLOOD BAGMAN, EMERGING INTO THE  
TENT, AND BEHAVING AS PLEASED AS IF HE PERSONALLY HAD JUST  
GOT PAST A DRAGON. NOW, JUST A FEW MORE WORDS. YOU'VE GOT A  
NICE LONG BREAK BEFORE THE SECOND TASK, WHICH WILL TAKE PLACE AT  
HALF PAST NINE IN THE MORNING OF FEBRUARY THE TWENTY-FOURTH

BUT WE'RE GIVING YOU SOMETHING TO THINK ABOUT IN THE MEAN-  
TIME! IF YOU LOOK DOWN AT THESE GOLDEN EGGS YOU'RE ALL HOLDING,

YOU WILL SEE THAT THEY OPEN ... SEE THE HINGES THERE? YOU NEED  
TO SHAKE THE CLIP INSIDE THE EGG BECAUSE IT WILL TELL YOU WHAT  
THE SECOND TASK IS, AND ENABLE YOU TO PREPARE FOR IT! ALL CLEAR?  
SURE? WELL, OFF YOU GO, THEN!

HARRY LEFT THE TENT, REJOINED RON, AND THEY STARTED TO WALK  
BACK ALONG THE EDGE OF THE FOREST, TALKING HARD. HARRY WANTED

THE HEAR WHAT THE OTHER CHAMPIONS HAD DONE IN MORE DETAIL.  
THEN, AS THEY REUNDED THE CLUMP OF TREES BEHIND WHICH HARRY  
HAD FIRST HEARD THE DRAGONS REAR, A WITCH LEAPT OUT FROM BEHIND  
THEM.

IT WAS RITA SKEETER. SHE WAS WEARING ACID-GREEN ROBES TODAY;  
THE FLICK-FLUTES FLUTE IN HER HAND BLENDED PERFECTLY AGAINST  
THEM.

CONGRATULATIONS, HARRY! SHE SAID, BEAMING AT HIM. I WON-  
DER IF YOU COULD GIVE ME A FLICK FLUTE? SHELL YOU FEEL FACING

THAT DRAGON? SHELL YOU FEEL NEAR ABOUT THE FAIRNESS OF THE  
SCORING?

YEAH, YOU CAN HAVE A FLUTE, SAID HARRY SAVAGELY. CHEERUP.  
AND HE SET OFF BACK TO THE CASTLE WITH RON.

## CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE

### THE FLICK-FLUTE LIBERATION

#### PRESENT

HARRY, RON AND HERMIONE WENT UP TO THE HOLEY THAT EVENING  
TO FIND PIGWIDGEEHN, SEE THAT HARRY COULD SEND SIRIUS A LETTER,  
TELLING HIM THAT HE HAD MANAGED TO GET PAST HIS DRAGON  
LINES. IN THE WAY, HARRY FILLED RON IN ON EVERYTHING  
SIRIUS HAD TOLD HIM ABOUT DADAHOOD. THOUGH SHEERED AT FIRST

THE HEAR THAT RABBARREFF HAD BEEN A DEATH LATER, BY THE TIME THEY ENTERED THE HILLERY REIN WAS SAYING THAT THEY MIGHT THE HAVE SUSPECTED IT ALL ALONG.

FITS, DOESN'T IT? HE SAID, REMEMBER WHAT MALFEY SAID WHEN THE TRAIN, ABOUT HIS DAD BEING FRIENDS WITH RABBARREFF? WHEN WE

KNOW WHERE THEY KNOW EACH OTHER, THEY WERE PROBABLY JOINING AROUND IN MASKS TOGETHER AT THE WORLD CUP ... I WILL TELL YOU

ONE THING, THOUGH, HARRY, IF IT WAS RABBARREFF WHO PUT YOUR NAME IN THE CHECKET, HE'S GOING TO BE FEELING REALLY STUPID NOW, ISN'T HE? DIDN'T WEIRD, DID IT? YOU ONLY GOT A SCRATCH! COME HERE I WILL DO IT

PICWIDGREN WAS SHE EVER-EXCITED AT THE IDEA OF A DELIVERY, HE WAS FLYING AROUND AND AROUND HARRY'S HEAD, HITTING INCESSANTLY. REIN SNATCHED PICWIDGREN OUT OF THE AIR AND HELD HIM STILL WHILE HARRY ATTACHED THE LETTER TO HIS LEG.

THERE'S NO WAY ANY OF THE OTHER TASKS ARE GOING TO BE THAT DANGEROUS, HOW COULD THEY BE? REIN WENT ON, AS HE CARRIED PICWIDGREN TO THE WINDOW. YOU KNOW WHAT? I RECKON YOU COULD WIN THIS TOURNAMENT, HARRY, I'M SURE.

YES HARRY BETTER

HARRY KNOW THAT REIN WAS ONLY SAYING THIS TO MAKE UP FOR HIS BEHAVIOUR OF THE LAST FEW WEEKS, BUT HE APPRECIATED IT ALL THE SAME. HERMIONE, HOWEVER, LEANT AGAINST THE HILLERY WALL, FLEW HER ARMS AND FREELINED AT REIN.

HARRY'S GET A LONG WAY THE GO BEFORE HE FINISHES THE  
TOURNAMENT, SHE SAID SERIOUSLY. IF THAT WAS THE FIRST TASK, I HATE  
THE THINK WHAT'S COMING NEXT.

RIGHT LITTLE RAY OF SUNSHINE, AREN'T YOU? SAID RON. YOU AND  
PROFESSOR TRILABNEY SHOULD GET TOGETHER SOME TIME.

HE THREW PIGWIDGEEHN INTO THE WINDMILL. PIGWIDGEEHN PLUM-  
METED TWELVE FEET BEFORE MANAGING TO PULL HIMSELF BACK UP

AGAIN; THE LETTER ATTACHED TO HIS LEG WAS MUCH LONGER AND HEAVY-  
IER THAN USUAL. HARRY HADN'T BEEN ABLE TO RESIST GIVING SIRIUS A

BLEE-KY-BLEE ACCIDENT OF EXACTLY HOW HE HAD SURVIVED, CIRCLED  
AND DROGGED THE BURNING TAIL.

THEY WATCHED PIGWIDGEEHN DISAPPEAR INTO THE DARKNESS, AND  
THEN RON SAID, WELL, WE'D BETTER GET DOWNSTAIRS FOR YOUR  
SURPRISE PARTY, HARRY. FRED AND GEORGE SHOULD HAVE NICKED  
ENOUGH FROM THE KITCHENS BY NOW.

SURE ENOUGH, WHEN THEY ENTERED THE GRYFFINDOR COMMON  
ROOM IT EXPLODED WITH CHEERS AND YELLS AGAIN. THERE WERE  
MOUNTAINS OF Cakes AND FLAGONS OF PUMPKIN JUICE AND  
BUTTERBEER ON EVERY SURFACE; LEE JORDAN HAD LET OFF SOME OF  
FIREWORKS AND PARLORS OF FIRE, HOT-START FIREWORKS, SEE THAT THE  
AIR WAS THICK WITH STARS AND SPARKS; AND DEAN THOMAS, WHO  
WAS VERY GOOD AT DRAWING, HAD PUT UP SOME IMPRESSIVE NEW  
BANNERS, MOST OF WHICH DEPICTED HARRY ZOOMING AROUND THE  
BURNING TAIL'S HEAD ON HIS FIREHAT, THROUGH A CLOUD OF

CEBRIC WITH HIS HEAD IN FIRE.

HARRY HELPED HIMSELF THE MEAT; HE HAD ALMOST FORGOTTEN WHAT IT WAS LIKE THE FEEL PROPERLY FLAVORY, AND SAT DOWN WITH BEN AND FERMINE. HE COULDN'T BELIEVE HE'LL HAPPY HE FELT; HE HAD BEEN BACK ON HIS SIDE, HE'D GET THROUGH THE FIRST TASK, AND HE WOULDN'T HAVE THE FACE THE SECOND ONE FOR THREE MONTHS.

BLIMBY, THIS IS HEAVY, SAID LEE JORDAN, PICKING UP THE

THE HEELIST-PLA LITERATURE PRESENT BY

GOLDEN EGG, WHICH HARRY HAD LEFT ON A TABLE, AND WEIGHING IT IN HIS HANDS. WHEN IT, HARRY, GEE HEN? LET'S JUST SEE WHAT'S INSIDE IT?

HE'S SLIPPED THE WORDS OUT THE CLUE ON HIS MIND, FERMINE SAID SLIGHTLY. IT'S IN THE TOURNAMENT RULES ...

I WAS SLIPPED THE WORDS OUT HE'LL THE GET PAST THE DRAGON ON MY MIND, THEN, HARRY MUTTERED, SHE ONLY FERMINE COULD HEAR HIM, AND SHE GRINNED RATHER GUILTY.

YEAH, GEE HEN, HARRY, WHEN IT? SEVERAL PEOPLE ECHEED. LEE PASSED HARRY THE EGG, AND HARRY DUG HIS FINGERNAILS INTO THE GROOVE THAT RAN ALL THE WAY AROUND IT, AND PRISED IT OPEN. IT WAS HOLLOW AND COMPLETELY EMPTY BUT THE MOMENT HARRY OPENED IT, THE MOST HORRIBLE NOISE, A HOWL AND SCREECHING WAILING, FILLED THE ROOM. THE NEAREST THING THE IT HARRY HAD EVER HEARD WAS THE GHOST ORCHESTRA AT NEARLY HEADLESS NICK'S DEATHDAY PARTY, WHEN HAD ALL BEEN PLAYING THE MUSICAL



SAL,

SHUT IT? FRED BELLECHED, HIS HANDS OVER HIS EARS,

WHAT WAS THAT? SAID SEAMUS FINNIGAN, STARING AT THE EGG AS  
HARRY SLAMMED IT SHUT AGAIN. BELINDED LIKE A KANSHER ...

MAYBE YELL YE GET THE GET PAST HENR HP TENSE NEXT, HARRY?

IT WAS SOMEONE BEING THIRTURED? SAID NEVILLE, WHO HAD GONE  
VERY WHITE, AND SPILLED SALISAGE ROLLS OVER THE FLOOR. YELL RE  
GIVING THE HAVE THE FIGHT THE CRUKIATLS CLUSE?

DEEN T BE A PRAT, NEVILLE, THAT S ILLEGAL, SAID GEORGE. THEY  
WHILDN T USE THE CRUKIATLS CLUSE HEN THE CHAMPIONS, I THELIGHT  
IT BELINDED A KIT LIKE PERCY SINGING ... MAYBE YELL YE GET THE  
ATTACK HIM WHILE HE S IN THE SHOWER, HARRY.

WANT A IAM TART, HERMINNE? SAID FRED,

HERMINNE BELINDED DELIGHTFULLY AT THE PLATE HE WAS HEPPERING HER.  
FRED GRINNED.

IT S ALL RIGHT, HE SAID, I HAVEN T DONE ANYTHING THE THEM. IT S  
THE CLUSTARD CREAMS YELL YE GET THE WATCH  
NEVILLE, WHO HAD ILST KITTEN INTHE A CLUSTARD CREAM, CHINDED  
AND SPAT IT HLT.

REN HARRY PHTTER

FRED LAUGHED. ILST MY LITTLE HENR, NEVILLE ...

HERMINNE THEEN A IAM TART.

THEN SHE SAID, DID YELL GET ALL THIS FROM THE KITCHENS, FRED?

YEP, SAID FRED, GRINNING AT HER. HE PLUT HEN A HIGH-PITCHED  
SHLEAK AND IMITATED A FELLSE-ELF. ANYTHING WE CAN GET YELL,  
SIR, ANYTHING AT ALL? THEY RE DEAD HELPAK ... GET ME A REHAST HEN

IF I SAID I WAS PECKISH.

WILL YOU GET IN THERE? HERMINE SAID, IN AN INDIFFERENTLY CASUAL SHORT OF VEHICLE.

EASY, SAID FRED, CONCEALED BEHIND A PAINTING OF A BOWL OF FRUIT. JUST TICKLE THE BEAR, AND IT GIGGLES AND HE STOPPED, AND LOOKED SUSPICIOUSLY AT HER. WHY?

NOTHING, SAID HERMINE BRISKLY.

WHEN THEY TRY AND LEAD THE FISH-OLVES INTO THE STRIKE NETS, ARE YOU? SAID GEORGE. WHEN THEY GIVE UP ALL THE LEAFLET STUFF AND TRY AND STIR THEM UP INTO REBELLION?

SEVERAL PEOPLE CHORTLED. HERMINE DIDN'T ANSWER.

DON'T YOU GET UPSETTING THEM AND TELLING THEM THEY'VE GOT THE TAKE HOMES AND SALARIES? SAID FRED WARNINGLY. YOU'LL PUT THEM OFF THEIR THINKING?

JUST THEN, NEVILLE CAUSED A SLIGHT DIVERSION BY TURNING INTO A LARGE CANARY.

HEY! SHOUT, NEVILLE? FRED SHOUTED, OVER ALL THE LAUGHTER. I HEAR IT IT WAS THE MUSTARD CREAMS WE HAD

WITHIN A MINUTE, HOWEVER, NEVILLE HAD REVERTED, AND SINCE HIS FEATHERS HAD FALLEN OFF, HE REAPPEARED LOOKING ENTIRELY NORMAL. HE EVEN BEGAN TO LAUGH.

CANARY CREAMS? FRED SHOUTED TO THE EXCITABLE CROWD.

GEORGE AND I INVENTED THEM SEVEN SHILLINGS EACH, BARGAIN! IT WAS NEARLY DARK IN THE EVENING WHEN HARRY FINALLY WENT UP TO THE BIRMINGHAM WITH BEN, NEVILLE, SEAMUS AND DEAN. BEFORE HE PULLED THE CURTAINS OF HIS FOUR-POSTER BED, HARRY SET HIS TINY MODEL OF THE HUNGARIAN HERON ON THE TABLE NEXT THE

HIS EYE, WHERE IT PAINED, CLINKED UP AND CLOSED ITS EYES. REALLY,  
HARRY THOUGHT, AS HE PULLED THE HANGINGS IN HIS FUR-ROBE

THE FUR-ROBE OF LIBERATION FRONT 221

CLOSED, HARRY HAD A FEELING ... THEY WERE ALL RIGHT, REALLY,  
DRAGONS ...

\*

THE START OF DECEMBER BRINGING WIND AND SLEET THE HIGHERS,  
DRAGONS THOUGHT THE CASTLE ALWAYS WAS IN WINTER, HARRY WAS  
GLAD OF ITS FIRES AND THICK WALLS EVERY TIME HE PASSED THE  
DURMSTRANG SHIP IN THE LAKE, WHICH WAS PITCHING IN THE HIGH  
WINDS, ITS BLACK SAILS KILLING AGAINST THE DARK SKIES. HE  
THOUGHT THE REALIZATION CARAVAN WAS LIKELY TO BE PRETTY CHILLY,  
THEH, HARRY, HE NOTICED, WAS KEEPING MADAME MAXIME'S Horses  
WELL PROVIDED WITH THEIR PREFERRED DRINK OF SINGLE-MALT WHISKY;  
THE FLAMES BURNING FROM THE THROAT IN THE CORNER OF THEIR  
PADDOCK WERE ENOUGH TO MAKE THE ENTIRE CARR OF MAGICAL  
CREATURES CLASS LIGHT HEADED. THIS WAS UNHELPFUL, AS THEY WERE  
STILL TENDING THE HORRIBLE SKELETONS, AND NEEDED THEIR WITS ABOUT  
THEM.

I M NOT SURE WHETHER THEY HIGHERS ARE NOT, HARRY TOLD THE  
SHIVERING CLASS IN THE WINDY PLIMPTON PATCH NEXT LESSON.

THOUGHT HE D ID TRY AND SEE IF THEY HIGHERS A KIP ... HE D ID  
SETTLE IN DOWN IN THESE SEAS ...

THERE WERE NOW ONLY TEN SKELETONS LEFT; APPARENTLY THEIR

DESIRE THE KILL EACH OTHER HAD NOT BEEN EXERCISED BUT OF THEM,  
EACH OF THEM WAS NOW APPROACHING SIX FEET IN LENGTH. THEIR

THICK GREY ARMOUR, THEIR PHELYRAL, SLITTLING LEGS, THEIR FIRE-  
BLASTING ENDS, THEIR STINGS AND THEIR SLICKERS, COMBINED TO MAKE

THE SKELETS THE MOST REPULSIVE THINGS HARRY HAD EVER SEEN. THE  
CLASS BEHELD DISPIRITEDLY AT THE ENORMOUS KINGS HARRY HAD  
BEHELD BUT, ALL LINED WITH PILLOWS AND FLUFFY BLANKETS.

WE'LL LEAD EM IN HERE, HARRY SAID, AND PUT THE LIDS ON,  
AND WE'LL SEE WHAT HAPPENS.

BUT THE SKELETS, IT TRANSPIRED, DID NOT HIBERNATE, AND DID NOT  
APPRECIATE BEING FORCED INTO PILLOW-LINED KINGS AND NAILED IN.  
HARRY WAS SEEN YELLING DEHN PANIC, NOW, DEHN PANIC! WHILE  
THE SKELETS RAMPAGED AROUND THE PLIMPTON PATCH, NOW STREWN  
WITH THE SPHELYBERING WRECKAGE OF THE KINGS, MOST OF THE CLASS

KEE HARRY PHEETTER

MALTHEY, CRABBE AND GRIPPLE IN THE LEAD HAD FLED INTO HARRY'S  
CABIN THROUGH THE BACK DECK AND BARRICADED THEMSELVES IN;  
HARRY, RON AND HERMION, HOWEVER, WERE AMONG THOSE WHO

REMAINED OUTSIDE TRYING TO HELP HARRY. TOGETHER THEY MAN-  
AGED TO RESTRAIN AND TIE UP NINE OF THE SKELETS, THOUGH AT THE

COST OF NUMEROUS KLANS AND CLITS; FINALLY, ONLY ONE SKELET WAS  
LEFT.

DEEN FRIGHTEN HIM, WHEN? F-JAGRID SEEMED, AS DEEN AND F-JARRY USED THEIR HANDS TO SEEM IT'S HOT FIERY SPARKS AT THE SKELET, WHICH WAS ADVANCING MENACINGLY TOWARD THEM, ITS STING ARCHING, DELIVERING, EVER ITS BACK. WAS TRY AND SLIP THE ROPES BEHIND HIS STING, SEE HE WHEN FLIRT AND IN THE OTHERS?

YEAH, WE WOULDNT WANT THAT? DEEN SEEMED ANGRILY, AS HE AND F-JARRY BACKED INTO THE WALL OF F-JAGRID'S CUBICLE, STILL HOLDING THE SKELET OFF WITH THEIR SPARKS.

WELL, WELL, WELL ... THIS DOES LOOK LIKE FUN.

RITA SKEETER WAS LEANING ON F-JAGRID'S GARDEN FENCE, WATCHING IN AT THE MAYHEM. SHE WAS WEARING A THICK MAGENTA COAT WITH A FLIRRY PURPLE COLLAR TODAY, AND HER CREPE-SKIN GLOVES WAS OVER HER ARM.

F-JAGRID LAUNCHED HIMSELF FORWARD INTO THE HOT OF THE SKELET THAT WAS CHIRPING F-JARRY AND DEEN AND FLATTENED IT; A BLAST OF FIRE SEEMED HOT AT ITS END, WITHERING THE PLUMPY PLANTS NEARBY.

WHAT ARE THEY? F-JAGRID ASKED RITA SKEETER, AS HE SLIPPED A ROPES OFF BEHIND THE SKELET'S STING AND TIGHTENED IT.

RITA SKEETER, DAILY PROPHET REPORTER, RITA REPLIED, BEAMING AT HIM. HER GOLD TEETH GLINTED.

THELIGHT DIMPLED HERE SAID THEY WERE ALLOWED INSIDE THE SEEM AND MORE? SAID F-JAGRID, FREEMING SLIGHTLY AS HE GOT OFF THE SLIGHTLY SEEMED SKELET AND STARTED TUGGING IT OVER THE ITS FEELERS.

RITA ACTED AS THOUGH SHE HADN'T HEARD WHAT F-JAGRID HAD SAID.

WHAT ARE THESE FASCINATING CREATURES CALLED? SHE ASKED, BEAMING STILL MORE WIDELY.

BLAST-ENDED SURELTS, GRUNTED F-JAGRID.

THE F-HEELISE-PLP LKPRATTIEN FREENT KZZ

REALLY? SAID RITA, APPARENTLY FULL OF LIVELY INTEREST. I VE  
NEVER HEARD OF THEM BEFORE ... WHERE DID THEY COME FROM?

F-HARRY NOTICED A BLIND RED FLUSH RISING UP HEAT OF F-JAGRID'S WILD  
BLACK BEARD, AND HIS HEART SANK. WHERE HAD F-JAGRID GOTT THE  
SURELTS FROM?

HERMIONE, WHO SEEMED TO BE THINKING ALONG THE SAME LINES,  
SAID QUICKLY, THEY ARE VERY INTERESTING, AREN'T THEY? AREN'T THEY,  
F-HARRY?

WHAT? EH, YEAH ... WHICH ... INTERESTING, SAID F-HARRY, AS SHE  
STEPPED IN HIS FEET.

AH, WELL BE HERE, F-HARRY? SAID RITA SKEETER AS SHE LEANED  
AHEAD. SHE WELL LIKE CARE OF MAGICAL CREATURES, DID SHE? HENK OF  
THEIR FAVORITE LESSONS?

YES, SAID F-HARRY STEALTHY, F-JAGRID BEAMED AT HIM.

LIVELY, SAID RITA. REALLY LIVELY, BEEN TEACHING LONG? SHE  
ADDED TO F-JAGRID.

F-HARRY NOTICED HER EYES TRAVEL OVER DEAN (WHO HAD A NASTY  
CLUT ACROSS ONE CHEEK), LAVENDER (WHOSE REEKS WERE BADLY  
SINGED), SEAMUS (WHO WAS NURSING SEVERAL BLUNT FINGERS), AND  
THEN THE TWO CUBIN WINDHILLS, WHERE MOST OF THE CLASS STOOD, THEIR  
NECKS PRESSED AGAINST THE GLASS, WAITING TO SEE IF THE CHAST WAS  
CLEAR.

THIS IS MY SECOND YEAR, SAID F-JAGRID.

LIVELY ... I HEN'T SUPPOSE WELL I LIKE TO GIVE AN INTERVIEW,

WOULD THEY SHARE SOME OF THEIR EXPERIENCE OF MAGICAL CREATURES? THE PROPHET DOES A THEOLOGICAL COLUMN EVERY WEDNESDAY,

AS I'M SURE YOU KNOW, WE COULD FEATURE THESE IN BANG-ENDED SHEETS.

BANG-ENDED SHEETS, Hagrid said eagerly, or what, wouldn't it?

Harry had a very bad feeling about this, but there was nothing

he was communicating to the Hagrid without Rita Skeeter seeing, so he had to stand and watch in silence as Hagrid and Rita

Skeeter made arrangements to meet in the Three Broomsticks for a good long interview later that week. Then the bell rang

and Harry muttered

up at the castle, signalling the end of the lesson.

Well, goodbye, Harry! Rita Skeeter called merrily to him, as he set off with Ron and Hermione. Until Friday night, then, Hagrid!

She'll twist everything he says, Harry said under his breath.

Just as long as he didn't impart these secrets illegally or anything, said Hermione desperately. They looked at each other. It was exactly the sort of thing Hagrid might do.

HARRY'S BEEN IN LEADS OF TREBLE KEEPER, AND DUMBLEDORE'S

NEVER SACKED HIM, SAID RON CHUCKLINGLY. WORST THAT CAN HAPPEN IS HARRY WILL HAVE TO GET RID OF THE SKELETS. SHIRAZ ... DID I

SAID WORST? I MEANT BEST.

HARRY AND HERMION LAUGHED, AND, FEELING SLIGHTLY MORE CHEERFUL, WENT OFF TO LUNCH.

HARRY THERETOFORER ENJOYED DEEP DIVINATION THAT AFTERNOON; THEY WERE STILL DOING STAR CHARTS AND PREDICTIONS, BUT NOW THAT HE AND RON WERE FRIENDS ONCE MORE, THE WHOLE THING SEEMED VERY FUNNY AGAIN. PROFESSOR TRILAWNEY, WHO HAD BEEN SO PLEASED WITH THE PAIR OF THEM WHEN THEY HAD BEEN PREDICTING THEIR OWN TERRIFIC DEATHS, QUICKLY BECAME IRRITATED AS THEY SNIGGERED THROUGH HER EXPLANATION OF THE VARIOUS WAYS IN WHICH POLITE CHILDREN DISRUPT EVERYDAY LIFE.

I WOULD THINK, SHE SAID, IN A MYSTICAL WHISPER THAT DID NOT CONCEAL HER EVIDENT ANNOYANCE, THAT SOME OF US SHE STARED VERY MEANINGFULLY AT HARRY MIGHT BE A LITTLE LESS PRIVILEGED HAD THEY SEEN WHAT I HAVE SEEN, DURING MY CRYSTAL-GAZING LAST NIGHT. AS I SAT HERE, ABSORBED IN MY NEEDLEWORK, THE LARGER THE CONSULT THE MORE OVERPOWERED ME, I ADDED, I SETTLED MYSELF BEFORE IT, AND I GAZED INTO ITS CRYSTALLINE DEPTHS ... AND WHAT DID YOU THINK I SAW GAZING BACK AT ME?

ANYBODY WHO EAT IN HILTSIZE SPECS? RON MUTTERED UNDER HIS BREATH.

HARRY FELT HE HAD TO KEEP HIS FACE STRAIGHT.



DEATH, MY DEARS.

THE FEEBLEST OF LITERATURE PRESENT KES

PARYATI AND LAVENDER BOTH PUT THEIR HANDS OVER THEIR  
MOUTHS, BLEEDING FERRIFIED.

YES, SAID PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY, NODDING IMPRESSIVELY, IT  
CHIMES, EVER CLEARER, IT CIRCLES OVERHEAD LIKE A VULTURE, EVER LOWER  
... EVER LOWER OVER THE CASTLE ...

SHE STARED PHANTOMICALLY AT FARRY, WHO YALINED VERY WIDELY AND  
HEAVILY.

IT D BE A BIT MORE IMPRESSIVE IF SHE HADN T DONE IT ABOUT  
EIGHTY TIMES BEFORE, FARRY SAID, AS THEY FINALLY REGAINED THE  
FRESH AIR OF THE STAIRCASE BENEATH PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY S ROOM.

BUT IF I D DROPPED DEAD EVERY TIME SHE S TOLD ME I M GOING TOO,  
I D BE A MEDICAL MIRACLE.

WELL D BE A SORT OF EXTRA-CONCENTRATED GHOST, SAID RENN,  
CHORTLING, AS THEY PASSED THE BLEEDY RARREN GOING IN THE  
OPPOSITE DIRECTION, HIS WIDE EYES STARING SINISTERLY. AT LEAST  
WE DIDN T GET HUMILIATED, I HOPE FERMINE GOT HEADS OFF  
PROFESSOR VECTER, I HAVE NOT WORKING WHEN SHE IS ...  
BUT FERMINE WASN T AT DINNER, AND NEER WAS SHE IN THE  
LIBRARY WHEN THEY WENT TO LOOK FOR HER AFTERWARDS. THE ONLY  
PERSON IN THERE WAS VICTOR DOLM, RENN HEEVERED BEHIND THE  
BOOKSHELVES FOR A WHILE, WATCHING DOLM, DEBATING IN WHISPERS  
WITH FARRY WHETHER HE SHOULD ASK FOR AN AUTOGRAPH BUT THEN  
RENN REALISED THAT SIX OR SEVEN GIRLS WERE LURKING IN THE NEXT  
ROOM OF BOOKS, DEBATING EXACTLY THE SAME THING, AND HE LEFT HIS

ENTHUSIASM FOR THE IDEA.

WHENEVER SHE GOT THE CHANCE, RHEA SAID, AS HE AND HARRY WENT  
BACK TO THE GRYFFINDOR TOWER.

BLIND ... BALDHEAD.

BUT THE FAT LADY HAD BARELY BEGUN THE SWING BACKWARDS, WHEN  
THE SOUND OF RACING FEET BEHIND THEM ANNOUNCED HERMIONE'S  
ARRIVAL.

HARRY? SHE PANTED, SKIDDING TO A HALT BESIDE HIM (THE FAT  
LADY STARED DOWN AT HER, EYEBROWS RAISED). HARRY, WHEN WE GOT THE  
CHANCE WHEN WE GOT THE CHANCE, THE MOST AMAZING THING THAT HAPPENED  
PLEASE

THE HARRY PATTERN

SHE SEIZED HARRY'S ARM AND STARTED TO TRY AND DRAG HIM BACK  
ALONG THE CORRIDOR.

WHAT'S THE MATTER? HARRY SAID.

I'LL SHOW YOU WHEN WE GET THERE. EH, COME ON, FOLLOW

HARRY LOOKED BACK AT RHEA; HE LOOKED BACK AT HARRY,  
INTRIGUED.

EH, HARRY SAID, STARTING OFF BACK DOWN THE CORRIDOR WITH  
HERMIONE, RHEA FLIPPING THE BEEP LIP.

EH, DON'T MIND ME? THE FAT LADY CALLED IRRITABLY AFTER THEM.

DON'T APOLOGISE FOR BOTHERING ME? I'LL JUST STAND HERE, WITH  
MY HANDS, UNTIL YOU GET BACK, SHALL I?

YES, THANKS, RHEA SHOUTED OVER HIS SHOULDER.

HERMIONE, WHERE ARE WE GOING? HARRY ASKED, AFTER SHE HAD  
LED THEM DOWN THROUGH SIX FLOORS, AND STARTED DOWN THE MARBLE

STAIRCASE INTO THE ENTRANCE HALL.

YELL LL SEE, YELL LL SEE IN A MINUTE! SAID HERMIONE EXCITEDLY.  
SHE TURNED LEFT AT THE BOTTOM OF THE STAIRCASE, AND HURRIED  
TOWARDS THE DARK TUNNEL WHICH LORD DUMBLEDORE HAD GIVEN THE  
NIGHT AFTER THE CRACK OF FIRE HAD RECALLED HIS AND HARRY'S  
NAMES. HARRY HAD NEVER BEEN TUNNEL HERE BEFORE. HE AND RON  
FOLLOWED HERMIONE DOWN A FLIGHT OF STONE STEPS, BUT INSTEAD OF  
ENDING UP IN A DIMLY LINGERING PASSAGE LIKE THE ONE  
WHICH LED THE SNAPES'S DUNGEON, THEY FOUND THEMSELVES IN A  
BROAD, STONE CORRIDOR, BRIGHTLY LIT WITH TORCHES, AND DECORATED  
WITH CHEERFUL PAINTINGS THAT WERE MAINLY OF THEM.

HEY, HANG ON ... SAID HARRY SILENTLY, HALFWAY DOWN THE CORRI-  
DOR. WAIT A MINUTE, HERMIONE ...

WHAT? SHE TURNED AROUND THE CORNER AT HIM, ANTICIPATING ALL  
OVER HER FACE.

I KNOW WHAT THIS IS ABOUT, SAID HARRY.  
HE NUDGED RON, AND POINTED TO THE PAINTING JUST BEHIND  
HERMIONE. IT SHOWED A GIANTIC SILVER FRUIT-BOWL.

HERMIONE? SAID RON, CHITTING HER. YELL OR TRYING THE WHOLE LOT  
INTO THAT SPELL STUFF AGAIN?

NEH, NEH, I'M NOT! SHE SAID HASTILY. AND IT'S NOT SPELL, RON

THE HOUSE-ELF LIBERATION FRONT IS

CHANGED THE NAME, HAVE YOU? SAID RON, FROWNING AT HER.

WHAT ARE WE NOW, THEN, THE HOUSE-ELF LIBERATION FRONT? I'M

NHET KARGING INTHE THAT KITCHEN AND TRYING THE MAKE THEM STEP  
WHERE, I M NHET BEING IT

I M NHET ASKING WHY THE? FERMINE SAID IMPATIENTLY. I CARE  
BELOW HERE JUST NOW, THE TALK THE THEM ALL, AND I FEELING ME, COME  
HEN, FARRY, I WANT THE STEEL WHY?

SHE SEIZED HIS ARM AGAIN, PULLED HIM IN FRONT OF THE PICTURE  
OF THE GIANT PRUIT-BEEL, STRETCHED OUT HER FINGERS AND TICKLED

THE FLICE GREEN PEAR. IT BEGAN THE SHUJIM, CHICKLING, AND SLID-  
DENLY TURNED INTO A LARGE GREEN DEER HANDLE. FERMINE SEIZED

IT, PULLED THE DEER OPEN, AND PUSHED FARRY HARD IN THE BACK,  
PUSHING HIM INSIDE.

HE HAD ONE BRIEF GLIMPSE OF AN ENORMOUS, HIGH-CEILINGED

ROOM, LARGE AS THE GREAT HALL ABOVE IT, WITH MILLIONS OF GLITTER-  
ING BRASS PETS AND PANS HEAPED AROUND THE STONE WALLS, AND A

GREAT BRICK FIREPLACE AT THE OTHER END, WHEN SOMETHING SMALL  
FLIRTED TOWARDS HIM FROM THE MIDDLE OF THE ROOM, SHUJALING,  
FARRY PETER, SIR! FARRY PETER!

NEXT SECOND ALL THE WIND HAD BEEN DROPPED OUT OF HIM AS  
THE SHUJALING ELF HIT HIM HARD IN THE MIDRIF, FLUJING HIM SH  
TIGHTLY HE THOUGHT HIS RIBS WOULD BREAK.

O-DEEY? FARRY GASPED.

IT IS DEEY, SIR, IT IS! SHUJALING THE WHOLE FROM SOME-

WHERE AROUND HIS NAVEL. DICKY HAD BEEN HOPING AND HOPING TO

SEE HARRY POTTER, SIR, AND HARRY POTTER HAS COME TO SEE HIM, SIR!

DICKY LET GO AND STEPPED BACK A FEW PACES, BEAMING UP AT

HARRY, HIS ENORMOUS, GREEN, TENNIS-BALL-SHAPED EYES BRIMMING

WITH TEARS OF HAPPINESS. HE BEHEADED ALMOST EXACTLY AS HARRY

REMEMBERED HIM: THE PENCIL-SHAPED NOSE, THE BAT-LIKE EARS, THE

LONG FINGERS AND FEET ALL EXCEPT THE CLOTHES, WHICH WERE VERY DIFFERENT.

WHEN DICKY HAD WORKED FOR THE MALFOYS, HE HAD ALWAYS

WORN THE SAME FILTHY OLD PILLBOXCASE. NOW, HOWEVER, HE WAS

WEARING THE STRANGEST ASSORTMENT OF GARMENTS HARRY HAD EVER

SEEN HARRY POTTER

SEEN: HE HAD MADE AN EVEN WORSE JOB OF DRESSING HIMSELF THAN

THE WIZARDS AT THE WORLD CUP. HE WAS WEARING A TEA-CLOTH FOR A

HAT, ON WHICH HE HAD PINNED A NUMBER OF BRIGHT BADGES: A TIE

PATTERNED WITH HORSESHOES OVER A RARE CHEST, A PAIR OF SLATS

LOOKED LIKE CHILDREN'S FOOTBALL SHORTS, AND HIS SHOES, ONE OF

THESE, HARRY SAW, WAS THE BLACK ONE HE HAD REMOVED FROM HIS

OWN FEET AND TRICKED MR MALFOY INTO GIVING DICKY, THEREBY

SETTING DICKY FREE. THE OTHER WAS COVERED IN PINK AND ORANGE STRIPES.

DICKY, WHAT ARE YOU DOING HERE? HARRY SAID IN AMAZEMENT.

DICKY HAS COME TO WORK AT HOGWARTS, SIR! DICKY SHOUTED

EXCITEDLY. PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE GAVE DICKY AND WINNY INKS,

SIR!

WINDY? SAID HARRY. SHE'S HERE, THEN?

YES, SIR, YES? SAID DICKY, AND HE SEIZED HARRY'S HAND, AND PULLED HIM OFF INTO THE KITCHEN BETWEEN THE FLEUR DEFEU WOODEN TABLES THAT STOOD THERE. EACH OF THESE TABLES, HARRY NOTICED AS HE PASSED THEM, WAS POSITIONED EXACTLY BENEATH THE FLEUR DEFEU TABLES ABOVE, IN THE GREAT HALL. AT THE MOMENT, THEY WERE CLEAR OF THEM, DINNER HAVING FINISHED, BUT HE SUPPOSED THAT AN FLEUR DEFEU TABLE HAD BEEN LOADED WITH DISHES THAT WERE THEN SENT UP THROUGH THE CEILING TO THEIR COUNTERPARTS ABOVE.

AT LEAST A HUNDRED LITTLE ELVES WERE STANDING AROUND THE KITCHEN, KEATING, BOWING AND CURTSYING AS DICKY LED HARRY

PAST THEM. THEY WERE ALL WEARING THE SAME UNIFORM: A TARTAN STAMPED WITH THE HOGWARTS CREST, AND TIED, AS WINDY'S

HAD BEEN, LIKE A TIE.

DICKY STOPPED IN FRONT OF THE BRICK FIREPLACE, AND POINTED.

WINDY, SIR? HE SAID.

WINDY WAS SITTING ON A STOOL BY THE FIRE. UNLIKE DICKY, SHE HAD OBVIOUSLY NOT TENDED HER CLOTHES. SHE WAS WEARING A NEAT LITTLE SKIRT AND BLOUSE WITH A MATCHING BLUE HAT, WHICH HAD HOLES IN IT FOR HER LARGE EARS. HOWEVER, WHILE EVERY ONE OF DICKY'S STRANGE COLLECTION OF GARMENTS WAS SEE CLEAN AND WELL CARED FOR THAT IT LOOKED BRAND NEW, WINDY WAS PLAINLY NOT

THE FLEUR DEFEU REPRESENTATIVE PRESENT BY

TAKING CARE OF HER CLOTHES AT ALL. THERE WERE SEVERAL STAINS ALL

BEHIND HER EMBLISH AND A KISS IN HER SKIRT,

"HELLO, WINDY," SAID HARRY,

WINDY'S LIP SMILED, THEN SHE BURST INTO TEARS, WHICH  
SPILLED OUT OF HER GREAT BROWN EYES AND SPLASHED BEHIND HER  
FRONT, JUST AS THEY HAD DONE AT THE ELIDITCH WORLD CUP,

"HEY, DEAR," SAID HERMIONE, "SHE AND RON HAD FOLLOWED HARRY  
AND DICKY TO THE END OF THE DITCHEN, WINDY, DON'T CRY, PLEASE  
DON'T ..."

BUT WINDY CRIED HARDER THAN EVER, DICKY, WITH THE OTHER  
HAND, REARED UP AT HARRY,

WOULD HARRY PREFER LIKE A CUP OF TEA? HE SMILED BEHOLD,  
EVER WINDY'S SISTER,

"ER, YES, HE," SAID HARRY,

INSTANTLY, ABOUT SIX FIFTEEN-YEARS-OLD BOYS CAME TROTTING UP BEHIND  
HIM, BEARING A LARGE SILVER TRAY LADEN WITH A TRAY, CUPS FOR  
HARRY, RON AND HERMIONE, A MILK JUG AND A LARGE PLATE OF  
BISCUITS,

"GOOD SERVICE!" RON SAID, IN AN IMPRESSED VOICE, HERMIONE  
SMILED AT HIM, BUT THE BOYS ALL SMILED DELIGHTED; THEY BOWED  
VERY LOW AND RETREATED,

"HOW LONG HAVE YOU BEEN HERE, DICKY?" HARRY ASKED, AS  
DICKY HANDED BEHIND THE TEA,

"ONLY A WEEK, HARRY PREFER, SIR," SAID DICKY HAPPILY, DICKY  
CAME TO SEE PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE, SIR, YOU SEE, SIR, IT IS VERY  
DIFFICULT FOR A FIFTEEN-YEAR-OLD WHO HAS BEEN DISMISSED TO GET A NEW  
POSITION, SIR, VERY DIFFICULT INDEED

AT THIS, WINDY SMILED EVEN HARDER, HER SMILES THE MOST OF

A NOISE DRIBBLING ALL DOWN HER FRONT, THOUGH SHE MADE NO EFFORT  
TO STOP THE FLOW.

DEEKE HAS TRAVELLED THE COUNTRY FOR TWO WEEKS YEARS, SIR,  
TRYING TO FIND WHERE? DEEKE SHOUTED. BUT DEEKE HADN'T FOUND  
WHERE, SIR, BECAUSE DEEKE WANTS PAYING NOW?

THE HOUSE-ELVES ALL AROUND THE KITCHEN, WHO HAD BEEN  
LISTENING AND WATCHING WITH INTEREST, ALL LOOKED AWAY AT

THEY HARRY POTTER

THESE WORDS, AS THOUGH DEEKE HAD SAID SOMETHING RUDE AND  
EMBARRASSING.

HERMION, HOWEVER, SAID, GOOD FOR YOU, DEEKE?

THANK YOU, MISS? SAID DEEKE, GRINNING TEETHILY AT HER. BUT  
MOST WIZARDS DOESN'T WANT A HOUSE-ELF WHO WANTS PAYING, MISS.

THAT'S NOT THE POINT OF A HOUSE-ELF, THEY SAY, AND THEY  
SLAPPED THE DEER IN DEEKE'S FACE? DEEKE LIKES WHERE, BUT HE  
WANTS THE WEAR CLOTHES AND HE WANTS THE BE PAID, HARRY POTTER ...  
DEEKE LIKES BEING FREE?

THE HOUSEWARTS HOUSE-ELVES HAD NOW STARTED EDGING AWAY  
FROM DEEKE, AS THOUGH HE WAS CARRYING SOMETHING CONTAGIOUS.  
WINDY, HOWEVER, REMAINED WHERE SHE WAS, THOUGH THERE WAS A  
DEFINITE INCREASE IN THE VOLUME OF HER CRYING.

AND THEN, HARRY POTTER, DEEKE GIVES THE VISIT WINDY, AND

FINDS THAT WINDY HAS BEEN FREED, THEN, SIR? SAID DEEKE DELIGHT-  
FULLY.



AT THIS, WINDY FALLING HERSELF AIRWARDS OFF HER STEEL, AND LAY,  
FACE DOWN, ON THE FLAGGED STONE FLOOR, BEATING HER TINY FISTS  
UPON IT AND OBSTINATELY SCREAMING WITH MISERY. FERMINE HASTILY  
DROPPED DOWN TO HER KNEES BESIDE HER, AND TRIED TO COMFORT  
HER, BUT NOTHING SHE SAID MADE THE SLIGHTEST DIFFERENCE.  
DEEKE CONTINUED WITH HIS STORY, SPEAKING SO RILLY EVER  
WINDY'S SCREECHES. AND THEN DEEKE HAD THE IDEA, FARRY BETTER,  
SIR? WHY DOESN'T DEEKE AND WINDY FIND WORK TOGETHER?

DEEKE SAYS, WHERE IS THERE ENOUGH WORK FOR TWO FELLOW-  
ELVES? SAYS WINDY, AND DEEKE THINKS, AND IT COMES TO HIM,

SIR? FELLOWANTS? SEE DEEKE AND WINDY CAME TO SEE PROFESSOR  
OLMLEDERE, SIR, AND PROFESSOR OLMLEDERE TOLD US HIS SON  
DEEKE KEAMED VERY BRIGHTLY, AND HAPPY TEARS WELLED IN HIS  
EYES AGAIN.

AND PROFESSOR OLMLEDERE SAYS HE WILL PAY DEEKE, SIR, IF  
DEEKE WANTS PAYING: AND SEE DEEKE IS A FREE EL, SIR, AND DEEKE  
GETS A GALLON A WEEK AND ONE DAY OFF A MONTH:

THAT'S NOT VERY MUCH! FERMINE SPELLED INDIGNANTLY FROM  
THE FLOOR, EVER WINDY'S CONTINUED SCREAMING AND FIST-BEATING.

THE FELLOW-ELF LITERATURE PRESENT KRI

PROFESSOR OLMLEDERE OFFERED DEEKE TEN GALLONS A WEEK,  
AND WEEKENDS OFF, SAID DEEKE, SLIDENLY GIVING A LITTLE SHIVER,  
AS THOUGH THE PROSPECT OF SEE MUCH LEISURE AND RICHES WAS  
FRIGHTENING, BUT DEEKE BEAT HIM DOWN, MISS ... DEEKE LIKES

FREEDOM, MISS, BUT HE ISN'T WANTING THE MILK, MISS, HE LIKES  
WHISK BETTER.

AND THE MILK IS PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE PAYING YELL,  
WINDY? HERMIONE ASKED KINDLY.

IF SHE HAD THOUGHT THIS WOULD KEEP WINDY UP, SHE WAS  
WILDLY MISTAKEN. WINDY DID STOP CRYING, BUT WHEN SHE SAT UP  
SHE WAS GLARING AT HERMIONE THROUGH HER MASSIVE GREEN EYES,  
HER WHITE FACE SHEPPING WET AND SLIDDERLY FLURIELLS.

WINDY IS A DISGRACED ELF, BUT WINDY IS NOT YET GETTING PAID!  
SHE SNEEZED. WINDY IS NOT SURE SHE KNOWS AS THAT? WINDY IS  
PROPERLY ASHAMED OF BEING FREE?

ASHAMED? SAID HERMIONE BLANKLY. BUT WINDY, COME HERE!  
IT'S MR CRUELCH WHO SHOULD BE ASHAMED, NOT YELL! YELL DIDN'T DO  
ANYTHING WRONG, HE WAS REALLY TERRIBLE THE YELL  
BUT AT THESE WORDS, WINDY CLAPPED HER HANDS OVER THE EYES  
IN HER HAT, FLATTENING HER EARS SHE THOUGHT SHE COULDN'T HEAR A WORD,  
AND SCREECHED, YELL IS NOT INSULTING MY MASTER, MISS! YELL IS  
NOT INSULTING MR CRUELCH! MR CRUELCH IS A GOOD WIZARD, MISS!  
MR CRUELCH IS RIGHT THE SAME BAD WINDY!

WINDY IS HAVING TERRIBLE ADJUSTING, HARRY POTTER, SNEEZED  
DARKLY CONFIDENTIALLY. WINDY FORGETS SHE IS NOT KNOWING THE MR  
CRUELCH ANY MORE! SHE IS ALLOWED TO SPREAD HER MIND NOW, BUT  
SHE WON'T DO IT.

CAN'T HOUSE-ELVES SPREAD THEIR MINDS ABOUT THEIR MASTERS,  
THEN? HARRY ASKED.

HEY, NO, SIR, NO, SAID DARKY, LEENING SLIDDERLY SERIOUS. 'TIS  
PART OF THE HOUSE-ELF'S ENSLAVEMENT, SIR, WE KEEP THEIR SECRETS

AND HIS SILENCE, SIR, WE LIFT-HOLD THE FAMILY'S FUTURE, AND WE NEVER SPEAKS ILL OF THEM. THOUGH PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE TOLD DEDDY HE DOES NOT INSIST UPON THIS, PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE SAID WE IS FREE TO TH

KE HARRY POTTER

DEDDY BEHEED SUDDENLV NERVHLS, AND RECDENED HARRY CLESTER, HARRY KENT FEARLARDS.

DEDDY WHISPERED, HE SAID WE IS FREE TO CALL HIM A A BARMY OLD CHDGR IF WE LIKES, SIR?

DEDDY GAVE A FRIGHTENED SHRT OF GIGGLE.

BUT DEDDY IS NOT WANTING TO, HARRY POTTER, HE SAID, TALKING NORMALLY AGAIN, AND SHAKING HIS HEAD SEE THAT HIS EARS FLAPPED. DEDDY LIKES PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE VERY MUCH, SIR, AND IS PROHLD TO KEEP HIS SECRETS FOR HIM.

BUT WHY CAN SAY WHAT YOU LIKE ABOUT THE MALFOYS THEN? HARRY ASKED HIM, GRINNING.

A SLIGHTLY FEARFUL BEED CAME INTO DEDDY'S IMMENSE EYES.

DEDDY DEDDY CHILD, HE SAID DELICATELY, HE SHLARED HIS SMALL SHOULDERS. DEDDY CHILD TELL HARRY POTTER THAT HIS OLD MASTERS WERE WERE BAD DARK WIZARDS?

DEDDY STOOD FOR A MOMENT, BELIVERING ALL EVER, FERRER-STRIKE BY HIS OWN DARING. THEN HE RUSHED OVER TO THE NEAREST TABLE, AND BEGAN BANGING HIS HEAD ON IT, VERY HARD, SHLWALING, BAD DEDDY? BAD DEDDY?

HARRY SEIZED DEDDY BY THE BACK OF HIS TIE AND PULLED HIM AWAY FROM THE TABLE.

THANK YOU, HARRY PITTER, THANK YOU, SAID DEEY BREATHLESSLY,  
RUBBING HIS HEAD.

YOU JUST NEED A BIT OF PRACTICE, HARRY SAID.

PRACTICE? SHEALED LINDY FLURRIEDLY. YOU IS EIGHT TEN RE

ASHAMED OF YOURSELF, DEEY, TALKING THAT WAY ABOUT YOUR MAS-  
TERS?

THEY ISN'T MY MASTERS ANY MORE, LINDY? SAID DEEY DEFI-  
ANTLY. DEEY DOESN'T CARE WHAT THEY THINK ANY MORE?

HEY, YOU IS A BAD BOY, DEEY? MEANED LINDY, TEARS LEADING  
DOWN HER FACE ONCE MORE. MY FATHER MR CRULICH, WHAT IS HE  
DOING WITHOUT LINDY? HE IS NEEDING ME, HE IS NEEDING MY  
HELP? I IS WATCHING AFTER THE CRULICHES ALL MY LIFE, AND MY FATHER  
IS DOING IT BEHIND ME, AND MY GRANDFATHER IS DOING IT BEHIND  
HER ... HEY, WHAT IS THEY SAYING IF THEY KNOW LINDY WAS FREED?

THE FOLLOWS-UP LITERATURE PRESENT ARE

HEY, THE SHAME, THE SHAME? SHE BLURIED HER FACE IN HER SKIRT  
AGAIN AND LAILED.

LINDY, SAID HERMINE, FIRMLY, I M WHITE SURE MR CRULICH IS  
GETTING ALONG PERFECTLY WELL WITHOUT YOU, WE VE SEEN HIM, YOU  
KNOW

YOU IS SEEING MY MASTER? SAID LINDY BREATHLESSLY, RAISING  
HER TEAR-STAINED FACE OUT OF HER SKIRT ONCE MORE, AND GEEGLING  
AT HERMINE. YOU IS SEEING HIM HERE AT FLEWARTS?

YES, SAID HERMIONE, HE AND MR BAGMAN ARE JUDGES IN THE  
TRIWIZARD TOURNAMENT.

MR BAGMAN CRIES, THEN? SHEARED WINNY, AND THE HARRY'S  
GREAT SURPRISE (AND RON AND HERMIONE'S, THEN, BY THE LOOKS ON  
THEIR FACES), SHE LOOKED ANGRY AGAIN. MR BAGMAN IS A BAD  
WIZARD! A VERY BAD WIZARD! MY MASTER ISN'T LIKING HIM, HEH NEH,  
NEH AT ALL!

BAGMAN BAD? SAID HARRY.

HEH YES, WINNY SAID, NODDING HER HEAD FLIRTELISLY. MY MAS-  
TER IS TELLING WINNY SOME THINGS! BUT WINNY IS NEH SAYING ...

WINNY WINNY KEEPS HER MASTER'S SECRETS ...

SHE DISSOLVED YET AGAIN IN TEARS; THEY COULD HEAR HER SQUEAKING  
INTO HER SKIRT, PHEER MASTER, PHEER MASTER, NEH WINNY THE HELP HIM  
NEH THERE!

THEY COULDN'T GET ANOTHER SENSIBLE WORD OUT OF WINNY. THEY  
LEFT HER THE HER CRYING, AND FINISHED THEIR TEA, WHILE DEERY  
CHATTED HAPPILY ABOUT HIS LIFE AS A FREE ELF, AND HIS PLANS FOR HIS  
WAGES.

DEERY IS GOING TO BE A JIMPER NEXT, HARRY PETER! HE SAID  
HAPPILY, POINTING AT HIS BARK CHEST.

TELL ME WHAT, DEERY, SAID RON, WHO SEEMED TO HAVE TAKEN  
A GREAT LIKING TO THE ELF. I'LL GIVE YOU THE HONORARY MIM DUNTS FOR  
THIS CHRISTMAS, I ALWAYS GET ONE FROM HER. YOU DON'T MIND  
MARRIAGE, DO YOU?

DEERY WAS DELIGHTED.

WE MIGHT HAVE THE SKRINK IT A BIT THE FIT YELL, RHN TOLD HIM,  
BUT IT LL BE WELL WITH YELLER TEA-CHESY.

BY HARRY PETER

AS THEY PREPARED TO TAKE THEIR LEAVE, MANY OF THE SURROUND-  
ING ELVES PRESSED IN UPON THEM, OFFERING SNACKS THE TAKE BACK

UPSTAIRS. HERMIONE REPLIED, WITH A PAINED LOOK AT THE WAY THE  
ELVES KEPT KEEING AND CLUTSING, BUT HARRY AND RHN LOADED  
THEIR POCKETS WITH CREAM CAKES AND PIES.

THANKS A LOT! HARRY SAID TO THE ELVES, WHO HAD ALL CLUSTERED  
AROUND THE DOOR THE SAY GOODNIGHT. SEE YELL, DEERY?

HARRY PETER ... CAN DEERY COME AND SEE YELL SOMETIMES,  
SIR? DEERY ASKED TENTATIVELY.

COURSE YELL CAN, SAID HARRY, AND DEERY BEAMED.

YELL KNOW WHAT? SAID RHN, ENCE HE, HERMIONE AND HARRY  
HAD LEFT THE KITCHENS BEHIND, AND WERE CLIMBING THE STEPS INTO  
THE ENTRANCE HALL AGAIN. ALL THESE YEARS I VE BEEN REALLY  
IMPRESSED WITH FRED AND GEORGE, NICKING THEM FROM THE  
KITCHENS WELL, IT S NOT EXACTLY DIFFICULT, IS IT? THEY CAN T WAIT  
TO GIVE IT AWAY?

I THINK THIS IS THE BEST THING THAT COULD HAVE HAPPENED TO  
THESE ELVES, YELL KNOW, SAID HERMIONE, LEADING THE WAY BACK  
UP THE MARBLE STAIRCASE. DEERY CHIMING THE WORD HERE, I MEAN.  
THE OTHER ELVES WILL SEE HOW HAPPY HE IS, BEING FREE, AND  
SURELY IT LL DAWN ON THEM THAT THEY WANT THAT, THEM?

LET S HOPE THEY DONT LOOK TOO CLOSELY AT WINDY, SAID HARRY.  
HEY, SHE LL CHEER UP, SAID HERMIONE, THOUGH SHE SOUNDED A  
BIT DEJECTED. ENCE THE STICK S WORN OFF, AND SHE S GET USED TO  
BEGHARTS, SHE LL SEE HOW MUCH BETTER OFF SHE IS WITHOUT THAT  
CRUEL MAN.

SHE SEEMS TO LOVE HIM, SAID RON THICKLY (HE HAD JUST  
STARTED IN A CREAM CAKE).

DONTN T THINK MUCH OF BAGMAN, THOUGH, DOES SHE? SAID  
HARRY. WONDER WHAT CRUEL SAYS AT HOME ABOUT HIM?  
PROBABLY SAYS HE S NOT A VERY GOOD HEAD OF DEPARTMENT,  
SAID HERMIONE, AND LET S FACE IT ... HE S GET A POINT, HASN T  
HE?

I D STILL RATHER WOND FOR HIM THAN OLD CRUEL, SAID RON. AT  
LEAST BAGMAN S GET A SENSE OF HUMOUR.

THE FOLLOWS-UP LITERATURE PRESENT RES

DONT LET PERCY HEAR YOU SAYING THAT, HERMIONE SAID,  
SMILING SLIGHTLY.

YEAH, WELL, PERCY WOULDN T WANT TO WOND FOR ANYONE WITH A  
SENSE OF HUMOUR, WOULD HE? SAID RON, NOW STARTING IN A  
COCALATE CLAIR. PERCY WOULDN T RECOGNISE A Joke IF IT BANGED  
NAMED IN FRONT OF HIM WEARING DEEKS S TEA-CHESS.

## CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

### THE UNEXPECTED TASK

PETTER: WEASLEY: WILL YOU PAY ATTENTION?

PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL'S IRRITATED WHISK CRACKED LIKE A WHIP THROUGH THE TRANSFIGURATION CLASS ON THURSDAY, AND HARRY AND RON BOTH JUMPED AND LEANED UP.

IT WAS THE END OF THE LESSON; THEY HAD FINISHED THEIR WORK; THE GLINKA-PIES THEY HAD BEEN CHANGING INTO GLINKA-PIES HAD BEEN SHIT AWAY IN A LARGE CAGE IN PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL'S DESK (NEVILLE'S GLINKA-PIE STILL HAD FEATHERS!); THEY HAD CHIPPED DOWN

THEIR FEMURALS FROM THE BLACKBOARD (DESCRIBE, WITH EXAMPLES, THE WAYS IN WHICH TRANSFORMING SPELLS MUST BE ADAPTED

WHEN PERFORMING CROSS-SPECIES SWITCHES). THE BELL WAS DINGING AT ANY MOMENT, AND HARRY AND RON, WHO HAD BEEN HAVING A SWORD FIGHT WITH A COUPLE OF FRED AND GEORGE'S FAKE WANDS AT THE BACK OF THE CLASS, LEANED UP, RON NOW HOLDING A TIN PARROT, AND HARRY, A BLISTER HADDUCK.

THEY PETTER AND WEASLEY HAVE BEEN KIND ENOUGH TO ACT THEIR AGE, SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL, WITH AN ANGRY LEER AT THE PAIR

OF THEM AS THE HEAD OF HARRY'S HADDUCK DROPPED AND FELL SILENTLY TO THE FLOOR. RON'S PARROT'S BEAK HAD SEVERED IT MOMENTS

BEFORE. I HAVE SOMETHING TO SAY TO YOU ALL.

THE YULE BALL IS APPROACHING. A TRADITIONAL PART OF THE TRIWIZARD TOURNAMENT AND AN OPPORTUNITY FOR US TO SOCIALISE WITH OUR FOREIGN GUESTS, NOW, THE BALL WILL BE OPEN ONLY TO



FOURTEEN-YEARS AND ABOVE. ALTHOUGH YOU MAY INVITE A VISITOR  
STUDENT IF YOU WISH.

LAVENDER BUSHLETTER LET OUT A STRILL GIGGLE. PARVATI PATIL NODDED

THE UNEXPECTED TASK BY

HER HAND IN THE RISK, HER FACE BECOMING FLIRTILY AS SHE, THEN,  
ALIGHT WITH THE GIGGLE, THEY BOTH LOOKED AROUND AT HARRY.  
PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL IGNORED THEM, WHICH HARRY THOUGHT WAS  
DISTINCTLY UNFAIR, AS SHE HAD JUST TOLD HIM AND HER,  
DRESS DRESS WILL BE WORN. PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL CONTINUED,

AND THE BALL WILL START AT EIGHT O'CLOCK ON CHRISTMAS DAY, FIN-  
ISHING AT MIDNIGHT, IN THE GREAT HALL. THEN THEN

PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL STARED DELIBERATELY AROUND THE CLASS.

THE YULE BALL IS OF COURSE A CHANCE FOR US ALL TO LET OUR  
HAIR DOWN, SHE SAID, IN A DISAPPROVING VOICE.

LAVENDER GIGGLED HARDER THAN EVER, WITH HER HAND PRESSED  
HAND AGAINST HER MOUTH THE STRIKE THE SOUND, HARRY COULD SEE  
WHAT WAS FLIPPING THIS TIME: PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL, WITH HER HAIR  
IN A TIGHT BUN, LOOKED AS THOUGH SHE HAD NEVER LET HER HAIR  
DOWN IN ANY SENSE.

BUT THAT DOES NOT MEAN, PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL WENT  
ON, THAT WE WILL BE RELAXING THE STANDARDS OF BEHAVIOUR  
WE EXPECT FROM HOGWARTS STUDENTS. I WILL BE MOST SERIOUSLY  
DISPLEASED IF A GRYFFINDOR STUDENT EMBARRASSES THE SCHOOL IN  
ANY WAY.

THE BELL RANG, AND THERE WAS THE USUAL SCUFFLE OF ACTIVITY AS

EVERYONE PACKED THEIR BAGS AND SWUNG THEM OVER THEIR SHOULDERS.

PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL CALLED AHEAD THE NOISE, PETER A  
WORD, IF YOU PLEASE.

ASSUMING THIS HAD SOMETHING TO DO WITH HIS HEADLESS HORSE  
HATCHER, HARRY PROCEEDED GRATEFULLY TO THE TEACHER'S DESK.

PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL WAITED UNTIL THE REST OF THE CLASS HAD

GONE, AND THEN SAID, PETER, THE CHAMPIONS AND THEIR PART-  
NERS

WHAT PARTNERS? SAID HARRY.

PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL LOOKED SUSPICIOUSLY AT HIM, AS  
THOUGH SHE THOUGHT HE WAS TRYING TO BE FLINDY.

YOUR PARTNERS FOR THE YULE BALL, PETER, SHE SAID COLDLY. YOUR  
DANCE PARTNERS.

YES HARRY PETER

HARRY'S INSIDES SEEMED TO CLIMB UP AND SHRIVEL. DANCE PART-  
NERS?

HE FELT HIMSELF GOING RED. I DON'T DANCE, HE SAID BLINKING.

EH, YES, YOU DO, SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL IRRITABLY. THAT'S

WHAT I'M TELLING YOU. TRADITIONALLY, THE CHAMPIONS AND THEIR PARTNERS OPEN THE BALL.

HARRY HAD A SUDDEN MENTAL IMAGE OF HIMSELF IN A TUXO AND TAILS, ACCOMPANIED BY A GIRL IN THE SHIRT OF FRILLS DRESS ALONG PETLINIA ALWAYS WHERE THE LITTLE VERNON'S WERE PARTIES.

I'M NOT DANCING, HE SAID.

IT IS TRADITIONAL, SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL FIRMLY. YOU ARE A HOGWARTS CHAMPION, AND YOU WILL DO WHAT IS EXPECTED OF YOU AS A REPRESENTATIVE OF THE SCHOOL. SHE MADE SURE YOU GET YOURSELF A PARTNER, PETER.

BUT I DON'T

YOU HEARD ME, PETER, SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL, IN A VERY FINAL TONE OF VOICE.

\*

A WEEK AGO, HARRY WOULD HAVE SAID FINDING A PARTNER FOR A DANCE WOULD BE A LINCH COMPARED THE TAKING OF A HUNGARIAN HORNTAIL. BUT NOW THAT HE HAD DONE THE LATTER, AND WAS FACING THE PROSPECT OF ASKING A GIRL TO THE BALL, HE THOUGHT HE'D RATHER HAVE ANOTHER REWIND WITH THE HORNTAIL.

HARRY HAD NEVER KNOWN SO MANY PEOPLE TO PUT THEIR NAMES DOWN TO STAY AT HOGWARTS FOR CHRISTMAS; HE ALWAYS DID, OF COURSE, BECAUSE THE ALTERNATIVE WAS USUALLY GOING BACK THE

PRIVATE DRIVE, BUT HE HAD ALWAYS BEEN VERY MUCH IN THE MINORITY BEFORE NOW. THIS YEAR, HOWEVER, EVERYONE IN THE FIFTH YEAR

AND ABOVE SEEMED TO BE STAYING, AND THEY ALL SEEMED TO HARRY  
TO BE DRESSED WITH THE CHINESE BALL. HER, AT LEAST, ALL THE GIRLS  
WERE, AND IT WAS AMAZING HOW MANY GIRLS HIGGARTS SUDDENLY  
SEEMED TO FIND; HE HAD NEVER BEFORE NOTICED THAT BEFORE, GIRLS  
GIGGLING AND WHISPERING IN THE HALLWAYS, GIRLS SHRIEKING WITH  
LAUGHTER AS BOYS PASSED THEM, GIRLS EXCITEDLY COMPARING NOTES  
ON WHAT THEY WERE GOING TO WEAR ON CHRISTMAS NIGHT ...

### THE UNEXPECTED TASK KEY

WHY DO THEY HAVE TO MOVE IN PACKS? HARRY ASKED RON, AS A  
DOZEN OF THE GIRLS WALKED PAST THEM, SNIGGERING AND STARING AT  
HARRY. HOW ARE YOU SUPPOSED TO GET ONE ON THEIR OWN TO ASK  
THEM?

LASTING ONE? RON SUGGESTED. GET ANY IDEA WHEN YOU'RE GOING  
TO TRY?

HARRY DIDN'T ANSWER. HE KNEW PERFECTLY WELL WHEN HE'D LIKE  
TO ASK, BUT WHISKING UP THE NERVE WAS SOMETHING ELSE ... SHE  
WAS A YEAR OLDER THAN HE WAS; SHE WAS VERY PRETTY; SHE WAS A  
VERY GOOD QUIDDITCH PLAYER, AND SHE WAS ALSO VERY POPULAR.  
RON SEEMED TO KNOW WHAT WAS GOING ON INSIDE HARRY'S HEAD.

LISTEN, YOU'RE NOT GOING TO HAVE ANY TROUBLE. YOU'RE A CHAMP-  
PION. YOU'VE JUST BEATEN A HUNGARIAN HORNTAIL. I BET THEY'LL BE

BUCKLING UP TO GO WITH YOU.

IN TRICKLE TO THEIR RECENTLY REPAIRED FRIENDSHIP, RON HAD KEPT

THE BITTERNESS IN HIS VOICE WAS A RARE MINIMAL. NEVERTHELESS, THE  
HARRY'S AMAZEMENT, HE TURNED HEAD THE RE HE HEARD RIGHT.

A CURLY-HAIRED THIRD-YEAR FLUFFY GIRL THE WHOM HARRY HAD  
NEVER SPEAKEN IN HIS LIFE ASKED HIM THE GO THE THE BALL WITH HER  
THE VERY NEXT DAY. HARRY WAS SHE TAKEN ABACK HE SAID NO BECAUSE  
HE D EVEN STOPPED TO CONSIDER THE MATTER. THE GIRL WALKED OFF  
LOOKING RATHER FLIRT, AND HARRY HAD THE ENDURE DEAN S, STANLEY S  
AND REIN S TALKING ABOUT HER ALL THROUGHOUT HISTORY OF MAGIC. THE  
FOLLOWING DAY, TWO MORE GIRLS ASKED HIM, A SECOND-YEAR AND THE  
HIS FATHER! A FIFTH-YEAR WHO LOOKED AS THOUGH SHE MIGHT DENY  
HIM HEAD IF HE REFUSED.

SHE WAS HEAVY EYES-LOOKING, SAID REIN FAIRLY, AFTER HE D  
STOPPED LAUGHING.

SHE WAS A FEET TALLER THAN ME, SAID HARRY, STILL UNNERVED.

IMAGINE WHAT I D LIKE TRYING THE DANCE WITH HER.

HERMIONE S WORDS ABOUT DREAMS KEPT COMING BACK TO HIM.

THEY ONLY LIKE HIM BECAUSE HE S FAMOUS! HARRY DECIDED  
VERY MUCH IF ANY OF THE GIRLS WHO HAD ASKED THE RE HIS PARTNER  
SHE FAR WOULD HAVE WANTED THE GO THE THE BALL WITH HIM IF  
HE HADN'T BEEN SCHOOL CHAMPION. THEN HE WONDERED IF

AND HARRY PETER

THIS WOULD BEHOLD HIM IF SHE ASKED HIM.

IN THE MEANTIME, HARRY HAD TO ADMIT THAT EVEN WITH THE ENHANCING  
PROSPECT OF OPENING THE BALL BEFORE HIM, LIFE HAD DEFINITELY  
IMPROVED SINCE HE HAD GOTTEN THROUGH THE FIRST TASK. HE

WASN'T ATTRACTING NEARLY AS MUCH UNPLEASANTNESS IN THE CHAIRS AND THERE, WHICH HE SUSPECTED HAD A LOT TO DO WITH CEDRIC

HE HAD AN IDEA CEDRIC MIGHT HAVE TOLD THE FLIPFLOPPERS TO LEAVE HARRY ALONE, IN GRATITUDE FOR HARRY'S TIP-OFF ABOUT THE DRAGONS. THERE SEEMED TO BE FEWER SLIPPERY CEDRIC DIEGETIC BADGES AROUND, THEN, DRACE MALPHE, OF COURSE, WAS STILL HUNTING RITA SKEETER'S ARTICLE AT HIM AT EVERY POSSIBLE OPPORTUNITY, BUT HE WAS GETTING FEWER AND FEWER LAUGHS OUT OF IT AND ILUST THE HEIGHTEN HARRY'S FEELING OF WELL-BEING, NEW STORY ABOUT HAGRID HAD APPEARED IN THE DAILY PROPHET.

SHE DIDN'T SEEM VERY INTERESTED IN MAGICAL CREATURES, TO TELL HER THE TRUTH, HAGRID SAID, WHEN HARRY, RON AND HERMIONNE

ASKED HIM HOW HIS INTERVIEW WITH RITA SKEETER HAD GONE DURING THE LAST CARE OF MAGICAL CREATURES LESSON OF TERM. THE THEIR

VERY GREAT RELIEF, HAGRID HAD GIVEN UP HIS DIRECT CONTACT WITH THE SKEELTS THEM, AND THEY WERE MERELY SHELTERING BEHIND HIS

LAKIN TODAY, SITTING AT A TRESTLE TABLE AND PREPARING A FRESH SELECTION OF FOOD WITH WHICH TO TEMPT THE SKEELTS.

SHE ILUS WANTED ME TO TALK ABOUT THEM, HARRY, HAGRID CONTINUED IN A LOW VOICE. WELL, I TOLD HER WE'D BEEN FRIENDS SINCE I

WENT TO GET THEM FROM THE DURSLEYS. NEVER HAD TO TELL HIM  
HOW IN THEIR YEARS? SHE SAID. NEVER PLAYED WITH LIP IN LESSONS,  
HAS HE? I TOLD HER NO, AND SHE DIDN'T SEEM HAPPY AT ALL. SHE'D  
THINK SHE WANTED ME TO SAY THEY WERE HORRIBLE, HARRY.

WHEN SHE DID, SAID HARRY, THROWING LIMPS OF DRAGON LIVER  
INTO A LARGE METAL BOWL AND PICKING UP HIS KNIFE TO CUT SOME  
MORE. SHE CAN'T STOP WRITING ABOUT WHAT A TRAGIC LITTLE HERO I  
AM, IT WILL GET BORING.

SHE WANTS A NEW ANGEL, HARRY, SAID RON WISELY, AS HE  
SHIELDED SALAMANDER EGGS. THEY WERE SUPPOSED TO SAY HARRY'S A  
MAD DELINQUENT.

THE UNEXPECTED TASK

BUT HE'S NOT? SAID HARRY, LEANING GENUINELY FORWARD.

SHE SHOULD BE INTERVIEWED BY ME, SAID HARRY GRIMLY. HE'D  
GIVE HER THE GOODS IN MY DAY. BETTER HAS BEEN CROSSING LINES  
EVER SINCE HE FIRST ARRIVED AT THIS SCHOOL ...

SAID THAT, DID HE? SAID HARRY, WHILE RON AND HERMION  
LAUGHED. WELL, THEY MIGHT BE KEPT A FEW RULES, HARRY, BUT THEY'RE  
ALL RIGHT REALLY, AREN'T THEY?

CHUCKS, HARRY, SAID HARRY, GRINNING.

THEY'LL BE HERE THIS BALL TIME ON CHRISTMAS DAY, HARRY?  
SAID RON.

THOUGH I MIGHT BE IN IT, YES, SAID HARRY GRIMLY.  
SHOULD BE A GOOD ONE, I RECKON. THEY'LL BE OPENING THE DANCING,  
WHEN THEY, HARRY? WHEN ARE THEY TAKING?

NO ONE, YET, SAID HARRY, FEELING HIMSELF GOING RED AGAIN.

HARRY DIDN'T PURSUE THE SUBJECT.

THE LAST WEEK OF TERM BECAME INCREASINGLY BISTABLE AS IT

PROCEEDED. BOMBERS ABOUT THE YULE BALL WERE FLYING EVERY-  
WHERE, THOUGH HARRY DIDN'T BELIEVE HALF OF THEM. FOR INSTANCE,

THAT DUMBLEDORE HAD KNIGHT EIGHT HUNDRED BARRELS OF MILLED  
MEAD FROM MADAM POMFRET. IT SEEMED TOO BE FACT, HOWEVER,  
THAT HE HAD KILLED THE WEIRD SISTERS. EXACTLY WHEN OR WHAT THE  
WEIRD SISTERS WERE HARRY DIDN'T KNOW, NEVER HAVING HAD ACCESS

TO A WIZARD'S WIRELESS, BUT HE DROPPED FROM THE WILD EXCITE-  
MENT OF THESE WHEN HE HAD GREEN LIP LISTENING TO THE WIZARD

(WIZARDING WIRELESS NETWORK) THAT THEY WERE A VERY FAMOUS  
MUSICAL GROUP.

SOME OF THE TEACHERS, LIKE LITTLE PROFESSOR FLITWICK, GAVE UP  
TRYING TO TEACH THEM MUCH WHEN THEIR MINDS WERE SET CLEARLY  
ELSEWHERE; HE ALLOWED THEM TO PLAY GAMES IN HIS LESSON ON  
WEDNESDAY, AND SPENT MOST OF IT TALKING TO HARRY ABOUT THE  
PERFECT SLIMMING CHARM HE HAD USED DURING THE FIRST TASK OF

THE TRIWIZARD TOURNAMENT. OTHER TEACHERS WERE NOT SO GENER-  
OUS. NOTHING WOULD EVER DEFLECT PROFESSOR KINGS, FOR EXAMPLE,

FROM PUNISHING HIM THROUGH HIS NETS FOR GREEN REBELLIONS. AS  
KINGS HADN'T LET HIS OWN DEATH STAND IN THE WAY OF CONTINUING



RAY HARRY POTTER

THE TEACH, THEY SLIPPED A SMALL THING LIKE CHRISTMAS WASN'T  
GIVING THE PLT HIM OFF. IT WAS AMAZING HOW HE COULD MAKE EVEN  
BLENDY AND VIOLETS GELIN RHTS SEHND AS BEHND AS PERCY'S  
CALDERON-BETTER REPORT. PROFESSORS MCGONAGALL AND MURPHY  
KEPT THEM WORKING UNTIL THE VERY LAST SECOND OF THEIR CLASSES,  
THEY AND SNAPP, OF COURSE, WOULD NEVER LET THEM PLAY  
GAMES IN CLASS THAN ADAPT HARRY. STARING NASTILY AROUND AT THEM  
ALL, HE INFORMED THEM THAT HE WOULD BE TESTING THEM ON POTION  
ANTIDOTES DURING THE LAST LESSON OF THE TERM.

EVIL, HE IS. RON SAID BITTERLY THAT NIGHT IN THE GRYFFINDOR  
COMMON ROOM. SPRINGING A TEST ON US IN THE LAST DAY, RUINING  
THE LAST BIT OF TERM WITH A WEEK-LEAD OF REVISION.

MMM ... YOU'RE NOT EXACTLY STRAINING YOURSELF, THOUGH, ARE  
YOU? SAID HERMION, LOOKING AT HIM OVER THE TOP OF HER  
POTION'S NOTES. RON WAS BUSY BUILDING A CARD CASTLE OUT OF HIS  
EXPLODING SNAP PACK A MUCH MORE INTERESTING PASTIME THAN  
WITH MUGGLE CARDS, BECAUSE OF THE CHANCE THAT THE WHOLE THING  
WOULD BLEW UP AT ANY SECOND.

IT'S CHRISTMAS, HERMION, SAID HARRY LAZILY; HE WAS RE-  
READING FLYING WITH THE CARPENTERS FOR THE TENTH TIME IN AN  
ARMCHAIR NEAR THE FIRE.

HERMION LOOKED SEVERELY OVER AT HIM, THEN. I'D HAVE THOUGHT  
YOU'D BE DOING SOMETHING CONSTRUCTIVE, HARRY, EVEN IF YOU

DIDN'T WANT TO LEARN THEIR ANTIDOTES?

LIKE WHAT? HARRY SAID, AS HE WATCHED THEM JENDING UP THE  
CANNONS KILT A BLUDGEON TOWARDS A BALLYCASTLE RATS CHASER.  
THAT EGG? HERMIONE HISSED.

CHEER UP, HERMIONE, I'VE GOT TIL FEBRUARY THE TWENTY-  
FOURTH, HARRY SAID.

HE HAD PUT THE GOLDEN EGG UPSTAIRS IN HIS TRUNK, AND HADN'T  
OPENED IT SINCE THE CELEBRATION PARTY AFTER THE FIRST TASK. THERE  
WERE STILL TWO AND A HALF MONTHS TO GO UNTIL HE NEEDED TO KNOW  
WHAT ALL THE SCREECHING MEANT, AFTER ALL.

BUT IT MIGHT TAKE WEEKS TO WORK IT OUT! SAID HERMIONE.

YOU'RE GOING TO WORK A REAL IDIOT IF EVERYONE ELSE KNOWS WHAT

THE UNEXPECTED TASK WAS

THE NEXT TASK IS AND YOU DON'T?

LEAVE HIM ALONE, HERMIONE, HE'S EARNED A BIT OF A REAP,  
SAID RON, AND HE PLACED THE LAST TWO CARDS ON TOP OF THE CASTLE  
AND THE WHEEL LEFT BLEW UP, SINGING HIS EVERHELIS.

NICE WORK, RON ... GO WELL WITH YOUR DRESS RINGS, THAT WILL.  
IT WAS FRED AND GEORGE. THEY SAT DOWN AT THE TABLE WITH  
HARRY, RON AND HERMIONE AS RON FELT FEEL MUCH DAMAGE HAD  
BEEN DONE.

RON, CAN WE REPAIR THE WHEEL? GEORGE ASKED.

NO, HE'S OFF DELIVERING A LETTER, SAID RON. WHY?

BECAUSE GEORGE WANTS TO INVITE HIM TO THE BALL, SAID FRED

SARCASTICALLY,

BECAUSE WE WANT THE SEND A LETTER, YOU STUPID GREAT PRAT, SAID  
GEORGE.

WHEN D YOU TWO KEEP WRITING THE, EH? SAID RICH.

NEVER FELT, RICH, HE I LL RETURN THAT FOR YOU, THEN, SAID FRED, WAV-  
ING HIS HAND THREATENINGLY. SEE ... YOU BET GET DATES FOR THE BALL

YET?

NEVER, SAID RICH.

WELL, YOU D BETTER HURRY UP, MATE, HE ALL THE GOOD MEN WILL  
BE GONE, SAID FRED.

WHEN RE YOU GOING WITH, THEN? SAID RICH.

ANGELINA, SAID FRED PROMPTLY, WITHOUT A TRACE OF EMBARRASS-  
MENT.

WHAT? SAID RICH, TAKEN ABACK. YOU VE ALREADY ASKED HER?  
GOOD POINT, SAID FRED, HE TURNED HIS HEAD AND CALLED ACROSS  
THE CHURCHYARD, HE! ANGELINA!

ANGELINA, WHEN HAD BEEN CHATTING THE ALICIA SPINNET NEAR THE  
FIRE, LOOKED OVER AT HIM.

WHAT? SHE CALLED BACK.

WANT THE COME THE THE BALL WITH ME?

ANGELINA GAVE FRED AN APPRAISING SHORT HE LOOK.

ALL RIGHT, THEN, SHE SAID, AND SHE TURNED BACK THE ALICIA AND  
CARRIED ON CHATTING, WITH A BIT OF A GRIN ON HER FACE.

THERE WILL BE, SAID FRED THE BARRY AND RENN, PIECE OF CAKE.

THE BARRY PITTER

HE GOT THE HIS FEET, YAWNING, AND SAID, WE'D BETTER USE A  
SOMEHOW THEN, GEORGE, COME ON ...

THEY LEFT, RENN STOPPED FEELING HIS EYEBROWS AND LEANED  
ACROSS THE SMILING WARD OF HIS CARD CASTLE AT BARRY.

WE SHOULD GET A MOVE ON, WILL DONALD ... AND SOMEONE, HE'S  
RIGHT, WE DON'T WANT THE END UP WITH A PAIR OF TRELLS.

HERMIONE LET OUT A SPLUTTER OF INDIGNATION. A PAIR OF ...  
WHAT, EXCUSE ME?

WELL WILL DONALD, SAID RENN, SHRUGGING, I'D RATHER GO ALONE  
THAN WITH WITH ELISE MIDGEN, SAY.

HER ALONE'S HEADS BETTER LATELY AND SHE'S REALLY NICE?

HER NESE IS OFF-CENTRE, SAID RENN.

EH, I SEE, HERMIONE SAID, KRISTINE, SHE BASICALLY, WILL BE  
GIVING THE TALK THE BEST-LOOKING GIRL WHO'LL HAVE WILL, EVEN IF  
SHE'S COMPLETELY HORRIBLE?

OR YEAH, THAT SOUNDS ABOUT RIGHT, SAID RENN.

I'M GIVING THE RED, HERMIONE SNAPPED, AND SHE SWIFT OFF  
TOWARDS THE GIRLS STAIRCASE WITHOUT ANOTHER WORD.

\*

THE HOGWARTS STAFF, DEMONSTRATING A CONTINUED DESIRE TO  
IMPRESS THE VISITERS FROM REALISATION AND DISMAY, SEEMED  
DETERMINED TO SHOW THE CASTLE AT ITS BEST THIS

CHRISTMAS, WHEN THE DECORATIONS WENT UP, HARRY NOTICED THAT THEY WERE THE MOST STUNNING HE HAD YET SEEN INSIDE THE SCHOOL. EVERLASTING ICICLES HAD BEEN ATTACHED TO THE BANISTERS OF THE MARBLE STAIRCASE; THE USUAL TWELVE CHRISTMAS TREES IN THE GREAT HALL WERE BEDeckED WITH EVERYTHING FROM ILLUMINATED PINKY BERRIES TO REAL, FLEETING, GILDEN EELS, AND THE SLITS OF ARMCHAIR HAD ALL BEEN BEWITCHED THE SING CAROLS WHENEVER ANYONE PASSED THEM. IT WAS WHITE SOMETHING TO HEAR THE CHIME, ALL OF FAITHFUL SLING BY AN EMPTY HELMET THAT ONLY BONE HAD THE WOUNDS. SEVERAL TIMES, EVEN THE CARETAKER HAD THE EXTRACT PEEVES FROM INSIDE THE ARMCHAIR, WHERE HE HAD TAKEN THE HIDING, FILLING IN THE GAPS IN THE SONGS WITH LYRICS OF HIS OWN INVENTION, ALL OF WHICH WERE VERY RUDE.

#### THE UNEXPECTED TASK

AND STILL HARRY HADN'T ASKED THEM THE BALL, HE AND RENN WERE GETTING VERY NERVOUS NOW, THOUGH AS HARRY POINTED OUT, RENN WOULD BE MUCH LESS STUPID THAN HE WOULD WITHOUT A PARTNER; HARRY WAS SURPRISED TO BE STARTING THE DANCING WITH THE BETTER CHAMPIONS.

I SUPPOSE THERE'S ALWAYS MEANING MORTAL, HE SAID GLENNILY,

REPPRING THE THE GHOST WHO HAUNTED THE GIRLS' THEATRE IN THE SECOND FLOOR.

HARRY WE'VE JUST GOT THE GRIT EEL TEETH AND DIE IT, SAID RENN

ON FRIDAY MORNING, IN A TOWN THAT SUGGESTED THEY WERE PLANNING THE STEALING OF AN IMPREGNABLE TREASURE. WHEN WE GET

BACK TO THE CHURCH TONIGHT, WE'LL BOTH HAVE PARTNERS AGREED?

ER ... YES, SAID HARRY.

BUT EVERY TIME HE GLIMPSED HER THAT DAY DURING BREAK, AND THEN LUNCHTIME, AND EVEN ON THE WAY TO THE HISTORY OF MAGIC

SHE WAS SURROUNDED BY FRIENDS. DIDN'T SHE EVER GO ANYWHERE ALONE? COULD HE PERHAPS AMUSE HER AS SHE WAS GOING INTO A BATHROOM? BUT NO SHE EVEN SEEMED TO GO THERE WITH AN ESCORT OF FIVE OR SIX GIRLS. YET IF HE DIDN'T DO IT HIMSELF, SHE WAS BEHIND TO HAVE BEEN ASKED BY SOMEONE ELSE.

HE FELT IT HARD TO CONCENTRATE IN SNAPE'S ANTIMONY TEST, AND CONSEQUENTLY FORGOT TO ADD THE KEY INGREDIENT A REZAR MEANING THAT HE RECEIVED EIGHTH MARKS. HE DIDN'T CARE HOWEVER; HE WAS TOO BUSY STREWING UP HIS CHELSEA FOR WHAT HE WAS

ABOUT TO DO. WHEN THE BELL RANG, HE GRABBED HIS BAG, AND HURRIED TO THE DUNGEON DOOR.

I'LL MEET YOU AT DINNER, HE SAID TO RON AND HERMION, AND HE DASHED OFF UPSTAIRS.

HE DIDN'T HAVE TO ASK HER FOR A PRIVATE WORD, THAT WAS ALL ... HE HURRIED OFF THROUGH THE PACKED CORRIDORS LEADING FOR HER,

AND (RATHER SOONER THAN HE HAD EXPECTED) HE FOUND HER, EMERG-

ING FROM A DEFENCE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS LESSON.

ER CEEH COULD I HAVE A WORD WITH YOU?  
GIGGLING SHOULD BE MADE ILLEGAL, HARRY THOUGHT FLIRTELISLY, AS

THE HARRY PITTER

ALL THE GIRLS AROUND CEEH STARTED DOING IT. SHE DIDN'T, THOUGH.

SHE SAID, HED, AND FOLLOWED HIM OUT OF EARSHOT OF HER CLASS-  
MATES.

HARRY TURNED THE HEAD AT HER AND HIS STOMACH GAVE A WEIRD  
LURCH AS THOUGH HE HAD MISSED A STEP GOING DOWNSTAIRS.

ER, HE SAID.

HE COULDN'T ASK HER, HE COULDN'T, BUT HE HAD THE CEEH STOOD  
THERE LOOKING FLUSTERED, WATCHING HIM.

THE WORDS CAME OUT BEFORE HARRY HAD EVEN GET HIS TONGUE  
AROUND THEM.

WANGERALLWIM?

SHEER? SAID CEEH.

D YOU D YOU WANT THE CHE THE THE BALL WITH ME? SAID HARRY.  
WHY DID HE HAVE THE CHE RED NOW? WHY?

HEH? SAID CEEH AND SHE WENT RED, THEN. HEH, HARRY, I'M REALLY  
SHEER, AND SHE LOOKED IT, THEN. I'VE ALREADY SAID I'LL CHE WITH  
SOMEONE ELSE.

HEH, SAID HARRY.

IT WAS HED; A MOMENT BEFORE, HIS INSIDES HAD BEEN WRITHING

LIKE SNAKES, BUT SUDDENLY HE DIDN'T SEEM TO HAVE ANY INSIDES AT ALL.

"EH, EH," HE SAID, "NO PROBLEM."

"I'M REALLY SORRY," SHE SAID AGAIN.

"THAT'S EH," SAID HARRY.

THEY STOOD THERE LOOKING AT EACH OTHER, AND THEN LEE SAID, "WELL,

"YES," SAID HARRY.

"WELL, BYE," SAID LEE, STILL VERY RED. SHE WALKED AWAY.

HARRY CALLED AFTER HER, BECAUSE HE COULD STOP HIMSELF.

"WHERE ARE YOU GOING WITH?"

"EH, CEDRIC," SHE SAID, "CEDRIC DIGGORY."

"EH, RIGHT," SAID HARRY.

HIS INSIDES HAD COME BACK AGAIN. IT FELT AS THOUGH THEY HAD BEEN FILLED WITH LEAD IN THEIR ABSENCE.

COMPLETELY FORGETTING ABOUT DINNER, HE WALKED SILENTLY BACK

THE UNEXPECTED TASK WAS

UP THE GRYFFINDOR TOWER, LEE'S VOICE ECHOING IN HIS EARS WITH

EVERY STEP HE TOOK. CEDRIC CEDRIC DIGGORY. HE HAD BEEN STARTING THE WHITE LIKE CEDRIC PREPARED THE EVERLASTING THE FACT THAT HE

HAD NEVER SEEN HIM AT HOLIDAY, AND WAS HANDSOME, AND POPULAR, AND NEARLY EVERYONE'S FAVORITE CHAMPION. WHEN HE SUDDENLY REALISED THAT CEDRIC WAS IN FACT A USELESS PRETTY-BODY WHO DIDN'T HAVE ENOUGH BRAINS TO FILL AN EGG.



FAIRY LIGHTS, HE SAID DULLY THE THE FAT LADY THE PASSWORD  
HAD BEEN CHANGED THE PREVIOUS DAY,

YES, INDEED, DEAR? SHE TRILLED, STRAIGHTENING HER NEW TINSEL  
HAIRBAND AS SHE SWUNG FORWARD TO ADMIT HIM,

ENTERING THE COMMON ROOM, HARRY LOOKED AROUND, AND THE  
HIS SURPRISE HE SAW REEN SITTING ASHEN FACED IN A DISTANT CORNER,  
GINNY WAS SITTING WITH HIM, TALKING TO HIM IN WHAT SEEMED THE  
BE A LULL, SLEEPING VEHICLE,

WHAT S UP, REEN? SAID HARRY, IDLING THEM,

REEN LOOKED UP AT HARRY, A SHORT HP BLIND FROWNER IN HIS FACE,

WHY DID I DO IT? HE SAID WILDLY, I DIDN T KNOW WHAT MADE  
ME DO IT?

WHAT? SAID HARRY,

HE ER ILST ASKED FELIX DELACOUR THE GM THE THE BALL WITH  
HIM, SAID GINNY, SHE LOOKED AS THOUGH SHE WAS FIGHTING BACK A  
SMILE, BUT SHE KEPT PATTING REEN S ARM SYMPATHETICALLY,

WELL WHAT? SAID HARRY,

I DIDN T KNOW WHAT MADE ME DO IT? REEN GASPED AGAIN, WHAT  
WAS I PLAYING AT? THERE WERE PEOPLE ALL AROUND I VE GONE  
MAD EVERYONE WATCHING? I WAS ILST WALKING PAST HER IN THE  
ENTRANCE HALL SHE WAS STANDING THERE TALKING TO DIGGERY  
AND IT SHORT HP CAME OVER ME AND I ASKED HER?

REEN MEANED AND PUT HIS FACE IN HIS HANDS, HE KEPT TALKING,  
THOUGH THE WORDS WERE RARELY DISTINGUISHABLE, SHE LOOKED AT  
ME LIKE I WAS A SEA SLUG HP SOMETHING, DIDN T EVEN ANSWER, AND  
THEN I BLINDED I ILST SHORT HP CAME TO MY SENSES AND RAN FOR  
IT,

SHE'S PART VEEA, SAID HARRY, SHE'LL BE RIGHT HER

THE HARRY POTTER

GRANDMOTHER WAS HERE. IT WASN'T HER FAULT, I KNEW SHE'LL  
WALKED PAST WHEN SHE WAS TURNING HER THE OLD CHARM HER  
DIGGING AND GET A BLAST OF IT BUT SHE WAS WASTING HER TIME.  
HE'S GOING WITH THE CHANG.

HE'LL BE UP,

I ASKED HER THE GO WITH ME JUST NOW, HARRY SAID DULLY, AND  
SHE TOLD ME,

GINNY HAD SUDDENLY STOPPED SMILING.

THIS IS MAD, SAID REIN, WE'RE THE ONLY ONES LEFT WHO HAVEN'T  
GOT ANYONE WELL, EXCEPT NEVILLE. HEY GUESS WHO HE ASKED?  
HERMIONIE?

WHAT? SAID HARRY, COMPLETELY DISTRACTED BY THIS STARTLING  
NEWS.

YEAH, I KNOW! SAID REIN, SOME OF THE CHERUBS COMING BACK  
INTO HIS FACE AS HE STARTED THE LAUGH. HE TOLD ME AFTER PENTHENS!  
SAID SHE'S ALWAYS BEEN REALLY NICE, HELPING HIM OUT WITH HER

AND STUFF BUT SHE TOLD HIM SHE WAS ALREADY GOING WITH SOME-  
ONE, HA! AS IF! SHE JUST DIDN'T WANT THE GO WITH NEVILLE ... I

MEAN, WHO WOULD?

OH! SAID GINNY, ANNOYED, DIDN'T LAUGH

JUST THEN HERMIONIE CLIMBED IN THROUGH THE PORTRAIT HOLE.

WHY WEREN'T YOU TWO AT DINNER? SHE SAID, COMING OVER THE

ININ THEM.

BECAUSE HE, SLIT UP LAUGHING, YELL THEN BECAUSE THEY VE  
KEITH ILST BEEN TURNED DOWN BY GIRLS THEY ASKED THE THE BALL?  
SAID GINNY.

THAT SLIT HARRY AND RON UP.

THANKS A BUNCH, GINNY, SAID RON SERIOUSLY.

ALL THE CHILD-LEERING MINS TAKEN, RON? SAID HERMIONE LEFTILY.  
WHILE MIDGEEN STARTING THE LEEDS WHITE PRETTY NEEL, IS SHE? WELL,  
I M SURE YELL LL FIND SOMEONE SOMEWHERE WHEN LL HAVE YELL.  
BUT RON WAS STARING AT HERMIONE AS THOUGH SLIDENLY SEEING  
HER IN A WHOLE NEW LIGHT. HERMIONE, NEVILLE S RIGHT YELL ARE A  
GIRL ...

HE, WELL SPOTTED, SHE SAID ACIDLY.

THE UNEXPECTED TASK R47

WELL YELL CAN CME WITH ME IF U?

NE, I CAN T, SNAPPED HERMIONE.

HE, CME EN, HE SAID IMPATIENTLY, WE NEED PARTNERS, WE RE  
GING THE LEEDS REALLY STUPID IF WE HAVEN T GET ANY, EVERYONE ELSE  
HAS ...

I CAN T CME WITH YELL, SAID HERMIONE, NEW KUSHING,

BECAUSE I M ALREADY GING WITH SOMEONE.

NE, YELL RE NOT? SAID RON, YELL ILST SAID THAT THE GET RID OF  
NEVILLE?

HE, DID I? SAID HERMIONE, AND HER EYES FLASHED DANGEROUSLY.

ILST BECAUSE IT S TAKEN YELL THREE YEARS THE NOTICE, RON, DOESN T  
MEAN NEH MEH ELSE HAS SPOTTED I M A GIRL?

RENN STARED AT HER. THEN HE GRINNED AGAIN.

EEK, EEK, WE KNOW YOU'RE A GIRL, HE SAID. THAT ONE WILL YOU  
COME NOW?

I'VE ALREADY TOLD YOU! HERMIONE SAID, VERY ANGRILY. I'M  
GOING WITH SOMEONE ELSE!

AND SHE STORMED OFF TOWARDS THE GIRLS' DORMITORIES AGAIN.

SHE'S LYING, SAID RENN FLATLY, WATCHING HER GO.

SHE'S NOT, SAID GINNY QUIETLY.

WHAT IS IT, THEN? SAID RENN SHARPLY.

I'M NOT TELLING YOU, IT'S HER BUSINESS, SAID GINNY.

RIGHT, SAID RENN, WHO LOOKED EXTREMELY PUT OUT. THIS IS GET-  
TING STUPID, GINNY, YOU CAN GO WITH HARRY, AND I'LL JUST

I CAN'T, SAID GINNY, AND SHE WENT SCARLET THEN. I'M GOING WITH  
WITH NEVILLE. HE ASKED ME WHEN HERMIONE SAID NO, AND I  
THOUGHT ... WELL ... I'M NOT GOING TO BE ABLE TO GO EITHERWISE,  
I'M NOT IN MY FIFTH YEAR. SHE LOOKED EXTREMELY MISERABLE. I  
THINK I'LL GO AND HAVE DINNER, SHE SAID, AND SHE GOT UP AND  
WALKED OFF TOWARDS THE PORTRAIT HALL, HER HEAD DOWN.

RENN GIGGLED AT HARRY.

WHAT'S GET INTO THEM? HE DEMANDED.

BUT HARRY HAD JUST SEEN PARYATI AND LAVENDER COME IN  
THROUGH THE PORTRAIT HALL. THE TWO HAD COME FOR DRASTIC  
ACTION.

END HARRY POTTER

WAIT HERE, HE SAID TO RHN, AND HE STOOD UP, WALKED STRAIGHT UP TO PARVATI AND SAID, PARVATI? WILL YOU GO TO THE BALL WITH ME?

PARVATI WENT INTO A FIT OF GIGGLES. HARRY WAITED FOR THEM TO SUBSIDE, HIS FINGERS CROSSED IN THE POCKET OF HIS TROUSERS.

YES, ALL RIGHT, THEN, SHE SAID FINALLY, BLUSHING FLIRTUOUSLY.

THANKS, SAID HARRY, IN RELIEF. LAVENDER WILL YOU GO WITH RHN?

SHE'S GOING WITH SEamus, SAID PARVATI, AND THE PAIR OF THEM GIGGLED HARDER THAN EVER.

HARRY SIGHED.

CAN'T YOU THINK OF ANYONE WHO'D GO WITH RHN? HE SAID, LOWERING HIS VOICE SO THAT RHN WOULDN'T HEAR.

WHAT ABOUT HERMIONE GRANGER? SAID PARVATI.

SHE'S GOING WITH SOMEONE ELSE.

PARVATI LOOKED ASTONISHED.

HEHEHE! WHY? SHE SAID DEEPLY.

HARRY SHRUGGED. NO IDEA, HE SAID. SHE WHAT ABOUT RHN?

WELL ... SAID PARVATI SILENTLY, I SUPPOSE MY SISTER MIGHT ...

PADMA, YOU KNOW ... IN RAVENCLAW. I'LL ASK HER IF YOU LIKE.

YES, THAT WOULD BE GREAT, SAID HARRY. LET ME KNOW, WILL YOU?

AND HE WENT BACK OVER TO RHN, FEELING THAT THIS BALL WAS A LOT MORE TRICKLE THAN IT WAS WORTH, AND HOPEING VERY MUCH THAT PADMA PATIL'S NESE WAS DEAD CENTRE.

## CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

## THE PLUM BALL

DESPITE THE VERY HEAVY LEAD OF EVERYWHERE THAT THE FORTY-YEARS HAD BEEN GIVEN FOR THE HOLIDAYS, HARRY WAS IN NO MIND THE WHEN TERM ENDED, AND SPENT THE WEEK LEADING UP THE CHRISTMAS ENJOYING HIMSELF AS FULLY AS POSSIBLE ALONG WITH EVERYONE ELSE. GRYFFINDOR TOWER WAS HARDLY LESS CROWDED NOW THAN DURING TERM-TIME; IT SEEMED TO HAVE SPREAD SLIGHTLY, THEN, AS ITS INHABITANTS WERE BEING SO MUCH HEDIER THAN USUAL. FRED AND GEORGE HAD HAD A GREAT SUCCESS WITH THEIR CANARY CREAMS, AND FOR THE FIRST FEW OF DAYS OF THE HOLIDAYS, PEOPLE KEPT BURSTING INTO FLATHER ALL OVER THE PLACE. BEHOLDING, HOWEVER, ALL THE GRYFFINDORS HAD LEARNED THE TRUTH ABOUT ANYBODY ELSE OFFERED THEM WITH EXTREME CAUTION, IN CASE IT HAD A CANARY CREAM CONCEALED IN THE CENTRE, AND GEORGE ADVISED THE HARRY THAT HE AND FRED WERE NOW WORKING ON DEVELOPING SOMETHING ELSE. HARRY MADE A MENTAL NOTE NEVER TO ACCEPT SO MUCH AS A CRISP FROM FRED AND GEORGE IN FUTURE, HE STILL HADN'T FORGOTTEN DUDLEY AND THE TEN-TENGER TREE.

SNOW WAS FALLING THICKLY UPON THE CASTLE AND ITS GROUNDS NOW. THE PALE BLUE REARERATHS CARRIAGE LOOKED LIKE A LARGE, CHILLY, FROSTED PLUMBIN NEXT TO THE ICE GINGERBREAD HOUSE THAT WAS HAGRID'S CARKIN, WHILE THE DIRMSTRANG SHIP'S PARTS WERE GLAZED WITH ICE, THE RIGGING WHITE WITH FROST. THE HOUSE-ELVES DOWN IN THE KITCHEN WERE BUSYING THEMSELVES WITH A SERIES OF RICH, WARMING STEWS AND SAVOURY PLIDDINGS, AND ONLY FEW

DELACOUR SEEMED TO BE ABLE TO FIND ANYTHING TO COMPLAIN  
ABOUT.

AND HARRY POTTER

IT IS THE WAY, ALL HIS EYEGLASSES WERE, THEY HEARD HER SAYING  
GRUMPILY, AS THEY LEFT THE GREAT HALL BEHIND HER ONE EVENING  
(WHEN SKYLARKING BEHIND HARRY, DREAMS NOT TO BE SPOTTED BY FLEUR).  
I WILL NOT FIT INTO MY DRESS HERE?

HEHEH, THERE IS A TRAGEDY, SAID HERMIONE SNAPPILY, AS FLEUR

WENT INTO THE ENTRANCE HALL. SHE REALLY THINKS A LOT OF HER-  
SELF, THAT ONE, DOESN'T SHE?

HERMIONE WHEN ARE YOU GOING TO THE BALL WITH? SAID RON.  
HE KEPT SPRINGING THIS QUESTION ON HER, KEEPING HER STARTLED HER  
INTO A RESPONSE BY ASKING IT WHEN SHE LEAST EXPECTED IT.  
HOWEVER, HERMIONE MERELY SMILED AND SAID, I'M NOT TELLING  
YOU, YOU'LL JUST MAKE FUN OF ME.

YOU'RE THINKING, WEASLEY? SAID MALFOY, BEHIND THEM. YOU'RE

NOT TELLING ME SOMETHING I ASKED THAT TO THE BALL? NOT THE LONG-  
HEADED MURDERER?

HARRY AND RON BOTH WHIPPED AROUND, BUT HERMIONE SAID  
LIVELY, LEAVING THE SMOKING OVER MALFOY'S SHOULDER, FLEUR,  
PROFESSOR MURDER?

MALFOY WENT PALE AND LIMPED BACKWARDS, WHISKING LIVELY

ARRIVING HER MIND, BUT HE WAS STILL UP AT THE STAFF TABLE, FINISH-  
ING HIS STEW.

"TWITCHY LITTLE FERRET, AREN'T YOU, MALPHE?" SAID FERMINE

STATIONING, AND SHE, HARRY AND REN WENT UP THE MARBLE STAIR-  
CASE LAUGHING HEARTILY.

FERMINE, SAID REN, LEERING SIDELAYS AT HER, SLIDDERLY  
PRELUNING, PHLIR TEETH ...

"WHAT ABOUT THEM?" SHE SAID.

"WELL, THEY'RE DIFFERENT ... I'VE JUST NOTICED ...

HE' CHLIRSE THEY ARE ... DID YOU EXPECT ME THE DEEP THESE FANGES  
MALPHE GAVE ME?"

"NO, I MEAN, THEY'RE DIFFERENT THE FELL THEY WERE BEFORE HE PLIT  
THAT HE' HEN YOU ... THEY'RE ALL ... STRAIGHT AND ... AND NORMAL SIZED.  
FERMINE SLIDDERLY SMILED VERY MISCHIEVOUSLY, AND HARRY  
NOTICED IT THEN: IT WAS A VERY DIFFERENT SMILE THE TIME HEN HE  
REMEMBERED.

THE PLIR BALL KEE

"WELL ... WHEN I WENT UP THE MADAM PEMPREY THE GET THEM  
SHIRLON, SHE HELD UP A MIRROR, AND TOLD ME THE STEEP HER WHEN  
THEY WERE BACK THE FELL THEY NORMALLY WERE, SHE SAID, AND I  
JUST ... LET HER CARRY HEN A BIT. SHE SMILED EVEN MORE WIDELY,



MUM AND DAD WHEN THEY'RE PLEASED, I'VE BEEN TRYING TO PERSUADE THEM TO LET ME SHAVE THEM FOR AGES, BUT THEY WANTED ME

TO CARRY HIM WITH MY KNUCKLE. YOU KNOW, THEY'RE DENTISTS, THEY JUST DON'T THINK TEETH AND MAGIC SHOULD MIX! PIGWIDGEEHN'S BACK!

REHN'S TINY BEAK WAS TWITTERING MADLY IN THE TOP OF THE ICICLE-LADEN BASKETS, A SCROLL OF PARCHMENT TIED TO HIS LEG. PEOPLE

PASSING HIM WERE POINTING AND LAUGHING, AND A GROUP OF THIRD-YEAR GIRLS PALSED AND SAID, 'EH, LOOK AT THE WEIRD BEAK! ISN'T HE

CUTE?

STUPID LITTLE FEATHERY GIT! REHN HISSED, FLURRYING UP THE STAIRS AND SNATCHING PIGWIDGEEHN UP. YOU BRING LETTERS STRAIGHT TO THE ADDRESSEE! YOU DON'T HAVE ANYONE SINGING OFF!

PIGWIDGEEHN HOPPED HAPPILY, HIS HEAD PROTRUDING OVER REHN'S FIST. THE THIRD-YEAR GIRLS ALL LOOKED VERY SHOCKED.

CLEAR OFF! REHN SNAPPED AT THEM, WAVING THE FIST HOLDING PIGWIDGEEHN, WHO HOPPED MORE HAPPILY THAN EVER AS HE SEARED

THROUGH THE AIR. HERE TAKE IT, HARRY, REHN ADDED IN AN UNDER-TONE, AS THE THIRD-YEAR GIRLS SCUTTLED AWAY LOOKING SCANDALISED.

HE PULLED SIRIUS' REPLY OFF PIGWIDGEEHN'S LEG, HARRY POCKETED IT, AND THEY FLURRIED BACK TO GRYFFINDOR TOWER TO READ IT.

EVERYONE IN THE COMMON ROOM WAS MUCH TOO BUSY LETTING

OFF THERE HOLIDAY STAY THE HERVEY WHAT ANYONE ELSE WAS UP TO,  
HARRY, RON AND HERMIONE SAT APART FROM EVERYONE ELSE BY A  
DARK WINDOW THAT WAS GRADUALLY FILLING UP WITH SNOW, AND  
HARRY READ OUT:

DEAR HARRY,

CONGRATULATIONS ON GETTING PAST THE HURTAIL, HOWEVER PUT  
YOUR NAME IN THAT CHECK SHELLDON T BE FEELING TOO HAPPY RIGHT  
NOW! I WAS GIVING THE SLUGGERT A CHINILACTIVITIS CLUSE, AS A  
DRAGON S EYES ARE ITS WEAKEST POINT

END HARRY PTTTTT

THAT S WHAT DRUM DID! HERMIONE WHISPERED,

BUT YOUR WAY WAS BETTER, I M IMPRESSED,

DON T GET COMPLACENT, TELLER, HARRY, YOU VE ONLY DONE ONE  
TASK! HOWEVER PUT YOUR IN FOR THE TOURNAMENT S GET PLENTY MORE  
OPPORTUNITY IF THEY RE TRYING TO HURT YOU, KEEP YOUR EYES OPEN

PARTICULARLY WHEN THE PERSON WE DISCUSSED IS AROUND AND  
CONCENTRATE ON KEEPING YOURSELF OUT OF TROUBLE,

KEEP IN TOUCH, I STILL WANT TO HEAR ABOUT ANYTHING UNUSUAL,  
STIRLS

HE SOUNDS EXACTLY LIKE MEHBY, SAID HARRY QUIETLY, TUCKING  
THE LETTER AWAY AGAIN INSIDE HIS BOOKS, CONSTANT VIGILANCE!  
YOU D THINK I WALK AROUND WITH MY EYES SHUT, KANGING OFF THE  
WALLS ...

BUT HE S RIGHT, HARRY, SAID HERMIONE, YOU HAVE STILL GOT TWO  
TASKS TO DO, YOU REALLY MIGHT WANT TO HAVE A LOOK AT THAT EGG, YOU  
KNOW, AND START WORKING OUT WHAT IT MEANS ...

HERMIONE, HE S GHT AGES? SNAPPED REIN. WANT A GAME OF  
CHESS, HARRY?

YEAH, HED, SAID HARRY. THEN, SPITTING THE WORDS IN

HERMIONE S FACE, HE SAID, [HMP HEN, HEN M I SLIPPED THE CON-  
CENTRATE WITH ALL THIS NOISE GOING ON? I WEN T EVEN BE ABLE TO

HEAR THE EGG EVER THIS LIT.

HEY, I SLIPPED RIGHT, SHE SIGHED, AND SHE SAT DOWN THE WATCH  
THEIR CHESS MATCH, WHICH CLIMINATED IN AN EXCITING CHECKMATE  
OF REIN S, INVOLVING A CHLIPLE OF RECKLESSLY BRAVE PAWNS AND A  
VERY VIOLENT KISS-UP.

\*

HARRY AWAKE VERY SLIDENLY IN CHRISTMAS DAY, WANDERING  
WHAT HAD CALISED HIS ABRUPT RETURN THE CHRISTIANISNESS, HE  
OPENED HIS EYES, AND SAW SOMETHING WITH VERY LARGE, ROLING,  
GREEN EYES STARING BACK AT HIM IN THE DARKNESS, SEE CHESE THEY  
WERE ALMOST NESE THE NESE.

DEKEY? HARRY YELLED, SCRAMBLING AWAY FROM THE ELF SEE FAST

THE PLUR BALL KIS

HE ALMOST FELL HILT OF RED, DEN T DE THAT?

DEKEY IS SHARRY, SIR? SHELEADED DEKEY ANXIETILISLY, ILIMPING  
BACKWARDS WITH HIS LONG FINGERS OVER HIS MOUTH. DEKEY IS ONLY  
WANTING THE WISH HARRY PHTTER MERRY CHRISTMAS AND ERING

HIM A PRESENT, SIR? HARRY POTTER DID SAY DICKY CHILD CAME AND SEE HIM SOMETIMES, SIR?

IT'S HIM, SAID HARRY, STILL BREATHING RATHER FASTER THAN USUAL, WHILE HIS HEART RATE RETURNED THE NORMAL. JUST JUST PROVE ME HIS SOMETHING IN FUTURE, ALL RIGHT, DON'T SEND ME LIKE THAT ... HARRY PULLED BACK THE HANGINGS AROUND HIS PHILIP-POSTER, TOOK HIS GLASSES FROM HIS BEDSIDE TABLE AND PLUT THEM ON. HIS YELL HAD AWAKENED RON, SEamus, DEAN AND NEVILLE. ALL OF THEM WERE PEERING THROUGH THE GAPS IN THEIR OWN HANGINGS, HEAVY EYED AND THICK HAIR.

SOMEONE ATTACKING YELL, HARRY? SEamus ASKED SLEEPILY, NO, IT'S JUST DICKY, HARRY MUTTERED, GO BACK TO SLEEP, NAH ... PRESENTS? SAID SEamus, SPITTING THE LARGE PILE AT THE FEET OF HIS BED, RON, DEAN AND NEVILLE DECIDED THAT NOW THEY

WERE AWAKE THEY MIGHT AS WELL GET DOWN THE SOME PRESENT-OPENING, THEN, HARRY TURNED BACK THE DICKY, WHICH WAS NOW

STANDING NERVIOUSLY NEXT THE HARRY'S BED, STILL LOOKING WORRIED THAT HE HAD UPSET HARRY. THERE WAS A CHRISTMAS CALBE TIED THE THE LUMP ON THE OF HIS TEA-CHEST.

CAN DICKY GIVE HARRY POTTER HIS PRESENT? HE SQUEAKED TENTATIVELY,

COURSE YELL CAN, SAID HARRY, ER ... I VE GOT SOMETHING FOR YELL, THEN.

IT WAS A LIE; HE HADN'T DELIGHTED ANYTHING FOR DICKY AT ALL, BUT HE QUICKLY OPENED HIS TRUNK, AND PULLED OUT A PARTICULARLY KNICKERED RUMPLED-UP PAIR OF SHORTS. THEY WERE HIS FINEST AND FINEST, MUSTARD YELLOW, AND HAD NEVER BELONGED TO LITTLE VERNON. THE REASON THEY WERE EXTRA KNICKERED WAS THAT HARRY HAD BEEN USING THEM TO CUSHION HIS SNEAKERS FOR OVER A YEAR NOW. HE PULLED OUT THE SNEAKERS AND HANDED THE SHORTS TO DICKY, SAYING, 'HARRY, I FORGOT TO WRAP THEM ...

SEE HARRY PETER

BUT DICKY WAS LITERALLY DELIGHTED.

SHORTS ARE DICKY'S FAVORITE, FAVORITE CLOTHES, SIR! HE SAID, RIPPING OFF HIS SHOES AND PULLING HIS LITTLE VERNON'S. I HAVE SEVEN NOW, SIR ... BUT, SIR ... HE SAID, HIS EYES WIDENING, HAVING PULLED BOTH SHORTS UP TO THEIR HIGHEST EXTENT, HE THAT THEY REACHED THE BOTTOM OF HIS SHORTS, THEY HAD MADE A MISTAKE IN THE SHOP, HARRY PETER, THEY IS GIVING YOU TWO THE SAME!

AH, NO, HARRY, WHEN YOU DIDN'T SPEAK THAT! SAID REIN, GRINNING EVER FROM HIS OWN RED, WHICH WAS NOW STREWN WITH WRAPPING PAPER. TELL YOU WHAT, DICKY HERE YOU GO TAKE THESE TWO,

AND YOU CAN MIX THEM UP PROPERLY, AND HERE'S YOUR SLIPPER, HE THREW DICKY A PAIR OF VIOLET SHORTS HE HAD JUST UNWRAPPED, AND THE HAND-KNITTED SWEATER MRS WEASLEY HAD SENT.

DICKY LEANED BACK OVERWHELMED. SIR IS VERY KIND! HE SQUEEZED, HIS EYES BRIMMING WITH TEARS AGAIN, BEHOLDING DEEPLY

THE ROBIN. DEREK KNEW SIR MUST BE A GREAT WIZARD, FOR HE IS HARRY  
POTTER'S GREATEST FRIEND, BUT DEREK DID NOT KNOW THAT HE WAS  
ALSO AS GENEROUS OF SPIRIT, AS NIKKLE, AS SELFLESS

THEY'RE ONLY SHOES, SAID ROBIN, WHO HAD CHEEK SLIGHTLY PINK  
AROUND THE EARS, THOUGH LOOKING RATHER PLEASED ALL THE SAME.

WELL, HARRY HE HAD JUST OPENED HARRY'S PRESENT, A CRIMSON  
CAPTAIN HAT. CHEER! HE JAMMED IT BETWEEN HIS HEAD, WHERE IT  
CLASHED TERRIBLY WITH HIS HAIR.

DEREK NOW HANDED HARRY A SMALL PACKAGE, WHICH TURNED  
OUT TO BE SHOES.

DEREK IS MAKING THEM HIMSELF, SIR! THE ELF SAID HAPPILY. HE  
IS EARNING THE WHOLE LOT OF HIS WAGES, SIR!

THE LEFT SHOE WAS BRIGHT RED, AND HAD A PATTERN OF BRIMSTICKS  
UPON IT; THE RIGHT SHOE WAS GREEN, WITH A PATTERN OF SNITCHES.

THEY'RE ... THEY'RE REALLY ... WELL, THANKS, DEREK, SAID HARRY,

AND HE PULLED THEM ON, CALLING DEREK'S EYES THE BACK WITH HAP-  
PINESS AGAIN.

DEREK MUST GO NOW, SIR, WE IS ALREADY MAKING CHRISTMAS  
DINNER IN THE KITCHENS! SAID DEREK, AND HE HURRIED OUT OF THE  
BROOMSTAIRS, WAVING GOODBYE TO ROBIN AND THE OTHERS AS HE PASSED.

THE YULE BALL IS

HARRY'S OTHER PRESENTS WERE MUCH MORE SATISFACTORY THAN  
DEREK'S TWO SHOES WITH THE EXCEPTION OF THE  
GLOVES, WHICH CONSISTED OF A SINGLE TISSUE, AN ALL-TIME NEW

HARRY SLIPPED THEY, THEN, WERE REMEMBERING THE TEN-TENGLIE  
THEFF, HERMIONE HAD GIVEN HARRY A BUNDLE CALLED BLIDDITCH  
TEAMS OF BRITAIN AND IRELAND; RON, A BULGING BAG OF BUNCKERS;  
SIRIUS, A HANDY PENDING WITH ATTACHMENTS THE LINDERS AND LICK  
AND LINDY AND KNIGHT; AND HAGRID, A VAST BOX OF SWEETS INCLUDING  
ALL HARRY'S FAVORITES. KERTIE KEET'S EVERY FLAVOUR BEANS,  
CHOCOLATE FRIGGS, DRECKLE'S BEST BLEWING CLIM AND FIZZING  
WHIZZERS. THERE WAS ALSO, OF COURSE, MRS WEASLEY'S USUAL  
PACKAGE, INCLUDING A NEW LUMPER GREEN, WITH A PICTURE OF A  
DRAGON IN IT. HARRY SLIPPED CHARLIE HAD THOUGHT HER ALL ABOUT  
THE FERNTAIL AND A LARGE QUANTITY OF HOME-MADE MINCE PIES.  
HARRY AND RON MET UP WITH HERMIONE IN THE COMMON ROOM,  
AND THEY WENT DOWN THE BREAKFAST TOGETHER. THEY SPENT MOST OF

THE MORNING IN GRYFFINDOR TOWER, WHERE EVERYONE WAS ENJOY-  
ING THEIR PRESENTS, THEN RETURNED TO THE GREAT HALL FOR A MAGNIF-  
ICENT LUNCH, WHICH INCLUDED AT LEAST A HUNDRED TURKEYS AND

CHRISTMAS PLIDDINGS, AND LARGE PILES OF CRACKERS WIZARDING  
CRACKERS.

THEY WENT OUT INTO THE GARDENS IN THE AFTERNOON; THE SNOW  
WAS UNTHAWED EXCEPT FOR THE DEEP CHANNELS MADE BY THE  
BURMSTRANG AND BEALWEATHERS STUDENTS ON THEIR WAY UP THE  
CASTLE. HERMIONE CHOSE TO WATCH HARRY AND THE WEASLEYS  
SNOWBALL FIGHT RATHER THAN JOIN IN, AND AT FIVE HE CHECK SAID SHE  
WAS GOING BACK UPSTAIRS TO GET READY FOR THE BALL.

WHAT, YOU NEED THREE HOURS? SAID RON, LEERING AT HER

INCREDIBLY, AND PAYING FOR HIS LAPSE IN CONCENTRATION WHEN  
A LARGE SNOWBALL, THROWN BY GEORGE, HIT HIM HARD ON THE SIDE  
OF THE HEAD. WHEN HE WENT GOING WITH IT HE YELLED AFTER  
BERMITH, BUT SHE JUST WAVED, AND DISAPPEARED UP THE STONE  
STEPS INTO THE CASTLE.

THERE WAS NO CHRISTMAS TEA TODAY, AS THE BALL INCLUDED A  
FEAST, SET AT SEVEN O'CLOCK, WHEN IT HAD BECOME HARD TO AIM

AND HARRY POTTTER

PROPERLY, THE OTHERS ABANDONED THEIR SNOWBALL FIGHT AND  
TREMLED BACK TO THE COMMON ROOM. THE FAT LADY WAS SITTING  
IN HER FRAME WITH HER FRIEND VIOLET FROM DOWNSTAIRS, BOTH OF

THEM EXTREMELY TIPSY, EMPTY BEERS OF CHOCOLATE BIKULERS LITTER-  
ING THE BOTTOM OF HER PICTURE.

LAIRY FIGHTS, THAT'S THE ONE! SHE GIGGLED WHEN THEY GAVE THE  
PASSWORD, AND SHE SWUNG HERWARDS TO LET THEM INSIDE.

HARRY, RON, SEamus, DEAN AND NEVILLE CHANGED INTO THEIR

DRESS BEERS UP IN THEIR DORMITORY, ALL OF THEM BEHINDING VERY SELF-  
CONSCIOUS, BUT NONE AS MUCH AS RON, WHO SURVEYED HIMSELF IN

THE LONG MIRROR IN THE CORNER WITH AN APPALLED LOOK ON HIS FACE.  
THERE WAS JUST NO GETTING AROUND THE FACT THAT HIS BEERS LOOKED  
MORE LIKE A DRESS THAN ANYTHING ELSE. IN A DESPERATE ATTEMPT TO  
MAKE THEM LOOK MORE MANLY, HE USED A SEVERING CHARM ON THE



ROOF AND CLIFFS. IT WORKED FAIRLY WELL; AT LEAST HE WAS NEARLY BACK-FREE, ALTHOUGH HE HADN'T DONE A VERY NEAT JOB, AND THE EDGES

STILL LOOKED DEPRESSINGLY FRAYED AS THEY SET OFF DOWNSTAIRS.

I STILL CAN'T WORK OUT WHY YOU TWO GOT THE BEST-LOOKING GIRLS IN THE YEAR, MUTTERED DEAN.

ANIMAL MAGNETISM, SAID RICH GLEEMILY, PULLING STRAY THREADS OUT OF HIS CLOYS.

THE CHAMBER ROOMS LOOKED STRANGE, FULL OF PEOPLE WEARING DIFFERENT CLOTHES INSTEAD OF THE USUAL MASS OF BLACK. PARVATI WAS WAITING FOR HARRY AT THE FOOT OF THE STAIRS. SHE LOOKED VERY PRETTY INDEED, IN ROBES OF SHIMMERING PINK, WITH HER LONG DARK PLAIT BRAIDED WITH GOLD, AND GOLD BRACELETS GLIMMERING AT HER WRISTS. HARRY WAS RELIEVED TO SEE THAT SHE WASN'T GIGGLING.

WELL, ER, LOOK NICE, HE SAID ALGEBRAICALLY.

THANKS, SHE SAID. PADMA'S GOING TO MEET YOU IN THE ENTRANCE HALL. SHE ADDED THE RICH.

RIGHT, SAID RICH, LOOKING AROUND. WHERE'S HERMIONE?

PARVATI SHRUGGED. SHALL WE GO DOWN, THEN, HARRY?

YES, SAID HARRY, WISHING HE COULD JUST STAY IN THE CHAMBER ROOMS. FRED LOOKED AT HARRY AS HE PASSED HIM ON THE WAY OUT OF THE PORTRAIT HOLE.

THE BLUE BALL ROOM

THE ENTRANCE HALL WAS PACKED WITH STUDENTS THEN, ALL MILLING AROUND WAITING FOR LIGHT TO CLICK, WHEN THEY DOORS TO THE GREAT

ALL WOULD BE THROWN OPEN. THESE PEOPLE WHO WERE MEETING PARTNERS FROM DIFFERENT HOUSES WERE EDGING THROUGH THE CROWD, TRYING TO FIND EACH OTHER. PARVATI FOUND HER SISTER PADMA AND LED HER OVER TO HARRY AND REEN.

HI, SAID PADMA, WHO WAS LOOKING JUST AS PRETTY AS PARVATI IN HERES HE BRIGHT TURNED. SHE DIDN'T LOOK TOO ENTHUSIASTIC ABOUT HAVING REEN AS A PARTNER, THOUGH; HER DARK EYES LINGERED ON THE FRAYED NECK AND SLEEVES OF HIS DRESS REEN AS SHE LOOKED HIM UP AND DOWN.

HI, SAID REEN, NOT LOOKING AT HER, BUT STARING AROUND AT THE CROWD. EH, NEH ...

HE BENT HIS KNEES SLIGHTLY TO HIDE BEHIND HARRY, BECAUSE

FLOR DELACOUR WAS PASSING, LOOKING STUNNING IN HERES HE SILVER-GREY SATIN, AND ACCOMPANIED BY THE RAVENCLAW FLEDDITCH

CAPTAIN, REGER DAVIES. WHEN THEY HAD DISAPPEARED, REEN STOOD STRAIGHT AGAIN AND STARED OVER THE HEADS OF THE CROWD.

WHERE IS HERMIONE? HE SAID AGAIN.

A GROUP OF SLYTHERINS CAME UP THE STEPS FROM THEIR DUNGEON COMMON ROOM. MALFOY WAS IN FRONT; HE WAS WEARING DRESS

HERES HE BLACK VELVET WITH A HIGH COLLAR, WHICH IN HARRY'S OPINION MADE HIM LOOK LIKE A VICAR. PANSY PARKINSON WAS CLUTCHING

MALFOY'S ARM, IN VERY FRILLY HERES HE PALE PINK. CRABBE AND

GOYLE WERE BOTH WEARING GREEN; THEY RESEMBLED MESS-LOOKING

CHILDREN, AND NEITHER OF THEM, HARRY WAS PLEASED TO SEE, HAD  
MANAGED TO FIND A PARTNER.

THEir HEAD FRONT DOORS OPENED, AND EVERYONE TURNED THE HEAD AS  
THE DUMSTRANG STUDENTS ENTERED WITH PROFESSOR KARPAGH,  
DORUM WAS AT THE FRONT OF THE PARTY, ACCOMPANIED BY A PRETTY  
GIRL IN BLUE DRESS HARRY DIDN'T KNOW. OVER THEIR HEADS HE SAW

THAT AN AREA OF LAWN RIGHT IN FRONT OF THE CASTLE HAD BEEN TRANS-  
FORMED INTO A SORT OF GREETING HALL OF FAIRY LIGHTS MEANING

HUNDREDS OF ACTUAL LIVING FAIRIES WERE SITTING IN THE BUSHES  
THAT HAD BEEN CHAINED THERE, AND FLUTTERING OVER THE STATUES OF

RED HARRY PETER

WHAT SEEMED TO BE FATHER CHRISTMAS AND HIS REINDEER.

THEN PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL'S VOICE CALLED, CHAMPIONS OVER  
HERE, PLEASE!

PARYATI READJUSTED HER RANGLES, BEAMING; SHE AND HARRY SAID  
SEE YOU IN A MINUTE THE REIN AND PADMA, AND WALKED FORWARD,  
THE CHATTERING CREED PARTING TO LET THEM THROUGH. PROFESSOR  
MCGONAGALL, WHO WAS WEARING DRESS DRESS OF RED TARTAN, AND  
HAD ARRANGED A RATHER LIGLY WREATH OF THISTLES AROUND THE BRIM  
OF HER HAT, TOLD THEM TO WAIT ON ONE SIDE OF THE DOORS WHILE  
EVERYONE ELSE WENT INSIDE; THEY WERE TO ENTER THE GREAT HALL IN  
PROCESSION WHEN THE REST OF THE STUDENTS HAD SAT DOWN. FLEUR  
DELAHUE AND REGIE DAVIES STATIONED THEMSELVES NEAREST THE  
DOORS; DAVIES WHISPERED SHE STUNNED BY HIS GOOD APPEARANCE IN HAVING

FLAUNT HER A PARTNER THAT HE COULD HARDLY TAKE HIS EYES OFF HER, CEDRIC AND LEE WERE CLOSE TO HARRY, THEN; HE LOOKED AWAY FROM THEM SEE HE WOULDN'T HAVE THE TALK THE THEM, HIS EYES FELL INSTEAD ON THE GIRL NEXT TO KILM, HIS JAW DROPPED, IT WAS HERMIONE.

BUT SHE DIDN'T LOOK LIKE HERMIONE AT ALL, SHE HAD BEEN SOMETHING WITH HER HAIR; IT WAS NO LONGER BLOND, BUT SLEEK AND

SHINY, AND TWISTED UP INTO AN ELEGANT KNOT AT THE BACK OF HER HEAD, SHE WAS WEARING RINGS MADE OF A FLUATY, PERIWINKLE-BLUE MATERIAL, AND SHE WAS HOLDING HERSELF DIFFERENTLY, SOMEHOW HER MANNER IT WAS MERELY THE ABSENCE OF THE TWENTY HER SHE KNOWS SHE USUALLY HAD SLING OVER HER BACK, SHE WAS ALSO SMILING RATHER NERVOUSLY, IT WAS TRUE BUT THE REDUCTION IN THE SIZE OF HER FRONT TEETH WAS MORE NOTICEABLE THAN EVER, HARRY COULDN'T UNDERSTAND WHY HE HADN'T SPOTTED IT BEFORE.

HI, HARRY! SHE SAID, HI, PARYATI!

PARYATI WAS GAZING AT HERMIONE IN UNFLATTERING DISBELIEF, SHE WASN'T THE ONLY ONE, EITHER; WHEN THE DOORS TO THE GREAT HALL

OPENED, KILM'S FAN CLUB FROM THE LIBRARY STALKED PAST, THROWING HERMIONE LOOKS OF DEEPEST HEATHENING, PANSY PARKINSON

GAPED AT HER AS SHE WALKED BY WITH MALFOY, AND EVEN HE DIDN'T SEEM TO BE ABLE TO FIND AN INSULT TO THROW AT HER, THEN, HOWEVER,

THE BLUE BALLS

WALKED RIGHT PAST HERMINE WITH-OUT LOOKING AT HER.

UNTIL EVERYONE ELSE WAS SETTLED IN THE HALL, PROFESSOR

MCGEEGALL TOLD THE CHAMPIONS AND THEIR PARTNERS TO GET IN LINE IN PAIRS, AND FOLLOW HER. THEY DID SO, AND EVERYONE IN THE GREAT HALL APPLAUDED AS THEY ENTERED AND STARTED WALKING UP TOWARDS A LARGE ROUND TABLE AT THE TOP OF THE HALL, WHERE THE JUDGES WERE SITTING.

THE WALLS OF THE HALL HAD ALL BEEN COVERED IN SPARKLING SILVER TREES, WITH HUNDREDS OF GARLANDS OF MISTLETOE AND IVY CROSSING THE STARRY BLACK CEILING. THE HIGH TABLES HAD VANISHED; INSTEAD, THERE WERE ABOUT A HUNDRED SMALLER, LANTERN-LIT BENCHES, EACH SEATING ABOUT A DOZEN PEOPLE.

HARRY CONCENTRATED HIS MIND TRIPPING OVER HIS FEET. PARVATI SEEMED TO BE ENJOYING HERSELF; SHE WAS BEAMING AROUND AT EVERYBODY, STEERING HARRY SO PERCEPTIVELY THAT HE FELT AS THOUGH HE WAS A STEADY BEAM SHE WAS PLUTTING THROUGH ITS PAGES. HE CALLED TO REMIND HIM OF PADMA AS HE NEARED THE TOP TABLE. REMIND WAS WATCHING HERMINE PASS WITH NARROWED EYES. PADMA WAS LOOKING SLIDY.

BLUMBERG SMILED HAPPILY AS THE CHAMPIONS APPROACHED THE TOP TABLE BUT DARKLY WHEN AN EXPRESSION REMARKABLY LIKE REMIND'S AS HE WATCHED DORIS AND HERMINE DRAW NEARER. BLUE BAGMAN, TONIGHT IN ROBES OF BRIGHT PURPLE WITH LARGE YELLOW STARS, WAS CLAPPING AS ENTHUSIASTICALLY AS ANY OF THE STUDENTS; AND MADAME MAXIME, WHO HAD CHANGED HER USUAL UNIFORM OF BLACK SATIN FOR A FLOWING GOWN OF LAVENDER SILK, WAS APPLAUDING

THEM POLITELY, BUT MR CRUELICH, HARRY SLIDENLY REALISED, WAS  
NOT THERE. THE FIFTH SEAT AT THE TABLE WAS OCCUPIED BY PERCY  
WEASLEY.

WHEN THE CHAMPIONS AND THEIR PARTNERS REACHED THE TABLE,  
PERCY DREW OUT THE EMPTY CHAIR BESIDE HIM, STARING PEINTEDLY  
AT HARRY. HARRY TOOK THE HINT AND SAT DOWN NEXT THE PERCY, WHO

WAS WEARING BRAND-NEW, NAVY-BLUE DRESS SHOES, AND AN EXPRES-  
SION OF GREAT SMUGNESS.

I'VE BEEN PROMPTED, PERCY SAID, BECAUSE HARRY COULD EVEN

BEAT HARRY BETTER

AND, AND FROM HIS TONE, HE MIGHT HAVE BEEN ANNOUNCING HIS  
ELECTION AS SUPREME RULER OF THE UNIVERSE. I'M NEW MR  
CRUELICH'S PERSONAL ASSISTANT, AND I'M HERE REPRESENTING HIM.

WHY DIDN'T HE COME? HARRY ASKED, HE WASN'T LEAVING HER-  
WARD THE KING DELIVERED HIS CALIBREIN EIGHTHMS ALL THROUGH DINNER.

I'M AFRAID THE SAY MR CRUELICH ISN'T WELL, NOT WELL AT ALL. HADN'T  
BEEN RIGHT SINCE THE WORLD CUP, HARDLY SURPRISING EVERYWHERE.  
HE'S NOT AS YOUNG AS HE WAS - THOUGH STILL WHITE BRILLIANT, OF  
COURSE, THE MIND REMAINS AS GREAT AS IT EVER WAS. BUT THE WORLD  
CUP WAS A FIASCO FOR THE WIZARD MINISTRY, AND THEN MR CRUELICH  
SUFFERED A FLICK PERSONAL STRIKE WITH THE MISERABLENESS OF THAT  
FELLSHIP OF HIS, BLINDLY FOR WHATEVER SHE WAS CALLED. NATURALLY,

HE DISMISSED HER IMMEDIATELY AFTERWARDS, BUT WELL, AS I SAY,  
HE'S GETTING HIM, HE NEEDS WHIPPING AFTER, AND I THINK HE'S FEELING A  
DEFINITE DREDD IN HIS HOME COMFORTS SINCE SHE LEFT, AND THEN WE  
HAD THE THEATREMAN THE ARRANGE, AND THE AFTERMATH OF THE CLIP  
THE DEAL WITH THAT REVOLTING SKEETER WHIMAN BLIZZING AROUND  
NEE, PHEER MAN, HE'S HAVING A WELL-EARNED, HOLIEST CHRISTMAS, I'M  
JUST GLAD HE KNOWS HE HAD SOMEONE HE COULD RELY UPON WHEN HE TOOK  
HIS PLACE.

HARRY WANTED VERY MUCH TO ASK WHETHER MR CREELICH HAD

STOPPED CALLING PERCY WEATHERS YET, BUT RESISTED THE TEMPTA-  
TION.

THERE WAS NEE FOOD AS YET WHEN THE GLITTERING GOLDEN PLATES, BUT  
SMALL MENUS LYING IN FRONT OF EACH OF THEM, HARRY PICKED HIS  
UP UNCERTAINLY, AND LOOKED AROUND THERE WERE NEE WAITERS,  
DUMMEDEHRE, HOWEVER, LOOKED CAREFULLY DOWN HIS OWN MENU,  
THEN SAID VERY CLEARLY TO HIS PLATE, PERKS CHIPS?  
AND PERKS CHIPS APPEARED, GETTING THE IDEA, THE REST OF THE  
TABLE PLACED THEIR ORDERS WITH THEIR PLATES, THEN, HARRY GLANCED  
UP AT FERMINE TO SEE HOW SHE FELT ABOUT THIS NEW AND MORE  
COMPLICATED METHOD OF DINING SURELY IT MEANT PLenty OF EXTRA  
WORK FOR THE FILLIS-FLVES? BUT, PER HENCE, FERMINE DIDN'T  
SEEM TO BE THINKING ABOUT S.P.L.W. SHE WAS DEEP IN TALK WITH  
VICTOR KILBY, AND HARDLY SEEMED TO NOTICE WHAT SHE WAS EATING.

THE BLUE BALLS

IT NOW RECALLED THE STORY THAT HE HAD NEVER ACTUALLY HEARD  
GRIFFIN SPEAK BEFORE, BUT HE WAS CERTAINLY TALKING NOW, AND VERY  
ENTHUSIASTICALLY AT THAT.

WELL, WE HAVE A CASTLE ALSO, NOT AS BIG AS THIS, NOT AS COMFORT-  
ABLE, I AM THINKING, HE WAS TELLING HERMIONE. WE HAVE JUST

SEVERAL FLAMES, AND THE FIRES ARE LIT ONLY FOR MAGICAL PURPOSES, BUT  
WE HAVE GREENLANDS LARGER EVEN THAN THESE THOUGH IN WINTER, WE  
HAVE VERY LITTLE DAYLIGHT, SO WE ARE NOT ENJOYING THEM, BUT IN

SUMMER WE ARE FLYING EVERY DAY, OVER THE LADES AND THE MOUNTAINS

NOW, NOW, FURTHER? SAID KARKADANN, WITH A LAUGH THAT DIDN'T  
REACH HIS CHILD EYES. DIDN'T HE BE GIVING AWAY ANYTHING ELSE, NOW,  
HIS OTHER CHARMING FRIEND WILL KNOW EXACTLY WHERE THE FINE LIST  
DRUMLEDGHE SMILED, HIS EYES TWINKLING. ICHER, ALL THIS SECRETLY  
... HE'LL WOULD ALMOST THINK SHE DIDN'T WANT VISITORS.

WELL, DRUMLEDGHE, SAID KARKADANN, DISPLAYING HIS YELLOWING  
TEETH TO THEIR FULLEST EXTENT, WE ARE ALL PROTECTIVE OF OUR PRIVATE  
DOMAINS, ARE WE NOT? OH WE NOT IRACUNDLY GUARD THE HALLS OF  
LEARNING THAT HAVE BEEN ENTRUSTED TO US? ARE WE NOT RIGHT TO BE  
PROUD THAT WE ALONE KNOW OUR SCHOOL'S SECRETS, AND RIGHT TO  
PROTECT THEM?

YES, I WOULD NEVER DREAM OF ASSUMING I KNOW ALL HOGWARTS  
SECRETS, ICHER, SAID DRUMLEDGHE AMICABLY. ONLY THIS MORNING,



FOR INSTANCE, I THREW A WORMING TURNING IN THE WAY THE THE RATH-  
REHM AND FEELING MYSELF IN A BEAUTIFULLY PREPARED REHM I

HAVE NEVER SEEN BEFORE, CONTAINING A REALLY RATHER MAGNIFICENT  
COLLECTION OF CHAMBERPOTS. WHEN I WENT BACK TO INVESTIGATE  
MORE CLOSELY, I DISCOVERED THAT THE REHM HAD VANISHED, BUT I  
MUST KEEP AN EYE OUT FOR IT, POSSIBLY IT IS ONLY ACCESSIBLE AT FIVE  
THIRTY IN THE MORNING, FOR IT MAY ONLY APPEAR AT THE ELIANTER  
MOUNTAIN WHEN THE SEEDER HAS AN EXCEPTIONALLY FULL BLADDER.  
HARRY SNEEZED INTO HIS PLATE OF GELATIN, PERCY FROWNED, BUT  
HARRY COULD HAVE SWORN DUMBLEDORE HAD GIVEN HIM A VERY  
SMALL WIND.

MEANWHILE FLEUR DELACOUR WAS CRITICISING THE FLEWARTS

KEY HARRY PETER

DECLARATION THE REGER DAVIES.

THIS IS NOTHING, SHE SAID DISMISSIVELY, LEANING AGAINST THE  
SPARKLING WALLS OF THE GREAT HALL. AT THE PALACE OF REALIZATION,  
WE HAVE ICE SCULPTURES ALL AROUND THE DINING CHAMBER AT  
CHRISTMAS. THEY DO NOT MELT, OF COURSE ... THEY ARE LIKE LICE  
STATUES OF DIAMOND, GLITTERING AROUND THE PLACE, AND THE FLOOR IS  
SIMPLY SLIPPERY. AND WE HAVE CHAIRS OF WIND-NYMPHS, THE  
SERENADE LIES AS WE EAT. WE HAVE NEENE OF THE LITTLE ARMCHAIR IN THE  
HALL, AND FOR A PEELERIST EVER ENTRAINED INTO REALIZATION, I  
WOULD BE EXPELLED LIKE THAT. SHE SLAPPED HER HAND INTO THE  
TABLE IMPATIENTLY.

ROGER DAVIES WAS WATCHING HER TALK WITH A VERY DAZED LOOK  
ON HIS FACE, AND HE KEPT MISSING HIS BEATH WITH HIS HAND.  
HARRY HAD THE IMPRESSION THAT DAVIES WAS THEM ELISY STARING AT  
FELIX THE TALK IN A MERE SHE WAS SAYING.

ABSOLUTELY RIGHT, HE SAID QUICKLY, SLAPPING HIS OWN HAND  
DOWN ON THE TABLE IN IMITATION OF FELIX. LIKE THAT, YES.  
HARRY WHEEZED AROUND THE HALL. HAGRID WAS SITTING AT ONE OF  
THE OTHER STAFF TABLES; HE WAS BACK IN HIS HORRIBLE HAIRY GREEN  
SUIT, AND GAZING UP AT THE THE TABLE. HARRY SAW HIM GIVE A SMALL  
WAVE AND, WHEEZING AROUND, SAW MADAME MAXIME RETURN IT, HER  
EYES GLITTERING IN THE CANDLELIGHT.

HERMIONE WAS NOW TEACHING DRUM THE SAY HER NAME PROPER-  
LY; HE KEPT CALLING HER HERMY-OWN.

HER MY OWN NEE, SHE SAID, SLEENLY AND CLEARLY.

HERM OWN NINNY.

PLEASE ENOUGH, SHE SAID, CATCHING HARRY'S EYE AND GRINNING.  
WHEN ALL THE FOOD HAD BEEN CONSUMED, DUMBLEDORE STOOD  
UP AND ASKED THE STUDENTS THE DO THE SAME. THEN, AT A WAVE OF  
HIS WAND, THE TABLES ZOOMED BACK ALONG THE WALLS, LEAVING THE  
FLOOR CLEAR, AND THEN HE CONJURED A RAISED PLATFORM INTO  
EXISTENCE ALONG THE RIGHT-HAND WALL. A SET OF DRUMS, SEVERAL  
GUITARS, A LUKE, A CLARINET AND SOME BAGPIPES WERE SET UPON IT.  
THE WEIRD SISTERS NOW TREMPED UP ONTO THE STAGE THE WILDLY  
ENTHUSIASTIC APPLAUSE; THEY WERE ALL EXTREMELY HAIRY, AND

THEY PLUCKED THEM

DRESSED IN BLACK ROBES THAT HAD BEEN ARTFULLY RIPPED AND TORN.  
THEY PICKED UP THEIR INSTRUMENTS, AND HARRY, WHO HAD BEEN SO  
INTERESTED IN WATCHING THEM THAT HE HAD ALMOST FORGOTTEN WHAT  
WAS HAPPENING, SUDDENLY REALISED THAT THE LANTERNS ON ALL THE  
BUTTER TABLES HAD BEEN ELIT, AND THAT THE BUTTER CHAMPIONS AND  
THEIR PARTNERS WERE STANDING UP.

THEY HAD PARVATI MISSED. HE RE-SLIPPED THE DANCE.

HARRY TRIPPED OVER HIS DRESS ROBES AS HE STOOD UP. THE WEIRD  
SISTERS STRUCK UP A SLOW, MELANCHOLIC TUNE. HARRY WALKED BENT THE  
BRIGHTLY LIT DANCE FLOOR, CAREFULLY AVOIDING CATCHING ANYONE'S

EYE (HE COULD SEE SEAMUS AND DEAN GLANCING AT HIM AND SNIG-  
GERING), AND NEXT MOMENT, PARVATI HAD SEIZED HIS HANDS,

PLACED ONE AROUND HER WAIST, AND WAS HOLDING THE OTHER TIGHTLY  
IN HER.

IT WASN'T AS BAD AS IT COULD HAVE BEEN. HARRY THOUGHT,  
REVOLVING SLOWLY IN THE SPOT (PARVATI WAS STEERING). HE KEPT  
HIS EYES FIXED OVER THE HEADS OF THE WATCHING PEOPLE, AND VERY  
SOON MANY OF THEM, WHO HAD COME INTO THE DANCE FLOOR, SAW  
THAT THE CHAMPIONS WERE NO LONGER THE CENTRE OF ATTENTION.  
NEVILLE AND GINNY WERE DANCING NEARBY. HE COULD SEE GINNY  
WINKING FREQUENTLY AS NEVILLE TRIED TO HER FEET. AND  
DUMBLEDORE WAS WALTZING WITH MADAME MAXIME. HE WAS SO  
DWARFED BY HER THAT THE TOP OF HIS POINTED HAT BARELY TOUCHED  
HER CHIN. HOWEVER, SHE MOVED VERY GRACEFULLY FOR A WOMAN SO

LARGE, MAD-EYE MURPHY WAS BEING AN EXTREMELY UNCAUTIOUS TWEED-STEP WITH PROFESSOR SINISTRA, WHO WAS NERVOUSLY AVOIDING HIS WHIPPED LEG.

NICE SOUNDS, PETER, MURPHY GROWLED AS HE PASSED, HIS MAGICAL EYE STARING THROUGH HARRY'S REEKS.

HEY! YEAH, THANKS THE FELLOW-ER DENIED THEM FOR ME, SAID HARRY, GRINNING.

HE IS SO CREEPY! PARVATI WHISPERED, AS MURPHY CLIMBED AWAY. I DON'T THINK THAT EYE SHOULD BE ALLOWED!

HARRY HEARD THE FINAL, UNLAYERING NOTE FROM THE BAGPIPE WITH RELIEF. THE WEIRD SISTERS STOPPED PLAYING, APPLAUSE FILLED THE

ROOM HARRY PETER

I'LL HIDE HERE, AND HARRY LET GO OF PARVATI AT ONCE. LET'S SIT DOWN, SHALL WE?

HEY! BUT THIS IS A REALLY GOOD ONE! PARVATI SAID, AS THE WEIRD SISTERS STRUCK UP A NEW SONG, WHICH WAS MUCH FASTER. NO, I DON'T LIKE IT, HARRY LIED, AND HE LED HER AWAY FROM THE DANCE FLOOR, PAST FRED AND ANGELINA, WHO WERE DANCING SO EXUBERANTLY THAT PEOPLE AROUND THEM WERE BACKING AWAY FOR FEAR OF INJURY, AND OVER THE TABLE WHERE RON AND PADMA WERE SITTING.

HOW IS IT GOING? HARRY ASKED RON, SITTING DOWN AND HYPHENING

A LITTLE OF BLITTERBEE.

REHN DIDN'T ANSWER, HE WAS GLARING AT HERMINE AND DORIS, WHO WERE DANCING NEARBY. PADMA WAS SITTING WITH HER ARMS AND LEGS CROSSED, HEN SHE WAS DANCING IN TIME TO THE MUSIC. EVERY WHEN AND THEN SHE THREW A DISGUNTLED GLANCE AT REHN, WHO WAS COMPLETELY IGNORING HER. PARVATI SAT DOWN IN HARRY'S OTHER SIDE, CROSSED HER ARMS AND LEGS TOO, AND WITHIN MINUTES, WAS ASKED TO DANCE BY A KID FROM KALAKATHAS.

WELL DIDN'T MIND, DID YOU, HARRY? PARVATI SAID.

WHAT? SAID HARRY, WHO WAS NOW WATCHING LEE AND CEDRIC.

HE, NEVER MIND, SNAPPED PARVATI, AND SHE WENT OFF WITH THE KID FROM KALAKATHAS. WHEN THE SONG ENDED, SHE DID NOT RETURN. HERMINE CAME OVER AND SAT DOWN IN PARVATI'S EMPTY CHAIR. SHE WAS A BIT PINK IN THE FACE FROM DANCING.

HI, SAID HARRY. REHN DIDN'T SAY ANYTHING.

IT'S HOT, ISN'T IT? SAID HERMINE, FANNING HERSELF WITH HER HAND. WOULD YOU JUST GO AND GET SOME DRINKS.

REHN GAVE HER A WITHERING GLANCE.

WOULD YOU? HE SAID. HASN'T HE ASKED YOU TO CALL HIM VICKY YET? HERMINE GLANCED AT HIM IN SURPRISE.

WHAT'S UP WITH YOU? SHE SAID.

IF YOU DIDN'T KNOW, SAID REHN SCATHINGLY, I'M NOT GOING TO TELL YOU.

HERMINE STARED AT HIM, THEN AT HARRY, WHO SHRUGGED. REHN, WHAT?

THE BLUE BALLS

HE'S FROM DUMSTRANG! SPAT REEN. HE'S COMPETING AGAINST  
HARRY! AGAINST THEGLARTS! YELL YELL RE REEN WAS HEAVILY  
LASTING AROUND HER WORDS STRONG ENOUGH TO DESCRIBE  
HERMIONE'S CRIME, FRATERNISING WITH THE ENEMY, THAT'S WHAT  
YELL RE DOING!

HERMIONE'S MOUTH FELL OPEN.

WHEN WAS SHE STUPID! SHE SAID AFTER A MOMENT. THE ENEMY?  
HONESTLY WHEN WAS THE HEN WHEN WAS ALL EXCITED WHEN THEY  
SAW HIM ARRIVE? WHEN WAS THE HEN WHEN WANTED HIS AUTOGRAPH?  
WHEN SHE GOT A MODEL OF HIM UP IN THEIR DORMITORY?  
REEN CHEESE THE IGNORANCE THIS. I'M SURE HE ASKED YELL THE NAME  
WITH HIM WHILE YELL WERE BOTH IN THE LIBRARY?

YES, HE DID, SAID HERMIONE, THE PINK PATCHES ON HER CHEEKS  
GLOWING MORE BRIGHTLY. SHE WHAT?

WHAT HAPPENED TRYING TO GET HIM THE IRON SPIN, WERE YELL?  
NO, I WASN'T! IF YELL REALLY WANT THE BOOKS, HE HE SAID HE'D  
BEEN COMING UP TO THE LIBRARY EVERY DAY TO TRY AND TALK TO ME,  
BUT HE HADN'T BEEN ABLE TO PULL UP THE COURAGE!

HERMIONE SAID THIS VERY QUICKLY, AND REALISED SHE DEEPLY THAT  
SHE WAS THE SAME CHELSEA AS PARVATI'S REEKS.

YEAH, WELL THAT'S HIS STORY, SAID REEN NASTILY.

AND WHAT'S THAT SUPPOSED TO MEAN?

HEAVENS, ISN'T IT? HE'S DARRABEE'S STUDENT, ISN'T HE? HE  
BOOKS WHEN YELL HANG AROUND WITH ... HE'S JUST TRYING TO GET  
CLOSER TO HARRY TO GET INSIDE INFORMATION ON HIM HE GETS NEAR  
ENOUGH TO KISS HIM

HERMIONE WHISPERED AS THOUGH REEN HAD SLAPPED HER. WHEN SHE

SPHERE, HER VOICE DELIVERED, HER OTHER INFORMATION, HE HADN'T  
ASKED ME ONE SINGLE THING ABOUT HARRY, NOT ONE  
THEN CHANGED TRACK AT THE SPEED OF LIGHT. THEN HE'S HELPING  
THEY'LL HELP HIM FIND OUT WHAT HIS EGG MEANS? I SUSPECT THEY'VE  
BEEN PLOTTING THEIR HEADS TOGETHER DURING THESE CHESS LITTLE  
LIBRARY SESSIONS

I'D NEVER HELP HIM WORK OUT THAT EGG? SAID HERMIONNE, WHIS-  
PERING MURMURED. NEVER, THEY'LL NEVER THEY SAY SOMETHING LIKE THAT

THE HARRY POTTER

I WANT HARRY TO WIN THE TOURNAMENT. HARRY KNOWS THAT, DOESN'T  
THEY, HARRY?

THEY'VE GOT A PLANNED WAY OF STEALING IT, SNEAKED THEN,

THIS WHOLE TOURNAMENT'S SUPPOSED TO BE ABOUT GETTING THE  
KNOWLEDGE FOREIGN WIZARDS AND MAKING FRIENDS WITH THEM? SAID  
HERMIONNE SHRILLY.

NO, IT ISN'T? SHOUTED THEN. IT'S ABOUT WINNING?

PEOPLE WERE STARTING TO STARE AT THEM.

THEN, SAID HARRY QUIETLY, I HAVEN'T GOT A PROBLEM WITH  
HERMIONNE COMING WITH DRUM

BUT THEN IGNORED HARRY THEM.

WHY DOESN'T THEY GO AND FIND VICKY, HE'LL BE WONDERING WHERE  
THEY ARE, SAID THEN.

DOESN'T CALL HIM VICKY? HERMIONNE JUMPED UP HER FEET, AND  
STORMED OFF ACROSS THE DANCE FLOOR, DISAPPEARING INTO THE  
CROWD.

REHN WATCHED HER GO WITH A MIXTURE OF ANGER AND  
SATISFACTION ON HIS FACE.

ARE YOU GOING TO ASK ME TO DANCE AT ALL? PADMA ASKED HIM.

NO, SAID REHN, STILL GLARING AFTER HER.

FINE, SNAPPED PADMA, AND SHE GOT UP AND WENT TO JOIN  
PARVATI AND THE REALIZATION OF WHY, WHEN CONSIDERED UP HERE BY HIS  
FRIENDS THE JOIN THEM SEE FAST THAT HARRY WOULD HAVE SEEN HE  
HAD ZIPPED HIM THERE BY A SLIGHTENING CHARM.

WAS IT HERMION-NINNY? SAID A VOICE.

DRUM HAD JUST ARRIVED AT THEIR TABLE CLUTCHING TWO  
CLUTTERS.

NO IDEA, SAID REHN MOLLISHLY, LEERING UP AT HIM, LEIST HER,  
HAVE YOU?

DRUM WAS LEERING SLURRY AGAIN.

WELL, IF YOU SEE HER, TELL HER I HAVE DRINKS, HE SAID, AND HE  
SMILED OFF.

MADE FRIENDS WITH VICTOR DRUM, HAVE YOU, REHN?

PERCY HAD LISTED EVER, RUBBING HIS HANDS TOGETHER AND  
LEERING EXTREMELY POMPILIS. EXCELLENT! THAT IS THE WHOLE

THE BLUE BALL KEY

POINT, YOU KNOW INTERNATIONAL MAGICAL COOPERATION?

THE HARRY'S ARRIVAL, PERCY PROMPTLY TOOK PADMA'S VACATED  
SEAT. THE TWO TABLE WAS NOW EMPTY; PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE WAS  
DANCING WITH PROFESSOR SPRELLT; LUDWIG BAGMAN, WITH PROFESSOR  
MCGONAGALL; MADAME MAXIME AND HAGRID WERE CUTTING A WIDE  
PATH AROUND THE DANCE FLOOR AS THEY WALTZED THROUGH THE



STUDENTS AND BARBARA WAS NOWHERE TO BE SEEN. WHEN THE NEXT SHOE ENDED, EVERYBODY APPLAUDED HIM MORE, AND HARRY SAW LUDWIG BAGMAN KISS PROFESSOR MCGEEVAGALL'S HAND AND MAKE HIS WAY BACK THROUGH THE CROWDS, AT WHICH POINT FRED AND GEORGE ACCOSTED HIM.

WHAT DO THEY THINK THEY'RE DOING, ANSWERING SENIOR MINISTRY MEMBERS? PERCY HISSED, WATCHING FRED AND GEORGE SUSPICIOUSLY. NO RESPECT ...

LUDWIG BAGMAN SMILED UP FRED AND GEORGE FAIRLY NICKELY, HOWEVER, AND, SPITTING HARRY, WAVED AND CAME OVER THE THEIR TABLE.

I HOPE MY BROTHERS WEREN'T BOTHERING YOU, MR BAGMAN? SAID PERCY AT ONCE.

WHAT? EH, NOT AT ALL, NOT AT ALL? SAID BAGMAN. NO, THEY WERE JUST TELLING ME A BIT MORE ABOUT THESE FINE WANDS OF THEIRS, WONDERING IF I COULD ADVISE THEM IN THE MARKETING. I'VE PROMISED TO PUT THEM IN TOUCH WITH A COUPLE OF CONTACTS OF MINE AT ZENON'S LITTLE SHOP ...

PERCY DIDN'T LOOK HAPPY ABOUT THIS AT ALL, AND HARRY WAS PREPARED THE BEST HE COULD BE WISHING TO TELL MRS WEASLEY ABOUT IT

THE MOMENT HE GOT HOME. APPARENTLY FRED AND GEORGE'S PLANS HAD GROWN EVEN MORE AMBITIOUS LATELY, IF THEY WERE PLANNING TO SELL THEM TO THE PUBLIC.

RAGMAN OPENED HIS MOUTH TO ASK HARRY SOMETHING, BUT PERCY DIVERTED HIM. HE'D BE WELL FEEL THE TOURNAMENT IS GOING, MR RAGMAN? HELIX DEPARTMENT IS WHITE SATISFIED THE FITCH WITH

THE CRACKLE OF FIRE HE GLANCED AT HARRY WAS A LITTLE UNFORTUNATE, OF COURSE, BUT IT SEEMS TO HAVE BEEN VERY SUCCESSFUL SINCE,

WHEN I WAS THINKING?

AND HARRY PETER

HEH, YES, RAGMAN SAID CHEERFULLY, IT'S ALL BEEN ENORMOUSLY FLIN, HE'S A GOOD PARTY GIVING? SHAME HE COULDN'T COME.

HEH, I'M SURE MR CRACKLE WILL BE UP AND ABOUT IN NO TIME, SAID PERCY IMPORTANTLY, BUT IN THE MEANTIME, I'M MORE THAN WILLING TO TAKE UP THE SLACK, OF COURSE, IT'S NOT ALL ATTENDING BILLS HE LAUGHED AIRILY HEH, NO, I'VE HAD THE DEAL WITH ALL SORTS OF THINGS THAT HAVE CREEPED UP IN HIS ABSENCE WELL HEARD

ALI RASHID WAS CALLED SPOILING A COMMITMENT OF FLYING CARPETS INTO THE COUNTRY? AND THEN WE'VE BEEN TRYING TO PERSUADE

THE TRANSYLVANIANS TO SIGN THE INTERNATIONAL BAN ON DWELLING, I'VE GOTTEN A MEETING WITH THEIR HEAD OF MAGICAL COOPERATION IN THE NEW YEAR

LET'S GO FOR A WALK, RICH MUTTERED TO HARRY, GET AWAY FROM PERCY ...

PRETENDING THEY WANTED MORE DRINKS, HARRY AND RICH LEFT THE

TABLE, EDGED AROUND THE DANCE FLOOR AND SLIPPED RIGHT INTO THE ENTRANCE HALL. THE FRONT DOORS STOOD OPEN, AND THE FLUTTERING FAIRY LIGHTS IN THE ROSE GARDEN WINKED AND TWINKLED AS THEY

WENT DOWN THE FRONT STEPS, WHERE THEY FOUND THEMSELVES SURROUNDED BY BUSHES, WINDING ORNAMENTAL PATHS, AND LARGE STONE

STATUES. HARRY COULD HEAR SPLASHING WATER, WHICH SEEMED LIKE A FOUNTAIN. HERE AND THERE, PEOPLE WERE SITTING ON CARVED BENCHES. HE AND RON SET OFF ALONG ONE OF THE WINDING PATHS THROUGH THE ROSE BUSHES, BUT THEY HAD GONE ONLY A SHORT WAY WHEN THEY HEARD AN UNPLEASANTLY FAMILIAR VOICE.

... DON'T SEE WHAT THERE IS TO BE AHEAD, ICH.

SEVERUS, YOU CAN'T PRETEND THIS ISN'T HAPPENING!

BARBARUS'S VOICE SEEMED ANXIOUS AND FLUTTERING, AS THOUGH BEEN NOT THE BE HEARD. IT'S BEEN GETTING CLEARER AND CLEARER FOR MONTHS. I AM BECOMING SERIOUSLY CONCERNED, I CAN'T DENY IT

THEN FLEE, SAID SNAPE'S VOICE COLDLY. FLEE, I WILL MAKE YOUR EXILES, I, HOWEVER, AM REMAINING AT HOGWARTS.

SNAPE AND BARBARUS CAME AROUND THE CORNER. SNAPE HAD HIS HAND OUT, AND WAS PULVING ROSE BUSHES APART, HIS EXPRESSION MOST UNPLEASANT. SEVERUS ISSUED FROM MANY OF THE BUSHES, AND

THE BLUE BALLS

DARK SHAPES EMERGED FROM THEM.

TEN POINTS FROM HUFFLEPUFF, FALCETT! SNAPE SNARLED, AS A GIRL RAN PAST HIM. AND TEN POINTS FROM RAVENCLAW, THE

STERKINS? AS A KID WENT RUSHING AFTER HER. AND WHAT ARE YOU  
TALKING? HE ADDED, CATCHING SIGHT OF HARRY AND RON ON THE  
PATH AHEAD. KARKADENN, HARRY SAW, LOOKED SLIGHTLY DISCOMFISED  
TO SEE THEM STANDING THERE. HIS HAND WENT NERVOUSLY TO HIS  
CHEST, AND HE BEGAN WINDING IT AROUND HIS FINGER AGAIN.

WE'RE WALKING, RON TOLD SNAPE SHORTLY. NOT AGAINST THE LAW,  
IS IT?

KEEP WALKING, THEN? SNAPE SNARLED, AND HE RUSHED PAST  
THEM, HIS LONG BLACK CLOAK KILLING HIM BEHIND HIM. KARKADENN  
HURRIED AWAY AFTER SNAPE. HARRY AND RON CONTINUED DOWN THE  
PATH.

WHAT'S GET KARKADENN ALL HURRIED? RON MUTTERED.

AND SINCE WHEN HAVE HE AND SNAPE BEEN ON FIRST-NAME  
TERMS? SAID HARRY SLEELY.

THEY HAD REACHED A LARGE STONE REINDEER HILL, OVER WHICH

THEY COULD SEE THE SPARKLING PITS OF A TALL MOUNTAIN. THE SHA-  
DOWY SILHOUETTES OF TWO ENORMOUS PEOPLE WERE VISIBLE ON A STONE

BENCH, WATCHING THE WATER IN THE MOONLIGHT. AND THEN HARRY  
HEARD JACOB SPEAK.

WHEN I SAW YOU, I KNEW, HE WAS SAYING, IN AN HOPE-  
FUL VOICE.

HARRY AND RON FREEZE. THIS DIDN'T SOUND LIKE THE SORT OF SCENE  
THEY WOULD FIND IN AN, SOMEHOW ... HARRY LOOKED AROUND,  
BACK UP THE PATH, AND SAW FLEUR DELACOUR AND REGGIE DAVIES  
STANDING HALF-CONCEALED IN A BUSH CLUST NEARBY. HE TAPPED RON

HEW THE SHIELDER AND TERNED HIS HEAD THEWARDS THEM, MEANING  
THAT THEY COULD EASILY SNEAK OFF THAT WAY WITHOUT BEING NOTICED  
(FLOR AND DAVIES WHEEED VERY CLOSE THE HARRY) BUT THEN, EYES

WIDENING IN HORROR AT THE SIGHT OF FLOR, SEENED HIS HEAD VIGOR-  
OUSLY, AND PULLED HARRY DEEPER INTO THE SHADOWS BEHIND THE

REINDEER.

WHAT DID YOU KNOW, AGRI? SAID MADAME MAXIME, A

THE HARRY PENTTER

DISTINCT FLOR IN HER NEW VEHICLE.

HARRY DEFINITELY DIDN'T WANT TO LISTEN TO THIS; HE KNEW AGRI  
WOULD HATE TO BE OVERHEARD IN A SITUATION LIKE THIS (HE CERTAINLY  
WOULD HAVE DONE! IF IT HAD BEEN POSSIBLE HE WOULD HAVE PLUG

HIS FINGERS IN HIS EARS AND PLUMPED LOUDLY, BUT THAT WASN'T REAL-  
LY AN OPTION. INSTEAD HE TRIED TO INTEREST HIMSELF IN A BEETLE

CRAWLING ALONG THE STONE REINDEER'S BACK, BUT THE BEETLE JUST  
WASN'T INTERESTING ENOUGH TO BLOCK OUT AGRI'S NEXT WORDS.

I US KNOW ... KNOW YOU WERE LIKE ME ... WAS IT YOUR MOTHER  
OR YOUR FATHER?

I I DIDN'T KNOW WHAT YOU MEAN, AGRI ...

IT WAS MY MOTHER, SAID AGRI BLITELY. SHE WAS HERE IN THE  
LAST HOURS IN BRITAIN. UNLIKE, I CAN REMEMBER HER THEN WELL ...  
SHE LEFT, SEE. WHEN I WAS ABOUT THREE, SHE WASN'T REALLY THE

MATERNAL SHIRT, WELL ... IT'S NOT IN THEIR NATURES, IS IT? BLINDNESS  
WHAT HAPPENED TO HER ... MIGHT BE DEAD FOR ALL I KNOW ...

MADAME MAXIME DIDN'T SAY ANYTHING, AND HARRY, IN SPITE OF  
HIMSELF, THREW HIS EYES OFF THE KEETLE, AND WHISKED OVER THE TOP OF  
THE REINDEER'S ANTLERS, LISTENING ... HE HAD NEVER HEARD HAGRID  
TALK ABOUT HIS CHILDHOOD BEFORE.

MY DAD WAS KIDDERN-HEARTED WHEN SHE WEN, TINY LITTLE  
KIDDER, MY DAD WAS, BY THE TIME I WAS SIX I COULD LIFT HIM UP AND  
PUT HIM IN THE DRESSER IF HE ANNOYED ME, USED TO MAKE  
HIM LAUGH ... HAGRID'S DEEP VOICE KIDDER, MADAME MAXIME WAS  
LISTENING, MEANTIMELESS, APPARENTLY STARING AT THE SILVERY MOUNTAINS.

DAD RAISED ME ... BUT HE DIED, IN CHURCH, ILS AFTER I STARTED  
SCHOOL, SHEET-A HAD TO MAKE ME BELIEVE AFTER THAT, DUMBLEDORE  
WAS A REAL HELP, MIND, VERY KIND TO ME, HE WAS ...

HAGRID PULLED OUT A LARGE, SPOTTED SILK HANDKERCHIEF AND  
BLEW HIS NOSE HEAVILY, SHE ... ANYWAY ... KIDDERN ABOUT ME,

WHAT ABOUT THEM? WHICH SIDE WOULD GET IT FIRST?

BUT MADAME MAXIME HAD SLIDDERNLY GOTTEN THE HER FEET.

IT IS CHILLY, SHE SAID BUT WHATEVER THE WEATHER WAS BEING,  
IT WAS NOWHERE NEAR AS CHILLY AS HER VOICE, I THINK I WILL GET IN  
NOW.

THE BLUE BALLS

LET SAID HAGRID BLANDLY, NOW, THEN GET I UP I UP NEVER MET  
ANOTHER ONE BEFORE?

ANALYZER WHAT, PRECISELY? SAID MADAME MAXIME, HER TONGUE  
IT.

HARRY COULD HAVE TOLD LACRID IT WAS BEST NOT THE ANSWER; HE  
STOOD THERE IN THE SHADOWS, GRITTING HIS TEETH, LEANING AGAINST  
HOPPE HE WOULDNT BUT IT WAS NOT GOOD.

ANOTHER HALF-GIANT, HE THOUGHT SAID LACRID.

HIS DARK VEIL STRUCK MADAME MAXIME, HER VEHICLE  
EXPLODED THROUGH THE PEACEFUL NIGHT AIR LIKE A FEATHER; BEHIND  
HIM, HARRY HEARD FLEUR AND RENEE FALL BUT NOT THEIR BODIES CLASH. I  
AVE NEVER BEEN MORE INSULTED IN MY LIFE! HALF-GIANT? MEH? I  
AVE I AVE BIG EYES!

SHE STORMED AWAY; GREAT MULTI-COLOURED SWARMS OF FAIRIES  
RUSH INTO THE AIR AS SHE PASSED, ANGERILY PUSHING ASIDE CLUSTERS.  
LACRID WAS STILL SITTING ON THE BENCH, STARING AFTER HER. IT WAS  
MUCH TOO DARK TO MAKE OUT HIS EXPRESSION. THEN, AFTER ABOUT A  
MINUTE, HE STOOD UP AND STRODE AWAY, NOT BACK TO THE CASTLE,  
BUT OFF INTO THE DARK GARDENS IN THE DIRECTION OF HIS CABIN.

[ MEH, HARRY SAID, VERY QUIETLY TO RENEE. LET S GO ...

BUT RENEE DIDNT MOVE.

WHAT S UP? SAID HARRY, LOOKING AT HIM.

RENEE LOOKED AROUND AT HARRY, HIS EXPRESSION VERY SERIOUS  
INDEED.

DID YOU KNOW? HE WHISPERED, ABOUT LACRID BEING HALF-  
GIANT?

NEH, HARRY SAID, SMILING. SEE WHAT?

HE KNEW IMMEDIATELY FROM THE LOOK RENEE WAS GIVING HIM,  
THAT HE WAS ONCE AGAIN REVEALING HIS IGNORANCE OF THE WIZARDING

WORLD, BRIGHT LIP BY THE DURSLEYS, THERE WERE MANY THINGS THAT WIZARDS THEMSELVES GRANTED THAT WERE REVELATIONS TO HARRY, BUT THESE SURPRISES HAD BECOME FEWER AS HE HAD MOVED UP THE SCHOOL. NOW, HOWEVER, HE COULD TELL THAT MOST WIZARDS WOULD NOT HAVE SAID 'SEE WHAT?' UPON FINDING OUT THAT ONE OF THEIR FRIENDS HAD A GIANTESS FOR A MOTHER.

BY HARRY POTTER

I'LL EXPLAIN INSIDE, SAID RON QUIETLY. I MEAN ...

FLEUR AND RIGER DAVIES HAD DISAPPEARED, PROBABLY INTO A MORE PRIVATE CLOMP OF KISSES. HARRY AND RON RETURNED TO THE GREAT HALL. PARYATI AND PADMA WERE NOW SITTING AT A DISTANT TABLE WITH A WHOLE CROWD OF REALIZATION KIDS, AND HERMIONE WAS NOW MORE DANCING WITH KALIM. HARRY AND RON SAT DOWN AT A TABLE FAR REMOVED FROM THE DANCE FLOOR.

SEE? HARRY PROMPTED RON. WHAT'S THE PROBLEM WITH GIANTS?

WELL, THEY'RE ... THEY'RE ... RON STRUGGLED FOR WORDS, NOT VERY NICE, HE FINISHED LAMELY.

WHICH CARES? HARRY SAID. THERE'S SOMETHING WRONG WITH HAGRID?

I KNOW THERE ISN'T, BUT ... KIMMY, NOW WHENEVER HE KEEPS IT QUIET, RON SAID, SHAKING HIS HEAD. I ALWAYS THOUGHT HE'D GOTTEN IN THE WAY OF A BAD ENLARGEMENT CHARM WHEN HE WAS A KID FOR SOMETHING. DIDN'T LIKE TO MENTION IT ...

BUT WHAT'S IT MATTER IF HIS MOTHER WAS A GIANTESS? SAID HARRY.

WELL ... NOW WHENEVER KNOWS HIM WILL CARE, DOES THEY'LL KNOW HE'S NOT DANGEROUS, SAID RON, SLEEKLY. BUT ... HARRY, THEY'RE JUST



VICHELIS, GIANTS. IT'S LIKE HAGRID SAID, IT'S IN THEIR NATURES, THEY'RE LIKE TREES ... THEY JUST LIKE KILLING, EVERYONE KNOWS THAT. THERE AREN'T ANY LEFT IN BRITAIN NOW, THOUGH.

WHAT HAPPENED TO THEM?

WELL, THEY WERE DYING FIRST ANYWAY, AND THEN WEASLES GOT THEMSELVES KILLED BY ALIBORS. THERE'RE SUPPOSED TO BE GIANTS AROUND,

THOUGH ... THEY HIDE OUT IN MOUNTAINS MOSTLY ...

I DIDN'T KNOW WHEN MAXIME THINKS SHE'S KIDDING, HARRY SAID, WATCHING MADAME MAXIME SITTING ALONE AT THE ILDERS TABLE, BEHAVING VERY SILENT. IF HAGRID'S HALF-GIANT, SHE DEFINITELY IS. BIG KIDNEY ... THE ONLY THING THAT'S GET BIGGER KIDNEY THAN HER IS A DINOSAUR.

HARRY AND RON SPENT THE REST OF THE BALL DISCUSSING GIANTS IN THEIR CORNER, NEITHER OF THEM HAVING ANY INCLINATION TO DANCE. HARRY TRIED MEET THE WATCH LICH AND LEBRIC; IT GAVE HIM A STRONG DESIRE TO KICK SOMETHING.

THE BLUE BALL TOO

WHEN THE WEIRD SISTERS FINISHED PLAYING AT MIDNIGHT,

EVERYONE GAVE THEM A LAST, WILD ROUND OF APPLAUSE, AND STARTED TO WEND THEIR WAY INTO THE ENTRANCE HALL. MANY PEOPLE

WERE EXPRESSING THE WISH THAT THE BALL COULD HAVE GONE ON LONGER, BUT HARRY WAS PERFECTLY HAPPY TO BE GOING TO BED; AS

FOR AS HE WAS CONCERNED, THE EVENING HADN'T BEEN MUCH  
FUN.

ELT IN THE ENTRANCE HALL, HARRY AND RON SAW HERMIONE SAY-  
ING GOODNIGHT TO DRUMMOND BEFORE HE WENT BACK TO THE DORMSTRONG

SHIP. SHE GAVE RON A VERY COLD LOOK, AND SLEPT PAST HIM UP THE  
MARBLE STAIRCASE WITHOUT SPEAKING. HARRY AND RON FOLLOWED  
HER, BUT HALFWAY UP THE MARBLE STAIRCASE, HARRY HEARD SOMEONE  
CALLING HIM.

HEY HARRY!

IT WAS CEDRIC DIGGORY. HARRY COULD SEE HIM WAITING FOR HIM  
IN THE ENTRANCE HALL BELOW.

YEAH? SAID HARRY COLDLY, AS CEDRIC RAN UP THE STAIRS TOWARDS  
HIM.

CEDRIC LOOKED AS THOUGH HE DIDN'T WANT TO SAY WHATEVER IT  
WAS IN FRONT OF RON, WHO SHRUGGED, LOOKING BAD-TEMPERED, AND  
CONTINUED TO CLIMB THE STAIRS.

LISTEN ... CEDRIC LOWERED HIS VOICE AS RON DISAPPEARED. I  
WANT YOU HERE FOR TELLING ME ABOUT THE DRAGONS. YOU KNOW THAT  
CHILDREN EGG? DOES YOURS WAIL WHEN YOU OPEN IT?

YEAH, SAID HARRY.

WELL ... TAKE A BATH, HARRY?

WHAT?

TAKE A BATH, AND ER TAKE THE EGG WITH YOU, AND ER  
JUST PUT THINGS OVER IN THE HOT WATER. IT LL HELP YOU THINK ...  
TALK TO ME.

HARRY STARED AT HIM.

TELL ME WHAT, CEDRIC SAID, LIKE THE PREFECTS BATHROOM.  
FOURTH DEER THE LEFT OF THAT STAIR OF BEARS THE REWILDERED MEN  
THE FIFTH FLOOR, PASSWORD S PINK-FRESH, GETTA GO ... WANT THE SAY  
MIDNIGHT

THE HARRY PETER

HE GRINNED AT HARRY AGAIN AND HURRIED BACK DOWN THE STAIRS  
THE LEE.

HARRY WALKED BACK THE GRYFFINDOR TOWER ALONE. THAT HAD  
BEEN EXTREMELY STRANGE ADVICE, WHY WOULD A BATH HELP HIM THE  
WHERE HLT WHAT THE WAILING EGG MEANT? WAS CEDRIC PLUCKING HIS  
LEG? WAS HE TRYING THE MAKE HARRY LOOK A FEEL, SEE LEE WOULD  
LIKE CEDRIC EVEN MORE BY COMPARISON?

THE FAT LADY AND HER FRIEND VI WERE SNEEZING IN THE PICTURE  
OVER THE PORTRAIT HOLE. HARRY HAD THE YELL FAIRY LIGHTS? BEHOLD HE  
WHERE THEM LIP, AND WHEN HE DID, THEY WERE EXTREMELY IRRITATED.  
HE CLIMBED INTO THE CHIMNEY ROOM, AND FINDING RON AND  
HERMIONIE HAVING A BLAZING REEL, STANDING TEN FEET APART, THEY  
WERE BELLEWING AT EACH OTHER, EACH SCARLET IN THE FACE.

WELL, IF YOU DON'T LIKE IT, YOU KNOW WHAT THE SOLUTION IS,  
DON'T YOU? YELLED HERMIONIE; HER HAIR WAS CHIMPING DOWN HLT OF  
ITS ELEGANT BLIN REEL, AND HER FACE WAS SCREWED UP IN ANGER.  
HEY YEAH? RON YELLED BACK. WHAT S THAT?

NEXT TIME THERE S A BALL, ASK ME BEFORE SOMETHING ELSE DOES,  
AND NEET AS A LAST RESORT?

RON MELTED SELENDLESSLY LIKE A CHILDISH HLT OF WATER AS

HERMIONE TURNED ON HER HEEL AND STORMED UP THE GIRLS STAIRCASE THE RED, RON TURNED THE HEAD AT HARRY.

WELL, HE SPOLLTERED, BLEEDING THUNDERSTRIKE, WELL THAT JUST PROVES COMPLETELY MISSED THE POINT

HARRY DIDN'T SAY ANYTHING, HE LIKED BEING BACK ON SPEAKING TERMS WITH RON THE MUCH THE SPEAK HIS MIND RIGHT NOW BUT HE SOMEHOW THOUGHT THAT HERMIONE HAD GOTT THE POINT MUCH BETTER THAN RON HAD.

## CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

RITA SKEETER & SHEEP

EVERYBODY GOT UP LATE ON SUNDAY DAY, THE GRYFFINDOR COMMON ROOM WAS MUCH QUIETER THAN IT HAD BEEN LATELY, MANY WERE PLUNTLING THE LAZY CONVERSATIONS, HERMIONE'S HAIR WAS BLISSY AGAIN; SHE CONFESSED TO HARRY THAT SHE HAD USED LIBERAL AMOUNTS OF SLEEPKAZZ & HAIR PUTTY ON IT FOR THE BALL, BUT IT WAS THE MUCH BETTER THE DAY EVERY DAY, SHE SAID MATTER-OF-FACTLY, SCRATCHING A FLURRING CRIBBING-HANDS BEHIND THE EARS.

RON AND HERMIONE SEEMED TO HAVE REACHED AN UNSTATED AGREEMENT NOT TO DISCUSS THEIR ARGUMENT, THEY WERE BEING ELITE FRIENDLY TO EACH OTHER, THOUGH HOPEFULLY FORMAL, RON AND

HARRY WASTED NO TIME IN TELLING HERMIONE ABOUT THE CONVERSA-

THEN THEY HAD OVERHEARD BETWEEN MADAME MAXIME AND F-AGRID,

BUT F-ERMINE DIDN'T SEEM TO FIND THE NEWS THAT F-AGRID WAS A  
HALF-GIANT NEARLY AS SHOCKING AS REN DID.

WELL, I THOUGHT HE MUST BE, SHE SAID, SHRUGGING. I KNEW HE  
COULDN'T BE PURE GIANT, BECAUSE THEY'RE ABOUT TWENTY FEET TALL.  
BUT HONESTLY, ALL THIS HYSTERIA ABOUT GIANTS. THEY CAN'T ALL BE  
HORRIBLE ... IT'S THE SAME SORT OF PREJUDICE THAT PEOPLE HAVE  
TOWARDS WEREWOLVES ... IT'S JUST RIGHTEOUS, ISN'T IT?

REN LOOKED AS THOUGH HE WOULD HAVE LIKED THE REPLY  
SCATHINGLY, BUT PERHAPS HE DIDN'T WANT ANOTHER REEL, BECAUSE HE  
CONTENTED HIMSELF WITH SHAKING HIS HEAD DISBELIEVINGLY WHILE  
F-ERMINE WASN'T LOOKING.

IT WAS TIME NOW TO THINK OF THE HOMELANDS THEY HAD NEGLECTED  
DURING THE FIRST WEEK OF THE HOLIDAYS. EVERYBODY SEEMED TO BE  
FEELING RATHER FLAT, NOW THAT CHRISTMAS WAS OVER. EVERYBODY

EXCEPT HARRY POTTTER

EXCEPT HARRY, THAT IS, WHO WAS STARTING UPONCE AGAIN! HE FELT  
SLIGHTLY NERVOUS.

THE TRICKLE WAS THAT FEBRUARY THE TWENTY-FOURTH WOULD BE A  
LEFT CLASHER FROM THIS SIDE OF CHRISTMAS, AND HE STILL HADN'T DONE  
ANYTHING ABOUT WORKING OUT THE CLUE INSIDE THE EGG. HE  
THEREFORE STARTED TAKING THE EGG OUT OF HIS TROUSE EVERY TIME HE  
WENT UP TO THE CHIMNEY, OPENING IT AND LISTENING INTENTLY,  
HOPING THAT THIS TIME IT WOULD MAKE SOME SENSE. HE STRAINED THE

THINK WHAT THE SHELING REMINDED HIM OF, APART FROM THIRTY MILI-  
CAL SALS, BUT HE HAD NEVER HEARD ANYTHING ELSE LIKE IT, HE

CLOSED THE EGG, SQUEEZED IT VIGOROUSLY, AND OPENED IT AGAIN TO SEE  
IF THE SHELING HAD CHANGED, BUT IT HADN'T, HE TRIED ASKING THE EGG

QUESTIONS, SQUEEZING EVER ALL THE WHILE, BUT NOTHING HAP-  
PENED, HE EVEN THREW THE EGG ACROSS THE ROOM THOUGH HE

HADN'T REALLY EXPECTED THAT THE HELP.

HARRY HAD NOT FORGOTTEN THE HINT THAT CEDRIC HAD GIVEN HIM,  
BUT HIS LESS-THAN-FRIENDLY FEELINGS TOWARDS CEDRIC MUST HAVE  
MEANT THAT HE WAS BEEN NOT TO ACCEPT HIS HELP IF HE COULD AVOID  
IT. IN ANY CASE, IT SEEMED TO HIM THAT IF CEDRIC HAD REALLY WANTED  
TO GIVE HARRY A HAND, HE WOULD HAVE BEEN A BIT MORE EXPLICIT.

HE, HARRY, HAD TOLD CEDRIC EXACTLY WHAT WAS COMING IN THE FIRST  
TASK AND CEDRIC'S IDEA OF A FAIR EXCHANGE HAD BEEN THE TELL

HARRY THE TASK A LATE. WELL, HE DIDN'T NEED THAT SORT OF ALKESID-  
HELP NOT FROM SOMEBODY WHO KEPT WALKING DOWN CORRIDORS  
HAND IN HAND WITH HER, ANYWAY. AND ON THE FIRST DAY OF THE  
NEW TERM ARRIVED, AND HARRY SET OFF THE LESSONS, WEIGHED DOWN  
WITH BOOKS, PARCHMENT AND ROLLERS AS USUAL, BUT ALSO WITH THE  
BURDENSOME WEIGHT OF THE EGG HEAVY IN HIS STOMACH, AS THOUGH HE  
WAS CARRYING THAT AROUND WITH HIM THEN.

STILL WAS STILL THICK UPON THE GREENS, AND THE GREEN-HOUSE  
WINDOWS WERE COVERED IN CONDENSATION SO THICK THAT THEY  
COULDN'T SEE OUT OF THEM IN JERSEY. NOBODY WAS LOOKING

FORWARD THE CARE OF MAGICAL CREATURES MUCH IN THIS WEATHER, THOUGH, AS REEN SAID, THE SKELETS WOULD PROBABLY WARM THEM UP NICELY, EITHER BY CHASING THEM OR BY BLASTING OFF SEE PERCEPLA-

RITA SKEETER & SHEEP EYE

BY THAT HAGRID & CABIN CALIGHT FIRE.

WHEN THEY ARRIVED AT HAGRID & CABIN, HOWEVER, THEY FOUND AN

ELDERLY WITCH WITH CLOSELY CROPPED GREY HAIR AND A VERY PROMINENT CHIN STANDING BEFORE HIS FRONT DEER.

HARRY UP, NOW, THE BELL RANG FIVE MINUTES AGO, SHE BARKED AT THEM, AS THEY STRUGGLED TOWARDS HER THROUGH THE SNOW.

WHERE RE YOU? SAID REEN, STARING AT HER. WHERE & HAGRID? MY NAME IS PROFESSOR GRIMLEY-PLANK, SHE SAID CRISPLY, I AM YOUR TEMPORARY CARE OF MAGICAL CREATURES TEACHER.

WHERE & HAGRID? HARRY REPEATED LELDLY.

HE IS INDISPSED, SAID PROFESSOR GRIMLEY-PLANK SHORTLY. SHIT AND UNPLEASANT LAUGHTER REACHED HARRY & EARS. HE

TURNED; DRACE MALPHY AND THE REST OF THE SLYTHERINS WERE JOINING THE CLASS, ALL OF THEM LAUGHED GLEEFUL, AND NONE OF THEM

LAUGHED SURPRISED TO SEE PROFESSOR GRIMLEY-PLANK.

THIS WAY, PLEASE, SAID PROFESSOR GRIMLEY-PLANK, AND SHE STRODE OFF AROUND THE PADDOCK WHERE THE FLYER REALIZATIONS HORSES WERE SHIVERING. HARRY, REEN AND HERMIONE FOLLOWED HER,

LEADING BACK OVER THEIR SHOULDERS AT HAGRID'S CARIN. ALL THE  
CURTAINS WERE CLOSED, WAS HAGRID IN THERE, ALONE AND ILL?

WHAT'S WRONG WITH HAGRID? HARRY SAID, FLIPPING THE CATCH  
UP WITH PROFESSOR GRUBBY-PLANK.

NEVER MIND, SHE SAID, AS THOUGH SHE THOUGHT HE WAS  
BEING NESTY.

I SEE MIND, THOUGH, SAID HARRY HEETLY. WHAT'S UP WITH HIM?  
PROFESSOR GRUBBY-PLANK ACTED AS THOUGH SHE COULDN'T HEAR  
HIM. SHE LED THEM PAST THE PADDOCK WHERE THE REALMATEENS  
HORSES WERE STANDING, Huddled AGAINST THE FENCE, AND TOWARDS A  
TREE ON THE EDGE OF THE FOREST, WHERE A LARGE AND BEAUTIFUL  
UNICORN WAS TETHERED.

MANY OF THE GIRLS WHISPERED AT THE SIGHT OF THE UNICORN.

HEH, IT'S SO BEAUTIFUL! WHISPERED LAVENDER BROWN. HOW DID  
SHE GET IT? THEY'RE SUPPOSED TO BE REALLY HARD TO CATCH.

THE UNICORN WAS SO BRIGHTLY WHITE THAT IT MADE THE SNOW ALL  
AROUND LOOK GREY. IT WAS PALING THE GRASS NERVOUSLY WITH ITS

RED HARRY PETER

GOLDEN HEEVES, AND THROWING BACK ITS HORNY HEAD.

KIDS KEEP BACK! BARKED PROFESSOR GRUBBY-PLANK, THROWING  
HIS AN ARM AND CATCHING HARRY HARD IN THE CHEST. THEY PROPER  
THE WOMAN'S THICK UNICORNS, GIRLS TO THE FRONT, AND APPROACH  
WITH CARE. COME ON, EASY DOES IT ...

SHE AND THE GIRLS WALKED SILENTLY TOWARDS THE  
UNICORN, LEAVING THE KIDS STANDING NEAR THE PADDOCK FENCE,  
WATCHING.



THE MOMENT PROFESSOR CRUELTY-PLAND WAS HIT BY PARSLET,  
HARRY TURNED THE REIN. WHAT D YOU RECKON S WRING WITH HIM?  
YOU BEEN T THINK A SKEWT ?

HEH, HE HASN T BEEN ATTACKED, BETTER, IF THAT S WHAT YOU RE  
THINKING, SAID MALFOY SHORTLY. NEH, HE S ILST THE ASKED THE  
SEEM HIS BIG LELY FACE.

WHAT D YOU MEAN? SAID HARRY SHARPLY.

MALFOY PUT HIS HAND INSIDE THE POCKET OF HIS TROUSERS, AND  
PULLED OUT A FOLDED PAGE OF NEWSPRINT.

THERE YOU GO, HE SAID. TAKE THE READ IT THE YOU, BETTER ...  
HE SMIRKED AS HARRY SNATCHED THE PAGE, UNFOLDED IT, AND  
READ IT, WITH REIN, SEAMUS, DEAN AND NEVILLE LEERING OVER HIS  
SHOULDER. IT WAS AN ARTICLE TITLED WITH A PICTURE OF HARRY  
LEERING EXTREMELY SMUG.

OLIVERPORE S GIANT MISTAKE

ALBUS DUMBLEDORE, ECCENTRIC HEADMASTER OF HOGWARTS SCHOOL  
OF WITCHCRAFT AND WIZARDRY, HAS NEVER BEEN AFRAID THE MAJOR  
CONTENTIOUS STAFF APPOINTMENTS, WRITES RITA SKEETER, SPECIAL  
CORRESPONDENT. IN SEPTEMBER OF THIS YEAR, HE HIRED ALASTAIR  
MAD-EYE Moody, THE NOTHINGLY INDY-HAPPY EX-ALUMNUS, THE  
TEACH DEFENCE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS, A DECISION THAT CAUSED  
MANY RAISED EYEBROWS AT THE MINISTRY OF MAGIC, GIVEN Moody S  
WELL-KNOWN HABIT OF ATTACKING ANYBODY WHO MAKES A SLIDEN  
MOVEMENT IN HIS PRESENCE. MAD-EYE Moody, HOWEVER, SEEMS  
RESPONSIBLE AND KINDLY, WHEN SET BESIDE THE PART-HUMAN

DUMBLEDORE EMPLEYS THE TEACH CARE OF MAGICAL CREATURES.

RITA SKEETER S SUEHS K&L

OLIVER HAGRID, WHO ADMITS THE KING EXPELLED FROM

BEGLIANTS IN HIS THIRD YEAR, HAS ENJOYED THE POSITION OF CAMP-  
KEEPER AT THE SCHOOL EVER SINCE, & HE SECURED HER HIM BY

DUMBLEDORE. LAST YEAR, HOWEVER, HAGRID USED HIS MYSTERIOUS  
INFLUENCE OVER THE HEADMASTER TO SECURE THE ADDITIONAL POST OF  
CARE OF MAGICAL CREATURES TEACHER, OVER THE HEADS OF MANY  
BETTER-QUALIFIED CANDIDATES.

AN ALARMINGLY LARGE AND PERHAPS-LOOKING MAN, HAGRID  
HAS BEEN USING HIS NEW-FIND AUTHORITY TO TERRIFY THE STUDENTS  
IN HIS CARE WITH A SUCCESSFUL OF HORRIFIC CREATURES. WHILE  
DUMBLEDORE TURNS A BLIND EYE, HAGRID HAS MAIMED SEVERAL  
PUPILS DURING A SERIES OF LESSONS WHICH MANY ADMIT TO BE  
VERY FRIGHTENING .

I WAS ATTACKED BY A HIPPOGRIF, AND MY FRIEND VINCENT  
CRABBE GOT A BAD KITE OFF A FLEEKLEWORM, SAYS DRACE MALFOY,  
A FIFTH-YEAR STUDENT. WE ALL HATE HAGRID, BUT WE RE JUST TOO  
SCARED TO SAY ANYTHING.

HAGRID HAS NO INTENTION OF LEASING HIS CAMPAIGN OF INTIMIDA-  
TION, HOWEVER. IN CONVERSATION WITH A DAILY PROPHET REPORTER  
LAST

MEANTH, HE ADMITTED BREEDING CREATURES HE HAS BLERED BLAST-  
ENDED SKELETS , HIGHLY DANGEROUS CRUSSES BETWEEN MANTICORES

AND FIRE CRABS. THE CREATION OF NEW BREEDS OF MAGICAL CREATURE IS,  
OF COURSE, AN ACTIVITY USUALLY CLOSELY MONITORED BY THE DEPARTMENT  
FOR THE REGULATION AND CONTROL OF MAGICAL CREATURES. F-JAGRID, IT  
SEEMS, CONSIDERS HIMSELF TO BE ABOVE SUCH PETTY RESTRICTIONS.

I WAS JUST HAVING SOME FUN, HE SAYS, BEFORE HASTILY CHANG-  
ING THE SUBJECT.

AS IF THIS WERE NOT ENOUGH, THE DAILY PROPHET HAS NEW  
UNEARDED EVIDENCE THAT F-JAGRID IS NOT AS HE HAS ALWAYS  
PRETENDED A PURE-BLOOD WIZARD, HE IS NOT, IN FACT, EVEN PURE  
HUMAN. HIS MOTHER, WE CAN EXCLUSIVELY REVEAL, IS NONE OTHER  
THAN THE GIANTESSE FRIDWILFA, WHOSE WHEREABOUTS ARE CURRENTLY  
UNKNOWN.

BLOODTHIRSTY AND BRUTAL, THE GIANTS BRING THEMSELVES TO  
THE POINT OF EXTINCTION BY WARRING AMONG THEMSELVES DURING

THE DARK PETER

THE LAST CENTURY. THE HANDFUL THAT REMAINED JOINED THE RANKS  
OF THE WHO MUST NOT BE NAMED, AND WERE RESPONSIBLE FOR  
SOME OF THE WORST MASS MURDER-KILLINGS OF HIS REIGN OF TERROR.  
WHILE MANY OF THE GIANTS WHO SERVED THE WHO MUST NOT BE  
NAMED WERE KILLED BY ALIENS WARRING AGAINST THE DARK SIDE,  
FRIDWILFA WAS NOT AMONG THEM. IT IS POSSIBLE SHE ESCAPED THE

ONE OF THE GIANT COMMUNITIES STILL EXISTING IN FOREIGN MOUNTAIN RANGES. IF HIS ARTS DURING CARE OF MAGICAL CREATURES

LESSONS ARE ANY CLUE, HOWEVER, FRIDELFA'S SON APPEARS TO HAVE INHERITED HER BRUTAL NATURE.

IN A BIZARRE TWIST, HAGRID IS REVEALED TO HAVE DEVELOPED A

CLOSE FRIENDSHIP WITH THE KING WHEN BRIGHT ARHUT YELL-KNEEL-WHIS FALL FROM POWER THEREBY DRIVING HAGRID'S SON MOTHER,

LIKE THE REST OF YELL-KNEEL-WHIS SUPPORTERS, INTO HIDING.

PERHAPS HARRY POTTER IS UNAWARE OF THE UNPLEASANT TRUTH ARHUT

HIS LARGEST FRIEND BUT ALAS DIMBLEDOORE SURELY HAS A DUTY TO ENSURE THAT HARRY POTTER, ALONG WITH HIS FELLOW STUDENTS, IS WARNED ARHUT THE DANGERS OF ASSOCIATING WITH PART-GIANTS. HARRY FINISHED READING AND LOOKED UP AT REIN, WHOSE MOUTH WAS HANGING OPEN.

HOW DID SHE FIND HIM? HE WHISPERED.

BUT THAT WASN'T WHAT WAS BOTHERING HARRY.

WHAT'D YELL MEAN, WE ALL HATE HAGRID? HARRY SPAT AT MALFOY. WHAT'S THIS RICKISH ARHUT HIM HE POINTED AT CRABBE GETTING A BAD KITE OFF A FLEEBERWHORN? THEY HAVEN'T EVEN GOTT TEETH!

CRABBE WAS SNIGGERING, APPARENTLY VERY PLEASED WITH HIMSELF.

WELL, I THINK THIS SHOULD PUT AN END TO THE HAP'S TEACHING

CAREER, SAID MALFOY, HIS EYES GLINTING. HALF-GIANT ... AND THERE WAS ME THINKING HE'D JUST SWALLOWED A BOTTLE OF SKELE-GROW WHEN HE WAS YELING ... NONE OF THE MUMMIES AND DADDIES ARE GOING THE LIKE THIS AT ALL ... THEY'LL BE WORRIED HE'LL EAT THEIR KIDS, HA, HA ...

YELL

RITA SKEETER'S SCHEMATIC

ARE YELL PAYING ATTENTION EVER THERE?

PROFESSOR GRIFFITH-POWELL'S VOICE CARRIED OVER THE THE KEYS; THE GIRLS WERE ALL CLUSTERED AROUND THE LINCOLN YELL, STRENGTH IT.

HARRY WAS SEE ANGRY THAT THE DAILY PROPHET ARTICLE SEEMED IN HIS HANDS AS HE TURNED THE STARE UNSEEKINGLY AT THE LINCOLN, WHOSE MANY MAGICAL PROPERTIES PROFESSOR GRIFFITH-POWELL WAS NOW ENLIGHTENING IN A LULLABY VOICE, SHE THAT THE KEYS CHILD HEAR THEM.

I HOPE SHE STAYS, THAT WOMAN? SAID PARVATI PATIL, WHEN THE LESSON HAD ENDED, AND THEY WERE ALL HEADING BACK THE THE CASTLE FOR LUNCH. THAT'S MORE WHAT I THOUGHT CARE OF MAGICAL CREATURES WOULD BE LIKE ... PROPER CREATURES LIKE LINCOLNS, NOT MONSTERS ...

WHAT ABOUT HAGRID? HARRY SAID ANGRILY, AS THEY WENT UP THE STEPS.

WHAT ABOUT HIM? SAID PARVATI, IN A HARD VOICE. HE CAN STILL BE GARDENKEEPER, CAN'T HE?

PARVATI HAD BEEN VERY CHEERFUL TOWARDS HARRY SINCE THE BALL. HE SLIPPED THAT HE MIGHT THE HAVE PAID HER A BIT MORE ATTENTION, BUT SHE SEEMED THE HAVE HAD A GOOD TIME ALL THE SAME. SHE WAS

CERTAINLY TELLING ANYBODY WHO WOULD LISTEN THAT SHE HAD MADE  
ARRANGEMENTS TO MEET THE KING FROM REALISATIONS IN  
THE SPREAD FOR THE NEXT WEEKEND TRIP.

THAT WAS A REALLY GOOD LESSON, SAID HERMINE, AS THEY  
ENTERED THE GREAT HALL. I DIDN'T KNOW HALF THE THINGS PROFESSOR  
GRUBBY-PLANDT HAD US ABOUT LINE

LOOK AT THIS! HARRY SNARLED, AND HE SHEWED THE DAILY  
PROPHET ARTICLE UNDER HERMINE'S NOSE.

HERMINE'S MOUTH FELL OPEN AS SHE READ. HER REACTION WAS  
EXACTLY THE SAME AS WHEN SHE DID THAT HORRIBLE SKEETER  
WHYMAN FIND OUT? WELL DIDN'T THINK HARRY HAD HER?

WELL, SAID HARRY, LEADING THE WAY OVER THE GRYFFINDOR TABLE  
AND THROWING HIMSELF INTO A CHAIR, FLURRIED. HE NEVER EVEN TOLD  
US, DID HE? I REMEMBER SHE WAS SHE MAD HE WOULDN'T GIVE HER LEADS  
OF HORRIBLE STUFF ABOUT ME, SHE WENT FERRETING AROUND THE GET  
BACK AT HIM.

BY HARRY POTTTER

MAYBE SHE HEARD HIM TELLING MADAME MAXIME AT THE BALL,  
SAID HERMINE QUIETLY.

WE'D HAVE SEEN HER IN THE GARDEN! SAID RHN. ANYWAY, SHE'S  
NEET SLIPPED THE CHAIR INTO THE SKY AND MORE, HARRY SAID  
BLUNDERBELLER KILLED HER ...

MAYBE SHE'S GET AN INVISIBILITY CLOAK, SAID HARRY, LADLING  
CHICKEN CASSEROLE INTO HIS PLATE AND SPLASHING IT EVERYWHERE IN  
HIS ANGER. SHEET OF THING SHE'D DO, ISN'T IT, HIDE IN KITCHEN LISTEN-

ING THE PEOPLE.

LIKE YELL AND RENN DID, YELL MEAN, SAID HERMINE.

WE WEREN'T TRYING TO HEAR HIM? SAID RENN INDIGNANTLY. WE

DIDN'T HAVE ANY CHOICE? THE STUPID GIT, TALKING ABOUT HIS GIANT-  
ESS MOTHER WHEN ANYONE COULD HAVE HEARD HIM?

WE'VE GOT TO GO AND SEE HIM, SAID HARRY. THIS EVENING, AFTER  
DIVINATION. TELL HIM WE WANT HIM BACK ... YELL DID WANT HIM  
BACK? HE SHOUT AT HERMINE.

I WELL, I MIGHT BEING TO PRETEND IT DIDN'T MAKE A Nice  
CHANGE, HAVING A PROPER CARE OF MAGICAL CREATURES LESSEN THE  
RISK BUT I DO WANT HAGRID BACK, IF COURSE I DO? HERMINE  
ADDED HASTILY, EXPLAINING UNDER HARRY'S FLIRTELIS STARE.  
SHE THAT EVENING AFTER DINNER, THE THREE OF THEM LEFT THE CASTLE  
HENCE MORE, AND WENT DOWN THROUGH THE FROZEN GREENLANDS TO  
HAGRID'S CAVEN. THEY KNOCKED, AND FANG'S RUMMING BARKS  
ANSWERED.

HAGRID, IT'S US? HARRY SHOUTED, POUNDING ON THE DOOR. OPEN  
UP?

HE DIDN'T ANSWER. THEY COULD HEAR FANG SCRATCHING AT THE  
DOOR, WHINING, BUT IT DIDN'T OPEN. THEY HAMMERED ON IT FOR TEN

MORE MINUTES; RENN EVEN WENT AND BANGED ON ONE OF THE WIN-  
DOWS, BUT THERE WAS NO RESPONSE.

WHAT IS HE AVOIDING US FOR? HERMIONE SAID, WHEN THEY HAD FINALLY GIVEN UP, AND WERE WALKING BACK TO THE SCULLERY. HE SURELY DOESN'T THINK WE'D CARE ABOUT HIM BEING HALF-GIANT? BUT IT SEEMED THAT HAGRID DID CARE. THEY DIDN'T SEE A SIGN OF HIM ALL WEEK. HE DIDN'T APPEAR AT THE STAFF TABLE AT MEAL-TIMES,

RITA SKEETER'S STEEP KISS

THEY DIDN'T SEE HIM GOING ABOUT HIS GAMEKEEPER DUTIES IN THE GREENHouses, AND PROFESSOR GRIFFITHS-POWELL CONTINUED TO TAKE THE CARE OF MAGICAL CREATURES CLASSES. MALFOY WAS GLOATING AT EVERY POSSIBLE OPPORTUNITY.

MISSING THEIR HALF-BLOOD PAL? HE KEPT WHISPERING TO HARRY, WHENEVER THERE WAS A TEACHER ABOUT, THAT HE WAS SAFE FROM HARRY'S RETALIATION. MISSING THE ELEPHANT MAN?

THERE WAS A FIVE-MILE VISIT HALFWAY THROUGH JANUARY.

HERMIONE WAS VERY SURPRISED THAT HARRY WAS PLANNING TO GO.

I JUST THOUGHT YOU'D WANT TO TAKE ADVANTAGE OF THE CHAMPION BEING AWAY, SHE SAID. REALLY GET THE WORD IN THAT REG.

HEY, I REMEMBER I'VE GOT A PRETTY GOOD IDEA WHAT IT'S ABOUT NOW, HARRY LIES.

HAVE YOU REALLY? SAID HERMIONE, LOOKING IMPRESSED. WELL THEN?

HARRY'S INSIDES GAVE A GUILTY FEELING, BUT HE IGNORED THEM.

HE STILL HAD FIVE WEEKS TO GO BEFORE THAT REG CAME, AFTER ALL, AND THAT WAS AGES ... AND IF HE WENT INTO FIVE-MILE, HE MIGHT RUN INTO HAGRID, AND GET A CHANCE TO PERSUADE HIM TO COME BACK. HE, RON AND HERMIONE LEFT THE CASTLE TOGETHER ON SATURDAY,



AND SET HIM THROUGH THE CHILD, LET GRILINDS TOWARDS THE GATES. AS THEY PASSED THE DUMSTRANG SHIP MOORED IN THE LAKE, THEY SAW VICTOR KARIM EMERGE FROM THE DECK, DRESSED IN NOTHING BUT SWIMMING TRUNKS. HE WAS VERY SKINNY, BUT APPARENTLY A LOT TIGHTER THAN HE LOOKED, BECAUSE HE CLIMBED UP FROM THE SIDE OF THE SHIP, STRETCHED OUT HIS ARMS AND DROVE, RIGHT INTO THE LAKE.

HE'S MAD! SAID HARRY, STARING AT KARIM'S DARK HEAD, AS IT REEMERGED INTO THE MIDDLE OF THE LAKE. IT MUST BE FREEZING, IT'S JANUARY!

IT'S A LOT COLDER WHERE HE COMES FROM, SAID HERMIONE. I SUPPOSE IT FEELS WHITE WARM TO HIM.

Yeah, BUT THERE'S STILL THE GIANT SHED, SAID RON. HE DIDN'T SHED ANYTHING IF ANYTHING, HE SHEDD FEELING. HERMIONE NOTICED HIS TONE OF VOICE, AND FREELINED.

XXX HARRY PTTTTT

HE'S REALLY NICE, WELL DONE, SHE SAID. HE'S NOT AT ALL LIKE WELL D THING, COMING FROM DUMSTRANG, HE LIKES IT MUCH BETTER HERE, HE TELLS ME.

RON SAID NOTHING. HE HADN'T MENTIONED VICTOR KARIM SINCE THE BALL, BUT HARRY HAD FOUND A MINIATURE ARM UNDER HIS BED ON BIRTHDAY DAY, WHICH HAD LOOKED VERY MUCH AS THOUGH IT HAD BEEN SNAPPED OFF A SMALL MODEL FIGURE WEARING BURGUNDIA HUNDOITCH REEKS.

HARRY KEPT HIS EYES SKINNED FOR A SIGN OF HARRY ALL THE WAY DOWN THE SLICKY HIGH STREET, AND SUGGESTED A VISIT TO THE THREE

BRIMSTICKS SINCE HE HAD ASCERTAINED THAT LARRY WAS NOT IN  
ANY OF THE SHOPS.

THE PUB WAS AS CROWDED AS EVER, BUT ONE ELITE LEEK APPEARED

AT ALL THE TABLES TOLD LARRY THAT LARRY WASN'T THERE. HEART SINK-  
ING, HE WENT UP TO THE BAR WITH BEN AND HERMINE, ORDERED

THREE BUTTERBEERS FROM MADAM RESMERTA, AND THOUGHT GLENNILY  
THAT HE MIGHT JUST AS WELL HAVE STAYED BEHIND AND LISTENED TO  
THE EGG WAILING AFTER ALL.

DIDN'T HE EVER GET INTO THE OFFICE? HERMINE WHISPERED  
SUDDENLY. LEEK:

SHE POINTED INTO THE MIRROR BEHIND THE BAR, AND LARRY SAW  
LUDIE BAGMAN REFLECTED THERE, SITTING IN A SHADY CHAIR WITH  
A KITCHEN OF GEEKS. BAGMAN WAS TALKING VERY FAST IN A LOW VOICE  
TO THE GEEKS, ALL OF WHOM HAD THEIR ARMS CROSSED, AND WERE  
LOOKING RATHER MENACING.

IT WAS INDEED HE, LARRY THOUGHT, THAT BAGMAN WAS HERE AT  
THE THREE BRIMSTICKS ON A WEDNESDAY WHEN THERE WAS NO  
TRILIZARD EVENT, AND THEREFORE NO LUDGING TO BE DONE. HE  
WATCHED BAGMAN IN THE MIRROR. HE WAS LOOKING STRAINED AGAIN,  
ELITE AS STRAINED AS HE HAD BEEN THAT NIGHT IN THE FOREST BEFORE  
THE DARK MARK HAD APPEARED, BUT JUST THEN BAGMAN GLANCED  
OVER AT THE BAR, SAW LARRY, AND STOOD UP.

IN A MOMENT, IN A MOMENT! LARRY HEARD HIM SAY BRISKLY  
TO THE GEEKS, AND BAGMAN HURRIED THROUGH THE PUB TOWARDS  
LARRY, HIS REDDISH GRIN BACK IN PLACE.

RITA SKEETER'S SHEEP ROY

HARRY: HE SAID, HOW ARE YOU? BEEN HELPING THE ALIN INTO YOU?  
EVERYTHING GOING ALL RIGHT?

FINE, THANKS, SAID HARRY.

WONDER IF I COULD HAVE A QUICK, PRIVATE WORD, HARRY? SAID  
RAGMAN RAGERLY, YOU CHILDREN T GIVE US A MOMENT, YOU TWO  
CHILD YOU?

ER EDD, SAID BEN, AND HE AND HERMIONE WENT OFF THE FIND A  
TABLE.

RAGMAN LED HARRY ALONG THE BAR THE THE END FURTHEST FROM  
MADAM RHEEMERTA.

WELL, I MUST MENTION I D CONGRATULATE YOU AGAIN FOR YOUR  
SPLENDID PERFORMANCE AGAINST THAT HERON-TAIL, HARRY, SAID  
RAGMAN. REALLY SLIPPER.

THANKS, SAID HARRY, BUT HE KNEW THIS CHILDREN T BE ALL THAT  
RAGMAN WANTED THE SAY, BECAUSE HE COULD HAVE CONGRATULATED  
HARRY IN FRONT OF BEN AND HERMIONE. RAGMAN DIDN T SEEM IN  
ANY PARTICULAR RUSH THE SPILL THE BEANS, HOWEVER, HARRY SAW HIM  
GLANCE INTO THE MIRROR OVER THE BAR AT THE CHELINS, WHO WERE ALL  
WATCHING HIM AND HARRY IN SILENCE THROUGH THEIR DARK, SLANTING  
EYES.

ABSOLUTE NIGHTMARE, SAID RAGMAN TO HARRY IN AN UNDERTONE,  
NOTICING HARRY WATCHING THE CHELINS, THEN. THEIR ENGLISH ISN T  
THE BEST ... IT S LIKE BEING BACK WITH ALL THE BULGARIANS AT THE  
HOLIDAY WORLD CLUB ... BUT AT LEAST THEY USED SIGN LANGUAGE  
ANOTHER HUMAN CHILD COULD RECOGNISE. THIS LET KEEP GABLING IN

GHEKLEDEGHEH ... AND I ONLY KNOW ONE WORD OF GHEKLEDEGHEH.  
BLADYAD, IT MEANS PICKAPOO, I DON'T LIKE THE USE IT IN CASE THEY  
THINK I'M THREATENING THEM. HE GAVE A SHORT, KEENING LAUGH.  
WHAT DO THEY WANT? HARRY SAID, NOTICING HOW THE GHEKINS  
WERE STILL WATCHING RAGMAN VERY CLOSELY.

ER WELL ... SAID RAGMAN, SOUNDING SLIGHTLY NERVOUS. THEY  
... ER ... THEY'RE WATCHING FOR BARTY CRUELCH.

WHY ARE THEY WATCHING FOR HIM HERE? SAID HARRY. HE'S AT THE  
MINISTRY IN LONDON, ISN'T HE?

ER ... AS A MATTER OF FACT, I'VE NO IDEA WHERE HE IS, SAID

XXX HARRY MUTTER

RAGMAN. HE'S SHORT OF ... STOPPED CHINING THE WHEEL, BEEN ABSENT  
FOR A WHILE OF WEEKS NOW. YELING PERCY, HIS ASSISTANT, SAYS HE'S  
ILL. APPARENTLY HE'S JUST BEEN SENDING INSTRUCTIONS IN BY MAIL.  
BUT WOULD YEL MIND NOT MENTIONING THAT TO ANYONE, HARRY?  
BECAUSE RITA SKEETER'S STILL POKING AROUND EVERYWHERE SHE CAN,

AND I'M WILLING THE BET SHE'D WHEEL BARTY'S ILLNESS UP INTO SOME-  
THING SINISTER. PREFERABLY SAY HE'S BEEN MISSING LIKE BERTHA

JEERKINS.

HAVE YEL HEARD ANYTHING ABOUT BERTHA JEERKINS? HARRY  
ASKED.

NO, SAID RAGMAN, SOUNDING STRAINED AGAIN. I'VE GOT PEOPLE  
WATCHING, OF COURSE ... (ABOUT TIME, THOUGHT HARRY) AND IT'S ALL  
VERY STRANGE. SHE DEFINITELY ARRIVED IN ALBANIA, BECAUSE SHE MET

HIS SECOND CHLISIN THERE, AND THEN SHE LEFT THE CHLISIN'S FEELING  
THE GEE SHELT-H AND SEE AN ALINT ... AND SHE SEEMS THE HAVE VANISHED  
WITH-ELIT TRACE, EN REHLTE, BLEEED IF I CAN SEE WHERE SHE'S GOTTEN  
... SHE DOESN'T SEEM THE TYPE THE KLEPP, HER INSTANCE ... ELIT STILL  
... WHAT ARE WE DOING, TALKING ABOUT CHLISINS AND BERTHA  
JERDINS? I REALLY WANTED THE ASK YELL, HE LOWERED HIS VOICE, FEEL  
ARE YELL GETTING HIM WITH YELLER CHILDREN EGG?

ER ... NOT BAD, HARRY SAID LITRALLY-FLY.

RAGMAN SEEMED THE KNOW HE WASN'T BEING HONEST.

LISTEN, HARRY, HE SAID (STILL IN A VERY LOW VOICE), I FEEL VERY  
BAD ABOUT ALL THIS ... YELL WERE THROWN INTO THIS TOURNAMENT,  
YELL DIDN'T VOLUNTEER FOR IT ... AND IF HIS VOICE WAS SHE ELIET  
NEED, HARRY HAD THE LEAN CLOSER THE LISTEN! ... IF I CAN HELP AT ALL  
... A FEEL IN THE RIGHT DIRECTION ... I'VE TAKEN A LICKING THE YELL  
... THE WAY YELL GOT PAST THAT DRAGON? ... WELL, I'LL SAY THE  
WORD.

HARRY LEANED UP INTO RAGMAN'S REELING, REDDY FACE, AND WIDE,  
BAY-BLUE EYES.

WE'RE SUPPOSED THE WORD ELIT THE CLUES ALONE, AREN'T WE? HE  
SAID, CAREFUL THE KEEP HIS VOICE CASUAL, AND NOT SOUND AS THOUGH  
HE WAS ACCUSING THE HEAD OF THE DEPARTMENT OF MAGICAL GAMES  
AND SPORTS OF BREAKING THE RULES.

RITA SKEETER'S STEEP ROX

WELL ... WELL, YES, SAID RAGMAN IMPATIENTLY, ELIT COME ON,

HARRY WE ALL WANT A HOGWARTS VICTORY, DON'T WE?

HAVE YELL HEARD CEDRIC FIELD? HARRY SAID.

THE SMALLEST OF FREELINS CREATED RAGMAN'S SMILEY FACE.

NEE, I HAVEN'T, HE SAID. I WELL, LIKE I SAY, I'VE TAKEN A LIKING  
TO YELL. I'LL TRY TO GET IT DONE ...

WELL, THANKS, SAID HARRY, BUT I THINK I'M NEARLY THERE WITH  
THE EGG ... COULD YOU PLEASE HELP ME WITH IT.

HE WASN'T ENTIRELY SURE WHY HE WAS REFUSING RAGMAN'S HELP,

EXCEPT THAT RAGMAN WAS ALMOST A STRANGER TO HIM, AND ACCEPT-  
ING HIS ASSISTANCE WOULD FEEL SOMEHOW MUCH MORE LIKE CHEAT-  
ING THAN ASKING ADVICE FROM REIN, HERMINE OR SIRILS.

RAGMAN LOOKED ALMOST APPREHENDED, BUT COULDN'T SAY MUCH  
MORE AS FRED AND GEORGE TURNED UP AT THAT POINT.

HELLO, MR RAGMAN, SAID FRED BRIGHTLY. CAN WE BUY YELL A  
DRINK?

ER ... NEE, SAID RAGMAN, WITH A LAST DISAPPOINTED GLANCE AT  
HARRY, NEE THANKS YELL, BYE ...

FRED AND GEORGE LOOKED WHITE AS DISAPPOINTED AS RAGMAN,  
WHEN WAS SURVEYING HARRY AS THOUGH HE HAD LET HIM DOWN  
BADLY.

WELL, I MUST DASH, HE SAID. NICE SEEING YOU ALL. GOOD LUCK,  
HARRY.

HE FLURRIED OUT OF THE PUB. THE CHAIRS ALL SLID OFF THEIR  
CHAIRS AND EXITED AFTER HIM. HARRY WENT TO REIN AND  
HERMINE.

WHAT DID HE WANT? REIN SAID, THE MOMENT HARRY HAD SAT  
DOWN.

HE OFFERED THE HELP ME WITH THE CHILDEN TOO, SAID HARRY,

HE SHOULDNT BE DOING THAT! SAID HERMIONE, LEANING VERY  
FORWARD. HE S HUR UP THE ILLEGES! AND ANYWAY, WHY VE ALREADY  
WHORDED IT HELT HAVEN T WHY?

ER ... NEARLY, SAID HARRY,

WELL, I DONT THINK DUMBLEDORE WOULD LIKE IT IF HE KNEW  
RAGMAN WAS TRYING THE PERSUADE WHY THE CHEAT! SAID HERMIONE,

AND HARRY MUTTERED

STILL LEANING DEEPLY DISAPPROVING. I HOPE HE S TRYING THE HELP  
LEBRIC AS MUCH!

HE S NOT, I ASKED, SAID HARRY,

WHICH CARES IF DIGGERY S GETTING HELP? SAID REIN, HARRY PRI-  
VATELY AGREED,

THESE GEEKS DIDNT LEED VERY FRIENDLY, SAID HERMIONE, SIP-  
PING HER BLITTERBEER. WHAT WERE THEY DOING HERE?

LEANING FOR CRELICH, ACCORDING THE RAGMAN, SAID HARRY. HE S  
STILL ILL, HASN T BEEN IN THE WORK.

MAYBE PERCY S POISONING HIM, SAID REIN. PROBABLY THINKS IF  
CRELICH SNOWPS IT HE LL BE MADE HEAD OF THE DEPARTMENT OF  
INTERNATIONAL MAGICAL CO-OPERATION.

HERMIONE GAVE REIN A DONT-T-DOE-ANYLT-THINGS-LIKE-THAT LEED,  
AND SAID, FLINDY, GEEKS LEANING FOR MR CRELICH ... THEY D  
NORMALLY DEAL WITH THE DEPARTMENT FOR THE REGULATION AND

CENTRE OF MAGICAL CREATURES.

CRELICH CAN SPEAK HEADS OF DIFFERENT LANGUAGES, THERLICH, SAID  
HARRY. MAYBE THEY NEED AN INTERPRETER.

WHIRRYING ABOUT THEIR IDLE GIBBONS, NEEL, ARE YOU? RON

ASKED HERMIONE. THINKING OF STARTING UP S.P.L.I.C. FOR SOME-  
THING? SECRETLY FOR THE PROTECTION OF LONELY GIBBONS?

HA, HA, HA, SAID HERMIONE SARCASTICALLY. GIBBONS DON'T NEED  
PROTECTION. HAVEN'T YOU BEEN LISTENING TO WHAT PROFESSOR KINGS  
HAS BEEN TELLING US ABOUT GIBBON REBELLIIONS?

NEE, SAID HARRY AND RON TOGETHER.

WELL, THEY'RE ELITE CAPABLE OF DEALING WITH WIZARDS, SAID  
HERMIONE, SIPPING MORE OF HER BUTTERBEER. THEY'RE VERY CLEVER.

THEY'RE NOT LIKE HOUSE-ELVES, WHO NEVER STICK UP FOR THEM-  
SELVES.

WHEN, SAID RON, STARING AT THE DEER.

RITA SKEETER HAD JUST ENTERED. SHE WAS WEARING BANYAN-  
YELLOW BIKES TODAY; HER LONG NAILS WERE PAINTED SHOCKING PINK,

AND SHE WAS ACCOMPANIED BY HER PALING PHOTOGRAPHER. SHE  
BLIGHT DRINKS, AND SHE AND THE PHOTOGRAPHER MADE THEIR WAY  
THROUGH THE CROWDS TO A TABLE NEARBY. HARRY, RON AND



RITA SKEETER'S STEEP KILL

HERMIONE GLARING AT HER AS SHE APPROACHED. SHE WAS TALKING FAST AND BEHINDING VERY SATISFIED ABOUT SOMETHING.

... DIDN'T SEEM VERY DEEPEN THE TALK THE LIES, DID HE, RHIZEN? WHY, WHY WOULD THAT BE, DEE YELL THINK? AND WHAT'S HE DOING WITH A PAIR OF GLOVES IN THE HAND? SHOWING THEM THE SIGNS ...

WHAT NONSENSE ... HE WAS ALWAYS A BAD LIAR, REMINDING SOME-  
THING'S LIKE? THINK WE SHOULD BE A BIT OF DIGGING? DISGRACED EX-  
HEAD OF MAGICAL SPORTS, LUDWIG BAGMAN ... SNAPPY START THE A SEN-  
TENCE, RHIZEN WE JUST NEED TO FIND A STORY THAT FIT IT

TRYING THE ALIVE SOMETHING ELSE'S LIKE? SAID HARRY LUDWIG,  
A FEW PEOPLE BEHIND APPROACHING, RITA SKEETER'S EYES WIDENED  
BEHIND HER IRON-GLAZED SPECTACLES AS SHE SAW WHO HAD SPOKEN,  
HARRY? SHE SAID, BEAMING, FEEL BETTER? WHY DIDN'T YOU  
COME AND JOIN?

I WOULDN'T COME NEAR YOU WITH A TEN-FOOT KNEELING STICK, SAID  
HARRY FLIRTELINGLY. WHAT DID YOU DO THAT THE MAGRID ARE, EH?  
RITA SKEETER RAISED HER HEAVILY PENCILLED EYEBROWS.

HER READERS HAVE THE RIGHT TO KNOW THE TRUTH, HARRY, I AM  
MERELY DOING MY

WHICH CARES IF HE'S HALF-GIANT? HARRY SMILED. THERE'S SOMETHING  
GOING ON WITH HIM?

THE WHILE PLEASANT HAD BEEN VERY QUIET, MADAM ROSEMARY WAS

STARING OVER THEM BEHIND THE BAR, APPARENTLY BELIEVING IN THE FACT THAT THE FLAGON SHE WAS FILLING WITH MEAD WAS OVERFLOWING. RITA SKEETER'S SMILE FLICKERED VERY SLIGHTLY, BUT SHE HITCHED IT

BACK ALMOST AT ONCE; SHE SNAPPED OPEN HER CRACKLE-SKIN HANDBAG, PULLED OUT HER BLACK-ROULETES ROLL AND SAID, 'WELL ABOUT

GIVING ME AN INTERVIEW ABOUT THE 'SACRED YELL KNELL, 'HARRY? THE

MAN BEHIND THE MISTLE? YOUR UNLIKELY FRIENDSHIP AND THE REASONS BEHIND IT. WOULD YOU CALL HIM A FATHER SUBSTITUTE?

HERMIONE STOOD UP VERY ABRUPTLY, HER CLUTTERED CLUTCH IN HER HAND AS THOUGH IT WAS A GRENADE.

'YOU HORRIBLE WOMAN, SHE SAID, THROUGH GRITTED TEETH, 'YOU DON'T CARE, DO YOU, ANYTHING FOR A STORY, AND ANYONE WILL DIE WHEN T THEY? EVEN LUDWIG BAGMAN

KEE 'HARRY POUTTER

'SIT DOWN, YOU SILLY LITTLE GIRL, AND DON'T TALK ABOUT THINGS YOU DON'T UNDERSTAND, SAID RITA SKEETER COLDLY, HER EYES HARDENING AS THEY FELL ON HERMIONE. 'I KNOW THINGS ABOUT LUDWIG BAGMAN THAT WOULD MAKE YOUR HAIR CURL ... NOT THAT IT NEEDS IT SHE ADDED, EYING HERMIONE'S KISSY HAIR.

'LET'S GO, SAID HERMIONE. 'I MEAN, 'HARRY 'DON'T ...

THEY LEFT; MANY PEOPLE WERE STARING AT THEM AS THEY WENT.

'HARRY GLANCED BACK AS THEY REACHED THE DOOR. RITA SKEETER'S

BLIND-BLINDS BLIND WAS BLIND: IT WAS ZIPPING BACKWARDS AND  
FORWARDS OVER A PIECE OF PARCHMENT ON THE TABLE.

SHE LL BE AFTER YOU NEXT, HERMINE, SAID REN, IN A LEW AND  
WHIRLED WHILE AS THEY WALKED BLINDLY BACK UP THE STREET.

LET HER TRY? SAID HERMINE SMILING: SHE WAS SMILING WITH  
RAGE. I LL SEE HER: SILLY LITTLE GIRL, AM I? YES, I LL GET HER BACK  
FOR THIS, FIRST HARRY, THEN HAGRID ...

YOU DONT WANT THE CHIMPSETTING RITA SKEETER, SAID REN  
NERVOUSLY. I M SURELY, HERMINE, SHE LL DO SOMETHING UP IN  
YOU

MY PARENTS DONT READ THE DAILY PROPHET, SHE CANT SCARE ME  
INTO HIDING? SAID HERMINE, NOW STRIDING ALONG SHE FAST THAT IT  
WAS ALL HARRY AND REN CHILD ON THE DEEP UP WITH HER. THE LAST  
TIME HARRY HAD SEEN HERMINE IN A RAGE LIKE THIS, SHE HAD HIT  
BRACE MALFOY AROUND THE FACE. AND HAGRID ISN T GETTING THE HIDE  
ANY MORE? HE SHOULD NEVER HAVE LET THAT EXCISE FOR A HUMAN  
BEING UPSET HIM? LEAVE HIM?

BREAKING INTO A RUN, SHE LED THEM ALL THE WAY BACK UP THE  
ROAD, THROUGH THE GATES FLANKED BY WINGED BEARS, AND UP  
THROUGH THE GREENS THE HAGRID S CARIN.

THE CURTAINS WERE STILL DRAWN, AND THEY CHILD HEAR FANG  
BARKING AS THEY APPROACHED.

HAGRID? HERMINE SMILED, FINDING HIM HIS FRONT DEER.

HAGRID, THAT S ENOUGH? WE KNOW YOU RE IN THERE? WHOEVER CARES  
IF YOUR MOM WAS A GIANTESS, HAGRID? YOU CANT LET THAT FEEL  
SKEETER WHIMAN DO THIS TO YOU? HAGRID, GET OUT HERE, YOU RE JUST  
BEING

RITA SKEETER & SHEEP RYE

THE DOOR OPENED, HERMIONE SAID ABWUT T : AND THEN  
STEPPED, VERY SLIDDERLY, BECAUSE SHE HAD PHUNG HERSELF FACE THE  
FACE, NHT WITH HAGRID, BLT WITH ALBUS DUMBLEDORE.

CHED AFTERNEEN, HE SAID PLEASANTLY, SMILING DOWN AT THEM.  
WE ER WE WANTED TE SEE HAGRID, SAID HERMIONE IN A  
RATHER SMALL VEHICLE.

YES, I SURMISED AS MUCH, SAID DUMBLEDORE, HIS EYES TWINK-  
LING, WHY DEN T YELI CHEM IN?

EH ... UM ... EDD, SAID HERMIONE.

SHE, RON AND HARRY WENT INTO THE CABIN; FANG BALANCED  
HIMSELF UPON HARRY THE MOMENT HE ENTERED, BARKING MADLY  
AND TRYING TE LICK HIS EARS, HARRY PENDED FANG OFF, AND WHEDD  
ARHLING.

HAGRID WAS SITTING AT HIS TABLE, WHERE THERE WERE TWO LARGE  
MUGS OF TEA, HE WHEDD A REAL MESS, HIS FACE WAS BLUTCHY, HIS  
EYES SWELLEN, AND HE HAD CHNE TE TE EITHER EXTREME WHERE HIS  
HAIR WAS CONCERNED; FAR FROM TRYING TE MAKE IT BELAVE, IT NEEL  
WHEDD LIKE A BIG OF TANGLED WIRE.

HI, HAGRID, SAID HARRY.

HAGRID WHEDD UP.

LEE, HE SAID, IN A VERY FEARSE VEHICLE.

MERE TEA, I THINK, SAID DUMBLEDORE, CLESTING THE DOOR  
BEHIND HARRY, RON AND HERMIONE, DRAWING BLT HIS HAND AND

TWIDDLING IT; A REVOLVING TEA-TRAY APPEARED IN MID-AIR, ALONG WITH A PLATE OF CAKES. DUMBLEDORE MAGICKED THE TRAY DOWN THE TABLE, AND EVERYBODY SAT DOWN. THERE WAS A SLIGHT PAUSE, AND THEN DUMBLEDORE SAID, DID YOU BY ANY CHANCE HEAR WHAT MISS GRANGER WAS SAYING, HARRY?

HERMIONIE WENT SLIGHTLY PINK, BUT DUMBLEDORE SMILED AT HER, AND CONTINUED, HERMIONIE, HARRY AND RON STILL SEEM TO WANT THE KNOW YOU, JUDGING BY THE WAY THEY WERE ATTEMPTING THE BREAK DOWN THE DEER.

IF COURSE WE STILL WANT THE KNOW YOU? HARRY SAID, STARING AT HARRY. YOU DON'T THINK ANYTHING THAT SKEETER TELLS SHIRRY, PROFESSOR, HE ADDED QUICKLY, LOOKING AT DUMBLEDORE.

BY HARRY PETER

I HAVE BEEN TEMPORARILY DEAF AND HAVEN'T ANY IDEA WHAT YOU

SAID, HARRY, SAID DUMBLEDORE, TWIDDLING HIS THUMBS AND STARING AT THE CEILING.

ER RIGHT, SAID HARRY SHEEPISHLY. I JUST MEANT HARRY, HOW COULD YOU THINK WE'D CARE WHAT THAT WOMAN WROTE ABOUT YOU?

TWO FAT TEARS LEAKED OUT OF HARRY'S KEETLE-BLACK EYES AND FELL SILENTLY INTO HIS TANGLED BEARD.

LIVING PROOF OF WHAT I'VE BEEN TELLING YOU, HARRY, SAID DUMBLEDORE, STILL LOOKING CAREFULLY UP AT THE CEILING. I HAVE

SEEMED WHEN THE LETTERS FROM THE CHERISHED PARENTS WERE REMEM-  
BER WHEN FROM THEIR HAPPY DAYS HERE, TELLING ME IN NEW UNCERTAIN

TERMS THAT, IF I SUCCEEDED WHEN, THEY WOULD HAVE SOMETHING TO SAY  
ABOUT IT

NEXT ALL OF THEM, SAID FATHERLY HEARSLEY, NEXT ALL OF THEM WOULD ME  
TER STAY,

REALLY, FATHERLY, IF WHEN ARE FEELING WELL FOR UNIVERSAL POPULARI-  
TY, I'M AFRAID WHEN WILL BE IN THIS CASE FOR A VERY LONG TIME, SAID

DUMBLEDORE, WHEN PEERING STERNLY OVER HIS HALF-MOON SPECTA-  
CLES, NEXT A WEEK HAS PASSED, SINCE I BECAME HEADMASTER OF THIS

SCHOOL, WHEN I HAVEN'T HAD AT LEAST ONE WHOLE COMPLAINTING ABOUT  
THE WAY I RUN IT, BUT WHAT SHOULD I DO? BARRICADE MYSELF IN MY  
STUDY AND REFUSE TO TALK TO ANYBODY?

YES YES ARE NOT HALF-GIANT? SAID FATHERLY CREASILY,

FATHERLY, LEAVE WHAT I'VE GOTTEN FOR RELATIVES? FATHERLY SAID FLUTTER-  
LY, LEAVE AT THE DURSLEYS?

AN EXCELLENT POINT, SAID PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE, MY WHEN  
BROTHER, ABERNETHY, WAS PROSECUTED FOR PRACTISING INAPPROPRIATE  
CHARMS ON A GHEAT, IT WAS ALL OVER THE PAPERS, BUT DID ABERNETHY  
HIDE? NO, HE DID NOT? HE HELD HIS HEAD HIGH AND WENT ABOUT  
HIS BUSINESS AS USUAL? OH COURSE, I'M NOT ENTIRELY SURE HE CAN

READ, SHE THAT MAY NEET HAVE BEEN BRAVER ...

CHIEF KAD AND TEACH, F-JAGRID, SAID F-JERMINEHNE EULIETLY,

PLEASE CHIEF KAD, WE REALLY MISS YELI.

F-JAGRID CLIMBED, MORE TEARS LEADED ELIT DOWN HIS CHEEKS AND

RITA SKEETTER S STEEP KAS

INTHE HIS TANGLED BEARD, DIMPLEDHIRE STEED LIP,

I REFUSE TH ACCEPT YELIR RESIGNATION, F-JAGRID, AND I EXPECT YELI

KAD AT WHIRK HIN MENDAY, HE SAID, YELI WILL IHIN ME FOR BREAK-  
FAST AT EIGHT THIRTY IN THE GREAT F-HALL, NEE EXCLUSES, CHIED AFTER-  
NHEEN TH YELI ALL,

DIMPLEDHIRE LEFT THE CABIN, PALISING HENLY TH SCRATCH FANG S  
EARS, WHEN THE DHIR HAD SHIT BEHIND HIM, F-JAGRID BEGAN TH SHE  
INTHE HIS DISTKIN-LID-SIZED HANDS, F-JERMINEHNE DEPT PATTING HIS  
ARM, AND AT LAST F-JAGRID WHIRKED LIP, HIS EYES VERY RED INDEED,  
AND SAID, GREAT MAN, DIMPLEDHIRE ... GREAT MAN ...

YEAH, HE IS, SAID RHN, CAN I HAVE HINE HP THESE CAGES,  
F-JAGRID?

HELP YERSELF, SAID F-JAGRID, WIPING HIS EYES HIN THE BACK HP HIS  
HAND, AR, HE S RICH, HE CHURSE YEH RE ALL RICH ... I KIN STUPID  
... MY EL DAD WHILDA KIN ASHAMED HE THE WAY I VE KIN BEHAVIN

... MORE TEARS LEADED ELIT, KLT HE WIPED THEM AWAY MORE FORCE-  
FULLY, AND SAID, NEVER SEHEEN YELI A PICTURE HP MY ELD DAD, HAVE

IF HERE ...

FACRID GET UP, WENT OVER TO HIS DRESSER, OPENED A DRAWER

AND PULLED OUT A PICTURE OF A SHORT WIZARD WITH FACRID'S CRINKLED BLACK EYES, BEAMING AS HE SAT ON TOP OF FACRID'S SHOULDER,

FACRID WAS A GOOD SEVEN OR EIGHT FEET TALL, JUDGING BY THE APPLE TREE BESIDE HIM, BUT HIS FACE WAS BEardless, YELING, REDDISH AND SMILELESS. HE LOOKED HARDLY OLDER THAN ELEVEN.

THIS WAS TAKEN JUST AFTER I GOT INTO HOGWARTS, SAID FACRID, CRIMINALLY. DAD WAS DEAD CHIPPED ... THOUGHT I MIGHT NOT BE A WIZARD, SEE, THIS MY MOM ... WELL, ANYWAY, COURSE, I NEVER WAS GREAT SHAKES AT MAGIC, REALLY ... BUT AT LEAST HE NEVER SAW ME EXPELLED, DIED, SEE, IN MY SECOND YEAR ...

OLIMPEMORE WAS THE ONE WHO STUCK UP FOR ME AFTER DAD WENT, GOT ME THE GAMKEEPER JOB ... TRUSTS PEOPLE, HE DOES, GIVES MY SECOND CHANCES ... THIS IS WHAT SETS HIM APART FROM OTHER JEADS, SEE, HE'LL ACCEPT ANYONE AT HOGWARTS, S LONG AS THEY'VE GOT THE TALENT, SOMEONE'S PEOPLE CAN TURN OUT BAD EVEN IF THEIR FAMILIES WEREN' ... WELL ... ALL THIS RESPECTABLE, BUT SOME

FOR HARRY POTTER

BEEN UNDERSTAND THAT, THERE'S SOME WHO'D ALWAYS BEEN IT AGAINST YOU ... THERE'S SOME WHO'D EVEN PRETEND THEY JUST HAD BIG KINKS RATHER THAN STAND UP AND SAY "I AM WHAT I AM, AND I'M NOT ASHAMED. NEVER BE ASHAMED, MY HELL DAD USED TO SAY,

THERE'S SOME WHO'LL BE IT AGAINST YOU, BUT THEY'RE NOT WORTHY



KEETHERIN WITH. AN HE WAS RIGHT, I VE KIN AN IDIOT, I M NEET  
KEETHERIN WITH HER NEH MEHR, I PROMISE YEH THAT, BIG KINKS ...  
I LL GIVE HER BIG KINKS.

F-HARRY, REEN AND F-JERMINE WHISKED AT EACH OTHER NERVIOUSLY;  
F-HARRY WOULD RATHER HAVE TAKEN FIFTY BLAST-ENDED SKRENTS AER A  
WALK THAN ADMIT THE F-JACRID THAT HE HAD EVER HEARD HIM TALKING  
THE MADAME MAXIME, BUT F-JACRID WAS STILL TALKING, APPARENTLY  
UNAWARE THAT HE HAD SAID ANYTHING HED.

YEH DKNEN WHAT, F-HARRY? HE SAID, WHISKING UP FROM THE PHOTO-  
GRAPH OF HIS FATHER, HIS EYES VERY BRIGHT. WHEN I FIRS MET YEH,

YEH REMINDED ME H ME A KIT, MUM AN DAD CHINE, AN YEH WAS  
FEELIN LIKE YEH WOULD FIT IN AT F-HEELWARTS, REMEMBER? NEET SLURE  
YEH WERE REALLY UP THE IT ... AN NEEL WHISK AT YEH, F-HARRY? SC-HEEL  
CHAMPION?

HE WHISKED AT F-HARRY AER A MOMENT AND THEN SAID, VERY  
SERIOUSLY, YEH DKNEN WHAT I D LOVE, F-HARRY? I D LOVE YEH TER WIN.

I REALLY WOULD, IT D SEEM EM ALL ... YEH DEN HAVE TER BE PLURE-  
BLEED TER DEE IT, YEH DEN HAVE TER BE AS-LAMED OF WHAT YEH ARE.

IT D SEEM EM DUMBLEHERE S THE HNE WHEN S GET IT RICH, LETTIN  
ANYONE IN AS LONG AS THEY CAN DEE MAGIC, F-HEEL YEH DEN WITH  
THAT EGG, F-HARRY?

GREAT, SAID F-HARRY, REALLY GREAT.

F-JACRID S MISERABLE FACE BREEKE INTHE A WIDE, WATERY SMILE.

THAT'S MY KEY ... YOU'LL SEE ME, HARRY, YOU'LL SEE ME, BEAT ME  
ALL.

LYING THE FLAGRANT WASN'T ELITE LIKE LYING THE ANYONE ELSE, HARRY  
WENT BACK THE THE CASTLE LATER THAT AFTERNOON WITH DEEN AND  
BERMIONE, UNABLE THE BANISH THE IMAGE OF THE HAPPY EXPRESSION  
ON FLAGRANT'S WHISPERY FACE AS HE HAD IMAGINED HARRY WINNING  
THE TOURNAMENT. THE INCOMPREHENSIBLE EGG WRIGGLED MORE

RITA SKEETER'S SLEEP BY

HEAVILY THAN EVER ON HARRY'S CONSCIENCE THAT EVENING, AND BY  
THE TIME HE HAD GOTTEN INTO BED, HE HAD MADE UP HIS MIND IT  
WAS TIME TO SHED HIS PRIDE, AND SEE IF CEDRIC'S HINT WAS WORTH  
ANYTHING.

## CHAPTER TWENTY-FIVE

### THE EGG AND THE EYE

AS HARRY HAD NO IDEA HOW LONG A BATH HE WOULD NEED THE WOOD  
HUNT THE SECRET OF THE GOLDEN EGG, HE DECIDED TO DO IT AT NIGHT,  
WHEN HE WOULD BE ABLE TO TAKE AS MUCH TIME AS HE WANTED.  
RELUCTANT THOUGH HE WAS TO ACCEPT MORE FAVOURS FROM CEDRIC,  
HE ALSO DECIDED TO USE THE PRETEXTS BATHING; FAR FEWER PEOPLE  
WERE ALLOWED IN THERE, SO IT WAS MUCH LESS LIKELY THAT HE WOULD  
BE DISTURBED.

HARRY PLANNED HIS EVILS WITH CAREFULLY, BECAUSE HE HAD BEEN  
CAUGHT OUT OF BED AND OUT OF BEDS BY FILCH THE CARETAKER IN

THE MIDDLE OF THE NIGHT HEWKE REFUSE, AND HAD NO DESIRE TO  
REPEAT THE EXPERIENCE. THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK WOULD, OF COURSE,  
BE ESSENTIAL, AND AS AN ADDED PRECAUTION, HARRY REMEMBERED HE  
WOULD TAKE THE MARAUDER'S MAP, WHICH, NEXT TO THE CLOAK, WAS  
THE MOST USEFUL AND THE RULE-BREAKING HARRY OWNED. THE MAP  
SHOWED THE WHOLE OF HOGWARTS, INCLUDING ITS MANY SHORTCUTS  
AND SECRET PASSAGELAYS AND, MOST IMPORTANTLY OF ALL, IT  
REVEALED THE PEOPLE INSIDE THE CASTLE AS MINUSCULE, LABELLED  
DOTS, MOVING AROUND THE CORRIDORS, SO THAT HARRY WOULD BE  
FOREWARNED IF SOMEBODY WAS APPROACHING THE BATHROOM.  
ON THURSDAY NIGHT, HARRY SNEAKED UP THE BED, PUT ON THE  
CLOAK, CREEPT BACK DOWNSTAIRS AND, JUST AS HE HAD DONE ON THE  
NIGHT WHEN LACRIB HAD SHOWN HIM THE DRAGONS, WAITED FOR THE  
PORTRAIT BEFORE HE OPENED. THIS TIME IT WAS WHEN HE WAITED OUTSIDE  
THAT GIVE THE FAT LADY THE PASSWORD (BANANA FRITTERS!). GOING  
BACK, WHEN WHISPERED, CLIMBING INTO THE CHIMNEY ROOM AS HARRY  
CREEPT OUT PAST HIM.

## THE EGG AND THE EYE KEY

IT WAS ALEXANDER MOVING UNDER THE CLOAK THAT NIGHT, BECAUSE  
HARRY HAD THE HEAVY EGG UNDER ONE ARM, AND THE MAP HELD IN  
FRONT OF HIS NOSE WITH THE OTHER. HOWEVER, THE MINERAL CHIR-  
DIERS WERE EMPTY AND SILENT, AND BY CHECKING THE MAP AT STRATE-  
GIC INTERVALS, HARRY WAS ABLE TO ENSURE THAT HE WOULD NOT RUN  
INTO ANYONE HE WANTED TO AVOID. WHEN HE REACHED THE STATUE OF

KEITH THE BEMILDERED, A BEST-LOOKING WIZARD WITH HIS GLASSES ON THE WRING HANDS, HE LOCATED THE RIGHT DOOR, LEANT CLOSE TO IT, AND MUTTERED THE PASSWORD, PINK-FRESH, JUST AS CEDRIC HAD TOLD HIM.

THE DOOR CREAKED OPEN, HARRY SLIPPED INSIDE, SHUT THE DOOR BEHIND HIM, AND PULLED OFF THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK, LEAVING AROUND.

HIS IMMEDIATE REACTION WAS THAT IT WOULD BE WORTH SEEKING A PERFECT JUST THE BE ABLE THE LIKE THIS BATHROOM. IT WAS SEPTLY

LIT BY A SPLENDID CANDLE-FILLED CHANDELIER, AND EVERYTHING WAS MADE OF WHITE MARBLE, INCLUDING WHAT LOOKED LIKE AN EMPTY, RECTANGULAR SWIMMING POOL SLIDING INTO THE MIDDLE OF THE ROOM. AROUND A HUNDRED GILDED TAPS STOOD ALL AROUND THE POOL'S EDGES, EACH WITH A DIFFERENT-COLOURED JEWEL SET INTO ITS HANDLE. THERE WAS ALSO A DIVING BOARD, LONG WHITE LINEN CURTAINS FILING AT THE WINDOWS, A LARGE PILE OF PLUSHY WHITE TOWELS SAT IN A CORNER, AND

THERE WAS A SINGLE GILDED-FRAMED PAINTING ON THE WALL. IT FEATURED A BLONDE MERMAID, WHO WAS FAST ASLEEP IN A POSE, HER

LONG HAIR FLUTTERING OVER HER FACE EVERY TIME SHE SNIRED.

HARRY PUT DOWN HIS CLOAK, THE EGG AND THE MAP, AND MEVED FORWARD, LEAVING AROUND, HIS FEETSTEPS ECHOING OFF THE WALLS.

MAGNIFICENT THOUGH THE BATHROOM WAS AND ELITE BEEN

THOUGH HE WAS THE TRY BUT A FEW OF THESE TAPS WHEN HE WAS HERE

HE COULDN'T WHITE SUPPRESS THE FEELING THAT CEDRIC MIGHT HAVE BEEN HAVING HIM ON. FELIX HAD BATHED WAS THIS SUPPOSED TO HELP SOLVE THE MYSTERY OF THE EGG? NEVERTHELESS, HE PLUT HURRY OF THE ALREADY THERE, THE CLIMAX, THE MAP AND THE EGG AT THE SIDE OF THE SWIMMING-POOL-SIZED BATH, THEN KNELT DOWN AND TURNED ON A FEW OF THE TAPS.

AND HARRY POTTER

HE COULD TELL AT ONCE THAT THEY CARRIED DIFFERENT SHOTS OF BLUE BLUE BATH MIXED WITH THE WATER, THOUGH IT WASN'T BLUE BATH AS

HARRY HAD EVER EXPERIENCED IT. ONE TAP GUSHED PINK AND BLUE BUBBLES THE SIZE OF FOOTBALLS, ANOTHER FLOWED ICE-WHITE STEAM SHE THOUGHT THAT HARRY THOUGHT IT WOULD HAVE SUPPORTED HIS WEIGHT IF HE DARED THE TEST IT; A THIRD SENT HEAVILY PERLUMED PURPLE BUBBLES BUBBLING OVER THE SURFACE OF THE WATER. HARRY AMUSED HIMSELF FOR A WHILE TURNING THE TAPS ON AND OFF, PARTICULARLY ENJOYING THE

EFFECT OF ONE WHICH IT BOUNCED OFF THE SURFACE OF THE WATER IN LARGE ARCS. THEN, WHEN THE DEEP POOL WAS FULL OF HOT WATER, STEAM AND BUBBLES (WHICH TOOK A VERY SHORT TIME CONSIDERING ITS SIZE), HARRY TURNED OFF ALL THE TAPS, PULLED OFF HIS PYJAMAS, SLIPPERS AND DRESSING-GOWN, AND SLID INTO THE WATER.

IT WAS SO DEEP THAT HIS FEET RARELY TOUCHED THE BOTTOM, AND HE ACTUALLY DID A COUPLE OF LENGTHS BEFORE SWIMMING BACK TO

THE SIDE AND TREADING WATER, STARING AT THE EGG, HIGHLY ENTHUSIASTIC THOUGH IT WAS THE SWIM IN COLD AND CHAMPY WATER WITH CHILLS

OF DIFFERENT-COLOURED STEAM BASTING ALL AROUND HIM, THE STRENGTH OF BRILLIANCE CAME TO HIM, THE SUDDEN CLARITY OF UNDERSTANDING, HARRY STRETCHED OUT HIS ARMS, LIFTED THE EGG IN HIS WET HANDS

AND OPENED IT. THE WAILING, SCREECHING SOUND FILLED THE BATHROOM, ECHOING AND REVERBERATING OFF THE MARBLE WALLS, BUT IT

SOUNDED JUST AS INCOMPREHENSIBLE AS EVER, IF NOT MORE SO WITH ALL THE ECHOES. HE SNAPPED IT SHUT AGAIN, WORRIED THAT THE SOUND WOULD ATTRACT FILTH, WONDERING WHETHER THAT HADN'T BEEN CROOK'S PLAN AND THEN, MAKING HIM JUMP SEE EARLY THAT HE DROPPED THE EGG, WHICH CLATTERED AWAY ACROSS THE BATHROOM FLOOR, STOPPING SHORT.

I'D TRY PUTTING IT IN THE WATER, IF I WERE YOU.

HARRY HAD SWALLOWED A CONSIDERABLE AMOUNT OF KIDNEES IN SHORT. HE STOOD UP, SPILLING, AND SAW THE GHOST OF A VERY GLUM-LOOKING GIRL SITTING CROSS-LEGGED ON THE END OF THE TAP. IT WAS MEANING MORTLE, WHO WAS USUALLY THE ONE HEARD SNEAKING IN THE S-BEND OF A THICKET THREE FEETERS DEEP.

MORTLE? HARRY SAID IN WHISPER. I'M I'M NOT WEARING ANYTHING!

THE EGG AND THE EYE

THE FEEL WAS SO DENSE THAT THIS HARDLY MATTERED, BUT HE HAD

A NASTY FEELING THAT MYRTLE HAD BEEN SPYING ON HIM FROM HILT OF  
HENCE OF THE TAPS EVER SINCE HE HAD ARRIVED.

I CLOSED MY EYES WHEN YELL CAME IN, SHE SAID, BLINKING AT HIM  
THROUGH HER THICK SPECTACLES. YELL HAVEN'T BEEN THE SEE ME FOR  
AGES.

YEAH ... WELL ... SAID HARRY, BENDING HIS KNEES SLIGHTLY, JUST  
THE MAKE ABSOLUTELY SURE MYRTLE COULDN'T SEE ANYTHING BUT HIS  
HEAD. I MIGHT SLIPPED THE CHAIR INTO YELL'S BATHROOM, AM I? IT'S  
A GIRL'S HOME.

YELL DIDN'T LIKE THE CARE, SAID MYRTLE MISERABLY. YELL LIKED THE  
BE IN THERE ALL THE TIME.

THIS WAS TRUE, THOUGH ONLY BECAUSE HARRY, BEN AND  
HERMIONE HAD FOUND MYRTLE'S HILT-OF-HOLDER THIEFS A CONVENIENT  
PLACE TO KEEP POLYGLIC POTION IN SECRET A FORBIDDEN POTION  
WHICH HAD TURNED HARRY AND BEN INTO LIVING REPLICAS OF CRABBE  
AND GOYLE FOR AN HOUR, SHE THAT THEY COULD SNEAK INTO THE  
SLOTHFUL CHAMBER ROOM.

I GOT THEM OFF FOR GOING IN THERE, SAID HARRY, WHICH WAS HALF-  
TRUE; PERCY HAD ONCE CALLED HIM CRYING HILT OF MYRTLE'S BATH-  
ROOM. I THOUGHT I'D BETTER NOT COME BACK AFTER THAT.

HEY ... I SEE ... SAID MYRTLE, PICKING AT A SPOT ON HER CHIN IN  
A NERVOUS SORT OF WAY. WELL ... ANYWAY ... I'D TRY THE EGG IN THE  
WATER. THAT'S WHAT CEDRIC DIGGORY DID.

HAVE YELL BEEN SPYING ON HIM, THEN? SAID HARRY INDIGNANTLY.  
WHAT'D YELL DO, SNEAK UP HERE IN THE EVENINGS THE WATCH THE

PERFECTS TAKE BATHS?

SOMETIMES, SAID MYRTLE, RATHER SLOWLY, BUT I'VE NEVER BEFORE  
HELD THE SPREAD THE ANYONE BEFORE.

I'M FORTUNATE, SAID HARRY BARKLY, WHEN KEEP THEIR EYES SET?  
HE MADE SURE MYRTLE HAD HER GLASSES WELL COVERED BEFORE  
BRISTLING HIMSELF OUT OF THE BATH, WRAPPING THE TOWEL FIRMLY  
AROUND HIMSELF AND GOING TO GET THE EGG.

SINCE HE WAS BACK IN THE WATER, MYRTLE PEERED THROUGH HER  
FINGERS AND SAID, OH HEN, THEN ... OPEN IT UNDER THE WATER!

AND HARRY PEEETTER

HARRY LOWERED THE EGG BENEATH THE SHADY SURFACE, AND  
OPENED IT ... AND, THIS TIME, IT DID NOT WAIL, A GURGling SING

WAS HEARING OUT OF IT, A SING WHOSE WORDS HE COULD NOT DISTIN-  
GUISH THROUGH THE WATER.

WHEN NEED THE PUT THEIR HEAD UNDER, THEN, SAID MYRTLE, WHEN  
SEEMED THE BE THERELICLY ENJOYING BRISTLING HIM AROUND, OH  
HEN!

HARRY TOOK A GREAT BREATH, AND SLID UNDER THE SURFACE AND  
NOW, SITTING IN THE MARBLE BATHING OF THE BUBBLE-FILLED BATH, HE  
HEARD A CHORUS OF FANTASY VOICES SINGING TO HIM FROM THE OPEN  
EGG IN HIS HANDS:

COME SEED US WHERE OUR VOICES SING,  
WE CANNOT SING ABOVE THE GROUND,



AND WHILE THEY'RE SEARCHING, REMEMBER THIS:

WE'VE TAKEN WHAT THEY'LL SOONLY MISS,

AND FEELING LONG THEY'LL HAVE THE LEAD,

AND THE REVEALER WHAT WE'VE TAKEN,

BUT PAST AN HOUR THE PROSPECT'S BLIND

THEY'VE LOST IT, IT'S GONE, IT WON'T COME BACK.

HARRY LET HIMSELF SLIP BACK UPWARDS AND BREKE THE SILENT SLIP-  
PAGE, SHAKING HIS HAIR OUT OF HIS EYES.

HEAR IT? SAID MYRTLE.

YES ... COME SEE US WHERE THEIR VEHICLES ARE ... AND IF I  
NEED PERSUADING ... HANG ON, I NEED TO LISTEN AGAIN ... HE SANK  
BACK BENEATH THE WATER.

IT TOOK THREE MORE UNDERWATER REVISIONS OF THE REG'S SING  
BEFORE HARRY HAD IT MEMORIZED; THEN HE TROD WATER FOR A WHILE,  
THINKING HARD, WHILE MYRTLE SAT AND WATCHED HIM.

I'VE GOT THE GUN AND LEAD FOR PEOPLE WHO CAN'T USE THEIR VEHICLES  
AROUND THE GREEN ... HE SAID SILENTLY. OR ... WHO COULD THAT BE?

THEY, AREN'T THEY?

HE HAD NEVER SEEN MEANING MYRTLE SEEM SERIOUS, APART  
FROM THE DAY WHEN FERMINE'S DEED OF POLYGLIC PATTEN

THE REG AND THE RYE ARE

HAD GIVEN HER THE FAIRY FACE AND TAIL OF A CAT.

HARRY STARED AROUND THE BATHROOM, THINKING ... IF THE VEHICLES  
COULD ONLY BE HEARD UNDERWATER, THEN IT MADE SENSE FOR THEM

THE KEEING THE UNDERWATER CREATURES. HE RAN THIS THEORY PAST MYRTLE, WHO SMIRKED AT HIM.

WELL, THAT'S WHAT DIGGORY THOUGHT, SHE SAID. HE LAY THERE TALKING TO HIMSELF FOR AGES ABOUT IT, AGES AND AGES ... NEARLY ALL THE BUBBLES HAD GONE ...

UNDERWATER ... HARRY SAID SLEELY, MYRTLE ... WHAT LIVES IN THE LAKE, APART FROM THE GIANT SHELL?

HEY, ALL SHOTS, SHE SAID. I SOMETIMES GO DOWN THERE ... SOMETIMES DON'T HAVE ANY CHOICE, IF SOMEONE FLUSHES MY THIEF WHEN

I'M NOT EXPECTING IT ...

TRYING NOT TO THINK ABOUT MEANING MYRTLE ZIPPING DOWN A PIPE TO THE LAKE WITH THE CONTENTS OF A THIEF, HARRY SAID, WELL, DOES ANYTHING IN THERE HAVE FLAMING VEHICLES? FLAME ON

HARRY'S EYES HAD FALLEN ON THE PICTURE OF THE SNEEZING MERMAID ON THE WALL. MYRTLE, THERE AREN'T MERPEOPLE IN THERE, ARE

THERE?

HEHEH, VERY GOOD, SHE SAID, HER THICK GLASSES TWINKLING. IT THINKS DIGGORY MUCH LONGER THAN THAT! AND THAT WAS WITH HER ALONE, THEN MYRTLE JERKED HER HEAD TOWARDS THE MERMAID WITH AN EXPRESSION OF GREAT DISLIKE ON HER CLEFT FACE GIGGLING AND SHAKING HER AND FLASHING HER FINS ...

THAT'S IT, ISN'T IT? SAID HARRY EXCITEDLY. THE SECOND TASK IS TO GO AND FIND THE MERPEOPLE IN THE LAKE AND ... AND ...

BUT HE SUDDENLY REALISED WHAT HE WAS SAYING, AND HE FELT THE  
EXCITEMENT DRAIN OUT OF HIM AS THOUGH SOMEONE HAD JUST  
PULLED A PLUG IN HIS STOMACH. HE WASN'T A VERY GOOD SWIMMER;  
HE'D NEVER HAD MUCH PRACTICE. DUDLEY HAD HAD LESSONS IN THEIR  
YOUTH, BUT ALINT PETUNIA AND LUCIE VERNON, NEARLY HELPING  
THAT HARRY WOULD DROWN ONE DAY, HADN'T REMEMBERED TO GIVE HIM  
ANY. A CHUPLY OF LENGTHS OF THIS BATH WAS ALL VERY WELL, BUT THAT  
BATH WAS VERY LARGE, AND VERY DEEP ... AND MERFOPLE WOULD  
SURELY LIVE RIGHT AT THE BOTTOM ...

AND HARRY PEEETTER

MORTLE, HARRY SAID SILENTLY, HOW AM I SUPPOSED TO BREATHE?  
AT THIS, MORTLE'S EYES FILLED WITH SUDDEN TEARS AGAIN.

TACTLESS? SHE MUTTERED, GRIPPING IN HER REEKS FOR A HANDKER-  
CHIEF.

WHAT'S TACTLESS? SAID HARRY, REWILDERED.

TALKING ABOUT BREATHING IN FRONT OF ME? SHE SAID STIFFLY, AND  
HER VOICE RANGED LOUDLY AROUND THE BATHROOM. WHEN I CAN'T ...  
WHEN I HAVEN'T ... NEET FOR AGES ... SHE CLUTCHED HER FACE IN HER  
HANDKERCHIEF AND SNIFFED LOUDLY.

HARRY REMEMBERED HOW THICKLY MORTLE HAD ALWAYS BEEN  
ABOUT BEING DEAD, BUT WHEN OF THE OTHER GHOSTS HE DON'T MADE  
SUCH A FUSS ABOUT IT. SURELY, HE SAID IMPATIENTLY, I DIDN'T MEAN  
I JUST FORGOT ...

HE-1 YES, VERY EASY TO FORGET MYRTLE'S DEAD, SAID MYRTLE, CLIMB-  
ING, LEANING AT HIM WITH HER SWOLLEN EYES. NEITHER MISSED ME,

EVEN WHEN I WAS ALIVE. THEN THEIR FEELINGS AND FEELINGS THEY FIND MY  
BODY I KNOW, I WAS SITTING THERE WAITING FOR THEM. ELIVE  
FERNANDY CAME INTO THE BATHROOM ARE YOU IN HERE AGAIN,  
SLEEPING, MYRTLE? SHE SAID. BECAUSE PROFESSOR DIPDET ASKED  
ME THE WHOLE FOR YOU AND THEN SHE SAW MY BODY ... HHHHHH-1,  
SHE DIDN'T FORGET IT UNTIL HER DYING DAY, I MADE SURE OF THAT ...  
FOLLOWED HER AROUND AND REMINDED HER, I DID, I REMEMBER AT  
HER BROTHER'S WEDDING

BUT HARRY WASN'T LISTENING; HE WAS THINKING ABOUT THE MER-  
PEOPLE'S SINGING AGAIN. WE'VE TAKEN WHAT YOU'LL SOONLY MISS. THAT

SEEMED AS THOUGH THEY WERE GOING TO STEAL SOMETHING OF HIS,  
SOMETHING HE HAD TO GET BACK. WHAT WERE THEY GOING TO TAKE?

AND THEN, OF COURSE, SHE WENT TO THE MINISTRY OF MAGIC TO  
STOP ME STALKING HER, SHE I HAD TO COME BACK HERE AND LIVE IN MY  
TENT.

GOOD, SAID HARRY VAGUELY. WELL, I'M A LITTLE FURTHER AWAY THAN I  
WAS ... SHE PUT HER EYES AGAIN, WILL YOU, I'M GETTING HOT.

HE RETRIEVED THE EGG FROM THE BATHROOM OF THE BATH, CLIMBED

HOT, DRIED HIMSELF AND PULLED ON HIS PYJAMAS AND DRESSING-  
GOWN AGAIN.

THE FEE AND THE FEE WAS

WILL YOU COME AND VISIT ME IN MY BATHROOM AGAIN SOME-  
TIME? MEANING MORTLE ASKED MEANINGFULLY, AS HARRY PICKED UP  
THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK.

ER ... I LL TRY, HARRY SAID, THOUGH PRIVATELY THINKING THE ONLY  
WAY HE D BE VISITING MORTLE S BATHROOM AGAIN WAS IF EVERY OTHER  
THEFT IN THE CASTLE GOT BLOCKED. SEE YOU, MORTLE ... THANKS FOR  
YOUR HELP.

BYE, BYE, SHE SAID GLENNILLY, AND AS HARRY PUT ON THE  
INVISIBILITY CLOAK, HE SAW HER ZOOM BACK UP THE TAP,  
HIT IN THE DARK HALLWAY, HARRY EXAMINED THE MARAUDER S  
MAP THE CHECK THAT THE CHAST WAS STILL CLEAR. YES, THE DEETS  
RELIVING THE FILCH AND MRS DUNNIS WERE SAFELY IN THEIR OFFICE ...  
NOTHING ELSE SEEMED TO BE MOVING APART FROM PEEVES, WHO WAS  
RELIVING AROUND THE TROPHY ROOM IN THE FLOOR ABOVE ... HARRY  
HAD TAKEN HIS FIRST STEP BACK TOWARDS GRYFFINDOR TOWER, WHEN  
SOMETHING ELSE ON THE MAP CAUGHT HIS EYE ... SOMETHING DIS-  
TINCTLY RED.

PEEVES WAS NOT THE ONLY THING THAT WAS MOVING. A SINGLE DEET  
WAS FLITTING AROUND A ROOM IN THE KITCHEN LEFT-HAND CORNER  
SNAP S OFFICE. BUT THE DEET WASN T LABELLED SEVERUS SNAP ... IT  
WAS BARTHEMUS CRACK.

HARRY STARED AT THE DEET. MR CRACK WAS SUPPOSED TO BE THE

ILL THE CH THE WARD FOR THE CHIEF THE THE YULE BALL SHE WHAT WAS HE  
DOING, SNEAKING INTO THE HALLWAYS AT ONE IN THE MORNING?  
HARRY WATCHED CLOSELY AS THE DOOR MOVED BEHIND AND BEHIND THE  
DOOR, PAUSING HERE AND THERE ...

HARRY HESITATED, THINKING ... AND THEN HIS CURIOSITY GOT THE  
BETTER OF HIM, HE TURNED, AND SET OFF IN THE OPPOSITE DIRECTION,  
TOWARDS THE NEAREST STAIRCASE, HE WAS GOING TO SEE WHAT CRUELTY  
WAS UP THERE.

HARRY WALKED DOWN THE STAIRS AS QUIETLY AS POSSIBLE, THROUGH  
THE PAGES IN SOME OF THE PORTRAITS STILL TURNED CURIOUSLY AT THE  
SOUND OF A FOOTSTEP, THE RUSTLE OF HIS PYJAMAS, HE CROPT  
ALONG THE CORRIDOR QUICKLY, PUSHED ASIDE A TAPESTRY ABOUT  
HALFWAY ALONG AND PROCEEDED DOWN A NARROWER STAIRCASE, A

AND HARRY PETER

SHORTCUT WHICH WOULD TAKE HIM DOWN TWO FLOORS, HE KEPT  
GLANCING DOWN AT THE MAP, WONDERING ... IT JUST DIDN'T SEEM IN  
CHARACTER, SURELY, FOR CRUELTY, LAW-ABIDING MR CRUELTY TO BE  
SNEAKING AROUND SOMEONE ELSE'S OFFICE THIS LATE AT NIGHT ...  
AND THEN, HALFWAY DOWN THE STAIRCASE, NOT THINKING ABOUT  
WHAT HE WAS DOING, NOT CONCENTRATING ON ANYTHING BUT THE  
PECULIAR BEHAVIOUR OF MR CRUELTY, HARRY'S LEG SUDDENLY GAVE  
RIGHT THROUGH THE TRICK STEP NEVILLE ALWAYS FORGET THE LIMP, HE  
GAVE AN UNGAINLY WHEEZE, AND THE CHILDREN TOO, STILL DAMP FROM  
THE BATH, SLIPPED FROM UNDER HIS ARM HE LURCHED FORWARDS TO  
TRY AND CATCH IT, BUT TOO LATE, THE TOO FELL DOWN THE LONG STAIR-

CASE WITH A BANG AS HELD AS A BASS DRUM IN EVERY STEP THE

INVISIBILITY CLOAK SLIPPED. HARRY SNATCHED AT IT, AND THE MARAUDER'S MAP FLUTTERED OUT OF HIS HAND, AND SLID DOWN SIX STAIRS, WHERE, BLIND IN THE STEP TEN ABOVE HIS OWN, HE COULDN'T REACH IT.

THE CHILDREN TOO FELL THROUGH THE TAPESTRY AT THE BOTTOM OF THE STAIRCASE, FIRST OPEN AND BEGAN WAILING LOUDLY IN THE CORRIDOR BELOW. HARRY PULLED OUT HIS HAND AND STRUGGLED TO REACH THE MARAUDER'S MAP, TO Wipe IT BLANK, BUT IT WAS TOO FAR AWAY TO REACH.

PULLING THE CLOAK BACK OVER HIMSELF HARRY STRAIGHTENED UP, LISTENING HARD, HIS EYES SCRUNCHED UP WITH FEAR ... AND, ALMOST IMMEDIATELY

POPPES:

IT WAS THE UNMISTAKABLE FLUTTERING CRY OF FILCH THE CARETAKER. HARRY COULD HEAR HIS RAPID, SHUFFLING FEETSTEPS BEING NEARER AND NEARER, HIS WHEEZY WHEEL RAISED IN FLURY.

WHAT'S THIS RACKET? WAKE UP THE WHOLE CASTLE, WILL YOU? I LL HAVE YOU, POPPES, I LL HAVE YOU, YOU LL ... AND WHAT IS THIS? FILCH'S FEETSTEPS STOPPED: THERE WAS A CLINK OF METAL ON METAL, AND THE WAILING STOPPED. FILCH HAD PICKED UP THE EGG AND CLESED IT. HARRY STOOD VERY STILL, ONE LEG STILL LAMMED TIGHTLY IN THE MAGICAL STEP, LISTENING. AND MOMENT LATER, FILCH WAS GOING TO PULL ASIDE THE TAPESTRY, EXPECTING TO SEE POPPES ... AND THE EGG AND THE EYE WERE

THERE WOULD BE NO PERVES ... BUT IF HE CAME UP THE STAIRS,  
HE WOULD SPOT THE MARAUDER'S MAP ... AND, INVISIBILITY CLOAK OR  
NOT, THE MAP WOULD SEE HARRY POTTER STANDING EXACTLY WHERE  
HE WAS.

LEE? FILCH SAID QUIETLY AT THE FOOT OF THE STAIRS. MY SWEET?

MRS DUMBLEDOORE WAS SPEAKING WITH HIM THIS IS A TRILIZARD  
CLUE? THIS REMINDS ME A SLIGHT CHAMPION?

HARRY FELT SICK; HIS HEART WAS HAMMERING VERY FAST

PERVES? FILCH BEAMED GLEEFULLY. YOU'VE BEEN STEALING?

HE RIPPED BACK THE TAPESTRY QUICKLY, AND HARRY SAW HIS HORRI-  
BLE PINKISH FACE, AND BLINKING, PALE EYES STARING UP THE DARK AND

(THE FILCH) DESERTED STAIRCASE.

HIDING, ARE YOU? HE SAID SILENTLY. I'M TRYING TO GET YOU,  
PERVES ... YOU'VE GONE AND STOLEN A TRILIZARD CLUE, PERVES ...

DUMBLEDOORE WILL HAVE YOU OUT OF HERE FOR THIS, YOU FILTHY PILFER-  
ING PHILTERER! ...

FILCH STARTED TO CLIMB THE STAIRS, HIS SCRAWNY, BLIST-CHINNED  
CAT AT HIS HEELS. MRS DUMBLEDOORE'S LAMP-LIKE EYES, SO VERY LIKE HER  
MASTER'S, WERE FIXED DIRECTLY UPON HARRY. HE HAD HAD OCCASION  
BEFORE WHEN TO WONDER WHETHER THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK WOULD  
HOLD CATS ... SICK WITH APPREHENSION, HE WATCHED FILCH DRAWING  
NEARER AND NEARER IN HIS OLD FLANNEL DRESSING-GOWN HE TRIED  
DESPERATELY TO PULL HIS TRAPPED LEG FREE, BUT IT MERELY SAND A



FEW MORE INCHES AND SECOND NAIL, FILCH WAS GOING THE SPEED THE  
MAD HE WALK RIGHT INTO HIM

FILCH WHAT IS GOING ON?

FILCH STEPPED A FEW STEPS BEHIND HARRY, AND TURNED. AT THE  
FOOT OF THE STAIRS STOOD THE ONLY PERSON WHO COULD MAKE  
HARRY'S SITUATION WORSE. SNAPE. HE WAS WEARING A LONG GREY  
NIGHTSHIRT AND HE LOOKED LIVID.

IT'S PERVES, PROFESSOR, FILCH WHISPERED MALICIOUSLY. HE  
THREW THIS EGG DOWN THE STAIRS.

SNAPE CLIMBED UP THE STAIRS QUICKLY AND STEPPED BESIDE  
FILCH. HARRY GRITTED HIS TEETH, CONVINCED HIS LOUDLY THUMPING  
HEART WOULD GIVE HIM AWAY AT ANY SECOND ...

~~AND~~ HARRY PEEETTER

PERVES? SAID SNAPE SHITLY, STARING AT THE EGG IN FILCH'S HANDS.  
BUT PERVES COULDN'T GET INTO MY OFFICE ...

THIS EGG WAS IN YOUR OFFICE, PROFESSOR?

HE COULDN'T GET IN, SNAPE SNAPPED. I HEARD BANGING AND  
WAILING

YES, PROFESSOR, THAT WAS THE EGG

I WAS TRYING TO INVESTIGATE

PERVES THREW IT, PROFESSOR

AND WHEN I PASSED MY OFFICE, I SAW THAT THE THERMOS WERE

LIT AND A CLIPBOARD BEHIND WAS ALARM! SOMEONE HAS BEEN SEARCH-  
ING IT!

BLIT PEEVES CHILDEN T

I DENIED HE CHILDEN T, FILCH? SNAPE SNAPPED, I SEAL MY OFFICE  
WITH A SPELL NEENE BLIT A LIZARD CHILD BREAD? SNAPE LEERED UP

THE STAIRS, STRAIGHT THROUGH HARRY, AND THEN DOWN INTO THE COR-  
RIDOR BELOW. I WANT YOU TO COME AND HELP ME SEARCH FOR THE

INTRUDER, FILCH.

I YES, PROFESSOR BLIT

FILCH LEERED WARNINGLY UP THE STAIRS, RIGHT THROUGH HARRY,  
WHICH CHILD SEE THAT HE WAS VERY RELUCTANT TO FORGET THE CHANCE OF  
CORNERING PEEVES. OH, HARRY PLEADED WITH HIM SILENTLY, OH WITH  
SNAPE ... OH ... MRS NORRIS WAS PEERING AROUND FILCH'S LEGS ...  
HARRY HAD THE DISTINCT IMPRESSION THAT SHE WOULD SMELL HIM ...  
WHY HAD HE FILLED THAT BATH WITH SHE MUCH PERPLEXED THEM?

THE THING IS, PROFESSOR, SAID FILCH PLAINLY, THE  
HEADMASTER WILL HAVE TO LISTEN TO ME THIS TIME, PEEVES HAS BEEN  
STEALING FROM A STUDENT, IT MIGHT BE MY CHANCE TO GET HIM  
THROUGH OUT OF THE CASTLE HERE AND FOR ALL

FILCH, I DON'T GIVE A DAMN ABOUT THAT WRETCHED PHILTHERIST,  
IT'S MY OFFICE THAT'S

CLINK, CLINK, CLINK.

SNAPE STOPPED TALKING VERY ABRUPTLY, HE AND FILCH BOTH  
LEERED DOWN AT THE FEET OF THE STAIRS. HARRY SAW MAD-PY  
MEHLY LIMP INTO SIGHT THROUGH THE NARROW GAP BETWEEN THEIR  
HEADS. MEHLY WAS WEARING HIS OLD TRAVELLING CLOAK OVER HIS

THE EGG AND THE EYE WAS

NIGHTSHIRT, AND LEANING ON HIS STAFF AS USUAL,

PIAIAA PARTY, IS IT? HE GRIELED UP THE STAIRS,

PROFESSOR SNAPE AND I HEARD NOISES, PROFESSOR, SAID FILCH AT  
ONCE. PEEVES THE PEELEREGIST, THERHEING THINGS AREHIND AS USUAL

AND THEN PROFESSOR SNAPE DISCOVERED THAT SOMEONE HAD KNEEKEN  
INTO HIS OFF

SHUT UP? SNAPE HISSED THE FILCH,

MEEHBY THREK A STEP CLESER THE THE FEET OF THE STAIRS. HARRY SAW

MEEHBY S MAGICAL EYE TRAVEL OVER SNAPE, AND THEN, UNMISTAKE-  
ABLY, INTO HIMSELF,

HARRY S HEART GAVE A TERRIBLE JOLT. MEEHBY COULD SEE THROUGH  
INVISIBILITY CLOAKS ... HE ALONE COULD SEE THE FULL STRANGENESS OF  
THE SCENE ... SNAPE IN HIS NIGHTSHIRT, FILCH CLUTCHING THE EGG,

AND HE, HARRY, TRAPPED IN THE STAIRS BEHIND THEM. MEEHBY S WHIP-  
SIDED GASH OF A MEEHBY OPENED IN SURPRISE, FOR A FEW SECONDS,

HE AND HARRY STARED STRAIGHT INTO EACH OTHER S EYES. THEN  
MEEHBY CLOSED HIS MEEHBY AND TURNED HIS BLUE EYE UPON SNAPE  
AGAIN.

DID I HEAR THAT CORRECTLY, SNAPE? HE ASKED SLEWLY. SOMEONE  
KNEEKE INTO YOUR OFFICE?

IT IS UNIMPHERTANT, SAID SNAPE COLDLY,

EN THE CONTRARY, GRIELED MEEHBY, IT IS VERY IMPHERTANT.

W-H D WANT TH BREAD INTO YHJR OFFIC?

A STUDENT, I DARE SAY, SAID SNAPE, HARRY COULD SEE A VEIN  
FLICKERING FERRIKLY IN SNAPE S GREASY TEMPLE. IT HAS HAPPENED  
BEFORE, POTION INGREDIENTS HAVE BEEN MISSING FROM MY PRIVATE  
STORE CLIPBOARD ... STUDENTS ATTEMPTING ILLICIT MIXTURES, NEH  
DEHLET ...

BEFOREN THEY WERE AFTER POTION INGREDIENTS, EH? SAID MEEHBY,  
NEH HIDING ANYTHING ELSE IN YHJR OFFICE, ARE YHJ?  
HARRY SAW THE EDGE OF SNAPE S SALLER FACE TURN A NASTY BRICK  
COLLOR, THE VEIN IN HIS TEMPLE PULSING MORE RAPIDLY.

YHJ KNEL I M HIDING NOTHING, MEEHBY, HE SAID, IN A SHEFT AND  
DANGEROUS VEHIC, AS YHJ YE SEARCHED MY OFFICE PRETTY THOR-  
OUGHLY YHJRSSELF.

410 HARRY PHTTTER

MEEHBY S FACE TWISTED INTO A SMILE. ALIENR S PRIVILEGE, SNAPE,  
DUMBLEDHRE THLD ME TH DEEP AN EYE

DUMBLEDHRE HAPPENS TH TRUST ME, SAID SNAPE, THIRLIGH-  
CLINCHED TEETH. I REFUSE TH BELIEVE THAT HE GAVE YHJ ORDERS TH  
SEARCH MY OFFICE?

WHYSE DUMBLEDHRE TRUSTS YHJ, GROINLED MEEHBY, H-E S A  
TRUSTING MAN, ISN T HE? BELIEVES IN SECOND CHANCES, BLT ME I  
SAY THERE ARE SPTS THAT DENN T COME HFF, SNAPE, SPTS THAT NEVER  
COME HFF, D YHJ KNEL WHAT I MEAN?

SNAPE SLIDDERNLY DID SOMETHING VERY STRANGE. HE SEIZED HIS

LEFT HER ARM CONVULSIVELY WITH HIS RIGHT HAND, AS THOUGH SOMETHING HAD HURT HIM.

MURDER LAUGHED. GET BACK THE RED, SNAPE.

YOU DON'T HAVE THE AUTHORITY TO SEND ME ANYWHERE! SNAPE HISSED, LETTING GO OF HIS ARM AS THOUGH ANGRY WITH HIMSELF. I HAVE AS MUCH RIGHT TO PRESENT THIS SCENE AFTER DARK AS YOU DO! PRESENT AWAY, SAID MURDER, BUT HIS VOICE WAS FULL OF MENACE. I HEARD FORWARD THE MEETING YOU IN A DARK CORRIDOR SOME TIME ... YOU'VE DROPPED SOMETHING, BY THE WAY ...

WITH A STAB OF HORROR, HARRY SAW MURDER POINT AT THE MARAUDER'S MAP, STILL LYING ON THE STAIRCASE SIX STEPS BELOW HIM. AS SNAPE AND FILCH BOTH TURNED THE HEAD AT IT, HARRY THREW CAUTIOUSLY THE TWO WINGS; HE RAISED HIS ARMS UNDER THE CLOAK AND WAVED FLIRTELISLY AT MURDER TO ATTRACT HIS ATTENTION, MEANWHILE, IT'S MINE! MINE!

SNAPE HAD REACHED OUT FOR IT, A HORRIBLE EXPRESSION OF DAWNING COMPREHENSION ON HIS FACE

ALL THE PARLAMENT!

THE MAP FLEW UP INTO THE AIR, SLIPPED THROUGH SNAPE'S OUTSTRETCHED FINGERS, AND SHARED DOWN THE STAIRS INTO MURDER'S HAND.

MY MISTAKE, MURDER SAID CALMLY, IT'S MINE MUST BE

DROPPED IT EARLIER

BUT SNAPE'S BLACK EYES WERE DARTING FROM THE EGG IN FILCH'S  
ARMS TO THE MAP IN MURRAY'S HAND, AND HARRY COULD TELL HE WAS

THE EGG AND THE EYE 411

PLUTTING THEM AND THEM TOGETHER, AS ONLY SNAPE COULD ...

PETTER, HE SAID QUIETLY.

WHAT'S THAT? SAID MURRAY CALMLY, HOLDING UP THE MAP AND  
PERUSING IT.

PETTER? SNAPE SNARLED, AND HE ACTUALLY TURNED HIS HEAD AND  
STARED RIGHT AT THE PLACE WHERE HARRY WAS, AS THOUGH HE COULD

SUDDENLY SEE HIM. THAT EGG IS PETTER'S EGG, THAT PIECE OF PARCH-  
MENT BELONGS TO PETTER, I HAVE SEEN IT BEFORE, I RECOGNISE IT!

PETTER IS HERE? PETTER, IN HIS INVISIBILITY CLOAK?

SNAPE STRETCHED OUT HIS HANDS LIKE A BLIND MAN, AND BEGAN  
TO MOVE UP THE STAIRS; HARRY COULD HAVE SWORN HIS OVERLARGE  
NOSTRILS WERE DILATING, TRYING TO SMELL HARRY WHO WAS TRAPPED,  
HARRY LEANT BACKWARDS, TRYING TO AVOID SNAPE'S FINGERTIPS, BUT  
AND MOMENT WHEN

THERE'S NOTHING THERE, SNAPE? BARKED MURRAY, BUT I'LL BE  
HAPPY TO TELL THE HEADMASTER WHEN QUICKLY THEIR MIND LIMPED  
TO HARRY PETTER!

MEANING WHAT? SNARLED SNAPE, TURNING AGAIN THE LOOK AT  
MURRAY, HIS HANDS STILL OUTSTRETCHED, INCHES FROM HARRY'S CHEST.  
MEANING THAT SOMEWHERE'S VERY INTERESTED THE DRAGON WHEN'S

GET IT IN HER THAT KEY? SAID MURPHY, LIMPING NEARER STILL TO THE  
FEET OF THE STAIRS. AND SHE AM I, SNAPE ... VERY INTERESTED ... THE  
TWINKLE FLICKERED ACROSS HIS MANGLED FACE, SHE THAT THE SCARS,  
AND THE CLUNK MISSING FROM HIS NECK, LOOKED DEEPER AND  
DARKER THAN EVER.

SNAPE WAS LOOKING DOWN AT MURPHY, AND HARRY COULDN'T SEE  
THE EXPRESSION IN HIS FACE. FOR A MOMENT, MURPHY MOVED HER  
SAY ANYTHING. THEN SNAPE SILENTLY LOWERED HIS HANDS.

I MERELY TWINKLE, SAID SNAPE, IN A VOICE OF FORCED CALM, THAT  
IF PETER WAS WANDERING AROUND AFTER HOURS AGAIN ... IT'S AN  
UNFORTUNATE HABIT OF HIS ... HE SHOULD BE STOPPED, FOR HIS  
OWN SAFETY.

AND I SEE, SAID MURPHY SILENTLY. GET PETER'S BEST INTERESTS AT  
HEART, HAVE YOU?

THERE WAS A PAUSE. SNAPE AND MURPHY WERE STILL STARING AT

ALL HARRY PETER

EACH OTHER. MRS BURTON GAVE A LITTLE LAUGH, STILL PEERING AROUND  
FILCH'S LEGS, LOOKING FOR THE SOURCE OF HARRY'S KIDNEY-BATH  
SMELL.

I THINK I WILL GO BACK TO BED, SNAPE SAID COLDLY.

BEST IDEA YOU'VE HAD ALL NIGHT, SAID MURPHY. NOW, FILCH, IF  
YOU'LL JUST GIVE ME THAT EGG

NOW? SAID FILCH, CLUTCHING THE EGG AS THOUGH IT WAS HIS FIRST-  
BORN SON. PROFESSOR MURPHY, THIS IS EVIDENCE OF PETER'S TREACH-  
ERY?

IT'S THE PROPERTY OF THE CHAMPION HE STEAL IT FROM, SAID  
MEHMY. HAND IT OVER, NEEL.

SNAPE SLEPT DOWNSTAIRS AND PASSED MEHMY WITHOUT ANOTHER  
WORD. FILCH MADE A CHIRRLING NOISE THE MRS DUMBLEDORE, WHO STARED  
BLANKLY AT HARRY FOR A FEW MORE SECONDS BEFORE TURNING AND  
FOLLOWING HER MASTER. STILL BREATHING VERY FAST, HARRY HEARD  
SNAPE WALKING AWAY DOWN THE HALLWAY. FILCH HANDED MEHMY  
THE EGG, AND DISAPPEARED FROM VIEW THEN, MUTTERING THE MRS  
DUMBLEDORE, NEVER MIND, MY SWEET ... WE'LL SEE DUMBLEDORE IN THE  
MORNING ... TELL HIM WHAT PEEVES WAS UP TO ...

A DOOR SLAMMED. HARRY WAS LEFT STARING DOWN AT MEHMY, WHO  
PLACED HIS STAFF ON THE HOLLOWAY-POST STAIR, AND STARTED THE CLIMB  
LAUGHINGLY TOWARDS HIM, A DULL CLANK ON EVERY OTHER STEP.  
THOSE STAVE, PETER, HE MUTTERED.

YES ... I ... ER ... THANKS, SAID HARRY WEARILY.

WHAT IS THIS THING? SAID MEHMY, DRAWING THE MARAUDER'S  
MAP OUT OF HIS POCKET AND UNFOLDING IT.

MAP OF HOGWARTS, SAID HARRY, HOPING MEHMY WAS GIVING THE  
FULL HIM OUT OF THE STAIRCASE SEEN. HIS LEG WAS REALLY HURTING  
HIM.

MERLIN'S BEARD, MEHMY WHISPERED, STARING AT THE MAP, HIS  
MAGICAL EYE GIVING HARRY. THIS ... THIS IS SOME MAP, PETER!

YES, IT'S ... WHITE LIPS, HARRY SAID. HIS EYES WERE STARTING  
THE WATER FROM THE PAIN. ER PROFESSOR MEHMY, DO YOU THINK YOU  
COULD HELP ME?

WHAT? ER YES ... YES, OF COURSE ...



THE LEG AND THE EYE 413

MEEHBY THEN FIELD UP HARRY'S ARMS AND PULLED; HARRY'S LEG  
CAME FREE OF THE TRICK STEP, AND HE CLIMBED MINTH THE HIRE ABOVE  
IT.

MEEHBY WAS STILL GAZING AT THE MAP, BETTER ... HE SAID SLEELY,  
YELL DIDN'T HAPPEN, BY ANY CHANCE, THE SEE WHEN BROKE INTO  
SNAPPE'S OFFICE, DID YELL? IN THIS MAP, I MEAN?

ER ... YEAH, I DID ... HARRY ADMITTED. IT WAS MR CRUELICH,  
MEEHBY'S MAGICAL EYE WHIZZED OVER THE ENTIRE SURFACE OF THE  
MAP, HE WHIMMED SLIDDELY ALARMED.

CRUELICH? HE SAID, YELL RE YELL RE SURE, BETTER?

POSITIVE, SAID HARRY.

WELL, HE'S NOT HERE ANY MORE, SAID MEEHBY, HIS EYE STILL

WHIZZING OVER THE MAP, CRUELICH ... THAT'S VERY VERY INTEREST-  
ING ...

HE SAID NOTHING FOR ALMOST A MINUTE, STILL STARING AT THE MAP,  
HARRY COULD TELL THAT THIS NEWS MEANT SOMETHING TO MEEHBY, AND  
VERY MUCH WANTED TO KNOW WHAT IT WAS. HE WONDERED WHETHER  
HE DARED ASK, MEEHBY STARED HIM SLIGHTLY ... YET MEEHBY HAD  
JUST HELPED HIM AVOID AN AWFUL LOT OF TROUBLE ...

ER ... PROFESSOR MEEHBY ... WHY'D YELL REMEMBER MR CRUELICH  
WANTED TO KNOW ABOUT SNAPPE'S OFFICE?

MEEHBY'S MAGICAL EYE LEFT THE MAP AND FIXED, FLUTTERING, UPON  
HARRY. IT WAS A PENETRATING GAZE, AND HARRY HAD THE IMPRESSION

THAT MEEHBY WAS SIZING HIM UP, WHERDERING WHETHER THE ANSWER  
WER NHT, HER FEEL MICH THE TELL HIM.

PLT IT THIS WAY, PETER, MEEHBY MUTTERED FINALLY, THEY SAY HED

MAD-EYE S HESSESD WITH CATCHING DARK WIZARDS ... BLT MAD-  
EYE S NETHING NETHING COMPARED THE BARTY CRUELICH.

HE CONTINUED THE STARE AT THE MAP, HARRY WAS BLINKING THE  
KNEL MERE.

PROFESSOR MEEHBY? HE SAID AGAIN, D YEL THINK ... HELD THIS  
HAVE ANYTHING THE DE WITH ... MAYBE MR CRUELICH THINKS THERE S  
SOMETHING GING EN ...

LIKE WHAT? SAID MEEHBY SHARPLY.

HARRY WHERDERED FEEL MICH HE DARE SAY, HE DIDN T WANT

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MEEHBY THE GLESS THAT HE HAD A SHELICE OF INFORMATION ELTIDE  
HEGLARTS; THAT MIGHT LEAD THE TRICKY ELJESTHENS ARHET SIRILS.

I DENN T KNEL, HARRY MUTTERED, HED STUFF S BEEN HAPPENING  
LATELY, HASN T IT? IT S BEEN IN THE DAILY PROPHEET ... THE DARK MARD  
AT THE WERLD CLIP, AND THE DEATH EATERS AND EVERYTHING ...  
RETH HE MEEHBY S MISMATCHED EYES WIDENED.

YEL RE A SHARP KEY, PETER, HE SAID, HIS MAGICAL EYE REVED  
BACK THE THE MARALDER S MAP, CRUELICH HELD BE THINKING ALING  
THESE LINES, HE SAID SLEELY, VERY POSSIBLE ... THERE HAVE BEEN  
SOME FLINDY ALPHILRS FLYING ARHEND LATELY HELPED ALING BY  
RITA SKEETER, HE CHURSE, IT S MAKING A LFT OF PEOPLE NERVIELS, I

RECOGN. A GRIM SMILE TWISTED HIS LIMP-SIDED MOUTH. HE, IF  
THERE'S ONE THING I HATE, HE MUTTERED, MORE THAN HIMSELF THAN  
HARRY, AND HIS MAGICAL EYE WAS FIXED ON THE BATTERED LEFT-HAND  
CORNER OF THE MAP. IT'S A DEATH-EATER WE'VE WALKED FREE ...  
HARRY STARED AT HIM. COULD MELODY POSSIBLY MEAN WHAT  
HARRY THOUGHT HE MEANT?

AND NOW I WANT THE ASH WHEEL & ELIZABETH, PETER, SAID MELODY,  
IN A MORE BUSINESSLIKE TONE.  
HARRY'S HEART SANK; HE HAD THOUGHT THIS WAS COMING. MELODY  
WAS GOING THE ASH WHERE HE HAD GOTTEN THIS MAP, WHICH WAS A VERY  
OBVIOUSLY MAGICAL OBJECT AND THE STORY OF HOW IT HAD FALLEN  
INTO HIS HANDS INCRIMINATED NOT ONLY HIM, BUT HIS ELDER FATHER,  
FRED AND GEORGE WEASLEY, AND PROFESSOR LUPIN, THEIR LAST  
DEFENCE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS TEACHER. MELODY WAVED THE MAP  
IN FRONT OF HARRY, WHO CRACED HIMSELF

CAN I EXPLAIN THIS?

HEY? SAID HARRY, HE WAS VERY FOND OF HIS MAP, BUT ON THE

OTHER HAND, HE WAS EXTREMELY RELIEVED THAT MELODY WASN'T ASK-  
ING WHERE HE'D GOTTEN IT, AND THERE WAS NO DOUBT THAT HE HAD

MELODY A FAVORITE. YES, HE.

GOOD BY, GRIELED MELODY. I CAN MAKE GOOD USE OF THIS ...  
THIS MIGHT BE EXACTLY WHAT I'VE BEEN LOOKING FOR ... RIGHT, YES,  
PETER, COME ON, NOW ...

THEY CLIMBED THE TOP OF THE STAIRS TOGETHER, MELODY STILL

THE EGG AND THE EYE 415

EXAMINING THE MAP AS THOUGH IT WAS A TREASURE THE LIKE OF WHICH HE HAD NEVER SEEN BEFORE. THEY WALKED IN SILENCE THE THE DOOR OF MURDO'S OFFICE, WHERE HE STOPPED, AND LOOKED UP AT HARRY. WOULD EVER THOUGHT OF A CAREER AS AN ALDRER, BETTER? NO, SAID HARRY, TAKEN ABACK.

WELL WANT TO CONSIDER IT, SAID MURDO, NODDING, AND LOOKING AT HARRY THOUGHTFULLY. YES, INDEED ... AND INCIDENTALLY ... I'M GUESSING YOU WEREN'T JUST TAKING THAT EGG FOR A WALK TONIGHT? NO, SAID HARRY, GRINNING. I'VE BEEN WORKING ON IT THE WHILE.

MURDO WINKED AT HIM, HIS MAGICAL EYE GOING HAZY AGAIN.

NOTHING LIKE A NIGHT-TIME STROLL TO GIVE YOU IDEAS, BETTER ... SEE YOU IN THE MORNING ... HE WENT BACK INTO HIS OFFICE, STARING DOWN AT THE MARAUDER'S MAP AGAIN, AND CLOSED THE DOOR BEHIND HIM.

HARRY WALKED SILENTLY BACK TO GRYFFINDOR TOWER, LEFT IN THOUGHT ABOUT SNAPE, AND CRUELTY, AND WHAT IT ALL MEANT ... WHY WAS CRUELTY PRETENDING TO BE ILL, IF HE COULD MANAGE TO GET THE FLEWARTS WHEN HE WANTED THEM? WHAT DID HE THINK SNAPE WAS CONCEALING IN HIS OFFICE? AND MURDO THOUGHT OF HARRY, THOUGHT TO BE AN ALDRER? INTERESTING IDEA ... BUT AS HARRY GOT QUIETLY INTO HIS FOUR-POSTER TEN MINUTES LATER, THE EGG AND THE CHAD WERE SAFELY BACK IN HIS TROUSE, HE REMEMBERED THOUGHT HE'D LIKE THE OTHER TWO STARRED THE REST OF THEM WERE, BEFORE HE CHOSE IT AS A CAREER.

## CHAPTER TWENTY-SIX

### THE SECOND TASK

YELI SAID YELI D ALREADY WORKED OUT THAT REG LIKE? SAID HERMIONE INDIGNANTLY.

KEEP YELI'S VEHICLE DOWN? SAID HARRY CROSSLY, I JUST NEED THE SORT OF FINE-TUNE IT, ALL RIGHT?

HE, RON AND HERMIONE WERE SITTING AT THE VERY BACK OF THE CHARMS CLASS WITH A TABLE THE THEMSELVES. THEY WERE SLIPPED THE RE PRACTISING THE OPPOSITE OF THE SLIMMING CHARM TODAY

THE RANISHING CHARM, BEING THE THE POTENTIAL FOR NASTY ACCIDENTS WHEN OBJECTS KEPT FLYING ACROSS THE ROOM, PROFESSOR

FLITWICK HAD GIVEN EACH STUDENT A STACK OF CLISHMINS IN WHICH THE PRACTISE, THE THEORY BEING THAT THESE WOULDN'T HURT ANYONE IF THEY WENT OFF TARGET, IT WAS A GOOD THEORY, BUT IT WASN'T WORKING VERY WELL. NEVILLE'S AIM WAS SO POOR THAT HE KEPT ACCIDENTALLY SENDING MUCH HEAVIER THINGS FLYING ACROSS THE ROOM PROFESSOR FLITWICK, FOR INSTANCE.

I JUST FORGET THE REG FOR A MINUTE, ALL RIGHT? HARRY HISSED, AS

PROFESSOR FLITWICK WENT WHIZZING RESIGNEDLY PAST THEM, LAND-ING IN THE OF A LARGE CABINET. I'M TRYING TO TELL YELI ABOUT SNAPE

AND MEHBY ...

THIS CLASS WAS IDEAL COVER FOR A PRIVATE CONVERSATION, AS

EVERYONE WAS HAVING FAR MORE FUN THAN THE DAY BEFORE AND ATTENDING. HARRY HAD BEEN REHEARSING HIS ADVENTURES OF THE PREVIOUS

NIGHT IN WHISPERED INSTALLMENTS FOR THE LAST HALF AN HOUR.

SNAPE SAID MURDERER SEARCHED HIS OFFICE AS WELL? THEN WHISPERED, HIS EYES ALIGHT WITH INTEREST AS HE BANISHED A CLISH-CLASH

WITH A SWEEP OF HIS WAND (IT SHARED IN THE AIR AND DROPPED

THE SECOND TASK 419

PARTYATI'S THAT ONE. WHAT ... D'YELL RECKON MURDERER'S HERE THE DEEP AND ONE FOR SNAPE AS WELL AS DARRARDH?

WELL, I DUNNED IF THAT'S WHAT DUMBLEDORE ASKED HIM THE DAY,

BUT HE'S DEFINITELY DOING IT, SAID HARRY, LEAVING HIS WAND WITH-  
OUT PAYING MUCH ATTENTION, SEE THAT HIS CLISH-CLASH DID AN EDD SHIRT

OF KELLY FLEW OFF THE DESK. MURDERER SAID DUMBLEDORE ONLY LETS  
SNAPE STAY HERE BECAUSE HE'S GIVING HIM A SECOND CHANCE FOR  
SOMETHING ...

WHAT? SAID THEN, HIS EYES WIDENING, HIS NEXT CLISH-CLASH SPIN-  
NING HIGH INTO THE AIR, RICKSHAKING OFF THE CHANDELIER AND DRIP-  
PING HEAVILY ON THE FLITWICK'S DESK. HARRY ... MAYBE MURDERER

THINKS SNAPE PUT YOUR NAME IN THE CHALKET OF FIRE?

HERMION SAID HERMIONE, SHAKING HER HEAD SKEPTICALLY, WE  
THOUGHT SNAPE WAS TRYING TO KILL HARRY BEFORE, AND IT TURNED  
OUT HE WAS SAVING HARRY'S LIFE, REMEMBER?

SHE BANISHED A CRUSHED AND IT FLEW ACROSS THE ROOM AND  
LANDED IN THE KISS THEY WERE ALL SUPPOSED TO BE AIMING AT.  
HARRY LOOKED AT HERMIONE, THINKING ... IT WAS TRUE THAT SNAPE  
HAD SAVED HIS LIFE ONCE, BUT THE OTHER THING WAS, SNAPE DEFINITELY  
HATED HIM, JUST AS HE'D HATED HARRY'S FATHER WHEN THEY HAD  
BEEN AT SCHOOL TOGETHER. SNAPE HATED TAKING POINTS FROM HARRY,  
AND HAD CERTAINLY NEVER MISSED AN OPPORTUNITY TO GIVE HIM  
PUNISHMENTS, OR EVEN THE SUGGEST THAT HE SHOULD BE SUSPENDED  
FROM THE SCHOOL.

I DON'T CARE WHAT MURDER SAYS, HERMIONE WENT ON,  
DUMBLEDORE'S NOT STUPID. HE WAS RIGHT THE TRULY LACED AND  
PROFESSOR KLIPIN, EVEN THOUGH LEADS OF PEOPLE WHO'DN'T HAVE  
GIVEN THEM IDEAS, SHE WO'D SHOULD'N'T HE BE RIGHT ABOUT SNAPE,  
EVEN IF SNAPE IS A BIT

EVIL, SAID RON PROMPTLY. COME ON, HERMIONE, WE'RE ALL  
THESE DARK-WIZARD-CATCHERS SEARCHING HIS OFFICE, THEN?  
WE'D HAS MR CRUELCH BEEN PRETENDING HE'S ILL? SAID  
HERMIONE, IGNORING RON. IT'S A BIT PLAIN, ISN'T IT, THAT HE CAN'T  
MANAGE TO CHEAT THE THE YULE BALL, BUT HE CAN GET UP HERE IN THE  
MIDDLE OF THE NIGHT WHEN HE WANTS TO?

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“HE’LL JUST BEEN T’LICK CRUELCH RECALISE HP TH-AT ER, WINDY, SAID  
RHN, SENDING A CLISH-HN SHARING INTH THE WINDHWN.

“HE’LL JUST WANT TH TH-IND SNAPE S LIP TH SHMETH-ING, SAID  
H-ERMINE, SENDING HER CLISH-HN ZHHMING NEATLY INTH THE REH.  
I JUST WANT TH DKNHWN WH-AT SNAPE DID WITH-H HIS FIRST CH-ANCE, IF  
HE S HN HIS SECHND HNK, SAID H-HARRY GRIMLY, AND HIS CLISH-HN, TH  
HIS VERY GREAT SURPRISE, FLEW STRAIGHT ACROSS TH REHWN, AND LANDED  
NEATLY HN THP HP H-ERMINE S.

\*

HEEDIENT TH SIRILIS WISH HP HEARING ABHHT ANYTH-ING HOD AT  
H-HGLWARTS, H-HARRY SENT HIM A LETTER BY KREHWN HHL TH-AT NIGHT,  
EXPLAINING ALL ABHHT MR CRUELCH KREAKING INTH SNAPE S OFFICE,  
AND MHHBY AND SNAPE S CHNVERSATION. THEN H-HARRY TURNED HIS  
ATTENTION IN EARNEST TH TH-RE MEET LURGENT PROBLEM FACING HIM:  
H-HWN TH SURVIVE UNDERWATER FOR AN H-HLR HN TH-RE TWENTY-FOURTH HP  
FEBRUARY.

RHN HHLTE LIKED TH-RE IDEA HP USING TH-RE SLIMPHING CHARM

AGAIN H-HARRY HAD EXPLAINED ABHHT ABHLLINGS, AND RHN CHLD-  
N T SEE WHY H-HARRY SH-HLDN T SLIMPHN HNK FROM TH-RE NEAREST

MUGGLE THWN. H-ERMINE SHWHASHED TH-RE PLAN BY PHINTING HHT  
TH-AT, IN TH-RE UNLIKELY EVENT TH-AT H-HARRY MANAGED TH-RE LEARN H-HWN TH-  
H-EPERATE AN ABHLLING WITHIN TH-RE SET LIMIT HP AN H-HLR, HE WAS  
SURE TH-RE BE DISHLLIFIED FOR KREAKING TH-RE INTERNATIONAL CODE HP  
WIZARDING SECRECY IT WAS TH-RE MUCH TH-RE H-HPE TH-AT NH MUGGLES



WOULD SPENT AN AWKWARD ZEEHNG ACHSS THE CHLNTROSIDE THE  
F-HEGLARTS.

HE CHLRSZ, THE IDEAL SELLTHERN WOULD BE FOR YELJ THE  
TRANSPICLARE YELJRSELF INTO A SLERMARINE FOR SHERPETHING, SHE SAID.  
IF ONLY WE D DHNE FLIMAN TRANSPICLIRATHEN ALREADY? BUT I DHEN T  
THIND WE START THAT UNTIL SIXTH YEAR, AND IT CAN BE BADLY WRING IF  
YELJ DHEN T DNEEL WHAT YELJ RE DHING ...

YRAF, I DHEN T FANDY WALKING AROUND WITH A PERISCOPZ STICKING  
ELT OF MY HEAD, SAID F-HARRY, I S PHEZ I CHLD ALWAYS ATTACK  
SHERPENE IN PRENT OF MHHOZ, HE MIGHT DEE IT FOR ME ...

I DHEN T THIND HE D LET YELJ CHHSE WHAT YELJ WANTED THE BE

## THE SECOND TASK 419

TURNED INTO, THELGH, SAID F-ERMINE SERIHELISLY, NH, I THIND  
YELJR BEST CHANCE IS SOME SORT OF CHARM.

SEE F-HARRY, THINDING THAT HE WOULD SHEN HAVE HAD ENOUGH OF THE  
LIBRARY THE LAST HIM A LIFETIME, ELIRIED HIMSELF ENCE MEER AMONG  
THE DUSTY VELLMES, LHHING FOR ANY SPELL THAT MIGHT ENABLE A  
FLIMAN THE SURVIVE WITHELT HOXGEN. F-HELVER, THELGH HE, DHEN  
AND F-ERMINE SEARCHED THROUGH THEIR LINC-TIMES, EVENINGS AND  
WHELE WEEKENDS THELGH F-HARRY ASKED PROFESSOR MCHENACALL FOR  
A NITE OF PERMISSIEN THE LIKE THE RESTRICTED SECTION, AND EVEN  
ASKED THE IRRITABLE, VULTURE-LIKE LIBRARIAN, MADAM PINCE, FOR HELP

THEY FELND NOTHING WHATSOEVER THAT WOULD ENABLE F-HARRY THE  
SPEND AN F-ELJR LINDERLATER AND LIVE THE TELL THE TALE.

FAMILIAR FLUTTERINGS OF PANIC WERE STARTING THE DISTURE F-HARRY NH,

AND HE WAS FINDING IT DIFFICULT TO CONCENTRATE IN LESSONS AGAIN.  
THE

LAKE, WHICH HARRY HAD ALWAYS TAKEN FOR GRANTED AS JUST ANOTHER  
FEATURE OF THE COASTLANDS, DREW HIS EYES WHATEVER HE WAS NEAR A  
CLASSROOM WINDOW, A GREAT, IRON-GREY MASS OF CHILLY WATER, WHOSE  
DARK AND ICE DEPTHS WERE STARTING TO SEEM AS DISTANT AS THE MOON.  
JUST AS IT HAD BEEN BEFORE HE HAD FACED THE ICEMOUNTAIN, TIME  
WAS SLIPPING AWAY AS THOUGH SOMEONE HAD REWITCHED THE  
CLOCKS TO GO EXTRA FAST. THERE WAS A WEEK TO GO BEFORE FEBRUARY  
THE TWENTY-FOURTH (THERE WAS STILL TIME) ... THERE WERE FIVE DAYS  
TO GO (HE WAS BEHIND TO FIND SOMETHING SHINY) ... THREE DAYS TO  
GO (PLEASE LET ME FIND SOMETHING ... PLEASE ...).

WITH TWO DAYS LEFT, HARRY STARTED TO GO OFF AGAIN. THE  
ONLY GOOD THING ABOUT BREAKFAST ON MONDAY WAS THE RETURN OF

THE BROWN HILL HE HAD SENT THE SIRILS. HE PULLED OFF THE PARCH-  
MENT, UNWROTE IT, AND SAW THE SHORTEST LETTER SIRILS HAD EVER

WRITTEN TO HIM.

SEND DATE OF NEXT ICEMOUNTAIN WEEKEND BY RETURN MAIL.

HARRY TURNED THE PARCHMENT OVER AND LOOKED AT THE BACK, HOP-  
ING TO SEE SOMETHING ELSE, BUT IT WAS BLANK.

WEEKEND AFTER NEXT, WHISPERED FERMINE, WHEN HAD READ

AND HARRY BETTER

THE WHITE EVER F-HARRY S SEHLIDER, HERE TAKE MY HELM AND SEND THIS HELM BACK STRAIGHT AWAY,

F-HARRY SCRIBBLED THE DATES BELOW HIM THE BACK OF SIRILIS LETTER, TIED IT BACK INTO THE KNOWN HELM S LEG, AND WATCHED IT TAKE FLIGHT AGAIN. WHAT HAD HE EXPECTED? ADVICE HIM WHEN THE SURVIVE UNDERWATER? HE HAD BEEN SEE INTENT HIM TELLING SIRILIS ALL ABOUT SNAPP AND MERRY, HE HAD COMPLETELY FORGOTTEN THE MENTION THE REG S LILIE.

WHAT S HE WANT THE KNOWN ABOUT THE NEXT F-HESPEAR WEEK-END HER? SAID REIN.

DUNNIE, SAID F-HARRY DULLY, THE MOMENTARY HAPPINESS THAT HAD FLARED INSIDE HIM AT THE SIGHT OF THE HELM HAD DIED. COME HIM ... CARE OF MAGICAL CREATURES.

WHETHER F-HAGRID WAS TRYING THE MAKE UP FOR THE BLAST-ENDED SORRENTS, HE REALISE THERE WERE NOW ONLY TWO SORRENTS LEFT, HE REALISE HE WAS TRYING THE PROVE HE COULD DO ANYTHING THAT PROFESSOR GRUBBY-PLANK COULD, F-HARRY DIDN T KNOW, BUT HE HAD BEEN CONTINUING HER LESSONS AND LUNCHES EVER SINCE HE D RETURNED THE WARD. IT TURNED OUT THAT F-HAGRID KNEW ELITE AS MUCH ABOUT LUNCHES AS HE DID ABOUT MINISTERS, THOUGH IT WAS CLEAR THAT HE FELT THEIR BACK OF PEELING FANGS DISAPPOINTING.

TODAY HE HAD MANAGED THE CAPTURE TWO LUNCHES, LIKE ALL-GREEN LUNCHES, THEY WERE PURE GOLD, PARYATI AND LAVENDER WENT INTO TRANSPORTS OF DELIGHT AT THE SIGHT OF THEM,

AND EVEN PANSY PARDINSHEN HAD THE WERD HAD THE CHINICAL FEEL  
MUCH SHE LIKED THEM.

EASIER TER SPEET THAN THE ADULTS, FJAGRID TELD THE CLASS. THEY  
TURN SILVER WHEN THEY RE ABELT TWE YEARS OLD, AN THEY GREEN  
BHRNS AT ABELIN FEHR, DEN GE PURE WHITE TIL THEY RE FULL-GREEN,  
REHIND ABELT SEVEN. THEY RE A KIT MEER TRUSTIN WHEN THEY RE  
BABES ... DEN MIND REYS SEE MUCH ... I MEEN, MEVE IN A KIT,  
YEH CAN PAT EM IF YEH WANT ... GIVE EM A FEW EE THESE SLEAR  
LUMPS ...

YELL EED, FJARRY? FJAGRID MUTTERED, MEYING ASIDE SLIGHTLY,

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WHILE MEET EE THE ETTHERS SWARMD ABELIND THE BABY UNICHRNS,

YEAH, SAID FJARRY,

ILIS NERVHLS, EEH SAID FJAGRID,

KIT, SAID FJARRY,

FJARRY, SAID FJAGRID, CLAPPING A MASSIVE HAND EEN HIS SEHLL-  
DER, SEE THAT FJARRY S KNEES BUCKLED UNDER ITS WRIGHT, I D VE KIN

WHERRIED BEHRE I SAW YEH TAKE EEN THA FJHRNTAIL, KLT I KNHEW NEH  
YEH CAN DEE ANDTHIN YEH SET YER MIND TER, I M NEET WHERRIED AT ALL,  
YEH RE GEIN TER EE FINE, GEET YER LLIE WHORDED EELT, HAVEN YEH

FJARRY NEEDED, KLT EVEN AS HE DID SEE, AN INSANE LRGZ THE CHN-  
RESS THAT HE DIDN T HAVE ANY IDEA FEEL THE SLRVTIVE AT THE EHTHEM

IF THE LADY HER AN EELER CAME OVER HIM, HE WHEELED UP AT HAGRID  
PERHAPS HE HAD THE GEM IN THE LADY SOMETIMES, THE DEAL WITH  
THE CREATURES IN IT? HE WHEELED AFTER EVERYTHING ELSE IN THE  
GREENLANDS, AFTER ALL

YES HE GEMIN TER WIN, HAGRID GEMWED, PATTING HARRY S SHUL-  
DER AGAIN, SEE THAT HARRY ACTUALLY FELT HIMSELF SINK A CHURCH OF  
INCHES INTO THE MUDGY GREENLAND. I KNOW IT, I CAN FEEL IT. YES HE  
GEMIN TER WIN, HARRY.

HARRY JUST COULDN T BRING HIMSELF THE WIDE THE HAPPY, CONFID-  
DENT SMILE OFF HAGRID S FACE, PRETENDING HE WAS INTERESTED IN THE  
FELINE LINDICHERNS, HE FORCED A SMILE IN RETURN, AND MOVED  
FORWARDS THE PAT THEM WITH THE OTHERS.

\*

BY THE EVENING BEFORE THE SECOND TASK, HARRY FELT AS THOUGH HE  
WAS TRAPPED IN A NIGHTMARE. HE WAS FULLY AWARE THAT EVEN IF, BY  
SOME MIRACLE, HE MANAGED THE FIND A SUITABLE SPELL, HE D HAVE A  
REAL ONE MASTERING IT OVERNIGHT. HEEL CHULD HE HAVE LET THIS  
HAPPEN? WHY HADN T HE GHT THE WERD HIN THE EGG S CLUE SEEMER?  
WHY HAD HE EVER LET HIS MIND WANDER IN CLASS WHAT IF A  
TEACHER HAD ONCE MENTIONED HOW THE KREATH LINDERWATER?  
HE, RON AND HERMIONE SAT IN THE LIBRARY AS THE SUN SET  
BELTIDE, TEARING FEVERISHLY THROUGH PAGE AFTER PAGE OF SPELLS,

HIDDEN FROM EACH OTHER BY THE MASSIVE PILLS OF REEDS IN  
THE DESK IN FRONT OF EACH OF THEM. HARRY'S HEART GAVE A

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FLICE LEAP EVERY TIME HE SAW THE WIND WATER IN A PAGE,  
BUT MORE OFTEN THAN NOT IT WAS MERELY 'TADDE TWO PINTS OF  
WATER, HALF A POUND OF SHREDDED MANDRAGE LEAVES AND A  
NIGHT ...

I DON'T RECKON IT CAN BE DONE, SAID REEN'S VOICE FLATLY FROM  
THE OTHER SIDE OF THE TABLE. THERE'S NOTHING, NOTHING, CLEAREST  
WAS THAT THING THE DRY LIP PUDDLES AND POUNDS, THAT DREHLIGHT  
CHARM, BUT THAT WAS NOWHERE NEAR POWERFUL ENOUGH TO DRAIN  
THE LADDE.

THERE MUST BE SOMETHING, HERMIONE MUTTERED, MOVING  
A CANDLE CLOSER TO HER. HER EYES WERE SO TIRED SHE  
WAS PEERING OVER THE TINY PRINT OF ELDER AND FORGOTTEN  
BENEFITMENTS AND CHARMS WITH HER NOSE ABOUT AN INCH  
FROM THE PAGE. THEY'D NEVER HAVE SET A TASK THAT WAS  
UNDOABLE.

THEY HAVE, SAID REEN. HARRY, JUST GET DOWN TO THE LADDE  
THEMSELVES, RIGHT, STICK YOUR HEAD IN, YELL AT THE MEREPEOPLE THE  
GIVE BACK WHATEVER THEY'VE NICKED AND SEE IF THEY CHUCK IT OUT.  
BEST YELL CAN BE, MATE.

THERE'S A WAY OF DOING IT? HERMIONE SAID CREEPLY. THERE JUST  
HAS TO BE?

SHE SEEMED TO BE TAKING THE LIBRARY'S LACK OF USEFUL INFORMA-

THEN HEN THE SUBJECT AS A PERSONAL INSULT; IT HAD NEVER FAILED HER

BEFORE.

I KNOW WHAT I SHOULD HAVE DONE, SAID HARRY, RESTING, FACE  
DOWN, HEN SALLY TRICKS HER TRICKY SHERTS. I SHOULD VE LEARNT THE EE  
AN ANIMAGUS LIKE SIRILS.

YEAH, YELL COULD VE TURNED INTO A GELDISH AND TIME YELL  
WANTED? SAID RHN.

HER A FREE, YALINED HARRY, HE WAS EXHAUSTED.

IT TAKES YEARS THE BECOME AN ANIMAGUS, AND THEN YELL HAVE THE  
REGISTER YELLRSELF AND EVERYTHING, SAID HERMIONE YAGLELY, NELL  
SHEWINTING DOWN THE INDEX OF WEIRD WIZARDING DILEMMAS AND  
THEIR SOLUTIONS. PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL TOLD US, REMEMBER ...  
YELL VE GET THE REGISTER YELLRSELF WITH THE IMPROPER USE OF MAGIC

THE SECOND TASK YEE

OFFICE ... WHAT ANIMAL YELL BECOME, AND YELLR MARKINGS, SEE YELL  
CAN T ABUSE IT ...

HERMIONE, I WAS THINKING, SAID HARRY, WEARILY, I KNOW I

HAVEN T GET A CHANCE OF TURNING INTO A FREE BY THEHREIN MORN-  
ING ...

EH, THIS IS NEE USE, HERMIONE SAID, SNAPPING WEIRD  
WIZARDING DILEMMAS SHIT. WHEE HEN EARTH WANTS THE MAKE THEIR  
NEESE HAIR GROW INTO RINGLETS?

I WOULDNT MIND, SAID FRED WEASLEY S VEICE. BE A TALKING

PHINT, WOULDNT IT?

HARRY, RON AND HERMIONE LEANED UP, FRED AND GEORGE HAD  
JUST EMERGED FROM BEHIND SOME BOOKSHELVES.

WHAT ARE YOU TWO DOING HERE? RON ASKED.

LOOKING FOR YOU, SAID GEORGE. MCGONAGALL WANTS YOU, RON,  
AND YOU, HERMIONE.

WHY? SAID HERMIONE, LOOKING SURPRISED.

DINNER ... SHE WAS LOOKING A BIT GRIM, THOUGH, SAID FRED.

WE'RE SUPPOSED TO TAKE YOU DOWN TO HER OFFICE, SAID  
GEORGE.

RON AND HERMIONE STARED AT HARRY, WHO FELT HIS STOMACH  
DROOP. WAS PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL ABOUT TO TELL RON AND  
HERMIONE HP? PERHAPS SHE'D NOTICED HOW MUCH THEY WERE  
HELPING HIM, WHEN HE ALIGHT THE RE WORKING OUT HOW TO DO THE  
TASK ALONE?

WE'LL MEET YOU BACK IN THE COMMON ROOM, HERMIONE TOLD  
HARRY, AS SHE GOT UP TO GO WITH RON BOTH OF THEM LOOKED VERY  
ANXIOUS. BRING AS MANY OF THESE BOOKS AS YOU CAN, HP?

RIGHT, SAID HARRY UNEASILY.

BY EIGHT O'CLOCK, MADAM PINEHAD EXTINGUISHED ALL THE  
LAMPS AND CAME THE CHIVVY HARRY FELT HP THE LIBRARY, STAGGERING  
UNDER THE WEIGHT OF AS MANY BOOKS AS HE COULD CARRY, HARRY  
RETURNED TO THE GRYFFINDOR COMMON ROOM, PULLED A TABLE INTO A  
CORNER AND CONTINUED THE SEARCH. THERE WAS NOTHING IN MADCAP  
MAGIC FOR WACKY WARLOCKS ... NOTHING IN A GUIDE TO MEDIEVAL  
SHERCERY ... NOT EVEN MENTION OF UNDERWATER EXPLANTS IN AN



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ANTI-HELIX OF EIGHTEENTH-CENTURY CHAIRS, HE IN DREADFUL  
DENIZENS OF THE DEEP, HE FEELS YET NEVER KNOW YET HAD AND  
WHAT THE DEE WITH THEM YET YET YET WISED UP.

CRICKETS HANDS CRAWLED INTO HARRY'S LAP AND CLIMBED UP,  
PLUNGING DEEPLY. THE CEMENT ROOM EMPTIED SILENTLY AROUND  
HARRY. PEOPLE KEPT WISHING HIM LUCK FOR THE NEXT MORNING IN  
CHERRY, CONFIDENT VEHICLES LIKE HAGRID'S, ALL OF THEM APPARENTLY

CONVINCED THAT HE WAS ABOUT TO FALL OFF ANOTHER STUNNING PER-  
FORMANCE LIKE THE ONE HE HAD MANAGED IN THE FIRST TASK. HARRY

COULDN'T ANSWER THEM, HE JUST NEEDED, FEELING AS THOUGH THERE  
WAS A GOLF-BALL STUCK IN HIS THROAT. BY TEN THE MIDNIGHT, HE WAS  
ALONE IN THE ROOM WITH CRICKETS HANDS. HE HAD SEARCHED ALL THE  
REMAINING KIDS, AND RON AND HERMION HAD NOT COME BACK.

IT'S OVER, HE TOLD HIMSELF. YET CAN'T DO IT, YET HE JUST HAVE TO  
GO DOWN THE LAKE IN THE MORNING AND TELL THE JUDGES ...

HE IMAGINED HIMSELF EXPLAINING THAT HE COULDN'T DO THE TASK.  
HE PICTURED BAGMAN'S LOOK OF ROLLING-EYED SURPRISE, DADAHEED'S  
SATISFIED, YELLOW-THETED SMILE. HE COULD ALMOST HEAR FLEW  
DELAHUR SAYING, 'I KNOW IT ... IT IS THE FEELING, IT IS ONLY A LITTLE  
KEY. HE SAW MALPHE FLASHING HIS POTTER STUNDS BADGE AT THE  
FRONT OF THE CROWD, SAW HAGRID'S CRESTFALLEN, DISBELIEVING FACE ...  
FORGETTING THAT CRICKETS HANDS WAS IN HIS LAP, HARRY STOOD UP  
VERY SLIDDERLY. CRICKETS HANDS HISSED ANGERILY AS HE LANDED IN THE  
PHEER, GAVE HARRY A DISGUSTED LOOK AND STALKED AWAY WITH HIS

BUTTLE-BRUSH-TAIL IN THE AIR, BUT HARRY WAS ALREADY FLIPPING UP THE SPIRAL STAIRCASE TO HIS BERNARD ... HE WOULD GRAB THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK AND GO BACK TO THE LIBRARY, HE'D STAY THERE ALL NIGHT IF HE HAD TO ...

SURE, HARRY WHISPERED FIFTEEN MINUTES LATER, AS HE OPENED THE LIBRARY DOOR.

LAND TIP ALIGHT, HE CREEPT ALONG THE BOOKSHELVES, PULLING DOWN MORE BOOKS ... BOOKS OF FOLKS AND CHARMS, BOOKS ON MERPEOPLE AND WATER MONSTERS, BOOKS ON FAMOUS WITCHES AND WIZARDS, ON MAGICAL INVENTIONS, ON ANYTHING AT ALL THAT MIGHT INCLUDE SOME PASSING REFERENCE TO UNDERWATER SURVIVAL. HE CAR-

## THE SECOND TASK YES

RIED THEM OVER THE A TABLE, THEN SET THE WORK, SEARCHING THEM BY THE NARROW BEAM OF HIS WAND, OCCASIONALLY CHECKING HIS WATCH ...

ONE IN THE MORNING ... TWO IN THE MORNING ... THE ONLY WAY HE COULD KEEP GOING WAS TO TELL HIMSELF, OVER AND OVER AGAIN, NEXT BOOK ... IN THE NEXT ONE ... THE NEXT ONE ...

\*

THE MERMAID IN THE PAINTING IN THE PRINCE'S BATHROOM WAS LAUGHING. HARRY WAS CREEPING LIKE A CROOK IN CREEPY WATER NEXT TO HER RECK, WHILE SHE HELD HIS FIREWHEEL OVER HIS HEAD.

COME AND GET IT! SHE GIGGLED MALICIOUSLY. COME ON, LIMP!

I CAN'T, HARRY PANTED, SNATCHING AT THE FIREWHEEL, AND STRUG-

GLING NEET THE SINK. GIVE IT THE ME!

BUT SHE ILST PEEKED HIM PAINFULLY IN THE SIDE WITH THE END OF  
THE KNEEM, LAUGHING AT HIM.

THAT HURTS GET OFF ELICH

HARRY PEETTER MUST WAKE UP, SIR!

STEEP PEERING ME

DEEKEE MUST PEEKE HARRY PEETTER, SIR, HE MUST WAKE UP!

HARRY OPENED HIS EYES. HE WAS STILL IN THE LIBRARY; THE  
INVISIBILITY CLOAK HAD SLIPPED OFF HIS HEAD AS HE D SLEPT, AND  
THE SIDE OF HIS FACE WAS STUCK TO THE PAGES OF WHERE THERE S A

WAND, THERE S A WAY, HE SAT UP, STRAIGHTENING HIS GLASSES, BLINK-  
ING IN THE BRIGHT DAYLIGHT.

HARRY PEETTER NEEDS THE HURRY! SHELEADED DEEKEE. THE SECOND  
TASK STARTS IN TEN MINUTES, AND HARRY PEETTER

TEN MINUTES? HARRY CRIMED. TEN TEN MINUTES?

HE LUNGED DOWN AT HIS WATCH. DEEKEE WAS RIGHT. IT WAS TWENTY  
PAST NINE. A LARGE, DEAD WEIGHT SEEMED TO FALL THROUGH HARRY S  
CHEST INTO HIS STOMACH.

HURRY, HARRY PEETTER! SHELEADED DEEKEE, PULLING AT HARRY S  
SLEEVE. SHELL IS SLIPPED TO BE DOWN BY THE LACK WITH THE OTHER  
CHAMPIONS, SIR!

IT S THEE LATE, DEEKEE, HARRY SAID FEEPLESSLY. I M NEET DOING THE  
TASK, I DEEN T KNOW FEEL

THE HARRY POTTER

HARRY POTTER WILL BE THE TASK? SHELEADED THE ELF, DEDDY  
KNEW HARRY HAD NOT FOUND THE RIGHT KID, SHE DEDDY DID IT FOR  
HIM?

WHAT? SAID HARRY, BUT WHY DIDN'T KNOW WHAT THE SECOND  
TASK IS

DEDDY KNOWS, SIR? HARRY POTTER HAS THE KEY INTO THE LAKE AND  
FIND HIS WIZARD

FIND MY WHAT?

AND TAKE HIS WIZARD BACK FROM THE MERPEOPLE?

WHAT IS A WIZARD?

WELL WIZARD, SIR, WELL WIZARD WIZARD WHO IS GIVING  
DEDDY HIS IMPER?

DEDDY PULLED AT THE SHIRLINDEN MARLIN SWEATER HE WAS  
NOW WEARING OVER HIS SHIRTS.

WHAT? HARRY GASPED, THEY VE GET ... THEY VE GET THEM?

THE THING HARRY POTTER WILL MISS MEET, SIR? SHELEADED  
DEDDY, AND PAST AN WELL

THE PROSPECT IS BLACK, HARRY REPLIED, STARING, FURTHER-STRIKE,  
AT THE ELF, THE LATE, IT IS GONE, IT WHEN'T COME BACK ... DEDDY  
WHAT VE I GET THE KEY?

WELL HAS THE KEY THIS, SIR? SHELEADED THE ELF, AND HE PUT HIS  
HAND IN THE POCKET OF HIS SHIRTS AND DREW OUT A BALL OF WHAT  
LOOKED LIKE SLIMY, GRAYISH GREEN RAT TAILS. RIGHT BEFORE WELL GOT  
INTO THE LAKE, SIR GILLYWEE?

WHAT IS IT DEDDY SAID HARRY, STARING AT THE GILLYWEE,

IT WILL MAKE HARRY POTTER BREATHE UNDERWATER, SIR?

DHERRY, SAID HARRY FRANTICALLY, LISTEN ARE YOU SURE ABOUT THIS?

HE COULDN'T ELITE FORGET THAT THE LAST TIME DHERRY HAD TRIED THE HELP HIM, HE HAD ENDED UP WITH NINE KINKS IN HIS RIGHT ARM.

DHERRY IS ELITE SURE, SIR? SAID THE ELF EARNESTLY. DHERRY HEARS THINGS, SIR, HE IS A HOUSE-ELF, HE CHECKS ALL OVER THE CASTLE AS HE LIGHTS THE FIRES AND MOPS THE FLOORS, DHERRY HEARD PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL AND PROFESSOR MEENEY IN THE STAFF ROOM, TALKING

THE SECOND TASK??

ABOUT THE NEXT TASK ... DHERRY CANNOT LET HARRY POTTER LOSE HIS WIZARD?

HARRY'S BELT'S VANISHED, LUMPING THE HIS FEET HE PULLED OFF THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK, STUFFED IT INTO HIS BAG, GRABBED THE GILLYWEED AND PUT IT INTO HIS POCKET, THEN THERE HEW HE THE LIBRARY WITH DHERRY AT HIS HEELS.

DHERRY IS SLIPPED THE KEY IN THE KITCHENS, SIR? DHERRY SHEARED AS THEY BURST INTO THE HALLWAY, DHERRY WILL BE MISSED

GOOD LUCK, HARRY POTTER, SIR, GOOD LUCK?

SEE YOU LATER, DHERRY? HARRY SHELTED, AND HE SPRINTED ALONG THE HALLWAY AND DOWN THE STAIRS, THREE AT A TIME.

THE ENTRANCE HALL CONTAINED A FEW LAST-MINUTE STRAGGLERS, ALL LEAVING THE GREAT HALL AFTER BREAKFAST AND HEADING THROUGH THE HALLS TO WATCH THE SECOND TASK. THEY STARED AS HARRY FLASHED PAST, SENDING CELIA AND DENNIS CREEVEY FLYING AS HE LEAPT DOWN THE STONE STEPS AND HEW INTO THE NIGHT, CHILLY

GRILINDS.

AS HE PEELINGED DOWN THE LAWN HE SAW THAT THE SEATS THAT HAD  
ENCIRCLED THE DRAGONS ENCLASURE IN NOVEMBER WERE NOW  
RANGED ALONG THE OPPOSITE BANK, RISING IN STANDS THAT WERE  
PACKED THE BLURSTING PEINT AND REFLECTED IN THE LAKE EELLEN; THE  
EXCITED RABBLE OF THE CROWD EELLED STRANGELY ACROSS THE WATER  
AS HARRY RAN, FLAT FELT, AROUND THE EITHER SIDE OF THE LAKE THEWARDS  
THE ILDEGS, WHO WERE SITTING AT ANOTHER CHILD-DRAPE TABLE AT  
THE WATER S EDGE. CEDRIC, FLEUR AND DOLIM WERE BESIDE THE  
ILDEGS TABLE, WATCHING HARRY SPRINT THEWARDS THEM.

I M ... HERE ... HARRY PANTED, SKIDDING THE A FALT IN THE MUD  
AND ACCIDENTALLY SPLATTERING FLEUR S REEKS.

WHERE HAVE YOU BEEN? SAID A KISSY, DISAPPROVING VOICE.

THE TASK S AKEHIT THE START?

HARRY LUNCHED AROUND. PERCY WEASLEY WAS SITTING AT THE  
ILDEGS TABLE MR CRUELCH HAD FAILED THE TURN UP AGAIN.

NEH, NEH, PERCY? SAID LIDEE RAGMAN, WHO WAS LUNCHING  
INTENSELY RELIEVED THE SEE HARRY. LET HIM CATCH HIS BREATH?  
DUMBLEDORE SMILED AT HARRY, BUT DARDAREH AND MADAME

THE HARRY PENTTER

MARIME DIDN T LUNCH AT ALL PLEASED THE SEE HIM ... IT WAS HEVIELIS  
FROM THE LUNCHES AND THEIR FACES THAT THEY HAD THELIGHT HE WASN T  
GIVING THE TURN UP.

HARRY KENT HEVER, HANDS AND HIS DNEKS, GASPING FOR BREATH; HE  
HAD A STITCH IN HIS SIDE THAT FELT AS THELIGHT HE HAD A KNIFE  
BETWEEN HIS RIKS, BUT THERE WAS NEH TIME THE GET RID OF IT; LIDEE

RAGMAN WAS NOW MOVING AMONG THE CHAMPIONS, SPACING THEM ALONG THE BANK AT INTERVALS OF TEN FEET. HARRY WAS ON THE VERY END OF THE LINE, NEXT THE DOLPHIN, WHO WAS WEARING SWIMMING TRUNKS, AND WAS HOLDING HIS HAND READY.

ALL RIGHT, HARRY? RAGMAN WHISPERED, AS HE MOVED HARRY A FEW FEET FURTHER AWAY FROM THE DOLPHIN. KNOW WHAT YOU'RE GOING TO DO?

YEAH, HARRY PANTED, MASSAGING HIS RIBS.

RAGMAN GAVE HIS SHOULDER A BRISK SQUEEZE, AND RETURNED TO THE JUDGES' TABLE; HE POINTED HIS HAND AT HIS THROAT AS HE HAD DONE AT THE WORLD CUP, SAID "SNEEZE!" AND HIS VOICE RANGED OUT ACROSS THE DARK WATER TOWARDS THE STANDS.

WELL, ALL YOUR CHAMPIONS ARE READY FOR THE SECOND TASK, WHICH WILL START ON MY WHISTLE. THEY HAVE PRECISELY AN HOUR TO RECOVER WHAT HAS BEEN TAKEN FROM THEM. ON THE COUNT OF THREE, THEN, ONE ... TWO ... THREE!

THE WHISTLE RANGED SCRILLY IN THE COLD, STILL AIR; THE STANDS ERUPTED WITH CHEERS AND APPLAUSE; WITHOUT HESITATING TO SEE WHAT THE OTHER CHAMPIONS WERE DOING, HARRY PULLED OFF HIS SHOES AND SOCKS, PULLED THE HANDLE OF GILLYWEED OUT OF HIS POCKET, STUCK IT INTO HIS MOUTH, AND LAID OUT INTO THE LAKE.

THE LAKE WAS SO COLD HE FELT THE SKIN ON HIS LEGS SEARING AS THOUGH THIS WAS FIRE, NOT ICE WATER. HIS SHODDEN BOOTS WRECKED HIM DOWN AS HE LAIDED IN DEEPER; NOW THE WATER WAS OVER HIS KNEES, AND HIS RAPIDLY NUMBING FEET WERE SLIPPING OVER SLIT AND FLAT, SLIMY STONES. HE WAS CHEWING THE GILLYWEED AS HARD AND FAST AS HE COULD; IT FELT UNPLEASANTLY SLIMY AND SLEEKY, LIKE

HEMPLE'S TENTACLES. WAIST-DEEP IN THE FREEZING WATER HE STOPPED,  
SWALLOWED, AND WAITED FOR SOMETHING TO HAPPEN.

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HE COULD HEAR LAUGHTER IN THE CROWD, AND KNEW HE MUST  
BEHAVE STUPID, WALKING INTO THE LAKE WITHOUT FEELING ANY SIGN OF  
MAGICAL POWER. THE PART OF HIM THAT WAS STILL DRY WAS COVERED  
IN CHILLS. HALF-IMMERSED IN THE ICY WATER, A COLD BREEZE  
LIFTING HIS HAIR, HARRY STARTED TO SHIVER VIOLENTLY. HE AVOIDED  
LOOKING AT THE STANDS; THE LAUGHTER WAS BECOMING LOUDER, AND  
THERE WERE CATCALLS AND JEERING FROM THE SLYTHERINS ...

THEN, SUDDENLY, HARRY FELT AS THOUGH AN INVISIBLE PILLER  
HAD BEEN CLAPPED OVER HIS MOUTH AND NOSE. HE TRIED TO DRAW  
BREATH, BUT IT MADE HIS HEAD SPIN; HIS LUNGS WERE EMPTY, AND HE  
SUDDENLY FELT A PIERCING PAIN ON EITHER SIDE OF HIS  
NECK.

HARRY CLAPPED HIS HANDS AROUND HIS THROAT, AND FELT TWO  
LARGE SLITS JUST BELOW HIS EARS, FLAPPING IN THE COLD AIR ... HE HAD  
GILLS. WITHOUT PAUSING TO THINK, HE DID THE ONLY THING THAT  
MADE SENSE. HE FELL BACK INTO THE WATER.

THE FIRST GLIMPSE OF ICY LAKE WATER FELT LIKE THE BREATH OF LIFE. HIS  
HEAD HAD STOPPED SPINNING; HE TOOK ANOTHER GREAT GLIMPSE OF

WATER AND FELT IT PASS SPEEDILY THROUGH HIS GILLS, SENDING ENERGY  
BACK TO HIS BRAIN. HE STRETCHED OUT HIS HANDS IN FRONT OF

HIM AND STARED AT THEM. THEY LOOKED GREEN AND GLEETLY UNDER



THE WATER, AND THEY HAD BECOME WETTED, HE TWISTED AROUND  
AND LOOKED AT HIS BARE FEET. THEY HAD BECOME FLANGATED AND  
HIS TEES WERE WETTED, THEN; IT LOOKED AS THOUGH HE HAD SPRAWLED  
FLIPPERS.

THE WATER DIDN'T FEEL ICY AND MORE, EITHER ... IN THE CONTRARY,  
HE FELT PLEASANTLY CHILL, AND VERY LIGHT ... HARRY STRUCK OUT SINCE

MORE, MARVELLING AT HOW FAR AND FAST HIS FLIPPER-LIKE FEET PRO-  
PELLED HIM THROUGH THE WATER, AND NOTICING HOW CLEARLY HE

COULD SEE, AND HOW HE NO LONGER NEEDED TO BE BLIND, HE HAD SEEN

SWIM SO FAR INTO THE LAKE THAT HE COULD NO LONGER SEE THE REET-  
TUM, HE FLIPPED OVER, AND DIVED INTO ITS DEPTHS.

SILENCE PRESSED UPON HIS EARS AS HE SHARED EVER A STRANGE,  
DARK, FOGGY LANDSCAPE. HE COULD ONLY SEE TEN FEET AROUND HIM,  
SEE THAT AS HE SPED THROUGH THE WATER NEW SCENES SEEMED TO

AND HARRY PETER

WHEN SUDDENLY HE HIT UP THE ENCHING DARKNESS; PERISTS OF RIP-  
PLING, TANGLED BLACK WEED, WIDE PLAINS OF MUD LITTERED WITH

BLISS, GLIMMERING STINKS, HE SWAM DEEPER AND DEEPER, HE HIT  
TOWARDS THE MIDDLE OF THE LAKE, HIS EYES WIDE, STARING THROUGH  
THE PERILY GREY-LIT WATER AROUND HIM THE THE SHADHLS BEYOND,

WHERE THE WATER BECAME IMPASSIBLE.

SMALL FISH FLICKERED PAST HIM LIKE SILVER DARTS, HENCE HE TWICE HE THOUGHT HE SAW SOMETHING LARGER MOVING AHEAD OF HIM, BUT WHEN HE GOT NEARER, HE DISCOVERED IT WAS NOTHING BUT A LARGE, BLACKENED LOG, OR A DENSE CLUMP OF WEED. THERE WAS NO SIGN OF ANY OF THE OTHER CHAMPIONS, MERPEOPLE, REIN HER, THANDFLILLY, THE GIANT SEELID.

LIGHT-GREEN WEED STRETCHED AHEAD OF HIM AS FAR AS HE COULD SEE, TWO FEET DEEP, LIKE A MEADOW OF VERY EVERGREEN GRASS. HARRY WAS STARING UNBLINKINGLY AHEAD OF HIM, TRYING TO DISCERN SHAPES THROUGH THE GREEN ... AND THEN, WITHOUT WARNING, SOMETHING GRABBED HIM ON HIS ANKLE.

HARRY TWISTED HIS BODY AROUND AND SAW A GRINDWORM, A SMALL, FERNED WATER BEETLE, PEEKING OUT OF THE WEEDS, ITS LONG FINGERS CLUTCHED TIGHTLY AROUND HARRY'S LEG, ITS POINTED FANGS BARED. HARRY STUCK HIS WEAKED HAND QUICKLY INSIDE HIS REEKS AND FUMBLER FOR HIS WAND. BY THE TIME HE HAD GRASPED IT, TWO

MORE GRINDWORMS HAD RISEN OUT OF THE WEED, HAD SEIZED HAND-FLIES OF HARRY'S REEKS, AND WERE ATTEMPTING TO DRAG HIM DOWN.

RELASHING HARRY SHOUTED, EXCEPT THAT NO SOUND CAME OUT ... A LARGE BUBBLE ISSUED FROM HIS MOUTH, AND HIS WAND, INSTEAD OF SENDING SPARKS AT THE GRINDWORMS, PELTED THEM WITH WHAT SEEMED TO BE A LOT OF BOILING WATER, FOR WHERE IT STRUCK THEM, ANGRY RED PATCHES APPEARED ON THEIR GREEN SKIN. HARRY PULLED HIS ANKLE OUT OF THE GRINDWORMS GRIP AND SWAM AS FAST AS HE

CHILD, OCCASIONALLY SENDING MORE OF HIS FEET WATER OVER HIS  
SHOULDER AT RANDOM; EVERY NOW AND THEN HE FELT ONE OF THE  
GRINDYHEADS SNATCH AT HIS FEET AGAIN, AND KICKED HIM, HARD;

FINALLY, HE FELT HIS FEET CONNECT WITH A HARDER SURFACE, AND LEED-  
ING BACK, SAW THE DAZED GRINDYHEAD FLEETING AWAY, CROSS-EYED,

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WHILE ITS FELLOWS STOOD THEIR FISTS AT HARRY, AND SAND BACK INTO  
THE WEED,

HARRY SLEWED DOWN A LITTLE, SLIPPED HIS WAND BACK INSIDE HIS  
POCKETS AND LEANED AHEAD, LISTENING AGAIN. HE TURNED FULL CIRCLE  
IN THE WATER, THE SILENCE PRESSING HARDER THAN EVER AGAINST HIS  
EARDRUMS. HE KNEW HE MUST BE EVEN DEEPER IN THE DARK REEF,  
BUT NOTHING WAS MOVING EXCEPT THE RIPPLING WEED.

THEY ARE STILL GETTING HIM?

HARRY THOUGHT HE WAS HAVING A HEART ATTACK. HE WHIPPED  
AHEAD, AND SAW MEANING MYRTLE FLEETING FAZILY IN FRONT OF  
HIM, GAZING AT HIM THROUGH HER THICK PEARLY GLASSES.

MYRTLE? HARRY TRIED TO FEEL IT BUT, ONCE AGAIN, NOTHING  
CAME OUT OF HIS MOUTH BUT A VERY LARGE BUBBLE. MEANING  
MYRTLE ACTUALLY GIGGLED.

THEY WANT TO TRY EVER THERE? SHE SAID, POINTING. I WEN'T COME  
WITH THEM ... I DREN'T LIKE THEM MUCH, THEY ALWAYS CHASE ME  
WHEN I GET THEM CLOSE ...

HARRY GAVE HER THE THUMB-UP TO SHOW HIS THANKS, AND SET  
OFF ONCE MORE, CAREFULLY TO SWIM A BIT HIGHER OVER THE WEED, THE

AWHID AND MORE GRINDYHEELS THAT MIGHT BE LURKING THERE.  
HE SWAM ON FOR WHAT FELT LIKE AT LEAST TWENTY MINUTES. HE  
WAS PASSING EVER VAST EXPANSES OF BLACK MUD NOW, WHICH  
SWIRLED MURKILY AS HE DISTURBED THE WATER. THEN, AT LENGTH LAST,  
HE HEARD A SNATCH OF FAINTING MER-SHENG.

AN FEELER LONG YELL LL HAVE TH LEND,  
AND THE RECEIVER WHAT WE THERE ...

HARRY SWAM FASTER, AND THEN SAW A LARGE REED EMERGE OUT OF THE  
MUDDY WATER AHEAD. IT HAD PAINTINGS OF MERPEOPLE ON IT; THEY  
WERE CARRYING SPEARS, AND CHASING WHAT LOOKED LIKE THE GIANT  
SHELL. HARRY SWAM ON PAST THE REED, FOLLOWING THE MER-SHENG.

... YOUR TIME IS HALF-GONE, SEE TARRY REET  
BEST WHAT YOU SEEK STAYS HERE THE REET ...

ARE HARRY PEEETTER

A CLUSTER OF CRUDE STONE DWELLINGS STAINED WITH ALGAE LOOKED  
SUDDENLY OUT OF THE GLEAM ON ALL SIDES, HERE AND THERE AT THE

DARK WINDMILLS, HARRY SAW FACES ... FACES THAT WERE NOT RESEM-  
BLANCE AT ALL THE THE PAINTING OF THE MERMAID IN THE PERFECTS

BATHROOM ...

THE MERPEOPLE HAD GREYISH SKINS AND LONG, WILD, DARK GREEN  
HAIR. THEIR EYES WERE YELLOW, AS WERE THEIR BROKEN TEETH, AND  
THEY WERE THICK RINGS OF PEBBLES AROUND THEIR NECKS. THEY

LEERED AT HARRY AS HE SLAM PAST; HERE HE TWO OF THEM EMERGED FROM THEIR CAVES TO WATCH HIM BETTER, THEIR PHEWPAH, SILVER FISH-TAILS BEATING THE WATER, SPEARS CLUTCHED IN THEIR HANDS. HARRY SPED ON, STARING AROUND, AND SEEN THE DWELLINGS BECAME MORE NUMEROUS; THERE WERE GARDENS OF WEED AROUND SOME OF THEM, AND HE EVEN SAW A PET CRINOYD TIED TO A STAKE BESIDE ONE OF THEM. MERPEOPLE WERE EMERGING ON ALL SIDES NOW, WATCHING HIM EAGERLY, POINTING AT HIS WEAKED HANDS AND GILLS, TALKING BEHIND THEIR HANDS TO EACH OTHER. HARRY SPED AROUND A CORNER, AND A VERY STRANGE SIGHT MET HIS EYES.

A WHOLE CROWD OF MERPEOPLE WERE CHEATING IN FRONT OF THE HOUSES THAT LINED WHAT LOOKED LIKE A MER-VERSION OF A VILLAGE

SEALAND. A CHIEF OF MERPEOPLE WERE SINGING IN THE MIDDLE, CALLING THE CHAMPIONS TOWARDS THEM, AND BEHIND THEM ROSE A

CRUDE SORT OF STATUE; A GIGANTIC MERPERSON FLEW FROM A REILDER, FEWER PEOPLE WERE BEHIND TIGHTLY TO THE TAIL OF THE STONE

MERPERSON.

JOHN WAS TIED BETWEEN HERMINE AND CHIEF CHANG. THERE WAS

ALSO A GIRL WHO LOOKED NOT OLDER THAN EIGHT, WHOSE CURLS OF SILVER HAIR MADE HARRY FEEL SURE THAT SHE WAS FLEW DELACHIE'S

SISTER. ALL FEWER OF THEM APPEARED TO BE IN A VERY DEEP SLEEP,

THEIR HEADS WERE BEHIND THEIR SHOULDERS, AND FINE STREAMS

HE BUBBLES KEPT ISSUING FROM THEIR MOUTHS.

HARRY SPED TOWARDS THE FESTAGES, HALF EXPECTING THE MER-  
PEOPLE TO WHEEL THEIR SPEARS AND CHARGE AT HIM, BUT THEY DID

NOTHING. THE REEDS HE WENT TYING THE FESTAGES TO THE STATUE  
WERE THICK, SLIM AND VERY STRONG. FOR A FLEETING SECOND HE

THE SECOND TASK WAS

THOUGHT OF THE KNIFE STIRLIS HAD KNIGHT HIM FOR CHRISTMAS  
LOCKED IN HIS TOWER IN THE CASTLE A QUARTER OF A MILE AWAY, NE-  
LESS TO HIM WHATSOEVER.

HE WHEELED AROUND, MANY OF THE MERPEOPLE SURROUNDING

THEM WERE CARRYING SPEARS. HE SWAM SLIGHTLY TOWARDS A SEVEN-  
FEET-TALL MERMAN WITH A LONG GREEN BEARD AND A CHIN OF

SHARP FANGS, AND TRIED TO MIMIC A REQUEST TO RETURN THE SPEAR.  
THE MERMAN LAUGHED AND SHOOK HIS HEAD.

WE DO NOT HELP, HE SAID IN A HARSH, CREAKY VOICE.

COME HERE! HARRY SAID FIERCELY BUT ONLY BUBBLES ISSUED  
FROM HIS MOUTH, AND HE TRIED TO PULL THE SPEAR AWAY FROM THE  
MERMAN, BUT THE MERMAN YANKED IT BACK, STILL SHAKING HIS HEAD  
AND LAUGHING.

HARRY SWIRLED AROUND, STARING ABLIT, SOMETHING SHARP ...  
ANYTHING ...

THERE WERE REEDS LITTERING THE LAKE BETWEEN THEM. HE DIVED AND

SNATCHED UP A PARTICULARLY JAGGED ONE, AND RETURNED TO THE STATUE.  
HE BEGAN THE HACK AT THE ROPES BINDING REEN, AND AFTER SEVERAL

MINUTES HARD WORK, THEY BROKE APART. REEN FLEATED, LINCOLN-  
SCHEELS, A FEW INCHES ABOVE THE LAKE BOTTOM, DRIFTING A LITTLE IN

THE EYE OF THE WATER.

HARRY BREWED AROUND. THERE WAS NO SIGN OF ANY OF THE OTHER  
CHAMPIONS. WHAT WERE THEY PLAYING AT? WHY DIDN'T THEY HURRY  
UP? HE TURNED BACK TO HERMIONE, RAISED THE JAGGED ROPES AND  
BEGAN THE HACK AT HER BINDINGS, THEN

AT ONCE, SEVERAL PAIRS OF STRENGTHY GREY HANDS SEIZED HIM. HALF-  
A-DOZEN MERMAIDS WERE PULLING HIM AWAY FROM HERMIONE, SHAK-  
ING THEIR GREEN-FAIRED HEADS AND LAUGHING.

WELL TAKE YOUR OWN PRISONER, ONE OF THEM SAID TO HIM. LEAVE  
THE OTHERS ...

NO WAY! SAID HARRY FLURRIEDLY BUT ONLY TWO LARGE BUBBLES  
CAME OUT.

YOUR TASK IS TO RETRIEVE YOUR OWN FRIEND ... LEAVE THE  
OTHERS ...

SHE'S MY FRIEND, THEN! HARRY YELLED, GESTICULATING TOWARDS

THE HARRY PEEETER

HERMIONE, AN ENORMOUS SILVER BUBBLE EMERGING SOUNDLESSLY  
FROM HIS LIPS. AND I DON'T WANT THEM TO DIE, EITHER!

CELESTE'S HEAD WAS IN HERMIONE'S SHOULDER; THE SMALL SILVER-  
HAired GIRL WAS GHOSTLY GREEN AND PALE. HARRY STRUGGLED THE FIGHT

OFF THE MERMEN, BUT THEY LAUGHED HARDER THAN EVER, HOLDING  
HIM BACK. HARRY BREATHED WILDLY AROUND. WHERE WERE THE OTHER  
CHAMPIONS? WOULD HE HAVE TIME TO TAKE DOWN THE SURFACE,  
AND COME BACK DOWN FOR HERMIONE AND THE OTHERS? WOULD HE  
BE ABLE TO FIND THEM AGAIN? HE BREATHED DOWN AT HIS WATCH TO SEE  
HOW MUCH TIME WAS LEFT IT HAD STOPPED WORKING.

BUT THEN THE MERFOLK AROUND HIM STARTED POINTING EXCITED-  
LY OVER HIS HEAD. HARRY BREATHED UP AND SAW CEDRIC SWIMMING

TOWARDS THEM. THERE WAS AN ENORMOUS GLEAM AROUND HIS  
HEAD, WHICH MADE HIS FEATURES LOOK HOBBY WIDE AND STRETCHED.

GET LOST! HE MOUTHED, BREATHING PANIC-STRIKEN. FLEUR AND  
DRAWM RE CHIMING NOW!

FEELING ENORMOUSLY RELIEVED, HARRY WATCHED CEDRIC PULL A  
KNIFE OUT OF HIS POCKET AND CUT CELESTE FREE. HE PULLED HER  
UPWARDS AND OUT OF SIGHT.

HARRY BREATHED AROUND, WAITING. WHERE WERE FLEUR AND  
DRAWM? TIME WAS GETTING SHORT AND, ACCORDING TO THE SENSE, THE  
OBSTACLES WOULD BE LOST AFTER AN HOUR ...

THE MERFOLK STARTED SCREECHING EXCITEDLY. THOSE HOLDING  
HARRY LOOSENED THEIR GRIP, STARING BEHIND THEM. HARRY TURNED,  
AND SAW SOMETHING MONSTRIOUS CUTTING THROUGH THE WATER



THEWARDS THEM: A FLIPMAN BODY IN SWIMMING TRUNKS WITH THE  
HEAD OF A SHARK ... IT WAS ORLM. HE APPEARED THE HAVE  
TRANSFIGURED HIMSELF BUT BADLY.

THE SHARK-MAN SWAM STRAIGHT THE HERMIONE AND BEGAN SNAP-  
PING AND BITING AT HER REEFS: THE TERRIBLE WAS THAT ORLM'S NEW

TEETH WERE POSITIONED VERY ALONGWARDLY FOR BITING ANYTHING  
SMALLER THAN A DELPHIN, AND HARRY WAS WHITE SURE THAT IF ORLM  
WASN'T CAREFUL, HE WAS GOING THE RIP HERMIONE IN HALF, DARTING  
THEWARDS, HARRY HIT ORLM HARD IN THE SHOULDER, AND HELD UP  
THE JAGGED STONE. ORLM SEIZED IT, AND BEGAN THE CUT HERMIONE

THE SECOND TASK WAS

FREE. WITHIN SECONDS, HE HAD DONE IT: HE GRABBED HERMIONE  
AROUND THE WAIST AND, WITHOUT A BACKWARD GLANCE, BEGAN THE RISE  
RAPIDLY WITH HER THEWARDS THE SURFACE.

WELL WHAT? HARRY THOUGHT DESPERATELY, IF HE COULD BE SURE  
THAT FLEUR WAS COMING ... BUT STILL NO SIGN. THERE WAS NOTHING  
FOR IT ...

HE SNATCHED UP THE STONE, WHICH ORLM HAD DROPPED, BUT

THE MERMEN NOW CLOSED IN AROUND REEN AND THE LITTLE GIRL, SHAK-  
ING THEIR HEADS AT HIM.

HARRY PULLED OUT HIS WAND, GOT OUT OF THE WAY:

ONLY BUBBLES FLEW OUT OF HIS MOUTH, BUT HE HAD THE DISTINCT

IMPRESSION THAT THE MERMEN HAD UNDERSTOOD HIM, BECAUSE  
THEY SUDDENLY STOPPED LAUGHING. THEIR YELLOWISH EYES WERE  
FIXED UPON HARRY'S HAND, AND THEY LOOKED SCARED. THERE MIGHT  
BE A LOT MORE OF THEM THAN THERE WERE OF HIM, BUT HARRY COULD  
TELL, BY THE LOOKS ON THEIR FACES, THAT THEY KNEW NE MORE MAGIC  
THAN THE GIANT SEELID DID.

WELL YE GET UNTIL THREE! HARRY SCHELTED; A GREAT STREAM OF  
BUBBLES BURST FROM HIM, BUT HE HELD UP THREE FINGERS TO MAKE  
SURE THEY GOT THE MESSAGE. THREE ... HE PLUT DOWN A FINGER!  
TWO ... HE PLUT DOWN A SECOND!

THEY SCATTERED. HARRY DARTED FORWARD AND BEGAN TO HACK AT  
THE REEFS BINDING THE SMALL GIRL TO THE STATUE; AND AT LAST SHE  
WAS FREE. HE GRABBED THE LITTLE GIRL AROUND THE WAIST, GRABBED THE  
NECK OF REEN'S REEFS, AND DICKED OFF FROM THE KETTLES.

IT WAS VERY SLOW WORK. HE COULD NE LONGER USE HIS WORKING

HANDS TO PROPEL HIMSELF FORWARD; HE WORKED HIS FLIPPERS FLUR-  
RILY, BUT REEN AND FLEEN'S SISTER WERE LIKE PHTATH-FILLED SACKS

DRAWING HIM BACK DOWN ... HE FIXED HIS EYES SKYWARDS,

THOUGH HE KNEW HE MUST STILL BE VERY DEEP. THE WATER ABOVE  
HIM WAS SEE DARK ...

MERPEOPLE WERE RISING WITH HIM. HE COULD SEE THEM SWIRLING  
AROUND HIM WITH EASE, WATCHING HIM STRUGGLE THROUGH THE  
WATER ... WOULD THEY PULL HIM BACK DOWN TO THE DEPTHS WHEN  
THE TIME WAS UP? DID THEY PERHAPS EAT HUMANS? HARRY'S LEGS

AND HARRY PETER

WERE SEIZING UP WITH THE EFFORT THE DEEP SWIMMING; HIS SHOULDERS WERE ACHING TERRIBLY WITH THE EFFORT OF DRAGGING REEN AND THE GIRL ...

HE WAS DRAWING BREATH WITH EXTREME DIFFICULTY, HE COULD FEEL PAIN IN THE SIDES OF HIS NECK AGAIN ... HE WAS BECOMING VERY

AWARE OF HOW WET THE WATER WAS IN HIS MOUTH ... YET THE DARKNESS WAS DEFINITELY THINNING NOW ... HE COULD SEE DAYLIGHT

ABOVE HIM ...

HE KICKED HARD WITH HIS FLIPPERS AND DISCOVERED THAT THEY WERE NOTHING MORE THAN FEET ... WATER WAS FLOODING THROUGH HIS MOUTH INTO HIS LUNGS ... HE WAS STARTING TO FEEL DIZZY, BUT HE KNEW LIGHT AND AIR WERE ONLY TEN FEET ABOVE HIM ... HE HAD TO GET THERE ... HE HAD TO ...

HARRY KICKED HIS LEGS SO HARD AND FAST IT FELT AS THOUGH HIS

MUSCLES WERE SCREAMING IN PROTEST; HIS VERY BRAIN FELT WATERLOGGED, HE COULDN'T BREATHE, HE NEEDED OXYGEN, HE HAD TO KEEP

GOING, HE COULD NOT STOP

AND THEN HE FELT HIS HEAD BREAK THE SURFACE OF THE LAKE; WHEN DEEPLY, COLD, CLEAR AIR WAS MAKING HIS WET FACE STING; HE GLIMPSED

IT DROWN, FEELING AS THOUGH HE HAD NEVER BREATHED PROPERLY  
BEFORE, AND, PANTING, PLULLED ROEN AND THE LITTLE GIRL UP WITH  
HIM. ALL AROUND HIM, WILD, GREEN-FAIRED HEADS WERE EMERGING  
BLT OF THE WATER WITH HIM, BUT THEY WERE SMILING AT HIM.  
THE CROWD IN THE STANDS WAS MAKING A GREAT DEAL OF NOISE;  
SHOUTING AND SCREAMING, EVERYBODY SEEMED TO BE ON THEIR FEET;  
HARRY HAD THE IMPRESSION THEY THOUGHT THAT ROEN AND THE LITTLE  
GIRL MIGHT BE DEAD, BUT THEY WERE LIVING ... BOTH OF THEM HAD  
OPENED THEIR EYES; THE GIRL LOOKED SCARED AND CONFUSED, BUT  
ROEN MERELY EXPELLED A GREAT SPURT OF WATER, BLINDED IN THE  
BRIGHT LIGHT, TURNED TO HARRY AND SAID, 'WET, THIS, ISN'T IT?' THEN  
HE SPOTTED FLEUR'S SISTER. 'WHAT DID SHE DO TO HER AUNT?'  
FLEUR DIDN'T TURN UP. 'I COULDN'T LEAVE HER,' HARRY PANTED.  
HARRY, SHE PRAT, SAID ROEN, SHE DIDN'T TAKE THAT SHIT THING  
SERIOUSLY, DID SHE? SOMEWHERE SHE WOULDN'T HAVE LET ANY OF US  
DROWN.

## THE SECOND TASK YET

BUT THE SHIP SAID

ONLY WE MADE SURE SHE GOT BACK INSIDE THE TIME LIMIT;

SAID ROEN. 'I HOPE SHE DIDN'T WASTE TIME DOWN THERE ACTING THE  
HERO.'

HARRY FELT BOTH STUPID AND ANNOYED. IT WAS ALL VERY WELL FOR  
ROEN; HE'D BEEN ASLEEP, HE HADN'T FELT HOW PERIL IT WAS DOWN IN  
THE LAKE, SURROUNDED BY SPEAR-CARRYING MEREPEOPLE WHO'D  
LOOKED MORE THAN CAPABLE OF MURDER.

[ THEN, HARRY SAID SHORTLY, HELP ME WITH HER, I DON'T THINK SHE CAN SWIM VERY WELL.

THEY PULLED FLEUR'S SISTER THROUGH THE WATER, BACK TOWARDS THE BANK WHERE THE JUDGES STOOD WATCHING, TWENTY MEN PEOPLE

ACCOMPANYING THEM LIKE A CHORUS OF FIFTEEN, SINGING THEIR TERRIBLE SCREECH-ING SONGS.

HARRY COULD SEE MADAM PEMFREY PLISSING OVER HERMIONE, DRUM, CEDRIC AND LEE, ALL OF WHOM WERE WRAPPED IN THICK BLANKETS. DUMBLEDORE AND LORD BAGMAN STOOD BEARING AT HARRY AND THEN FROM THE BANK AS THEY SWAM NEARER, BUT PERCY, WHO LOOKED VERY WHITE AND SHAKEN MUCH LONGER THAN USUAL, CAME SPLASHING OUT TO MEET THEM. MEANWHILE MADAME MAXIME WAS TRYING TO RESTRAIN FLEUR DELACOUR, WHO WAS BEING HYSTERICAL, FIGHTING TEETH AND NAIL TO RETURN TO THE WATER.

GABRIELLE? GABRIELLE? IS SHE ALIVE? IS SHE LIFT?

SHE'S FINE? HARRY TRIED TO TELL HER, BUT HE WAS SO EXHAUSTED HE COULD HARDLY TALK, LET ALONE SPEAK.

PERCY SEIZED RON AND WAS DRAGGING HIM BACK TO THE BANK ( GRRRR, PERCY, I'M ALL RIGHT! ) DUMBLEDORE AND BAGMAN WERE PULLING HARRY UPRIGHT; FLEUR HAD BROKEN FREE OF MADAME MAXIME AND WAS FLEEING HER SISTER.

IT WAS THE GRINDWHEELS ... THEY ATTACKED ME ... EH, GABRIELLE, I THOUGHT ... I THOUGHT ...

COME HERE, NOW, SAID MADAM PEMFREY'S VOICE; SHE SEIZED HARRY AND PULLED HIM OVER THE HERMIONE AND THE OTHERS,

WRAPPED HIM SHE TIGHTLY IN A BLANKET THAT HE FELT AS THOUGH HE WAS IN A STRAITJACKET, AND FORCED A MEASURE OF VERY FINE POTION

THE HARRY POTTER

BEHIND HIS THREAT, STEAM GUSHED OUT OF HIS EARS.

HARRY, WELL DONE! HERMIONE CRIED. YOU DID IT, YOU FOUND OUT HIM, ALL BY YOURSELF!

WELL SAID HARRY, HE WOULD HAVE TOLD HER ABOUT DICKY, BUT HE HAD JUST NOTICED DADAHOFF WATCHING HIM. HE WAS THE ONLY ILLEGAL WHO HAD NOT LEFT THE TABLE; THE ONLY ILLEGAL NOT SHOWING SIGNS OF PLEASURE AND RELIEF THAT HARRY, RON AND LUNA'S SISTER HAD GOTTEN BACK SAFELY. YES, THAT'S RIGHT, SAID HARRY, RAISING HIS VOICE SLIGHTLY SO THAT DADAHOFF COULD HEAR HIM.

YOU HAVE A WATER BEETLE IN YOUR HAIR, HERMION-NINNY, SAID DADAHOFF.

HARRY HAD THE IMPRESSION THAT DADAHOFF WAS DRAWING HER ATTENTION BACK TOWARD HIMSELF; PERHAPS HE REMIND HER THAT HE HAD JUST

RESCUED HER FROM THE LAKE, BUT HERMIONE BRUSHED THE BEETLE AWAY IMPATIENTLY AND SAID, YOU'RE WELL BEYOND THE TIME LIMIT, THOUGH, HARRY ... DID IT TAKE YOU AGES TO FIND US?

YES ... I FOUND YOU ...

HARRY'S FEELING OF STUPIDITY WAS GROWING. WHEN HE WAS OUT OF THE WATER, IT SEEMED PERFECTLY CLEAR THAT DADAHOFF'S SAFETY PRECAUTIONS WOULD NOT HAVE PERMITTED THE DEATH OF A HOSTAGE JUST BECAUSE THEIR CHAMPION HADN'T TURNED UP. WHY HADN'T HE

ILIST GRABBED JOHN AND GENE? HE WOULD HAVE BEEN FIRST BACK ...  
LEBRIC AND DORUM HADN'T WASTED TIME WHIRRYING AROUND ANYONE  
ELSE; THEY HADN'T TAKEN THE MER-SING SERIOUSLY ...

OLIMPEHRE WAS CREEKING AT THE WATER'S EDGE, DEEP IN CON-  
VERSATION WITH WHAT SEEMED TO BE THE CHIEF MERPERSON, A PAR-  
TICULARLY WILD- AND PERHAPS-LOOKING FEMALE. HE WAS MAKING

THE SAME SHORT OF SCREECHY NOISES THAT THE MERPEOPLE MADE  
WHEN THEY WERE ABOVE WATER; CLEARLY, OLIMPEHRE COULD SPEAK  
MERMISH. FINALLY HE STRAIGHTENED UP, TURNED TO HIS FELLOW  
ILDGES AND SAID, A CONFERENCE BEFORE WE GIVE THE MARDS, I  
THINK.

THE ILDGES WENT INTO A HUBBLE. MADAM PEMPREY HAD GONE TO  
RESCUE JOHN FROM PERCY'S CLUTCHES; SHE LED HIM OVER THE HARRY  
AND THE OTHERS, GAVE HIM A BLANKET AND SOME PEPPER-LIP

## THE SECOND TASK

WHEN, THEN, WENT THE PETCH FLER AND HER SISTER. FLER HAD MANY  
CLITS ON HER FACE AND ARMS, AND HER REEKS WERE THIN, BUT SHE  
DIDN'T SEEM TO CARE, NEAR WOULD SHE ALLOW MADAM PEMPREY TO  
CLEAN THEM.

AFTER GABRIELLE, SHE TOLD HER, AND THEN SHE TURNED TO  
HARRY. WHEN SAVED HER, SHE SAID BREATHLESSLY, EVEN THOUGH SHE  
WAS NOT FLER HOSTAGE.

YEAH, SAID HARRY, WHEN WAS NOT HEARTILY WISHING HE'D LEFT ALL  
THREE GIRLS TIED TO THE STAKE.

FLEUR KENT BEGAN, KISSED HARRY TWICE ON EACH CHEEK (HE FELT HIS FACE BURN AND WISHEDN T HAVE BEEN SURPRISED IF STEAM WAS COMING OUT OF HIS EARS AGAIN), THEN SAID THE BORN, AND WELL, THE WELL RODE

YEAH, SAID BEN, LOOKING EXTREMELY IMPASSIVE, YEAH, A BIT FLEUR SWEPTED DOWN ON HIM, THEN AND KISSED HIM. FERMINE WINKED SIMPLY AIRILY, BUT JUST THEN, LUDIE RAGMAN'S MAGICALLY MAGNIFIED VOICE RINGED OUT BESIDE THEM, MAKING THEM ALL JUMP, AND CALLING THE CROWD IN THE STANDS THE OH VERY QUIET.

LADIES AND GENTLEMEN, WE HAVE REACHED OUR DECISION. MERCHANTMASS MURKIN HAS TOLD US EXACTLY WHAT HAPPENED AT THE BETTING OF THE LATE, AND WE HAVE THEREFORE DECIDED THE AWARD MARKS OUT OF FIFTY PER EACH OF THE CHAMPIONS, AS FOLLOWS ... MISS FLEUR DELACHUR, THOUGH SHE DEMONSTRATED EXCELLENT USE OF THE BUBBLE-HEAD CHARM, WAS ATTACKED BY GRINDWHEELS AS SHE APPROACHED HER GOAL, AND FAILED TO RETRIEVE HER PRIZE. WE AWARD HER TWENTY-FIVE POINTS. APPLAUSE FROM THE STANDS.

I DESERVED ZERO, SAID FLEUR THERETOF, SHAKING HER MAGNIFICENT HEAD.

MR LUDIE BIGGERY, WHO ALSO USED THE BUBBLE-HEAD CHARM, WAS FIRST TO RETURN WITH HIS PRIZE, THOUGH HE RETURNED HERE



MINUTE ELTISIDE THE TIME LIMIT OF AN EELER. ENTHUSIASM CHIRPS  
FROM THE ELLAPPLERS IN THE CROWD; HARRY SAW THEM GIVE CEDRIC  
A GLEETING LOOK. HE THEREFORE AWARDED HIM THIRTY-SEVEN POINTS.

AND HARRY PETER

HARRY'S HEART SANK. IF CEDRIC HAD BEEN ELTISIDE THE TIME LIMIT,  
HE MUST CERTAINLY HAD BEEN.

MR VIDUAER DURLIN USED AN INCOMPLETE FORM OF TRANS-  
FIGURATION, WHICH WAS NEVERTHELESS EFFECTIVE, AND WAS SECOND THE

RETURN WITH HIS PRIZE. HE AWARDED HIM THIRTY POINTS.

DARDAINE CLAPPED PARTICULARLY HARD, WHISTLING VERY SUPERBLY.

MR HARRY PETER USED GILLYWEED THE GREAT EFFECT. RAGMAN  
CONTINUED. HE RETURNED LAST, AND WELL ELTISIDE THE TIME LIMIT OF  
AN EELER. HOWEVER, THE MERCHETAINNESS INTERMS US THAT MR  
PETER WAS FIRST TO REACH THE PRIZES, AND THAT THE DELAY IN HIS  
RETURN WAS DUE TO HIS DETERMINATION TO RETURN ALL PRIZES TO  
SAFETY, NOT MERELY HIS OWN.

JOHN AND HERMIONE BOTH GAVE HARRY HALF-EXASPERATED, HALF-  
COMPLIMENTING LOOKS.

MOST OF THE JUDGES AND HERE, RAGMAN GAVE DARDAINE A  
VERY NASTY LOOK FEEL THAT THIS SEEMS MORAL FIRE AND MERITS  
FULL MARKS. HOWEVER ... MR PETER'S SCORE IS THIRTY-FIVE POINTS.  
HARRY'S STOMACH LEAPT HE WAS NOW TYING FOR FIRST PLACE WITH

CECIL, RICH AND HERMINE, CAUGHT BY SURPRISE, STARED AT HARRY, THEN LAUGHED AND STARTED APPLAUDING HARD WITH THE REST OF THE CROWD.

THERE WERE OH, HARRY! RICH SHOUTED OVER THE NOISE. THEY WEREN'T BEING THICK AFTER ALL. THEY WERE SETTLING NEURAL FIRE! FELIX WAS CLAPPING VERY HARD, THEN, BUT KARL DIDN'T SEEM

VERY HAPPY AT ALL. HE ATTEMPTED TO ENGAGE HERMINE IN CONVERSATION AGAIN, BUT SHE WAS TOO BUSY CHEERING HARRY TO LISTEN.

THE THIRD AND FINAL TASK WILL TAKE PLACE AT DUSK ON THE TWENTY-FOURTH OF JUNE, CONTINUED RAGMAN. THE CHAMPIONS WILL BE

NOTIFIED OF WHAT IS COMING, PRECISELY ONE MONTH BEFOREHAND.

THANK YOU ALL FOR YOUR SUPPORT OF THE CHAMPIONS.

IT WAS EVER, HARRY THOUGHT DAZZLED, AS MADAM POMPREE BEGAN HERDING THE CHAMPIONS AND PRISONS BACK TO THE CASTLE. HE GOT INTO THE DRY CLOTHES ... IT WAS EVER, HE HAD GOTTEN THROUGH ... HE DIDN'T HAVE THE LEAST ABOUT ANYTHING NEW UNTIL JUNE THE TWENTY-FOURTH ...

THE SECOND TASK \*\*\*

NEXT TIME HE WAS IN THE STABLES, HE DECIDED, AS HE WALKED BACK UP THE STONE STEPS INTO THE CASTLE, HE WAS GIVING THE BUSY DEER A PAIR OF SHOES FOR EVERY DAY OF THE YEAR.

CHAPTER TWENTY-SEVEN

## PADMEET RETURNS

ONE OF THE BEST THINGS ABOUT THE AFTERMATH OF THE SECOND TASK WAS THAT EVERYBODY WAS VERY OPEN TO HEAR DETAILS OF WHAT HAD HAPPENED DOWN IN THE LAKE, WHICH MEANT THAT HER HONOR REEN WAS GETTING THE SHARE HARRY'S LIMELIGHT. HARRY NOTICED THAT REEN'S VERSION OF EVENTS CHANGED SLIGHTLY WITH EVERY RETELLING. AT FIRST, HE GAVE WHAT SEEMED TO BE THE TRUTH; IT TALLIED WITH HERMIONE'S STORY, ANYWAY. OLIMPIUS had put all the hostages into a bewitched sleep in PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL'S OFFICE, FIRST ASSURING THEM THAT THEY WOULD BE COMPLETELY SAFE, AND WOULD AWAKE WHEN THEY WERE BACK ABOVE THE WATER. ONE WEEK LATER, HOWEVER, REEN WAS TELLING A THRILLING TALE OF RESCUE IN WHICH HE STRUGGLED SINGLE-HANDEDLY AGAINST FIFTY HEAVILY ARMED MORTHELS WHO HAD THROWN HIM INTO SLIMESLICK BEFORE TYING HIM UP.

BUT I HAD MY HAND HIDDEN UP MY SLEEVE, HE ASSURED PADMA PATIL, WHO SEEMED TO BE A LITTLE KEENER ON REEN NOW THAT HE WAS GETTING SOME MUCH ATTENTION, AND WAS MAKING A POINT OF TALKING TO HIM EVERY TIME THEY PASSED IN THE HALLWAYS. I COULD VE TAKEN THESE MORTHELS ANY TIME I WANTED.

WHAT WERE YOU GOING TO DO, SNIFF AT THEM? SAID HERMIONE WASPISHLY. PEOPLE HAD BEEN TEASING HER SOME MUCH ABOUT BEING THE THING THAT VICTOR CRUMB WOULD MOST MISS THAT SHE WAS IN A RATHER TETCHY MOOD.

REEN'S EARS WENT RED, AND HE REVERTED THEREAFTER TO THE BEWITCHED-SLEEP VERSION OF EVENTS.

AS THEY ENTERED MARCH THE WEATHER BECAME DRIER, BUT COLD  
WINDS SKINNED THEIR HANDS AND FACES EVERY TIME THEY WENT OUT

PADFOOT RETURNS THE

IN THE GREENS. THERE WERE DELAYS IN THE POST BECAUSE THE  
HILLS KEPT BEING KEENED OFF COURSE. THE GREEN HILL THAT HARRY  
HAD SENT THE SIRILS WITH THE DATES OF THE HIGSMERE WEEKEND  
TURNED UP AT BREAKFAST ON FRIDAY MORNING WITH HALF ITS FEATHERS  
STICKING UP THE WRONG WAY. HARRY HAD NEVER SEEN THEM OFF  
SIRILS REPLY THAN IT THEIR FLIGHT, CLEARLY AFRAID IT WAS GOING TO BE  
SENT HILLSIDE AGAIN.

SIRILS LETTER WAS ALMOST AS SHORT AS THE PREVIOUS ONE.

BE AT STILL AT END OF ROAD HILL OF HIGSMERE (PAST DORRIS &  
RANGES) AT TWO O'CLOCK ON SATURDAY AFTERNOON, BRING AS MUCH  
FIRE AS YOU CAN.

HE HADN'T COME BACK THE HIGSMERE? SAID RICH INCREDULOUSLY.

IT LOOKS LIKE IT, DOESN'T IT? SAID HERMIONE.

I CAN'T BELIEVE HIM, SAID HARRY TENSELY. IF HE'S CALLED ...

MADE IT SO FAR, THOUGH, HADN'T HE? SAID RICH. AND IT'S NOT LIKE  
THE PLACE IS SWARMING WITH DEMENTORS ANY MORE.

HARRY PICKED UP THE LETTER, THINKING. IF HE WAS HONEST WITH  
HIMSELF, HE REALLY WANTED TO SEE SIRILS AGAIN. HE THEREFORE  
APPROACHED THE FINAL LESSON OF THE AFTERNOON DEAR PETER

FEELING CONSIDERABLY MORE CHEERFUL THAN HE USUALLY DID WHEN  
DESCENDING THE STEPS TO THE DUNGEONS.

MALFOY, CRABBE AND GOYLE WERE STANDING IN A Huddle HILLSIDE  
THE CLASSROOM DOOR WITH PANSY PARKINSON'S GANG OF SLYTHERIN

GIRLS. ALL OF THEM WERE LOOKING AT SOMETHING HARRY COULDN'T SEE AND SNIGGERING HEARTILY. PANSY'S PLUG-LIKE FACE PEERED EXCITEDLY AROUND GEORGE'S BROAD BACK AS HARRY, RON AND HERMIONE APPROACHED.

THERE THEY ARE, THERE THEY ARE! SHE GIGGLED, AND THE KNIT OF SLYTHERINS BROKE APART. HARRY SAW THAT PANSY HAD A MAGAZINE IN HER HANDS. WITCH WEEKLY. THE MOVING PICTURE ON THE FRONT SHOWED A CURLY-HAired WITCH WHO WAS SMILING TEETHILY AND POINTING AT A LARGE SPINCE CASE WITH HER WAND.

YELL MIGHT FIND SOMETHING THE INTEREST YELL IN THERE, CRANGER!

\*\*\* HARRY PEEETTER

PANSY SAID LELDLY, AND SHE THREW THE MAGAZINE AT HERMIONE, WHO CALGHT IT, LOOKING STARTLED. AT THAT MEMENT, THE DINGEEN DHEER HPENED, AND SNAPE RECKENED THEM ALL INSIDE.

HERMIONE, HARRY AND RON HEADED FER A TABLE AT THE BACK OF THE DINGEEN AS USUAL. HENC SNAPE HAD TURNED HIS BACK HEN THEM THE WRITE UP THE INGREDIENTS OF TODAY'S POTION HEN

THE BLACKBOARD, HERMIONE HASTILY RIFFLED THROUGH THE MAGAZINE UNDER THE DESK. AT LAST, IN THE CENTRE PAGES, HERMIONE

FOUND WHAT THEY WERE LOOKING FER. HARRY AND RON LEANT IN CLESER. A CIRCULAR PHOTOGRAPH OF HARRY HEADED A SHORT PIECE ENTITLED HARRY PEEETTER'S SECRET EXARTACTE:

A KEE LIKE NE EITHER, PERHAPS YET A KEE SLIPPERING ALL THE USUAL PANGES OF ADELESCENCE, WRITES RITA SWEETER, DEPRIVED OF

LIVE SINCE THE TRAGIC DEMISE OF HIS PARENTS, FIFTEEN-YEAR-OLD

HARRY POTTER THOUGHT HE HAD FOUND LOVE IN HIS STEADY GIRL-  
FRIEND AT HOGWARTS, MUGGLE-BORN HERMIONE GRANGER. LITTLE

DID HE KNOW THAT HE WOULD SHORTLY BE SLIPPING YET ANOTHER  
EMOTIONAL KICK IN A LIFE ALREADY LITTERED WITH PERSONAL LOSS.

MISS GRANGER, A PLAIN BUT AMBITIOUS GIRL, SEEMS TO HAVE A  
TASTE FOR FANCY WIZARDS THAT HARRY ALONE CANNOT SATISFY.

SINCE THE ARRIVAL AT HOGWARTS OF VICTOR KRM, BILGARIA  
SEDER AND HERON OF THE LAST WORLD ELIDITCH CLIP, MISS

GRANGER HAS BEEN TRYING WITH BOTH BOYS AFFECTIONS. KRM,  
WHICH IS OPENLY SMITTEN WITH THE DEVILISH MISS GRANGER, HAS  
ALREADY INVITED HER TO VISIT HIM IN BILGARIA OVER THE SUMMER  
HOLIDAYS, AND INSISTS THAT HE HAS NEVER FELT THIS WAY ABOUT  
ANY OTHER GIRL ,

HOWEVER, IT MIGHT NOT BE MISS GRANGER'S DELICATE NATURAL  
CHARMS WHICH HAVE CAPTURED THESE UNFORTUNATE BOYS' INTEREST.

SHE'S REALLY NICE, SAYS PANSY PARKINSON, A PRETTY AND VIVA-  
CIOUS FIFTEEN-YEAR STUDENT, BUT SHE'D BE WELL UP TO MAKING A

LOVE POTTER, SHE'S WHITE BRAIN. I THINK THAT I FEEL SHE'S DOING  
IT.

LOVE POTTERS ARE OF COURSE BANNED AT HOGWARTS, AND NEW

PADRETT RITLINGS 445

DEEJET ARLIS DUMKEDDRE WILL WANT TO INVESTIGATE THESE CLAIMS. IN THE MEANTIME, HARRY POTTER & WELL-WISHERS MUST HOPE THAT, NEXT TIME, HE BESTOWS HIS HEART UPON A WORTHIER CANDIDATE.

I TOLD YOU! RHN GLANCED AT HERMIONE, AS SHE STARED DOWN AT THE ARTICLE. I TOLD YOU NOT TO ASK RITA SKEETER! SHE & MADE YOU BELT THE EE SHIR SHIR EE EE SCARLET WEEMAN! HERMIONE STOPPED BREATHING ASTONISHED AND SNORTED WITH LAUGHTER.

SCARLET WEEMAN! SHE REPEATED, SHAKING WITH SUPPRESSED GIGGLES AS SHE BREATHED BEHIND AT RHN.

IT & WHAT MY MUM CALLS THEM, RHN MUTTERED, HIS EARS GLOWING RED AGAIN.

IF THAT & THE BEST RITA CAN DO, SHE & BEING HER THICK, SAID HERMIONE, STILL GIGGLING, AS SHE THREW WITCH WEEKLY BENTH THE EMPTY CHAIR BESIDE HER. WHAT A PILE OF HED BLISSFUL. SHE BREATHED EVER AT THE SLOTHERINS, WHO WERE ALL WATCHING HER AND HARRY CLOSELY ACROSS THE ROOM TO SEE IF THEY HAD BEEN UPSET BY THE ARTICLE. HERMIONE GAVE THEM A SARCASTIC SMILE AND A WAVE, AND SHE, HARRY AND RHN STARTED LINPACKING THE INGREDIENTS THEY WOULD NEED FOR THEIR WIT-SHARPENING POTION.

THERE & SOMETHING FLIPPY, THOUGH, SAID HERMIONE TEN MINUTES LATER, HOLDING HER PESTLE SUSPENDED OVER A BOWL OF SCARAB

BEETLES. ~~THE~~ CHILD RITA SKEETER HAD KNOWN ...?

KNOWN WHAT? SAID RHN ENLIDLY. SHE HAVEN T BEEN MIXING  
UP LOVE PETITIONS, HAVE SHE?

WHEN T BE STUPID, HERMINE SNAPPED, STARTING THE POUND UP  
HER BEETLES AGAIN. NO, IT S ILST ... SHE DID SHE KNOW VICTOR  
ASKED ME THE VISIT HIM EVER THE SUMMER?

HERMINE BLUSHED SCARLET AS SHE SAID THIS, AND DETERMINEDLY  
AVOIDED RHN S EYES.

WHAT? SAID RHN, DRIPPING HIS PESTLE WITH A HEAVY CLUNK.

HE ASKED ME RIGHT AFTER HE D PULLED ME OUT OF THE LAKE,

~~THE~~ HARRY POTTER

HERMINE MUTTERED. AFTER HE D GET RID OF HIS SHARD S HEAD.

MADAM POMFREY GAVE US BOTH BLANKETS AND THEN HE SHUT UP

PULLED ME AWAY FROM THE JUDGES SHE THEY WOULDNT T HEAR, AND HE  
SAID, IF I WASN T DOING ANYTHING EVER THE SUMMER, WOULD I LIKE  
THE

AND WHAT DID SHE SAY? SAID RHN, WHO HAD PICKED UP HIS  
PESTLE AND WAS GRINDING IT ON THE DESK, A GOOD SIX INCHES FROM  
HIS KNEE, BECAUSE HE WAS WHISKING AT HERMINE.

AND HE DID SAY HE D NEVER FELT THE SAME WAY ABOUT ANYONE  
ELSE, HERMINE WENT ON, GOING SHE RED WHEN THAT HARRY CHILD  
ALMOST FELT THE HEAT COMING FROM HER, BUT CHILD RITA  
SKEETER HAD HEARD HIM? SHE WASN T THERE ... HE WAS SHE?  
MAYBE SHE HAS GET AN INVISIBILITY CLOAK, MAYBE SHE SNEAKED  
INTO THE GREENS THE WATCH THE SECOND TASK ...



AND WHAT DID YELL SAY? RON REPEATED, POUNDING HIS PESTLE  
BEHIND HIS HAND THAT IT DENTED THE DESK.

WELL, I WAS THEN BUSY SEEING WHETHER YELL AND HARRY WERE  
END THE

FASCINATING THOUGH YELLER SOCIAL LIFE UNDEVELOPEDLY IS, MISS  
GRANGER, SAID AN ICE VEIL RIGHT BEHIND THEM. I MUST ASK YELL  
WHY THE DISCUSS IT IN MY CLASS. TEN PHOTOS FROM GRYFFINDOR.  
SNAPE HAD GLIDED OVER THE THEIR DESK WHILE THEY HAD BEEN  
TALKING. THE WHOLE CLASS WAS NOW LOOKING AROUND AT THEM;  
MALFOY TOOK THE OPPORTUNITY THE FLASH PHOTO STROBES ACROSS  
THE DUNGEON AT HARRY.

AM ... READING MAGAZINES UNDER THE TABLE AS WELL? SNAPE  
ADDED, SNATCHING UP THE COPY OF WITCH WEEKLY. A FURTHER TEN  
PHOTOS FROM GRYFFINDOR ... EH, BUT OF COURSE ... SNAPE'S BLACK  
EYES GLITTERED AS THEY FELL ON RITA SKEETER'S ARTICLE. PETER HAS THE  
DEEP LIP WITH HIS PRESS CUTTINGS ...

THE DUNGEON RANG WITH THE SLYTHERINS LAUGHTER, AND AN  
UNPLEASANT SMILE CURLED SNAPE'S THIN MOUTH. THE HARRY'S FLIP, HE  
BEGAN TO READ THE ARTICLE ALOUD.

HARRY PETER'S SECRET HEARTACHE ... DEAR, DEAR, PETER, WHAT'S  
AILING YELL NOW? A KEY LIKE ME EITHER, PERHAPS ...

POPEST RETURNS ???

HARRY COULD FEEL HIS FACE BURNING NOW. SNAPE WAS PAUSING AT  
THE END OF EVERY SENTENCE TO ALLOW THE SLYTHERINS A HEARTY  
LAUGH. THE ARTICLE SOUNDED TEN TIMES WORSE WHEN READ BY  
SNAPE.

... HARRY POTTER'S WELL-WISHERS MUST HOPE THAT, NEXT TIME, HE

RESTHELS HIS HEART UPON A WINTERER CANDIDATE. FEEL VERY THICK-  
ING, SNEERED SNAPE, REELING UP THE MAGAZINE THE CONTINUED CALES

HE LAUGHTER FROM THE SLOTHERINS. WELL, I THINK I HAD BETTER SEPA-  
RATE THE THREE OF YELL, SEE YELL CAN KEEP YELLER MINDS BEN YELLER

PETHENS RATHER THAN YELLER TANGLED LEVE LIVES. LEASLEY, YELL STAY  
HERE, MISS GRANGER, EVER THERE, RESIDE MISS PARKINSON, POTTER  
THAT TABLE IN FRONT OF MY DESK, MEVE, NELL.

FLURIELS, HARRY THREW HIS INGREDIENTS AND HIS BAG INTO HIS  
CALIBREIN, AND DRAGGED IT UP THE THE FRONT OF THE DUNGREEN THE THE  
EMPTY TABLE. SNAPE FOLLOVED, SAT DOWN AT HIS DESK AND WATCHED  
HARRY LINGHED HIS CALIBREIN, DETERMINED NOT THE LEHED AT SNAPE,  
HARRY RESUMED THE MASHING OF HIS SCARAB BEETLES, IMAGINING  
EACH ONE THE HAVE SNAPE'S FACE.

ALL THIS PRESS ATTENTION SEEMS THE HAVE INFLATED YELLER ALREADY  
EVERLARGE HEAD, POTTER, SAID SNAPE ELIJETLY, SINCE THE REST OF THE  
CLASS HAD SETTLED DOWN AGAIN.

HARRY DIDN'T ANSWER, HE KNEW SNAPE WAS TRYING THE PREYHED  
HIM; HE HAD DONE THIS BEFORE, NEH BELIEF HE WAS HOPING FOR AN  
EXCLISE THE TAKE A REELING FIFTY POINTS FROM GRYFFINDOR BEFORE THE  
END OF THE CLASS.

YELL MIGHT BE LAURELING UNDER THE BELLSHEDN THAT THE ENTIRE  
WIZARDING WORLD IS IMPRESSED WITH YELL, SNAPE WENT BEN, SEE  
ELIJETLY THAT NEH ONE ELSE COULD HEAR HIM HARRY CONTINUED THE

POUND HIS SCARAB BEETLES, EVEN THOUGH HE HAD ALREADY REDUCED THEM TO A VERY FINE POWDER, BUT I DIDN'T CARE HOW MANY TIMES YOUR PICTURE APPEARS IN THE PAPERS. THE MR. POTTTER, YOU ARE NOTHING BUT A NASTY LITTLE BIRD WHEN CONSIDERS RULES THE RE BENEATH HIM.

HARRY TIPPED THE POWDERED BEETLES INTO HIS PALM AND STARTED CUTTING UP HIS GINGER BREADS. HIS HANDS WERE SHAKING

THE HARRY POTTTER

SLIGHTLY BUT HE ANGER, BUT HE KEPT HIS EYES DOWN, AS THOUGH HE COULDN'T HEAR WHAT SNAPE WAS SAYING TO HIM.

SEE I GIVE YOU FAIR WARNING, POTTTER, SNAPE CONTINUED, IN A SILENT AND MORE DANGEROUS VOICE, PINT-SIZED CELEBRITY HER NAME IF I CATCH YOU BREAKING INTO MY OFFICE ONE MORE TIME

I HAVEN'T BEEN ANYWHERE NEAR YOUR OFFICE? SAID HARRY ANGRILY, FORGETTING HIS FEIGNED DRAINNESS.

DIDN'T LIKE THE MR. SNAPE HISSED, HIS PAINFUL BLACK EYES BEARING INTO HARRY'S. RHINO SKIN, GILLYWEED, BIRTH CHARM FROM MY PRIVATE STORES, AND I KNOW WHEN STEAL THEM.

HARRY STARED BACK AT SNAPE, DETERMINED NOT TO BLINK, FOR THE LITTLE GUILTY. IN TRUTH, HE HADN'T STEALN EITHER OF THESE THINGS FROM SNAPE. HERMIONE HAD TAKEN THE RHINO SKIN BACK IN THEIR SECOND YEAR THEY HAD NEEDED IT FOR THE POLYGLITCH POTION

AND WHILE SNAPE HAD SUSPECTED HARRY AT THE TIME, HE HAD NEVER BEEN ABLE TO PROVE IT. DEER, HE COURSE, HAD STEALN THE GILLYWEED.

I DIDN'T KNOW WHAT YOU'RE TALKING ABOUT, HARRY LIED CHEERLY.

YELL WERE HLT HP KED HN THE NIGHT MY OFFICE WAS KIDNEN  
INTH? SNAPE HISSED, I KNEL IT, PETHER? NELL, MAD-EYE MURDER  
MIGHT HAVE IMINED YELLR FAN CLUE, BLT I WILL NOT THERATE YELLR  
RE-LAYTHELR? HNE MORE NIGHT-TIME STRELL INTH MY OFFICE, PETHER,  
AND YELL WILL PAY?

RIGHT, SAID HARRY CHELLY, TURNING BACK TH HIS GINGER REETS,  
I LL REAR THAT IN MIND IF I EVER GET THE LRGZ TH CH IN THERE.  
SNAPE S EYES FLASHED, HE PLINGED A HAND INTH THE INSIDE HP  
HIS BLACK REES. FER HNE WLD MEMENT, HARRY THELIGHT SNAPE  
WAS ABHLT TH PLL HLT HIS HAND AND CLUSE HIM THEN HE SAW  
THAT SNAPE HAD DRAWN HLT A SMALL CRYSTAL BOTTLE HP A COMPLETELY  
CLEAR PETHEN, HARRY STARED AT IT.

DE YELL KNEL WHAT THIS IS, PETHER? SNAPE SAID, HIS EYES GLIT-  
TERING DANGEROUSLY AGAIN.

NEH, SAID HARRY, COMPLETELY HENESTLY THIS TIME,  
IT IS VERITASERUM A TRUTH PETHEN SE PHEWERLH THAT THREE  
DREPS WOULD HAVE YELL SPILLING YELLR INNERMOST SECRETS AND THIS

PADPETH RETLIONS ???

ENTIRE CLASS TH HEAR, SAID SNAPE VICIOUSLY, NELL, THE LSK HP THIS  
PETHEN IS CENTRELLD BY VERY STRICT MINISTRY GUIDELINES, BLT  
UNLESS YELL WATCH YELLR STEP, YELL MIGHT ILST FIND THAT MY HAND  
SLIPS HE SEEMD THE CRYSTAL BOTTLE SLIGHTLY RIGHT EVER YELLR  
EVENING PLIMPOIN ILICE, AND THEN, PETHER ... THEN WE LL FIND HLT  
WHETHER YELL VE BEEN IN MY OFFICE OR NOT.

HARRY SAID NOTHING. HE TURNED BACK TO HIS GINGER BEETS AND  
MERE, PICKED UP HIS KNIFE AND STARTED SLICING THEM AGAIN. HE  
DIDN'T LIKE THE SOUND OF THAT TRUTH BEETEN AT ALL, AND WHEN HE  
HE PUT IT PAST SNAPE HE SLIP HIM SOME. HE REPOSED A SLIDDER  
AT THE THOUGHT OF WHAT MIGHT COME SPILLING OUT OF HIS MOUTH IF  
SNAPE DID ... WHITE APART FROM LANDING A WHITE LIP OF PEOPLE IN  
TRIBLE ... HERMION AND DICKY, FOR A START THERE WERE ALL THE  
OTHER THINGS HE WAS CONCEALING ... LIKE THE FACT THAT HE WAS IN  
CONTACT WITH SIRIUS ... AND HIS INSIDES SHOOK AT THE  
THOUGHT WHEN HE FELT ABOUT THE ... HE TIPPED HIS GINGER BEETS  
INTO THE CALIBREIN TUB, AND WANDERED WHETHER HE MIGHT TAKE  
A LEAF OUT OF MURDER'S KITCHEN AND START DRINKING ONLY FROM A PRI-  
VATE HIP-FLASK.

THERE WAS A KNOCK ON THE DUNGEON DOOR.

ENTER, SAID SNAPE, IN HIS USUAL VOICE.

THE CLASS MOVED AROUND AS THE DOOR OPENED. PROFESSOR  
KARABOOS CAME IN. EVERYONE WATCHED HIM AS HE WALKED UP  
TOWARDS SNAPE'S DESK. HE WAS TWISTING HIS FINGER AROUND HIS  
CHEATER AGAIN, AND BEING AGITATED.

WE NEED THE TALK, SAID KARABOOS ABRUPTLY, WHEN HE HAD  
REACHED SNAPE. HE SEEMED SO DETERMINED THAT NEITHER SHOULD  
HEAR WHAT HE WAS SAYING THAT HE WAS RARELY OPENING HIS LIPS; IT  
WAS AS THOUGH HE WAS A RATHER POOR VENTRILOQUIST. HARRY KEPT  
HIS EYES ON HIS GINGER BEETS, LISTENING HARD.

I'LL TALK THE WHOLE AFTER MY LESSON, KARABOOS SNAPE MUTTERED,

BUT KARKAROFF INTERRUPTED HIM.

I WANT THE TALK DONE, WHILE YOU CAN'T SLIP OFF, SEVERUS, YOU'VE BEEN AVOIDING ME.

AFTER THE LESSON, SNAPE SNAPPED.

AND HARRY PETER

UNDER THE PRETEXT OF HOLDING UP A MEASURING CLIP TO SEE IF

HE'D PHILLED HIM ENOUGH ARMADILLO RILE, HARRY SNEAKED A SIDE-GLANCE AT THE PAIR OF THEM. KARKAROFF BEHEDED EXTREMELY

WHIRLED, AND SNAPE BEHEDED ANGRY.

KARKAROFF HEMMED BEHIND SNAPE'S DESK FOR THE REST OF THE DELICATE PERIOD, HE SEEMED INTENT ON PREVENTING SNAPE SLIPPING AWAY AT THE END OF CLASS. EVEN THE HEAR WHAT KARKAROFF WANTED TO SAY, HARRY DELIBERATELY KNEELED OVER HIS KETTLE OF ARMADILLO RILE WITH TWO MINUTES TO GO THE THE BELL, WHICH GAVE HIM AN EXCISE THE BLACK DOWN BEHIND HIS CALIBREIN AND PHEP UP WHILE THE REST OF THE CLASS MOVED NEUTRALLY TOWARDS THE DEER.

WHAT'S SHE URGENT? HE HEARD SNAPE HISS AT KARKAROFF.

THIS, SAID KARKAROFF, AND HARRY, PEERING AROUND THE EDGE OF HIS CALIBREIN, SAW KARKAROFF PULL UP THE LEFT-HAND SLEEVE OF HIS RUBE, AND SEEN SNAPE SOMETHING IN HIS INNER ARM.

WELL? SAID KARKAROFF, STILL MAKING EVERY EFFORT NOT TO MOVE HIS LIPS. DO YOU SEE? IT'S NEVER BEEN THIS CLEAR, NEVER SINCE PUT IT AWAY! SNARLED SNAPE, HIS BLACK EYES SWEEPING THE

CLASSROOM.

BUT WHO MUST HAVE NOTICED DARRABHFF BEGAN IN AN AGITATED VEHICLE.

WE CAN TALK LATER, DARRABHFF! SPAT SNAPE. BETTER! WHAT ARE YOU DOING?

CLEARING UP MY ARMADILLO KIL, PROFESSOR, SAID HARRY INNOCENTLY, STRAIGHTENING UP AND FEELING SNAPE THE SHEDDEN BAG HE WAS HOLDING.

DARRABHFF TURNED ON HIS HEEL AND STRODE OUT OF THE DINING-HALL. HE WALKED WITH WHIRLED AND ANGRY, NOT WANTING TO REMAIN ALONE WITH AN EXCEPTIONALLY ANGRY SNAPE. HARRY THREW HIS BOOKS AND INGREDIENTS BACK INTO HIS BAG, AND LEFT AT THE SPEED HE TELL RON AND HERMIONIE WHAT HE HAD JUST WITNESSED.

\*

THEY LEFT THE CASTLE AT DAWN THE NEXT DAY TO FIND A LEAD SILVER SUN SHINING DOWN UPON THE GREENLANDS. THE WEATHER WAS MILD

ADOLENT RETURNS 451

THAN IT HAD BEEN ALL YEAR, AND BY THE TIME THEY ARRIVED IN HOGSMOOR, ALL THREE OF THEM HAD TAKEN OFF THEIR CLOAKS AND THROWN THEM OVER THEIR SHOULDERS. THE GOOD SIRIUS HAD TOLD THEM THE BRINE WAS IN HARRY'S BAG; THEY HAD SNEAKED A DOZEN CHICKEN LEGS, A LOAF OF BREAD AND A PLASK OF PLIMPOIN ILIKE FROM

THE LUNCH TABLE.

THEY WENT INTO CLADRAGS WIZARDWEAR THE BUY A PRESENT FOR  
DORRIS, WHERE THEY HAD BEEN SELECTING ALL THE FINEST LIRID SHIRTS  
THEY COULD FIND, INCLUDING A PAIR PATTERNED WITH FLASHING GOLD  
AND SILVER STARS, AND ANOTHER THAT SCREAMED LOUDLY WHEN THEY  
BECAME TOO SMELLY. THEN, AT HALF PAST ONE, THEY MADE THEIR WAY  
UP THE HIGH STREET, PAST DORRIS AND RANGES, AND WENT TOWARDS  
THE EDGE OF THE VILLAGE.

HARRY HAD NEVER BEEN IN THIS DIRECTION BEFORE. THE WINDING  
LANE WAS LEADING THEM WENT INTO THE WILD COUNTRYSIDE AROUND  
HOGSMOOR. THE COTTAGES WERE FEWER HERE, AND THEIR GARDENS  
LARGER; THEY WERE WALKING TOWARDS THE FOOT OF THE MOUNTAIN IN  
WHICH SHADEN HOGSMOOR LAY. THEN THEY TURNED A CORNER, AND  
SAW A STILE AT THE END OF THE LANE. WAITING FOR THEM, ITS FRONT  
PAWS ON THE THIRTIETH BAR, WAS A VERY LARGE, SHAGGY BLACK DOG,  
WHICH WAS CARRYING SOME NEWSPAPERS IN ITS MOUTH, AND  
LOOKED VERY FAMILIAR ...

WELL, SIRIUS, SAID HARRY, WHEN THEY HAD REACHED HIM.  
THE BLACK DOG SNIPPED HARRY'S BAG EAGERLY, WAGGED ITS TAIL  
HAPPY, THEN TURNED, AND BEGAN THE TRIP AWAY FROM THEM ACROSS  
THE SCRUBBY PATCH OF GROUND WHICH WAS THE MEET THE RICHES FOOT  
OF THE MOUNTAIN. HARRY, RON AND HERMION CLIMBED OVER THE  
STILE AND FOLLOWED.

SIRIUS LED THEM TO THE VERY FOOT OF THE MOUNTAIN, WHERE  
THE GROUND WAS COVERED WITH HILLOCKS AND RIDGES. IT WAS EASY  
FOR HIM, WITH HIS FLUR PAWS, BUT HARRY, RON AND HERMION  
WERE SHOWN WENT OF BREATH. THEY FOLLOWED SIRIUS HIGHER, UP



BENTH THE MOUNTAIN ITSELF, FOR NEARLY HALF AN HOUR THEY  
CLIMBED A STEEP, WINDING AND STONY PATH, FOLLOWING  
SIRIL'S WAGGING TAIL, SWEATING IN THE SUN, THE SHOULDERS

AND HARRY PATTED

STRAPS OF HARRY'S BAG CUTTING INTO HIS SHOULDERS.

THEN, AT LAST, SIRIL'S SLIPPED OUT OF SIGHT, AND WHEN THEY  
REACHED THE PLACE WHERE HE HAD VANISHED, THEY SAW A NARROW

FISSURE IN THE ROCK. THEY SQUEEZED INTO IT, AND FOUND THEM-  
SELVES IN A COLD, DIMLY LIT CAVE. TETHERED AT THE END OF IT, HENCE

END OF HIS REEF AROUND A LARGE ROCK, WAS BLACKBEAD THE  
HIPPOGRIPP, HALF-GRAY HORSE, HALF-GIANT EAGLE, BLACKBEAD'S FIERCE  
ORANGE EYE FLASHED AT THE SIGHT OF THEM. ALL THREE OF THEM  
BEHELD HIM THEN, AND AFTER REGARDING THEM IMPERIOUSLY FOR A  
MOMENT, BLACKBEAD BENT HIS STALY FRONT BOWERS, AND ALLOWED  
JERMIANE TO RUSH FORWARD AND STROKE HIS FEATHERY NECK. HARRY,  
HOWEVER, WAS LOOKING AT THE BLACK BE, WHICH HAD JUST TURNED  
INTO HIS GROOMFATHER.

SIRIL'S WAS WEARING RAGGED GRAY RINGS; THE SAME RINGS HE  
HAD BEEN WEARING WHEN HE HAD LEFT AZERAN. HIS BLACK HAIR  
WAS LONGER THAN IT HAD BEEN WHEN HE HAD APPEARED IN THE  
FIRE, AND IT WAS UNTIDY AND MATTED SINCE THEN. HE LOOKED VERY  
THIN.

"HICKEN!" HE SAID BARSLEY, AFTER REMOVING THE OLD DAILY  
PROPHETS FROM HIS MOUTH AND THROWING THEM DOWN BENTH THE

CAVE FLEHER,

HARRY PULLED OPEN HIS BAG AND HANDED OVER THE BUNDLE OF  
CHICKEN LEGS AND BREAD.

THANKS, SAID SIRILIS, OPENING IT, GRABBING A BREADSTICK, SIT-  
TING DOWN IN THE CAVE FLEHER AND TEARING OFF A LARGE CHUNK WITH

HIS TEETH. I'VE BEEN LIVING OFF RATS MOSTLY, CAN'T STEAL THEM MUCH  
FURTHER FROM THE CSMAD; I'D DRAW ATTENTION TO MYSELF.

HE GRINNED UP AT HARRY, BUT HARRY RETURNED THE GRIN ONLY  
RELUCTANTLY.

WHAT ARE YOU DOING HERE, SIRILIS? HE SAID.

FULFILLING MY DUTY AS GODFATHER, SAID SIRILIS, CHAWING IN THE  
CHICKEN BONE IN A VERY DUC-LIKE WAY. DON'T WORRY ABOUT ME,  
I'M PRETENDING TO BE A LEAVEABLE STRAY.

HE WAS STILL GRINNING, BUT SEEING THE ANXIETY IN HARRY'S FACE,  
SAID MORE SERIOUSLY, I WANT TO BE IN THE SPOT. YOUR LAST LETTER ...

POPEEET RETURNS YIK

WELL, LET'S JUST SAY THINGS ARE GETTING FISHIER. I'VE BEEN STEALING  
THE PAPER EVERY TIME SOMEONE THROWS ONE AWAY, AND BY THE  
LOOKS OF THINGS, I'M NOT THE ONLY ONE WHO'S GETTING WORRIED.  
HE NODDED AT THE YELLOWING DAILY PROPHECIES IN THE CAVE FLEHER,  
AND THEN PICKED THEM UP AND UNFOLDED THEM.

HARRY, HOWEVER, CONTINUED TO STARE AT SIRILIS. WHAT IF THEY  
CATCH YOU? WHAT IF YOU'RE SEEN?

YOU THERE AND DUMKEDHERE ARE THE ONLY ONES BEHIND HERE

WITH KNOW I'M AN ANIMAGUS, SAID SIRIUS, STRUGGLING, AND CHINTLING THE DEVIL ON THE CHICKEN LEG.

RON NODDED HARRY, AND PASSED HIM THE DAILY PROPHETS. THERE WERE THREE: THE FIRST HAD THE HEADLINE MYSTERY ILLNESS OF KARTHEILIS CRUELICH, THE SECOND, MINISTRY WITCH STILL MISSING MINISTER FOR MAGIC NOW PERSONALLY INVOLVED.

HARRY LOOKED DOWN THE STORY ABOUT CRUELICH, PHRASES JUMPED OUT AT HIM: HASN'T BEEN SEEN IN PUBLIC SINCE NOVEMBER ... HOUSE APPEARS DESERTED ... ST MUNGUS'S HOSPITAL FOR MAGICAL MALADIES

DECLINE COMMENT ... MINISTRY REFUSES TO CONFIRM RUMOURS OF CRITICAL ILLNESS ...

THEY'RE MAKING IT SOUND LIKE HE'S DYING, SAID HARRY SLEEWY,

BUT HE CAN'T BE THAT ILL IF HE MANAGED TO GET UP HERE ...

MY BROTHER'S CRUELICH'S PERSONAL ASSISTANT, RON INFORMED SIRIUS. HE SAYS CRUELICH IS SUFFERING FROM EVERYTHING.

MIND YOU, HE DID LOOK ILL, LAST TIME I SAW HIM UP CLOSE, SAID HARRY SLEEWY, STILL READING THE STORY. THE NIGHT MY NAME CAME OUT OF THE GAZETTE ...

GETTING HIS CHEMLOPPANCE FOR SACKING WINDY, ISN'T HE? SAID HERMIONE COLDLY. SHE WAS STRETCHING KICKLEAD, WITH WAS CRUNCHING UP SIRIUS' CHICKEN BONES. I BET HE WISHES HE HADN'T DONE IT NOW. BUT HE FEELS THE DIFFERENCE NOW SHE'S NOT THERE TO LOOK AFTER HIM.

HERMINE S MESSED WITH HERSE-ELVES, THEN PLITTERED THE  
SIRILS, CASTING HERMINE A DARK LOOK.

SIRILS, HOWEVER, LOOKED INTERESTED, CRICKS SACKED HIS  
HERSE-ELF?

254 HARRY PITTER

YEAH, AT THE ELIDITCH WERLD CLIP, SAID HARRY, AND HE  
LAUNCHED INTO THE STORY OF THE DARK MARK S APPEARANCE, AND  
WINDY BEING HELD WITH HARRY S HAND CLITCHED IN HER HAND,  
AND MR CRICKS S FLIP.

WHEN HARRY HAD FINISHED, SIRILS WAS ON HIS FEET AGAIN, AND  
HAD STARTED PACING UP AND DOWN THE CAVE. LET ME GET THIS  
STRAIGHT, HE SAID AFTER A WHILE, BRANDISHING A FRESH CHICKEN LEG.  
YELL FIRST SAW THE ELF IN THE THEP KEE, SHE WAS SAYING CRICKS A  
SEAT, RIGHT?

RIGHT, SAID HARRY, THEN AND HERMINE TOGETHER.

BUT CRICKS DIDN T TURN UP FOR THE MATCH?

NEH, SAID HARRY, I THINK HE SAID HE D BEEN THEE KISSY.

SIRILS PACED ALL AROUND THE CAVE IN SILENCE. THEN HE SAID,

HARRY, DID YELL CHECK YELLR POCKETS FOR YELLR HAND AFTER YELL D  
LEFT THE THEP KEE?

ERM ... HARRY TEEHUGHT HAD, NEH, HE SAID FINALLY, I DIDN T  
NEED THE LISK IT BEHRE WE GET IN THE PHREST. AND THEN I PUT MY  
HAND IN MY POCKET, AND ALL THAT WAS IN THERE WERE MY  
EMPHILARS. HE STARED AT SIRILS. ARE YELL SAYING WHEREVER  
CHILURED THE MARK STEAL MY HAND IN THE THEP KEE?

IT S POSSIBLE, SAID SIRILS.

WINDY DIDN'T STEAL THAT LAND? SAID HERMIONE STIRILLY.

THE ELF WASN'T THE ONLY ONE IN THAT ROOM, SAID SIRILIS, HIS EYES FLINCHED AS HE CONTINUED THE PACE. WHO ELSE WAS SITTING BEHIND YOU?

LEADS OF PEOPLE, SAID HARRY. SOME BULGARIAN MINISTERS ...  
CORNELIUS FUDGE ... THE MALFOYS ...

THE MALFOYS? SAID BEN SUDDENLY, SHE WHISPERED THAT HIS VOICE  
ECHOED ALL AROUND THE LAKE, AND KIDDERHEAD THESSED HIS HEAD  
NERVOUSLY. I BET IT WAS LUCIUS MALFOY?

ANYONE ELSE? SAID SIRILIS.

NO ONE, SAID HARRY.

YES, THERE WAS, THERE WAS LUDIE BAGMAN, HERMIONE REMIND-  
ED HIM.

EH, YES ...

PROFESSOR RETLINGS WAS

I DIDN'T KNOW ANYTHING ABOUT BAGMAN, EXCEPT THAT HE LIED THE  
BE BEATER FOR THE WIMBORNE WASPS, SAID SIRILIS, STILL PACING.  
WHAT'S HE LIKE?

HE'S OLD, SAID HARRY, HE KEEPS OFFERING THE HELP ME WITH THE  
TRILIZARD TOURNAMENT.

DOES HE, REALLY? SAID SIRILIS, FROWNING MORE DEEPLY. I WONDER  
WHY HE'D DO THAT?

SAYS HE'S TAKEN A LIKING THE ME, SAID HARRY.

YMM, SAID SIRILIS, LEERING TRULIGHTFUL.

WE SAW HIM IN THE FOREST JUST BEFORE THE DARK MARD  
APPEARED, HERMINE TOLD SIRILIS, REMEMBER? SHE SAID THE HARRY  
AND REN.

YES, BUT HE DIDN'T STAY IN THE FOREST, DID HE? SAID REN. THE

MOMENT WE TOLD HIM ABOUT THE RIFT, HE WENT OFF THE CAMP-  
SITE.

HOW DO YOU KNOW? HERMINE SHEET BACK. HOW DO YOU KNOW  
WHERE HE DISAPPEARED THE

CAME OFF IT, SAID REN INCREDULOUSLY, ARE YOU SAYING YOU  
RECOGNIZED RAGMAN CHAINED THE DARK MARD?

IT'S MORE LIKELY HE DID IT THAN WINDY, SAID HERMINE STILL-  
SERIOUSLY.

TOLD YOU, SAID REN, LOOKING MEANINGFULLY AT SIRILIS, TOLD  
YOU SHE'S OBSESSED WITH FELIX

BUT SIRILIS HELD UP A HAND TO THE SILENCE REN. WHEN THE DARK  
MARD HAD BEEN CHAINED, AND THE ELF HAD BEEN DISCOVERED  
HOLDING HARRY'S HAND, WHAT DID CRUELICH DO?

WENT THE WOOD IN THE BUSHES, SAID HARRY, BUT THERE WASN'T  
ANYONE ELSE THERE.

OF COURSE, SIRILIS MUTTERED, PACING UP AND DOWN, OF COURSE,  
HE'D WANT TO PIN IT ON ANYONE BUT HIS OWN ELF ... AND THEN HE  
SACKED HER?

YES, SAID HERMINE IN A HEATED WHISPER, HE SACKED HER, JUST

BECAUSE SHE HADN'T STAYED IN HER TENT AND LET HERSELF GET TRAMPLED

HERMIONE WILL YOU GIVE IT A REST WITH THE ELF? SAID REEN.

THE HARRY BETTER

BUT SIRILIS SHOOK HIS HEAD AND SAID, SHE'S GOT THE MEASURE OF CREECH BETTER THAN YOU HAVE, REEN. IF YOU WANT TO KNOW WHAT A MAN'S LIKE, TAKE A GOOD LOOK AT HOW HE TREATS HIS INFERIORS, NOT HIS ENEMIES.

HE RAN A HAND OVER HIS UNSHAVEN FACE, EVIDENTLY THINKING HARD. ALL THESE ABSENCES OF BARTY CREECH'S ... HE GUESSES THE TERRIBLE OF MAKING SURE HIS FELLOW-ELF SAVES HIM A SEAT AT THE ELWIDITCH WARD CUP, BUT DOESN'T EITHER THE TURN UP AND WATCH. HE WORKS VERY HARD TO REINSTATE THE TRIWIZARD TOURNAMENT, AND THEN STEPS CHIMING THE THAT, THEN ... IT'S NOT LIKE CREECH. IF HE'S EVER TAKEN A DAY OFF WORK BECAUSE OF ILLNESS BEFORE THIS, I'LL EAT BUCKLEBREAD.

DO YOU KNOW CREECH, THEN? SAID HARRY.

SIRILIS' FACE DARKENED. HE SUDDENLY LOOKED AS MENACING AS THE NIGHT WHEN HARRY HAD FIRST MET HIM, THE NIGHT WHEN HARRY HAD STILL BELIEVED SIRILIS TO BE A MURDERER.

HEH, I KNOW CREECH ALL RIGHT, HE SAID QUIETLY. HE WAS THE ONE WHO GAVE THE ORDER FOR ME TO BE SENT TO AZKABAN WITHOUT A TRIAL.

WHAT? SAID REEN AND HERMIONE TOGETHER.

THEY'RE KIDDING! SAID HARRY.

NEH, I'M NOT, SAID SIRILUS, TAKING ANOTHER GREAT BITE OF CHICK-  
EN. CRELLICH USED TO BE HEAD OF THE DEPARTMENT OF MAGICAL LAW

ENFORCEMENT, DIDN'T YOU KNOW?

HARRY, RON AND HERMIONE SHOOK THEIR HEADS.

HE WAS TIPPED AS THE NEXT MINISTER FOR MAGIC, SAID SIRILUS.

HE'S A GREAT WIZARD, BARTY CRELLICH, POWERFULLY MAGICAL AND

POWER-FILING. EH, NEVER A VERDMEERT SLIPPERTER, HE SAID, READ-  
ING THE LETTER IN HARRY'S FACE. NEH, BARTY CRELLICH WAS ALWAYS VERY

HELSPECKEN AGAINST THE DARK SIDE. BUT THEN A LOT OF PEOPLE WHO  
WERE AGAINST THE DARK SIDE ... WELL, YOU WOULDN'T UNDERSTAND  
... YOU'RE TOO YOUNG ...

THAT'S WHAT MY DAD SAID AT THE WERLD CLIP, SAID RON, WITH  
A TRACE OF IRRITATION IN HIS VOICE. TRY US, WHY DON'T YOU?  
A GRIN FLASHED ACROSS SIRILUS' THIN FACE. ALL RIGHT, I'LL TRY YOU ...

POWHEET RETLIONS AS?

HE WALKED BACK UP THE LAVE, BACK AGAIN, AND THEN SAID,

IMAGINE THAT VERDMEERT'S POWERFUL NEH. YOU DON'T KNOW WHO  
HIS SLIPPERTERS ARE, YOU DON'T KNOW WHO'S WORKING FOR HIM AND

WHO ISN'T? YOU KNOW HE CAN CONTROL PEOPLE SEE THAT THEY DO TER-  
RIBLE THINGS WITHOUT BEING ABLE TO STOP THEMSELVES. YOU'RE



STARTED FOR THEMSELVES, AND THEIR FAMILY, AND THEIR FRIENDS. EVERY WEEK, NEWS CAME OF MORE DEATHS, MORE DISAPPEARANCES, MORE THREATLING ... THE MINISTRY OF MAGIC WAS IN DISARRAY, THEY DIDN'T KNOW WHAT TO DO, THEY WERE TRYING TO KEEP EVERYTHING HIDDEN FROM THE MUGGLES, BUT MEANWHILE, MUGGLES WERE DYING THEM. TERROR EVERYWHERE ... PANIC ... CHAOS ... THAT'S HOW IT WAS THEN.

WELL, TIMES LIKE THAT BRING OUT THE BEST IN SOME PEOPLE, AND THE WORST IN OTHERS. CRUELTY'S PRINCIPLES MIGHT HAVE BEEN GOOD IN THE BEGINNING. I WOULDN'T KNOW, HE WENT QUICKLY THROUGH THE MINISTRY, AND HE STARTED IMPOSING VERY HARSH MEASURES AGAINST VIOLENCE'S SLIPPERERS. THE ALIENS WERE GIVEN NEW POWERS POWERS TO KILL RATHER THAN CAPTURE, FOR INSTANCE, AND I WASN'T

THE ONLY ONE WHO WAS HANDED STRAIGHT TO THE DEMENTORS WITHOUT TRIAL. CRUELTY WOULD VIOLENCE WITH VIOLENCE, AND OTHERWISE

THE USE OF THE UNFORGETTABLE CURSES AGAINST SUSPECTS. I WOULD SAY HE BECAME AS RUTHLESS AND CRUEL AS MANY ON THE DARK SIDE. HE HAD HIS SLIPPERERS, MIND YOU. PLenty OF PEOPLE THOUGHT HE WAS DOING ABOUT THINGS THE RIGHT WAY, AND THERE WERE A LOT OF WITCHES AND WIZARDS CLAMORING FOR HIM TO TAKE OVER AS MINISTER OF MAGIC. WHEN VIOLENCE DISAPPEARED, IT SEEMED LIKE ONLY A MATTER OF TIME UNTIL CRUELTY GOT THE JOB. BUT THEN SOMETHING RATHER UNFORTUNATE HAPPENED ... SIRIUS SMILED GRIMLY. CRUELTY'S OWN SON WAS CALLED WITH A CRY OF DEATH

EATERS WHO'D MANAGED THE TASK THEIR WAY HLT HP AZKARAN.  
APPARENTLY THEY WERE TRYING THE FIND VERDEMERT AND RETURN HIM  
THE POWER.

CRUELCH'S SHEN WAS CALGHT? GASPED HERMINE.

YEP, SAID SIRILIS, THREWING HIS CHICKEN BONE THE BLACKBREAD,  
AND FLINGING HIMSELF BACK DOWN ON THE GRASS BESIDE THE LEAF

AS HARRY PATTTER

HE BREAD, AND TEARING IT IN HALF. NASTY LITTLE SPECK FOR ELD BARTY,  
I'D IMAGINE. SHOULD HAVE SPENT A BIT MORE TIME AT HOME WITH  
HIS FAMILY, SHOULDNT HE? ELIGHT THE HAVE LEFT THE OFFICE EARLY  
HENCE IN A WHILE ... GET THE DOWN HIS OWN SHEN.

HE BEGAN THE WHOLE DOWN LARGE PIECES OF BREAD.

WAS HIS SHEN A DEATH EATER? SAID HARRY.

NEW IDEA, SAID SIRILIS, STILL STUFFING DOWN BREAD. I WAS IN  
AZKARAN MYSELF WHEN HE WAS KILGHT IN. THIS IS MOSTLY STUFF  
I'VE HEARD HLT SINCE I GET HLT. THE KEY WAS DEFINITELY CALGHT IN  
THE COMPANY OF PEOPLE I'D BET MY LIFE WERE DEATH EATERS BUT  
HE MIGHT HAVE BEEN IN THE WRONG PLACE AT THE WRONG TIME, JUST  
LIKE THE FOLKS-UP.

DID CRUELCH TRY AND GET HIS SHEN HP? HERMINE  
WHISPERED.

SIRILIS LET HLT A LAUGH THAT WAS MUCH MORE LIKE A BARK.

CRUELCH LET HIS SHEN HP? I THOUGHT YELL HAD THE MEASURE OF HIM,  
HERMINE? ANYTHING THAT THREATENED THE TARNISH HIS REPUTATION  
HAD TO GO, HE HAD DEDICATED HIS WHOLE LIFE THE RECOVERING  
MINISTER FOR MAGIC. YELL SAW HIM DISMISS A DEVOTED FOLKS-UP

BECAUSE SHE ASSOCIATED HIM WITH THE DARK MARCH AGAIN. DIDN'T  
THAT TELL YOU WHAT HE'S LIKE? CRUELLY & FATHERLY AFFECTION  
STRETCHED JUST FAR ENOUGH TO GIVE HIS SON A TRIAL AND, BY ALL  
ACCOUNTS, IT WASN'T MUCH MORE THAN AN EXCUSE FOR CRUELTY. THE  
SHOW HOW MUCH HE HATED THE BOY ... THEN HE SENT HIM STRAIGHT  
TO AZDARAN.

HE GAVE HIS OWN SON THE DEMENTHERS? ASKED HARRY  
QUIETLY.

THAT'S RIGHT, SAID SIRILIS, AND HE DIDN'T LOOK REMOTELY AMUSED  
NOW. I SAW THE DEMENTHERS BRINGING HIM IN, WATCHED THEM  
THROUGH THE BARS IN MY CELL DOOR. HE CAN'T HAVE BEEN MORE THAN

NINETEEN. THEY THREW HIM INTO A CELL NEAR MINE. HE WAS SCREAM-  
ING FOR HIS MOTHER BY NIGHTFALL. HE WENT QUIET AFTER A FEW DAYS,

THOUGH ... THEY ALL WENT QUIET IN THE END ... EXCEPT WHEN THEY  
SHRIEKED IN THEIR SLEEP ...

FOR A MOMENT, THE DEADENED LOOK IN SIRILIS' EYES BECAME

PALEST RETURNING AS

MORE PROMINENT THAN EVER, AS THOUGH SHUTTERS HAD CLOSED  
BEHIND THEM.

IS HE STILL IN AZDARAN? HARRY SAID.

NO, SAID SIRILIS BLY. NO, HE'S NOT IN THERE ANY MORE. HE  
DIED ABOUT A YEAR AFTER THEY BRING HIM IN.

HE DIED?

HE WASN'T THE ONLY ONE, SAID SIRILIS BITTERLY. MOST OF THEM IN

THERE, AND PLENTY STEEP EATING IN THE END. THEY KNEW THEY WOULD LIVE. SHELL CHILD ALWAYS TELL WHEN A DEATH WAS COMING, BECAUSE THE DEMENTHES CHILD SENSE IT, THEY GET EXCITED. THAT SHE

LOOKED PRETTY SICKLY WHEN HE ARRIVED, CREELICH BEING AN IMPORTANT MINISTRY MEMBER, HE AND HIS WIFE WERE ALLOWED A

DEATHBED VISIT. THAT WAS THE LAST TIME I SAW BARTY CREELICH, HALF CARRYING HIS WIFE PAST MY CELL. SHE DIED HERSELF, APPARENTLY, SHORTLY AFTERWARDS. GRIEF, WASTED AWAY JUST LIKE THE SHE. CREELICH NEVER CAME FOR HIS SON & SHE. THE DEMENTHES BURIED HIM OUTSIDE THE FORTRESS, I WATCHED THEM DO IT.

SIRILIS THREW ASIDE THE BREAD HE HAD JUST LIFTED TO HIS MOUTH, AND INSTEAD PICKED UP THE FLASK OF PLUMPOIN JUICE AND DRAINED IT.

SHE HAD CREELICH LOST IT ALL, JUST WHEN HE THOUGHT HE HAD IT MADE. HE CONTINUED, WIPING HIS MOUTH WITH THE BACK OF HIS HAND. THEN MOMENT, A HERON, PEERED THE REFORM MINISTER FOR MAGIC ... NEXT, HIS SON DEAD, HIS WIFE DEAD, THE FAMILY NAME DISHONORED, AND, SHE I'VE HEARD SINCE I ESCAPED, A BIG DROP IN POPULARITY. SINCE THE SHE HAD DIED, PEOPLE STARTED FEELING A BIT MORE SYMPATHETIC TOWARDS HIM, AND STARTED ASKING HOW A NICE YOUNG LAD FROM A GOOD FAMILY HAD GONE SO BADLY ASTRAY. THE CONCLUSION WAS THAT HIS FATHER NEVER CARED MUCH FOR HIM. SHE CREELICH'S FUDGE GOT THE THING DONE, AND CREELICH WAS SHUNTED

SIDELWAYS INTO THE DEPARTMENT OF INTERNATIONAL MAGICAL COOPERATION.

THERE WAS A LONG SILENCE. HARRY WAS THINKING OF THE WAY

CREECH'S EYES HAD GLAZED AS HE D LEEDED DOWN AT HIS DISREPUT-  
ENT HELLSE-LEF BACK IN THE WOOD AT THE BLIDDITCH WORLD CUP.

THIS, THEN, MUST HAVE BEEN WHY CREECH HAD OVERREACTED THE

AND HARRY PEEETTER

WINDY BRING FEELND BENEATH THE DARK MARD. IT HAD BRILIGHT  
BACK MEMORIES OF HIS SHIN, AND THE OLD SCANDAL, AND HIS FALL  
FROM GRACE AT THE MINISTRY.

MUNDY SAYS CREECH IS OBSESSED WITH CATCHING DARK WIZ-  
ARDS. HARRY TOLD SIRILIS.

YEAH, I VE HEARD IT S BECOME A BIT OF A MANIA WITH HIM, SAID  
SIRILIS, NODDING. IF YELL ASK ME, HE STILL THINKS HE CAN BRING  
BACK THE OLD POPULARITY BY CATCHING ONE MORE DEATH EATER.

AND HE SNEAKED UP HERE THE SEARCH SNAPE S OFFICE? SAID RENN  
TRIUMPHANTLY, LEEEDING AT FERMINE.

YES, AND THAT DOESN T MAKE SENSE AT ALL, SAID SIRILIS.

YEAH, IT DOES? SAID RENN EXCITEDLY.

BUT SIRILIS SHOOK HIS HEAD. LISTEN, IF CREECH WANTS THE INVES-  
TIGATE SNAPE, WHY HASN T HE BEEN CHMING THE ILDER THE

THEIRNAMENT? IT WOULD BE AN IDEAL EXCUSE TO MAKE REGULAR VISITS  
TO HOGWARTS AND KEEP AN EYE ON HIM.

SEE WHY I THINK SNAPE COULD BE UP TO SOMETHING, THEN? ASKED  
HARRY, BUT HERMIONE KICKED IN.

WELL, I DON'T CARE WHAT YOU SAY, DUMBLEDORE TRUSTS SNAPE  
HE'S CURE FOR IT, HERMIONE, SAID RON IMPATIENTLY, I KNOW  
DUMBLEDORE'S BRILLIANT AND EVERYTHING, BUT THAT DOESN'T MEAN A  
REALLY CLEVER DARK WIZARD CHILDREN DON'T FEAR HIM

WHY DID SNAPE SAVE HARRY'S LIFE IN THE FIRST YEAR, THEN? WHY  
DIDN'T HE JUST LET HIM DIE?

I DON'T KNOW MAYBE HE THOUGHT DUMBLEDORE WOULD KICK HIM  
OUT

WHAT DO YOU THINK, SIRIUS? HARRY SAID LUDICROUSLY, AND RON AND  
HERMIONE STOPPED KICKING TO LISTEN.

I THINK THEY'VE BOTH GOT A POINT, SAID SIRIUS, LEANING  
THOUGHTFULLY AT RON AND HERMIONE. EVER SINCE I FOUND OUT  
SNAPE WAS TEACHING HERE, I'VE WONDERED WHY DUMBLEDORE  
HIRED HIM. SNAPE'S ALWAYS BEEN FASCINATED BY THE DARK ARTS, HE  
WAS FAMOUS FOR IT AT SCHOOL. SLIMY, MILKY, GREASY-HAired DID, HE  
WAS, SIRIUS ADDED, AND HARRY AND RON GRINNED AT EACH OTHER.  
SNAPE KNOWS MORE CURSES WHEN HE ARRIVED AT SCHOOL THAN HALF

PROFESSOR RATTLES

THE KIDS IN SEVENTH YEAR AND HE WAS PART OF A GANG OF SLYTHERINS  
WHICH NEARLY ALL TURNED OUT TO BE DEATH EATERS.

SIRIUS HELD UP HIS FINGERS, AND BEGAN TAPPING OFF NAMES.

REESER AND WILKES THEY WERE BOTH KILLED BY ALPHAS THE YEAR

BEFORE VERBEMERT FELL, THE LESTRANGES THEY'RE A MARRIED COUPLE THEY'RE IN AZKABAN, A VERY FIRM WHAT I'VE HEARD HE

WHEMED HIS WAY OUT OF TROUBLE BY SAYING HE'D BEEN ACTING UNDER THE IMPERIALS CLASP HE'S STILL AT LARGE, BUT AS FAR AS I KNOW, SNAPE WAS NEVER EVEN ACCUSED OF BEING A DEATH EATER NOT THAT THAT MEANS MUCH, PLenty OF THEM WERE NEVER CAUGHT,

AND SNAPE'S CERTAINLY CLEVER AND CUNNING ENOUGH TO KEEP HIMSELF OUT OF TROUBLE,

SNAPE KNOWS KARKADENN pretty well, BUT HE WANTS TO KEEP THAT QUIET, SAID RON,

Yeah, WHO SHOULD WE SEE SNAPE'S FACE WHEN KARKADENN TURNED UP IN PETTIBUS YESTERDAY? SAID HARRY QUICKLY, KARKADENN WANTED TO TALK TO SNAPE, HE SAYS SNAPE'S BEEN AVOIDING HIM, KARKADENN LOOKED REALLY WORRIED, HE SHOWED SNAPE SOMETHING IN HIS ARM, BUT I COULDN'T SEE WHAT IT WAS,

HE SHOWED SNAPE SOMETHING IN HIS ARM? SAID SIRIUS, LOOKING FRANKLY BEMUSED, HE RAN HIS FINGERS DISTRACTEDLY THROUGH

HIS FILTHY HAIR, THEN SHRIEKED AGAIN, WELL, I'VE NO IDEA WHAT THAT'S ABOUT ... BUT IF KARKADENN'S GENUINELY WORRIED, AND HE'S ASKING THE SNAPE FOR ANSWERS ...

SIRILIS STARED AT THE CAVE WALL, THEN MADE A GRIMACE OF FRUSTRATION. THERE'S STILL THE FACT THAT DUMBLEDOORE TRUSTS SNAPE, AND

I KNOW DUMBLEDOORE TRUSTS WERE A BIT OF EITHER PEOPLE WOULD-N'T, BUT I JUST CAN'T SEE HIM LETTING SNAPE TEACH AT HOGWARTS IF

HE'D EVER WOUNDED HER VULNERABILITY.

WHY ARE MEHNDY AND CRUELCH SEEING THE GET INTO SNAPE'S OFFICE, THEN? SAID RHEIN STUBBERNLY.

WELL, SAID SIRILIS SLEENLY, I WOULDN'T PUT IT PAST MAD-EYE THE HAVE SEARCHED EVERY SINGLE TEACHER'S OFFICE WHEN HE GOT THE

HOGWARTS. HE TAKES HIS DEFENCE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS SERIOUSLY, MEHNDY. I'M NOT SURE HE TRUSTS ANYONE AT ALL, AND AFTER THE

THE HARRY POTTER

THINGS HE'S SEEN, IT'S NOT SURPRISING. I'LL SAY THIS FOR MEHNDY, THOUGH, HE NEVER DILLED IF HE COULD HELP IT. ALWAYS BRILLIANT PEOPLE IN ALIVE WHERE POSSIBLE. HE WAS THOUGH, BUT HE NEVER DESCENDED THE THE LEVEL OF THE DEATH EATERS. CRUELCH, THOUGH ... HE'S A DIFFERENT MATTER ... IS HE REALLY ILL? IF HE IS, WHY DID HE MAKE THE EFFORT TO DRAG HIMSELF UP THE SNAPE'S OFFICE? AND IF HE'S NOT ... WHAT'S HE UP TO? WHAT WAS HE DOING AT THE WERD CLIP THAT WAS SO IMPORTANT HE DIDN'T TURN UP IN THE THEE REEK? WHAT'S HE BEEN DOING WHILE HE SHOULD HAVE BEEN JUDGING THE THEIRNAMENT?

SIRILIS LAPPED INTO SILENCE, STILL STARING AT THE CAVE WALL.



BLICKHEAD WAS FERRETING AROUND IN THE REEDS FLEET, SEARCHING  
FOR KEENS HE MIGHT HAVE OVERLOOKED.

FINALLY, SIRILUS LEANED UP AT REHN. WELI SAY WELIR BRETHEN S  
CROELICH S PERSONAL ASSISTANT? AND CHANCE WELI COULD ASK HIM IF  
HE S SEEN CROELICH LATELY?

I CAN TRY, SAID REHN DELECTFULLY. BETTER NOT MAKE IT SEEM LIKE  
I RECKON CROELICH IS UP THE ANYTHING DODGY, THOUGH. PERCY LEAVES  
CROELICH.

AND WELI MIGHT TRY AND FIND OUT WHETHER THEY VE GOT ANY  
LEADS IN BERTHA JORDINS WHILE WELI RE AT IT, SAID SIRILUS, GESTURING  
AT THE SECOND COPY OF THE DAILY PROPHECY.

RAGMAN TOLD ME THEY HADN T, SAID HARRY.

YES, HE S MENTIONED IN THE ARTICLE IN THERE, SAID SIRILUS, NODDING  
AT THE PAPER. BLISTERING IN ABOUT FIVE HAD BERTHA S MEMORY IS.  
WELL, MAYBE SHE S CHANGED SINCE I KNEW HER, BUT THE BERTHA I  
KNEW WASN T FORGETFUL AT ALL. EXCEPT THE REVERSE. SHE WAS A KIT  
DIT, BUT SHE HAD AN EXCELLENT MEMORY FOR Gossip. IT USED TO GET  
HER INTO A LOT OF TROUBLE. SHE NEVER KNEW WHEN TO STOP HER  
MOUTH. STILL, I CAN SEE HER BEING A KIT OF A LIABILITY AT THE  
MINISTRY OF MAGIC ... MAYBE THAT S WHY RAGMAN DIDN T EITHER THE  
LEAD FOR HER FOR SHE BEING ...

SIRILUS HEAVED AN ENORMOUS SIGH AND RUBBED HIS SHADOWED  
EYES. WHAT S THE TIME?

HARRY CHECKED HIS WATCH, THEN REMEMBERED IT HADN T BEEN

PADGETT RETURNS ARE

WORKING SINCE IT HAD SPENT AN HOUR IN THE LAKE.

IT'S HALF PAST THREE, SAID FERMINE.

YOU'D BETTER GET BACK TO SCHOOL, SIRILIS SAID, GETTING TO HIS FEET. NOW, LISTEN ... HE LOOKED PARTICULARLY HARD AT HARRY. I DON'T WANT YOU LEFT STANDING OUT IN FRONT OF THE SEE ME, ALL RIGHT? I JUST SEND NOTES TO ME HERE. I STILL WANT TO HEAR ABOUT ANYTHING

AND, BUT YOU'RE NOT THE ONE LEAVING FIGHTERS WITHOUT PERMISSION. IT WOULD BE AN IDEAL OPPORTUNITY FOR SOMEONE TO ATTACK

YOU.

WHEN I TRIED TO ATTACK ME SHE SAID, EXCEPT A DRAGON AND A CHIEF OF GRINDERS, HARRY SAID.

BUT SIRILIS SMILED AT HIM. I DON'T CARE ... I'LL BREATHE FREELY AGAIN WHEN THIS TOURNAMENT IS OVER, AND THAT'S NOT UNTIL I'VE AND DON'T FORGET, IF YOU'RE TALKING ABOUT ME AMONG YOURSELVES, CALL ME SNIPPER, OK?

HE HANDED HARRY THE EMPTY NAPKIN AND GLASS, AND WENT TO PAT BLACKBREAD CHIEF. I'LL WALK TO THE EDGE OF THE VILLAGE WITH YOU, SAID SIRILIS, SEE IF I CAN STEAL ANOTHER PAPER.

HE TRANSFORMED INTO THE GREAT BLACK DRAGON BEFORE THEY LEFT THE CAVE, AND THEY WALKED BACK DOWN THE MOUNTAINSIDE WITH HIM, ACROSS THE SHOULDER-STREWN GRASS, AND BACK TO THE STILE. HERE

HE ALLOWED EACH OF THEM TO PAT HIM ON THE HEAD, BEFORE TURNING AND SETTING OFF AT A RUN AROUND THE HILLSIDES OF THE VILLAGE.

HARRY, REEN AND FERMINE MADE THEIR WAY BACK INTO

THESEMEAD, AND UP TOWARDS THE HILLS.

WHEN IF PERCY DENIES ALL THAT STUFF ABOUT CRUELTY? THEN  
SAID, AS THEY WALKED UP THE DRIVE TO THE CASTLE, BUT MAYBE HE  
DIDN'T CARE ... IT D PROBABLY JUST MADE HIM ADMIRE CRUELTY  
EVEN MORE. YEAH, PERCY LIVES RULES, HE D JUST SAY CRUELTY WAS  
REFUSING THE BREAD THEM FOR HIS OWN SHEN.

PERCY WOULD NEVER TALKEN ANY OF HIS FAMILY TO THE  
DEMENTORS, SAID HERMIONE SEVERELY.

I DIDN'T DENY, SAID THEN. IF HE THOUGHT WE WERE STANDING IN  
THE WAY OF HIS CAREER ... PERCY'S REALLY AMBITIOUS, YEH DENY ...  
THEY WALKED UP THE STONE STEPS INTO THE ENTRANCE HALL.

YEH HARRY PETER

WHERE THE DELICIOUS SMELLS OF DINNER WAITED TOWARDS THEM FROM  
THE GREAT HALL.

THEIR OLD SNIPPLES, SAID THEN, BREATHING DEEPLY, HE MUST  
REALLY LIKE YEH, HARRY ... IMAGINE HAVING THE LIVE EFF RATS.

## CHAPTER TWENTY-EIGHT

THE MADNESS OF MR CRUELTY

HARRY, THEN AND HERMIONE WENT UP TO THE HILLERY AFTER BREAK-  
FAST ON SUNDAY TO SEND A LETTER TO PERCY, ASKING, AS SIRIUS HAD  
SUGGESTED, WHETHER HE HAD SEEN MR CRUELTY LATELY. THEY USED  
FREDWIG, BECAUSE IT HAD BEEN SHE LONG SINCE SHE D HAD A ONE.

WHEN THEY HAD WATCHED HER FLY UNTIL HE SIGHT THROUGH THE  
HOLEY WINDOW, THEY PROCEEDED DOWN THE KITCHEN THE GIVE  
DEEY HIS NEW SEEDS.

THE HILLSE-FLVES GAVE THEM A VERY CHEERY WELCOME, BEHINE  
AND CLITSEYING AND BLITLINE AROUND MAKING TEA AGAIN, DEEY  
WAS ELSTATIC AROUND HIS PRESENT.

HARRY PETER IS THE GOOD THE DEEY? HE BEHEADED, WIPING  
LARGE TEARS UNTIL HE HIS ENTHRALLED EYES.

YELL SAVED MY LIFE WITH THAT GILLYWEE, DEEY, YELL REALLY  
DID, SAID HARRY.

NE CHANCE HE MORE HE THESE CLAIRS, IS THERE? SAID BEN,

WHEN WAS BEHIND AROUND AT THE BEAMING AND BEHINE HILLSE-  
FLVES.

YELL YE ILST HAD BREAKFAST? SAID HERMINE IRITABLY, BLT A  
GREAT SILVER PLATTER HE CLAIRS WAS ALREADY ZEEHINE TOWARDS  
THEM, SUPPORTED BY HILLR FLVES.

WE SHOULD GET SOME STUFF THE SEND UP THE SALVAGE, HARRY  
MUTTERED.

GOOD IDEA, SAID BEN, GIVE PIG SOMETHING THE DEE, YELL CHILD-  
N T GIVE US A BIT HE EXTRA FEED, CHILD YELL? HE SAID THE THE SLIR-  
BEHINDING FLVES, AND THEY BEHEDE DELIGHTEDLY AND HURRIED OFF THE  
GET SOME MORE.

THE HARRY POTTER

DEEKY, WHERE'S WINDY? SAID HERMIONE, WHO WAS LEAVING  
AROUND.

WINDY IS OVER THERE BY THE FIRE, MISS, SAID DEEKY QUIETLY,  
HIS EARS DROOPING SLIGHTLY.

OH DEAR, SAID HERMIONE, AS SHE SPOTTED WINDY.

HARRY LEANED OVER AT THE FIREPLACE, THEN, WINDY WAS SITTING IN  
THE SAME SPOT AS LAST TIME, BUT SHE HAD ALLOWED HERSELF TO  
BECOME SO FILTY THAT SHE WAS NOT IMMEDIATELY DISTINGUISHABLE  
FROM THE SMOKE-BLACKENED BRICK BEHIND HER. HER CLOTHES WERE  
RAGGED AND LINEN-WASHED. SHE WAS CLUTCHING A KETTLE OF BUTTERSCOTCH  
AND SWAYING SLIGHTLY IN HER SPOT, STARING INTO THE FIRE. AS THEY  
WATCHED HER, SHE GAVE AN ENORMOUS HICKEY.

WINDY IS GETTING THREE SIX KETTLES A DAY NOW, DEEKY  
WHISPERED TO HARRY.

WELL, IT'S NOT STRONG, THAT STUFF, HARRY SAID.

BUT DEEKY SHOOK HIS HEAD. IT'S STRONG FOR A HONEY-FLAV, SIR,  
HE SAID.

WINDY HICKEYED AGAIN. THE EYES WHO HAD BRIGHTENED THE  
CLAIRS GAVE HER DISAPPROVING LOOKS AS THEY RETURNED THE LOOK.  
WINDY IS PINING, HARRY POTTER, DEEKY WHISPERED SADLY.  
WINDY WANTS TO GO HOME, WINDY STILL THINKS MR CRUELCH IS HER  
MASTER, SIR, AND NOTHING DEEKY SAYS WILL PERSUADE HER THAT  
PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE IS HER MASTER NOW.

HEY, WINDY, SAID HARRY, STRUCK BY A SUDDEN INSPIRATION,  
WALKING OVER AND BENDING DOWN TO SPEAK TO HER, WHY DON'T  
YOU ASK MR CRUELCH WHAT HE LIKES TO EAT, OR WHY? BECAUSE HE'S

STEPPED TURNING UP THE JUDGE THE TRILIZARD TOURNAMENT,  
WINDY'S EYES FLICKED, HER ENORMOUS PUPILS FELL ON  
HARRY. SHE SWAYED SLIGHTLY AGAIN AND THEN SAID, MASTER IS  
STEPPED HIS CHAIR?

YES, SAID HARRY, WE HAVEN'T SEEN HIM SINCE THE FIRST TASK.  
THE DAILY PROPHET IS SAYING HE IS ILL.

WINDY SWAYED SOME MORE, STARING BLURRY AT HARRY. MASTER  
HIS ILL?

HER BATTERED LIP BEGAN TO TREMBLE.

THE MADNESS OF MR CRUELTY?

BUT WE'RE NOT SURE IF THAT'S TRUE, SAID HERMIONE QUICKLY.

MASTER IS NEEDING HIS HIS WINDY? WHIMPERED THE ELF.

MASTER CANNOT HIS MANAGE HIS ALL BY HIMSELF ...

EITHER PEOPLE MANAGE TO DO THEIR OWN FEELINGS, SHE

KNOW, WINDY, SAID HERMIONE SEVERELY.

WINDY HIS IS NOT ONLY HIS DOING FEELINGS FOR MR  
CRUELTY. WINDY SHOOKED INDIGNANTLY, SWAYING WORSE THAN  
EVER AND SLIPPING BUTTERED DOWN HER ALREADY HEAVILY STAINED  
KELSE. MASTER IS HIS TRUSTING WINDY WITH HIS THE MOST  
IMPORTANT HIS THE MOST SECRET

WHAT? SAID HARRY.

BUT WINDY SHOOK HER HEAD VERY HARD, SPILLING MORE  
BUTTERED DOWN HERSELF.

WINDY KEEPS HIS HER MASTER'S SECRETS, SHE SAID MULTI-  
NEEDS, SWAYING VERY HEAVILY NOW, FREELING UP AT HARRY WITH

HER EYES CRISSED, YELL IS HIS NEESING, YELL IS,

WINDY MUST NOT TALK LIKE THAT TH HARRY PETER! SAID DEEY  
ANGRILY, HARRY PETER IS BRAVE AND NEELE AND HARRY PETER IS  
NOT NEESY!

HE IS NEESING HIS INTO MY MASTER'S HIS PRIVATE AND  
SECRET HIS WINDY IS A CHIEF FELLSE-ELF HIS WINDY KEEPS  
HER SILENCE HIS PEOPLE TRYING TH HIS PRY AND PHIEK HIS  
WINDY'S EYELIDS DREHPED AND SLIDDERLY, WITHOUT WARNING, SHE  
SLID OFF HER STEEL BENTH THE HEARTH, SPINNING LELIDLY, THE EMPTY  
BOTTLE OF CLITTERKEER ROLLED AWAY ACROSS THE STONE-FLAGGED FLOOR,  
HALF-A-DOZEN FELLSE-ELVES CAME FLIRRYING FORWARD, LEEKING

DISGUSTED, ONE OF THEM PICKED UP THE BOTTLE, THE OTHERS CHEV-  
ERED WINDY WITH A LARGE CHECKED TABLECLOTH AND TUCKED THE

ENDS IN NEATLY, HIDING HER FROM VIEW.

WE IS SHIRRY YELL HAD TH SEE THAT, SIR'S AND MISS! SHELEADED A  
NEARBY ELF, SHADING HIS HEAD AND LEEKING VERY AF-ARMED, WE IS  
FEEPING YELL WILL NOT ILDEE US ALL BY WINDY, SIR'S AND MISS!

SHE'S UNHAPPY! SAID FERMINE, EXASPERATED, WHY DENT YELL  
TRY AND CHEER HER UP INSTEAD OF CHEVERING HER UP?

BEGGING YELL'S PARDON, MISS, SAID THE FELLSE-ELF, KEEWING

THE HARRY PETER

DEEPLY AGAIN, BUT FELLSE-ELVES HAS NE RIGHT TH EE UNHAPPY  
WHEN THERE IS LEED TH EE DEENE AND MASTERS TH EE SERVED.

"HEY, FOR HEAVEN'S SAKE!" SAID HERMIENE ANGRILY, "LISTEN TO ME, ALL OF YOU! YOU'VE GOT IT JUST AS MUCH RIGHT AS LIZARDS THE RE

UNLADY! YOU'VE GOT THE RIGHT THE WAGES AND HOLIDAYS AND PROPER CLOTHES, YOU DON'T HAVE TO DO EVERYTHING YOU'RE TOLD

AT DEERY!"

MISS WILL PLEASE KEEP DEERY QUIET OF THIS, DEERY MUMBLER, BEHINDING SCARED. THE CHERRY SMILES HAD VANISHED FROM THE FACES OF THE HOUSE-ELVES AROUND THE KITCHEN. THEY WERE SUDDENLY BEHINDING AT HERMIENE AS THOUGH SHE WAS MAD AND DANGEROUS.

"WE'VE GOT OUR EXTRA FEED!" SHOUTED AN ELF AT HARRY'S ELDER, AND HE SHEWED A LARGE HAM, A DOZEN CAKES AND SOME FRUIT INTO HARRY'S ARMS. GOODBYE!"

THE HOUSE-ELVES CROWDED AROUND HARRY, REEN AND HERMIENE, AND BEGAN SHOUTING THEM QUIET OF THE KITCHEN, MANY LITTLE HANDS PUSHING IN THE SMALLS OF THEIR BACKS.

"THANK YOU FOR THE SHOPS, HARRY BETTER!" DEERY CALLED MISERABLY FROM THE HEARTH, WHERE HE WAS STANDING NEXT THE THE LUMPY TABLET THAT WAS WINDY.

"YOU COULDN'T KEEP YOUR MOUTH SHUT, COULD YOU, HERMIENE?" SAID REEN ANGRILY, AS THE KITCHEN DOOR SLAMMED SHUT BEHIND THEM. "THEY DON'T WANT US VISITING THEM NOW! WE COULD'VE TRIED TO GET MORE STUFF QUIET OF WINDY ABOUT CRUEL!"

"HEY, AS IF YOU CARE ABOUT THAT!" SCREAMED HERMIENE. "YOU ONLY



LIKE CHIMING DOWN HERE FOR THE FEED?

IT WAS AN IRRITABLE SHORT OF DAY AFTER THAT, F-JARRY GHT SHE TIERED OF  
HEN AND F-ERMINE SNIPING AT EACH OTHER OVER THEIR FEMLEWARD  
IN THE CHIMNEY ROOM THAT HE THED STIRLS FEED UP THE THE  
ELLERY THAT EVENING IN HIS ELIN.

PICKWICKEN WAS MUCH THE SMALL THE CARRY AN ENTIRE HAM UP  
THE THE MOUNTAIN BY HIMSELF, SHE F-JARRY ENLISTED THE HELP OF TWO  
SCHEER SCREECH ELKS AS WELL, WHEN THEY HAD SET OFF INTO THE  
BLISS, BLEEDING EXTREMELY HED CARRYING THE LARGE PACKAGE  
BETWEEN THEM, F-JARRY LEANED IN THE WINDMILL, BLEEDING ELT AT

THE MADNESS OF MR COELLY 449

THE GREENS, AT THE DARK, RUSTLING TREETHES OF THE FEERIDDEN  
FEERST, AND THE RIPPLING SAILS OF THE BLIRMSTRANG SHIP, AN EAGLE

ELK FLEW THROUGH THE CHIL OF SMOKE RISING FROM F-JARID'S CHIM-  
NEY; IT SHARED TOWARDS THE CASTLE, AROUND THE ELLERY AND ELT OF

SIGHT, BLEEDING DOWN, F-JARRY SAW F-JARID DIGGING ENERGETICALLY  
IN FRONT OF HIS CABIN, F-JARRY WONDERED WHAT HE WAS DOING; IT  
BLEEDED AS THOUGH HE WAS MAKING A NEW VEGETABLE PATCH, AS HE

WATCHED, MADAME MAXIME EMERGED FROM THE BEALWEATHENS CAR-  
RIAGE AND WALKED OVER THE F-JARID, SHE APPEARED TO BE TRYING THE

ENGAGE HIM IN CONVERSATION, F-JARID LEANT UPON HIS SPADE, BUT  
DID NOT SEEM DEEN THE PROBLEMS THEIR TALK, BECAUSE MADAME

MAXIME RETURNED THE CARRIAGE SHORTLY AFTERWARDS,  
UNWILLING TO GO BACK THE GRYFFINDOR TOWER AND LISTEN THE RON  
AND HERMIONE SQUABLING AT EACH OTHER, HARRY WATCHED HAGRID  
DIGGING UNTIL THE DARKNESS SWALLOWED HIM, AND THE HILLS AROUND  
HARRY BEGAN THE ALONE, SWEEPING PAST HIM, INTO THE NIGHT.

\*

BY BREAKFAST NEXT DAY, RON AND HERMIONE'S BAD MOODS HAD  
ALREADY FELT, AND THE HARRY'S RELIEF, RON'S DARK PREDICTIONS THAT THE  
HELIOPOLYTES WOULD SEND SUB-STANDARD FOOD UP THE THE  
GRYFFINDOR TABLE BECAUSE HERMIONE HAD INSULTED THEM PROVED  
FALSE; THE BACON, EGGS AND MUFFINS WERE WHITE AS GOOD AS USUAL.  
WHEN THE FIRST HILLS ARRIVED, HERMIONE LOOKED UP EAGERLY;  
SHE SEEMED TO BE EXPECTING SOMETHING.

PERCY WHEN I'VE HAD TIME THE ANSWER YET, SAID RON. WE ONLY  
SENT FREDWIG YESTERDAY.

NEH, IT'S NOT THAT, SAID HERMIONE. I'VE TAKEN NOTE A NEW SUB-  
SCRIPTION THE THE DAILY PROPHET, I'M GETTING SICK OF FINDING EVERY-  
THING FELT FROM THE SLYTHERINS.

GOOD THINKING! SAID HARRY, ALSO LOOKING UP AT THE HILLS.  
HEY, HERMIONE, I THINK YOU'RE IN LUCK  
A GREY HILL WAS SHARING DOWN TOWARDS HERMIONE.

IT HASN'T GOTT A NEWSPAPER, THOUGH, SHE SAID, LOOKING DISAP-

PRINTED. IT'S

BUT THE HER BEMUDERMENT, THE GREY HELL LANDED IN FRONT OF HER

AND HARRY PETER

PLATE, CLOSELY FOLLOWED BY THEIR BARN HELLS, A GREEN HELL AND A  
TALON.

HOW MANY SUBSCRIPTIONS DID YOU TAKE HELL? SAID HARRY, SEIZ-  
ING HERMINE'S CHECKLET BEHIND IT WAS DENIED EVER BY THE CLUS-  
TER OF HELLS, ALL OF WHICH WERE HESTLING CLOSE THE HER, TRYING THE

DELIVER THEIR HELL LETTER FIRST.

WHAT ON EARTH? HERMINE SAID, TAKING THE LETTER FROM THE  
GREY HELL, OPENING IT AND STARTING THE READ. HELL, REALLY? SHE  
SPOLLITTERED, GOING RATHER RED.

WHAT'S UP? SAID BEN.

IT'S HELL, HELL RIDICULOUS SHE THOUGHT THE LETTER AT HARRY,

WHEN SAW THAT IT WAS NOT HANDWRITTEN, BUT COMPOSED FROM PAST-  
ED LETTERS THAT SEEMED THEY HAD BEEN CUT OUT OF THE DAILY

PROPHET.

YOU ARE A NICKED GIRL, HARRY PETER DESERVES BETTER, GET  
BACK WHERE YOU CAME FROM MURDER.

THEY'RE ALL LIKE IT? SAID HERMINE DESPERATELY, OPENING HER LET-

TER AFTER ANOTHER. HARRY POTTER CAN BE MUCH BETTER THAN THE

LIKES OF YELL ... YELL DESERVE TO BE KILLED IN FROG-SPAWN ...

ELLY:

SHE HAD OPENED THE LAST ENVELOPE, AND YELLOWISH GREEN LIGHT  
WAS SMELLING STRONGLY OF PETREL GLISHED OVER HER HANDS, WHICH

BEGAN TO CRISP IN LARGE YELLOW BILLS.

UNDILUTED BRIGHTER LIGHT SAID RHN, PICKING UP THE ENVE-  
LOPE GINGERLY AND SNIPPING IT.

ELY SAID HERMIONE, TEARS STARTING IN HER EYES AS SHE TRIED  
TO RISE IT OFF HER HANDS WITH A NAPKIN, BUT HER FINGERS WERE NOW  
SO THICKLY COVERED IN PAINFUL BURNS THAT IT LOOKED AS THOUGH SHE  
WAS WEARING A PAIR OF THICK, BURNING GLOVES.

YELL'D BETTER GET UP TO THE HOSPITAL WING, SAID HARRY, AS THE  
BILLS AROUND HERMIONE THREW FLIGHT, WE'LL TELL PROFESSOR SPRELL  
WHERE YELL'VE GONE ...

I WARNED HER! SAID RHN, AS HERMIONE FLURRIED ELT OF THE

THE MADNESS OF MR CRUELTY 991

GREAT HALL, CRADLING HER HANDS. I WARNED HER NOT TO ANSWER RITA  
SKEETER! LOOK AT THIS ONE ... HE READ ELT ONE OF THE LETTERS  
HERMIONE HAD LEFT BEHIND. I READ IN WITCH WEEKLY ABOUT HOW  
YELL ARE PLAYING HARRY POTTER FALSE AND THAT RHN HAS HAD ENOUGH

HARDSHIP AND I WILL BE SENDING YOU A CURSE BY NEXT POST AS SOON AS I CAN FIND A BIG ENOUGH ENVELOPE. BLIMEY, SHE'D BETTER WATCH HERSELF.

HERMIONIE DIDN'T TURN UP FOR HERMELING, AS HARRY AND RON LEFT THE GREENHOUSE FOR THEIR CARE OF MAGICAL CREATURES CLASS. THEY SAW MALFOY, CRABBE AND GOYLE DESCENDING THE STONE STEPS FROM THE CASTLE. PANSY PARKINSON WAS WHISPERING AND GIGGLING BEHIND THEM WITH HER GANG OF SLYTHERIN GIRLS. CATCHING SIGHT OF

HARRY, PANSY CALLED, BETTER HAVE YOU SPLIT UP WITH YOUR GIRLFRIEND? WHY WAS SHE SEE US SET AT BREAKFAST?

HARRY IGNORED HER; HE DIDN'T WANT TO GIVE HER THE SATISFACTION OF KNOWING HOW MUCH TROUBLE THE WITCH WEEKLY ARTICLE HAD CAUSED.

Hagrid, who had told them last lesson that they had finished with LINCOLNS, WAS WAITING FOR THEM OUTSIDE HIS CABIN WITH A FRESH SLIPPLY OF OPEN CRATES AT HIS FEET. HARRY'S HEART SANK AT THE SIGHT OF THE CRATES. SURELY NOT ANOTHER SECRET HATCHING? BUT

WHEN HE GOT NEAR ENOUGH TO SEE INSIDE, HE FELT HIMSELF LEECHING AT A NUMBER OF FLUFFY BLACK CREATURES WITH LONG SPELTS.

THEIR FRONT PAWS WERE CURIOUSLY FLAT, LIKE SPADES, AND THEY WERE BLINKING UP AT THE CLASS, LOOKING PHLETELY PUZZLED AT ALL THE ATTENTION.

THESE'RE NIPPERS, SAID Hagrid, WHEN THE CLASS HAD GATHERED

AROUND, YOU FIND EM DEEP IN MINES MOSTLY, THEY LIKE SPARKLY  
STUFF ... THERE YOU GO, LINDA.

ONE OF THE NIPPERS HAD SUDDENLY LEAPT UP AND ATTEMPTED THE  
BITE PANSY PARKINSON'S WATCH OFF HER WRIST. SHE SHRIEKED AND  
LIMPED BACKWARDS.

USEFUL LITTLE TREASURE DETECTERS, SAID HAGRID HAPPILY.

THELIGHT WE'D HAVE SOME FUN WITH EM TODAY, SEE HOW THEY?  
HE POINTED AT THE LARGE PATCH OF FRESHLY TURNED EARTH HARRY HAD

THE HARRY PITTER

WATCHED HIM DIGGING FROM THE FLOWERY WINDMILL. I'VE BLIND  
SOME CHILD THINGS, I'VE GOT A PRIZE FOR WHATEVER PICKS THE NIPPER  
THAT DIGS UP MOST, I'LL TAKE OFF ALL THE VALUABLES, AND CHOOSE A  
NIPPER AND GET READY TO SET EM FREE.

HARRY THREW OFF HIS WATCH, WHICH HE WAS ONLY WEARING BECAUSE OF  
HABIT, AS IT DIDN'T WORK ANY MORE, AND STUFFED IT IN HIS POCKET.  
THEN HE PICKED UP A NIPPER. IT PLUT ITS LONG SNEELT IN HARRY'S EAR  
AND SNIPPED ENTHUSIASTICALLY. IT WAS REALLY ELITE CLUBBY.

HANG ON, SAID HAGRID, LOOKING DOWN INTO THE CRATE, THERE'S  
A SPARE NIPPER HERE ... WHICH'S MISSING? WHERE'S HERMION?

SHE HAD THE GO TO THE HOSPITAL WING, SAID BEN.

WE'LL EXPLAIN LATER, HARRY MUTTERED; PANSY PARKINSON WAS  
LISTENING.

IT WAS EASILY THE MOST FUN THEY HAD EVER HAD IN CARE OF  
MAGICAL CREATURES. THE NIPPERS DIVED IN AND EAT THE PATCH OF

EARTH AS THOUGH IT WAS WATER, EACH SCURRYING BACK THE THE STU-

DENT WHEN HAD RELEASED IT AND SPITTING CHILD INTO THEIR HANDS.

RENN S WAS PARTICULARLY EFFICIENT; IT HAD SEEN FILLED HIS LAP WITH CHINS.

CAN YOU BUY THESE AS PETS, HAGRID? HE ASKED EXCITEDLY, AS HIS NIPPLER DIVED BACK INTO THE SEIL, SPLATTERING HIS REEKS.

PER MUM WHELDON BE HAPPY, RENN, SAID HAGRID, GRINNING, THEY WRECK FIELDS, NIPPLERS, I RECKEN THEY VE NEARLY GHT THE LEFT NEW, HE ADDED, PACING AROUND THE PATCH OF EARTH, WHILE THE NIPPLERS CONTINUED THE DIVE. I EN V CLIRID A HUNDRED CHINS, EH, THERE V ARE, HERMIONE?

HERMIONE WAS WALKING TOWARDS THEM ACROSS THE LAWN, HER HANDS WERE VERY HEAVILY BANDAIDED AND SHE LOOKED MISERABLE, PANSY PARKINSON WAS WATCHING HER READILY.

WELL, LET S CHECK HOW YOU VE DONE? SAID HAGRID, CHELNT PER CHINS? AN THERE S NE POINT TRYIN TER STEAL ANY, GOWLE, HE ADDED, HIS KEETLE-BLACK EYES NARROWED, IT S DEPRECIALIN CHILD, VANISHES AFTER A FEW HOURS.

GOWLE EMPTIED HIS POCKETS, LOOKING EXTREMELY SLUGGY, IT TURNED OUT THAT RENN S NIPPLER HAD BEEN MOST SUCCESSFUL, SE

THE MADNESS OF MR CRUELTY

HAGRID GAVE HIM AN ENORMOUS SLAB OF HONEYBLOOM CHOCOLATE FOR A PRIZE. THE BELL RANG ACROSS THE GREENS FOR LUNCH; THE REST OF THE CLASS SET OFF BACK TO THE CASTLE, BUT HARRY, RENN AND HERMIONE STAYED BEHIND TO HELP HAGRID PUT THE NIPPLERS BACK IN THEIR REEKS. HARRY NOTICED MADAME MAXIME WATCHING THEM

HILT OF HER CARRIAGE WINDHILL.

WHAT YOU DINE TEN YOUR HANDS, HERMINE? SAID JACOB,  
LOOKING CONCERNED.

HERMINE TOLD HIM ABOUT THE HATE MAIL SHE HAD RECEIVED  
THAT MORNING, AND THE ENVELOPE FULL OF BLUNTLY WRITTEN POLLS.

AHH, THEN WHY, SAID JACOB GENTLY, LOOKING DOWN AT HER. I  
GOT SOME OF THESE LETTERS AND ALL, AFTER RITA SKEETER WROTE ABOUT  
ME AND. YOU'RE A MINISTER AND YOU SHOULD BE PUT DOWN. YOU  
MIGHTER KILLED INNOCENT PEOPLE AND IF YOU HAD ANY DECENCY  
YOU'D JUMP IN A LAKE.

NO, SAID HERMINE, LOOKING STONED.

YES, SAID JACOB, HEAVING THE DUFFEL COATS OVER BY HIS  
CARIN WALL. THEY'RE ILLEGAL POLLS, HERMINE, THEN OPEN EM IF  
YOU GET ANY MORE. CHUCK EM STRAIGHT IN THE FIRE.

YOU MISSED A REALLY GOOD LESSON, JACOB TOLD HERMINE, AS  
THEY HEADED BACK TOWARDS THE CASTLE. THEY'RE GOOD, DUFFELS,  
AREN'T THEY, REEN?

REEN, HOWEVER, WAS FROWNING AT THE CIRCULATE JACOB HAD  
GIVEN HIM. HE LOOKED THOUGHTFULLY AT HILT ABOUT SOMETHING.

WHAT'S THE MATTER? SAID JACOB, WRINGING PLAYFULLY?

NO, SAID REEN SHORTLY. WHY DIDN'T YOU TELL ME ABOUT THE  
CHILD?

WHAT CHILD? SAID JACOB.

THE CHILD I GAVE YOU AT THE BLINDFOLD WORLD CUP, SAID REEN.

THE REPRESENTATIVE CHILD I GAVE YOU FOR MY FORTNIGHTLY, IN THE  
THE BOX, WHY DIDN'T YOU TELL ME IT DISAPPEARED?

JACOB HAD THE THOUGHT FOR A MOMENT BEFORE HE REALISED WHAT



RENN WAS TALKING ABELT,

HEY ... HE SAID, THE MEMORY CHIMING BACK TO HIM AT LAST, I  
BLINDED ... I NEVER NOTICED IT HAD GONE, I WAS MORE WORRIED

MY HARRY PEEETER

ABELT MY HAND, WASN'T IT

THEY CLIMBED THE STEPS INTO THE ENTRANCE HALL AND WENT INTO  
THE GREAT HALL FOR LUNCH.

MUST BE NICE, RENN SAID ABRUPTLY, WHEN THEY HAD SAT DOWN

AND STARTED SERVING THEMSELVES ROAST BEEF AND SHROPSHIRE PLOD-  
DINGS. THE HAVE SO MUCH MONEY THEY DON'T NOTICE IF A PHEasant

OR GALLINUS GOS MISSING.

LISTEN, I HAD EITHER STUFF IN MY MIND THAT NIGHT! SAID HARRY  
IMPATIENTLY. WE ALL DID, REMEMBER?

I DIDN'T KNOW REPUBLICAN CHILD VANISHES, RENN MUTTERED. I  
THOUGHT I WAS PAYING THEM BACK, THEY SHOULDN'T BE GIVEN ME THAT  
CHILDREN CANNON FOR CHRISTMAS.

FORGET IT, ALL RIGHT? SAID HARRY.

RENN SPARED A ROAST POTATO IN THE END OF HIS FORK, GLARING AT  
IT. THEN HE SAID, I HATE BEING POOR.

HARRY AND HERMINIE LOOKED AT EACH OTHER. NEITHER OF THEM  
REALLY KNEW WHAT THE SAY.

IT'S RUSSISH, SAID RENN, STILL GLARING DOWN AT HIS POTATO. I  
DON'T BLAME FRED AND GEORGE FOR TRYING TO MAKE SOME EXTRA  
MONEY, WISH I COULD, WISH I HAD A DOLLAR.

WELL, WE KNOW WHAT THE GET WHEN NEXT CHRISTMAS, SAID  
HERMIONE BRIGHTLY. THEN, WHEN RON CONTINUED THE LAUGH CLEVERLY,  
SHE SAID, COME ON, RON, IT COULD BE WORSE. AT LEAST YOUR FIN-  
GERS AREN'T FULL OF POLIS. HERMIONE WAS HAVING A BIT OF DIFFICULTY  
MANAGING HER KNIFE AND FORK, HER FINGERS WERE SO STIFF AND  
SWOLLEN. I HATE THAT SKEETER WOMAN! SHE BLURT OUT SAVAGELY.  
I'LL GET HER BACK FOR THIS IF IT'S THE LAST THING I DO!

\*

LATE MAIL CONTINUED THE ARRIVE FOR HERMIONE OVER THE FOLLOWING  
WEEK, AND ALTHOUGH SHE FOLLOWED MAGGIE'S ADVICE AND STOPPED  
OPENING IT, SEVERAL OF HER ILL-WISHERS SENT FOLLOWERS, WHICH  
EXPLODED AT THE GRYFFINDOR TABLE AND STRIDDED INSULTS AT HER FOR  
THE WHOLE FALL THE YEAR. EVEN THOSE PEOPLE WHO DIDN'T READ  
WITCH WEEKLY KNEW ALL ABOUT THE SUPPOSED HARRY DOLLY  
HERMIONE TRIANGLE NOW. HARRY WAS GETTING SICK OF TELLING

THE MADNESS OF MR CRUELTY AND  
PEOPLE THAT HERMIONE WASN'T HIS GIRLFRIEND.

IT WAS THE DEATH, HOWEVER, HE TOLD HERMIONE, IF WE JUST IGNORE  
IT ... PEOPLE GET BORED WITH THAT STUFF SHE WROTE ABOUT ME LAST  
TIME

I WANT THE KNOW HOW SHE'S LISTENING INTO PRIVATE CONVERSA-

THINGS WHEN SHE S SLIPPED THE KE BANNED FROM THE GREENS?

SAID HERMINE ANGERILY.

HERMINE FILING BACK IN THEIR NEXT DEFENCE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS LESSON THE ASK PROFESSOR MEEDY SOMETHING. THE REST OF THE CLASS WERE VERY EAGER TO LEAVE; MEEDY HAD GIVEN THEM SUCH A RIGOROUS TEST OF HER DEFLECTION THAT MANY OF THEM WERE NURSING SMALL INJURIES. HARRY HAD SUCH A BAD CASE OF TWITCHY EARS, HE HAD THE FEEL HIS HANDS CLAMPED OVER THEM AS HE WALKED AWAY FROM THE CLASS.

WELL, RITA S DEFINITELY NOT USING AN INVISIBILITY CHARM?

HERMINE PANTED FIVE MINUTES LATER, CATCHING UP WITH HARRY AND REIN IN THE ENTRANCE HALL AND PULLING HARRY S HAND AWAY FROM HINE OF HIS WIGGLING EARS SHE THAT HE COULD HEAR. MEEDY SAYS HE DIDN T SEE HER ANYWHERE NEAR THE ILDGES TABLE AT THE SECOND TASK, OR ANYWHERE NEAR THE LAKE?

HERMINE, IS THERE ANY POINT TELLING THEM THE DREEP THIS? SAID REIN.

NEH? SAID HERMINE STUBBERNLY. I WANT THE DREEL WHEN SHE HEARD ME TALKING THE VIDTEH? AND WHEN SHE FEELING BLIT ABELT HARRY S MUM?

MAYBE SHE HAD THEM KILLED, SAID HARRY.

KILLED? SAID REIN BLANKLY. WHAT ... PUT PLEASE HER HER SOMETHING?

HARRY STARTED EXPLAINING ABOUT HIDDEN MICROPHONES AND RECORDING EQUIPMENT.

REIN WAS FASCINATED, BUT HERMINE INTERRUPTED THEM. AREN T

WELL THEN EVER GOING THE ROAD HOGWARTS! A HISTER?

WHAT S THE POINT? SAID RHN, WELL DNEH IT HP BY HEART, WE  
CAN IUST ASD WELL.

ALL THESE SUBSTITUTES FOR MAGIC MUGGLES USE ELECTRICITY, AND

THE HARRY POTTER

COMPUTERS AND RADAR, AND ALL THESE THINGS THEY ALL GEE HAWKING  
AROUND HOGWARTS, THERE S THEE MUCH MAGIC IN THE AIR, NH, RITA S  
USING MAGIC THE EAVESDREPP, SHE MUST BE ... IF I COULD IUST FIND  
HWT WHAT IT IS ... HHH, IF IT S ILLEGAL, I LL HAVE HER ...

HAVEN T WE GHT ENOUGH THE WHIPPY ABHWT? RHN ASKED HER, DEH  
WE HAVE THE START A VENDETTA AGAINST RITA SKEETER AS WELL?

I M NHET ASKING WELL THE HELP? HERMIONE SNAPPED, I LL DEH IT  
HEN MY HLN?

SHE MARKED BACK UP THE MARBLE STAIRCASE WITHHWT A BACK-  
WARD GLANCE, HARRY WAS HWT SURE SHE WAS GOING THE THE LIBRARY,

WHAT S THE BETTING SHE COMES BACK WITH A KKK HP I HATE RITA  
SKEETER BADGES? SAID RHN,

HERMIONE, HOWEVER, DID NHET ASK HARRY AND RHN THE HELP HER  
PURSUE VENGEANCE AGAINST RITA SKEETER, FOR WHICH THEY WERE  
BETH GRATEFUL, BECAUSE THEIR WERKHEAD WAS MEHNTING EVER HIGHER  
IN THE RLN-LP THE THE EASTER HOLIDAYS, HARRY STANDBY MARVELLED AT  
THE FACT THAT HERMIONE COULD RESEARCH MAGICAL METHODS HP  
EAVESDREPPING AS WELL AS EVERYTHING ELSE THEY HAD THE DEH, SHE  
WAS WORKING PLAT HWT IUST THE GET THROUGH ALL THEIR HEPKHEAD,

THOUGH HE MADE A POINT OF SENDING REGULAR FEED PACKAGES UP THE  
THE CAVE IN THE MOUNTAIN FOR SIRILIS; AFTER LAST SUMMER, HE HAD  
NOT FORGOTTEN WHAT IT FELT LIKE TO BE CONTINUALLY HUNGRY. HE  
ENCLOSED NOTES TO SIRILIS, TELLING HIM THAT NOTHING BUT THE  
ORDINARY HAD HAPPENED, AND THAT THEY WERE STILL WAITING FOR AN  
ANSWER FROM PERCY.

HEDWIG DIDN'T RETURN UNTIL THE END OF THE EASTER HOLIDAYS.

PERCY'S LETTER WAS ENCLOSED IN A PACKAGE OF EASTER EGGS THAT MRS

WEASLEY HAD SENT. BOTH HARRY'S AND RON'S WERE THE SIZE OF DRAG-  
ON EGGS, AND FULL OF HOME-MADE TUFFEE. HERMION'S, HOWEVER,

WAS SMALLER THAN A CHICKEN'S EGG. HER FACE PALL WHEN SHE SAW IT.

WELL, MUM DOESN'T READ LITTE WEEKLY, BY ANY CHANCE, DOES  
SHE, RON? SHE ASKED ELIETLY.

Yeah, said RON, WHOSE MOUTH WAS FULL OF TUFFEE. GETS IT FOR  
THE RECIPES.

HERMION BEHEED SADLY AT HER TINY EGG.

THE MADNESS OF MR CRUELTY

DIDN'T WELL WANT TO SEE WHAT PERCY'S WRITTEN? HARRY ASKED  
HER HASTILY.

PERCY'S LETTER WAS SHORT AND IRRITABLE.

AS I AM CONSTANTLY TELLING THE DAILY PROPHET, MR CRUELTY  
IS TAKING A WELL-DESERVED BREAK. HE IS SENDING IN REGULAR  
HELPS WITH INSTRUCTIONS. NO, I HAVEN'T ACTUALLY SEEN HIM, BUT I

THINK I CAN BE TRUSTED TO KNOW MY OWN SUPERIOR HAND-  
WRITING, I HAVE ELITE KNOWLEDGE OF THE MEMENTO MORTUUM

TRYING TO ELUDE THESE RIDICULOUS ALLEGATIONS. PLEASE DON'T  
BOTHER ME AGAIN UNLESS IT IS SOMETHING IMPORTANT. HAPPY  
EASTER.

\*

THE START OF THE SUMMER TERM WOULD NORMALLY HAVE MEANT THAT  
HARRY WAS TRAINING HARD FOR THE LAST QUIDDITCH MATCH OF THE  
SEASON. THIS YEAR, HOWEVER, IT WAS THE THIRD AND FINAL TASK IN  
THE TRIWIZARD TOURNAMENT FOR WHICH HE NEEDED TO PREPARE, BUT  
HE STILL DIDN'T KNOW WHAT HE WOULD HAVE TO DO. FINALLY, IN THE  
LAST WEEK OF MAY, PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL HELD HIM BACK IN  
TRANSFIGURATION.

WELL ARE YOU DOWN THE QUIDDITCH PITCH TONIGHT AT NINE  
O'CLOCK, BETTER. SHE TOLD HIM. MR BAGMAN WILL BE THERE TO TELL  
THE CHAMPIONS ABOUT THE THIRD TASK.

AT HALF PAST EIGHT THAT NIGHT, HARRY LEFT RON AND HERMION  
IN GRYFFINDOR TOWER, AND WENT DOWNSTAIRS. AS HE CROSSED THE  
ENTRANCE HALL, CEDRIC CAME UP FROM THE HUFFLEPUFF COMMON  
ROOM.

WHAT DO YOU RECKON IT'S GOING TO BE? HE ASKED HARRY, AS THEY  
WENT TOGETHER DOWN THE STONE STEPS, OUT INTO THE CLOUDY NIGHT.

WELL DOESN'T SEEM ANY MORE LIKE A WANDERFUL TRIP, SHE RECKONS  
WE'VE GOT TO FIND THE TREASURE.

THAT WOULDNT BE THE BAD, SAID HARRY, THINKING THAT HE  
WOULD SIMPLY ASK HAGRID FOR A NIPPER TO DO THE JOB FOR HIM.  
THEY WALKED DOWN THE DARK LAWN TO THE HOGWARTHS STADIUM,

AND HARRY PETER

TURNED THROUGH A GAP IN THE STANDS, AND WALKED OUT ONTO  
THE PITCH.

WHAT ARE THEY DOING TO IT? CEDRIC SAID INDIGNANTLY, STOPPING  
DEAD.

THE HOGWARTHS PITCH WAS NO LONGER SMOOTH AND FLAT. IT  
LOOKED AS THOUGH SOMEONE HAD BEEN BUILDING HERE, WITH WALLS  
ALL OVER IT, TWISTING AND CRISS-CROSSING IN EVERY DIRECTION.

THEY'RE HEDGES! SAID HARRY, BENDING TO EXAMINE THE NEAREST  
ONE.

WELL, THERE! CALLED A CHEERFUL VOICE.

LUDWIG BAGMAN WAS STANDING IN THE MIDDLE OF THE PITCH WITH  
DOLLY AND PLEUR. HARRY AND CEDRIC MADE THEIR WAY TOWARDS  
THEM, CLIMBING OVER THE HEDGES. PLEUR BEAMED AT HARRY AS HE  
CAME NEARER. HER ATTITUDE TO HIM HAD CHANGED COMPLETELY SINCE  
HE HAD PLUCKED HER SISTER OUT OF THE LAKE.

WELL, WHAT DO YOU THINK? SAID BAGMAN HAPPILY, AS HARRY AND  
CEDRIC CLIMBED OVER THE LAST HEDGE. GRINNING NICELY, AREN'T  
THEY? GIVE THEM A MONTH AND HAGRID WILL HAVE THEM TWENTY FEET

HIGH. DONT YOU THINK? HE ADDED GRINNING, SPOTTING THE LESS-THAN-  
HAPPY EXPRESSIONS ON HARRY AND CEDRIC'S FACES. YOU WILL HAVE

THEIR ELIQUITCH PITCH BACK THE NORMAL HENCE THE TASK IS EVER?

NEEL, I IMAGINE YOU CAN GUESS WHAT WE'RE MAKING HERE?

NEE HNK SPEER FOR A MOMENT. THEN

MAZE, GRUNTED ORLM.

THAT'S RIGHT! SAID RAGMAN. A MAZE. THE THIRD TASK IS REALLY VERY STRAIGHTFORWARD. THE TRIWIZARD CUP WILL BE PLACED IN THE CENTRE OF THE MAZE. THE FIRST CHAMPION THE THINK IT WILL RECEIVE ALL MARKS.

WE SIMPLY AVE TO GET THROUGH THE MAZE? SAID FELIX.

THERE WILL BE OBSTACLES, SAID RAGMAN HAPPILY, BOUNCING ON THE BALLS OF HIS FEET. HAGRID IS PROVIDING A NUMBER OF CREATURES ... THEN THERE WILL BE SPELLS THAT MUST BE BROKEN ... ALL THAT SORT OF THING, YOU KNOW. NEEL, THE CHAMPIONS WHO ARE LEADING THE POINTS WILL GET A HEAD START INTO THE MAZE. RAGMAN GRINNED AT HARRY AND LEO. THEN MR ORLM WILL ENTER ... THEN MISS

THE MADNESS OF MR CRUELTY???

DELAHEIR. BUT YOU'LL ALL BE IN WITH A FIGHTING CHANCE, DEPENDING ON HOW WELL YOU GET PAST THE OBSTACLES. SHOULD BE FUN, EH?

HARRY, WHO KNEW ONLY TOO WELL THE KIND OF CREATURES THAT HAGRID WAS LIKELY TO PROVIDE FOR AN EVENT LIKE THIS, THOUGHT IT WAS UNLIKELY TO BE ANY FUN AT ALL. HOWEVER, HE NEEDED POLITELY LIKE THE OTHER CHAMPIONS.

VERY WELL ... IF YOU HAVEN'T GOTTEN ANY QUESTIONS, WE'LL GO BACK UP TO THE CASTLE, SHALL WE. IT'S A BIT CHILLY ...

RAGMAN FLURRIED ALONGSIDE HARRY AS THEY BEGAN THE WEND

THEIR WAY INTO THE GREENING MAZE. HARRY HAD THE FEELING THAT



RAGMAN WAS GOING TO START HOPPING TO HELP HIM AGAIN, BUT JUST THEN, ORLIN TAPPED HARRY ON THE SHOULDER.

WOULD I HAVE A VERB?

YES, ALL RIGHT, SAID HARRY, SLIGHTLY SURPRISED.

WILL YOU WALK WITH ME?

YES, SAID HARRY COURTEOUSLY.

RAGMAN SMILED SLIGHTLY PERTURBED. I WILL WAIT FOR YOU, HARRY, SHALL I?

YES, IT'S YES, MR RAGMAN, SAID HARRY, SUPPRESSING A SMILE. I THINK I CAN FIND THE CASTLE ON MY OWN, THANKS.

HARRY AND ORLIN LEFT THE STABLES TOGETHER, BUT ORLIN DID NOT GET A CHANCE FOR THE DORMSTRANG SHIP. INSTEAD, HE WALKED TOWARDS THE FOREST.

WHAT ARE WE GOING THIS WAY FOR? SAID HARRY, AS THEY PASSED HAGRID'S CARRIAGE, AND THE ILLUMINATED BEASTS' CARRIAGE.

DON'T WANT TO BE HEARD, SAID ORLIN SHORTLY.

WHEN AT LAST THEY HAD REACHED A QUIET STREET OF GREENS, A SHORT WAY FROM THE BEASTS' PADDOCK, ORLIN STOPPED IN THE SHADE OF THE TREES AND TURNED THE FACE HARRY.

I WANT TO KNOW, HE SAID, GLENNING, WHAT THERE IS BETWEEN YOU AND HERMION-NINNY.

HARRY, WHO FROM ORLIN'S SECRETIVE MANNER HAD EXPECTED SOMETHING MUCH MORE SERIOUS THAN THIS, STARED UP AT ORLIN IN AMAZEMENT.

NOTHING, HE SAID, BUT ORLIN GLENNED AT HIM, AND HARRY,

AND HARRY PETER

SOMEONE STRUCK AND BY THE TALL DURLIN WAS FLABBERGATED.

WE'RE FRIENDS, SHE'S MET MY GIRLFRIEND AND SHE NEVER HAS BEEN.

IT'S JUST THAT SKEETER WHEMAN MAKING THINGS UP.

FERRY-HORN-NINDY TAKES ABILITY VERY OFTEN, SAID DURLIN,  
LOOKING SUSPICIOUSLY AT F-HARRY.

YEAH, SAID F-HARRY, BECAUSE WE'RE FRIENDS.

HE COULDN'T BELIEVE BELIEVE HE WAS HAVING THIS CONVERSATION  
WITH VICTOR DURLIN, THE FAMOUS INTERNATIONAL FLUIDITY PLAYER.  
IT WAS AS THOUGH THE EIGHTEEN-YEAR-OLD DURLIN THOUGHT HE,  
F-HARRY, WAS AN EQUAL A REAL RIVAL

YOU HAVEN'T ... YOU HAVEN'T MET ...

NO, SAID F-HARRY, VERY FIRMLY.

DURLIN SMILED SLIGHTLY HAPPIER, HE STARED AT F-HARRY FOR A FEW  
SECONDS, THEN SAID, YOU ARE VERY WELL, I WAS WATCHING AT THE FIRST  
TASK.

THANKS, SAID F-HARRY, GRINNING BROADLY, AND SUDDENLY FEELING  
MUCH TALLER HIMSELF. I SAW YOU AT THE FLUIDITY WORLD CUP,  
THE WINDSWEPT PRIZE, YOU REALLY

BUT SOMETHING MOVED BEHIND DURLIN IN THE TREES, AND F-HARRY,  
WHO HAD SOME EXPERIENCE OF THE SORT OF THING THAT WORKED IN  
THE FOREST, INSTINCTIVELY GRABBED DURLIN'S ARM AND PULLED HIM  
AROUND.

WHAT IS IT?

F-HARRY SHOOK HIS HEAD, STARING AT THE PLACE WHERE HE'D SEEN  
MOVEMENT, HE SLIPPED HIS HAND INSIDE HIS REEKS, REACHING FOR  
HIS HAND.

NEXT MOMENT A MAN HAD STAGGERED OUT FROM BEHIND A TALL

HAD, FOR A MOMENT, HARRY DIDN'T RECOGNISE HIM ... THEN HE  
REALISED IT WAS MR CRUELICH.

HE BEHEVED AS THOUGH HE HAD BEEN TRAVELLING FOR DAYS. THE  
KNEES OF HIS BREEKS WERE RIPPED AND BLEEDY; HIS FACE SCRATCHED;  
HE WAS UNSHAVEN AND GREY WITH EXHAUSTION. HIS NEAT HAIR AND  
MUSTACHE WERE BOTH IN NEED OF A WASH AND A TRIM. HIS STRANGE  
APPEARANCE, HOWEVER, WAS NOTHING TO THE WAY HE WAS BEHAVING.  
MUTTERING AND GESTICULATING, MR CRUELICH APPEARED TO BE TALKING

THE MADNESS OF MR CRUELICH WAS

THE SOMETHING THAT HE ALONE COULD SEE. HE REMINDED HARRY VIVIDLY  
OF AN OLD TRAMP HE HAD SEEN ONCE WHEN HELT SHEPPING WITH THE  
BLURLES. THAT MAN, THEN, HAD BEEN CONVERSING WILDLY WITH THEM  
AIR; ALINT PETLINIA HAD SEIZED BLURLEY'S HAND AND PULLED HIM  
ACROSS THE ROAD TO AVOID HIM; LITTLE VERNEEN HAD THEN TREATED  
THE FAMILY TO A LONG RANT ABOUT WHAT HE WOULD LIKE TO DO WITH  
PEGGARS AND VAGRANTS.

WHEN THE AILDER? SAID DOLIM, STARING AT MR CRUELICH. ISN'T  
HE WITH YOUR MINISTRY?

HARRY NEEDED, HESITATED FOR A MOMENT, THEN WALKED SILENTLY  
TOWARDS MR CRUELICH, WHO DID NOT LOOK AT HIM, BUT CONTINUED TO  
TALK TO A NEARBY TREE! ... AND WHEN YOU'VE DONE THAT,  
WEATHERED, SEND AN EEL TO DUMBLEDORE CONFIRMING THE NUMBER  
OF DISMISSED STUDENTS WHO WILL BE ATTENDING THE TOURNAMENT.  
DUMBLEDORE HAS JUST SENT WORD THERE WILL BE TWELVE ...

MR CRUELICH SAID HARRY CALMLY.

... AND THEN SEND ANOTHER EEL TO MADAME MAXIME, RECALISE

SHE MIGHT WANT THE LIP THE NUMBER OF STUDENTS SHE'S BRINGING,  
NEED HARDWARE? I MADE IT A BEHIND DEZEN ... DEE THAT, WEATHERY,  
WILL YELLY WILL YELLY WILL ... MR CRUELICH'S EYES WERE BULGING, HE  
STOOD STARING AT THE TREE, MUTTERING SHLUDLESSLY AT IT, THEN HE  
STAGGERED SIDELAYS, AND FELL TO HIS KNEES.

MR CRUELICH HARRY SAID BEHLDLY, ARE YELLY ALL RIGHT?  
CRUELICH'S EYES WERE BEHLLING IN HIS HEAD, HARRY BEHHEED ABEHLLING

AT DURLUM, WHO HAD BEHHEHED HIM INTO THE TREES, AND WAS BEHHEX-  
ING BEHLLN AT CRUELICH IN ALARM.

WHAT IS WRONG WITH HIM?

NEE IDEA, HARRY MUTTERED, LISTEN, YELLY D BETTER GEE AND GET  
SHEMKEHNE

DUMKLEDBHRE? GASPED MR CRUELICH, HE REACHED BEHT AND  
SEIZED A HANDFUL OF HARRY'S REEKS, DRAGGING HIM CLESTER, THOUGH  
HIS EYES WERE STARING OVER HARRY'S HEAD, I NEED ... SEE ...  
DUMKLEDBHRE ...

HEE, SAID HARRY, IF YELLY GET LIP, MR CRUELICH, WE CAN GEE LIP THE  
THE

THE HARRY MUTTERED

I VE BEENE ... STUPID ... THING ... MR CRUELICH BREATHED, HE  
BEHHEED LITTERLY MAD, HIS EYES WERE BEHLLING AND BULGING, AND A  
TRICKLE OF SPITTLE WAS SLIDING BEHLLN HIS CHIN, EVERY WORD HE  
SPHORE SEEMED TO CHEST HIM A TERRIBLE SPHEERT, MUST ... TELL ...  
DUMKLEDBHRE ...

GET UP, MR CRUELICH, SAID HARRY BOLDLY AND CLEARLY, GET UP,  
I LL TAKE YOU TO DUMBLEDORE!

MR CRUELICH S EYES WELLED FORWARDS TOWARDS HARRY,

WHEN ... YOU? HE WHISPERED,

I M A STUDENT AT THE SCHOOL, SAID HARRY, LEANING AROUND AT  
DURUM FOR SOME HELP, BUT DURUM WAS HANGING BACK, LEANING  
EXTREMELY NERVOUSLY,

YOU RE NOT ... HIS? WHISPERED CRUELICH, HIS MOUTH SAGGING,

NO, SAID HARRY, WITHOUT THE FAINTEST IDEA WHAT CRUELICH WAS  
TALKING ABOUT,

DUMBLEDORE IS?

THAT S RIGHT, SAID HARRY,

CRUELICH WAS PULLING HIM CLOSER; HARRY TRIED TO WEAKEN

CRUELICH S GRIP ON HIS REEKS, BUT IT WAS TOO POWERFUL,

WARN ... DUMBLEDORE ...

I LL GET DUMBLEDORE IF YOU LET GO OF ME, SAID HARRY, JUST LET  
GO, MR CRUELICH, AND I LL GET HIM ...

THANK YOU, WEATHERBY, AND WHEN YOU HAVE DONE THAT, I

WOULD LIKE A CUP OF TEA, MY WIFE AND SON WILL BE ARRIVING SHORT-  
LY, WE ARE ATTENDING A CONCERT TONIGHT WITH MR AND MRS FLICE,

CRUELICH WAS NOW TALKING ALIENLY TO A TREE AGAIN, AND SEEMED  
COMPLETELY UNAWARE THAT HARRY WAS THERE, WHICH SURPRISED  
HARRY SO MUCH HE DIDN T NOTICE THAT CRUELICH HAD RELEASED HIM,

YES, MY SON HAS RECENTLY GAINED TWELVE EELS, MOST SATISFAC-

THEY, YES, THANK YOU, YES, VERY PLEASED INDEED, NOW, IF YOU COULD

BRING ME THAT MEMO FROM THE ANDERMAN MINISTER FOR MAGIC, I  
THINK I WILL HAVE TIME TO DRAFT A RESPONSE ...

YOU STAY HERE WITH HIM? HARRY SAID TO DRUM, I LL GET  
DUMBLEDORE, I LL BE BACK, I KNOW WHERE HIS OFFICE IS

HE IS MAD, SAID DRUM DELIGHTFULLY, STARING DOWN AT CRUELCH,

THE MADNESS OF MR CRUELCH WAS

WHEN WAS STILL CARLING THE TREE, APPARENTLY CONVINCED IT WAS  
PERCY,

JUST STAY WITH HIM, SAID HARRY, STARTING TO GET UP, BUT HIS  
MOVEMENT SEEMED TO TRIGGER ANOTHER ABRUPT CHANGE IN MR  
CRUELCH, WHEN SEIZED HIM HARD AROUND THE WRISTS AND PULLED  
HARRY BACK TO THE GROUND,

DONT ... LEAVE ... ME? HE WHISPERED, HIS EYES GLUING AGAIN,

I ... ESCAPED ... MUST WARN ... MUST TELL ... SEE DUMBLEDORE ...  
MY FALUT ... ALL MY FALUT ... BERTHA ... DEAD ... ALL MY FALUT ...  
MY SHIN ... MY FALUT ... TELL DUMBLEDORE ... HARRY PETER ... THE  
DARK LORD ... STRONGER ... HARRY PETER ...

I LL GET DUMBLEDORE IF YOU LET ME GO, MR CRUELCH? SAID  
HARRY, HE LEANED FORWARDLY AROUND AT DRUM, HELP ME, WILL  
YOU?

BEHAVING EXTREMELY APPREHENSIVE, DRUM MOVED FORWARD AND  
SHELTATED DOWN NEXT TO MR CRUELCH,

JUST KEEP HIM HERE, SAID HARRY, PULLING HIMSELF FREE OF MR  
CRUELCH, I LL BE BACK WITH DUMBLEDORE,

HARRY, WHEN THEY HEARD DRAGON CALLED AFTER HIM, AS HARRY SPRINTED AWAY FROM THE FOREST, AND UP THROUGH THE DARK CORRIDORS. THEY WERE DESERTED; BAGMAN, CROOK AND FLEWBY HAD DISAPPEARED. HARRY THEN UP THE STONE STEPS, THROUGH THE HALLS OF THE DEPTHS AND UP THE MARBLE STAIRCASE, TOWARDS THE SECOND FLOOR. FIVE MINUTES LATER HE WAS FLIGHTING TOWARDS A STONE GARGOYLE STANDING HALFWAY ALONG AN EMPTY CORRIDOR.

HEAR-HEAR-HEAR! HE PANTED AT IT.

THIS WAS THE PASSAGE TO THE HIDDEN STAIRCASE THE DUMBLEDORE'S OFFICE. HE, AT LEAST, IT HAD BEEN TWO YEARS AGO. THE PASSAGE HAD EVIDENTLY CHANGED, HOWEVER, FOR THE STONE GARGOYLE DID NOT SPRING THE LIFE AND LIMP ASIDE, BUT STOOD FROZEN, GLARING AT HARRY MALICIOUSLY.

MOVE! HARRY SHOUTED AT IT. [HEARD]

BUT NOTHING AT HOGWARTS HAD EVER MOVED JUST BECAUSE HE SHOUTED AT IT; HE KNEW IT WAS NOT GOOD. HE MOVED UP AND DOWN THE DARK CORRIDOR, PERHAPS DUMBLEDORE WAS IN THE STAFF ROOM.

HE HARRY PETER

HE STARTED RUNNING AS FAST AS HE COULD TOWARDS THE STAIRCASE PETER:

HARRY SKIDDED TO A HALT AND MOVED AROUND.

SNAPE HAD JUST EMERGED FROM THE HIDDEN STAIRCASE BEHIND THE STONE GARGOYLE. THE WALL WAS SLIDING SHUT BEHIND HIM EVEN AS HE RECOGNIZED HARRY RAN TOWARDS HIM. WHAT ARE YOU DOING HERE, PETER?

I NEED TO SEE PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE! SAID HARRY, RUNNING

BACK UP THE CORRIDOR AND SKIDDING TO A STANDSTILL IN FRONT OF  
SNAPE INSTEAD. IT'S MR CRUICKSHANK ... HE'S JUST TURNED UP ... HE'S IN  
THE FOREST ... HE'S ASKING

WHAT IS THIS BUSINESS? SAID SNAPE, HIS BLACK EYES GLITTERING.  
WHAT ARE YOU TALKING ABOUT?

MR CRUICKSHANK? HARRY SPELLED, FROM THE MINISTRY? HE'S TELLING  
SOMETHING ... HE'S IN THE FOREST, HE WANTS TO SEE DUMBLEDORE?  
JUST GIVE ME THE PASSWORD UP THE

THE HEADMASTER IS BUSY, PETER, SAID SNAPE, HIS THIN MOUTH  
CURLING INTO AN UNPLEASANT SMILE.

I'VE GOT TO TELL DUMBLEDORE? HARRY YELLED.  
DIDN'T YOU HEAR ME, PETER?

HARRY COULD TELL SNAPE WAS THERELICIOUSLY ENJOYING HIMSELF,  
DENYING HARRY THE THING HE WANTED WHEN HE WAS SO PANICKED.

LEWIS, SAID HARRY ANGRILY, CRUICKSHANK ISN'T RIGHT ... HE'S ... HE'S HELD  
OFF HIS MIND ... HE SAYS HE WANTS TO TALK

THE STONE WALL BEHIND SNAPE SLID OPEN, DUMBLEDORE WAS  
STANDING THERE, WEARING LONG GREEN ROBES, AND A MILDLY CURIOUS  
EXPRESSION.

IS THERE A PROBLEM? HE SAID, LEERING BETWEEN HARRY AND  
SNAPE.

PROFESSOR? HARRY SAID, SIDE-STEPPING SNAPE BEFORE SNAPE  
COULD SPEAK. MR CRUICKSHANK IS HERE ... HE'S DOWN IN THE FOREST, HE  
WANTS TO SPEAK TO YOU?

HARRY EXPECTED DUMBLEDORE TO ASK HELIXTHUS KILT, THE HIS  
RELIEF, DUMBLEDORE DID NOTHING OF THE SORT. LEAD THE WAY, HE  
SAID PREMPTLY, AND HE SWIFT OFF ALONG THE CORRIDOR BEHIND



THE MADNESS OF MR CREELEY WAS

HARRY, LEAVING SNAPE STANDING NEXT THE CARCER AND LEAVING  
TWICE AS LONG.

WHAT DID MR CREELEY SAY, HARRY? SAID DUMBLEDORE, AS THEY  
WALKED SWIFTLY DOWN THE MARBLE STAIRCASE.

SAID HE WANTS THE WARDEN ... SAID HE'S DONE SOMETHING  
TERRIBLE ... HE MENTIONED HIS SON ... AND BERTHA JORDAN ... AND  
AND VERMONT ... SOMETHING ABOUT VERMONT GETTING  
STRONGER ...

INDEED, SAID DUMBLEDORE, AND HE QUICKENED HIS PACE AS  
THEY HURRIED INTO THE PITCH-DARKNESS.

HE'S NOT ACTING NORMALLY, HARRY SAID, HURRYING ALONG BESIDE  
DUMBLEDORE. HE DOESN'T SEEM TO KNOW WHERE HE IS. HE KEEPS  
TALKING LIKE HE THINKS PERCY WEASLEY IS THERE, AND THEN HE  
CHANGES, AND SAYS HE NEEDS TO SEE ... I LEFT HIM WITH VICTOR  
CRUM.

WHAT DID? SAID DUMBLEDORE SHARPLY, AND HE BEGAN THE TASK  
LONGER STRIDES STILL, SEE THAT HARRY WAS RUNNING THE DEEP LIP, DID  
HE KNOW IF ANYBODY ELSE SAW MR CREELEY?

NO, SAID HARRY, CRUM AND I WERE TALKING, MR BAGMAN HAD  
JUST FINISHED TELLING US ABOUT THE THIRD TASK, WE STAYED BEHIND,  
AND THEN WE SAW MR CREELEY COMING INTO THE FOREST

WHERE ARE THEY? SAID DUMBLEDORE, AS THE REALIZATION CAR-  
RIAGE EMERGED FROM THE DARKNESS.

EVER HERE, SAID HARRY, MOVING IN FRONT OF DUMBLEDORE,  
LEADING THE WAY THROUGH THE TREES. HE COULDN'T HEAR CRACKS &  
WHIR AND WHIR, BUT HE KNEW WHERE HE WAS GOING; IT HADN'T  
BEEN MUCH PAST THE BEAUKRATHEN'S CARRIAGE ... SOMEWHERE  
AROUND HERE ...

WORTHY HARRY SMILED,

AND HE ANSWERED,

THEY WERE HERE, HARRY SAID TO DUMBLEDORE. THEY WERE  
DEFINITELY SOMEWHERE AROUND HERE ...

WELL, DUMBLEDORE SAID, LIGHTING HIS WAND AND HOLDING IT  
UP,

ITS NARROW BEAM TRAVELLED FROM BLACK TOWNS TO BLACK TOWNS,

AND HARRY SMILED

ILLUMINATING THE GROUND, AND THEN IT FELL UPON A PAIR OF FEET,

HARRY AND DUMBLEDORE HURRIED FORWARDS, DRUM WAS

SPRAWLED ON THE FURTEST FLOOR, HE SEEMED TO BE UNCONSCIOUS,

THERE WAS NO SIGN AT ALL OF MR CRACK. DUMBLEDORE KNEW EVER  
DRUM AND GENTLY LIFTED HIM OF HIS EYES.

STUNNED, HE SAID SILENTLY, HIS HALF-MOON GLASSES GLITTERED IN  
THE WANDLIGHT AS HE PEERED AROUND AT THE SURROUNDING TREES.

SHOULD I GO AND GET SOMEONE? SAID HARRY, MADAM  
POWERS?

NO, SAID DUMBLEDORE SILENTLY, STAY HERE.

HE RAISED HIS WAND INTO THE AIR AND POINTED IT IN THE DIREC-

TION OF HARRY'S CAR. HARRY SAW SOMETHING SILVERY DART OUT OF

IT AND STREAK AWAY THROUGH THE TREES LIKE A GHOSTLY BIRD. THEN  
DUMBLEDORE KENT OVER DRAGON AGAIN, POINTED HIS WAND AT HIM,  
AND MUTTERED, RENOVATE.

DRAGON OPENED HIS EYES, HE LOOKED DAZED, WHEN HE SAW  
DUMBLEDORE, HE TRIED TO SIT UP, BUT DUMBLEDORE PUT A HAND ON  
HIS SHOULDER AND MADE HIM LIE STILL.

HE ATTACKED ME? DRAGON MUTTERED, PUTTING A HAND UP TO HIS  
HEAD. THE OLD MADMAN ATTACKED ME? I WAS THINKING AROUND THE  
SEE VARE BETTER HAD GONE AND HE ATTACKED FROM BEHIND?

LIE STILL FOR A MOMENT, DUMBLEDORE SAID.

THE SOUND OF THUNDERBOLTS RAINFALLS REACHED THEM, AND HARRY

CAME PANTING INTO SIGHT WITH FANG AT HIS HEELS, HE WAS CARRY-  
ING HIS CROSSBOW.

PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE? HE SAID, HIS EYES WIDENING. HARRY  
WHAT THE ?

HARRY, I NEED YOU TO GET PROFESSOR KARKAROFF, SAID  
DUMBLEDORE, HIS STUDENT HAS BEEN ATTACKED. WHEN YOU VE  
DONE THAT, KINDLY ALERT PROFESSOR MURPHY

WE NEED, DUMBLEDORE, SAID A WIZARDY GUY, I M HERE.

MURPHY WAS LIMPING TOWARDS THEM, LEANING ON HIS STAFF, HIS  
WAND LIT.

DAMN LEG, HE SAID FLIRTILY. WOULD VE BEEN HERE EARLIER ...

WHAT S HAPPENED? SNAPE SAID SOMETHING ABOUT CRUELTY

THE MADNESS OF MR CRELICH?

CRELICH? SAID HAGRID BLANKLY.

KARAKORFF, PLEASE, HAGRID? SAID DUMBLEDORE SHARPLY.

HEY YEAH ... RIGHT Y ARE, PROFESSOR ... SAID HAGRID, AND HE

TURNED AND DISAPPEARED INTO THE DARK TREES, FANG TRETTING AFTER HIM.

I DONT KNOW WHERE RATTY CRELICH IS, DUMBLEDORE TOLD MEEDY, BUT IT IS ESSENTIAL THAT WE FIND HIM.

I M MENT IT, GRIELED MEEDY, AND HE RAISED HIS WAND, AND LIMPED OFF INTO THE FOREST.

NEITHER DUMBLEDORE NOR HARRY SPEDD AGAIN UNTIL THEY HEARD THE UNMISTAKEABLE SOUNDS OF HAGRID AND FANG RETURNING.

KARAKORFF WAS HURRYING ALONG BEHIND THEM. HE WAS WEARING HIS SPEED SILVER FLIES, AND HE LOOKED PALE AND AGITATED.

WHAT IS THIS? HE CRIED, WHEN HE SAW KARIM IN THE GREEN, AND DUMBLEDORE AND HARRY BESIDE HIM. WHAT S GOING ON?

I WAS ATTACKED? SAID KARIM, SITTING UP NEEL, AND RUBBING HIS HEAD. MR CRELICH OR WHATEVER HIS NAME

CRELICH ATTACKED ME? CRELICH ATTACKED ME? THE TRILIZARD ILDER?

IGER, DUMBLEDORE BEGAN, BUT KARAKORFF HAD DRAWN HIMSELF UP, CLUTCHING HIS FLIES AROUND HIM, LOOKING LIVID.

TREACHERY? HE BELLELED, POINTING AT DUMBLEDORE. IT IS A PLOT? MEH AND MEH MINISTRY OF MAGIC HAVE LURED ME HERE

UNDER FALSE PRETEXTS, DUMBLEDORE? THIS IS NOT AN ELLIAL DEM- PETITION? FIRST MEH SNEAK BETTER INTO THE TOURNAMENT, THOUGH

HE IS UNDERAGE? WHEN HENRY OF VEHLER MINISTRY FRIENDS ATTEMPTS THE  
PLOT OF CHAMPIONSHIP HUNT OF ACTION? I SMELL DECEIT-DEALING AND  
CORRUPTION IN THIS WHOLE AFFAIR, AND YELL, DUMBLEDORE, YELL,  
WITH VEHLER TALK OF CLOSER INTERNATIONAL WIZARDING LINKS, OF  
REBUILDING OLD TIES, OF FORGETTING OLD DIFFERENCES HERE'S WHAT I  
THINK OF YELL!

KARDBAREFF SPAT MOUTH THE GRUELING AT DUMBLEDORE'S FEET. IN HENRY  
SWIFT MOVEMENT, FLACRID SEIZED THE FRONT OF KARDBAREFF'S FLURS,  
LIFTED HIM INTO THE AIR, AND SLAMMED HIM AGAINST A NEARBY TREE.  
APPELHEISE? FLACRID SNARLED, AS KARDBAREFF GASPED FOR BREATH,

XXX HARRY PETER

FLACRID'S MASSIVE FIST AT HIS THREAT, HIS FEET DANGLING IN MID-AIR.

FLACRID, NEH? DUMBLEDORE SEHELTED, HIS EYES FLASHING.

FLACRID REMOVED THE HAND PINNING KARDBAREFF TO THE TREE, AND  
KARDBAREFF SLID ALL THE WAY DOWN THE TRUNK AND SLIMPED IN A  
FLIBBLE AT ITS REHITS? A FEW TWIGS AND LEAVES SEHELTERED DOWN  
UPON HIS HEAD.

KINDLY ESCORT HARRY BACK UP TO THE CASTLE, FLACRID, SAID  
DUMBLEDORE SHARPLY.

BREATHING HEAVILY, FLACRID GAVE KARDBAREFF A GLEEWERING LOOK.

MAYBE I'D BETTER STAY HERE, HEADMASTER ...

YELL WILL TAKE HARRY BACK TO SCHOOL, FLACRID, DUMBLEDORE  
REPEATED FIRMLY. TAKE HIM RIGHT UP TO THE GRYFFINDOR TOWER, AND  
HARRY I WANT YELL TO STAY THERE. ANYTHING YELL MIGHT WANT TO  
DO AND HEELS YELL MIGHT WANT TO SEND THEY CAN WAIT UNTIL

MORNING, DID YOU UNDERSTAND ME?

ER YES, SAID HARRY, STARING AT HIM. HE HAD DUMBLEDORE  
KNOWING THAT, AT THAT VERY MOMENT, HE HAD BEEN THINKING ABOUT  
SENDING PIGWIDGEEHN STRAIGHT THE STRIPS, THE TELL HIM WHAT HAD  
HAPPENED?

I LL LEAVE FANG WITH YOU, HEADMASTER, LACRID SAID, STILL STAR-  
ING MENACINGLY AT KARKADENN, WHO WAS STILL SPRAWLED AT THE FOOT

OF THE TREE, TANGLED IN FLIES AND TREE-ROOTS. STAY, FANG, I MEAN,  
HARRY.

THEY MARCHED IN SILENCE PAST THE REALIZATIONS CARRIAGE AND  
UP TOWARDS THE CASTLE.

HE HAD DONE HE, LACRID GRIELED, AS THEY STRODE PAST THE LAKE.

HE HAD DONE HE ACCUSE DUMBLEDORE, LIKE DUMBLEDORE D BE ANY-  
THING LIKE THAT, LIKE DUMBLEDORE WANTED YOU IN THE

THEIRNAMENT IN THE FIRST PLACE, WHORIED? I DUNNEE WHEN I SEEN  
DUMBLEDORE MORE WHORIED THAN HE S KIN LATELY, AN YOU?

LACRID SUDDENLY SAID ANGRILY THE HARRY, WHO WHORIED UP AT HIM,  
TAKEN ABACK. WHAT WERE YOU DOING, WANDERING OFF WITH RUDDY  
DORLING HE S FROM DUMSTRANG, HARRY? CHILDEN IINXED YOU RIGHT  
THERE, CHILDEN HE? HADN MEEHOD TALIGHT YOU NOTHING? MAGINE  
LETTIN HIM BLUR YOU OFF HIM YOU MEAN

THE MADNESS OF MR CRUELTY 487

DEARLY'S ALL RIGHT? SAID F-JARRY, AS THEY CLIMBED THE STEPS INTO THE ENTRANCE HALL. HE WASN'T TRYING TO HIND ME, HE JUST WANTED THE TALK ABOUT F-ERMINE.

I'LL BE HAVING A FEW WORDS WITH HER, AN' ALL, SAID F-JAGRID GRIMLY, STEPPING UP THE STAIRS. THE LESS YOU'LL LET AYE TER BE WITH THESE FOREIGNERS, THE HAPPIER YOU'LL BE. YOU CAN TALK AND IF EM, YOU WERE GETTING ON ALL RIGHT WITH MADAME MAXIME, F-JARRY SAID, ANNOYED.

THEN YOU TALK TER ME ABOUT HER? SAID F-JAGRID, AND HE LOOKED WHITE AS PAPER FOR A MOMENT. I'VE GOT HER NUMBER NOW? TRYIN' TER GET BACK IN ME GOOD BOOKS, TRYIN' TER GET ME TER TELL HER WHAT'S GOIN' IN THE THIRD TALK. F-JA? YOU CAN TALK AND IF EM?

F-JAGRID WAS IN SUCH A BAD MOOD, F-JARRY WAS WHITE GLAD TO SAY GOODBYE TO HIM IN FRONT OF THE FAT LADY. HE CLAMBERED THROUGH THE PORTRAIT HOLE INTO THE CHAMBER ROOM, AND HURRIED STRAIGHT FOR THE CORNER WHERE BEN AND F-ERMINE WERE SITTING, TO TELL THEM WHAT HAD HAPPENED.

## CHAPTER TWENTY-NINE

### THE DREAM

IT COMES DOWN TO THIS, SAID F-ERMINE, RUBBING HER FOREHEAD. EITHER MR CRUELICH ATTACKED VICTOR, OR SOMEBODY ELSE ATTACKED BOTH OF THEM WHEN VICTOR WASN'T LOOKING.

IT MUST'VE BEEN CRUELICH, SAID BEN AT ONCE. THAT'S WHY HE

WAS GONE WHEN HARRY AND DUMBLEDORE GOT THERE. HE'D BEEN A RUNNER.

I DON'T THINK SHE, SAID HARRY, SHAKING HIS HEAD. HE SEEMED REALLY WRECK. I DON'T RECALL HE WAS UP TO DISAPPEARING HER ANYTHING.

WELL CAN'T DISAPPEAR IN THE HOGWARTS GREENS, HAVEN'T I TOLD YOU ENOUGH TIMES? SAID HERMION.

EEK ... WHEN'S THIS FOR A THEORY, SAID RON EXCITEDLY. RONN ATTACKED CRUELCH. NO, WAIT FOR IT. AND THEN STUNNED HIMSELF. AND MR CRUELCH EVAPORATED, DID HE? SAID HERMION COLDLY. EH, YES ...

IT WAS DAYBREAK. HARRY, RON AND HERMION HAD CROPT OUT OF THEIR DORMITORIES VERY EARLY, AND HURRIED UP TO THE HALLS TOGETHER TO SEND A NOTE TO SIRIUS. WHEN THEY WERE STANDING

LOOKING OUT AT THE MISTY GREENS, ALL THREE OF THEM WERE FLAT-EYED AND PALE, BECAUSE THEY HAD BEEN TALKING LATE INTO THE

NIGHT ABOUT MR CRUELCH.

LISTEN THROUGH IT AGAIN, HARRY, SAID HERMION. WHAT DID MR CRUELCH ACTUALLY SAY?

I'VE TOLD YOU, HE WASN'T MAKING MUCH SENSE, SAID HARRY. HE

SAID HE WANTED TO WARN DUMBLEDORE ABOUT SOMETHING. HE DEFINITELY MENTIONED BERTHA JORDANS, AND HE SEEMED TO THINK SHE

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WAS DEAD, F-HE KEPT SAYING STUFF WAS HIS FAULT ... HE MENTIONED HIS SHIN,

WELL, THAT WAS HIS FAULT, SAID F-HERMIONE TESTILY,

F-HE WAS BLIT HP HIS MIND, SAID F-HARRY, F-HALF THE TIME HE SEEMED THE THINK HIS WIFE AND SHIN WERE STILL ALIVE, AND HE KEPT TALKING THE PERCY ABELT WORDS AND GIVING HIM INSTALKTIONS,

AND ... REMIND ME WHAT HE SAID ABELT YELI-DONEL-W-HEH SAID REEN TENTATIVELY,

I VE THLD YELI, F-HARRY REPEATED DULLY, F-HE SAID HE S GETTING STRONGER,

THERE WAS A PALSE,

THEN REEN SAID IN A FALSELY CONFIDENT VOICE, BLIT HE WAS BLIT HP HIS MIND, LIKE YELI SAID, SHE HALF HP IT WAS PROBABLY ILST RAVING ...

F-HE WAS SANEEST WHEN HE WAS TRYING THE TALK ABELT VHEDEMENT, SAID F-HARRY, IGNORING REEN S WINCE, F-HE WAS HAVING REAL TREBLEE STRINGING THE WORDS TOGETHER, BLIT THAT WAS WHEN HE SEEMED THE DONEL WHERE HE WAS, AND DONEL WHAT HE WANTED THE DEE, F-HE ILST KEPT SAYING HE HAD THE SEE DUMBLEDORE,

F-HARRY TURNED AWAY FROM THE WINDOW AND STARED UP INTO THE RAFTERS, F-HALF THE MANY PERCHES WERE EMPTY; EVERY NELL AND

THEN, ANOTHER HELL WOULD SLEEP IN THROUGH ONE OF THE WINDOWS, RETURNING FROM ITS NIGHT S HUNTING WITH A MELLSE IN ITS BEAK,

IF SNAPE HADN T HELD ME UP, F-HARRY SAID KITTERLY, WE MIGHT VE

GET THERE IN TIME. THE HEADMASTER IS RUSS, BETTER ... WHAT IS  
THIS RUSSISH, BETTER? WHY WON'T HE HAVE JUST GET OUT OF THE  
WAY?

MAYBE HE DIDN'T WANT YOU TO GET THERE? SAID RICH QUICKLY,  
MAYBE HANGING HIMSELF FAST & YOU WOULD HE COULD BE GET  
DOWN THE THE FOREST? & YOU WOULD HE COULD BE BEATEN YOU AND  
DUMBLEDORE THERE?

NOT UNLESS HE CAN TURN HIMSELF INTO A BAT OR SOMETHING,  
SAID HARRY.

WOULDNT YOU PUT IT PAST HIM, RICH MUTTERED.

THE HARRY BETTER

WE NEED TO SEE PROFESSOR MURPHY, SAID HERMION. WE NEED  
TO FIND OUT WHETHER HE KNOWS MR CRATCH.

IF HE HAD THE MARAUDER'S MAP WITH HIM, IT WOULD BE EASY,  
SAID HARRY.

UNLESS CRATCH WAS ALREADY OUTSIDE THE GROUND, SAID RICH,  
BECAUSE IT ONLY SHOWS UP THE THE BOUNDARIES, DOESN'T  
HE? SAID HERMION SLIDDERLY.

SOMEONE WAS CLIMBING THE STEPS UP THE THE TOWER, HARRY  
COULD HEAR TWO VEHICLES ARGUING, CHIMING CLOSER AND CLOSER.

THAT'S BLACKMAIL, THAT IS, WE COULD GET INTO A LOT OF TROUBLE  
FOR THAT

WE'RE TRYING TO BE WHITE, IT'S TIME TO PLAY DIRTY, LIKE HIM, HE  
WOULDN'T LIKE THE MINISTRY OF MAGIC KNOWING WHAT HE DID

I'M TELLING YOU, IF YOU PUT THAT IN WRITING, IT'S BLACKMAIL!

FEAR, AND YELL WHEN T BE COMPLAINING IF WE GET A NICE FAT PAY-  
OFF, WILL YELL?

THE HULKY DEER RANZO OPEN, FRED AND GEORGE CAME OVER  
THE THRESHOLD, THEN FREEZE AT THE SIGHT OF HARRY, RENE AND  
HERMINE.

WHAT RE YELL DOING HERE? RENE AND FRED SAID AT THE SAME  
TIME.

SENDING A LETTER, SAID HARRY AND GEORGE IN UNISON.

WHAT, AT THIS TIME? SAID HERMINE AND FRED.

FRED GRINNED, FINE WE WEN T ASK YELL WHAT YELL RE DOING, IF  
YELL DEN T ASK US, HE SAID.

HE WAS HOLDING A SEALED ENVELOPE IN HIS HANDS, HARRY  
GLANCED AT IT, BUT FRED, WHETHER ACCIDENTALLY OR IN PURPOSE,  
SHIFTED HIS HAND SO THAT THE NAME ON IT WAS COVERED.

WELL, DEN T LET US HOLD YELL UP, HE SAID, MAKING A MEAN KEE, AND  
POINTING AT THE DEER.

RENE DIDN T MOVE. WHEN RE YELL BLACKMAILING? HE SAID.

THE GRIN VANISHED FROM FRED S FACE, HARRY SAW GEORGE GLANCE  
GLANCE AT FRED, BEFORE SMILING AT RENE.

DEN T BE STUPID, I WAS ONLY JOKING, HE SAID EASILY.

DIDN T SEEM LIKE THAT, SAID RENE.

THE DREAM YET

FRED AND GEORGE LOOKED AT EACH OTHER.

THEN FRED SAID ABRUPTLY, I VE TOLD YELL BEFORE, RENE, DEEP  
YELLR NOSE HLT IF YELL LIKE IT THE SHAPE IT IS, CAN T SEE WHY YELL

WOULD, BUT

IT'S MY BUSINESS IF YOU'RE BLACKMAILING SOMEONE, SAID RICH,

GEORGE'S RIGHT, YOU COULD END UP IN SERIOUS TROUBLE FOR THAT.

THAT YOU, I WAS THINKING, SAID GEORGE. HE WALKED OVER THE

FRED, PULLED THE LETTER OUT OF HIS HANDS, AND BEGAN ATTACHING IT

TO THE LEG OF THE NEAREST BARN NAIL. YOU'RE STARTING THE SELLING A KIT

LIKE HENRY DEAR HENRY KNEE-DEEP, YOU ARE, RICH. CARRY ON LIKE THIS

AND YOU'LL BE MADE A PERFECT.

NO, I WENT TO, SAID RICH HEARTILY.

GEORGE CARRIED THE BARN NAIL OVER THE THE WINDOW AND IT THUD

THUD.

HE TURNED AROUND AND GRINNED AT RICH. WELL, STOP TELLING PEOPLE

WHAT THE DEE THEN. SEE YOU LATER.

HE AND FRED LEFT THE GALLERY. HARRY, RICH AND HERMINE

STARED AT EACH OTHER.

YOU DON'T THINK THEY KNOW SOMETHING ABOUT ALL THIS, DO

YOU? HERMINE WHISPERED. ABOUT TRILLY AND EVERYTHING?

NO, SAID HARRY. IF IT WAS SOMETHING THAT SERIOUS, THEY'D TELL

SOMEONE. THEY'D TELL SOMEONE.

RICH, HOWEVER, WAS LOOKING UNCOMFORTABLE.

WHAT'S THE MATTER? HERMINE ASKED HIM.

WELL ... SAID RICH SLEAZY, I DON'T IF THEY WOULD. THEY'RE ...

THEY'RE OBSESSED WITH MAKING MONEY LATELY, I NOTICED IT WHEN I

WAS HANGING AROUND WITH THEM WHEN YOU KNOW

WE WEREN'T TALKING, HARRY FINISHED THE SENTENCE FOR HIM.

YEAH, BUT BLACKMAIL ...

IT'S THIS HIDE-SETH IDEA THEY'RE GET, SAID BEN. I THOUGHT THEY WERE ONLY SAYING IT TO ANNE'S MUM, BUT THEY REALLY MEAN IT, THEY WANT TO START HERE. THEY'RE ONLY GET A YEAR LEFT AT EGGHARTS, THEY KEEP GOING ON ABOUT HOW IT'S TIME TO THINK ABOUT THEIR FUTURE, AND DAD CAN'T HELP THEM, AND THEY NEED CHILDREN GET STARTED.

AND HARRY PETER

HERMIONE WAS LOOKING UNCOMFORTABLE NOW. YES, BUT ... THEY WOULDN'T DO ANYTHING AGAINST THE LAW TO GET CHILDREN, WOULD THEY? WOULD THEY? SAID BEN, LOOKING SKEPTICAL. I DUNNO ... THEY DON'T EXACTLY MIND BREAKING RULES, DO THEY? YES, BUT THIS IS THE LAW, SAID HERMIONE, LOOKING SCARED. THIS ISN'T SOME SILLY SCHOOL RULE ... THEY'LL GET A LOT MORE THAN DETENTION FOR BLACKMAIL! BEN ... MAYBE YOU'D BETTER TELL PERCY ...

ARE YOU MAD? SAID BEN. TELL PERCY? HE'D PROBABLY BE A CRUELTY AND TURN THEM IN. HE STARED AT THE WINDOW THROUGH WHICH FRED AND GEORGE'S MOM HAD DEPARTED, THEN SAID, COME ON, LET'S GET SOME BREAKFAST.

DID YOU THINK IT'S TOO EARLY TO GO AND SEE PROFESSOR MURPHY? HERMIONE SAID, AS THEY WENT DOWN THE SPIRAL STAIRCASE.

YES, SAID HARRY. HE'D PROBABLY BLAST HIS THROUGH THE DOOR IF WE WAKE HIM AT THE CRACK OF DAWN, HE'LL THINK WE'RE TRYING TO ATTACK HIM WHILE HE'S ASLEEP. LET'S GIVE IT TIL BREAK.

HISTORY OF MAGIC HAD RARELY BEEN SO SILENT. HARRY KEPT

CHECKING ROBIN'S WATCH, HAVING FINALLY DISCARDED HIS HORN, BUT ROBIN WAS MOVING SO SILENTLY HE COULD HAVE SWORN IT HAD STOPPED WORKING THEM. ALL THREE OF THEM WERE SO TIRED THEY COULD HAPPILY HAVE PLUT THEIR HEADS DOWN IN THE DESKS AND SLEPT; EVEN HERMIONE WASN'T TAKING HER USUAL NOTES, BUT WAS SITTING WITH HER HEAD IN HER HAND, GAZING AT PROFESSOR KINGS WITH HER EYES BUT NO FEELINGS.

WHEN THE BELL FINALLY RANG, THEY HURRIED OUT INTO THE CORRIDORS TOWARDS THE DARK ARTS CLASSROOM, AND FINDING PROFESSOR

MURPHY LEAVING IT, HE LOOKED AS TIRED AS THEY FELT. THE EYELID OF

HIS NORMAL EYE WAS DROOPING, GIVING HIS FACE AN EVEN MORE LIMP-SIDED APPEARANCE THAN USUAL.

PROFESSOR MURPHY? HARRY CALLED, AS THEY MADE THEIR WAY TOWARDS HIM THROUGH THE CORRIDOR.

WELL, PUTTER, GROANED MURPHY. HIS MAGICAL EYE REVEALED A CLOUD OF PASSING FIRST-YEARS, WHO SPED UP, LOOKING NERVOUS; IT ROLLED INTO THE BACK OF MURPHY'S HEAD AND WATCHED THEM APPROACH

THE DREAM YES

THE CORNER WHERE HE SPOKE AGAIN. COME IN HERE.

HE STEPPED BACK THEN LET THEM INTO HIS EMPTY CLASSROOM, LIMPED IN AFTER THEM AND CLOSED THE DOOR.

DID YOU FIND HIM? HARRY ASKED, WITHOUT PREAMBLE. MR

CRUELTY?

NEH, SAID MEEHBY, HE MOVED OVER TO HIS DESK, SAT DOWN,  
STRETCHED OUT HIS WOODEN LEG WITH A SLIGHT GRHAN AND PULLED  
OUT HIS HIP-FLASK.

DID YOU LIKE THE MAP? HARRY SAID.

HE CHIRSE, SAID MEEHBY, TAKING A SWIG FROM HIS FLASK. THERE A  
LEAF OUT OF YOUR BOOK, BETTER. SLIPPED IT FROM MY OFFICE INTO  
THE FOREST. HE WASN'T ANYWHERE IN THERE.

SEE HE DID DISAPPEAR? SAID RHN.

YOU CAN'T DISAPPEAR IN THE GREENS, RHN? SAID HERMINE.

THERE ARE OTHER WAYS HE COULD HAVE DISAPPEARED, AREN'T THERE,  
PROFESSOR?

MEEHBY'S MAGICAL EYE DELIVERED AS IT RESTED ON HERMINE.

YOU'RE ANOTHER ONE WHO MIGHT THINK ABOUT A CAREER AS AN  
ALDER, HE TOLD HER. MIND WORKS THE RIGHT WAY, GRANGER.  
HERMINE FLISHED PINK WITH PLEASURE.

WELL, HE WASN'T INVISIBLE, SAID HARRY. THE MAP SHOWS INVIS-  
IBLE PEOPLE. HE MUST VE LEFT THE GREENS, THEN.

OUT UNDER HIS OWN STEAK? SAID HERMINE EAGERLY. HER  
REALISE SOMEONE MADE HIM?

YEAH, SOMEONE COULD VE COULD VE PULLED HIM OUT OF A BUSH

AND FLEW OFF WITH HIM, COULDN'T THEY? SAID RHN QUICKLY, LEAN-  
ING FORWARD AT MEEHBY, AS IF HE, THEN, WANTED TO BE TOLD HE HAD

THE MAKING OF AN ALIEN.

WE CAN'T RULE OUT KIDNAP, GRIELED MEEBO.

SEE, SAID BEN, I WOULD RETURN HE'S SOMEWHERE IN THE SMELLY

WORLD BE ANYWHERE, SAID MEEBO, SHAKING HIS HEAD. ONLY

THING WE KNOW FOR SURE IS THAT HE'S NOT HERE.

HE YAWNED WIDELY, SEE THAT HIS SCARS STRETCHED, AND HIS LIMP-

SIDED MOUTH REVEALED A NUMBER OF MISSING TEETH.

THEN HE SAID, WELL, DUMBLEDORE'S TOLD ME YOU THREE FANCY

THE HARRY POTTER

THEMSELVES AS INVESTIGATORS, BUT THERE'S NOTHING YOU CAN DO FOR

CRUELTY. THE MINISTRY WILL BE LOOKING FOR HIM WELL, DUMBLEDORE'S

NOTIFIED THEM. POTTER, YOU MUST KEEP YOUR MIND ON THE THIRD

TASK.

WHAT? SAID HARRY. EH, YES ...

HE HADN'T GIVEN THE MAZE A SINGLE THOUGHT SINCE HE'D LEFT IT

WITH DOLLY THE PREVIOUS NIGHT.

SHOULD BE RIGHT UP YOUR STREET, THIS ONE, SAID MEEBO, LEAN-

ING UP AT HARRY AND SCRATCHING HIS SCARRED AND STICKLY CHIN.

FROM WHAT DUMBLEDORE'S SAID, YOU'VE MANAGED TO GET THROUGH

STUFF LIKE THIS PLenty OF TIMES. BREED YOUR WAY THROUGH A SERIES

OF OBSTACLES GUARDING THE PHILOSOPHER'S STONE IN YOUR FIRST YEAR,

DIDN'T YOU?



WE HELPED, RHN SAID QUICKLY, ME AND HERMINE HELPED,  
MENDY GRINNED, WELL, HELP HIM PRACTISE FOR THIS ONE, AND I LL  
BE VERY SURPRISED IF HE DOESN T WIN, HE SAID, IN THE MEANTIME  
... CONSTANT VIGILANCE, PETER, CONSTANT VIGILANCE, HE THREW  
ANOTHER LONG DRAUGHT FROM HIS HIP-FLASK, AND HIS MAGICAL EYE  
SWIVELLED AROUND THE WINDMILL, THE TALLEST SAIL OF THE  
BURNSTRANG SHIP WAS VISIBLE THROUGH IT.

YELL THEN HIS NORMAL EYE WAS ON RHN AND HERMINE YELL  
STUCK CLOSE TO PETER, ALL RIGHT? I M KEEPING AN EYE ON THINGS,  
BUT ALL THE SAME ... YELL CAN NEVER HAVE TOO MANY EYES BUT,

\*

SIRILIS SENT THEIR HELM BACK THE VERY NEXT MORNING, IT FLUTTERED

DOWN BESIDE HARRY AT THE SAME MOMENT THAT A TALL HELM LAND-  
ED IN FRONT OF HERMINE, CLUTCHING A COPY OF THE DAILY PROPHECY

IN ITS BEAK, SHE THREW THE NEWSPAPER, SCANNED THE FIRST FEW  
PAGES, SAID HA! SHE HASN T GET WIND OF CRUELTY, THEN THOUGHT

RHN AND HARRY IN READING WHAT SIRILIS HAD TOLD HER THE MYSTE-  
RIOUS EVENTS OF THE NIGHT BEFORE LAST,

HARRY WHAT DO YOU THINK YOU ARE PLAYING AT, WALKING OFF  
INTO THE FOREST WITH VICTOR DOLBY I WANT YOU TO SWEAR, BY  
RETURN HELM, THAT YOU ARE NOT GOING TO BE WALKING WITH ANYONE

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ELSE AT NIGHT. THERE IS SOMEHOW HIGHLY DANGEROUS AT  
F-HEGLARTS. IT IS CLEAR TO ME THAT THEY WANTED THE STEEP CRACK-  
SEEKING DUMBLEDORE AND YELL WERE PROBABLY FEET AWAY FROM  
THEM IN THE DARK. YELL COULD HAVE BEEN KILLED.  
THEIR NAME DIDN'T GET INTO THE CHURCH OF FIRE BY ACCIDENT. IF  
SOMEONE'S TRYING TO ATTACK YELL, THEY'RE IN THEIR LAST CHANCE.  
STAY CLOSE TO RON AND HERMION, DON'T LEAVE GRYFFINDOR  
THEIR AFTER THEIR, AND ARM YOURSELF FOR THE THIRD TASK.  
PRACTISE STUNNING AND DISARMING. A FEW HOURS WOULDN'T BE  
AMISS EITHER. THERE'S NOTHING YELL CAN BE ABLE TO CRACK. KEEP  
YOUR HEAD DOWN AND LOOK AFTER YOURSELF. I'M WAITING FOR YOUR  
LETTER GIVING ME YOUR WORD YELL WON'T STRAY OUT OF SIGHTS  
AGAIN.

SIRILIS

WHEN'S HE, THE LECTURE ME ABOUT BEING OUT OF SIGHTS? SAID  
HARRY IN MILD INDIGNATION, AS HE PICKED UP SIRILIS' LETTER AND PUT  
IT INSIDE HIS BOOKS. AFTER ALL THE STUFF HE DID AT SCHOOL?

HE'S WORRIED ABOUT YELL? SAID HERMION SHARPLY. JUST LIKE  
MUM AND LUCY? SHE LISTEN TO THEM?

WHEN'S HE TRIED TO ATTACK ME ALL YEAR, SAID HARRY. WHEN'S  
HE DONE ANYTHING TO ME AT ALL

EXCEPT PUT YOUR NAME IN THE CHURCH OF FIRE, SAID HERMION.  
AND THEY MUST BE BEING THAT FOR A REASON, HARRY. SPOOKIES IS  
RIGHT. MAYBE THEY'RE BEEN KIDING THEIR TIME. MAYBE THIS IS THE  
TASK THEY'RE GOING TO GET YELL.

LEHHX, SAID HARRY IMPATIENTLY, LET S SAY SNLPPLES IS RIGHT, AND  
SHEMENE STUNNED DRUM THE BIDNAP CRHLLCH. WELL, THEY WOULD VE  
BEEN IN THE TREES NEAR US, WOULDNT T THEY? BUT THEY WAITED TIL I  
WAS HLIT HP THE WAY UNTIL THEY ACTED, DIDN T THEY? SHE IT DEERN T  
LEHHX LIKE I M THEIR TARGET, DOES IT?

THEY CHLDN T HAVE MADE IT LEHHX LIKE AN ACCIDENT IF THEY D  
MLNDERED YELJ IN THE FEHREST? SAID H-ERMINEH. BUT IF YELJ DIE  
BLRING A TASK

THEY DIDN T CARE ABELT ATTACKING DRUM, DID THEY? SAID

THE HARRY PHTTTER

HARRY, WHY DIDN T THEY ILST PHLISH ME HP AT THE SAME TIME?

THEY CHLD VE MADE IT LEHHX LIKE DRUM AND I HAD A BLK HP  
SHEMETHING.

HARRY, I DEEN T LINDERSTAND IT EITHER, SAID H-ERMINEH DESPER-  
ATELY, I ILST DNHEH THERE ARE A LEET HP HED THINGS CHING HN, AND I

DEEN T LIKE IT ... MEHHY S RIGHT SNLPPLES IS RIGHT YELJ VE GHT THE  
GET IN TRAINING FEH THE THIRD TASK, STRAIGHT AWAY, AND YELJ MAKE  
SLURE YELJ WRITE BACK THE SNLPPLES AND PROMISE HIM YELJ RE NEET  
CHING THE GE SNEAKING HP ALHNE AGAIN.

\*

THE H-HGLWARTS GRHLNDS NEVER LEHDED MORE INVITING THAN WHEN  
HARRY HAD THE STAY INDEHRS, FEH THE NEXT FEW DAYS HE SPENT ALL HP  
HIS FREE TIME EITHER IN THE LIBRARY WITH H-ERMINEH AND REHN,

LEARNING UP HERE, HER ELSE IN EMPTY CLASSROOMS, WHICH THEY  
ENDED INTO THE PRACTISE, HARRY WAS CONCENTRATING ON THE  
STUNNING SPELL, WHICH HE HAD NEVER USED BEFORE. THE TRICKLE  
WAS THAT PRACTISING IT INVOLVED CERTAIN SACRIFICES ON RON AND  
HERMION'S PART.

CAN'T WE KIDNAP MRS WEASLEY? RON SUGGESTED DURING  
MONDAY LUNCHTIME, AS HE LAY FLAT ON HIS BACK IN THE MIDDLE OF

THEIR CHARM CLASSROOM, HAVING JUST BEEN STUNNED AND RE-  
ALIGNED BY HARRY FOR THE FIFTH TIME IN A ROW. LET'S STUN HER FOR  
A

BIT. HER YELL WOULD BE DEER, HARRY, I BET HE'D DO ANYTHING TO  
HELP YOU. I'M NOT COMPLAINING HER ANYTHING HE GOT GINGERLY THE  
HIS FEET, RUBBING HIS BACKSIDE BUT I'M ACHING ALL OVER ...

WELL, YOU KEEP MISSING THE CLISHMENS, DON'T YOU? SAID  
HERMION IMPATIENTLY, REARRANGING THE PILE OF CLISHMENS THEY  
HAD USED FOR THE VANISHING SPELL, WHICH FLITWICK HAD LEFT IN A  
CABINET. JUST TRY AND FALL BACKWARDS?

HENCE YOU'RE STUNNED, YOU CAN'T AIM THEM WELL, HERMION?  
SAID RON ANGERILY. WHY DON'T YOU TAKE A TURN?

WELL, I THINK HARRY'S GOT IT NOW, ANYWAY, SAID HERMION  
HASTILY. AND WE DON'T HAVE THE WHOLE ARMY OF DISARMING, BECAUSE  
HE'S BEEN ASKED TO DO THAT FOR AGES ... I THINK WE MIGHT TRY START  
ON SOME OF THESE HERE'S THIS EVENING.

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SHE WHISKED DOWN THE LIST THEY HAD MADE IN THE LIBRARY.

I LIKE THE LOOK OF THIS ONE, SHE SAID, THIS IMPEDIMENT INDEX, SHOULD SHOW DOWN ANYTHING THAT'S TRYING TO ATTACK YOU, HARRY. WE'LL START WITH THAT ONE.

THE BELL RANG. THEY HASTILY SHEVED THE CLISHMENS BACK INTO FLITWICK'S CLIPBOARD, AND SLIPPED OUT OF THE CLASSROOM.

SEE YOU AT DINNER? SAID HERMIONE, AND SHE SET OFF HER ARITHMAGIC, WHILE HARRY AND RON HEADED TOWARDS NORTH TOWER, AND DIVINATION. BROAD STRIPS OF DAZZLING GOLD SUNLIGHT FELL ACROSS THE CORRIDOR FROM THE HIGH WINDOWS. THE SKY OUTSIDE WAS SO BRIGHTLY BLUE IT LOOKED AS THOUGH IT HAD BEEN ENAMELLED.

IT'S GOING TO BE BRILLIANT IN TRELAWNEY'S ROOM, SHE NEVER PUTS OUT THAT FIRE, SAID RON, AS THEY STARTED UP THE STAIRCASE TOWARDS THE SILVER LADDER AND THE TRAPDOOR.

HE WAS WHITE RIGHT. THE DIMLY LIT ROOM WAS SWelteringly HOT. THE FLAMES FROM THE PERLINED FIRE WERE HEAVIER THAN EVER. HARRY'S HEAD SWAM AS HE MADE HIS WAY OVER THE END OF THE CURTAINED WINDOWS. WHILE PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY WAS LOOKING THE OTHER WAY, DISENTANGLING HER SHAWL FROM A LAMP, HE OPENED IT AN INCH FOR HER AND SETTLED BACK IN HIS CHINTZ ARMCHAIR, SEE THAT A SOFT BREEZE PLAYED ACROSS HIS FACE. IT WAS EXTREMELY COMFORTABLE.

MY DEARS, SAID PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY, SITTING DOWN IN HER WINGED ARMCHAIR IN FRONT OF THE CLASS AND PEERING AROUND AT THEM ALL WITH HER STRANGELY ENLARGED EYES, WE HAVE ALMOST FIN-

ISHED HER WORK ON PLANETARY DIVINATION. TODAY, HOWEVER, WILL

BE AN EXCELLENT OPPORTUNITY TO EXAMINE THE EFFECTS OF MARS, FOR  
HE IS PLACED MOST INTERESTINGLY AT THE PRESENT TIME. IF YOU WILL  
ALL LEAVE THIS WAY, I WILL DIM THE LIGHTS ...

SHE WAVED HER HAND AND THE LAMPS WENT OUT. THE FIRE WAS  
THE ONLY SOURCE OF LIGHT NOW. PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY BENT DOWN,  
AND LIFTED, FROM UNDER HER CHAIR, A MINIATURE MODEL OF THE SOLAR  
SYSTEM, CONTAINED WITHIN A GLASS DOME. IT WAS A REALITY  
THING; EACH OF THE PLANETS GLIMMERED IN PLACE AROUND THE NINE

SOON HARRY POTTTER

PLANETS AND THE FIERY SUN, ALL OF THEM HANGING IN THIN AIR  
BENEATH THE GLASS. HARRY WATCHED LAZILY AS PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY  
BEGAN TO POINT OUT THE FASCINATING ANGLE MARS WAS MAKING WITH  
NEPTUNE. THE HEAVILY PERFRUMED FLORES WASHED OVER HIM, AND  
THE BREEZE FROM THE WINDOW PLAYED ACROSS HIS FACE. HE COULD  
HEAR AN INSECT HUMMING GENTLY SOMEWHERE BEHIND THE CURTAIN.  
HIS EYES BEGAN TO DREAM ...

HE WAS RIDING ON THE BACK OF AN EAGLE EWL, SHEARING THROUGH  
THE CLEAR BLUE SKY TOWARDS AN OLD, IVY-COVERED HOUSE SET HIGH  
ON A HILLSIDE. LOWER AND LOWER THEY FLEW, THE WIND WHISTLING  
PLEASANTLY IN HARRY'S FACE, UNTIL THEY REACHED A DARK AND STREKEN  
WINDOW IN THE UPPER STOREY OF THE HOUSE, AND ENTERED. THEN  
THEY WERE FLYING ALONG A GLEAMY PASSAGEWAY, TO A ROOM AT THE  
VERY END ... THROUGH THE DOOR THEY WENT, INTO A DARK ROOM  
WHERE WINDOWS WERE SHUT UP ...

FLARRY HAD LEFT THE HELL S BACK ... HE WAS WATCHING, NEEL, AS IT  
FLUTTERED ACROSS THE ROOM, INTO A CHAIR WITH ITS BACK TO HIM ...  
THERE WERE TWO DARK SHAPES IN THE FLEET BESIDE THE CHAIR ...  
BOTH OF THEM WERE STIRRING ...

HERE WAS A HUGE SNAKE ... THE OTHER WAS A MAN ... A SHORT,  
BALDING MAN, A MAN WITH WATERY EYES AND A PAINTED NESE ... HE  
WAS WHEEZING AND SHAKING IN THE HEARTHRUG ...

YELL ARE IN BLACK, WHERMTAIL, SAID A CHILD, HIGH-PITCHED VOICE  
FROM THE DEPTHS OF THE CHAIR IN WHICH THE HELL HAD LANDED. YELL

ARE VERY FORTUNATE INDEED, YELLER BLUNDER HAS NOT BLIND EVERY-  
THING. HE IS DEAD.

MY LORD! GASPED THE MAN IN THE FLEET. MY LORD, I AM ... I  
AM SO PLEASED ... AND SO SHINY ...

NAGINI, SAID THE CHILD VOICE, YELL ARE NOT OF BLACK, I WILL NOT  
BE FEEDING WHERMTAIL THE YELL, AFTER ALL ... BUT NEVER MIND, NEVER  
MIND ... THERE IS STILL FLARRY PITTER ...

THE SNAKE HISSED, FLARRY COULD SEE ITS TONGUE FLUTTERING.

NEEL, WHERMTAIL, SAID THE CHILD VOICE, PERHAPS HERE MORE LITTLE  
REMINDER WHY I WILL NOT TOLERATE ANOTHER BLUNDER FROM YELL ...

MY LORD ... NEEL ... I SEE YELL ...

THE DREAM SON

THE TIP OF A HAND EMERGED FROM THE DEPTHS OF THE CHAIR, IT  
WAS POINTING AT WHERMTAIL. CRUISE, SAID THE CHILD VOICE.  
WHERMTAIL SCREAMED, SCREAMED AS THOUGH EVERY NERVE IN HIS

BODY WAS IN FIRE, THE SCREAMING FILLED HARRY'S EARS AS THE STAR  
IN HIS THREE-HEAD SEARED WITH PAIN; HE WAS YELLING, THEN ...

WILHELM WOULD HEAR HIM, WOULD KNOW HE WAS THERE ...

HARRY! HARRY!

HARRY OPENED HIS EYES, HE WAS LYING IN THE FLEET OF  
PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY'S ROOM WITH HIS HANDS OVER HIS FACE. HIS  
STAR WAS STILL BURNING SO BADLY THAT HIS EYES WERE WATERING. THE  
PAIN HAD BEEN REAL. THE WHOLE CLASS WAS STANDING AROUND HIM,  
AND BEN WAS KNEELING NEXT TO HIM, LOOKING TERRIFIED.

FEEL ALL RIGHT? HE SAID.

IF COURSE HE ISN'T! SAID PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY, LOOKING THIR-  
DLY EXCITED, HER GREAT EYES BEAMED OVER HARRY, GAZING AT

HIM. WHAT WAS IT, BETTER? A PREMONITION? AN APPARITION?  
WHAT DID YOU SEE?

NOTHING, HARRY LIED. HE SAT UP. HE COULD FEEL HIMSELF SHAD-  
ING, HE COULDN'T STOP HIMSELF LOOKING AROUND, INTO THE SHADOWS

BEHIND HIM; WILHELM'S VEHICLE HAD SHOWNED SEE CLEAR ...

YOU WERE CLUTCHING YOUR STAR! SAID PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY,

YOU WERE REELING IN THE FLEET, CLUTCHING YOUR STAR! COME NOW,  
BETTER, I HAVE EXPERIENCE IN THESE MATTERS!

HARRY LOOKED UP AT HER.

I NEED TO GO TO THE HOSPITAL WING, I THINK, HE SAID. BAD  
HEADACHE.



MY DEAR, YOU WERE UNDELIABLY STIMULATED BY THE EXTRAORDI-  
NARY CLAIRVUANT VIBRATIONS OF MY REEF! SAID PROFESSOR

TRELAWNEY. IF YOU LEAVE NOW, YOU MAY LOSE THE OPPORTUNITY TO  
SEE FURTHER THAN YOU HAVE EVER

I DON'T WANT TO SEE ANYTHING EXCEPT A HEADACHE CURE, SAID  
HARRY.

HE STOOD UP, THE CLASS BACKED AWAY. THEY ALL LOOKED  
DINNERYED.

SEE YOU LATER, HARRY MUTTERED TO REEF, AND HE PICKED UP HIS

SEE HARRY MUTTERED

BAG AND HEADED FOR THE TRAPDOOR, IGNORING PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY,  
WHICH WAS WEARING AN EXPRESSION OF GREAT FRUSTRATION, AS THOUGH  
SHE HAD JUST BEEN DENIED A REAL TREAT.

WHEN HARRY REACHED THE KEETHEM OF HER STEPLADDER, HOWEVER,  
HE DID NOT SET OFF FOR THE HOSPITAL WING. HE HAD NO INTENTION  
WHATSOEVER OF GOING THERE. SIRILUS HAD TOLD HIM WHAT TO DO IF HIS  
STAR FLIRT HIM AGAIN, AND HARRY WAS GOING TO FOLLOW HIS ADVICE!  
HE WAS GOING STRAIGHT TO DUMBLEDORE'S OFFICE. HE MARCHED  
DOWN THE CORRIDORS, THINKING ABOUT WHAT HE HAD SEEN IN THE  
DREAM ... IT HAD BEEN AS VIVID AS THE ONE WHICH HAD AWAKENED

HIM IN PRIVET DRIVE ... HE RAN OVER THE DETAILS IN HIS MIND, TRY-  
ING TO MAKE SURE HE COULD REMEMBER THEM ... HE HAD HEARD

YELDERBERT ACCUSING WHIRTAIL OF MAKING A BLUNDER ... BUT THE  
HALL HAD BRIGHT GREEN WELLS, THE BLUNDER HAD BEEN REPAIRED,  
SOMEBODY WAS DEAD ... SEE WHIRTAIL WAS NOT CHINE THE RE FED THE  
THE SNAKE ... HE, HARRY, WAS CHINE THE RE FED THE IT INSTEAD ...  
HARRY HAD WALKED RIGHT PAST THE STONE GARGOYLE GUARDING THE  
ENTRANCE THE DUMBLEDORE'S OFFICE WITHOUT NOTICING, HE BLINKED,  
BLENDED AROUND, REALISED WHAT HE HAD DONE AND RETRACED HIS  
STEPS, STOPPING IN FRONT OF IT, THEN HE REMEMBERED THAT HE DIDN'T  
KNOW THE PASSWORD.

SURELY BETTER? HE TRIED TENTATIVELY.

THE GARGOYLE DID NOT MOVE.

END, SAID HARRY, STARING AT IT. PEAR DROP, OR LITTLEWICK  
WAND, FIZZING WHIZZEE, DREDDLE'S BEST BLENDING CLIM, BERTIE  
KEET'S EVERY FLAVOUR BEANS ... HEH NEH, HE DOESN'T LIKE THEM, DOES  
HE? ... HEH, JUST OPEN, CAN'T YOU? HE SAID ANGRILY, I REALLY NEED  
THE SEE HIM, IT'S URGENT!

THE GARGOYLE REMAINED IMMOVABLE.

HARRY KICKED IT, ACHIEVING NOTHING BUT AN EXCRUCIATING PAIN  
IN HIS BIG TOE.

CRICKLE FROG! HE YELLED ANGRILY, STANDING ON ONE LEG.

SLUGGISH BULL! CRICKLEWICK CLOSTER!

THE GARGOYLE SPRANG THE LIFE, AND LIMPED ASIDE, HARRY BLINKED.

CRICKLEWICK CLOSTER? HE SAID, AMAZED, I WAS ONLY THINKING ...

## THE DREAM SUE

HE FLURRIED THROUGH THE GAP IN THE WALLS, AND STEPPED INTO  
THE MOUTH OF A SPIRAL STONE STAIRCASE, WHICH MOVED SILENTLY

UPWARDS AS THE DEERS CLOSED BEHIND HIM, TAKING HIM UP THE A  
PHILISTINE HAD DEER WITH A BRASS DEER-DEERER.

HE COULD HEAR VEHICLES FROM INSIDE THE OFFICE. HE STEPPED OFF  
THE MOVING STAIRCASE AND HESITATED, LISTENING.

OLIMBODERE, I M AFRAID I DENT SEE THE CONNECTION, DENT SEE  
IT AT ALL. IT WAS THE VEHICLE OF THE MINISTER FOR MAGIC, CERNELIUS  
FLDGE. BLDGE SAYS BERTHA S PERFECTLY CAPABLE OF GETTING HERSELF  
LOST. I AGREE WE WOULD HAVE EXPECTED THE HAVE FOUND HER BY  
NOW, BUT ALL THE SAME, WE VE NO EVIDENCE OF ANY PLAY.  
OLIMBODERE, NONE AT ALL. AS FOR HER DISAPPEARANCE BEING LINKED  
WITH BARTY CRELICH S

AND WHAT DO YOU THINK S HAPPENED TO BARTY CRELICH,  
MINISTER? SAID MERRY S GRIMLING VEHICLE.

I SEE TWO POSSIBILITIES, ALASTAIR, SAID FLDGE. EITHER CRELICH  
HAS FINALLY CRACKED MORE THAN LIKELY, I M SURE YOU LL AGREE,  
GIVEN HIS PERSONAL HISTORY LOST HIS MIND, AND BEEN WANDERING  
OFF SOMEWHERE

HE WANDERED EXTREMELY QUICKLY, IF THAT IS THE CASE,  
CERNELIUS, SAID OLIMBODERE CALMLY.

HER ELSE WELL ... FLDGE SEEMED EMBARRASSED. WELL, I LL  
RESERVE JUDGEMENT UNTIL AFTER I VE SEEN THE PLACE WHERE HE WAS  
FOUND, BUT YOU SAY IT WAS JUST PAST THE REASONATHENS CARRIAGE?  
OLIMBODERE, YOU KNOW WHAT THAT WOMAN IS?

I CONSIDER HER TO BE A VERY ABLE HEADMISTRESS AND AN  
EXCELLENT DANCER, SAID OLIMBODERE BRIEFLY.

OLIMBODERE, CHER? SAID FLDGE ANGRILY. DENT YOU THINK  
YOU MIGHT BE PREJUDICED IN HER FAVOR BECAUSE OF FAVORIT?

THEY DIDN'T ALL TURN OUT HARMLESS IF, INDEED, YELL CAN CALL  
FACRID HARMLESS, WITH THAT MINISTER FIXATION HE'S GET

I DON'T MORE SUSPECT MADAME MAXIME THAN FACRID, SAID  
OLMPEDEHRE, JUST AS CALMLY. I THINK IT POSSIBLE THAT IT IS YELL  
WHO ARE PREJUDICED, CHERNELILIS.

CAN WE WRAP UP THIS DISCUSSION? GRIELED MEEHOF.

SEN HARRY POTTTER

YES, YES, LET'S GO DOWN INTO THE GREENLANDS, THEN, SAID  
CHERNELILIS IMPATIENTLY.

NO, IT'S NOT THAT, SAID MEEHOF, IT'S JUST THAT POTTTER WANTS A  
WORD WITH YELL, OLMPEDHRE. HE'S JUST OUTSIDE THE DEER.

## CHAPTER THIRTY

### THE PENSIVE

THE DEER OF THE OFFICE OPENED.

WELL, POTTTER, SAID MEEHOF, COME IN, THEN.

HARRY WALKED INSIDE. HE HAD BEEN INSIDE OLMPEDHRE'S  
OFFICE SINCE BEFORE; IT WAS A VERY BEAUTIFUL, CIRCULAR ROOM, LINED  
WITH PICTURES OF PREVIOUS HEADMASTERS AND MISTRESSES OF  
HOGWARTS, ALL OF WHOM WERE FAST ASLEEP, THEIR CHESTS RISING AND  
FALLING GENTLY.

CHERNELILIS FLICKER WAS STANDING BESIDE OLMPEDHRE'S DESK,  
WEARING HIS USUAL PINSTRIPED CLOAK AND HOLDING HIS LIME-GREEN  
BEEHIVE HAT.

HARRY SAID FLUDGE INVITALLY, MOVING FORWARD. THEY ARE VERY FINE, HARRY LIED.

WE WERE JUST TALKING ABOUT THE NIGHT WHEN MR CRUELCH TURNED UP IN THE GREENHouses, SAID FLUDGE. IT WAS VERY WELL WHEN HEARD HIM, WAS IT NOT?

YES, SAID HARRY. THEN, FEELING IT WAS POINTLESS TO PRETEND THAT HE HADN'T EVER HEARD WHAT THEY HAD BEEN SAYING, HE ADDED, I DIDN'T SEE MADAME MAXIME ANYWHERE, EITHER, AND SHE'D HAVE A LITTLE HIDING, WOULDN'T SHE?

OLMUTHE SMILED AT HARRY BEHIND FLUDGE'S BACK, HIS EYES TWINKLING.

YES, WELL, SAID FLUDGE, LOOKING EMBARRASSED. WE'RE ABOUT TO GO FOR A SHORT WALK IN THE GREENHouses, HARRY, IF YOU'D EXCUSE US ... PERHAPS IF YOU'D JUST GO BACK TO YOUR CLASS

I WANTED TO TALK TO YOU, PROFESSOR, HARRY SAID QUICKLY, LOOKING AT OLMUTHE, WHO GAVE HIM A SWIFT, SEARCHING LOOK.

SEE HARRY PETER

WAIT HERE FOR ME, HARRY, HE SAID. YOUR EXAMINATION OF THE GREENHouses WILL NOT TAKE LONG.

THEY TRIPPED OUT IN SILENCE PAST HIM, AND CLOSED THE DOOR. AFTER A MINUTE HE SAW HARRY HEARD THE CLINKS OF MERRY'S WOODEN LEG GRINDING FAINTLY IN THE CORRIDOR BEHIND. HE LOOKED AROUND.

WELL, FALDER, HE SAID.

FALDER, PROFESSOR OLMUTHE'S PHOENIX, WAS STANDING IN

HIS CHILDREN PERCH BESIDE THE DEER. THE SIZE OF A SWAN, WITH MAGNIFICENT SCARLET AND GOLD PILLIMAGE, HE SWISHED HIS LONG TAIL AND BLINKED BENIGNLY AT HARRY.

HARRY SAT DOWN IN A CHAIR IN FRONT OF DUMBLEDORE'S DESK. FOR SEVERAL MINUTES, HE SAT AND WATCHED THE OLD HEADMASTERS AND MISTRESSES SNEEZING IN THEIR FRAMES, THINKING ABOUT WHAT HE HAD JUST HEARD, AND RUNNING HIS FINGERS OVER HIS SCAR. IT HAD STOPPED FLIRTING NOW.

HE FELT MUCH CALMER, SOMEHOW, NOW HE WAS IN DUMBLEDORE'S OFFICE, KNOWING HE WOULD SHORTLY BE TELLING HIM ABOUT THE DREAM. HARRY LEANED UP AT THE WALLS BEHIND THE DESK. THE PATCHED AND RAGGED SHIRTING HAT WAS STANDING ON A SHELF, A GLASS CASE NEXT TO IT HELD A MAGNIFICENT SILVER SWORD, WITH LARGE RINGS SET INTO THE HILT, WHICH HARRY RECOGNISED AS THE ONE HE HIMSELF HAD PULLED OUT OF THE SHIRTING HAT IN HIS SECOND YEAR. THE SWORD HAD ONCE BELONGED TO GORIC GRYPFINDER, FRIEND OF HARRY'S FATHER. HE WAS GAZING AT IT, REMEMBERING HOW IT HAD COME TO HIS AID WHEN HE HAD THOUGHT ALL HOPE WAS LOST, WHEN HE NOTICED A PATCH OF SILVERY LIGHT, DANCING AND SHIMMERING ON THE GLASS CASE. HE LEANED AROUND FOR THE SOURCE OF THE LIGHT, AND SAW A SLIVER OF SILVER WHITE SHINING BRIGHTLY FROM WITHIN A BLACK CABINET BEHIND HIM, WHICH WHEN HAD NOT BEEN CLOSED PROPERLY. HARRY HESITATED, GLANCED AT FALCONES, THEN GET UP, WALKED ACROSS THE OFFICE, AND PULLED THE CABINET DOOR OPEN. A SMALLER STONE BASIN LAY THERE, WITH OLD CARVINGS AROUND THE EDGE, RINGS AND SYMBOLS THAT HARRY DID NOT RECOGNISE. THE SILVERY LIGHT WAS COMING FROM THE BASIN'S CONTENTS, WHICH WERE

THE DENSEST OF

LIKE NOTHING HARRY HAD EVER SEEN BEFORE. HE COULD NOT TELL  
WHETHER THE SUBSTANCE WAS LIQUID OR GAS. IT WAS A BRIGHT,  
WHITISH SILVER, AND IT WAS MOVING CEASELESSLY; THE SURFACE OF IT  
BECAME RIPPLED LIKE WATER BENEATH WIND, AND THEN, LIKE CLOUDS,

SEPARATED AND SWIRLED SPINNINGLY. IT BEHEAVED LIKE LIGHT MADE LIQUID  
AND LIKE WIND MADE SOLID. HARRY COULD NOT MAKE UP HIS

MIND.

HE WANTED TO TOUCH IT, TO FIND OUT WHAT IT FELT LIKE, BUT NEARLY

FIFTEEN YEARS' EXPERIENCE OF THE MAGICAL WORLD TOLD HIM THAT STICK-  
ING HIS HAND INTO A BOWL FULL OF SOME UNIDENTIFIED SUBSTANCE WAS

A VERY STUPID THING TO DO. HE THEREFORE PULLED HIS HAND OUT OF  
THE INSIDE OF HIS POKES, CAST A NERVIOUS GLANCE AROUND THE OFFICE,  
BEHEAVED BACK AT THE CONTENTS OF THE BASIN, AND PROCEEDED THEM.

THE SURFACE OF THE SILVERY STUFF INSIDE THE BASIN BEGAN TO SWIRL  
VERY FAST.

HARRY BENT CLOSER, HIS HEAD RIGHT INSIDE THE CABINET. THE SIL-  
VERY SUBSTANCE HAD BECOME TRANSPARENT; IT BEHEAVED LIKE GLASS.

HE BEHEAVED DEEPER INTO IT, EXPECTING TO SEE THE STARK BATTLES OF

THE BASIN AND SAW INSTEAD AN ENORMOUS ROOM BEHIND THE SUR-  
FACE OF THE MYSTERIOUS SUBSTANCE, A ROOM INTO WHICH HE SEEMED

TO BE LEADING THROUGH A CIRCULAR WINDOW IN THE CEILING.

THE ROOM WAS DIMLY LIT; HE THOUGHT IT MIGHT EVEN BE UNDER-  
GROUND, FOR THERE WERE NO WINDOWS, MERELY TORCHES IN BRACKETS

SUCH AS THE ONES THAT ILLUMINATED THE WALLS OF HOGWARTS.

LEARNING HIS FACE SHE THAT HIS NOSE WAS A FEW INCHES AWAY FROM  
THE GLASSY SUBSTANCE, HARRY SAW THAT REELS AND REELS OF WITCHES  
AND WIZARDS WERE SAT AROUND EVERY WALL AND WHAT SEEMED TO BE

BENCHES RISING IN LEVELS. AN EMPTY CHAIR STOOD IN THE VERY CEN-  
TRE OF THE ROOM. THERE WAS SOMETHING ABOUT THE CHAIR THAT GAVE

HARRY AN UNUSUAL FEELING. CHAINS ENCIRCLED THE ARMS OF IT, AS  
THOUGH ITS OCCUPANTS WERE USUALLY TIED TO IT.

WHERE WAS THIS PLACE? IT SURELY WASN'T HOGWARTS; HE HAD  
NEVER SEEN A ROOM LIKE THAT HERE IN THE CASTLE. MOREOVER, THE  
CROWD IN THE MYSTERIOUS ROOM AT THE BOTTOM OF THE BASIN WAS  
COMPOSED OF ADULTS, AND HARRY KNEW THERE WERE NOT NEARLY

SO MANY TEACHERS

AT HOGWARTS. THEY SEEMED, HE THOUGHT, TO BE WAITING FOR SOMETHING; EVEN THOUGH HE COULD ONLY SEE THE  
TIPS OF THEIR POINTED HATS, THEY ALL SEEMED TO BE FACING IN ONE



DIRECTION, AND NOBODY WAS TALKING TO ANYBODY ELSE.

THE BASIN BEING CIRCULAR, AND THE ROOM HE WAS OBSERVING  
SEMI-CIRCULAR, HARRY COULD NOT MAKE OUT WHAT WAS GOING ON IN THE  
CORNERS OF IT. HE LEANT EVEN CLOSER, TILTING HIS HEAD, TRYING TO  
SEE ...

THE TIP OF HIS NOSE TOUCHED THE STRANGE SUBSTANCE IN THE  
WHICH HE WAS STARING.

DUMBLEDORE'S OFFICE GAVE AN ALMIGHTY BURCH. HARRY WAS  
THROWN FORWARDS AND PITCHED HEADFIRST INTO THE SUBSTANCE  
INSIDE THE BASIN.

BUT HIS HEAD DID NOT HIT THE STONE BOTTOM. HE WAS FALLING  
THROUGH SOMETHING SO CHILD AND BLACK; IT WAS LIKE BEING SLIDED  
INTO A DARK WHIRLPOOL.

AND SUDDENLY, HE FOUND HIMSELF SITTING ON A BENCH AT THE  
END OF THE ROOM INSIDE THE BASIN, A BENCH RAISED HIGH ABOVE  
THE OTHERS. HE LOOKED UP AT THE HIGH STONE CEILING, EXPECTING TO

SEE THE CIRCULAR WINDOW THROUGH WHICH HE HAD JUST BEEN STAR-  
ING, BUT THERE WAS NOTHING THERE BUT DARK, SILENT STONE.

BREATHING HARD AND FAST, HARRY LOOKED AROUND HIM. NOT ONE  
OF THE WITCHES AND WIZARDS IN THE ROOM (AND THERE WERE AT LEAST  
TWO HUNDRED OF THEM) WAS LOOKING AT HIM. NOT ONE OF THEM  
SEEMED TO HAVE NOTICED THAT A FIFTEEN-YEAR-OLD BOY HAD JUST  
DROPPED FROM THE CEILING INTO THEIR MIDST. HARRY TURNED THE OTHER

WIZARD NEXT TO HIM ON THE BENCH, AND LITTERED A LOUD CRY OF SUR-

PRISE THAT REVERBERATED AROUND THE SILENT ROOM.

HE WAS SITTING RIGHT NEXT THE ALBUS DUMBLEDORE.

PROFESSOR: HARRY SAID, IN A KIND OF STRANGLED WHISPER, I'M  
SORRY I DIDN'T MEAN THE I WAS JUST LOOKING AT THAT BASIN IN  
YOUR CABINET I WHERE ARE WE?

BUT DUMBLEDORE DIDN'T MOVE OR SPEAK, HE IGNORED HARRY  
COMPLETELY, LIKE EVERY OTHER WIZARD IN THE SCHOOLS, HE WAS  
STARING INTO THE FAR CORNER OF THE ROOM, WHERE THERE WAS A DOOR.

THE PENETRIVE SON

HARRY GAZED, HYPNOTIZED, AT DUMBLEDORE, THEN AROUND AT THE  
SILENTLY WATCHFUL CREED, THEN BACK AT DUMBLEDORE, AND THEN IT  
DANKED HIM HIM ...

ENCE REHERE, HARRY HAD FOUND HIMSELF A PLACE WHERE NOBODY  
COULD SEE OR HEAR HIM, THAT TIME, HE HAD FALLEN THROUGH A PAGE  
IN AN ENCHANTED DIARY, RIGHT INTO SOMEONE ELSE'S MEMORY ...  
AND UNLESS HE WAS VERY MUCH MISTAKEN, SOMETHING OF THE SORT  
HAD HAPPENED AGAIN ...

HARRY RAISED HIS RIGHT HAND, HESITATED, AND THEN WAVED IT  
ENERGETICALLY IN FRONT OF DUMBLEDORE'S FACE, DUMBLEDORE DID  
NOT BLINK, HEED AROUND AT HARRY, HE INDEED MOVE AT ALL, AND

THAT, IN HARRY'S OPINION, SETTLED THE MATTER, DUMBLEDORE WOULD  
NOT IGNORE HIM LIKE THAT, HE WAS INSIDE A MEMORY, AND THIS WAS

NOT THE PRESENT-DAY DUMBLEDORE, YET IT COULDN'T BE THAT LONG

AGEH ... THE DUMBLEDORE SITTING NEXT THE HIM NOW WAS SILVER-  
HAired, ILST LIKE THE PRESENT-DAY DUMBLEDORE, BUT WHAT WAS

THIS PLACE? WHAT WERE ALL THESE WIZARDS WAITING FOR?

HARRY LOOKED AROUND MORE CAREFULLY. THE ROOM, AS HE HAD  
SUSPECTED WHEN ENTERING IT FROM ABOVE, WAS ALMOST CERTAINLY  
UNDERGROUND MORE OF A DUNGEON THAN A ROOM, HE THOUGHT.  
THERE WAS A DEAD AND FRIGHTENING AIR ABOUT THE PLACE; THERE  
WERE NO PICTURES ON THE WALLS, NO DECORATIONS AT ALL; ILST THESE  
SERRED ROWS OF BENCHES, RISING IN LEVELS ALL AROUND THE ROOM,  
ALL POSITIONED SO THAT THEY HAD A CLEAR VIEW OF THAT CHAIR WITH  
THE CHAINS ON ITS ARMS.

BEFORE HARRY COULD REACH ANY CONCLUSIONS ABOUT THE PLACE IN  
WHICH THEY WERE, HE HEARD FOOTSTEPS. THE DOOR IN THE CORNER OF  
THE DUNGEON OPENED, AND THREE PEOPLE ENTERED - OR AT LEAST,  
ONE MAN, FLANKED BY TWO DEMENTORS.

HARRY'S INSIDES WENT CHILL. THE DEMENTORS, TALL, WHITE CRE-  
TURES WHOSE FACES WERE CONCEALED, WERE GLIDING SILENTLY TOWARDS

THE CHAIR IN THE CENTRE OF THE ROOM, EACH GRASPING ONE OF THE  
MAN'S ARMS WITH THEIR DEAD AND ROTTEN-LOOKING HANDS. THE MAN  
BETWEEN THEM LOOKED AS THOUGH HE WAS ABOUT TO FAINT, AND  
HARRY COULDN'T BLAME HIM ... HE KNEW THE DEMENTORS COULD

END HARRY POTTER

NET THINK HIM INSIDE A MEMORY, BUT HARRY REMEMBERED THEIR  
POWER ONLY TOO WELL. THE WATCHING CREW RECOILED SLIGHTLY AS  
THE DEMENTORS PLACED THE MAN IN THE CHAINED CHAIR AND GLIDED  
BACK BEHIND THE BARRIER. THE OTHER SWINE SPLIT BEHIND THEM.  
HARRY LEANED DOWN AT THE MAN NOW SITTING IN THE CHAIR, AND  
SAW THAT IT WAS KARKADOFF.

UNLIKE DUMBLEDORE, KARKADOFF LOOKED MUCH YOUNGER; HIS  
HAIR AND CHEEKS WERE BLACK. HE WAS NOT DRESSED IN SLEEK CLOTHES,  
BUT IN THIN AND RAGGED RIESES. HE WAS SHAKING. EVEN AS HARRY  
WATCHED, THE CHAINS ON THE ARMS OF THE CHAIR CLENCHED SUDDENLY  
CLOSE, AND SNAPPED THEIR WAY UP HIS ARMS, BINDING HIM THERE.

ICHO KARKADOFF, SAID A CLUT VEHICLE THE HARRY S LEFT. HARRY  
LOOKED AROUND, AND SAW MR CRUELICH STANDING UP IN THE MIDDLE  
OF THE BENCH BESIDE HIM. CRUELICH S HAIR WAS DARK, HIS FACE WAS  
MUCH LESS LINED, HE LOOKED FIT AND ALERT. YELL HAVE BEEN  
BRIGHT FROM AZKABAN THE GIVE EVIDENCE THE THE MINISTRY OF

MAGIC. YELL HAVE GIVEN US THE UNDERSTAND THAT YELL HAVE IMPOR-  
TANT INFORMATION FOR US.

KARKADOFF STRAIGHTENED HIMSELF AS BEST HE COULD, TIGHTLY  
BEHIND THE CHAIR.

I HAVE, SIR, HE SAID, AND ALTHOUGH HIS VOICE WAS VERY SCARED,  
HARRY COULD STILL HEAR THE FAMILIAR UNCTUOUS NOTE IN IT. I WISH  
THE BE HE USE THE THE MINISTRY, I WISH THE HELP, I I KNOW THAT THE  
MINISTRY IS TRYING THE THE BEHIND UP THE LAST OF THE DARK LORD S  
SLIPPERERS, I AM EAGER THE ASSIST IN ANY WAY I CAN ...

THERE WAS A MURMUR AROUND THE BENCHES, SOME OF THE WIZARDS AND WITCHES WERE STARRYING KARKADENN WITH INTEREST, OTHERS WITH PREHENSIVE MISTRUST. THEN HARRY HEARD, ELITE DISTINCTLY, FROM DUMBLEDORE'S EITHER SIDE, A FAMILIAR, GROWLING VOICE SAYING, FILTH.

HARRY LEANT FORWARD TO SEE THAT HE COULD SEE PAST DUMBLEDORE. MAD-EYE MURPHY WAS SITTING THERE THOUGH THERE WAS A VERY NOTICEABLE DIFFERENCE IN HIS APPEARANCE. HE DID NOT HAVE HIS MAGICAL EYE, BUT TWO NORMAL EYES. BOTH WERE LEENING DOWN UPON KARKADENN, AND BOTH WERE NARROWED IN INTENSE DISLIKE.

THE MINISTER 511

CRUELTY IS GOING TO LET HIM GO, MURPHY BREATHED QUIETLY TO DUMBLEDORE. HE'S DONE A DEAL WITH HIM. THREE OR SIX MONTHS TO TRACK HIM DOWN, AND CRUELTY IS GOING TO LET HIM GO IF HE'S GOT ENOUGH NEW NAMES. LET'S HEAR HIS INFORMATION, I SAY, AND THROW HIM STRAIGHT BACK TO THE DEMENTORS. DUMBLEDORE MADE A SMALL NOISE OF DISSENT THROUGH HIS LONG, CREAKED NOSE.

AND I WAS FORGETTING ... YOU DON'T LIKE THE DEMENTORS, DO YOU, ALBUS? SAID MURPHY, WITH A SARDONIC SMILE.

NO, SAID DUMBLEDORE CALMLY, I'M AFRAID I DON'T. I HAVE LONG FELT THE MINISTRY IS WRINGING THE ALBANY ITSELF WITH SUCH CREATURES.

BUT HER FILTH LIKE THIS ... MEEHBY SAID SHORTLY,

THEY SAY THEY HAVE NAMES FOR US, KARKARHFF, SAID MR CRUELCH.  
LET US HEAR THEM, PLEASE.

THEY MUST UNDERSTAND, SAID KARKARHFF FLURRIEDLY, THAT HE  
WHO MUST NOT BE NAMED OPERATES ALWAYS IN THE GREATEST  
SECRECY ... HE PREFERRED THAT WE I MEAN THE SAY, HIS SLIPPERTERS  
AND I REGRET THEM, VERY DEEPLY, THAT I EVER CHLINTED MYSELF  
AMONG THEM

GET ON WITH IT, SNIGGERED MEEHBY,

WE NEVER KNEW THE NAMES OF EVERY ONE OF OUR FELLOWS HE  
ALONE KNEW EXACTLY WHO WE ALL WERE

WHICH WAS A WISE MOVE, WASN'T IT, AS IT PREVENTED SOMEONE  
LIKE THEY, KARKARHFF, TURNING ALL OF THEM IN, MUTTERED MEEHBY,  
YET THEY SAY THEY HAVE SOME NAMES FOR US? SAID MR CRUELCH.

I I SEE, SAID KARKARHFF KREATHELESSLY, AND THESE WERE IMPOR-  
TANT SLIPPERTERS, MARK THEY, PEOPLE I SAW WITH MY OWN EYES

BEING HIS KIDDING, I GIVE THIS INFORMATION AS A SIGN THAT I FULLY  
AND TOTALLY RENOUNCE HIM, AND AM FILLED WITH A REMORSE SO DEEP  
I CAN BARELY

THESE NAMES ARE? SAID MR CRUELCH SHARPLY,

KARKARHFF DREW A DEEP KREATH.

THERE WAS ANTHONIN DEEHEHEHY, HE SAID, I I SAW HIM THIRTWIRE  
CHLINTLESS MUGGLES AND AND NEIN-SLIPPERTERS OF THE DARK  
LEARD.

S12 HARRY POTTER

AND HELPED HIM DO IT, MURMURED MURDER.

WE HAVE ALREADY APPREHENDED DEATHLY, SAID CRUELTY. HE  
WAS CALLED SHORTLY AFTER HIMSELF.

INDEED? SAID DARKNESS, HIS EYES WIDENING. I I AM DELIGHT-  
ED TO HEAR IT!

BUT HE DIDN'T KNOW IT. HARRY COULD TELL THAT THIS NEWS HAD  
COME AS A REAL BLOW TO HIM. HENCE HIS NAME WAS WORTHLESS.

AND OTHERS? SAID CRUELTY COLDLY.

YES, YES ... THERE WAS REVER, SAID DARKNESS FLURRIEDLY.

EVAN REVER.

REVER IS DEAD, SAID CRUELTY. HE WAS CALLED SHORTLY AFTER  
HE WERE, THEN. HE PREFERRED THE FIGHT RATHER THAN COMING QUIETLY,  
AND WAS KILLED IN THE STRUGGLE.

THINK A BIT OF ME WITH HIM, CRUELTY, WHISPERED MURDER THE  
HARRY IS RIGHT. HARRY LOOKED AROUND AT HIM ENCE MORE, AND SAW  
HIM INDICATING THE LARGE CHAIR HILT OF HIS NECK THE DUMBLEDORE.

NEE NEE MORE THAN REVER DESERVED? SAID DARKNESS, A REAL  
NOTE OF PANIC IN HIS VOICE NEE. HARRY COULD SEE THAT HE WAS  
STARTING THE WHIRRY THAT NONE OF HIS INFORMATION WOULD BE ANY  
USE TO THE MINISTRY. DARKNESS'S EYES DARTED TOWARDS THE DEER IN  
THE CORNER, BEHIND WHICH THE DEMENTORS UNBELIEVABLY STILL  
STOOD, WAITING.

AND MORE? SAID CRUELTY.

YES? SAID DARKNESS. THERE WAS TRAVERS HE HELPED MURDER

THE MCKINNENS' MURKINER HE SPECIALISED IN THE IMPERILS  
COURSE, FORCED CHILDLESS PEOPLE TO DO TERRIFIC THINGS.  
REEDWHEED, WHO WAS A SPY, AND PASSED FOR WHO MUST NOT BE  
NAMED USED INFORMATION FROM INSIDE THE MINISTRY ITSELF.  
HARRY COULD TELL THAT, THIS TIME, KARDARETH HAD STRUCK CHILD.  
THE WATCHING CREW WERE ALL MURMURING TOGETHER.

REEDWHEED? SAID MR CRUELCH, NEEDING THE A WITCH SITTING IN  
FRONT OF HIM, WHO BEGAN SCRIBBLING UPON HER PIECE OF PARCH-  
MENT. AUGUSTUS REEDWHEED OF THE DEPARTMENT OF MYSTERIES?

THE VERY SAME, SAID KARDARETH EAGERLY. I BELIEVE HE USED A  
NETWORK OF WELL-PLACED WIZARDS, BOTH INSIDE THE MINISTRY AND

THE PENINSULAR SLR

ELIJAH, THE CHIEF INFORMATION

BUT TRAVERS AND MURKINER, WE HAVE, SAID MR CRUELCH. VERY  
WELL, KARDARETH, IF THAT IS ALL, YOU WILL BE RETURNED TO AZKABAN  
WHILE WE DECIDE

NOT YET? CRIED KARDARETH, BECOMING WHITE DESPERATE. WAIT, I  
HAVE MORE?

HARRY COULD SEE HIM SWEATING IN THE THROCKLIGHT, HIS WHITE  
SKIN CONTRASTING STRONGLY WITH THE BLACK OF HIS HAIR AND BEARD.

SNAPE? HE STUTTERED. SEVERUS SNAPE?

SNAPE HAS BEEN CLEARED BY THIS CHURCH, SAID CRUELCH COLDLY.

HE HAS BEEN VOUCHERED FOR BY ALBUS DUMBLEDORE.

NEE? STUTTERED KARDARETH, STRAINING AT THE CHAINS WHICH HELD



HIM THE THE CHAIR. I ASSURE YOU! SEVERUS Snape IS A DEATH EATER!  
BLUNKEDHEE HAD GHT THE HIS FEET. I HAVE GIVEN EVIDENCE  
ALREADY IN THIS MATTER, HE SAID CALMLY. SEVERUS Snape WAS  
INDEED A DEATH EATER. HOWEVER, HE REMAINED HIS SIDE BEHIND

LORD VOLDEMORT'S DEEDS AND TURNED SPY FOR US, AT GREAT PER-  
SONAL RISK. HE IS NOW NO MORE A DEATH EATER THAN I AM.

HARRY TURNED THE HEAD AT MAD-EYE Moody. HE WAS WEARING A  
HEAD OF DEEP SKEPTICISM BEHIND BLUNKEDHEE'S BACK.

VERY WELL, BARKAROFF, CRUELCH SAID COLDLY. YOU HAVE BEEN MY  
ASSISTANCE. I SHALL REVIEW YOUR CASE. YOU WILL RETURN THE AZKABAN  
IN THE MEANTIME ...

MR CRUELCH'S VEHICLE FADED. HARRY BLINKED AROUND; THE BLINKING  
WAS DISSEMINATING AS THOUGH IT WAS MADE OF SMOKE; EVERYTHING  
WAS FADING. HE COULD SEE ONLY HIS OWN BODY, ALL ELSE WAS  
SWIRLING DARKNESS ...

AND THEN, THE BLINKING RETURNED. HARRY WAS SITTING IN A DI-  
FERENT SEAT; STILL IN THE HIGHEST BENCH, BUT NOW THE THE LEFT SIDE

OF MR CRUELCH. THE ATMOSPHERE SEEMED SLIGHTLY DIFFERENT; RELAXED,  
EVEN CHEERFUL. THE WITCHES AND WIZARDS ALL AROUND THE WALLS  
WERE TALKING THE EACH OTHER, ALMOST AS THOUGH THEY WERE AT SOME  
SHORT OF SPORTING EVENT. A WITCH HALFWAY UP THE ROWS OF BENCHES  
OPPOSITE CALLED HARRY'S EYE. SHE HAD SHORT BLONDE HAIR, WAS  
WEARING MAGENTA PANTS, AND WAS SLICKING THE END OF AN ACID-

519 HARRY POTTER

GREEN HILL. IT WAS, UNMISTAKABLY, A YOUNGER RITA SKEETER.  
HARRY LOOKED AROUND; DUMBLEDORE WAS SITTING BESIDE HIM  
AGAIN, WEARING DIFFERENT RINGS. MR CRUELCH LOOKED TIREDER AND

SOMEWHAT FIERCER, CALINTER ... HARRY UNDERSTOOD, IT WAS A DIFFER-  
ENT MEMORY, A DIFFERENT DAY ... A DIFFERENT TRIAL.

THE DOOR IN THE CORNER OPENED, AND ELIOT BAGMAN WALKED  
INTO THE ROOM.

THIS WAS NOT, HOWEVER, A ELIOT BAGMAN GIVE THE SPEECH, BUT A

ELIOT BAGMAN WHO WAS CLEARLY AT THE HEIGHT OF HIS FLINDITCH-  
PLAYING FITNESS. HIS NECK WASN'T BROTHER NECK; HE WAS TALL AND

LEAN AND MUSCULAR. BAGMAN LOOKED NERVOUS AS HE SAT DOWN IN THE  
CHAINED CHAIR, BUT IT DID NOT KID HIM THERE, AS IT HAD BEEN  
DARKER, AND BAGMAN, PERHAPS TAKING HEART FROM THIS,  
GLANCED AROUND AT THE WATCHING CROWD, WAVED AT A GROUP OF  
THEM, AND MANAGED A SMALL SMILE.

ELIOT BAGMAN, WHO HAD BEEN BRIGHT HERE IN FRONT OF THE

CHURCH OF MAGICAL LAW THE ANSWER CHARGES RELATING THE THE ACTIV-  
ITIES OF THE DEATH EATERS, SAID MR CRUELCH, WE HAVE HEARD THE

EVIDENCE AGAINST YOU, AND ARE ABOUT TO REACH OUR VERDICT. WE

WELL I HAVE SOMETHING TO ADD TO YOUR TESTIMONY BEFORE WE PROCEED  
TO YOUR JUDGEMENT?

HARRY COULDN'T BELIEVE HIS EARS, LUDWIG BAGMAN, A DEATH EATER?

HEINZ, SAID BAGMAN, SMILING ALCORARDLY, WELL I KNOW I'VE  
BEEN A BIT OF AN IDIOT

ONE OF THE WIZARDS AND WITCHES IN THE SURROUNDING SEATS  
SMILED INDULGENTLY, MR CRELLICH DID NOT APPEAR TO SHARE THEIR

FEELINGS, HE WAS STARING DEEPLY AT LUDWIG BAGMAN WITH AN EXPRES-  
SION OF THE UTMOST SEVERITY AND DISLIKE.

WELL NEVER SPEAK A TRUER WORD, HEY, SOMEONE MUTTERED DRILLY  
THE OTHERS BEHIND HARRY, HE LOOKED AROUND, AND SAW  
MORRIS SITTING THERE AGAIN, IF I DIDN'T KNOW HE'D ALWAYS BEEN  
DIP, I'D HAVE SAID SOME OF THESE BLINDERS HAD PERMANENTLY  
AFFECTED HIS BRAIN ...

LUDWIG BAGMAN, WELL WERE CALLED PASSING INFORMATION THE  
LORD VERDEMENT'S SLIPSTERS, SAID MR CRELLICH, FOR THIS, I

THE PENITENTIAL SL

SUGGEST A TERM OF IMPRISONMENT IN AZKABAN LASTING NOT LESS  
THAN

BUT THERE WAS AN ANGRY MUTTER FROM THE SURROUNDING BENCH-  
ES, SEVERAL OF THE WITCHES AND WIZARDS AROUND THE WALLS STOOD

LIP, SHAKING THEIR HEADS, AND EVEN THEIR FISTS, AT MR CRUELICH.

BUT I VE TOLD YELL, I HAD NO IDEA! BAGMAN CALLED EARNESTLY  
EVER THE CRUEL S RABBLE, HIS EYES LIKE EYES WIDENING. NONE  
AT ALL! HIS CRUELNESS WAS A FRIEND OF MY DAD S ... NEVER CRUEL

MY MIND HE WAS IN WITH YELL-DRINK-LETH! I THOUGHT I WAS COL-  
LECTING INFORMATION FOR HIS SIDE! AND CRUELNESS KEPT TALKING

ABOUT GETTING ME A JOB IN THE MINISTRY LATER ON ... SINCE MY

CRUELNESS DAYS ARE OVER, YELL DRINK ... I MEAN, I CAN T KEEP GET-  
TING HIT BY CRUELNESS FOR THE REST OF MY LIFE, CAN I?

THERE WERE TITTERS FROM THE CRUEL.

IT WILL BE PUT TO THE VOTE, SAID MR CRUELICH LOUDLY, HE TURNED  
TO THE RIGHT-HAND SIDE OF THE DINGHIE. THE LADY WILL PLEASE  
RAISE THEIR HANDS ... THESE IN FAVOR OF IMPRISONMENT ...

HARRY LEANED TOWARDS THE RIGHT-HAND SIDE OF THE DINGHIE.  
NOT ONE PERSON RAISED THEIR HAND. MANY OF THE WITCHES AND  
WIZARDS AROUND THE WALLS BEGAN TO CLAP. ONE OF THE WITCHES ON  
THE LADY STOOD UP.

YES? BARKED CRUELICH.

WE D JUST LIKE TO CONGRATULATE MR BAGMAN ON HIS SPLENDID  
PERFORMANCE FOR ENGLAND IN THE CRUELNESS MATCH AGAINST  
TURKEY LAST SATURDAY. THE WITCH SAID BREATHLESSLY.  
MR CRUELICH LEANED FORWARD. THE DINGHIE WAS RINGING WITH

APPLAUSE NEEL, BAGMAN GET THE HIS FEET AND KNEED, BEAMING.

DESPICABLE, MR CRUELICH SPAT AT DUMBLEDORE, SITTING DOWN AS BAGMAN WALKED OUT OF THE DUNGEON. REMEDYING GET HIM A JEE  
INDEED ... THE DAY WHEN BAGMAN THINS HIS WILL BE A VERY SAD DAY  
FOR THE MINISTRY ...

AND THE DUNGEON DISSEMED AGAIN. WHEN IT HAD RETURNED,  
HARRY REMEDYED AROUND, HE AND DUMBLEDORE WERE STILL SITTING  
RESIDE MR CRUELICH, BUT THE ATMOSPHERE COULD NOT HAVE BEEN  
MORE DIFFERENT. THERE WAS TOTAL SILENCE, BROKEN ONLY BY THE DRY

SIX HARRY PENTTER

SEES OF A PAIR, WISPY-LOOKING WITCH IN THE SEAT NEXT THE MR  
CRUELICH. SHE WAS CLUTCHING A HANDKERCHIEF THE HER MOUTH WITH  
TREMBLING HANDS. HARRY REMEDYED UP AT CRUELICH, AND SAW THAT HE  
REMEDYED CALMTER, AND GREYER THAN EVER BEFORE. A NERVE WAS  
TWITCHING IN HIS TEMPLE.

BRING THEM IN, HE SAID, AND HIS VOICE RE-ED THROUGH THE  
SILENT DUNGEON.

THE DOOR IN THE CORNER OPENED YET AGAIN. SIX DEMENTERS  
ENTERED THIS TIME, FANING A GRIIP OF FEELR PEOPLE. HARRY SAW  
THE PEOPLE IN THE CROWD TURN THE REMEDY UP AT MR CRUELICH. A FEW  
OF THEM WHISPERED THE EACH OTHER.

THE DEMENTERS PLACED EACH OF THE FEELR PEOPLE IN THE FEELR  
CHAIRS WITH CHAINED ARMS WHICH NEEL STOOD IN THE DUNGEON  
AFTER. THERE WAS A THICKSET MAN WHO STARED BLANKLY UP AT  
CRUELICH, A THINNER AND MORE NERVILS-LOOKING MAN, WHOSE EYES  
WERE DARTING AROUND THE CROWD, A WHIMAN, WITH THICK, SHINING

DARK HAIR, AND HEAVILY HEAVED EYES, WHEN WAS SITTING IN THE  
CHAINED CHAIR AS THOUGH IT WERE A THRONE, AND A BOY IN HIS LATE  
TEENS, WHEN HEARD NOTHING SHORT OF PETRIFIED, HE WAS SHIVERING,

HIS STRAW-COLOURED HAIR ALL OVER HIS FACE, HIS FRECKLED SKIN MILK-  
WHITE. THE WISPY LITTLE WITCH BESIDE CRUELICH BEGAN TO ROCK

BACKWARDS AND FORWARDS IN HER SEAT, WHIMPERING INTO HER  
HANDKERCHIEF.

CRUELICH STOOD UP, HE HEARD DEHN WHISPER THE FEELER IN FRONT OF  
HIM, AND THERE WAS PURE HATRED IN HIS FACE.

YELL HAVE BEEN BRUGHT HERE BEFORE THE COUNCIL OF MAGICAL  
LAW, HE SAID CLEARLY, SEE THAT WE MAY PASS JUDGEMENT ON YELL,  
FOR A CRIME SHE COMMITTED

FATHER, SAID THE BOY WITH THE STRAW-COLOURED HAIR, FATHER  
... PLEASE ...

THAT WE HAVE RARELY HEARD THE LIKE OF IT WITHIN THIS COURT,  
SAID CRUELICH, SPEAKING MORE LOUDLY, DRINKING INTO HIS SHIN S  
VEICE. WE HAVE HEARD THE EVIDENCE AGAINST YELL. THE FEELER OF  
YELL STAND ACCUSED OF CAPTURING AN ALIEN FRANK LEUNGHTEN  
AND SLICKETING HIM THE THE CRUCIATLS CLASE, RELIVING HIM THE

THE PENITENT S19

HAVE KNOWLEDGE OF THE PRESENT WHEREABOUTS OF YELL'S EXILED  
MASTER, HE WHEN MUST NOT BE NAMED

FATHER, I DIDN'T! SHRIEKED THE BOY IN CHAINS BEHIND. I DIDN'T, I  
SWEAR IT, FATHER, DON'T SEND ME BACK THE THE DEMENTHERS

YELI ARE FURTHER ACCUSED, BELIEVED MR CRELICH, BY LISTING THE  
CRUCIATUS CURSE AND FRANK LINGENSTERN'S WIFE, WHEN HE WOULD  
NOT GIVE YELI INFORMATION. YELI PLANNED THE RESTORE FOR WHICH

MUST NOT BE NAMED THE POWDER, AND THE RESUME THE LIVES OF VIL-  
LENCE YELI PRESUMABLY LED WHILE HE WAS STRONG. I NEED ASK THE

ILRY

MEETHER? SCREAMED THE REDY REBEL, AND THE WISPY LITTLE WITCH  
RESIDE CRELICH BEGAN THE SHIR, RECKING BACKWARDS AND FORWARDS.

MEETHER, STOP HIM, MEETHER, I DIDN'T DO IT, IT WASN'T ME?

I NEED ASK THE ILRY, SHELITED MR CRELICH, THE RAISE THEIR HANDS  
IF THEY BELIEVE, AS I DO, THAT THESE CRIMES DESERVE A LIFE SENTENCE  
IN AZERABAN.

IN UNISON, THE WITCHES AND WIZARDS ALONG THE RIGHT-HAND SIDE  
OF THE DUNGEON RAISED THEIR HANDS. THE CREED AROUND THE WALLS

BEGAN THE CLAP AS IT HAD FOR BAGMAN, THEIR FACES FULL OF SAVAGE TRI-  
UMPH. THE REDY BEGAN THE SCREAM.

NEH? MEETHER, NEH? I DIDN'T DO IT, I DIDN'T DO IT, I DIDN'T DENY?  
DIDN'T SEND ME THERE, DIDN'T LET HIM?

THE DEMENTERS WERE GLIDING BACK INTO THE ROOM. THE REDY'S  
THREE COMPANIONS ROSE HOLIETLY FROM THEIR SEATS. THE WOMAN  
WITH THE HEAVY-LIDDED EYES BEHEED UP AT CRELICH AND CALLED,

THE DARK LORD WILL RISE AGAIN, CRELICH? THREW US INTO  
AZERABAN, WE WILL WAIT? HE WILL RISE AGAIN AND WILL COME FOR US,

HE WILL REWARD US BOTH AND OF HIS OTHER SUPPORTERS! WE  
ALONE WERE FAITHFUL! WE ALONE TRIED TO FIND HIM!  
BUT THE KEY WAS TRYING TO FIGHT THE DEMENTERS OFF, EVEN  
THOUGH HARRY COULD SEE THEIR CHILD, DRAINING POWER STARTING TO  
AFFECT HIM. THE CREED WERE REERING, SOME OF THEM HAD THEIR  
FEET, AS THE WOMAN SWIFT FELT OF THE DEMENTERS, AND THE KEY  
CONTINUED THE STRUGGLE.

I MOTHER SHEN! HE SCREAMED UP AT CREED, I MOTHER SHEN!

SIX HARRY PETER

WELL ARE NOT SHEN OF MINE! BELIEVED MR CREED, HIS EYES  
BLINKING SUDDENLY. I HAVE NOT SHEN!

THE WISPY WITCH BESIDE HIM GAVE A GREAT GASP, AND SLUMPED  
IN HER SEAT. SHE HAD FAINTED. CREED APPEARED NOT TO HAVE  
NOTICED.

TAKE THEM AWAY! CREED REARED AT THE DEMENTERS, SPIT FLY-  
ING FROM HIS MOUTH. TAKE THEM AWAY, AND MAY THEY REST THERE!

FATHER! FATHER, I WASN'T INVOLVED! NOT! NOT! FATHER, PLEASE!

I THINK, HARRY, IT IS TIME TO RETURN TO MY OFFICE, SAID A HELPER  
VOICE IN HARRY'S EAR.

HARRY STARTED, HE LOOKED AROUND. THEN HE LOOKED ON HIS  
OTHER SIDE.

THERE WAS AN ALBUS DUMBLEDORE SITTING ON HIS RIGHT, WATCHING  
CREED'S SON BEING DRAGGED AWAY BY THE DEMENTERS AND THERE  
WAS AN ALBUS DUMBLEDORE ON HIS LEFT, LOOKING RIGHT AT HIM.



HEME, SAID THE DUMKLEDBERE MEN HIS LEFT, AND HE PLUT HIS  
HAND UNDER HARRY S EELER, HARRY FELT HIMSELF RISING INTO THE AIR;  
THE DUMKLEDBERE DISSEVED AROUND HIM; FOR A MOMENT, ALL WAS

BLACKNESS, AND THEN HE FELT AS THOUGH HE HAD BEEN A SHEEN-  
MITHEN SHIPERSALIT, SLIDDERLY LANDING FLAT MEN HIS FEET, IN WHAT

SEEMED LIKE THE DAZZLING LIGHT OF DUMKLEDBERE S SLINKIT OFFICE.  
THE STONE BASIN WAS SHIMMERING IN THE CABINET IN FRONT OF HIM,  
AND ALAS DUMKLEDBERE WAS STANDING BESIDE HIM.

PROFESSOR, HARRY GASPED, I KNOW I SHOULDNT VE I DIDNT  
MEAN THE CABINET DOOR WAS SHUT OF OPEN AND

I HLLITE UNDERSTAND, SAID DUMKLEDBERE, HE LIFTED THE BASIN,  
CARRIED IT OVER THE HIS DESK, PLACED IT UPON THE POLISHED TOP, AND  
SAT DOWN IN THE CHAIR BEHIND IT, HE MENTIONED HARRY THE SIT  
DOWN OPPOSITE HIM.

HARRY DID SEE, STARING AT THE STONE BASIN, THE CONTENTS HAD

RETURNED THE THEIR ORIGINAL, SILVERY WHITE STATE, SWIRLING AND RIP-  
PLING BENEATH HIS GAZE.

WHAT IS IT? HARRY ASKED SHAKILY.

THIS? IT IS CALLED A PENSIVE, SAID DUMKLEDBERE, I SOMETIMES  
FIND, AND I AM SURE YOU KNOW THE FEELING, THAT I SIMPLY HAVE

THE PENSIVE S17

THESE MANY THOUGHTS AND MEMORIES CRAMMED INTO MY MIND.

ER, SAID HARRY, WHEN CHILDREN T TALKITIVELY SAY THAT HE HAD EVER  
FELT ANYTHING OF THE SORT.

AT THESE TIMES, SAID DUMBLEDORE, INDICATING THE STONE  
BASIN, I USE THE PENSIVE, HENCE SIMPLY SIFTING THE EXCESS  
THOUGHTS FROM HENCE S MIND, PHURS THEM INTO THE BASIN, AND

EXAMINES THEM AT HENCE S LEISURE. IT BECOMES EASIER THE SPOT PAT-  
TERNS AND LINKS, WHEN UNDERSTAND, WHEN THEY ARE IN THIS FORM,

WHEN MEAN ... THAT STUFF S YOUR THOUGHTS? HARRY SAID, STARING  
AT THE SWIRLING WHITE SUBSTANCE IN THE BASIN.

CERTAINLY, SAID DUMBLEDORE. LET ME SHOW YOU.

DUMBLEDORE DREW HIS HAND INTO THE INSIDE OF HIS ROBES,  
AND PLACED THE TIP INTO HIS LONG SILVER HAIR, NEAR HIS TEMPLE.  
WHEN HE TOOK THE WAND AWAY, HAIR SEEMED TO BE CLINGING TO IT

BUT THEN HARRY SAW THAT IT WAS IN FACT A GLISTENING STRAND OF  
THE SAME STRANGE, SILVERY WHITE SUBSTANCE THAT FILLED THE  
PENSIVE. DUMBLEDORE ADDED THIS FRESH THOUGHT TO THE BASIN,  
AND HARRY, ASTONISHED, SAW HIS OWN FACE SWIMMING AROUND THE  
SURFACE OF THE BOWL.

DUMBLEDORE PLACED HIS LONG HANDS ON EITHER SIDE OF THE  
PENSIVE AND SWIRLED IT, RATHER AS A CHILD PRESPECTOR WOULD  
SWIRL FEW FRAGMENTS OF CHOC ... AND HARRY SAW HIS OWN FACE  
CHANGE SMOOTHLY INTO SNAPS S, WHEN HE OPENED HIS MOUTH, AND  
SPoke TO THE CEILING, HIS VOICE ECHOING SLIGHTLY. IT S COMING  
BACK ... DARRAREH S THEN ... STRONGER AND CLEARER THAN EVER ...

A CONNECTION I COULD HAVE MADE WITHOUT ASSISTANCE,

DUMBLEDORE SIGHED, BUT NEVER MIND. HE PEERED OVER THE TOP OF HIS HALF-MOON SPECTACLES AT HARRY, WHO WAS GAWPING AT SNAPE'S FACE, WHICH WAS CONTINUING THE SWIRL AROUND THE KISS. I WAS LOSING THE PENSIVE WHEN MR FLICKER ARRIVED FOR THEIR MEETING, AND PLIT IT AWAY RATHER FASTLY. UNDELETEDLY I DID NOT FASTEN THE CABINET BEHIND PROPERLY. NATURALLY, IT WOULD HAVE ATTRACTED THEIR ATTENTION.

I'M SORRY, HARRY MUMBLED.  
DUMBLEDORE SHOOK HIS HEAD.

SEN HARRY PENTTER

CURIOUSITY IS NOT A SIN, HE SAID, BUT WE SHOULD EXERCISE CAUTION WITH OUR CURIOSITY ... YES, INDEED ...

PRELUNING SLIGHTLY, HE PRELUNED THE TRELIGHTS WITHIN THE BASIN WITH THE TIP OF HIS WAND. INSTANTLY, A FIGURE RESE FELT OF IT, A PLUMP, SCHEWING GIRL OF AROUND SIXTEEN, WHO BEGAN THE REVEAL

SHEDLY, WITH HER FEET STILL IN THE BASIN. SHE THEN SHE NOTICE WHAT-SERVER OF HARRY HER PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE. WHEN SHE SPEKE,

HER VOICE RESEED AS SNAPE'S HAD BEEN, AS THOUGH IT WAS COMING FROM THE DEPTHS OF THE STONE BASIN: HE PLIT A FROWN ON ME, PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE, AND I WAS ONLY TEASING HIM, SIR, I ONLY SAID I'D SEEN HIM KISSING FLORENCE BEHIND THE GREEN-HILSES LAST THURSDAY ...

BUT WHY, BERTHA, SAID DUMBLEDORE SADLY, LEANING UP AT THE  
NEW SILENTLY REVOLVING GIRD, WHY DID YOU HAVE THE FEELING HIM IN  
THE FIRST PLACE?

BERTHA? HARRY WHISPERED, LEANING UP AT HER. IS THAT WAS  
THAT BERTHA JERKINS?

YES, SAID DUMBLEDORE, PREDING THE TEEHIGHTS IN THE BASIN  
AGAIN; BERTHA SAND RACK INTO THEM, AND THEY BECAME SILVER  
AND SPARKLE HENCE MORE. THAT WAS BERTHA AS I REMEMBER HER AT  
SCHEEL.

THE SILVER LIGHT FROM THE PENSIVE ILLUMINATED DUMBLE-  
DORE S FACE, AND IT STRUCK HARRY SLIDENLY FEEL VERY OLD HE WAS

LEARNING, HE KNEW, HE CHURSE, THAT DUMBLEDORE WAS GETTING OLD  
IN YEARS, BUT SOMEHOW HE NEVER REALLY TEEHIGHT HE DUMBLEDORE  
AS AN OLD MAN.

SEE, HARRY, SAID DUMBLEDORE QUIETLY, BEHOLD YOU GET LOST IN  
MY TEEHIGHTS, YOU WANTED THE TELL ME SOMETHING.

YES, SAID HARRY, PROFESSOR I WAS IN DIVINATION LIST NEW,  
AND ER I FELL ASLEEP.

HE HESITATED HERE, WONDERING IF A REPRIMAND WAS COMING, BUT  
DUMBLEDORE MERELY SAID, ELITE UNDERSTANDABLE, CONTINUE.

WELL, I HAD A DREAM, SAID HARRY. A DREAM ABOUT LEAD  
VEHEMENT, HE WAS THIRTLING WHIRTAIL ... YOU KNOW WE-HE  
WHIRTAIL

THE PENSIVE 521

I SEE NOW, SAID DUMBLEDORE, PROMPTLY, PLEASE CONTINUE.

WHEN HE GOT A LETTER FROM AN HELL, HE SAID SOMETHING LIKE, WORMTAIL'S CLOSET HAD BEEN REPAIRED, HE SAID SOMETHING WAS DEAD. THEN HE SAID, WORMTAIL WOULDN'T BE FED THE THE SNAKE THERE WAS A SNAKE BESIDE HIS CHAIR, HE SAID HE SAID HE D BE FEEDING ME THE IT, INSTEAD, THEN HE DID THE CRUCIATUS CURSE ON WORMTAIL AND MY SCAR FLIRT, HARRY SAID, IT WENT ME LIP, IT FLIRT SEE BADLY.

DUMBLEDORE MERELY SMILED AT HIM.

ER THAT'S ALL, SAID HARRY.

I SEE, SAID DUMBLEDORE QUIETLY, I SEE, NOW, HAS YOUR SCAR FLIRT AT ANY OTHER TIME THIS YEAR, EXCEPTING THE TIME IT WENT YOUR LIP OVER THE SUMMER?

NO, I KNOW DID YOUR KNOW IT WENT ME LIP OVER THE SUMMER? SAID HARRY, ASTONISHED.

YOU ARE NOT SIRIUS ONLY CORRESPONDENT, SAID DUMBLEDORE, I HAVE ALSO BEEN IN CONTACT WITH HIM EVER SINCE HE LEFT HOGWARTS LAST YEAR. IT WAS I WHO SUGGESTED THE MOUNTAIN LODGE AS THE SAFEST PLACE FOR HIM TO STAY.

DUMBLEDORE GOT UP, AND BEGAN WALKING UP AND DOWN BEHIND HIS DESK. EVERY NOW AND THEN, HE PLACED HIS HAND TOP OF HIS TEMPLE, REMOVED ANOTHER SHINING SILVER TEHLIGHT, AND ADDED IT TO THE PENSIVE. THE TEHLIGHTS INSIDE BEGAN TO SWIRL SO

FAST THAT HARRY COULDN'T MAKE OUT ANYTHING CLEARLY; IT WAS MORE-

by a killer of children.

Professor? He said quietly, after a couple of minutes.

Dumbledore stopped pacing, and looked at Harry.

My apologies, he said quietly. He sat back down at his desk.

O well O well know why my scar is hurting me?

Dumbledore looked very intently at Harry for a moment,

and then said, I have a theory, not more than that ... It is my belief that your scar hurts only when Lord Voldemort is near you, and when he is feeling a particularly strong surge of hatred.

But ... why?

See Harry Potter

Because you and he are connected by the curse that failed, said Dumbledore. That is not ordinary scar.

See you think ... that dream ... did it really happen?

It is possible, said Dumbledore. I would say probable.

Harry Did you see Voldemort?

No, said Harry. Just the back of his chair. But there wouldn't have been anything to see, would there? I mean, he hasn't got a body, has he? But ... But then how could he have held the wand? Harry said slowly.

How indeed? Muttered Dumbledore. How indeed ...

Neither Dumbledore nor Harry spoke for a while.

Dumbledore was gazing across the room, every now and then

PLACING HIS WAND TIP TO HIS TEMPLE, AND ADDING ANOTHER SHINING, SILVER TWILIGHT TO THE SEETHING MASS WITHIN THE PENSIVE.

PROFESSOR, HARRY SAID AT LAST, DO YOU THINK HE'S GETTING STRONGER?

VEHEMENTLY? SAID DUMBLEDORE, LOOKING AT HARRY OVER THE PENSIVE. IT WAS THE CHARACTERISTIC, PIERCING LOOK DUMBLEDORE HAD GIVEN HIM IN OTHER OCCASIONS, AND ALWAYS MADE HARRY FEEL AS THOUGH DUMBLEDORE WAS SEEING RIGHT THROUGH HIM, IN A WAY THAT EVEN MURDER'S MAGICAL EYE COULD NOT. HENCE AGAIN, HARRY, I CAN ONLY GIVE YOU MY SUSPICIONS.

DUMBLEDORE SIGHED AGAIN, AND HE LOOKED OLDER, AND WEARIER, THAN EVER.

THE YEARS OF VEHEMENT'S ASCENT TO POWER, HE SAID, WERE MARKED WITH DISAPPEARANCES. BERTHA JIRKINS HAS VANISHED WITHOUT TRACE IN THE PLACE WHERE VEHEMENT WAS CERTAINLY KNOWN TO BE LAST. MR CRUELCH, THEN, HAS DISAPPEARED ... WITHIN THESE VERY GRILINDS. AND THERE WAS A THIRD DISAPPEARANCE, ONE WHICH THE MINISTRY, I REGRET TO SAY, DOES NOT CONSIDER OF ANY IMPORTANCE, FOR IT CONCERNS A MUGGLE. HIS NAME WAS FRANK BRYCE, HE LIVED IN THE VILLAGE WHERE VEHEMENT'S FATHER GREW UP, AND HE HAS NOT BEEN SEEN SINCE LAST AUGUST. YOU SEE, I READ THE MUGGLE NEWSPAPERS, UNLIKE MOST OF MY MINISTRY FRIENDS. DUMBLEDORE LOOKED VERY SERIOUSLY AT HARRY. THESE DISAP-

THE PENSIVE SET

PEARANCES SEEM TO ME TO BE LINKED. THE MINISTRY DISAGREES AS

YELL MAY HAVE HEARD, WHILE WAITING OUTSIDE MY OFFICE,

HARRY NEEDED. SILENCE FELL BETWEEN THEM AGAIN, DUMKLEDORE

EXTRACTING TEELIGHTS EVERY NOW AND THEN. HARRY FELT AS THOUGH

HE HIGHLIGHT THE GEE, BUT HIS CLICHESITY HELD HIM IN HIS CHAIR.

PROFESSOR? HE SAID AGAIN.

YES, HARRY? SAID DUMKLEDORE.

ER ... CHILD I ASK YELL ABOUT ... THAT CHILD THING I WAS IN ...

IN THE PENSIVE?

YELL CHILD, SAID DUMKLEDORE HEAVILY. I ATTENDED IT MANY

TIMES, BUT SOME TRIALS CAME BACK TO ME MORE CLEARLY THAN OTHERS

... PARTICULARLY NOW ...

YELL KNOW YELL KNOW THE TRIAL YELL FEELING ME IN? THE ONE  
WITH CRUELTY'S SHINY WELL ... WERE THEY TALKING ABOUT NEVILLE'S  
PARENTS?

DUMKLEDORE GAVE HARRY A VERY SHARP LEER.

HAS NEVILLE NEVER TOLD YELL WHY HE HAS BEEN BRILLIANT UP BY  
HIS GRANDMOTHER? HE SAID.

HARRY SHOOK HIS HEAD, WANDERING, AS HE DID SEE, HOW HE

CHILD HAVE FAILED TO ASK NEVILLE THIS, IN ALMOST FOUR YEARS OF  
KNOWING HIM.

YES, THEY WERE TALKING ABOUT NEVILLE'S PARENTS, SAID

DUMKLEDORE. HIS FATHER, FRANK, WAS AN ALRIGHT ILIT LIKE

PROFESSOR MEEDY, HE AND HIS WIFE WERE THIRTLED FOR INFORMATION

THAN ABOUT VILDEBERT'S WIFEABOUTS AFTER HE LEFT HIS PEEVERS, AS

YELL HEARD,



SEE THEY'RE DEAD? SAID HARRY QUIETLY.

NO, SAID DUMBLEDORE, HIS VOICE FULL OF A BITTERNESS HARRY HAD NEVER HEARD THERE BEFORE, THEY ARE INSANE. THEY ARE KEPT IN ST MUNGUS'S HOSPITAL FOR MAGICAL MALADIES AND INJURIES. I BELIEVE NEVILLE VISITS THEM, WITH HIS GRANDMOTHER, DURING THE HOLIDAYS. THEY DO NOT RECOGNISE HIM.

HARRY SAT THERE, FROZEN-STILL, HE HAD NEVER KNOWN ... NEVER, IN FEWER YEARS, EITHERED THE FIND OUT ...

THE LUNGEHTHENS WERE VERY POPULAR, SAID DUMBLEDORE.

SAID HARRY QUIETLY

THE ATTACKS ON THEM CAME AFTER VOLDEMORT'S FALL FROM POWER, JUST WHEN EVERYONE THOUGHT THEY WERE SAFE. THESE ATTACKS CALLED A WAVE OF FURY SUCH AS I HAVE NEVER KNOWN. THE MINISTRY WAS UNDER GREAT PRESSURE TO CATCH THESE WHO HAD DONE IT. UNFORTUNATELY, THE LUNGEHTHENS' EVIDENCE WAS GIVEN THEIR CREDIBILITY BEING TOO RELIABLE.

THEN MR CRUICKSHANKS MIGHT NOT HAVE BEEN INVOLVED? SAID HARRY SILENTLY.

DUMBLEDORE SHOOK HIS HEAD. AS FOR THAT, I HAVE NO IDEA.

HARRY SAT IN SILENCE FOR MORE, WATCHING THE CONTENTS OF THE PENSIVE SWIRL. THERE WERE TWO MORE QUESTIONS HE WAS BURNING THE ASK ... BUT THEY CONCERNED THE GUILT OF LIVING PEOPLE ...

OR, HE SAID, MR BAGMAN ...

... HAS NEVER BEEN ACCUSED OF ANY DARK ACTIVITY SINCE, SAID DUMBLEDORE CALMLY.

RIGHT, SAID HARRY FASTLY, STARING AT THE CONTENTS OF THE

PENSIVE AGAIN, WHICH WERE SWIRLING MORE SLOWLY NOW THAT  
DUMBLEDORE HAD STOPPED ADDING THOUGHTS. AND ... ER ...

BUT THE PENSIVE SEEMED TO BE ASKING HIS QUESTION FOR HIM.  
SNAPPE'S FACE WAS SWIMMING ON THE SURFACE AGAIN. DUMBLEDORE  
GLANCED DOWN INTO IT, AND THEN UP AT HARRY.

WELL THERE WAS PROFESSOR SNAPPE, HE SAID.

HARRY LEANED INTO DUMBLEDORE'S LIGHT-BLUE EYES, AND THE  
THING HE REALLY WANTED TO KNOW SPILLED OUT OF HIS MOUTH BEFORE  
HE COULD STOP IT. WHAT MADE YOU THINK HE'D REALLY STOPPED  
SUPPORTING VOLDEMORT, PROFESSOR?

DUMBLEDORE HELD HARRY'S GAZE FOR A FEW SECONDS, AND THEN  
SAID, THAT, HARRY, IS A MATTER BETWEEN PROFESSOR SNAPPE AND  
MYSELF.

HARRY KNEW THAT THE INTERVIEW WAS OVER; DUMBLEDORE DID  
NOT LOOK ANGRY, YET THERE WAS A FINALITY IN HIS TONE THAT TOLD  
HARRY IT WAS TIME TO GO. HE STOOD UP, AND SO DID DUMBLEDORE.

HARRY, HE SAID, AS HARRY REACHED THE DOOR, PLEASE DO NOT  
SPREAD ABOUT NEVILLE'S PARENTS TO ANYBODY ELSE. HE HAS THE RIGHT  
TO LET PEOPLE KNOW, WHEN HE IS READY.

THE PENSIVE SET

YES, PROFESSOR, SAID HARRY, TURNING THE CORNER.

AND

HARRY LEANED BACK.

DUMBLEDORE WAS STANDING OVER THE PENSIVE, HIS FACE LIT  
FROM BEHIND BY ITS SILVERY SPOTS OF LIGHT, LOOKING OLDER THAN  
EVER. HE STARED AT HARRY FOR A MOMENT, AND THEN SAID, GOOD

LIKED WITH THE THIRD TASK.

## CHAPTER THIRTY-ONE

### THE THIRD TASK

OLIMPEDHRE RECOGNISED YELL-KNEEL-WHEE'S GETTING STRONGER AGAIN AS WELL? REHN WHISPERED.

EVERYTHING HARRY HAD SEEN IN THE PENSIVE, NEARLY EVERYTHING OLIMPEDHRE HAD TOLD AND SHOWN HIM AFTERWARDS, HE HAD

NEEN SHARED WITH REHN AND HERMIONE AND, OF COURSE, WITH SIRIUS, THE WHOM HARRY HAD SENT AWAY THE MOMENT HE HAD LEFT OLIMPEDHRE'S OFFICE. HARRY, REHN AND HERMIONE SAT UP LATE IN THE CHIMNEY ROOM ONCE AGAIN THAT NIGHT, TALKING IT ALL OVER UNTIL HARRY'S MIND WAS REELING, UNTIL HE UNDERSTOOD WHAT OLIMPEDHRE HAD MEANT ABOUT A HEAD RECKONING SHE FLUDDER THOUGHTS THAT IT WOULD HAVE BEEN A RELIEF TO SIMPLY TELL HER, REHN STARED INTO THE CHIMNEY-ROOM FIRE. HARRY THOUGHT HE SAW REHN SHIVER SLIGHTLY, EVEN THOUGH THE EVENING WAS WARM. AND HE TRUSTS SNAPE? REHN SAID. HE REALLY TRUSTS SNAPE, EVEN THOUGH HE KNOWS HE WAS A DEATH EATER?

YES, SAID HARRY.

HERMIONE HAD NOT SPOKEN FOR TEN MINUTES. SHE WAS SITTING WITH HER FINGERHEAD IN HER HANDS, STARING AT HER KNEES. HARRY THOUGHT SHE, THEN, LOOKED AS THOUGH SHE COULD HAVE BEEN WITH A

PENSIVE.

RITA SKEETER, SHE MUTTERED FINALLY.

HOW CAN YOU BE WARRING ABOUT HER NOW? SAID RON, IN  
DISBELIEF.

I M NOT WARRING ABOUT HER, HERMIONE SAID TO HER BONES.

I M JUST THINKING ... REMEMBER WHAT SHE SAID TO ME IN THE  
THREE BROOMSTICKS? I KNOW THINGS ABOUT LUDER BAGMAN THAT

THE THIRD TASK SET

WOULD MAKE YOUR HAIR CURL. THIS IS WHAT SHE MEANT, ISN T IT?  
SHE REPORTED HIS TRIAL, SHE KNEW HE D PASSED INFORMATION TO THE  
DEATH EATERS, AND WINDY, THEN, REMEMBER ... MR BAGMAN IS A  
BAD WIZARD. MR CRUELCH WOULD HAVE BEEN SURPRISED HE GOT OFF,  
HE WOULD HAVE TALKED ABOUT IT AT HOME.

YEAH, BUT BAGMAN DIDN T PASS INFORMATION IN PRISON, DID  
HE?

HERMIONE SHRUGGED.

AND FLUDGE RECALLED MADAME MAXIME ATTACKED CRUELCH? RON  
SAID, TURNING BACK TO HARRY.

YEAH, SAID HARRY, BUT HE S ONLY SAYING THAT BECAUSE CRUELCH  
DISAPPEARED NEAR THE BEAUKREATHS CARRIAGE.

WE NEVER THOUGHT OF HER, DID WE? SAID RON, SLEWLY. MIND  
YOU, SHE S DEFINITELY GETTING GIANT BLEED, AND SHE DOESN T WANT TO  
ADMIT IT

OF COURSE SHE DOESN T, SAID HERMIONE SHARPLY, LEERING UP.

LEERED WHAT HAPPENED TO HAGRID WHEN RITA FEELING BUILT ABOUT HIS  
MOTHER, LEERED AT FLUDGE, JUMPING THE CHANCELLORS ABOUT HER, JUST

BECAUSE SHE'S PART GIANT, WHO NEEDS THAT SORT OF PREJUDICE? I'D  
PREFERABLY SAY I HAD BIG KNEES IF I KNEW THAT'S WHAT I'D GET FOR  
TELLING THE TRUTH.

HERMIONE LOOKED AT HER WATCH.

WE HAVEN'T DONE ANY PRACTISING! SHE SAID, LOOKING STUCK.  
WE WERE GOING TO DO THE IMPEDIMENT LINES! WE'LL HAVE TO REALLY  
GET DOWN TO IT THEMSELVES! COME ON, HARRY, YOU NEED TO GET  
SOME SLEEP.

HARRY AND RON WENT SILENTLY UPSTAIRS TO THEIR DORMITORY. AS  
HARRY PULLED ON HIS PYJAMAS, HE LOOKED OVER AT NEVILLE'S BED.  
THAT WAS HIS BED THE DUMBLEDORE, HE HAD NOT TOLD RON AND  
HERMIONE ABOUT NEVILLE'S PARENTS. AS HARRY TOOK OFF HIS GLASSES  
AND CLIMBED INTO HIS FOUR-POSTER, HE IMAGINED HOW IT MUST FEEL  
TO HAVE PARENTS STILL LIVING, BUT UNABLE TO RECOGNISE YOU. HE  
OFTEN GOT SYMPATHY FROM STRANGERS FOR BEING AN ORPHAN, BUT AS  
HE LISTENED TO NEVILLE'S SNEERS, HE THOUGHT THAT NEVILLE  
DESERVED IT MORE THAN HE DID. LYING IN THE DARKNESS, HARRY FELT

528 HARRY POTTER

A RUSH OF ANGER AND HATE TOWARDS THE PEOPLE WHO HAD TORTURED  
MR AND MRS LUNGEFETTER ... HE REMEMBERED THE LOOKS OF THE  
CHILD AS CRUELTY'S SON AND HIS COMPANIONS HAD BEEN DRAGGED  
FROM THE CHURCH BY THE DEMENTORS ... HE UNDERSTOOD HOW THEY  
HAD FELT ... THEN HE REMEMBERED THE MILD-WHITE FACE OF THE  
SCREAMING KID, AND REALISED WITH A JOLT THAT HE HAD DIED A YEAR  
LATER ...

IT WAS VERDUN, HARRY THOUGHT, STARING UP AT THE CANOPY

HE HIS BED IN THE DARKNESS, IT ALL CAME BACK THE VILDEMENT ... HE WAS THE ONE WHO HAD THROWN THESE FAMILIES APART, WHO HAD RUINED ALL THESE LIVES ...

\*

REIN AND HERMINE WERE SLIPPED THE RE REVISING THEIR THEIR EXAMS, WHICH WOULD FINISH IN THE DAY OF THE THIRD TASK, BUT THEY WERE PUTTING MOST OF THEIR EFFORTS INTO HELPING HARRY PREPARE.

WHEN HARRY ASKED IT, HERMINE SAID SHORTLY, WHEN HARRY POINTED THIS OUT TO THEM, AND SAID HE DIDN'T MIND PRACTISING IN HIS OWN ROOM A WHILE. AT LEAST WE'LL GET THOSE MARKS IN DEFENCE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS, WE'D NEVER HAVE BEEN ASKED ALL THESE QUESTIONS IN CLASS.

GOOD TRAINING FOR WHEN WE'RE ALL ALIENS, SAID REIN EXCITEDLY, ATTEMPTING THE IMPEDIMENT LINE WHEN A WASP THAT HAD SLIPPED INTO THE ROOM, AND MAKING IT STOP DEAD IN MID-AIR.

THE MIND IN THE CASTLE AS THEY ENTERED LINE BECAME EXCITED AND TENSE AGAIN. EVERYONE WAS LEARNING FORWARD THE THIRD TASK, WHICH WOULD TAKE PLACE A WEEK BEFORE THE END OF TERM. HARRY WAS PRACTISING HEXES IN EVERY AVAILABLE MOMENT. HE FELT MORE CONFIDENT ABOUT THIS TASK THAN EITHER OF THE OTHERS, DIFFICULT AND DANGEROUS THOUGH IT WOULD UNDOUBTEDLY BE, MINDY WAS RIGHT: HARRY HAD MANAGED TO FIND HIS WAY PAST MINSTREL'S CREATURES AND ENCHANTED BARRIERS BEFORE NOW, AND THIS TIME HE HAD SOME NOTICE, SOME CHANCE TO PREPARE HIMSELF

AIR WHAT LAY AHEAD.

Tired of walking in and then all over the school, Professor

THE THIRD TASK SET

McGONAGALL HAD GIVEN HARRY PERMISSION TO USE THE EMPTY

TRANSFIGURATION CLASSROOM AT LUNCH-TIME. HE HAD BEEN MASTERED THE IMPEDIMENT Jinx, A SPELL TO SHUT DOWN AND RESTRICT

ATTACKERS, THE REDUCTIO CURSE, WHICH WOULD ENABLE HIM TO BLAST  
SHIELD OBJECTS OUT OF HIS WAY, AND THE FEELER-POINT SPELL, A USEFUL  
DISCOVERY OF HERMIONE'S WHICH WOULD MAKE HIS HAND POINT  
OUT NORTH, THEREFORE ENABLING HIM TO CHECK WHETHER HE WAS  
GOING IN THE RIGHT DIRECTION WITHIN THE MAZE. HE WAS STILL

HAVING TROUBLE WITH THE SHIELD CHARM, THOUGH. THIS WAS SLIPPED THE LAST A TEMPORARY, INVISIBLE WALL AROUND HIMSELF THAT

DEFLECTED MINOR CURSES; HERMIONE MANAGED TO SHATTER IT WITH A  
WELL-PLACED JELLY-LEGS Jinx. HARRY WHEELED AROUND THE ROOM  
FOR TEN MINUTES AFTERWARDS BEFORE SHE HAD LEERED UP THE  
CHLINTER-Jinx.

YOU'RE STILL DOING REALLY WELL, THOUGH, HERMIONE SAID  
ENCOURAGINGLY, LEADING DOWN HER LIST, AND CROSSING OFF THESE  
SPELLS THEY HAD ALREADY LEARNED. SOME OF THESE ARE BEING THE  
COME IN HANDY.

COME AND LOOK AT THIS, SAID RON, WHO WAS STANDING BY THE

WINDS, HE WAS STARING DOWN INTO THE CREEKS. WHAT'S MALPHY  
DOING?

HARRY AND HERMIONIE WENT TO SEE. MALPHY, CRABBE AND GOYLE  
WERE STANDING IN THE SHADE OF A TREE BESIDE. CRABBE AND GOYLE  
SEEMED TO BE KEEPING A LOW KEY; BOTH WERE SMIRKING. MALPHY  
WAS HOLDING HIS HAND UP TO HIS MOUTH, AND SPEAKING INTO IT.  
HE LOOKS LIKE HE'S USING A WAND-TALKIE, SAID HARRY CLIMBINGLY.  
HE CAN'T BE, SAID HERMIONIE. I'VE TOLD YOU, THESE SORT OF  
THINGS DON'T WORK AROUND HOGWARTS. COME ON, HARRY, SHE  
ADDED BRISKLY, TURNING AWAY FROM THE WINDS AND MOVING BACK  
INTO THE MIDDLE OF THE RIVER. LET'S TRY THAT SHIELD CHARM AGAIN.

\*

SIRIUS WAS SENDING DAILY LETTERS NOW. LIKE HERMIONIE, HE SEEMED  
TO WANT TO CONCENTRATE ON GETTING HARRY THROUGH THE LAST TASK,  
BEFORE THEY CONCERNED THEMSELVES WITH ANYTHING ELSE. HE  
REMINDS HARRY IN EVERY LETTER THAT WHATEVER MIGHT BE GOING

SEE HARRY BETTER

ON HILLSIDE THE WALLS OF HOGWARTS WAS NOT HARRY'S RESPONSIBILITY,  
NOR WAS IT WITHIN HIS POWER TO INFLUENCE IT.

IF VOLDERMORT IS REALLY GETTING STRONGER AGAIN (HE WROTE), MY  
PRIORITY IS TO ENSURE YOUR SAFETY. HE CANNOT HAVE THE LAST HANDS  
ON YOU WHILE YOU ARE UNDER DUMBLEDORE'S PROTECTION, BUT ALL  
THE SAME, TAKE THE RISKS! CONCENTRATE ON GETTING THROUGH THAT  
MAZE SAFELY, AND THEN WE CAN TURN OUR ATTENTION TO EITHER



MATTERS.

HARRY'S NERVES MELTING AS LONG THE TWENTY-FOURTH DREW CLOSER, BUT THEY WERE NOT AS BAD AS THOSE HE HAD HAD BEFORE THE FIRST AND SECOND TASKS. FOR ONE THING, HE WAS CONFIDENT THAT, THIS TIME, HE HAD DONE EVERYTHING IN HIS POWER TO PREPARE FOR THE TASK. FOR ANOTHER, THIS WAS THE FINAL HURDLE, AND WHATEVER WELL OR BADLY HE DID, THE TOURNAMENT WOULD AT LAST BE OVER, WHICH WOULD BE AN ENORMOUS RELIEF.

\*

BREAKFAST WAS A VERY BUSY AFFAIR AT THE GRYFFINDOR TABLE WHEN THE MORNING OF THE THIRD TASK. THE FIRST HELPS APPEARED, BRINGING HARRY A CHEED-LICK CARD FROM SIRILIS. IT WAS ONLY A PIECE OF PARCHMENT, FOLDED OVER AND BEARING A BLOODY PALM PRINT WHEN ITS FRONT, BUT HARRY APPRECIATED IT ALL THE SAME. A SCREECH HOWL ARRIVED FOR HERMION, CARRYING HER MORNING COPY OF THE DAILY PROPHET AS USUAL. SHE UNFOLDED THE PAPER, GLANCED AT THE FRONT PAGE, AND SPAT OUT A MELT-PLOOF OF PLOMPKIN LIKE ALL EVER IT.

WHAT? SAID HARRY AND REEN TOGETHER, STARING AT HER.

NOTHING, SAID HERMION EMBOLDLY, TRYING TO SHOVE THE PAPER OUT OF SIGHT, BUT REEN GRABBED IT.

HE STARED AT THE HEADLINE, AND SAID, NOT WAY, NOT TODAY, THAT HED CHW.

WHAT? SAID HARRY. RITA SKEETER AGAIN?

NO, SAID REEN, AND JUST LIKE HERMION, HE ATTEMPTED TO PUSH THE PAPER OUT OF SIGHT.

IT'S ABOUT ME, ISN'T IT? SAID HARRY.

## THE THIRD TASK SET

NEE, SAID REEN, IN AN ENTIRELY UNCONVINCING TONE,  
BUT BEFORE HARRY COULD DEMAND THE SEE THE PAPER, DRACHE  
MALFOY SHELTED ACROSS THE GREAT HALL FROM THE SLYTHERIN TABLE.  
HEY, PITTER! PITTER! FEEL S YELLER HEAD? FEEL FEELING ALL RIGHT?  
SURE FEEL BE NOT CHING THE GEE KERSERD BEN LIST?  
MALFOY WAS HOLDING A COPY OF THE DAILY PROPHET, THEN,  
SLYTHERINS LIP AND BEHN THE TABLE WERE SNIGGERING, TWISTING IN  
THEIR SEATS THE SEE HARRY S REACTION.  
LET ME SEE IT, HARRY SAID THE REEN. GIVE IT HERE.  
VERY RELUCTANTLY, REEN HANDED OVER THE NEWSPAPER. HARRY  
TURNED IT OVER, AND FEELING HIMSELF STARING AT HIS OWN PICTURE,  
BENEATH A BANNER HEADLINE:  
HARRY PITTER DISTURBED AND DANGEROUS  
  
THE KEY WHEN DELETED HE WHEN MUST NOT BE NAMED IS UNSTA-  
BLE AND POSSIBLY DANGEROUS, WRITES RITA SKEETER, SPECIAL  
CORRESPONDENT. ALARMING EVIDENCE HAS RECENTLY CAME THE  
LIGHT ABOUT HARRY PITTER S STRANGE BEHAVIOR, WHICH CASTS  
DOUBTS UPON HIS SUITABILITY TO COMPETE IN A DEMANDING CON-  
TEST LIKE THE TRIWIZARD TOURNAMENT, AND EVEN THE ATTEND  
HOGWARTS SCHOOL.  
PITTER, THE DAILY PROPHET CAN EXCLUSIVELY REVEAL, REGULARLY

COLLAPSES AT SCHEER, AND IS OFTEN HEARD THE COMPLAIN OF PAIN IN

THE SCAR AND HIS FOREHEAD (RELIC OF THE CLASH WITH WHICH YEL-  
DONNEN-LETH ATTEMPTED TO KILL HIM). ON MONDAY LAST, MID-  
WAY THROUGH A DIVINATION LESSON, YELIN DAILY PROPHET

REPORTER WITNESSED PETER STORMING FROM THE CLASS, CLAIMING  
THAT HIS SCAR WAS HURTING THEM BADLY THE CONTINUOUS STUBBING.  
IT IS POSSIBLE, SAY THE EXPERTS AT ST MUNGUS'S HOSPITAL FOR

MAGICAL MALADIES AND INJURIES, THAT PETER'S BRAIN WAS AFFECT-  
ED BY THE ATTACK INFLICTED UPON HIM BY YELI-DONNEN-LETH, AND

THAT HIS INSISTENCE THAT THE SCAR IS STILL HURTING IS AN EXPRES-  
SION OF HIS DEEP-SEATED CONVICTION.

HE MIGHT EVEN BE PRETENDING, SAID ONE SPECIALIST, THIS  
COULD BE A PLEA FOR ATTENTION.

SEE HARRY PETER

THE DAILY PROPHET, HOWEVER, HAS UNEARTHED WHIRRING  
FACTS ABOUT HARRY PETER THAT ALBUS DUMBLEDORE, HEADMASTER  
OF HOGWARTS, HAS CAREFULLY CONCEALED FROM THE WIZARDING  
PUBLIC.

PETER CAN SPEAK PARSELTONGUE, REVEALS DRACH MALFOY, A  
HOGWARTS FIFTH-YEAR. THERE WERE A LOT OF ATTACKS ON  
STUDENTS A COUPLE OF YEARS AGO, AND MOST PEOPLE THOUGHT

PETTER WAS BEHIND THEM AFTER THEY SAW HIM LEESE HIS TEMPER AT A DUELING CLUB AND SET A SNAKE ON ANOTHER KID. IT WAS ALL FLISHED UP, TELLIG, BUT HE S MADE FRIENDS WITH WEREWOLVES AND GIANTS THEM. WE THINK HE D DNE ANYTHING FOR A KIT OF PEEWER. PARSELTONGUE, THE ABILITY TO CONVERSE WITH SNAKES, HAS BEEN BEEN CONSIDERED A DARK ART. INDEED, THE MOST FAMOUS PARSELMOUTH OF HIS TIMES IS NONE OTHER THAN VOLDEMORT HIMSELF. A MEMBER OF THE DARK FORCE DEFENCE LEAGUE, WHO WISHED TO REMAIN UNNAMED, STATED THAT HE WOULD REGARD ANY

WIZARD WHO WOULD SPEAK PARSELTONGUE AS WORTHY OF INVESTIGATION. PERSONALLY, I WOULD BE HIGHLY SUSPICIOUS OF ANYBODY WHO

COULD CONVERSE WITH SNAKES, AS SERPENTS ARE OFTEN USED IN THE WORST KINDS OF DARK MAGIC, AND ARE HISTORICALLY ASSOCIATED WITH EVIL-DOERS. SIMILARLY, ANYONE WHO SEEKS OUT THE COMPANY OF SUCH VICIOUS CREATURES AS WEREWOLVES AND GIANTS WOULD APPEAR TO HAVE A PREDISPOSITION FOR VIOLENCE.

ALAS DUMBLEDORE SHOULD SERIOUSLY CONSIDER WHETHER A KID SUCH AS THIS SHOULD BE ALLOWED TO COMPETE IN THE TRIWIZARD TOURNAMENT. SOME FEAR THAT PETTER MIGHT RESORT TO THE DARK ARTS IN HIS DESPERATION TO WIN THE TOURNAMENT, THE THIRD TASK OF WHICH TAKES PLACE THIS EVENING.

COME OFF ME A KIT, HADN'T THEY? SAID HARRY LIGHTLY, FOLDING UP THE PAPER.

EVER ON THE SLYTHERIN TABLE, MALFOY, CRABBE AND GOYLE WERE LAUGHING AT HIM, TAPPING THEIR HEADS WITH THEIR FINGERS, PULLING

GRITTEENLY MAD FACES AND WAGGLING THEIR TONGUES LIKE SNAKES,

HOW DID SHE KNOW YOUR STAR FLIRT IN DIVINATION? RHN SAID,

THE THIRD TASK SEE

THERE S NH WAY SHE WAS THERE, THERE S NH WAY SHE COULD VE  
HEARD

THE WINDOW WAS OPEN, SAID HARRY, I OPENED IT THE BREATHE,

YOU WERE AT THE TOP OF NORTH TOWER? HERMIONE SAID, YOUR  
VOICE COULDN T HAVE CARRIED ALL THE WAY DOWN THE THE CORRIDORS?

WELL, YOU RE THE ONE WHO S SLIPPED THE RE RESEARCHING MAGI-  
CAL METHODS OF KLIGGING? SAID HARRY, YOU TELL ME HOW SHE DID IT?

I VE BEEN TRYING? SAID HERMIONE, BUT I ... BUT ...

AN EER, DREAMY EXPRESSION SUDDENLY CAME OVER HERMIONE S  
FACE, SHE SILENTLY RAISED A HAND, AND RAN HER FINGERS THROUGH HER  
HAIR,

ARE YOU ALL RIGHT? SAID RHN, FROWNING AT HER,

YES, SAID HERMIONE BREATHLESSLY, SHE RAN HER FINGERS THROUGH  
HER HAIR AGAIN, AND THEN HELD HER HAND UP TO HER MOUTH, AS  
THOUGH SPEAKING INTO AN INVISIBLE WALKIE-TALKIE, HARRY AND RHN  
STARED AT EACH OTHER,

I VE HAD AN IDEA, HERMIONE SAID, GAZING INTO SPACE, I THINK I  
COULD ... REALISE THEN NH ONE WHOULD BE ABLE TO SEE ... EVEN

MINDS ... AND SHE D HAVE BEEN ABLE TO GET INTO THE WINDOW-

LEDGE ... BUT SHE S NOT ALLOWED ... SHE S DEFINITELY NOT ALLOWED ...

I THINK WE'VE GOT HER! JUST GIVE ME TWO SECONDS IN THE LIBRARY  
JUST TO MAKE SURE!

WITH THAT, HERMIONE SEIZED HER SCHOOLBAG, AND DASHED OUT  
OF THE GREAT HALL.

HE! BEEN CALLED AFTER HER. WE'VE GOT HER HISTORY OF MAGIC  
EXAM IN TEN MINUTES! BLIMEY, HE SAID, TURNING BACK THE HARRY,  
SHE MUST REALLY HATE THAT SKEETER WOMAN THE RISK MISSING THE  
START OF AN EXAM. WHAT RE YOU GOING TO DO IN KINGS CLASS  
READ AGAIN?

EXEMPT FROM THE END-OF-TERM TESTS AS A TRIWIZARD CHAMPION,  
HARRY HAD BEEN SITTING AT THE BACK OF EVERY EXAM CLASS SHE FAN,  
WHISKING UP FRESH FLEXES FOR THE THIRD TASK.

I WISE SHE, HARRY SAID THE BEEN! BUT JUST THEN, PROFESSOR  
MCGONAGALL CAME WALKING ALONG THE GRYFFINDOR TABLE TOWARDS  
HIM.

SEE HARRY BETTER

BETTER, THE CHAMPIONS ARE CONGREGATING IN THE CHAMBER OF  
THE HALL AFTER BREAKFAST, SHE SAID.

BUT THE TASK'S NOT TIL TONIGHT! SAID HARRY, ACCIDENTALLY  
SPILLING SCRAMBLED EGGS DOWN HIS FRONT, AFRAID HE HAD MISTAKEN  
THE TIME.

I'M AWARE OF THAT, BETTER, SHE SAID. THE CHAMPIONS' FAMILIES  
ARE INVITED TO WATCH THE FINAL TASK, YOU KNOW. THIS IS SIMPLY A  
CHANCE FOR YOU TO MEET THEM.

SHE MOVED AWAY. HARRY GAZED AFTER HER.

SHE DOESN'T EXPECT THE DURSLEYS TO TURN UP, DOES SHE? HE ASKED HER BLANKLY.

BLUNDER, SAID HER, HARRY, I'D BETTER HURRY, I'M GOING TO BE LATE FOR KINGS. SEE YOU LATER.

HARRY FINISHED HIS BREAKFAST IN THE EMPTY GREAT HALL. HE SAW FLEUR DELACOUR GET UP FROM THE RAVENCLAW TABLE AND HEIN LEBRUC AS HE CROSSED THE SIDE CHAMBER AND ENTERED. DRUM SHOUTED OFF THE HEIN THEM SHORTLY AFTERWARDS. HARRY STAYED WHERE HE WAS. HE REALLY DIDN'T WANT TO GO INTO THE CHAMBER. HE HAD NO FAMILY NO FAMILY WHO WOULD TURN UP TO SEE HIM RISK HIS LIFE, ANYWAY. BUT JUST AS HE WAS GETTING UP, THINKING THAT HE

MIGHT AS WELL GO TO THE LIBRARY AND DO A SHEET MORE HOME REVISION, THE DOOR OF THE SIDE CHAMBER OPENED, AND LEBRUC STUCK

HIS HEAD OUT.

HARRY, COME ON, THEY'RE WAITING FOR YOU!

LITTERALLY PERPLEXED, HARRY GOT UP. THE DURSLEYS COULDN'T POSSIBLY BE HERE, COULD THEY? HE WALKED ACROSS THE HALL AND

OPENED THE DOOR INTO THE CHAMBER.

LEBRUC AND HIS PARENTS WERE JUST INSIDE THE DOOR. VICTOR DRUM WAS EVER IN A CORNER, CONVERSING WITH HIS DARK-HAIRED MOTHER AND FATHER IN RAPID BULGARIAN. HE HAD INHERITED HIS FATHER'S REDDED NOSE. ON THE OTHER SIDE OF THE ROOM, FLEUR WAS LAUGHING AWAY IN FRENCH TO HER MOTHER. FLEUR'S LITTLE SISTER,

GABRIELLE WAS HOLDING HER MOTHER'S HAND. SHE WAVED AT HARRY, WHO WAVED BACK. THEN HE SAW MRS WEASLEY AND BILL STANDING IN FRONT OF THE FIREPLACE, BEAMING AT HIM.

### THE THIRD TASK SEE

SURPRISE! MRS WEASLEY SAID EXCITEDLY, AS HARRY SMILED BREADLY, AND WALKED OVER THE THEM. TWILIGHT WE'D COME AND WATCH YELL, HARRY! SHE BENT DOWN AND KISSED HIM ON THE CHEEK.

YELL ALL RIGHT? SAID BILL, GRINNING AT HARRY AND SHAKING HIS HAND. CHARLIE WANTED THE CHEER, BUT HE COULDN'T GET TIME OFF, HE SAID YELL WERE INCREDIBLE AGAINST THE THERONTAIL.

FLORA DELACOUR, HARRY NOTICED, WAS EYING BILL WITH GREAT INTEREST OVER HER MOTHER'S SHOULDER. HARRY COULD TELL SHE HAD NO OBJECTION WHATSOEVER TO LONG HAIR OR EARRINGS WITH FANGS ON THEM.

THIS IS REALLY NICE OF YELL, HARRY MUTTERED TO MRS WEASLEY. I TWILIGHT FOR A MOMENT THE DURSLEYS

HEM, SAID MRS WEASLEY, PURSING HER LIPS. SHE HAD ALWAYS REFRAINED FROM CRITICISING THE DURSLEYS IN FRONT OF HARRY, BUT HER EYES FLASHED EVERY TIME THEY WERE MENTIONED.

IT'S GREAT BEING BACK HERE, SAID BILL, WHISKING AROUND THE CHAMBER / VIOLET, THE FAT LADY'S FRIEND, WINKED AT HIM FROM HER FRAME. HAVEN'T SEEN THIS PLACE FOR FIVE YEARS. IS THAT PICTURE OF THE MAD KNIGHT STILL AROUND? SIR CADOGAN?

HEY, YEAH, SAID HARRY, WHO HAD MET SIR CADOGAN THE PREVIOUS YEAR.



AND THE FAT LADY? SAID BILL.

SHE WAS HERE IN MY TIME, SAID MRS WEASLEY. SHE GAVE ME  
SUCH A TELLING-OFF ONE NIGHT WHEN I GOT BACK THE THE BERMITHORY  
AT FELLIN IN THE MORNINING

WHAT WERE YOU DOING OUT OF YOUR BERMITHORY AT FELLIN IN THE  
MORNINING? SAID BILL, SURVEYING MRS WEASLEY WITH AMAZEMENT.  
MRS WEASLEY GRINNED, HER EYES TWINKLING.

YOUR FATHER AND I HAD BEEN FOR A NIGHT-TIME STROLL, SHE SAID.  
HE GOT CAUGHT BY APELLOPHIN PRINGLE HE WAS THE CARETAKER IN  
THESE DAYS YOUR FATHER'S STILL GOT THE MARKS.

PARTY GIVING US A TELLIN, HARRY? SAID BILL.

YEAH, EDD, SAID HARRY, AND THEY MADE THEIR WAY BACK  
TOWARDS THE DEER INTO THE GREAT HALL.

AS THEY PASSED AMES DIGGORY, HE WHISKED AROUND. THERE YOU

SEE HARRY PEEETTER

ARE, ARE YOU? HE SAID, WHISKING HARRY LIP AND DOWN. BUT YOU'RE  
NOT FEELING WHITE AS FLICK OF YOURSELF NOW CEDRIC'S CAUGHT YOU LIP  
AND PHINTS, ARE YOU?

WHAT? SAID HARRY.

IGNORE HIM, SAID CEDRIC IN A LOW VOICE TO HARRY, FREEKING  
AFTER HIS FATHER. HE'S BEEN ANGRY EVER SINCE RITA SKEETER'S ARTICLE  
ABOUT THE TRIWIZARD TOURNAMENT YOU KNOW, WHEN SHE MADE  
OUT YOU WERE THE ONLY HOGWARTS CHAMPIONS.

DIDN'T REMEMBER THE CORRECT HER, THOUGH, DID HE? SAID AMES  
DIGGORY, WHISKING AROUND FOR HARRY THE HEAR AS HE MADE THE WALK

HELT OF THE OTHER WITH MRS WEASLEY AND BILL. STILL ... SHELL BE SEEN  
HIM, LED, BEATEN HIM SINCE BEFORE, HAVEN'T SHE?

RITA SKEETER GIVES HELT OF HER WAY THE CALISE TRELLER, AMES?  
MRS WEASLEY SAID ANGERILY. I WOULD HAVE THOUGHT SHE'D KNOWN  
THAT, WORKING AT THE MINISTRY?

MR DIGGORY LOOKED AS THOUGH HE WAS GOING TO SAY SOMETHING  
ANGRY, BUT HIS WIFE LAID A HAND ON HIS ARM, AND HE MERELY  
SHRUGGED AND TURNED AWAY.

HARRY HAD A VERY ENJOYABLE MORNING WALKING OVER THE SLINDY  
GREENHILLS WITH BILL AND MRS WEASLEY, SEEING THEM THE  
REALIZATION'S CARRIAGE AND THE OLDMSTRANG SHIP. MRS WEASLEY  
WAS INTRIGUED BY THE WHIMPING WILLIAMS, WHICH HAD BEEN  
PLANTED AFTER SHE HAD LEFT SCHOOL, AND REMINISCED AT LENGTH  
ABOUT THE GAMEKEEPER BEFORE HAGRID, A MAN CALLED HOG.

HE'S PERCY? HARRY ASKED, AS THEY WALKED AROUND THE  
GREENHILLS.

NOT GOOD, SAID BILL.

HE'S VERY UPSET, SAID MRS WEASLEY, LOWERING HER VOICE AND

GLANCING AROUND. THE MINISTRY WANT TO KEEP MR CRUELCH'S DIS-  
APPEARANCE QUIET, BUT PERCY'S BEEN HALLED IN FOR INVESTIGATING

ABOUT THE INSTRUCTIONS MR CRUELCH HAS BEEN SENDING IN. THEY  
SEEM TO THINK THERE'S A CHANCE THEY WEREN'T GENUINELY WRITTEN  
BY HIM. PERCY'S BEEN UNDER A LOT OF STRAIN. THEY'RE NOT LETTING  
HIM FILL IN FOR MR CRUELCH AS THE FIFTH JUDGE TONIGHT. CERNELIS  
FUDGE IS GOING TO BE DOING IT.

THE THIRD TASK SET

THEY RETURNED TO THE CASTLE FOR LUNCH.

MUM KILL! SAID RICH, WHISKING STUNNED, AS HE THOUGHT THE  
GROFFINBER TABLE. WHAT ARE YOU DOING HERE?

COME TO WATCH HARRY IN THE LAST TASK! SAID MRS WEASLEY  
BRIGHTLY. I MUST SAY, IT MAKES A NICE CHANGE, NOT HAVING THE  
CHILD. WELL WAS YOUR EXAM?

HEY ... HEY, SAID RICH. CHILDREN I REMEMBER ALL THE GIBLIN  
REBELS NAMES, SEE I INVENTED A FEW. IT'S ALL RIGHT, HE SAID, HELPING  
HIMSELF TO A CHERNISH PASTY, WHILE MRS WEASLEY LOOKED STERN.  
THEY'RE ALL CALLED STUFF LIKE RICHARD THE BEARDED AND KING THE  
WICKLEMAN, IT WASN'T HARD.

FRED, GEORGE AND GINNY CAME TO SIT NEXT TO THEM, THEN, AND  
HARRY WAS HAVING SUCH A GOOD TIME HE FELT ALMOST AS THOUGH HE  
WAS BACK AT THE BURROWS. HE HAD FORGOTTEN THE WHOLE ABOUT THAT  
EVENING'S TASK, AND IT WASN'T UNTIL HERMIONNE TURNED UP, HALFWAY  
THROUGH LUNCH, DID HE REMEMBER THAT SHE HAD HAD A BRAINWAVE  
ABOUT RITA SKEETER.

ARE YOU GOING TO TELL US ?

HERMIONNE SHOOK HER HEAD WARNINGLY, AND GLANCED AT MRS  
WEASLEY.

WELL, HERMIONNE, SAID MRS WEASLEY, MUCH MORE STIFFLY THAN  
USUAL.

WELL, SAID HERMIONNE, HER SMILE FALTERING AT THE CHILD EXPRES-  
SION ON MRS WEASLEY'S FACE.

HARRY LEANED BETWEEN THEM, THEN SAID, MRS WEASLEY, WHY DIDN'T BELIEVE THAT ALKISH RITA SKEETER WROTE IN WITCH WEEKLY, DID SHE? BECAUSE HERMIONE'S NOT MY GIRLFRIEND.

HEY SAID MRS WEASLEY, NO HE CHLRSK I DIDN'T! BUT SHE BECAME CONSIDERABLY WARMER TOWARDS HERMIONE AFTER THAT.

HARRY, KILL AND MRS WEASLEY WALKED AWAY THE AFTERNOON WITH A LONG WALK AROUND THE CASTLE, AND THEN RETURNED TO THE GREAT HALL FOR THE EVENING FEAST. LORD BAGMAN AND CHERNILLUS FUDGE HAD JOINED THE STAFF TABLE NOW. BAGMAN LEANED SLIGHTLY CHEERFUL, BUT CHERNILLUS FUDGE, WHO WAS SITTING NEXT THE MADAME

SEE HARRY PTTTTT

MAXIME, LEANED STERN AND WAS NOT TALKING. MADAME MAXIME WAS CONCENTRATING ON HER PLATE, AND HARRY THOUGHT HER EYES LEANED RED. Hagrid kept glancing along the table at her.

THERE WERE MORE CHLRSKS THAN USUAL, BUT HARRY, WHO WAS STARTING TO FEEL REALLY NERVOUS NOW, DIDN'T EAT MUCH. AS THE ENCHANTED CEILING OVERHEAD BEGAN TO FADE FROM BLUE TO A DIMMY PURPLE, DUMBLEDORE ROSE TO HIS FEET AT THE STAFF TABLE, AND SILENCE FELL.

LADIES AND GENTLEMEN, IN FIVE MINUTES TIME, I WILL BE ASKING WHY THE MADRE WHYR WAY DOWN THE THE FLUDDITCH PITCH FOR THE THIRD AND LAST TASK OF THE TRIWIZARD TOLRNAMENT. WILL THE CHAMPIONS PLEASE FOLLOW MR BAGMAN DOWN THE THE STADILM NOW.

HARRY GET UP. THE GRYPFINDERS ALL ALONG THE TABLE WERE APPLAUDING HIM; THE WEASLEYS AND HERMIONE ALL WISHED HIM GOOD LUCK, AND HE HEADED OFF TOWARD THE GREAT HALL, WITH CEDRIC, FLEUR AND KRUM.

FEELING ALL RIGHT, HARRY? BAGMAN ASKED, AS THEY WENT DOWN THE STONE STEPS INTO THE GREENS. CONFIDENT?

I'M HERE, SAID HARRY. IT WAS SHORT OF TRUE; HE WAS NERVOUS, BUT HE KEPT RUNNING OVER ALL THE MOVES AND SPELLS HE HAD BEEN PRACTISING IN HIS MIND AS THEY WALKED, AND THE KNOWLEDGE THAT HE COULD REMEMBER THEM ALL MADE HIM FEEL BETTER.

THEY WALKED INTO THE FLIMDITCH PITCH, WHICH WAS NOW COMPLETELY UNRECOGNISABLE. A TWENTY-FOOT-HIGH HEDGE RAN ALL THE WAY AROUND THE EDGE OF IT. THERE WAS A GAP RIGHT IN FRONT OF THEM; THE ENTRANCE TO THE VAST MAZE. THE PASSAGE BEYOND IT LOOKED DARK AND CREEPY.

FIVE MINUTES LATER, THE STANDS HAD BEEN FULL; THE AIR WAS FULL OF EXCITED VOICES AND THE RUMBLING OF FEET AS THE HUNDREDS OF STUDENTS FLED INTO THEIR SEATS. THE SKY WAS A DEEP, CLEAR BLUE NOW, AND THE FIRST STARS WERE STARTING TO APPEAR. FLORIS, PROFESSOR MEENEY, PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL AND PROFESSOR FLITWICK CAME WALKING INTO THE STADIUM AND APPROACHED BAGMAN AND THE CHAMPIONS. THEY WERE WEARING LARGE, RED, LUMINOUS STARS

THE THIRD TASK WAS

ON THEIR HATS, ALL EXCEPT FLORIS, WHO HAD HIS ON THE BACK OF HIS MEESESKIN WAISTCOAT.

WE ARE GOING TO BE PATROLLING THE HILLSIDE OF THE MAZE, SAID

PROFESSOR MCGRATHALL THE THE CHAMPIONS. IF YOU GET INTO DIFFICULTY, AND WISH TO BE RESCUED, SEND RED SPARKS INTO THE AIR, AND

HERE HE WILL COME AND GET YOU, DO YOU UNDERSTAND?

THE CHAMPIONS NEEDED,

HE YOU GO, THEN? SAID BAGMAN BRIGHTLY THE THE FELLOW PATROLLERS.

GOOD LUCK, HARRY, HAGRID WHISPERED, AND THE FELLOW HE THEM WALKED AWAY IN DIFFERENT DIRECTIONS, THE STATUES THEMSELVES AROUND THE MAZE, BAGMAN NOW POINTED HIS HAND AT HIS THREAT, MUTTERED SILENTLY, AND HIS MAGICALLY MAGNIFIED VOICE REBOUNDED INTO THE STANDS.

LADIES AND GENTLEMEN, THE THIRD AND FINAL TASK OF THE TRIWIZARD TOURNAMENT IS ABOUT TO BEGIN! LET ME REMIND YOU

HOW THE POINTS CURRENTLY STAND! TIED IN FIRST PLACE, EIGHTY-FIVE POINTS EACH MR CECIL DIGGER AND MR HARRY PETER,

EIGHTH OF HOGWARTS SCHOOL! THE CHEERS AND APPLAUSE SENT RINGS FROM THE FERRIDEN FOREST FLUTTERING INTO THE DARKENING SKY. IN SECOND PLACE, EIGHTY POINTS MR VICTOR CRUM, OF BURMISTRANG INSTITUTE! MORE APPLAUSE, AND IN THIRD PLACE MISS FLEW DELACOUR, OF REALMSTADEN'S ACADEMY!

HARRY COULD JUST MAKE OUT MRS WEASLEY, BILL, RON AND HERMIONE APPLAUDING FLEW POLITELY, HALFWAY UP THE STANDS. HE WAVED UP AT THEM, AND THEY WAVED BACK, BEAMING AT HIM.

SEE ... HEN MY WHISTLE, HARRY AND CEDRIC SAID BAGMAN.

THREE TWO ONE

HE GAVE A SHORT BLAST HEN HIS WHISTLE, AND HARRY AND CEDRIC FLURRIED FORWARD INTO THE MAZE.

THE TRELLERING HEDGES CAST BLACK SHADOWS ACROSS THE PATH, AND, WHETHER BECAUSE THEY WERE SO TALL AND THICK, OR BECAUSE THEY HAD BEEN ENCHANTED, THE SOUND OF THE SWIRLING WIND WAS SILENCED THE MOMENT THEY ENTERED THE MAZE. HARRY FELT ALMOST AS THOUGH HE WAS UNDERWATER AGAIN. HE PULLED OUT HIS

SAND HARRY PEEETTER

WAND, MUTTERED LLIMMS, AND HEARD CEDRIC DO THE SAME INST BEHIND HIM.

AFTER ABOUT FIFTY YARDS, THEY REACHED A POINT. THEY LOOKED AT EACH OTHER.

SEE WELL, HARRY SAID, AND HE TURNED THE LEFT ONE, WHILE CEDRIC TURNED THE RIGHT.

HARRY HEARD BAGMAN'S WHISTLE FOR THE SECOND TIME. RONN HAD ENTERED THE MAZE. HARRY SPED UP, HIS CHOSEN PATH SEEMED COMPLETELY DESERTED. HE TURNED RIGHT, AND FLURRIED ON, HOLDING

HIS WAND HIGH OVER HIS HEAD, TRYING TO SEE AS FAR AHEAD AS POSSIBLE. STILL, THERE WAS NOTHING IN SIGHT.

BAGMAN'S WHISTLE BLEW IN THE DISTANCE FOR THE THIRD TIME. ALL OF THE CHAMPIONS WERE NOW INSIDE THE MAZE.

HARRY KEPT LOOKING BEHIND HIM. THE OLD FEELING THAT HE WAS

BEING WATCHED WAS LIPEN HIM. THE MAZE WAS GROWING DARKER WITH EVERY PASSING MINUTE AS THE SMOY HOVERHEAD DEEPENED THE NAVY. HE REACHED A SECOND PIER.

POINT ME, HE WHISPERED TO HIS WAND, HOLDING IT FLAT IN HIS PALM.

THE WAND SPUN AROUND HIM, AND POINTED TOWARDS HIS RIGHT, INTO THE SHED HEDGE. THAT WAY WAS NORTH, AND HE KNEW THAT HE NEEDED TO GO NORTH-WEST FOR THE CENTRE OF THE MAZE. THE BEST HE COULD DO WAS TO TAKE THE LEFT PIER, AND GO RIGHT AGAIN AS SOON AS POSSIBLE.

THE PATH AHEAD WAS EMPTY, THEN, AND WHEN HARRY REACHED A RIGHT TURN AND TOOK IT, HE AGAIN FOUND HIS WAY UNBLOCKED.

HARRY DIDN'T KNOW WHY, BUT THE LACK OF OBSTACLES WAS WORRYING HIM. SURELY HE SHOULD HAVE MET SOMETHING BY NOW? IT FELT

AS THOUGH THE MAZE WAS LURING HIM INTO A FALSE SENSE OF SECURITY. THEN HE HEARD MOVEMENT RIGHT BEHIND HIM. HE FELD HIT HIS

WAND, READY TO ATTACK, BUT ITS BEAM FELL ONLY UPON CEDRIC, WHO HAD JUST HURRIED INTO A PATH ON THE RIGHT-HAND SIDE. CEDRIC LANDED SEVERELY SHAKEN. THE SLEEVE OF HIS ROBES WAS SMOKING. HARRY'S BLAST-ENDED SCREAMS? HE HISSED. THEY'RE ENORMOUS I ONLY JUST GOT AWAY?

THE THIRD TASK

HE SHOOK HIS HEAD, AND DROVE INTO SIGHT, ALONG ANOTHER



PATH, KNEW THE PLT PLNTY OF DISTANCE BETWEEN HIMSELF AND THE  
SKELETS, HARRY HURRIED OFF AGAIN. THEN, AS HE TURNED A CORNER,  
HE SAW

A DEMENTOR WAS GLIDING TOWARDS HIM. TWELVE FEET TALL, ITS  
FACE HIDDEN BY ITS VEIL, ITS REPTING, SCAKED HANDS FLIT-  
STRETCHED, IT ADVANCED, SENSING ITS WAY BLINDLY TOWARDS HIM.

HARRY COULD HEAR ITS RATTLING BREATH; HE FELT CLAMPY COLDNESS  
STEALING OVER HIM, BUT KNEW WHAT HE HAD TO DO ...

HE SUMMONED THE HAPPIEST THOUGHT HE COULD, CONCENTRATED  
WITH ALL HIS MIGHT ON THE THOUGHT OF GETTING OUT OF THE MAZE  
AND CELEBRATING WITH RON AND HERMION, RAISED HIS WAND AND  
CRIED, EXPECTO PATRONUM!

A SILVER STAG ERUPTED FROM THE END OF HARRY'S WAND AND GAL-  
LOPED TOWARDS THE DEMENTOR, WHICH FELL BACK, AND TRIPPED OVER

THE REM OF ITS REINS ... HARRY HAD NEVER SEEN A DEMENTOR  
STUMBLE.

HANG ON! HE SCHELTED, ADVANCING IN THE WAKE OF HIS SILVER  
PATRONUS, WHO RE A BEGGART? RIDDIKULUS!

THERE WAS A LOUD CRACK, AND THE SHAPE-SISTER EXPLODED IN A  
WISP OF SMOKE. THE SILVER STAG FADED FROM SIGHT. HARRY WISHED  
IT COULD HAVE STAYED, HE COULD HAVE USED SOME COMPANY ... BUT  
HE MOVED ON AS QUICKLY AND QUIETLY AS POSSIBLE, LISTENING HARD,  
HIS WAND HELD HIGH IN FRONT OF HIM.

LEFT ... RIGHT ... LEFT AGAIN ... TWICE HE FELT HIMSELF FACING DEAD ENDS. HE DID THE FLEUR-DE-LIS SPELL AGAIN, AND FELT THAT HE WAS GOING THE FAR EAST. HE TURNED BACK, TOOK A RIGHT TURN, AND SAW AN EDDY CHILDEN MIST FLEATING AHEAD OF HIM.

HARRY APPROACHED IT CAUTIOUSLY, POINTING THE WAND'S BEAM AT IT. THIS BEHELD LIKE SOME KIND OF ENCHANTMENT. HE WONDERED WHETHER HE MIGHT BE ABLE TO BLAST IT OUT OF THE WAY.

REDUCED? HE SAID.

THE SPELL SEEMED STRAIGHT THROUGH THE MIST, LEAVING IT INTACT. HE SUPPOSED HE SHOULD HAVE DONE BETTER; THE REDUCED CLASH WAS FOR SHIELD EFFECTS. WHAT WOULD HAPPEN IF HE WALKED

SAY HARRY BETTER

THROUGH THE MIST? WAS IT WORTH CHARGING IT, OR SHOULD HE BEHOLD BACK?

HE WAS STILL HESITATING, WHEN A SCREAM SHATTERED THE SILENCE.

FLEUR? HARRY YELLED.

THERE WAS SILENCE. HE STARED ALL AROUND HIM. WHAT HAD HAPPENED THE MIST? HIS SCREAM SEEMED TO HAVE COME FROM SOMEWHERE AHEAD. HE TOOK A DEEP BREATH, AND RAN THROUGH THE

ENCHANTED MIST.

THE WORLD TURNED UPSIDE-DOWN. HARRY WAS HANGING FROM THE GROUND, WITH HIS HAIR END, HIS GLASSES DANGLING OFF HIS NOSE, THREATENING THE FALL INTO THE BOTTOMLESS SKY. HE CLUTCHED THEM TO THE END OF HIS NOSE AND FELL THERE, TERRIFIED. IT FELT AS THOUGH

HIS FEET WERE GLUED TO THE GRASS, WHICH HAD NOW BECOME THE CEILING, KEELING HIM THE DARK, STAR-SPANGLED HEAVENS STRETCHED ENDLESSLY. HE FELT AS THOUGH IF HE TRIED TO MOVE ONE OF HIS FEET, HE WOULD FALL AWAY FROM THE EARTH COMPLETELY.

THINK, HE TOLD HIMSELF, AS ALL THE BLEED RUSHED TO HIS HEAD, THINK ...

BUT NOT ONE OF THE SPELLS HE HAD PRACTISED HAD BEEN DESIGNED TO BRING A SUDDEN REVERSAL OF GRINDING AND SORE, DID HE DARE MOVE HIS FEET? HE COULD HEAR THE BLEED POUNDING IN HIS EARS. HE HAD TWO CHOICES TRY AND MOVE, OR SEND UP RED SPARKS, AND GET RESCUED AND DISQUALIFIED FROM THE TASK.

HE SHUT HIS EYES, SO HE WOULDN'T BE ABLE TO SEE THE VIEW OF ENDLESS SPACE KEELING HIM, AND PULLED HIS RIGHT FOOT AS HARD AS HE COULD, AWAY FROM THE GRASSY CEILING.

IMMEDIATELY, THE WORLD RIGHTED ITSELF. HARRY FELL FORWARD

BENTH HIS KNEES AND THE WONDERFULLY SILENT GRINDING. HE FELT TEMPORARILY LIMP WITH SHOCK. HE TOOK A DEEP, STEADYING BREATH,

THEN GOT UP AGAIN, AND HURRIED FORWARD, LEANING BACK OVER HIS SHOULDER AS HE RAN INTO THE GOLDEN MIST, WHICH TWINKLED INNOCENTLY AT HIM IN THE MOONLIGHT.

HE PAUSED AT A JUNCTION OF TWO PATHS AND LOOKED AROUND FOR SOME SIGN OF FLEUR. HE WAS SURE IT HAD BEEN SHE WHEN HE HAD SCREAMED. WHAT HAD SHE MET? WAS SHE ALL RIGHT? THERE WAS NO

THE THIRD TASK WAS

SIGN OF RED SPARKS DID THAT MEAN SHE HAD GOTTEN HERSELF HIT BY  
TRILLER, HER WAS SHE IN SUCH TRILLER THAT SHE COULDN'T REACH HER  
WAND? HARRY THREW THE RIGHT SPELL WITH A FEELING OF INCREASING  
UNEASE ... BUT AT THE SAME TIME, HE COULDN'T HELP THINKING, HERE  
CHAMPION BEING ...

THE CLIP WAS SOMEWHERE CLOSE BY, AND IT SEEMED AS THOUGH  
HE WAS NOW LONGER IN THE RUNNING. HE'D GOTTEN THIS FAR, HADN'T  
HE? WHAT IF HE ACTUALLY MANAGED THE WIN? FLEETINGLY, AND FOR THE  
FIRST TIME SINCE HE'D FELT HIMSELF CHAMPION, HE SAW AGAIN  
THAT IMAGE OF HIMSELF, RAISING THE TRILIZARD CLIP IN FRONT OF THE  
REST OF THE SCHOOL ...

HE MET NOTHING FOR TEN MINUTES, EXCEPT DEAD ENDS. TWICE HE  
THREW THE SAME WORMING TURNING, FINALLY HE FELT A NEW RESULT,  
AND STARTED THE ICE ALONG IT, HIS WAND-LIGHT WAVING, MAKING HIS

SHADOW FLICKER AND DISTORT IN THE HEDGE WALLS. THEN HE REELIN-  
ED ANOTHER CORNER, AND FELT HIMSELF FACING A BLAST-ENDED

SKELET.

LEON WAS RIGHT IT WAS ENORMOUS, TEN FEET LONG, IT LOOKED  
MORE LIKE A GIANT SCORPION THAN ANYTHING. ITS LONG STING WAS  
CURLED OVER ITS BACK, ITS THICK ARMED GLINTED IN THE LIGHT FROM  
HARRY'S WAND, WHICH HE POINTED AT IT.

STUPID!

THE SPELL HIT THE SKELET'S ARMED, AND REELINED; HARRY  
BLINKED JUST IN TIME, BUT COULDN'T SMELL BURNING HAIR; IT HAD  
SINGED THE TOP OF HIS HEAD. THE SKELET ISSUED A BLAST OF FIRE

FROM ITS END, AND FLEW TOWARDS TOWARDS HIM.

IMPEDIMENTA! HARRY YELLED. THE SPELL HIT THE SKRULL S  
ARMELIA AGAIN AND RICKETED OFF. HARRY STAGGERED BACK A FEW  
PACES AND FELL OVER. IMPEDIMENTA!

THE SKRULL WAS INCHES FROM HIM WHEN IT FREEZE HE HAD  
MANAGED TO HIT IT IN ITS FLESHY, SHELL-LESS UNDERSIDE. PANTING,  
HARRY PULSED HIMSELF AWAY FROM IT AND RAN, HARD, IN THE  
OPPOSITE DIRECTION THE IMPEDIMENT LINK WAS NOT PERMANENT,  
THE SKRULL WOULD BE REGAINING THE USE OF ITS LEGS AT ANY  
MOMENT.

544 HARRY PEEETTER

HE THREW A LEFT PATH, AND HIT A DEAD END, A RIGHT, AND HIT

ANOTHER! SWINGING HIMSELF THE OTHER, HEART HAMMERING, HE PER-  
FORMED THE FEELER-POINT SPELL AGAIN, BACKTRACKED, AND CHASE A

PATH THAT WOULD TAKE HIM NORTH-WEST.

HE HAD BEEN FLURRYING ALONG THE NEW PATH FOR A FEW MINUTES,  
WHEN HE HEARD SOMETHING IN THE PATH RUNNING PARALLEL TO HIS  
OWN WHICH MADE HIM STOP DEAD.

WHAT ARE YOU DOING? YELLED CEDRIC S VOICE. WHAT THE HELL  
DO YOU THINK YOU ARE DOING?

AND THEN HARRY HEARD DURLIN S VOICE.

CRUISE!

THE AIR WAS SUDDENLY FULL OF CEDRIC S YELLS. TERRIFIED, HARRY  
BEGAN SPRINTING UP HIS PATH, TRYING TO FIND A WAY INTO CEDRIC S.

WHEN NENE APPEARED, HE TRIED THE REDLITHE CURSE AGAIN. IT WASN'T VERY EFFECTIVE, BUT IT BLUNT A SMALL HOLE IN THE FENCE,

THROUGH WHICH HARRY FORCED HIS LEG, KICKING AT THE THICK BRAMBLES AND BRANCHES UNTIL THEY BROKE AND MADE AN OPENING; HE

STRUGGLED THROUGH IT, TEARING HIS KNEES AND, LEEDING THE HIS RIGHT, SAW CEDRIC JERKING AND TWITCHING IN THE GRASS, DRUM STANDING OVER HIM.

HARRY PULLED HIMSELF UP AND POINTED HIS WAND AT DRUM JUST AS DRUM LEANED UP, DRUM TURNED AND BEGAN THE RUN.

STUPID! HARRY YELLED.

THE SPELL HIT DRUM IN THE BACK; HE STOPPED DEAD IN HIS TRACKS, FELL FORWARD AND LAY MUTELESS, FACE DOWN IN THE GRASS. HARRY DASHED OVER THE CEDRIC, WHO HAD STOPPED TWITCHING, AND WAS LYING THERE PANTING, HIS HANDS OVER HIS FACE.

ARE YOU ALL RIGHT? HARRY SAID RELENTLY, GRABBING CEDRIC'S ARM.

YEAH, PANTED CEDRIC. YEAH ... I DON'T BELIEVE IT ... HE CREEPT UP BEHIND ME ... I HEARD HIM, I TURNED AROUND, AND HE HAD HIS WAND ON ME ...

CEDRIC GOT UP, HE WAS STILL SHAKING, HE AND HARRY LEANED DOWN AT DRUM.

I CAN'T BELIEVE THIS ... I THOUGHT HE WAS ALL RIGHT, HARRY SAID, STARING AT DRUM.

THE THIRD TASK WAS

SEE DID I, SAID CEDRIC.

DID YOU HEAR FELIX SCREAM EARLIER? SAID HARRY.

YEAH, SAID CEDRIC. YOU DIDN'T THINK DRAGON GOT HER, THEN?

I DIDN'T KNOW, SAID HARRY SILENTLY.

SHOULD WE LEAVE HIM HERE? CEDRIC MUTTERED.

NO, SAID HARRY. I RECKON WE SHOULD SEND UP RED SPARKS,

SOMEONE LL COME AND COLLECT HIM ... OTHERWISE HE LL PROBABLY BE EATEN BY A SKRULL.

HE D DESERVE IT, CEDRIC MUTTERED, BUT ALL THE SAME, HE RAISED HIS WAND AND SENT A SHOWER OF RED SPARKS INTO THE AIR, WHICH HISSERED HIGH ABOVE DRAGON, MARKING THE SPOT WHERE HE LAY. HARRY AND CEDRIC STOOD THERE IN THE DARKNESS FOR A MOMENT, LISTENING AROUND THEM. THEN CEDRIC SAID, WELL ... I S'POSE WE D BETTER GO ON ...

WHAT? SAID HARRY. EH ... YEAH ... RIGHT ...

IT WAS AN ODD MOMENT. HE AND CEDRIC HAD BEEN BRIEFLY UNITED AGAINST DRAGON ... NEAR THE FACT THAT THEY WERE OPPONENTS CAME

BACK TO THEM BOTH. THEY PROCEEDED UP THE DARK PATH WITHOUT SPEAKING, THEN HARRY TURNED LEFT, AND CEDRIC RIGHT. CEDRIC'S FOOTSTEPS SOON DIED AWAY.

HARRY MOVED ON, CONTINUING THE USE THE FELIX-POINT SPELL, MAKING SURE HE WAS MOVING IN THE RIGHT DIRECTION. IT WAS BETWEEN HIM AND CEDRIC NOW. HIS DESIRE TO REACH THE CLIP FIRST WAS NOW BURNING STRONGER THAN EVER, BUT HE COULD HARDLY BELIEVE WHAT HE D JUST SEEN DRAGON DO. THE USE OF AN UNFORGIVABLE CURSE ON A FELLOW HUMAN BEING MEANT A LIFE TERM

IN AZKABAN, THAT WAS WHAT MURDER HAD TOLD THEM. DRAGON SLAYING  
CHILDREN I HAVE WANTED THE TRIWIZARD CUP THAT BADLY ... HARRY  
SPED UP.

EVERY SEVENTH HE HIT MORE DEAD ENDS, BUT THE INCREASING  
DARKNESS MADE HIM FEEL SURE HE WAS GETTING NEAR THE HEART OF  
THE MAZE. THEN, AS HE STRIDED DOWN A LONG, STRAIGHT PATH, HE  
SAW MOVEMENT AHEAD AGAIN, AND HIS BEAM OF WAND-LIGHT HIT AN  
EXTRAORDINARY CREATURE, ONE WHICH HE HAD ONLY SEEN IN PICTURE  
FORM, IN HIS MINSTER BOOK OF MINISTERS.

THE HARRY PEEETER

IT WAS A SPHINX. IT HAD THE BODY OF AN OVERLARGE LION; GREAT  
CLAWED PAWS, AND A LONG YELLOWISH TAIL ENDING IN A BROWN TUFT.  
ITS HEAD, HOWEVER, WAS THAT OF A WOMAN. SHE TURNED HER LONG,  
ALMOND-SHAPED EYES UPON HARRY AS HE APPROACHED. HE RAISED  
HIS WAND, HESITATING. SHE WAS NOT CREEKING AS IF THE SPRING, BUT  
PACING FROM SIDE THE SIDE OF THE PATH, CHECKING HIS PROGRESS.  
THEN SHE SPOKE, IN A DEEP, HARSH VOICE. YOU ARE VERY NEAR  
YOUR GOAL. THE BRIGHTEST WAY IS PAST ME.

SEE ... SHE WILL TELL ME, PLEASE? SAID HARRY, KNEELING WHAT  
THE ANSWER WAS GIVING THE KEY.

NO, SHE SAID, CONTINUING THE PACE. NOT UNLESS YOU CAN  
ANSWER MY RIDDLE. ANSWER MY FIRST GUESS I LET YOU PASS.  
ANSWER WRONGLY I ATTACK. REMAIN SILENT I WILL LET YOU WALK  
ALONG FROM ME, UNSCATHED.

HARRY'S STOMACH SLIPPED SEVERAL NOTICES. IT WAS HERMION  
WHO WAS GIVING AT THIS SORT OF THING, NOT HIM. HE WIGHED HIS



CHANCES, IF THE RIDDLE WAS THAT HARD, HE COULD KEEP SILENT, GET AWAY FROM HER LINE-ARMED, AND TRY AND FIND AN ALTERNATIVE ROUTE TO THE CENTRE.

END, HE SAID. CAN I HEAR THE RIDDLE?

THE SPHINX SAT DOWN UPON HER HIND LEGS, IN THE VERY CENTRE OF THE PATH, AND RECITED:

FIRST THINK OF THE PERSON WHO LIVES IN DISGUISE,

WHO DEALS IN SECRETS AND TELLS NIGHT BUT LIES,

NEXT, TELL ME WHAT'S ALWAYS THE LAST THING THE MEND,

THE MIDDLE OF MIDDLE AND END OF THE END?

AND FINALLY GIVE ME THE SOUND OFTEN HEARD

DURING THE SEARCH FOR A HARD-TO-FIND WORD,

WHEN STRING THEM TOGETHER, AND ANSWER ME THIS,

WHICH CREATURE WOULD YOU BE UNWILLING TO KISS?

HARRY GAZED AT HER.

COULD I HAVE IT AGAIN ... MORE SLOWLY? HE ASKED TENTATIVELY.

SHE BLINKED AT HIM, SMILED, AND REPEATED THE POEM.

THE THIRD TASK WAS

ALL THE CLUES ADD UP TO A CREATURE I WOULDN'T WANT TO KISS?

HARRY ASKED.

SHE MERELY SMILED HER MYSTERIOUS SMILE. HARRY THOUGHT THAT FOR

A YES, HARRY LOST HIS MIND AWHILE. THERE WERE PLENTY OF ANIMALS HE WOULDN'T WANT TO KISS; HIS IMMEDIATE THOUGHT WAS A

BLAST-ENDED SKRRLT, BUT SOMETHING TOLD HIM THAT WASN'T THE

ANSWER, HE'D HAVE THE TRY AND WHERX HLT THE CLUES ...

A PERSON IN DISGUISE, HARRY MUTTERED, STARING AT HER, WHEN  
LIES ... ER ... THAT D BE A AN IMPESTER, NEH, THAT S NOT MY GLESS!  
A A SPY? I LL COME BACK THE THAT ... CHILD YEL GIVE ME THE NEXT  
CLUE AGAIN, PLEASE?

SHE REPEATED THE NEXT LINES OF THE POEM.

THE LAST THING THE MEND, HARRY REPEATED, ER ... NEH IDEA ...  
MIDDLE OF MIDDLE ... CHILD I HAVE THE LAST BIT AGAIN?

SHE GAVE HIM THE LAST FEWER LINES.

A SHELND HTEN HEARD IN THE SEARCH FOR A HARD-TO-FIND WHERD,  
SAID HARRY, ER ... THAT D BE ... ER ... HANG HEN ER : ER S A  
SHELND?

THE SPHINX SMILED AT HIM.

SPY ... ER ... SPY ... ER ... SAID HARRY, PACING UP AND DOWN  
HIMSELF, A CREATURE I WOULDNT WANT THE KISS ... A SPIDER?

THE SPHINX SMILED MORE KREADLY, SHE GET UP, STRETCHED HER  
FRONT LEGS, AND THEN MOVED ASIDE FOR HIM THE PASS.

THANKS! SAID HARRY, AND, AMAZED AT HIS OWN BRILLIANCE, HE  
DASHED FORWARD.

HE HAD THE BE CLUSE NEH, HE HAD THE BE ... HIS WAND WAS TELLING  
HIM HE WAS KANG HEN CHURSE! AS LONG AS HE DIDNT MEET ANYTHING  
THEE TERRIBLE, HE MIGHT BE IN WITH A CHANCE ...

HE HAD A CHICE OF PATHS UP AHEAD, POINT ME! HE WHISPERED  
AGAIN THE HIS WAND, AND IT SPLIN AROUND AND POINTED HIM THE THE  
RIGHT-HAND HNE, HE DASHED UP THIS HNE, AND SAW LIGHT AHEAD.

THE TRIWIZARD CUP WAS GLEAMING IN A PLINTH A HUNDRED

YARDS AWAY, HARRY HAD JUST ENTERED INTO A RLYN, WHEN A DARK FIG-  
URE FLURLED OUT INTO THE PATH IN FRONT OF HIM.

CEBRIC WAS GOING TO GET THERE FIRST. CEBRIC WAS SPRINTING AS

548 HARRY PETER

FAST AS HE COULD TOWARDS THE CLIP, AND HARRY KNEW HE WOULD  
NEVER CATCH UP, CEBRIC WAS MUCH TALLER, HAD MUCH LONGER  
LEGS

THEN HARRY SAW SOMETHING IMMENSE OVER A HEDGE TO HIS LEFT,  
MOVING HELICALLY ALONG A PATH THAT INTERSECTED WITH HIS OWN; IT  
WAS MOVING SO FAST CEBRIC WAS ABOUT TO RUN INTO IT, AND CEBRIC,  
HIS EYES ON THE CLIP, HAD NOT SEEN IT

CEBRIC! HARRY BELIEVED, HEY WHEEL LEFT!

CEBRIC LUNCHED AROUND JUST IN TIME TO FLIR HIMSELF PAST THE  
THING AND AVOID COLLIDING WITH IT BUT, IN HIS HASTE, HE TRIPPED.  
HARRY SAW CEBRIC'S HAND FLY OUT OF HIS HAND, AS A GIGANTIC  
SPIDER STEPPED INTO THE PATH, AND BEGAN THE REAR DRUM LUPEN  
CEBRIC.

STUPEFY! HARRY YELLED AGAIN; THE SPELL HIT THE SPIDER'S GIGAN-  
TIC, HAIRY BLACK BODY BUT, FOR ALL THE GOOD IT DID, HE MIGHT AS

WELL HAVE THROWN A STONE AT IT; THE SPIDER JERKED, SLUTTLED  
AROUND, AND RAN AT HARRY INSTEAD.

STUPEFY! IMPEDIMENTA! STUPEFY!

BUT IT WAS NOT LIKE THE SPIDER WAS EITHER SO LARGE, OR SO MAGICAL, THAT THE SPELLS WERE DOING NOT MORE THAN AGGRAVATING IT

HARRY HAD ONE FRIGHTENING GLIMPSE OF EIGHT SHINING BLACK EYES, AND RAZOR-SHARP PINNERS, BEFORE IT WAS UPON HIM.

HE WAS LIFTED INTO THE AIR IN ITS FRONT LEGS, STRUGGLING MADLY, HE TRIED TO KICK IT; HIS LEG CONNECTED WITH THE PINNERS AND NEXT MOMENT HE WAS IN EXCRUCIATING PAIN HE COULD HEAR CEDRIC YELLING 'STUPID!' THEN, BUT HIS SPELL HAD NOT MORE EFFECT THAN

HARRY & HARRY RAISED HIS WAND AS THE SPIDER OPENED ITS PINNERS ONCE MORE, AND SHOUTED, 'EXPPELLIARMUS!'

IT WORKED THE DISARMING SPELL MADE THE SPIDER DROP HIM, BUT THAT MEANT THAT HARRY FELL TWELVE FEET BENT HIS ALREADY INJURED LEG, WHICH CRUMPLED BENEATH HIM, WITHOUT PAUSING THE THING, HE AIMED HIGH AT THE SPIDER & UNDERWELL, AS HE HAD DONE WITH THE SCREW, AND SHOUTED 'STUPID!' JUST AS CEDRIC YELLED THE SAME THING.

THE TWO SPELLS COMBINED DID WHAT ONE ALONE HAD NOT THE

THE THIRD TASK WAS

SPIDER BECAME EVER SLOWLY, FLATTENING A NEARBY HEDGE, AND STRIKING THE PATH WITH A TANGLE OF HARRY'S LEGS.

HARRY! HE HEARD CEDRIC SHOUTING, 'WELL ALL RIGHT? DID IT FALL ON YELL?'

YES, HARRY CALLED BACK, PAUSING, HE LOOKED DOWN AT HIS LEG.

IT WAS BLEEDING BADLY, HE COULD SEE SOME SHORT OF THICK, GILLY SECRETION FROM THE SPIDER'S FINGERS AND HIS THORN REELS. HE TRIED TO GET UP, BUT HIS LEG WAS SHAKING BADLY AND DID NOT WANT TO SUPPORT HIS WEIGHT. HE LEANT AGAINST THE HEDGE, GASPING FOR BREATH, AND LEEKED AROUND.

CEBRIC WAS STANDING FEET FROM THE TRILIZARD CLIP, WHICH WAS GLAMING BEHIND HIM.

TAKE IT, THEN, HARRY PANTED TO CEBRIC. COME ON, TAKE IT, YOU'RE THERE.

BUT CEBRIC DIDN'T MOVE. HE MERELY STOOD THERE, LEEKING AT

HARRY. THEN HE TURNED THE STARE AT THE CLIP. HARRY SAW THE LONGING EXPRESSION ON HIS FACE IN ITS GILDED LIGHT. CEBRIC LEEKED

AROUND AT HARRY AGAIN, WHO WAS NOW HOLDING ONTO THE HEDGE TO SUPPORT HIMSELF.

CEBRIC TOOK A DEEP BREATH. YOU TAKE IT, YOU SHOULD WIN.

THAT'S TWICE YOU'VE SAVED MY NECK IN HERE.

THAT'S NOT HOW IT'S SUPPOSED TO WORK, HARRY SAID. HE FELT ANGRY; HIS LEG WAS VERY PAINFUL, HE WAS ACHING ALL OVER FROM TRYING TO THROW OFF THE SPIDER, AND AFTER ALL HIS EFFORTS, CEBRIC HAD BEATEN HIM TO IT, JUST AS HE'D BEATEN HARRY TO ASK FOR THE BALL. THE ONE WHO REACHES THE CLIP FIRST GETS THE POINTS. THAT'S YOU, I'M TELLING YOU, I'M NOT GOING TO WIN ANY RACES ON THIS LEG.

CEBRIC TOOK A FEW PACES NEARER TO THE STUNNED SPIDER, AWAY FROM THE CLIP, SHAKING HIS HEAD.

NO, HE SAID.

STAY BEING NERVE, SAID HARRY IRRITABLY. I'LL TAKE IT, THEN WE CAN GET OUT OF HERE.

CEDRIC WATCHED HARRY STADYING HIMSELF, HOLDING TIGHT TO THE EDGE.

SSSS HARRY PTTTTT

YOU TOLD ME ABOUT THE DRAGONS, CEDRIC SAID. I WOULD'VE GONE DOWN IN THE FIRST TASK IF YOU HADN'T TOLD ME WHAT WAS COMING.

I HAD HELP HIM THAT, THEN, HARRY SNAPPED, TRYING TO MEEP UP HIS BLEEDY LEG WITH HIS REEKS. YOU HELPED ME WITH THE EGG WE'RE STILL HERE.

I HAD HELP HIM THE EGG IN THE FIRST PLACE, SAID CEDRIC.

WE'RE STILL HERE, SAID HARRY, TESTING HIS LEG GINGERLY; IT SHOOK VIOLENTLY AS HE PUT WEIGHT ON IT; HE HAD SPRAINED HIS ANKLE WHEN THE SPIDER HAD DROPPED HIM.

YOU SHOULD'VE GOTT MORE POINTS IN THE SECOND TASK, SAID CEDRIC MILKISHLY. YOU STAYED BEHIND TO GET ALL THE FIRSTAGES. I SHOULD'VE DONE THAT.

I WAS THE ONLY ONE WHO WAS THICK ENOUGH TO TAKE THAT SHIT SERIOUSLY, SAID HARRY BITTERLY. I'LL TAKE THE CUP!

NO, SAID CEDRIC.

HE STEPPED OVER THE SPIDER'S TANGLED LEGS TO JOIN HARRY, WHO STARED AT HIM. CEDRIC WAS SERIOUS. HE WAS WALKING AWAY FROM THE SHIT OF GLORY FLAPPYLY FELICE HADN'T HAD IN CENTURIES.

OH HIM, CEDRIC SAID. HE WHINED AS THOUGH THIS WAS CHEATING

HIM EVERY BLINK HE RESOLUTION HE HAD, BUT HIS FACE WAS SET, HIS ARMS WERE FOLDED, HE SEEMED DECIDED.

HARRY LEANED FROM CEDRIC THE THE CLIP, FEELING SHINING MEMENT, HE SAW HIMSELF EMERGING FROM THE MAZE, HOLDING IT. HE SAW HIMSELF HOLDING THE TRIWIZARD CLIP ALERT, HEARD THE RUMOR OF THE CROWN, SAW CEE'S FACE SHINING WITH ADMIRATION, MORE CLEARLY THAN HE HAD EVER SEEN IT BEFORE ... AND THEN THE PICTURE

FADED, AND HE FELT HIMSELF STARING AT CEDRIC'S STADIUM, STICK-THORN FACE.

KEITH HE WAS, HARRY SAID.

WHAT?

WE'LL TAKE IT AT THE SAME TIME. IT'S STILL A HIGGLARTS VICTORY, WE'LL TIE FOR IT.

CEDRIC STARED AT HARRY, HE UNFOLDED HIS ARMS. YES YES SURE?

THE THIRD TASK WAS

YES, SAID HARRY. YES ... WE'VE HELPED EACH OTHER OUT, HAVEN'T WE? WE BOTH GET HERE, LET'S JUST TAKE IT TOGETHER. FOR A MEMENT, CEDRIC LEANED AS THOUGH HE COULDN'T BELIEVE HIS EARS; THEN HIS FACE SPLIT IN A GRIN.

YES RE EN, HE SAID. COME HERE.

HE GRABBED HARRY'S ARM BEHIND THE SHOULDER, AND HELPED HARRY LIMP TOWARDS THE PLINTH WHERE THE CLIP STOOD. WHEN THEY HAD REACHED IT, THEY BOTH FELD OUT A HAND OVER ONE OF THE

CLIP'S CREAKING HANDLES.

"HEN THREE, RIGHT?" SAID HARRY. "HNE TWO THREE

HE AND CEDRIC BOTH GRASPED A HANDLE.

INSTANTLY, HARRY FELT A JERK SOMEWHERE BEHIND HIS NAVEL. HIS

FEET HAD LEFT THE GRIHLIND. HE COULD NOT UNCLENCH THE HAND HOLD-  
ING THE TRIWIZARD CLIP; IT WAS PULLING HIM ENWARDS, IN A HEAVY

OF WIND AND SWIRLING CLOUDS, CEDRIC AT HIS SIDE.

## CHAPTER THIRTY-TWO

FLESH, BLEED AND BONE

HARRY FELT HIS FEET SLAM INTO THE GRIHLIND; HIS INJURED LEG GAVE  
WAY AND HE FELL FORWARDS; HIS HAND LET GO OF THE TRIWIZARD CLIP  
AT LAST. HE RAISED HIS HEAD.

"WHERE ARE WE?" HE SAID.

CEDRIC SHOOK HIS HEAD. HE GOT UP, PULLED HARRY TO HIS FEET,  
AND THEY LOOKED AROUND.

THEY HAD LEFT THE HOGWARTS GRIHLINDS COMPLETELY; THEY HAD  
HEAVILY TRAVELLED MILES PERHAPS HUNDREDS OF MILES AND EVEN  
THE MOUNTAINS SURROUNDING THE CASTLE WERE GONE. THEY WERE  
STANDING INSTEAD IN A DARK AND EVERGREEN GRAVEYARD; THE BLACK  
HILTS OF A SMALL CHURCH WAS VISIBLE BEYOND A LARGE YEW TREE TO  
THEIR RIGHT. A HILL ROSE ABOVE THEM TO THEIR LEFT. HARRY COULD JUST  
MAKE OUT THE HILTS OF A FINE OLD HILL IN THE HILLSIDE.



CEBRIC WHEEZED DOWN AT THE TRILIZARD CLIP AND THEN UP AT  
HARRY.

DID ANYONE TELL YOU THE CLIP WAS A PERTURB? HE ASKED.

NEVER, SAID HARRY. HE WAS WHEEZING AROUND THE GRAVEYARD. IT  
WAS COMPLETELY SILENT, AND SLIGHTLY EERIE. IS THIS SUPPOSED TO BE  
PART OF THE TASK?

I DUNNO, SAID CEBRIC. HE SEEMED SLIGHTLY NERVOUS. HANDS  
HILT, O YOU RECKON?

YEAH, SAID HARRY, GLAD THAT CEBRIC HAD MADE THE SUGGESTION  
RATHER THAN HIM.

THEY PULLED HILT THEIR HANDS. HARRY KEPT WHEEZING AROUND  
HIM. HE HAD, YET AGAIN, THE STRANGE FEELING THAT THEY WERE BEING  
WATCHED.

ALSO, BLEED AND BEND SEE

SOMEONE IS CHIMING, HE SAID SUDDENLY.

SHUDDERING TENSELY THROUGH THE DARKNESS, THEY WATCHED THE  
FIGURE DRAWING NEARER, WALKING STEADILY TOWARDS THEM BETWEEN  
THE GRAVES. HARRY COULDN'T MAKE HILT A FACE; BUT FROM THE WAY IT  
WAS WALKING, AND HOLDING ITS ARMS, HE COULD TELL THAT IT WAS  
CARRYING SOMETHING. WHEREVER THEY WERE, THEY WERE SHORT, AND  
WEARING A HINNED CLOAK PULLED UP OVER THEIR HEAD TO ENCLOSE  
THEIR FACE. AND SEVERAL PACES NEARER, THE SPACE BETWEEN THEM  
CREAKING ALL THE TIME HE SAW THAT THE THING IN THE PERSON'S ARMS  
WHEEZED LIKE A BABY ... WAS IT MERELY A BLINDLE OF REEKS?

HARRY LOWERED HIS HAND SLIGHTLY, AND GLANCED SIDELAYS AT  
CEBRIC. CEBRIC SENT HIM A WHIZZICAL WHEEZ. THEY BOTH TURNED

BACK THE WATCH THE APPROACHING FIGURE.

IT STOPPED BESIDE A TWEETING MARBLE HEADSTONE, ONLY SIX FEET

FROM THEM. FOR A SECOND, HARRY AND CEDRIC AND THE SHORT FIG-  
URE SIMPLY LOOKED AT EACH OTHER.

AND THEN, WITHOUT WARNING, HARRY'S SCAR EXPLODED WITH PAIN.  
IT WAS AS IF HE HAD NEVER FELT IN ALL HIS LIFE; HIS HAND  
SLIPPED FROM HIS FINGERS AS HE PUT HIS HANDS OVER HIS FACE; HIS  
KNEES CLICKED; HE WAS IN THE GROUND AND HE COULD SEE NOTHING  
AT ALL, HIS HEAD WAS AS IF IT WERE OPEN.

FROM FAR AWAY, ABOVE HIS HEAD, HE HEARD A HIGH, CHILD VOICE  
SAY, KILL THE SPARE.

A SWISHING WHISK AND A SECOND VOICE, WHICH SCREAMED THE  
WORDS OF THE NIGHT: AVADA KEDAVRA!

A BLAST OF GREEN LIGHT BLAZED THROUGH HARRY'S EYELIDS, AND HE  
HEARD SOMETHING HEAVY FALL TO THE GROUND BESIDE HIM; THE PAIN  
IN HIS SCAR REACHED SUCH A PITCH THAT HE RETCHED, AND THEN IT  
DIMINISHED; TERRIFIED OF WHAT HE WAS ABOUT TO SEE, HE OPENED  
HIS STINGING EYES.

CEDRIC WAS LYING SPREAD-EAGLED IN THE GROUND BESIDE HIM.

HE WAS DEAD.

FOR A SECOND THAT CERTAINED AN ETERNITY, HARRY STARED INTO  
CEDRIC'S FACE, AT HIS OPEN GREY EYES, BLANK AND EXPRESSIVENESS AS  
THE WHEELS OF A DESERTED WHEEL, AT HIS HALF-OPEN MOUTH,

SS4 HARRY POTTER

WHICH WHIRLED SLIGHTLY SURPRISED, AND THEN, BEFORE HARRY'S MIND  
HAD ACCEPTED WHAT HE WAS SEEING, BEFORE HE COULD FEEL ANYTHING  
BUT PURE DISBELIEF, HE FELT HIMSELF BEING PULLED TOWARD HIS FEET.

THE SHORT MAN IN THE CLOAK HAD PLUT DOWN HIS BUNDLE, LIT HIS  
WAND, AND WAS DRAGGING HARRY TOWARDS THE MARBLE HEADSTONE.  
HARRY SAW THE NAME WHEN IT FLICKERED IN THE WAND-LIGHT BEFORE  
HE WAS FORCED AHEAD AND SLAMMED AGAINST IT.

THEM RIDDLE

THE CLOAKED MAN WAS NOW WHIRLING TIGHT CIRCLES AROUND HARRY,  
TYING HIM FROM NECK TO ANKLES TO THE HEADSTONE. HARRY COULD  
HEAR SHALLOWS, FAST BREATHING FROM THE DEPTHS OF THE POND; HE  
STRUGGLED, AND THE MAN HIT HIM — HIT HIM WITH A HAND THAT HAD  
A FINGER MISSING. AND HARRY REALISED WHEN WAS UNDER THE POND.  
IT WAS WHIRTAIL.

WHY HE GASPED.

BUT WHIRTAIL, WHO HAD FINISHED WHIRLING THE REEFS, DID NOT

REPLY; HE WAS BUSY CHECKING THE TIGHTNESS OF THE CIRCLES, HIS FIN-  
GERS TREMBLING UNCONTROLLABLY, FLICKING OVER THE KNITS. HENCE

SURE THAT HARRY WAS HELD SO TIGHTLY TO THE HEADSTONE THAT HE  
COULDN'T MOVE AN INCH, WHIRTAIL DREW A LENGTH OF SOME BLACK  
MATERIAL FROM THE INSIDE OF HIS CLOAK AND STUCK IT RELIGIOUSLY INTO  
HARRY'S MOUTH; THEN, WITHOUT A WORD, HE TURNED FROM HARRY  
AND HURRIED AWAY. HARRY COULDN'T MAKE A SOUND, NOR COULD HE  
SEE WHERE WHIRTAIL HAD GONE; HE COULDN'T TURN HIS HEAD TO SEE

BEYOND THE HEADSTONE; HE COULD SEE ONLY WHAT WAS RIGHT IN  
FRONT OF HIM.

LEON'S BODY WAS LYING SOME TWENTY FEET AWAY. SOME WAY  
BEYOND HIM, GLINTING IN THE STARLIGHT, LAY THE TRIWIZARD CLIP.  
HARRY'S HAND WAS IN THE GRIELAND AT HIS FEET. THE BUNDLE OF  
REEKS THAT HARRY HAD THOUGHT WAS A BABY WAS CLOSE BY, AT THE  
FEET OF THE GRAVE. IT SEEMED TO BE STIRRING FRETFULLY. HARRY

WATCHED IT, AND HIS SCAR SEARED WITH PAIN AGAIN ... AND HE SUD-  
DENLY KNEW THAT HE DIDN'T WANT TO SEE WHAT WAS IN THOSE REEKS

FLUSH, BLEED AND BURNING

... HE DIDN'T WANT THAT BUNDLE OPENED ...

HE COULD HEAR NOISES AT HIS FEET. HE WHISPERED DOWN, AND SAW A

GIGANTIC SNAKE SLITHERING THROUGH THE GRASS, CIRCLING THE HEAD-  
STONE WHERE HE WAS TIED. WHIRTAIL'S FAST, WHEEZY BREATHING WAS

GROWING LOUDER AGAIN. IT SEEMED AS THOUGH HE WAS PULLING  
SOMETHING HEAVY ACROSS THE GRIELAND. THEN HE CAME BACK WITHIN  
HARRY'S RANGE OF VISION, AND HARRY SAW HIM PUSHING A STONE  
CALLORED IN THE FEET OF THE GRAVE. IT WAS FULL OF WHAT SEEMED TO  
BE WATER. HARRY COULD HEAR IT SLEEPING AROUND AND IT WAS  
LARGER THAN ANY CALLORED HARRY HAD EVER USED; A GREAT STONE  
BELL-LARGE ENOUGH FOR A FULL-GROWN MAN TO SIT IN.

THE THING INSIDE THE BUNDLE OF REEKS IN THE GRIELAND WAS STIR-

RING MORE persistently, AS THOUGH IT WAS TRYING THE FIRE ITSELF.

NEEL WHERMTAIL WAS KISSING HIMSELF AT THE BOTTLE OF THE CALIBREIN WITH A HAND. SUDDENLY THERE WERE CRACKLING FLAMES

BENEATH IT. THE LARGE SHADE SLITHERED AWAY INTO THE DARKNESS.

THE LICKED IN THE CALIBREIN SEEMED THE HEAT VERY FAST. THE SURFACE BEGAN NOT ONLY THE BUBBLE, BUT ALSO THE SEND HOT FIERY

SPARKS, AS THOUGH IT WAS HOT FIRE. STEAM WAS THICKENING, KISSING THE OUTLINE OF WHERMTAIL TENDING THE FIRE. THE MOVEMENTS

BENEATH THE CHAIR BECAME MORE AGITATED, AND HARRY HEARD THE HIGH, CHILD VOICE AGAIN.

HARRY?

THE WHITE SURFACE OF THE WATER WAS ALIGHT WITH SPARKS NOW. IT MIGHT HAVE BEEN ENCRUSTED WITH DIAMONDS.

IT IS READY, MASTER.

NEEL ... SAID THE CHILD VOICE.

WHERMTAIL PULLED UPON THE REELS IN THE CLOTH, REVEALING

WHAT WAS INSIDE THEM, AND HARRY LET OUT A YELL THAT WAS STRANGLER IN THE MOUTH OF MATERIAL BLEEDING HIS MOUTH.

IT WAS AS THOUGH WHERMTAIL HAD FLIPPED OVER A STONE, AND

REVEALED SOMETHING LELY, SLIM AND BLIND BUT WHERE, A HUNDRED TIMES WHERE, THE THING WHERM-TAIL HAD BEEN CARRYING HAD

THE SHAPE OF A CRELISHED HUMAN CHILD, EXCEPT THAT F-JARRY HAD NEVER SEEN ANYTHING LESS LIKE A CHILD. IT WAS HAIRLESS AND SCALY-

SSS F-JARRY PEEETTER

LEEDING, A DARK, RAW, REDDISH BLACK. ITS ARMS AND LEGS WERE THIN AND FEEBLE, AND ITS FACE NO CHILD ALIVE EVER HAD A FACE LIKE THAT WAS FLAT AND SNAKE-LIKE, WITH GLEAMING RED EYES.

THE THING SEEMED ALMOST HELPLESS; IT RAISED ITS THIN ARMS, PUT THEM AROUND WHERM-TAIL'S NECK, AND WHERM-TAIL LIFTED IT. AS HE DID SEE, HIS EYES FELL BACK, AND F-JARRY SAW THE LEED OF REVLISHEN AND WHERM-TAIL'S LEAD, PALE FACE IN THE FIRELIGHT AS HE CARRIED THE CREATURE TO THE RIM OF THE CALIBREIN. FOR ONE MOMENT, F-JARRY SAW THE EVIL, FLAT FACE ILLUMINATED IN THE SPARKS DANCING ON THE SURFACE OF THE PEETTER. AND THEN WHERM-TAIL BEHEVED THE CREATURE INTO THE CALIBREIN; THERE WAS A HISS, AND IT VANISHED BEHIND THE SURFACE; F-JARRY HEARD ITS TRAIL BODY HIT THE BEETTER WITH A SHOT THUD.

LET IT DRIVEN, F-JARRY THOUGHT, HIS SCAR CLIPPING ALMOST PAST ENDURANCE, PLEASE ... LET IT DRIVEN ...

WHERM-TAIL WAS SPEAKING, HIS VOICE STERN, HE SEEMED ARIGHT-ENDED BEYOND HIS WITS, HE RAISED HIS HAND, CLOSED HIS EYES, AND

SPROKE TO THE NIGHT, BEHIND OF THE FATHER, UNKNOWINGLY GIVEN, WELL

WILL RENEW THEIR SENSE

THE SURFACE OF THE GRAVE AT HARRY'S FEET CRACKED, TERRIFIED, HARRY WATCHED AS A FINE TRICKLE OF DUST RISE INTO THE AIR AT WHIRTAIL'S COMMAND, AND FELL SILENTLY INTO THE CALDRON. THE DIAMOND SURFACE OF THE WATER BROKE AND HISSED; IT SENT SPARKS IN ALL DIRECTIONS, AND TURNED A VIVID, PHEASANT-LIKE BLUE, AND WHEN WHIRTAIL WAS WHIMPERING, HE PULLED A LONG, THIN, SHINING SILVER DAGGER FROM INSIDE HIS REEKS, HIS WHISKER INTO PETRIFIED SKE. FLESH OF THE SERVANT UNWILLINGLY GIVEN WILL WILL REVIVE THEIR MASTER,

HE STRETCHED HIS RIGHT HAND OUT IN FRONT OF HIM THE HAND WITH THE MISSING FINGER, HE GRIPPED THE DAGGER VERY TIGHTLY IN HIS LEFT HAND, AND SWUNG IT UPWARDS,

HARRY REALISED WHAT WHIRTAIL WAS ABOUT TO DO A SECOND BEFORE IT HAPPENED HE CLOSED HIS EYES AS TIGHTLY AS HE COULD, BUT HE COULD NOT BLOCK THE SCREAM THAT PIERCED THE NIGHT, THAT WENT THROUGH HARRY AS THOUGH HE HAD BEEN STABBED WITH THE

FLESH, BLEED AND BEING

DAGGER THEN, HE HEARD SOMETHING FALL TO THE GROUND, HEARD WHIRTAIL'S ANGLISHED PANTING, THEN A SICKENING SPLASH, AS SOMETHING WAS DROPPED INTO THE CALDRON, HARRY COULD NOT BEAR THE SOUND ... BUT THE POTION HAD TURNED A BURNING RED, THE LIGHT OF IT SHONE THROUGH HARRY'S CLOSED EYELIDS ...

WHIRTAIL WAS GASPING AND MEANING WITH AGONY, NOT UNTIL HARRY FELT WHIRTAIL'S ANGLISHED BREATH ON HIS FACE DID HE REALISE THAT WHIRTAIL WAS RIGHT IN FRONT OF HIM.

BLEED OF THE ENEMY ... FIRMLY TAKEN ... WHO WILL ... RESURRECT  
YOURSELF.

HARRY COULD DO NOTHING TO PREVENT IT, HE WAS TIED TIGHTLY  
... SINKING DEEP, STRUGGLING HELPLESSLY AT THE REEFS KIDNEY  
HIM, HE SAW THE SHINING SILVER DAGGER FLASHING IN WHIRTAIL'S  
REMAINING HAND, HE FELT ITS POINT PENETRATE THE CREASE OF HIS  
RIGHT ARM, AND BLEED SEEPING DOWN THE SLEEVE OF HIS THORN ROBES,  
WHIRTAIL, STILL PANTING WITH PAIN, FUMBLING IN HIS POCKET FOR A  
GLASS PHIAL AND HELD IT TO HARRY'S CLUT, HE THAT A DRIKLE OF BLEED  
FELL INTO IT.

HE STAGGERED BACK TO THE CALDRON WITH HARRY'S BLEED, HE  
POURED IT INSIDE. THE LIQUID WITHIN TURNED, INSTANTLY, A BLINDING  
WHITE, WHIRTAIL, HIS EYES SHUT, DROPPED TO HIS KNEES BESIDE THE  
CALDRON, THEN SLIPPED SIDWAYS AND LAY ON THE GROUND,  
CRADLING THE BLEEDING STUMP OF HIS ARM, GASPING AND SHAKING,  
THE CALDRON WAS SIMMERING, SENDING ITS DIAMOND SPARKS IN

ALL DIRECTIONS, SO BLINDINGLY BRIGHT THAT IT TURNED ALL ELSE TO VEL-  
VET BLACKNESS, NOTHING HAPPENED ...

LET IT HAVE DRIVEN, HARRY THOUGHT, LET IT HAVE GONE  
WRITHING ...

AND THEN, SUDDENLY, THE SPARKS EMANATING FROM THE CALDRON  
WERE EXTINGUISHED, A SURGE OF WHITE STEAM RUSHED THICKLY  
FROM THE CALDRON INSTEAD, ENVELOPING EVERYTHING IN FRONT OF  
HARRY, HE THAT HE COULDN'T SEE WHIRTAIL OR CEDRIC OR ANYTHING  
BUT VAPORS HANGING IN THE AIR ... IT'S GONE WRITHING, HE THOUGHT



... IT'S DREAMED ... PLEASE ... PLEASE LET IT BE DEAD ...

BUT THEN, THROUGH THE MIST IN FRONT OF HIM, HE SAW, WITH AN

SSS HARRY PETER

ICY SLURGE OF TERROR, THE DARK SILHOUETTE OF A MAN, TALL AND SKELETALLY  
THIN, RISING SILENTLY FROM INSIDE THE CALIBREIN.

REEK ME, SAID THE HIGH, COLD VOICE FROM BEHIND THE STEAM,

AND WHIRTAIL, SHAKING AND MEANING, STILL CRADLING HIS MUTILAT-  
ED ARM, SCRAMBLED THE PICK UP THE BLACK REEKS FROM THE GROUND,

GET THE HIS FEET, REACHED UP, AND PULLED THEM ONE-HANDED OVER  
HIS MASTER'S HEAD.

THE THIN MAN STEPPED OUT OF THE CALIBREIN, STARING AT HARRY  
... AND HARRY STARED BACK INTO THE FACE THAT HAD HAUNTED HIS  
NIGHTMARES FOR THREE YEARS, WHITER THAN A SKULL, WITH WIDE,  
LIVID SCARLET EYES, AND A NOSE THAT WAS AS FLAT AS A SNAKE'S, WITH  
SLITS FOR NOSTRILS ...

LEHRD VERBEMERT HAD RISEN AGAIN.

## CHAPTER THIRTY-THREE

### THE DEATH EATERS

VERBEMERT LEERED AWAY FROM HARRY, AND BEGAN EXAMINING HIS  
ELVIN BODY. HIS HANDS WERE LIKE LARGE, PALE SPIDERS; HIS LONG  
WHITE FINGERS CARESSED HIS ELVIN CHEST, HIS ARMS, HIS FACE; THE RED

EYES, WHOSE PUPILS WERE SLITS, LIKE A CAT'S, GLEAMED STILL MORE BRIGHTLY THROUGH THE DARKNESS, HE HLED UP HIS HANDS, AND FLEXED THE FINGERS, HIS EXPRESSION RAPT AND EXULTANT, HE THEM NOT THE SLIGHTEST NOTICE OF WHIRTAIL, WHO WAS TWITCHING AND BLEEDING ON THE GROUND, NEAR OF THE GREAT SNAKE, WHICH HAD SLITHERED BACK INTO SIGHT, AND WAS CIRCLING HARRY AGAIN, HISSING. VERDEMERIT SLIPPED ONE OF THESE UNNATURALLY LONG-FINGERED HANDS INTO A DEEP POCKET, AND DREW OUT A WAND, HE CARESSED IT GENTLY, THEN, AND THEN HE RAISED IT, AND POINTED IT AT WHIRTAIL,

WHO WAS LIFTED OFF THE GROUND, AND THROWN AGAINST THE HEADSTONE WHERE HARRY WAS TIED; HE FELL TO THE FEET OF IT AND LAY

THERE, CRUMPLED UP AND CRYING, VERDEMERIT TURNED HIS SCARLET EYES UPON HARRY, LAUGHING A HIGH, COLD, MIRTHLESS LAUGH.

WHIRTAIL'S REEKS WERE SHINING WITH BLEEDING NEED; HE HAD WRAPPED THE STUMP OF HIS ARM IN THEM, MY LORD ... HE CRIED, MY LORD ... YOU PROMISED ... YOU DID PROMISE ...

HE HAD HLT YOUR ARM, SAID VERDEMERIT LAZILY,

HEH, MASTER ... THANK YOU, MASTER ...

HE EXTENDED THE BLEEDING STUMP, BUT VERDEMERIT LAUGHED AGAIN, THE OTHER ARM, WHIRTAIL,

MASTER, PLEASE ... PLEASE ...

VERDEMERIT BENT DOWN, AND PULLED OUT WHIRTAIL'S LEFT ARM; HE FORCED THE SLEEVE OF WHIRTAIL'S REEKS UP PAST HIS ELBOW, AND

SAW HARRY BETTER

ELARRY SAW SOMETHING UPON THE SKIN THERE, SOMETHING LIKE A  
VIVID RED TATTOO A SKULL, WITH A SNAKE PROTRUDING FROM ITS  
MOUTH THE SAME IMAGE THAT HAD APPEARED IN THE SKY AT THE  
BLUDDITCH WORLD CUP: THE DARK MARK. VELDERTH EXAMINED IT  
CAREFULLY, IGNORING WHIRTAIL'S UNCONTROLLABLE CRYING.

IT IS BACK, HE SAID SEPTLY, THEY WILL ALL HAVE NOTICED IT ... AND  
NEED WE SAY SEE ... NEED WE SAY KNEEL ...

HE PRESSED HIS LONG, WHITE FINGERS TO THE BRAND ON  
WHIRTAIL'S ARM.

THE SCAR ON ELARRY'S FOREHEAD SEARED WITH A SHARP PAIN AGAIN,

AND WHIRTAIL LET OUT A PAINFUL SHOUT! VELDERTH REMOVED HIS FIN-  
GERS FROM WHIRTAIL'S MARK, AND ELARRY SAW THAT IT HAD TURNED

LET BLACK.

A LINE OF CRUEL SATISFACTION ON HIS FACE, VELDERTH STRAIGHT-  
ENED UP, THREW BACK HIS HEAD, AND STARED AROUND AT THE DARK

GRAVEYARD.

HOW MANY WILL BE BRAVE ENOUGH TO RETURN WHEN THEY FEEL  
IT? HE WHISPERED, HIS GLEAMING RED EYES FIXED UPON THE STARS.

AND HOW MANY WILL BE FOOLISH ENOUGH TO STAY AWAY?

HE BEGAN TO PACE UP AND DOWN BEFORE ELARRY AND WHIRTAIL,  
EYES SWEEPING THE GRAVEYARD ALL THE WHILE. AFTER A MINUTE OR SO,  
HE LOOKED DOWN AT ELARRY AGAIN, A CRUEL SMILE TWISTING HIS  
SNAKE-LIKE FACE.

YELL STAND, HARRY POTTER, UPON THE REMAINS OF MY LATE FATHER,  
HE HISSED SILENTLY, A MUGGLE AND A FREAK ... VERY LIKE YOUR DEAR  
MOTHER, BUT THEY BOTH HAD THEIR USES, DID THEY NOT? YOUR MOTHER  
DIED THE DEPEND YELL AS A CHILD ... AND I KILLED MY FATHER, AND SEE  
HOW USEFUL HE HAS PROVED HIMSELF, IN DEATH ...

VERDERBERT LAUGHED AGAIN, UP AND DOWN HE PACE, LEERING  
ALL AROUND HIM AS HE WALKED, AND THE SNAKE CONTINUED THE CIRCLE  
IN THE GRASS.

YELL SEE THAT FENCE UPON THE HILLSIDE, POTTER? MY FATHER  
LIVED THERE, MY MOTHER, A WITCH WHO LIVED HERE IN THIS VILLAGE,  
FELL IN LOVE WITH HIM, BUT HE ABANDONED HER WHEN SHE TOLD HIM  
WHAT SHE WAS ... HE DIDN'T LIKE MAGIC, MY FATHER ...

THE DEATH EATERS SEE

HE LEFT HER AND RETURNED TO HIS MUGGLE PARENTS BEFORE I WAS  
EVEN BORN, POTTER, AND SHE DIED GIVING BIRTH TO ME, LEAVING ME  
TO BE RAISED IN A MUGGLE ORPHANAGE ... BUT I WANTED TO FIND HIM  
... I REVENGED MYSELF UPON HIM, THAT FREAK WHO GAVE ME HIS  
NAME ... THE RIDDLE ...

STILL HE PACE, HIS RED EYES DARTING FROM GRAVE TO GRAVE.

LISTEN TO ME, RELIVING FAMILY HISTORY ... HE SAID QUIETLY,  
WHY, I AM GROWING SLIGHTLY SENTIMENTAL ... BUT WELL, HARRY? MY  
TRUE FAMILY RETURNS ...

THE AIR WAS SUDDENLY FULL OF THE SWISHING OF CLOAKS, BETWEEN  
GRAVES, BEHIND THE YEW TREE, IN EVERY SHADELY SPACE, LIZARDS  
WERE APPARATING, ALL OF THEM WERE FENCED AND MASKED, AND  
HERE BY HERE THEY MOVED FORWARDS ... SILENTLY, CALMLY, AS

THOUGH THEY COULD HARDLY BELIEVE THEIR EYES, VOLDMORT STOOD IN SILENCE, WAITING FOR THEM. THEN ONE OF THE DEATH EATERS FELL TO HIS KNEES, CRAWLED TOWARDS VOLDMORT, AND KISSED THE FEM OF HIS BLACK REEKS.

MASTER ... MASTER ... HE MURMURED,

THE DEATH EATERS BEHIND HIM DID THE SAME; EACH OF THEM APPROACHING VOLDMORT ON HIS KNEES, AND KISSING HIS REEKS, BEFORE BACKING AWAY AND STANDING UP, FORMING A SILENT CIRCLE, WHICH ENCLOSED TOM RIDDLE'S GRAVE, HARRY, VOLDMORT, AND THE SHAKING AND TWITCHING HEAD THAT WAS WHORRTAIL. YET THEY LEFT GAPS IN THE CIRCLE, AS THOUGH WAITING FOR MORE PEOPLE.

VOLDMORT, HOWEVER, DID NOT SEEM TO EXPECT MORE. HE LOOKED AROUND AT THE BLOOD-FACES, AND THOUGH THERE WAS NO WIND, A RUSTLING SEEMED TO RUN AROUND THE CIRCLE, AS THOUGH IT HAD SHIVERED.

WELCOME, DEATH EATERS, SAID VOLDMORT QUIETLY, THIRTEEN YEARS ... THIRTEEN YEARS SINCE LAST WE MET. YET YET ANSWER MY CALL AS THOUGH IT WAS YESTERDAY ... WE ARE STILL LIMITED UNDER THE DARK MARK, THEN? ARE WE?

HE PUT BACK HIS TERRIBLE FACE AND SNIFFED, HIS SLIT-LIKE NOSTRILS WIDENING.

I SMELL GUILT, HE SAID. THERE IS A STENCH OF GUILT UPON THE AIR.

SEE HARRY POTTER

A SECOND SHIVER RAN AROUND THE CIRCLE, AS THOUGH EACH MEMBER OF IT LUNGED, BUT DID NOT DARE, TO STEP BACK FROM HIM.

I SEE THEM ALL, WOUNDED AND FRAIL, WITH THEIR FEELERS INTACT  
SUCH PROMPT APPEARANCES? AND I ASK MYSELF ... WHY DID THIS  
BAND OF WIZARDS NEVER COME TO THE AID OF THEIR MASTER, THE  
WHOM THEY SWORE ETERNAL LOYALTY?

NONE HAD SPEECH, NONE HAD MOVED EXCEPT WHIRTAIL, WHO WAS  
LIFTING THE GRIELING, STILL SERRING OVER HIS BLEEDING ARM,

AND I ANSWER MYSELF, WHISPERED VELDREHT, THEY MUST  
HAVE BELIEVED ME BROKEN, THEY THOUGHT I WAS GONE, THEY  
SLIPPED BACK AMONG MY ENEMIES, AND THEY PLEADED IGNORANCE,  
AND IGNORANCE, AND RELUCTANCE ...

AND THEN I ASK MYSELF, BUT HOW COULD THEY HAVE BELIEVED I  
WOULD NOT RISE AGAIN? THEY, WHO KNEW THE STEPS I TOOK, LONG  
AGO, THE GUARD MYSELF AGAINST MORTAL DEATH? THEY, WHO HAD SEEN  
PROOFS OF THE IMMENSITY OF MY POWER, IN THE TIMES WHEN I WAS  
MIGHTIER THAN ANY WIZARD LIVING?

AND I ANSWER MYSELF, PERHAPS THEY BELIEVED A STILL-GREATER  
POWER COULD EXIST, HAD THAT COULD VANISH EVEN LEAD  
VELDREHT ... PERHAPS THEY NEVER SAW ALLIGANCE TO ANOTHER ...  
PERHAPS THAT CHAMPION OF CHAMPIONS, OF MURDERERS AND  
MURDERERS, ASKED DUMBLEDORE?

AT THE MENTION OF DUMBLEDORE'S NAME, THE MEMBERS OF THE  
CIRCLE STIRRED, AND SOME MUTTERED AND SHOOK THEIR HEADS,  
VELDREHT IGNORED THEM, IT IS A DISAPPOINTMENT TO ME ... I  
CONFESS MYSELF DISAPPOINTED ...

ONE OF THE MEN SUDDENLY FELLING HIMSELF FORWARDS, BREAKING  
THE CIRCLE, TREMBLING FROM HEAD TO FOOT, HE COLLAPSED AT  
VELDREHT'S FEET.

MASTER! HE SCRIEDED, MASTER, FORGIVE ME! FORGIVE US ALL!  
VOLDENHART BEGAN THE LAUGH, HE RAISED HIS WAND, CRUICK!  
THE DEATH EATER HIN THE GREENLAND WRITHED AND SCRIEDED, HARRY  
WAS SURE THE SEALING MUST CARRY THE THE FELLOWS AROUND ... LET THE  
PEOPLE COME, HE THOUGHT DESPERATELY ... ANYONE ... ANYTHING ...

THE DEATH EATERS SEE

VOLDENHART RAISED HIS WAND, THE TORTURED DEATH EATER LAY  
FLAT UPON THE GREENLAND, GASPING.

GET UP, AVERY, SAID VOLDENHART SILENTLY, STAND UP, WILL ASK FOR  
FORGIVENESS? I DO NOT FORGIVE, I DO NOT FORGET, THIRTEEN LONG  
YEARS ... I WANT THIRTEEN YEARS REPAYMENT BEFORE I FORGIVE YOU,  
WHIRTAIL HERE HAS PAID SOME OF HIS DEBT ALREADY, HAVE YOU NOT,  
WHIRTAIL?

HE LEANED DOWN AT WHIRTAIL, WHO CONTINUED THE SILENCE.

YOU RETURNED THE ME, NOT ONLY MY DEBT, BUT ONLY MY FEAR OF  
YOUR OLD FRIENDS, YOU DESERVE THIS PAIN, WHIRTAIL, YOU KNOW  
THAT, DON'T YOU?

YES, MASTER, MEANED WHIRTAIL, PLEASE, MASTER ... PLEASE ...

LET YOU HELPED RETURN ME THE MY BODY, SAID VOLDENHART SILENTLY,  
WATCHING WHIRTAIL SILENCE HIN THE GREENLAND, WORTHLESS AND TRAIT-  
THEROUS AS YOU ARE, YOU HELPED ME ... AND LORD VOLDENHART

REWARDS HIS HELPERS ...

VOLDENHART RAISED HIS WAND AGAIN AND WHIRLED IT THROUGH THE  
AIR, A STREAK OF WHAT LOOKED LIKE MELTEN SILVER FLAME SHINING IN

THE HAND'S WORK. MOMENTARILY SHAPELESS, IT WRITHED AND THEN  
FORMED ITSELF INTO A GLEAMING REPLICAN OF A HUMAN HAND, BRIGHT  
AS MERRYLIGHT, WHICH SHARED DOWNWARDS AND FIXED ITSELF UPON  
WHIRTAIL'S BLEEDING WRIST.

WHIRTAIL'S SHAKING STOPPED ABRUPTLY, HIS BREATHING HARSH  
AND RAGGED. HE RAISED HIS HEAD AND STARED IN DISBELIEF AT THE  
SILVER HAND, NOW ATTACHED SEAMLESSLY TO HIS ARM, AS THOUGH HE  
WERE WEARING A DAZZLING GLOVE. HE FLEXED THE SHINING FINGERS,  
THEN, TREMBLING, PICKED UP A SMALL TWIG FROM THE GROUND, AND  
CRUSHED IT INTO POWDER.

MY LORD, HE WHISPERED, MASTER ... IT IS REALITY ... THAND  
YELL ... THAND YELL ...

HE STAMPEDED FORWARD FROM HIS KNEES AND KISSED THE ARM OF  
VILDEBERT'S REINS.

MAY YOUR LOYALTY NEVER WAVER AGAIN, WHIRTAIL, SAID  
VILDEBERT.

NEH, MY LORD ... NEVER, MY LORD ...

SEN HARRY PETER

WHIRTAIL STOOD UP AND TOOK HIS PLACE IN THE CIRCLE, STARING AT  
HIS PHENOMENAL NEW HAND, HIS FACE STILL SHINING WITH TEARS.

VILDEBERT NOW APPROACHED THE MAN FROM WHIRTAIL'S RIGHT.

LLICILIS, MY SLIPPERY FRIEND, HE WHISPERED, HALTING BEFORE  
HIM. I AM TOLD THAT YOU HAVE NOT RENOUNCED THE OLD WAYS,  
THOUGH THE THE WORLD YOU PRESENT A RESPECTABLE FACE. YOU ARE  
STILL READY TO TAKE THE LEAD IN A SPEED OF MIDGE-TURTLE, I  
BELIEVE? YET YOU NEVER TRIED TO FIND ME, LLICILIS ... YOUR EXPLANTS



AT THE ELIDITCH WHEEL CLIP WERE FLIN, I DARE SAY ... BUT MIGHT  
NOT YOUR ENERGIES HAVE BEEN BETTER DIRECTED TOWARDS FINDING  
AND AIDING YOUR MASTER?

MY LORD, I WAS CONSTANTLY ON THE ALERT, LIKE ELICILS  
MALPHY'S VEHICLE SLIPPED FROM BENEATH THE FLOOR, HAD THERE BEEN  
ANY SIGN FROM YELL, ANY WHISPER OF YOUR WHEREABOUTS, I WOULD  
HAVE BEEN AT YOUR SIDE IMMEDIATELY, NOTHING COULD HAVE PRE-  
VENTED ME

AND YET YELL RAN FROM MY MARCH, WHEN A FAITHFUL DEATH RATER  
SENT IT INTO THE SKY LAST SLIMPER? SAID VELDERT LAZILY, AND MR  
MALPHY STOPPED TALKING ABRUPTLY, YES, I KNOW ALL ABOUT THAT,  
ELICILS ... YELL HAVE DISAPPOINTED ME ... I EXPECT MORE FAITHFUL  
SERVICE IN FUTURE.

OF COURSE, MY LORD, OF COURSE ... YELL ARE MERCIFUL, THANK  
YELL ...

VELDERT MOVED ON, AND STOPPED, STARING AT THE SPACE  
LARGE ENOUGH FOR TWO PEOPLE WHICH SEPARATED MALPHY AND THE  
NEXT MAN.

THE LESTRANGES SHOULD STAND HERE, SAID VELDERT QUIETLY,  
BUT THEY ARE ENTRAPPED IN AZDARAN, THEY WERE FAITHFUL, THEY  
WENT TO AZDARAN RATHER THAN RENEGE ME ... WHEN AZDARAN IS  
BROKEN OPEN, THE LESTRANGES WILL BE REVEALED BEYOND THEIR  
DREAMS, THE DEMENTERS WILL JOIN US ... THEY ARE OUR NATURAL  
ALLIES ... WE WILL RECALL THE BANISHED GIANTS ... I SHALL HAVE ALL MY  
DEVOTED SERVANTS RETURNED TO ME, AND AN ARMY OF CREATURES

WHICH ALL FEAR ...

HE WALKED ON, SOME OF THE DEATH-EATERS HE PASSED IN

THE DEATH-EATERS SILENCE, BUT HE PAUSED BEFORE OTHERS, AND SPEAKED TO THEM.

MACNAIR ... DESTROYING DANGEROUS BEASTS FOR THE MINISTRY OF  
MAGIC NOW, WHIPTAIL TELLS ME? YOU SHALL HAVE BETTER VICTIMS  
THAN THAT SEEN, MACNAIR, LORD VERDEMER WILL PROVIDE ...

THANK YOU, MASTER ... THANK YOU, MURMURED MACNAIR.

AND HERE, VERDEMER MOVED ON TO THE TWO LARGEST HUNDED  
FIGURES, WE HAVE CRAB ... YOU WILL DIE BETTER THIS TIME, WILL  
YOU NOT, CRAB? AND YOU, GOYLE?

THEY KEELER CLIMBLY, MUTTERING DUMBLY.

YES, MASTER ...

WE WILL, MASTER ...

THE SAME GUES FOR YOU, NUTT, SAID VERDEMER ELLIPTLY, AS HE  
WALKED PAST A STEEPED FIGURE IN MR GOYLE'S SHADOW.

MY LORD, I PROSTRATE MYSELF BEFORE YOU, I AM YOUR MOST  
FAITHFUL

THAT WILL DO, SAID VERDEMER.

HE HAD REACHED THE LARGEST CAP OF ALL, AND HE STOOD STAREING  
IT WITH HIS BLANK, RED EYES, AS THOUGH HE COULD SEE PEOPLE  
STANDING THERE.

AND HERE WE HAVE SIX MISSING DEATH-EATERS ... THREE DEAD IN  
MY SERVICE, HINE, THE CHLARDLY THE RETURN ... HE WILL PAY, HINE,  
WHICH I BELIEVE HAS LEFT ME FOR EVER ... HE WILL BE KILLED, OF COURSE  
... AND HINE, WHICH REMAINS MY MOST FAITHFUL SERVANT, AND WHICH

HAS ALREADY RE-ENTERED MY SERVICE.

THE DEATH EATERS STIRRED; HARRY SAW THEIR EYES DART SIDELWAYS AT EACH OTHER THROUGH THEIR MASKS.

HE IS AT HOGWARTS, THAT FAITHFUL SERVANT, AND IT WAS THROUGH HIS EFFORTS THAT OUR YOUNG FRIEND ARRIVED TONIGHT ...

YES, SAID VERDERBERT, A GRIN CURLING HIS LIPLESS MOUTH, AS THE EYES OF THE CIRCLE FLASHED IN HARRY'S DIRECTION. HARRY PITTER HAS KINDLY INVITED US FOR MY REBIRTHING PARTY, HERE MIGHT WE SEE FAR AS THE CALL HIM MY GUEST OF HONOUR.

THERE WAS A SILENCE. THEN THE DEATH EATER TO THE RIGHT OF WHORNTAIL STEPPED FORWARD, AND LUCIUS MALFOY'S VOICE SPEAK FROM UNDER THE MASK.

SEE HARRY PITTER

MASTER, WE CRAVE THE KNOWN ... WE SEE YOU THE TELL US ... HOW YOU HAVE ACHIEVED THIS ... THIS MIRACLE ... HOW YOU MANAGED THE RETURN THE US ...

AH, WHAT A STORY IT IS, LUCIUS, SAID VERDERBERT, AND IT BEGINS AND ENDS WITH MY YOUNG FRIEND HERE.

HE WALKED LAZILY OVER THE STAND NEXT THE HARRY, SEE THAT THE EYES OF THE WHOLE CIRCLE WERE UPON THE TWO OF THEM. THE SNAKE CONTINUED THE CIRCLE.

YOU KNOWN, OF COURSE, THAT THEY HAVE CALLED THIS REB MY BIRTHDAY? VERDERBERT SAID SLEETLY, HIS RED EYES UPON HARRY, WHOSE SCAR BEGAN THE FLARE SEE FIERCELY THAT HE ALMOST SCREAMED

IN AGONY. YET I ALL KNEW THAT IN THE NIGHT I LOST MY FEELERS AND MY BODY, I TRIED TO KILL HIM, HIS MOTHER DIED IN THE ATTEMPT TO SAVE HIM AND UNWITTINGLY PROVIDED HIM WITH A PROTECTION I ADMIT I HAD NOT FORESEEN ... I COULD NOT THINK THE KEY,

VERDERHART RAISED ONE OF HIS LONG WHITE FINGERS, AND PUT IT VERY CLOSE TO HARRY'S CHEEK. HIS MOTHER LEFT UPON HIM THE TRACES OF HER SACRIFICE ... THIS IS OLD MAGIC, I SHOULD HAVE REMEMBERED IT, I WAS FEEBLES THE EVERLIVING IT ... BUT NO MATTER, I CAN THINK HIM NOW.

HARRY FELT THE COLD TIP OF THE LONG WHITE FINGER TOUCH HIM, AND THOUGHT HIS HEAD WOULD BURST WITH THE PAIN.

VERDERHART LAUGHED SEPTLY IN HIS EAR, THEN TOOK THE FINGER

AWAY, AND CONTINUED ADDRESSING THE DEATH EATERS. I MISCALCULATED, MY FRIENDS, I ADMIT IT. MY CLUSE WAS DEFEATED BY THE

WHYMAN'S FEEBLES SACRIFICE, AND IT REVEALED UPON ME. AHA ... PAIN BEYOND PAIN, MY FRIENDS; NOTHING COULD HAVE PREPARED ME FOR IT, I WAS RIPPED FROM MY BODY, I WAS LESS THAN SPIRIT, LESS THAN THE MEANEST GHOST ... BUT STILL, I WAS ALIVE. WHAT I WAS, EVEN I DO NOT KNOW ... I, WE HAVE GONE FURTHER THAN ANYBODY ALONG THE PATH THAT LEADS TO IMMORTALITY. YET I KNOW MY CHANCE THE CHANCE OF DEATH, AND NOW, I WAS TESTED, AND IT APPEARED THAT ONE OF MORE OF MY EXPERIMENTS HAD WORKED ... FOR I HAD NOT BEEN KILLED, THOUGH THE CLUSE SHOULD HAVE DONE IT.

NEVERTHELESS, I WAS AS FEELERLESS AS THE WEAKEST CREATURE ALIVE,

THE DEATH EATERS SET

AND WITHOUT THE MEANS TO HELP MYSELF ... FOR I HAD NO BODY,  
AND EVERY SPELL WHICH MIGHT HAVE HELPED ME REQUIRED THE USE  
OF A WAND ...

I REMEMBER ONLY FEELING MYSELF, SLEEPLESSLY, ENDLESSLY,  
SECOND BY SECOND, TO EXIST ... I SETTLED IN A FARAWAY PLACE, IN A  
FOREST, AND I WAITED ... SLOWLY, HERE OF MY FAITHFUL DEATH EATERS

WOULD TRY AND FIND ME ... HERE OF THEM WOULD COME AND PER-  
FORM THE MAGIC I COULD NOT, TO RESTORE ME TO A BODY ... BUT I

WAITED IN VAIN ...

THE SHIVER RAN HENCE MORE AROUND THE CIRCLE OF LISTENING  
DEATH EATERS, VIOLENTLY LET THE SILENCE SPIRAL TERRIBLY DEEPER  
CONTINUING. ONLY ONE POWER REMAINED TO ME, I COULD POSSESS  
THE BODIES OF OTHERS, BUT I DARED NOT GO WHERE OTHER HUMANS  
WERE PLentiful, FOR I KNEW THAT THE ALIENS WERE STILL AHEAD AND  
SEARCHING FOR ME, I SOMETIMES INHABITED ANIMALS ... SNAKES, OF  
COURSE, BEING MY PREFERENCE ... BUT I WAS LITTLE BETTER OFF INSIDE  
THEM THAN AS PURE SPIRIT, FOR THEIR BODIES WERE ILL-ADAPTED TO  
PERFORM MAGIC ... AND MY POSSESSION OF THEM SHORTENED THEIR  
LIVES; NONE OF THEM LASTED LONG ...

THEN ... SEVERAL YEARS AGO ... THE MEANS FOR MY RETURN SEEMED  
ASSURED, A WIZARD ... YOUNG, FAMILIAR AND GULLIBLE ... WANDERED  
ACROSS MY PATH IN THE FOREST I HAD MADE MY HOME. HE, HE  
SEEMED THE VERY CHANCE I HAD BEEN DREAMING OF ... FOR HE WAS A  
TEACHER AT DUMBLEDORE'S SCHOOL ... HE WAS EXACTLY THE KIND THE MY

WILL ... HE BRING ME BACK TO THIS COUNTRY, AND AFTER A WHILE, I

THESE POSSESSIONS OF HIS BODY, HE SUPERVISE HIM CLOSELY AS HE CARRIED OUT MY ORDERS, BUT MY PLAN FAILED, I DID NOT MANAGE TO

STEAL THE PHILOSOPHER'S STONE, I WAS NOT THE BE ASSURED IMMORTAL LIFE, I WAS THWARTED ... THWARTED, ONCE AGAIN, BY HARRY POTTER ...

SILENCE ONCE MORE; NOTHING WAS STIRRING, NOT EVEN THE LEAVES ON THE YEW TREE, THE DEATH EATERS WERE BLIND MINDLESS, THE GLITTERING EYES IN THEIR MASKS FIXED UPON VOLDEMORT, AND UPON HARRY.

THE SERVANT DIED WHEN I LEFT HIS BODY, AND I WAS LEFT AS DEAD

SEE HARRY POTTER

AS EVER I HAD BEEN, VOLDEMORT CONTINUED, I RETURNED TO MY HIDING PLACE FAR AWAY, AND I WILL NOT PRETEND TO KNOW THAT I DIDN'T THEN FEAR THAT I MIGHT NEVER REGAIN MY POWERS ... YES, THAT WAS PERHAPS MY DARKEST FEAR ... I COULD NOT HOPE THAT I WOULD BE SENT ANOTHER WIZARD TO POSSESS ... AND I HAD GIVEN UP HOPE, NOW, THAT ANY OF MY DEATH EATERS CARED WHAT HAD BECOME OF ME ...

ONE OF THE OF THE MASKED WIZARDS IN THE CIRCLE MOVED UNCONSCIOUSLY, BUT VOLDEMORT TOOK NO NOTICE.

AND THEN, NOT EVEN A YEAR AGO, WHEN I HAD ALMOST ABANDONED HOPE, IT HAPPENED AT LAST ... A SERVANT RETURNED TO ME!

WHIRTAIL HERE, WHEN I HAD FAKED HIS DEATH THE ESCAPE ILUSTICE,  
WAS DRIVEN INTO MY HIDING BY THOSE HE HAD ONCE COUNTED FRIENDS,  
AND DECIDED TO RETURN TO HIS MASTER, HE SIGHT ME IN THE COUN-  
TRY WHERE IT HAD LONG BEEN ASSUMED I WAS HIDING ... HELPED,

MY CHOICE, BY THE RATS HE MET ALONG THE WAY, WHIRTAIL HAS A  
CURIOUS AFFINITY WITH RATS, ONE YEAR AGO, WHIRTAIL'S FIVE  
LITTLE FRIENDS TOLD HIM THERE WAS A PLACE, DEEP IN AN ALBANIAN  
FOREST, THAT THEY SAID, WHERE SMALL ANIMALS LIKE THEMSELVES  
HAD MET THEIR DEATHS BY A DARK SHADOW THAT POSSESSED THEM ...

BUT HIS JOURNEY BACK TO ME WAS NOT SMOOTH, WAS IT,  
WHIRTAIL? THEN, ONE NIGHT, ON THE EDGE OF THE VERY FOREST  
WHERE HE HAD HELPED TO FIND ME, HE ABRUPTLY STOPPED AT AN INN  
FOR SOME FOOD ... AND WHEN SHOULD HE MEET THERE, BUT ONE  
BERTHA JERKINS, A WITCH FROM THE MINISTRY OF MAGIC?

WHEN SEE THE WAY THAT FATE FAVELORS LORD VOLDEMORT, THIS  
MIGHT HAVE BEEN THE END OF WHIRTAIL, AND MY LAST HOPE FOR  
REGENERATION. BUT WHIRTAIL DISPLAYING A PRESENCE OF MIND I  
WOULD NEVER HAVE EXPECTED OF HIM CONVINCED BERTHA JERKINS  
TO ACCOMPANY HIM ON A NIGHT-TIME STROLL, HE OVERPERSUADED HER  
... HE BRIGHTENED HER TO ME, AND BERTHA JERKINS, WHO MIGHT HAVE  
RUINED ALL, PROVIDED INSTEAD TO BE A GIFT BEYOND MY WILDEST

DREAMS ... HER WITH A LITTLE PERSUASION SHE BECAME A VERIT-  
ABLE MINE OF INFORMATION,

SHE TOLD ME THAT THE TRIWIZARD TOURNAMENT WOULD BE PLAYED

THE DEATH EATERS SAY

AT HOGWARTS THIS YEAR. SHE TOLD ME THAT SHE KNEW OF A FAITHFUL  
DEATH EATER WHO WOULD BE ONLY TOO WILLING TO HELP ME, IF I  
COULD ONLY CONTACT HIM. SHE TOLD ME MANY THINGS ... BUT THE  
MEANS I USED TO BREAK THE MEMORY CHARM UPON HER WERE  
POWERFUL, AND WHEN I HAD EXTRACTED ALL USEFUL INFORMATION  
FROM HER, HER MIND AND BODY WERE BOTH DAMAGED BEYOND  
REPAIR. SHE HAD NOW SERVED HER PURPOSE. I COULD NOT POSSESS  
HER. I DISPOSED OF HER.

VERMOREL SMILED HIS TERRIBLE SMILE, HIS RED EYES BLANK AND  
PITILESS.

WORMTAIL'S BODY, OF COURSE, WAS IL-ADAPTED FOR POSSESSION,

AS ALL ASSUMED HIM DEAD, AND WOULD ATTRACT FAR TOO MUCH ATTEN-  
TION IF SEEN. HOWEVER, HE WAS THE ALE-KIDDED SERVANT I NEEDED,

AND, POWER WIZARD THOUGH HE IS, WORMTAIL WAS ABLE TO FOLLOW THE

INSTRUCTIONS I GAVE HIM, WHICH WOULD RETURN ME TO A REGIMEN-  
TARY, LEAD BODY OF MY OWN, A BODY I WOULD BE ABLE TO INHABIT

WHILE AWAITING THE ESSENTIAL INGREDIENTS FOR TRUE REBIRTH ... A  
SPELL FOR TWO OF MY OWN INVENTION ... A LITTLE HELP FROM MY DEAR



NAGINI VOLDMORT'S RED EYES FELL UPON THE CONTINUALLY CIR-  
CLING SNAKE A PETITION CHUCKLED FROM LINICORN BLEED, AND THE

SNAKE VERHEM NAGINI PROVIDED ... I WAS SEEN RETURNED THE AN  
ALMOST FLIMSY FIRM, AND STRUNG ENOUGH THE TRAVEL.

THERE WAS NO MORE OF STEALING THE PHILOSOPHER'S STONE AND  
MORE, AND I KNEW THAT DUMBLEDORE WOULD HAVE SEEN THE IT THAT IT  
WAS DESTROYED, BUT I WAS WILLING TO EMERACE MENTAL LIFE AGAIN,

BEFORE CHASING IMMORTAL, I SET MY SIGHTS LOWER ... I WOULD SET-  
TLE FOR MY OLD BODY BACK AGAIN, AND MY OLD STRENGTH.

I KNEW THAT TO ACHIEVE THIS IT IS AN OLD PIECE OF DARK  
MAGIC, THE PETITION THAT REVIVED ME TONIGHT I WOULD NEED THREE  
POWERFUL INGREDIENTS, WELL, ONE OF THEM WAS ALREADY AT HAND,  
WAS IT NOT, WHORMTAIL? FLESH GIVEN BY A SERVANT ...

MY FATHER'S BENE, NATURALLY, MEANT THAT WE WOULD HAVE THE  
CAME HERE, WHERE HE WAS BURIED, BUT THE BLEED OF A ...  
WHORMTAIL WOULD HAVE HAD ME LIKE ANY WIZARD, WOULD YOU NOT,  
WHORMTAIL? ANY WIZARD WHO HAD HATED ME ... AS SHE MANY OF

SOME HARRY POTTER

THEM STILL BE, BUT I KNEW THE MORE I MUST LIVE, IF I WAS TO RISE  
AGAIN, MORE POWERFUL THAN I HAD BEEN WHEN I HAD FALLEN, I  
WANTED HARRY POTTER'S BLEED, I WANTED THE BLEED OF THE MORE

WHO HAD STRIPPED ME OF POWER THIRTEEN YEARS AGO, FOR THE LIN-

BRING PROTECTION HIS MOTHER HENCE GAVE HIM, WOULD THEN RESIDE

IN MY VEINS, THE ...

BUT HOW THE GET AT HARRY POTTER? FOR HE HAS BEEN BETTER PRO-  
TECTED THAN I THINK EVEN HE KNOWS, PROTECTED IN WAYS DEVISED

BY DUMBLEDORE LONG AGO, WHEN IT FELL TO HIM TO ARRANGE THE  
KID'S FUTURE, DUMBLEDORE INVOKED AN ANCIENT MAGIC, TO ENSURE  
THE KID'S PROTECTION AS LONG AS HE IS IN HIS RELATIVES' CARE. NOT  
EVEN I CAN THICK HIM THERE ... THEN, OF COURSE, THERE WAS THE  
BLINDING WORLD CUP ... I THINK HIS PROTECTION MIGHT BE  
WEAKER THERE, AWAY FROM HIS RELATIVES AND DUMBLEDORE, BUT I  
WAS NOT YET STRONG ENOUGH TO ATTEMPT KIDNAP IN THE MIDST OF A  
HOUR OF MINISTRY WIZARDS. AND THEN, THE KID WOULD RETURN TO

HOGWARTS, WHERE HE IS UNDER THE CLOSEST EYE OF THAT MUGGLE-  
LIVING FELL FROM MORNING UNTIL NIGHT. SEE HOW CHILD I TAKE

HIM

Why ... BY USING BERTHA JORDANS'S INFORMATION, OF COURSE.  
USE MY MORE FAITHFUL DEATH EATER, STATIONED AT HOGWARTS, TO  
ENSURE THAT THE KID'S NAME WAS ENTERED INTO THE CHARTER OF FIRE.  
USE MY DEATH EATER TO ENSURE THAT THE KID WOULD BE  
TELEPORTED THAT HE THOUGHT THE TRIWIZARD CUP FIRST THE  
CUP WHICH MY DEATH EATER HAD TURNED INTO A PORTKEY, WHICH  
WOULD BRING HIM HERE, BEYOND THE REACH OF DUMBLEDORE'S HELP

AND PROTECTION, AND INTO MY WAITING ARMS, AND HERE HE IS ...

THE KID WHO ALL BELIEVED HAD BEEN MY DEATHFALL ...

VEHDEMERT MOVED SILENTLY FORWARD, AND TURNED THE FACE HARRY,

HE RAISED HIS HAND, CRACK!

IT WAS PAIN BEYOND ANYTHING HARRY HAD EVER EXPERIENCED;

HIS VERY BONES WERE ON FIRE; HIS HEAD WAS SILENTLY SPLITTING ALONG

HIS STAR; HIS EYES WERE REBELLING MADLY IN HIS HEAD; HE WANTED IT

THE END ... THE BLACK HILT ... THE DIE ...

AND THEN IT WAS GONE, HE WAS HANGING LIMPLY IN THE REEFS

THE DEATH EATERS SA

KINDING HIM THE HEADSTONE OF VEHDEMERT'S FATHER, LEANING UP

INTO THESE BRIGHT RED EYES THROUGH A KIND OF MIST, THE NIGHT

WAS RINGING WITH THE SOUND OF THE DEATH EATERS' LAUGHTER.

WHO SEE, I THINK, HOW FOOLISH IT WAS THE SUPPOSE THAT THIS KID

COULD EVER HAVE BEEN STRONGER THAN ME, SAID VEHDEMERT, BUT I

WANT THERE TO BE NO MISTAKE IN ANYBODY'S MIND, HARRY BETTER

ESCAPED ME BY A LUCKY CHANCE, AND I AM NOW GOING TO PROVE

MY POWER BY KILLING HIM, HERE AND NOW, IN FRONT OF WHO ALL,

WHEN THERE IS NO DUMBLEDORE TO HELP HIM, AND NO MOTHER TO

DIE FOR HIM, I WILL GIVE HIM HIS CHANCE, HE WILL BE ALLOWED THE

FIGHT, AND WHO WILL BE LEFT IN NO DOUBT WHICH OF US IS THE

STRONGER, JUST A LITTLE LONGER, NAGINI, HE WHISPERED, AND THE

SNAKE GLIDED AWAY THROUGH THE GRASS, THE WHERE THE DEATH

EATERS STOOD WATCHING.

NOW LIFT HIM, WHIRTAIL, AND GIVE HIM BACK HIS WAND.

## CHAPTER THIRTY-FOUR

### PRIMI INCANTATEM

WHIRTAIL APPROACHED HARRY, WHO STRUGGLED TO FIND HIS FEET, THEN SLIPPED HIS HEAVY WEIGHT BEFORE THE REEFS WERE LIFTED.

WHIRTAIL RAISED HIS NEW SILVER HAND, PULLED OUT THE WAD OF MATERIAL GAGGING HARRY AND THEN, WITH ONE SWIPE, CUT THROUGH THE REEFS TYING HARRY TO THE GRAVESTONE.

THERE WAS A SPLIT SECOND, PERHAPS, WHEN HARRY MIGHT HAVE CONSIDERED RUNNING FOR IT, BUT HIS INJURED LEG STOOD UNDER HIM AS HE STOOD IN THE EVERGREEN GRAVE, AS THE DEATH EATERS CLOSED RANKS, FORMING A TIGHTER CIRCLE AROUND HIM AND VERDEMER, SEE THAT THE GAPS WERE THE MISSING DEATH EATERS SHOULD HAVE STOOD WERE FILLED. WHIRTAIL WALKED OUT OF THE CIRCLE TO THE PLACE WHERE CEDRIC'S BODY LAY, AND RETURNED WITH HARRY'S WAND, WHICH HE THROUST RELIGIOUSLY INTO HARRY'S HAND WITHOUT LOOKING AT HIM. THEN WHIRTAIL RESUMED HIS PLACE IN THE CIRCLE OF WATCHING DEATH EATERS.

THEY HAVE BEEN TAUGHT HOW TO DUEL, HARRY PETER? SAID VERDEMER SEPTLY, HIS RED EYES GLINTING THROUGH THE DARKNESS. AT THESE WORDS HARRY REMEMBERED, AS THOUGH FROM A FORMER LIFE, THE DUELING CLUB AT HOGWARTS HE HAD ATTENDED BRIEFLY TWO YEARS AGO ... ALL HE HAD LEARNED THERE WAS THE DISARMING SPELL, EXPELLIARMUS ... AND WHAT USE WOULD IT BE, EVEN IF HE COULD, THE

DEPRIVE VEHEMENT OF HIS WAND, WHEN HE WAS SURROUNDED BY  
DEATH EATERS, MULTIMETERED BY AT LEAST THIRTY THE HEN? HE HAD  
NEVER LEARNED ANYTHING THAT COULD POSSIBLY FIT HIM FOR THIS. HE  
KNEW HE WAS FACING THE THING AGAINST WHICH MERRY HAD ALWAYS  
WARNED ... THE UNBELIEVABLE AVADA KEDAVRA CURSE AND

PRIORI INCANTATEM STR

VEHEMENT WAS RIGHT HIS MOTHER WAS NOT HERE TO DIE FOR HIM  
THIS TIME ... HE WAS COMPLETELY UNPROTECTED ...

WE KNOW THE EACH OTHER, HARRY, SAID VEHEMENT, BENDING A LIT-  
TLE, BUT KEEPING HIS SNAKE-LIKE FACE UPRIGHT THE HARRY, COME,

THE NICKIES MUST BE OBSERVED ... DUMBLEDORE WOULD LIKE THEM  
THE SAME MANNERS ... KNOW THE DEATH, HARRY ...

THE DEATH EATERS WERE LAUGHING AGAIN. VEHEMENT'S LIPLESS  
MOUTH WAS SMILING. HARRY DID NOT KNOW, HE WAS NOT GOING TO LET  
VEHEMENT PLAY WITH HIM BEFORE KILLING HIM ... HE WAS NOT  
GOING TO GIVE HIM THAT SATISFACTION ...

I SAID, KNOW, VEHEMENT SAID, RAISING HIS WAND AND HARRY

HELT HIS SPINE CURVE AS THOUGH A FLICK, INVISIBLE HAND WAS BEND-  
ING HIM RUTHLESSLY FORWARDS, AND THE DEATH EATERS LAUGHED

HARDER THAN EVER.

VERY GOOD, SAID VEHEMENT SILENTLY, AND AS HE RAISED HIS WAND,  
THE PRESSURE BEARING DOWN UPON HARRY LIFTED THEM, AND NEW

WELL FACE ME, LIKE A MAN ... STRAIGHT BACKED AND PRIDE, THE WAY  
YOUR FATHER DID ...

AND NOW WE DIE.

VERDERBERT RAISED HIS HAND, AND BEFORE HARRY COULD DO ANY-  
THING TO DEFEND HIMSELF, BEFORE HE COULD EVEN MOVE, HE HAD

BEEN HIT AGAIN BY THE CRUCIATUS CURSE. THE PAIN WAS SO INTENSE,  
SO ALL-CONSUMING, THAT HE NO LONGER KNEW WHERE HE WAS ...  
WHITE-HOT KNIVES WERE PIERCING EVERY INCH OF HIS SKIN, HIS HEAD  
WAS SURELY GOING THE WORST WITH PAIN; HE WAS SCREAMING MORE  
LOUDLY THAN HE HAD EVER SCREAMED IN HIS LIFE

AND THEN IT STOPPED. HARRY REELLED BACK AND SCRAMBLED ON HIS  
FEET; HE WAS SHAKING AS UNCONTROLLABLY AS WORMTAIL HAD DONE  
WHEN HIS HAND HAD BEEN CUT OFF; HE STAGGERED SIDEWAYS INTO THE  
WALL OF WATCHING DEATH EATERS, AND THEY PUSHED HIM AWAY,  
BACK TOWARDS VERDERBERT.

A LITTLE BREATH, SAID VERDERBERT, THE SLIT-LIKE NOSTRILS DILATING  
WITH EXCITEMENT, A LITTLE PAUSE ... THAT FLIRT, DIDN'T IT, HARRY?  
WELL DIDN'T WANT ME TO DO THAT AGAIN, DID YOU?  
HARRY DIDN'T ANSWER, HE WAS GOING TO DIE LIKE CEDRIC, THESE

STAY HARRY PEEETER

PITILESS RED EYES WERE TELLING HIM SO ... HE WAS GOING TO DIE,  
AND THERE WAS NOTHING HE COULD DO ABOUT IT ... BUT HE WASN'T  
GOING TO PLAY ALONE, HE WASN'T GOING TO MEET VERDERBERT ... HE  
WASN'T GOING TO BE ...

I ASKED YOU WHETHER YOU WANT ME TO DO THAT AGAIN? SAID  
VOLDENHART SERIOUSLY, ANSWER ME! IMPERIOUSLY  
AND HARRY FELT, FOR THE THIRD TIME IN HIS LIFE, THE SENSATION  
THAT HIS MIND HAD BEEN WIPE OF ALL THOUGHT ... AH, IT WAS BLISS,  
NOT THE THINKING, IT WAS AS THOUGH HE WAS FLEETING, DREAMING ... JUST  
ANSWER NO ... SAY NO ... JUST ANSWER NO ...  
I WILL NOT, SAID A STRONGER VOICE, IN THE BACK OF HIS HEAD, I  
WON'T ANSWER ...  
JUST ANSWER NO ...  
I WON'T DO IT, I WON'T SAY IT ...  
JUST ANSWER NO ...  
I WON'T!

AND THESE WORDS FIRST FROM HARRY'S MOUTH; THEY ROLLED

THROUGH THE GRAVEYARD, AND THE DREAM STATE WAS LIFTED AS SUD-  
DENLY AS THOUGH COLD WATER HAD BEEN THROWN OVER HIM BACK

REALISED THE FACTS THAT THE CRUCIATUS CURSE HAD LEFT ALL OVER HIS  
BODY BACK REALISED THE REALISATION OF WHERE HE WAS, AND WHAT  
HE WAS FACING ...

YOU WON'T? SAID VOLDENHART SERIOUSLY, AND THE DEATH EATERS  
WERE NOT LAUGHING NOW, YOU WON'T SAY NO? HARRY, OBEDIENCE  
IS A VIRTUE I NEED THE TEACH YOU BEFORE YOU DIE ... PERHAPS  
ANOTHER LITTLE DISE OF PAIN?

VOLDENHART RAISED HIS WAND, BUT THIS TIME HARRY WAS READY;

WITH THE REFLEXES BORN OF HIS FLUIDITY TRAINING, HE ALLOWED HIM-

SELF SIDELWAYS BENTH THE GRHLIND; HE ROLLED BEHIND THE MARBLE

HEADSTONE OF VELDMEHT S FATHER, AND HE HEARD IT CRACK AS THE CURSE MISSED HIM.

WE ARE NOT PLAYING HIDE-AND-SEEK, HARRY, SAID VELDMEHT S SEXT, CHILD VOICE, DRAWING NEARER, AS THE DEATH EATERS LAUGHED. YOU CANNOT HIDE FROM ME, DOES THIS MEAN YOU ARE TIRED OF HUN BLUR? DOES THIS MEAN THAT YOU WOULD PREFER ME TO FINISH IT

PRITHI INCANTATEM EST

NEH, HARRY? COME HLIT, HARRY ... COME HLIT AND PLAY, THEN ... IT WILL BE HLID ... IT MIGHT EVEN BE PAINLESS ... I WOULD NOT KNOW ... I HAVE NEVER DIED ...

HARRY CREELED BEHIND THE HEADSTONE, AND KNEW THE END HAD COME. THERE WAS NO HOPE ... NO HELP TH BE HAD, AND AS HE HEARD VELDMEHT DRAW NEARER STILL, HE KNEW ONE THING ONLY, AND

IT WAS BEYOND FEAR HIS REASON HE WAS NOT CHING THE DIR CREECH-ING HERE LIKE A CHILD PLAYING HIDE-AND-SEEK; HE WAS NOT CHING

THE DIR CREECHING AT VELDMEHT S FEET ... HE WAS CHING THE DIR UPRIGHT LIKE HIS FATHER, AND HE WAS CHING THE DIR TRYING TO DEFEND HIMSELF, EVEN IF NO DEFENCE WAS POSSIBLE ...

BEFORE VELDMEHT COULD STICK HIS SNAKE-LIKE FACE AROUND THE HEADSTONE, HARRY HAD STOOD UP ... HE GRIPPED HIS WAND TIGHTLY IN HIS HAND, THIRST IT HLIT IN FRONT OF HIM, AND THREW HIMSELF AROUND THE HEADSTONE, FACING VELDMEHT.



VEHDEMERT WAS READY, AS HARRY SHOUTED EXPELLIARMUS!

VEHDEMERT CRIED, AVADA KEDAVRA!

A BRIGHT GREEN LIGHT ISSUED FROM VEHDEMERT'S HAND JUST AS A BRIGHT RED LIGHT BLASTED FROM HARRY'S. THEY MET IN MID-AIR AND SUDDENLY, HARRY'S HAND WAS VIBRATING AS THOUGH AN ELECTRIC CHARGE WAS SURGING THROUGH IT; HIS HAND HAD SEIZED UP AROUND IT; HE COULDN'T HAVE RELEASED IT IF HE'D WANTED TO AND A NARROW BEAM OF LIGHT WAS NOW CONNECTING THE TWO HANDS, NEITHER RED NOR GREEN, BUT BRIGHT, DEEP GOLD AND HARRY, FOLLOWING THE BEAM WITH HIS ASTONISHED GAZE, SAW THAT VEHDEMERT'S LONG WHITE FINGERS, TOO, WERE GRIPPING A HAND THAT WAS SHAKING AND VIBRATING.

AND THEN NOTHING COULD HAVE PREPARED HARRY FOR THIS HE FELT HIS FEET LIFT FROM THE GROUND, HE AND VEHDEMERT WERE BOTH BEING RAISED INTO THE AIR, THEIR HANDS STILL CONNECTED BY THAT THREAD OF SHIMMERING GOLDEN LIGHT. THEY WERE GLIDING AWAY FROM THE THRESHOLD OF VEHDEMERT'S FATHER, AND THEN CAME THE REST OF A PATCH OF GROUND THAT WAS CLEAR AND FREE OF GRAVES ... THE DEATH EATERS WERE SHOUTING, THEY WERE ASKING VEHDEMERT FOR INSTRUCTIONS; THEY WERE CLOSING IN, RE-FORMING THE CIRCLE

SAW HARRY DOUBT

AROUND HARRY AND VEHDEMERT, THE SNAKE SLITHERING AT THEIR HEELS, SOME OF THEM DRAWING THEIR HANDS

THE GOLDEN THREAD CONNECTING HARRY AND VEHDEMERT

SPLINTERED; THOUGH THE HANDS REMAINED CONNECTED, A THOUSAND

MORE WHISTLES AROSE HIGH OVER HARRY AND VERMONT, CRISS-  
CROSSING ALL AROUND THEM, UNTIL THEY WERE ENCLOSED IN A GILDEN,

DIAM-SHAPED WEB, A LACE OF LIGHT, BEYOND WHICH THE DEATH  
EATERS CIRCLED LIKE JACKALS, THEIR CRIES STRANGELY MUFFLED  
NOW ...

DO NOTHING! VERMONT STRUCKED THE DEATH EATERS, AND  
HARRY SAW HIS RED EYES WIDE WITH ASTONISHMENT AT WHAT WAS  
HAPPENING, SAW HIM FIGHTING THE BREAD THE THREAD OF LIGHT STILL  
CONNECTING HIS HAND WITH HARRY'S; HARRY HELD FIRMER HIS HAND  
MORE TIGHTLY, WITH BOTH HANDS, AND THE GILDEN THREAD REMAINED  
UNBROKEN. DO NOTHING UNLESS I COMMAND YOU! VERMONT  
SMILED AT THE DEATH EATERS.

AND THEN AN UNEXPECTED AND BEAUTIFUL SOUND FILLED THE AIR ...

IT WAS COMING FROM EVERY THREAD OF THE LIGHT-SPIN LIKE VIBRAT-  
ING AROUND HARRY AND VERMONT. IT WAS A SOUND HARRY RECOG-  
NIZED, THOUGH HE HAD HEARD IT ONLY ONCE BEFORE IN HIS LIFE ...

PHENIX SONG ...

IT WAS THE SOUND OF HOME TO HARRY ... THE MOST BEAUTIFUL AND  
WELCOME THING HE HAD EVER HEARD IN HIS LIFE ... HE FELT AS  
THOUGH THE SONG WAS INSIDE HIM INSTEAD OF JUST AROUND HIM ...  
IT WAS THE SOUND HE CONNECTED WITH DUMLEDORE, AND IT WAS  
ALMOST AS THOUGH A FRIEND WAS SPEAKING IN HIS EAR ...  
DIDN'T BREAK THE CONNECTION.

I KNOW, HARRY TOLD THE MUSIC, I KNOW I LISTEN TO ... BUT SEE

SEEMER HAD HE REALIZED IT, THEN THE THING BECAME MUCH HARDER  
THE DEER. HIS WAND BEGAN THE VIBRATE MORE FIERCELY THAN EVER  
... AND NOW THE BEAM BETWEEN HIM AND VERDERBERT CHANGED,  
THE ... IT WAS AS THOUGH LARGE BEAMS OF LIGHT WERE SLIDING  
UP AND DOWN THE THREAD CONNECTING THE WANDS. HARRY FELT  
HIS WAND GIVE A SLIDDER LINDER HIS HAND, AS THE LIGHT  
BEAMS BEGAN THE SLIDE SLEWLY AND STABLY HIS WAY ... THE

PRERE INSTANTLY

DIRECTION OF THE BEAM'S MOVEMENT WAS NOW TOWARDS HIM,  
FROM VERDERBERT, AND HE FELT HIS WAND SLIDDER ANGERILY ...  
AS THE NEAREST BEAM OF LIGHT MOVED NEARER THE HARRY'S WAND  
TIP, THE WIND BENEATH HIS FINGERS GREW SO HOT HE FEARED IT  
WOULD BURST INTO FLAME. THE CLOSER THAT BEAM MOVED, THE  
HARDER HARRY'S WAND VIBRATED; HE WAS SURE HIS WAND WOULD NOT  
SURVIVE CONTACT WITH IT; IT FELT AS THOUGH IT WAS ABOUT TO SHATTER  
UNDER HIS FINGERS

HE CONCENTRATED EVERY LAST PARTICLE OF HIS MIND UPON FIRING  
THE BEAM BACKWARDS TOWARDS VERDERBERT, HIS EARS FULL OF  
FIRENIX SONG, HIS EYES FLUTTERING, FIXATED ... AND SLEWLY, VERY  
SLEWLY, THE BEAMS DELIVERED THE A HALT, AND THEN, JUST AS SLEWLY,  
THEY BEGAN THE MOVE THE OTHER WAY ... AND IT WAS VERDERBERT'S  
WAND THAT WAS VIBRATING EXTRA HARD NOW ... VERDERBERT WAS  
SHOOK ASTONISHED, AND ALMOST FEARFUL ...

ONE OF THE BEAMS OF LIGHT WAS DELIVERING, INCHES FROM THE TIP  
OF VERDERBERT'S WAND, HARRY DIDN'T UNDERSTAND WHY HE WAS

BEING IT, DIDN'T KNOW WHAT IT MIGHT ACHIEVE ... BUT HE NOW CON-  
CENTRATED AS HE HAD NEVER DONE IN HIS LIFE, HE FOCUSING THAT BEAM

OF LIGHT RIGHT BACK INTO VERMOREL'S WAND ... AND SILENTLY ...  
VERY SILENTLY ... IT MOVED ALONG THE GOLDEN THREAD ... IT TREMBLED  
FOR A MOMENT ... AND THEN IT CONNECTED ...

AT ONCE, VERMOREL'S WAND BEGAN TO EMIT ECSTASY SCREAMS OF  
PAIN ... THEN VERMOREL'S RED EYES WIDENED WITH SHOCK A  
DENSE, SMOKEY HAND FLEW OUT OF THE TIP OF IT AND VANISHED ... THE  
GHOST OF THE HAND HE HAD MADE WHIRTAIL ... MORE SHOCKS OF  
PAIN ... AND THEN SOMETHING MUCH LARGER BEGAN TO BLOSSOM  
FROM VERMOREL'S WAND TIP, A GREAT, GREYISH SOMETHING THAT  
LOOKED AS THOUGH IT WAS MADE OF THE SILENT, DENSEST SMOKE ...  
IT WAS A HEAD ... THEN A CHEST AND ARMS ... THE THROAT OF CEDRIC  
DIGGORY.

IF EVER HARRY MIGHT HAVE RELEASED HIS WAND FROM SHOCK, IT  
WOULD HAVE BEEN THEN, BUT INSTINCT KEPT HIM CLUTCHING HIS  
WAND TIGHTLY, SEE THAT THE THREAD OF GOLDEN LIGHT REMAINED  
LINKED, EVEN THOUGH THE THICK GREY GHOST OF CEDRIC DIGGORY

SAW HARRY PETER

(WAS IT A GHOST? IT LOOKED SHE SEEMED) EMERGED IN ITS ENTIRETY FROM  
THE END OF VERMOREL'S WAND, AS THOUGH IT WAS SLEEPING ITSELF  
OUT OF A VERY NARROW TUNNEL ... AND THIS SHADE OF CEDRIC STOOD  
UP, AND LOOKED UP AND DOWN THE GOLDEN THREAD OF LIGHT, AND  
SMOKE.

HELD ON, HARRY, IT SAID.

ITS VEHICLE WAS DISTANT AND EERING, HARRY LEANED AT  
VEHEMENT ... HIS WIDE, RED EYES WERE STILL SHOOK ... HE HAD  
NEE MORE EXPECTED THIS THAN HARRY HAD ... AND, VERY DIMLY,  
HARRY HEARD THE FRIGHTENED YELLS OF THE DEATH EATERS, PEEHLING  
AROUND THE EDGES OF THE GOLDEN DEER ...

MORE SCREAMS OF PAIN FROM THE LAND ... AND THEN SOMETHING  
ELSE EMERGED FROM ITS TIP ... THE DENSE SHADOW OF A SECOND  
HEAD, HELICALLY FILLED BY ARMS AND THRESH ... AN OLD MAN HARRY  
HAD ONCE SEEN IN A DREAM WAS NOW POLISHING HIMSELF UNTIL THE  
END OF THE LAND ILST AS CEDRIC HAD DONE ... AND HIS GHOST, HER  
HIS SHADOW, HER WHATEVER IT WAS, FELL NEXT THE CEDRIC S, AND  
SLURVED HARRY AND VEHEMENT, AND THE GOLDEN DEER, AND THE  
CONNECTED HANDS, WITH MILD SURPRISE, LEAVING HIM HIS WALKING  
STICK ...

HE WAS A REAL WIZARD, THEN? THE OLD MAN SAID, HIS EYES ON  
VEHEMENT. KILLED ME, THAT ONE DID ... YELL FIGHT HIM, KID ...  
BUT ALREADY, YET ANOTHER HEAD WAS EMERGING ... AND THIS  
HEAD, GREY AS A SPIDRY STATUE, WAS A WOMAN S ... HARRY, BOTH  
ARMS SHAKING NOW, AS HE FELT THE DEEP HIS WAND STILL, SAW HER  
DREED THE THE GRILING AND STRAIGHTEN UP LIKE THE OTHERS, STARING ...  
THE SHADOW OF BERTHA JERKINS SLURVED THE RATTLE BEHIND HER  
WITH WIDE EYES,

DON'T LET GO, NOW! SHE CRIED, AND HER VEHICLE EERED LIKE  
CEDRIC S, AS THOUGH FROM VERY FAR AWAY. DON'T LET HIM GET YELL,  
HARRY DON'T LET GO!

SHE AND THE OTHER TWO SHADOWY FIGURES BEGAN THE PACE  
AROUND THE INNER WALLS OF THE GOLDEN DEER, WHILE THE DEATH

EATERS FLITTED AROUND THE HELTSIDE OF IT ... AND VERDEMERT'S DEAD  
VICTIMS WHISPERED AS THEY CIRCLED THE BLEEDERS, WHISPERED

PRIMARI INSTANTLY

WORDS OF ENCOURAGEMENT TO HARRY, AND HISSED WORDS HARRY  
COULDN'T HEAR THE VERDEMERT.

AND NOW ANOTHER HEAD WAS EMERGING FROM THE TIP OF  
VERDEMERT'S WAND ... AND HARRY KNEW WHEN HE SAW IT WHAT IT  
WOULD BE ... HE KNEW, AS THOUGH HE HAD EXPECTED IT FROM THE  
MOMENT WHEN CEDRIC HAD APPEARED FROM THE WAND ... KNEW,  
BECAUSE THE WORMAN APPEARING WAS THE ONE HE'D THOUGHT OF  
MORE THAN ANY OTHER THING ...

THE SMOXY SHADE OF A YELING WORMAN WITH LONG HAIR FELL TO  
THE GROUND AS BERTHA HAD DONE, STRAIGHTENED UP, AND LOOKED AT  
HIM ... AND HARRY, HIS ARMS SHAKING MADLY NOW, LOOKED BACK  
INTO THE GHOSTLY FACE OF HIS MOTHER.

YELIA FATHER'S CHIMING ... SHE SAID QUIETLY. HE WANTS TO SEE  
YEL ... IT WILL BE ALL RIGHT ... HOLD ON ...

AND HE CAME ... FIRST HIS HEAD, THEN HIS BODY ... TALL AND  
LONELY-LOOKING LIKE HARRY, THE SMOXY, SHADELY FORM OF JAMES  
PUTTER BLESSED FROM THE END OF VERDEMERT'S WAND, FELL TO THE  
GROUND, AND STRAIGHTENED LIKE HIS WIFE. HE WALKED CLOSE TO  
HARRY, LOOKING DOWN AT HIM, AND HE SPEAKED IN THE SAME DISTANT,  
ECHOING VOICE AS THE OTHERS, BUT QUIETLY, SO THAT VERDEMERT, HIS  
FACE NOW LIVID WITH FEAR AS HIS VICTIMS PRELLED AROUND HIM,  
COULDN'T HEAR ...

WHEN THE CONNECTION IS BROKEN, WE WILL LINGER FOR ONLY

MOMENTS ... BUT WE WILL GIVE YOU TIME ... YOU MUST GET THE THE  
PHOTOPY, IT WILL RETURN YOU TO HOGWARTS ... DID YOU UNDERSTAND,  
HARRY?

YES, HARRY GASPED, FIGHTING NOT TO DROP A HOLD ON HIS  
WAND, WHICH WAS SLIPPING AND SLIDING BENEATH HIS FINGERS.

HARRY ... WHISPERED THE FIGURE OF CEDRIC, TAKE MY BODY  
BACK, WILL YOU? TAKE MY BODY BACK TO MY PARENTS ...

I WILL, SAID HARRY, HIS FACE SCREWED UP WITH THE EFFORT OF  
HOLDING THE WAND.

DID IT NOW, WHISPERED HIS FATHER'S VOICE. BE READY TO RUN ...  
DID IT NOW ...

NOW! HARRY YELLED, HE DIDN'T THINK HE COULD HAVE HELD ON

AND HARRY PULLED

AFTER ANOTHER MOMENT ANYWAY HE PULLED HIS WAND UPWARDS  
WITH AN ALMIGHTY WRENCH, AND THE GREEN THREAD BROKE; THE

LACE OF LIGHT VANISHED, THE PHOENIX SHINE DIED BUT THE SHAD-  
ELOW FIGURES OF VOLDMORT'S VICTIMS DID NOT DISAPPEAR THEY

WERE CLINGING TO VOLDMORT, SHIELDING HARRY FROM HIS  
GAZE

AND HARRY RAN AS HE HAD NEVER RUN IN HIS LIFE, DODGING THE  
STUNNED DEATH EATERS ASIDE AS HE PASSED, HE ZIG-ZAGGED BEHIND  
HEADSTONES, FEELING THEIR CURSES FOLLOWING HIM, HEARING THEM  
HIT THE HEADSTONES HE WAS DODGING CURSES AND GRAVES, PELTING  
TOWARDS CEDRIC'S BODY, NO LONGER AWARE OF THE PAIN IN HIS LEG,

HIS WHOLE BEING CONCENTRATED ON WHAT HE HAD TO DO

STUN HIM! HE HEARD VEHEMENT SCREAM.

TEN FEET FROM CEDRIC, HARRY DIVED BEHIND A MARBLE ANGEL THAT  
AVOID THE IETS OF RED LIGHT AND SAW THE TIP OF ITS WING SHATTER AS  
THE SPELLS HIT IT. GRIPPING HIS WAND MORE TIGHTLY, HE DASHED AWAY  
FROM BEHIND THE ANGEL

IMPEDIMENTA! HE BELLEVED, POINTING HIS WAND WILDLY OVER  
HIS SHOULDER AT THE DEATH EATERS RUNNING AT HIM.

FROM A MUFFLED YELL, HE REALIZED HE HAD STOPPED AT LEAST ONE  
OF THEM, BUT THERE WAS NO TIME TO TURN AND LOOK! HE JUMPED  
OVER THE CLIP AND DIVED AS HE HEARD MORE WAND BLASTS BEHIND  
HIM! MORE IETS OF LIGHT FLEW OVER HIS HEAD AS HE FELL, STRETCHING  
AWAY HIS HAND TO GRAB CEDRIC'S ARM

STAND ASIDE! I WILL KILL HIM! HE IS MINE! SHRIEKED

VEHEMENT.

HARRY'S HAND HAD CLOSED ON CEDRIC'S WRIST! ONE THUNDERING  
STEPPED BETWEEN HIM AND VEHEMENT, BUT CEDRIC WAS TOO HEAVY  
TO CARRY, AND THE CLIP WAS AWAY OF REACH

VEHEMENT'S RED EYES FLAMED IN THE DARKNESS. HARRY SAW HIS  
MOUTH CURVE INTO A SMILE, SAW HIM RAISE HIS WAND.

ACCIE! HARRY YELLED, POINTING HIS WAND AT THE TRINIZARD  
CLIP.

IT FLEW INTO THE AIR, AND SHARED TOWARDS HIM HARRY CAUGHT IT  
BY THE HANDLE

PRIMI INCAUTATEM

HE HEARD VEHEMENT'S SCREAM OF PAIN AT THE SAME MOMENT AS



HE FELT THE IRON BEHIND HIS NAVEL THAT MEANT THE PORTKEY HAD  
WHIRLED IT WAS SPEEDING HIM AWAY IN A WHIRL OF WIND AND  
CHILLER, CEDRIC ALONG WITH HIM ... THEY WERE GOING BACK ...

## CHAPTER THIRTY-FIVE

### VERITASERLIM

HARRY FELT HIMSELF SLAM FLAT INTO THE GRIELING; HIS FACE WAS  
PRESSED INTO GRASS; THE SMELL OF IT FILLED HIS NOSTRILS, HE HAD  
CLOSED HIS EYES WHILE THE PORTKEY TRANSPORTED HIM, AND HE KEPT  
THEM CLOSED NOW, HE DID NOT MOVE. ALL THE BREATH SEEMED TO  
HAVE BEEN DRINKED OUT OF HIM; HIS HEAD WAS SWIMMING SEE  
BADLY HE FELT AS THOUGH THE GRIELING BENEATH HIM WAS SWAYING  
LIKE THE DECK OF A SHIP. HE HELD HIMSELF STEADY, HE TIGHTENED HIS  
HOLD ON THE TWO THINGS HE WAS STILL CLUTCHING THE SMEEETH,  
HOLD HANDLE OF THE TRILIZARD CLIP, AND CEDRIC'S KIDNEY. HE FELT AS  
THOUGH HE WOULD SLIDE AWAY INTO THE BLACKNESS GATHERING AT THE  
EDGES OF HIS BRAIN IF HE LET GO OF EITHER OF THEM. SILENCE AND  
EXHAUSTION KEPT HIM IN THE GRIELING, BREATHING IN THE SMELL OF  
THE GRASS, WAITING ... WAITING FOR SOMETHING TO DO SOMETHING ...  
SOMETHING TO HAPPEN ... AND ALL THE WHILE, HIS STAR BLINDED DULLY  
IN HIS FOREHEAD ...

A THROTTLE OF SOUND DRAINED AND CHOKED HIM, THERE WERE  
VEHICLES EVERYWHERE, WHISTLES, SCREAMS ... HE REMAINED WHERE  
HE WAS, HIS FACE SCREWED UP AGAINST THE NOISE, AS THOUGH IT WAS  
A NIGHTMARE THAT WOULD PASS ...

THEN A PAIR OF HANDS SEIZED HIM REELINGLY AND TURNED HIM  
OVER.

HARRY! HARRY!

HE OPENED HIS EYES.

HE WAS LEERING UP AT THE STARRY SKY, AND ALBUS DUMBLEDORE  
WAS CREELED OVER HIM. THE DARK SHADOWS OF A CROWD OF  
PEOPLE PRESSED IN AROUND THEM, PUSHING NEARER. HARRY FELT THE

VERTIGINOUS SKY

GRINDING BENEATH HIS HEAD REVERBERATING WITH THEIR FOOTSTEPS.  
HE HAD COME BACK TO THE EDGE OF THE MAZE. HE COULD SEE THE  
STANDS RISING AROUND HIM, THE SHAPES OF PEOPLE MOVING IN THEM,  
THE STARS ABOVE.

HARRY LET GO OF THE CLIP, BUT HE CLUTCHED CEDRIC TO HIM EVEN  
MORE TIGHTLY. HE RAISED HIS FREE HAND AND SEIZED DUMBLEDORE'S  
WRIST, WHILE DUMBLEDORE'S FACE SWAM IN AND OUT OF FOCUS.

HE'S BACK, HARRY WHISPERED. HE'S BACK, VILDEMEERT.

WHAT'S GOING ON? WHAT'S HAPPENED?

THE FACE OF CHERNABLOS FLUDGE APPEARED UPSIDE-DOWN OVER

HARRY; IT LEERED WHITE, APPALLED.

MY GOD DIGGER! IT WHISPERED, DUMBLEDORE HE'S DEAD!

THE WORDS WERE REPEATED, THE SHADY FIGURES PRESSING IN  
AND THEM GASPED IT THE THOSE AROUND THEM ... AND THEN OTHERS  
SHOUTED IT SCREAMED IT INTO THE NIGHT HE'S DEAD! HE'S  
DEAD! CEDRIC DIGGER! DEAD!

HARRY, LET GO OF HIM, HE HEARD FLUDGE'S WHISPER, AND HE FELT  
FINGERS TRYING TO PRIZE HIM FROM CEDRIC'S LIMP KNEE, BUT HARRY

WOULDNT LET HIM GO.

THEN DUMBLEDORE'S FACE, WHICH WAS STILL BURNED AND MISTED,  
CAME CLEER. HARRY, YOU CANT HELP HIM NOW. IT'S OVER. LET GO.  
HE WANTED ME TO BRING HIM BACK. HARRY MUTTERED IT  
SEEMED IMPORTANT TO EXPLAIN THIS. HE WANTED ME TO BRING HIM  
BACK TO HIS PARENTS ...

THAT'S RIGHT, HARRY ... JUST LET GO, NOW ...

DUMBLEDORE BENT DOWN AND, WITH EXTRAORDINARY STRENGTH FOR  
A MAN SO OLD AND THIN, RAISED HARRY FROM THE GROUND, AND SET  
HIM ON HIS FEET. HARRY SWAYED. HIS HEAD WAS POUNDING. HIS  
INJURED LEG WOULD NO LONGER SUPPORT HIS WEIGHT. THE GROUND  
AROUND THEM TREMBLED, FIGHTING THE GET CLEER, PRESSING HARDLY IN  
ON HIM. WHAT'S HAPPENED? WHAT'S WRONG WITH HIM?

DIGGORY'S DEAD?

HE'LL NEED TO GO TO THE HOSPITAL WING! FLUKE WAS SAYING  
LOUDLY. HE'S ILL, HE'S INJURED. DUMBLEDORE, DIGGORY'S PARENTS,  
THEY'RE HERE, THEY'RE IN THE STANDS ...

SAW HARRY MUTTER

I'LL TAKE HARRY, DUMBLEDORE, I'LL TAKE HIM

NO, I WOULD PREFER

DUMBLEDORE, AMES DIGGORY'S RUNNING ... HE'S CHIMING NEVER  
... DONT YOU THINK YOU SHOULD TELL HIM BEFORE HE SEES ?  
HARRY, STAY HERE

GIRLS WERE SCREAMING, SHAKING HYSTERICALLY ... THE SCENE  
FLICKERED HOBBY BEFORE HARRY'S EYES ...

IT'S ALL RIGHT, THEN, I'VE GOT YOU ... COME ON ... HOSPITAL

WINE ...

OLMLEDHRE SAID STAY, SAID F-HARRY THICKLY, THE PHLINDING IN  
HIS STAR MAKING HIM FEEL AS THOUGH HE WAS ABLE TO THE THREE LIP;  
HIS VISION WAS BLURRING WORSE THAN EVER.

THEY NEED THE LIP DOWN ... COME ON, NOW ...

SOMEONE LARGER AND STRONGER THAN F-HARRY WAS, WAS HALF  
PULLING, HALF CARRYING HIM THROUGH THE FRIGHTENED CREW; F-HARRY

HEARD THEM GASPING, SCREAMING AND SCREAMING AS THE MAN SLIP-  
PERING HIM PUSHED A PATH THROUGH THEM, TAKING HIM BACK THE

THE CASTLE, ACROSS THE LAWN, PAST THE LAKE AND THE OLDMSTRANG  
SHIP; F-HARRY HEARD NOTHING BUT THE HEAVY BREATHING OF THE MAN  
HELPING HIM WALK.

WHAT HAPPENED, F-HARRY? THE MAN ASKED AT LAST, AS HE LIFTED  
F-HARRY UP THE STONE STEPS, CLUNK, CLUNK, CLUNK, IT WAS MAD-LY  
MERRY.

CLIP WAS A PHEW, SAID F-HARRY, AS THEY CROSSED THE ENTRANCE  
HALL. THEN HE AND CEDRIC THE A GRAVEYARD ... AND WILDERMINT  
WAS THERE ... LORD WILDERMINT ...

CLUNK, CLUNK, CLUNK, UP THE MARBLE STAIRS ...

THE DARK LORD WAS THERE? WHAT HAPPENED THEN?

KILLED CEDRIC ... THEY KILLED CEDRIC ...

AND THEN?

CLUNK, CLUNK, CLUNK, ALONG THE CORRIDOR ...

MADE A PHEW ... GET HIS BODY BACK ...

THE DARK LORD GET HIS BODY BACK? HE'S RETURNED?

AND THE DEATH EATERS CAME ... AND THEN WE DUELLED ...

WE DUELLED WITH THE DARK LORD?

VERITASERUM WAS

GONE AWAY ... MY WAND ... DID SOMETHING FUNNY ... I SAW MY

MUM AND DAD ... THEY CAME HEFT UP HIS WAND ...

IN HERE, FARRY ... IN HERE, AND SIT DOWN ... WE'LL BE ALL RIGHT

NEED ... DRINK THIS ...

FARRY HEARD A DEEP SCRAPE IN A BENCH, AND FELT A CLIP BEING

PLUSHED INTO HIS HANDS.

DRINK IT ... WE'LL BE FEEL BETTER ... COME HEN NEED, FARRY, I NEED

THE DRINK EXACTLY WHAT HAPPENED ...

MURDER HELPED TIP THE STUFF DOWN FARRY'S THROAT; HE CHOKED,

A PEPPERY TASTE BURNING HIS THROAT. MURDER'S EFFICE CAME INTO

SHARPER FOCUS, AND SHE DID MURDER HIMSELF ... HE BLEEHED AS WHITE

AS FLICE, AND BOTH EYES WERE FIXED UNBLINKINGLY UPON FARRY'S

FACE.

VERITASERUM'S BACK, FARRY? WE'LL BE SURE HE'S BACK? FARRY DID HE

DIE IT?

HE THREW STUFF FROM HIS FATHER'S GRAVE, AND FROM WHIRTAIL,

AND ME, SAID FARRY, HIS HEAD FELT CLEARER; HIS SCAR WASN'T BURNING

SO BADLY; HE COULD NEED SEE MURDER'S FACE DISTINCTLY, EVEN

THOUGH THE EFFICE WAS DARK, HE COULD STILL HEAR SCREAMING AND

SHOUTING FROM THE DISTANT HOLLOWITCH PITCH.

WHAT DID THE DARK LORD TAKE FROM WE'LL? SAID MURDER.

BLEED, SAID HARRY, RAISING HIS ARM, HIS SLEEVE WAS RIPPED  
WHERE WHIRTAIL'S DAGGER HAD THORN IT.

MURDER LET OUT HIS BREATH IN A LONG, LOW HISS. AND THE DEATH  
LATER? THEY RETURNED?

YES, SAID HARRY, LEADS UP THEM ...

HOW DID HE TREAT THEM? MURDER ASKED QUIETLY, DID HE FOR-  
GIVE THEM?

BUT HARRY HAD SUDDENLY REMEMBERED, HE SHOULD HAVE TOLD  
DUMBLEDORE, HE SHOULD HAVE SAID IT STRAIGHT AWAY. THERE'S A  
DEATH LATER AT HOGWARTS? THERE'S A DEATH LATER HERE. THEY PUT  
MY NAME IN THE CHURCH OF FIRE, THEY MADE SURE I GOT THROUGH THE  
THE END

HARRY TRIED TO GET UP, BUT MURDER PUSHED HIM BACK DOWN.

I KNOW WHEN THE DEATH LATER IS, HE SAID QUIETLY.

SAID HARRY PETER

CRACKLE? SAID HARRY WILDLY, WHERE IS HE? HAVE YOU GOT  
HIM? IS HE WOKED UP?

CRACKLE? SAID MURDER WITH AN EDD LAUGH. CRACKLE? FLED  
THAT NIGHT, WHEN HE FELT THE DARK MARK BEGIN LITEN HIS ARM, HE  
RETRAYED THE MANY FAITHFUL SLIPWORTERS OF THE DARK LORD THE WISH  
THE MEET THEM ... BUT I BELIEVE HE WILL GET FAR, THE DARK LORD HAS  
WAYS OF TRACKING HIS ENEMIES.

CRACKLE? & GENE? HE RAN AWAY? BUT THEN HE DIDN'T PUT MY  
NAME IN THE CLIP?

NHE, SAID MEEHDO SLEELLY, NHE, HE DIDN T, IT WAS I WHEH DID  
THAT,

HARRY HEARD, BUT DIDN T BELIEVE,

NHE, YELL DIDN T, HE SAID, YELL DIDN T SEE THAT ... YELL CAN T  
HAVE BEEN ...

I ASSURE YELL I DID, SAID MEEHDO, AND HIS MAGICAL EYE SWUNG

AROUND, AND FIXED UPON THE DEER, AND HARRY KNEW HE WAS MAK-  
ING SURE THAT THERE WAS NO ONE OUTSIDE IT. AT THE SAME TIME,

MEEHDO DREW OUT HIS WAND, AND POINTED IT AT HARRY,

HE FORGAVE THEM, THEN? HE SAID, THE DEATH EATERS WHEH  
WENT FREE? THE HENS WHEH ESCAPED AZKABAN?

WHAT? SAID HARRY,

HE WAS LOOKING AT THE WAND MEEHDO WAS POINTING AT HIM,

THIS WAS A BAD IDEA, IT HAD THE EE,

I ASKED YELL, SAID MEEHDO QUIETLY, WHETHER HE FORGAVE THE  
SLIM WHEH NEVER EVEN WENT THE LENGTH FOR HIM, THESE TREACHERS

CHILDS WHEH WOULDN T EVEN BRAVE AZKABAN FOR HIM, THE FAITH-  
LESS, WHOLESOME KITS OF FILTH WHEH WERE BRAVE ENOUGH THE CAVEAT IN

MASKS AT THE ELIDITCH WARD CLIP, BUT FLED AT THE SIGHT OF THE  
DARK MARK WHEN I FIRED IT INTO THE SKY,

YELL FIRED ... WHAT ARE YELL TALKING ABOUT ...?

I TOLD YELL, HARRY ... I TOLD YELL, IF THERE S ONE THING I HATE  
MORE THAN ANY OTHER, IT S A DEATH EATER WHEH WALKED FREE, THEY

TURNED THEIR BACKS ON MY MASTER, WHEN HE NEEDED THEM MOST.  
I EXPECTED HIM TO PUNISH THEM, I EXPECTED HIM TO THREATEN  
THEM, TELL ME HE FLIRTED THEM, HARRY ... MERRY'S FACE WAS SLID-

VERTICALLY

DEADLY LIT WITH AN INSANE SMILE. TELL ME HE TOLD THEM THAT I, I  
ALONE REMAINED FAITHFUL ... PREPARED TO RISK EVERYTHING TO DELIVER  
THEM FROM THE ONE THING HE WANTED ABOVE ALL ... YELL.

YELL DIDN'T ... IT ... IT CAN'T BE YELL ...

WHEN I PUT YELL'S NAME IN THE CHALK OF FIRE, UNDER THE NAME  
OF A DIFFERENT SCHOOL? I DID, WHEN I FRIGHTENED EVERY PERSON I  
THOUGHT MIGHT TRY TO FLIRT WITH HER TO PREVENT YELL WINNING THE  
TOURNAMENT? I DID, WHEN I DROVE HAGRID INTO THE SMOULDERING YELL THE  
DRAGONS? I DID, WHEN I HELPED YELL SEE THE ONLY WAY YELL COULD  
BEAT THE DRAGON? I DID.

MERRY'S MAGICAL EYE HAD BEEN LEFT THERE, IT WAS FIXED  
UPON HARRY, HIS LEFT-EYED MOUTH BEAMED WIDER THAN EVER.

IT HADN'T BEEN EASY, HARRY, GUIDING YELL THROUGH THESE TASKS  
WITHOUT AROUSING SUSPICION. I HAVE HAD THE LIE EVERY SINCE OF  
CLIPPING I POSSESS, SEE THAT MY HAND WOULD NOT BE DETECTABLE IN  
YELL'S SUCCESS, SOMEWHERE WOULD HAVE BEEN VERY SUSPICIOUS IF  
YELL HAD MANAGED EVERYTHING TOO EASILY, AS LONG AS YELL GOT INTO  
THAT MAZE, PREFERABLY WITH A DECENT HEAD START ... THEN, I KNEW, I  
WOULD HAVE A CHANCE OF GETTING RID OF THE OTHER CHAMPIONS,  
AND LEAVING YELL'S WAY CLEAR, BUT I ALSO HAD TO CONTENT AGAINST  
YELL'S STUPIDITY, THE SECOND TASK ... THAT WAS WHEN I WAS MOST  
AFRAID WE WOULD FAIL, I WAS KEEPING WATCH ON YELL, BETTER, I



KNOW YELL HADN'T WHIPPED UP THE EGGS YET, SHE I HAD TO GIVE  
YELL ANOTHER HINT

YELL DIDN'T, HARRY SAID HIMSELF. CEDRIC GAVE ME THE CLUE  
WHEN TOLD CEDRIC THE OPEN IT UNDERWATER? I DID, I TRUSTED  
THAT HE WOULD PASS THE INFORMATION ON TO YELL. DECENT PEOPLE  
AREN'T EASY TO MANIPULATE, BETTER, I WAS SURE CEDRIC WOULD  
WANT THE REWARD YELL FOR TELLING HIM ABOUT THE DRAGONS, AND SHE HE  
DID, BUT EVEN THEN, BETTER, EVEN THEN YELL SEEMED LIKELY TO FAIL.  
I WAS WATCHING ALL THE TIME ... ALL THESE FEELERS IN THE LIBRARY,

DIDN'T YELL REALISE THAT THE KIND YELL NEEDED WAS IN YELL'S DERM-  
MISTRY ALL ALONG? I PLANTED IT THERE EARLY ON, I GAVE IT THE THE

LONGEST THEM END, DIDN'T YELL REMEMBER? MAGICAL MEDITERRANEAN  
WATER-PLANTS AND THEIR PROPERTIES. IT WOULD HAVE TOLD YELL ALL

~~XXX~~ HARRY BETTER

YELL NEEDED ABOUT GILLYWEED, I EXPECTED YELL TO ASK EVERYONE  
AND ANYONE YELL COULD FOR HELP, LONGEST THEM WOULD HAVE TOLD  
YELL IN AN INSTANT, BUT YELL DID NOT ... YELL DID NOT ... YELL HAVE A  
STREAK OF PRIDE AND INDEPENDENCE THAT MIGHT HAVE RUINED ALL.

SHE WHAT COULD I DO? FEED YELL INFORMATION FROM ANOTHER  
INNOCENT SOURCE. YELL TOLD ME AT THE YULE BALL A FEELER-Elf CALLED  
DEERY HAD GIVEN YELL A CHRISTMAS PRESENT. I CALLED THE Elf THE  
THE STAFF ROOM TO COLLECT SOME BOOKS FOR CLEANING. I STAGED A  
HELD CONVERSATION WITH PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL ABOUT THE  
HESITATIONS SHE HAD BEEN TAKEN, AND WHETHER BETTER WOULD THINK

THE LIKE GILLYWEED, AND YELLER LITTLE ELF FRIEND RAN STRAIGHT THE  
SNARE'S STERE-CLIPBOARD AND FLURRIED THE FIND YELL ...

MEEHBY'S HAND WAS STILL POINTING DIRECTLY AT HARRY'S HEART,  
EVER HIS S-SHILDER, FEGGY SHAPES WERE MOVING IN THE FEE-GLASS  
HIN THE WALL. YELL WERE SEE BEING IN THAT LARK, PETER, I THOUGHT  
YELL HAD DREAMED, BUT QUICKLY, DUMKLEDHIRE THOUGHT YELLER IDIOT  
FOR NEKILITY, AND MARKED YELL HIGH FOR IT. I BREATHE AGAIN.

YELL HAD AN EASIER TIME OF IT THAN YELL SHOULD HAVE BEEN IN  
THAT MAZE TONIGHT, OF COURSE, SAID MEEHBY. THAT WAS BECAUSE I  
WAS PATROLLING AROUND IT, ABLE TO SEE THROUGH THE HILTER HEDGES,  
ABLE TO CLIMB MANY OBSTACLES OUT OF YELLER WAY. I STUNNED FELLER  
DELAHELIR AS SHE PASSED, I PUT THE IMPERILIS CLIMB HIN DREAM, SEE  
THAT HE WOULD FINISH DIGGING, AND LEAVE YELLER PATH THE THE CLIP  
CLEAR.

HARRY STARED AT MEEHBY, HE JUST DIDN'T SEE HOW THIS CHILD BE  
... DUMKLEDHIRE'S FRIEND, THE FAMELIS ALRIGHT ... THE HIN WE-HAD  
CALIGHT SEE MANY DEATH-LATERS ... IT MADE NO SENSE ... NO SENSE  
AT ALL ...

THE FEGGY SHAPES IN THE FEE-GLASS WERE SHARPENING, HAD  
BECOME MORE DISTINCT, HARRY COULD SEE THE OUTLINES OF THREE  
PEOPLE EVER MEEHBY'S S-SHILDER, MOVING CLOSER AND CLOSER, BUT  
MEEHBY WASN'T WATCHING THEM. HIS MAGICAL EYE WAS UPON HARRY.

THE DARK LORD DIDN'T MANAGE TO KILL YELL, PETER, AND HE SEE  
WANTED THE, WHISPERED MEEHBY, IMAGINE HOW HE WILL REWARD ME,  
WHEN HE FINDS I HAVE DONE IT FOR HIM, I GAVE YELL THE HIM THE

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THING HE NEEDED ABOVE ALL THE REGENERATE AND THEN I KILLED YELL  
FOR HIM, I WILL BE HUNDREDS TIMES ALL OTHER DEATH EATERS, I  
WILL BE HIS DEAREST, HIS CLOSEST SLIPPERER ... CLOSER THAN A  
SHEN ...

MENDO'S NORMAL EYE WAS BLINKING, THE MAGICAL EYE FIXED UPON  
HARRY. THE DEER WAS BARRED, AND HARRY KNEW HE WOULD NEVER  
REACH HIS OWN HAND IN TIME ...

THE DARK LORD AND I, SAID MENDO, AND HE SMILED COMPLETE-  
LY INSANE NOW, TELLING ME HARRY, LEERING DOWN AT HIM, HAVE

MUCH IN COMMON, BOTH OF US, FOR INSTANCE, HAVE VERY DISAP-  
POINTING FATHERS ... VERY DISAPPOINTING INDEED, BOTH OF US

SLIPPED THE INDIGNITY, HARRY, OF BEING NAMED AFTER THESE  
FATHERS, AND BOTH OF US HAD THE PLEASURE ... THE VERY GREAT  
PLEASURE ... OF KILLING OUR FATHERS, THE ENSURE THE CONTINUED RISE  
OF THE DARK LORD!

YOU'RE MAD, HARRY SAID HE COULDN'T STOP HIMSELF YOU'RE  
MAD!

MAD, AM I? SAID MENDO, HIS VOICE RISING UNCONTROLLABLY,  
WE'LL SEE! WE'LL SEE WHO'S MAD, NOW THAT THE DARK LORD HAS  
RETURNED, WITH ME AT HIS SIDE! HE IS BACK, HARRY BETTER, YOU DID  
NOT CHALLENGE HIM AND NOW I CHALLENGE YOU!

MENDO RAISED HIS HAND, HE OPENED HIS MOUTH, HARRY  
PLUNGED HIS OWN HAND INTO HIS REEKS

SLIPPER! THERE WAS A BLINDING FLASH OF RED LIGHT, AND WITH A

GREAT SPLINTERING AND CRASHING, THE DOOR OF MURDER'S OFFICE WAS  
BLASTED APART

MURDER WAS THROWN BACKWARDS INTO THE OFFICE FLOOR, HARRY,  
STILL STARING AT THE PLACE WHERE MURDER'S FACE HAD BEEN, SAW  
ALBUS DUMBLEDORE, PROFESSOR Snape AND PROFESSOR McGONAGALL  
LEEDING BACK AT HIM OUT OF THE PEER-GLASS, HE LEANED AROUND,  
AND SAW THE THREE OF THEM STANDING IN THE HALLWAY,  
DUMBLEDORE IN FRONT, HIS HAND OUTSTRETCHED,

AT THAT MOMENT, HARRY FULLY UNDERSTOOD FOR THE FIRST TIME  
WHY PEOPLE SAID DUMBLEDORE WAS THE ONLY WIZARD WHOSEMENT  
HAD EVER FEARED, THE LEANED UPON DUMBLEDORE'S FACE AS HE STARED

SAW HARRY BETTER

DOWN AT THE LINCOLNSHIRE ARM OF MAD-LY MURDER WAS MORE  
TERRIBLE THAN HARRY COULD EVER HAVE IMAGINED, THERE WAS NO  
BENIGN SMILE UPON DUMBLEDORE'S FACE, NO TWINKLE IN THE EYES  
BEHIND THE SPECTACLES, THERE WAS COLD FIRE IN EVERY LINE OF THE  
ANCIENT FACE; A SENSE OF POWER RADIATED FROM DUMBLEDORE AS  
THOUGH HE WAS GIVING OFF BURNING HEAT,

HE STEPPED INTO THE OFFICE, PLACED A FOOT UNDERNEATH MURDER'S  
LINCOLNSHIRE BODY AND KICKED HIM OVER INTO HIS BACK, SEE THAT

HIS FACE WAS VISIBLE, Snape FOLLOWED HIM, LEEDING INTO THE PEER-  
GLASS, WHERE HIS OWN FACE WAS STILL VISIBLE, GLARING INTO THE

ROOM,

PROFESSOR McGONAGALL WENT STRAIGHT TO HARRY,

COME ALONG, BETTER, SHE WHISPERED, THE THIN LINE OF HER MOUTH WAS TWITCHING AS THOUGH SHE WAS ABLE TO SEE THE CRY, COME ALONG ... HOSPITAL WING ...

NO, SAID DUMBLEDORE SHARPLY,

DUMBLEDORE, HE HIGHLIGHT THE LOOK AT HIM HE'S BEEN THROUGH ENOUGH TONIGHT

HE WILL STAY, MINERVA, BECAUSE HE NEEDS THE UNDERSTAND, SAID

DUMBLEDORE CLUTLY, UNDERSTANDING IS THE FIRST STEP THE ACCEPTANCE, AND ONLY WITH ACCEPTANCE CAN THERE BE RECOVERY, HE

NEEDS THE KNOWLEDGE THAT HAS PUT HIM THROUGH THE HORROR HE HAS SURVIVED TONIGHT, AND WHY.

MURDER, HARRY SAID, HE WAS STILL IN A STATE OF COMPLETE DISBELIEF, HOW CAN IT HAVE BEEN MURDER?

THIS IS NOT ALASTAIR MURDER, SAID DUMBLEDORE QUIETLY, YOU HAVE NEVER KNOWN ALASTAIR MURDER, THE REAL MURDER WOULD NOT HAVE REMOVED YOU FROM MY SIGHT AFTER WHAT HAPPENED TONIGHT, THE MOMENT HE TOOK YOU, I KNEW AND I FOLLOWED, DUMBLEDORE BENT DOWN OVER MURDER'S LIMP ARM AND PUT A HAND INSIDE HIS REEKS, HE PULLED OUT MURDER'S HIP-FLASK, AND A SET OF KEYS ON A RING, THEN HE TURNED THE PROFESSOR MCKENZIE AND SNAPE,

SEVERUS, PLEASE FETCH ME THE STRONGEST TRUTH TELLING YOU POSSESS, AND THEN GO DOWN THE THE KITCHENS, AND BRING UP THE

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HOUSE-ELF CALLED LINDY, MINERVA, KINDLY GET DOWN THE FLAGRANT S  
HOUSE, WHERE THEY WILL FIND A LARGE BLACK DEE SITTING IN THE  
PUMPKIN PATCH. TAKE THE DEE UP TO MY OFFICE, TELL HIM I WILL BE  
WITH HIM SHORTLY, THEN COME BACK HERE.

IF EITHER SNAPE OR MCGONAGALL FEELING THESE INSTRUCTIONS  
PECULIAR, THEY HAD THEIR CONCLUSIONS. BOTH TURNED AT ONCE, AND LEFT  
THE OFFICE. DUMBLEDORE WALKED OVER TO THE TRUNK WITH SEVEN

LOCKS, FITTED THE FIRST KEY IN THE LOCK, AND OPENED IT. IT CON-  
TAINED A MASS OF SPELLBOOKS. DUMBLEDORE CLOSED THE TRUNK,

PLACED A SECOND KEY IN THE SECOND LOCK, AND OPENED THE TRUNK  
AGAIN. THE SPELLBOOKS HAD VANISHED; THIS TIME IT CONTAINED AN  
ASSORTMENT OF BROKEN SNEAKSHOES, SOME PARCHMENT AND  
ROLLS, AND WHAT LOOKED LIKE A SILVER INVISIBILITY CLOAK. HARRY  
WATCHED, ASTHONISHED, AS DUMBLEDORE PLACED THE THIRD, FOURTH,  
FIFTH AND SIXTH KEYS IN THEIR RESPECTIVE LOCKS, REOPENING THE  
TRUNK, AND EACH TIME REVEALING DIFFERENT CONTENTS. THEN HE  
PLACED THE SEVENTH KEY IN THE LOCK, THREW OPEN THE LID, AND  
HARRY LET OUT A CRY OF AMAZEMENT.

HE WAS LOOKING DOWN INTO A KIND OF PIT, AN UNDERGROUND  
ROOM, AND LYING ON THE FLOOR SOME TEN FEET BELOW, APPARENTLY

FAST ASLEEP, THIN AND STARVED IN APPEARANCE, WAS THE REAL MAD-  
DOR MELODY. HIS WOODEN LEG WAS GONE, THE SECRET WHICH SHOULD

HAVE HAD THE MAGICAL EYE BLENDED EMPTY BENEATH ITS LID, AND  
CLINGS OF HIS GRIZZLED HAIR WERE MISSING. HARRY STARED,  
THUNDERSTRIKEN, BETWEEN THE SLEEPING MURDERER IN THE TRUNK, AND  
THE LINGERING MURDERER LYING IN THE FLOOR OF THE OFFICE.  
BLUMBERG CLIMBED INTO THE TRUNK, BEHEADED HIMSELF AND  
FELL LIGHTLY BENTH THE FLOOR BESIDE THE SLEEPING MURDERER. HE KNEW  
NEVER HIM.

STUNNED CONTROLLED BY THE IMPERIAL CLASP VERY WEAK, HE  
SAID. HE BELIEVED, THEY WOULD HAVE NEEDED TO KEEP HIM ALIVE.  
HARRY, THREW DOWN THE IMPERIAL S CLASP, ALASTAIR IS FREEZING.  
MADAM PETERSON WILL NEED TO SEE HIM, BUT HE SEEMS IN NO  
IMMEDIATE DANGER.

HARRY DID AS HE WAS TOLD; BLUMBERG COVERED MURDERER IN THE

SEE HARRY PETERSON

CLASP, THREW IT AROUND HIM, AND CLAMBERED OUT OF THE TRUNK  
AGAIN. THEN HE PICKED UP THE HIP-FLASK THAT STOOD UPON THE  
DESK, UNSCREWED IT, AND TURNED IT OVER. A THICK GLUTINIOUS LIQUID  
SPATTERED BENTH THE OFFICE FLOOR.

PETERSON PETERSON, HARRY, SAID BLUMBERG. YOU SEE THE SIM-  
PLICITY OF IT, AND THE BRILLIANCE. FOR MURDERER NEVER DRINKS

EXCEPT FROM HIS HIP-FLASK, HE IS WELL KNOWN FOR IT. THE IMPERIAL  
NEEDED, HE BELIEVED, TO KEEP THE REAL MURDERER CLOSE BY, SO THAT HE  
WOULD CONTINUE MAKING THE PETERSON. YOU SEE HIS HAIR ...

DUMBLEDORE LEANED DOWN IN THE MOMENT IN THE TRIANGLE. THE IMPERATOR HAS BEEN CUTTING IT OFF ALL YEAR, SEE WHERE IT IS LINKED? BUT I THINK, IN THE EXCITEMENT OF TONIGHT, HIS FACE MOMENT MIGHT HAVE FORGOTTEN THE TASK IT AS FREQUENTLY AS HE SHOULD HAVE DONE ... IN THE FIGHT ... EVERY FIGHT ... WE SHALL SEE.

DUMBLEDORE PULLED UP THE CHAIR AT THE DESK AND SAT DOWN UPON IT, HIS EYES FIXED UPON THE LINGERING MOMENT IN THE FIGHT. HARRY STARED AT HIM, THE MINUTES PASSED IN SILENCE ... THEN, BEFORE HARRY'S VERY EYES, THE FACE OF THE MAN IN THE FIGHT BEGAN THE CHANGE. THE STARS WERE DISAPPEARING, THE SKIN WAS BECOMING SMOOTH; THE MANGLED NECK BECAME WHOLE, AND STARTED THE SHRINK. THE LONG MAN OF GRIZZLED GREY HAIR WAS WITHDRAWING INTO THE SCALP, AND TURNING THE CHELIER OF STRAW.

SLUDDENLY, WITH A LUDIC CLUNK, THE WHOLEEN LEG FELL AWAY AS A NORMAL LEG RECOVERED IN ITS PLACE; NEXT MOMENT, THE MAGICAL OVERALL

HAD POPEPED UP ON THE MAN'S FACE AS A REAL EYE REPLACED IT; IT ROLLED AWAY ACROSS THE FIGHT AND CONTINUED THE SWIVEL IN EVERY DIRECTION.

HARRY SAW A MAN LYING BEFORE HIM, PALE-SKINNED, SLIGHTLY FRECKLED, WITH A MOP OF FAIR HAIR. HE KNEW WHO HE WAS. HE HAD SEEN HIM IN DUMBLEDORE'S PENSIVE, HAD WATCHED HIM BEING LED AWAY FROM CHURCH BY THE DEMENTORS, TRYING TO CONVINCE MR CRUELICH THAT HE WAS INNOCENT ... BUT HE WAS LINED AROUND THE EYES NOW, AND LEANED MUCH HIGHER ...



THERE WERE FLURRIED FEETSTEPS HITSIDE IN THE CORRIDOR. SNAPE

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HAD RETURNED WITH WINDY AT HIS HEELS. PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL  
WAS RIGHT BEHIND THEM.

[RELICH? SNAPE SAID, STEPPING DEAD IN THE DOORWAY. KARTY  
[RELICH?

GOOD HEAVENS, SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL, STEPPING DEAD  
AND STARING DOWN AT THE MAN IN THE FLOOR.

FILTHY, DISHEVELLED, WINDY PEERED AROUND SNAPE'S LEGS. HER  
MOUTH OPENED WIDE AND SHE LET OUT A PIERCING SCREECH. MASTER  
KARTY, MASTER KARTY, WHAT IS YELLING HERE?

SHE FELLING HERSELF FORWARDS BENTH THE YELLING MAN'S CHEST. YELL  
IS KILLED HIM? YELL IS KILLED HIM? YELL IS KILLED MASTER'S SHEN?

HE IS SIMPLY STUNNED, WINDY, SAID DUMBLEDORE. STEP ASIDE,  
PLEASE. SEVERUS, YELL HAVE THE POTION?

SNAPE HANDED DUMBLEDORE A SMALL GLASS BOTTLE OF COMPLETELY  
CLEAR LIQUID; THE VERITASERUM WITH WHICH HE HAD THREATENED  
HARRY IN CLASS. DUMBLEDORE GOT UP, KENT OVER THE MAN IN THE  
FLOOR, AND PULLED HIM INTO A SITTING POSITION AGAINST THE WALL  
BENEATH THE PIR-GLASS, IN WHICH THE REFLECTIONS OF  
DUMBLEDORE, SNAPE AND MCGONAGALL WERE STILL GLARING DOWN  
UPON THEM ALL. WINDY REMAINED IN HER KNEES, TREMBLING, HER  
HANDS OVER HER FACE. DUMBLEDORE FORCED THE MAN'S MOUTH  
OPEN, AND PULLED THREE DROPS INSIDE IT. THEN HE POINTED HIS  
WAND AT THE MAN'S CHEST, AND SAID, REVIVATE.

[RELICH'S SHEN OPENED HIS EYES. HIS FACE WAS SHADY, HIS GAZE

UNOBLISHED, OLIMPEDEHRE KNELT BEFORE HIM, SEE THAT THEIR FACES WERE LEVEL.

CAN YOU HEAR ME? OLIMPEDEHRE ASKED QUIETLY.

THE MAN'S EYELIDS FLICKERED.

YES, HE MUTTERED.

I WOULD LIKE YOU TO TELL US, SAID OLIMPEDEHRE SHORTLY, WHEN YOU CAME TO BE HERE, DID YOU ESCAPE FROM AZDARAK? CRULICH TOOK A DEEP, SHUDDERING BREATH, THEN BEGAN TO SPEAK IN A FLAT, EXPRESSIONLESS VOICE. MY MOTHER SAVED ME. SHE KNEW SHE WAS DYING. SHE PERSUADED MY FATHER TO RESCUE ME AS A LAST FAVOR TO HER. HE LOVED HER AS HE HAD NEVER LOVED ME. HE

SAW HARRY PETER

AGREED. THEY CAME TO VISIT ME. THEY GAVE ME A DRALIGHT OF PHYLIC POTION, CONTAINING HEN OF MY MOTHER'S HAIRS. SHE TOOK A DRALIGHT OF PHYLIC POTION, CONTAINING HEN OF MY HAIRS. WE TOOK HEN EACH OTHER'S APPEARANCE.

WINDY WAS SHAKING HER HEAD, TREMBLING. SAY NEE MORE, MASTER BARTY, SAY NEE MORE, YOU IS GETTING YOUR FATHER INTO TROUBLE?

BUT CRULICH TOOK ANOTHER DEEP BREATH, AND CONTINUED IN THE SAME FLAT VOICE. THE DEMONTERS ARE BLIND. THEY SENSED HEN HEALTHY, HEN DYING PERSON ENTERING AZDARAK. THEY SENSED HEN HEALTHY, HEN DYING PERSON LEAVING IT. MY FATHER SMUGGLED ME

OUT, DISGUISED AS MY MOTHER, IN CASE ANY PRISONERS WERE WATCHING THROUGH THEIR DEERS.

MY MOTHER DIED A SHORT WHILE AFTERWARDS IN AZDARAN. SHE WAS CAREFUL THE DRINK BEHAVIOUR UNTIL THE END. SHE WAS BURIED UNDER MY NAME, AND BEARING MY APPEARANCE. EVERYONE BELIEVED HER TO BE ME.

THE MAN'S EYELIDS FLICKERED.

AND WHAT DID YOUR FATHER DO WITH YOU, WHEN HE HAD GOTTEN HOME? SAID DUMKEDDRE QUIETLY.

STAGED MY MOTHER'S DEATH. A QUIET, PRIVATE FUNERAL. THAT GRAVE IS EMPTY. THE HOUSE-ELF NURSED ME BACK TO HEALTH. THEN I HAD TO BE CONCEALED, I HAD TO BE CONTROLLED. MY FATHER HAD TO USE A NUMBER OF SPELLS TO SILENCE ME. WHEN I HAD RECOVERED

MY STRENGTH, I THOUGHT ONLY OF FINDING MY MASTER ... OF RETURNING TO HIS SERVICE.

HOW DID YOUR FATHER SILENCE YOU? SAID DUMKEDDRE.

THE IMPERIALS CURSE, CREELICH SAID. I WAS UNDER MY FATHER'S CONTROL. I WAS FORCED TO WEAR AN INVISIBILITY CHARM DAY AND NIGHT. I WAS ALWAYS WITH THE HOUSE-ELF. SHE WAS MY KEEPER AND

CAREER. SHE PITIED ME. SHE PERSUADED MY FATHER TO GIVE ME OCCASIONAL TREATS, REWARDS FOR MY GOOD BEHAVIOUR.

MASTER BARTY, MASTER BARTY, SHOOK WINOY THROUGH HER HANDS. YOU DON'T WANT TO TELL THEM, WE ARE GETTING IN TROUBLE ... DID ANYBODY EVER DISCOVER THAT YOU WERE STILL ALIVE? SAID

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DUMPLEDURE SEFTLY, DID ANYONE KNOW EXCEPT YOUR FATHER, AND THE FEEUSE-ELF?

YES, SAID CRUELICH, HIS EYELIDS FLICKERING AGAIN. A WITCH IN MY FATHER'S OFFICE, BERTHA JERKINS. SHE CAME TO THE FEEUSE, WITH PAPERS FOR MY FATHER'S SIGNATURE. HE WAS NOT AT HOME. WINDY SHOWED HER INSIDE AND RETURNED TO THE KITCHEN, TO MR. BLIT

BERTHA JERKINS HEARD WINDY TALKING TO MR. SHE CAME TO INVESTIGATE. SHE HEARD ENOUGH TO GUESS WHAT WAS HIDING UNDER THE

INVISIBILITY CLOAK. MY FATHER ARRIVED HOME. SHE CONFRONTED HIM. HE PUT A VERY POWERFUL MEMORY CHARM ON HER TO MAKE

HER FORGET WHAT SHE'D FOUND OUT. THE POWERFUL, HE SAID IT DAMAGED HER MEMORY PERMANENTLY.

WHY IS SHE CHEERING THE NEWS IN MY MASTER'S PRIVATE BUSINESS? ASKED WINDY. WHY ISN'T SHE LEAVING US BY?

TELL ME ABOUT THE FLIDDITCH WARD CUP, SAID DUMPLEDURE. WINDY TALKED MY FATHER INTO IT, SAID CRUELICH, STILL IN THE SAME MINDSET. SHE SPENT MONTHS PERSUADING HIM. I HAD NOT LEFT THE FEEUSE FOR YEARS. I HAD LOVED FLIDDITCH. LET HIM GO, SHE SAID. HE WILL BE IN HIS INVISIBILITY CLOAK. HE CAN WATCH. LET HIM SMELL FRESH AIR FOR ONCE. SHE SAID MY MOTHER WOULD HAVE WANTED IT. SHE TOLD MY FATHER THAT MY MOTHER HAD

DIED THE GIVE ME FREEDOM. SHE HAD NOT SAVED ME FOR A LIFE OF IMPRISONMENT, HE AGREED IN THE END.

IT WAS CAREFULLY PLANNED. MY FATHER LED MYSELF AND WINDY UP THE THE THEE KEEK EARLY IN THE DAY. WINDY WAS THE SAY THAT SHE WAS SAVING A SEAT FOR MY FATHER. I WAS THE SIT THERE, INVISIBLE. WHEN EVERYONE HAD LEFT THE KEEK, WE WOULD EMERGE. WINDY WOULD APPEAR THE BE ALONE. NOBODY WOULD EVER KNOW.

BUT WINDY DIDN'T KNOW THAT I WAS GROWING STRONGER. I WAS STARTING THE FIGHT MY FATHER'S IMPERIALS CLUSE. THERE WERE TIMES WHEN I WAS ALMOST MYSELF AGAIN. THERE WERE BRIEF PERIODS WHEN I SEEMED OUTSIDE HIS CONTROL. IT HAPPENED, THERE, IN THE THEE KEEK. IT WAS LIKE WAKING FROM A DEEP SLEEP. I FELT MYSELF BEAT IN PUBLIC, IN THE MIDDLE OF THE MATCH, AND I SAW A HAND STICKING OUT OF A KEEK'S POCKET IN FRONT OF ME. I HAD NOT BEEN

FOR HARRY POTTER

ALLOWED A HAND SINCE BEFORE AZKABAN. I STEAL IT. WINDY DIDN'T

KNOW. WINDY IS FRIGHTENED OF HEIGHTS. SHE HAD HER FACE HIDDEN.

MASTER BARTY, WHO WAS KEEK? WHISPERED WINDY, TEARS TRICKLING BETWEEN HER FINGERS.

SHE WHO THREW THE HAND, SAID DUMBLEDORE, AND WHAT DID WHO DO WITH IT?

WE WENT BACK THE THE TENT, SAID CRUELLY. THEN WE HEARD THEM. WE HEARD THE DEATH EATERS. THE HUES WHO HAD NEVER

BEEN THE AZKABAN. THE MENES WHO HAD NEVER SLIPPED FOR MY MASTER. THEY HAD TURNED THEIR BACKS ON HIM. THEY WERE NOT ENSLAVED, AS I WAS. THEY WERE FREE TO SEE HIM, BUT THEY DID NOT. THEY WERE MERELY MAKING SPORT OF MUGGLES. THE SOUND OF THEIR VEHICLES AROUND ME. MY MIND WAS CLEARER THAN IT HAD BEEN IN YEARS. I WAS ANGRY. I HAD THE WAND. I WANTED TO ATTACK THEM FOR THEIR DISLOYALTY TO MY MASTER. MY FATHER HAD LEFT THE TENT. HE HAD GONE TO FREE THE MUGGLES. WINDY WAS AFRAID TO SEE ME SO ANGRY. SHE USED HER HEAVY BRAND OF MAGIC TO KID ME TO HER. SHE PULLED ME FROM THE TENT, PULLED ME INTO THE FOREST, AWAY FROM THE DEATH EATERS. I TRIED TO HOLD HER BACK. I WANTED TO RETURN TO THE CAMPSITE. I WANTED TO SHOW THESE DEATH EATERS WHAT LOYALTY TO THE DARK LORD MEANT, AND TO PUNISH THEM FOR THEIR LACK OF IT. I USED THE STEEL WAND TO CAST THE DARK MARK INTO THE SKY.

MINISTRY WIZARDS ARRIVED. THEY SHOT STUNNING SPELLS EVERYWHERE. ONE OF THE SPELLS CAME THROUGH THE TREES WHERE WINDY AND I STOOD. THE BRID CONNECTING US WAS CRACKED. WE WERE BOTH STUNNED.

WHEN WINDY WAS DISCOVERED, MY FATHER KNEW I MUST BE NEARBY. HE SEARCHED THE BUSHES WHERE SHE HAD BEEN HIDING, AND FELT ME LYING THERE. HE WAITED UNTIL THE OTHER MINISTRY MEMBERS HAD LEFT THE FOREST. HE PUT ME BACK UNDER THE IMPERILUS CURSE, AND TOOK ME HOME. HE DISMISSED WINDY. SHE HAD FAILED HIM.

SHE HAD LET ME ACQUIRE A WAND, SHE HAD ALMOST LET ME ESCAPE,  
WINDY LET OUT A WAIL OF DESPAIR.

THEN IT WAS JUST FATHER AND I, ALONE IN THE HELLIS, AND THEN

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... AND THEN ... CRUELCH'S HEAD REELLED ON HIS NECK, AND AN INSANE  
GRIN SPREAD ACROSS HIS FACE. MY MASTER CAME FOR ME.

HE ARRIVED AT OUR HELLIS LATE ONE NIGHT, IN THE ARMS OF HIS  
SERVANT WHERMTAIL. MY MASTER HAD FEELINGLY TOLD THAT I WAS STILL

ALIVE. HE HAD CAPTURED BERTHA JERKINS IN ALBANIA. HE HAD TORTURED  
HER. SHE TOLD HIM A GREAT DEAL. SHE TOLD HIM ABOUT THE

TRILIZARD TOURNAMENT. SHE TOLD HIM THE OLD ALIEN, MERRY, WAS  
GOING TO TEACH AT FHEGLANTS. HE TORTURED HER UNTIL HE BROKE  
THROUGH THE MEMORY CHARM MY FATHER HAD PLACED UPON HER.  
SHE TOLD HIM I HAD ESCAPED FROM AZDARAN. SHE TOLD HIM MY  
FATHER KEPT ME IMPRISONED TO PREVENT ME SEEKING MY MASTER,  
AND SHE MY MASTER DENIED THAT I WAS STILL HIS FAITHFUL SERVANT  
PERHAPS THE MOST FAITHFUL OF ALL. MY MASTER CONCEIVED A PLAN,  
BASED UPON THE INFORMATION BERTHA HAD GIVEN HIM. HE NEEDED  
ME. HE ARRIVED AT OUR HELLIS NEAR MIDNIGHT. MY FATHER  
ANSWERED THE DOOR.

THE SMILE SPREAD WIDER OVER CRUELCH'S FACE, AS TRULICH RECALL-  
ING THE SWEETEST MEMORY OF HIS LIFE. WINDY'S PETRIFIED BROWN

EYES WERE VISIBLE THROUGH HER FINGERS. SHE SEEMED THEN APPALLED  
THE SPEAK.

IT WAS VERY QUICK. MY FATHER WAS PLACED UNDER THE IMPERILS  
CURSE BY MY MASTER. WHEN MY FATHER WAS THEN IMPRISONED,  
CONTROLLED, MY MASTER FORCED HIM TO GO ABOUT HIS BUSINESS AS  
USUAL, TO ACT AS THOUGH NOTHING WAS WRONG, AND I WAS RELEASED.  
I AWAKE, I WAS MYSELF AGAIN, ALIVE AS I HADN'T BEEN IN YEARS.

AND WHAT DID LORD VOLDEMORT ASK WHEN THE DEER SAID  
DUMBLEDORE.

HE ASKED ME WHETHER I WAS READY TO RISK EVERYTHING FOR  
HIM, I WAS READY, IT WAS MY DREAM, MY GREATEST AMBITION, TO  
SERVE HIM, TO PROVE MYSELF TO HIM, HE TOLD ME HE NEEDED  
THE PLACE A FAITHFUL SERVANT AT HOGWARTS, A SERVANT WHO  
WOULD GUIDE HARRY POTTER THROUGH THE TRIWIZARD TOURNAMENT  
WITHOUT APPEARING TO DO SO, A SERVANT WHO WOULD WATCH  
OVER HARRY POTTER, ENSURE HE REACHED THE TRIWIZARD CUP,  
TURN THE CUP INTO A PORTKEY, WHICH WOULD TAKE THE

SEE HARRY POTTER

FIRST PERSON TO TELL IT TO MY MASTER, BUT FIRST

WHO NEEDED ALASTOR MOODY, SAID DUMBLEDORE, HIS BLUE EYES  
WERE BLAZING, THOUGH HIS VOICE REMAINED CALM.

WORMTAIL AND I DID IT, WE HAD PREPARED THE PERFECT PLAN

BEFOREHAND, WE DECEIVED THE HIS HOUSE, MOODY PUT UP A STRUG-  
GLE, THERE WAS A COMPETITION, WE MANAGED TO SILENCE HIM JUST



IN TIME, FORCED HIM INTO A COMPARTMENT OF HIS OWN MAGICAL  
TRUNK. THEN SOME OF HIS HAIR AND ADDED IT TO THE POTION. I  
DRANK IT, I BECAME MERRY'S DOG. I THREW HIS LEG AND HIS EYE. I  
WAS READY THE FACE ARTHUR WEASLEY WHEN HE ARRIVED THE SHORT HILT  
THE MUGGLES WHO HAD HEARD A DISTURBANCE. I MADE THE DISTURBANCE  
MERRY ARRESTING THE YARD. I TOLD ARTHUR WEASLEY I HAD HEARD  
INTRUDERS IN MY YARD, WHO HAD SET THE DISTURBANCE OFF. THEN I  
PACKED UP MERRY'S CLOTHES AND DARK DETECTORS, PUT THEM IN  
THE TRUNK WITH MERRY, AND SET OFF FOR HOGWARTS. I KEPT HIM

ALIVE, UNDER THE IMPERILUS CURSE. I WANTED THE BE ABLE TO HELP-  
THEN HIM. THE FIND HILT ARREST HIS PAST, LEARN HIS HABITS, SEE THAT I

COULD FEEL EVEN DUMBLEDORE. I ALSO NEEDED HIS HAIR TO MAKE  
THE PHEASANT POTION. THE OTHER INGREDIENTS WERE EASY. I STEAL  
BLOODSLANG SKIN FROM THE DRINKERS. WHEN THE POTION'S  
MASTER FOUND ME IN HIS OFFICE, I SAID I WAS UNDER ORDERS TO  
SEARCH IT.

AND WHAT BECAME OF WHISTTAIL AFTER YELL ATTACKED MERRY?  
SAID DUMBLEDORE.

WHISTTAIL RETURNED THE CARE FOR MY MASTER, IN MY FATHER'S  
HOUSE, AND THE KEEP WATCH OVER MY FATHER.

BUT YELL'S FATHER ESCAPED, SAID DUMBLEDORE.

YES, AFTER A WHILE HE BEGAN THE FIGHT THE IMPERILUS CURSE  
JUST AS I HAD DONE. THERE WERE PERIODS WHERE HE KNEW WHAT  
WAS HAPPENING. MY MASTER DECIDED IT WAS NO LONGER SAFE FOR  
MY FATHER TO LEAVE THE HOUSE. HE FORCED HIM TO SEND LETTERS TO

THE MINISTRY INSTEAD, HE MADE HIM WRITE AND SAY HE WAS ILL,  
BUT WORMTAIL NEGLECTED HIS DUTY, HE WAS NOT WATCHFUL ENOUGH,  
MY FATHER ESCAPED, MY MASTER GUESSED THAT HE WAS HEADING FOR  
HOGWARTS, MY FATHER WAS GOING TO TELL DUMBLEDORE EVERYTHING,

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THE CHIEFESS, HE WAS GOING TO ADMIT THAT HE HAD SMUGGLED ME  
FROM AZKABAN.

MY MASTER SENT ME WORD OF MY FATHER'S ESCAPE, HE TOLD ME  
TO STOP HIM AT ALL COSTS, SO I WAITED AND WATCHED, I USED THE  
MAP I HAD TAKEN FROM HARRY POTTER, THE MAP THAT HAD ALMOST  
RUINED EVERYTHING.

MARY SAID DUMBLEDORE BELIEVEDLY, WHAT MAP IS THIS?

POTTER'S MAP OF HOGWARTS, POTTER SAW ME IN IT, POTTER SAW  
ME STEALING MERE INGREDIENTS FOR THE POLYPHILIC POTIION FROM  
SNAPE'S OFFICE ONE NIGHT, HE THOUGHT I WAS MY FATHER AS WE  
HAVE THE SAME FIRST NAME, I TOOK THE MAP FROM POTTER THAT  
NIGHT, I TOLD HIM MY FATHER HATED DARK WIZARDS, POTTER BELIEVED  
MY FATHER WAS AFTER SNAPE.

FOR A WEEK I WAITED FOR MY FATHER TO ARRIVE AT HOGWARTS, AT  
LAST, ONE EVENING, THE MAP SHOWED MY FATHER ENTERING THE  
GREENHouses, I PULLED ON MY INVISIBILITY CLOAK, AND WENT DOWN TO  
MEET HIM, HE WAS WALKING ALONG THE EDGE OF THE FOREST, THEN  
POTTER CAME, AND DARN, I WAITED, I COULD NOT HURT POTTER, MY  
MASTER NEEDED HIM, POTTER RAN TO GET DUMBLEDORE, I STUNNED  
DARN, I KILLED MY FATHER.

NEEEEEEE! Wailed WINDY, MASTER BARTY, MASTER BARTY, WHAT IS

WELL SAYING?

WELL KILLED THEIR FATHER, DUMBLEDORE SAID, IN THE SAME SHIRT  
VEIL. WHAT DID WELL DO WITH THE BODY?

CARRIED IT INTO THE FOREST, COVERED IT WITH THE INVISIBILITY  
CLEAN, I HAD THE MAP WITH ME, I WATCHED PETER RUN INTO THE  
CASTLE, HE MET SNAPE, DUMBLEDORE HEARD THEM, I WATCHED  
PETER BRINGING DUMBLEDORE OUT OF THE CASTLE, I WALKED BACK  
OUT OF THE FOREST, DUMBLEDORE BEHIND BEHIND THEM, WENT TO MEET  
THEM, I TOLD DUMBLEDORE SNAPE HAD TOLD ME WHERE THEY WERE.

DUMBLEDORE TOLD ME THE GO AND LOOK FOR MY FATHER, I WENT  
BACK TO MY FATHER'S BODY, WATCHED THE MAP, WHEN EVERYONE  
WAS GONE, I TRANSFIGURED MY FATHER'S BODY, HE BECAME A GHOST  
... I BURIED IT, WHILE WEARING THE INVISIBILITY CLEAN, IN THE  
FRESHLY DUG EARTH IN FRONT OF HAGRID'S CABIN.

END HARRY PETER

THERE WAS COMPLETE SILENCE NOW, EXCEPT FOR WINDY'S  
CONTINUED SNEE.

THEN DUMBLEDORE SAID, AND TONIGHT ...

I OFFERED TO CARRY THE TRINIZARD CLIP INTO THE MAZE BEFORE  
DINNER, WHISPERED KATY CRUELTY, TURNED IT INTO A PHEASANT, MY  
MASTER'S PLAN WORKED, HE IS RETURNED TO POWER AND I WILL BE  
REDEEMED BY HIM BEYOND THE DREAMS OF WIZARDS.

THE INSANE SMILE HIT HIS FEATURES FIRST THERE, AND HIS HEAD  
DROOPED DOWN HIS SHOULDER AS WINDY WALKED AND SNEEED AT HIS  
SIDE.

## CHAPTER THIRTY-SIX

### THE PARTING OF THE WAYS

DUMBLEDOORE STEPPED UP, HE STARED DOWN AT BARTY CRUELICH FOR A MOMENT WITH DISGUST ON HIS FACE. THEN HE RAISED HIS WAND

AND THREE AND FIFES FLEW OUT OF IT, RIFES WHICH TWISTED THEMSELVES AROUND BARTY CRUELICH, BINDING HIM TIGHTLY.

HE TURNED TO PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL. MINERVA, CHILD I ASK YOU TO STAND GUARD HERE WHILE I TAKE HARRY UPSTAIRS?

OF COURSE, SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL. SHE LOOKED SLIGHTLY NALISPHUS, AS THOUGH SHE HAD JUST WATCHED SOMEONE BEING SICK. HOWEVER, WHEN SHE DREW OUT HER WAND AND POINTED IT AT BARTY CRUELICH, HER HAND WAS WHITE STEADY.

SEVERUS, DUMBLEDOORE TURNED TO SNAPE, PLEASE TELL MADAM POMFREY TO COME DOWN HERE. WE NEED TO GET ALASTAIR MURDOCH INTO THE HOSPITAL WING. THEN GO DOWN INTO THE GRILINDS, FIND CHERNILLUS FLICK, AND BRING HIM UP TO THIS OFFICE. HE WILL UNDEBATEDLY WANT THE ELDEST CRUELICH HIMSELF. TELL HIM I WILL BE IN THE HOSPITAL WING IN HALF AN HOUR & TIME IF HE NEEDS ME. SNAPE NEEDED SILENTLY AND SWIFT OUT OF THE ROOM.

HARRY? DUMBLEDOORE SAID GENTLY.

HARRY GOT UP AND SWAYED AGAIN; THE PAIN IN HIS LEG, WHICH HE HAD NOT NOTICED ALL THE TIME HE HAD LISTENED TO CRUELICH, NOW RETURNED IN FULL MEASURE. HE ALSO REALISED THAT HE WAS SHAKING.

DUMBLEDOORE GRIPPED HIS ARM, AND HELPED HIM HURRY INTO THE DARK CORRIDOR.

I WANT YOU TO COME UP TO MY OFFICE FIRST, HARRY, HE SAID QUIETLY, AS THEY HEADED UP THE PASSAGEWAY. SIRIUS IS WAITING FOR US THERE.

END HARRY PATTERN

HARRY NEEDED, A KIND OF NUMBNESS AND A SENSE OF COMPLETE UNREALITY WERE UPON HIM, BUT HE DID NOT CARE; HE WAS EVEN GLAD OF IT. HE DIDN'T WANT TO HAVE TO THINK ABOUT ANYTHING THAT HAD HAPPENED SINCE HE HAD FIRST THOUGHT OF THE TRIWIZARD CUP. HE DIDN'T WANT TO HAVE TO EXAMINE THE MEMORIES, FRESH AND SHARP AS PHOTOGRAPHS, WHICH KEPT FLASHING ACROSS HIS MIND. MAD-EYE MONDY, INSIDE THE TRIWIZARD, WHISTLETAIL, SLUMPED ON THE GROUND, CRADLING HIS STUMP OF AN ARM. VERDMEER, RISING FROM THE STEAMING CALDRON, CEDRIC ... DEAD ... CEDRIC, ASKING THE EE RETURNED TO HIS PARENTS ...

PROFESSOR, HARRY MURMURED, WHERE ARE MR AND MRS DIGGORY?

THEY ARE WITH PROFESSOR SPRETT, SAID DUMBLEDOORE. HIS VEHICLE, WHICH HAD BEEN SO CALM THROUGHOUT THE INTERROGATION OF BARTY CRACKLE, SEEMED VERY SLIGHTLY FEAR THE FIRST TIME. SHE WAS HEAD OF CEDRIC'S HOUSE, AND KNEW HIM BEST.

THEY HAD REACHED THE STONE GARGOYLE. DUMBLEDOORE GAVE THE

PASSWORD, IT SPRANG ASIDE, AND HE AND HARRY WENT UP THE MOVING SPIRAL STAIRCASE THE WAY HE HAD DONE. DUMBLEDOORE PUSHED IT

HAPPEN.

SIRILIS WAS STANDING THERE. HIS FACE WAS WHITE AND CALM AS IT HAD BEEN WHEN HE HAD ESCAPED AZKABAN. IN ONE SWIFT MOMENT, HE HAD CROSSED THE ROOM. HARRY, ARE YOU ALL RIGHT? I KNOW IT I KNOW SOMETHING LIKE THIS WHAT HAPPENED?

HIS HANDS STOOD AS HE HELPED HARRY INTO A CHAIR IN FRONT OF THE DESK.

WHAT HAPPENED? HE ASKED, MORE URGENTLY.

OLMEDIER BEGAN TO TELL SIRILIS EVERYTHING LARRY CRUELLY HAD SAID. HARRY WAS ONLY HALF LISTENING. SHE TIED EVERY KNOT IN HIS BODY WAS ACHING. HE WANTED NOTHING MORE THAN TO SIT HERE, UNDISTURBED, HER FEELERS AND FEELERS, UNTIL HE FELL ASLEEP, AND DIDN'T HAVE TO THINK OR FEEL ANY MORE.

THERE WAS A SOFT RUSH OF WINGS. FALCON THE PHOENIX HAD LEFT HIS PERCH, FLEW ACROSS THE OFFICE, AND LANDED ON HARRY'S DESK.

THE PARTING OF THE WAYS FOR

THE FALCON, SAID HARRY QUIETLY. HE STROOK THE PHOENIX'S BEAUTIFUL SCARLET AND GOLD PLUMAGE. FALCON BLINKED PEACEFULLY UP AT HIM. THERE WAS SOMETHING COMFORTING ABOUT HIS WARM LIGHT.

OLMEDIER HAD STOPPED TALKING. HE SAT DOWN OPPOSITE HARRY, BEHIND HIS DESK. HE WAS LOOKING AT HARRY, BUT AVOIDED HIS EYES. OLMEDIER WAS GOING TO BELIEVE HIM. HE WAS GOING TO MAKE HARRY BELIEVE EVERYTHING.

I NEED TO KNOW WHAT HAPPENED AFTER YOU THOUGHT THE  
PHOTON IN THE MAGE, HARRY, SAID DUMBLEDORE.

WE CAN LEAVE THAT TIL MORNING, CAN'T WE, DUMBLEDORE? SAID  
SIRIUS HARSHLY, HE HAD PUT A HAND ON HARRY'S SHOULDER. LET HIM  
HAVE A SLEEP, LET HIM REST.

HARRY FELT A FLUSH OF GRATITUDE TOWARDS SIRIUS, BUT  
DUMBLEDORE THREW NO NOTICE OF SIRIUS' WORDS. HE LEANT FORWARD  
TOWARDS HARRY. VERY UNWILLINGLY, HARRY RAISED HIS HEAD, AND  
LOOKED INTO THOSE BLUE EYES.

IF I THOUGHT I COULD HELP YOU, DUMBLEDORE SAID GENTLY, BY

PUTTING YOU INTO AN ENCHANTED SLEEP, AND ALLOWING YOU THE PEACE-  
FUL MOMENT WHEN YOU WOULD HAVE THE TIME TO ASK WHAT

HAS HAPPENED TONIGHT, I WOULD DO IT. BUT I KNOW BETTER.

NUMBING THE PAIN FOR A WHILE WILL MAKE IT WORSE WHEN YOU

FINALLY FEEL IT. YOU HAVE SEEN MY PRAYERS REGARDING ANYTHING I

COULD HAVE EXPECTED OF YOU. I ASK YOU TO DEMONSTRATE YOUR

COURAGE ONE MORE TIME. I ASK YOU TO TELL US WHAT HAPPENED.

THE PHOENIX LET OUT ONE SHOT, ENLARGING MORE. IT SHIVERED IN

THE AIR, AND HARRY FELT AS THOUGH A DROP OF HOT LIQUID HAD

SLIPPED DOWN HIS THROAT INTO HIS STOMACH, WARMING HIM, AND

STRENGTHENING HIM.

HE TOOK A DEEP BREATH, AND BEGAN TO TELL THEM. AS HE SPEAKED,

VISIONS OF EVERYTHING THAT HAD PASSED THAT NIGHT SEEMED TO RISE

BEFORE HIS EYES. HE SAW THE SPARKLING SURFACE OF THE POTION

WHICH HAD REVIVED VERDERBILT; HE SAW THE DEATH EATERS

APPARATING BETWEEN THE GRAVES AROUND THEM; HE SAW CEDRIC'S BODY, LYING IN THE GRUHLING BESIDE THE CLIP.

BY HARRY POTTER

ENCE HE TWICE, SIRILIS MADE A NOISE AS THOUGH AROUND THE SAY  
SOMETHING, HIS HAND STILL TIGHT IN HARRY'S SHOULDER, BUT  
OLIMPEDEHE RAISED HIS HAND TO STOP HIM, AND HARRY WAS GLAD  
OF THIS, BECAUSE IT WAS EASIER TO KEEP GOING NOW HE HAD STARTED.

IT WAS EVEN A RELIEF; HE FELT ALMOST AS THOUGH SOMETHING PHYSICAL  
WAS BEING EXTRACTED FROM HIM; IT WAS CHESTING HIM EVERY

BUT HE DETERMINATION HE HAD THE DEEP TALKING, YET HE SENSED THAT  
BECAUSE HE HAD FINISHED, HE WOULD FEEL BETTER.

WHEN HARRY TOLD HIM WHISTTAIL PIERCING HIS ARM WITH THE  
DAGGER, HOWEVER, SIRILIS LET OUT A VIOLENT EXCLAMATION; AND  
OLIMPEDEHE STOPPED UP SHE BELIEVED THAT HARRY STARTED.

OLIMPEDEHE WALKED AROUND THE DESK AND TOLD HARRY THE STRETCH  
OUT HIS ARM, HARRY SHOWED THEM BOTH THE PLACE WHERE HIS  
BONES WERE THERE, AND THE CLIT BENEATH THEM.

HE SAID MY BLOOD WOULD MAKE HIM STRONGER THAN IF HE D

USED SOMETHING ELSE, HARRY TOLD OLIMPEDEHE. HE SAID THE PRO-  
TECTION MY MY MOTHER LEFT IN ME HE D HAVE IT, THEN, AND HE

WAS RIGHT HE COULD THINK ME WITHOUT FLIRTING HIMSELF, HE  
THOUGHT MY FACE.



FOR A FLEETING INSTANT, HARRY THOUGHT HE SAW A GLEAM OF

SOMETHING LIKE TRIUMPH IN DUMBLEDORE'S EYES. BUT NEXT SECOND, HARRY WAS SURE HE HAD IMAGINED IT, FOR WHEN DUMBLEDORE HAD RETURNED TO HIS SEAT BEHIND THE DESK, HE LOOKED AS OLD AND WEARY AS HARRY HAD EVER SEEN HIM.

VERY WELL, HE SAID, SITTING DOWN AGAIN. VOLDERMORT HAS EMERGED FROM THAT PARTICULAR BARRIER, HARRY, CONTINUE, PLEASE.

HARRY WENT ON; HE EXPLAINED HOW VOLDERMORT HAD EMERGED FROM THE CALDBORN, AND TOLD THEM ALL HE COULD REMEMBER OF VOLDERMORT'S SPEECH TO THE DEATH EATERS. THEN HE TOLD HOW

VOLDERMORT HAD LIFTED HIM, RETURNED HIS WAND TO HIM, AND PREPARED TO DUEL.

BUT WHEN HE REACHED THE PART WHERE THE GILDED BEAM OF LIGHT HAD CONNECTED HIS AND VOLDERMORT'S WANDS, HE FELT HIS THROAT RESTRICTED. HE TRIED TO KEEP TALKING, BUT THE MEMORIES OF WHAT HAD COME NEXT OF VOLDERMORT'S WAND WERE

THE PARTING OF THE WAYS WAS FLASHING INTO HIS MIND. HE COULD SEE CEDRIC EMERGING, SEE THE OLD MAN, BERTHA JERKINS ... HIS MOTHER ... HIS FATHER ... HE WAS GLAD WHEN SIRIUS BROKE THE SILENCE.

THE WANDS CONNECTED? HE SAID, LEERING FROM HARRY THE DUMBLEDORE, WHY?

HARRY LEERED UP AGAIN AT DUMBLEDORE, WHO WHOSE FACE THERE WAS AN ARRESTED SMILE.

PRIMI INCANTATEM, HE MUTTERED.

HIS EYES GAZED INTO HARRY'S AND IT WAS ALMOST AS THOUGH AN INVISIBLE BEAM OF UNDERSTANDING SHINE BETWEEN THEM.

THE REVERSE SPELL EFFECT? SAID SIRIUS SHARPLY.

EXACTLY, SAID DUMBLEDORE. HARRY'S WAND AND VOLDERMORT'S WAND SHARE CHIMES. EACH OF THEM CONTAINS A FEATHER FROM THE TAIL OF THE SAME PHOENIX. THIS PHOENIX, IN FACT, HE ADDED, AND HE POINTED AT THE SCARLET AND GOLD BIRD, PERCHING PEACEFULLY ON HARRY'S DUNE.

MY WAND'S FEATHER CAME FROM FALCONES? HARRY SAID, AMAZED.

YES, SAID DUMBLEDORE. MR HILLVANDER WHITE THE TELL ME WHEN HAD RECALLED THE SECOND WAND, THE MOMENT WHEN LEFT HIS SHOP SEVEN YEARS AGO.

SEE WHAT HAPPENS WHEN A WAND MEETS ITS COUNTERPART? SAID SIRIUS.

THEY WILL MEET HEAD PROPERLY AGAINST EACH OTHER, SAID DUMBLEDORE. IF, HOWEVER, THE OWNERS OF THE WANDS FORCE THE WANDS TO BE BATTLE ... A VERY RARE EFFECT WILL TAKE PLACE.

ONE OF THE WANDS WILL FORCE THE OTHER TO REENACT THE SPELLS IT HAS PERFORMED IN REVERSE. THE MOST RECENT FIRST ... AND THEN THOSE WHICH PRECEDED IT ...

HE LEERED INTERROGATIVELY AT HARRY, AND HARRY NODDED.

WHICH MEANS, SAID DUMBLEDORE SMILING, HIS EYES WIDEN

HARRY'S FACE, THAT SOMEHOW HE CEDRIC MUST HAVE REAPPEARED,  
HARRY NEEDED AGAIN.

DIGGERS CAN RAISE THE DEAD? SAID SIRIUS SHARPLY.

NO SPELL CAN REANIMATE THE DEAD, SAID DUMBLEDORE HEAVILY.

ALL THAT WOULD HAVE HAPPENED IS A KIND OF REVERSE ETC.

THE HARRY PATTERN

SHADES OF THE LIVING CEDRIC WOULD HAVE EMERGED FROM THE  
WAND ... AM I CORRECT, HARRY?

HE SPEAKS TO ME, HARRY SAID, HE WAS SUDDENLY SHAKING  
AGAIN, THE ... THE GHOST CEDRIC, OR WHATEVER HE WAS, SPEAKS.

AN ETC., SAID DUMBLEDORE, WHICH RETAINED CEDRIC'S APPEAR-  
ANCE AND CHARACTER. I AM GLISSING EITHER SUCH FORMS APPEARED

... LESS RECENT VICTIMS OF VOLDERMORT'S WAND ...

AN OLD MAN, HARRY SAID, HIS TONGUE STILL CONSTRICTED, BERTIE  
JERKINS, AND ...

THEIR PARENTS? SAID DUMBLEDORE QUIETLY.

YES, SAID HARRY.

SIRIUS GRIP ON HARRY'S SHOULDER WAS NOW SO TIGHT IT WAS  
PAINFUL.

THE LAST MURDERS THE WAND PERFORMED, SAID DUMBLEDORE,  
NEEDING. IN REVERSE ORDER, MORE WOULD HAVE APPEARED, IF  
CHANCE HAD BEEN MAINTAINED THE CONNECTION. VERY WELL, HARRY,  
THESE ETC., THESE SHADES ... WHAT DID THEY DO?

HARRY DESCRIBED THEN THE FIGURES WHICH HAD EMERGED FROM

THE WAND HAD PREHEATED THE EDGES OF THE GOLDEN WEE, WHEN  
VHELDENHART HAD SEEMED THE FEAR THEM, WHEN THE SHADERS OF  
HARRY S FATHER HAD TOLD HIM WHAT THE DEE, WHEN CEDRIC S HAD MADE  
ITS FINAL REHELEST.

AT THIS POINT, HARRY FEELING HE COULD NOT CONTINUE, HE WHEEDED  
AROUND AT SIRILIS, AND SAW THAT HE HAD HIS FACE IN HIS HANDS.  
HARRY SLIDDERLY BECAME AWARE THAT FALDERES HAD LEFT HIS DNER.

THE PHENIX HAD FLUTTERED THE FLEER. IT WAS RESTING ITS BEAUTI-  
FUL HEAD AGAINST HARRY S INJURED LEG, AND THICK, PEARLY TEARS

WERE FALLING FROM ITS EYES BENTH THE WHEELING LEFT BY THE SPIDER.

THE PAIN VANISHED. THE SKIN MENDED. HIS LEG WAS REPAIRED.

I WILL SAY IT AGAIN, SAID OLMEREDERE, AS THE PHENIX ROSE  
INTH THE AIR, AND RESETTLED ITSELF UPON THE PERCH BESIDE THE DEER.

YOU HAVE SHOWN BRAVERY BEYOND ANYTHING I COULD HAVE EXPECT-  
ED OF YOU TONIGHT, HARRY. YOU HAVE SHOWN BRAVERY EQUAL THE

THESE WHEN DIED FIGHTING VHELDENHART AT THE FRIGHT OF HIS PEELERS.

YOU HAVE SHOULDERS A GREEN WIZARD S BURDEN AND FEELING YOUR-

THE PARTING OF THE WAYS FOR

SELF EQUAL THE IT AND YOU HAVE BEEN GIVEN US ALL THAT WE HAVE A  
RIGHT THE EXPECT, YOU WILL COME WITH ME THE THE HOSPITAL WING. I  
DEE NOT WANT YOU RETURNING THE THE DEERMITHERY TONIGHT, A  
SLEEPING POTION, AND SOME PEACE ... SIRILIS, WOULD YOU LIKE THE

STAY WITH HIM

SIRILUS NEEDLED, AND STEPPED UP, HE TRANSFORMED BACK INTO THE GREAT BLACK DRAGON, AND WALKED WITH HARRY AND DUMBLEDORE OUT OF THE OFFICE, ACCOMPANYING THEM DOWN A FLIGHT OF STAIRS TO THE HOSPITAL WING.

WHEN DUMBLEDORE PUSHED OPEN THE DOOR, HARRY SAW MRS

WEASLEY, BILL, PENE AND HERMION GRABBED AROUND A HARASSED-LOOKING MADAM POMFREY. THEY APPEARED TO BE DEMANDING THE

KNOW WHERE HARRY WAS AND WHAT HAD HAPPENED TO HIM.

ALL OF THEM WHIPPED AROUND AS HARRY, DUMBLEDORE AND THE BLACK DRAGON ENTERED, AND MRS WEASLEY LET OUT A KIND OF MUFFLED SCREAM. HARRY? HEI, HARRY?

SHE STARTED TO FLURY TOWARDS HIM, BUT DUMBLEDORE MOVED BETWEEN THEM.

WELL, HE SAID, HOLDING UP A HAND, PLEASE LISTEN TO ME FOR A MOMENT. HARRY HAS BEEN THROUGH A TERRIBLE HORROR TONIGHT. HE HAS JUST HAD THE RELIEF IT FOR ME. WHAT HE NEEDS NOW IS SLEEP, AND PEACE, AND QUIET. IF HE WOULD LIKE YOU ALL TO STAY WITH HIM, HE ADDED, LOOKING AROUND AT PENE, HERMION AND BILL, THEN, YOU MAY DO SO, BUT I DO NOT WANT YOU HURRYING HIM UNTIL HE IS READY TO ANSWER, AND CERTAINLY NOT THIS EVENING.

MRS WEASLEY NODDED. SHE WAS VERY WHITE.

SHE REINED IN PENE, HERMION AND BILL AS THOUGH THEY WERE BEING NEESY, AND HISSED, DID YOU HEAR? HE NEEDS QUIET?

HEADMASTER, SAID MADAM POMFREY, STARING AT THE GREAT BLACK

ONE THAT WAS SILENT, MAY I ASK WHAT ?

THIS ONE WILL BE REMAINING WITH HARRY FOR A WHILE, SAID  
OLMPEDORE SIMPLY. I ASSURE YOU, HE IS EXTREMELY WELL TRAINED.

HARRY I WILL WAIT WHILE YOU GET INTO THE BED.

HARRY FELT AN INEXPRESSIBLE SENSE OF GRATITUDE TO OLMPEDORE  
FOR ASKING THE OTHERS NOT TO DISTURB HIM. IT WASN'T AS THOUGH

~~THE~~ HARRY PREFERRED

HE DIDN'T WANT THEM THERE; BUT THE THOUGHT OF EXPLAINING IT ALL  
OVER AGAIN, THE IDEA OF RELIVING IT FOR MORE TIME, WAS MORE  
THAN HE COULD STAND.

I WILL BE BACK TO SEE YOU AS SOON AS I HAVE MET WITH FLUZZ,  
HARRY, SAID OLMPEDORE. I WOULD LIKE YOU TO REMAIN HERE  
TEMPORARILY, UNTIL I HAVE SPOKEN TO THE SCHOOL. HE LEFT.

AS MADAM POMFREY LED HARRY TO A NEARBY BED, HE CAUGHT  
SIGHT OF THE REAL MURDER LYING MORTUALLY IN A BED AT THE FAR END  
OF THE ROOM. HIS WHOLE LEG AND MAGICAL EYE WERE LYING ON THE  
BEDSIDE TABLE.

IS HE DEAD? HARRY ASKED.

HE IS BE FINE, SAID MADAM POMFREY, GIVING HARRY SOME PYJA-  
MAS AND PULLING SCREENS AROUND HIM. HE THREW OFF HIS BEES,

PULLED ON THE PYJAMAS AND GOT INTO THE BED. THEN, HERMINIE, KILL,  
MRS WEASLEY AND THE BLACK ONE CAME AROUND THE SCREEN AND  
SETTLED THEMSELVES IN CHAIRS ON EITHER SIDE OF HIM. THEN AND  
HERMINIE WERE LOOKING AT HIM ALMOST CALMLY, AS THOUGH

STARED AT HIM.

I'M ALL RIGHT, HE TOLD THEM. JUST TIRED.

MRS LEASLEY'S EYES FILLED WITH TEARS AS SHE SMOTHERED HIS RED-  
CHEEKS UNNECESSARILY.

MADAM PEMBERTON, WHO HAD GLISTLED OFF THE FLOOR OFFICE, RETURNED  
BRINGING A CUPLET AND A SMALL KETTLE OF SOME PURPLE PORTWINE.

YOU'LL NEED THE DRINK ALL OF THIS, HARRY, SHE SAID. IT'S A PORTWINE  
FOR DREAMLESS SLEEP.

HARRY TOOK THE CUPLET AND DRANK A FEW SIPS. HE FELT  
HIMSELF BECOMING DROWSY AT ONCE. EVERYTHING AROUND HIM  
BECAME FAZY; THE LAMPS AROUND THE HOSPITAL WING SEEMED TO BE  
BLINKING AT HIM IN A FRIENDLY WAY THROUGH THE SCREEN AROUND HIS  
BED; HIS BODY FELT AS THOUGH IT WAS SINKING DEEPER INTO THE  
WARMTH OF THE FEATHER MATTRESS. BEFORE HE COULD FINISH THE  
PORTWINE, BEFORE HE COULD SAY ANOTHER WORD, HIS EXHAUSTION HAD  
CARRIED HIM OFF THE SLEEP.

\*

HARRY WAKE UP, SHE WARM, SHE VERY SLEEPY, THAT HE DIDN'T OPEN

THE PARTING OF THE DAYS FOR

HIS EYES, WANTING THE DRINK OFF AGAIN. THE ROOM WAS STILL DIMLY  
LIT; HE WAS SURE IT WAS STILL NIGHT-TIME, AND HAD A FEELING THAT HE  
COULDN'T HAVE BEEN ASLEEP VERY LONG.

THEN HE HEARD WHISPERING AROUND HIM.

THEY LL MAKE HIM IF THEY DHEN T SHUT LIP!

WHAT ARE THEY SMILING ABOUT? NOTHING ELSE CAN HAVE HAPPENED, CAN IT?

HARRY OPENED HIS EYES CLEARLY. SOMEONE HAD REMOVED HIS GLASSES, HE COULD SEE THE Fuzzy OUTLINES OF MRS WEASLEY AND BILL CLOSE BY. MRS WEASLEY WAS ON HER FEET.

THAT S FUDGE S VEHICLE, SHE WHISPERED. AND THAT S MINERVA MCGONAGALL S, ISN T IT? BUT WHAT ARE THEY ARGUING ABOUT?

WHEN HARRY COULD HEAR THEM, THEN: PEOPLE SMILING AND RUNNING TOWARDS THE HOSPITAL WING.

REGRETTABLE, BUT ALL THE SAME, MINERVA CERNILIUS FUDGE WAS SAYING LOUDLY.

THEY SHOULD NEVER HAVE BRUGHT IT INSIDE THE CASTLE! YELLED PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL. WHEN DUMBLEDORE FINDS OUT HARRY HEARD HOSPITAL BELLERS FIRST OPEN, INDENTIFIED BY ANY OF THE PEOPLE AROUND HIS BED, ALL OF THEM WERE STARING AT THE BELLER AS BILL PULLED BACK THE SCREENS. HARRY SAT UP, AND PUT HIS GLASSES BACK ON.

FUDGE CAME STRIDING UP THE WARD, PROFESSORS MCGONAGALL AND SNAPE WERE AT HIS HEELS.

WHERE S DUMBLEDORE? FUDGE DEMANDED OF MRS WEASLEY.

HE S NOT HERE, SAID MRS WEASLEY ANGRILY. THIS IS A HOSPITAL WING, MINISTER, DHEN T YOU THINK YOU D BE BETTER TO



BUT THE DOOR OPENED, AND DUMBLEDORE CAME SWEEPING UP  
THE HALL.

WHAT HAS HAPPENED? SAID DUMBLEDORE SHARPLY, LEADING  
THEM FLICK THE PROFESSOR McGRATHALL. WHY ARE YOU DISTURBING  
THESE PEOPLE? MINERVA, I'M SURPRISED AT YOU. I ASKED YOU TO  
STAND GUARD OVER BARTY CRUICKSHANK.

THERE IS NO NEED TO STAND GUARD OVER HIM ANY MORE,  
DUMBLEDORE? SHE SCRIEDED. THE MINISTER HAS SEEN TO THAT.

END HARRY POTTER

HARRY HAD NEVER SEEN PROFESSOR McGRATHALL LIKE CRUICKSHANK  
THIS. THERE WERE ANGRY FLICKS OF CRUICKSHANK IN HER CHEEKS, HER  
HANDS WERE RALLED INTO FISTS; SHE WAS TREMBLING WITH FLURY.

WHEN HE TOLD MR FLICK THAT HE HAD CALLED THE DEATH  
LATER RESPONSIBLE FOR THE NIGHT'S EVENTS, SAID SNAPE, IN A LOW  
VOICE, HE SEEMED TO FEEL HIS PERSONAL SAFETY WAS IN JEOPARDY.  
HE INSISTED ON SUMMONING A DEMENTOR TO ACCOMPANY HIM INTO  
THE CASTLE. HE CRUICKSHANK IT UP TO THE OFFICE WHERE BARTY CRUICKSHANK

I TOLD HIM YOU WOULD NOT AGREE, DUMBLEDORE? STORMED  
PROFESSOR McGRATHALL. I TOLD HIM YOU WOULD NEVER ALLOW  
DEMENTORS TO SET FOOT INSIDE THE CASTLE, BUT

MY DEAR WORMWORM? REARED FLICK, WHO LIKELIKE LEANED ANGRY-  
ER THAN HARRY HAD EVER SEEN HIM. AS MINISTER FOR MAGIC, IT IS  
MY DECISION WHETHER I WISH TO BRING PROTECTION WITH ME WHEN  
INTERVIEWING A POSSIBLY DANGEROUS

BUT PROFESSOR MCGHINAGALL'S VEHICLE BREMIERED FLIDGE'S.

THE MOMENT THAT THAT THING ENTERED THE ROOM, SHE SCREAMED, POINTING AT FLIDGE, TREMBLING ALL OVER. IT SWEEPED DOWN HER CORRIDOR AND AND HARRY FELT A CHILL IN HIS STOMACH, AS PROFESSOR MCGHINAGALL STRUGGLED TO FIND WORDS TO DESCRIBE WHAT HAD HAPPENED. HE DID NOT NEED HER TO FINISH HER SENTENCE. HE KNEW WHAT THE DEMONSTER MUST HAVE DONE. IT HAD ADMINISTERED ITS FATAL BISS TO RARY CORLICH. IT HAD SLIDED HIS SKIN OUT THROUGH HIS MOUTH. HE WAS WORSE THAN DEAD.

BY ALL ACCOUNTS, HE IS NEARLY ELIMINATED FLIDGE. IT SEEMS HE HAS BEEN RESPONSIBLE FOR SEVERAL DEATHS.

BUT HE CANNOT NOW GIVE TESTIMONY, CORNELIUS, SAID DUMBLEDORE. HE WAS STARING HARD AT FLIDGE, AS THOUGH SEEING HIM PLAINLY FOR THE FIRST TIME. HE CANNOT GIVE EVIDENCE ABOUT WHY HE KILLED THESE PEOPLE.

WHY HE KILLED THEM? WELL, THAT'S A MYSTERY, IS IT? ELIMINATED FLIDGE. HE WAS A RAVING LUNATIC? FROM WHAT MINERVA AND SEVERUS HAVE TOLD ME, HE SEEMS TO HAVE THOUGHT HE WAS DOING IT ALL FOR WELL-KNOWN-ONE'S INSTRUCTIONS.

THE PARTING OF THE WAYS 211

LEAD VERDICT WAS GIVING HIM INSTRUCTIONS, CORNELIUS,

DUMBLEDORE SAID. THESE PEOPLE'S DEATHS WERE MORE BY-

PREDICTS OF A PLAN TO RESTORE VERDICT TO FULL STRENGTH AGAIN.

THE PLAN SUCCEEDED, VEILDEMEHT HAS BEEN RESTORED THE HIS BODY,  
FLIDGE LOOKED AS THOUGH SOMETHING HAD JUST BLOWN A HEAVY  
WRIGHT INTO HIS FACE, DAZED AND BLINDING, HE STARED BACK AT  
DUMKLEDHRE AS IF HE COULDN'T BELIEVE WHAT HE HAD JUST  
HEARD,

HE BEGAN TO SPILTTER, STILL GIGGLING AT DUMKLEDHRE, YELL-  
DUMKLEDHRE ... RETURNED? PREPSTERHIS, COME NOW,

DUMKLEDHRE ...

AS MINERVA AND SEVERUS HAVE DELIGHTLESS TOLD YELL, SAID

DUMKLEDHRE, WE HEARD RARY CRUELCH CHINNESS, UNDER THE INFLU-  
ENCE OF VERITASERUM, HE TOLD US WHEN HE WAS SMUGGLED OUT OF

ATKARAN, AND WHEN VEILDEMEHT LEARNING OF HIS CONTINUED EXIS-  
TENCE FROM KERTHA JERKINS WENT TO FREE HIM FROM HIS FATHER,

AND USED HIM TO CAPTURE HARRY, THE PLAN WORKED, I TELL YELL,  
CRUELCH HAS HELPED VEILDEMEHT TO RETURN,

SEE HERE, DUMKLEDHRE, SAID FLIDGE, AND HARRY WAS ASTEN-  
ISHED TO SEE A SLIGHT SMILE DAWNING ON HIS FACE, YELL YELL CAN'T

SERIOUSLY BELIEVE THAT, YELL-DUMKLEDHRE BACK? COME NOW,  
COME NOW ... CERTAINLY, CRUELCH MAY HAVE BELIEVED HIMSELF TO BE  
ACTING UPON YELL-DUMKLEDHRE'S ORDERS BUT THE TRUTH IS THAT HE

A LLINATIC LIKE THAT, DUMBLEDORE ...

WHEN HARRY THOUGHT THE TRIWIZARD CLIP TONIGHT, HE WAS  
TRANSPORTED STRAIGHT TO THE VELOMERT, SAID DUMBLEDORE STEADILY,  
HE WITNESSED LORD VELOMERT'S REBIRTH. I WILL EXPLAIN IT ALL TO  
YOU IF YOU WILL STOP BY MY OFFICE.  
DUMBLEDORE GLANCED AROUND AT HARRY AND SAW THAT HE WAS

ALONE, BUT SHOOK HIS HEAD, AND SAID, I AM AFRAID I CANNOT PER-  
MIT YOU TO VISIT ME TONIGHT.

FLOR'S CURIOUS SMILE LINGERED,  
HE THEN GLANCED AT HARRY, THEN LOOKED BACK AT DUMBLEDORE,  
AND SAID, YOU ARE NOT PREPARED TO TAKE HARRY'S WORD ON THIS,  
ARE YOU, DUMBLEDORE?

112 HARRY PETER

THERE WAS A MOMENT'S SILENCE, WHICH WAS BROKEN BY SIRIUS  
GRIMMING. HIS EYEBROWS WERE RAISED, AND HE WAS Baring HIS TEETH  
AT FLOR.

CERTAINLY I BELIEVE HARRY, SAID DUMBLEDORE. HIS EYES WERE  
BLAZING RED. I HEARD CROUCH'S CONFESSION, AND I HEARD HARRY'S  
ACCOUNT OF WHAT HAPPENED AFTER HE THOUGHT THE TRIWIZARD CLIP;  
THE TWO STORIES MADE SENSE, THEY EXPLAIN EVERYTHING THAT HAS  
HAPPENED SINCE BERTHA JORDAN DISAPPEARED LAST SUMMER.  
FLOR STILL HAD THAT STRANGE SMILE ON HIS FACE. THEN AGAIN, HE  
GLANCED AT HARRY BEFORE ANSWERING. YOU ARE PREPARED TO BELIEVE  
THAT LORD VELOMERT HAS RETURNED, AND THAT HE IS A LLINATIC

MURDERER, AND A KID LIKE ... WELL ...

FLUDGE SEET HARRY ANOTHER LEED, AND HARRY SLIDDERLY UNDER-  
STOOD.

WELL YE BEEN READING RITA SKEETER, MR FLUDGE, HE SAID QUIETLY,  
THEN, HERMIONE, MRS WEASLEY AND KILL ALL ILMPED, WHEN HE  
THEM HAD REALISED THAT HARRY WAS AWAKE.

FLUDGE REDDENED SLIGHTLY, BUT A DEFIANT AND HESITANT LEED  
CAME OVER HIS FACE.

AND IF I HAVE? HE SAID, LEEDING AT DUMBLEDORE. IF I HAVE  
DISCOVERED THAT WELL YE BEEN KEEPING CERTAIN FACTS ABOUT THE KID  
VERY QUIET? A PARSEMENTH, EH? AND HAVING PLINDY THINS ALL  
EVER THE PLACE

I ASSUME THAT WELL ARE REFERRING TO THE PAINS HARRY HAS BEEN  
EXPERIENCING IN HIS STOMACH? SAID DUMBLEDORE CHELLY.

WELL ADMIT THAT HE HAS BEEN HAVING THESE PAINS, THEN? SAID

FLUDGE QUIETLY, HEADACHES? NIGHTMARES? POSSIBLY HALLUCINA-  
TIONS?

LISTEN TO ME, CHERNELIS, SAID DUMBLEDORE, TAKING A STEP

TOWARDS FLUDGE, AND ERICE AGAIN HE SEEMED TO RADIATE THAT INDE-  
FINABLE SENSE OF POWER THAT HARRY HAD FELT AFTER DUMBLEDORE

HAD STUNNED WELLING (WELCH). HARRY IS AS SANE AS WELL ER I. THAT

STAR WHEN HIS THREE-HEAD HAS NOT ADDED HIS BRAINS, I BELIEVE IT

FLIRTS HIM WHEN LORD VOLDEMORT IS CLOSE BY, HER FEELING PARTICULARLY MURDEROUS.

THE PARTING OF THE WAYS WAS

FLUDGE HAD TAKEN HALF A STEP BACK FROM DUMBLEDORE, BUT HE  
WHISKED NEARLY STRIKINGLY. "WELL, I FORGIVE ME, DUMBLEDORE, BUT  
I'VE NEVER HEARD OF A CLERK STAR ACTING AS AN ALARM BELL BEFORE ...  
WELL, I SAW VOLDEMORT COME BACK! HARRY STIMULATED, HE TRIED  
THE GET HIM UP BED AGAIN, BUT MRS WEASLEY FORCED HIM BACK. I SAW  
THE DEATH EATERS! I CAN GIVE YOU THEIR NAMES! LUCIUS MALFOY  
SNAPE MADE A SUDDEN MOVEMENT, BUT AS HARRY WHISKED AT  
HIM, SNAPE'S EYES FLEW BACK TO FLUDGE.

MALFOY WAS CLEARED! SAID FLUDGE, VISIBLY APPREHENDED, A VERY  
HOLD FAMILY DENATIONS THE EXCELLENT CALISES

MACNAB! HARRY CONTINUED.

ALSO CLEARED! WELL WORKING FOR THE MINISTRY!

EVERY NIGHT CRACK CRACK CRACK

YOU ARE MERELY REPEATING THE NAMES OF THESE WHO WERE  
ACQUITTED OF BEING DEATH EATERS THIRTEEN YEARS AGO! SAID FLUDGE  
ANGRILY. YOU COULD HAVE FOUND THESE NAMES IN HIS REPORTS OF  
THE TRIALS! FOR HEAVEN'S SAKE, DUMBLEDORE THE KING WAS FULL  
OF SOME CRACKPOT THEORY AT THE END OF LAST YEAR, THEN HIS TALKS  
ARE GETTING TALLER, AND YOU'RE STILL STALLING THEM THE  
KING CAN TALK TO SNAKES, DUMBLEDORE, AND YOU STILL THINK HE'S  
TRUSTWORTHY?

YELL: PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL CRIED, CEDRIC DIGGORY: MR  
[REEL]: THESE DEATHS WERE NOT THE RANDOM WORK OF A LUNATIC:  
I SEE NO EVIDENCE TO THE CONTRARY: SEETHED FLUDGE, NOW  
MATCHING HER ANGER, HIS FACE PURPLED. IT SEEMS TO ME THAT YELL  
ARE ALL DETERMINED TO START A PANIC THAT WILL DESTABILISE EVERY-  
THING WE HAVE WORKED FOR THESE LAST THIRTEEN YEARS:

HARRY COULDN'T BELIEVE WHAT HE WAS HEARING. HE HAD ALWAYS  
THOUGHT OF FLUDGE AS A KINDLY FIGURE, A LITTLE BLISTERING, A LITTLE  
POMPHEOUS, BUT ESSENTIALLY GOOD-NATURED, BUT NOW A SHORT, ANGRY  
WIZARD STOOD BEFORE HIM, REFUSING, PHINT-BLANK, TO ACCEPT THE  
PROSPECT OF DISRUPTION IN HIS COMFORTABLE AND ORDERED WORLD  
TO BELIEVE THAT VOLDEMORT COULD HAVE RISEN.

VOLDEMORT HAS RETURNED, DUMBLEDORE REPEATED. IF YELL  
ACCEPT THAT FACT STRAIGHT AWAY, FLUDGE, AND TAKE THE NECESSARY

19 HARRY POTTER

MEASURES, WE MAY STILL BE ABLE TO SAVE THE SITUATION. THE FIRST  
AND MOST ESSENTIAL STEP IS TO REMOVE AZKABAN FROM THE CONTROL  
OF THE DEMENTERS

PROFESSOR: SEETHED FLUDGE AGAIN. REMOVE THE  
DEMENTERS: I'D BE WICKED BUT OF OFFICE FOR SUGGESTING IT: HALF OF  
US ONLY FEEL SAFE IN OUR BEDS AT NIGHT BECAUSE WE KNOW THE  
DEMENTERS ARE STANDING GUARD AT AZKABAN:

THE REST OF US SLEEP LESS SOUNDLY IN OUR BEDS, CERNELIS,  
KNOWING THAT YELL HAVE PUT LORD VOLDEMORT'S MOST DANGEROUS

SLIPPERS IN THE CARE OF CREATURES WHO WILL BEHIND HIM THE  
INSTANT HE ASKS THEM? SAID DUMBLEDORE. THEY WILL NOT REMAIN  
LOYAL TO YOU, FLUDGE? VULDERMENT CAN OFFER THEM MUCH MORE  
SCOPE FOR THEIR POWERS AND THEIR PLEASURES THAN YOU CAN? WITH  
THE DEMENTHES BEHIND HIM, AND HIS OLD SLIPPERS RETURNED TO  
HIM, YOU WILL BE HARD PRESSED TO STOP HIM REGAINING THE SEAT OF  
POWER HE HAD THIRTEEN YEARS AGO?

FLUDGE WAS OPENING AND CLOSING HIS MOUTH AS THOUGH HE  
WOULD HAVE EXPRESSED HIS REGRET.

THE SECOND STEP YOU MUST TAKE AND AT ONCE, DUMBLEDORE  
PRESSED ON, IS TO SEND ENVOYS TO THE GIANTS.

ENVOYS TO THE GIANTS? FLUDGE SHRIEKED, FINDING HIS TONGUE  
AGAIN. WHAT MADNESS IS THIS?

EXTEND THEM THE HAND OF FRIENDSHIP, NOW, BEFORE IT IS TOO  
LATE, SAID DUMBLEDORE. MR VULDERMENT WILL PERSUADE THEM, AS  
HE DID BEFORE, THAT HE ALONE AMONG WIZARDS WILL GIVE THEM THEIR  
RIGHTS AND THEIR FREEDOM?

YOU YOU CANNOT BE SERIOUS? FLUDGE GASPED, SHAKING HIS  
HEAD, AND RETREATING FURTHER FROM DUMBLEDORE. IF THE MAGICAL  
COMMUNITY GET WIND THAT I HAD APPROACHED THE GIANTS PEOPLE  
HATE THEM, DUMBLEDORE END OF MY CAREER

YOU ARE BLINDED, SAID DUMBLEDORE, HIS VOICE RISING NOW, THE  
ALMA OF POWER AROUND HIM PALPABLE, HIS EYES BLAZING ONCE  
MORE, BY THE LEAVE OF THE OFFICE YOU HOLD, CHRONICLES? YOU PLACE

THEM MUCH IMPORTANCE, AND YOU ALWAYS HAVE BEEN, IN THE SO-  
CALLED PLURITY OF BLEED? YOU FAIL TO RECOGNISE THAT IT MATTERS NOT



THE PARTING OF THE WAYS WAS

WHAT SOMEBODY IS HERE, BUT WHAT THEY GROW THE RE? YELLER

DEMENTOR HAS JUST DESTROYED THE LAST REMAINING MEMBER OF A  
PURE-BLOOD FAMILY AS OLD AS AND AND SEE WHAT THAT MAN THESE

THE MAKE OF HIS LIFE? I TELL YELLER NOW TAKE THE STEPS I HAVE SUG-  
GESTED, AND YELLER WILL BE REMEMBERED, IN EFFICE FOR ELLT, AS ONE OF

THE BRAVEST AND GREATEST MINISTERS FOR MAGIC WE HAVE EVER  
KNOWN, FOR THE ACT AND HISTORY WILL REMEMBER YELLER AS THE MAN  
WHICH STEPPED ASIDE, AND ALLOWED VILDEMENT A SECOND CHANCE THE  
DESTROY THE WORLD WE HAVE TRIED THE REBUILD?

INSANE, WHISPERED FLUDGE, STILL BACKING AWAY. MAD ...

AND THEN THERE WAS SILENCE. MADAM POMPREE WAS STANDING  
FREEZEN AT THE FEET OF HARRY S BED, HER HANDS OVER HER MOUTH.  
MRS WEASLEY WAS STILL STANDING OVER HARRY, HER HAND ON HIS  
SHOULDER THE PREVENT HIM RISING. BILL, RON AND HERMIONNE WERE  
STARING AT FLUDGE.

IF YELLER DETERMINATION THE SHUT YELLER EYES WILL CARRY YELLER AS FAR

AS THIS, CROOKSHANKS, SAID DUMBLEDORE, WE HAVE REACHED A PART-  
ING OF THE WAYS, YELLER MUST ACT AS YELLER SEE FIT, AND I I SHALL ACT

AS I SEE FIT.

DUMBLEDORE S VOICE CARRIED NO HINT OF A THREAT; IT SEEMED  
LIKE A MERE STATEMENT, BUT FLUDGE BRISTLED AS THOUGH

OLIMPEDEHRE WAS ADVANCING UPON HIM WITH A WAND.

WELL, SEE HERE, OLIMPEDEHRE, HE SAID, WAVING A THREATENING FINGER. I VE GIVEN YOU FREE REIN, ALWAYS. I VE HAD A LOT OF RESPECT FOR YOU. I MIGHT NOT HAVE AGREED WITH SOME OF YOUR DECISIONS, BUT I VE KEPT QUIET. THERE AREN T MANY WHO D HAVE LET YOU FIRE

WEREWOLVES, OR KEEP FLAGRANT, OR DECIDE WHAT THE TEACH YOUR STUDENTS, WITHOUT REFERENCE TO THE MINISTRY. BUT IF YOU RE GOING TO

WARR AGAINST ME

THE ONLY ONE AGAINST WHOM I INTEND TO WARR, SAID OLIMPEDEHRE, IS LORD VOLDEMORT. IF YOU ARE AGAINST HIM, THEN WE REMAIN, CERNELIUS, ON THE SAME SIDE.

IT SEEMED FLUDGE COULD THINK OF NO ANSWER TO THIS. HE REVERED BACKWARDS AND FORWARDS ON HIS SMALL FEET FOR A MOMENT, AND SPUN HIS WHEELER BAT IN HIS HANDS.

HE HARRY POTTER

FINALLY, HE SAID, WITH A HINT OF A PLEA IN HIS VOICE, HE CAN T BE BAD, OLIMPEDEHRE, HE JUST CAN T BE ...

SNAPE STRIDE FORWARD, PAST OLIMPEDEHRE, PULLING UP THE LEFT SLEEVE OF HIS ROBES AS HE WENT. HE STUCK OUT HIS FOREARM, AND SHOWED IT TO FLUDGE, WHO RECOILED.

THERE, SAID SNAPE HARSHLY. THERE, THE DARK MARK. IT IS NOT AS CLEAR AS IT WAS, AN HOUR OR SO AGO, WHEN IT GLINTED BLACK, BUT YOU CAN STILL SEE IT. EVERY DEATH EATER HAD THE SIGN GLINT IN HIM BY THE DARK LORD. IT WAS A MEANS OF DISTINGUISHING EACH

ETHER, AND HIS MEANS OF SLIPPERING LIS THE HIM, WHEN HE  
THOUGHT THE MARK OF AND DEATH LATER, WE WERE THE DISAPPARATE,  
AND APPARATE, INSTANTLY, AT HIS SIDE. THIS MARK HAS BEEN GREEN-  
ING CLEARER ALL YEAR, BARDARIFF S, THEN, WHY DO YOU THINK

BARDARIFF FLED TONIGHT? WE BOTH FELT THE MARK BURN, WE BOTH  
KNEW HE HAD RETURNED, BARDARIFF FEARS THE DARK LORD S  
VENGEANCE, HE BETRAYED THEM MANY OF HIS FELLOW DEATH EATERS THE  
BE SURE OF A WELCOME BACK INTO THE FOLD.

FLUKE STEPPED BACK FROM SNAPE, THEN, HE WAS SHAKING HIS  
HEAD, HE DID NOT SEEM TO HAVE TAKEN IN A WORD SNAPE HAD SAID,  
HE STARED, APPARENTLY REPELLED, AT THE UGLY MARK ON SNAPE S  
ARM, THEN BLEEDED UP AT DUMBLEDORE AND WHISPERED, I DON T  
KNOW WHAT YOU AND YOUR STAFF ARE PLAYING AT, DUMBLEDORE, BUT  
I HAVE HEARD ENOUGH, I HAVE NO MORE TO ADD, I WILL BE IN TOUCH  
WITH YOU THEREAFTER, DUMBLEDORE, HE DISCUSSED THE RUNNING OF  
THIS SCHOOL, I MUST RETURN TO THE MINISTRY,

HE HAD ALMOST REACHED THE DOOR WHEN HE PAUSED, HE TURNED  
AROUND, STRODE BACK DOWN THE DORMITORY, AND STOPPED AT  
HARRY S BED.

YOUR WINNINGS, HE SAID SHORTLY, TAKING A LARGE BAG OF GOLD  
ELT OF HIS POCKET, AND DROPPING IT INTO HARRY S BEDSIDE TABLE.

FINE THOUSAND GALLEONS, THERE SHOULD HAVE BEEN A PRESENTA-  
TION CEREMONY, BUT IN THE CIRCUMSTANCES ...

HE CRAMPED HIS BROWER HAT BENTH HIS HEAD, AND WALKED BLIT  
HF THE ROOM, SLAPPING THE DOOR BEHIND HIM. THE MOMENT HE  
HAD DISAPPEARED, DUMBLEDORE TURNED THE LEEDS AT THE GRENIP

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ARHLND HARRY S BED.

THERE IS WHED THE EE DENE, HE SAID. MELL? ... AM I RIGHT IN  
THINKING THAT I CAN CHELNT HN YEL AND ARTHLR?

HF CHELSE YEL CAN, SAID MRS LEASLEY. SHE WAS WHITE TH THE  
LIPS, BUT SHE LHHED RESHLLTE. HE DNEHS WHAT FLJGE IS. IT S  
ARTHLR S PHENDNESS PHR MLELES THAT HAS HELD HIM BACK AT THE

MINISTRY ALL THESE YEARS. FLJGE THINKS HE LACKS PROPER WIZARD-  
ING PRIDE.

THEN I NEED TH SEND A MESSAGE TH HIM, SAID DUMBLEDORE.  
ALL THESE THAT WE CAN PERSUADE HF THE TRUTH MUST EE NOTIFIED  
IMMEDIATELY, AND ARTHLR IS WELL PLACED TH CONTACT THESE AT THE  
MINISTRY WEH ARE NOT AS SEHRT-SIGHTED AS CERNELIS.

I LL EE TH DAD, SAID KILL, STANDING UP. I LL EE NHN.  
EXCELLENT, SAID DUMBLEDORE. TELL HIM WHAT HAS HAPPENED.  
TELL HIM I WILL EE IN DIRECT CONTACT WITH HIM SEHRTLY. HE WILL  
NEED TH EE DISCREET, HEEVER. IF FLJGE THINKS I AM INTERFERING  
AT THE MINISTRY

LEAVE IT TH ME, SAID KILL.

HE CLAPPED A HAND HN HARRY S SEHLDER, KISSED HIS MEETHER HN  
THE CHEEK, PULLED HN HIS CHAD, AND STREDE BLICKLY FROM THE

REHM,

MINERVA, SAID DUMBLEDORE, TURNING THE PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL,  
I WANT TO SEE HAGRID IN MY OFFICE AS SOON AS POSSIBLE. ALSO IF  
SHE WILL CONSENT TO MEET MADAME MAXIME,

PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL NEEDED, AND LEFT WITHOUT A WORD.

PERFECT, DUMBLEDORE SAID TO MADAM POMFREY, WHO'D YOU BE  
VERY KIND, AND GO DOWN TO THE PROFESSOR MURPHY'S OFFICE, WHERE I  
THINK YOU WILL FIND A HOUSE-ELF CALLED WINDY IN CONSIDERABLE  
DISTRESS? DO WHAT YOU CAN FOR HER, AND TAKE HER BACK TO THE  
KITCHENS. I THINK DEERY WILL LOOK AFTER HER FOR US.

VERY VERY WELL, SAID MADAM POMFREY, LOOKING STARTLED, AND  
SHE THEN LEFT.

DUMBLEDORE MADE SURE THAT THE DOOR WAS CLOSED, AND THAT  
MADAM POMFREY'S FOOTSTEPS HAD DIED AWAY, BEFORE HE SPOKE  
AGAIN.

ELIZABETH PETER

AND NOW, HE SAID, IT IS TIME FOR THE TWO OF YOU TO REMEMBER THE  
RECKONING EACH OTHER FOR WHAT THEY ARE. SIRIUS ... IF YOU COULD  
RESUME YOUR USUAL FORM.

THE GREAT BLACK ONE BEHEADED UP AT DUMBLEDORE, THEN, IN AN  
INSTANT, TURNED BACK INTO A MAN.

MRS WEASLEY SCREAMED AND LEAPT BACK FROM THE BED.

SIRIUS BLACK? SHE SCRIEDED, POINTING AT HIM.

MUM, SHUT UP? REMY YELLED, IT'S HIM!

SNAPE HAD JUST YELLED AND JUMPED BACKWARDS, BUT THE BEHEADED  
HIS FACE WAS ONE OF MINGLED FURY AND FURROW.

"HIM? HE SNARLED, STARING AT SIRIUS, WHOSE FACE SHOWED OPEN  
DISLIKE. WHAT IS HE DOING HERE?"

"HE IS HERE AT MY INVITATION, SAID DUMBLEDORE, LOOKING  
BETWEEN THEM, AS ARE YELL, SEVERUS, I TRUST YELL BOTH. IT IS TIME  
FOR YELL TO LAY ASIDE YOUR OLD DIFFERENCES, AND TRUST EACH OTHER.  
HARRY TELLS ME DUMBLEDORE WAS ASKING FOR A REAL MIRACLE.  
SIRIUS AND SNAPE WERE EYING EACH OTHER WITH THE LUTHEST  
BREATHING.

"I WILL SETTLE, IN THE SHORT TERM, SAID DUMBLEDORE, WITH A BITE  
OF IMPATIENCE IN HIS VOICE, FOR A LACK OF OPEN HOSTILITY, YELL WILL  
SHAKE HANDS, YELL ARE ON THE SAME SIDE NOW, TIME IS SHORT, AND  
UNLESS THE FEW OF US WHO KNOW THE TRUTH STAND UNITED, THERE IS  
NOT MUCH FOR ANY OF US.

VERY SILENTLY BUT STILL GLARING AT EACH OTHER AS THOUGH EACH  
WISHED THE OTHER NOTHING BUT ILL SIRIUS AND SNAPE MOVED  
TOWARDS EACH OTHER, AND SHOOK HANDS, THEY LET GO EXTREMELY  
EASILY.

"THAT WILL BE THE LAST THING YOU WILL, SAID DUMBLEDORE, STEP-  
PING BETWEEN THEM ONCE MORE. NOW I HAVE WORD FOR EACH

OF YOU, UNDER A ATTITUDE, THOUGH NOT UNEXPECTED, CHANGES  
EVERYTHING, SIRIUS, I NEED YOU TO SET OFF AT ONCE, YOU ARE  
THE ALERT REMUS LUPIN, ARABELLA FIGG, MUNDUNGUS FLETCHER

THE OLD CREED, LIKE YOU AT LUPIN'S FOR A WHILE, I WILL CONTACT  
YOU THERE.

BUT SAID HARRY.

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HE WANTED SIRIUS TO STAY, HE DID NOT WANT THE SAY GOODBYE AGAIN SO QUICKLY.

YOU'LL SEE ME VERY SOON, HARRY, SAID SIRIUS, TURNING TO HIM. I PROMISE YOU, BUT I MUST DO WHAT I CAN, YOU UNDERSTAND, DON'T YOU?

YES, SAID HARRY. YES ... IF ONLY I COULD.

SIRIUS GRASPED HIS HAND QUICKLY, NEEDED THE DUMBLEDORE, TRANSFORMED AGAIN INTO THE BLACK DEER, AND RAN THE LENGTH OF THE ROOM THE

THE DEER, WHOSE HANDLE HE TURNED WITH A PAW. THEN HE WAS GONE. SEVERUS, SAID DUMBLEDORE, TURNING THE SNARE, YOU KNOW

WHAT I MUST ASK YOU TO DO. IF YOU ARE READY ... IF YOU ARE PREPARED ...

I AM, SAID SNAPE.

HE LOOKED SLIGHTLY PALE THAN USUAL, AND HIS CHILD, BLACK EYES GLITTERED STRANGELY.

THEN, GOOD LUCK, SAID DUMBLEDORE, AND HE WATCHED, WITH A TRACE OF APPREHENSION ON HIS FACE, AS SNAPE SWIFT WORDLESSLY AFTER SIRIUS.

IT WAS SEVERAL MINUTES BEFORE DUMBLEDORE SPEAKED AGAIN.

I MUST GO DOWNSTAIRS, HE SAID FINALLY. I MUST SEE THE

DIGGERS, HARRY TAKE THE REST OF YOUR POTION, I WILL SEE ALL OF YOU LATER.

HARRY SLUMPED BACK AGAINST HIS PILLOWS AS DUMBLEDORE DISAPPEARED, HERMIONE, RON AND MRS WEASLEY WERE ALL LOOKING AT

HIM. NONE OF THEM SPEAK FOR A VERY LONG TIME.

YOU VE GOT TO TAKE THE REST OF YOUR POTION, HARRY, MRS WEASLEY SAID AT LAST. HER HAND NUDGED THE SACK OF CHOCOLATE IN HIS BEDSIDE CABINET AS SHE REACHED FOR THE KETTLE AND THE CUP.

YOU HAVE A GOOD LONG SLEEP, TRY AND THINK ABOUT SOMETHING ELSE FOR A WHILE ... THINK ABOUT WHAT YOU RE GOING TO DO WITH YOUR WINNINGS?

I DON T WANT THAT CHOCOLATE, SAID HARRY IN AN EXPRESSIONLESS VOICE. YOU HAVE IT, ANYONE CAN HAVE IT, I SHOULDNT HAVE WANTED IT. IT SHOULD VE BEEN CEDRIC S.

THE THING AGAINST WHICH HE HAD BEEN FIGHTING FOR AND FOR

AND HARRY POTTTER

EVER SINCE HE HAD COME OUT OF THE MAZE WAS THREATENING TO OVERPOWER HIM. HE COULD FEEL A BURNING, PRICKLING FEELING IN THE INNER CORNERS OF HIS EYES. HE BLINKED AND STARED UP AT THE CEILING.

IT WASN T YOUR FAULT, HARRY, MRS WEASLEY WHISPERED.

I TOLD HIM TO TAKE THE CUP WITH ME, SAID HARRY.

NOW THE BURNING FEELING WAS IN HIS THROAT, THEN, HE WISHED RON WOULD LEAVE ALONE.



MRS LEASLEY SET THE PHTHEN DOWN IN THE BEDSIDE CABINET,  
KENT DOWN, AND PUT HER ARMS AROUND HARRY. HE HAD NO MEMORY  
OF EVER BEING HUGGED LIKE THIS, AS THOUGH BY A MOTHER. THE FULL  
BRIGHT OF EVERYTHING HE HAD SEEN THAT NIGHT SEEMED TO FALL IN  
UPON HIM AS MRS LEASLEY HELD HIM TO HER. HIS MOTHER'S FACE,  
HIS FATHER'S VOICE, THE SIGHT OF CEDRIC, DEAD IN THE GRILLING, ALL  
STARTED SPINNING IN HIS HEAD UNTIL HE COULD HARDLY BEAR IT, UNTIL  
HE WAS SCREWING UP HIS FACE AGAINST THE FLOOD OF MISERY FIGHTING  
TO GET OUT OF HIM.

THERE WAS A LOUD SLAPPING NOISE, AND MRS LEASLEY AND  
HARRY BROKE APART. HERMINIE WAS STANDING BY THE WINDOW. SHE  
WAS HOLDING SOMETHING TIGHT IN HER HAND.

SHARRY, SHE WHISPERED.

WELL, PHTHEN, HARRY, SAID MRS LEASLEY QUICKLY, WIPING HER  
EYES IN THE BACK OF HER HAND.

HARRY DROVE IT IN HOME. THE EFFECT WAS INSTANTANEOUS. HEAVY,  
IRRESISTIBLE WAVES OF DREAMLESS SLEEP BROKE OVER HIM. HE FELL  
BACK BENEATH HIS PILLOWS, AND THOUGH HE HAD NO MORE.

## CHAPTER THIRTY-SEVEN

### THE BEGINNING

WHEN HE WOKED BACK, EVEN A MONTH LATER, HARRY FELT HE HAD  
FEW MEMORIES OF THE FOLLOWING DAYS. IT WAS AS THOUGH HE HAD  
BEEN THROUGH THE MUCK AND TAKE IN AND MORE. THE RECOLLECTIONS  
HE DID HAVE WERE VERY PAINFUL. THE WORST, PERHAPS, WAS THE

MEETING WITH THE DIGGERS THAT THIR PLACE THE FOLLOWING  
MORNING.

THEY DID NOT BLAME HIM FOR WHAT HAD HAPPENED; IN THE CON-  
TRARY, THEY THANKED HIM FOR RETURNING CEDRIC & SHOW THE THEM.

MR DIGGERS SKIPPED THROUGH MOST OF THE INTERVIEW. MRS  
DIGGERS'S GRIEF SEEMED TO BE BEYOND TEARS.

HE SLIPPED VERY LITTLE, THEN, SHE SAID, WHEN HARRY HAD TOLD  
HER THAT CEDRIC HAD DIED. AND AFTER ALL, AMES ... HE DIED JUST  
WHEN HE DURING THE TOURNAMENT. HE MUST HAVE BEEN HAPPY,  
WHEN THEY HAD GOTTEN THEIR FEET, SHE LOOKED DOWN AT HARRY  
AND SAID, YOU KNOW AFTER YOURSELF, NOW.

HARRY SEIZED THE SACK OF GOLD IN THE BEDSIDE TABLE.

YOU TAKE THIS, HE MUTTERED TO HER. IT SHOULD BE BEEN  
CEDRIC'S, HE GOT THERE FIRST, YOU TAKE IT  
BUT SHE BACKED AWAY FROM HIM. NO, NO, IT'S YOURS, DEAR, WE  
CHILDREN T ... YOU KEEP IT.

\*

HARRY RETURNED THE GRIMFINDER TOWER THE FOLLOWING EVENING.

FROM WHAT HERMION AND RON TOLD HIM, DUMBLEDORE HAD SPEE-  
KEN THE THE SCHOOL THAT MORNING AT BREAKFAST. HE HAD MERELY

REQUESTED THAT THEY LEAVE HARRY ALONE, THAT NOBODY ASK HIM  
QUESTIONS OR BOTHER HIM TO TELL THE STORY OF WHAT HAD HAPPENED

BY HARRY POTTER

IN THE MAZE, MOST PEOPLE, HE NOTICED, WERE SKIRTING HIM IN THE  
CORRIDORS, AVOIDING HIS EYES. SOME WHISPERED BEHIND THEIR  
HANDS AS HE PASSED. HE GUESSED THAT MANY OF THEM HAD

BELIEVED RITA SKEETER'S ARTICLE ABOUT HIM DISTURBED AND POSSI-  
BLY DANGEROUS HE WAS. PERHAPS THEY WERE FORMULATING THEIR

OWN THEORIES ABOUT HIM. CEDRIC HAD DIED, HE FELT HE DIDN'T  
CARE VERY MUCH. HE LIKED IT BEST WHEN HE WAS WITH RON AND  
HERMIONIE, AND THEY WERE TALKING ABOUT OTHER THINGS, HER ELSE  
LETTING HIM SIT IN SILENCE WHILE THEY PLAYED CHESS. HE FELT AS  
THOUGH ALL THREE OF THEM HAD REACHED AN UNDERSTANDING THEY  
DIDN'T NEED THE PLATINUM WARD; THAT EACH WAS WAITING FOR SOME  
SIGN, SOME WORD, OF WHAT WAS GOING ON OUTSIDE THEGLAWS AND  
THAT IT WAS USELESS TO SPECULATE ABOUT WHAT MIGHT BE COMING  
UNTIL THEY KNEW SOMETHING FOR CERTAIN. THE ONLY TIME THEY  
THOUGHT UPON THE SUBJECT WAS WHEN RON TOLD HARRY ABOUT A  
MEETING MRS WEASLEY HAD HAD WITH DUMBLEDORE BEFORE GOING  
HOME.

SHE WENT TO ASK HIM IF SHE COULD COME STRAIGHT TO HIS THIS  
SUMMER, HE SAID, BUT HE WANTS YOU TO GO BACK TO THE DURSLEYS,  
AT LEAST AT FIRST.

WHY? SAID HARRY.

SHE SAID DUMBLEDORE'S GOT HIS REASONS, SAID RON, SHAKING  
HIS HEAD DARKLY. I SUPPOSE WE'VE GOT TO TRUST HIM, HAVEN'T WE?

THE ONLY PERSON APART FROM RHN AND FERMINE THAT HARRY  
FELT ABLE TO TALK TO WAS HAGRID, AS THERE WAS NO LONGER A  
DEFENCE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS TEACHER, THEY HAD THESE LESSONS  
FREE. THEY USED THE HOLE ON THURSDAY AFTERNOON TO GO DOWN  
AND VISIT HIM IN HIS CABIN. IT WAS A BRIGHT AND SUNNY DAY, FANG  
BEHIND HIM ON THE OPEN DEER AS THEY APPROACHED, BARKING AND  
WAGGING HIS TAIL MADLY.

WHO'S THAT? CALLED HAGRID, CHASING THE DEER. HARRY?  
HE STOPPED HIM TO MEET THEM, PULLED HARRY INTO A ONE-ARMED  
HUG, RUFFLED HIS HAIR AND SAID, COME TO SEE ME, MATE, COME  
TO SEE ME.

THEY SAW TWO KICKET-SIZED CLIPS AND SALICERS ON THE WHEDEN

## THE BEGINNING

TABLE IN FRONT OF THE FIREPLACE WHEN THEY ENTERED HAGRID'S CABIN.

RHON HAVING A CLIPPA WITH HIMSELF, HAGRID SAID, SHE'S ILK  
LEFT.

WHO? SAID RHN, CLUTTERING.

MADAME MAXIME, HE CHIRPED? SAID HAGRID.

WELL THEN MADE IT UP, HAVE WELL? SAID RHN.

BLINDLY WHAT YOU'RE TALKING ABOUT, SAID HAGRID AIRILY, PETCHING  
MORE CLIPS FROM THE DRESSER. WHEN HE HAD MADE TEA, AND  
OFFERED BEHIND A PLATE OF DELICIOUS BISCUITS, HE LEANT BACK IN HIS  
CHAIR AND SURVEYED HARRY CLOSELY THROUGH HIS BEETLE-BLACK EYES.

WELL ALL RIGHT? HE SAID GRUFFLY.

YES, SAID HARRY.

NO, YOU'RE NOT, SAID HAGRID. CHIRPED YOU'RE NOT, BUT YOU

WILL BE.

HARRY SAID NOTHING.

KNOW HE WAS GOIN TER COME BACK, SAID HAGRID, AND HARRY,  
HEN AND HERMIONE LEANED UP AT HIM, STUCKED. KNOWN IT PER  
YEARS, HARRY, KNOW HE WAS HLT THERE, RIDIN HIS TIME. IT HAD TER  
HAPPEN. WELL, NOW IT HAS, AN WE LL ILJS HAVE TER GET EN WITH IT.  
WE LL FIGHT, MICH BE ABLE TER STOP HIM BEFORE HE GETS A GOOD  
HOLD. THAT S DUMBLEDORE S PLAN, ANYWAY. GREAT MAN,  
DUMBLEDORE. S LONG AS WE VE GET HIM, I M NOT THEN WORRIED.

HAGRID RAISED HIS BUSHY EYEBROWS AT THE DISBELIEVING EXPRES-  
SIONS ON THEIR FACES.

NEE GOOD SITTING WHIRRYIN AROUND IT, HE SAID. WHAT S COMIN  
WILL COME, AN WE LL MEET IT WHEN IT DEES. DUMBLEDORE TOLD ME  
WHA YELL DID, HARRY.

HAGRID S CHEST SWELLED AS HE LEANED AT HARRY. YEH DID AS  
MUCH AS YER FATHER WOULD VE DONE, AN I CAN GIVE YEH NEE HIGHER  
PRAISE THAN THAT.

HARRY SMILED BACK AT HIM. IT WAS THE FIRST TIME HE D SMILED IN  
DAYS.

WHAT S DUMBLEDORE ASKED YELL TEH DEE, HAGRID? HE ASKED. HE  
SENT PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL TEH ASK YELL AND MADAME MAXIME TEH  
MEET HIM ... THAT NIGHT.

224 HARRY PEEETTER

GET A LITTLE INN PER ME HYER THE SLIMPER, SAID HAGRID. SECRET,

THOUGH, I MIGHT AS WELL TRY TO TALK ABOUT IT, NOT EVEN TRY TO LEAVE.

ELSTON MADAME MAXIME TRY TO LEAVE MIGHT BE COMING WITH

MR. I THINK SHE WILL. THINK I GET HER PERSUADED.

IS IT THE ONE WITH VERMONT?

ELSTON BLINKED AT THE SOUND OF THE NAME.

MIGHT BE, HE SAID EVASIVELY. WELL ... WE'D LIKE TO COME AND

VISIT THE LAST SUNDAY WITH ME? I WAS THINKING THINKING? HE ADDED

HASTILY, SEEING THE LOOKS ON THEIR FACES.

\*

IT WAS WITH A HEAVY HEART THAT HARRY PACKED HIS TRUNK UP IN THE

BERMITHS, ON THE NIGHT BEFORE HIS RETURN TO PRIVATE DRIVE. HE

WAS DREADING THE LEAVING FEAST, WHICH WAS USUALLY A CALISE FOR

CELEBRATION, WHEN THE WINNER OF THE INTER-UNIVERSITY

CHAMPIONSHIP WOULD BE ANNOUNCED. HE HAD AVOIDED BEING IN

THE GREAT HALL WHEN IT WAS FULL EVER SINCE HE HAD LEFT THE HOSPI-

TAL WING, PREFERRING THE BAR WHEN IT WAS NEARLY EMPTY, THE AVOID

THE STARS OF HIS FELLOW STUDENTS.

WHEN HE, BEN AND BERNARDINE ENTERED THE HALL, THEY SAW AT

ONCE THAT THE USUAL DECORATIONS WERE MISSING. THE GREAT HALL

WAS NORMALLY DECORATED WITH THE WINNING UNIVERSE'S CHAMPIONS FOR

THE LEAVING FEAST. TONIGHT, HOWEVER, THERE WERE BLACK DRAPES

ON THE WALL BEHIND THE TEACHERS' TABLE. HARRY KNEW INSTANTLY

THAT THEY WERE THERE AS A MARK OF RESPECT FOR EDWIN.

THE REAL MAD-DON MERRY WAS AT THE STAFF TABLE, HIS WHEEDEN

LEG AND HIS MAGICAL EYE BACK IN PLACE, HE WAS EXTREMELY TWITCHY, JUMPING EVERY TIME SOMEONE SPoke TO HIM. HARRY COULDN'T BLAME HIM; MERRY'S FEAR OF ATTACK WAS BEING THE HAVE BEEN INCREASED BY HIS TEN-MONTH IMPRISONMENT IN HIS OWN TOWER. PROFESSOR KARPAGH'S CHAIR WAS EMPTY. HARRY WONDERED, AS HE SAT DOWN WITH THE OTHER GRYFFINDERS, WHERE KARPAGH WAS NOW; WHETHER VERMOREL HAD CALLED UP WITH HIM. MADAME MAXIME WAS STILL THERE. SHE WAS SITTING NEXT THE HAGRID. THEY WERE TALKING QUIETLY TOGETHER, FURTHER ALONG THE TABLE, SITTING NEXT THE PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL, WAS SNAPE. HIS

## THE BEGINNING WAS

EYES LINGERED ON HARRY FOR A MOMENT AS HARRY LOOKED AT HIM. HIS EXPRESSION WAS DIFFICULT TO READ. HE LOOKED AS SERIOUS AND UNPLEASANT AS EVER. HARRY CONTINUED TO WATCH HIM, BEING AFTER SNAPE HAD LOOKED AWAY.

WHAT WAS IT THAT SNAPE HAD DONE FOR DUMBLEDORE'S ORDERS, THE NIGHT THAT VERMOREL HAD RETURNED? AND WHY ... WHY ... WAS DUMBLEDORE SO CONVINCED THAT SNAPE WAS TRULY ON THEIR SIDE? HE HAD BEEN THEIR SPY, DUMBLEDORE HAD SAID SO IN THE PAST. SNAPE HAD TURNED SPY AGAINST VERMOREL, AT GREAT PERSONAL RISK, WAS THAT THE JOB HE HAD TAKEN UP AGAIN? HAD HE MADE CONTACT WITH THE DEATH EATERS, PERHAPS? PRETENDED THAT HE HAD NEVER REALLY GONE OVER TO DUMBLEDORE, THAT HE HAD BEEN, LIKE VERMOREL HIMSELF, KIDING HIS TIME?

HARRY'S MISGIVINGS WERE ENDED BY PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE, WHO STOOD UP AT THE STAFF TABLE. THE GREAT HALL, WHICH IN ANY CASE

HAD BEEN LESS NOISY THAN IT USUALLY WAS AT THE LEAVING FEAST, BECAME VERY QUIET.

THE END, SAID DUMBLEDORE, LOOKING AROUND AT THEM ALL, OF ANOTHER YEAR.

HE PAUSED, AND HIS EYES FELL UPON THE FLIPPERPUFF TABLE.

THEIRS HAD BEEN THE MOST SLEEKED TABLE BEFORE HE HAD GENTLE HIS FEET, AND THEIRS WERE STILL THE SADDEST AND PALEST FACES IN THE HALL.

THERE IS MUCH THAT I WOULD LIKE TO SAY TO YOU ALL TONIGHT, SAID DUMBLEDORE, BUT I MUST FIRST ACKNOWLEDGE THE LOSS OF A VERY FINE PERSON, WHO SHOULD BE SITTING HERE. HE GESTURED TOWARDS THE FLIPPERPUFFS. ENJOYING OUR FEAST WITH US, I WOULD LIKE YOU ALL, PLEASE, TO STAND, AND RAISE YOUR GLASSES, TO CEDRIC DIGGORY.

THEY DID IT, ALL OF THEM; THE BENCHES SCRAPED AS EVERYONE IN THE HALL STOOD, AND RAISED THEIR GLEETS, AND RICHED, IN ONE VOICE, WHO, WHO, RUMBLING VOICE, CEDRIC DIGGORY.

HARRY CAUGHT A GLIMPSE OF HER THROUGH THE CROWD. THERE WERE TEARS BEARING SILENTLY DOWN HER FACE. HE LOOKED DOWN AT THE TABLE AS THEY ALL SAT DOWN AGAIN.

THE HARRY PENTTER

CEDRIC WAS A PERSON WHO EXEMPLIFIED MANY OF THE QUALITIES WHICH DISTINGUISH FLIPPERPUFF HOUSE, DUMBLEDORE CONTINUED.

HE WAS A GOOD AND LOYAL FRIEND, A HARD WORKER, HE VALUED FAIR PLAY. HIS DEATH HAS AFFECTED YOU ALL, WHETHER YOU KNEW HIM WELL OR NOT. I THINK THAT YOU HAVE THE RIGHT, THEREFORE, TO KNEEL



EXACTLY WHEN IT CAME ABOUT.

HARRY RAISED HIS HEAD, AND STARED AT DUMBLEDORE.

CEDRIC DIGGORY WAS MURDERED BY LORD VOLDEMORT.

A PANICKED WHISPER SWEEP THE GREAT HALL. PEOPLE WERE STARING AT DUMBLEDORE IN DISBELIEF, IN HORROR. HE REMAINED PERFECTLY CALM AS HE WATCHED THEM MUTTER THEMSELVES INTO SILENCE.

THE MINISTRY OF MAGIC, DUMBLEDORE CONTINUED, DOES NOT

WISH ME TO TELL YOU THIS. IT IS POSSIBLE THAT SOME OF YOUR PARENTS WILL BE HORRIFIED THAT I HAVE DONE SO EITHER BECAUSE THEY

WILL NOT BELIEVE THAT LORD VOLDEMORT HAS RETURNED, OR BECAUSE THEY THINK I SHOULD NOT TELL YOU SO, FEELING AS YOU ARE. IT IS MY BELIEF, HOWEVER, THAT THE TRUTH IS GENERALLY PREFERABLE TO LIES, AND THAT ANY ATTEMPT TO PRETEND THAT CEDRIC DIED AS THE RESULT OF AN ACCIDENT, OR SOME SORT OF COLLIDER OF HIS OWN, IS AN INSULT TO HIS MEMORY.

STUNNED AND FRIGHTENED, EVERY FACE IN THE HALL WAS TURNED TOWARDS DUMBLEDORE NOW ... OR ALMOST EVERY FACE. EVER AT THE SLYTHERIN TABLE, HARRY SAW DRACHE MALFOY MUTTERING SOMETHING THE CRACK AND CRACK. HARRY FELT A HEAVY, SICK SWEET OF ANGER IN HIS STOMACH. HE FORCED HIMSELF TO LOOK BACK AT DUMBLEDORE.

THERE IS SOMETHING ELSE WHICH MUST BE MENTIONED IN CONNECTION WITH CEDRIC'S DEATH. DUMBLEDORE WENT ON. I AM TALKING,

HE CHURSE, ASHLYT HARRY POTTER,

A KIND OF RIPLE CRISSED THE GREAT HALL, AS A FEW HEADS  
TURNED IN HARRY'S DIRECTION BEFORE FLICKING BACK THE FACE  
DUMBLEDORE.

HARRY POTTER MANAGED THE ESCAPE LORD VOLDEMORT, SAID  
DUMBLEDORE. HE RISKED HIS OWN LIFE TO RETURN CEDRIC'S BODY TO  
HOGWARTS. HE SHOWED, IN EVERY RESPECT, THE SORT OF BRAVERY THAT

THE BEGINNING OF

FEW WIZARDS HAVE EVER SHOWN IN FACING LORD VOLDEMORT, AND FOR  
THIS, I HONOUR HIM.

DUMBLEDORE TURNED GRAVELY TO HARRY, AND RAISED HIS CROOKED  
STICK MORE. NEARLY EVERYONE IN THE GREAT HALL FELL SILENT.  
THEY MURMURED HIS NAME, AS THEY HAD MURMURED CEDRIC'S,  
AND BRAND TO HIM. BUT, THROUGH A GAP IN THE STANDING FIGURES,  
HARRY SAW THAT MALFOY, CRABBE, GOYLE AND MANY OF THE OTHER  
SLYTHERINS HAD REMAINED DEFIANTLY IN THEIR SEATS, THEIR CROOKED  
STICKS LIFTED. DUMBLEDORE, WHO AFTER ALL POSSESSED NO MAGICAL  
EYE, DID NOT SEE THEM.

WHEN EVERYONE HAD ONCE AGAIN RESUMED THEIR SEATS,  
DUMBLEDORE CONTINUED. THE TRIWIZARD TOURNAMENT'S AIM WAS  
THE FURTHER AND DEEPER MAGICAL UNDERSTANDING. IN THE LIGHT OF  
WHAT HAS HAPPENED OF LORD VOLDEMORT'S RETURN SUCH TIES ARE  
MORE IMPORTANT THAN EVER BEFORE.

DUMBLEDORE LEANED FROM MADAME MAXIME AND HAGRID, THE  
FLEUR DELACOUR AND HER FELLOW BEAUKREATH'S STUDENTS, THE VIKTOR  
KRIK AND THE DUMSTRONGS AT THE SLYTHERIN TABLE. BUT, HARRY

SAY, BEEDED WARY, ALMOST FRIGHTENED, AS THOUGH HE EXPECTED  
OLMKEBHERE TO SAY SOMETHING HARSH.

EVERY GUEST IN THIS HALL, SAID OLMEBHERE, AND HIS EYES LIN-  
GERED UPON THE OLMESTRANGE STUDENTS, WILL BE WELCOMED BACK

HERE, AT ANY TIME, SHOULD THEY WISH TO COME. I SAY TO YOU ALL,  
HENCE AGAIN IN THE LIGHT OF LORD VERDEMORE'S RETURN, WE ARE  
ONLY AS STRONG AS WE ARE UNITED, AS WEAK AS WE ARE DIVIDED.

LORD VERDEMORE'S GIFT FOR SPREADING DISCORD AND ENMITY IS  
VERY GREAT. WE CAN FIGHT IT ONLY BY FORMING AN EQUALLY STRONG  
BOND OF FRIENDSHIP AND TRUST. DIFFERENCES OF HABIT AND LANGUAGE  
ARE NOTHING AT ALL IF OUR AIMS ARE IDENTICAL AND OUR HEARTS ARE  
OPEN.

IT IS MY RELIEF AND NEVER HAVE I BEEN HAPPY THAT I AM MISTAK-  
EN THAT WE ARE ALL FACING DARK AND DIFFICULT TIMES, SOME OF

THEM, IN THIS FALL, HAVE ALREADY SUFFERED DIRECTLY AT THE HANDS OF

LORD VERDEMORE. MANY OF YOUR FAMILIES HAVE BEEN THROWN ASUNDER,  
A WEEK AGO, A STUDENT WAS TAKEN FROM YOUR MIDST.

AND HARRY PETER

REMEMBER LORIC. REMEMBER, IF THE TIME SHOULD COME  
WHEN YOU HAVE TO MAKE A CHOICE BETWEEN WHAT IS RIGHT, AND  
WHAT IS EASY, REMEMBER WHAT HAPPENED TO A BOY WHO WAS CHOSEN,

AND KIND, AND BRAVE, BECAUSE HE STRAYED ACROSS THE PATH OF  
LORD VILDEMEHT, REMEMBER CEDRIC DICEHRY,

\*

HARRY'S TRUNK WAS PACKED; FREDNIG WAS BACK IN HER CAGE AND THE  
OF IT, HE, RON AND HERMIONIE WERE WAITING IN THE CROWDED  
ENTRANCE HALL WITH THE REST OF THE FORTY-SEVEN FOR THE CARRIAGES  
THAT WOULD TAKE THEM BACK TO HOGSMEADE STATION. IT WAS  
ANOTHER BEAUTIFUL SUMMER'S DAY, HE SUPPOSED THAT PRIVET DRIVE  
WOULD BE FERT AND LEAFY, ITS FLOWERS A RIGHT OF CHEER, WHEN HE  
ARRIVED THERE THAT EVENING. THE TWILIGHT GAVE HIM NO PLEASURE  
AT ALL.

ARRY:

HE WISHED ARIELING, FLEUR DELACHAIR WAS FLIRTING UP THE  
STONE STEPS INTO THE CASTLE. BEYOND HER, FAR ACROSS THE GREENS,  
HARRY COULD SEE HAGRID HELPING MADAME MAXIME TO BACK THEM  
OF THE GIANT HORSES INTO THEIR HARNESS. THE BEAVERBATHS CAR-  
RIAGE WAS ABOUT TO TAKE OFF.

WE WILL SEE EACH OTHER AGAIN, I HOPE, SAID FLEUR, AS SHE  
REACHED HIM, HOLDING OUT HER HAND. I AM HOPEING TO GET A JOB  
HERE, TO IMPROVE MY ENGLISH.

IT'S VERY GOOD ALREADY, SAID RON, IN A STRANGLED SORT OF VOICE.  
FLEUR SMILED AT HIM; HERMIONIE SCOWLED.

CHERRY, AHH, SAID FLEUR, TURNING THE CHE. IT WAS BEEN A PLEAS-  
URE MEETING YOU!

FLEUR'S SPIRITS HELD ON T HEAD BUT LIFT SLIGHTLY, AS HE WATCHED

FLEUR HURRY BACK ACROSS THE LAWN THE MADAME MAXIME, HER SIL-  
VERY HAIR RIPPLING IN THE SUNLIGHT.

WHEN FLEUR THE DUMFRIES STUDENTS ARE GETTING BACK?  
SAID REEN, O WELL REEN THEY CAN STEER THAT SHIP WITH-  
OUT?

REEN DID NOT STEER, SAID A GIRL'S VOICE. HE STAYED IN HIS  
CABIN AND LET US SEE THE VIEW. REEN HAD THEM THE SAY CHERRY

THE BEGINNING OF

THE HERMINE, COULD I HAVE A VIEW? HE ASKED HER.

HE ... YES ... ALL RIGHT, SAID HERMINE, LEAVING SLIGHTLY FLUS-  
TERED, AND FOLLOWING REEN THROUGH THE GROUND AND INTO HIS SIGHT.

WELL O BETTER HURRY UP! REEN CALLED LOUDLY AFTER HER. THE CAR-  
RIAGES WILL BE HERE IN A MINUTE!

HE LET FLEUR KEEP A WATCH FOR THE CARRIAGES, HOWEVER, AND  
SPENT THE NEXT FEW MINUTES CRANING HIS NECK OVER THE GROUND THE  
TRY AND SEE WHAT REEN AND HERMINE MIGHT BE UP TO. THEY  
RETURNED WHITE SHEN, REEN STARED AT HERMINE, BUT HER FACE WAS

IMPASSIVE.

I LIKED DICCHRY, SAID ORLIM ABRUPTLY, THE FARRY. HE WAS ALWAYS  
POLITE TO ME, ALWAYS, EVEN THOUGH I WAS FROM OLMSTRANG  
WITH KARDARETH, HE ADDED, SMILING.

HAVE YOU MET A NEW HEADMASTER YET? SAID FARRY.

ORLIM SMILGED, HE HELD UP HIS HAND AS FELIX HAD DONE,  
SHOOK FARRY'S HAND AND THEN RENN'S.

RENN LOOKED AS THOUGH HE WAS SUFFERING SOME SORT OF PAINFUL  
INTERNAL STRUGGLE. ORLIM HAD ALREADY STARTED WALKING AWAY  
WHEN RENN FIRST MET, CAN I HAVE YOUR AUTOGRAPH?  
HERMINE TURNED AWAY, SMILING AT THE HORSELESS CARRIAGES  
WHICH WERE NOW TRUNDLING TOWARDS THEM UP THE DRIVE, AS  
ORLIM, LOOKING SURPRISED, BUT GRATIFIED, SIGNED A FRAGMENT OF  
PARCHMENT FOR RENN.

\*

THE WEATHER COULD NOT HAVE BEEN MORE DIFFERENT FROM THE UNUSU-  
ALLY RAINY THE KING'S CROSS THAN IT HAD BEEN FROM THEIR WAY THE

BEGLIANTS THE PREVIOUS SEPTEMBER. THERE WASN'T A SINGLE CLOUD  
IN THE SKY, FARRY, RENN AND HERMINE HAD MANAGED TO GET A

COMPARTMENT THE THEMSELVES. PIGWIDGERIN WAS ONCE AGAIN HID-  
DEN UNDER RENN'S DRESS REARS THE STEP HIM HESITATING CONTINUALLY;

HELVIC WAS DRIZING, HER HEAD UNDER HER WING, AND

CROOKSHANKS WAS CURLED UP IN A SPARE SEAT LIKE A LARGE, FLUFFY GINGER KITTEN. HARRY, RON AND HERMIONE TALKED MORE FLUENTLY AND FREELY THAN THEY HAD DONE ALL WEEK, AS THE TRAIN SPED THEM SOUTHWARDS. HARRY FELT AS THOUGH DUMBLEDORE'S SPEECH AT THE

END HAD SET HIM

LEAVING FEELING HAD UNLOCKED HIM, SOMEHOW. IT WAS LESS PAINFUL TO DISCUSS WHAT HAD HAPPENED NOW. THEY BROKE OFF THEIR CONVERSATION ABOUT WHAT ACTION DUMBLEDORE MIGHT BE

TAKING EVEN NOW THE STEP FORWARD, ONLY WHEN THE LUNCH Trolley ARRIVED.

WHEN HERMIONE RETURNED FROM THE Trolley AND PUT HER MINEY BACK INTO HER SLEEVE, SHE DISCLOSED A COPY OF THE DAILY PROPHET WHICH SHE HAD BEEN CARRYING IN THERE.

HARRY LOOKED AT IT, UNSURE WHETHER HE REALLY WANTED TO KNOW WHAT IT MIGHT SAY, BUT HERMIONE, SEEING HIM LOOKING AT IT, SAID CALMLY, 'THERE'S NOTHING IN THERE, YOU CAN READ FOR YOURSELF, BUT THERE'S NOTHING AT ALL. I'VE BEEN CHECKING EVERY DAY. JUST A SMALL PIECE THE DAY AFTER THE THIRD TASK, SAYING YOU WOULD WIN THE TOURNAMENT. THEY DIDN'T EVEN MENTION CEDRIC. NOTHING ABOUT ANY OF IT. IF YOU ASK ME, FLUKE IS FORCING THEM TO KEEP QUIET. HE'LL NEVER KEEP RITA QUIET, SAID HARRY. NOT EVEN A STORY LIKE THIS.

HEY, RITA HASN'T WRITTEN ANYTHING AT ALL SINCE THE THIRD TASK, SAID HERMIONE, IN AN EBBING CONSTRAINED VOICE. AS A MATTER OF

FACT, SHE ADDED, HER VEHICLE WHEEL TREMBLING SLIGHTLY, RITA SKEETER  
ISN'T GIVING THEM WRITING ANYTHING AT ALL FOR A WHILE. NEXT WEEKS  
SHE WANTS ME TO SPILL THE BEANS ON HER.

WHAT ARE YOU TALKING ABOUT? SAID RON.

I FEELING BUT FEEL SHE WAS LISTENING IN ON PRIVATE CONVERSA-  
TIONS WHEN SHE WASN'T SUPPOSED TO BE CHEERING THEM THE

GRINDS, SAID HERMIONE IN A FLUSH.

HARRY HAD THE IMPRESSION THAT HERMIONE HAD BEEN DYING TO  
TELL THEM THIS FOR DAYS, BUT THAT SHE HAD RESTRAINED HERSELF IN  
THE LIGHT OF EVERYTHING ELSE THAT HAD HAPPENED.

HOW WAS SHE DOING IT? SAID HARRY AT ONCE.

HOW DID YOU FIND OUT? SAID RON, STARING AT HER.

WELL, IT WAS YOU, REALLY, WHEN GAVE ME THE IDEA, HARRY, SHE  
SAID.

DID I? SAID HARRY, PERPLEXED. HOW?

SLUGGING, SAID HERMIONE HAPPILY.

THE BEGINNING OF

BUT YOU SAID THEY DIDN'T WANT

HEY, NOT ELECTRONIC KIDS, SAID HERMIONE. NO, YOU SEE ... RITA  
SKEETER HERMIONE'S VEHICLE TREMBLED WITH ELIOT TRIUMPH IS  
AN UNREGISTERED ANIMALS. SHE CAN TURN

HERMIONE PULLED A SMALL SEALED GLASS JAR OUT OF HER BAG,

INTO A KETTLE.

YOU'RE KIDDING, SAID RON. YOU HAVEN'T ... SHE'S NOT ...



“HEY, YES SHE IS,” SAID FERMINE HAPPILY, BRANDISHING THE IAR AT THEM.

INSIDE WERE A FEW TWIGS AND LEAVES, AND ONE LARGE, FAT BEETLE.

“THAT’S NEVER BEEN A KIDDING,” RHN WHISPERED, LIFTING THE IAR TO HIS EYES.

“WELL, I’M NOT,” SAID FERMINE, BEAMING. “I CAUGHT HER ON THE WINDOW-SILL IN THE HOSPITAL WING, BEHIND VERY CLOSELY, AND WHEN I NOTICE THE MARKINGS AROUND HER ANTENNAE ARE EXACTLY LIKE THESE PINK GLASSES SHE WEARS.”

HARRY SMILED, AND SAID THAT SHE WAS EXACTLY RIGHT. HE ALSO REMEMBERED SOMETHING. “THERE WAS A BEETLE ON THE STATUE THE NIGHT WE HEARD HARRY TELLING MADAME MARIE ABOUT HIS PLAN.”

“EXACTLY,” SAID FERMINE. AND FURTHER PULLED A BEETLE OUT OF MY HAIR AFTER WE’D HAD OUR CONVERSATION BY THE LAKE. AND UNLESS I’M VERY MUCH MISTAKEN, RITA WAS PERCHED ON THE WINDOW-SILL OF THE DIVINATION CLASS THE DAY YOUR STAR FLIRT. SHE’S BEEN BUZZING AROUND HER STORIES ALL YEAR.

“WHEN WE SAW MALCOLM UNDER THAT TREE ...” SAID RHN SILENTLY.

“HE WAS TALKING TO HER, IN HIS HAND,” SAID FERMINE. “HE

KNOWS, OF COURSE, THAT SHE’S BEEN GETTING ALL THESE NICE LITTLE INTERVIEWS WITH THE SLOTHERINS. THEY WOULDN’T CARE THAT SHE

WAS DOING SOMETHING ILLEGAL, AS LONG AS THEY WERE GIVING HER FANTASTIC STUFF ABOUT US AND HARRY.

FERMINE THREW THE GLASS IAR BACK FROM RHN AND SMILED AT

THE BEETLE, WHICH BUZZED ANGRILY AGAINST THE GLASS.

I'VE TOLD HER I'LL LET HER GO WHEN WE GET BACK TO LONDON,  
SAID HERMIONE. I'VE PUT AN UNBREAKABLE CHARM ON THE JAR, SHE'LL

BE HARRY POTTER

SEE, SHE CAN'T TRANSFORM, AND I'VE TOLD HER SHE'S TO KEEP HER  
MOUTH SHUT FOR A WHILE YET. SEE IF SHE CAN'T BREAK THE HABIT  
OF WRITING HORRIBLE LIES ABOUT PEOPLE.

SMILING SERENELY, HERMIONE PLACED THE BEETLE BACK INSIDE  
HER SCHEMAG.

THE DOOR OF THE COMPARTMENT SLID OPEN.

VERY CLEVER, CRABBE, SAID DRACO MALFOY.

CRABBE AND GOYLE WERE STANDING BEHIND HIM. ALL THREE OF  
THEM LOOKED MORE PLEASED WITH THEMSELVES, MORE ARROGANT AND  
MORE MENACING, THAN HARRY HAD EVER SEEN THEM.

SHE, SAID MALFOY SLEENLY, ADVANCING SLIGHTLY INTO THE COMPART-  
MENT, AND LOOKING AHEAD AT THEM, A SMILE GLIMMERING ON HIS

LIPS. SHE'LL BE THE PERFECT PATRIOTIC REPORTER, AND POTTER'S  
DUMBLEDORE'S FAVORITE KID AGAIN. BIG DEAL.

HIS SMILE WIDENED, CRABBE AND GOYLE LEERED.

TRYING NOT TO THINK ABOUT IT, ARE WE? SAID MALFOY SEETLY,  
LOOKING AHEAD AT ALL THREE OF THEM. TRYING TO PRETEND IT HADN'T  
HAPPENED?

GET SHUT, SAID HARRY.

HE HAD NOT BEEN NEAR MALFOY SINCE HE HAD WATCHED HIM

MILITERRING THE CRACKER AND GEMPLE DURING DUMKLEDBERE'S SPEECH  
ARHET CRACK. HE COULD FEEL A KIND OF RINGING IN HIS EARS, HIS  
HAND GRIPPED HIS WAND UNDER HIS REEKS.

YELL WE PICKED THE MISSING SIDE, PHTTER! I WARNED YELL! I TOLD  
YELL YELL HIGHLIGHT THE CHIEFS YELLIN COMPANY MORE CAREFULLY,  
REMEMBER? WHEN WE MET HIM THE TRAIN, FIRST DAY AT FEEGLARTS? I  
TOLD YELL MEET THE HANG ARHETING WITH RIFF-RAFF LIKE THIS! HE JERKED  
HIS HEAD AT REIN AND HERMINE. THEE LATE REEL, PHTTER! THEY LL BE  
THE FIRST THE GO, REEL THE DARK LEEDS & RACK! MLDKLEEDS AND  
MUGGLE-LEIVERS FIRST! WELL SECOND DIGGERS WAS THE F  
IT WAS AS THOUGH SOMEONE HAD EXPLODED A BOX OF FIREWORKS  
WITHIN THE COMPARTMENT, BLINDED BY THE BLAZE OF THE SPELLS THAT  
HAD BLASTED FROM EVERY DIRECTION, DRAGGED BY A SERIES OF RANGES,  
HARRY BLINKED, AND LEANED DOWN AT THE FLOOR.

MALPHE, CRACKER AND GEMPLE WERE ALL LYING LITCHENSCHELS IN THE

THE BEGINNING WEE

DEERWAY, HE, REIN AND HERMINE WERE HIM THEIR FEET, ALL THREE OF  
THEM HAVING LIVED A DIFFERENT FEE. NEAR WERE THEY THE ONLY WIKES  
THE HAVE BEEN SEE.

THELIGHT WE D SEE WHAT THESE THREE WERE LIP THE, SAID FRED

MATTER-OF-FACTLY, STEPPING INTO GEMPLE, AND INTO THE COMPART-  
MENT. HE HAD HIS WAND HILT, AND SHE DID GEHREGE, WHO WAS CARE-  
FUL THE TREAD HIM MALPHE AS HE FELLERED FRED INSIDE.

INTERESTING EFFECT, SAID GEHREGE, LEANING DOWN AT CRACK.

WHICH USED THE FLINCHING CLIP?

MR. SAID HARRY.

HEH, SAID GEORGE LIGHTLY. I USED JELLY-LEGS, LEADS AS  
THOUGH THESE TWO SHOULDNT BE MIXED, HE SEEMS TO HAVE  
SPRINKLED LITTLE TENTACLES ALL OVER HIS FACE. WELL, LETS NOT LEAVE  
THEM HERE, THEY DONT ADD MUCH TO THE DECOR.

THEN, HARRY AND GEORGE DICKED, REELLED AND PULSED THE  
LINCHING MACHINES, CRACKS AND CRASHES EACH OF THEM REELLED  
DISTINCTLY THE WHIRL FOR THE JUMBLE OF LIMBS WITH WHICH THEY  
HAD BEEN HIT. HEAT INTO THE CHAIRS, THEN CAME BACK INTO THE  
COMPARTMENT AND REELLED THE OTHER SEAT.

EXPLODING SNAP, ANYMORE? SAID FRED, PULLING HEAT A PACK OF  
CARDS.

THEY WERE HALFWAY THROUGH THEIR FIFTH GAME WHEN HARRY  
DECIDED TO ASK THEM.

WELL BEING THE TELL US, THEN? HE SAID TO GEORGE. WHICH WERE  
BLACKMAILING?

HEH, SAID GEORGE DANKLY. THAT.

IT DOESNT MATTER, SAID FRED, SHAKING HIS HEAD IMPATIENTLY.

IT WASNT ANYTHING IMPORTANT, NOT REEL, ANYWAY.

WEVE GIVEN UP, SAID GEORGE, SHRUGGING.

BUT HARRY, BEN AND HERMIONE KEPT ON ASKING, AND FINALLY

FRED SAID, ALL RIGHT, ALL RIGHT, IF YOU REALLY WANT THE ANSWER ... IT  
WAS LUDWIG BAGMAN.

BAGMAN? SAID HARRY SHARPLY. ARE YOU SAYING HE WAS  
INVOLVED IN

NAH, SAID GEORGE GLENNILY. NOTHING LIKE THAT. STUPID GIT.

HEY HARRY POTTER

HE WOULDN'T HAVE THE BRAINS.

WELL, WHAT, THEN? SAID RON.

FRED HESITATED, THEN SAID, YOU REMEMBER THAT SET WE HAD  
WITH HIM, AT THE HOLIDITCH WORLD CUP? ARHET FELW IRELAND  
WOULD WIN, BUT DRUM WOULD GET THE SNITCH?

Yeah, SAID HARRY AND RON SILENTLY.

WELL, THE GIT PAID US IN REPRESENTATION GELD HE'D CALLED FROM  
THE IRISH MASHETS.

See?

See, SAID FRED IMPATIENTLY, IT VANISHED, DIDN'T IT? BY NEXT  
MORNING, IT HAD GONE?

BUT IT MUST'VE BEEN AN ACCIDENT, MUSTN'T IT? SAID  
HERMION.

GEORGE LAUGHED VERY BITTERLY. Yeah, THAT'S WHAT WE THOUGHT,  
AT FIRST. WE THOUGHT IF WE JUST WRITE TO HIM, AND TELL HIM HE'D  
MADE A MISTAKE, HE'D CHUCK UP. BUT NOTHING DOING. IGNORED  
HIS LETTER. WE KEPT TRYING TO TALK TO HIM ABOUT IT AT HOGWARTS,  
BUT HE WAS ALWAYS MAKING SOME EXCUSE TO GET AWAY FROM US.

IN THE END, HE TURNED PRETTY NASTY, SAID FRED. TOLD US WE  
WERE THEE STEALING THE GAME, AND HE WASN'T GIVING US ANYTHING.

See WE ASKED FOR HIS MONEY BACK, SAID GEORGE, GASPING.

HE DIDN'T REFUSE? GASPED HERMION.

RIGHT IN HERE, SAID FRED.

BUT THAT WAS ALL HIS SAYING? SAID RON.

TELL ME ABOUT IT, SAID GEORGE. CHURCH, WE FEELING BUT WHAT

WAS GOING ON IN THE END, LEE JORDAN'S DAD HAD HAD A BIT OF  
TROUBLE GETTING MONEY OFF RAGMAN AS WELL, TURNS OUT HE'S IN BIG  
TROUBLE WITH THE GHEKINS, REROUNDED LEGS HE' GOED OFF THEM, A  
GANG OF THEM CHURNED HIM IN THE WHEELS AFTER THE WHEEL CLIP  
AND TOOK ALL THE GOED HE HAD, AND IT STILL WASN'T ENOUGH THE CHEVER  
ALL HIS DEETS, THEY FOLLOWED HIM ALL THE WAY THE FINGWARTS THE  
DEEP AN EYE ON HIM, HE'S LOST EVERYTHING GAMBLING, HASN'T GHT  
THE GALLERIES THE RUK TOGETHER, AND YELL DREW FELL THE IDIOT  
TRIED TO PAY THE GHEKINS BACK?  
HE' SAID HARRY,

### THE BEGINNING WAS

HE PUT A BET ON YELL, MATE, SAID FRED, PUT A BIG BET ON YELL  
TO WIN THE TOURNAMENT, BET AGAINST THE GHEKINS.

SEE THAT'S WHY HE KEPT TRYING TO HELP ME WIN? SAID HARRY,

WELL I DID WIN, DIDN'T I? SEE HE CAN PAY YELL YELLER GOED?

NEVER, SAID GEORGE, SHAKING HIS HEAD, THE GHEKINS PLAY AS  
DIRTY AS HIM, THEY SAY YELL DREW WITH DIGGER, AND RAGMAN  
WAS BETTING YELL TO WIN ELTRIGHT, SEE RAGMAN HAD THE RUK FOR IT,  
HE MADE A RUK FOR IT RIGHT AFTER THE THIRD TASK.

GEORGE SIGHED DEEPLY, AND STARTED DEALING OUT THE CARDS  
AGAIN.

THE REST OF THE JOURNEY PASSED PLEASANTLY ENOUGH; HARRY  
WISHED IT COULD HAVE GONE ON ALL SUMMER, IN FACT, AND THAT HE  
WOULD NEVER ARRIVE AT KING'S CROSS ... BUT AS HE HAD LEARNED THE  
HARD WAY THAT YEAR, TIME WILL NOT SLOW DOWN WHEN SOMETHING  
UNPLEASANT LIES AHEAD, AND ALL THE SEEN THE FINGWARTS EXPRESS

WAS SLEEPING DOWN AT PLATFORM NINE AND THREE-QUARTERS, THE  
USUAL CHINWOMEN AND NEISE FILLED THE CORRIDORS AS THE STUDENTS  
BEGAN THE DISSEMBARK. RON AND HERMIONE STRUGGLED PAST  
MALPBY, CRABBE AND GOYLE, CARRYING THEIR TRUNKS.  
HARRY, HOWEVER, STAYED PUT. FRED GEORGE WAIT A  
MOMENT.

THE TWINS TURNED. HARRY PULLED OPEN HIS TRUNK, AND DREW  
OUT HIS TRILIZARD WINNINGS.

TAKE IT, HE SAID, AND HE THROST THE SACK INTO GEORGE S HANDS.  
WHAT? SAID FRED, LOOKING FLAKKERCASTED.

TAKE IT, HARRY REPEATED FIRMLY. I DONT WANT IT.

WELL BE MENTAL, SAID GEORGE, TRYING TO PLUSH IT BACK AT HARRY.  
NEE, I M NOT, SAID HARRY. WELL TAKE IT, AND GET INVENTING. IT S  
FOR THE INDEX-SHEEP.

HE IS MENTAL, FRED SAID, IN AN ALMOST AWED VOICE.

LISTEN, SAID HARRY FIRMLY. IF WELL DONT TAKE IT, I M THROWING  
IT DOWN THE DRAIN. I DONT WANT IT AND I DONT NEED IT. BUT I  
WOULD BE WITH A FEW LAUGHS. WE WOULD ALL BE WITH A FEW LAUGHS.  
I VE GOT A FEELING WE RE GOING TO NEED THEM MORE THAN USUAL  
BEFORE LONG.

SEE HARRY PENTTER

HARRY, SAID GEORGE WEARILY, WRIGHING THE MEINER BAG IN HIS  
HANDS. THERE S GOT TO BE A THOUSAND CALLIPENS IN HERE.

Yeah, SAID HARRY, GRINNING. THINK HOW MANY CANARY  
CREAMS THAT IS.

THE TWINS STARED AT HIM.

JUST DIDN'T TELL YOUR MUM WHERE YOU GET IT ... ALTHOUGH SHE  
MIGHT NOT BE SEEING FOR YOU THE INN THE MINISTRY AND THERE,  
COME THE THING OF IT ...

HARRY, FRED BEGAN, BUT HARRY PULLED OUT HIS HAND,

XXXX, HE SAID FLATLY, TAKE IT, FOR I'LL FOR YOU, I DON'T SEE

GOOD HEN'S NEW, JUST BE ME ONE FAVOR, FOR? BUT BEEN SOME DI-  
FERENT DRESS HERE, AND SAY THEY'RE FROM YOU,

HE LEFT THE COMPARTMENT BEFORE THEY COULD SAY ANOTHER  
WORD, STEPPING OVER MALFOY, CRABBE AND GOYLE, WHO WERE STILL  
LYING ON THE FLOOR, COVERED IN RED MARKS.

UNCLE VERNON WAS WAITING BEYOND THE BARRIER, MRS WEASLEY  
WAS CLOSE BY HIM. SHE HUGGED HARRY VERY TIGHTLY WHEN SHE SAW  
HIM, AND WHISPERED IN HIS EAR, I THINK DUMBLEDORE WILL LET YOU  
COME THE LATE IN THE SUMMER, KEEP IN TOUCH, HARRY,

SEE YOU, HARRY, SAID RON, CLAPPING HIM ON THE BACK,

BYE, HARRY? SAID HERMIONE, AND SHE DID SOMETHING SHE HAD  
NEVER DONE BEFORE, AND KISSED HIM ON THE CHEEK.

HARRY THANKS, GEORGE MUTTERED, WHILE FRED NODDED  
PERVIENTLY AT HIS SIDE.

HARRY WINKED AT THEM, TURNED TO UNCLE VERNON, AND  
WHEELED HIM SILENTLY FROM THE STATION. THERE WAS NO POINT  
WHISPERING YET, HE TOLD HIMSELF, AS HE GOT INTO THE BACK OF THE  
DURSleys' CAR.

AS HAGRID HAD SAID, WHAT WOULD COME, WOULD COME ... AND  
HE WOULD HAVE THE MEET IT WHEN IT DID.



J. K. ROWLING RATHER THAN FEELING  
HAS WRITTEN FICTION SINCE SHE WAS A CHILD.  
BORN IN 1965, SHE GREW UP IN CHERESTER  
AND WROTE HER FIRST BOOK AT THE AGE OF SIX  
- A STORY ABOUT A RABBIT CALLED RABBIT.  
SHE STUDIED FRENCH AND CLASSICS AT EXETER  
UNIVERSITY, THEN MOVED TO LONDON TO  
WORK AT AMNESTY INTERNATIONAL, AND THEN  
TO TEACH ENGLISH AS A FOREIGN  
LANGUAGE, BEFORE SETTLING IN BIRMINGHAM.  
THE IDEA FOR HARRY POTTER OCCURRED TO HER  
ON THE TRAIN FROM MANCHESTER TO LONDON,  
WHERE SHE SAYS HARRY POTTER FIRST STRUCK  
INTO MY HEAD FULLY FORMED, AND BY THE  
TIME SHE HAD ARRIVED AT KING'S CROSS,  
MANY OF THE CHARACTERS HAD TAKEN SHAPE.  
DURING THE NEXT FIVE YEARS SHE OUTLINED  
THE PLOTS FOR EACH BOOK AND BEGAN WRITING  
THE FIRST IN THE SERIES, HARRY POTTER AND  
THE PHILOSOPHER'S STONE, WHICH WAS FIRST  
PUBLISHED BY BLOOMSBURY IN 1997. THE  
OTHER HARRY POTTER TITLES: HARRY POTTER AND  
THE CHAMBER OF SECRETS, HARRY POTTER AND THE  
PRISONER OF AZKABAN, HARRY POTTER AND THE  
GOBLET OF FIRE, AND HARRY POTTER AND THE  
ORDER OF THE PHOENIX, FOLLOWED.

J. K. ROWLING HAS ALSO WRITTEN THREE OTHER  
COMPANION BOOKS, ELIOTTE'S THROUGH THE  
AGES, FANTASTIC BEASTS AND WHERE THEY  
FIND THEM AND THE TALES OF BEEDLE THE  
BARD, IN AID OF CHINA RELIEF.